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Mark

Mark 1:1

Section 1:1–8: God sent John the Baptizer to prepare the people to receive Jesus

These notes have divided this section into three paragraphs:

1:1 serves as an introduction both to section 1:1–8 and to the book as a whole.

1:2–3 introduces John the Baptizer by quoting the Old Testament verses that predict his ministry.

1:4–8 describes John, his ministry and his message.

In some languages it may be more natural to make different paragraph breaks. For example:

- 1:1–3 and 1:4–8 (GNT, NCV)
- 1:1–8 (NRSV, REB, NAB, NJB)

Divide the paragraphs in a way that will fit the style of your language.

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a section heading for it. You will need to use terms in the heading that you have used in the verses within the section. For example, before you write a section heading for this section, you will need to know how you have translated the word “Baptizer.” See the note on 1:4a.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The preaching of John the Baptizer

John prepared people for Jesus to arrive

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 3:1–12; Luke 3:1–18; and John 1:19–28.

Paragraph 1:1

This paragraph introduces the book of Mark. It tells readers that the subject of the entire book is the gospel about Jesus Christ. This gospel begins with how John the Baptizer prepared people for the coming of Jesus. Scholars are evenly divided as to whether this verse introduces 1:1–8 or the book as a whole. But this difference is not apparent in most English versions. Either way, the book as a whole is about Jesus Christ, and the next verses begin with an account about John the Baptist.

1:1

This is the beginning of the gospel of Jesus Christ, the Son of God.

- ¶ This is the beginning of the good news about Jesus, who is the Christ, the Son of God.
- ¶ The joyous account of Jesus the Child of God, whom God appointed to be the Messiah, begins here.
- ¶ This book/writing contains the good news/story about Jesus the Christ/Messiah. He is the Son of God. This is how the story/news begins.

This is the beginning of the gospel of Jesus Christ, the Son of God: The BSB has supplied the words This is to make this verse a complete sentence. The Greek phrase is an incomplete sentence and is more like a title. Translate in a way that is natural in your own language.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

The story of the good news about Jesus the Christ, God’s Son, begins in this way:

This is how the good news about Jesus the Messiah, the Son of God, begins.

the beginning of the gospel: The phrase the beginning of the gospel indicates that in this section the author tells how the gospel began. It began with the prophecy in 1:2–3 and the ministry of John the Baptizer in 1:4–8. The phrase does not indicate that the entire book of Mark is only the beginning of the gospel.

gospel: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gospel means “good news.” In Mark, this word refers to the good news about Jesus Christ and the kingdom of God.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

good/sweet news

good news about Jesus Christ

good news from God

message/report that causes joy

Be sure that the term you choose does not refer only to a news report or to a story that is not true.

of Jesus Christ: The phrase that the BSB translates as of Jesus Christ means that the good news is about Jesus Christ. It does not mean that the good news came from Jesus Christ.

Christ: Here the word Christ is used as a title. It is not just one of Jesus' names. In the other verses where it is used in Mark, it is clearly used as a title, not just a name.

The Jews used the title Christ to refer to the person whom God had appointed and promised to send as King and Savior. The title Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word "Messiah," and the two words have the same meaning.

Here are some other ways to translate Christ:

- Transliterate it according to the sounds of your language. For example:

Krais

Karisiti

- Transliterate it and indicate in some way that it is a title. For example:

the Christ

the Kirisita

- Transliterate Christ and include a phrase that explains the meaning. For example:

Christ, the appointed one

Cristo, the Savior God promised

the Christ who comes from God

If you do not indicate the meaning of Christ in the text, you may want to include a footnote to explain the meaning of Christ. Or you may want to explain the meaning in a glossary. For example:

The word/title "Christ" refers to the King and Savior whom God had promised to send.

If you use a descriptive phrase, be sure that it fits smoothly with the title "the Son of God" in the last part of the verse.

See also Christ in the Glossary.

the Son of God: The Bible uses the title Son of God to express the fact that Jesus has the same nature as God. The title also indicates that the relationship between God and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship of human fathers and sons. God does not have a physical body, and he did not create/produce Jesus the way a human father produces a son. Jesus existed eternally as the Son with his Father.

In areas where people do not understand the term Son of God in this way, you may wish to include a footnote. For example:

God is the Father of Jesus the Son in a different way than human males are fathers of their sons. The Bible uses the word Son to express the fact that Jesus has the same nature as God. It also indicates that the relationship between God and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship of human fathers and sons.

In languages where there is no single word for Son, many translators have used a more general expression, such as:

child of God

Other verses will usually make clear that Jesus was a male child. If you use a descriptive phrase such as "male child of God," be sure that this expression does not imply that God had another child who was female.

God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as God here refers to the eternal Spirit who created everything. He is more powerful than any other spirit, and he is perfectly good and wise. He deserves to be worshiped.

Here are some ways to translate God:

- Use a name or title for God that people in your culture already use.
- Use a descriptive term that fits the truth about God that is revealed in the Bible. For example:

Creator

Great Spirit

Ruler of the universe

Choose a term that is acceptable to the believers and churches in your area. For more detailed information, see God in the Glossary.

Mark 1:2

Section 1:1–8: God sent John the Baptizer to prepare the people to receive Jesus

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The preaching of John the Baptizer

John prepared people for Jesus to arrive

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 3:1–12; Luke 3:1–18; and John 1:19–28.

Paragraph 1:2–3

The quotes in 1:2–3 come from two books of the Old Testament. The quote in 1:3 is from Isaiah 40:3. The quote in 1:2 is from Malachi 3:1. Some parts of 1:2–3 may also be from Exodus 23:20. Mark mentioned only Isaiah. Consider whether it would be helpful to your readers to use footnotes to give the references for these Old Testament quotations.

1:2a

As it is written in Isaiah the prophet:

- ¶ In the book that Isaiah the prophet wrote long ago, God said to his Son, the Christ,
- ¶ Long ago, God said something to his Son, the Messiah, and he caused it to be written by Isaiah, who was one of his spokesmen. He said,

As: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *As* indicates the connection between 1:2a and 1:4: Just as Isaiah prophesied in 1:2–3, so John appeared in 1:4 and fulfilled that prophecy. Another way to show this connection is to indicate it only in 1:4. Many English versions that omit the word “as” in 1:2a follow this option. See the note on 1:4a.

it is written in Isaiah the prophet There is a textual issue in 1:2a: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have in Isaiah the prophet. For example, the RSV says: “As it is written in Isaiah the prophet” (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NJB, ESV, NET, NASB, REB, GW, NLT, CEV, JBP, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have in the prophets. For example, the KJV says: “As it is written in the prophets” (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The phrase *Isaiah the prophet* refers here to the book that Isaiah the prophet wrote. The manuscript evidence for the reading “in Isaiah the prophet” has both early and widespread support. The quote in 1:2 actually comes from Exodus 23:20 and Malachi 3:1 and only 1:3 comes from Isaiah. Because Isaiah was a major prophet in the Old Testament, and often quoted in the New, it is possible that Mark mentions Isaiah the prophet as representative of these quotes from the Old Testament. (Gundry page 35) Also, it must be noted that Mark was not writing for a Jewish but a Gentile audience, who would not be familiar with all the prophets mentioned in the Jewish Scriptures. This book is in the Old Testament. In this book Isaiah wrote the messages that God gave him to tell people. The first readers of Mark’s Gospel knew that Mark was quoting God’s message that Isaiah had written long before. If this information is not clear to your readers, you may need to make it explicit. For example:

Long ago, God caused the prophet Isaiah to write these words:

The prophet Isaiah wrote these words from God long ago. He said...

it is written: The phrase *it is written* is the usual way that authors of New Testament books introduced a quote from the Old Testament. You should be as consistent as possible in translating this phrase.

prophet: A prophet is a man who speaks on behalf of God. He tells people what God has revealed to him, and he also gives them messages from God.

Here are some ways to translate prophet:

a spokesman for God

a man who speaks God's words

God's message-speaker

When choosing a term for prophet, consider how you will translate other words which are similar in meaning such as "angel," "apostle," and "preacher."

While prophets did foretell the future, this was not their only function. Avoid using a word that focuses on telling the future.

See also prophet in the Glossary.

1:2b–c

I will send My messenger ahead of You, who will prepare Your Way: Here the pronoun I refers to God, and the pronoun You refers to the Christ. It is important to translate this quotation carefully so that readers will understand to whom the pronouns in 1:2b–c refer. In Malachi 3:1 the quotation can be translated as, "I am sending my messenger to prepare the way before me," and the quotation from Isaiah 40:3 can be translated as, "prepare the way of the LORD ." When these quotations are interpreted in relation to Mark 1:2, they indicate that the LORD himself was coming to earth in the person of the Messiah.

If this meaning will not be clear in your translation, you may need to make it explicit. For example, the GNT makes explicit that I refers to God. It has:

God said, "I will send..."

See the meaning lines for 1:2a in the Display for other ways to indicate who the pronouns refer to.

1:2b

"Behold, I will send My messenger ahead of You,

- "I will order my messenger to go before you,^(sing)
- "I have something to tell you.^(sing) I will send someone ahead of you^(sing) to announce my message

Behold: The word that the BSB translates as Behold indicates that the speaker will say something important or surprising, and he wants people to listen carefully to it.

This word is not easy to translate into English, so many English versions do not translate it (see the NIV). Consider whether you have a natural way in your language to translate this Greek word.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Look/Listen

Take note of this

I have something to tell you

I will send My messenger: In many cultures at that time, a king would choose a person to go as his messenger to tell people that he was coming. The messenger would tell the people to prepare for his coming. Here God indicated that he would send a messenger to tell people that the Christ was coming.

send: The Greek word that the BSB translates as send means to order someone to go somewhere for a particular purpose.

My messenger: In some languages it may be more natural to express the word messenger as a verb phrase. For example:

I will send someone ahead of you to make known my message/words.

ahead of You: The phrase that the BSB translates as ahead of You is literally "before your face." In this context the phrase may indicate either or both of the following options:

1. I will send my messenger before I send you.
2. I will send my messenger to go in front of you.

In some languages there may be a natural way to translate the clause so that both meanings are possible. If you must choose one of these meanings, choose option (a).

1:2c

who will prepare Your way."

- who will prepare people for your^(sing) coming/arrival.
- that people must prepare for you^(sing) to come. My messenger will be like a person who prepares a road for a king's coming.

prepare Your way: In this context the phrase prepare Your way is a metaphor. It is based on the custom of preparing roads before a king came. People repaired the roads so that the king could travel easily on them.

Here the metaphor indicates that God was sending someone to prepare people for the Christ by telling them to repent of their sins. (This metaphor is also used in Matthew 11:10, Mark 1:2–3, Luke 3:4–6, and Luke 7:27.)

In some languages people may not understand the meaning of the metaphor. They may wrongly think that it refers to repairing roads. If that is true in your language, consider one of these options:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

I will send my messenger ahead of you. He will prepare people for your coming, like a person who prepares the roads before a king comes.

- Translate the meaning of the metaphor directly. For example:

I will send my messenger ahead of you to tell people to prepare themselves for your coming.

way: The word that the BSB translates as way literally means “road,” “path,” or “highway.” Use a word that is appropriate for your area.

Mark 1:3

Section 1:1–8: God sent John the Baptizer to prepare the people to receive Jesus

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There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 3:1–12; Luke 3:1–18; and John 1:19–28.

Paragraph 1:2–3

The quotes in 1:2–3 come from two books of the Old Testament. The quote in 1:3 is from Isaiah 40:3. The quote in 1:2 is from Malachi 3:1. Some parts of 1:2–3 may also be from Exodus 23:20. Mark mentioned only Isaiah. Consider whether it would be helpful to your readers to use footnotes to give the references for these Old Testament quotations.

1:3a

“A voice of one calling in the wilderness,”

- His voice will be heard in the wilderness, shouting,
- He will be in the region with no inhabitants, and he will call out to those who come to hear him, saying,
- He will stay in remote areas and announce to people that

A voice of one calling in the wilderness: The words A voice of one calling in the wilderness refer to the messenger who was mentioned in 1:2c. The messenger would prepare the way for the Christ by shouting out God’s message in the wilderness. The messenger had not yet come at the time when Isaiah was writing. He was writing about what would happen in the future. So in many languages it will be necessary to use the future tense here in 1:3a, as well as in 1:2b–c. For example:

A voice of one will be calling in the wilderness

A voice of one calling: In this context the phrase A voice is a figure of speech. The voice represents the “messenger” whom God was sending. If it will not be clear that the voice and the “messenger” refer to the same person, you may need to make this explicit.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

He is a voice shouting (NLT)

He will call out...

The messenger’s voice will call out...

calling: The Greek word that the BSB translates as calling refers to shouting or speaking in a loud voice. Be sure that your translation does not imply that John was angry or insane. Use a term that describes speaking loudly so that people can hear the words clearly.

in the wilderness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wilderness refers to an area where few people live. Some versions translate this word as “desert,” but this does not necessarily refer to a dry, sandy desert. Some languages have a special word to refer to such areas, such as “the bush” (Africa) or “steppes” (Asia).

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

land with few people

place with no inhabitants

wild, open area

Because the wilderness was an area where few or no people lived, 1:3a may imply that John was calling out loudly with no one to listen. If so, you may need to make explicit that people went to listen to him. For example:

He will shout out to those who go to listen to him in the wilderness.

1:3b–c

This part of the verse is from the Old Testament. It consists of two lines of poetry that have similar meanings. These two lines also contain a quote within a quote. See the General Comment on 1:3b–c below for advice on these two issues.

1:3b

‘Prepare the way for the Lord,

- ‘Prepare^(plur) the way for the Lord’s coming,
- ‘Prepare yourselves for the Lord’s arrival,
- they must get ready for God the Lord to come.

Prepare the way: This phrase is a metaphor that has the same meaning as the similar phrase in 1:2c (see the note there). Both metaphors use the illustration of preparing a road for a king’s arrival. These metaphors indicate that people should prepare their minds and hearts for the coming of the Lord.

It is good to use similar words in translating both metaphors. However, if you made some details explicit in 1:2c, you may be able to translate more simply here.

Your translation should sound like natural speech for someone who is proclaiming a message to people.

the Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “master, one who has authority over others.” Here it refers to God. It is a translation of God’s personal name in Hebrew. In this context it indicates that God was coming to people as the Messiah.

Here are some other ways to translate Lord:

Master/Chief

Ruler

In some languages people may not naturally use a word that means “master” to refer to God. If speakers of your language do not understand that your word for “Lord” refers to God in this context, here are other ways to translate it:

- Use your word for God.
- Use your word for God and indicate that he is the Lord. For example:

God the Lord

Master God

If you include the word for God in your translation of Lord, you may want to include a footnote to give the literal Greek meaning. For example:

Here the Greek text is literally “Lord.”

See Lord, Context 2, in the Glossary.

1:3c

make straight paths for Him.”

- straighten^(plur) the paths that he will take.”
- so that his path will be straight.”
- They must fix the path on which he will travel.”

make straight paths for Him: The phrase make straight paths for Him is a metaphor. It refers to the same action as the metaphor in 1:3b. It explains how to prepare the way. People prepared a path by making the crooked places straight. The GNT translates this as:

make a straight path for him to travel (GNT)

General Comment on 1:3b–c

In 1:3b and 1:3c Mark referred to the same activity. In some languages you may need to make this clear in some way. For example:

Prepare the road/path for the Lord's coming by making it straight.

Clear and straighten the road that the Lord will take so that it will be ready for his coming.

In 1:3b–c Mark was quoting God, and God was saying the words that his messenger would shout to people. This is a quote within a quote. In some languages you may need to use an indirect quote for the words of the messenger. For example:

^{3a–c}He will shout in the wilderness, announcing to those who go to listen that they should prepare the road for the Lord's coming. They should make it straight and smooth.

Mark 1:4

Section 1:1–8: God sent John the Baptizer to prepare the people to receive Jesus

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The preaching of John the Baptizer

John prepared people for Jesus to arrive

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 3:1–12; Luke 3:1–18; and John 1:19–28.

Paragraph 1:4–8

This paragraph describes the fulfillment of Isaiah's prophecy in 1:2–3. It identifies John as “the messenger” and “the voice” that were mentioned in those verses. It also describes what John did and what he preached. In some languages you may want to divide 1:4–8 into two paragraphs: 1:4–5 and 1:6–8.

1:4a

John the Baptist appeared in the wilderness,

- ¶ So John the Baptizer appeared in the wilderness,
- ¶ Those words were fulfilled when John who baptized people began his work in the region where few people lived.

There is an implied connection between 1:4 and the prophecy in 1:2–3. John fulfilled this prophecy. He was the messenger whom Isaiah predicted. Try to indicate this connection in a natural way in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

So (GNT)

And so (NIV)

And those words were fulfilled, because

See the notes at the beginning of 1:2a for more discussion on this connection.

John the Baptist appeared: There is a textual issue with the Greek word that the BSB translates as Baptist:

1. Some Greek manuscripts indicate that this word is used as a title for John. These manuscripts have the definite article before the word “baptizing.” It means “John, the Baptizing [One].” For example:

John the Baptizer (GW)

John who baptized people (BSB, NIV11, RSV, NJB, NLT, CEV, NET, GW, NRSV, NASB, REB)

1. Some Greek manuscripts indicate that this word goes with came and describes John's actions. These manuscripts do not have the definite article before

“baptizing.” It means “John came, baptizing.” For example:

So John appeared...baptizing... (GNT) (NIV84, GNT, NCV, KJV, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It has the best manuscript and version support. However, if a major language Bible in your area follows option (2), you may choose to follow it. There is good evidence for both options, and the difference in meaning is slight.

Be careful that the title does not imply that John was a member of a Baptist Church. This may be a problem with a transliterated title like “John the Baptist.”

Here is another way to translate John the Baptist appeared :

John the Baptizer appeared

John the Baptist: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Baptist can also be translated as “baptizer.” It refers to a person who baptizes people. The verb “baptize” means to purify people with a special ritual that uses water. In some verses, the verbs “wash” and “clean” are used to translate the Greek verb “baptize.” Luke 11:38 says, “But the Pharisee was surprised to see that Jesus did not first wash before the meal.” (The Greek verb here is baptizo, but English versions translate it as “wash.” The context refers to a ritual washing, not merely a removal of dirt.). Mark 7:4 and Matthew 23:25 both speak of washing/cleaning cups and other utensils. The verb in Mark is baptizo while the verb in Matthew is katharizo (clean). Again, a ritual cleansing is involved. Mark 7:4 says, “And there are many other traditions for them to observe, including the washing of cups, pitchers, kettles, and couches for dining.” Matthew 23:25 says, “You clean (katharizo) the outside of the cup and dish.” However, the above references do not indicate that “wash/cleanse” is the only meaning of the rite of baptism as practiced by John and by the early Christians. And certainly Jesus’ baptism of people with the Holy Spirit signified more than purification. In this context the ritual involved purification from sin. It did not mean that the person was cleaned to remove dirt. Baptism was an initiation that marked the beginning of a person’s life as one of God’s pure people.

You will probably need to decide how to translate the verb “baptize” before you translate the title “John the Baptist.”

Here are some ways to translate “baptize”:

- Use a descriptive term. For example:

ritually wash

initiate people in/with water

immerse people in water for God

sprinkle/shower people with God’s initiation water

- Use a term for a similar ritual that is already used in your culture. You may need to indicate that in this context it has a special connection with God. For example:

purify people with God’s ceremonial bath

wash people in initiation water for God

- Use a term that is already accepted by the local churches. In some areas this term may have been borrowed from the national language or transliterated from Greek or English.

Churches use different ways to baptize people. Choose a term that is acceptable to the different churches in your area.

Here are some other ways to translate the title John the baptizer:

John who cleansed people for God

John the Ritual Purifier

John who initiated people with God’s washing

See baptize, Meaning 1, in the Glossary.

appeared: The Greek word that the BSB translates as appeared has more than one meaning. There are two ways to interpret it here:

1. It indicates that John came/appeared. For example:

John went to a place in the wilderness (EASY) (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, CEV, NRSV, NASB, REB, ESV)

1. It indicates that John lived/was in the wilderness. For example:

He lived in the wilderness. (NLT96) (NJB, NCV, GW, NLT96)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). John may have lived in the wilderness before this time. However, the focus here is that he began to preach publicly and that many people quickly heard about him. An idiom to describe this in English is “John appeared/came on the scene.”

In some languages a word that means “appeared” can imply a wrong meaning. It may imply that John was invisible and then he suddenly became visible or that John appeared to people in a vision. Be careful to avoid these wrong meanings.

in the wilderness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wilderness is the same word in 1:3a. See the note in 1:3a on wilderness.

1:4b preaching

- and he preached regularly. He told people
- He was proclaiming/telling the Lord’s message to those who came to hear him. He said,

Here in 1:4b John preached in an area where no people lived, but people came to listen to him. In 1:4a also, he was calling out his message in a place where few people lived, but people came from other places to listen to him. If you made this information explicit in 1:4a, consider whether you need to do so again here. See the note on “in the wilderness” at 1:3a. See also the General Comment on 1:4b–d for a suggestion about how to translate the content of John’s preaching.

preaching: The Greek word that the BSB translates as preaching means to publicly tell people something important. John was proclaiming God’s message to the crowds who came to listen. He did this often, and your translation should imply that.

Here are some other ways to translate preaching in this context:

announcing

proclaiming

telling people

In some languages it may be natural to start a new clause or sentence here. For example:

He was preaching to the people.

1:4c–d

a baptism of repentance for the forgiveness of sins: In this phrase there are four important nouns: baptism, repentance, forgiveness, and sins. In many languages you may need to translate some or all of these nouns as verbs. Then you may need to make other information explicit. For example:

[preaching that] people should be baptized to show that they were rejecting their sins so that God would forgive them.

In many languages it may also be more natural to use direct speech here. For example:

Allow me to baptize you to show that you are turning from your sins so that God will forgive you for the evil things that you have done.

See the General Comment on 1:4b–d for another example. See baptize, Meaning 1, in the Glossary.

1:4c

a baptism of repentance

- to be baptized to show that they were turning away from their sins,
- “You^(plur) must change your^(plur) sinful thinking and behavior and let me baptize you.^(plur)”

a baptism of repentance: The phrase a baptism of repentance means “a baptism that shows repentance.” Baptism was the way people could show that they had repented.

People repented and then were baptized. So in some languages it may be necessary to translate the actions in a different order. For example, the GNT has:

Turn away from your ^(plur) sins and be baptized.
(GNT)

In some languages it may be not be natural or even possible to use the passive verb “be baptized.” In those languages it may be possible to say:

Turn away from your ^(plur) sins and allow me to baptize you ^(plur).

Turn from your ^(plur) sins and receive/accept baptism.

baptism: The word baptism refers to a special ritual washing that purifies someone. In this context the

ritual implied purifying/cleansing from sin. It was an initiation that marked the beginning of that person's life as one of God's pure people.

You should translate baptism in a similar way as you translate "baptize." However, the form of the word or phrase may be different. For example, here are some ways to translate baptism with a descriptive term:

ritual washing

purification/initiation for God

entering the water

Be sure that the term you use is acceptable to the different churches in your area. See the note on 1:4a for more translation suggestions. Remember that in 1:4a the focus was on John as the one who baptized people, rather than on the people who were being baptized. You may need to modify your term for baptism to fit different contexts.

repentance: The Greek word that the BSB translates as repentance means "a change of a person's mind, heart, or will." In the Bible it refers specifically to a change of mind and heart about sin and about God. The person who repents is sorry for his past sins. He decides to stop sinning and to obey God.

Here are some other ways to translate repentance:

changing heart/mind

rejecting sin

In some languages, you may have an idiom for this type of change. For example:

turning from sin to God

leaving sin behind

In some languages it may be more natural to translate repentance here with a verb or verb phrase. For example:

Turn away from your sins (GNT)

Change your ^(plur) thinking/mind/heart

1:4d

for the forgiveness of sins.

- so that God would forgive them.
- If you^(plur) do that, God will forgive your^(plur) sins."

for the forgiveness of sins: The phrase for the forgiveness of sins indicates that the purpose of repenting and being baptized is to receive forgiveness. It also implies that the forgiveness is the result that people can expect from these actions. Louw and Nida (page 784) define *eis* here as "a marker of intent, often with the implication of expected result." UBS (page 12) also says that in this context the preposition may indicate "either purpose or result." Hiebert (page 32) speaks of forgiveness as being the spiritual result or end of baptism, and Taylor (page 154) describes baptism as an action that leads to forgiveness. In some languages it may be necessary to emphasize either purpose or result. For example:

Stop sinning and be baptized in order that God will pardon your sins.

Turn away from your ^(plur) sins and be baptized... and God will forgive your sins. (GNT)

Turn back to God and be baptized! Then your sins will be forgiven. (CEV)

forgiveness of sins: In this context the phrase forgiveness of sins means that God chooses not to punish a person for the evil things that he has done and thought. God cancels his guilt and treats him as though he had never offended.

Here are some other ways to translate forgiveness of sins:

canceling sins

release from sins

taking away of sins

In some languages it may be necessary to translate the noun forgiveness with a verb. Here are some ways to do this:

pardon sins

cancel sins

In many languages there may be an idiom for this. For example:

erase guilt

wiping away sins

In some languages it is more natural to say “forgive people,” rather than to “forgive sins.” For example:

forgive people for their sins

sins: The word sins refers to offenses against God. Sins include acts, thoughts, and attitudes that are not what God wants or approves. In Greek, the verb that English versions translate as sin is also a term that is used in archery to mean “miss the target”. When a person sins, he “misses” the target, that is, he fails to reach God’s standard. A person can also offend God by not doing what God wants him to do.

It is helpful to translate sins with a general term that can include any offense against God. Here are problems to avoid:

1. The term should not imply that only serious crimes like murder or stealing are sins. Other offenses like gossip and greed are also sins.
2. The term should not include accidents or mistakes that are not against God’s will.

Here are some ways to translate sins:

wrong acts

offenses against God

evil deeds

In some languages it may be natural to translate sins with a phrase that includes a verb. For example:

wrong things that you have done

General Comment on 1:4b–d

This part of the verse tells what John preached to the people. In some languages it may be more natural to use a direct quote. For example, the GNT says:

...preaching. “Turn away from your ^(plur) sins and be baptized,” he told the people, “and God will forgive your ^(plur) sins.”

Mark 1:5

Section 1:1–8: God sent John the Baptizer to prepare the people to receive Jesus

These notes have divided this section into three paragraphs:

1:1 serves as an introduction both to section 1:1–8 and to the book as a whole.

1:2–3 introduces John the Baptizer by quoting the Old Testament verses that predict his ministry.

1:4–8 describes John, his ministry and his message.

In some languages it may be more natural to make different paragraph breaks. For example:

- 1:1–3 and 1:4–8 (GNT, NCV)
- 1:1–8 (NRSV, REB, NAB, NJB)

Divide the paragraphs in a way that will fit the style of your language.

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a section heading for it. You will need to use terms in the heading that you have used in the verses within the section. For example, before you write a section heading for this section, you will need to know how you have translated the word “Baptizer.” See the note on 1:4a.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The preaching of John the Baptizer

John prepared people for Jesus to arrive

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 3:1–12; Luke 3:1–18; and John 1:19–28.

Paragraph 1:4–8

This paragraph describes the fulfillment of Isaiah’s prophecy in 1:2–3. It identifies John as “the messenger” and “the voice” that were mentioned in those verses. It also describes what John did and what he preached. In some languages you may want to divide 1:4–8 into two paragraphs: 1:4–5 and 1:6–8.

1:5a

People went out to him from all of Jerusalem and the countryside of Judea.

- All the people in Jerusalem and in the rest of Judea went to hear him preach.
- Many people who lived in the city of Jerusalem and in other parts of the area/region of Judea came/traveled to the wilderness to hear/see him.

went out: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as went out means that people left their homes in the city or countryside. They went to the place where John was. The verb also indicates that people went to listen to John many times, not just once.

Here are some other ways to say this in English:

were going out

kept going out

In some languages, it may be more natural to say here that people “came” to John rather than they “went.” Use the verb that is more natural in this context.

In some languages it may be necessary to specify a location or a purpose for going. For example:

traveled out into the wilderness to see and hear John (NLT96)

came/went to where he was

from all of Jerusalem and the countryside of Judea:

In this context the author used the word all to emphasize that many people from these areas went to hear John. It is a hyperbole. It does not mean that every person in Jerusalem and the countryside of Judea went to hear John.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

from Jerusalem and from all over Judea (NLT96)

from most of Jerusalem and the countryside of Judea

countryside of Judea: The phrase that the BSB translates as countryside of Judea refers to the region or land of Judea.

Jerusalem: Jerusalem was a city within Judea. If you use footnotes, you may want to add a footnote with information like the following:

Jerusalem was the capital city of Judea province/land.

1:5b

Confessing their sins, they were baptized by him in the Jordan River.

- When/As they confessed their sins, John baptized them in the Jordan River.
- They admitted that they had sinned, and John baptized them in the Jordan River.

Confessing their sins, they were baptized by him in the Jordan River:

The form of the word Confessing indicates that people confessed their sins before or during their baptism. You may translate it either way. For example:

They told how sorry they were for their sins, and he baptized them in the Jordan River. (CEV)

And when they confessed their sins, he baptized them in the Jordan River. (NLT)

As they confessed their sins, he baptized them in the Jordan River. (GW)

Confessing their sins: The word that the BSB translates as Confessing indicates that the people admitted that they had sinned. France (page 68) says there is no indication whether the confession was silent or aloud, but Hiebert (page 33), Lenski (page 36), UBS (page 17), TRT (page 5) and Louw and Nida (page 420) all say that this was a public acknowledgment of having sinned, though not necessarily a detailed list of specific sins. They may have confessed their sins in a general way without listing in detail all their specific sins. It is not clear whether they confessed to John or whether they confessed to God in the presence of John and the other people.

Here are some ways to translate this:

confessed/admitted their sins

acknowledged that they were sinners

said that they had sinned

sins: See the note in 1:4d.

they were baptized by him in the Jordan River: This clause is passive. In some languages it may be more natural to make it active. Be sure to use an appropriate form of your term for “baptize.” For example:

John baptized them in the Jordan river

John ceremonially cleansed them for God in the Jordan river

Mark 1:6

Section 1:1–8: God sent John the Baptizer to prepare the people to receive Jesus

These notes have divided this section into three paragraphs:

1:1 serves as an introduction both to section 1:1–8 and to the book as a whole.

1:2–3 introduces John the Baptizer by quoting the Old Testament verses that predict his ministry.

1:4–8 describes John, his ministry and his message.

In some languages it may be more natural to make different paragraph breaks. For example:

- 1:1–3 and 1:4–8 (GNT, NCV)
- 1:1–8 (NRSV, REB, NAB, NJB)

Divide the paragraphs in a way that will fit the style of your language.

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a section heading for it. You will need to use terms in the heading that you have used in the verses within the section. For example, before you write a section heading for this section, you will need to know how you have translated the word “Baptizer.” See the note on 1:4a.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The preaching of John the Baptizer

John prepared people for Jesus to arrive

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 3:1–12; Luke 3:1–18; and John 1:19–28.

Paragraph 1:4–8

This paragraph describes the fulfillment of Isaiah’s prophecy in 1:2–3. It identifies John as “the messenger” and “the voice” that were mentioned in those verses. It also describes what John did and what he preached. In some languages you may want to divide 1:4–8 into two paragraphs: 1:4–5 and 1:6–8.

1:6a

John was clothed in camel’s hair,

- John wore clothes that were woven from camel’s hair,
- John dressed like a prophet in a simple/rough robe

John was clothed in camel’s hair: John probably wore a long, loose robe made with a rough kind of cloth that was woven from the hair of a camel. It was not made from camel skin with the hair still on it. Clothing made from camel’s hair was commonly worn by poor people and by prophets.

In some languages, it may sound like John had expensive fur clothes. If that is true in your language, it may be necessary to add a word such as “only” or “simple” to indicate that John did not wear fancy clothes. For example:

John’s clothes were only made from woven camel hair

John wore a simple robe made from woven camel hair

John was dressed in a rough coat of camel’s hair (REB)

See the General Comment on 1:6a–b at the end of the notes for 1:6b for another suggestion.

was clothed in camel’s hair: The phrase was clothed in camel’s hair is passive. In some languages it may be more natural to use an active phrase. For example, the CSB says:

wore a camel-hair garment (CSB)

camel: If a camel is an unknown animal in your language, consider using one of the following options:

- Use a loan word plus a general term. For example:

an animal called camel

- Use a general word such as “animal.” For example:

clothes made of animal hair

- Omit the reference to an animal or camel and just translate the significance of this kind of clothing. For example:

simple clothes/robe like a prophet

Avoid using a phrase that describes the appearance or usefulness of a camel. That may distract your readers from the actual significance of the clothing.

1:6b**with a leather belt around his waist.**

- and his belt was made from animal skin.
- and had a strip/piece of animal skin tied around his waist.

with a leather belt around his waist: This belt was probably a piece of animal skin that John tied around his robe at the waist. It was not like the leather belts that can be bought in a store.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

strip of rawhide

belt made of animal skin

In some languages the word belt may already imply that it is worn around the waist. In such languages, you may not need to translate the words “around the waist” explicitly.

General Comment on 1:6a–b

It may be helpful to include a footnote with information about the clothes and belt in 1:6a–b. For example:

This kind of clothing/robe was worn by poor people and by prophets. The prophet Elijah also wore a leather belt (2 Kings 1:8).

1:6c**His food was locusts and wild honey.**

- His food was locusts and honey that was made by wild bees.
- He ate locusts and honey that he found in the wilderness.

In Greek this sentence begins with a common conjunction that is often translated as “and” (see the NIV). This conjunction connects 1:6c to 1:6a–b. 1:6a–b describes John’s clothing and 1:6c describes John’s food. Connect these facts in a natural way in your language.

His food was locusts and wild honey: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as His food was indicates that John ate locusts and wild honey as his regular food. In some languages, a word like food is not used with things such as honey. If your language is like this, you will need to use a different word that fits with the word “honey.” For example:

His food was locusts and his drink was wild honey.

locusts: The word locusts refers to insects that resemble very large grasshoppers. If you have a word for “locust” or “grasshopper,” be sure that it refers to a type that people can eat. If locusts or grasshoppers are not known in the language area, you may use one of the following options:

- Use a general term plus a loan word. For example:

insects called locusts

- Use a general term. For example:

insects/bugs

- Use a phrase that describes the significance of this kind of food. For example:

simple food that he could find in the wilderness
If you use this option, the description will include “wild honey.” You may want to add a footnote to describe both foods.

It may be helpful to include a footnote that explains the significance of these foods. For example:

In Palestine, people who wandered from place to place with their flocks often ate locusts and wild honey. People who lived in cities or towns did not usually eat these kinds of food.

wild honey: The words wild honey refer to honey that wild bees make. It contrasts with honey that people get by keeping bees to produce honey for them. If people do not keep bees in your culture, the word “wild” may not be necessary. Use a natural expression in your language. For example:

water of wild-bees

honey that he found

Mark 1:7**Section 1:1–8: God sent John the Baptizer to prepare the people to receive Jesus**

These notes have divided this section into three paragraphs:

1:1 serves as an introduction both to section 1:1–8 and to the book as a whole.

1:2-3 introduces John the Baptizer by quoting the Old Testament verses that predict his ministry.

1:4-8 describes John, his ministry and his message.

In some languages it may be more natural to make different paragraph breaks. For example:

- 1:1-3 and 1:4-8 (GNT, NCV)
- 1:1-8 (NRSV, REB, NAB, NJB)

Divide the paragraphs in a way that will fit the style of your language.

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a section heading for it. You will need to use terms in the heading that you have used in the verses within the section. For example, before you write a section heading for this section, you will need to know how you have translated the word “Baptizer.” See the note on 1:4a.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The preaching of John the Baptizer

John prepared people for Jesus to arrive

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 3:1-12; Luke 3:1-18; and John 1:19-28.

Paragraph 1:4-8

This paragraph describes the fulfillment of Isaiah’s prophecy in 1:2-3. It identifies John as “the messenger” and “the voice” that were mentioned in those verses. It also describes what John did and what he preached. In some languages you may want to divide 1:4-8 into two paragraphs: 1:4-5 and 1:6-8.

1:7a

And he began to proclaim:

- As John preached, he told the people,
- When John proclaimed his message to the people, he said,

And: The word And here connects what John wore and ate to what John did and said. As with 1:6c, use a natural way in your language to connect this verse to the preceding verse. Many English versions start this verse with a separate sentence. For example:

He announced (GW)

This is what John preached to the people (NCV)

he began to proclaim: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as he began to proclaim is literally “he was proclaiming/preaching, saying....” The word “proclaiming/preaching” is from the same Greek verb as “preaching” in 1:4b. See the note there.

This clause introduces a summary of what John preached regularly. But 1:4 indicates that he also preached about repentance and baptism. It is good to express 1:7a so that it does not imply that John’s message was only the words 1:7b-c. For example:

In the course of his preaching he said (NJB)

John also told the people (CEV)

1:7b

“After me will come One more powerful than I,

- “A man who is greater than I am will come after me.
- “Another person with more authority than I have will soon arrive.

After me will come: The phrase After me means “later than me [in time].” John’s work had already started. Jesus would begin his work soon afterwards. The Greek verb form that the BSB translates as will come is more literally “is coming.” It indicates that Jesus was coming very soon. He was about to begin his work while John was still alive.

In some languages, a literal translation of After me may imply that Jesus did not come until after John died. If that is true in your language, you should translate in a different way. For example:

Someone is coming soon who is far greater than I am (NLT96)

I have already started my work. Very soon someone else will arrive/come...

One more powerful than I: The Greek word that the BSB translates as powerful here refers to greatness. The Christ was greater or more important than John. John was not saying that the Christ was physically stronger than he was.

1:7c

the straps of whose sandals I am not worthy to stoop down and untie.

- I am not worthy even to kneel before him and untie his sandals.

- Because of his greatness, I am too lowly even to serve as his slave and remove his sandals for him.

the straps of whose sandals I am not worthy to stoop down and untie: In Jewish culture, only a slave would untie someone's sandals. John mentioned this action to indicate that Jesus was very important. Jesus was of such great status that John did not feel worthy even to serve as Jesus' slave. If the meaning of this action is not clear to your readers, here are some options to consider:

- Mention the action and indicate the symbolic meaning. For example:

I feel inadequate to even serve him like a slave by stooping and loosening the ties of his sandals.

- Omit the action and translate only its meaning. For example, the NLT96 says:

I am not even worthy to be his slave. (NLT96)

If you use a word like "slave," be sure that your translation does not imply that Jesus owned slaves.

straps...sandals...untie: In some areas sandals are not used. In other areas, sandals do not need to be untied. If that is true in your area, you may use a more general word, such as shoes. It may also be more natural to focus on removing the shoes, since that was the purpose for untying the straps. For example:

I am not even qualified to bend down to take off his shoes.

Because of his greatness, I would be ashamed to even remove his shoes.

straps of whose sandals: The word sandals means a type of shoe. The sandals that people wore at that time were usually made from a piece of leather that formed the bottom of a shoe. People tied leather straps onto this piece of leather and then wrapped them around the foot and lower legs.

worthy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as worthy means "qualified" or "adequate" to do something. John felt that he was not important enough to act as Jesus' slave. He felt he did not deserve the honor of serving him. He was emphasizing how great Jesus was.

In this context the focus of worthy is on John's status, not his character. Do not imply that John was a bad

or evil person. Also do not imply that John was not physically able to do this task.

stoop down: The words stoop down describe what someone must do in order to untie another person's sandals. It implies that it is a humble or lowly thing to do.

The NCV has another way to translate this phrase:

kneel down

In some languages, it may seem redundant to mention this action, because it is already implied in untying someone's sandals. If this is true in your language, it may be necessary to emphasize the humbling nature of the action in a different way.

Mark 1:8

Section 1:1–8: God sent John the Baptizer to prepare the people to receive Jesus

These notes have divided this section into three paragraphs:

1:1 serves as an introduction both to section 1:1–8 and to the book as a whole.

1:2–3 introduces John the Baptizer by quoting the Old Testament verses that predict his ministry.

1:4–8 describes John, his ministry and his message.

In some languages it may be more natural to make different paragraph breaks. For example:

- 1:1–3 and 1:4–8 (GNT, NCV)
- 1:1–8 (NRSV, REB, NAB, NJB)

Divide the paragraphs in a way that will fit the style of your language.

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a section heading for it. You will need to use terms in the heading that you have used in the verses within the section. For example, before you write a section heading for this section, you will need to know how you have translated the word "Baptizer." See the note on 1:4a.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The preaching of John the Baptizer

John prepared people for Jesus to arrive

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 3:1–12; Luke 3:1–18; and John 1:19–28.

Paragraph 1:4–8

This paragraph describes the fulfillment of Isaiah's prophecy in 1:2–3. It identifies John as “the messenger” and “the voice” that were mentioned in those verses. It also describes what John did and what he preached. In some languages you may want to divide 1:4–8 into two paragraphs: 1:4–5 and 1:6–8.

1:8

I baptize you with water, but He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit: In Greek the pronouns I and He are emphatic, indicating a strong contrast between John and Jesus. Some languages may have emphatic pronouns or put the pronouns in an introductory phrase. For example:

As for me, I baptize you with water, but as for him, he will baptize you with the Holy Spirit

Use a natural way in your language to express this kind of contrast.

1:8a

I baptize you with water,

- As for me, I baptize you^(plur) with water,
- I use only water to purify/initiate you,

I baptize: There are two ways to interpret the past tense form of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as baptize here:

1. It refers to ongoing, habitual action. It indicates that John baptized people often. For example, the GNT has:

I baptize you with water (GNT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NCV, NLT, CEV, NET)

1. It refers to past action. It indicates that John had already baptized people. For example, the GW has:

I have baptized you with water (GW) (GW, NRSV, REB, NJB, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). 1:7a indicates that John said this repeatedly, and he was still baptizing people when he said it. Also, the parallel passages in both Matthew and Luke use the present tense.

baptize: The word that the BSB translates as baptize refers here to using water in a ceremony of purification. The ceremony shows that a person was being pu-

rified/cleansed from sin and was committed to being one of God's true people. This purification and identification with God's people is based on repentance. For more information on how to translate baptize, see the note on “baptizer” in 1:4a. See also baptize, Meaning 1, in the Glossary.

you: John used the word you to refer to anyone whom he baptized. This included those who were listening to him on that day, and those whom he had baptized on previous days. So in some languages it may be more natural to translate the pronoun you more generally. For example:

I baptize people with water

I baptize with water

with water: The phrase with water means “using water” or “by means of water.” When John baptized people, he used the water of the Jordan River.

1:8b

but He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit.”

- but as for him, he will baptize you^(plur) with the Holy Spirit.”
- but he will purify/initiate you by means of God's Holy Spirit.”

but He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit: The clause but He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit contrasts with 1:8a. In 1:8a John said that when he baptized people, he used water. Here in 1:8b he indicates that Jesus will use the Holy Spirit to baptize people. This fact implies that the Holy Spirit baptizes (that is, purifies and initiates) people in a more powerful way.

If possible, use the same term for baptize in the phrases “baptize you with water” and baptize you with the Holy Spirit in order to express the contrast. For example:

As for me, I only clean/initiate you with water.
But as for him, he will clean/initiate you with the Holy Spirit.

As for me, I put you in water, but as for him, he will put the Holy Spirit in your hearts/minds.

If your term for baptize includes the word “water,” you may need to use a different term to translate baptize... with the Holy Spirit. If that is true in your language, consider how to express the contrast between John's

baptism and Christ's baptism in another way. For example:

I give you only a baptism-in-water; as for him, he will purify you with the Holy Spirit.

with the Holy Spirit: The phrase with the Holy Spirit means "using the Holy Spirit" or "by means of the Holy Spirit." Jesus, the one who was coming, would use the Holy Spirit to baptize people.

Holy Spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Holy Spirit refers to the Spirit of God. The Holy Spirit is God, together with God the Father and God the Son. The Holy Spirit is Spirit in the sense that he is a living being who does not have a physical body. He is Holy in the sense that he is God and is pure and sinless.

Here are some other ways to translate Holy Spirit:

Spirit/Breath of/from God

Holy/Sacred Spirit

Do not imply that the Holy Spirit is like the ghost of a dead person or that God has died.

Mark 1:9

Section 1:9–11: John baptized Jesus

The previous section described how John the Baptizer prepared people for the coming of Jesus. The present section forms a transition from the work of John to the work of Jesus. Jesus came to John to be baptized. After John baptized Jesus, God's Spirit descended on Jesus in the form of a dove, and God spoke to him from heaven. These were signs that Jesus was the Messiah whom God had sent.

You will probably want to translate this section before you decide on a section heading. Here is another example of a heading for this section:

The baptism of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 3:13–17; Luke 3:21–22.

1:9a

In those days Jesus came from Nazareth in Galilee

- ¶ During that time, Jesus came/arrived from Nazareth in the region of Galilee,

- ¶ During those days when John was baptizing, Jesus traveled from the town of Nazareth, located in the province of Galilee.

In those days: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as In those days is literally "And it happened in those days." This phrase introduces the event that follows. It refers to the time when John was preaching to people and baptizing them. While John was doing these things, Jesus arrived at the place where John was.

Most English versions do not translate the phrase "And it happened," because it is not natural in English. Consider how your language introduces the next major part of a story. Translate in a way that is natural for your language.

Jesus came: Languages differ in the way they use words like "come" and "go." In some languages it may be more natural to say "went" or "traveled" instead of came.

In some languages it may also be natural to make explicit that Jesus "arrived" at that location. It may be necessary to specify that he came to John or to where John was baptizing. This implicit information may fit in either 1:9a or 1:9b. For example:

During those days, Jesus traveled from Nazareth in Galilee and arrived in the wilderness where John was baptizing.

from Nazareth in Galilee: Nazareth was a town with about two thousand people. Galilee was an area in the northern part of the country of Israel. In some languages it may be helpful to indicate some of this information. For example:

from Nazareth in the province of Galilee (GNT)

from Nazareth town in the region of Galilee

from Nazareth in the district of Galilee

It may also be helpful to include a footnote with more information. For example:

Nazareth was a town in the province/region of Galilee where Jesus and his parents lived. Jesus grew up there but later lived in Capernaum. About 2000 people lived in Nazareth.

1:9b**and was baptized by John in the Jordan.**

- and then John baptized Jesus/him in the Jordan River.
- When he arrived at the place where John was preaching, John baptized him in the Jordan River.

was baptized by John: The phrase was baptized by John is passive. In some languages it may be more natural to use an active phrase. For example, the CEV says:

John baptized him in the Jordan River. (CEV)

baptized: See the notes on 1:4a and 1:8a for ways to translate baptized.

in the Jordan: The Jordan refers to the Jordan River. In some languages you may need to make this explicit. For example:

in the river Jordan

Mark 1:10**Section 1:9–11: John baptized Jesus**

The previous section described how John the Baptizer prepared people for the coming of Jesus. The present section forms a transition from the work of John to the work of Jesus. Jesus came to John to be baptized. After John baptized Jesus, God's Spirit descended on Jesus in the form of a dove, and God spoke to him from heaven. These were signs that Jesus was the Messiah whom God had sent.

You will probably want to translate this section before you decide on a section heading. Here is another example of a heading for this section:

The baptism of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 3:13–17; Luke 3:21–22.

1:10

As soon as Jesus came up out of the water, He saw...: In Greek, this verse literally says: "And immediately coming up out of the water he saw..." The phrase "and immediately" here introduces an important new event in the story. It also indicates that this event will be surprising or unexpected and that it occurred as soon as Jesus had been baptized. Levinsohn 2003, Ellingsworth and France (page 76) agree that the phrase *kai euthus* ("and immediately") indicates a new, significant or dramatic development within

a story. Ellingsworth also comments that the new event may be surprising. In this context the event is clearly surprising and unexpected. France (page 76) further comments that the phrase "and immediately" connects the new event closely to Jesus' baptism, and translations such as "as soon as..." communicate this in English.

Some English versions do not explicitly translate this expression. Others use an expression like "just as." If your language has a way to indicate that an event is surprising and important in the story, you should use it here. For example:

As Jesus was leaving the water, this is what happened: he saw...

1:10a**As soon as Jesus came up out of the water,**

- While Jesus was coming up from the water,
- Then, suddenly while Jesus was going up onto the land,
- As Jesus was stepping onto the river bank, an amazing thing happened.

As soon as Jesus came up out of the water: Jesus had stepped down into the river in order to be baptized. The phrase came up out of the water indicates that he returned to the edge of the river and stepped onto dry land. Use a natural expression in your language to describe the action of stepping up out of a river onto the land.

1:10b**He saw the heavens breaking open**

- he saw the sky/heaven being split apart/open;
- He saw the sky splitting open

He saw the heavens breaking open: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as breaking open means "split apart, divided." Most scholars interpret this as a passive verb. The Greek verb is ambiguous. It can also be understood as a middle participle ("tear open"), which is what the BSB does. Renderings such as "open" (NCV, CEV), "split open" (GW, NLT), and "opening" (GNT) may reflect this understanding. The context implies that the actor is God, but the focus here is on the action, not the actor. Jesus saw the sky being torn open, but the text does not say that he saw God tearing the sky.

In some languages it may be natural to use a passive verb in this context, as the Greek does. For example:

he saw heaven being torn open (NIV)

The text does not mean that Jesus saw heaven being destroyed, or that God was destroying heaven. If a literal translation would give that wrong meaning, use a different expression. For example:

he saw the sky opening up

If you do this, consider using a footnote to help readers understand the connection between this verse and 15:38. Here is a suggested footnote:

The Greek says literally: “being torn open.” These are the same words that are used in 15:38 when the curtain of the Temple was torn open.

He: Most scholars agree that He refers to Jesus, not John. Although John also saw this event (see John 1:32–33), the focus here is entirely on Jesus.

the heavens: The Greek word that the BSB translates as heavens is also used in 1:11a. It can have two different meanings, depending on the context:

1. the heavens, the place where God lives,
2. the sky.

In the New Testament, God often showed supernatural signs from the sky, such as a voice, fire, or bright light. In this verse either “heavens” or “sky” would fit the context. The Holy Spirit came down like a dove and God’s voice came from heaven or from the sky. Here are some points to consider:

- If your language has a term that can mean either “heaven” or “sky,” use it in both 1:10b and 1:11a.
- If it is difficult to speak about heaven (God’s home) being torn open, you may use “the sky” in 1:10b and “heaven” in 1:11a.
- In languages that do not have a single word for heavens, you may need to use a descriptive phrase:

the place of God

the place where God lives

1:10c

and the Spirit descending on Him like a dove.

- and then he saw the Holy Spirit gliding down and landing on him like a dove/pigeon.
- and the Holy Spirit like a small bird coming down to land on him.

and: The word and introduces the other thing that Jesus saw. He saw the sky being torn open, and he also saw the Spirit descending.

the Spirit: The phrase the Spirit refers to the Holy Spirit. To avoid confusion, you should probably use the same term as you used for “Holy Spirit” in 1:8b. See the note there. Several English versions also have “Holy Spirit.”

descending on Him like a dove: The Holy Spirit came down on Jesus like a dove. There are two ways to interpret the phrase like a dove in this context:

1. It refers to the appearance of the Holy Spirit. He looked like a dove. For example:

and the Holy Spirit coming down on him with the form/appearance of a dove

1. It refers to the way that the Spirit descended. He flew gently down like a dove. For example:

and the Spirit descending on him like a dove gently descends

In this context the Greek text and almost all English versions are ambiguous on the issue. For this reason, it is good to use an expression that can imply either interpretation. However, if you must choose between these interpretations, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The parallel verse in Luke 3:22 specifies that the Holy Spirit had the bodily form of a dove.

on Him: Many scholars and almost all English versions understand this phrase to mean that the Holy Spirit came down and landed on Jesus. The preposition used here is eis, which usually means “into” or “to.” The preposition epi “upon” is used in the parallels in Matthew 3:16 and Luke 3:22. Some scholars understand this verse to mean that the Holy Spirit descended and entered “into” Jesus to empower him for his ministry. However, other scholars and almost all versions understand that the Holy Spirit came down and landed “on” Jesus. The GW and CEV have “to him,” which seems closer to “on” than “into.” Since all the major versions have “on,” these differences of interpretation have not been discussed in the Notes. Consider how people would describe a bird flying down and landing on someone in your language. The text does not specify exactly whether the dove landed on Jesus’ head or on another part of his body. If possible, you should avoid being specific about where the dove landed.

dove: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as dove refers to several different species of birds. In English, these birds are sometimes called “doves” and sometimes called “pigeons.” The dove described in this passage is probably similar to a common pigeon today.¹¹⁰ In *Animals in the Bible* (UBS), “Dove, Pigeon”, it is suggested that the most common bird in the dove-pigeon family in the Middle East today is the Asiatic Rock Dove (also called the Rock Pigeon or Common Pigeon), *Columba livia*, and would be the most likely identification for yonah in Hebrew and peristera in Greek. Doves/pigeons are medium-sized birds (30–36 centimeters long). They are usually gray or blue-gray with more color on their necks. They are found all around the world.

For Jews, doves were a symbol of something that is gentle and peaceful. Doves/pigeons that we know today are often not gentle. They can be aggressive and attack other birds. It is important to consider this here where the Holy Spirit is described like a dove.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- If your readers know doves/pigeons, and they are considered good birds, you should use your word for a dove/pigeon.
- If doves/pigeons are unknown, or if they are considered bad, you may want to use the general word for “bird.”

Mark 1:11

Section 1:9–11: John baptized Jesus

The previous section described how John the Baptizer prepared people for the coming of Jesus. The present section forms a transition from the work of John to the work of Jesus. Jesus came to John to be baptized. After John baptized Jesus, God’s Spirit descended on Jesus in the form of a dove, and God spoke to him from heaven. These were signs that Jesus was the Messiah whom God had sent.

You will probably want to translate this section before you decide on a section heading. Here is another example of a heading for this section:

The baptism of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 3:13–17; Luke 3:21–22.

1:11a

And a voice came from heaven:

- The voice of God from heaven said,
- Then God spoke from heaven and said to Jesus,

a voice came from heaven: The word voice is used figuratively here. It refers to the person who spoke in heaven. In this context, the voice was the voice of God. God spoke from heaven. The words in 1:11b are what God said to Jesus.

If it is not clear or natural to say a voice came from heaven in your language, here are some other ways to translate this clause:

a voice spoke from heaven

they heard a voice speaking from heaven

God spoke from heaven and said to Jesus...

heaven: Here the word heaven refers to the place where God lives. In some languages, you may need to use a different word than the word you used for “heaven” in 1:10b.

1:11b

“You are My beloved Son; in You I am well pleased.”

- “You^(sing) are my Son. I love you,^(sing) and I am very pleased/happy with you.^(sing)”
- “You^(sing) are my Son whom I love. You^(sing) cause/give me great joy.”

You are My beloved Son: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as You are My beloved Son is literally “You are my son the loved-one.” The words “the loved-one” indicate that Jesus was God the Father’s dear Son. Be sure that it is clear in your translation that the word You refers to Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

You are my Son, the Beloved (NJB)

You are my own dear Son. (GNT)

You are my Son. I love you.

Son: The Bible uses the title Son to express the fact that Jesus has the same nature as God. The title also indicates that the relationship between God and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship of human fathers and sons. God does not have a physical body, and he did not create/produce Jesus in the way that a human father produces a son. Jesus existed eternally as the Son with his Father.

Even though this use of the word Son may be difficult for your readers to understand, it is important to use this title. You may wish to include a footnote in your translation about this title. See the note on “Son of God” in 1:1.

in You I am well pleased: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in You I am well pleased means, “I am delighted with you” or “I am very pleased/satisfied with you.” Jesus caused God to feel pleasure and delight. A translation should not imply sexual pleasure.

Here are some other ways to express this meaning:

You make me very happy/pleased.

I have delight in you.

Mark 1:12

Section 1:12–13: Jesus refused Satan’s temptations

In this section Satan tried to persuade Jesus to sin, but Jesus refused to do what Satan wanted. It is good to translate this section before you decide on a section heading.

Here are some other options for this section heading:

The temptation of Jesus

Satan tempts Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 4:1–11 and Luke 4:1–13.

1:12

At once the Spirit drove Jesus into the wilderness,

- ¶ Then the Holy Spirit sent Jesus into another part of the wilderness.
- ¶ Right after Jesus had been baptized, the Holy Spirit compelled/caused Jesus to go farther into the region where no one lived.

At once: The phrase that the BSB translates as At once is literally “And immediately.” It indicates that this event is the next thing that happened to Jesus. It also indicates that this event is an important new event in the story. See the note in 1:10a on the phrase “As soon as...”

The phrase At once here does not imply that the Holy Spirit hurried to send Jesus out into the wilderness. It also does not imply that the Holy Spirit sent Jesus into the wilderness at the exact time that God finished speaking in 1:11.

the Spirit: The phrase the Spirit refers to the Holy Spirit. It is recommended that you use the same term here as you used in 1:10c and 1:8b. See the notes there.

drove Jesus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as drove can be used in many ways. It is often used of expelling demons, but in other verses it means to send out or lead out of a place.

Here are some other ways that English versions translate it in this context:

drove him out (NRSV)

compelled (NLT)

made him/Jesus go (GNT, CEV)

sent/sent out (NCV, NIV)

It is good to use an expression that implies some compulsion or forcefulness but not too much. Do not imply that the Holy Spirit treated Jesus cruelly or that Jesus resisted the Holy Spirit and had to be forced to go.

into the wilderness: The word wilderness refers to a wild, desolate area where few people lived. This word was also used in 1:3a. You should translate it the same way here.

Jesus and John were already in the wilderness. So this verse must mean that the Holy Spirit sent him to a different place in the wilderness. See the Display on 1:12 for two ways to indicate this.

Mark 1:13

Section 1:12–13: Jesus refused Satan’s temptations

In this section Satan tried to persuade Jesus to sin, but Jesus refused to do what Satan wanted. It is good to translate this section before you decide on a section heading.

Here are some other options for this section heading:

The temptation of Jesus

Satan tempts Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 4:1–11 and Luke 4:1–13.

1:13a**and He was there for forty days, being tempted by Satan.**

- He was in the wilderness for forty days, and Satan tempted him there.
- He was there forty days, during which time Satan tried to cause/persuade him to sin.

and He was there for forty days, being tempted by Satan: The phrase for forty days indicates the time period during which Jesus was tempted by Satan.

The verb being tempted is passive. In some languages it may be natural to use an active verb. For example:

He stayed there for forty days while Satan tempted him.

tempted: The Greek word that the BSB translates as tempted has more than one meaning. Scholars differ about what it means in this context:

1. It means “to try to cause someone to sin,” that is, “to entice/encourage someone to do what is wrong.” For example, the NIV says:

being tempted by Satan (NIV11) (BSB, NIV, RSV, GNT, REB, NASB, GW, NLT, NCV, NET, ESV)

1. It means “to test.” For example, the CEV says:

while Satan tested him (CEV) (CEV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most English versions and scholars.

In some languages, a statement such as “Satan tempted Jesus” implies that Jesus yielded to the temptation. If that is true in your language, you may need to make clear that Satan only tried to cause Jesus to sin. For example:

Satan tried to tempt him.

Satan: The word Satan is the Hebrew name of the chief or leader of all the evil spirits. In Hebrew his name means “enemy.” He is the enemy of God and God’s people. Here are some ways to translate Satan:

- Use a local name or idiom that refers to the chief of all demons.
- Use a descriptive phrase such as:

the chief/leader of the evil spirits

the spirit enemy of God

- Transliterate the name Satan. If this word is not already known in your area, you may also want to add a descriptive phrase. For example:

Satanas, the ruler of demons

Shaitan If you transliterate Satan or borrow a word from another language, be sure that it communicates the biblical meaning to people in your culture. It is important to check this in each biblical context.

Try to use a term that will be acceptable to churches in the area. It is suggested that you also add a footnote or glossary entry that further explains who Satan is. For example:

Satan is the leader of all the evil spirits or demons. Once he was an angel in heaven, but he rebelled against God. God expelled him from heaven, and now he tempts people on earth. Here are other names for Satan that are used in the Bible: “Beelzebul,” “the Devil,” “the Evil One,” “the Enemy,” and “the Tempter.”

1:13b**He was with the wild animals,**

- Only wild animals lived in that place.
- The area where he/Jesus was staying was far from any other people. Only wild animals lived there.

He was with the wild animals: The phrase He was with the wild animals implies that no other people lived in this place where Jesus had gone. Jesus was in a desolate, uninhabited area where only wild animals lived.

He: The pronoun He refers to Jesus. In some languages it may be necessary to make it explicit that He refers to Jesus rather than to Satan.

1:13c**and the angels ministered to Him.**

- And angels came to that place and were taking care of him.
- But there were angels who came and helped him.

This part of the verse tells another fact about the time when Jesus was in the wilderness. Angels were helping him. This help contrasted with the difficulties that Mark mentioned in 1:13a–b, so the GNT uses a connector that shows contrast:

Wild animals were there also, but angels came and helped him. (GNT)

However, your translation should not imply that wild beasts would have harmed Jesus if the angels had not helped him. Connect this part of the verse to the context in a natural way in your language.

the angels ministered to Him: This is the first time that angels are mentioned in the book of Mark. In some languages, it may be necessary to introduce them in some way before saying that they attended Jesus. For example:

and there were angels who took care of him

and some angels came and gave him what he needed

the angels: The Greek word that the BSB translates as angels means “messengers.” It refers here to spirit beings who serve God. Sometimes God sends an angel to give a message to human beings. He also sends angels to serve him in other ways. Some ways to translate this term are:

- Use a descriptive word or phrase. For example:

messengers from God/heaven

good/holy spirit-beings

- Use a local term that fits the biblical meaning.
- In some areas the churches may already be using a borrowed term or a transliterated word for “angel.” If you use this term, be sure that it fits the biblical meaning. If some people do not understand the right meaning from it, you may need to indicate the meaning in some way. For example:

an angelos messenger from God

a sacred angelos spirit

Be sure that your term for “angel” is different from your terms for “prophet” and “apostle.” See angel, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for a chart that shows the differences in these three terms.

ministered to Him: In this context, the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as ministered to Him means “served him.” It indicates that angels helped him in various ways.

According to Matthew 4:11, the angels came after Satan had finished tempting Jesus. However, the verb form here in Mark indicates that the angels helped Jesus over a period of time or perhaps at various times. Your translation should have that meaning.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

took care of him (NLT)

helped him (GNT)

Mark 1:14

Section 1:14–15: Jesus began to preach to people

In this section Mark told how Jesus began to preach in Galilee after Satan tempted Jesus in the wilderness.

It is good to translate the section before you decide what heading to use for it. Here is another idea for this section heading:

The beginning of Jesus’ work

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 4:12–17; Luke 4:14–15; John 1:43a.

1:14a

After the arrest of John,

- ¶ When John had already been imprisoned,
- ¶ After some time had passed, Herod had John arrested and jailed. After that,

After the arrest of John: Mark assumed that his readers already knew the time when John was put in prison. The purpose of the clause is to help the readers know the approximate time when the next event happened.

In some languages it may be confusing to start a new section of a story in this way. If that is true in your language, you may need to present the information in a different order. You may need to first state that John was put in prison, then indicate that Jesus went into Galilee after that. For example:

When some time went by, John was arrested and put in prison. After that, Jesus went into Galilee...

In other languages you may need to change the order of the clauses in this verse. See the General Comment on 1:14a–b for a suggestion.

After: Jesus went to Galilee After John had been put in prison. We do not know how much time passed be-

tween John's imprisonment and Jesus' trip to Galilee. You should use a general time expression if possible.

the arrest of John: The Greek word that the BSB translates as arrest indicates that John was taken to government authorities for punishment.

Here is another way to translate the word, as the RSV has done:

John was arrested (RSV)

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as the arrest is passive and can be translated more literally as "was delivered over." In some languages, you may need to use an active verb and supply the person who put John in prison. Mark 6:14-29 indicates that King Herod was the ruler who caused John to be put in prison.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Later on, after King Herod had put John in prison...

After Herod had caused his men to put John in prison

You may also want to include a footnote mentioning Mark 6:14-29. A sample footnote is:

The story about when John the Baptizer was put in prison and killed is found in Mark 6:14-29.

John: The name John refers to John the Baptist. If this will not be clear to your readers, you may use the same title as you did in 1:4a.

1:14b

Jesus went into Galilee and proclaimed the gospel of God.

- Jesus returned to the region/province of Galilee, and he habitually preached the good news from God to the people there.
- Jesus traveled to the towns in Galilee, and there he told people the good news that came from God.

Jesus went: Mark 1:9 indicates that Jesus came from Galilee, so in some languages, it may be more natural to say here that Jesus returned to Galilee.

into Galilee: If you identified Galilee in 1:9a as a region/province, you may not have to make that information explicit again here. Consider whether it is natural in your language to mention this again.

proclaimed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as proclaimed is the same word that is translated as "preaching" in 1:4b. It means to publicly tell people something important. The verb form used here implies that Jesus preached the good news repeatedly as he traveled from place to place in Galilee.

Here are some other ways to translate proclaimed in this context:

announced

told people

the gospel of God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the gospel here is the same word that was translated as "gospel" in 1:1. The phrase gospel of God means the "gospel from God." There is a textual issue in 1:14b: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the gospel of God. For example, the RSV says: "preaching the gospel of God" (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NJB, ESV, NET, NASB, REB, GW, NLT, CEV, JBP, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the gospel of the kingdom of God. For example, the KJV says: "preaching the gospel of the kingdom of God" (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1).

General Comment on 1:14a-b

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the information in this verse. For example:

^{14a}After that, ^{14b}Jesus went to Galilee and told people Good News that came from God. ^{14a}(At that time John had already been put in prison.) ^{14b}In his preaching Jesus said....

Mark 1:15

Section 1:14-15: Jesus began to preach to people

In this section Mark told how Jesus began to preach in Galilee after Satan tempted Jesus in the wilderness.

It is good to translate the section before you decide what heading to use for it. Here is another idea for this section heading:

The beginning of Jesus' work

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 4:12-17; Luke 4:14-15; John 1:43a.

1:15a

"The time is fulfilled," He said,

- He said, “The right/appointed time has arrived/ come.
- He said, “These are the days that God designated/ decided.

This verse quotes words that Jesus said as he preached. See the note on “he said” below.

The time is fulfilled: The clause that the BSB translates as The time is fulfilled indicates that the time that God had appointed and chosen for the Messiah to begin his work had arrived.

Here are some other ways to say this:

The right time has come (GNT)

The appointed/designated time is here

This clause is passive. In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit that God was the one who decided the time. For example:

The time that God designated has arrived

Now is the time that God chose

In some languages it might be more natural to use the word “day” instead of time with the verbs “arrived” or “has come.” Use word combinations that are natural in your language.

He said: In Greek, the phrase that the BSB translates as He said is literally, “and saying.” It identifies Jesus as the speaker. Use a natural way in your language to identify the speaker of a quote. In Greek the phrase occurs at the beginning of 1:15a. Place this information wherever it is natural in your language.

1:15b

“and the kingdom of God is near.

- The time of God’s ruling is near/soon.
- The time when God will rule over his people is already beginning.

the kingdom of God: The phrase kingdom of God refers to God’s activity of ruling and caring for his people as their king. It does not refer to a land or country that he rules over. It refers to the relationship that he has with his people. He leads, protects, and cares for them. They obey, trust, and submit to him as their king.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- As a noun. For example:

God’s rule/reign

God’s kingship

God’s chieftaincy

God’s government

- As a verbal expression:

God rules his people

God cares for his people as King

See also kingdom of God, Context 3, in the Glossary.

is near: The Greek word that the BSB translates as is near is literally “has approached.” Here it probably indicates that God was establishing his rule in a new way in this world. There is disagreement among the scholars as to whether this phrase means near spatially (i.e., already here, in the person of Jesus) or near in time (God will soon rule over people through the ministry that the Messiah is just beginning). No versions unambiguously follow the first interpretation. In the context of the preceding words “The time has come,” it seems more likely that “near” is a temporal expression rather than a spatial one. However, it also seems likely that “near” does not rule out the idea that God’s rule was already beginning through Jesus’ work.

Here are some other ways the entire clause may be translated:

God has established his chieftaincy here and now.

God has come as King for his people.

1:15c

Repent and believe in the gospel!”

- So turn from your^(plur) sins and believe this good news.”
- Change your^(plur) sinful thinking, and believe and act on his good news.”

Repent and believe in the gospel: This statement is a command that is based on the fact that God’s rule is near. In some languages this relationship is indicated with a connector like “so” or “therefore.” Use a natural way in your language to indicate the relationship.

Repent: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Repent means for a person “to change his mind, heart, or will.” In the Bible, it refers specifically to changing the mind and heart about sin and about God. When a person repents, he is sorry for his past sins. He decides to stop sinning and obey God.

Here are some other ways to translate Repent in this context:

Change your thinking/mind/heart

Reject your sins to live/be for God

In some languages, you may have an idiom for this type of change. For example:

Turn from sin to God

Leave your sinning behind

See how you translated the word “repentance” at 1:4c.

believe in the gospel: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as believe in the gospel means “to accept that the gospel is true.” In this context the gospel is the statement in 1:15b that the kingdom of God is near.

believe: The word believe here implies that the person who believes will act on the good news by committing himself to God.

In some languages it may be good to use more than one verb to express this type of belief. For example:

believe and trust in this gospel

believe and act on this gospel

See believe, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

the gospel: In this context, the phrase the gospel probably refers to the statement that Jesus had just made about the kingdom of God being near. It also refers to the “gospel of God” in 1:14b.

Here are some ways to specify this:

his gospel

this good news

Mark 1:16

Section 1:16–20: Jesus chose his first four disciples

The previous section indicated that Jesus went to Galilee and was preaching in various places in that region. This section describes two events that happened near Lake Galilee during that time.

The Notes has two paragraphs for these events. In 1:16–18 Jesus chose his first two disciples. In 1:19–20 he chose his next two disciples. In some languages it may be more natural to tell about these two events in one paragraph. Make natural paragraphs for your language.

For information on the word “disciples,” see the note in 2:15b.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other ideas for section headings:

Jesus’ first disciples

Jesus chose his first disciples

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 4:18–22 and Luke 5:1–11.

1:16a

As Jesus was walking beside the Sea of Galilee,

- ¶ One day, as Jesus was walking near the Lake of Galilee,
- ¶ On one occasion, as Jesus walked along the shore/edge of Lake Galilee,

As Jesus was walking beside the Sea of Galilee: This clause introduces the next event and tells where it happened. The previous section told what Jesus was doing over a period of time. Because of that, it may be helpful here to indicate that the event in this paragraph happened on a particular day. For example, the NLT96 says:

One day as Jesus was walking along the shores of the Sea of Galilee (NLT96)

beside: The word beside indicates that Jesus was walking along the shore. Use a natural word in your language to refer to the land close to the edge of a lake.

the Sea of Galilee: The phrase that the BSB translates as Sea of Galilee refers to an inland lake that had fresh

water. Use an appropriate word in your language for this type of lake. For example:

Lake Galilee (CEV)

Lake Galilee was about 21 kilometers long and 11 kilometers wide (13.1 miles long and 6.9 miles wide). If your language has different words for “lake” based on its size, this information may help you decide which word to use.

If lakes are not known in your area, consider using a descriptive phrase. For example:

wide pond

broad pool

1:16b

He saw Simon and his brother Andrew.

- he saw Simon and his younger brother Andrew.
- he saw the brothers/siblings Simon and Andrew

Simon: This is the first time that Simon is mentioned in the book of Mark. Jesus later named him “Peter” (3:16b). You may wish to add a footnote about that here. For example:

Simon was also called Peter (see Mark 3:16).

and his brother Andrew: Andrew was Simon’s brother. The text does not indicate whether he was the older brother or the younger brother. However, most scholars believe that Peter was the older brother. It is also likely that Peter and Andrew had the same father and mother. Use the appropriate term in your language to refer to this relationship.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the brother/sibling-pair, Simon and Andrew

Simon and Andrew, his younger sibling

1:16c

They were casting a net into the sea,

- They were tossing/throwing a net into the water/lake to catch fish,
- net fishing,

casting a net: The Greek word that the BSB translates as casting a net refers to throwing a net into the water

to catch fish. The person who casts the net may stand either on shore or in a boat.

In some languages it may be difficult to translate the idea of throwing a net into the water. Do not use a phrase that implies that the brothers were throwing their nets away. In some languages it may be good to use a more general expression. For example:

catching fish with a net (GNT)

fishing with a net (NLT96)

net: The type of net that was used in this context was made of string or thread. The string was knotted together to form a circle and small weights were attached to the edges to make it sink quickly. It was small enough for one man to handle.

into the sea: In areas where people are familiar with net fishing, it may not be necessary to include the words into the sea. If that is true in your language, you may leave the information implicit.

1:16d

for they were fishermen.

- because their work was to catch fish.
- because that was their^(dual) occupation.

for they were fishermen: This clause explains the reason that Simon and Andrew were fishing with a net. The reason is because they were fishermen.

fishermen: The word fishermen refers to men who catch fish and sell them to earn a living. That is their work or occupation. If your translation of “casting a net” in 1:16c used a phrase like “to catch fish,” you may be able to use a more general expression here. For example:

because that was their work

Mark 1:17

Section 1:16–20: Jesus chose his first four disciples

The previous section indicated that Jesus went to Galilee and was preaching in various places in that region. This section describes two events that happened near Lake Galilee during that time.

The Notes has two paragraphs for these events. In 1:16–18 Jesus chose his first two disciples. In 1:19–20 he chose his next two disciples. In some languages it may be more natural to tell about these two events in one paragraph. Make natural paragraphs for your language.

For information on the word “disciples,” see the note in 2:15b.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other ideas for section headings:

Jesus' first disciples

Jesus chose his first disciples

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 4:18–22 and Luke 5:1–11.

1:17a

“Come, follow Me,” Jesus said,

- Jesus said to them, “Come^(plur) and follow^(plur) me.
- He said, “Come^(dual/plur) with me and be^(dual/plur) my disciples.

Come, follow Me: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Come, follow Me is literally “Come after me.” Jesus said this to invite Simon and Andrew to go with him and become his disciples. Jesus did not simply want them to walk along behind him. He wanted them to be with him and learn from him. In some languages you may need to indicate this explicitly. For example:

Come, be my disciples (NLT96)

See disciple in the Glossary for information on how to translate it.

Jesus said: The BSB has placed the phrase Jesus said in the middle of what Jesus was saying. In the Greek text it comes before Jesus' words. In some languages, the phrase Jesus said would occur after his words in 1:17b. You should place this phrase wherever it is most natural in your language.

1:17b

“and I will make you fishers of men.”

- I will teach you^(plur) how to catch people instead of catching fish.”
- Until now you^(dual/plur) have been bringing in fish. But now I will teach you^(dual/plur) to bring people to believe in me.”

I will make you fishers of men: This statement is a figure of speech. It indicates that Jesus would train the disciples to gain people for the kingdom of God. This work of gaining people contrasted with their work of gaining fish.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

I will teach you how to catch people instead of fish. (GW)

I will show you how to fish for people! (NLT)

In some languages an expression like “catch people” may imply a wrong meaning. It may imply that they were going to gather people to do forced labor or that they were going to catch criminals. In other languages it may not be possible to use a phrase like “fish for people.”

If that is true in your language, here are some other ways to translate it:

I will teach you how to bring in people instead of fish (CEV)

You have been gaining fish, but now I will show you how to gain people to believe in me.

Your work has been to catch fish. But now I will teach you to do the work of bringing people to me.

If a literal translation of 1:17b is well known in a major language version in your area, you may want to mention this literal wording in a footnote. For example:

Here is a more literal translation of these words:
“I will teach you to fish for people.”

make you: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as make you is literally “make you to become.” It means “teach or train you” to do a different kind of work. It does not imply that Jesus would force them to change their work.

men: The Greek word that the BSB translates as men refers to people in general. It does not refer only to males.

General Comment on 1:17a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the parts of 1:17a–b. For example:

^{17a}He said to them, “^{17b}Until now your^(dual) work has been to catch fish. ^{17a}Come^(dual) with me and become^(dual) my disciples ^{17b}and then I will teach you^(dual) to do the work of persuading people to believe in me.”

Mark 1:18

Section 1:16–20: Jesus chose his first four disciples

The previous section indicated that Jesus went to Galilee and was preaching in various places in that region. This section describes two events that happened near Lake Galilee during that time.

The Notes has two paragraphs for these events. In 1:16–18 Jesus chose his first two disciples. In 1:19–20 he chose his next two disciples. In some languages it may be more natural to tell about these two events in one paragraph. Make natural paragraphs for your language.

For information on the word “disciples,” see the note in 2:15b.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other ideas for section headings:

Jesus’ first disciples

Jesus chose his first disciples

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 4:18–22 and Luke 5:1–11.

1:18

And at once they left their nets and followed Him.

- Right away, they left their nets and they followed him.
- Immediately, they^(dual) stopped their work of catching fish and became his disciples.

And at once: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as And at once introduces an important and surprising event in the story. See the note in 1:10 and 1:12. It also indicates that this event is the next thing that happened. Simon and Andrew obeyed Jesus without delay.

they left their nets and followed Him: The phrase they left their nets implies here that Simon and Andrew left their work as fishermen. They left their fishing work in order to become Jesus’ disciples.

Mark 1:19

Section 1:16–20: Jesus chose his first four disciples

The previous section indicated that Jesus went to Galilee and was preaching in various places in that region. This section describes two events that happened near Lake Galilee during that time.

The Notes has two paragraphs for these events. In 1:16–18 Jesus chose his first two disciples. In 1:19–20 he chose his next two disciples. In some languages it may be more natural to tell about these two events in one paragraph. Make natural paragraphs for your language.

For information on the word “disciples,” see the note in 2:15b.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other ideas for section headings:

Jesus’ first disciples

Jesus chose his first disciples

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 4:18–22 and Luke 5:1–11.

1:19a

Going on a little farther,

- ¶ When he walked a little farther,
- ¶ Then Jesus and his two followers walked a short distance along the shore.

Going on a little farther: The phrase Going on a little farther connects 1:19a with the preceding verse.

Here is another way to translate this:

Jesus walked on and soon saw (CEV)

He: The pronoun He refers to Jesus. The focus is on Jesus, but Simon and Andrew were also still with Jesus. In some languages, it may be necessary to indicate that in some way. For example:

Jesus and his two followers

1:19b

He saw James son of Zebedee and his brother John.

- Jesus saw two other brothers named James and John, the sons of Zebedee.
- He soon saw two men named James and John, whose father’s name was Zebedee.

He saw James son of Zebedee and his brother John:

In New Testament times Jewish people used the name of their father to identify the family they belonged to. Zebedee was the father of James and John. See “Proper Names in Mark” in the Introduction for information on how to transliterate these names.

See the note in 1:16b for ways to translate the word brother. Since John was mentioned last, he was probably the younger brother.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he saw James and John, the sons of Zebedee (GW)

Jesus saw two more brothers, James and John, the sons of Zebedee (NCV)

Notice that in the GW, the word “brother” is implied by the fact that both James and John were sons of the same man. If you follow a model like the NCV, be sure that “more brothers” does not imply that James and John were also brothers of Simon and Andrew.

1:19c

They were in a boat, mending their nets.

- They were sitting in a boat, mending their nets.
- They^(dual) were riding in a boat, and preparing their nets to go fishing.

They were in a boat: The boats used on Lake Galilee were small boats used for fishing and travel across the lake. They could hold from about four to fifteen people. People used sails or oars (long paddles) to cause the boats to move across the water. If you do not have a word for boat in your language, here are some translation options:

- Use a phrase that describes the function of a boat. For example:

a vehicle for crossing water

something for carrying people on top of water

- Use the word for a specific kind of boat in your culture. For example:

canoe

Consider how your language talks about people in a boat. In some languages it may be more natural to say that they were riding or sitting in a boat.

mending their nets: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mending means “restoring to a former condition.” This would include cleaning, repairing, and folding the nets. In translating this phrase, you may focus either on “preparing” the nets or on mending the nets. For example:

repairing their nets (NLT)

getting their nets ready (GNT)

preparing their nets to [go fishing] (GW)

Mark 1:20

Section 1:16–20: Jesus chose his first four disciples

The previous section indicated that Jesus went to Galilee and was preaching in various places in that region. This section describes two events that happened near Lake Galilee during that time.

The Notes has two paragraphs for these events. In 1:16–18 Jesus chose his first two disciples. In 1:19–20 he chose his next two disciples. In some languages it may be more natural to tell about these two events in one paragraph. Make natural paragraphs for your language.

For information on the word “disciples,” see the note in 2:15b.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other ideas for section headings:

Jesus’ first disciples

Jesus chose his first disciples

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 4:18–22 and Luke 5:1–11.

1:20a

Immediately Jesus called them,

- At once he invited/summoned them to become his disciples.
- As soon as Jesus saw them,^(dual) he told them, “Come^(dual/plur) with me and be my disciples.”
- As soon as Jesus saw them, he told them that they should come with him and be his followers.

Immediately: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Immediately probably indicates here that Jesus called James and John as soon as he saw them. For example:

As soon as Jesus saw them, he called them (GNT)

Jesus called them: In this context, the Greek verb that the BSB translates as called means “invited” or “summoned.” It does not mean “called out” or

“shouted.” The text implies that Jesus was inviting them to become his disciples. This invitation may also be expressed as a direct quote. For example:

Jesus said to them, “Come with me and be my disciples.”

them: The pronoun them refers only to James and John. It does not include their father Zebedee.

1:20b

and they left their father Zebedee in the boat with the hired men

- Then they left their father Zebedee in the boat with his paid workers,
- So they^(dual) left their^(dual) father and the men who worked for him in the boat,

they left their father Zebedee in the boat with the hired men: In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the boat and the hired men. For example:

they left their father Zebedee and the hired men in the boat (GW)

their father Zebedee: Because James and John were called the “sons of Zebedee” in 1:19b, it may not be necessary to say here that he was their father. You may leave this information implied if that is natural in your language. For example:

they left Zebedee in the boat

they left their father in the boat (CEV)

1:20c

and followed Him.

- and they followed Jesus.
- and they^(dual) went with Jesus to become his disciples.

and followed Him: The pronoun Him refers to Jesus. The Greek word that the BSB translates as followed means “departed, set out.” James and John began to follow Jesus. In some languages it may be natural to translate this with the same word for “follow” that you used in 1:18.

Mark 1:21

Section 1:21–28: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a man

In this section Mark described the first of four events that happened in the town of Capernaum in the region of Galilee. Paragraph 1:21–26 tells how Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a man in the synagogue at Capernaum. Paragraph 1:27–28 describes the people’s amazed reaction to Jesus’ authority over evil spirits. See the note on “unclean spirit” in 1:23a for ways to translate “evil/unclean spirit.”

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here is another idea for this section heading:

The time when Jesus expelled an evil spirit

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 4:31–37.

Paragraph 1:21–26

This paragraph begins with a change of location. Jesus and his four disciples walked along the shore of the Sea of Galilee to the town of Capernaum.

1:21a

Then Jesus and His companions went to Capernaum,

- ¶ Jesus and his disciples went to the town of Capernaum.

Jesus and His companions went: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Jesus and His companions went is more literally “they went.” The pronoun “they” refers to Jesus and the four disciples who were mentioned in 1:16–20. Since this is the start of a new section, you may want to make explicit who “they” refers to, as the BSB does. For example:

Jesus and his disciples (GNT)

Jesus and his followers (NCV)

Capernaum: Capernaum was a small town that probably had fewer than two thousand people. It was located on the northern shore of the Sea of Galilee. In some languages it may be helpful to indicate that Capernaum refers to a town. For example, the NLT says:

the town of Capernaum (NLT)

1:21b**and right away Jesus entered the synagogue on the Sabbath**

- On the next Sabbath day, Jesus entered the synagogue building
- When the next rest day arrived, Jesus entered the meeting place.

and right away Jesus entered the synagogue on the Sabbath:

This part of the verse tells when the event in this section happened. It also tells the specific place in Capernaum where it happened. Consider how your language would naturally connect this part of the verse to what precedes it. In some languages it may be more natural to begin this part of the verse with a new sentence. For example:

When the next Sabbath day arrived, Jesus went into the synagogue

Jesus and his disciples went to the town of Capernaum. Then on the next Sabbath (CEV)

and right away: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as and right away is literally “and immediately.” Here it refers to the next Sabbath day, as the CEV example in the preceding note indicates.

synagogue: A synagogue was a building where Jews gathered to pray, read scripture, teach their beliefs, and worship. The Jews also gathered there for cultural activities. There was only one temple (in Jerusalem), but each Jewish community had a synagogue.

Here are some other ways to translate synagogue:

prayer-house of the Jews

meeting-place of the Jews

worship building

house for gathering together

If you make explicit a phrase such as “of the Jews,” be sure that it does not imply that Jesus was not a Jew.

If the word synagogue is already known in your area, you may write it according to the sounds of your language. You may want to include a word or phrase to explain the meaning. For example:

synagog house/building

Consider using a footnote that contains some of the information above. See synagogue in the Glossary.

Sabbath: The word Sabbath is the name of the seventh and last day of the week for the Jews. The Sabbath was the special day in the week when the Jews rested and worshiped God. The Law of Moses said that the Jews must not do any work on that day (Deuteronomy 5:12–15).

Here are some other ways to translate Sabbath:

the Jewish rest day

the day for resting

the day to rest and worship God

If the word Sabbath is already known in your area, you may write it according to the sounds of your language. You may also want to include a phrase to explain the meaning. For example:

the Sabat, the Jews’ day for resting

Be careful that the term you choose is not confused with Sunday, the day when Christians worship. The Sabbath for the Jews began at sundown on Friday and went until sundown on Saturday. You may want to include a footnote to give more information. For example:

The Sabbath is a name for the seventh day of the week. It is the day when the Jews rested from work and worshiped God.

1:21c**and began to teach.**

- and started teaching about God’s words.
- and taught the message of God to the people who had come there.

and began to teach: The Greek verb that most English versions translate as began to teach may also be translated as “taught,” as in the RSV. Use a verb form that is natural in your language for this context.

In some languages a verb like teach may require you to tell what Jesus taught and whom he taught. In this context he taught God’s message to the people who gathered in the synagogue to worship.

Here is one way to make this information explicit:

began to teach God's message to the people there

Mark 1:22

Section 1:21–28: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a man

In this section Mark described the first of four events that happened in the town of Capernaum in the region of Galilee. Paragraph 1:21–26 tells how Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a man in the synagogue at Capernaum. Paragraph 1:27–28 describes the people's amazed reaction to Jesus' authority over evil spirits. See the note on "unclean spirit" in 1:23a for ways to translate "evil/unclean spirit."

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here is another idea for this section heading:

The time when Jesus expelled an evil spirit

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 4:31–37.

Paragraph 1:21–26

This paragraph begins with a change of location. Jesus and his four disciples walked along the shore of the Sea of Galilee to the town of Capernaum.

1:22a

The people were astonished at His teaching,

- The people were completely astonished at the way he taught,
- Jesus' manner of teaching impressed the people very much.

The people were astonished at His teaching: The Greek word that the BSB translates as were astonished emphasizes that the people were very surprised. The word means "overwhelmed," "astounded" or "deeply impressed." In Greek, the verb that the BSB translates as were astonished is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The people were amazed at his teaching (NIV)

And his teaching made a deep impression on them (NJB)

The people thought, "He teaches very well!"

at His teaching: The phrase His teaching probably refers to the way Jesus was teaching rather than the content of his teaching. So the GNT translates this as:

at the way he taught (GNT)

1:22b

because He taught as one who had authority,

- because he spoke to them like a teacher who had true/great authority,
- He had confidence that God had given him the right to teach that message.
- He taught them like a person who knows that his authority to teach is from God.

because: The connector because introduces the reason why people were amazed at Jesus' teaching. In some languages it may not be necessary to use a connector here. For example, the CEV has:

Everyone was amazed at his teaching. He taught with authority... (CEV)

Use a way that is natural in your language to express a reason.

He taught as one who had authority: In this context, the phrase as one who had authority means "authoritatively" or "with certainty." Jesus knew that what he said was true and that it was God's message.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he taught like a chief

he spoke to them like a teacher who knows that what he says is absolutely true

he taught them like one who has the right/authority to declare the truth

1:22c

and not as the scribes.

- not like the teachers of the law.
- But as for the experts in the Law, they did not teach like that.

and not as the scribes: The phrase not as the scribes indicates that Jesus did not teach in the same way that the scribes taught. When the scribes explained something, they always quoted other scholars to support their views. But Jesus did not quote other Jewish teachers to support the truth of what he said.

the scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes is sometimes translated as “teachers of the law,” as in the NIV. The original work of these men was to copy the laws of Moses by hand. In New Testament times, their main task was to study, interpret, and teach the law of Moses and related Jewish laws and traditions.

Here are some ways to translate this term:

teachers of the Law of Moses (CEV)

teachers of religious law (NLT)

experts on the law

See teacher of the law in the Glossary.

General Comment on 1:22a–c

The parts of this verse may be arranged in various ways. For example:

^{22c}But the way that Jesus taught was quite different from the scribes, ^{22b}because his way of teaching showed his great authority. ^{22a}So the people were completely amazed.

^{22a}The people who heard him were amazed at the way he taught, ^{22c}for he wasn’t like the teachers of the Law; ^{22b}instead, he taught with authority. (GNT)

Arrange these verse parts in a way that is natural in your language.

Mark 1:23

Section 1:21–28: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a man

In this section Mark described the first of four events that happened in the town of Capernaum in the region of Galilee. Paragraph 1:21–26 tells how Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a man in the synagogue at Capernaum. Paragraph 1:27–28 describes the people’s amazed reaction to Jesus’ authority over evil spirits. See the note on “unclean spirit” in 1:23a for ways to translate “evil/unclean spirit.”

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here is another idea for this section heading:

The time when Jesus expelled an evil spirit

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 4:31–37.

Paragraph 1:21–26

This paragraph begins with a change of location. Jesus and his four disciples walked along the shore of the Sea of Galilee to the town of Capernaum.

1:23–25

In 1:23–25 singular and plural forms are used in an interesting way. 1:23 talks about a man who was possessed by an evil/unclean spirit. The word for “spirit” is a singular form. The man shouted at Jesus, but the words that he shouted in 1:24a–b use the plural form “us.” This probably implies that the evil spirit was speaking for evil spirits as a group. In 1:24c the evil spirit changed from the pronoun “us” to “I.” When Jesus answered in 1:25, he rebuked “him/it.”

In your translation, use singular and plural forms in a way that is clear and natural in your language.

1:23a–b

Suddenly a man...cried out in the synagogue: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Suddenly here introduces an event that is surprising and significant in the story.

The Greek text does not indicate when the man entered the synagogue. He may have been there while Jesus was speaking or he may have entered as Jesus finished speaking and immediately cried out. Normally, a person with an unclean spirit was not allowed to worship in the synagogue, so the man probably entered after Jesus finished speaking. There are two interpretations here: (1) The man suddenly entered the synagogue while Jesus was teaching. (2) The man was in the synagogue all along but suddenly shouted out. Most scholars feel that the man was not a member of the synagogue or else entered against the normal rules. Most versions are either ambiguous or unclear in English. Since it is difficult to clearly indicate the different positions, the different interpretations have not been listed in the notes. The GNT and the CEV make this explicit. For example:

Just then a man with an evil spirit came into the synagogue and screamed (GNT)

1:23a

Suddenly a man with an unclean spirit

- Just then, unexpectedly, a man with an evil spirit
- There was a man whom an evil spirit controlled. Suddenly,

with an unclean spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as with an unclean spirit indicates that an unclean spirit controlled the man's thoughts and actions.

Languages have different ways to refer to possession by evil spirits.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

controlled by an evil spirit (GW)

had an evil spirit in him (NCV)

on whom an evil spirit had fastened

on whom an evil spirit was riding

Use an expression that is natural in your language to refer to an unclean spirit controlling a person.

unclean spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as unclean spirit refers to a spirit that is unclean and can control people's actions. The phrase unclean spirit refers to the same type of spirit as the Greek terms that are often translated as "demon" and "evil spirit."

Here are some other ways to translate unclean spirit:

- Use a general term in your language that refers to spirits that are evil and can control people. If there is one word with this meaning, you may not need a separate word like "unclean." For example:

demon

- Use a specific term in your language that refers to a certain type of spirit. This spirit should be able to do what is described in this context. Do not use a term that refers to the spirit of a dead person.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

an evil/bad spirit

an impure spirit (NIV11) Be sure that an expression like "unclean spirit" or "impure spirit" does not imply that the spirit is literally dirty.

See evil spirit in the Glossary for more information.

1:23b

cried out in the synagogue:

- entered the synagogue building. He shouted loudly at Jesus, saying,
- this man entered their meeting place, and he screamed/shrieked at Jesus. He said,

cried out: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as cried out means "shouted" or "screamed." Use a natural way in your language to describe a person shouting under the influence of an evil spirit.

In Greek it is the man who cried out. But the words that he shouted came from the evil spirit or spirits that possessed him. Use whatever subject is natural in your language to refer to a person speaking under the influence of an evil spirit.

in the synagogue: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the synagogue is more literally "their synagogue." This phrase refers to the synagogue where the people who lived in Capernaum worshiped. It does not imply that the synagogue belonged to Jesus and his disciples. It is clear from 1:21 that Jesus had entered the synagogue in that town, so the BSB does not translate the pronoun "their."

If your term for synagogue is a phrase such as "meeting place of the Jews," you may need to use a form like "their." For example:

their meeting place

See the note in 1:21b for the term synagogue. See also synagogue in the Glossary.

Mark 1:24

Section 1:21–28: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a man

In this section Mark described the first of four events that happened in the town of Capernaum in the region of Galilee. Paragraph 1:21–26 tells how Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a man in the synagogue at Capernaum. Paragraph 1:27–28 describes the people's amazed reaction to Jesus' authority over evil spirits. See the note on "unclean spirit" in 1:23a for ways to translate "evil/unclean spirit."

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here is another idea for this section heading:

The time when Jesus expelled an evil spirit

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 4:31–37.

Paragraph 1:21–26

This paragraph begins with a change of location. Jesus and his four disciples walked along the shore of the Sea of Galilee to the town of Capernaum.

1:24a

“What do You want with us, Jesus of Nazareth?”

- “Jesus from Nazareth, why are you^(sing) bothering us^(excl) evil spirits?”
- “Jesus from the town of Nazareth, leave us^(excl) evil spirits alone.

What do You want with us...?: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as What do You want with us...? is an idiom. It literally says, “What to us and to you?” It means “What relation do we^(excl) have with you?” The commentaries and a detailed article by Nigel Turner (Grammatical Insights Into the Greek NT, pages 43–47) discuss the differences in meaning between “What do we have in common?”, “What cause of enmity/injustice is there between us?” and “What business do we have with each other?” However, when the rhetorical nature of the question is appreciated, the differences between these renderings of the question largely dissolve. A sense close to “leave me alone” works well in all contexts where this is found, whether the occasion is some issue of injustice between parties, a request that someone get involved in a matter he felt was not his business, or a plea, as here, on the part of demons that Jesus refrain from punishing them. The evil spirit meant that Jesus had nothing in common with evil spirits as a group. He implied that Jesus should not interfere with them.

This idiom is a rhetorical question that expresses the evil spirit’s fear, dread, and hostility. Here are some ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a question. For example:

Why are you bothering us...? (NLT96)

What do you want with us...? (NCV)

Why are you interfering with us...?

- As a statement or command. For example:

Do not bother/disturb us!

We have nothing to do with one another!

Leave us alone! (NET)

Some languages may have an exclamation that shows that the speaker is afraid or hostile. In some languages it may be appropriate to use such an exclamation here. For example:

How terrible! Why are you bothering us?

us: The pronoun us probably refers to the evil spirit that possessed the man and to other evil spirits like him. There are several ways to interpret the pronoun us here: (1) It refers to the demon who was speaking and other demons like him, (2) It refers to several demons who were all possessing the man, or (3) It refers to the demon and the man he was possessing. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is the view of the majority of commentators. The evil spirit was speaking on behalf of other evil spirits. The evil spirit did not include Jesus in the group called us. If it is not clear who the pronoun us refers to, you may need to specify “us evil spirits.”

Jesus of Nazareth: The phrase Jesus of Nazareth means “Jesus from the town of Nazareth.” In those days Jewish people generally had only one personal name. They could be further identified by their hometown. If you have a different way to indicate that someone is from a certain town, you may use that.

The evil spirit used this phrase to get Jesus’ attention and to indicate that he was speaking to Jesus. The BSB puts this phrase at the end of the question. You may want to put it at the beginning if that is more natural in your language.

1:24b

Have You come to destroy us?

- Did you^(sing) come here to destroy us?^(excl)
- Why did you^(sing) come here? Are you^(sing) going to punish us^(excl) now?

Have You come to destroy us?: This is a real question. The evil spirit knew that Jesus was the Messiah and had the power to destroy evil spirits. The spirit may have feared that Jesus would immediately destroy him and the other evil spirits.

Have You come: In some languages a verb like “come” may require you to say where a person has come from and where he has arrived. In this context Jesus had come from heaven to earth. However, it may be awkward to make this information explicit. So you may be able to use a more general word like “here.” For example:

Have you come here...

Are you here...

to destroy us: The Greek word that the BSB translates as destroy means “ruin” rather than “kill.” The evil spirit was afraid that Jesus would destroy its power. The spirit was probably also afraid that Jesus would send it and the other evil spirits to a place where they would be imprisoned. They would have to wait there for God’s final judgment.

In many languages a word like destroy may refer to smashing or breaking something. You may need to use a different expression. For example:

end our power

punish us

1:24c–d

In Greek there is no word between the clause “I know who you are” in 1:24c and the phrase the Holy One of God in 1:24d. The BSB connects these verse parts with a dash. In some languages it may be more natural to connect them in a different way. For example, the CEV starts a new sentence in 1:24d:

I know who you are! You are God’s Holy One. (CEV)

The evil spirit knew that Jesus was the Son of God, the Messiah whom God had sent to earth.

1:24c

I know who You are—

- I know who you^(sing) are.

I know who You are: The pronoun I refers to the evil spirit who was speaking through the man’s mouth.

1:24d

the Holy One of God!”

- You^(sing) are the Holy one whom God sent!”
- You^(sing) are the Holy Son of God!”

the Holy One of God: The evil spirit identified Jesus here as the Holy One of God. The apostle Peter also used this term to refer to Jesus in John 6:69. In this context Jesus is the Holy One of God because he is divine and comes from God.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the Holy One sent from God (NLT)

the Divine/Sacred One who comes from God

In some languages it may not be possible to use the word One to refer to a person. It may be necessary to use a more specific term. For example:

You are the Holy Person/Man from God.

You are the Holy Child of God.

Holy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Holy refers to something or someone that is dedicated to God or set apart for him.

1:24d–25a

In 1:24d the evil spirit finished speaking. In 1:25a Jesus replied. Some languages may use a phrase such as “he said” to indicate the end of a quotation. Other languages may use a similar phrase to indicate the beginning of the next quotation. Be sure to identify the speakers and indicate the end and beginning of these quotations in a clear way in your language.

Mark 1:25

Section 1:21–28: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a man

In this section Mark described the first of four events that happened in the town of Capernaum in the region of Galilee. Paragraph 1:21–26 tells how Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a man in the synagogue at Capernaum. Paragraph 1:27–28 describes the people’s amazed reaction to Jesus’ authority over evil spirits. See the note on “unclean spirit” in 1:23a for ways to translate “evil/unclean spirit.”

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here is another idea for this section heading:

The time when Jesus expelled an evil spirit

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 4:31–37.

Paragraph 1:21–26

This paragraph begins with a change of location. Jesus and his four disciples walked along the shore of the Sea of Galilee to the town of Capernaum.

1:25a–b

But Jesus rebuked the spirit. “Be silent!” He said. “Come out of him!”

- Jesus rebuked the evil spirit, saying, “Be^(sing) silent and go^(sing) away from him!”
- Jesus commanded the evil spirit, “Stop^(sing) talking! Leave^(sing) that man!”

1:25a**But Jesus rebuked the Spirit. “Be silent,” He said:**

In Greek the phrase that the BSB translates as He said occurs at the beginning of the sentence. Place it wherever it is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Jesus commanded the evil spirit, “Be quiet!” (NCV)

But Jesus rebuked him, saying, “Be silent” (NRSV)

“Be quiet!” said Jesus sternly (NIV)

Be silent: The command Be silent uses a singular verb form. Jesus was speaking to the one demon who called him the Holy One of God.

1:25b

Come out of him!: The word that the BSB translates as Come out is a normal way in Greek to speak of a demon releasing control of a person. It indicates here that Jesus commanded the demon to leave the man and stop controlling him.

In some cultures, people do not think of demons as being in a person. If that is true in your language, it may not be natural to speak of them coming or going out of a person. Use a natural expression in your language for when a demon stops controlling a person.

Here are some other ways you could say this:

Leave him!

Release him!

Translate this command in a way that fits the expression you used for the phrase “with an unclean spirit” in 1:23a.

Mark 1:26**Section 1:21–28: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a man**

In this section Mark described the first of four events that happened in the town of Capernaum in the region of Galilee. Paragraph 1:21–26 tells how Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a man in the synagogue at Capernaum. Paragraph 1:27–28 describes the people’s amazed reaction to Jesus’ authority over evil spirits. See the note on “unclean spirit” in 1:23a for ways to translate “evil/unclean spirit.”

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here is another idea for this section heading:

The time when Jesus expelled an evil spirit

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 4:31–37.

Paragraph 1:21–26

This paragraph begins with a change of location. Jesus and his four disciples walked along the shore of the Sea of Galilee to the town of Capernaum.

1:26a–b

This verse describes three different things that the evil spirit did. It convulsed the man, left him, and shrieked. The Greek text does not indicate the exact order of these events. It says literally:

Having convulsed him and having cried out with a loud voice, the unclean spirit came out of him.

Possibly the demon was shrieking at the same time as it was convulsing the man. Possibly it was still shrieking as it left the man. You may use whatever order is natural in your language to describe a situation like this.

1:26a**At this, the unclean spirit threw the man into convulsions**

- The evil spirit caused the man to shake/convulse.
- Then the evil spirit caused the man to have a seizure/convulsion.

the unclean spirit threw the man into convulsions:

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as threw...into convulsions means that the evil spirit caused the man to have a seizure or a convulsion. It does not mean that the evil spirit grabbed the man’s body and threw him. Use a natural way in your language to describe a seizure or convulsion.

1:26b**and came out with a loud shriek.**

- Then it shouted very loudly as it came out of him.
- It screamed and then left him.

and came out: The verb came out was also used in Jesus’ command in 1:25b.

with a loud shriek: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as with a loud shriek is literally “having cried out with a great voice.” This phrase emphasizes the loudness of the sound. You may use whatever verb

is natural in your language to describe the shouting or screaming of an unclean spirit. See the note on 1:23b, which uses a different Greek verb that has a similar meaning.

The unclean spirit shrieked using the man's mouth. In some languages it may be more natural to describe this action by saying:

the unclean spirit caused the man to shriek

Mark 1:27

Section 1:21–28: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a man

In this section Mark described the first of four events that happened in the town of Capernaum in the region of Galilee. Paragraph 1:21–26 tells how Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a man in the synagogue at Capernaum. Paragraph 1:27–28 describes the people's amazed reaction to Jesus' authority over evil spirits. See the note on "unclean spirit" in 1:23a for ways to translate "evil/unclean spirit."

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here is another idea for this section heading:

The time when Jesus expelled an evil spirit

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 4:31–37.

Paragraph 1:27–28

This paragraph indicates that the people in the synagogue were amazed when the unclean spirit left. They were amazed that Jesus had the authority to cause unclean spirits to obey him.

1:27a

All the people were amazed

- ¶ All of the people in the synagogue were very surprised,
- ¶ Those who were gathered there were astonished,

All the people were amazed: In some languages it may be natural to say what amazed the people here. For example:

All the people were amazed at/by this

This miracle that Jesus had done amazed all the people

The people all thought, "He certainly has special/great power!"

See the General Comment on 1:27a–b at the end of 1:27b for ways to translate the relationship between 1:27a and 1:27b.

All the people: The Greek word that the BSB translates as All the people is literally "all" or "everyone." It refers to all the people in the synagogue who had just seen Jesus cause the evil spirit to leave the man.

amazed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as amazed also means "astonished," "shocked," or "stunned." It is not the same Greek word as the one used in 1:22a, but it has a similar meaning. There may be a idiom in your language to express the people's shock and amazement. For example:

[All who were there] widened their eyes

[The people all] had their mouths open

1:27b

and began to ask one another,

- so they began asking each other,
- and they began to discuss what had happened, and to say,

began to ask one another: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as began to ask one another can mean "discussed with one another" or "debated with one another." It does not only mean that the people asked each other questions. 1:27c gives the content of what the people asked or discussed with each other.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

they discussed what had happened. They asked one another:

they asked one another, saying:

General Comment on 1:27a–b

In Greek, 1:27b begins with a word that introduces a result. In this context it indicates that the statement "began to ask one another" in 1:27b is the result of the people being amazed in 1:27a.

Here are some different ways this relationship may be expressed:

The people were all so amazed that (NIV)

Everyone was stunned. They said to each other...
(GW)

Amazement gripped the audience, and they began to discuss what had happened. (NLT)

Notice that in the GW version, the result relationship is implied. In the NLT, the word “and” implies “and so.” Translate this relationship in a way that is clear and natural in your language.

1:27c–d

A new teaching with authority! He commands even the unclean spirits: There are two ways to understand how the phrase with authority relates to the context:

1. The phrase with authority relates to “a new teaching.” It means that Jesus’ teaching had authority. For example:

It must be some new kind of powerful teaching!
(CEV) (BSB, NIV, NRSV, REB, NJB, NCV, NLT, CEV)

1. The phrase with authority relates to “He commands even the unclean spirits.” It means that Jesus commanded the unclean spirits with authority. For example:

This man has authority to give orders to the evil spirits (GNT) (RSV, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with most English versions and scholars.

1:27c

“What is this? A new teaching with authority!”

- “What kind of teaching is this? We^(incl) have never heard anyone teach with such authority!
- “This is a new and amazing kind of teaching that shows authority!

What is this?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses surprise. There are at least three ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

What sort of new teaching is this? (NLT)

What is happening here? (NCV)

- As a statement or exclamation. For example:

This is amazing.

Wow! Amazing!

- As a tag question. For example:

This is amazing, isn’t it?

Some languages may have an idiom that expresses amazement. Use a natural way to express this type of amazement in your language.

A new teaching with authority!: The BSB translates the phrase A new teaching with authority as an exclamation that answers the rhetorical question. There is no verb in this exclamation. There are many other acceptable ways to translate this phrase. Here are some other possibilities:

- Combine the phrase with the rhetorical question at the beginning of 1:27c. For example, the NLT says:

“What sort of new teaching is this?” they asked excitedly. “It has such authority!” (NLT)

- Include some words to make the phrase into a sentence. For example, the GW says:

This is a new teaching that has authority behind it! (GW)

Translate in a way that will effectively express the people’s surprise at Jesus’ new and authoritative way of teaching.

A new teaching: The phrase A new teaching refers to the way Jesus taught. The word that the BSB translates as new means that the people had never before seen or heard anyone teach that way. Jesus’ manner of teaching was different and amazing. The Greek word kainos means “new” in quality, in other words, different, strange or remarkable. It is distinct from the Greek word neos, which means “new” in time (BAGD page 394, Cranfield page 81, Robertson page 261). Louw and Nida (page 645, #67.115) focus on the meaning “previously unknown.” A new teaching does not imply that Jesus’ current teaching was different from his previous teaching.

with authority: The characteristic of Jesus’ teaching that made it “new” or “amazing” or “different” is that he taught with authority. He showed absolute certainty about the truth of what he taught. See the note on 1:22b for an explanation of authority in this context.

1:27d**He commands even the unclean spirits, and they obey Him!”**

- He even commands the evil spirits to leave and they obey him.”
- Even evil spirits do what he says when he orders them to do something.”

He commands even the unclean spirits, and they obey Him: In this sentence the people indicated that they were amazed that Jesus had such great authority. Their statement means that Jesus even had the power to command unclean spirits to leave the people whom they were possessing.

they obey Him: The phrase they obey Him implies that the unclean spirits were forced to obey Jesus. They had to do what he told them even though they did not want to.

In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit the content of Jesus’ command. For example:

He even orders unclean spirits to leave people, and the unclean spirits obey him.

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses in 1:27d. For example:

Even unclean spirits must obey him when he commands them to leave!

Mark 1:28**Section 1:21–28: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a man**

In this section Mark described the first of four events that happened in the town of Capernaum in the region of Galilee. Paragraph 1:21–26 tells how Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a man in the synagogue at Capernaum. Paragraph 1:27–28 describes the people’s amazed reaction to Jesus’ authority over evil spirits. See the note on “unclean spirit” in 1:23a for ways to translate “evil/unclean spirit.”

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here is another idea for this section heading:

The time when Jesus expelled an evil spirit

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 4:31–37.

Paragraph 1:27–28

This paragraph indicates that the people in the synagogue were amazed when the unclean spirit left. They were amazed that Jesus had the authority to cause unclean spirits to obey him.

1:28**And the news about Jesus spread quickly through the whole region of Galilee.**

- So they told others about this, and soon people throughout Galilee had heard it.
- After this people kept telling others what Jesus had done. And soon people in all areas of Galilee heard about him.

And: The Greek word that the BSB translates as And introduces what happened next as a result of the events of the previous verses. Some English versions leave this connection implied. In some languages it may be natural to indicate the connection in some way. Use a natural way in your language to express a concluding event that is the result of previous actions in the story.

the news about Jesus spread quickly through the whole region of Galilee:

This sentence indicates that people kept telling others about what Jesus had done. Before long, people throughout the region or province of Galilee had heard about it. It did not take long for this to happen.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

People spread the news about what Jesus had done, and soon people all over Galilee had heard about it.

The people who were there told others what had happened. Within a short time people in every part of Galilee learned about it.

Mark 1:29**Section 1:29–34: Jesus healed many people and expelled many evil spirits**

In this section Jesus healed Peter’s mother-in-law from a fever. Then the people in the town of Capernaum brought many other sick people to him, and he healed them all. They also brought many people who were bothered by evil spirits, and he made the evil spirits leave them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here is another idea for a heading for this section:

Jesus heals many people

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:14–17 and Luke 4:38–41.

Paragraph 1:29–31

The events in this paragraph happened soon after Jesus expelled the evil spirit in the synagogue (1:26) but before the events in 1:28. Jesus and his disciples left the synagogue before the news about him spread throughout Galilee.

In some languages, it may be necessary to make the order of the events clear. Here are some ways to do this:

- Use a word or form that indicates that they left the synagogue before the events in 1:28 happened. For example:

Meanwhile, Jesus and his disciples left the synagogue.

- Make the connection with 1:26 explicit here in 1:29. For example:

After Jesus had caused the evil spirit to leave, he and his disciples left the synagogue.

Use a natural way in your language to make the order of events clear.

1:29a

As soon as Jesus and His companions had left the synagogue,

- ¶ Meanwhile, Jesus and his disciples left the synagogue building.
- ¶ Right after Jesus and his followers came/went out of the meeting place,

As soon as: In this context the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *As soon as* means that after Jesus and his disciples left the synagogue, they went directly to the home of Simon and Andrew. Nothing else happened between these two events. The GW has one way to express this meaning:

After they left the synagogue, they went directly to the house of Simon and Andrew. (GW)

Jesus and His companions had left the synagogue:

Here, the Greek word that the BSB translates as *Jesus and His companions had left* is more literally “they had left.” There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts say they left. The pronoun they refers to Jesus and some of his disciples. For example, the NIV has:

As soon as they left the synagogue (NIV) (BSB, NRSV, NIV, NASB, REB, NLT96, NCV, GW, CEV, GNT)

1. Some Greek manuscripts say he left. The pronoun “he” refers to Jesus. For example, the RSV has:

And immediately he left the synagogue (RSV) (RSV, NJB, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions and Greek manuscripts. The UBS4 (page 121) gives this a B rating, indicating that the text is almost certain. It is clear from 1:29b that Jesus left the synagogue along with his disciples. There is good reason to believe that some copyists chose the singular form of the verb in order to keep the focus on Jesus and to avoid the unclear reading “they came... with James and John.” (Metzger page 64 and EH page 31).

In some languages it may be necessary to use a specific phrase to indicate that they refers to Jesus’ disciples. This may be especially needed if you have a section heading before 1:29. The GNT has:

Jesus and his disciples, including James and John (GNT)

1:29b

they went with James and John to the home of Simon and Andrew.

- They walked directly to the house of Simon and Andrew and entered it. James and John were with them.
- they, including James and John, went to the house where Simon and Andrew lived.

they went with James and John to the home of Simon and Andrew:

Mark probably included the phrase with James and John to help his readers understand that these two men accompanied Jesus when he went to Simon and Andrew’s house. It is not clear in Greek whether Simon and Andrew were with Jesus in the synagogue or whether they were waiting for Jesus and the other disciples at their house. Most versions and scholars understand that all four disciples were with Jesus in the synagogue. That is certainly implied from the preceding paragraph. Be careful not to imply that James and John also owned the house. In Greek the

information about James and John comes at the end of this verse. In some languages it may be helpful to follow this order. For example:

...they went directly to the house of Simon and Andrew. James and John went with them. (GW)

...they went over to Simon and Andrew's home, and James and John were with them. (NLT96)

to the home of Simon and Andrew: The phrase the home of Simon and Andrew means “the home where Simon and Andrew lived.” Andrew also lived in the house with his older brother Simon and Simon's wife and mother-in-law.

to: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to usually means “into.” Here it indicates that Jesus and his disciples “went into” the house. For example, the NRSV says:

they entered the house (NRSV)

It is implied that they first went to the house or arrived at the house. Use a way that is natural in your language to indicate that they went to the house and entered.

Mark 1:30

Section 1:29–34: Jesus healed many people and expelled many evil spirits

In this section Jesus healed Peter's mother-in-law from a fever. Then the people in the town of Capernaum brought many other sick people to him, and he healed them all. They also brought many people who were bothered by evil spirits, and he made the evil spirits leave them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here is another idea for a heading for this section:

Jesus heals many people

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:14–17 and Luke 4:38–41.

Paragraph 1:29–31

The events in this paragraph happened soon after Jesus expelled the evil spirit in the synagogue (1:26) but before the events in 1:28. Jesus and his disciples left the synagogue before the news about him spread throughout Galilee.

In some languages, it may be necessary to make the order of the events clear. Here are some ways to do this:

- Use a word or form that indicates that they left the synagogue before the events in 1:28 happened. For example:

Meanwhile, Jesus and his disciples left the synagogue.

- Make the connection with 1:26 explicit here in 1:29. For example:

After Jesus had caused the evil spirit to leave, he and his disciples left the synagogue.

Use a natural way in your language to make the order of events clear.

1:30a

Simon's mother-in-law was sick in bed with a fever,

- When they came, Simon's mother-in-law was in bed, because she had a fever.
- This was the situation when they arrived: The mother of Simon's wife/spouse was sick. Her body was hot/feverish, and she was lying down on her bed.

This part of the verse gives background information. It directs the reader's attention to Simon's mother-in-law and provides the context for what Jesus did in 1:31a. Introduce this background information in a natural way in your language.

Simon's mother-in-law: The phrase Simon's mother-in-law refers to the mother of Simon's wife. Use a natural term in your language for “wife's mother.”

In some languages, certain kinship terms do not indicate whether the person is a man or a woman. If that is true in your language, you may have to specify that she was female. For example:

Simon's female parent-in-law

the mother of Simon's spouse

was sick in bed with a fever: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as was sick in bed with a fever is literally “was-lying-down having-a-fever.” It indicates that Simon's mother-in-law was sick. She had a fever, so she was lying down.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

was lying down because she was sick with fever

was sick. She had a fever and was lying in her bed

In some cultures it may be unusual for the mother of a man's wife to live in the same house as the married couple. If that is true in your culture, your readers may think that Jesus went to a different house to help the sick woman. You may need to say explicitly that she was in Simon's house. For example:

Simon's mother-in-law was lying down there in the house. She had a fever.

1:30b

and they promptly told Jesus about her.

- The people there immediately told Jesus that she was sick.
- And immediately they said to Jesus, "She's sick/ill."

and they promptly told Jesus about her: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as and...promptly is more literally "and immediately" (see the RSV). This is the same phrase that was used in 1:12. See the note on "at once" in 1:12. Here it indicates that the next action took place immediately after Jesus and his disciples entered the house. Other instances of the Greek phrase (*kai euthus*) that is often translated as "immediately" have indicated a significant new event in the story, but that does not seem to be the function here. Nor does it seem reasonable to think that this phrase indicates surprise. That someone would tell Jesus about the situation hardly seems surprising. Logically, the traditional meaning "immediately" makes the most sense. For example:

They told Jesus about her right away. (NLT)

The first thing they did was to tell Jesus about her. (GW)

The phrase about her in this context probably means "about her sickness." In some languages it may be necessary to specify what they told Jesus about the woman. For example:

they promptly told Jesus that she was sick

In other languages this information is clear from the context, and it may be more natural to leave it implied. For example:

Without delay they told Jesus.

they ... told Jesus about her: The text does not say to whom the pronoun they refers. If you must supply a subject, you may provide a general subject such as "some people."

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Jesus was told about her

there were those who told Jesus about her

some of the people there told Jesus about her

Jesus heard about her

General Comment on 1:30a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to start this verse with 1:30b. 1:30a may be expressed as an indirect quote or a direct quote. For example:

^{30b}People there told Jesus right away that
^{30a}Simon's mother-in-law had a fever and was lying down in her bed.

^{30b}As soon as they entered, there were people who said to Jesus, ^{30a}"Simon's wife's mother has a fever. She is in her bed, lying down."

Mark 1:31

Section 1:29–34: Jesus healed many people and expelled many evil spirits

In this section Jesus healed Peter's mother-in-law from a fever. Then the people in the town of Capernaum brought many other sick people to him, and he healed them all. They also brought many people who were bothered by evil spirits, and he made the evil spirits leave them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here is another idea for a heading for this section:

Jesus heals many people

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:14–17 and Luke 4:38–41.

Paragraph 1:29–31

The events in this paragraph happened soon after Jesus expelled the evil spirit in the synagogue (1:26)

but before the events in 1:28. Jesus and his disciples left the synagogue before the news about him spread throughout Galilee.

In some languages, it may be necessary to make the order of the events clear. Here are some ways to do this:

- Use a word or form that indicates that they left the synagogue before the events in 1:28 happened. For example:

Meanwhile, Jesus and his disciples left the synagogue.

- Make the connection with 1:26 explicit here in 1:29. For example:

After Jesus had caused the evil spirit to leave, he and his disciples left the synagogue.

Use a natural way in your language to make the order of events clear.

1:31a

So He went to her, took her by the hand, and helped her up.

- So he went to her. He grasped her hand and helped her to stand up.
- Jesus went to where she was lying and grasped her hand to help her get up.

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So is a common connector that is often translated as “and,” as in the RSV. It connects a sequence of events in a story. In this context the BSB uses So because it also introduces what Jesus did as a result of what the people told him. Connect this verse to 1:30 in a natural way in your language.

He went to her: The Greek word that the BSB translates as went to is literally “having approached.” In this context it indicates that Jesus came and stood close to where the woman was lying.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

So Jesus approached the place where she was lying

He went to where the woman was

took her by the hand, and helped her up: The phrase took her by the hand, and helped her up means that

Jesus grasped one of the woman’s hands in order to help her to sit or stand up.

took her by the hand: In some languages it is necessary to specify whether Jesus grasped the woman’s left hand or right hand. You may choose whatever one would be more appropriate in your language. The Greek text does not specify which hand.

helped her up: The phrase helped her up means that Jesus helped her to rise from a lying position. It is not clear whether he helped her to sit or to stand. If you need to specify one or the other, you should choose “stand.”

1:31b

The fever left her, and she began to serve them.

- Right then her fever ended/left, and she served them food.
- She became well and began to give them food to eat.

The fever left her: The phrase The fever left her means that the woman’s body cooled and became normal again, and she was well. The context implies that she became well immediately. The phrase The fever left her may be expressed differently in some languages. For example:

she became healthy

her fever/body cooled

and she began to serve them: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as she began to serve them indicates that the woman served or passed food and drink to them. The CEV says:

she served them a meal (CEV)

A translation should not imply that she cooked food for them. 1:12b and 1:32a indicate that Jesus healed her on the Sabbath day, and the law of the Jews forbade people to cook food on that day. A number of scholars comment that the woman prepared a meal, but the TRT (pages 15–16) reminds us of the importance of understanding an event in its historical context. According to the Jewish law, all food to be eaten on the Sabbath day had to be prepared the previous day.

them: Here the pronoun them refers to Jesus and his disciples.

Mark 1:32

Section 1:29–34: Jesus healed many people and expelled many evil spirits

In this section Jesus healed Peter's mother-in-law from a fever. Then the people in the town of Capernaum brought many other sick people to him, and he healed them all. They also brought many people who were bothered by evil spirits, and he made the evil spirits leave them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here is another idea for a heading for this section:

Jesus heals many people

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:14–17 and Luke 4:38–41.

1:32a

That evening, after sunset,

- ¶ When the sun had set that evening,
- ¶ When it was becoming night and the rest day had ended,

That evening, after sunset: The phrase That evening, after sunset refers to early evening, shortly after the sun had set. There was a special reason why the people waited until sunset to bring the sick people to Jesus. The Sabbath, the Jewish rest day, ended at sunset. The Jewish law did not allow people to work on the Sabbath, and they considered it work to carry a sick person.

In many areas the reason that people waited until sunset will not be clear. If that is true in your language, you may want to indicate the reason in some way. For example:

- Translate the cultural meaning of sunset rather than the literal term. For example:

That evening, after the rest day had ended

- Provide a footnote. For example:

The Jewish law did not allow people to work on the Sabbath, and they considered it work to carry a sick person. So they waited until the Sabbath ended at sunset before bringing the sick people to Jesus.

1:32b

people brought to Jesus all who were sick and demon-possessed,

- people from the town took to Jesus everyone who was sick and everyone who had demons controlling them.
- people from the town brought many others who had sicknesses and many people who were possessed by evil spirits to Jesus there.

people: The Greek word that the BSB translates as people is literally “they.” This word refers here to the people who lived in Capernaum. It does not refer specifically to the people who were in the house of Simon and Andrew.

Here is another way to say this:

people in the town brought to Jesus all the sick and those who had demons

brought to Jesus: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as brought indicates that people helped those who were sick to go to Jesus. They may have carried them or supported them as they walked. The form of the word here indicates that this action happened repeatedly. People started bringing the sick to Jesus after sunset and kept bringing them one after the other.

all who were sick and demon-possessed: The phrase all who were sick and demon-possessed refers to two kinds of people: those who were sick and those who were demon-possessed. The word all is a figure of speech here. It emphasizes that very many people were brought to Jesus. The NLT translates it as:

many sick and demon-possessed people (NLT)

demon-possessed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as demon-possessed indicates that demons controlled the people's thoughts and actions. The word demon refers to the same type of spirit as the Greek terms that are often translated as “evil spirit” and “unclean spirit.”

So you may translate demon-possessed in the same way you translated “with an unclean spirit.” See the note on 1:23a.

Mark 1:33

Section 1:29–34: Jesus healed many people and expelled many evil spirits

In this section Jesus healed Peter's mother-in-law from a fever. Then the people in the town of Capernaum brought many other sick people to him, and he healed them all. They also brought many people who were bothered by evil spirits, and he made the evil spirits leave them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here is another idea for a heading for this section:

Jesus heals many people

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:14–17 and Luke 4:38–41.

1:33

and the whole town gathered at the door.

- Everyone in the town came and gathered at the doorway of Simon's house,
- Almost everyone in the town crowded together at the entrance of that house.

the whole town: The phrase the whole town is a figure of speech that represents the people who lived in the town. It is also a hyperbole. It refers here to many or most people in the town. It does not literally mean "every person."

The previous verse already said that all the sick and demon-possessed people were brought to Jesus. So the phrase the whole town refers to an even larger group of people that includes those who were not sick or bringing the sick. The meaning may be translated in various ways. For example:

In fact, the whole town (CEV)

a huge crowd of people from all over Capernaum (NLT96)

gathered at the door: The phrase gathered at the door refers to the area outside the house in front of the door.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

gathered in front of the house (GNT)

gathered in the yard of the house

Use a natural way in your language to refer to a large number of people who come and gather outside a house.

Mark 1:34

Section 1:29–34: Jesus healed many people and expelled many evil spirits

In this section Jesus healed Peter's mother-in-law from a fever. Then the people in the town of Capernaum brought many other sick people to him, and he healed them all. They also brought many people who were bothered by evil spirits, and he made the evil spirits leave them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here is another idea for a heading for this section:

Jesus heals many people

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:14–17 and Luke 4:38–41.

1:34a

And He healed many who were ill with various diseases

- and Jesus healed the many people who were suffering from different sicknesses.
- Jesus healed all the people who were sick, whatever kind of sickness they had.

And He healed many: The Greek word that the BSB translates as many in this context refers to all the sick people who came to Jesus to be healed. In some languages a literal translation might imply that Jesus did not heal all the sick people who came to him. If that is true in your language, you will need to translate in a different way. For example:

And he healed the many sick people

Jesus healed great numbers of sick people (NLT96)

Jesus healed all kinds of terrible diseases (CEV)

healed: The word healed means "cured" or "made well." In this context it indicates that Jesus cured people miraculously. He did not use medicine to cure them. In some languages there is no term that refers unambiguously to miraculous healing. If that is true in your language, you may be able to use a more general expression that is correctly understood in this context. For example:

caused to become well

helped

Make sure that the expression you use refers clearly to miraculous healing.

various diseases: The phrase various diseases indicates here that Jesus healed many kinds of sicknesses. It does not imply that each sick person had several different diseases.

1:34b

and drove out many demons.

- He also expelled the many demons,
- He also commanded all the evil spirits to leave people,
- He also ordered the many evil spirits who controlled people, “Leave^(plur) now.”

and drove out many demons: Jesus drove out demons by commanding the demons to leave. In some languages it may be necessary to translate this clause by using a direct quote. For example:

and commanded many demons, saying, “Leave^(sing) that person.”

If you use a direct quote, you may need to decide whether to use a singular or plural form of a verb like “leave.” Jesus commanded many demons, but he probably commanded them one at a time. Use what is natural in your language for this kind of situation.

drove out: The Greek word that the BSB translates as drove out is literally “cast/threw out.” In this context it means that Jesus caused many evil spirits to stop controlling people. He did this by commanding the evil spirits to leave, as 1:25b indicates.

Jewish people often spoke of evil spirits as being in someone. Different cultures have different ways of speaking about people being controlled by demons and being released from the control of demons. Use a natural expression for this in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

sent the demons away

exorcized the evil spirits

freed people who were controlled by an evil spirit

many demons: There were many demons that were disturbing the people who came to Jesus. He expelled these demons from the people. The phrase many demons does not imply that Jesus did not expel some of the demons. In some languages it may be necessary to make this clear. For example:

the many demons

all the demons

For the word demons, see the note in 1:32b. See also evil spirit in the Glossary.

1:34c

But He would not allow the demons to speak,

- but he did not permit/allow them to speak,
- and he forbade the demons to say anything,
- He told each of the evil spirits, “You^(sing) be quiet,”

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But is often translated as “and,” as in the RSV. In this context it connects two things that Jesus did to the demons. He expelled the demons from people, and he would not let them speak. Connect these two clauses in a natural way in your language.

He would not allow the demons to speak: As in 1:34b, it may be more natural in some languages to express this clause as a direct quote. For example:

...he ordered them, “Be^(sing) silent.”

If you use a direct quote here, you may need to decide whether to use a singular or plural form of the verb or pronoun. See the note in 1:34b.

Some languages use different commands for a person of higher status and lower status. If that is true in your language, you should use a form that is appropriate for a person of higher status giving orders to someone of lower status.

1:34d

because they knew who He was.

- because they knew that he was the Son of God.

because they knew who He was: The clause they knew who He was means in this context that the demons knew that Jesus was the Son of God and the Christ/Messiah. See 1:11 and 1:24. It does not mean that the demons merely knew that his name was Jesus or that he was Mary’s son. Jesus did not want the demons to reveal who he was, because he did not want information about himself to be revealed by evil powers.

He also did not want people to find out that he was the Messiah before he had accomplished what God wanted him to do.

You should translate the phrase who He was in a general way if possible. If a general phrase is not possible or if people understand it to refer to Jesus' name, you may use an expression similar to the one that you used in 1:24. For example:

they knew that he was the Son of God

they knew that he was the Christ/Messiah

General Comment on 1:34c–d

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of 1:34c and 1:34d. For example:

^{34d}But because they knew who he was, ^{34c}he refused to allow the demons to speak. (NLT96)

Mark 1:35

Section 1:35–39: Jesus prayed alone and then preached in other villages

In this section Jesus got up very early in the morning and went out of the town alone to pray. When his disciples found him, they implied that he should come back to town and help more people. Jesus told them that he must go and preach in other villages. Then he and his disciples went to other villages so that he could preach there also.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other ideas for this section heading:

Jesus prays in an isolated place

Jesus preached in other villages in Galilee

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 4:23 and Luke 4:42–44.

1:35a

Early in the morning, while it was still dark,

- ¶ On the next day/morning, long before sunrise,
- ¶ Before it was light the next morning,

Early in the morning, while it was still dark: The phrases Early in the morning, while it was still dark indicate that the next event happened before daybreak, long before the sun rose. For example:

Very early the next morning, long before daylight (GNT)

In the morning, long before sunrise (GW)

Use a natural expression in your language that refers to this time of day.

in the morning: The phrase in the morning refers to the morning immediately after the events in 1:34. For example:

Early the next morning (NCV)

1:35b

Jesus got up and slipped out to a solitary place

- Jesus woke. He left the house and went to an isolated/lonely place
- Jesus got up and walked to a place where he was alone.

Jesus got up and slipped out: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as slipped out is literally “he went out and departed.” It does not mean that Jesus slipped on something and fell down. The phrase may imply that Jesus went out of the house or that he went out of the town. Both implications are true and both may be implied by the next phrase, which says that he went to a solitary place. Consider whether it is necessary in your language to make explicit that Jesus left the house or left the town. For example:

...Jesus got up and left the house. He went out of town... (GNT)

Jesus woke and left the house (NCV)

Jesus got up and went to a place (CEV)

to a solitary place: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as a solitary place refers to a desolate area where there were no people. The word solitary is a form of the same Greek word that the BSB translates as “wilderness” in 1:3a. See the note there. This was a place where Jesus could be alone.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to a remote spot (REB)

to a place where he could be alone (GW)

to an isolated place (NLT)

1:35c to pray.

- to talk to God.
- There he prayed to God.

to pray: The Greek word that the BSB translates as pray indicates here that Jesus spoke to God. The form of the verb that is used here is literally “was praying.” It may mean that Jesus began to pray and was still praying when Simon and the others found him.

Some languages may use different words to refer to specific kinds of prayer, such as requests, thanks, or praise. Here you should use a word or expression that has a general meaning. Avoid a term that may imply magical or meaningless words.

Mark 1:36

Section 1:35–39: Jesus prayed alone and then preached in other villages

In this section Jesus got up very early in the morning and went out of the town alone to pray. When his disciples found him, they implied that he should come back to town and help more people. Jesus told them that he must go and preach in other villages. Then he and his disciples went to other villages so that he could preach there also.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other ideas for this section heading:

Jesus prays in an isolated place

Jesus preached in other villages in Galilee

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 4:23 and Luke 4:42–44.

1:36

Simon and his companions went to look for Him,

- As for Simon and his companions, when they saw that Jesus was not there, they went and searched carefully for him.
- Later, Simon and the others woke up, and they looked for Jesus anxiously.

In this verse the focus of the story changes briefly from Jesus in a solitary place to Simon and his companions back at the house. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate this change of focus in some way. For example:

Now as for Simon and his companions

Simon and his companions went to look for Him:

The Greek text does not say when Simon and his companions went to look for Jesus. The previous verse implies that they went after they woke up and discovered that Jesus was not in the house. In some languages some or all of this implied information may be clear from the context of the story. In other languages it may be clearer and more natural to make some of this information explicit. For example:

Later Simon and the others went out (NLT)

When Simon and his companions woke up and saw that Jesus was not there, they went...

Simon and his companions: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Simon and his companions is literally “Simon and the ones with him.” Simon’s companions may have been the other disciples, but others may also have been included. This phrase may be translated in several ways. For example:

Simon and his friends (GW)

Simon and the others (NLT)

went to look for Him: In this context, the Greek verb that the BSB translates as look for means “search diligently.” It may also imply that Simon and his companions searched anxiously.

Mark 1:37

Section 1:35–39: Jesus prayed alone and then preached in other villages

In this section Jesus got up very early in the morning and went out of the town alone to pray. When his disciples found him, they implied that he should come back to town and help more people. Jesus told them that he must go and preach in other villages. Then he and his disciples went to other villages so that he could preach there also.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other ideas for this section heading:

Jesus prays in an isolated place

Jesus preached in other villages in Galilee

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 4:23 and Luke 4:42–44.

1:37a and when they found Him,

- When they found him,
- When they saw/located him,

and when: The Greek word that the BSB translates as and when here connects the events in this verse with the events in the preceding verse. In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

They found him

When they found him

they found Him: The phrase they found Him indicates that they discovered where he was. Simon and his friends located Jesus after looking for him for a while. Your translation should not imply that Jesus was lost. Simon did not know where he was, but he was not lost. He himself knew where he was.

1:37b they said, “Everyone is looking for You!”

- they said to him, “All the people in town are looking for you!(sing)”
- they said to him, “Crowds of people are looking for you(sing) in the town. Should we not go back there?”
- they told him that everyone was looking for him.

they said: The Greek word that the BSB translates as they said introduces an exclamation. Consider the content of the quote and the context in which it occurred. You will want to express the emphasis or emotion in a natural way in your language. In some languages this emphasis may be expressed in the words that introduce the exclamation. For example, the NIV has:

they exclaimed (NIV)

Everyone is looking for You!: The quote Everyone is looking for You! implies that the disciples did not understand why Jesus had gone away into an area with no people. They expected him to stay in the town in order to teach and heal all the people who were there. Unless this implied information is clear, Jesus’ reply in 1:38a may be hard to understand.

In some languages it may be necessary to make this information more explicit. Here are ways to do this:

- Use an expression of surprise. For example:

We^(excl) are surprised to find you^(sing) out here! The people in town are all looking for you!^(sing)

So we^(excl) have found you^(sing) out here in the wilderness! Everyone back in town is looking for you!^(sing)

- Use a statement or a question that implies a request for Jesus to return. For example:

Everyone in town is looking for you!^(sing) Maybe we^(incl) should return there.

Do you^(sing) think we^(incl) should return to town? Everyone there is looking for you.^(sing)

Be careful not to imply that Simon and his companions scolded Jesus disrespectfully.

Everyone: In this context the word Everyone refers to “many people.” It does not refer literally to every person. Simon and his companions used this word to give more emphasis to what they said. Another way to express this emphasis is:

So many people are looking for you!

Use a natural way in your language to express this meaning.

is looking: The Greek word that the BSB translates as is looking here implies that everyone wanted to know where Jesus was. They were trying to find him. This word is less emphatic than the word used in 1:36 that implies a diligent search.

Mark 1:38

Section 1:35–39: Jesus prayed alone and then preached in other villages

In this section Jesus got up very early in the morning and went out of the town alone to pray. When his disciples found him, they implied that he should come back to town and help more people. Jesus told them that he must go and preach in other villages. Then he and his disciples went to other villages so that he could preach there also.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other ideas for this section heading:

Jesus prays in an isolated place

Jesus preached in other villages in Galilee

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 4:23 and Luke 4:42–44.

1:38a

But Jesus answered, “Let us go on to the neighboring towns

- But Jesus/he said, “Let us^(incl) go anyway to the other villages that are close by,
- Jesus answered, “That is true, but we^(incl) must go instead to the people of other villages close to this place.
- Jesus replied that they^(incl) should go to the other villages that were close by

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But is a common connector that is often translated as “and,” as in the RSV. Here, Jesus’ reply contrasted with what the disciples expected him to say. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this contrast explicit in the quote introducer, as the BSB does. The contrast may also be made explicit in the quote. See the examples at the end of the note for “Let us go” down below.

Jesus answered: The word answered refers here to Jesus’ response to what Simon and his companions said in 1:37b. In some languages a word like answered or “replied” is only used in response to a question. Decide whether it is appropriate here in your language.

Let us go: In this context, the phrase that the BSB translates as Let us go is a gentle command or invitation. Jesus implied that he and his disciples should or must go somewhere else. For example:

We should go (NCV)

We must go (GNT)

In some cultures, a person who directly disagrees with what someone else has suggested is considered to be rude. In Greek Jesus’ statement was not rude. Consider how to express it in your language without implying disrespect. For example:

Yes, that is true, but we need to go...

Yes, but isn’t it necessary for us to go...?

on to the neighboring towns: The Greek word that the BSB translates as on is more literally “elsewhere.” This word refers to somewhere other than Capernaum. The Greek word that the BSB translates as towns refers to villages or small towns. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

somewhere else, to the small towns that are nearby (GW)

to other towns around here (NCV)

1:38b

so I can preach there as well,

- in order that I may also preach to the people there.
- We^(incl) need to do that so that I can also tell the people there the good news from God,
- so that he could proclaim the good news there, too.

so I can preach there as well: The clause so I can preach there as well is a purpose clause. Jesus went to other nearby towns in order to preach to the people there also. He did not want to limit himself to preaching to people in one location.

preach: The Greek word that the BSB translates as preach means to publicly tell people something important. It is the same word that is used in 1:14b. See the note there. In this context, it refers to the same kind of action as “teach” in 1:21c.

If it is necessary to make the object of preach explicit here, you may use the same phrase that you used in 1:21c. For example:

preach God’s message to the people

1:38c

for that is why I have come.”

- That is the reason that I came here.”
- because this is why I came here.”
- He said, “That is why I came.”

for that is why I have come: This part of the verse indicates that 1:38a–b was the purpose for Jesus’ coming. He came to preach to people in many places, not just to people in Capernaum. It is better not to specify whether Jesus came from heaven or from Capernaum. The place that Jesus came from is not in focus here. If it is necessary to say where Jesus came to, you should use a general place like “here.” For example:

for that is why I came here.

This part of the verse is the end of Jesus' response to the disciples. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate the end of a quote explicitly. For example:

“for that is the reason that I came here,” he said.

“for that is the reason that I came here.” After Jesus said that...

Mark 1:39

Section 1:35–39: Jesus prayed alone and then preached in other villages

In this section Jesus got up very early in the morning and went out of the town alone to pray. When his disciples found him, they implied that he should come back to town and help more people. Jesus told them that he must go and preach in other villages. Then he and his disciples went to other villages so that he could preach there also.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other ideas for this section heading:

Jesus prays in an isolated place

Jesus preached in other villages in Galilee

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 4:23 and Luke 4:42–44.

1:39a

So He went throughout Galilee,

- So/Then Jesus and his disciples traveled through the entire region of Galilee,
- After Jesus said that, they walked to the various towns in Galilee.

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So is the common conjunction that is often translated as “And,” as in the RSV. It introduces the conclusion of this section. It also introduces what happened as a result of what Jesus said in 1:38. Introduce these things in a natural way in your language.

He went throughout Galilee: The word He refers here to Jesus. The focus of the sentence is on Jesus and what he did in Galilee. The word He does not imply that Jesus abandoned the disciples and went throughout Galilee without them. In some languages, it may be necessary to make explicit that the disciples went with Jesus. For example:

Jesus and his companions/disciples...

went throughout Galilee: The phrase went throughout Galilee indicates that Jesus and his disciples walked from place to place through the whole region of Galilee.

1:39b

preaching in their synagogues

- and he/Jesus preached in their synagogue buildings,
- In each town, they went to the meeting place, and Jesus taught/told the people the good news from God.

preaching: For the word preaching, see the note in 1:38b. In this context, it indicates that Jesus preached repeatedly. In each town he went to the synagogue and preached to the people there.

their synagogues: In the Jewish culture, Synagogues were buildings where Jewish people prayed, read Scripture, taught their beliefs, and worshiped. The same word occurs in 1:21b, 1:23b, and 1:29a. Here it refers to the synagogues that were in the towns in Galilee. The pronoun Their refers to the people in those towns. See synagogue in the Glossary.

1:39c

and driving out demons.

- and he commanded/caused evil spirits to leave people.
- He also expelled demons.

driving out demons: The phrase driving out demons indicates that Jesus was causing evil spirits to release their control over people and to leave them. See the note on 1:34b. See also evil spirit in the Glossary.

General Comment on 1:39b–c

In some languages, the phrases with the words preaching and driving out may need to be expressed as main verbs. For example:

he preached...and he drove out

Use ways that are natural in your language to express these phrases and to connect them with each other.

Mark 1:40

Section 1:40–45: Jesus healed a man with a skin disease called “leprosy”

In this section, Jesus healed a man who had a skin disease that is sometimes called “leprosy.” The Jewish law declared that such a person was ritually unclean and therefore was an outcast. He could not go to the

temple to worship God until he was cured. If he was cured, he had to make certain sacrifices to God before people would consider him “clean” again. The law did not allow anyone even to touch such a person. But Jesus touched the man and healed him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The healing of an outcast

Jesus healed a man with a dreaded skin disease

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:1–4 and Luke 5:12–16.

1:40a

Then a leper came to Jesus,

- ¶ A man with a dreaded skin disease called leprosy came to Jesus.
- ¶ A certain man came to Jesus. This man was sick with a terrible skin disease.

Then a leper came to Jesus: This sentence begins a new story and introduces a new person. Consider how you would introduce this story and person in a natural way in your language.

Here are some other ways to do this in English:

There was a certain man who came to Jesus. He had leprosy...

One day a man came to Jesus. This man was sick with leprosy...

leper: The Greek word that the BSB translates as leper refers to a person who has a disease called “leprosy.” The word “leprosy” refers to several different skin diseases. Scholars disagree as to whether these diseases included modern-day leprosy (Hansen’s disease). They agree that in New Testament times the Greek word referred to dreaded skin diseases. People believed that these diseases were spread by contact with someone who had the disease. A person who had one of these diseases was also considered ritually unclean. Some ways to translate this word are:

- Use a general phrase that describes the nature or significance of the disease. For example:

a man suffering from a dreaded skin disease (GNT)

a man with a serious skin disease (GW)

a man with a contagious skin disease

- Use a term that refers specifically to leprosy. For example:

a man with leprosy

a man with something like leprosy

A term that refers specifically to leprosy may be appropriate in areas where readers are already familiar with the term “leprosy.” If you decide to use a word meaning “leprosy,” it is recommended that you add a footnote to give more information. For example:

The disease that is mentioned here refers to various contagious and dreaded skin diseases. A person who had one of these diseases was considered ritually unclean. According to the Jewish law, he was not allowed to associate with other people or to worship in the Temple.

Jesus: Here the Greek text is literally the pronoun “him” (as in the RSV). The pronoun “him” refers to Jesus. Since this is the beginning of a new section, it may be natural in your language to use the name Jesus here, as the BSB does.

1:40b

begging on his knees:

- He knelt down and begged Jesus for help, saying,
- He humbly begged Jesus to heal him. He said,

begging on his knees: The phrase on his knees indicates that the man knelt on the ground. He knelt like this to show that he was coming to Jesus in a very humble way. He showed great respect to Jesus as he requested his help.

In some cultures, kneeling may not show humility. It may even have a different meaning. If that is true in your language, here are some other ways to translate this:

- Translate the action and explain the meaning. For example:

getting on his knees to show humility and begging Jesus

kneeling to show respect as he urgently asked Jesus to help him

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

humbly begging Jesus to help him

- Use an idiom that shows humility in your language.

1:40c

“If You are willing, You can make me clean.”

- “If you^(sing) will, you^(sing) are able to heal me and make me ritually pure.”
- “You^(sing) have the power to heal me if you^(sing) want to, and then I will be ritually clean. Please, will you heal me?”

If You are willing, You can make me clean: This statement indicates that the man with leprosy believed that Jesus had the power to heal him. But he did not know whether Jesus was willing to do it. This statement was a polite way for the man to ask Jesus to heal him.

In some languages it may be necessary to make that request explicit. For example:

I know that if you want to, you can make me clean.
So please, I beg you, to heal me.

If you are willing, you can make me clean, so will you please heal me?

Notice that the second example expresses the man’s request as a question. This makes it more polite in some languages. Consider how the man would express his request politely in your language.

make me clean: The phrase make me clean in this context means “make me ritually clean by healing me.” It does not refer to cleansing from physical dirt.

According to Jewish law, people with the skin disease called “leprosy” were ritually unclean or impure. They were not allowed to participate in public religious ceremonies or to worship God in the temple. They had to live away from other people who did not have this disease. When they were healed, they became ritually clean, and then they were allowed to enter the temple again and participate in community activities.

Here are several ways to translate the phrase make me clean:

- Translate both the idea of healing and the idea of causing the man to become ritually clean. Translate

the ideas in a natural order in your language. For example:

you can heal me and make me ritually clean

you can heal me so that I will be ritually pure

- Translate only the idea of healing here. For example:

you have the power to make me well

- Translate only the idea of causing the man to be ritually clean. For example:

you can make me ritually clean so I can worship God and be around people again

Mark 1:41

Section 1:40–45: Jesus healed a man with a skin disease called “leprosy”

In this section, Jesus healed a man who had a skin disease that is sometimes called “leprosy.” The Jewish law declared that such a person was ritually unclean and therefore was an outcast. He could not go to the temple to worship God until he was cured. If he was cured, he had to make certain sacrifices to God before people would consider him “clean” again. The law did not allow anyone even to touch such a person. But Jesus touched the man and healed him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The healing of an outcast

Jesus healed a man with a dreaded skin disease

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:1–4 and Luke 5:12–16.

1:41a

Moved with compassion, Jesus reached out His hand and touched the man.

- Jesus felt much pity for the man, so he extended his hand and touched him.
- Jesus felt very sorry for the man. So he reached out and put his hand on the man.
- Jesus thought, “I am greatly concerned for this man.” Then Jesus touched him with his hand.

Moved with compassion, Jesus reached out His hand and touched the man: The phrase Moved with compassion gives the reason for Jesus' action in this sentence. Jesus touched the man because he felt much compassion for the man.

Here are some other ways to show the connection between Jesus' compassion and his action:

Jesus was filled with pity, and reached out and touched him. (GNT)

Jesus felt sorry for the man. So he put his hand on him... (CEV)

Moved with compassion: There is a textual issue in this verse: (1) Most manuscripts have a Greek word that means "to be moved with pity." (2) Some other manuscripts have a different word that means "angry." It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with most versions. The Greek word that the BSB translates with the idiom Moved with compassion indicates that Jesus felt much pity for the man with leprosy.

Here are some other ways to translate Moved with compassion:

Moved with pity (NLT96)

Jesus cared greatly about him

Jesus thought, "I am deeply concerned for this man."

Jesus reached out His hand and touched the man: The phrase reached out His hand emphasizes the action touched. It showed amazing compassion for a person to touch someone with leprosy.

In some languages it may sound unnatural to say that Jesus "reached out his hand" because this action is implied by the phrase touched the man. If this is true in your language, use a natural way to express the action in your language. For example:

reached out and touched him (GNT)

1:41b

"I am willing," He said. "Be clean!"

- Jesus said to him, "I am willing to do that. Be well."

- Jesus said to him, "I do want to heal you and purify you^(sing). Now you^(sing) are well/clean."

I am willing: The phrase I am willing means here, "I am willing to do as you ask" or "I do want to heal you."

He said: In Greek the phrase that the BSB translates as He said occurs at the beginning of 1:41b. The BSB has placed it after "I am willing." Place this phrase where it is natural in your language.

Be clean!: The command Be clean! indicates here that Jesus was healing the man and that he was also making him ritually pure. In some languages it may not be natural to use a command to express this idea. It may be necessary to indicate that Jesus himself was doing these actions. For example:

You are now pure. I heal you.

I take away your leprosy and make you ritually clean.

Now you are well. (CEV)

If you have healers in your culture, they may use an expression to pronounce someone well. Consider whether an expression like that would be appropriate for Jesus to say here.

Mark 1:42

Section 1:40–45: Jesus healed a man with a skin disease called "leprosy"

In this section, Jesus healed a man who had a skin disease that is sometimes called "leprosy." The Jewish law declared that such a person was ritually unclean and therefore was an outcast. He could not go to the temple to worship God until he was cured. If he was cured, he had to make certain sacrifices to God before people would consider him "clean" again. The law did not allow anyone even to touch such a person. But Jesus touched the man and healed him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The healing of an outcast

Jesus healed a man with a dreaded skin disease

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:1–4 and Luke 5:12–16.

1:42

And immediately the leprosy left him, and the man was cleansed.

- Immediately the man was healed from leprosy.
- Instantly, the man became well, and he was cleansed from the terrible skin disease.

And immediately: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as *And immediately* introduces what happened when Jesus spoke to the man. As soon as Jesus spoke, the man was healed. This is the climax of the story. Introduce this climax in a natural way in your language.

the leprosy left him, and the man was cleansed: The phrase *the leprosy left him* refers to the same event as *the man was cleansed*. This repetition is another way that the author emphasized the climax of the story. Consider how to emphasize it in a natural way in your language.

In some languages it may not be possible to speak of leprosy leaving someone. If that is true in your language, use a different way to express the idea. For example:

his skin disease disappeared and he was well again

he was completely healed/cured of his leprosy

the man was cleansed: The verb *was cleansed* is passive. In some languages it may be more natural not to use a passive verb. For example:

He was/became clean

Jesus had cleansed him

cleansed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *cleansed* is another form of the same word that the BSB translated as “Be clean!” in 1:41b. You may want to translate in a similar way here. However, in some languages it may be more natural to focus more on the healing in this part of the verse. For example, the NIV says:

cured (NIV)

Mark 1:43

Section 1:40–45: Jesus healed a man with a skin disease called “leprosy”

In this section, Jesus healed a man who had a skin disease that is sometimes called “leprosy.” The Jewish law declared that such a person was ritually unclean and therefore was an outcast. He could not go to the temple to worship God until he was cured. If he was cured, he had to make certain sacrifices to God before people would consider him “clean” again. The law did not allow anyone even to touch such a person. But Jesus touched the man and healed him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The healing of an outcast

Jesus healed a man with a dreaded skin disease

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:1–4 and Luke 5:12–16.

1:43–44

In some languages it may be helpful to combine 1:43–44 and change the order of some of the information. See the General Comment on 1:43–44 at the end of the notes on 1:44e for an example.

1:43

Jesus promptly sent him away with a stern warning:

- Then Jesus sent the man away, but first he sternly warned him:
- Jesus spoke harshly to him before he sent him away.
- Then Jesus spoke sternly to him.

Jesus promptly sent him away with a stern warning: In Greek this part of the verse literally says, “and having sternly warned him, immediately he sent him away.”

Here are some other ways to express this in English:

Then Jesus spoke sternly to him and sent him away at once. (GNT)

After Jesus strictly warned the man, he sent him on his way. (CEV)

promptly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *promptly* is often translated as “immediately.” It

indicates that Jesus did not delay in sending the man away.

sent him away: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sent...away means “told/commanded to go away.” It indicates that Jesus spoke forcefully. He ordered the man to leave. See the note “drove Jesus” in 1:12.

with a stern warning: The Greek word that the BSB translates as stern warning is literally “speak harshly to.” The words a stern warning indicate that the warning was emphatic. Use a natural way in your language to indicate that Jesus spoke sternly. In some languages it may be natural to indicate this in your translation of Jesus’ words in 1:44.

Mark 1:44

Section 1:40–45: Jesus healed a man with a skin disease called “leprosy”

In this section, Jesus healed a man who had a skin disease that is sometimes called “leprosy.” The Jewish law declared that such a person was ritually unclean and therefore was an outcast. He could not go to the temple to worship God until he was cured. If he was cured, he had to make certain sacrifices to God before people would consider him “clean” again. The law did not allow anyone even to touch such a person. But Jesus touched the man and healed him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The healing of an outcast

Jesus healed a man with a dreaded skin disease

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:1–4 and Luke 5:12–16.

1:44a

“See that you don’t tell anyone.”

- “Be sure that you^(sing) do not tell anyone that I healed you^(sing).”
- He said, “Do not tell anyone at all that I healed you^(sing).”

In the Greek text, this verse starts with the phrase “and he said to him.” The BSB and some English versions have not translated this phrase because Jesus’ words are already introduced by 1:43. The RSV, GNT and other English versions do include this phrase.

See that you don’t tell anyone: The clause See that you don’t tell anyone is a stern warning. It is the type of warning that a father would give to a son who might not want to follow his instructions.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as See that emphasizes Jesus’ warning in this part of the verse. It does not refer to looking with the eyes (or even thinking with the mind). Use a natural way in your language to emphasize what Jesus said. For example:

Listen, don’t tell anyone about this. (GNT)

Be sure not to tell anyone about this.

In some languages there may be a special verb form or other way to indicate emphasis.

1:44b

But go, show yourself to the priest

- But go^(sing) to the priest and show him that you are well.
- Instead, go to the priest at the temple and let him examine you.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But indicates contrast. In 1:44a Jesus told the man what he should not do. In this part of the verse Jesus told him what he should do. Express the connection in a natural way in your language.

go, show yourself to the priest: These two commands contain implied information that was understood by Mark’s readers. This implied information may be displayed like this:

Go to Jerusalem, show yourself to the priest who is performing his duties in the temple. Most commentators (including UBS page 66, France page 119, and Lane page 87) agree that official pronouncements regarding leprosy were made only by the priest on duty at the temple in Jerusalem. It is possible that the man went first to a local priest, but the prescribed animal sacrifices could be offered only in Jerusalem, and only there was a person pronounced clean.

This implied information may not need to be made explicit in a translation. However, it does explain that Jesus commanded the man to go to the temple. It also explains who “the priest” was. It was not just any priest. It was the priest who was on duty at the temple in Jerusalem at that time.

In some languages the verb “go” may require a location, or a definite noun such as “the priest” may require more information. If this is true in your language, you may need to make some of the implied information explicit.

show yourself: The phrase show yourself is a command. It means that the man should ask the priest to examine him and confirm that he no longer had leprosy.

One way to translate this idea is as the GNT has done:

go straight to the priest and let him examine you
(GNT)

priest: A Jewish priest was a man who offered sacrifices to God on behalf of the people. He also performed other religious rituals for them. He had the authority to declare that a person who had been ritually unclean was now clean. Some ways to translate priest are:

- Use a descriptive term that focuses on the function of a priest. For example:

sacrificer

man/person who offers sacrifices to God

one who represents people to God

- Use a local word for priest. This option may be acceptable if the duties of a local priest are similar to those of a Jewish priest. You may need to indicate that the word refers to a Jewish priest. For example:

Jewish people's priest/sacrificer

If possible, you should choose a term that can be used in both Old Testament and New Testament contexts. Remember that in the book of Hebrews believers are called priests and Christ is called our high priest.

1:44c

and present the offering Moses prescribed

- Then sacrifice/offer^(sing) to God what Moses wrote in his law long ago,
- Give the offerings to God that Moses commanded people who are healed from leprosy to offer,

1:44d

for your cleansing,

- so that you can be pronounced ritually clean.

- so that the priest can declare that you are ritually pure.

1:44c-d

present the offering Moses prescribed for your cleansing: In the Old Testament God gave laws to Moses for the Jewish people. These laws included detailed instructions about what a person should do after he had been healed of leprosy. These commands for purification are found in Leviticus 14:2-31.

Moses wrote these laws for all the Jewish people. Your translation should not imply that Moses had given his command only to the particular person whom Jesus healed. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

that Moses commanded people who were healed from leprosy to offer

A person who was healed was required to bring to the temple two birds, three lambs, grain, and oil. The priest who served in the temple would then offer these as sacrifices to God.

present the offering: In this context the phrase present the offering indicates that the healed man should give the offering to the priest. The priest would present the offering to God.

Here is another way to translate this:

cause the offering to be presented

Moses prescribed: Moses wrote down God's laws about leprosy long before Jesus was born. Your translation should not imply that Moses was living at the same time as Jesus.

for your cleansing: The phrase for your cleansing indicates the purpose for which the man must present the offering. The Law of Moses required a person who was healed from leprosy to offer certain sacrifices to God. Then the priest would declare that he was ritually clean. He would be able to worship again at the temple and associate with others in the community. Another way to translate for your cleansing is:

so that you will become ritually clean

1:44e

as a testimony to them.”

- Then everyone will know that you are well.”
- This will be proof to people that you are really healthy again.”

as a testimony to them: In this context the phrase as a testimony to them means “to prove to the people. Some scholars believe that “them” refers to the priests. When the priests examined the man who was healed, it might prove to them that Jesus had the power to heal leprosy. It might also be an accusation against them because they refused to believe who Jesus was. that you are well.” After the priest had declared the man to be clean/well, he could participate in public worship and live with his family again. People would believe that he was healthy because the priest had declared that he was clean.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

as evidence to them (NJB)

to prove to everyone that you are cured (GNT)

This will show the people what I have done. (NCV)

General Comment on 1:43–44

Jesus sent the man away after he healed him. Before Jesus sent him away, Jesus first warned the man and gave him instructions. In some languages it may be more natural to combine these verses and change the order of the information. For example:

⁴³Jesus sternly warned him, saying, ^{44a}“See that you do not tell anyone. ^{44b}But go, show yourself to the priest ^{44c}and present the offering that Moses prescribed ^{44d}for your cleansing, ^{44e}as a testimony to them.” ⁴³As soon as Jesus said this, he sent the man away.

In your translation, both verse numbers (43–44) can be written at the beginning of verse 43.

Mark 1:45

Section 1:40–45: Jesus healed a man with a skin disease called “leprosy”

In this section, Jesus healed a man who had a skin disease that is sometimes called “leprosy.” The Jewish law declared that such a person was ritually unclean and therefore was an outcast. He could not go to the temple to worship God until he was cured. If he was cured, he had to make certain sacrifices to God before people would consider him “clean” again. The law did not allow anyone even to touch such a person. But Jesus touched the man and healed him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The healing of an outcast

Jesus healed a man with a dreaded skin disease

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:1–4 and Luke 5:12–16.

1:45a

But the man went out and openly began to proclaim

- But the man left that place and spoke to many people
- But the man did not obey Jesus. He walked around and told everyone,
- But the man talked so much

But: In this context the Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces a contrast. Although Jesus had warned the man not to tell other people, the man disobeyed. Express the contrast in a natural way in your language.

the man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the man is literally “he,” as in the RSV. The BSB uses the phrase the man so that it is clear that Jesus is not the one who “went out.” Refer to the man in a way that is natural in your language.

went out: The words went out indicate here that the man left that place.

openly began to proclaim: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as openly began to proclaim is literally “began to proclaim much.” It indicates that the man told many people that Jesus had healed him.

1:45b

and spread the news.

- and told them that Jesus had healed him.
- “Jesus healed/cleansed me.”
- about what had happened that people from many places heard about Jesus.

spread the news: The phrase spread the news is an idiom. It indicates that the man told many people in different places about what Jesus had done for him.

1:45c

Consequently, Jesus could no longer enter a town in plain view,

- And so Jesus could not enter a town at times when people would see him, because very many people would come to him.

- Because of that, so many people wanted to get help from Jesus that he could not easily/publicly enter a town.

Consequently: The word Consequently introduces what happened as a result of the man's actions in 1:45a–b.

Here are some other ways to express the connection in English:

so that (NET)

As a result (NIV)

The result was that

Jesus could no longer enter a town in plain view:

This sentence includes implied information: So many people wanted Jesus to heal them that he could not enter a town openly. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

Jesus could no longer enter a town in plain view because so many people would crowd around him to be healed

in plain view: The phrase in plain view in this context means “publicly.” Jesus could no longer enter a town freely and easily, in the normal way. If people saw him, they crowded around him.

1:45d

but He stayed out in solitary places.

- Instead he lived away from the towns in areas where few people lived.
- He stayed away from towns and went to places where no people had settled.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but introduces what Jesus had to do because he could not enter towns publicly. In some languages it may not be necessary to translate it explicitly.

solitary places: The Greek word that the BSB translates as solitary places refers to isolated areas where few people lived. It is the plural of the Greek word used in 1:3a (“wilderness”) and 1:4a (“wilderness”).

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

deserted places (NJB)

places where he could be alone (GW)

countryside

places where there were few/no people

1:45e

Yet people came to Him from every quarter.

- But the people still kept coming to him from many places.
- Even so, people came/went to him from many different areas.

Yet: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Yet is often translated as “and,” as in the RSV. However, in this context it introduces an unexpected action on the part of the people.

Here are some other ways of expressing this unexpected action:

Even so, people from all around (NJB)

but people still came to him (CEV)

people came to Him from every quarter: The phrase every quarter is a hyperbole. It indicates that people came to him from many places. If your readers will think this meant that people from every place in the world came to him, you may need to say something like this:

people came to him from many different places

Mark 2:1

Section 2:1–12: Jesus healed a paralyzed man and forgave his sins

In this section, some people brought a paralyzed man to Jesus. They hoped that Jesus would heal him. First, Jesus told the man that his sins were forgiven. Then Jesus proved that God had given him authority to both heal and forgive sins by healing the paralyzed man.

When Jesus said, “your sins,” he was referring to the sins that the man had done in his life. He was not implying that the man had offended him personally. The Jews thought that only God could forgive all of the sins that a person had done. They were offended that Jesus also claimed to have that authority.

You should translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority to forgive people's sins

Jesus healed a paralyzed man

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:1–8 and Luke 5:17–26.

2:1a

A few days later Jesus went back to Capernaum.

- ¶ After several days Jesus went back to Capernaum,
- ¶ Some days after that, Jesus returned to the town of Capernaum.

A few days later: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as A few days later is literally “after some days.” This phrase begins a new story that happened a few days after Jesus healed the man with leprosy in 1:40–45. Begin the story in a natural way in your language.

went: In this context the word went refers to going into the town.

back: The word back indicates that Jesus had been to Capernaum before (see 1:21a).

Capernaum: Capernaum was a small town with probably fewer than two thousand people. In some languages it may be natural to indicate that Capernaum was a town. For example:

to the town of Capernaum

2:1b

And when the people heard that He was home,

- and everyone there soon learned that he was back in town.
- The news/report spread that he was in the house where he normally stayed.
- People said, “Jesus has come home,”

And when the people heard: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the people heard is literally “it was heard.” It means that the people living in Capernaum learned that Jesus had come to a house there. They heard people talking about it. They did not necessarily hear Jesus’ own voice or footsteps.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the news spread (NET)

the people there told one another

that He was home: The phrase He was home in this context indicates that Jesus was in or at a house in Capernaum. It probably implies that he returned to that same house often. It does not imply that he owned the house or that the house was in the town where he was born. Use an appropriate word in your language.

Mark 2:2

Section 2:1–12: Jesus healed a paralyzed man and forgave his sins

In this section, some people brought a paralyzed man to Jesus. They hoped that Jesus would heal him. First, Jesus told the man that his sins were forgiven. Then Jesus proved that God had given him authority to both heal and forgive sins by healing the paralyzed man.

When Jesus said, “your sins,” he was referring to the sins that the man had done in his life. He was not implying that the man had offended him personally. The Jews thought that only God could forgive all of the sins that a person had done. They were offended that Jesus also claimed to have that authority.

You should translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority to forgive people's sins

Jesus healed a paralyzed man

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:1–8 and Luke 5:17–26.

2:2a

they gathered in such large numbers that there was no more room,

- So many people came into the house where he was that there was no space left for anyone else,
- As a result, many people crowded into the house and no one else could find a place in it.
- and a large crowd came to him and filled the whole house where he was.

they gathered in such large numbers that: The phrase they gathered in such large numbers that here means “large numbers of people came to the house, and as a result....”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Many people gathered together and so...

such a crowd collected that... (REB)

there was no more room: The phrase there was no more room indicates that there were so many people in the house that no one else could enter. There was no space left for people to sit or stand inside the house. In some languages it may be more natural to express this idea in a positive way. For example:

the house was full of people

2:2b not even outside the door,

- not even near/outside the house around the door.
- No one else could even get near the door.

not even outside the door: The phrase not even outside the door indicates that people were crowding around the entry to the house. There was no space in the area outside the door for more people to stand. If you used a positive expression for the previous phrase, you may need to express this phrase positively as well. For example:

Even the area outside the doorway was full of people.

2:2c as Jesus spoke the word to them.

- While Jesus was proclaiming God's word to the people,
- Meanwhile, Jesus was telling the people God's message.

This part of the verse tells what Jesus was doing while the people were gathering.

spoke the word: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as spoke the word is literally "was speaking the word." The phrase the word refers to God's word or to God's message. Jesus told the people what God wanted him to tell them.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

taught God's word

made known God's message

to them: The pronoun them refers to the people who were in the house and around the house.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Jesus was speaking [God's] Word to them (GW)

Jesus was teaching them God's message (NCV)

Mark 2:3

Section 2:1–12: Jesus healed a paralyzed man and forgave his sins

In this section, some people brought a paralyzed man to Jesus. They hoped that Jesus would heal him. First, Jesus told the man that his sins were forgiven. Then Jesus proved that God had given him authority to both heal and forgive sins by healing the paralyzed man.

When Jesus said, "your sins," he was referring to the sins that the man had done in his life. He was not implying that the man had offended him personally. The Jews thought that only God could forgive all of the sins that a person had done. They were offended that Jesus also claimed to have that authority.

You should translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority to forgive people's sins

Jesus healed a paralyzed man

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:1–8 and Luke 5:17–26.

2:3a Then a paralytic was brought to Him,

- some other people arrived, bringing a paralyzed man to Jesus.
- As Jesus was speaking, some people brought to him a man who could not walk so that Jesus could heal him.

2:3b carried by four men.

- Four of them were carrying the paralyzed man.
- Four of them were carrying the man on a mat/stretcher.

2:3a–b

This verse tells the next event in the story. This next event probably occurred while Jesus was still preach-

ing. In some languages it may be necessary to use an introductory expression here. For example:

As he was preaching...

Then a paralytic was brought to Him, carried by four men: In Greek the expression that the BSB translates as a paralytic was brought to Him is literally “they came, bringing to him a paralytic.” It does not indicate how many people came or whether they were men or women. However, the phrase four men indicates that four people carried the paralytic. At least some of these were men. Scholars have two views about how many people came with the paralytic:

1. More than four people came with the paralytic, and four of them carried him. For example:

Some people came bringing to him a paralytic, carried by four of them. (NET) (BSB, NIV, KJV, NJB, RSV, NASB, JBP)

1. Four people came, all carrying the paralytic. For example:

four men arrived, carrying a paralyzed man to Jesus (GNT) (GNT, CEV, NLT, GW, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

a paralytic was brought to Him: The context implies that the people were bringing the paralytic to Jesus so that Jesus would heal him. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

a paralytic was brought to him to be healed

paralytic: A paralytic is a person who is unable to move some part or all of his body. In this context the paralytic could not walk.

carried by four men: The verb here is passive. If your language would not use a passive verb in this context, you may need to make it active. For example:

four people carried him

four men arrived, carrying a paralyzed man to Jesus (GNT)

In 2:4c Mark indicates that the paralytic was lying on a mat. See the note on 2:4c. In some languages it may be helpful to mention the mat here in 2:3, as well. If

that is true in your language, you can use the same word for it in both verses.

Here is another way to translate this:

carrying him on a mat/stretchers

Some languages have specific words for carrying something by the four corners or carrying something from either end. If your language has such words, one of them may be appropriate here.

Mark 2:4

Section 2:1–12: Jesus healed a paralyzed man and forgave his sins

In this section, some people brought a paralyzed man to Jesus. They hoped that Jesus would heal him. First, Jesus told the man that his sins were forgiven. Then Jesus proved that God had given him authority to both heal and forgive sins by healing the paralyzed man.

When Jesus said, “your sins,” he was referring to the sins that the man had done in his life. He was not implying that the man had offended him personally. The Jews thought that only God could forgive all of the sins that a person had done. They were offended that Jesus also claimed to have that authority.

You should translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority to forgive people's sins

Jesus healed a paralyzed man

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:1–8 and Luke 5:17–26.

2:4a

Since they were unable to get to Jesus through the crowd,

- Because it was so crowded that they could not bring him inside to Jesus,
- They were not able to carry the man to Jesus through so many people, so
- They could not carry the man through the crowd/people to Jesus, so

Since they were unable to get to Jesus through the crowd: This part of the verse explains the reason for the action in 2:4b. Because the men could not get near

Jesus by going through the crowd, they brought the paralytic to him in a different way.

Here is another way to translate this:

They could not get him to Jesus because of the crowd. So....

they were unable to get to Jesus: The phrase they were unable to get to Jesus indicates that they could not bring him all the way to Jesus. The men were unable to reach Jesus while carrying the paralyzed man.

they: The word they here refers to the people who were carrying the paralyzed man.

through the crowd: The phrase through the crowd indicates that so many people were at the door that there was no space for the men to enter.

2:4b

they uncovered the roof above Him, made an opening,

- they made a hole in the roof above where Jesus was
- they climbed on top of the house and dug through the roof above Jesus until they had made a wide hole.

The houses in Capernaum and other places in Israel had flat roofs. There were ladders or stairs so that people could get onto the roof of the house. To make the roof, people put wooden beams and smaller poles and sticks across the walls. These beams and poles were covered with thatch and then with a layer of tiles that were made of burnt clay. That is the reason that the men could dig through it and make a hole in it.

they uncovered the roof above Him, made an opening: Here the author used two different ways to express a similar meaning. The men uncovered the roof by making an opening in it. You may need to say this only once. For example:

They made an opening in the roof

They dug through the roof

they uncovered the roof: The original readers of the Gospel of Mark would have understood that the men climbed stairs to get onto the roof. They would also have known that the roof was flat and the men could walk across it. In some languages it may be necessary to communicate some of this implied information.

Here are several ways to do this:

- Make some of the details explicit in the text. For example:

they climbed stairs onto the flat roof and uncovered it

- Use a footnote to explain how the men got onto the roof.
- Include a drawing of a Galilean home with a ladder or stairs and four men carrying a paralyzed man onto the roof.

Use an appropriate option for your translation.

2:4c

and lowered the paralytic on his mat.

- and lowered the pallet/bed with the paralyzed man on it down in front of Jesus.
- Then they took the man on his mat/stretchers and used ropes to lower him to the floor near Jesus.

lowered the paralytic on his mat: The paralyzed man was lying on a mat when the men lowered him through the roof. The text does not say exactly how the men lowered the mat. Probably they held onto ropes that they had attached to the four corners of the mat. Then they slowly lowered ropes until the man was on the floor in front of Jesus. Describe this in a way that will not be confusing in your language.

mat: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mat refers to a stretcher or pallet that was strong enough to use for carrying a person.

Mark 2:5

Section 2:1–12: Jesus healed a paralyzed man and forgave his sins

In this section, some people brought a paralyzed man to Jesus. They hoped that Jesus would heal him. First, Jesus told the man that his sins were forgiven. Then Jesus proved that God had given him authority to both heal and forgive sins by healing the paralyzed man.

When Jesus said, “your sins,” he was referring to the sins that the man had done in his life. He was not implying that the man had offended him personally. The Jews thought that only God could forgive all of the sins that a person had done. They were offended that Jesus also claimed to have that authority.

You should translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority to forgive people's sins

Jesus healed a paralyzed man

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:1–8 and Luke 5:17–26.

2:5a

When Jesus saw their faith,

- Jesus saw how much faith they had in him,
- When Jesus realized that the man and his friends truly believed that he could heal the man,

When Jesus saw their faith: This part of the verse introduces the way that Jesus responded when he saw what the men had done in 2:4. What they did showed him their faith. In some languages it may be necessary to make 2:5a more explicit. For example:

When Jesus saw what the men had done, he realized that they had faith in him

saw: In this context the word saw means “realized” or “perceived.” Jesus realized that the people had faith. In some languages it may not be natural to say that someone can “see” a person’s faith.

Here are some other ways to express the meaning:

Jesus perceived

Jesus realized

their faith: The phrase their faith probably refers to the faith of the whole group who had brought the paralytic to Jesus. It probably also includes the faith of the paralytic himself.

faith: The Greek word that the BSB translates as faith refers here to the action of believing and trusting Jesus. The men believed that Jesus would heal the paralytic. In some languages it may be more natural to translate faith as a verb. If that is true in your language, you may also need to say what they believed. For example:

Jesus realized that the paralytic and those who brought him believed that he could heal the paralytic

See believe, meaning 3, in the Glossary.

2:5b

He said to the paralytic,

- so he said to the paralyzed man,
- he declared to him

He said to the paralytic: This phrase introduces Jesus’ words to the paralytic in 2:5c. See the General Comment on 2:5b–c at the end of the notes on 2:5c for a suggestion about indirect speech.

2:5c

“Son, your sins are forgiven.”

- “Child, your^(sing) sins are forgiven.”
- “Friend, I forgive your^(sing) sins.”
- that he was forgiving the wrong/evil things that the paralyzed man had done against God.

Son: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Son means “child.” In this context it is a gentle way to address the man who had come to him for help. It does not indicate that the man was a child or that he was a literal child of Jesus. In some languages it may be more natural to use a different way to express this. For example, the CEV says:

My friend (CEV)

your sins are forgiven: The verb are forgiven is passive. Jesus did not say who was forgiving the man for his sins. But the context shows that Jesus meant that he himself was forgiving the man’s sins. It is clear that the people who heard Jesus also interpreted Jesus’ statement in the same way. If this is not clear in your language, it may be necessary to use an active verb and make this explicit. For example:

I forgive your sins.

your sins: In this context the word sins refers to the paralytic’s offenses against God. Jesus used the word in a general way. He was not implying that the paralytic had offended him personally.

If this is not clear in your language, it may be necessary to make it explicit. For example:

I forgive your sins against God

See the note on sins in 1:4d.

sins: The word sins refers to offenses against God. Sins include acts, thoughts, and attitudes that are not what God wants or approves. In Greek, the verb that English versions translate as sin is also a term that

is used in archery to mean “miss the target.” When a person sins, he “misses” the target, that is, he fails to reach God’s standard. A person can also offend God by not doing what God wants him to do.

It is helpful to translate sins with a general term that can include any offense against God. Here are problems to avoid:

1. The term should not imply that only serious crimes like murder or stealing are sins. Other offenses like gossip and greed are also sins.
2. The term should not include accidents or mistakes that are not against God’s will.

Here are some other ways to translate sins:

wrong acts

offenses against God

evil deeds

In some languages it may be natural to translate sins with a phrase that includes a verb. For example:

wrong things that you have done

are forgiven: In this context the verb are forgiven indicates that as Jesus spoke, he was canceling the paralytic’s sins. The man would not be punished for them. God would treat him as though he had not offended him in those ways.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

are taken away

are cancelled

are pardoned

Refer to the way you translated “forgiveness of sins” in 1:4d.

General Comment on 2:5b–c

In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech here. For example:

he/Jesus declared to the paralytic that he was forgiving the sins that he had committed

Make sure that your readers will understand to whom the pronouns refer. If there is any doubt, say explicitly “Jesus” or “the sick/paralyzed man.”

Mark 2:6

Section 2:1–12: Jesus healed a paralyzed man and forgave his sins

In this section, some people brought a paralyzed man to Jesus. They hoped that Jesus would heal him. First, Jesus told the man that his sins were forgiven. Then Jesus proved that God had given him authority to both heal and forgive sins by healing the paralyzed man.

When Jesus said, “your sins,” he was referring to the sins that the man had done in his life. He was not implying that the man had offended him personally. The Jews thought that only God could forgive all of the sins that a person had done. They were offended that Jesus also claimed to have that authority.

You should translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority to forgive people’s sins

Jesus healed a paralyzed man

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:1–8 and Luke 5:17–26.

Paragraph 2:6–12

In this section the teachers of the law reacted to Jesus’ statement that the sins of the paralytic were forgiven. They thought that Jesus was an ordinary person who could not be the Messiah.

2:6a

But some of the scribes were sitting there

- ¶ There were some teachers of the law who were also sitting there.
- ¶ Some experts in the law were sitting in the house,

But: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as But introduces background information. It is not indicating contrast in this case. Use the style that is natural in your language to indicate background information.

scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes is sometimes translated as “teachers of the law,” as in the NIV. The original work of these men was to copy the laws of Moses by hand. In New Testament

times, their main task was to study, interpret, and teach the law of Moses and related Jewish laws and traditions.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

teachers of the Law of Moses (CEV)

teachers of religious law (NLT)

experts on the law

See how you translated this term in 1:22. See also teacher of the law in the Glossary.

there: The word there refers to the fact that the scribes were in the house with Jesus. The scribes were close enough to Jesus to see and hear what was happening.

2:6b

and thinking in their hearts,

- When Jesus said that, they thought,
- and they argued in their minds about this, thinking,

thinking in their hearts: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as thinking in their hearts is literally “reasoning in their hearts.” It indicates that the teachers of the law were thinking about what Jesus had just said, but they did not speak their thoughts out loud. Use a natural expression in your language to describe this.

Mark 2:7

Section 2:1–12: Jesus healed a paralyzed man and forgave his sins

In this section, some people brought a paralyzed man to Jesus. They hoped that Jesus would heal him. First, Jesus told the man that his sins were forgiven. Then Jesus proved that God had given him authority to both heal and forgive sins by healing the paralyzed man.

When Jesus said, “your sins,” he was referring to the sins that the man had done in his life. He was not implying that the man had offended him personally. The Jews thought that only God could forgive all of the sins that a person had done. They were offended that Jesus also claimed to have that authority.

You should translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority to forgive people’s sins

Jesus healed a paralyzed man

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:1–8 and Luke 5:17–26.

Paragraph 2:6–12

In this section the teachers of the law reacted to Jesus’ statement that the sins of the paralytic were forgiven. They thought that Jesus was an ordinary person who could not be the Messiah.

2:7a–c

Each part of this verse expresses something that the religious leaders were thinking.

2:7a

“Why does this man speak like this?”

- “How could he say that this paralyzed man’s sins are forgiven?”
- “Why should this man think that he can forgive sins?”
- “This man should not say that!”

Why does this man speak like this?: This is a rhetorical question that the teachers of the law were asking in their minds. It expresses their disapproval of what Jesus had said. There are two ways to express this rhetorical question:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why would he say such a thing? (CEV)

How does he dare talk like this? (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

This man/fellow should not say that!

Use a natural form in your language to express surprise and disapproval. Translate in a way that would not imply that the question was spoken out loud.

this man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as this man indicates that the teachers of the law felt disrespect or even contempt for Jesus.

speak like this: The words speak like this refer to Jesus’ words to the paralytic, “Your sins are forgiven.”

2:7b

He is blaspheming!

- He is dishonoring God!
- He is doing a terrible thing by acting as if he is God.

- It is blasphemy! (RSV)

blaspheming: The Greek word the BSB translates as blaspheming often means “speaking against God” or “dishonoring God in a serious way.” In this context it refers to claiming to do something that only God had the authority to do. So the NCV says:

speaking as if he were God (NCV)

2:7c

Who can forgive sins but God alone?”

- Who except God can forgive sins?”
- Only God has the authority/power to forgive sins.”
- God can forgive sins but a person cannot.”

Who can forgive sins but God alone?: This is a rhetorical question. The teachers of the law believed that God is the only one who has authority to forgive sins. They used the rhetorical question to express this belief in a very emphatic way. There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a question. For example:

Doesn't he know that only God can forgive sins?

- As an emphatic statement:

No one except God can forgive sins!

Only God can forgive sins. (NCV)

Jesus is just a man. He cannot forgive sins. Only God can forgive sins.

Use whichever form is most natural in your language to emphasize a belief. Do not imply that the teachers of the law were speaking aloud.

forgive: In this context the word forgive refers to canceling sins so that a person will not be punished for them. It is another form of the same word that was used in 2:5c. You should translate in a similar way here.

sins: See the note on 2:5c.

God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as God refers here to the eternal spirit who created everything. He is more powerful than any other spirit, and he is perfectly good and wise. He deserves to be worshipped. Here are some ways to translate God:

- Use a name or title for God that people in your culture already use.

- Use a descriptive term that fits the truth about God that is revealed in the Bible. For example:

Creator

Great Spirit

Ruler of the universe

See how you translated God in 1:1. For more detailed information, see God in the Glossary.

General Comment on 2:7a–c

In some languages it may be more natural to express the parts of this verse in a different order. For example:

^{7a}It is blasphemy for a person ^{7b}to say that a man's sins are forgiven! ^{7c}No one can forgive a person's sins except God.

^{7c}No one can forgive a person's sins except God.

^{7b}This person is blaspheming ^{7a}by saying that the paralytic's sins are forgiven.

^{7c}God can forgive sins, but a person cannot.

^{7a}When this man says he forgives the paralytic man's sins, ^{7b}he is blaspheming against God.

Mark 2:8

Section 2:1–12: Jesus healed a paralyzed man and forgave his sins

In this section, some people brought a paralyzed man to Jesus. They hoped that Jesus would heal him. First, Jesus told the man that his sins were forgiven. Then Jesus proved that God had given him authority to both heal and forgive sins by healing the paralyzed man.

When Jesus said, “your sins,” he was referring to the sins that the man had done in his life. He was not implying that the man had offended him personally. The Jews thought that only God could forgive all of the sins that a person had done. They were offended that Jesus also claimed to have that authority.

You should translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority to forgive people's sins

Jesus healed a paralyzed man

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:1–8 and Luke 5:17–26.

Paragraph 2:6–12

In this section the teachers of the law reacted to Jesus' statement that the sins of the paralytic were forgiven. They thought that Jesus was an ordinary person who could not be the Messiah.

2:8–11

Jesus was comparing two ideas in these verses: forgiving sins and healing a paralyzed man. He used the form of a question to make the people think. He was not saying that either one of these things was easy. They are both impossible for a person to do by himself. Only someone with God's power and authority can do either one of them. In these verses Jesus showed that he had that power and authority.

Many Jews believed that when a person was sick, it was because he or someone in his family had sinned (see John 5:8; 5:14; 9:1–2). They believed that he could not become well until God forgave his sins.

2:8a

At once Jesus knew in His spirit

- Right away Jesus understood
- At once Jesus perceived/realized

At once: The Greek word that the BSB translates as At once indicates that 2:8a happened as soon as 2:7 had happened. Jesus perceived what the teachers of the law were thinking as soon as they had the thoughts.

Here are some other ways that English versions translate this idea:

Immediately (NIV)

Right away (CEV)

knew in His spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as knew in His spirit is an idiom. It means that he “perceived” or “realized.” In some languages there may be a different idiom to express this meaning. For example:

knew in his mind/heart

In other languages it may not be natural to specify a location for knowing. In that case, the phrase in His spirit can be left implicit. For example, both the CEV and GNT have:

Jesus knew what they were thinking

His spirit: The phrase His spirit refers to Jesus' own mind, not to the Holy Spirit.

2:8b

that they were thinking this way within themselves.

- what they were thinking.
- what their thoughts were.

they: The pronoun they refers to the teachers of the law.

thinking this way within themselves: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as thinking this way within themselves is the same idiom as in 2:6b. See the note there.

2:8c

“Why are you thinking these things in your hearts?” He asked.

- He said to them, “Why are you^(plur) thinking those thoughts?”
- Jesus said to the teachers of the law, “You^(plur) should not think like that.”

Why are you thinking these things in your hearts?:

This is a rhetorical question. It functions as a rebuke. Jesus was telling the religious leaders that they were wrong to think that he was blaspheming.

There are at least two ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the GNT says:

Why do you think such things?

- As a statement or command. For example:

You are mistaken/wrong in what you are thinking.

Do not think like that!

Use whichever form is most natural to express a rebuke in your language.

these things: The words these things refer to the teachers' thoughts in 2:7a, 2:7b, and 2:7c.

Mark 2:9

Section 2:1–12: Jesus healed a paralyzed man and forgave his sins

In this section, some people brought a paralyzed man to Jesus. They hoped that Jesus would heal him. First, Jesus told the man that his sins were forgiven. Then

Jesus proved that God had given him authority to both heal and forgive sins by healing the paralyzed man.

When Jesus said, “your sins,” he was referring to the sins that the man had done in his life. He was not implying that the man had offended him personally. The Jews thought that only God could forgive all of the sins that a person had done. They were offended that Jesus also claimed to have that authority.

You should translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority to forgive people's sins

Jesus healed a paralyzed man

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:1–8 and Luke 5:17–26.

Paragraph 2:6–12

In this section the teachers of the law reacted to Jesus' statement that the sins of the paralytic were forgiven. They thought that Jesus was an ordinary person who could not be the Messiah.

2:9

In this verse Jesus asked the teachers of the law a rhetorical question. He asked it because he wanted people to think carefully about his authority. He did not ask it to get information from them. There are two main ways to translate this rhetorical question.

- As a question. For example:

I have said to the paralytic, “Your sins are forgiven.” Would it be easier to tell him, “Rise, take your mat, and walk?”

- As a statement. For example:

Think about this: I have told the paralytic that his sins are forgiven. Consider whether it would be easier to tell him to get up and walk.

Use a form that will express the meaning most clearly in your language.

2:9a

“Which is easier: to say to a paralytic, ‘Your sins are forgiven,’

- Which is easier to do: to tell this paralyzed man, ‘Your sins are forgiven,’
- I said to the paralytic, ‘I forgive the sins you have done against God.’ Would it be easier
- I have told the paralytic that I forgive his sins. Consider whether it would be easier

“Which is easier: to say...?: The phrase Which is easier: to say... introduces a rhetorical question that compares two sayings. These sayings represent two actions: forgiving the paralytic's sins and healing the paralytic.

Both of these actions require God's power. Forgiving sins requires great authority, so in that way, it is harder to do. However, the teachers could not see whether Jesus could really pardon the paralytic's sins against God. They could see that he healed the paralytic if the paralytic really got up from his mat and walked. The majority view about the answer seems to be that saying “your sins are forgiven” is easier because there was no way for people to prove whether it had happened. However, there are other opinions. Some believe that Jesus' question was a trick question because both actions that he mentioned were equally difficult. The question made the teachers of the law think and realize that both these things were impossible for men to do in their own power or authority. A third opinion is that Jesus and his audience would understand healing the man to be the easier of the two actions, since people who had power (from God) to heal were known, but God alone could forgive sins. Following the majority view, Deibler fills out the implied information in the argument in this way: It is easier to say ‘Your sins are forgiven’ [because people won't be able to tell if you are a fake or not]. [It is far more risky] to say ‘Rise up and walk’ [because people can see if it happens]. [I will do something that you consider to be God's prerogative, but which can be easily verified], so that you may know that the Son of Man has the authority on earth to forgive sins, [which you consider to be God's prerogative, but which cannot be visibly verified.]

Consider the way that people in your language would ask such a question. If they do not use comparatives, you may need to express it in a different way. For example:

Is it easy for me to...? Or is easy for me to...?

Which is easy and which is hard...?

to say to a paralytic: The Greek words which the BSB translates as to say to a paralytic introduce a quote within a quote. Jesus was telling the teachers of the law what he had said to the paralytic. See the General Comment on 2:9a–b for an example of using indirect speech here.

paralytic: A paralytic is a person who cannot move some or all of his body. This particular paralytic could not walk. See the note on 2:3.

Your sins are forgiven: In 2:5 Jesus had already told the paralytic that his sins were forgiven. See the note on 2:5c.

2:9b

or to say, ‘Get up, pick up your mat, and walk’?

- or to tell him, ‘Stand up. Take your mat and walk’?
- to say to him, ‘Stand on your feet, take your mat and walk’?
- to tell him to get up and walk home, carrying his mat.

or to say: The phrase or to say introduces different words that Jesus could say to the paralytic. See the note on 2:9a.

‘Get up, pick up your mat, and walk’: This sentence is expressed as a command (or as three commands). If the man obeyed these commands, everyone would be able to see that Jesus had healed him.

mat: The mat refers to the thin mattress or stretcher on which the man was lying. See the note on 2:4c.

General Comment on 2:9a–b

This verse contains two quotes within a quote. Jesus was quoting something that he had said and something that he might say. In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech for these quotes. For example, the CEV says:

Is it easier for me to tell this crippled man that his sins are forgiven or to tell him to get up and pick up his mat and go on home?

Mark 2:10

Section 2:1–12: Jesus healed a paralyzed man and forgave his sins

In this section, some people brought a paralyzed man to Jesus. They hoped that Jesus would heal him. First, Jesus told the man that his sins were forgiven. Then Jesus proved that God had given him authority to both heal and forgive sins by healing the paralyzed man.

When Jesus said, “your sins,” he was referring to the sins that the man had done in his life. He was not implying that the man had offended him personally. The Jews thought that only God could forgive all of the sins that a person had done. They were offended that Jesus also claimed to have that authority.

You should translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority to forgive people’s sins

Jesus healed a paralyzed man

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:1–8 and Luke 5:17–26.

Paragraph 2:6–12

In this section the teachers of the law reacted to Jesus’ statement that the sins of the paralytic were forgiven. They thought that Jesus was an ordinary person who could not be the Messiah.

2:10a

But so that you may know that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins...

- But now I will show you^(plur) that the Son of Man has authority from God to forgive sins on earth.”
- Now I will prove to you^(plur) that I, the Son of Man, have power from God to forgive sins on earth.”

But so that you may know that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins...: This clause expresses Jesus’ purpose for healing the paralytic. He wanted the teachers of the law and everyone else to know that he had the power or authority to forgive sins. In some languages it may be necessary to express this purpose as a complete sentence. For example, the GNT says:

I will prove to you, then, that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins.

Use a natural way in your language to express this.

But so that: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as But so that introduces a purpose clause. There are several ways it can be translated. For example:

I want you to know that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins. (GW)

I will show you that the Son of Man has the right to forgive sins here on earth. (CEV)

But to prove to you that the Son of man has authority to forgive sins on earth... (NJB)

the Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is literally “the Son of the human/person.” Jesus used this title to imply that:

1. he was a true human being, and he represented all people.
2. he came from God and had authority from God.

Try to use an expression that implies both meanings.

Here are some other expressions that translators have used:

the Man whom God Sent

the True Man from God/Heaven

the Representative of Mankind

The Older Brother of All People

In some cases, an unusual title may correctly suggest a deeper meaning. For example:

the Child of a Person

the One who was Born as a Human

Translators have also used expressions that are more literal. These more literal expressions may be appropriate where readers are familiar with a literal title in another version.

In some languages it may be necessary to use a form like “I” or “me” to indicate that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

me, the Son of Man

I who became man/human

on earth: The phrase on earth emphasizes Jesus’ authority to forgive sins here on earth. The people listening to Jesus already knew that God had this authority in heaven.

to forgive sins: In this context the phrase to forgive sins refers to canceling people’s offenses so that God will not punish them for those offenses. See the notes on 2:5c and 1:4d.

General Comment on 2:10a

The BSB uses an ellipsis mark (...) to indicate that Jesus did not end his sentence. Instead he began to talk to the paralytic. Some English versions use a dash to indicate this. Other versions make Jesus’ words a complete sentence. For example, the NLT says:

So I will prove to you that the Son of Man has the authority on earth to forgive sins.

Express this part of the verse in a natural way in your language.

2:10b

He said to the paralytic,

- So he said to the paralyzed man,
- Then he told the man who was paralyzed,
- Then he ordered the paralyzed man to

He said to the paralytic: This part of the verse introduces what Jesus said to the paralytic. He turned from talking to the teachers of the law in 2:10a to speaking to the paralytic in 2:10c. The way you translate this depends partly on the way you translate 2:10a.

Here are some examples from English versions:

Then he said to the paralyzed man (GW)

So he said to the paralyzed man (GNT)

—he turned to the paralysed man—(REB)

Connect 2:10b with 2:10a in a natural way in your language.

Mark 2:11

Section 2:1–12: Jesus healed a paralyzed man and forgave his sins

In this section, some people brought a paralyzed man to Jesus. They hoped that Jesus would heal him. First, Jesus told the man that his sins were forgiven. Then Jesus proved that God had given him authority to both heal and forgive sins by healing the paralyzed man.

When Jesus said, “your sins,” he was referring to the sins that the man had done in his life. He was not implying that the man had offended him personally. The Jews thought that only God could forgive all of the

sins that a person had done. They were offended that Jesus also claimed to have that authority.

You should translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority to forgive people's sins

Jesus healed a paralyzed man

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:1–8 and Luke 5:17–26.

Paragraph 2:6–12

In this section the teachers of the law reacted to Jesus' statement that the sins of the paralytic were forgiven. They thought that Jesus was an ordinary person who could not be the Messiah.

2:11

"I tell you, get up, pick up your mat, and go home."

- "Listen^(sing) to me. Stand up, pick up your^(sing) mat, and go to your house."
- "I am healing you. Stand^(sing) to your feet, pick up your^(sing) mat, and return to your home."
- rise to his feet, pick up his mat, and walk home.

I tell you: The pronoun you is singular and refers to the paralytic. The phrase I tell you emphasizes that Jesus was now speaking to the paralyzed man.

Mark 2:12

Section 2:1–12: Jesus healed a paralyzed man and forgave his sins

In this section, some people brought a paralyzed man to Jesus. They hoped that Jesus would heal him. First, Jesus told the man that his sins were forgiven. Then Jesus proved that God had given him authority to both heal and forgive sins by healing the paralyzed man.

When Jesus said, "your sins," he was referring to the sins that the man had done in his life. He was not implying that the man had offended him personally. The Jews thought that only God could forgive all of the sins that a person had done. They were offended that Jesus also claimed to have that authority.

You should translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority to forgive people's sins

Jesus healed a paralyzed man

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:1–8 and Luke 5:17–26.

Paragraph 2:6–12

In this section the teachers of the law reacted to Jesus' statement that the sins of the paralytic were forgiven. They thought that Jesus was an ordinary person who could not be the Messiah.

2:12a

And immediately the man got up, picked up his mat, and walked out in front of them all.

- All of them watched the man stand up, pick up his mat and walk out of the house.
- All of the people saw the man as he stood up, picked up his mat and went out.
- Immediately, the man stood up, picked up his mat, and left the house. All the people watched him

And immediately the man got up, picked up his mat, and walked out:

The phrase that the BSB translates as "And immediately" introduces what happened when Jesus spoke to the man. As soon as Jesus spoke, the man was healed. He got up and walked out. This is the climax of the story. Introduce this climax in a natural way in your language. See 1:42.

walked out: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as walked out is literally "went out." The man was no longer paralyzed, and he went out of the house to go to his own home.

in front of them all: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates with the idiom in front of them all indicates that everyone there could see what happened. All the teachers of the law and everyone else who was there saw that the man who had been paralyzed could now walk.

2:12b–c

they... glorified God, saying, "We have never seen anything like this!":

Some languages do not have a word like "glorify." If that is true in your language, you may need to express the meaning in a quote. In this context the verb saying already introduces a quote. The words that are said to glorify God can be part of this quote. For example:

They said, "God is very good! We have never seen anything like this!"

2:12b

As a result, they were all astounded and glorified God, saying,

- They were all astonished and they glorified God. They said,
- Everyone was amazed and said, “God is good/great!
- with astonishment. They praised God, saying that

As a result, they were all astounded: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as As a result, they were all astounded is literally “so that they were all amazed” (RSV). It expresses the result of 2:12a. What had happened caused everyone to be amazed. They were amazed that Jesus had healed the paralyzed man and he was now able to walk.

glorified God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as glorified means to speak about how wonderful and excellent someone or something is.

2:12c

“We have never seen anything like this!”

- “We^(excl) have never seen anything as wonderful/amazing as this!”
- “This is the first time that we^(excl) ever have seen someone heal a man who was paralyzed. It is truly astonishing.”
- they had never seen a miracle like that before.

We have never seen anything like this!: This is an exclamation that expresses amazement and joy. The people had never seen a paralyzed man be healed so that he was able to walk again.

Mark 2:13

Section 2:13–17: Jesus chose a tax collector to be his disciple

In this section Jesus called a man named Levi to be his disciple. For the meaning of “disciple,” see the note on 2:15.

Levi was a tax collector who worked for the Roman government. The Roman people had conquered the Jews, and they forced them to pay taxes to Rome. The Romans hired Jews to collect taxes from their own people. The other Jews despised these tax collectors because they worked for the Romans. They also hated tax collectors because they sometimes collected more money than necessary. Then they kept the extra money and became rich.

This story also tells about another conflict that Jesus had with the Jewish religious leaders. After Levi became Jesus’ disciple, Jesus came to have dinner at his house. Levi’s friends, who were also tax collectors or other sinners, also came to the dinner. During the

dinner, the religious leaders criticized Jesus for associating with such people. Jesus answered that it is people who know they are sinners who need him, not those who believe themselves to be righteous.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cares for outcasts

Jesus loves sinners

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:9–13 and Luke 5:27–32.

2:13a

Once again Jesus went out beside the sea.

- ¶ And Jesus again went down to the shore/edge of Lake Galilee.
- ¶ Then Jesus walked out of the town and went to the lake again.

Once again: The phrase Once again introduces a new story. This story is a new event in the larger story about Jesus in Mark.

Here are some other ways to express the connection:

Then Jesus went out to the lakeshore again (NLT)

Jesus went to the lake again

Use a natural way in your language to introduce this new event. Notice that the phrase Once again also indicates that Jesus had done the action in 2:13a before.

Jesus went out beside the sea: The phrase Jesus went out beside the sea indicates here that Jesus left the town of Capernaum to go to the lake.

beside the sea: The phrase the sea refers to Lake Galilee. This is the same lake that was mentioned in 1:16. Refer to the way you translated it there. Since the phrase the sea indicates a specific lake, in some languages you may need to say:

beside Lake Galilee

2:13b

All the people came to Him, and He taught them there.

- Many people went to him and he taught them the message of God.
- A great many people were coming to him, and he was teaching them God's word/talk.

All the people: The phrase All the people refers to many people who gather in the same place. Use a natural expression in your language.

came: The form of the Greek verb came indicates an action that continued. Many people were coming to Jesus and gathering around him.

to Him: The pronoun Him refers to Jesus. He is still in focus in this story. Use a natural way to refer to him here.

He taught them there: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as He taught them there is literally "he was teaching them." In this context it probably means that Jesus was teaching them over a period of time. It may indicate here that he was teaching the people as he walked along.

Mark 2:14

Section 2:13–17: Jesus chose a tax collector to be his disciple

In this section Jesus called a man named Levi to be his disciple. For the meaning of "disciple," see the note on 2:15.

Levi was a tax collector who worked for the Roman government. The Roman people had conquered the Jews, and they forced them to pay taxes to Rome. The Romans hired Jews to collect taxes from their own people. The other Jews despised these tax collectors because they worked for the Romans. They also hated tax collectors because they sometimes collected more money than necessary. Then they kept the extra money and became rich.

This story also tells about another conflict that Jesus had with the Jewish religious leaders. After Levi became Jesus' disciple, Jesus came to have dinner at his house. Levi's friends, who were also tax collectors or other sinners, also came to the dinner. During the dinner, the religious leaders criticized Jesus for associating with such people. Jesus answered that it is people who know they are sinners who need him, not those who believe themselves to be righteous.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cares for outcasts

Jesus loves sinners

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:9–13 and Luke 5:27–32.

2:14a

As He was walking along, He saw Levi son of Alphaeus

- As Jesus continued to walk, he noticed Levi, who was the son of Alphaeus,
- As he was walking, he saw a tax collector named Levi, who was Alphaeus's son.

As He was walking along, He saw Levi: The words As He was walking along, he saw Levi indicate here that Jesus saw Levi during the time that Jesus was walking by the lake.

Levi son of Alphaeus: The phrase Levi son of Alphaeus identifies who Levi was. He was the son of a man named Alphaeus. This is the first time that Levi is referred to in Mark. Introduce him into the story in a natural way in your language.

2:14b

sitting at the tax booth.

- He was sitting at a table where he collected taxes.
- He was sitting at his desk/stall, collecting taxes for the Roman government.

sitting at the tax booth: The phrase sitting at the tax booth implies that Levi was doing his work. He was collecting taxes for the Roman government. The other Jews despised people who did this job. See the discussion about this in the introduction to Section 2:13–17.

tax booth: The tax booth was probably some sort of small table under a shade where Levi sat to receive taxes from the people.

tax: In this context a tax was money that a tax collector received from his own people to give to the Roman government that ruled them. See the discussion about this in the introduction to this section. If you do not have a word in your language for tax, you may need to use a descriptive phrase. For example:

money that was collected for the/another government

money taken from people to pay something to a conqueror

something paid to a conqueror

You may want to include a footnote to explain the meaning of this word. You may also want to explain it in a glossary. For example:

Taxes are money that a tax collector takes from people and gives to the government. In the New Testament, the tax collectors worked for the Romans, who were ruling over the Jews. The tax collectors often cheated people by forcing them to pay more money than they owed. Many Jews despised the tax collectors.

2:14c

“Follow Me,” He told him,

- Jesus said to him, “Follow me.”
- Jesus said to him, “Come with me. Be my disciple.”
- Jesus told him to get up and follow him.

“Follow Me,” He told him: In Greek this part of the verse begins with the words that the BSB translates as He told him. The BSB places these words after the phrase Follow me. Put these words in a natural place in your language.

Follow Me: In this context the phrase Follow me means “become my disciple (or learner or apprentice).” Jesus was inviting Levi to be with him every day, listen to his teaching, observe his actions, and learn from him. See also the note on 1:17a, where a similar phrase is used.

2:14d

and Levi got up and followed Him.

- And he rose and followed him.
- And Levi stood, left his tax desk/stall, and became a disciple of Jesus.

and Levi got up and followed Him: The forms of the Greek verbs that the BSB translates as got up and followed imply that Levi was definite about his action. He left his seat in the tax collector’s booth and went with Jesus so that Jesus could teach him. The Greek verbs emphasize that action of abandoning his work and going with Jesus. Translate this sudden action in a natural way.

Mark 2:15

Section 2:13–17: Jesus chose a tax collector to be his disciple

In this section Jesus called a man named Levi to be his disciple. For the meaning of “disciple,” see the note on 2:15.

Levi was a tax collector who worked for the Roman government. The Roman people had conquered the Jews, and they forced them to pay taxes to Rome. The Romans hired Jews to collect taxes from their own people. The other Jews despised these tax collectors because they worked for the Romans. They also hated tax collectors because they sometimes collected more money than necessary. Then they kept the extra money and became rich.

This story also tells about another conflict that Jesus had with the Jewish religious leaders. After Levi became Jesus’ disciple, Jesus came to have dinner at his house. Levi’s friends, who were also tax collectors or other sinners, also came to the dinner. During the dinner, the religious leaders criticized Jesus for associating with such people. Jesus answered that it is people who know they are sinners who need him, not those who believe themselves to be righteous.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cares for outcasts

Jesus loves sinners

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:9–13 and Luke 5:27–32.

2:15a

While Jesus was dining at Levi’s house,

- ¶ Later Jesus went to eat at the house of Levi,
- ¶ Levi invited Jesus to eat with him. So Jesus and his disciples went to eat at Levi’s house.

While Jesus was dining at Levi’s house: The Greek that the BSB translates as While introduces something that happened later, possibly several days afterwards. Here is another way to translate this word:

Later (CEV)

In some languages it may be necessary to introduce this new action or event with a phrase such as:

Later Jesus went to Levi’s house. He was dining with Levi and others.

Levi invited Jesus to have dinner at his house. Later when Jesus was having dinner there...

dining: The Greek word that the BSB translates as dining indicates that Jesus (and the other dinner guests) were lying down to eat. This was the custom of the times, and it is not necessary to say this explicitly. However, it would be good if the word you use for dining does not exclude the idea of lying down to eat.

Levi's house: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Levi's house is literally "his house." Your translation should make it clear that the house belonged to Levi, not to Jesus. (see Luke 5:29).

2:15b

many tax collectors and sinners were eating with Him and His disciples—

- and many tax collectors and other sinners were also there eating with Jesus and his disciples.
- Many people who collected taxes and many other people who were considered sinners were also there and ate with him and his followers,

tax collectors and sinners: The phrase tax collectors and sinners refers to people whom the Pharisees despised because the Pharisees considered them to be particularly unrighteous. The tax collectors were one group or type of sinners. So in some languages it may be necessary to translate this as:

tax collectors and other sinners

tax collectors: In this context tax collectors received taxes from their own people to give to the people of Rome who had conquered them. See the discussion about this in the introduction to Section 2:13–17. Refer to how you translated "tax" in 2:14b.

sinners: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sinners refers to someone who habitually does what is contrary to God's law. The Pharisees had added many other rules to God's law. They considered people who did not obey those rules to be sinners. Tax collectors were included in this group of people.

The Bible implies that God did not necessarily consider such people to be worse sinners than other people. The NIV indicates this by using quote marks: "sinners," and the GNT translates the word as "outcasts." In some languages there may be a special way to refer to people whom others consider to be bad.

In other languages it may be helpful to include a footnote to explain the use of the word sinners in this context.

eating: In the Jewish culture, to eat with someone implied accepting that person as a friend. The Pharisees considered it inappropriate for a teacher like Jesus to

eat with sinners. If eating with a "bad" person is not considered to be a problem in your culture, consider how to imply the Jewish viewpoint in your language. You may also want to include a footnote to explain this information.

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means "learners" who are in a relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Here are some ways to translate disciples:

- Use a term that refers to people who learn from a teacher or an expert. It is helpful if the term also implies that the learners are often with their teacher. For example:

learners/students

apprentices Be careful not to use a term that would refer only to a student in a school or classroom.

- Use a term that refers to people who follow a teacher or leader by obeying his teaching. It is helpful if this term also implies learning from the teacher and actually following the teacher wherever he goes. For example:

followers

those who are committed/faithful (to a teacher/leader)

See disciple in the Glossary.

2:15c

for there were many who followed Him.

- There were many such people who were followers of Jesus.
- since many people like that were habitually going around with him to learn from him.

for: The Greek word that the BSB translates as for here introduces an explanation of the fact that tax collectors were eating with Jesus and Levi in 2:15b. Use a natural way to connect 2:15b and 2:15c in your language. See the General Comment on 2:15b–c for a suggestion about how to reorder the verse.

there were many who followed Him: This clause indicates that many tax collectors and sinners had become followers of Jesus.

followed Him: The phrase followed Him indicates here that the tax collectors and sinners accompanied Jesus and tried to learn from his teaching and obey it.

General Comment on 2:15b–c

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder these two parts of 2:15. For example:

^{15c}Many tax collectors and sinners were followers of Jesus, ^{15b}so they came to eat with him and his disciples.

Mark 2:16

Section 2:13–17: Jesus chose a tax collector to be his disciple

In this section Jesus called a man named Levi to be his disciple. For the meaning of “disciple,” see the note on 2:15.

Levi was a tax collector who worked for the Roman government. The Roman people had conquered the Jews, and they forced them to pay taxes to Rome. The Romans hired Jews to collect taxes from their own people. The other Jews despised these tax collectors because they worked for the Romans. They also hated tax collectors because they sometimes collected more money than necessary. Then they kept the extra money and became rich.

This story also tells about another conflict that Jesus had with the Jewish religious leaders. After Levi became Jesus’ disciple, Jesus came to have dinner at his house. Levi’s friends, who were also tax collectors or other sinners, also came to the dinner. During the dinner, the religious leaders criticized Jesus for associating with such people. Jesus answered that it is people who know they are sinners who need him, not those who believe themselves to be righteous.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cares for outcasts

Jesus loves sinners

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:9–13 and Luke 5:27–32.

2:16

This verse implies that some scribes were at Levi’s house also or that they were near enough to see Jesus eating. They were disturbed that Jesus was eating with tax collectors and sinners. Introduce the teachers of the law in a natural way in your language. Here is one way to do this in English:

Some scribes were also there. These scribes were part of the Pharisee group. When they saw...

2:16a

When the scribes who were Pharisees

- There were also some teachers of the law there who were from the group named Pharisees.
- Some experts in the law who belonged to the Pharisee party/group

the scribes who were Pharisees: There is a textual issue in 2:16a. (1) Some Greek manuscripts have “the scribes of the Pharisees.” This indicates that some of the Pharisees were also scribes. For example, the CEV says: “Some of the teachers of the Law of Moses were Pharisees” (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NJB, ESV, NASB, REB, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have “the scribes and the Pharisees.” For example, the NET says: “experts in the law and the Pharisees” (NET, KJV, JBP). It is recommended that you follow option (1). This phrase refers to the scribes who belonged to the religious group called the Pharisees. See the notes scribes and on Pharisees below.

scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes refers to teachers of the law. In New Testament times, their main task was to study and teach the law of Moses. The scribes were also mentioned in the preceding story in 2:6. See the note on 2:6a. They were first mentioned in Mark in 1:22. See also teacher of the law in the Glossary.

Pharisees: The Pharisees were a Jewish religious group or party. It was very important to them to obey all of the Jewish religious laws carefully and in detail.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Transliterate the word Pharisees according to the sounds of your language and indicate that it refers to a group of people. For example:

Farisi members

Parise adherents

- Transliterate the word Pharisees and indicate that it refers to a group of people with certain beliefs. For example:

people belonging to the Farise religious sect/
group

members of the Jewish group called the Farasi

You may also want to include an explanation of Pharisees in the glossary of your translation.

2:16b

saw Jesus eating with these people,

- They saw that he was eating with people who were known as sinners, including people who collected taxes,
- noticed that he was sharing a meal with these tax collectors and other people who had a reputation for doing sinful things.

saw Jesus eating with these people: The Pharisees observed what was happening at Levi's house. They noticed that Jesus was being friendly to sinners and tax collectors by eating with them. In some languages it may be possible to use a phrase that suggests friendliness. For example;

saw him sharing a meal with the sinners and tax collectors

these people: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as these people is literally "sinners and tax collectors." See the notes on 2:15b for these words. In some languages it may be natural to use the same order here as you did there:

tax collectors and other sinners

2:16c

they asked His disciples,

- so they asked his disciples,
- Then the teachers of the law said to Jesus' followers,
- Then those experts in the law told Jesus' followers that

they: The pronoun they refers to the Pharisees.

His disciples: The phrase His disciples refers to Jesus' disciples. See the note on "disciple" in 2:15b.

2:16d

"Why does He eat with tax collectors and sinners?"

- "Why does Jesus eat with people who collect taxes and with other sinners?"
- "Jesus should not share meals with tax collectors and other people who sin!"
- he should not be eating with tax collectors and other sinners.

"Why does He eat with tax collectors and sinners?":

This is a rhetorical question. The Pharisees were rebuking Jesus and his disciples. They did not really want to know the reason Jesus ate with the sinners. They wanted everyone to realize that it was wrong for Jesus to eat with despised people and they did not approve of it.

There are two ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the NASB says:

Why is He eating and drinking with tax collectors and sinners?

- As a statement. For example:

He should not eat with tax collectors and other sinners!

It is wrong for him to eat with tax collectors and other sinners!

Use whichever form is most natural for expressing this rebuke and showing disapproval in your language.

eat with: There is a textual issue in 2:16d: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have eat. For example, the GNT says: "eat" (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NJB, NET, ESV, NASB, REB, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV, JBP). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have eat and drink. For example, the KJV says: "eateth and drinketh" (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). However, if the phrase "eat and drink" is a natural way in your language to describe eating a meal with other people, you may follow option (2). Jesus was eating a meal with the tax collectors and "sinners." Use a natural expression in your language to describe this situation.

tax collectors and sinners: Here the Pharisees were speaking about people whom they considered worse sinners than others. Use an appropriate expression in your language. See the notes on 2:15b and 2:16b.

Mark 2:17

Section 2:13–17: Jesus chose a tax collector to be his disciple

In this section Jesus called a man named Levi to be his disciple. For the meaning of “disciple,” see the note on 2:15.

Levi was a tax collector who worked for the Roman government. The Roman people had conquered the Jews, and they forced them to pay taxes to Rome. The Romans hired Jews to collect taxes from their own people. The other Jews despised these tax collectors because they worked for the Romans. They also hated tax collectors because they sometimes collected more money than necessary. Then they kept the extra money and became rich.

This story also tells about another conflict that Jesus had with the Jewish religious leaders. After Levi became Jesus’ disciple, Jesus came to have dinner at his house. Levi’s friends, who were also tax collectors or other sinners, also came to the dinner. During the dinner, the religious leaders criticized Jesus for associating with such people. Jesus answered that it is people who know they are sinners who need him, not those who believe themselves to be righteous.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cares for outcasts

Jesus loves sinners

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:9–13 and Luke 5:27–32.

2:17

In this verse Jesus responded to the Pharisees’ question in 2:16 with a proverb and applied the proverb to his own work. Notice that the proverb and the way that Jesus applied it are parallel, and the similar parts are in the same order:

It is not the healthy who need a doctor, but the sick.

I have not come to call the righteous, but sinners.

Jesus was comparing healthy people to righteous ones and sick people to sinners. He was comparing himself to a doctor.

Jesus used the words “healthy,” “sick,” and “doctor” as figures of speech. The “healthy” people represent people who think that they are already righteous and do not need any help. The “sick” represent people who know that they are sinners and need Jesus’ help. The “doctor” represents Jesus, who can help the sinners to become righteous.

It is important that people understand this figurative meaning. See the General Comment on 2:17a–c and 2:17b and 2:17c in the Display for translation suggestions.

2:17a

On hearing this, Jesus told them,

- When Jesus heard their question, he said to them,
- When Jesus heard what the experts in the law said, he answered them,

In Greek 2:17a begins with a common conjunction that the RSV translates as “And.” In this context it introduces Jesus’ response to the Pharisees. The BSB does not explicitly translate this conjunction, but you should introduce this change in subject in the way that is natural in your language.

On hearing this: This clause indicates that Jesus heard what the Pharisees had asked his disciples in 2:16.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus heard them (GNT)

When Jesus heard that (GW)

this: This Greek word *this* refers to the question that the Pharisees had asked his disciples.

Jesus told them: Although the Pharisees asked their question to the disciples, Jesus is the one who answered it.

told: In this context the verb *told* introduces a comparison that is a proverb. In some languages it may be helpful to use a verb or expression that people use when they tell a proverb or use a comparison. For example:

Jesus responded with this proverb

Jesus answered them with a comparison

them: This word them refers to the Pharisees.

2:17b

“It is not the healthy who need a doctor, but the sick.

- “People who are healthy do not need a doctor; sick people need a doctor.
- “Sick people need a doctor’s help. If they are not sick, they do not need his help.
- “A sinner is like a sick person. He is sick with sin and needs someone to help him, just like a sick person needs a doctor. If he were not a sinner, he would not need that help.

In this verse Jesus was using irony. See the General Comment on 2:17a–c at the end of the notes for 2:17c for an explanation. It is good to read this explanation before you decide how to translate the verse.

It is not the healthy who need a doctor, but the sick:

This verse is in the form of a proverb. Consider how to translate it so that it sounds like a proverb. There may be a traditional saying with a similar meaning in your own language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Sick people are the ones who crowd into the doctor’s house, not healthy ones.

There are no healthy people lining up to see the doctor.

It is not the healthy who need a doctor: The phrase It is not the healthy who need a doctor means that people who are healthy do not need a doctor to cure them. People in Jesus’ time did not go to see doctors when they were well.

need a doctor: In some languages it will be necessary to make explicit in what way people need a doctor. For example:

need a doctor to come and see them

need a doctor to help/heal them

need to consult a doctor

but the sick: The phrase but the sick is an ellipsis. In this context it means “but the sick people are the people who need a doctor.” People who know that they are sick are the ones who will go to a doctor for help.

2:17c

I have not come to call the righteous, but sinners.”

- I have come to invite sinful people, not those who think they are righteous.”
- In the same way, my work is to help sinners to repent; my work is not to help people who think they are righteous.”

I have not come to call the righteous, but sinners:

In this statement, Jesus used the proverb (in 2:17b) to explain the reason that he was eating with sinners. Jesus came to call people who were “sick with sin” to repent and be with him. Jesus did not come to call people who were already righteous. That would be like telling healthy people to go to a doctor.

I have not come to call the righteous: Jesus used the phrase I have not come to introduce a general statement about the purpose of his ministry. He was not referring specifically to his purpose for coming to Levi’s house. In some languages it may be necessary to express the meaning in a different way. For example:

My work is not to call the righteous

call: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as call means “invite.” Jesus did not specify exactly what he was inviting sinners to do. It is likely that he was inviting (telling) them to repent and be his disciples. The call to repent is an important theme in Mark, and the call to be his disciple is an important theme in this context.

the righteous: The Greek word that the BSB translates as righteous refers to people who live according to God’s standards. In other words, they consistently do what is right.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

those who obey God’s law

those who do what is right

In some languages there may be an idiom to describe this. For example:

those who follow a straight path

upright people

In this context Jesus was using irony. There are no truly righteous people because everyone has sinned. He may have referred to people who think that they are doing what is right and do not recognize their sins.

but sinners: The phrase but sinners is an ellipsis. Its full form is “but I came to call sinners.”

sinners: The word sinners refers here to people who have sinned and displeased God.

General Comment on 2:17a–c

In this verse Jesus implied that the Pharisees thought they were already righteous. That was the reason that they would not come to him for help to become truly righteous. Jesus did not mean that the tax collectors and sinners were the only sinners. He implied that they knew they needed him, just like sick people know that they need a doctor. There are other ways to think about the irony here. In one sense, no one fully recognizes his own sinfulness, and there is no one who is truly righteous. It is impossible for a person to see himself as God sees him unless God reveals that to him. Jesus came to offer salvation to all people. He was helping all people to recognize their sinfulness and turn to him, just as sick people turn to a doctor to help them. Only Jesus can make a person truly righteous so that the person is able to always do what is right.

In some languages it may be necessary to make some of the implied information explicit.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

When Jesus heard this, he replied with a proverb, “People who think they are healthy do not go to a doctor. It is the sick people who know that they need a doctor. Like that doctor, my work is not to invite people who think they are righteous to repent. I came to invite those who know that they are sinners to repent.”

When Jesus heard this, he told them, “Healthy people don’t need a doctor—sick people do. I have come to call not those who think they are righteous, but those who know they are sinners.” (NLT)

In some languages it may be more natural to use a different order for some of the information. For example:

When Jesus heard this, he said, “It is sick people who know that they need a doctor. People who think they are healthy do not seek a doctor. I came to invite people who know they are sinners to be

with me. I did not come for those who think they are already righteous.”

Mark 2:18

Section 2:18–22: People asked Jesus about fasting

At the time when Jesus lived, Jewish people often went without eating food for one or more days. They did this to show they were sorry for their sins or to ask for favor from God. This is called “fasting.”

In this section people asked Jesus why he and his disciples did not fast. Jesus answered the question about fasting. Then he indicated that he was teaching a new way to live for God. His new way would not fit into the old traditions. To illustrate this point, Jesus used three comparisons:

1. To explain why his disciples did not fast, Jesus compared himself to a bridegroom, and he compared his disciples to wedding guests. They could not fast while he was with them.
2. To show that his way and the old traditions did not match, Jesus compared his new way to new cloth. The old traditional ways were like an old garment. No one would sew new cloth onto an old garment.
3. Then Jesus compared his new way to new wine and the old way to old wineskins. When new wine was put into old wineskins, both were ruined.

This section can be difficult for people to understand because Jesus used comparisons to illustrate a point, but he did not make the point explicit. The point was that he was teaching a new way that was different from the old Jewish traditions. In some languages it may be necessary to include a footnote to explain this.

In this section there are some ideas that may not be familiar in certain cultures. For example:

1. fasting
2. Jewish wedding customs about bridegrooms
3. sewing patches onto cloth
4. new wine and old wineskins

Consider carefully how to translate each of these ideas in a meaningful way in your language. The Notes for this section will give suggestions.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus taught that his new way was different from Jewish traditions

Jesus’ new way and the old ways

This story also occurs in Matthew 9:14–17 and Luke 5:33–39.

Paragraph 2:18–20

In this paragraph it is important for readers to know what “fasting” meant in the Jewish culture. In this context, “fasting” means to abstain from food for religious reasons. The Jewish people often fasted at times when they were very serious about praying to God. See 1 Samuel 7:5, Matthew 6:16–18, Luke 2:37, Acts 13:2. Often Jewish people would fast for some time to prepare for God to speak to them (see Exodus 24, Daniel 9:3, Matthew 4:2).

John the Baptizer’s disciples and the Pharisees followed these Jewish customs.

2:18a

Now John’s disciples and the Pharisees were often fasting.

- ¶ The disciples of John the one who baptizes people and the Pharisees were fasting.
- ¶ At a certain time John the Baptizer’s followers and the Pharisees were deliberately abstaining from eating food,

This part of the verse is background information. It introduces a situation in which Jesus gave a new teaching. Translate this background information in a natural way in your language.

Now: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now here introduces background information. It is not a time word in this context.

John’s disciples: John had disciples, just as Jesus did. These disciples followed him, learned from him, and tried to obey his teachings. You should use the same word for “disciple” here as you use for Jesus’ disciples. See the note on 2:15b.

John: The name John refers here to John the Baptizer (John who baptized people). See the note on 1:4a. Since more than one John is mentioned in Mark, it may be necessary to make this explicit:

the disciples of John the Baptizer

the disciples of John, the one who baptized people

and the Pharisees: There is a textual issue in 2:18a. (1) Some Greek manuscripts have “the disciples of John and the Pharisees.” For example, the NET says: “John’s disciples and the Pharisees” (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NJB, NET, ESV, NASB, REB, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV).

(2) Some Greek manuscripts have “the disciples of John and those of the Pharisees.” For example, the JBP says: “The disciples of John and those of the Pharisees” (KJV, JBP). Option (1) has better support from Greek manuscripts. However, the phrase “disciples of the Pharisees” occurs in 2:18c. So in some languages, it may be more natural to follow option (2) and use that phrase here as well. The Pharisees were a Jewish religious group or party. They believed that it was very important to obey all of the Jewish religious laws very carefully and in detail. See the note on 2:16a.

fasting: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as fasting means “deliberately abstain from eating for some time.” If fasting for religious reasons is not a familiar idea in your language, you may need to explain it in a footnote or in your translation. For example:

often gave up eating for a certain time (NCV)

going without food to pray/meditate

not eating food for a certain length of time to show that they were devoted to God

2:18b

So people came to Jesus and asked,

- Some people came to Jesus and asked him,
- and/so some people came and said to Jesus,
- Some people approached Jesus and asked him

So: In Greek, 2:18b begins with a common conjunction that the BSB translates as So. Mark used this conjunction to connect what the people saw in 2:18a with what they asked Jesus in 2:18b. Connect these two events in a natural way in your language.

people: The Greek word that the BSB translates as people is literally “they.” In some languages you may need to identify more explicitly who “they” refers to. If that is true in your language, it is probably best to use a general subject, as the BSB does.

came to Jesus and asked: The people who observed the disciples of John the Baptizer and the Pharisees fasting came to Jesus to ask him a question. The NLT96 has another way to say this:

One day some people came to Jesus and asked

came: In some languages it is more natural to use a verb like “went” here instead of came. Some languages

prefer to express verbs of motion from the viewpoint of the source rather than the destination. For example:

On one occasion some people went to Jesus...

asked: The Greek word that the BSB translates as asked is a general verb of speech that is often translated as “said.” Because the people asked a question, the BSB uses the English word “asked.” Use the verb of speech that is most natural in your language.

Jesus: The Greek text refers to Jesus here with a pronoun (“him” in English). Refer to him in a natural way in your language for this context.

2:18c–d

Why don’t Your disciples fast like John’s disciples and those of the Pharisees?: The question in 2:18c–d is actually both a statement and a question. The people told Jesus that John’s disciples and the disciples of the Pharisees were fasting. They also asked him why his disciples were not fasting. In some languages it may be more natural to use two sentences to express these ideas. For example:

John’s disciples and the disciples of the Pharisees fast often. Why do your disciples not fast?

Why don’t Your disciples fast like John’s disciples and those of the Pharisees?: Scholars do not agree about the function of the question in this verse. There are two views:

1. It is a rhetorical question. It functions as an indirect rebuke. The people were critical of Jesus because he did not make his disciples follow the traditional religious practices of the Jews.
2. It is a real question. The people observed the disciples of Jesus not fasting, and they wondered why they did not fast.

In English (and in Greek) the same words would be used here for a real question or a rhetorical question, so the versions are ambiguous. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In Luke 5:33, where this same story occurs, it is clearer that the people who spoke were criticizing Jesus.

There are at least three ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a question. For example, the RSV says:

Why do John’s disciples and the disciples of the Pharisees fast, but your disciples do not fast?

- As a statement. For example:

John’s disciples and the disciples of the Pharisees fast. Your disciples should also fast.

- As a statement with a tag question. For example:

John’s disciples and the disciples of the Pharisees fast. Your disciples should fast, too, shouldn’t they?

Use whichever form is most natural in your language to indicate that the people who spoke to Jesus were indirectly criticizing Jesus.

2:18c

“Why don’t Your disciples fast

- “Why do your disciples not fast regularly,
- “Why do your disciples not go without eating because of your religion.
- “Why do your disciples eat every day

fast: There are two ways to interpret the verb fast in this part of the verse:

1. It refers to a general practice of fasting. For example, the NCV says:

Why do John’s followers and the followers of the Pharisees often give up eating, but your followers don’t? (BSB, GNT, CEV, NCV, RSV, NLT, NET, NASB, GW, KJV, NJB)

1. It refers to a specific time when the disciples were fasting and people observed them. For example, the REB says:

Why is it that John’s disciples and the disciples of the Pharisees are fasting, but yours are not? (NIV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Use a general expression that refers to the practice of fasting.

2:18d

like John’s disciples and those of the Pharisees?”

- like the disciples of John the Baptizer and of the Pharisees fast regularly?”
- like the disciples/followers of John the Baptizer and the disciples/followers of the Pharisees often go without eating because of their religion”
- but the disciples of John and the disciples of the Pharisees habitually fast.”

those of the Pharisees: In this context the phrase those of the Pharisees refers to people who followed/obeyed the teachings of the Pharisees.

There are at least two options for translating the term in this context:

- Use the same term for disciples as you used for the disciples of Jesus and of John. See the note on disciples at 2:15b. See also disciple in the Glossary. This is probably best unless your term for “disciple” would not be possible to use with a group like the Pharisees.
- Use a different expression or term for disciples of the Pharisees than you used for disciples of Jesus. For example:

people who obeyed the Pharisee-group teachings

If you use the first option, you may want to include a footnote to explain how the word disciples is used in this context.

General Comment on 2:18c–d

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of 2:18c and 2:18d. For example:

^{18d}The disciples of John and the Pharisees fast.

^{18c}Shouldn't your disciples fast as well?

^{18d}How is it that John's disciples and the disciples of the Pharisees are fasting, ^{18c}but yours are not? (NIV)

Mark 2:19

Section 2:18–22: People asked Jesus about fasting

At the time when Jesus lived, Jewish people often went without eating food for one or more days. They did this to show they were sorry for their sins or to ask for favor from God. This is called “fasting.”

In this section people asked Jesus why he and his disciples did not fast. Jesus answered the question about fasting. Then he indicated that he was teaching a new way to live for God. His new way would not fit into the old traditions. To illustrate this point, Jesus used three comparisons:

1. To explain why his disciples did not fast, Jesus compared himself to a bridegroom, and he compared his disciples to wedding guests. They could not fast while he was with them.
2. To show that his way and the old traditions did not match, Jesus compared his new way to new cloth.

The old traditional ways were like an old garment. No one would sew new cloth onto an old garment.

3. Then Jesus compared his new way to new wine and the old way to old wineskins. When new wine was put into old wineskins, both were ruined.

This section can be difficult for people to understand because Jesus used comparisons to illustrate a point, but he did not make the point explicit. The point was that he was teaching a new way that was different from the old Jewish traditions. In some languages it may be necessary to include a footnote to explain this.

In this section there are some ideas that may not be familiar in certain cultures. For example:

1. fasting
2. Jewish wedding customs about bridegrooms
3. sewing patches onto cloth
4. new wine and old wineskins

Consider carefully how to translate each of these ideas in a meaningful way in your language. The Notes for this section will give suggestions.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus taught that his new way was different from Jewish traditions

Jesus' new way and the old ways

This story also occurs in Matthew 9:14–17 and Luke 5:33–39.

Paragraph 2:18–20

In this paragraph it is important for readers to know what “fasting” meant in the Jewish culture. In this context, “fasting” means to abstain from food for religious reasons. The Jewish people often fasted at times when they were very serious about praying to God. See 1 Samuel 7:5, Matthew 6:16–18, Luke 2:37, Acts 13:2. Often Jewish people would fast for some time to prepare for God to speak to them (see Exodus 24, Daniel 9:3, Matthew 4:2).

John the Baptizer's disciples and the Pharisees followed these Jewish customs.

2:19–20

In these verses Jesus used an illustration or extended metaphor to answer the people's question. He compared himself to a bridegroom and his disciples to a bridegroom's friends.

The people listening to Jesus would have understood that he was comparing himself to a bridegroom and

his disciples to the friends of the bridegroom. If your readers would not understand this, it may be necessary to make this explicit. See the General Comment on 2:19b–c for ways to express this.

2:19a

Jesus replied,

- Jesus answered them with another question,
- Jesus replied to them with an illustration,

This sentence begins with the Greek connector that is often translated as “and.” It introduces Jesus’ response to the question that the people had just asked. Connect 2:18d and 2:19a in a natural way in your language.

Jesus replied: The Greek word that the BSB translates as replied is a general verb of speech like “said” in English. Jesus answered the people’s question with an illustration. He introduced this illustration with a rhetorical question. Consider how to introduce his response in a natural way in your language. Here are some examples:

Jesus answered them with an illustration

In reply, Jesus asked them

Then Jesus used a comparison to answer them, saying...

2:19b–c

In this verse Jesus answered the people with a rhetorical question. Then he himself answered the question in a negative way. In some languages there may be a special way to express a rhetorical question and answer like that. The NLT96 has:

Do wedding guests fast while celebrating with the groom? Of course not. They can’t fast while they are with the groom.

Use a natural way in your language to express the meaning. The Notes on 2:19b and 2:19c will give more suggestions.

2:19b

“How can the guests of the bridegroom fast while He is with them?”

- “Do you think that it is appropriate for the bridegroom’s friends to fast while the bridegroom is with them?”

- “The guests of a bridegroom do not abstain from food while the bridegroom is with them at the wedding feast.

How can the guests of the bridegroom fast while He is with them?:

This is a rhetorical question that expects a negative answer. This question emphasizes that the guests of the bridegroom cannot fast while he is with them. Fasting would imply that the guests were sad or serious. It would not be appropriate for them to be sad while they were at the wedding feast with the bridegroom. Every Jew knew that a Jewish bridegroom would celebrate his wedding with a feast that lasted for a week. No one would expect his guests to fast during that time.

There are at least three ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a question. For example, the RSV says:

Can the wedding guests fast while the bridegroom is with them?

- As a statement. For example, the CEV says:

The friends of a bridegroom don’t go without eating while he is still with them.

- As a statement with a tag question. For example, the NET says:

The wedding guests cannot fast while the bridegroom is with them, can they?

Use whichever form is most natural in your language to emphasize something that people know is true.

the guests of the bridegroom: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the guests of the bridegroom is literally “the sons of the wedding hall.” It refers to people who come to rejoice with the bridegroom at his wedding. There are at least two ways to translate this term:

- Use an expression that refers specifically to the bridegroom’s friends who come to his wedding. These friends may have a special role in the wedding. For example, the CEV has:

the friends of a bridegroom

- Use a general expression that refers to people who come to a wedding. For example, the RSV has:

the wedding guests

In some cultures marriage customs may be so different from those of the Jews that the term guests of the bridegroom may be difficult to translate. For example, there may be no celebration at the time of a couple's marriage, or the bridegroom may not be involved in the celebration. If that is true in your culture, you may need to use a very general phrase. For example:

friends who are celebrating with the man-who-has-gotten-a-wife

fast: The verb fast here is another form of the verb that the BSB translated as “fasting” in 2:18a. You should use the appropriate form of the same expression here. Fasting often indicates that people are sorrowful or mourning. In contrast to the sorrow of fasting, the wedding guests rejoice and celebrate with a feast.

He: The Greek word that the BSB translates as He is literally “bridegroom.” It refers to a man who is marrying a wife. Jesus used the “bridegroom” in the metaphor to represent himself. Use a natural term in your language. The figure of the bridegroom is used often in the Bible, so it is best to keep this figure if possible. Many times God spoke of himself as the bridegroom of Israel (see Isaiah 62:5) and referred to Israel as his bride (see Jeremiah 2:2). The church is also referred to as the bride of the Messiah or Jesus (see Revelation 21:9–10).

2:19c

As long as He is with them, they cannot fast.

- No, it is not appropriate for them to fast while he remains with them.
- It is not possible, because they are happy as long as he is still with them.

In this part of the verse Jesus answered his own question in 2:19b in a negative way. See the note on 2:19a–c for translation suggestions.

As long as He is with them: The phrase As long as as He is with them refers to the time of the wedding when the bridegroom is celebrating with his friends. In the metaphor this time represents the time that Jesus would be with the disciples here on earth.

He: The pronoun He refers to the bridegroom. In the metaphor this represents Jesus. In some languages it may therefore be necessary to use the first-person pronoun (I/me).

them: The pronoun them refers to the guests of the bridegroom. In the metaphor they represent Jesus' disciples.

they cannot: The friends of the bridegroom could not fast because it would be inappropriate. They were celebrating their friend's marriage, and it was a happy occasion. They would not want to fast. It was not, however, impossible, and so it may be necessary to translate this as:

they will/would not

General Comment on 2:19b–c

In some languages it may be necessary to translate these verse parts in a way that makes the meaning of the metaphor explicit. Here are some examples:

My disciples and I are like a bridegroom and his friends. Can the bridegroom's friends fast while he is with them at the wedding feast? Of course they cannot fast then.

While I am with my disciples, how can they fast? They cannot, because they are happy/celebrating, just as a bridegroom's friends celebrate with him at his wedding feast.

Just as the guests of a bridegroom do not abstain from food while the bridegroom is with them at the wedding feast, so my disciples do not abstain from food while I am with them.

Mark 2:20

Section 2:18–22: People asked Jesus about fasting

At the time when Jesus lived, Jewish people often went without eating food for one or more days. They did this to show they were sorry for their sins or to ask for favor from God. This is called “fasting.”

In this section people asked Jesus why he and his disciples did not fast. Jesus answered the question about fasting. Then he indicated that he was teaching a new way to live for God. His new way would not fit into the old traditions. To illustrate this point, Jesus used three comparisons:

1. To explain why his disciples did not fast, Jesus compared himself to a bridegroom, and he compared his disciples to wedding guests. They could not fast while he was with them.
2. To show that his way and the old traditions did not match, Jesus compared his new way to new cloth.

The old traditional ways were like an old garment. No one would sew new cloth onto an old garment.

3. Then Jesus compared his new way to new wine and the old way to old wineskins. When new wine was put into old wineskins, both were ruined.

This section can be difficult for people to understand because Jesus used comparisons to illustrate a point, but he did not make the point explicit. The point was that he was teaching a new way that was different from the old Jewish traditions. In some languages it may be necessary to include a footnote to explain this.

In this section there are some ideas that may not be familiar in certain cultures. For example:

1. fasting
2. Jewish wedding customs about bridegrooms
3. sewing patches onto cloth
4. new wine and old wineskins

Consider carefully how to translate each of these ideas in a meaningful way in your language. The Notes for this section will give suggestions.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus taught that his new way was different from Jewish traditions

Jesus' new way and the old ways

This story also occurs in Matthew 9:14–17 and Luke 5:33–39.

Paragraph 2:18–20

In this paragraph it is important for readers to know what “fasting” meant in the Jewish culture. In this context, “fasting” means to abstain from food for religious reasons. The Jewish people often fasted at times when they were very serious about praying to God. See 1 Samuel 7:5, Matthew 6:16–18, Luke 2:37, Acts 13:2. Often Jewish people would fast for some time to prepare for God to speak to them (see Exodus 24, Daniel 9:3, Matthew 4:2).

John the Baptizer's disciples and the Pharisees followed these Jewish customs.

2:20a

But the time will come when the bridegroom will be taken from them;

- But later the bridegroom will be taken away from his friends,
- But later people will take the bridegroom away from his friends/guests,

- But someday I, the bridegroom, will be led away from my friends/disciples,

But: The Greek connector that the BSB translates as But indicates that 2:19 contrasts with 2:20. In 2:19 the bridegroom's friends are rejoicing with the bridegroom, but in 2:20 he is taken away from them and they fast. Express the contrast in a natural way in your language.

the time will come when: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the time will come when is literally “days will come when.” It is an emphatic way to refer to an indefinite time in the future.

In some languages it may not be natural to speak of time coming. There may be another idiom or phrase to express this. Use an appropriate expression in your language. For example:

Someday

the bridegroom will be taken from them: The words the bridegroom will be taken from them refer to an event that was not a usual part of a wedding celebration. Usually the guests would leave the celebration first.

Jesus used this figure of speech to imply that he himself would be taken from his disciples. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit in some way. For example:

But the time will come when I, the bridegroom, will be taken from them

will be taken: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as will be taken is a passive. It implies that someone would use force to make the bridegroom leave. In some languages it may be necessary to make this verb active and provide a subject. If that is true in your language, it is best to use a general subject. For example:

people will take the bridegroom from them

2:20b

then they will fast.

- and on that day they will fast.
- and at that time it will be appropriate that they go without eating.

then they will fast: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as then they will fast is literally, “then they will fast on that day.” It emphasizes the time period

when Jesus' disciples (the bridegroom's friends) would fast. Jesus did not imply that they would fast only on the day that he left. He probably implied that as soon as he left his disciples, they would begin to fast regularly or often.

Here are some other ways to translate this.

at that time they will fast (NET)

that will be the time for them to fast. (REB)

they: The pronoun they refers to the bridegroom's friends and guests. In the metaphor they represent Jesus' disciples.

Mark 2:21

Section 2:18–22: People asked Jesus about fasting

At the time when Jesus lived, Jewish people often went without eating food for one or more days. They did this to show they were sorry for their sins or to ask for favor from God. This is called "fasting."

In this section people asked Jesus why he and his disciples did not fast. Jesus answered the question about fasting. Then he indicated that he was teaching a new way to live for God. His new way would not fit into the old traditions. To illustrate this point, Jesus used three comparisons:

1. To explain why his disciples did not fast, Jesus compared himself to a bridegroom, and he compared his disciples to wedding guests. They could not fast while he was with them.
2. To show that his way and the old traditions did not match, Jesus compared his new way to new cloth. The old traditional ways were like an old garment. No one would sew new cloth onto an old garment.
3. Then Jesus compared his new way to new wine and the old way to old wineskins. When new wine was put into old wineskins, both were ruined.

This section can be difficult for people to understand because Jesus used comparisons to illustrate a point, but he did not make the point explicit. The point was that he was teaching a new way that was different from the old Jewish traditions. In some languages it may be necessary to include a footnote to explain this.

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Consider carefully how to translate each of these ideas in a meaningful way in your language. The Notes for this section will give suggestions.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus taught that his new way was different from Jewish traditions

Jesus' new way and the old ways

This story also occurs in Matthew 9:14–17 and Luke 5:33–39.

Paragraph 2:21

In this paragraph Jesus compared his teaching to new cloth that no one has washed yet. He compared the traditions of the Jews to an old garment. No one uses a piece of new cloth to patch an old cloth. In the same way, people should not simply add his teaching to their old ways of life.

2:21a

No one sews a patch of unshrunk cloth on an old garment.

- ¶ "No one sews a patch of cloth that is not shrunk onto an old garment.
- ¶ "Here is another example: People do not sew a piece of new cloth onto an old garment as a patch, and my teaching cannot be patched onto the old traditions.
- ¶ "My teaching cannot be mixed with the old traditions. It is like a new patch of cloth that has not been shrunk, and the traditions are like an old garment. A person does not use a patch of new cloth to fix a hole in an old garment.

No one sews a patch of unshrunk cloth on an old garment:

The word No one in the BSB introduces a general statement of something that is true of everyone. In some languages it may be natural to introduce this statement with a general word like "people" or with a pronoun like "you" or "they." For example:

People do not patch their old clothes with new cloth.

You do not use a piece of new cloth to patch up an old coat.

patch: A patch is a small piece of cloth that someone sews over a hole or torn area of another cloth.

unshrunk cloth: The phrase unshrunk cloth refers to a piece of cloth that is new and has not been washed. Some types of cloth shrink (that is, get a little smaller) when they are washed for the first time. In some cultures this may be well known and it may be natural to translate this as:

new cloth

cloth that has not been washed

garment: The Greek word that the BSB translates as garment means “clothing.” It can refer to any item of clothing a person wore, but sometimes it refers specifically to the outer robe that people wore. In this context, it probably refers generally to any piece of clothing.

2:21b

If he does, the new piece will pull away from the old,

- Otherwise, the new piece will shrink when it is washed and tear away from the old garment,
- That would be like putting a new piece of cloth on an old garment. The new piece will shrink and tear the cloth.
- If he did use such a new patch, it would just tear away from the older garment

If he does: In Greek this part of the verse begins with a phrase that the BSB translates as If he does. It introduces a possibility that someone would do what 2:21a indicated that no one actually ever does. It implies here “If he were to do this (which he will not)....”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

The results of doing that, of course, would be that...

otherwise... (NET)

the new piece will pull away from the old: This clause refers to how a new piece of cloth shrinks so that it pulls away from the old cloth around it. Jesus used this action as a metaphor. For more details about the meaning of the metaphor, see the note on 2:21.

the new piece: The phrase the new piece refers to the new cloth that has not been shrunk yet.

pull away: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as pull away can also be translated as “separate” or “tear.”

Here are some other ways English versions translate this:

the new patch will shrink and tear off some of the old cloth (GNT)

the patch will shrink and pull away—the new patch will pull away from the old coat (NCV)

2:21c

and a worse tear will result.

- and then the hole in the old garment will become very big.
- and the result will be an even bigger hole.
- and make the tear worse.

and a worse tear will result: The phrase and a worse tear will result expresses the result of 2:21a–b. The cloth was already torn, and if a person tried to patch it with new cloth, it would result in a worse tear. In some languages it may be more natural to combine “pull away” in 2:21b and “making the tear worse” in 2:21c. For example, the CEV has:

The new piece would shrink and tear a bigger hole.

General Comment on 2:21a–c

In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit some of the meaning of Jesus’ illustration about the cloth. For example:

If my teaching is mixed with the old traditions, it will be like putting a new piece of cloth on an old one. The new piece will shrink and tear the cloth. My teaching will become unusable just like the cloth.

Mark 2:22

Section 2:18–22: People asked Jesus about fasting

At the time when Jesus lived, Jewish people often went without eating food for one or more days. They did this to show they were sorry for their sins or to ask for favor from God. This is called “fasting.”

In this section people asked Jesus why he and his disciples did not fast. Jesus answered the question about fasting. Then he indicated that he was teaching a new way to live for God. His new way would not fit

into the old traditions. To illustrate this point, Jesus used three comparisons:

1. To explain why his disciples did not fast, Jesus compared himself to a bridegroom, and he compared his disciples to wedding guests. They could not fast while he was with them.
2. To show that his way and the old traditions did not match, Jesus compared his new way to new cloth. The old traditional ways were like an old garment. No one would sew new cloth onto an old garment.
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This section can be difficult for people to understand because Jesus used comparisons to illustrate a point, but he did not make the point explicit. The point was that he was teaching a new way that was different from the old Jewish traditions. In some languages it may be necessary to include a footnote to explain this.

In this section there are some ideas that may not be familiar in certain cultures. For example:

1. fasting
2. Jewish wedding customs about bridegrooms
3. sewing patches onto cloth
4. new wine and old wineskins

Consider carefully how to translate each of these ideas in a meaningful way in your language. The Notes for this section will give suggestions.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus taught that his new way was different from Jewish traditions

Jesus' new way and the old ways

This story also occurs in Matthew 9:14–17 and Luke 5:33–39.

Paragraph 2:22

In this paragraph Jesus gave another illustration to show that his new way of life was different from the old way that the Jewish leaders taught. He compared his teaching to new wine. The traditions were like old animal skins that people sewed together to make containers for storing wine. The BSB calls these containers “wineskins.” If a person put new wine into old wineskins, the skins would burst. Jesus' new way was too different to fit into the old traditions of the Jewish people.

2:22a

And no one pours new wine into old wineskins.

- ¶ Here is another example. People do not take wine that was just made and pour it into old containers while it ferments.
- ¶ Mixing my teaching with the traditions of the Jewish religious leaders is like storing new wine in old containers made of animal skins. No one does that.

And: The Greek connector that the BSB translates as And introduces another illustration. Jesus gave this illustration to show again that he was teaching new things that did not fit the old traditions. Here are several possible ways to introduce this illustration.

- Use a quote introducer here. For example:

Then Jesus gave another example, saying, “And...”

- Introduce the illustration within the quote itself. For example:

Here is a similar example:

- Use a connector that indicates the similarity of this illustration with the one in 2:21. For example:

Likewise

In a similar way

no one pours new wine into old wineskins: As in 2:21a, the word that the BSB translates as no one introduces a general statement that is true of everyone. In some languages it may be natural to introduce this statement with a general word like “people” or with a pronoun like “you” or “they.” For example:

People also do not pour new wine into old wineskins.

Similarly, you do not pour new wine into old wineskins.

See the note on Paragraph 2:22 for information about the meaning of this illustration.

pours: In the context, pours refers to putting wine into a container in order to store it there. There would be no harm in pouring new wine into old wineskins in order to drink it right away.

new wine into old wineskins: When new wine ferments, it produces gas. This builds up pressure and causes the wineskin to stretch or expand. New wine would be put into new skins because these could stretch. Old wineskins would have been stretched once before and so no longer would not be able to stretch any further.

new wine: The term new wine means wine that has been pressed recently from grapes and is not yet fermented (or is just beginning to ferment).

Here are some other ways to translate new wine:

wine that is only beginning to ferment

still fermenting wine

wine: The word wine refers to alcoholic drink made from the juice of a fruit called grapes. When grape juice ferments, it becomes wine.

In some areas, people may not be familiar with grapes or with wine. If that is true in your area, here are some other ways to translate wine:

- Use a general term for an alcoholic drink.
- Use a specific term that can also be used to refer to alcoholic drinks in general. For example:

millet beer

palm wine

something like palm wine

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

fruit juice/water

grape juice

fermented grape juice

wineskins: The Jews used animal skins to make containers for storing their wine. (The most common animal skin that they used was goat.)

Wineskins are not common in many areas of the world. In many languages you may need to use a descriptive phrase. For example:

wine containers made of goat skin

leather bags for storing wine

In some cultures people do not use animal skins to store wine. They may not understand the reason that people did not put new wine in old skins. If that is true in your culture, consider explaining this in a footnote. For example:

Wineskins were made out of whole goat hides that had the neck and feet openings tied shut. New wineskins were able to expand as the wine fermented, but old wineskins were no longer able to expand.

2:22b

If he does, the wine will burst the skins,

- Otherwise, the wine will expand and cause the containers to burst.
- If a person tries to do that, the new wine will ferment and swell, causing the old animal skins to break.

If he does: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as If he does was also used in 2:21b in a slightly shorter form. See the note on 2:21b. Here it introduces the result of doing what 2:22a indicated that no one normally does. Use a natural connector in your language for this context.

the wine will burst the skins: The verb will burst here means “will break.” It is implied that the wine will expand or ferment and then cause the skins to burst. The CEV makes this implied information explicit:

The wine would swell and burst the old skins.
(CEV)

You may need to make this information explicit in your language.

2:22c

and both the wine and the wineskins will be ruined.

- Then both the wine and the containers will be spoiled.
- And so] the wine will be lost and the skins/containers will be ruined.

both the wine and the wineskins will be ruined:

This clause expresses the final bad result of 2:22a–b: no one would be able to use either the wine or the wineskins again. They would both be spoiled. In order

to avoid this result, people do not put new wine into old wineskins.

2:22d

Instead, new wine is poured into new wineskins.”

- Rather, people must pour wine that was just made into new containers.”
- No, my new teaching requires new ways of thinking and acting, just as a person needs to put new wine into new/fresh animal skins.”

In this part of the verse Jesus gave the conclusion to his illustration in this verse. In the metaphor, new wine represents Jesus’ power and the new way of living that he was teaching. The new wineskins represent new traditions, that is, new ways of thinking and acting. Jesus’ new teaching must go along with new ways of thinking and acting.

Instead: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *Instead* introduces a contrast between 2:22c and 2:22d. In 2:22c Jesus described what people do not do, but in 2:22d he described what people do and should do.

Here are some ways other English versions translate the conjunction:

But (NCV)

No, (NIV)

Rather (GW)

Express the connection in a natural way in your language.

new wine is poured into new wineskins: The phrase that the BSB translates as *new wine is poured into new wineskins* supplies the passive phrase *is poured*, while the Greek has the elliptical phrase, “new wine into new wineskins.” It implies that someone poured the new wine into new wineskins. In some languages it may be necessary to make this verb active and provide a subject. If that is true in your language, it is best to use a general subject. For example:

people pour new wine into new wineskins

people must put new wine into fresh skins.

The sentence that the BSB translates as *new wine is poured into new wineskins* is another statement that

is true for everyone. Be sure that your translation of this sentence fits with the way you translated 2:22a–c.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Instead, new wine must be poured into fresh wineskins. (GNT)

But you should pour new wine into new wineskins.

General Comment on 2:22a–d

In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit some of the meaning of Jesus’ illustration about the wine skins. Here is one suggestion:

Mixing my teaching with the old traditions is like putting unfermented wine into old, dry goatskin containers. People do not do that because they know that when the wine ferments and expands, the containers will not be able to expand, and thus burst. The result is that both the wine is lost and the wineskin is ruined. People know that new wine must be put into new goatskins that won’t break. In the same way, you should not mix my teaching with the old traditions.

Mark 2:23

Section 2:23–28: Jesus and religious leaders disagreed about the rest day

In the Old Testament God commanded the Jewish people to rest on the seventh day of each week. They called this day the “Sabbath.” The Pharisees made many strict rules about what people were not allowed to do on the Sabbath.

In this section, Jesus allowed his disciples to pick and eat grain on the Sabbath. Some Pharisees saw the disciples doing that and rebuked Jesus. Jesus told the Pharisees a story about King David to show them that the way they thought about the Sabbath was wrong. He told them that he had the authority to decide what was right or wrong to do on the Sabbath.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus taught that he had authority over what is done on the rest day

Jesus taught the true meaning of the Sabbath day

This story also occurs in Matthew 12:1–8 and Luke 6:1–5.

2:23a**One Sabbath Jesus was passing through the grainfields,**

- ¶ On one Sabbath day, Jesus was walking through a field of grain with his disciples.
- ¶ On one rest day, Jesus and his followers were walking along a path through a wheat farm,

One Sabbath: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as One Sabbath is literally “and it happened that on a Sabbath (rest day)....” This phrase introduces a new story or incident that happened one Sabbath day.

Sabbath: The word Sabbath is the name of the seventh and last day of the week for the Jews. This was the special day in the week when they rested and worshipped God.

Here are some other ways to translate Sabbath:

the Jewish rest day

the day for resting

the day to rest and worship God

If the word Sabbath is already known in your area, you may write it according to the sounds of your language. You may also want to include a phrase to explain the meaning. For example:

the Sabat, the Jews’ day for resting

See how you translated Sabbath at 1:21b.

Jesus was passing: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Jesus was passing is literally “he was going.” Since 2:23 begins a new section, it is more natural in English to refer to Jesus by his name here. Use a natural way in your language to refer to him here.

In this verse Jesus was walking with his disciples. In some languages it may also be necessary to make explicit that Jesus’ disciples were with him. For example:

Jesus and his disciples were going

through the grainfields: There were public paths through the grainfields where people could walk without damaging the grain. Jesus and the disciples did not walk in a place where they were not allowed to go.

grainfields: The grainfields were fields, farms, or gardens where the people grew grain crops. This grain

could have been wheat, barley, or a similar type of grain. Notice that some English versions (KJV, NJB, REB), following British English, call these “cornfields.” In these versions, “corn” has the general sense of “grain.” It does not refer to “maize” (which Americans call “corn”).

Here are some ways to translate grainfields:

- Use an expression that includes your term for “grain.” For example:

wheat fields

barley farms

fields where people grew something like millet

- Use a general expression for a field where people grow crops for food. For example:

cultivated field

fields/land for growing food

farms

2:23b**and His disciples began to pick the heads of grain as they walked along.**

- As they were walking, the disciples were plucking some clusters of seeds off the grain and eating them.
- and his followers started to pick and eat the seeds of wheat as they were walking.

and His disciples began to pick the heads of grain as they walked along: Jesus’ disciples were plucking some of the grain to eat as they walked along. In the Old Testament, God allowed the Jewish people to do this in fields owned by fellow Jews. They were not allowed to harvest the grain in large amounts. See Deuteronomy 23:25.

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means “learners” who are in a relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Use the same term you used in 2:15b. See the note there and see also disciple in the Glossary.

pick the heads of grain: The phrase pick the heads of grain means “pluck clusters of seed off the stalks of the grain plants.” See also the following notes on “heads of grain” and “grain.”

heads of grain: Grains like wheat and barley have a stalk. On top of the stalk there are clusters of seeds. These clusters are the heads of grain. These grains could be eaten raw.

grain: The text does not say what sort of grain this was. If you must be specific, you could say “wheat” or “barley” since these were common in Israel. If wheat or barley are not known in your area, here are other options for translation:

- Use a general word for grain.
- Use a phrase that describes the grain as similar to a grain which is known in your area and which can be eaten raw. For example:

something like rice/millet

Mark 2:24

Section 2:23–28: Jesus and religious leaders disagreed about the rest day

In the Old Testament God commanded the Jewish people to rest on the seventh day of each week. They called this day the “Sabbath.” The Pharisees made many strict rules about what people were not allowed to do on the Sabbath.

In this section, Jesus allowed his disciples to pick and eat grain on the Sabbath. Some Pharisees saw the disciples doing that and rebuked Jesus. Jesus told the Pharisees a story about King David to show them that the way they thought about the Sabbath was wrong. He told them that he had the authority to decide what was right or wrong to do on the Sabbath.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus taught that he had authority over what is done on the rest day

Jesus taught the true meaning of the Sabbath day

This story also occurs in Matthew 12:1–8 and Luke 6:1–5.

2:24a

So the Pharisees said to Him,

- The Pharisees were there also, and they asked Jesus,

- Some of the men from the Pharisee group came and said to Jesus,
- Some Pharisees told Jesus that

So: This verse begins with the Greek conjunction that is often translated as “and” in English and is translated as “So” in the BSB. Here it introduces what the Pharisees said when they saw the disciples plucking grain on the Sabbath. Consider this context and connect the verse to 2:23 in the most natural way in your language. In some languages a connector may not be needed.

the Pharisees said to Him: The Pharisees are mentioned here for the first time in this story. In some languages it may be necessary to introduce them before mentioning what they said. It may also be necessary to mention that they saw what Jesus’ disciples were doing. For example:

some Pharisees were also there. They saw what Jesus’ disciples were doing, so they said...

some Pharisees came along and saw what the disciples were doing

This phrase indicates that a group of the Pharisees spoke to Jesus. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate this in some way. For example:

some men of the Pharisee-group said to Jesus...

This statement does not imply that everyone in the group spoke at once. Probably one of them spoke for them all. Use a natural way in your language to introduce this quote. See the note on “said” below.

Pharisees: The Pharisees were a Jewish religious group or party. It was very important to them to obey all of the Jewish religious laws very carefully and in detail. For a discussion of how to translate Pharisees, see the note on Pharisees in 2:16a.

said: The Greek word that the BSB translates as said is a general verb of speech. Here it introduces a rhetorical question that functions as a rebuke. In some languages it may be more natural to use a different verb like “asked” or “objected.” Use a natural verb in your language for this context.

Him: The pronoun Him refers to Jesus.

2:24b

“Look, why are they doing what is unlawful on the Sabbath?”

- “Look, why are your disciples doing what our law does not allow on the Sabbath day?”
- “Look at your^(sing) followers. They are picking grain on the rest day. It says in the law that we^(incl) must not do that. Tell them to stop.”
- he should not allow his disciples to pick the grain, since it was not lawful to do that on the day for resting.

Look: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Look emphasizes the next statement.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Listen

See here!

why are they doing what is unlawful on the Sabbath?: This is a rhetorical question that is both a claim and a rebuke. The Pharisees were claiming that what the disciples were doing was unlawful. The Pharisees were also saying that Jesus should not allow them to do it.

There are at least two ways to translate this:

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the NCV says:

Why are your followers doing what is not lawful on the Sabbath day?

- As a statement or as two statements. For example:

It is against our Law for your disciples to do that on the Sabbath! You should tell them not to do that.

Use whichever form is most natural to express this rebuke in your language.

unlawful: The Greek word that the BSB translates as unlawful means “not allowed.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

forbidden (REB)

not permitted (GW)

what they ought not to do

In this context the term “unlawful” implies that the action was against the Jewish religious law.

The Pharisees interpreted the disciples’ action of picking handfuls of grain as “harvesting.” The Jewish religious law did not allow people to harvest on the Sabbath. The Pharisees did not accuse the disciples of stealing by taking grain that belonged to someone else. You may want to explain this in a footnote. For example:

Jewish law allowed someone to pick small amounts of grain from another person’s field (Deuteronomy 23:25). The Pharisees were not accusing the disciples of stealing. They were accusing them of doing the work of harvesting. The Law of Moses required that no one should work on the Sabbath day.

Mark 2:25

Section 2:23–28: Jesus and religious leaders disagreed about the rest day

In the Old Testament God commanded the Jewish people to rest on the seventh day of each week. They called this day the “Sabbath.” The Pharisees made many strict rules about what people were not allowed to do on the Sabbath.

In this section, Jesus allowed his disciples to pick and eat grain on the Sabbath. Some Pharisees saw the disciples doing that and rebuked Jesus. Jesus told the Pharisees a story about King David to show them that the way they thought about the Sabbath was wrong. He told them that he had the authority to decide what was right or wrong to do on the Sabbath.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus taught that he had authority over what is done on the rest day

Jesus taught the true meaning of the Sabbath day

This story also occurs in Matthew 12:1–8 and Luke 6:1–5.

2:25–26

In these verses Jesus responded to the Pharisees’ accusation by referring to a story about King David, who had lived long ago. When Jewish leaders debated, they often referred to teachings and stories from the Bible to support their statements. This story is found in 1 Samuel 21:1–6.

In order for readers to understand this story, they need to know certain background information about Jewish history and culture. It may be necessary to include footnotes in your translation to explain some of this

background information. You may also need to make some of the implied information explicit in the text. The notes on these verses will give suggestions.

In Greek, 2:25–26 are one long question. In many languages, it will be necessary to express this in shorter sentences. It may also be necessary to change the order of some information in these verses. In some languages it may be most natural to combine the verses and number them together as 25–26. See the General Comment on 2:25–26 at the end of the notes on 2:26d for an example.

2:25a

Jesus replied, “Have you never read what David did

- Jesus replied to the Pharisees, “Do you^(plur) not remember what David did?
- Jesus replied to them, “Think about the Scriptures you^(plur) have read concerning our great ancestor David and what he did
- Then Jesus told them that they seemed not to understand what David did

Jesus replied: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Jesus replied is literally “and he said to them.” Refer to both Jesus and the Pharisees in a natural way in your language for this context. In some languages you may need to use a more specific verb than “said.” Introduce Jesus’ speech in the most appropriate way in your language.

Have you never read what David did...?: The clause Have you never read what David did is the beginning of a rhetorical question.

Jesus used this clause in two ways:

1. He used it to introduce his answer to the Pharisees. In this question Jesus reminded them about a story of David in the Old Testament.
2. He used it to rebuke the Pharisees because they should have realized that the story about David indicated that God was concerned for his people. Jesus knew that the Pharisees had read this story, but their actions showed that they were ignoring it.

There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a question. For example:

Haven’t you ever read what David did...? (GW)

Didn’t you understand what you read about the time when David...?

- As a statement. For example:

Surely you have read what David did...

You speak as if you have never read what David did...

Translate the rhetorical question in an appropriate way in your language for this context.

read: Jesus referred to something the Pharisees would have read in the Scriptures. If your readers would not understand that this story is in the Scriptures, you may need to supply this information. For example, the NLT has:

Haven’t you ever read in the Scriptures what David did...?

David: David was a king of Israel who lived many years before Jesus and the Pharisees. The Pharisees and the other Jewish people had great respect for David. This story happened in David’s early life before he became king. If your readers would not be familiar with the life of David, you should include some information about him in a footnote.

2:25b

when he and his companions were hungry and in need?

- Once he and his friends were very hungry and they needed food.
- when he and his companions were very hungry.

This clause introduces a particular situation in David’s life. Jesus wanted the Pharisees to compare that situation with his disciples picking grain on the Sabbath.

when he and his companions were hungry and in need:

In Greek this part of the verse is literally “when he had need and was hungry, he and those with him.” The order of these words expresses a focus on David as the one who asked for the consecrated bread. The BSB has used a different order because of English style. You should translate this clause in a way that is natural in your language.

he: The pronoun he refers to David.

his companions: David’s companions were the men who were with him at the time that Jesus told about.

were hungry and in need: The phrases hungry and in need refer to the same situation. David and his companions needed food because they were hungry. Using both phrases emphasizes the situation. In some languages it may be more natural to emphasize it in a different way. For example:

when he and his companions were very hungry

when he and his men were hungry and had nothing to eat (REB)

Mark 2:26

Section 2:23–28: Jesus and religious leaders disagreed about the rest day

In the Old Testament God commanded the Jewish people to rest on the seventh day of each week. They called this day the “Sabbath.” The Pharisees made many strict rules about what people were not allowed to do on the Sabbath.

In this section, Jesus allowed his disciples to pick and eat grain on the Sabbath. Some Pharisees saw the disciples doing that and rebuked Jesus. Jesus told the Pharisees a story about King David to show them that the way they thought about the Sabbath was wrong. He told them that he had the authority to decide what was right or wrong to do on the Sabbath.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus taught that he had authority over what is done on the rest day

Jesus taught the true meaning of the Sabbath day

This story also occurs in Matthew 12:1–8 and Luke 6:1–5.

2:26a

During the high priesthood of Abiathar,

- During the time of Abiathar, the leader of the priests,
- In the lifetime of the ruling priest, Abiathar,
- Jesus told them that in the time when Abiathar, the high priest, was alive,

During the high priesthood of Abiathar: The phrase During the high priesthood of Abiathar refers to Abiathar’s lifetime or to the general time period when he became high priest. The name of the high priest who gave the bread to David was Ahimelech. After Ahimelech died, his son Abiathar became high priest for David. In your translation it is good to use a general expression that does not say explicitly that Abiathar was the high priest at this time. For example, the NCV says:

During the time of Abiathar the high priest

high priesthood: The Greek word that the BSB translates as high priesthood is literally “high priest.” The “high priest” was the leader of all the Jewish priests. All Jewish priests offered sacrifices on behalf of the people, but the high priest offered certain special sacrifices that no other priest could offer. In a special way, he represented the Jewish people to God.

Here are some other ways to translate “high priest”:

the chief/leader of all the priests

the Main/Principal Priest

the highest/leading priest

See how you translated priest at 1:44b.

priests: Jewish priests were men who offered sacrifices to God on behalf of the people. They also performed other rituals for them.

Here are some other ways to translate priests:

- Use a descriptive term that focuses on the function of priests. For example:

sacrificers

men/people who offer sacrifices to God

people who represent other people to God

- Use a local word for priest. This option may be acceptable if the duties of a local priest are similar to those of a Jewish priest. You may need to indicate that the word refers to a Jewish priest. For example:

Jewish people’s priests/sacrificers

If possible, you should choose a term that can be used in both Old Testament and New Testament contexts. Remember that in the book of Hebrews believers are called priests and Christ is called our high priest.

2:26b

he entered the house of God and ate the consecrated bread,

- David went into the house of God, and he ate some of the bread that the priests had dedicated to God.
- David went into the tent where people worshiped God. There he ate the bread that the priests had offered to God,

the house of God: The house of God was a Jewish expression that could refer to either the tabernacle or the temple. In this context, it refers to the tabernacle. The tabernacle was a tent that was like a portable temple. It was the place where the Jewish people presented sacrifices to God and where God revealed his presence to them.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

God's house/dwelling

the big tent where our ancestors worshiped God

God: See the note on 2:7.

ate the consecrated bread: In the story in 1 Samuel 21:1-6, David asked the priest for the bread, and the priest gave it to him. This information is not mentioned explicitly in this verse. Your readers might think that David stole the bread and ate it. If that is true, you may need to make explicit that the priest gave it to him or to mention this fact in a footnote. For example:

ate the consecrated bread that the priest gave him

the consecrated bread: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the consecrated bread refers to the bread that the priests offered or presented to God. Every Sabbath, the bread was replaced with fresh bread. Then, only the priests were allowed to eat the old bread. See Leviticus 24:5-9 and Exodus 25:30.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the sacred/holy bread

the bread offered to God (GNT)

special bread (NLT96)

It may also be helpful to include a footnote to explain this. For example, the TRT suggests this footnote:

Every Sabbath/resting day twelve fresh loaves of bread were put on a gold table in the Holy Place as a sacrifice to God. The old loaves were eaten by the priests (see Leviticus 24:5-9).

bread: The word bread refers to the main food of the Jewish people. Other ways to translate this could be

“loaf” or “loaf of bread.” If the people for whom you are translating do not eat bread, you could translate this with a generic term, such as “food.” Since this refers to a specific Jewish tradition, do not substitute another specific kind of food.

2:26c

which was lawful only for the priests.

- You^(plur) know that the law says that only the priests may eat it.
- even though our^(incl) Jewish law says that it is unlawful for ordinary people to eat it; only priests may eat it.
- which was lawful only for the priests to eat.

was lawful only for the priests: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as was lawful only for the priests is literally “not lawful/permitted for anyone to eat except the priests.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

not lawful for any but the priests to eat (RSV)

against the law for any but the priests to eat (NET)

no one but a priest is allowed to eat it

lawful: The word lawful here means “permitted.” In this context it refers to what the Jewish religious and ceremonial law allowed. The law about the dedicated bread is stated in the Law of Moses (see Leviticus 24:9).

priests: The term priests means men who were authorized to offer sacrifices to God for the people. Refer to the term you used for priests in 1:44b.

2:26d

And he gave some to his companions as well.”

- Then David gave some of the bread to his friends and they ate it also.”
- David even gave some of the bread offered to God to his men.”
- Jesus told them that David even gave some of this bread to his men.

In this part of the verse Jesus told the part of David's story that was similar to what he and his disciples were doing. Like David, Jesus was allowing his disciples to break a rule, and he had the authority to do that.

And he gave some to his companions as well: In this clause, Jesus finished his story about what David did. The clause implies that although David gave

some consecrated bread to his companions, it was not wrong. God did not punish him for it. You may need to make this explicit in your translation. For example:

He also gave some of the bread to his companions and they ate it too. But God did not punish David for doing that.

He even gave some to his companions and they also ate it. But what David did was not wrong.

he: The pronoun he refers to David.

gave some: The BSB has supplied the object some, meaning “some consecrated bread.” The Greek text does not have an explicit object of gave. You should supply an object if it is natural in your language.

his companions: Use the same term for his companions as you used in 2:25b.

as well: The Greek word that the BSB translates as as well is emphatic here. It means “even.” David even gave some of the bread that only priests should eat to his companions, who were ordinary people.

General Comment on 2:25–26

In Greek these verses are one long sentence. In some languages, it may be necessary to use shorter sentences. It also may be necessary to reorder some of the information and perhaps to combine 2:25–26. For example:

^{25a}Jesus said: “Have you not read what our ancestor David did long ago ^{26a}when Abiathar was High Priest? ^{25b}When David and his friends were hungry, ^{26b}he entered into the worship house and ate the bread that was dedicated to God, ^{26d}and he also distributed it to his companions. ^{26c}According to our religious laws, it is only priests who are allowed to eat that bread.”

If you combine these verses you can use a combined verse number (25–26) at the beginning of 2:25.

Mark 2:27

Section 2:23–28: Jesus and religious leaders disagreed about the rest day

In the Old Testament God commanded the Jewish people to rest on the seventh day of each week. They called this day the “Sabbath.” The Pharisees made many strict rules about what people were not allowed to do on the Sabbath.

In this section, Jesus allowed his disciples to pick and eat grain on the Sabbath. Some Pharisees saw the disciples doing that and rebuked Jesus. Jesus told the Pharisees a story about King David to show them that the way they thought about the Sabbath was wrong. He told them that he had the authority to decide what was right or wrong to do on the Sabbath.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus taught that he had authority over what is done on the rest day

Jesus taught the true meaning of the Sabbath day

This story also occurs in Matthew 12:1–8 and Luke 6:1–5.

2:27a

Then Jesus declared,

- Jesus concluded,
- Then Jesus said,
- And then Jesus said to the Pharisees,

Then Jesus declared: In 2:27 Jesus continued to speak, but his speech is introduced by the clause Then Jesus declared. This clause emphasizes Jesus’ conclusion in 2:27–28. Use the expression that is used in your language when a teacher announces his conclusion or main idea. For example:

And Jesus concluded (GNT)

Jesus finished by saying (CEV)

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then is the common one that is often translated as “and.” Use a natural way to introduce the conclusion in your language. In some languages a connector may not be needed.

Jesus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Jesus is literally the pronoun “he.” Use a natural way to refer to Jesus here.

2:27b–c

The Sabbath was made for man, not man for the Sabbath: In this part of the verse Jesus said what he wanted to teach from the story about David. He used a saying or parallel proverb. It is in a special Jewish style in which the middle ideas match and the outer ideas match. This style emphasized his conclusion:

The Sabbath was made for man,

not man for the Sabbath.

Consider whether you have a special way in your language to express a saying like this. Use a style that emphasizes the idea that the Sabbath was created to be helpful for man. Man was not created to be helpful to the Sabbath.

2:27b

“The Sabbath was made for man,

- “The Sabbath day was made for mankind;
- “God established/instituted the rest day to benefit people;
- “God created the day for resting to help people.

The Sabbath was made for man: The clause The Sabbath was made for man means that the Sabbath was started or established for the sake of people. This is a passive clause. If it is more natural in your language to use an active verb here, you may need to supply the subject, “God.” For example:

God made the Sabbath for man

God created/established the Sabbath for the good of people

The clause expresses the reason God wanted people to have the day of rest. Another way to say this is:

God commanded his people to have the day of rest. He wanted it to be helpful for people.

for man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as for man here means “for the sake of mankind/humanity” or “for the good of people.” The word man does not refer only to males. God wanted the day of rest to be helpful to people. The NLT96 has:

The Sabbath was made to benefit people

2:27c

not man for the Sabbath.

- mankind was not made for the Sabbath day.
- he did not make people to benefit the rest day.
- he did not create the day for resting to be a burden to them/people.

not man for the Sabbath: The phrase not man for the Sabbath is an ellipsis that means:

mankind was not made for the Sabbath

If your language would not use an ellipsis here, you may need to repeat the verb that you used in 2:27b or use a different appropriate verb. See the General Comment on 2:27b–c below for suggestions.

General Comment on 2:27b–c

As you translate this proverb or saying, consider how you would express a similar saying in your language. In some languages, you may want to use the same verb or a similar expression in both 2:27b and 2:27c. Use a verb that is appropriate for what God did when he decided that people should have the Sabbath. For example:

God created the rest day to benefit people. He did not create people to benefit the rest day.

In some languages it may not be possible to use the same verb in both clauses. You may need to use different verbs and make the statements similar in a different way. Choose appropriate expressions in your language. For example:

When God started the rest day, his purpose was to benefit people. He did not create people to benefit the rest day.

In some languages it may be more natural to state the negative expression first. For example:

God did not create people for the rest day. Instead, he established the rest day for people.

Mark 2:28

Section 2:23–28: Jesus and religious leaders disagreed about the rest day

In the Old Testament God commanded the Jewish people to rest on the seventh day of each week. They called this day the “Sabbath.” The Pharisees made many strict rules about what people were not allowed to do on the Sabbath.

In this section, Jesus allowed his disciples to pick and eat grain on the Sabbath. Some Pharisees saw the disciples doing that and rebuked Jesus. Jesus told the Pharisees a story about King David to show them that the way they thought about the Sabbath was wrong. He told them that he had the authority to decide what was right or wrong to do on the Sabbath.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus taught that he had authority over what is done on the rest day

Jesus taught the true meaning of the Sabbath day

This story also occurs in Matthew 12:1–8 and Luke 6:1–5.

2:28

Therefore, the Son of Man is Lord even of the Sabbath.”

- Therefore, the Son of Man is ruler even over the Sabbath day.”
- Therefore, I, the Son of Man, have authority to decide what people can do on the rest day.”
- So the one who has authority to say what people can do on the day for resting is I, the Son of Man.”

Therefore: In this context the Greek word the BSB translates as Therefore introduces the result and conclusion of Jesus’ statement in 2:27. Use an appropriate connector in your language. The GW translates it as:

For this reason

the Son of Man is Lord even of the Sabbath: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is Lord emphasizes the word Lord. Try to show this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

the Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is literally “the Son of the human/person.” It is a title that Jesus often used to refer to himself. It implies that:

1. he was a true human being, and he represented all people.
2. he came from God and had authority from God.

Here are some other ways to translate this title:

the Man whom God Sent

the True Man from God/Heaven

the Representative of Mankind

The Older Brother of All People

Refer to the way you translated this title in 2:10a. In this context there is a special connection between the title Son of Man and the statement that “the Sabbath was made for man” in 2:27. You should try to keep that connection in your translation here.

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate explicitly that Jesus was referring to himself here. For example:

I, the Son of Man

Lord even of the Sabbath: The word Lord means “master,” or “the one who has authority.” See Lord, Context 1, in the Glossary. In this context the word Lord refers to Jesus’ authority over the Sabbath day. The word even emphasizes that Jesus’ authority was great. Although the Sabbath was given by God, Jesus had authority over it. There are various ways to express Jesus’ authority over the Sabbath. For example:

I, the Son of Man, am master even of the Sabbath!
(NLT96)

I, the Son of Man, have authority over the rest day.

There is implied information here. Jesus had authority over the Sabbath in the sense that he had the right to decide what people could or could not do on the Sabbath day. This meaning may be expressed in several ways. For example:

I, the one who became a person, have the right to decide what a person can do on the day for resting.

I, the older brother of all people, have the authority to say what people are allowed to do on the rest day.

Mark 3:1

Section 3:1–6: Jesus healed a man on the rest day and angered the Pharisees

In this section, Mark continued to tell about how the Pharisees opposed Jesus. The Pharisees had decided that healing a person on the Sabbath was work. The Jewish religious law prohibited work on the Sabbath. So the Pharisees criticized Jesus because he worked on the Sabbath.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Man with a Paralyzed Hand (GNT)

Jesus Heals on the Sabbath (NLT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:9–14 and Luke 6:6–11.

Paragraph 3:1–6

Verse 3:1 provides the background for the story that is told in 3:2–6. It introduces the people in the story and the place where it happened.

3:1a

Once again Jesus entered the synagogue,

- ¶ On another day/opportunity when he/Jesus entered the synagogue,
- ¶ One other Sabbath/rest day, Jesus went into the meeting place.

Once again: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Once again is literally “again.” This indicates that the story in 3:1–6 happened on a different opportunity or day than the previous story did. The context indicates that it was another Sabbath day.

Several stories in Mark have happened on a Sabbath day. This is another story that happened on a Sabbath.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

On another Sabbath

One other Sabbath day

Translate “Sabbath” here in the same way you did in 1:21b.

the synagogue: A synagogue was a building where Jews gathered to pray, read scripture, teach their beliefs, and worship. The Jews also gathered there for cultural activities. There was only one temple (in Jerusalem), but each Jewish community had a synagogue. In this context the phrase the synagogue probably refers to the synagogue in Capernaum that was mentioned in 1:21.

Here are some other ways to translate the synagogue:

the prayer-house of the Jews

the meeting-place of the Jews

the worship building

the house for gathering together

If you make explicit a phrase such as “of the Jews,” be sure that it does not imply that Jesus was not a Jew.

If the word synagogue is already known in your area, you may write it according to the sounds of your language. You may want to include a word or phrase to explain the meaning. For example:

the sinagog house/building

See how you translated synagogue in 1:21b. You should translate synagogue consistently wherever it occurs. See also synagogue in the Glossary.

3:1b

and a man with a withered hand was there.

- a man whose hand/arm was paralyzed was there.
- A certain man was there. His hand/arm was crippled/ dead.

a withered hand: The phrase a withered hand refers to a hand that is shriveled and small because it is paralyzed or crippled. Some languages would say that this man’s hand was “dead” or “dried.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

paralyzed hand (GNT)

crippled hand (CEV)

hand: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hand includes the fingers, palm, wrist, and forearm. The Greek text does not specify how much of the man’s hand was paralyzed. Probably the whole area from the fingers to the forearm was included.

Each language divides the body differently. If you have a specific term that refers to the area from the forearm to the fingers, you could use that term here. Otherwise, you can use a general term for the hand and arm. If your language requires you to specify which hand, you should say the right hand, as in Luke 6:6.

Mark 3:2

Section 3:1–6: Jesus healed a man on the rest day and angered the Pharisees

In this section, Mark continued to tell about how the Pharisees opposed Jesus. The Pharisees had decided that healing a person on the Sabbath was work. The Jewish religious law prohibited work on the Sabbath. So the Pharisees criticized Jesus because he worked on the Sabbath.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Man with a Paralyzed Hand (GNT)

Jesus Heals on the Sabbath (NLT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:9-14 and Luke 6:6-11.

Paragraph 3:1-6

Verse 3:1 provides the background for the story that is told in 3:2-6. It introduces the people in the story and the place where it happened.

3:2

In 3:2, there are three clauses in Greek. The BSB has changed the Greek order of these clauses by moving the purpose statement from 3:3c to 3:3a. If it followed the Greek order it would read: They were watching to see if He would heal on the Sabbath in order to accuse Jesus. See the General Comment on 3:2a-c at the end of 3:2c regarding the order of the clauses in this verse.

3:2a

In order to accuse Jesus,

- So that they could accuse Jesus of breaking the Jewish law.
- They wanted to bring a charge against Jesus.
- They were hoping for an excuse/reason to prosecute Jesus for breaking the law.

In order to accuse Jesus: This is a purpose clause. Jesus' enemies wanted to accuse Jesus. In order to accuse him, they were watching him (3:2b).

In some languages it may be natural to move this to the beginning of the sentence as the BSB does or place it in a new sentence. For example:

They wanted to accuse Jesus

They were looking for a reason to accuse Jesus

accuse Jesus: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as accuse Jesus means "to say that he is doing wrong things." This is a term that describes what a person does in court when he says that someone has done something wrong. It can also be translated as:

bring a charge against Jesus

prosecute him

In some languages it may be necessary to say what the men wanted to accuse Jesus of doing. It may be possible to say:

accuse Jesus of doing wrong

accuse him of breaking the law

charge him with working on the rest day

3:2b

they were watching

- some of the people there watched Jesus carefully
- some men there were closely observing Jesus

they were watching: The phrase they were watching means that some of the people in the synagogue carefully observed everything Jesus did. This verse does not indicate who these people were. However, the context makes it clear that they were some of Jesus' enemies from the Pharisee party. In some languages it may be necessary to make that explicit. For example:

The Pharisees (CEV)

Jesus' enemies (NLT)

See the notes on "the Pharisees" and "Pharisees" in 3:6a.

3:2c

to see if He would heal on the Sabbath.

- to see if Jesus would heal the man on the Sabbath day,
- to find out if Jesus would make the man well on the rest day.

to see if He would heal: The pronoun He refers to Jesus. In some languages, the verb heal may require an explicit object so you may need to mention the man with a withered hand by pronoun or explicitly. For example:

to see if Jesus would heal the man with the paralyzed hand

to see if Jesus would heal him

on the Sabbath: The BSB capitalizes the word Sabbath, other translations do not capitalize it (sabbath).

In many languages it is probably not necessary to capitalize the term for Sabbath. However, if you decide to capitalize it, you should capitalize it consistently in your translation. The word Sabbath is the name of the seventh and last day of the week for the Jews. This was the special day in the week when they rested and worshipped God. The Law of Moses said that the Jews must not work on that day (Deuteronomy 5:12–15).

Here are some other ways to translate Sabbath:

the Jewish rest day

the day for resting

the day to rest and worship God

If the word Sabbath is already known in your area, you may write it according to the sounds of your language. You may also want to include a phrase to explain the meaning. For example:

the Sabat, the Jews' day for resting

Be careful that the term you choose is not confused with Sunday, the day when Christians worship. The Sabbath for the Jews began at sundown on Friday and went until sundown on Saturday. You may want to include a footnote to give more information. For example:

The Sabbath is a name for the seventh day of the week. It is the day when the Jews rested from work and worshipped God.

General Comment on 3:2a–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder the verse parts in 3:2 in a similar way to the BSB.

Use a natural order in your language.

Mark 3:3

Section 3:1–6: Jesus healed a man on the rest day and angered the Pharisees

In this section, Mark continued to tell about how the Pharisees opposed Jesus. The Pharisees had decided that healing a person on the Sabbath was work. The Jewish religious law prohibited work on the Sabbath. So the Pharisees criticized Jesus because he worked on the Sabbath.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Man with a Paralyzed Hand (GNT)

Jesus Heals on the Sabbath (NLT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:9–14 and Luke 6:6–11.

Paragraph 3:1–6

Verse 3:1 provides the background for the story that is told in 3:2–6. It introduces the people in the story and the place where it happened.

3:3a

Then Jesus said to the man with the withered hand,

- Jesus said to the man whose hand was paralyzed,
- Jesus said to the man with the crippled/dead hand,
- Jesus told the man (CEV)

the man with the withered hand: This is the second time that the man with the withered hand is mentioned. In some languages, it may not be natural to repeat this entire phrase. If this is true in your language, you can say:

Jesus said to the man (NLT)

3:3b

“Stand up among us.”

- “Stand up in the middle of everyone.”
- “Stand up where everyone can see you.”
- to stand up where everyone could see him. (CEV)

Stand up among us: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as among us literally means “in the middle.” This probably indicates that Jesus told the man to stand in the center of the synagogue so that everyone could see him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Stand in the center [of the synagogue]. (GW)

Stand up here in the middle of everyone. (NCV)

Come and stand in front of everyone. (NLT)

General Comment on 3:3a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech here. If this is true in your language, you could say:

Jesus told the man with the paralyzed hand to stand up in front of everyone.

Mark 3:4

Section 3:1–6: Jesus healed a man on the rest day and angered the Pharisees

In this section, Mark continued to tell about how the Pharisees opposed Jesus. The Pharisees had decided that healing a person on the Sabbath was work. The Jewish religious law prohibited work on the Sabbath. So the Pharisees criticized Jesus because he worked on the Sabbath.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Man with a Paralyzed Hand (GNT)

Jesus Heals on the Sabbath (NLT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:9–14 and Luke 6:6–11.

Paragraph 3:1–6

Verse 3:1 provides the background for the story that is told in 3:2–6. It introduces the people in the story and the place where it happened.

3:4a

And He asked them,

- Then Jesus said to them,
- Then Jesus asked the people who were accusing him,
- Then Jesus said to the people who wanted to accuse him,

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And introduces what Jesus said next. Connect 3:3 and 3:4 in the way that is most natural in your language.

He asked them: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as asked is literally “said,” as in the RSV. Because Jesus was about to ask a rhetorical question, the verb asked is appropriate here in English. Use the verb that is appropriate in your language.

He: The pronoun He refers to Jesus.

them: The pronoun them refers to the people who wanted to accuse Jesus. It does not refer to the whole crowd.

3:4b–d

Which is lawful on the Sabbath: to do good or to do evil, to save life or to destroy it?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus asked this question to rebuke the Pharisees. He rebuked them by emphasizing a fact that everyone knew to be true: It was lawful on the Sabbath to do good, not evil. It was also lawful to save life, not to kill. There are at least two ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Is it lawful on the sabbath to do good or to do harm...? (RSV)

Which is lawful on the Sabbath: to do good or to do evil...? (NIV)

What does our Law allow us to do on the Sabbath? To help or to harm? (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

It is certainly lawful on the Sabbath to do good, and not to do harm. It is certainly lawful to save life, and not to kill.

Use whichever form is most natural in your language to emphasize a fact that everyone knows is true and that expresses a rebuke.

3:4b

“Which is lawful on the Sabbath:

- “What does our^(incl) law allow on the Sabbath?
- “What are we^(incl) allowed to do on the rest day?
- “On the day for resting, it is certainly right

is lawful: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as is lawful here means “is permitted by the Jewish religious law.”

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

What does our Law allow us to do on the Sabbath? (GNT)

Is it right to do good or to do evil on the day of worship...? (GW)

Sabbath: See how you translated the word Sabbath in 1:21b and 3:2c. If you used a longer phrase, such as “the rest day of the Jews” in those verses, it may be

appropriate to use a shorter form of the phrase here, for example, “the rest day.”

3:4c

to do good or to do evil,

- Does it allow us^(incl) to do good works or evil?
- Should we^(incl) help people or harm them on the rest day?
- to do good to people. It is certainly not right to do evil to people, right?

to do good or to do evil: The phrase to do good here means to do good to people or to help them. The phrase to do evil here means to hurt or harm people.

Here is another way to translate this:

to help someone or to harm someone

3:4d

to save life or to destroy it?”

- Does our^(incl) law allow us to save people or kill them?”
- Should we^(incl) save them or kill them?”
- It is certainly right to save a person. It is not right to kill him.”

to save life: The phrase to save life in this context refers to saving someone from danger.

If you cannot speak generally about saving a life, here are some other ways to translate this:

to save/rescue a person

to save/rescue a person from danger/death

General Comment on 3:4b–d

In some languages, it may be clearer to express 3:4b–d as four separate questions or statements. For example:

Does our Law allow us to help people on the Sabbath? Or does it allow us to harm people? Does it allow us to save someone’s life? Or does it allow us to kill someone?

In other languages, it may be more natural to express 3:4b–d as two questions. One question could refer to the actions of doing good and saving life. The other question could refer to the actions of doing evil and killing. For example:

Is it lawful to do good and to save a life? Or it is lawful to do evil and to kill someone?

3:4e

But they were silent.

- But they did not reply.
- But no one answered him.
- When he said that, they did not say anything.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces a contrast. In this context it was expected that the Pharisees would answer Jesus. But instead they kept silent.

they: The pronoun they refers to those who wanted to accuse Jesus. The context shows that they were some of Jesus’ enemies from the Pharisee party.

were silent: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as were silent indicates that they did not respond to Jesus. They remained silent because they did not know how to answer Jesus without admitting that they themselves were wrong.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

But they wouldn’t answer him. (NLT)

But no one said a word. (CEV)

Mark 3:5

Section 3:1–6: Jesus healed a man on the rest day and angered the Pharisees

In this section, Mark continued to tell about how the Pharisees opposed Jesus. The Pharisees had decided that healing a person on the Sabbath was work. The Jewish religious law prohibited work on the Sabbath. So the Pharisees criticized Jesus because he worked on the Sabbath.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Man with a Paralyzed Hand (GNT)

Jesus Heals on the Sabbath (NLT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:9–14 and Luke 6:6–11.

Paragraph 3:1–6

Verse 3:1 provides the background for the story that is told in 3:2–6. It introduces the people in the story and the place where it happened.

3:5a

Jesus looked around at them with anger

- He looked around at them and was angry at them,
- Jesus was angry as he looked around at them, (GW)
- Jesus was angry as he looked from side to side at them.

Jesus looked around at them with anger: The phrase Jesus looked around at them probably indicates that Jesus looked at all of the people in every part of the room. The phrase in anger describes how Jesus felt as he looked at them. He was angry because they did not pity the man with the crippled hand.

In some languages it may be natural to change the order of phrases in 3:5a. For example, the GNT says:

Jesus was angry as he looked around at them

3:5b

and sorrow at their hardness of heart.

- He was very unhappy that they were so stubborn, and
- and was distraught/disturbed that they refused to agree.
- He felt very sad because they were so stubborn.

and sorrow: There are two ways to interpret the meaning of the word that the BSB translates as sorrow:

1. It means that Jesus was grieved or very sad. For example:

grieved at their hardness of heart (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NLT, NET, NCV, KJV, NASB, JBP, GW, REB)

1. It means that Jesus felt sorry for them because they were actually hurting themselves by their stubbornness. For example:

he felt sorry for them because they were so stubborn (CEV) (GNT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is a NT hapax. It is true that this word as found in Greek literature has the meaning of sharing sympathetically the sadness of another person. But that does not fit well in this context where those looking

for a reason to accuse Jesus were feeling no sadness for Jesus to share. The Greek prefix *συν-* may also function as an intensifier (BDAG page 956 suggests that it functions in this way in this context) and the meaning must be “to be grieved within himself” at the hardness of their hearts. It is followed by the majority of English versions and fits the context well.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

was very upset

felt great sorrow

hardness of heart: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as hardness of heart is an idiom (NLT: “hard hearts”). It means that the people were “stubborn” or “obstinate.” It refers to their unwillingness to change what they thought and believed. It does not refer literally to the heart as an organ in a person’s body. The CEV has another way to translate this:

because they were so stubborn (CEV)

In some languages, there may be a different idiom to refer to stubbornness. For example, the GW says:

their minds were closed (GW)

3:5c

Then He said to the man, “Stretch out your hand.”

- he said to the man, “Straighten your^(sing) hand/arm.”
- Then he/Jesus told the man to extend his hand/arm.

Stretch out your hand: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Stretch out means “to extend” or “reach out.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Hold out your hand. (GW)

Reach out your hand. (NLT96)

The same word is translated as reach in 1:41.

hand: The word that the BSB translates as hand can include part of the arm as well. See how you translated this in 3:1b.

General Comment on 3:5c

In some languages, it will be more natural to translate 3:5c as indirect speech. For example:

Jesus told the man to stretch out his hand/arm.

3:5d

So he stretched it out,

- The man stretched out his hand/arm,
- The man straightened his hand/arm,

3:5e

and it was restored.

- and his hand/arm became well.
- and it was healed.

it was restored: The word restored here means “healed.” The pronoun it refers to man’s hand which was made strong and well.

Mark 3:6

Section 3:1–6: Jesus healed a man on the rest day and angered the Pharisees

In this section, Mark continued to tell about how the Pharisees opposed Jesus. The Pharisees had decided that healing a person on the Sabbath was work. The Jewish religious law prohibited work on the Sabbath. So the Pharisees criticized Jesus because he worked on the Sabbath.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Man with a Paralyzed Hand (GNT)

Jesus Heals on the Sabbath (NLT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:9–14 and Luke 6:6–11.

Paragraph 3:1–6

Verse 3:1 provides the background for the story that is told in 3:2–6. It introduces the people in the story and the place where it happened.

3:6a

At this, the Pharisees went out

- The Pharisees left
- Then Jesus’ enemies there who were Pharisees left the synagogue building.

At this: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as At this here introduces what happened next in the story. Connect 3:6 to 3:5 in a way that is natural in your language.

the Pharisees: This is the first time in this chapter that Mark mentioned the Pharisees by name. The Pharisees are the people whom he referred to by saying, “they were watching” in 3:2b. As the note there said, you may need to introduce this information earlier than 3:6a, so that your readers will understand who was accusing Jesus.

The phrase the Pharisees does not refer here to all of the Pharisees, but only to those who were in that synagogue. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate that in some way. For example:

Jesus’ enemies there who were Pharisees

Pharisees: The Pharisees were a Jewish religious group or party. It was very important to them to obey all of the Jewish religious laws very carefully and in detail. Here are some ways to translate this word:

- Transliterate the word Pharisees according to the sounds of your language and indicate that it refers to people. For example:

Farisi members

Parise adherents

- Transliterate the word Pharisees and indicate that it refers to a group of people with certain beliefs. For example:

people belonging to the Farise religious sect/
group

members of the religious group called the Farasi

See how you translated Pharisees in 2:16. You may also want to include an explanation of Pharisees in the glossary of your translation.

went out: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as went out means that the Pharisees “left” or “exited” the synagogue.

3:6b

and began plotting with the Herodians

- and immediately began to plan with the supporters/followers of King Herod
- They went to the followers of King/Governor Herod and immediately held a meeting/council to plot/plan

began plotting: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as began plotting means “were meeting together to discuss (something) and make a plan.” The Greek verb form probably indicates that the action was repeated or continued at other times after this. The BSB and some other English versions add the word “began” to indicate this. In this context it is clear that the Pharisees’ plans were evil.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

met together and planned / discussed

plotted/conspired

The Greek phrase also includes the word that is sometimes translated as “immediately.” The GNT expresses it this way:

met at once with some members of Herod’s party (GNT)

The Pharisees immediately met with the Herodians and began to plan how they could cause the courts to sentence Jesus to death. It was a Sabbath day, but they decided to have a meeting immediately.

with the Herodians: The Herodians were a Jewish political group that supported the Jewish ruler whose name was Herod Antipas. The Roman government had appointed him to be king over the Roman province of Judea.

Both the Pharisees and the Herodians were against Jesus. So they joined together to oppose Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate Herodians:

those who supported Governor Herod

Herod’s followers (CEV)

some members of Herod’s party (GNT)

supporter of the ruler Herod

3:6c

how they might kill Jesus.

- how they could kill/destroy Jesus.
- what to accuse Jesus of to have/get him killed.

how they might kill Jesus: The Pharisees wanted Jesus to be killed, but they did not have the authority

to sentence him to death. So they were looking for a way to accuse him so that the government would kill him. The Pharisees were not planning to murder Jesus themselves.

If you need to make this explicit in your language, you can say:

how they might accuse Jesus to have him killed

Mark 3:7

Section 3:7–12: Crowds of people followed Jesus to Lake Galilee

Even though some people opposed Jesus (3:1–6), this section tells about the many people who wanted to come to Jesus. Some people wanted to hear him, and some wanted him to heal their sick people.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed many people at Lake Galilee

People come from many places to see Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:15–16 and Luke 6:17–19.

Paragraph 3:7–12

The story in 3:7–12 began sometime after the story in 3:1–6 ended. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories. The events in 3:7–12 could have happened on that day or on another day.

3:7a

So Jesus withdrew with His disciples to the sea,

- ¶ Jesus and his disciples departed to Lake Galilee,
- ¶ Then Jesus and his followers left that place and went to the shore of Lake Galilee.

So: The Greek that the BSB translates as So is a common connecting word which introduces the next story. In some languages, it is natural to begin a story with a time word or phrase. If your language is like that, use an expression here that is not too specific. For example:

Then (NET)

After that

In other languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this story in a natural way in your language.

Jesus withdrew: The Greek word that the BSB translates as withdrew means “went away,” “departed” or “left.” For example, the GW says:

Jesus left (GW)

If your language requires that you specify from where Jesus left, Scholars have different opinions about why Jesus left. The main ones are: (1) Some scholars believe Jesus withdrew from the Pharisees, getting away from their opposition. One way to translate this would be: “Because his enemies were plotting to kill him, Jesus left the village and went....” (2) Other scholars believe Jesus withdrew from the synagogue and village so that more people from other areas would come to him. One way to translate this would be: “Jesus left the village and went outside by the lake.” (3) Still other scholars believe Jesus withdrew from the village or crowds to be alone with his disciples. One way to translate this would be: “Jesus left the village and people and went alone with his disciples to the lake, but....” If your language does not require you to say why or from what Jesus withdrew, it is recommended that you leave it unstated. However, if your language requires that you specify where he is leaving or why, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1); because it agrees with the parallel passage in Matthew. you can say:

Jesus left that place

Jesus left that town

with His disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means “learners” who are in a relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Here are some other ways to translate disciples:

- Use a term that refers to people who learn from a teacher or an expert. It is helpful if the term also implies that the learners are often with their teacher. For example:

learners/students

apprentices Be careful not to use a term that would refer only to a student in a school or classroom.

- Use a term that refers to people who follow a teacher or leader by obeying his teaching. It is helpful if this term also implies learning from the teacher and actually following the teacher wherever he goes. For example:

followers

those who are committed/faithful (to a teacher/leader)

See how you translated this term in 2:15b. See also disciple in the Glossary.

to the sea: The phrase to the sea refers to going to the edge or shore of the sea. Jesus and his disciples went to the land right next to the sea. For example, the CEV says:

to the shore of the lake (CEV)

the sea: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as the sea refers to Lake Galilee. For example, the GNT says:

to Lake Galilee (GNT)

Lake Galilee is a large body of fresh water (21 kilometers long and 13 kilometers wide). Lakes are smaller than oceans but usually wider than rivers.

If you do not have a word for lake in your language, here are some other ways to translate it:

a large body/area of water

a wide river

See how you translated this phrase in 2:13a.

3:7b
accompanied by a large crowd

- and a large/huge crowd of people followed him
- Very many people went to him.

accompanied by a large crowd: Scholars differ as to whom the phrase accompanied by a large crowd refers:

1. It refers to people from all the places in 3:7b–8c. For example, the GNT says:

^{7b}...and a large crowd followed him. ^{7c}They had come from Galilee, from Judea, ^{8a}from Jerusalem, from the territory of Idumea, ^{8b}from the territory on the east side of the Jordan, ^{8c}and from the region around the cities of Tyre and Sidon. (BSB, GNT, CEV, RSV, GW, NLT, KJV, NASB, JBP, REB)

1. It refers only to the people from Galilee. The people from all the other places “came to him.” For example, the NIV says:

^{7b}...and a large crowd from Galilee followed. ^{8e}When they heard all he was doing, ^{8d}many people came to him from Judea, ^{8a}Jerusalem, Idumea, ^{8b}and the regions across the Jordan ^{8c}and around Tyre and Sidon. (NIV, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is the most natural way to understand the list in Greek.

a large crowd: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as a large crowd means “very many people.”

3:7c

from Galilee, Judea,

- from the province of Galilee and the province of Judea,
- They came from all over the regions of Galilee and Judea

from Galilee: The word Galilee is the name of a region. This region was a Roman province. Here the word Galilee does not refer to the lake.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

from the region of Galilee

from the province of Galilee

Judea: The word Judea is the name of a region. This was the region surrounding the city of Jerusalem. This region was also a Roman province.

As with Galilee, here are some other ways you can translate Judea:

the region of Judea

the province of Judea

Mark 3:8

Section 3:7–12: Crowds of people followed Jesus to Lake Galilee

Even though some people opposed Jesus (3:1–6), this section tells about the many people who wanted to come to Jesus. Some people wanted to hear him, and some wanted him to heal their sick people.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed many people at Lake Galilee

People come from many places to see Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:15–16 and Luke 6:17–19.

Paragraph 3:7–12

The story in 3:7–12 began sometime after the story in 3:1–6 ended. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories. The events in 3:7–12 could have happened on that day or on another day.

3:8a

Jerusalem, Idumea,

- from the city of Jerusalem, from the region of Idumea,
- and the city of Jerusalem and the region of Idumea

Jerusalem: The word Jerusalem is the name of a city. It was in the region of Judea.

Idumea: The word Idumea is the name of a region. It was south of the region of Judea.

As with Judea, here are some other ways you can translate Idumea:

the region of Idumea

the province of Idumea

3:8b

the region beyond the Jordan,

- from the region/area on the east/other/far side of the Jordan River,
- and the area across the Jordan River

the region beyond the Jordan: This particular region or territory was on the east side of the Jordan

River, which was other side of the Jordan River from Jerusalem.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and the region/area across the Jordan River

the lands across the Jordan River (NCV)

the Jordan: The word Jordan is the name of a river.

3:8c

and the vicinity of Tyre and Sidon.

- and from the region around Tyre and Sidon.
- and from the area around the cities of Tyre and Sidon.

and the vicinity of Tyre and Sidon: The words Tyre and Sidon are the names of cities. They were north of the region of Galilee on the west coast.

Another way to translate this phrase would be:

and...the region around the cities of Tyre and Sidon (GNT)

3:8d

The large crowd came to Him

- This huge/large crowd of people came to Jesus
- Many people from all these areas came to Jesus

3:8e

when they heard what great things He was doing.

- because they had heard of everything he was doing.
- because they had heard of the miracles he was doing.

what great things He was doing: The phrase what great things He was doing refers to the miracles Jesus had done before coming to the lake. He had been doing miracles such as healing the sick and casting out demons. Also, he was teaching people.

In some languages, it will be more natural to make the word “miracles” explicit. For example, the NLT says:

The news about his miracles

General Comment on 3:8d–e

In some languages, it will be more natural to change the order of 3:8d and 3:8e. For example:

^{8e}Many people had heard of the miracles that Jesus had done, ^{8d}that is why many of them came to him.

General Comment on 3:7–8

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of some of the parts of 3:7–8. For example:

^{7a}Jesus and his disciples went away to Lake Galilee. ^{8e}Many people had heard of the things he was doing, so ^{7b,8d}a large crowd followed him. ^{7c}They had come from Galilee, from Judea...

Mark 3:9

Section 3:7–12: Crowds of people followed Jesus to Lake Galilee

Even though some people opposed Jesus (3:1–6), this section tells about the many people who wanted to come to Jesus. Some people wanted to hear him, and some wanted him to heal their sick people.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed many people at Lake Galilee

People come from many places to see Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:15–16 and Luke 6:17–19.

Paragraph 3:7–12

The story in 3:7–12 began sometime after the story in 3:1–6 ended. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories. The events in 3:7–12 could have happened on that day or on another day.

3:9

In this verse Jesus told his disciples to get a small boat ready for him so the people would not crowd him or push him. In some languages you may need to use a different order than the BSB does. See the General Comment on 3:9a–d after 3:9d and the General Comment on 3:9–10 at the end of the notes on 3:10b for examples of how to reorder the verse parts.

3:9a

Jesus asked His disciples

- He/Jesus told his disciples
- He/Jesus said to his followers,

His disciples: The phrase His disciples is the same phrase as in 3:7a.

3:9b to have a boat ready for Him

- to get a small boat ready for him to use,
- “Prepare a small boat for me to sit in

See the General Comment on 3:9b–d below for a way to translate this as a direct quote.

to have a boat ready for Him: The clause to have a boat ready for Him indicates that Jesus asked his disciples to get or prepare a small boat for him in case he needed it. If the people pushed him too much, he intended to sit in the boat and teach from it.

a boat: The boats used on Lake Galilee were small boats used for fishing and travel across the lake. They could hold about two to fifteen people. People made them move across the water with oars and sails.

Here are some ways to translate the word boat:

a large canoe

a vehicle for crossing water

something for carrying people on top of water

The word “boat” first occurred in 1:19c and 1:20b. See how you translated it there.

3:9c so that the crowd

- because many people came,
- since there is such a big crowd,
- There were very many people; that is the reason why

3:9d would not crush Him.

- and he wanted to prevent the people from crowding/ crushing him.
- so that the people will not push/crush me.”

**3:9c–d
so that the crowd would not crush Him:** In Greek this is literally “because of the crowd so that they might not crowd him.” Jesus wanted a boat because the crowd had become so large that the people might have crushed

not crush Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as crush means “pushing,” “pressing hard,” “crushing.”

General Comment on 3:9a–d

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of some of the parts in 3:9a–d. For example:

^{9c}There were so many people ^{9d}that they might crush Jesus. ^{9a}That is why Jesus told his followers ^{9b}to have a boat ready for him to sit in while teaching the people.

General Comment on 3:9b–d

In some languages it will be more natural to translate 3:9b–d as a direct quote. For example:

Jesus said to his disciples, “Get a small boat for me to sit in, so that the crowd will not crush me.”

Mark 3:10

Section 3:7–12: Crowds of people followed Jesus to Lake Galilee

Even though some people opposed Jesus (3:1–6), this section tells about the many people who wanted to come to Jesus. Some people wanted to hear him, and some wanted him to heal their sick people.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed many people at Lake Galilee

People come from many places to see Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:15–16 and Luke 6:17–19.

Paragraph 3:7–12

The story in 3:7–12 began sometime after the story in 3:1–6 ended. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories. The events in 3:7–12 could have happened on that day or on another day.

3:10–12

In 3:10–12 Mark explained why the crowd of people might crush Jesus (3:9). They knew that he had healed many people, and they wanted Jesus to heal them also. People who were controlled by demons added more disorder by kneeling in front of him and shouting out who he was.

Express the explanation in 3:10–12 in a natural way in your language. There may be special ways to indicate

such explanations, such as certain verb forms. Here is an example from the GW:

^{9d}...so that the crowd would not crush him. ¹⁰He had cured so many that everyone with a disease rushed up to him in order to touch him. ¹¹Whenever people with evil spirits saw him, they would fall down in front of him and shout, “You are the Son of God!” ¹²He gave them orders not to tell people who he was.

Notice the verb forms and conjunctions that are underlined. The explanation describes events that happened often when Jesus was with a crowd.

3:10a

For He had healed so many

- Since/Because Jesus had healed very many sick people,
- Jesus had already healed many sick people,

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as **For** introduces an explanation of 3:9. Introduce this explanation in a natural way in your language. In some languages a connector may not be needed.

He had healed: The tense of the Greek verb meaning He had healed indicates that Jesus had already healed many people.

many: The word many refers to many sick people.

3:10b

that all who had diseases were pressing forward to touch Him.

- the people who were sick were pushing toward him in order to touch him.
- so the sick people were pushing towards Jesus, trying to be healed by touching him.

that: The Greek word that the BSB translates as **that** indicates that what follows is the result of Jesus having healed so many people.

Here some other ways to translate this:

^{10a}There had been many healings that day. ^{10b}As a result, many sick people were crowding around him... (NLT96)

He had healed many people, so all the sick were pushing toward him to touch him. (NCV)

all who had diseases: Here are some other ways to translate the phrase all who had diseases:

the people who were sick

the sick people

were pressing forward: The Greek word that the BSB translates as were pressing forward is literally “falling on him.” It indicates that the people were approaching eagerly and forcefully. They were pushing against each other and forcing their way forward to get near Jesus.

to touch Him: The phrase to touch Him tells why the people were pushing forward. They were pushing in order to touch him.

There is implied information here. The people believed that if they touched Jesus, they would be healed. In some languages, it may be necessary to add this information. For example:

to touch him so that they would be healed

Mark 3:11

Section 3:7–12: Crowds of people followed Jesus to Lake Galilee

Even though some people opposed Jesus (3:1–6), this section tells about the many people who wanted to come to Jesus. Some people wanted to hear him, and some wanted him to heal their sick people.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed many people at Lake Galilee

People come from many places to see Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:15–16 and Luke 6:17–19.

Paragraph 3:7–12

The story in 3:7–12 began sometime after the story in 3:1–6 ended. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories. The events in 3:7–12 could have happened on that day or on another day.

3:11a

And when the unclean spirits saw Him,

- Whenever the people possessed by evil spirits saw Jesus,

- Whenever evil spirits saw Jesus,

the unclean spirits: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as unclean spirits refers to spirits that are evil and can control people's actions. It does not imply that the spirits are literally dirty. The phrase unclean spirits refers to the same type of spirit as the Greek terms that are often translated as "demons" and "evil spirits."

Here are some other ways to translate unclean spirits:

- Use a general term in your language that refers to spirits that are evil and can control people. If there is one word with this meaning, you may not need a separate word like "evil." For example:

demons

- Use a specific term in your language that refers to a certain type of spirit. This spirit should be able to do what is described in this context. Do not use a term that refers to the spirit of a dead person.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

evil spirits

bad spirits Be sure that an expression like "unclean spirits" does not imply that the spirits are literally dirty.

See the note on "unclean spirit" in 1:23a. See also evil spirit in the Glossary.

3:11b

they fell down before Him and cried out,

- they knelt in front of Jesus, and they shouted,
- they caused the people they controlled to lie face down before him and shout

they fell down before Him: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as they fell down before Him indicates that the unclean spirits were causing the people to kneel or lie face down before Jesus. It does not mean that the people stumbled and fell. The unclean spirits did this because Jesus had authority over them.

they: The pronoun they refers grammatically to the unclean spirits. However, the action of lying face down on the ground refers to the people who were possessed by the unclean spirits. For example, the GW says:

Whenever people with evil spirits saw him, they would fall down

The GNT and NLT are similar.

In some languages it may be more natural to express this meaning with a causative verb. For example:

Whenever the evil spirits saw Jesus, they caused the people whom they possessed to kneel down in front of him

Use a natural way in your language to describe this action.

cried out: The phrase cried out means "shouted loudly." It introduces what the unclean spirits shouted to Jesus. The unclean spirits recognized who Jesus really was, and they caused the people whom they controlled to shout to him, "You are the Son of God!"

3:11c

"You are the Son of God!"

- "You^(sing) are the Son of God."
- to him that he was the Son of God.

the Son of God: The Bible uses the title Son of God to express the fact that Jesus has the same nature as God and that he comes from God. God does not have a physical body, and he did not create/produce Jesus the way a human father produces a son. Jesus existed eternally as the Son with his Father.

For further information, see the note on 1:1.

God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as God refers here to the eternal spirit who created everything. He is more powerful than any other spirit, and he is perfectly good and wise. He deserves to be worshiped. Here are some ways to translate God:

- Use a name or title for God that people in your culture already use.
- Use a descriptive term that fits the truth about God that is revealed in the Bible. For example:

Creator

Great Spirit

Ruler of the universe

See how you translated God in 1:1. For more detailed information, see God in the Glossary.

General Comment on 3:11c

The BSB has translated this as a direct quote. In some languages it will be more natural to translate this as an indirect quote. For example:

They shouted to Jesus that he was the Son of God.

Mark 3:12

Section 3:7–12: Crowds of people followed Jesus to Lake Galilee

Even though some people opposed Jesus (3:1–6), this section tells about the many people who wanted to come to Jesus. Some people wanted to hear him, and some wanted him to heal their sick people.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed many people at Lake Galilee

People come from many places to see Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:15–16 and Luke 6:17–19.

Paragraph 3:7–12

The story in 3:7–12 began sometime after the story in 3:1–6 ended. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories. The events in 3:7–12 could have happened on that day or on another day.

3:12a

But He warned them sternly

- But Jesus told/warned them strongly
- Jesus strongly/sternly ordered the evil spirits,
- But Jesus ordered/commanded the evil spirits

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB here translates as But is a simple connector that is often translated as “and” (as in the RSV). Here this word introduces what Jesus said to the unclean spirits. Jesus’ reaction was unexpected, so some English versions here translate this conjunction as But. Other versions do not translate this word here. You should connect 3:11 and 3:12 in a way that is natural in your language.

He warned them sternly: The Greek words that the BSB translates as He warned them sternly is literally “he rebuked them much.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Jesus strongly warned them (NCV)

he sternly ordered them (NET)

he insisted that they... (REB)

3:12b

not to make Him known.

- not to tell people/anyone who he was.
- “Do not tell people who I am.”
- not to tell that he was the Son of God.

not to make Him known: The clause not to make Him known is an indirect command. Jesus was commanding the unclean spirits not to tell people that he was the Son of God. Jesus truly was the Son of God. Scholars differ as to why Jesus would not allow the demons to tell who he was. (a) Some scholars think that the reason Jesus did not permit the evil spirits to tell who he was, was because the time had not yet come to reveal to everyone that he was the Son of God, the Messiah. At that time in Jesus’ ministry, the people would not have completely understood why he had come to the earth. They would have probably thought that he had come to deliver them politically from Rome. (b) Some scholars think that the reason Jesus would not allow evil spirits to tell who he was, was that the evil spirits are evil and he did not want the witness of who he was to come from an evil source. (c) Some scholars think that the reason Jesus would not allow evil spirits to tell who he was, was because he did not want more people to come to him. He already had so many people coming to him that it was difficult to minister to them. (See the General Comment below for a way to make this a direct command.)

If people will incorrectly think that Jesus was saying that he was not the Son of God, then you should add a footnote. A possible footnote is:

When Jesus ordered the demons to stop saying that he was the Son of God, this does not mean that Jesus was not the Son of God. He was. However, he did not want it announced in that way or at that time.

make Him known: The phrase make Him known refers to revealing the fact that Jesus was the Son of God.

General Comment on 3:12a–b

The clause make Him known in 3:12b is an indirect quotation. In some languages a direct command is more natural. For example:

^{12a}But Jesus commanded the evil spirits, ^{12b}“Do not tell people who I am.”

Mark 3:13

Section 3:13–19: Jesus chose twelve apostles

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus chose twelve special men

Jesus appointed the apostles

Jesus named twelve men to be his apostles

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 10:1–4 and Luke 6:12–16.

3:13a

Then Jesus went up on the mountain

- ¶ Then Jesus went up a mountain
- ¶ Later, Jesus/he ascended a hill.

The story in 3:13–15 began sometime after the story in 3:7–12 ended. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories.

Then: In some languages, it is natural to begin a story with a time word or phrase. If your language is like that, use an expression here that is not too specific. For example:

Afterward Jesus went up on a mountain (NLT)

Later he went up on to the hill-side. (JBP)

In other languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this story in a natural way in your language.

Jesus went up on the mountain: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Jesus went up on the mountain indicates that he walked up the slope of a mountain. This does not necessarily indicate that he went all the way to the top of the mountain. He went to a place where he could be away from most of the other people.

the mountain: This refers to one of the hills around Lake Galilee.

3:13b

and called for those He wanted,

- and summoned those whom he wanted to come,

- He asked those he wanted to chose from to come to him.

and called for: The Greek word that the BSB translates as called for here means “summoned” or “asked (them) to join him.” The parallel passage in Luke 6:12–13 indicates that Jesus went up the mountain, prayed throughout the night, and only the next morning did he call the disciples. It is possible that Jesus sent someone to call his disciples.

those He wanted: The phrase those He wanted means “those people Jesus wanted to come to him.” Scholars differ as to whom the phrase those He wanted refers:

1. Jesus called a larger group to come up the mountain, and then out of them he chose the twelve disciples.
2. Jesus called just the twelve disciples to come up the mountain.

If you must be specific, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The majority of scholars favor this interpretation.

3:13c

and they came to Him.

- and they came to where he was.
- They came to him, (GNT)

and they came to Him: The disciples came to where Jesus was on the mountain. The parallel passage in Luke 6:12–13 says that Jesus prayed throughout the night, and he called the disciples the following morning. Neither Mark nor Luke say where the disciples came from, so you should not be specific about the details.

Mark 3:14

Section 3:13–19: Jesus chose twelve apostles

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus chose twelve special men

Jesus appointed the apostles

Jesus named twelve men to be his apostles

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 10:1–4 and Luke 6:12–16.

3:14a-d

He appointed twelve of them, whom He designated as apostles, to accompany Him, to be sent out to preach: In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence after accompany Him. For example:

^{14a}Jesus appointed them ^{14b}to be apostles ^{14c}in order that they might be with him. ^{14d}He also wanted to send them out to preach...

3:14a

He appointed twelve of them,

- He chose twelve of them
- Then he selected twelve of them (NLT96)
- and from among them, he chose twelve men.

He appointed twelve of them: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as appointed here literally means “made.” Jesus made twelve men his apostles. This indicates that Jesus “chose” or “selected” twelve of the disciples he had summoned to be apostles. For example:

Then he chose twelve of them (CEV)

Then he selected twelve of them (NLT96)

3:14b

whom He designated as apostles,

- and designated them to be his apostles/messengers.
- to be his apostles. (CEV)
- He named/called them his apostles/representatives,

whom He designated as apostles: There is a textual issue in this verse. In some Greek manuscripts, there is a clause that means “designating them apostles.”

1. Most recent, major English versions follow the manuscripts that include this clause. For example, the GW says:

^{14a}He appointed twelve ^{14b}whom he called apostles. ^{14c}They were to accompany him. (BSB, NIV, GNT, CEV, GW, NCV, NLT, NRSV, NET)

1. Other English versions follow the manuscripts that do not include this clause. For example, the NJB says:

^{14a}and he appointed twelve; ^{14c}they were to be his companions (RSV, NJB, NASB, REB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), since it is supported by many of the earliest manuscripts. The UBS4 follows option (1), giving it a C rating, indicating some degree of doubt. Although this reading has the support of some of the oldest and most reliable manuscripts, there is also strong reason to believe that copyists may have taken this phrase from Luke 6:13 and added it here. The RSV and the NJB no doubt omitted it because of its considerable degree of uncertainty. The addition could be explained based on a copyist’s tendency to want to harmonize and/or further clarify a text. (Based on UBS4 page 128, Metzger page 69, and EH page 69).

However, if the major language version in your area followed option (2), it may be best to follow that option.

designated: The Greek word that the BSB translates as designated is literally “named.” For example:

whom he named apostles (GNT)

The CEV has another way to translate this:

to be his apostles (CEV)

apostles: The Greek word that English versions translate as apostles means “those who are sent.” It refers to people whom someone sends with authority to accomplish a mission or a particular task. Jesus chose twelve men to be his apostles.

Here are some other ways to translate apostle:

- Translate the meaning of the Greek word apostles. For example:

people sent to speak/act for him

special messengers

representatives

- Indicate the role or function of apostles. For example:

chief leaders of Jesus’ work

people who are in charge of Jesus’ work

Be careful to choose different terms for “apostle,” “angel,” “elder,” and “prophet.”

See also apostle in the Glossary.

3:14c

to accompany Him,

- He did this so that they might accompany him,
- He wanted them to be with him, (NCV)
- in order that they might follow him and learn from him.

to accompany Him: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as to accompany Him tells one of Jesus' purposes in appointing the twelve disciples as apostles. He appointed them as apostles in order that they would follow him and learn from him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He wanted them to be with him (NCV)

They were to accompany him (GW)

3:14d

to be sent out to preach,

- and so that he might send them to preach to the people,
- and he wanted to send them out to preach (NCV)
- He also chose/appointed them to be his apostles so that he could send them into the villages to proclaim/announce the good news to the people.

to be sent out: The phrase that the BSB translates as to be sent out introduces Jesus' second purpose in appointing the apostles. Jesus' plan was to tell the apostles to go to various villages. One way to say this is:

and in order that * he might send them out

to preach: Jesus sent out the disciples to do two things. The first thing was to preach. The word preach means to publicly tell people something important. In this context they were telling people the gospel.

Here are some other ways to translate to preach:

to announce

to proclaim

If your language needs to specify to whom the apostles would preach, you should supply a general term such as "people." For example:

to preach to the people

If in your language you need to tell what the apostles would preach, it is recommended that you supply a general term like "good news." For example:

to preach the good news

to spread [the Good News] (GW)

Mark 3:15

Section 3:13–19: Jesus chose twelve apostles

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus chose twelve special men

Jesus appointed the apostles

Jesus named twelve men to be his apostles

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 10:1–4 and Luke 6:12–16.

3:15

and to have authority to drive out demons.

- and to have the authority/power to send demons away from people.
- and to send them with authority to exorcize the evil spirits.
- He also gave them the power/right to cause demons to leave people.

and: The conjunction translated as and joins the two things that Jesus sent the twelve apostles to do. They were (a) to preach and (b) have authority to drive out demons.

have authority to drive out demons: There is a textual issue in 3:15: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have "and have authority to drive out demons." For example, the NET says: "and to have authority to cast out demons" (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NJB, ESV, NET, NASB, REB, GW, NLT, CEV, JBP, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have "and have authority to heal the sick and to drive out demons." For example, the KJV says: "And to have power to heal sicknesses, and to cast out devils" (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The Greek word that the BSB translates as authority refers here to both the right and the power to do something.

In this context, Jesus gave his twelve apostles the power to command evil spirits to release people that they controlled.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the power/right to command evil spirits to leave people

authority to cast out demons (NLT)

to drive out demons: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to drive out is literally “to cast/throw out.” To drive out demons means to cause evil spirits to stop controlling a person. The apostles would do this by commanding the evil spirits to leave.

Jewish people often spoke of evil spirits as being in someone. Different cultures have different ways of speaking about people being controlled by demons and being released from the control of demons. Use a natural expression for this in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

send the demons away

exorcize the evil spirits

free people who were controlled by evil spirits

See the notes on “and drove out many demons” in 1:34b.

demons: The Greek word that the BSB translates as demons refers to spirits that are evil and can control people’s actions. This Greek word refers to the same type of spirits as the Greek terms that are often translated as “evil spirits” and “unclean spirits.”

See the note on “unclean spirits” at 3:11a. Also see evil spirit in the Glossary.

Mark 3:16

Section 3:13–19: Jesus chose twelve apostles

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus chose twelve special men

Jesus appointed the apostles

Jesus named twelve men to be his apostles

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 10:1–4 and Luke 6:12–16.

3:16a

These are the twelve He appointed:

- ¶ These are the twelve disciples that Jesus appointed:
- ¶ Jesus made twelve of them to be his apostles. They were called:
- ¶ Here are the names of the twelve men he choose:

These are the twelve He appointed: There is a textual issue in this verse. Some Greek manuscripts include a clause that means “These are the twelve he appointed.”

1. Nearly every major English version follows the manuscripts that include this clause. For example, the REB says:

The Twelve he appointed were: (BSB, NIV, GNT, GW, NASB, NET, NCV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The versions that follow the manuscripts that do not include this clause have one long sentence from 3:14–19. So the verb “appointed” in 3:14a goes with 3:16. For example, the RSV says:

^{14a}And he appointed twelve...: ¹⁶Simon whom he surnamed Peter... (RSV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) since it has the best manuscript support. Also, the majority of English versions follow this option.

the twelve: The phrase the twelve refers to the twelve disciples that Jesus appointed as apostles. Mark often refers to the twelve disciples/apostles as simply “the twelve.”

He appointed: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as appointed is literally “made.” Here it indicates that Jesus “chose” or “selected” the twelve. For example, the NCV says:

These are the twelve men he chose (NCV)

This same verb occurs in 3:14a.

3:16b

Simon (whom He named Peter),

- Simon whom he named Peter,
- Simon whom he also called Peter,

Simon (whom He named Peter): Jesus added the name Peter to Simon's name. After this, people sometimes called him Simon, sometimes Peter, and sometimes Simon Peter. Simon was first mentioned in 1:16.

Peter: The Greek word that the BSB transliterates as Peter means "stone" or "rock." You may want to put this in a footnote. For example:

The name Peter means "rock" in Greek.

Mark 3:17

Section 3:13–19: Jesus chose twelve apostles

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus chose twelve special men

Jesus appointed the apostles

Jesus named twelve men to be his apostles

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 10:1–4 and Luke 6:12–16.

3:17a

James son of Zebedee and his brother John

- and James and his brother John. Both were the sons of a man called Zebedee.
- and James and his younger brother John, who were the children of Zebedee.

James son of Zebedee and his brother John: James is mentioned first, so he was probably the older of the two brothers. James, John, and Zebedee were previously mentioned in 1:19–20.

son of Zebedee: Zebedee was the name of the father of both James and John.

In languages where there is no single word for son, many translators have used a more general expression, such as "child."

3:17b

(whom He named Boanerges, meaning "Sons of Thunder"),

- Jesus gave them the name Boanerges, which means Sons of Thunder.

- Jesus called them Boanerges. This means that they were like thunder.

whom He named Boanerges: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as whom He named refers to Jesus' description of the character of James and John. The Greek is almost identical to the clause "to whom he gave the name" in 3:16b. Unlike the name "Peter," which is used throughout the New Testament, the term Boanerges is not referred to anywhere else in the New Testament.

The CEV has another way to translate this:

Jesus called them Boanerges (CEV)

Boanerges: Boanerges was a word in the language that Jesus and his disciples spoke. You should write this word according to the sounds of your language. The first part of the name Boanerges is clearly Aramaic and means "sons of," but the last part could refer to the Aramaic word for "crowd/com-motion" or "anger." Another possibility is that the last part refers to a similar word in Arabic which means "Thunder". Regardless of the origin, Mark obviously understood this to mean "Sons of Thunder."

meaning "Sons of Thunder": The idiom Sons of refers to one of the characteristics of James and John. Jesus was saying that they were "Thunder-like." Scholars are not certain in what way James and John were like thunder.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

this means "Sons of Thunder"

which means "Men of Thunder" (GNT)

this means that they were like thunder

Mark 3:18

Section 3:13–19: Jesus chose twelve apostles

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus chose twelve special men

Jesus appointed the apostles

Jesus named twelve men to be his apostles

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 10:1–4 and Luke 6:12–16.

3:18a

Andrew, Philip, Bartholomew, Matthew, Thomas,

- And he chose Andrew, Philip, Bartholomew, Matthew, Thomas,
- He also chose Andrew and Philip and Bartholomew and Matthew and Thomas,

Andrew, Philip, Bartholomew, Matthew, Thomas:

Andrew was previously mentioned in 1:16. This is the first mention of the other four men in the Gospel of Mark.

In some languages, it may be more natural to repeat the verb “chose” before this list of disciples. For example:

Jesus also chose Andrew, Philip, Bartholomew, Matthew...

3:18b

James son of Alphaeus, Thaddaeus, Simon the Zealot,

- James son of Alphaeus, Thaddaeus, Simon the Zealot,
- and James the child of Alphaeus and Thaddaeus and Simon who was the zealous/passionate/patriotic one

James son of Alphaeus, Thaddaeus: There were two disciples with the name “James.” In order to distinguish this James from James the brother of John (in 3:17a), this James was referred to as James son of Alphaeus.

Alphaeus: Alphaeus is the name of a man. He was the father of James.

Simon the Zealot: There were also two disciples with the name “Simon.” In order to distinguish this Simon from Simon Peter (in 3:16b), this Simon was referred to as Simon the Zealot.

the Zealot: Scholars differ as to the meaning of the Greek word that the BSB translates as Zealot:

1. Some understand this word to mean “someone who was zealous or passionate” for Jewish independence from Rome. That is, this Simon wanted Israel to be free from the control of the Roman government. For example, the GNT says:

Simon the Patriot (GNT) (NIV, BSB, GNT, NJB, NASB, NCV, NET, GW, CEV, JBP, REB)

1. Some understand this word to be a name of the place Simon came from. Those following this interpretation transliterate this word. For example, the RSV says:

Simon the Cananaean (RSV) (RSV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), since the majority of versions and scholars support this view.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the Zealous One

the Patriot (GNT)

the nationalist/revolutionary

Mark 3:19

Section 3:13–19: Jesus chose twelve apostles

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus chose twelve special men

Jesus appointed the apostles

Jesus named twelve men to be his apostles

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 10:1–4 and Luke 6:12–16.

3:19

and Judas Iscariot, who betrayed Jesus.

- and Judas Iscariot who betrayed Jesus to his enemies.
- and Judas Iscariot who later led Jesus’ enemies to him so they could arrest him.

Judas Iscariot: The name Judas was a common name, so the Judas who betrayed Jesus is referred to as Judas Iscariot. You should treat Iscariot. Some scholars understand the word Iscariot to mean “man from Kerioth.” However, most English versions treat Iscariot

as simply a name. So here it is recommended that you follow the majority of versions. as another name.

who betrayed Jesus: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as betrayed Jesus means “delivered Jesus into the control of his enemies.” This refers to the time when Judas led Jesus’ enemies to him so that they could arrest him. This happened three years after the events here.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

who betrayed Jesus to his enemies

who later led Jesus’ enemies to him so they could arrest him

who later turned against Jesus (NCV)

Mark 3:20

Section 3:20–30: Jesus proved that he did not use Satan’s power

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus is stronger than Satan

Jesus sends evil spirits away by defeating Satan

Do not insult the Holy Spirit

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:22–32 and Luke 11:14–23; 12:10.

3:20a

Then Jesus went home,

- ¶ Then Jesus entered a house, (NIV)
- ¶ When Jesus returned to the house where he was staying, (NLT96)

Then Jesus went home: English versions differ as to the verse in which the clause Then Jesus went home should be included:

1. Most translations and the UBS Greek text place this clause at the beginning of 3:20. For example, the NIV says:

¹⁹...and Judas Iscariot, who betrayed him.

²⁰Then Jesus entered a house, and again a crowd gathered, so that he and his disciples were not even able to eat. (NIV, BSB, GNT, NJB, NLT, CEV, NASB, NET, GW)

1. Some translations place this clause at the end of 3:19. For example, the RSV says:

¹⁹...and Judas Iscariot, who betrayed him.

Then he went home; ²⁰and the crowd came together again, so that they could not even eat. (RSV, REB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), because this clause provides the setting for the next story (3:20–30).

Then: This verse is the beginning of a new story. The events in this story happened sometime after the events in the preceding section. The BSB introduces this story with the word Then. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories.

It may be natural in your language to begin a story with a time word or phrase. If that is true, use an expression that is not too specific. For example:

After that

In some languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this story in a natural way in your language.

home: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as home is literally “house.” Scholars differ as to which house this was:

1. This was the house in Capernaum in which Jesus and his disciples usually stayed. This house could be considered Jesus’ home. For example:

Then Jesus went home. (GNT)

Jesus returned to the house where he was staying (NLT96) (BSB, RSV, GNT, CEV, NASB, NET, NJB, NLT96, NCV)

1. This was no specific house. For example, the REB says:

He entered a house (REB) (NIV, REB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The majority of English versions understand it to refer to the house where Jesus normally lived when he was in Capernaum. See also 2:1b, where the same house is probably mentioned.

3:20b

and once again a crowd gathered,

- and such a large crowd gathered once again
- another large group of people came and gathered there.

once again: The Greek word that the BSB translates as once again can also be translated as “once more.” This was not the first time that a crowd had gathered together to see Jesus.

Here is another way to translate this:

Another crowd gathered (GW)

a crowd gathered: The clause a crowd gathered means that “many people came” to the house.

3:20c

so that He and His disciples could not even eat.

- that Jesus and his disciples were not even able to eat.
- Because of the crowd, Jesus and his followers were too busy to eat.

so that: The Greek word that the BSB translates as so that introduces the result of the crowd coming to the house. So many people came to the house that Jesus was not able to eat.

Here are some others ways to translate this:

such a large crowd gathered that there was no chance even to eat (CEV)

Because of the crowd, Jesus and his disciples were not able to eat.

A crowd gathered again. That is why Jesus and his disciples did not have time to eat.

He and His disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as He and His disciples is literally “they” (as in the RSV). Most scholars believe that the “they” refers to Jesus and his disciples.

could not even eat: Jesus and his disciples were not able to eat because they were so busy teaching and helping all the people who had come.

Mark 3:21

Section 3:20–30: Jesus proved that he did not use Satan’s power

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus is stronger than Satan

Jesus sends evil spirits away by defeating Satan

Do not insult the Holy Spirit

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:22–32 and Luke 11:14–23; 12:10.

3:21a

When His family heard about this,

- When his family heard this,
- Jesus’ family heard that Jesus was too busy to eat,

When His family: The Greek idiom that the BSB translates as family is literally “those beside him.” Scholars have different opinions about what it refers to here:

1. It refers to Jesus’ immediate family, in other words Jesus’ mother and brothers.
2. It refers to Jesus’ extended family, in other words Jesus’ mother and cousins.
3. It refers to Jesus’ friends. For example, the KJV says:

And when his friends heard [of it]

Because the Greek idiom is vague, it is recommended that you use a general term like “family” or “relatives.” If you must use a more specific term, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and choose a term that refers to his mother and younger brothers.

heard about this: The Greek word that the BSB translates as heard about this indicates that his family heard that Jesus did not stop his work even to eat.

3:21b

they went out to take custody of Him,

- they went out to seize him,
- so they went to take him home with them.

they went out: This refers to Jesus’ family leaving their home or home village.

to take custody of Him: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates with the idiom to take custody is literally “to grab” or “to seize.” For example, the RSV says:

they went out to seize him

The NET has another way to say this:

they went out to restrain him

This phrase implies that Jesus’ family wanted to bring him back home with them.

3:21c saying,

- because they said,
- His family did this because they thought

saying: After saying there is a conjunction in Greek that means “because.” It introduces the reason for 3:21b. Jesus’ family went to seize him because they thought that he was crazy/mad. For example, the NCV says:

because they thought he was out of his mind

saying: Scholars disagree as to who was saying this:

1. It is Jesus’ family. For example, the CEV says:

When Jesus’ family heard what he was doing, they thought he was crazy and went to get him under control. (NIV, NLT, REB, NET, GW, NCV, CEV, KJV, NASB)

1. It refers to people in general. For example, the GNT says:

...because people were saying, “He’s gone mad!” (GNT, RSV, JBP)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The majority of English translations follow this interpretation.

3:21d “He is out of His mind.”

- “Jesus must be insane.”
- that Jesus had become crazy/mad.

He is out of His mind: The Greek word that the BSB translates by the English idiom out of His mind means “insane/mad.” For example, the JBP says:

He must be mad!

General Comment on 3:21c–d

In some languages it may be natural to use indirect speech here. For example:

for they thought that he had become insane/mad

because they thought he was out of his mind (NCV)

General Comment on 3:21b–d

In this verse, 3:21c–d expresses the reason for the result in 3:21b. In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of these clauses. For example:

^{21a}When Jesus’ family heard about this, ^{21c}they said, ^{21d}“He is out of his mind.” ^{21b}So they went to take charge of him.

^{21a}When Jesus’ family heard about this, ^{21c}they said, ^{21d}“He is out of his mind.” ^{21b}That is the reason why they went to take charge of him.

Mark 3:22

Section 3:20–30: Jesus proved that he did not use Satan’s power

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus is stronger than Satan

Jesus sends evil spirits away by defeating Satan

Do not insult the Holy Spirit

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:22–32 and Luke 11:14–23; 12:10.

Paragraph 3:22–30

In the previous paragraph, Jesus’ family decided that it was time to bring him home and restrain him. This paragraph continues Mark’s theme of people opposing Jesus. Here, Jesus’ enemies did not want to admit that Jesus was doing miracles by God’s power. So they accused him of using Satan’s power instead. Jesus had a good answer to give to them.

3:22a**And the scribes**

- ¶ Some of the teachers of the law
- ¶ Some of the experts in the law

And: This verse is the beginning of a new part of the story. The BSB introduces this new part of the story with the word And. Many English versions have no connecting word here.

You should begin this part of the story in a way that is natural in your language.

the scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the scribes is sometimes translated as “teachers of the law,” as in the NIV. The original work of these men was to copy the laws of Moses by hand. In New Testament times, their main task was to study, interpret, and teach the law of Moses and related Jewish laws and traditions.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

teachers of the Law of Moses (CEV)

teachers of religious law (NLT)

experts on the law

This term also occurs in 1:22c. See how you translated the term there. See also teacher of the law in the Glossary.

3:22b**who had come down from Jerusalem were saying,**

- came down from Jerusalem and said,
- had descended from the city of Jerusalem. They said,
- had come from the city of Jerusalem. They were telling the people that

who had come down from Jerusalem: The teachers of the law came from Jerusalem. This probably indicates that they were the leading authorities of the Jewish religion.

had come down: The city of Jerusalem was built on a hill. So anyone leaving the city had to walk down the hill to a place that was lower in elevation.

In some languages, it is important to say whether people go up or down when they travel. In other languages, this will be unusual or may be confusing. If it is confusing in your language, you should simply say:

who had come from Jerusalem (GNT)

Jerusalem: Jerusalem was the most important city for the Jewish people. It was the main city in their history and religion.

were saying: The verb that the BSB translates as were saying introduces a direct quote. For an example of a translation using an indirect quote, see the General Comment on 3:22c–d following 3:22d.

3:22c**“He is possessed by Beelzebul,”**

- “The prince/chief of the evil spirits named Beelzebul is controlling Jesus!
- “Jesus is using the power of Satan!
- Satan was controlling Jesus.

He is possessed by: The Greek word that the BSB translates as He is possessed by is literally “he has,” as in the NRSV. This is the Jewish way of saying that a person is “controlled” by an evil spirit. In this context the teachers of the law said that Jesus was controlled by Beelzebub, a powerful evil spirit. (See the note on Beelzebub below.) They also said that Jesus was using Beelzebub’s power to drive other evil spirits out of people.

Some languages may use different expressions to describe different types of demon possession. Use an appropriate expression in your language to describe someone who uses the power of an evil spirit to do things.

Here are some other ways to translate He is possessed by in this context:

He is controlled by...

This man uses the power of...

See evil spirit in the Glossary.

Beelzebul: The meaning of this word is uncertain. Jesus’ enemies were using this word as a name for Satan, the leader of the evil spirits. It is recommended that you transliterate it as Beelzebul, because that is close to the Greek text.

Here are some other ways to translate Beelzebul:

- Transliterate the name Beelzebul into your language.
- Use the name for Satan in your language.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

the chief of the evil spirits

the evil spirits' king

the leader of the evil spirits

- Use the name Beelzebul or Satan plus a descriptive phrase. For example, the NLT says:

He's possessed by Satan, the prince of demons.

3:22d

and, “By the prince of the demons He drives out demons.”

- It is the prince/chief of demons who gives him the power to cast out demons.”
- He casts/throws out demons using the power/help of the chief/ruler of demons.”
- They also said that it was by the power/help of Satan, the demons' chief, that Jesus was casting/throwing demons out of people.

By the prince of the demons He drives out demons:

The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as By the prince of demons indicates that Jesus cast out demons using the power of the prince of demons.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

It is the chief of the demons who gives him the power to drive them out. (GNT)

He uses power from the ruler of demons to force demons out of people. (NCV)

He is even forcing out demons with the help of Beelzebul. (CEV)

the prince of the demons: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the prince of demons is literally “the ruler/chief of demons” (as in the NRSV). This phrase explains what the teachers of the law meant by the word Beelzebul.

In your translation, make sure that it is clear that “Beelzebul” and “the prince of demons” refer to the same being.

demons: The Greek word that the BSB translates as demons refers to spirits that are evil and can control people's actions. The word demons refers to the same type of spirit as the Greek terms that are often translated as “evil spirits” and “unclean spirits.” See how you translated this term in 3:11a.

He: The pronoun He refers to Jesus.

drives out: The Greek word that the BSB translates as drives out indicates that Jesus was causing many evil spirits to stop controlling people. See the notes on 1:34b and 3:15.

General Comment on 3:22c–d

The BSB translates 3:22c–d as a direct quote. In some languages, it will be more natural to translate this as an indirect quote. For example:

They said that Satan was in/controlling Jesus. It was Satan, the chief of demons who was giving Jesus the power to cast/throw out the demons.

Mark 3:23

Section 3:20–30: Jesus proved that he did not use Satan's power

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus is stronger than Satan

Jesus sends evil spirits away by defeating Satan

Do not insult the Holy Spirit

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:22–32 and Luke 11:14–23; 12:10.

Paragraph 3:22–30

In the previous paragraph, Jesus' family decided that it was time to bring him home and restrain him. This paragraph continues Mark's theme of people opposing Jesus. Here, Jesus' enemies did not want to admit that Jesus was doing miracles by God's power. So they accused him of using Satan's power instead. Jesus had a good answer to give to them.

3:23a

So Jesus called them together

- So Jesus called them to him
- Jesus told the people to gather around him. (CEV)

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB here translates as So is a simple connector. It is often translated as “and” (as in the RSV). This word connects 3:22 to 3:23–39. It introduces what Jesus said and did in response to what his enemies accused him of doing.

The BSB shows this connection with the word So. Some English versions do not translate this word. You should

connect these verses in a way that is natural in your language.

Jesus called them together: Jesus told the people to come nearer before he confronted them. The CEV says:

Jesus told the people to gather around him.

them: The pronoun them refers to both the teachers of the law and the crowd.

3:23b

and began to speak to them in parables:

- and told them some parables:
- Then he told/recounted the following illustrations:

speak to them in parables: The phrase speak to them in parables describes what Jesus said to the people in 3:23–27. The Greek word that the BSB translates as parables is used to describe different types of wise speech like proverbs, illustrations, and metaphors.

In this context there are two different parables: 3:23c–26c and 3:27. You will need to read these two parables carefully. Then consider how you would describe this type of speech in your language. See parable, Type 2, in the Glossary.

3:23c–26c

Jesus' first parable is in 3:23c–26c. In this parable, Jesus proved that what the teachers of the law were saying could not be right. If Satan controlled Jesus, he would not want to send his own helpers away. If he did, then Satan would be fighting against himself.

3:23c

“How can Satan drive out Satan?”

- “How can Satan cast/throw out himself?”
- “Will Satan cast/force Satan's demons out of people? Of course not!”
- “Surely, Satan will not throw/force his own demons out of people!”

How can Satan drive out Satan?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus asked this question to rebuke the Jewish religious leaders. He did this by emphasizing a fact that everyone should know is true: Surely, Satan would not do something against himself. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

How can Satan be the one who forces his own evil spirits to leave?

Will Satan force his own demons out of people?
Of course not!

- As a statement. For example:

Surely, Satan will not want to force his own evil spirits to leave.

Satan does not work against himself by forcing/ causing his own demons to come out of people.

Satan will not force himself out of people. (NCV)

Use whichever form is most natural in your language to emphasize a fact that is obviously true and that expresses a rebuke.

Satan drive out Satan: Here, the word Satan occurs two times. The first Satan refers to Satan himself. The second Satan represents the demons over which Satan rules.

In some languages, it may be clearer to translate the second Satan as “his demons.” For example:

Why would Satan force out his own demons?

Satan: The word Satan is the Hebrew name of the chief or leader of all the evil spirits. In Hebrew his name means “enemy.” He is the enemy of God and God's people. Here are some ways to translate Satan:

- Use a local name or idiom that refers to the chief of all demons.
- Use a descriptive phrase such as:

the chief/leader of the evil spirits

the spirit enemy of God

- Transliterate the name Satan. If this word is not already known in your area, you may also want to add a descriptive phrase. For example:

Satanas, the ruler of demons

Shaitan If you transliterate Satan or borrow a word from another language, be sure that it communicates the biblical meaning to people in your culture. It is important to check this in each biblical context.

Try to use a term that will be acceptable to churches in the area. It is suggested that you also add a footnote or glossary entry that further explains who Satan is. For example:

Satan is the leader of all the evil spirits or demons. Once he was an angel in heaven, but he rebelled against God. God expelled him from heaven, and now he tempts people on earth. Here are other names for Satan that are used in the Bible: “Beelzebul,” “the Devil,” “the Evil One,” “the Enemy,” and “the Tempter.”

See how you translated this word in 1:13a.

drive out: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as drive out is literally “cast/throw out.” It refers to causing evil spirits to stop controlling someone. See the notes on 3:15 and 3:22d, where the same term is used.

Mark 3:24

Section 3:20–30: Jesus proved that he did not use Satan’s power

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus is stronger than Satan

Jesus sends evil spirits away by defeating Satan

Do not insult the Holy Spirit

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:22–32 and Luke 11:14–23; 12:10.

Paragraph 3:22–30

In the previous paragraph, Jesus’ family decided that it was time to bring him home and restrain him. This paragraph continues Mark’s theme of people opposing Jesus. Here, Jesus’ enemies did not want to admit that Jesus was doing miracles by God’s power. So they accused him of using Satan’s power instead. Jesus had a good answer to give to them.

3:24a

If a kingdom is divided against itself,

- If a kingdom/country is divided,
- If the people of a country fight among themselves,
- If clans within the same tribe war with each other,

a kingdom: A kingdom is a country ruled by a king. But Jesus was not talking only about countries that had kings. He was giving a general rule that can be applied to any country or tribe.

Here are some other ways to translate kingdom in this context:

nation

tribe

divided against itself: The phrase divided against itself refers to different groups of people within a country fighting against each other. For example, the CEV says:

A nation whose people fight each other

3:24b

it cannot stand.

- that kingdom/country will not last/endure.
- that country cannot last/continue.
- they will destroy that tribe.

it cannot stand: The phrase cannot stand is an idiom. It means “will not be able to endure/continue.” If the people of a country fight against each other, that country will be destroyed.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

cannot continue (NCV)

won’t last very long (CEV)

Mark 3:25

Section 3:20–30: Jesus proved that he did not use Satan’s power

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus is stronger than Satan

Jesus sends evil spirits away by defeating Satan

Do not insult the Holy Spirit

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:22–32 and Luke 11:14–23; 12:10.

Paragraph 3:22–30

In the previous paragraph, Jesus' family decided that it was time to bring him home and restrain him. This paragraph continues Mark's theme of people opposing Jesus. Here, Jesus' enemies did not want to admit that Jesus was doing miracles by God's power. So they accused him of using Satan's power instead. Jesus had a good answer to give to them.

3:25a

If a house is divided against itself,

- If family members are divided against one other,
- If the siblings/brothers fight each other,
- If the people in a family are always quarreling with each other,

house: The word that the BSB translates as house refers to the people or family living in the same house. The GNT and CEV translate house as:

a family

divided against itself: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as divided against itself is identical to the phrase in 3:24a. Here it refers to members of the same family forming groups which fight each other. For example, the CEV says:

a family that fights

3:25b

it cannot stand.

- their family will not continue/last.
- the family will not stay together.
- that family will fall apart. (GNT)

it cannot stand: The Greek word that the BSB translates as cannot stand is the same word as in 3:24b. As there, this word indicates that the family "cannot continue." That family will not remain together as a family. It will be destroyed or ruined. The GNT translates this as:

that family will fall apart

Mark 3:26

Section 3:20–30: Jesus proved that he did not use Satan's power

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus is stronger than Satan

Jesus sends evil spirits away by defeating Satan

Do not insult the Holy Spirit

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:22–32 and Luke 11:14–23; 12:10.

Paragraph 3:22–30

In the previous paragraph, Jesus' family decided that it was time to bring him home and restrain him. This paragraph continues Mark's theme of people opposing Jesus. Here, Jesus' enemies did not want to admit that Jesus was doing miracles by God's power. So they accused him of using Satan's power instead. Jesus had a good answer to give to them.

3:26

At this point, Jesus applied what he had just said about countries and families to Satan's rule over his followers. Jesus' point was that Satan would not oppose himself. Therefore, when Jesus forced demons to leave people, it was not Satan who gave him the power to do it.

To say this forcefully, Jesus used an "if" followed by imaginary situation to prove that it could not be true. For some other ways to translate an imaginary situation that cannot be true, see the General Comment 3:26a–c following 3:26c.

3:26a

And if Satan is divided and rises against himself,

- And if Satan is against himself and fights against himself
- So if it is true that Satan is fighting against his own followers/helpers,

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And is a common connector. Here it connects the truth in 3:24–25 to the way Jesus compared this truth to what the teachers of the law had said about him. The GNT and CEV say:

So

It could also be translated as:

Likewise

if: The conditional word if introduces a situation that is untrue. Jesus did this in order to show the teachers of the law that what they accused him of is also untrue.

Satan is divided: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as is divided is the same verb as in 3:24a and 3:25a. It refers to a situation in which Satan's followers are opposing and fighting each other.

rises against himself: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as rises against himself here indicates that Satan works against himself by fighting his own demons. It implies that the two sides were originally together and have become enemies.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

has rebelled against himself (NJB)

fight against himself (CEV)

fight against his own demons/spirits

3:26b–c

3:26b and 3:26c are saying the same thing. In some languages it will be more natural to combine these two statements into one. For example, the CEV says:

that will be the end of him

3:26b

he cannot stand;

- he cannot continue to exist.
- he will destroy/ruin himself.

he cannot stand: The Greek word that the BSB translates as cannot stand is the same word as in 3:24b and 3:25b. It means “he will not endure” or “he will not continue.” Satan will be destroyed/defeated. For example, the NCV says:

he cannot continue

3:26c

his end has come.

- That will be the end/ruin/destruction of him.
- He cannot continue to rule.

his end has come: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as his end has come here means “Satan's power is destroyed/finished.” The CEV and GW say:

that will be the end of him

General Comment on 3:26a–c

Verse 3:26 is talking about something that cannot be true. In some languages it will sound more natural to translate this verse without the conditional “if.” For example:

Obviously Satan will not want to fight against his own demons and destroy his own power.

Will Satan want to destroy himself by fighting against himself? Will he force his own demons out of people? Of course not!

Mark 3:27

Section 3:20–30: Jesus proved that he did not use Satan's power

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus is stronger than Satan

Jesus sends evil spirits away by defeating Satan

Do not insult the Holy Spirit

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:22–32 and Luke 11:14–23; 12:10.

Paragraph 3:22–30

In the previous paragraph, Jesus' family decided that it was time to bring him home and restrain him. This paragraph continues Mark's theme of people opposing Jesus. Here, Jesus' enemies did not want to admit that Jesus was doing miracles by God's power. So they accused him of using Satan's power instead. Jesus had a good answer to give to them.

3:27

Jesus' second parable is in 3:27. Jesus used this parable to explain how he was able to free people from evil spirits. Jesus compared Satan to a strong man. He compared himself to an even stronger man. He compared freeing people from evil spirits to robbing Satan's house. Jesus implied that he could release people controlled by Satan or his evil spirits because he was stronger than Satan.

In some languages, 3:27 will be more natural if its parts are reordered. See the General Comment on 3:27a–d at the end of 3:27d for some examples of how to reorder the verse.

3:27a

Indeed, no one can enter a strong man's house

- Certainly, no one can enter/invoke the house of a strong man
- Before anyone can invade a strong man's house
- Satan is like a strong man. A person cannot come into a house whose owner is very strong

Indeed: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Indeed is literally “but” (as in the RSV). This conjunction contrasts what Jesus said (in 3:27) with the wrong thinking of these teachers of the law. They were wrong about Jesus getting power from Satan to force demons out of people. In this illustration/parable, Jesus tells what was really happening.

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. You should connect 3:27 to the rest of this passage in a way that is natural in your language.

no one can enter a strong man's house: In this context, the phrase no one can enter implies going into the strong man's house uninvited, to rob him. You may want to use a stronger word like “invade” or “break into” to express this idea.

strong man's house: The words strong man refer to someone who has physical strength and power.

Here Jesus compared Satan to a strong man who owns a house.

3:27b

to steal his possessions

- and steal his possessions/things
- and steal what he owns,
- and rob him.

to steal his possessions: The phrase to steal his possessions means “loot” or “pillage” things from the house. This represents Jesus casting out demons to free people.

3:27c

unless he first ties up the strong man.

- unless he first ties him up.
- he must first defeat/overpower and tie up the strong man.
- Only a stronger person than he can overpower him and tie him up.

unless: The conjunction unless introduces an exception to the rule in 3:27a–b that no one can carry off the possessions of a strong man.

Here is another way to translate this:

except if

until

first: The conjunction first indicates the order of events. He must first tie up the strong man before he can enter the strong man's house and steal his things.

ties up the strong man: The phrase ties up the strong man implies that someone stronger than the strong man must first overpower him in order to tie him up.

General Comment on 3:27c

There is implied information here that you may need to make explicit in your translation. For example:

unless he is strong enough to overcome/defeat the strong man and tie him up

3:27d

Then he can plunder his house.

- Then he can loot his house.
- Then he can take things from his house.
- Then he can rob him.

Then: The conjunction Then marks the order of the events in the illustration. First someone stronger than the strong man must overpower him and tie him up. Then the stronger man can rob the strong man.

he can plunder his house: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as plunder was also used in 3:27b and translated as “carry off.” The phrase he can plunder his house means “he can steal/take from the house everything he wants.” In other words: he can loot or pillage the house. The CEV says:

Then he can take everything.

he: The pronoun he refers to the stronger man. This man represents Jesus.

his: The pronoun his refers to the strong man who is being robbed. This man represents Satan.

General Comment on 3:27a–d

In some languages, it will be more natural to change the order of some of the clauses in 3:27. For example:

^{27c}In fact, a person must first tie up a strong man.

^{27a}Only then can he enter his house, ^{27b}take his possessions, ^{27d}and rob his house.

Mark 3:28

Section 3:20–30: Jesus proved that he did not use Satan's power

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus is stronger than Satan

Jesus sends evil spirits away by defeating Satan

Do not insult the Holy Spirit

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:22–32 and Luke 11:14–23; 12:10.

Paragraph 3:22–30

In the previous paragraph, Jesus' family decided that it was time to bring him home and restrain him. This paragraph continues Mark's theme of people opposing Jesus. Here, Jesus' enemies did not want to admit that Jesus was doing miracles by God's power. So they accused him of using Satan's power instead. Jesus had a good answer to give to them.

3:28–30

The teachers of the law made a very serious error. They refused to believe that Jesus had power from the Holy Spirit to cast out demons. Instead, they said that Jesus' power came from Satan. That is like calling the Holy Spirit "Satan." So these teachers of the law from Jerusalem were blaspheming the Holy Spirit.

3:28a

Truly I tell you,

- Here is the truth.
- Listen, because this is important/true.

Truly I tell you: Jesus often used the words Truly I tell you to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. This is the first occurrence of the clause Truly I tell you in Mark. It also occurs in 8:12, 9:1, 9:41, 10:15, 11:23, 12:43, 13:30, 14:9, 14:18, 14:25, 14:30. He was asking people to listen with extra attention.

Some other ways to show this emphasis are:

- Use a phrase before Jesus' statement. For example:

I assure you that... (GNT)

Listen to this!

- Include an emphatic word or phrase such as "certainly" within the following statement. For example:

all the sins and blasphemies of men will certainly be forgiven them

3:28b

the sons of men will be forgiven all sins and blasphemies, as many as they utter.

- All the sins that people do and all the things they say to slander/defame someone will be forgiven.
- God can/will forgive people for their sins, even when they insult/slander someone.
- God can/will forgive someone every time that person does something wrong, including every time he speaks evil of/against God or someone else.

the sons of men will be forgiven all sins and blasphemies, as many as they utter:

This is a passive clause. If it is more natural in your language to use an active verb and indicate who will forgive sins, you should say "God." For example:

God will forgive people for all their sins and blasphemies.

The form of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as will be forgiven often refers to an event in the future. However, this part of the verse is not a promise that God will forgive every sin. Rather it means that it is possible that God will forgive every sin. For example:

God can forgive all the sins of people, and all their blasphemies.

the sons of men: The Greek noun phrase that the BSB translates as the sons of men means "people." All people, both men and women, are included.

will be forgiven all sins and blasphemies, as many as they utter: In this context the phrase will be forgiven all sins and blasphemies indicates that God can choose not to punish people for the evil/bad things that they have said, done, and thought. God can cancel their guilt and treat them as though they had never offended.

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase in this context:

God can cancel/pardon...their sins and blasphemies

they can be released from their sins and blasphemies

God can wipe away their sins and blasphemies

In some languages it is more natural to say “forgive people,” rather than to “forgive sins.” For example:

forgive them for their sins and blasphemies

See the note on “forgiveness of sins” in 1:4d.

all sins and blasphemies: The noun sins is a general term. The noun blasphemies refers to one particular type of sin.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

any sin...including blasphemy (NLT96)

all the blasphemies and other sins

sins: The word sins refers to offenses against God. Sins include acts, thoughts, and attitudes that are not what God wants or approves. In Greek, the verb that English versions translate as sin is also a term that is used in archery to mean “miss the target”. When a person sins, he “misses” the target, that is, he fails to reach God’s standard. A person can also offend God by failing to do what God wants him to do.

It is helpful to translate sins with a general term that can include any offense against God. Here are problems to avoid:

1. The term should not imply that only serious crimes like murder or stealing are sins. Other offenses like gossip and greed are also sins.
2. The term should not include accidents or mistakes that are not against God’s will.

Here are some other ways to translate sins:

wrong acts

offenses against God

bad/evil things/deeds

In some languages it may be natural to translate sins with a phrase that includes a verb. For example:

wrong/bad things that they have done

blasphemies, as many as they utter: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as blasphemies, as many as they utter is literally “blasphemies as much as they might blaspheme.” It refers to ways that people speak evil of God or of others. Blasphemies include slander and insults. People who speak like this dishonor God. Some languages have idioms for blasphemy.

Here are some other ways to translate the word blasphemies:

slander (REB)

all the evil things they may say (GNT)

all the things they say to defame someone

General Comment on 3:28b

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate the nouns “sins” and “blasphemies” as verbs. For example:

Every time someone does wrong, and every time someone says something against God, he/God will/can forgive that person.

Mark 3:29

Section 3:20–30: Jesus proved that he did not use Satan’s power

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus is stronger than Satan

Jesus sends evil spirits away by defeating Satan

Do not insult the Holy Spirit

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:22–32 and Luke 11:14–23; 12:10.

Paragraph 3:22–30

In the previous paragraph, Jesus' family decided that it was time to bring him home and restrain him. This paragraph continues Mark's theme of people opposing Jesus. Here, Jesus' enemies did not want to admit that Jesus was doing miracles by God's power. So they accused him of using Satan's power instead. Jesus had a good answer to give to them.

3:29a

But whoever blasphemes against the Holy Spirit

- But anyone who speaks against the Holy Spirit
- But if someone insults the Holy Spirit,
- But whoever says evil things about the Holy Spirit,

The teachers of the law had proof that Jesus was doing miracles by the power of God. However, they did not want to believe that he was from God. That is the reason they said that the Holy Spirit's work was Satan's work. Jesus referred to this as blaspheming against the Holy Spirit.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB here translates as *But* indicates a contrast between 3:28b and 3:29: God can forgive all blasphemies (3:28b). But (in contrast to this), there is an exception (3:29). There is a type of blasphemy that makes a person guilty forever.

whoever: The pronoun *whoever* refers to any person. It does not just refer to the teachers of the law. Another way to say this is "anyone."

blasphemes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *blasphemes* is the verb form of the noun "blasphemies" in 3:28b. This word refers to dishonoring or insulting God.

Here are some other ways to translate the word *blasphemes*:

slanders (REB)

speaks against (NCV)

Holy Spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *Holy Spirit* refers to the Spirit of God. The Holy Spirit is God, together with God the Father and God the Son. The Holy Spirit is Spirit in the sense that he is a living being who does not have a physical body. He is Holy in the sense that he is God and unique from every other being. He is perfect in every way and is completely pure and sinless.

Here are some other ways to translate *Holy Spirit*:

Spirit/Breath of/from God

Holy/Sacred Spirit

Do not imply that the Holy Spirit is like the ghost of a dead person or that God has died.

See the note in 1:8b.

3:29b–c

3:29b and 3:29c have the same meaning. For suggestions about ways to express 3:29b–c as one statement, see the General Comment on 3:29b–c at the end on the note on 3:29c.

3:29b

will never be forgiven;

- will never be forgiven by God.
- that is unforgivable.
- God will never forgive him for this.

will never be forgiven: The words will never be forgiven are similar to the phrase "will be forgiven" in 3:28b. If you need to indicate who will never forgive the blasphemy in 3:29, you should say "God." For example:

God will never forgive him

See the note on 3:28b for suggestions about how to translate *will...be forgiven*.

3:29c

he is guilty of eternal sin."

- He is guilty forever of that sin."
- God will hold/consider that person guilty forever for that sin."
- He has done something wrong for which God will blame him forever."

he is guilty of eternal sin: The clause *he is guilty of eternal sin* indicates that the person has committed a sin that God will never forgive. God will forever blame that person for that sin.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

That sin will be held against you forever. (CEV)

This is a sin with eternal consequences. (NLT)

General Comment on 3:29b–c

Verse 3:29c uses different words to express the same meaning as 3:29b. In some languages, it will be more natural to translate these two parts of the verse as one statement. For example:

God will blame him forever for that sin.

God will never forgive him for that sin.

Mark 3:30

Section 3:20–30: Jesus proved that he did not use Satan’s power

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus is stronger than Satan

Jesus sends evil spirits away by defeating Satan

Do not insult the Holy Spirit

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:22–32 and Luke 11:14–23; 12:10.

Paragraph 3:22–30

In the previous paragraph, Jesus’ family decided that it was time to bring him home and restrain him. This paragraph continues Mark’s theme of people opposing Jesus. Here, Jesus’ enemies did not want to admit that Jesus was doing miracles by God’s power. So they accused him of using Satan’s power instead. Jesus had a good answer to give to them.

3:30a

Jesus made this statement

- Jesus said this (GNT)
- Jesus talked about insulting the Holy Spirit
- Jesus warned them about speaking against the Holy Spirit

Jesus made this statement: The phrase Jesus made this statement is not in the Greek. The BSB has added it because it is implied, and it makes the sentence sound natural in English. It connects 3:30 to all that Jesus said in 3:23–29.

It may also be natural and helpful in your language to add a phrase that connects 3:30 to 3:23–29. Here are some ways to do this:

Jesus talked about speaking against the Holy Spirit...

Jesus warned them about insulting the Holy Spirit...

3:30b

because they were saying,

- because they had said,
- because they were insulting the Holy Spirit by saying

because: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as because introduces the reason why Jesus talked about the unforgivable sin.

they: The pronoun they refers to the scribes from Jerusalem. They were saying that Jesus was doing things by Satan’s power.

3:30c

“He has an unclean spirit.”

- “An evil spirit is controlling/possessing him.”
- that he had an evil spirit in him. (CEV)

He has an unclean spirit: In this context the scribes believed that an unclean spirit controlled Jesus. They believed that Jesus was using the power of that spirit. Use an appropriate expression in your language to describe this. For example:

He is controlled by an evil spirit.

He is using the power of an evil spirit.

See how you translated the similar expressions in 1:23a and 3:22c. See also evil spirit in the Glossary.

General Comment on 3:30b–c

In some languages it may be more natural to translate the quotation in 3:30b–c as indirect speech. For example, the CEV says:

because the people were saying that he had an evil spirit in him (CEV)

Mark 3:31

Section 3:31–35: Jesus’ family arrived to take him home, but he stayed to do God’s will

In this section, Jesus’ family, who thought that he was insane (3:21), arrived to take him home to Nazareth. Jesus refused to go with them. He also indicated that those who are truly related to him are those who do what God wants them to do. They are his true family.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus' family tries to take him home

Jesus says who his true family really is

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:46–50 and Luke 8:19–21.

3:31a

Then Jesus' mother and brothers came

- ¶ Then the mother and brothers of Jesus arrived at the place where Jesus was.
- ¶ Jesus' mother and younger brothers arrived from their home.

Then: This verse is the beginning of a new story. The events in this story happened soon after the events in the preceding section. The BSB introduces this story with the word Then.

It may be natural in your language to begin a story with a time word or phrase. If that is true, use an expression that is not too specific. For example:

Then (NCV)

After that

In some languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this story in a natural way in your language.

brothers: If your language must distinguish between “older” and “younger” brothers, it is recommended that you use a term for “younger brothers” here. If your language does not use terms that distinguish male and female, such as brother or sister, it may be more natural to use general terms. For example:

siblings

younger-siblings

came: In 3:21b, Jesus' family left their home to come and take Jesus back home. In this verse they arrived. It is implied that they came to the house where Jesus was. This house was mentioned in 3:20a. If you need to specify in your language where they arrived or where they came from, you could say:

arrived at the house where he was

arrived from their home

3:31b

and stood outside.

- Standing outside the house,
- They stood outside because there were many people there, but

stood outside: Jesus' mother and brothers stood outside the house where Jesus was because there were so many people inside the house. In some languages it may be helpful to make some of this information explicit. For example:

and stood outside the house

and standing outside because of the crowd inside

3:31c

They sent someone in to summon Him,

- they sent someone to call him to come out.
- they sent someone into the house to ask/tell him to come out and speak with them.

They sent someone in to summon Him: In Greek, this part of the verse is literally “they sent to him calling him.” It indicates that Jesus' mother and brothers sent a message to him to request him to come outside. The text does not specify how they sent the message to Jesus. The BSB supplies the words someone and in, because it is likely that they told someone to go inside the house to tell their message to Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

They...sent in a message, asking for him. (GNT)

they sent word to him to summon him (NET)

They caused him to be called.

Use a natural way in your language to express the idea.

Mark 3:32

Section 3:31–35: Jesus' family arrived to take him home, but he stayed to do God's will

In this section, Jesus' family, who thought that he was insane (3:21), arrived to take him home to Nazareth. Jesus refused to go with them. He also indicated that those who are truly related to him are those who do what God wants them to do. They are his true family.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus' family tries to take him home

Jesus says who his true family really is

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:46–50 and Luke 8:19–21.

3:32a and a crowd was sitting around Him.

- Many people were sitting around him.
- There were many people there, seated all around him listening to what he was saying.

and a crowd was sitting around Him: This clause indicates that many people were sitting around Jesus. They had been listening to his teaching. In some languages it may be necessary to make that explicit. For example:

Many people were sitting around him listening to his teaching

around: The word around indicates that people surrounded Jesus on many sides.

3:32b “Look,” He was told,

- They told him,
- The people informed him

Look: In Greek this part of the verse begins with a word that the BSB translates as Look. It indicates that the people wanted Jesus to stop teaching and listen to what they intended to tell him.

Here is another way to translate this:

Listen!

Some translations do not translate this word because it is not common English style for this context. Consider whether there is a similar expression in your language that would be natural to say to a teacher in a context like this.

He was told: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as He was told introduces what the people said to Jesus. In some languages an indirect quote may be

more natural here. See the General Comment on 3:32b–d for examples.

This is a passive clause. The people in the crowd sitting around Jesus were the ones who told him the message. Here are some ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

he was told by people in the crowd

- Use an active verb. For example:

people in the crowd told him

Your mother and brothers are outside: There is a textual issue in this part of the verse:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have Your mother and brothers. These manuscripts do not mention sisters. For example, the RSV says:

Your mother and your brothers are outside (RSV) (NIV, BSB, RSV, GW, JBP, NASB, NET, NCV, REB, KJV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts have Your mother and your brothers and your sisters. For example, the NRSV says:

Your mother and your brothers and sisters are outside (NRSV) (GNT, CEV, NJB, NLT96, NRSV).

It is recommended that you follow option (1), as do the majority of English versions, because it has the best manuscript support.

However, if the national language version follows option (2), you may want to consider following it instead. The UBS4 (page 130) does follow option (2) but gives it a C rating, indicating considerable doubt.

Your: The pronoun Your refers to Jesus.

mother and brothers: This is the same phrase as in 3:31a. Translate it here in the same way you did there.

outside: The word outside refers to outside the house where Jesus was. See how you translated this in 3:31b.

3:32c “Your mother and brothers are outside,

- “Listen, your^(sing) mother and brothers are outside
- that his mother and younger brothers were outside

3:32d asking for You.”

- wanting to talk with you.^(sing)
- and wanted to see him.

asking for You: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as asking for You indicates here that Jesus' family wanted him to come outside of the house and talk with them. In some languages an expression like asking for You might wrongly not clearly communicate their request to see him.

Here are some other ways to express the meaning:

they want you (GNT)

and want to see you (CEV)

asking for you (RSV)

General Comment on 3:32b–d

The BSB uses a direct quote for 3:32. In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech here. If this is true in your language, you could say:

and they told him that his mother and brothers were outside looking for him

word was brought that his mother and brothers were outside asking for him (REB)

Mark 3:33

Section 3:31–35: Jesus' family arrived to take him home, but he stayed to do God's will

In this section, Jesus' family, who thought that he was insane (3:21), arrived to take him home to Nazareth. Jesus refused to go with them. He also indicated that those who are truly related to him are those who do what God wants them to do. They are his true family.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus' family tries to take him home

Jesus says who his true family really is

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:46–50 and Luke 8:19–21.

3:33

But Jesus replied, "Who are My mother and My brothers?"

- Jesus asked them, "Who are my real mother and brothers?"
- Jesus answered by asking a question: "Who is my real family?"
- Jesus answered them by asking whom his real mother and brothers were.

In Greek, this verse begins with the phrase that the BSB translates as "he asked." The BSB puts the phrase at the end of the verse. In many languages it may be more natural to follow the Greek and put it at the beginning of 3:33. Use an appropriate place for this phrase in your language. For suggestions on how to translate it, see the note on "he asked" at the end of this verse.

But Jesus replied: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates here as But Jesus replied is literally "and having answered them Jesus says." This phrase introduces a rhetorical question that Jesus asked the people who were sitting around him. In some languages it may be more natural to use a different verb like "answered" or "said." For example:

He answered them and said, "Who are my mother and my brothers?" (NET)

And he replied, "Who are my mother and my brothers?" (RSV)

Who are My mother and My brothers?: Jesus already knew who his physical mother and brothers were. This is a rhetorical question that Jesus used to introduce a new idea. The new idea is that people who do the will of God are Jesus' true family.

There are at least two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a question. For example:

And who are really my mother and my brothers? (JBP)

Who are truly my mother and my brothers?

- As a statement. For example:

I will tell you who my mother and my brothers are.

Let me tell you who is like a mother and a brother to me.

Use the appropriate way in your language to introduce this new idea.

Be careful that your translation does not imply that Jesus or the other people did not know who his physical family was.

General Comment on 3:33

Since Jesus was introducing a new idea, it may be more natural in some languages to express it as an indirect quotation. For example:

Then Jesus told them who his real mother and brothers were.

Jesus answered by asking them who his real mother and brothers were.

Mark 3:34

Section 3:31–35: Jesus' family arrived to take him home, but he stayed to do God's will

In this section, Jesus' family, who thought that he was insane (3:21), arrived to take him home to Nazareth. Jesus refused to go with them. He also indicated that those who are truly related to him are those who do what God wants them to do. They are his true family.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus' family tries to take him home

Jesus says who his true family really is

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:46–50 and Luke 8:19–21.

3:34a

Looking at those seated in a circle around Him, He said,

- Then he looked at those who sat around him and said,
- Then he looked around at those people sitting around him and said,
- He looked at the people who sat there listening to him and told them that

In some languages you may need a word that connects Jesus' question with his next action (looking at the people around him) and his next speech. Use a natural connector if it is needed in your language for this context.

Looking at those seated in a circle around Him, He said:

This part of the verse introduces an important statement that Jesus would make in 3:34b. He looked around at the people who were waiting for what he was about to say. This pause emphasized his statement to the people. Try to express this emphasis in a natural way in your language.

Looking at: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Looked at is literally “to look around at.”

those seated in a circle around Him: The words those seated in a circle around Him refers to a smaller group than the crowd in 3:32. The phrase in 3:32 did not include the words that the BSB translates as in a circle. You should probably make that clear by using a different expression here than you used in 3:32.

The group that Jesus indicated in 3:34 probably included his disciples and other people who believed in him and followed him. It did not include the teachers of the law from Jerusalem, whom Jesus called to him in 3:23a. In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit that this group was his followers. For example:

his followers seated in a circle around him

He said: The words He said introduce what Jesus said in 3:34b–35. In some languages it may be necessary to use an indirect quotation. See the General Comment on 3:34b–35 at the end of the notes for 3:35 for an example.

3:34b

“Here are My mother and My brothers!”

- “Here are my mother and brothers!”
- they were his real mother and younger brothers.

Here are My mother and My brothers!: In Greek this part of the verse is literally, “Look! My mother and my brothers.” Jesus used these words to point out his disciples and other followers who were sitting there around him. He indicated that they were his mother and his brothers. Use a natural way to do this in your language.

Here: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Here is literally “see!” It is used to call attention to something and to emphasize a point. Translate it in a natural way in your language.

My mother and My brothers: Here Jesus used the words mother and brothers in a figurative way. Those who obey God (3:35) are like his family. He did not mean that all of his followers were literally from the same earthly family.

Mark 3:35

Section 3:31–35: Jesus' family arrived to take him home, but he stayed to do God's will

In this section, Jesus' family, who thought that he was insane (3:21), arrived to take him home to Nazareth. Jesus refused to go with them. He also indicated that those who are truly related to him are those who do what God wants them to do. They are his true family.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus' family tries to take him home

Jesus says who his true family really is

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 12:46–50 and Luke 8:19–21.

3:35

For whoever does the will of God is My brother and sister and mother."

- Anyone who does what God wants is my real brother and sister and mother."
- The reason I say that is that I consider anyone who obeys God to be my real siblings and mother."
- He said that all those who obeyed God were his real mother and younger sisters and younger brothers.

For whoever does the will of God is My brother and sister and mother.": In this verse Jesus explained what he meant by his statement in 3:34b. Jesus indicated that he considers every person who obeys God to be a member of his family.

In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit that this verse further explains the meaning of 3:34b. For example:

What I mean is that whoever does God's will...

because those who do what God wants...

the will of God: The phrase the will of God refers to whatever God wants us to do.

Here is another way to express this:

does what God wants him to do

My brother and sister and mother: The terms brother, sister, and mother indicate very close relationships in a family. Consider which kinship terms in your language are appropriate to use here for these close relationships. For example:

my siblings and mother

If you must specify between older and younger brothers and sisters, you should use the word "younger." For example:

my younger brother and younger sister and mother

General Comment on 3:34b–35

The English versions translate 3:34b–35 with a direct quotation. In some languages, it may be more natural to express this as an indirect quotation. For example:

Jesus said that those sitting around him were his real mother and brothers. His real mother and sister and brother were those who did what God wanted them to do.

Mark 4:1

Section 4:1–9: Jesus told a parable about four types of soil

Jesus told a parable about a man who scattered seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people. The seeds thrown by the man represent God's word. Different kinds of people receive God's word in different ways.

Satan causes some people to forget God's Word so they do not accept it. These people are represented by the soil along the path (4:4). Some people accept God's Word but when troubles or persecution happen to them, they quickly reject God's Word. These people are represented by the rocky soil (4:5–6). Some people accept God's Word but worries about daily living cause them to not do anything for God. These people are represented by the soil with thorns (4:7). Some people accept God's Word and do deeds that honor God. These people are represented by the good soil (4:8).

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable about four kinds of soil

The parable of the sower and the soils

The four soils parable/story/illustration

A parable of a man scattering seed

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:1–9 and Luke 8:4–8.

4:1a

Once again Jesus began to teach beside the sea,

- ¶ Once again Jesus began teaching by the lakeshore. (NLT)
- ¶ Another time Jesus went to the lake of Galilee and began to teach the people.

Once again: The phrase Once again indicates that this occasion was another time that Jesus taught by the lake. Previous occasions are mentioned in 2:13 and 3:7–12. The events in this section may have taken place later on the same day as the events in 3:7–12. Use whatever is most natural in your language to indicate that Jesus had taught by the lake before. For example:

Again (NIV)

Another time

Then once again (JBP)

Jesus began to teach: In some languages it may be more natural to supply an object for the verb teach. In other words, it may be more natural to say whom Jesus taught or what Jesus taught. For example:

Jesus began to teach the people

Jesus began to teach the good news

In some languages it may be natural to supply both whom Jesus taught and what he taught. For example:

Jesus began to teach the good news to the people

beside the sea: Jesus taught the people beside or “by” the sea. In some languages, it will be more natural to indicate that Jesus taught on the land or shore beside the lake. For example:

by the lakeshore (NLT)

by the lakeside (REB)

the sea: The phrase the sea here refers specifically to the Lake of Galilee. If people in your area refer to lakes by their names, you may want to include the name. For example, the GNT says:

Lake Galilee (GNT)

sea: Here, sea refers to a large body of water that is smaller than an ocean but wider than a river. For example, the NIV translates this word as “lake.” This body of water contains fresh water rather than salt water.

If you do not have a word for lake, here are some other ways to translate it:

body of water

wide pond/river

See how you translated this word in 1:16a.

General Comment on 4:1a

The context implies that Jesus left the house (3:20) and went to the sea. It may be more natural in your language to include a verb of motion. For example:

Again Jesus went to the sea and began to teach.

4:1b

and such a large crowd gathered around Him

- A very large crowd gathered around him.
- Many people crowded around Jesus.

4:1c

that He got into a boat

- That is the reason why he went/climbed into a boat
- Therefore/So he entered a boat

4:1b–c

In Greek, 4:1b begins with the conjunction that is usually translated “and” (as in the BSB). You should connect 4:1a and 4:1b in the way that is natural in your language.

such a large crowd gathered around Him that He got into a boat: 4:1b gives the reason for 4:1c.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

^{1b}The crowd that gathered around him was very large, ^{1c}that is the reason why he got into a boat.

^{1b}The crowd that gathered around him was very large, ^{1c}so he got into a boat.

^{1c}Jesus got into a boat ^{1b}because of the large crowd that gathered around him.

crowd: The word crowd refers to a large group of people.

He got into a boat: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as got is a specific verb for entering a boat.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

he entered a boat

he descended into a boat

he stepped/climbed into a boat

You should use whichever verb is appropriate in your language for entering a boat.

As in 3:9, Jesus probably got into a boat so that the crowd of people would not crush him.

boat: This boat was probably a wooden boat used for fishing. It was probably big enough for several people to sit inside.

If you do not have a word for boat in your language, some ways to translate it are:

- Use a phrase that describes the function of a boat. For example:

a vehicle for crossing water

something for carrying people on top of water

- Use the word for a specific kind of boat in your culture. For example:

canoe

The same word also occurs in 1:19c.

**4:1d
and sat in it,**

- and sat down in it and went out on the lake.
- and sat down in it to teach. The boat was a short distance out in the lake,

sat in it: The pronoun it refers to the boat. Jesus sat in the boat upon one of the wooden boards/seats laid across it from side to side. In this context, your language may use a different word than in. For example:

sat to teach upon the boat

in it: The phrase in it indicates that the boat was in the water while Jesus was sitting in it. Jesus probably got into the boat while it was on land. Then some men pushed the boat into the water a short distance from the shore.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

in it and went out on the lake

in the boat and asked some men to move the boat out into the water

in it. The boat was out on the lake

General Comment on 4:1c–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine 4:1c and 4:1d as follows:

he got into and sat down in a boat

**4:1e
while all the people crowded along the shore.**

- As for the whole crowd, they remained on the shore close to the water.
- while all the people were standing at the edge of the lake to listen.

all the people crowded: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as all the people is literally “all the crowd.” This phrase refers to the same crowd as in 4:1b. The verb that the BSB translates as crowded is literally “was.” It is general in meaning and does not indicate whether the people stood or sat. They probably stood (see Matthew 13:2). The GNT says:

the crowd stood

The implied purpose for the people crowding along the shore was to listen to Jesus. It may be more natural in your language to include the purpose here. For example:

the crowd stood to listen

along the shore: The Greek text that the BSB translates as along the shore is literally “at the sea on the land.” These two phrases indicate that the crowd was near the shore but not in the water. For example, the NCV has:

on the shore close to the water

In some languages, one phrase may be sufficient to express the proper meaning. For example:

along the shore (NLT96)

on the shore (CEV)

Mark 4:2

Section 4:1–9: Jesus told a parable about four types of soil

Jesus told a parable about a man who scattered seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people. The seeds thrown by the man represent God’s word. Different kinds of people receive God’s word in different ways.

Satan causes some people to forget God’s Word so they do not accept it. These people are represented by the soil along the path (4:4). Some people accept God’s Word but when troubles or persecution happen to them, they quickly reject God’s Word. These people are represented by the rocky soil (4:5–6). Some people accept God’s Word but worries about daily living cause them to not do anything for God. These people are represented by the soil with thorns (4:7). Some people accept God’s Word and do deeds that honor God. These people are represented by the good soil (4:8).

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable about four kinds of soil

The parable of the sower and the soils

The four soils parable/story/illustration

A parable of a man scattering seed

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:1–9 and Luke 8:4–8.

4:2a

And He taught them many things in parables,

- He taught them many things with parables/illustrations,
- He/Jesus taught them many things. He used stories to illustrate what he meant.

And He taught them many things in parables: This expression indicates that Jesus used parables to teach the people many things.

parables: The Greek word that the BSB translates as parables is literally “comparisons.” Parables teach a lesson or truth by showing how it is like something that people already know about. In this chapter, Jesus used several types of parables, including a symbolic story, metaphors, and wise sayings.

Here are some ways to translate parables in this context:

- Use a general term in your language that can be used to describe the different types of parables in this chapter. Here are some English examples:

illustrations

metaphors

- Use a descriptive term. For example:

symbolic sayings/words/stories

- Use more than one word or descriptive term for the different types of parables that Jesus used. For example:

stories and illustrations

symbols and sayings

The word parables was used in 3:23b to describe specific illustrations that Jesus used. See also parable, Type 2, in the Glossary.

4:2b

and in His teaching He said,

- and as he taught he said:
- One story he taught them was this:

and in His teaching He said: This expression introduces one of the parables that Jesus taught.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

...telling many stories in the form of parables,
such as this one: (NLT)

As he taught he said: (REB)

One parable he taught them was this:

Mark 4:3

Section 4:1–9: Jesus told a parable about four types of soil

Jesus told a parable about a man who scattered seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people. The seeds thrown by the man represent God's word. Different kinds of people receive God's word in different ways.

Satan causes some people to forget God's Word so they do not accept it. These people are represented by the soil along the path (4:4). Some people accept God's Word but when troubles or persecution happen to them, they quickly reject God's Word. These people are represented by the rocky soil (4:5–6). Some people accept God's Word but worries about daily living cause them to not do anything for God. These people are represented by the soil with thorns (4:7). Some people accept God's Word and do deeds that honor God. These people are represented by the good soil (4:8).

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable about four kinds of soil

The parable of the sower and the soils

The four soils parable/story/illustration

A parable of a man scattering seed

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:1–9 and Luke 8:4–8.

4:3a

“Listen!

- “Listen^(plur) to this!
- “You^(plur) listen to this story!

Listen: In Greek, this parable begins with two words: “Listen, look!” These words indicate that Jesus wanted the people to listen carefully to the parable that follows. Many English versions translate only the word that means Listen, as the BSB does. They do not translate both words. An exception to this is the KJV, which says “Hearken, behold.” Use whatever expression is natural in your language when someone wants people to listen carefully to a story that he is about to tell.

4:3b

A farmer went out to sow his seed.

- A farmer went to sow/scatter seeds on his field.
- There was once a man who went to his prepared land to plant it by throwing seeds over it.

farmer: The Greek word that the BSB translates as farmer is literally “one who sows/plants (seed).” Some English versions follow the Greek and use the more specific term “sower” (RSV). Others simply say “a man” (GNT) and allow the verb to explain his work. Use whatever term will be most natural in your language here.

went out: The Greek word that the BSB translates as went out indicates that the farmer went to his field. It may be more natural in your language not to translate the word out.

In some languages it may be necessary to say where the farmer went from. The farmer probably went from his home.

to sow: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sow refers to throwing seeds to the side and in front of the farmer. This method allowed the farmer to plant a large area quickly. In that culture, farmers did not plant grain seeds by putting them in the ground one by one.

If your readers know that this is the way the Jews planted seeds, they will more easily understand what the parable means. In languages that do not have a word for sow, you may be able to use a descriptive phrase such as:

to plant by throwing/scattering

to scatter in order to plant

- This method was the normal way for Jewish farmers to plant. It does not describe a foolish farmer. If your readers might think that this method of planting

is foolish, you may want to include a footnote. For example:

The Jewish custom was to scatter seeds over ground that the farmer had plowed, or that he would plow afterwards to cover the seeds. In this way, the farmer could plant a large area quickly.

It may also be helpful to include a picture here of a farmer scattering his seeds.

seed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as seed here refers to many seeds. You may want to use the plural form “seeds.” If you use a plural form here, you should also use plural pronouns throughout 4:5–8 to refer to these seeds. See, for example, the note on “it” at 4:4c.

The farmer was probably planting wheat seeds or seeds of another kind of grain. If you need to say what kind of seed the farmer was planting, here are some suggestions:

- Use a general word for grain.
- Supply the name of a specific crop grown in Israel in that time, such as wheat or barley.
- If you do not have a general word for grain and do not have wheat or barley in your area, compare this to something that is commonly grown in your area. For example, if rice or millet is common, you could say:

a farmer went out to plant something like rice/
millet

Mark 4:4

Section 4:1–9: Jesus told a parable about four types of soil

Jesus told a parable about a man who scattered seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people. The seeds thrown by the man represent God’s word. Different kinds of people receive God’s word in different ways.

Satan causes some people to forget God’s Word so they do not accept it. These people are represented by the soil along the path (4:4). Some people accept God’s Word but when troubles or persecution happen to them, they quickly reject God’s Word. These people are represented by the rocky soil (4:5–6). Some people accept God’s Word but worries about daily living cause them to not do anything for God. These people are represented by the soil with thorns (4:7). Some people

accept God’s Word and do deeds that honor God. These people are represented by the good soil (4:8).

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable about four kinds of soil

The parable of the sower and the soils

The four soils parable/story/illustration

A parable of a man scattering seed

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:1–9 and Luke 8:4–8.

4:4a

And as he was sowing,

- As he sowed/scattered the seeds,
- While he planted them by throwing,

And as he was sowing: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as sowing is from the same verb that is translated as “sow” in 4:3b. You may want to use the same expression as in 4:3b:

As he was planting by throwing

As he was scattering to plant

But if you used additional words to explain the method of planting or included a footnote in 4:3b, you may want to use a general expression here. It should refer back to the expression you used for “sow” in 4:3b:

As he was planting

As he was doing this

4:4b

some seed fell along the path,

- some of the seeds fell on a path,
- some of them landed/scattered beside/near the edge of a footpath.

some seed fell along the path: Because of the method of planting, some seeds accidentally fell on places where plants did not grow well. One such place is along the path. Be careful not to imply in your

translation that the farmer intended for some of the seeds to fall along the path.

Here are some other ways to translate fell along the path:

landed accidentally along the path

were scattered unintentionally along the path

along: The Greek word that the BSB translates as along usually means “near,” “beside,” or “alongside.” In this context, it may also mean “on.” The English versions show a similar range of meaning. For example:

some seed fell beside the road (NASB)

some of the seed fell on the edge of the path (NJB)

some seed fell on a footpath (NLT96)

Several English versions, including the BSB and the NIV, have “along,” which can mean either “beside” or “upon.” If you have a similar word in your language, you may use that word here. Otherwise use a word with a more specific meaning that is natural in your language. All these meanings fit the parable equally well. It should be noted that the Greek word *para* normally means “beside” (Louw & Nida, page 716 #83.25). The author could have used *epi* if he had wanted to specify “upon.” However, in this parable, it is unlikely that the author intended us to make a distinction. Seed would have fallen both on and beside the path. In either location the soil would be hard and the seed would not be ploughed in.

the path: The Greek word that the BSB translates as path refers to a footpath through or alongside a field. People who walk there trample on the soil and make it hard.

4:4c

and the birds came and devoured it.

- and birds flew there and devoured them.
- Some birds landed there and ate/pecked those seeds until they were gone.

the birds came: It may be more natural in your language to use a different verb rather than the verb came. For example:

the birds flew there

the birds landed there

the birds: The phrase the birds refers to birds in general and does not refer to any birds mentioned before. Introduce the birds in the story in the most natural way in your language. For example:

some birds flew down

there were some birds that landed there

devoured it: The Greek word that the BSB translates as devoured refers to eating something hungrily and completely.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

ate it up (NIV)

ate them until they were gone

If you have a specific word or phrase that describes the way that birds eat, such as the English word “pecked,” you may want to use that word:

pecked...hungrily

it: The pronoun it refers to the seed. If you used a plural form like “seeds” in 4:3b, you may need to use a plural form here also. The GW has:

them

Mark 4:5

Section 4:1–9: Jesus told a parable about four types of soil

Jesus told a parable about a man who scattered seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people. The seeds thrown by the man represent God’s word. Different kinds of people receive God’s word in different ways.

Satan causes some people to forget God’s Word so they do not accept it. These people are represented by the soil along the path (4:4). Some people accept God’s Word but when troubles or persecution happen to them, they quickly reject God’s Word. These people are represented by the rocky soil (4:5–6). Some people accept God’s Word but worries about daily living cause them to not do anything for God. These people are represented by the soil with thorns (4:7). Some people

accept God's Word and do deeds that honor God. These people are represented by the good soil (4:8).

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable about four kinds of soil

The parable of the sower and the soils

The four soils parable/story/illustration

A parable of a man scattering seed

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:1-9 and Luke 8:4-8.

4:5a

Some fell on rocky ground, where it did not have much soil.

- Some seeds fell on rock that had only a thin layer of earth/dirt over it.
- Other seeds landed on shallow soil/ground that had rock underneath it.

Some: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Some is literally "Others." It refers to another group of seeds.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Other seed (NLT)

Some of the seeds

fell: The verb fell is the same verb as in 4:4b. You can translate the verb here in the same way as you did there. In some languages, it may be good style to use words with similar meanings rather than to use exactly the same word for "fell" each time it appears. Do what is natural in your language.

rocky ground, where it did not have much soil: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rocky ground refers to a place on the ground that has solid rock underneath it. This kind of ground did not have much soil over the solid rock.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

shallow soil with underlying rock (NLT)

solid rock with a thin layer of soil

it did not have much soil: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as it did not have much soil means "there was not much soil in which the seed/seeds could grow." In some languages it may not be necessary to mention the seeds explicitly. For example the NCV says:

where there wasn't much dirt

4:5b

It sprang up quickly because the soil was shallow.

- Those seeds sprouted quickly, because the soil was shallow.
- The ground was not deep, so the plants soon began to grow.

It sprang up quickly because the soil was shallow:

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the phrases in this verse part. For example:

The soil was shallow and so it sprang up quickly.

Since the soil was shallow, it sprang up quickly.

The soil was shallow and that is why the seed sprang up quickly.

It sprang up quickly: The phrase It sprang up quickly refers to the seeds quickly sprouting and becoming seedling plants.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

The seeds soon sprouted (GNT)

The plants came up quickly

because: The conjunction because introduces the reason why the seeds sprang up quickly. The seeds sprang up quickly because the soil was shallow.

the soil was shallow: The clause the soil was shallow has almost the same meaning as "it did not have much soil" in 4:5a.

Here is another way to translate this:

the soil was not deep

Mark 4:6

Section 4:1-9: Jesus told a parable about four types of soil

Jesus told a parable about a man who scattered seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people. The seeds thrown by the man represent God's word. Different kinds of people receive God's word in different ways.

Satan causes some people to forget God's Word so they do not accept it. These people are represented by the soil along the path (4:4). Some people accept God's Word but when troubles or persecution happen to them, they quickly reject God's Word. These people are represented by the rocky soil (4:5-6). Some people accept God's Word but worries about daily living cause them to not do anything for God. These people are represented by the soil with thorns (4:7). Some people accept God's Word and do deeds that honor God. These people are represented by the good soil (4:8).

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable about four kinds of soil

The parable of the sower and the soils

The four soils parable/story/illustration

A parable of a man scattering seed

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:1-9 and Luke 8:4-8.

4:6a

But when the sun rose, the seedlings were scorched,

- But when the sun rose high in the sky, it burned the plants,
- But when the sun became hot, the plants turned brown.

But: There is some contrast between the seeds sprouting quickly (4:5b) and the plants being scorched (4:6a). So the BSB uses the conjunction But here. However, it may be more natural in your language to use a different conjunction here. Here are some examples:

and (RSV)

Then (GNT)

In other languages, no conjunction is necessary here. For example, the GW says:

When the sun came up

the sun rose: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as the sun rose here refers to the hottest part of the day. Here this clause does not refer to soon after sunrise, but to later in the day, perhaps midday. It may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

the sun rose high in the sky

the sun became hot

the seedlings were scorched: This is a passive clause. If it is more natural in your language to use an active verb here, you can say:

the plants burned/dried up in the heat

the sun scorched the plants

scorched: The word scorched indicates that the heat from the sun caused the plants to become dry and brown. Your language may use a different verb than scorched in this context. Here are some examples:

the plants withered

the sun caused the plants to turn brown

4:6b

and they withered because they had no root.

- and they dried up because they did not have enough roots.
- Because they lacked roots, they dried and died.

they withered because they had no root: The conjunction because introduces the reason why the plants withered. They withered because they had no root. In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses in this verse part. For example:

because they had no root, they withered

they had no root and so they withered

they had no root, that is why they withered

withered: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as withered means “became dry.” When a plant becomes dry, its leaves shrink and turn brown, and the plant dies.

they had no root: The expression had no root is hyperbole. The expression emphasizes the fact that, because the soil was shallow, the plants did not have enough roots to live under the hot sun. The roots could not grow down past the rock to find water.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

because they did not have deep roots (NCV)

since their roots were so little/weak

root: The word root is singular. It may be more natural in your language to use a plural form here.

General Comment on 4:6a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to describe the phrase “were scorched, and they withered” using only one verb. For example:

they soon dried up

Mark 4:7

Section 4:1–9: Jesus told a parable about four types of soil

Jesus told a parable about a man who scattered seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people. The seeds thrown by the man represent God’s word. Different kinds of people receive God’s word in different ways.

Satan causes some people to forget God’s Word so they do not accept it. These people are represented by the soil along the path (4:4). Some people accept God’s Word but when troubles or persecution happen to them, they quickly reject God’s Word. These people are represented by the rocky soil (4:5–6). Some people accept God’s Word but worries about daily living cause them to not do anything for God. These people are represented by the soil with thorns (4:7). Some people accept God’s Word and do deeds that honor God. These people are represented by the good soil (4:8).

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable about four kinds of soil

The parable of the sower and the soils

The four soils parable/story/illustration

A parable of a man scattering seed

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:1–9 and Luke 8:4–8.

4:7a

Other seed fell among thorns,

- Other seeds fell in an area with thorn seeds/roots,
- Some seeds landed where thorns/weeds were growing.

Other seed fell among thorns: The phrase among thorns probably refers to soil where roots or seeds of thorny plants were present. It is also possible that these seeds fell along the edge of the field where thorny plants were already growing. So when the seeds began to grow, the thorn plants also grew.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Some other seeds fell where thornbushes grew up (CEV)

Other seeds fell where thorns habitually grow

Other seeds fell upon soil with thorn seeds/roots

fell: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as fell is the same verb as in 4:4b and 4:5a. Consider whether it is natural in your language to use the same verb or another verb with a similar meaning.

thorns: The Greek word that the BSB translates as thorns can refer to any kind of thorny plant. In this context, this word probably refers to the seeds or roots of thorny plants. Or it may refer to young thorny plants.

Here are some other ways to translate the word thorns:

- Use a general term in your language for thorny plants or for undesirable plants that compete with grain plants. For example:

young thorny plants/bushes

thorn seeds/roots

weeds

- Use a specific word that describes a strong, fast-growing plant from your area that is annoying to farmers. If you choose a specific plant, try to choose one that has thorns. Do not use a word for a plant that only grows close to the ground (see the note in 4:7b).

4:7b

which grew up and choked the seedlings,

- which grew and crowded the good plants,
- The thorn plants grew tall and prevented/hindered the good plants from growing.

which grew up: The phrase which grew up refers to the thorn plants growing tall, perhaps one meter or more.

choked the seedlings: The Greek word that the BSB translates as choked here refers to the way that the thorns crowded the seedlings. These young plants did not have enough room, soil, water, or sunlight to grow well.

Here are some other ways you could translate this:

crowded the grain/good plants

kept the grain from growing to maturity

the seedlings: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the seedlings is literally “it” (as in the RSV). This pronoun refers to the seeds and the plants that grew from those seeds. The NIV uses the words “the plants.” Use a natural form in your language here.

4:7c

and they yielded no crop.

- and/so they did not produce any grain/seeds.
- Therefore, the good plants could not produce a crop.

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and here introduces the result of what happened in 4:7b. Use a natural way in your language to indicate that 4:7c is the result of 4:7b.

they yielded no crop: The Greek words that the BSB translates as yielded...crop refer to producing a harvest. No grain grew from the seeds, so the farmer did not get any harvest from them.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

So those plants did not produce a crop. (NCV)

they did not yield any grain

Use a natural expression in your language for this process.

Mark 4:8

Section 4:1–9: Jesus told a parable about four types of soil

Jesus told a parable about a man who scattered seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people. The seeds thrown by the man represent God’s word. Different kinds of people receive God’s word in different ways.

Satan causes some people to forget God’s Word so they do not accept it. These people are represented by the soil along the path (4:4). Some people accept God’s Word but when troubles or persecution happen to them, they quickly reject God’s Word. These people are represented by the rocky soil (4:5–6). Some people accept God’s Word but worries about daily living cause them to not do anything for God. These people are represented by the soil with thorns (4:7). Some people accept God’s Word and do deeds that honor God. These people are represented by the good soil (4:8).

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable about four kinds of soil

The parable of the sower and the soils

The four soils parable/story/illustration

A parable of a man scattering seed

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:1–9 and Luke 8:4–8.

4:8a

Still other seed fell on good soil,

- But/And other seeds fell on good/proper soil.
- Still other seed landed on fertile soil.

Still: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as Still is the common conjunction that is usually translated as “and” (as in the RSV). There is a difference between what happened to the other seeds and what happened to the seeds in this verse. Therefore, the

GNT translates the connection here as “but.” Introduce what happened to these seeds in the way that is natural in your language.

other seed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as other refers to the fourth and final group of seeds. Because of this, the BSB added the word seed because it is natural here in English.

If you have been using a plural form like “seeds” in this parable, you should continue to do so here.

fell: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as fell is the same verb as in 4:4b, 4:5a, and 4:7a. See the notes there.

good soil: The Greek word that the BSB translates as good in this context refers to the kind of soil in which plants grow well.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

rich soil

healthy soil

fertile soil

4:8b–c

where it sprouted, grew up, and produced a crop—one bearing thirtyfold, another sixtyfold, and another a hundredfold.”: The four verbs that the BSB translates as sprouted, grew up, produced, and bearing describe various stages in the life of the plants. In some languages, it may be more natural to describe only two or three stages. For example, the CEV says:

the plants grew and produced thirty or sixty or even a hundred times as much as was scattered

4:8b

where it sprouted, grew up, and produced a crop—

- It/they sprouted, grew up, and produced a good crop.
- These seeds grew and produced very many seeds.

it sprouted: The clause it sprouted refers to the seeds beginning to grow in the good soil. The NIV has:

the plants came up

grew up: The words grew up refer to plants maturing and becoming taller.

and produced a crop: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as produced a crop here means “bore

grain” (as in the GNT). The grain was ready for harvest, so the BSB uses the word crop. The NET has:

produced grain

4:8c

one bearing thirtyfold, another sixtyfold, and another a hundredfold.”

- Some produced thirty seeds, others sixty, and others even a hundred.”
- Some plants produced/bore thirty seeds/grain. Other plants produced/bore sixty seeds/grain. Other plants produced/bore a hundred seeds/grain.”

bearing: The Greek word that the BSB translates as bearing refers to what plants do when they produce fruit or grain.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

giving

yielding

thirtyfold, another sixtyfold, and another a hundredfold:

The words thirtyfold, sixtyfold, and a hundredfold refer to the amount of new grain that the mature plants produced. Some plants produced heads of grain that had thirty seeds. Other plants produced heads that had sixty seeds. Some plants produced heads with a hundred seeds.

Each of these numbers represented remarkably good harvests of various sizes. If this is not clear to your readers, you may want to indicate that these numbers are relative. The actual numbers are not important. For example:

such as thirty, sixty, or even a hundred times

for example thirty, sixty, or even a hundred times

You may also want to add a footnote. For example:

All of these were extremely good harvests. The average amount that people harvested in the provinces of Galilee and Judea at that time was ten seeds for every seed that was sown.

If your language does not use numbers in this way, here are some other translation options:

- Use numerals or number words from the major language in the area. For example:

such as 30, 60, or even 100 times

- Use descriptive words instead of numbers. For example:

a great harvest, an amazing harvest, and an unbelievable harvest

Mark 4:9

Section 4:1–9: Jesus told a parable about four types of soil

Jesus told a parable about a man who scattered seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people. The seeds thrown by the man represent God's word. Different kinds of people receive God's word in different ways.

Satan causes some people to forget God's Word so they do not accept it. These people are represented by the soil along the path (4:4). Some people accept God's Word but when troubles or persecution happen to them, they quickly reject God's Word. These people are represented by the rocky soil (4:5–6). Some people accept God's Word but worries about daily living cause them to not do anything for God. These people are represented by the soil with thorns (4:7). Some people accept God's Word and do deeds that honor God. These people are represented by the good soil (4:8).

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable about four kinds of soil

The parable of the sower and the soils

The four soils parable/story/illustration

A parable of a man scattering seed

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:1–9 and Luke 8:4–8.

4:9

Then Jesus said, “He who has ears to hear, let him hear.”

- Then Jesus said, “If/since you^(plur) have ears for listening, then listen^(plur) well!”

- Then Jesus said to the people, “Whoever is able to hear what I say should try to understand it.”
- Jesus concluded, “You^(plur) who are listening, think carefully about what you^(plur) have heard.”

Then Jesus said: The phrase that the BSB translates as Then Jesus said introduces the advice that Jesus gave at the conclusion of his parable. In some languages it may be helpful to make explicit that this is the conclusion of the parable. For example, the GNT has:

And Jesus concluded

He who has ears to hear, let him hear: With this saying, Jesus commanded or urged the crowd to give careful attention to the parable that they had just heard. Jesus wanted them to understand and respond correctly to the lesson of the parable.

If you have a similar expression in your language that urges an audience to listen carefully to what you are saying, you may want to use it here.

This saying assumes that everyone in the crowd has ears that are able to hear. So it is addressed to all the people who were listening to Jesus. In some languages it may not be natural or clear to translate the saying literally.

Here are some other ways to translate this saying:

- Use “they” or “you” instead of he. For example:

All those who have ears to hear, let them hear.

All of you who have ears to hear, hear.

- Use a different type of clause or clauses. In some languages it may be more natural to use an “if” clause or a reason clause. For example:

If you have ears that can hear, then give/pay attention.

Since you have ears that can hear, listen.

- Translate the saying without including the word “ears.” For example, the NCV says:

You people who can hear me, listen!

- Change the order of the clauses. For example, the GNT says:

Listen, then, if you have ears!

hear...hear: The word hear is used twice in this verse part but with slightly different meanings. The first hear refers to the physical ability to hear. The second hear means to think about, understand and respond to what the parable means.

Here are some other ways to translate these two meanings:

Anyone with ears to hear should listen and understand. (NLT)

Anyone who is listening should think about what he has just heard.

let him hear: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as let him hear is an indirect command. It is not a request for permission. The NJB has:

Anyone who has ears for listening should listen!

Mark 4:10

Section 4:10–12: Jesus told why he used parables

The disciples did not understand the parables that Jesus had been teaching. Jesus first explained the reasons that he taught with parables. Then he explained the parable of the sower (4:13–20).

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus explained his reason for teaching with parables

The reason Jesus taught in parables

The purpose of parables

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:10–15 and Luke 8:9–10.

4:10a

As soon as Jesus was alone with the Twelve and those around Him,

- ¶ When Jesus was alone with the twelve disciples and his other companions,

- ¶ After the crowd left him, the twelve disciples and other companions/followers

As soon as Jesus was alone with the Twelve and those around Him: The Greek words that the BSB translate as As soon as Jesus was alone are literally “when he was by himself.” In this context, the word alone indicates that the crowd had left. Jesus’ disciples were still there with him.

It may be more natural in your language to include the phrase the Twelve and the others around him in the clause When he was alone. For example, the REB says:

When Jesus was alone with the Twelve and his other companions

Or you may want to translate the idea of alone by referring to the crowd leaving. For example:

After the crowd left him, the Twelve and the others around him...

the Twelve: Mark used the phrase the Twelve to refer to the twelve disciples. Jesus appointed them as his apostles in 3:14. It may be more natural in your language to include the noun “disciples” or “apostles” here. For example:

the twelve disciples (GNT)

the twelve apostles (GW)

those around Him: The Greek words that the BSB translates as those around Him refer to people who stayed with Jesus. They were probably disciples, but not the twelve disciples whom Jesus had chosen earlier. The REB has:

his other companions

4:10b

they asked Him about the parable.

- they were asking him various questions about the parables.
- asked him/Jesus several questions about the meaning of the stories/illustrations he was telling them.

they asked Him about the parable: The phrase asked Him about the parable is a general request for explanation. The words the parable probably refers back to 4:2a, and includes more than the parable of the sower.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

[they] asked him to explain the parables (GNT)

they asked him what the parables meant (NLT)

they asked him about the parables that he had been telling them

If it is more natural in your language to use direct speech here, translate with a general question. For example:

...asked him, “Will you tell us about the parables?”

...asked him, “What do these parables mean?”

the parable: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the parable describes several types of speech such as metaphors, illustrations, and stories that were used to teach a lesson or a truth. Jesus taught the crowd many things in parables (4:2a). See how you translated this word in 4:2a. See also parable, Type 2, in the Glossary.

Mark 4:11

Section 4:10–12: Jesus told why he used parables

The disciples did not understand the parables that Jesus had been teaching. Jesus first explained the reasons that he taught with parables. Then he explained the parable of the sower (4:13–20).

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus explained his reason for teaching with parables

The reason Jesus taught in parables

The purpose of parables

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:10–15 and Luke 8:9–10.

4:11a

He replied,

- He said to them,

- He/Jesus replied to them,

He replied: Since the disciples were asking questions, it may be more natural in your language to use the verb “answered” or “told” here. For example, the NIV says:

he told them

4:11b

“The mystery of the kingdom of God has been given to you,

- “It is you^(plur) who have received the secret concerning the kingdom of God.
- “As for you,^(plur) you have been told the hidden truth about God’s rule/reign.
- “You^(plur) are the ones to whom God has given the opportunity to know what was not made known previously about how he rules over his people.

The mystery of the kingdom of God has been given to you: This is a passive clause. In some languages it may be necessary to use an active verb and supply the subject “God.” For example:

God has given to you the mystery of the kingdom of God.

This clause means that God has revealed a mystery about his kingdom to the disciples. People did not previously know this mystery. Another way to say this is:

God has revealed to you the mystery about his kingdom.

The mystery of the kingdom of God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mystery refers to a truth or secret that was previously hidden and is now revealed to certain people. The phrase kingdom of God refers to God’s activity of ruling and caring for his people as their king. It does not refer to a land or country that he rules over. The mystery of the kingdom of God refers to the way God’s rule works.

Here are some other ways to translate The mystery of the kingdom of God:

The hidden truth about how God rules his people...

What people have not known before about God’s rule/reign...

The secret concerning God's chieftaincy/government...

See also kingdom of God, Context 2, in the Glossary.

God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as God refers here to the eternal being who created everything. Although he is spirit, he is more powerful than any other spirit, and he is perfectly good and wise. He deserves to be worshipped. Here are some ways to translate God:

- Use a name or title for God that people in your culture already use.
- Use a descriptive term that fits the truth about God that is revealed in the Bible. For example:

Creator

Great Spirit

Ruler of the universe

Choose a term that is acceptable to the believers and churches in your area. For more detailed information, see God in the Glossary.

has been given: In some languages it may be necessary to express the idea of "giving a secret" in a different way. For example:

God has revealed to you the mystery

God has made known to you the hidden truth...

You have been allowed/enabled to learn what people did not previously understand

you: The pronoun you is plural. Its position in the clause in Greek emphasizes the disciples in contrast to the outsiders mentioned in 4:11c. In some languages this contrast may be emphasized in different ways. Some ways to emphasize this contrast are:

- Use a different word order. For example, the RSV says:

To you^(plur) has been given the mystery of the kingdom of God.

- Use a separate phrase. For example:

As for you, you have been given the mystery of the kingdom of God.

Use a natural way in your language to emphasize the contrast between you and the other people to whom Jesus is not speaking directly, whom he calls "those on the outside."

4:11c

but to those on the outside everything is expressed in parables,

- But to other people, everything is told using parables,
- But as for those who are not my followers, I always use parables when I teach them God's message,
- But I teach everything in/using parables to those who do not believe in me.

but to those on the outside: The word outside here refers to people who are not among the group of Jesus' followers. It refers to those who do not believe in Jesus. God does not give the mystery to them.

In languages where the word outside is only used literally, you may want to use a different expression. For example:

But to other people who are not my followers

But to those who do not believe in me

everything is expressed in parables: This clause is passive. Jesus referred here to his own use of parables. If it is more natural in your language to make this clause active, you can say:

I say everything in parables

I use parables to teach everything

everything: In this context, the word everything refers to the teachings about God and his kingdom. In some languages the idea of saying or teaching everything may need to be expressed in other ways. For example:

I only teach them by using parables

I always use parables when I teach them

parables: See the note on 4:10b.

Mark 4:12

Section 4:10–12: Jesus told why he used parables

The disciples did not understand the parables that Jesus had been teaching. Jesus first explained the reasons that he taught with parables. Then he explained the parable of the sower (4:13–20).

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus explained his reason for teaching with parables

The reason Jesus taught in parables

The purpose of parables

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:10–15 and Luke 8:9–10.

4:12a–c

All the words inside the single quote marks are from Isaiah 6:9–10. If you usually introduce Old Testament Scripture in a particular way, you may want to do so here. An example is:

...so that (as the Scriptures say), “they may be ever seeing but never perceiving, and ever hearing but never understanding; otherwise they might turn and be forgiven!”

4:12a

so that, ‘they may be ever seeing but never perceiving,

- in order that ‘they may indeed see, but they will not perceive,
- so that ‘although they keep seeing what I do, they do not understand what they are seeing,
- I do this so that they do/will not understand what they see.

so that: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as so that indicates purpose. Jesus spoke in parables so that those on the outside would not understand. In Hebrew thought, the distinction between purpose and result is blurred, since everything that happens is under God’s control. The difficult statement that Jesus used parables in order that outsiders would not understand probably needs to be understood in light of other passages in both the NT and OT that

speak of God hardening the hearts of people who had already shown their unwillingness to listen and obey. As Edwards (page 133) points out, this quotation from Isaiah occurs six times in the NT, always in contexts of unbelief and hardness of heart. The NRSV says:

in order that

In some languages it may be clearer or more natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

I do this in order that

My purpose/reason for doing this is so that

they may be ever seeing but never perceiving: The Greek words that the BSB translates as they may be ever seeing but never perceiving are literally “seeing they may see but not perceive.” The wording is different than the parallel verse in Matthew and Luke which have: “seeing, they do/may not see.” But the meaning is similar in all three. (as in the NASB). This clause is a quotation from the book of Isaiah. Jesus implied that the people who did not believe in him were like the people to whom Isaiah spoke. They would see what he did, but they would not understand the meaning of what they saw.

Most English versions use the word but to indicate the unexpected contrast between seeing and never perceiving. In some languages it may be more natural to express this contrast in other ways. For example:

although they are seeing, they are not understanding

they will not understand even though they see

Some languages may require an object for verbs like “see” and “understand.” Since this is a quotation from the Old Testament, it is good to make the object general. For example:

they may see and see proof of the truth, but never understand it

they may be ever seeing: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as they may be ever seeing refers to seeing the same thing many times. The people saw the things that Jesus did on many occasions over a period of time.

This meaning may be expressed in different ways. For example:

they may look and look (NJB)

they may indeed see (RSV)

never perceiving: In this context, the phrase never perceiving means that people did not understand the significance of what they had seen with their eyes.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

they do not understand

they will learn nothing (NLT)

4:12b

and ever hearing but never understanding;

- and they may indeed hear, but they will not understand,
- and although they hear what I say, they do not understand what they are hearing,
- They will also not understand what they hear.

ever hearing but never understanding: The expression ever hearing but never understanding is similar in both form and meaning to 4:12a. The difference is that 4:12a focuses on seeing, whereas this clause focuses on hearing. 4:12a–b is an example of Hebrew poetry (from Isaiah). An important feature of Hebrew poetry is parallelism, stating similar ideas but using different words. In this case, the words “seeing” and “hearing” in the first half of lines a and b both refer literally to ways in which a person receives information; that is, with his eyes and ears. The words “perceiving” and “understanding” in the second half of lines a and b both refer to the way a person processes that information with his mind.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

may indeed hear but not understand (RSV)

although they hear, they do/will not understand what they hear

In languages that require an object for the verb “hear,” the implied object is the truth. For example:

they hear the truth, but they do not understand it

General Comment on 4:12a–b

When you translate the similar ideas in 4:12a and 4:12b, use words in your language that fit naturally together. Some languages may need to use the same expression to translate “perceiving” and “understanding.”

In other languages, it may sound redundant to use the same word. If there is no other word that fits the context, the ideas in these two lines may be combined. For example:

they see and hear, but they do not understand anything

4:12c

otherwise they might turn and be forgiven.”

- lest they return to God and be forgiven.”
- and so they do not repent and receive God’s pardon.”
- If they did understand, they would turn to God, and he would clean/erase their sins.”

otherwise: The Greek word that the BSB translates as otherwise expresses another negative purpose for teaching in parables. The NJB takes this to refer to the people’s purpose in not paying attention: “to avoid changing their ways.” In English this negative purpose can be expressed in various ways. For example:

so that they may not turn again (NRSV)

lest they should turn again (RSV)

otherwise they might turn (REB)

This negative purpose is closely related to people fulfilling the preceding purposes in 4:12a–b. One way to express this relationship in English is with an “if” clause. For example:

If they did, they would turn to God (CEV)

If they did learn and understand, they would come back to me

turn: In this context, the verb turn means “repent.” It refers to turning from sin and toward God.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

turn to God (GNT)

turn from their sins (NLT96)

return to me (GW) The GW translates this expression with God speaking, which is the correct context in Isaiah.

repent (NET)

and be forgiven: The phrase and be forgiven expresses the result of the verb “turn.” The phrase is passive. If your language must say who forgives, you should say “God.”

Here is another way to translate the phrase in this context:

and God would forgive them

In this context the verb be forgiven means that God would choose not to punish the people for the evil/bad things that they had done, said, and thought. He would cancel their guilt and treat them as though they had not offended him.

See the note on “are forgiven” in 2:5c.

Mark 4:13

Section 4:13–20: Jesus explained the parable about four types of soil

In this section, Jesus talked about the meaning of the parable that he had just told. The basic meaning of Jesus’ explanation is clear. However, there are questions about the meaning of the seed in this section. In 4:14, the seed refers to the word. In 4:15–20, what is sown seems to refer to the people who hear the word. This has led to several interpretations for the seed in 4:15–20.

The interpretation that the Notes follows is that in 4:15–20 the seed continues to represent the word. The introductory expressions such as “these/others...are the ones sown” (RSV) refer to what happens when the word falls into different types of soil. It represents what happens when different types of people hear the word. For example, the REB says:

With some the seed falls along the footpath

Many scholars support this interpretation in their commentaries. In some versions the seed appears to refer to the people. However, even in these versions, the text implies that the seed of the word has different results in different kinds of people.

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There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:18–23 and Luke 8:11–15.

4:13a

Then Jesus said to them,

- ¶ Then Jesus told/asked them,
- ¶ Jesus said to his followers,

Then: This verse is the beginning of a new section. The events in this section probably happened immediately after the events in 4:10–12. Here, Jesus continued speaking, but he began to explain the parable. So the BSB uses the conjunction Then.

Here is another way to translate this in English:

After that

In some languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this part of the story in a natural way in your language.

Jesus said: In 4:13b, Jesus asked a rhetorical question. So it may be more natural in your language to use the verb “asked” here rather than said. For example, the GW says:

Jesus asked

to them: The pronoun them refers to the twelve apostles and other disciples (4:10a). If people in your area will think the pronoun refers to some other people, you may want to use nouns here. Some examples of translating this sentence are:

Jesus said to the disciples

Jesus asked his followers

4:13b

“Do you not understand this parable?”

- “Can it be that you^(plur) do not understand this parable?
- “If you^(plur) do not understand the meaning of this parable,

Do you not understand this parable?: In Greek, this clause is the first part of one rhetorical question that includes 4:13c. Together, these two parts indicate a rebuke and make an emphatic statement.

Some ways to translate this part of the rebuke and emphatic statement are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Can it be that you do not understand this parable?

- As a statement. For example:

I cannot believe that you do not understand this parable!

- As an “if” clause. For example:

If you don’t understand this story... (CEV)

But if you can’t understand this story... (NLT96)

parable: The Greek word that the BSB translates as parable can refer to several types of speech such as metaphors, illustrations, and stories that were used to teach a lesson or a truth. Use an appropriate word for the parable about the sower that Jesus told in Section 4:1–9. Refer to the general word for parable that you used in 4:2a.

4:13c

Then how will you understand any of the parables?

- Then how will you^(plur) understand any parable?

- then you^(plur) will certainly not understand any parables!

Then how will you understand any of the parables?:

In Greek, this is the second part of a rhetorical question. It is really a strong negative statement.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Then how will you ever understand any parable?

- As a negative statement. For example:

Then you will certainly not understand any other parable.

any of the parables: The Greek words that the BSB translates as any of the parables are literally “all the parables.” This could be represented with either a plural form (as the BSB does) or with a singular form. For example, the NIV translates this phrase as “any parable.” Use the singular or plural, whichever is most natural in your language.

Here is another example of how to translate this:

other parables

The term that you use for parables here should be general enough to include many types of wise speech, such as illustrations, metaphors, and sayings. See the note on 4:2a for translation suggestions.

Mark 4:14

Section 4:13–20: Jesus explained the parable about four types of soil

In this section, Jesus talked about the meaning of the parable that he had just told. The basic meaning of Jesus’ explanation is clear. However, there are questions about the meaning of the seed in this section. In 4:14, the seed refers to the word. In 4:15–20, what is sown seems to refer to the people who hear the word. This has led to several interpretations for the seed in 4:15–20.

The interpretation that the Notes follows is that in 4:15–20 the seed continues to represent the word. The introductory expressions such as “these/others...are the ones sown” (RSV) refer to what happens when the word falls into different types of soil. It represents what happens when different types of people hear the word. For example, the REB says:

With some the seed falls along the footpath

Many scholars support this interpretation in their commentaries. In some versions the seed appears to refer to the people. However, even in these versions, the text implies that the seed of the word has different results in different kinds of people.

Here is the meaning of the main metaphors in the parable:

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The meaning of the parable of a man scattering seed

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:18–23 and Luke 8:11–15.

4:14

The farmer sows the word.

- The farmer sows the word of God.
- Here is the meaning of the parable. The one sowing/scattering seed is like someone speaking the word of God.

This verse begins the explanation of the parable. It may be more natural in your language to indicate that. For example:

The meaning of the parable is this: The farmer...

The farmer sows the word: The clause The farmer sows the word is a metaphor that explains the events of the parable. The farmer represents a person who

tells the gospel to others. However, the phrase the word is part of the explanation. It may be more natural in your language to mention the seed also before explaining what it means. For example:

The farmer sows the seed that represents someone preaching the word.

Someone telling the word of God to others is like the farmer sowing/scattering the seed.

The farmer: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as The farmer is literally “the one who sows.” It is the same phrase that is used in 4:3b. You should translate it in the same way here.

sows: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sows refers to a method of planting seeds. The farmer planted the seeds by throwing them to the side and in front of himself. This same word occurs in 4:3b.

the word: The phrase the word refers to God’s word, that is, what God’s says. If people in your area will not understand that, you may want to include the implied words. Here are some examples:

the word of God

God’s message (NCV)

The phrase “the word of God” means “the word that comes from God” or “the message that God has made known.” Jesus referred primarily to his own teaching.

Mark 4:15

Section 4:13–20: Jesus explained the parable about four types of soil

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There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:18–23 and Luke 8:11–15.

4:15a

Some are like the seeds along the path, where the word is sown.

- Some people are like the soil along/beside the path where the word is sown.
- Some seed falls onto/beside the path where the word is sown. This is like when people
- Sometimes the seed falls/lands on the path. This represents what happens when people hear the word,

Some are like the seeds along the path, where the word is sown: The Greek text here is literally “these are the ones along the path, where the word is sown” (as in the RSV).

The words “these are the ones” (RSV) introduce the first group of people. These people are compared to the path along which the sower has sown the word/seed. Jesus described what happens when such people hear the word.

Here are some other ways to translate this comparison:

Sometimes the word/teaching falls along the path. This is like what happens when some people...

These/Some people are like the path along which the word is sown/scattered.

along the path: Translate this phrase as you did in 4:4b.

is sown: The verb is sown is passive. In the parable, the farmer sowed the seed. This event represents someone telling the gospel.

If it is more natural in your language to say who sowed, you may want to use “someone.” For example:

someone sowed/told the word

If possible keep the focus on the word.

4:15b

As soon as they hear it, Satan comes

- When they hear the word, Satan comes at once
- hear the word, but then immediately Satan comes
- but then at once Satan, the leader of the demons, comes

4:15c

and takes away the word that was sown in them.

- and removes the word that was sown in them.
- and removes the word of God that someone had told them.
- and causes them to forget God’s message that was put in their minds/hearts.

4:15b–c

As soon as they hear it, Satan comes: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as As soon as they hear it, Satan comes is literally “when they hear, Satan immediately comes” (as in the NRSV). The GW has another way to translate this:

Whenever they hear the word, Satan comes at once

If you have included the information that these people hear the word in 4:15a, it may be natural to translate this as:

as soon as that happens

immediately after that

Satan: The word Satan is the Hebrew name of the chief or leader of all the evil spirits. In Hebrew his name means “enemy.” He is the enemy of God and God’s people. See how you translated this name in 3:23–26. Here are some ways to translate Satan:

- Use a local name or idiom that refers to the chief of all demons.
- Use a descriptive phrase such as:

the chief/leader of the evil spirits

the spirit enemy of God

- Transliterate the name Satan. If this word is not already known in your area, you may also want to add a descriptive phrase. For example:

Satanas, the ruler of demons

Shaitan If you transliterate Satan or borrow a word from another language, be sure that it communicates the biblical meaning to people in your culture. It is important to check this in each biblical context.

Try to use a term that will be acceptable to churches in the area. It is suggested that you also add a footnote or glossary entry that further explains who Satan is. For example:

Satan is the leader of all the evil spirits or demons. Once he was an angel in heaven, but he rebelled against God. God expelled him from heaven, and now he tempts people on earth. Here are other names for Satan that are used in the Bible: “Beelzebul,” “the Devil,” “the Evil One,” “the Enemy,” and “the Tempter.”

See how you translated this word in 1:13a.

takes away the word that was sown in them: There is a minor textual issue here: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have in/into them. For example, the CEV says:

“Satan comes and snatches the word that was sown in them” (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, JBP, NET, REB, NCV). (2) Other Greek manuscripts have in their hearts. For example, the KJV says: “taketh away the word that was sown in their hearts” (KJV). You should follow option (1) since it has the best manuscript support. Again, this clause mixes the explanation with the metaphor. The phrase the word is part of the explanation. The phrase was sown in them is a metaphor. It may be more natural in your language to explain the metaphor here. For example:

takes away what has been sown in their minds (JBP)

removes the word of God that they heard

takes away the word: The Greek word that the BSB translates as takes away can also be translated as “removes.” Satan takes away the seed/word in the sense that he makes the person “forget” what they have heard. In some languages it may be natural to translate it in a non-figurative way. For example:

causes them to forget God’s message

Mark 4:16

Section 4:13–20: Jesus explained the parable about four types of soil

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There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:18–23 and Luke 8:11–15.

4:16a

Some are like the seeds sown on rocky ground.

- Other people are like the shallow soil that covers rocky places.
- Some seed falls onto shallow soil covering rock. This is like when people
- Sometimes the seed lands/falls on rocky places. This illustrates/represents people

Some are like the seeds sown on rocky ground: The Greek text here is literally “these are the ones among the rocky places, being sown.” For example, the NRSV says:

And these are the ones sown on rocky ground

The words “these are the ones” (NRSV) introduce the second group of people. These people are compared to rocky places on which the sower has sown seed. Jesus

described what happened when these people hear the word.

Here are some other ways to translate this comparison:

Sometimes the word/teaching falls on rocky places. This is like what happens when some people...

These/Some people are like the places/soil that had rock under it. This is where the seed is sown/scattered.

rocky ground: The phrase rocky ground also occurs in 4:5a. Use the same expression to translate this phrase here as you did there.

4:16b

They hear the word and at once receive it with joy.

- They hear the word and happily receive/welcome it immediately.
- hear the word of God and quickly accept it with joy,
- who hear God’s message and are happy to accept/believe it immediately,

at once receive it with joy: The word receive refers to accepting the word of God. These people quickly and happily believe the word.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

gladly hear the message and accept it right away (CEV)

quickly accept it with joy (NCV)

Mark 4:17

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4:17

On the rocky ground, the seeds become plants. But they cannot develop good roots in the rocky soil. Then the heat of the sun causes these plants to die. This is like people who accept the word of God, but they do not give the word a chance to take root in them. When they have trouble or when people persecute them, they stop obeying the word.

4:17a

But they themselves have no root,

- But since they are like plants without enough roots,

- but they do not let God’s word grow deep in their hearts/minds,

4:17b

and they remain for only a season.

- they do not last for a long time.
- so they accept/believe the word only for a short time.

4:17a–b

But: There is a contrast between what one would expect of a person who received the word with joy (4:16b) and what actually happens (4:17). These people did not continue to grow as believers. The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction But. Introduce this contrast in the way that is natural in your language.

they themselves have no root, and they remain for only a season: A literal translation of the Greek text is: “they have no root in themselves, but are temporary.” The plants are temporary, or only live for a short time, because they have no root.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they have no roots; that is why they last only a short time

they have no root, so they do not last for a long time

they live only for a little while because they have no root

they themselves have no root: The phrase they themselves have no root is a metaphor. The people who had received the word with joy were like plants without roots. They were not stable or firm because they did not believe God’s word enough to endure trouble. In some languages it may be necessary to translate this as a simile:

they are like plants with no root

Another possibility is to translate some of the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

the word had not taken deep root within them

they do not let God’s word grow deep in their hearts/minds

The phrase they themselves have no root is also a hyperbole. It emphasizes that they did not have enough roots. See the note on 4:6b.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

they have no deep roots

they have only a shallow root

they remain for only a season: The Greek word that the BSB translates as remain for only a season means “are temporary.” It refers to the fact that the person who is like a plant on rocky soil accepts the message for only a season.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

stay that way only a short time

quickly change their mind

do not endure (NET)

accept it only for a short time

4:17c

When trouble or persecution comes because of the word,

- When suffering and oppression happen to them because they received/welcome the word of God,
- Because they accept/believe God’s message, they have difficulties and people do harm/evil to them.

trouble or persecution comes because of the word:

In some languages, it may be natural to change the order of some of the parts of this verse. For example:

the word causes them trouble and persecution

on account of the word, they encounter trouble or persecution

Because they receive the word, they have difficulties and are persecuted

trouble or persecution comes: The word trouble is a general word that refers to difficulties of all kinds. The word persecution refers to someone deliberately harming someone else because of who they are or what they believe.

You may need a different verb than comes to refer to trouble or persecution happening to someone.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

When suffering and oppression happen to them

When they have difficulties and people do evil to them

When they have trouble or people persecute/oppress/harm them

because of the word: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as because of the word here means “because they received the word.” Trouble and persecution came because these people heard and accepted the word of God. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

When trouble or persecution comes because they accepted/welcome the word

4:17d

they quickly fall away.

- they quickly/immediately stop believing the word of God.
- When those things happen, they soon turn away from God’s message.

they quickly fall away: The phrase fall away is an idiom. In this context it means that these people stop believing the message and turn away from God. This happens quickly or immediately.

Here are some other ways to translate this idiom:

they immediately stop believing/obeying God’s message

they immediately turn away from the message

they give up at once (GNT)

they quickly lose faith (REB)

General Comment on 4:17a–d

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the parts of this verse. For example:

^{17a}But they lack roots, ^{17c}so when trouble arrives or people cause them hardship because they believed the word of God, ^{17b}they do not continue to believe. ^{17d}Rather they immediately turn away from their faith.

Mark 4:18

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There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:18–23 and Luke 8:11–15.

4:18a

Others are like the seeds sown among the thorns.

- Some other people are like the soil where there are thorn plants.
- Some seed falls onto soil with thorns. This is like what happens to a third group of people.
- Sometimes the seed lands on soil/places where young thorn plants are growing. This illustrates/represents certain people

4:18b

They hear the word,

- They hear the word,
- They hear the word of God,
- who hear God's message.

4:18a–b

Others are like the seeds sown among the thorns:

The Greek text here is literally “others are the ones among the thorns, being sown.” For example, the RSV says:

And others are the ones sown among thorns

The words “others are the ones” (RSV) introduce the third group of people. These people are compared to soil on which thorn plants are growing. Jesus described what happens when the seed/word falls among those thorn plants.

Here are some other ways to translate this comparison:

Sometimes the word/teaching falls among thorns. This is like what happens when some other people...

These other people are like the places with thorny plants where the word/seed was sown.

thorns: The word thorns also occurs in 4:7a. Translate this word using the same word or expression as you did there.

Mark 4:19

Section 4:13–20: Jesus explained the parable about four types of soil

In this section, Jesus talked about the meaning of the parable that he had just told. The basic meaning of Jesus' explanation is clear. However, there are questions about the meaning of the seed in this section. In 4:14, the seed refers to the word. In 4:15–20, what is sown seems to refer to the people who hear the word. This has led to several interpretations for the seed in 4:15–20.

The interpretation that the Notes follows is that in 4:15–20 the seed continues to represent the word. The introductory expressions such as “these/others...are the ones sown” (RSV) refer to what happens when the word falls into different types of soil. It represents what happens when different types of people hear the word. For example, the REB says:

With some the seed falls along the footpath

Many scholars support this interpretation in their commentaries. In some versions the seed appears to refer to the people. However, even in these versions, the text implies that the seed of the word has different results in different kinds of people.

Here is the meaning of the main metaphors in the parable:

1. The seeds represent **the word**, which is **the message from God**.
2. The sowing of the seed represents **telling the message to people**.
3. The different kinds of soil represents **the different people who hear the message**.

This section heading should be similar to the section heading for 4:1–9. You may use the word “explained” or “Jesus explained” (instead of “Jesus told”).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus explained the parable of the sower and the soils

The four soils parable/story/illustration explained

The explanation of the parable about four kinds of people

The meaning of the parable of a man scattering seed

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:18–23 and Luke 8:11–15.

4:19

The seeds that were sown among thorns (4:18) have now become grain plants. But these grain plants are not able to grow. The thorn plants cause the grain plants to remain small. In the same way, some people accept the word of God, but they continually think about earthly things. So they never become strong and faithful believers.

There are three things that “come in and choke the word.” They are “the worries of this life” (4:19a), “the deceitfulness of wealth” (4:19b), and “the desires for other things” (4:19b). Your translation should indicate that all three things “come in and choke the word.”

4:19a

but the worries of this life,

- but the worries about daily living,
- but continually worry about their daily lives.
- These people are anxious about getting the many things they need for their earthly lives.

but the worries of this life: The words worries of this life refers to the anxieties and concerns that are common to human beings.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

the cares of life on earth

the worries of life (GW)

the anxieties/concerns of daily living

If the word for worries in your language already implies worrying about earthly things, it may not be necessary to translate the phrase of this life.

In some languages it may be more natural to use a verb here rather than the noun worries. For example:

but worrying about this life

but they are worried about the needs of daily life

4:19b

the deceitfulness of wealth,

- the lure/seduction of riches,

- They are deceived into trying to be rich,
- They falsely believe that they need more and more money,

the deceitfulness of wealth: The Greek word that the BSB translates as deceitfulness describes something that “deceives” or “tricks” someone. Wealth/money appears to be something that will make people happy, but it does not. Wealth “deceives” a person so that he seeks riches more than he seeks ways to follow God.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

lure of riches (NJB)

seduction/enticement of riches

the lie that wealth will make one happy

deceitful pleasures of riches (GW)

In some languages it may be more natural to use a verb here rather than the noun deceitfulness. For example:

they are deceived by the false promise of wealth

they seek wealth and it tricks/traps them

4:19c

and the desire for other things come in

- and all other kinds of desires come
- and they desire many other things which they think about all the time.
- and they desire/want many other things.

the desire for other things: The phrase the desire for other things refers generally to wanting material things.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

all other kinds of desires (GNT)

they want many nice things

desire: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as desire may include lust or sexual desire. It also refers more generally to all kinds of evil desires or cravings.

If it is more natural in your language to use a verb here in place of the noun desire, you can say:

and desiring many other things

and they also desire/want other things

other things: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as other things here refers to other types of possessions and riches.

come in: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as come in here means “enter” the person’s life/heart/mind. Worries (4:19a), deceit (4:19b), and desires (4:19c) all happen in the mind/heart. Here, those three things are viewed as coming into the mind/heart from outside it.

Here are some other ways to say this:

enter their lives/mind/heart

fill the mind/heart

If you translate “worries,” “deceitfulness,” and “desires” 4:19a–c as verbs, it may not be necessary to also translate the phrase come in. For example:

^{19a}...but they are worried about the needs of daily life; ^{19b}they seek wealth and it deceives them, ^{19c}and they also desire/want/lust other things. So all these things ^{19d}choke...

4:19d

and choke the word, and it becomes unfruitful.

- and choke the word of God, so the word does not produce any fruit.
- Because of all those things, they no longer respond to God’s word and let it cause them to do good.
- These things crowd God’s message out of their lives and cause it not to produce anything good.

choke the word: The Greek verb that the BSB literally translates as choke refers to the way weeds and thorns crowd out other plants and prevent them from growing normally. This is same word as in 4:7b.

Here, this word is used metaphorically. It refers to the way the three things in 4:19a–c keep the mind too busy to think about the word.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

crowd/press the word of God

prevent/hinder the word of God from growing

overpower the word of God in their mind/thinking

and it becomes unfruitful: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as it becomes unfruitful tells what happens when the word of God is choked. The NLT has another way to express this result:

so no fruit is produced

unfruitful: The word unfruitful means “not producing fruit.” In the New Testament, fruit is a metaphor for doing good deeds/actions. The grain plants were crowded out and did not produce a crop. In the same way, the word of God was crowded out of this person’s mind/heart and did not produce any results in his life.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

so it produces no fruit in that person’s life

and there is no response in that person’s life

and so they do not act and think according to God’s message

In some languages, it may be more natural to start 4:19d with a new sentence. For example:

So all these things choke the word of God, and it bears no fruit.

As a result the word of God is never in their thoughts and it has no effect in their lives.

Mark 4:20

Section 4:13–20: Jesus explained the parable about four types of soil

In this section, Jesus talked about the meaning of the parable that he had just told. The basic meaning of Jesus’ explanation is clear. However, there are questions about the meaning of the seed in this section. In 4:14, the seed refers to the word. In 4:15–20, what is sown seems to refer to the people who hear the word. This has led to several interpretations for the seed in 4:15–20.

The interpretation that the Notes follows is that in 4:15–20 the seed continues to represent the word. The introductory expressions such as “these/others...are the ones sown” (RSV) refer to what happens when the word falls into different types of soil. It represents

what happens when different types of people hear the word. For example, the REB says:

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The four soils parable/story/illustration explained

The explanation of the parable about four kinds of people

The meaning of the parable of a man scattering seed

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:18–23 and Luke 8:11–15.

4:20a

Still others are like the seeds sown on good soil.

- Other people are like the good soil where the word is thrown/scattered.
- Some seed falls onto good soil. This is like when people
- Sometimes the seed lands on fertile soil. This represents people who

Still others are like the seeds sown on good soil: The Greek text here is literally “those are the ones upon

the good soil, being sown.” For example, the NRSV says:

And these are the ones sown on the good soil

The words “those are the ones” (NRSV) introduce the fourth group of people. These people are compared to the good soil on which the sower has sown/planted seed.

Here are some other ways to translate this comparison:

Sometimes the word/teaching falls on good soil. This is like what happens when some people...

Lastly, other people are like good soil where the word/seed was sown.

good soil: The Greek word that the BSB translates as good in this context refers to the kind of soil in which plants grow well. Refer to your translation of 4:8a, where the same term is used.

4:20b

They hear the word, receive it, and produce a crop—

- They hear the word of God, accept it and bear fruit.
- listen to the message from God, receive it as true, and produce good fruit.
- hear God’s message and accept/believe it. Then it has good results in their lives.

receive it: The Greek word that the BSB translates as receive means to agree that something is correct or right. This word is different from the word that the BSB translates as “receive” in 4:16b. But the meaning of the two words is the same in this context. You may want to use the same expression here as you did for “receive” in 4:16b.

produce a crop: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as produce a crop indicates here that the seeds produce a harvest. Jesus used this action as a metaphor to describe a person who receives the word of God. That person receives the word of God and shows the good effects of it in his life. That is like the seed that grows and produces a crop.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Keep the metaphor. For example the GNT has:

bear fruit

- Use a simile. For example:

the word has results in their lives like seeds that produce a crop

- Translate the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

the word has good results in their lives

4:20c

thirtyfold, sixtyfold, or a hundredfold.”

- Some produce thirty, others sixty, and others even a hundred times what was sown.”
- There are many good results in their lives, like plants that bear thirty seeds, sixty seeds, or even a hundred seeds.”

thirtyfold, sixtyfold, or a hundredfold: The Greek text that the BSB translates as thirtyfold, sixtyfold, or hundredfold is the same here as in 4:8c.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Keep the metaphor. Translate it in a similar way here as in 4:8c.
- Use a simile and make explicit the meaning of the numbers of seeds. For example:

and there are many good results in their lives, like plants bearing thirty seeds, sixty seeds, or even a hundred times what was sown

- Translate the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

Some have many results, some have even more results and some have amazing/outstanding results.

thirtyfold, sixtyfold, or a hundredfold: The numeric expressions thirtyfold, sixtyfold and a hundredfold are examples of a very good harvest, a great harvest, and an incredible or unbelievable harvest. You should translate this phrase like you did in 4:8c.

The NIV adds the words “what was sown,” which are not in the Greek text but are implied. Other versions have left these words implied, as the BSB has. Likewise, the GNT says:

They hear the message, accept it, and bear fruit: some thirty, some sixty, and some one hundred.

You will need to decide whether to make these words explicit or implicit in your language. Do whatever will make your translation clear and natural.

Mark 4:21

Section 4:21–25: Jesus told his disciples to study and share the truths that God revealed to them

In this section Jesus told a parable about a lamp (4:21). He told this parable in order to encourage his disciples to share the gospel and not to hide it. Then he talked about hidden things and urged his disciples to listen carefully to what he told them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parables of the lamp and measuring

We must not hide the light/truth

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 5:15 (also Matthew 7:2) and Luke 8:16–18 (also Luke 11:33, 6:38, 8:18).

4:21a

Jesus also said to them,

- ¶ Jesus also said to them,
- ¶ Jesus told another parable to the crowd,

Jesus also said to them: This verse is the beginning of a new parable. There is nothing in Greek to indicate when Jesus told this parable. There is nothing to indicate to whom the word them refers. He may have told it to the crowd immediately after the previous parable. He may have told it on a different day to only his disciples. Lane (page 164), Gundry (page 211) and TRT (page 51) support the view that Jesus is here addressing the crowds. Support for this comes from comparing 4:10 with 4:34, since 4:34 indicates that Jesus did not usually teach the intimate group with parables. However, several commentators, including Gould (page 77) and Lenski (page 179), feel that he was still addressing the inner circle.

Because of this uncertainty, you should not be specific about the time or the audience. However, you may want to indicate that Jesus was now speaking about another topic. For example:

Jesus also said (CEV)

Jesus continued (GNT)

Jesus told another parable to them

If your language requires you to specify who Jesus was talking to, you may still be able to maintain the ambiguity. For example:

Jesus said to those who were listening

4:21b

“Does anyone bring in a lamp to put it under a basket or under a bed?”

- “Does anyone bring a lamp and put it under a bowl or under a bed/couch?”
- “Is a lamp ever brought into the room/house and put under a clay pot or under a sofa/bed to hide its light?”
- “No one ever brings in a lamp and puts it under a basket or under a bed.”

Does anyone bring in a lamp to put it under a basket or under a bed?:

This is a rhetorical question. This rhetorical question is used to emphasize something negative. It means, “Certainly no one brings in a lamp and puts it under a bowl or under a bed to hide its light.” Translate this in a way that makes it clear that no one ever does this.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Is a lamp ever brought in and put under a bowl or under a bed?

Can it be that you would bring in a lamp and put it under a bowl or under a bed? Of course not!

No one ever brings in a lamp and puts it under a bowl or under a bed, does he?

- As a statement. For example:

No one ever brings in a lamp and puts it under a bowl or under a bed!

Does anyone bring in a lamp: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Does anyone bring in a lamp is passive. It is literally: “Surely a lamp is not brought.” This phrase refers to an action that no one would do. People do not bring in a lamp and put it where its light is hidden. The focus here is on the action and not on a

specific person who does not do it. Refer to this action in the way that is most natural in your language and use a natural subject.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Is a lamp brought in...? (RSV)

Do we^(incl) bring in a lamp...?

Do you^(plur) bring in a lamp...? (NIV)

Does anyone bring in a lamp...?

You will probably want to translate the example in 4:21c in a similar way, as well.

bring in: The verb bring indicates that the lamp is ready to be put somewhere in the house. The GW says:

bring...into a room

a lamp: A lamp in Jesus' time was a small clay bowl in which people put oil that burned and gave light. The bowl was shaped for a wick on one side. The exact kind of lamp is not important here, so you should use a general word for lamp.

basket: The Greek word that the BSB translates as basket refers to a bowl or clay pot. This type of container held approximately 8.8 liters of grain. You should use a common container of that size that will not let light shine out. Here are some examples:

basket (GW)

clay pot (CEV)

bed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as bed refers to a piece of furniture that people lie on to sleep. Such a piece of furniture had short legs to keep it off the ground. So it was possible to put a lamp underneath it.

If beds in your culture are flat on the floor, you may need to translate this with the name of another piece of furniture. You should use a word that refers to something with short legs under which you could put a small lamp. Something with short legs would block more light than something with long legs. This could be a couch, a chair, a low bench, or a cabinet with short legs.

4:21c

Doesn't he set it on a stand?

- On the contrary, doesn't he put it on a stand?
- No! It is put/placed on its stand.
- Indeed, he puts it on its shelf!

Doesn't he set it on a stand?: This is a rhetorical question. It is an emphatic positive statement that means: "Of course you put a lamp on its stand." A lamp is put on a stand so that everyone can see its light. Translate this in a way that emphasizes this positive idea. Here are some examples:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Isn't a lamp placed in a stand?

Is it not true that you put it on its stand?

Instead, you put it on its stand, don't you?

- As a statement. For example:

Indeed, you put it on its stand!

Jesus' example here is similar to the one in 4:21b. See the examples there. Translate it a natural way in your language.

Doesn't he: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Doesn't he introduces another rhetorical question that is in direct contrast to the previous one. Some English versions do not translate this phrase, but indicate that 4:21b expects the answer "no" and 4:21c expects the answer "yes." Some other translations make the contrast more explicit. For example, the NIV says "Instead." Indicate the contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

stand: A stand was a stone or wooden shelf inside the house where people normally put a lamp so that it would give light to the room.

Here are some other ways to translate stand:

an elevated place

lamp-support

lampstand (GNT)

General Comment on 4:21b–c

If 4:21b is translated as a question, it may be more natural in some languages to translate 4:21c as part of the answer to the question. For example, the NCV says:

Do you hide a lamp under a bowl or under a bed?
No! You put the lamp on a lampstand.

In other languages, it may be necessary or helpful to state the purpose of the lamp and the reason someone put it under a basket. This may also help to make the connection between 4:21b–c and 4:22a more clear. For example, the NLT96 says:

Would anyone light a lamp and then put it under a basket or under a bed to shut out the light? Of course not! A lamp is placed on a stand, where its light will shine.

Mark 4:22

Section 4:21–25: Jesus told his disciples to study and share the truths that God revealed to them

In this section Jesus told a parable about a lamp (4:21). He told this parable in order to encourage his disciples to share the gospel and not to hide it. Then he talked about hidden things and urged his disciples to listen carefully to what he told them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parables of the lamp and measuring

We must not hide the light/truth

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 5:15 (also Matthew 7:2) and Luke 8:16–18 (also Luke 11:33, 6:38, 8:18).

4:22b

and nothing concealed that will not be brought to light.

- and every concealed thing will become evident/clear.
- and every secret thing will be made known. (NCV)
- He will make known everything that is still covered/secret.

4:22a–b

This saying occurs in similar forms in Matthew 10:26 and Luke 12:2. However, the context in those passages is different. If you have already translated Matthew or Luke, you may not be able to use exactly the same wording here. You may need to adjust the wording that you used there to fit the different context here in Mark. In Matthew the point of the saying is that people should proclaim the gospel openly in spite of persecution. In Luke, the point is that hypocrisy will be uncovered. Here in Mark, the saying probably refers to the mystery about the kingdom of God that is hidden in parables but will soon be made known to a wider audience, perhaps referring to the spread of the gospel following the resurrection. See the discussion in France, pages 208–210.

For there is nothing hidden that will not be disclosed, and nothing concealed that will not be brought to light: This verse forms a doublet. A doublet states the same idea in two ways. In other words, 4:22a means the same thing as 4:22b. A doublet is a poetic form that adds emphasis to the idea.

There are at least two ways to translate this doublet:

- Keep the doublet. If it is natural in your language to state the same idea in two ways, you should translate both parts of the doublet. You may need to add a phrase at the beginning of the second part of the doublet to indicate that you are repeating the idea. For example:

...whatever is hidden is meant to be disclosed.
As I said, whatever is concealed is meant to be brought out into the open.

- Combine the two parts of the doublet into one statement. If people will think that each part of the doublet means a different thing, then you may want to combine the two statements. If you do this, you may want to include an expression that adds emphasis. Here is an example:

For whatever is hidden or concealed is indeed meant to be disclosed/revealed

4:22a

For there is nothing hidden that will not be disclosed,

- For everything that is hidden will be revealed,
- In the same way, anything that is hidden will be made clear,

- What I mean is, he/God will disclose/reveal everything that people do not yet know.

For: The word For indicates that this verse explains 4:21. Just as a lamp is not hidden but put in a place where everyone can see it, so God will reveal all things that are hidden.

Use a word or phrase in your language that indicates that what follows explains Jesus' words in 4:21. For example:

In the same way also

Likewise

In some languages the connection of 4:22 with 4:21 may be clear without using an explicit connecting word or phrase. If that is true in your language, you may be able to leave the connection implied.

there is nothing hidden that will not be disclosed:

The Greek clause that the BSB translates as there is nothing hidden that will not be disclosed indicates that "all hidden things will be disclosed/revealed." For example:

Whatever is hidden away will be brought out into the open (GNT)

Everything that is hidden will be made clear (NCV)

This clause is passive. It implies that at the proper time God intends to reveal whatever is hidden. In some languages you may need to make this meaning more explicit. For example:

God intends to disclose whatever is hidden now

nothing: In this context, the word that the BSB translates as nothing can refer to several things. It can refer to the teachings of Jesus, to who Jesus truly was as the Christ, and to the kingdom of God. You should use an expression that allows those possible meanings. You should avoid an expression that refers primarily to things or objects.

hidden: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hidden is used figuratively in this context. It refers to secret knowledge or teaching that has not previously been made known.

If there is no word in your language such as "hidden" or "concealed," you may be able to express the meaning in a different way. For example:

whatever has not been made known

all that people do not yet know

be disclosed: The verb be disclosed means "be revealed" or "be shown." This verb is passive. If it is more natural in your language to use an active statement and say who will disclose/reveal these hidden things, you may say "God." For example:

God will disclose/reveal

However, if it is possible to translate more generally, you should do so. See the following note on "be brought out into the open."

and nothing concealed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as concealed has a similar meaning as the Greek word that the BSB translates as "hidden" above. If you have two words like "hidden" and "secret" that are close in meaning, you should use the other one here. For example:

every secret thing (NCV)

whatever is covered (GNT)

be brought to light: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as be brought to light is literally "come into the light/open." It refers here to previously unknown truth becoming known, plain or evident.

This verse does not specify who will make known the secret information. It could be Jesus or God or the disciples or all three. Swete (page 82) understands the disciples. TRT (page 52) suggests Jesus or God. France (page 208) suggests God or the disciples or both. Clearly all three had a role in making known the new truth about God's kingdom. So if possible, translate this expression in a general way.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

will be made known (NCV)

will be uncovered (GNT)

be brought out into the open (NIV11)

In languages that do not use passive verbs, you may be able to translate this phrase in one of the following ways:

will become clear/evident

will become known

he/God will openly make known

Mark 4:23

Section 4:21–25: Jesus told his disciples to study and share the truths that God revealed to them

In this section Jesus told a parable about a lamp (4:21). He told this parable in order to encourage his disciples to share the gospel and not to hide it. Then he talked about hidden things and urged his disciples to listen carefully to what he told them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parables of the lamp and measuring

We must not hide the light/truth

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 5:15 (also Matthew 7:2) and Luke 8:16–18 (also Luke 11:33, 6:38, 8:18).

4:23

If anyone has ears to hear, let him hear.”

- If/since you^(plur) have ears for listening with, then listen^(plur) well!”
- Whoever is able to hear what I say should try to understand it.”
- You^(plur) who are listening, think carefully about what you^(plur) have heard.”

If anyone has ears to hear, let him hear: With this saying, Jesus urged the crowd to give careful attention to the parable that they had just heard. Jesus asked them to do more than just listen. He wanted them to understand and respond correctly to the lesson of the parable.

This expression is similar to 4:9. The only difference is that here the words *If anyone* is used instead of “He who.” The meaning is the same, so you should use the same expression that you used in 4:9.

Mark 4:24

Section 4:21–25: Jesus told his disciples to study and share the truths that God revealed to them

In this section Jesus told a parable about a lamp (4:21). He told this parable in order to encourage his disciples to share the gospel and not to hide it. Then he talked about hidden things and urged his disciples to listen carefully to what he told them.

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4:24a

He went on to say, “Pay attention to what you hear.

- ¶ Jesus continued speaking, “Think^(plur) carefully about what you^(plur) hear.
- ¶ Jesus also said to them, “Give^(plur) attention to all that you^(plur) hear.

He went on to say: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *He went on to say* is literally “And he said to them” (as in the RSV). This phrase shows that Jesus began a new topic. The GNT has another way to say this:

He also said to them

The Greek places this phrase at the beginning of 4:24a, as the BSB reflects. Some other translations may place this phrase in the middle or at the end of what Jesus said. Place this phrase where it is natural in your language.

Pay attention: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as *Pay attention* is literally “look.” Here it means “give attention to.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Think carefully about (NCV)

Consider carefully (NIV11)

Be diligent to understand

what you hear: The expression what you hear probably refers to Jesus' teaching. It also can refer generally to things people say. Your translation should allow for that meaning. For example:

everything that you hear

4:24b

With the measure you use, it will be measured to you,

- The measure of effort that you use to gain knowledge will be the measure of knowledge that you receive,
- God will give you understanding in proportion to the effort you use in listening to what I teach.

With the measure you use, it will be measured to you: This was likely a Jewish proverb commonly used in Jesus' time. Literally the proverb refers to any type of instrument that is used to measure the volume or weight of things that are sold in the marketplace.

In the context of selling things, this proverb has several meanings. One meaning is that if you measure generously when you sell something to others, people will also measure generously when they sell something to you. But if you measure in a stingy way when you sell something to others, people will also measure in a stingy way when they sell something to you.

Jesus used this proverb in several contexts with different meanings. He intended his listeners to understand the proverb figuratively. There are two main ways to interpret this proverb here:

1. The proverb refers to giving attention to Jesus' teaching. The more carefully you listen to and heed Jesus' teaching, the more God will enable you to understand. For example, the GW says:

[Knowledge] will be measured out to you by the measure [of attention] you give. (GW, NLT)

1. The proverb refers to judging people. The way you judge others will determine the way that God judges you. For example, the GNT says:

The same rules you use to judge others will be used by God to judge you (GNT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is supported by most scholars. At least a dozen schol-

ars support interpretation (1). The NRSV and REB are ambiguous, but their punctuation probably indicates that they follow interpretation (1) and better fits the context of listening carefully to Jesus' words.

Here are some other ways to translate this proverb:

- Translate the meaning literally or generally. For example, the NJB says:

The standard you use will be used for you To help the people in your area understand the meaning of the proverb in this context, you may want to add a footnote. An example footnote is:

Here, this proverb indicates that the more effort people exert to listen to and understand Jesus' teachings, the more God will increase their understanding.

- Translate the meaning as it applies here. For example:

The closer you listen, the more understanding you will be given (NLT)

God will give you understanding in proportion to the effort you use in listening to my teachings If you follow this option, you may want to add a footnote that gives the literal translation of the proverb. For example:

This proverb literally says: "the measure you give will be the measure you get."

it will be measured: The verb will be measured is passive. The focus is on the measure, not on who does the measuring. If you want to translate the proverb literally and cannot use a passive verb, you may need to make the subject explicit. If that is true in your language, you should use "God" France (page 211) says that God is the assumed source of the reciprocal measure. Lane agrees (page 168). Several commentaries mention God as the implied subject, as do the UBS (page 145) and TRT (page 52). as the subject. For example:

God will use the same measure for you

you will receive the same measure from God

4:24c**and even more will be added to you.**

- and you will receive still more.
- In fact, you will understand even more.
- The truth is, God will give you even more.

and even more will be added to you: The Greek words that the BSB literally translates as will be added to you are passive. Here the words even more indicate that God will reward that person with even greater understanding than he deserved to receive from the amount of effort he used to listen. In other words, God generously rewards the efforts a person makes to understand Jesus' teachings.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

and still more will be given you (RSV)

In fact, God will give you even more understanding

4:24c may not a part of the proverb. Jesus added these words here. But they are connected to the proverb and its meaning. To reflect this, the NIV11 separates these words from the proverb with a long dash at the end of 4:24b. Your language may have a natural way to indicate that 4:24c is not a part of the proverb but is connected to it. Or it may be more natural in your language to use normal punctuation and not separate these words from the proverb. For example, the BSB and the RSV use a comma here.

and even more: There is some contrast between equal measures in 4:24b and even more here. It may be more natural in your language to use "but" (as in the NCV).

Mark 4:25**Section 4:21–25: Jesus told his disciples to study and share the truths that God revealed to them**

In this section Jesus told a parable about a lamp (4:21). He told this parable in order to encourage his disciples to share the gospel and not to hide it. Then he talked about hidden things and urged his disciples to listen carefully to what he told them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parables of the lamp and measuring

We must not hide the light/truth

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 5:15 (also Matthew 7:2) and Luke 8:16–18 (also Luke 11:33, 6:38, 8:18).

4:25a**For whoever has will be given more.**

- Because he who has some things will be given more,
- Another way to say this is, those who have some knowledge/understanding will receive more.

For whoever has: This clause leaves implied what this person has. Because of the close connection of this verse with 4:24, the implied meaning is probably "Whoever has understanding."

In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit what this person has. Some ways to do this are:

- Use a word that specifically indicates the connection with 4:24. For example:

Those who have understanding (NCV)

Those who understand [these mysteries] (GW)

- Use a general word. For example:

Everyone who has something (CEV)

For: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as For indicates that the proverb in 4:25 is a further explanation of the preceding proverb in 4:24. In some languages the meaning of this conjunction can be expressed as:

Another way to say this is

Some versions leave the word For implied. You will need to decide whether it is natural in your language to introduce an explanation with a special word or phrase.

will be given more: The subject for the verb phrase will be given is implied but not repeated. It may be more natural in your language to repeat the subject. For example:

he will be given more

The verb given is passive. If it is more natural in your language to make this active and say who does the giving, the implied subject is God.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

he will receive more

God will add to his understanding

4:25b

But whoever does not have,

- but the one who does not have anything,
- but whoever has no understanding,
- And those who do not use the little knowledge they have,

4:25c

even what he has will be taken away from him.”

- even the little bit he has will be taken from him.”
- he will lose even the little understanding that he has.”
- God will take even that from them.”

4:25b–c

But whoever does not have, even what he has will be taken away from him: This is a hyperbole. It means that the person has very little. It implies that the person ignores the small amount of understanding or knowledge that he has.

It may be more natural in your language to translate the meaning without the hyperbole. For example:

whoever ignores the little he has, even what he has will be taken from him

whoever understands very little, even that will be taken from him

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But is often translated as “and” (as in the RSV). There is contrast between the one who had in 4:25a, and the one who does not have in 4:25b. For this reason, some versions like the BSB indicate this contrast with the conjunction But. Likewise, the NET says:

but whoever does not have

However, some translations do not translate this conjunction at all. You should connect 4:25a and 4:25b in a way that is natural in your language.

will be taken away from him: The Greek verb phrase that the BSB translates as will be taken away is passive. If it is more natural in your language to make this

active and say who will take something, you should refer to the same person as in 4:24c. For example:

God will take even that from him

will lose what little they have (CEV)

Mark 4:26

Section 4:26–29: Jesus told the parable of the sprouting seeds

This parable compares the kingdom of God to seeds. Seeds are planted, they sprout and grow and produce their own seeds (4:27–29a). The man who planted the seeds expects all this to happen but does not know how it happens (4:27c, 29b–c). In the same way, the followers of Jesus will grow in number and spiritual maturity, but people outside of the kingdom of God do not know how that happens. The identity of the man in the parable is not a part of the teaching of the parable. The man should not be compared to God in your translation.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the sprouting seeds

Jesus compared the kingdom of God to plants growing from seeds to harvest

There are no direct parallel passages for this section. Some similar terms are used in Matthew 13:24–30.

4:26a

Jesus also said,

- ¶ Furthermore he said,
- ¶ Then Jesus said to them,

Jesus also said: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Jesus also said is the same Greek phrase as in 4:24a, except here it does not have “to them.” As in 4:24a, this phrase indicates that Jesus was beginning a new topic.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

He continued, saying

Furthermore he said

If your language requires that you make explicit who Jesus said this to, you should use a general expression such as “to them.”

4:26b

“The kingdom of God is like

- “The kingdom of God is like
- “The kingdom of God is like this:

4:26c

a man who scatters seed on the ground.

- when someone scatters/sows seeds on the ground.
- A man/farmer plants/sows some seeds.

4:26b–c

The kingdom of God is like a man who scatters seed on the ground: The kingdom of God is compared to what happens when a man scatters seed on the ground. There are various interpretations of this parable. Some commentators, including Lenski (page 184), say that the kingdom of God is compared to the entire scene. Edwards (page 142) says that the kingdom of God is here compared to seed. France (page 213) says that it is the man who sows. Be careful to translate this in a way that does not imply that the kingdom of God is being compared only to a man.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Here is another illustration of what the Kingdom of God is like: A farmer planted seeds in a field (NLT96)

God’s kingdom is like what happens when a farmer scatters seed in a field (CEV)

This is what the kingdom of God is like. A man scatters seed on the ground (NIV)

Here is another illustration of what God’s reign/chieftancy is like:

The kingdom of God: The phrase The kingdom of God refers to God’s activity of ruling and caring for his people as their king. It does not refer to a land or country that he rules over.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

God’s rule/reign

God’s kingship

God’s chieftancy

God’s government

See also kingdom of God, Context 3, in the Glossary.

God: See how you translated God in 4:11b.

scatters seed on the ground: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scatters is literally “throw.” In that area of the world, farmers planted grain by throwing the seeds on the ground/soil in front and to the side of themselves. This is the same action as in 4:3b, but the verb is different.

The method of planting (scattering on the ground) is not important here. You may want to use the expression for the usual method of planting in your area or a general word for planting.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

sows

plants

If the verb or expression you use for the word scatters implies that the seed is scattered on the ground, the phrase on the ground may not be necessary.

seed: The word seed is singular in form but refers to many individual seeds. In some languages it may be more natural to use a plural form like “seeds” here.

In some languages there may be different words for different types of seeds. The seeds mentioned here are grain seeds.

Mark 4:27

Section 4:26–29: Jesus told the parable of the sprouting seeds

This parable compares the kingdom of God to seeds. Seeds are planted, they sprout and grow and produce their own seeds (4:27–29a). The man who planted the seeds expects all this to happen but does not know how it happens (4:27c, 29b–c). In the same way, the followers of Jesus will grow in number and spiritual maturity, but people outside of the kingdom of God do not know how that happens. The identity of the man in the parable is not a part of the teaching of the parable. The man should not be compared to God in your translation.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the sprouting seeds

Jesus compared the kingdom of God to plants growing from seeds to harvest

There are no direct parallel passages for this section. Some similar terms are used in Matthew 13:24–30.

4:27a

Night and day he sleeps and wakes,

- He sleeps each night and does his activities each day, while
- While he is asleep and while he is awake, as both night and day come and go,

Night and day he sleeps and wakes: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as Night and day he sleeps and wakes is literally: “he might sleep and rise, night and day.” This expression indicates that many days pass. It also indicates that the seeds sprout and grow while the farmer sleeps and while he is awake.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Night and day, whether he sleeps or gets up (NIV11)

He sleeps at night, is up and about during the day, and all the while (GNT)

then going to bed each night and getting up every morning, while (JBP)

While he is asleep and while he is awake, as both night and day pass...

4:27b

and the seed sprouts and grows,

- the seeds sprout and grow;
- the seeds become shoots and grow.

sprouts: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as sprouts refers to the way seeds become plants. Use the proper expression in your language.

4:27c

though he knows not how.

- but he does not know how that/it happens.
- Yet he has no idea of how they become plants and grow.

though: The word though means “despite the fact that.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Yet (GNT)

but (NCV)

although (GW)

he knows not how: The phrase he knows not how means that the man has no knowledge about the way a seed becomes a plant and grows.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he has no idea how it happens (JBP)

he is ignorant about the way they become plants and grow

Mark 4:28

Section 4:26–29: Jesus told the parable of the sprouting seeds

This parable compares the kingdom of God to seeds. Seeds are planted, they sprout and grow and produce their own seeds (4:27–29a). The man who planted the seeds expects all this to happen but does not know how it happens (4:27c, 29b–c). In the same way, the followers of Jesus will grow in number and spiritual maturity, but people outside of the kingdom of God do not know how that happens. The identity of the man in the parable is not a part of the teaching of the parable. The man should not be compared to God in your translation.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the sprouting seeds

Jesus compared the kingdom of God to plants growing from seeds to harvest

There are no direct parallel passages for this section. Some similar terms are used in Matthew 13:24–30.

4:28a

All by itself the earth produces a crop—

- The soil/ground, on its own, causes the seeds to become plants:
- The soil itself makes the seeds grow.

All by itself the earth produces a crop: The Greek words that the BSB translates as All by itself the earth produces a crop is literally: “The soil on its own bears fruit.” This expression indicates that the soil causes the seeds to become plants and causes them to grow. The man does not help the soil in this process.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

The soil itself makes the plants grow and bear fruit (GNT)

The land on its own causes the seeds to become plants and mature

4:28b–c

first the stalk, then the head, then grain that ripens within: These events describe the steps in the overall growth of the grain plant mentioned in 4:28a.

The BSB indicates the connection between 4:28a and 4:28b–c with the long dash (–) at the end of 4:28a. It does not make 4:28b–c a complete sentence. Other English versions begin a new sentence here. For example, the GW says:

First the green blade appears, then the head, then the head full of grain.

Connect 4:28b–c to 4:28a in a way that is natural in your language.

4:28b

first the stalk, then the head,

- first the stalk, then the head/pod,
- First the blade grows/appears, and then the head grows/appears,

first the stalk: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the stalk is literally “grass.” (Since wheat plants are similar to grass, the young plants look like grass at first.) In this context, this word refers to the first thing that grows out of the ground from the seed. This is called the “shoot,” “blade,” or “stalk.”

There is no verb here in the Greek. If you translate this as a sentence, you should use a verb that refers to a young plant coming out of the ground. Here are some examples:

first it grows stalks/shoots

First the green blade appears (GW)

First a leaf blade pushes through (NLT)

the head: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as head refers to the beginning of the head of grain (4:28c). Use a proper expression for that meaning. Here are some examples:

the pod

the top

It may be more natural in your language to include the stalk upon which the head forms. For example:

the stalk and the head

4:28c

then grain that ripens within.

- then full heads of grain.
- then the mature grain in the head grows/appears.

grain that ripens within: The Greek word that the BSB translates as grain that ripens within refers to a fully-formed head of grain. At this point, the individual grains/kernels have grown. The wheat or grain is almost ready for harvest.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the head full of grain (GNT)

the full kernel in the head (NIV)

mature grain in the head

There is no verb in the Greek here. If you translate this phrase as a sentence, you should include a verb similar to the verb that the BSB translates as “produces” in 4:28a. For example:

and finally the grain ripens (NLT)

the kernels/seeds develop/mature

Mark 4:29

Section 4:26–29: Jesus told the parable of the sprouting seeds

This parable compares the kingdom of God to seeds. Seeds are planted, they sprout and grow and produce their own seeds (4:27–29a). The man who planted the seeds expects all this to happen but does not know how it happens (4:27c, 29b–c). In the same way, the followers of Jesus will grow in number and spiritual maturity, but people outside of the kingdom of God do not know how that happens. The identity of the man in the parable is not a part of the teaching of the parable. The man should not be compared to God in your translation.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the sprouting seeds

Jesus compared the kingdom of God to plants growing from seeds to harvest

There are no direct parallel passages for this section. Some similar terms are used in Matthew 13:24–30.

4:29a

And as soon as the grain is ripe,

- As soon as the grain/crop has ripened,
- When the grain is mature/ready,

And as soon as the grain is ripe: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as ripe indicates that the grain is ready for harvesting. The NJB says:

when the crop is ready

grain: The Greek word that the BSB translates as grain is singular in form but refers to many individual grain seeds. In some languages it may be more natural to use a plural form like “grain seeds” or a different noun like “crop” here.

4:29b

he swings the sickle,

- he starts cutting it with his sickle,
- the man/farmer reaps it,

he swings the sickle: The verb swings is an indirect way of referring to cutting the grain with the sickle. Some other ways of translating this expression are:

the man starts cutting it with his sickle (GNT)

he puts the sickle to it (NIV)

sickle: The word sickle refers to a curved cutting tool. It is used to cut many stalks (with the grain still on them) at one time.

If people in your area do not use a tool like a sickle to cut grain, you may want to:

- Use a term for a cutting tool that could be used in this way. For example:

knife

machete

- Translate this verse part without referring to the kind of tool used. Here are some examples:

he cuts it

he reaps/harvests it

4:29c

because the harvest has come.”

- because the harvest is ready.”
- because the time to harvest it has arrived.”

because the harvest has come: The word that the BSB translates as because introduces the reason why the man begins to use his sickle. He uses it because the crops are ready to harvest.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

because harvest time has come (GNT)

because this is the harvest time (NCV)

because the crops are ripe

General Comment on 4:29a–c

In some languages, it may be redundant to translate 4:29c as a separate clause. This is because the meaning of 4:29c may already be clear from 4:29a–b. If that is true in your language, you may combine the three parts of the verse. For example:

When it is ripe, he takes his sickle and begins to harvest it.

Then when harvest season comes and the grain is ripe, the farmer cuts it with a sickle. (CEV)

As soon as it is ripe, he goes and harvests it.

General Comment on 4:29b–c

In this verse, 4:29c expresses the reason for the result in 4:29b. In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of these clauses. For example:

^{29c}the harvest has come, ^{29b}so he puts the sickle to it

^{29c}the harvest has come, ^{29b}that is why he puts the sickle to it

Mark 4:30

Section 4:30–34: Jesus told the parable of a mustard seed

This parable compares the kingdom of God to a mustard seed. The parable illustrates how God's kingdom will grow from a very small beginning to a very large size.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable about a mustard seed

Jesus compared the kingdom of God to a tiny seed that grows into a big shrub/bush

The mustard seed parable/story/illustration

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:31–34 and Luke 13:18–19.

4:30a

Then He asked,

- ¶ He also said,
- ¶ Then Jesus said/asked,

Then He asked: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Then He asked is the same phrase as in 4:26a that the BSB translated as Jesus also said. As there,

this phrase indicates that Jesus was beginning a new topic.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

He continued, saying

He also said

Then Jesus said (NCV)

Because Jesus asked a rhetorical question, it is also possible to translate this as the NLT96 has done:

Jesus asked

4:30b

“To what can we compare the kingdom of God?”

- “Is there something we^(incl) can compare the kingdom of God to?
- “Here’s what we^(incl) can compare God’s rule over his people to.

4:30c

With what parable shall we present it?

- Or is there a parable to describe it? Here is something to compare it to:
- Here is a story we^(incl) can use to illustrate what it is like.

4:30b–c

To what can we compare the kingdom of God? With what parable shall we present it?: These two questions are similar in meaning. The first question To what can we compare the kingdom of God? is asking about a comparison in a general way. The second question With what parable shall we present it? is asking specifically about a parable for comparison. Another way to translate these questions is:

What shall we say the kingdom of God is like?
What parable shall we use to describe it?

These are rhetorical questions. Jesus used them to introduce his teaching about the kingdom of God. They caused the listener to start thinking about what the kingdom of God is like. Jesus himself answered the rhetorical questions in 4:31–32. Translate these questions in a way which shows that Jesus was introducing a teaching about the kingdom of God. Some ways to translate this are:

- As a rhetorical question or questions. For example:

Is there something we^(incl) can compare the kingdom of God to, or a parable to describe it? Here is something to compare it to:

Shall we^(incl) find something to compare the kingdom of God to? Shall we find a parable to describe it? How about this comparison?

- As a statement. For example:

There is something we^(incl) can compare the kingdom of God to; we can use this parable to describe it.

Here's what we^(incl) can compare the kingdom of God to. Let me tell you^(plur) this parable.

- As a rhetorical question followed by a statement. For example:

To what shall we compare the kingdom of God?
Here is a parable we can use to describe it.

Use whichever form is most natural in your language to introduce a new teaching.

parable: Here Jesus used the word parable to describe the illustration about the mustard seed in 4:31–32. Use a word in your language that describes this illustration. See the notes on 4:2a and 4:10b.

Mark 4:31

Section 4:30–34: Jesus told the parable of a mustard seed

This parable compares the kingdom of God to a mustard seed. The parable illustrates how God's kingdom will grow from a very small beginning to a very large size.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable about a mustard seed

Jesus compared the kingdom of God to a tiny seed that grows into a big shrub/bush

The mustard seed parable/story/illustration

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:31–34 and Luke 13:18–19.

4:31

The BSB has reordered the clauses in the Greek text. For that reason, the Notes and Display for this verse use the CEV as the base text.

4:31a

It is like a mustard seed,

- The kingdom of God is like a mustard seed
- It is like the seed of the mustard plant/tree,

(CEV:) It is like what happens when a mustard seed:

This clause It is like what happens when a mustard seed is a type of comparison called a simile. It compares the kingdom of God to what happens when a mustard seed is planted in the ground. The Jewish people considered the mustard seed to be a symbol of smallness. However, the mustard plant grew to be a tree as large as three meters (ten feet) high.

The point of similarity in this comparison is the contrast in size. The mustard seed is small but the mature plant is large. Like the mustard plant, the kingdom of God is very small at its beginning, but it becomes very large.

Here is another way to translate It is like what happens when a mustard seed:

It is like a tiny grain of mustard-seed which... (JBP)

mustard seed: If people in your language group do not know about mustard seeds or plants, here are some ways to translate mustard seed:

- Use a loan word along with a general term if necessary. For example:

a seed of the plant/tree called mustard

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

a very tiny seed If you use this option, you may want to combine the information with 4:31a–b to avoid saying the same thing twice. For example:

The kingdom of heaven is like the smallest of all the seeds on the earth.

- Use the name of a local seed that is known to be very small, but grows into a tree. If you use this option, you may want to indicate the literal name

in a footnote. For example, you could say in the footnote:

The Greek text is literally “a mustard seed.”

Regardless of the way you translate mustard seed, it is suggested that you add a footnote that explains the significance of mustard seed in the Jewish culture. For example:

For the Jews, the mustard seed was a symbol of something that was very small. But the mustard seed that was planted in the country of the Jews grew into a tree that was three meters high.

4:31b

which is the smallest of all seeds sown upon the earth.

- that someone plants in the ground. A mustard seed is the smallest seed in the world.
- which is smaller than all of the seeds of the earth. When you^(plur) plant it in the ground,

(CEV:) is planted in the ground: The Greek verb that the CEV translates as is planted is passive. In some languages you may need to use an active verb and supply a general subject. For example:

you plant in the ground (NCV)

A man...plants it in the ground. (GNT)

(CEV:) It is the smallest seed in all the world: The Greek phrase that the CEV translates as It is the smallest seed in the world is literally: “being smaller than all of the seeds of the earth.” This expression is a hyperbole. It exaggerates the smallness of the seed. This helps teach the point that the kingdom of God started with only a few people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the smallest of all the seeds on earth (RSV)

one of the smallest seeds on earth (GW)

the smallest of all seeds (NLT)

Mark 4:32

Section 4:30–34: Jesus told the parable of a mustard seed

This parable compares the kingdom of God to a mustard seed. The parable illustrates how God’s kingdom will grow from a very small beginning to a very large size.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable about a mustard seed

Jesus compared the kingdom of God to a tiny seed that grows into a big shrub/bush

The mustard seed parable/story/illustration

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:31–34 and Luke 13:18–19.

4:32a

But after it is planted, it grows to be the largest of all garden plants

- But when he plants it, it grows and becomes the largest of all garden plants.
- it grows and becomes the largest plant in the garden,

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces a contrast with what one expects. The mustard seed is the smallest seed, but it becomes the largest plant. Introduce this contrast in a way that is most natural in your language.

after it is planted: The verb planted is passive. In this context, this clause refers generally to people planting mustard seeds. It may be more natural in your language to make this active and say who planted the seed. If that is true, you should use a general expression such as “we,” “you,” or “they.” For example:

when you^(plur) plant them

when we^(incl) plant one

garden plants: The Greek word that the BSB translates as garden plants refers to vegetable and herb plants. These plants do not have a trunk like a tree. They do not normally grow more than one meter high.

However, the mustard plant can grow as high as three meters. It was the largest plant that the Jews planted in their gardens. Use a term for garden plants that is natural in your language. For example:

the tallest of all vegetables

General Comment on 4:31a–32a

The verb “is planted” occurs in both 4:31b and 4:32a. In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the information in 4:31. If you put the verb “is planted” near the end of 4:31b, you may not need to repeat it in 4:32a. For example, the GNT says:

^{31a}It is like this. A man takes a mustard seed, ^{31b}the smallest seed in the world, and plants it in the ground. ^{32a}After a while it grows up...

4:32b

and puts forth great branches,

- and its branches become long/large,
- It grows such large branches (GW)

and puts forth great branches: Here is another way to say puts forth great branches:

It grows such large branches (GW)

In some languages the idea of a plant growing branches may be expressed by using a verb. For example:

It branches long/large branches

Use an expression that is natural in your language.

4:32c

so that the birds of the air nest in its shade.”

- so that it is possible for birds to make their nests in its shade.”
- that birds can nest in the branches that are in the shade.”

the birds of the air: The phrase birds of the air is the Jewish way of referring to wild birds that can fly. In some languages it may be natural to translate this simply as:

birds

nest: There are two interpretations for the Greek word that the BSB translates as nest:

1. It refers to making a place to live. Birds make nests. The RSV has:

can make nests (RSV, GNT, NCV, CEV, GW, NLT)

1. It refers to finding a temporary place to rest. For example, the REB says:

can roost (NIV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

in its shade: The phrase that the BSB translates as in its shade probably refers to lower branches that were shaded by higher branches. It should not imply that the birds made nests on the ground.

Here are some other ways to translate this whole phrase:

birds can nest in its shaded branches

birds can make nests in its branches that are under/in the shade

Mark 4:33

Section 4:30–34: Jesus told the parable of a mustard seed

This parable compares the kingdom of God to a mustard seed. The parable illustrates how God’s kingdom will grow from a very small beginning to a very large size.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable about a mustard seed

Jesus compared the kingdom of God to a tiny seed that grows into a big shrub/bush

The mustard seed parable/story/illustration

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:31–34 and Luke 13:18–19.

4:33a

With many such parables Jesus spoke the word to them,

- ¶ Many parables like that one are what Jesus used when he spoke/taught the word of God to the people,
- ¶ Jesus spoke/taught God's message to the crowds with/using many similar parables,

With many such parables Jesus spoke the word to them: The phrase With many such parables is emphasized in the Greek by being first in the clause. English can emphasize phrases in the same way, so the BSB put this phrase first. If you have a natural way to emphasize this phrase, you may want to do so.

parables: The Greek word that the BSB translates as parables is literally “comparisons.” Parables teach a lesson or truth by showing how it is like something that people already know about. In this chapter Jesus used several types of parables, including a symbolic story, metaphors, and wise sayings.

Here are some ways to translate parables in this context:

- Use a general term in your language that can be used to describe the different types of parables in this chapter. Some English examples are:

illustrations

metaphors

- Use a descriptive term. For example:

symbolic sayings/words/stories

- Use more than one word or descriptive term for the different types of parables that Jesus used. For example:

such stories and illustrations (NLT96)

symbols and sayings

See also parable, Type 2, in the Glossary.

the word: The phrase the word refers to “the word of God” or “God’s message.” This same phrase occurs in 4:14. Translate it here in the same way as you did there.

them: The word them refers here to the crowds who listened to Jesus. It does not refer only to the disciples. You may want to make that clear in your translation. For example:

the people (GNT)

the crowd (NCV)

4:33b

to the extent that they could understand.

- as much as they could accept/understand.
- as long as they were willing to listen to them.
- He spoke as many parables as they could pay attention to.

to the extent that they could understand: The Greek word that the BSB translates as understand is literally “hear,” as in the RSV. In this context, the word “hear” is used figuratively to mean “receive” or “understand.” The people were certainly capable of literally hearing what Jesus said. These figurative meanings do not conflict with the statement in 4:34b that Jesus later explained everything to his disciples. Most scholars mention that there were differing degrees of understanding. Jesus continued to teach people as long as they were willing to listen and had at least a limited understanding of what he was trying to say. Later, he explained the meaning of the parables in greater depth to his disciples.

This figurative meaning may be expressed in different ways. For example:

so far as they were able to receive it (REB)

so far as they were capable of understanding it (NJB)

as long as they were willing to listen

Mark 4:34

Section 4:30–34: Jesus told the parable of a mustard seed

This parable compares the kingdom of God to a mustard seed. The parable illustrates how God’s kingdom will grow from a very small beginning to a very large size.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable about a mustard seed

Jesus compared the kingdom of God to a tiny seed that grows into a big shrub/bush

The mustard seed parable/story/illustration

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:31–34 and Luke 13:18–19.

4:34a

He did not tell them anything without using a parable.

- He always used parables when he taught them.
- In fact, in his public teaching he taught only with parables, (NLT96)

He did not tell them anything without using a parable: This clause refers only to the times when Jesus was teaching the crowds.

There are two negative words here: not and without. It may be more natural in your language to use positive words.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Whenever he spoke to them about God, he used parables.

He taught the crowds using only parables.

In fact, in his public teaching he taught only with parables (NLT96)

parable: In this context the word parable is used in a general way to describe any of the types of wise speech that Jesus used in this chapter. See the note on 4:33a, and translate in a similar way here.

4:34b

But privately He explained everything to His own disciples.

- But when he and his disciples were alone by themselves, he explained every parable to them.
- but privately he explained everything to his followers.

But privately He explained everything to His own disciples: The words privately...to His own disciples indicates that the crowds had left and only Jesus and his disciples were present. For example:

when they were by themselves (NJB)

privately to his own disciples (RSV)

everything: In this context, the word everything refers to all the parables. It may be more natural in your language to refer in a different way to all the parables. For example:

all of them

every parable

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means “learners” who are in a relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Some ways to translate disciples are:

- Use a term that refers to people who learn from a teacher or an expert. It is helpful if the term also implies that the learners are often with their teacher. For example:

learners/students

apprentices Be careful not to use a term that would refer only to a student in a school or classroom.

- Use a term that refers to people who follow a teacher or leader by obeying his teaching. It is helpful if this term also implies learning from the teacher and actually following the teacher wherever he goes. For example:

followers

those who are committed/faithful (to a teacher/leader)

See how you translated this term at 3:9. See also disciple in the Glossary.

Mark 4:35

Section 4:35–41: Jesus commanded a storm to stop and it obeyed him

While Jesus and his disciples were going across Lake Galilee in a boat, a strong wind began to blow. The wind caused big waves on the lake. The waves were big enough to come into the boat. The boat was about to sink, but Jesus spoke to the waves and because Jesus

had the authority to command them to stop, the wind and the waves stopped.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus calmed a storm on the lake

Jesus stopped the wind and waves

A storm obeys Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:23–27 and Luke 8:22–25.

4:35a

When that evening came, He said to His disciples,

- ¶ That day when the sun was going down, he said to his disciples,
- ¶ That evening, Jesus said to his followers,
- ¶ In the evening of that day, Jesus told his disciples

When that evening came: The phrase that evening refers to the same day as the events in the previous section. The word evening refers to sundown or perhaps an hour or two before or after sundown. Your language may use a different verb than came or no verb at all. For example:

When the sun was going down

In the evening of that day

That evening (GW)

4:35b

“Let us cross to the other side.”

- “Let us^(incl) go to the other side of the lake.”
- “Come, we^(incl) will sail across the lake.”
- to sail with him to the other side of the lake.

Let us cross: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Let us cross is a command in the first person plural. Jesus was urging his disciples to cross the lake with him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Come, let’s go over

We should go over

cross to the other side: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as cross to the other side here refers to going in a boat to the other side of Lake Galilee. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as:

cross the lake

sail across the lake

Mark 4:36

Section 4:35–41: Jesus commanded a storm to stop and it obeyed him

While Jesus and his disciples were going across Lake Galilee in a boat, a strong wind began to blow. The wind caused big waves on the lake. The waves were big enough to come into the boat. The boat was about to sink, but Jesus spoke to the waves and because Jesus had the authority to command them to stop, the wind and the waves stopped.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus calmed a storm on the lake

Jesus stopped the wind and waves

A storm obeys Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:23–27 and Luke 8:22–25.

4:36a

After they had dismissed the crowd,

- Leaving the crowd,
- So they left the crowd,

In Greek, 4:36a begins with the common conjunction that is often translated as “And” (as in the RSV). The BSB and some other English versions do not translate this conjunction here.

Luke used this conjunction to connect the command Jesus gave in 4:35b to the response of the disciples in 4:36. One way to do this is to follow the GNT, which says:

So...

You should connect these verses in a way that is natural in your language.

After they had dismissed the crowd: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as After they had dismissed the crowd indicates that Jesus and his disciples went away together. They separated themselves from the other people there. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

So they left the crowd

4:36b

they took Jesus with them, since He was already in the boat.

- they got into the boat that Jesus was in and started across the lake together.
- and since Jesus was already sitting in the boat, the disciples got in it and began to cross the lake.

they took Jesus with them, since He was already in the boat: Jesus was already in a boat. So the disciples got into that same boat and began to row or sail it across the lake. The phrase took Jesus with them indicates that the disciples brought Jesus with them. The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as since He was already in the boat is literally “just as he was, in the boat.” It indicates that Jesus remained in the boat while the disciples got in. So Jesus did not go ashore or make any preparations to leave.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

they took Jesus as he was and began to cross the lake in the boat

the disciples got into the boat in which Jesus was already sitting, and they took him with them (GNT)

He was already in the boat, so they started out (NLT96)

4:36c

And there were other boats with Him.

- People in other boats also accompanied him/them.
- Other people also got into boats and began to cross the lake with him/them.

And there were other boats with Him: It is implied that there were other people in these boats. It may be

more natural in your language to mention the other people. For example:

Other people took other boats and accompanied him.

Other people also took boats and began to cross the lake with him.

with Him: Because the disciples were also in the boat with Jesus, it may be more natural in some languages to use the plural pronoun “them” rather than Him. For example:

There were also other boats that went with them.

Mark 4:37

Section 4:35–41: Jesus commanded a storm to stop and it obeyed him

While Jesus and his disciples were going across Lake Galilee in a boat, a strong wind began to blow. The wind caused big waves on the lake. The waves were big enough to come into the boat. The boat was about to sink, but Jesus spoke to the waves and because Jesus had the authority to command them to stop, the wind and the waves stopped.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus calmed a storm on the lake

Jesus stopped the wind and waves

A storm obeys Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:23–27 and Luke 8:22–25.

4:37–38a

Jesus began sleeping before the windstorm came. See the General Comment on 4:37–38a at the end of 4:38a for a possible way to reorder the verse parts.

4:37a

Soon a violent windstorm came up,

- A strong/swift wind suddenly arrived,
- A great windstorm began to blow,

Soon a violent windstorm came up: The words violent windstorm refer to a sudden and strong wind or storm. The phrase came up refers to the wind blowing.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Suddenly a windstorm struck the lake. (CEV)

A strong/swift wind suddenly arrived

4:37b

and the waves were breaking over the boat,

- and the waves came over the sides and into the boat,
- which caused big waves, and they/water poured/splashed into the boat

and the waves were breaking over the boat: The strong wind caused waves to form on the sea, that is, the Sea of Galilee. In some languages it may be necessary to make it explicit that the wind caused the waves. For example:

which caused big waves and the waves broke over the boat

waves: The word waves refers to water moving on the surface of a lake or sea. Wind often causes waves on lakes.

were breaking over: The words were breaking over are an English idiom. These words indicate that the waves were higher than the sides of the boat, so water came into the boat. This does not mean that the waves were “breaking” the boat.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

The waves came over the sides and into the boat (NCV)

Water started splashing into the boat

the waves began to spill over into the boat (GNT)

4:37c

so that it was being swamped.

- so that it was quickly filling with water.
- until it was about to sink.

so that: The phrase so that indicates that 4:37c is a result of 4:37b. Here are some other ways to express this result:

with the result that

and so

Express this result in a way that is natural in your language.

it was being swamped: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as being swamped indicates that water was already filling the boat. This meant that the boat was about to sink. For example:

it was about to sink (CEV)

it was nearly full of water (NLT96)

General Comment on 4:37b–c

Here are some other ways to connect 4:37b–c:

High waves began to break into the boat until it was nearly full of water. (NLT96)

Waves started splashing into the boat, and it was about to sink. (CEV)

Mark 4:38

Section 4:35–41: Jesus commanded a storm to stop and it obeyed him

While Jesus and his disciples were going across Lake Galilee in a boat, a strong wind began to blow. The wind caused big waves on the lake. The waves were big enough to come into the boat. The boat was about to sink, but Jesus spoke to the waves and because Jesus had the authority to command them to stop, the wind and the waves stopped.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus calmed a storm on the lake

Jesus stopped the wind and waves

A storm obeys Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:23–27 and Luke 8:22–25.

4:38a**But Jesus was in the stern, sleeping on the cushion.**

- But Jesus was asleep in the back of the boat with his head on a seat cushion.
- Meanwhile, Jesus was in the back/tail of the boat. He was sleeping with his head on a pillow.

4:38a-b

But Jesus was in the stern: The Greek word that the BSB translates as stern is a technical term. It refers to the back end of a boat. For example, the GNT says:

Jesus was in the back of the boat

Languages have different ways to refer to the stern of a boat. For example:

foot

tail

Use a word that is natural in your language. Be careful not to use an expression that implies that Jesus was behind the boat.

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But is a common conjunction that connects 4:38a to 4:37. It is often translated as “and.” In this context, there is some contrast (contra expectation) between what Jesus was doing (sleeping) and what we expected him to be doing (something other than sleeping such as helping the disciples). Because of this, the BSB and others versions such as the RSV and NJB translate this conjunction as But. However, other versions, such as the NIV, do not translate this conjunction at all. Connect these verse parts in a way that is natural in your language.

sleeping on the cushion: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as sleeping on the cushion means that Jesus was sleeping and his head was on a cushion/pillow. In some languages it may be natural to make that explicit. For example, the GNT says:

sleeping with his head on a pillow

General Comment on 4:37–38a

Jesus began sleeping before the wind storm came. It may be more natural in your language to use “began sleeping” rather than “was sleeping” in this context. If that is true, you may want to mention this event before 4:37. For example:

^{38a}Jesus began to sleep with his head on a cushion in the back of the boat. ^{37a}A furious squall came up, ^{37b}and the waves broke over the boat, so that it was nearly swamped.

Jesus continued sleeping during the wind storm and waves. Your translation should clearly indicate that Jesus continued sleeping.

4:38b**So they woke Him and said,**

- His disciples woke him and said,
- The disciples woke him up, shouting, (NLT)

So they woke Him and said: The Greek text does not specify how the disciples woke Jesus. They probably woke him by speaking to him. In this case the disciples were afraid, so they probably shouted the words in 4:38c. The NLT says:

The disciples woke him up, shouting

Translate this clause in a way that naturally expresses the drama and emotion of the context.

4:38c**“Teacher, don’t You care that we are perishing?”**

- “Teacher, we^(incl) are about to drown. Don’t you^(sing) care?”
- “Sir Teacher, the boat is about to sink and we^(incl) will drown. Don’t you^(sing) care?”
- “Sir/Master, you^(sing) act like it is not important to you^(sing) that we^(incl) are about to die in the water. Do^(sing) something!”

Teacher, don’t You care that we are perishing?: This is a rhetorical question. It is really a plea for Jesus to help them. It may also be a rebuke. Translate this sentence in a way which shows that the disciples wanted Jesus to help them and save them from potentially drowning. They were also possibly rebuking him because he had not already helped them.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the CEV says:

Teacher, don’t you care that we’re about to drown?

- As a statement. For example:

Teacher, you act like you do not care that we are about to drown. Please do something!

Teacher, we are about to drown and you do not seem to care! Help us!

Teacher: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Teacher was a polite title for a Jewish religious leader. It was a title of respect for a Jewish man who had authority to teach the things about God. In some languages the appropriate way to address a religious teacher may be:

Sir Teacher

Sir

Master

Be careful not to use a term that can refer only to a school teacher.

we are perishing: If your language has exclusive and inclusive pronouns, you will need to decide which pronoun to use here. Each pronoun implies different things:

1. The pronoun *we*^(incl) implies that the disciples were afraid that both they and Jesus would drown. It also implies that Jesus did not care if he and they all drowned.
2. The word *we*^(excl) implies that the disciples were afraid that they, but not Jesus, would drown. It also implies that Jesus did not care if the disciples drowned but he would probably save himself from drowning.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The disciples probably thought that everyone in the boat was in equal danger of drowning. They would not have expected Jesus to save himself but let them (the disciples) drown. The UBS (page 153) says that “we” refers to the disciples. The TRT (page 56) suggests that *we*^(excl) is more likely in view of Mt. 8:25 (the same story). However, both the UBS for Luke (page 342) and Translator’s Guide for Luke (page 136) recommend *we*^(incl). The disciples may have been concerned primarily for their own welfare, but it is unlikely that they would have expected Jesus to selfishly save only himself. Philippine language versions on TW use inclusive.

perishing: The Greek word that the BSB translates as perishing refers to dying because of not being able to breathe under water. The NIV translates this word as “drown.” In some languages it may be natural to translate it simply as:

die

Mark 4:39

Section 4:35–41: Jesus commanded a storm to stop and it obeyed him

While Jesus and his disciples were going across Lake Galilee in a boat, a strong wind began to blow. The wind caused big waves on the lake. The waves were big enough to come into the boat. The boat was about to sink, but Jesus spoke to the waves and because Jesus had the authority to command them to stop, the wind and the waves stopped.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus calmed a storm on the lake

Jesus stopped the wind and waves

A storm obeys Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:23–27 and Luke 8:22–25.

4:39a

Then Jesus got up and rebuked the wind and the sea. “Silence!” He commanded. “Be still!”

- Having been awakened, Jesus ordered the wind to stop blowing and told the waves, “Be^(plur) silent! Stop!”
- Then/So he stood/got up and commanded the wind and waves to be quiet and still.

Then Jesus got up: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as got up is literally “having been awoken.” This verb is passive. It means “having been awakened by the disciples.”

Some languages use repetition to connect events in a story. If this is true in your language, you may want to repeat from 4:38b the fact that the disciples had awakened Jesus. For example:

Being awake now

Having been awakened by the disciples

In other languages it may not be natural to repeat here a form of the verb wake. If that is true in your language, you may:

- Use a different word that is related to the action of waking up. For example:

Then he got up (GW)

Jesus stood up (GNT)

- Leave this phrase untranslated, since it is implied from 4:38b. Connect 4:38c directly to the phrase “rebuked the wind.” For example:

Then/So he rebuked the wind

rebuked the wind and the sea: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as rebuked the wind and the sea here literally says “he rebuked the wind and said to the sea” (see the NIV11). It means means that Jesus sternly commanded the wind to stop blowing. For example, the GW says:

ordered the wind to stop

the sea: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as sea refers to the water of Lake Galilee, which was tossing about in waves. You should refer to the water in whatever way is most natural in your language.

“Silence!”...“Be still!”: The Greek verbs that the BSB translates as Silence! and Be still! have similar meanings here. They are both commands for the water/waves to stop making sounds and stop moving violently. Jesus used the two verbs together for emphasis. In some language it may be natural to express this emphasis in a different way. For example:

Be silent right now!

Be still, absolutely still! (GW)

In some languages, it will be more natural to translate this as indirect speech. For example:

Jesus told the waves to be quiet and still.

The BSB places the phrase He commanded in the middle of Jesus’ rebuke to the wind and water/waves. This is good English style, but there is no such verb in

the Greek. In some languages, it may be helpful to translate as the NIV11 does:

Quiet! Be still!

General Comment on 4:39a

In the Greek text, Mark describes Jesus as rebuking the wind and then speaking directly to the waves (see NIV11). These were probably not two separate and different things that Jesus did. In some languages it may be natural to combine them, as in the BSB. For example:

ordered the wind and the waves to be quiet (CEV)

commanded the wind and the waves, “Quiet! Be still!”

In other languages it may be more natural to use one command for the wind and another command for the waves. For example:

He commanded the wind, saying, “Stop.” He also said to the waves, “Be calm/quiet.”

General Comment on 4:39a

Jesus spoke directly to the wind and the waves, like speaking to a person. In the context of this miracle, it may be natural in your language for someone to speak directly to the wind and the waves. But if speaking directly to the wind and the waves is not natural in your language, you may want to use indirect commands. For example:

He got up and commanded, “May the wind and waves be quiet and stop making noise!”

4:39b

And the wind died down, and it was perfectly calm.

- Then the wind ceased and everything calmed/quieted.
- Then the wind stopped blowing, and there was a great calm over the lake.

And the wind died down: The Greek word that the BSB translates as died down here means “stopped blowing.” The BSB has used an English idiom. The RSV has:

the wind ceased

and it was perfectly calm: The clause that the BSB translates as it was perfectly calm refers to the entire situation. Both the wind and the waves/lake became calm or still. The wind stopped blowing and the lake became smooth and quiet.

In the BSB the word calm is an adjective. In some languages it may be natural to translate it as a noun, as in the Greek. For example, the GNT says:

there was a great calm

In other languages it may be natural to translate it as a verb:

it completely calmed down

everything calmed down

perfectly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as perfectly is literally “great.” Before there was a “great wind” (4:37a) and now there was “great calm.” You may be able to use the same word (such as “great”) in both places to show the contrast. But if the same word does not fit naturally in both places, you may indicate the emphasis in a different way, as the BSB has done.

Mark 4:40

Section 4:35–41: Jesus commanded a storm to stop and it obeyed him

While Jesus and his disciples were going across Lake Galilee in a boat, a strong wind began to blow. The wind caused big waves on the lake. The waves were big enough to come into the boat. The boat was about to sink, but Jesus spoke to the waves and because Jesus had the authority to command them to stop, the wind and the waves stopped.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus calmed a storm on the lake

Jesus stopped the wind and waves

A storm obeys Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:23–27 and Luke 8:22–25.

4:40a

“Why are you so afraid?” He asked.

- Then he said to his disciples, “Why/How is it that you^(plur) are so timid/afraid?”
- Then Jesus said to his followers, “Do not be^(plur) cowardly.

“Why are you so afraid?”: This is a rhetorical question. It functions as a rebuke. Jesus was saying that his disciples should not have been so afraid. Translate this sentence in a way that indicates a rebuke.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

How is it that you are so cowardly?

- As a statement or a command. For example:

Do not be afraid!

You should not be so timid!

afraid: The Greek word that the BSB translates as afraid can also be translated as:

cowardly (NET)

timid

4:40b

“Do you still have no faith?”

- Do you^(plur) not yet have faith?”
- Do you^(plur) still not trust me?”
- By this time you^(plur) should trust me!”

“Do you still have no faith?”: The Greek words that the BSB translates as Do you still have no faith? say literally, “Do you still not have faith?” This is a rhetorical question. It is really an expression of surprise and rebuke. Jesus was saying that the disciples should have had faith in him by that time. Translate this sentence in a way which indicates a rebuke. Some ways to translate are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the NET says:

Do you still not have faith?

- As a statement. For example:

Surely you are not still without faith!

By now you should have had faith!

still have no faith: The word faith often means to trust someone, to rely on someone, to believe in someone. In this context the expression still have no faith indicates that the disciples did not yet have a specific type of faith. The text does not make the details explicit. However, the context implies that they did not yet believe that Jesus had the authority and power from God to protect them in every situation. In some languages it may be necessary to translate faith as a verb and make some information explicit. For example:

still do not trust me

do not yet believe that I will take care of you

See also believe, meaning 3, in the Glossary.

Mark 4:41

Section 4:35–41: Jesus commanded a storm to stop and it obeyed him

While Jesus and his disciples were going across Lake Galilee in a boat, a strong wind began to blow. The wind caused big waves on the lake. The waves were big enough to come into the boat. The boat was about to sink, but Jesus spoke to the waves and because Jesus had the authority to command them to stop, the wind and the waves stopped.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus calmed a storm on the lake

Jesus stopped the wind and waves

A storm obeys Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:23–27 and Luke 8:22–25.

4:41a

Overwhelmed with fear, they asked one another,

- They were filled with amazement and fear and asked each other,
- They were greatly amazed and fearful and said among themselves,

Overwhelmed with fear: The Greek words that the BSB translates as Overwhelmed with fear is literally “they feared with great fear.” The verb “feared” and the noun “fear” can mean both “afraid” and “wonder, amazement.” Probably both meanings are indicated here. If possible use an expression that includes these meanings. For example:

They were filled with fear and amazement

They were greatly afraid and amazed

They were astounded

asked: The first sentence in 4:41b is a question, but the second sentence is a statement. You will need to decide whether it is more natural in your language to use the verb “said” or “asked” here.

4:41b

“Who is this, that even the wind and the sea obey Him?”

- “What kind of man/person is this? Even the wind and waves/water obey him.”
- “Even the wind and the waves obey him, so where did this man get such authority?”

The Greek text of 4:41b includes a word that is translated in different ways by English versions. The BSB leaves this word implied. Some English versions have translated it as “then.” For example, the NET says:

Who then is this?

In this context the word “then” implies a conclusion that people make because of certain evidence. The disciples realized that Jesus had showed amazing authority. They were asking what that evidence showed about who he was.

Who is this, that even the wind and the sea obey Him?: In the Greek, 4:41b is one sentence in the form of a question. The NRSV follows the Greek structure and translates this literally as:

Who then is this, that even the wind and the sea obey him?

It may be natural in your language to follow the BSB and the NRSV and include the words even the wind and the sea obey Him in the question. However, if this would not be natural, you could follow the NIV and

other English versions that separate the words even the wind and the sea obey Him from the question:

Who is this? Even the wind and the waves obey him! (NIV)

Who then is this? Even the wind and sea obey him! (NET)

Translate this as one sentence or two, whichever is natural in your language.

Who is this: This is a rhetorical question. It strongly indicates surprise, fear, and amazement. The disciples were not asking for Jesus' name. Instead, they were wondering what kind of man Jesus was and how he could do such powerful miracles.

The Jews believed that only God controlled such things as wind and waves. So the disciples were asking who Jesus could be that he could do the same things God does. Translate this sentence in a way which indicates surprise and awe.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

What kind of man/person then is this?

- As an exclamatory statement. For example:

This man is amazing! No one but God can do what he has done!

that even the wind and the sea obey Him?: Usually the subject of the verb obey is a person or an animal. But here the subject is the wind and the sea. It may be more natural in your language to reword this clause to indicate that the wind and waves did as Jesus commanded. For example:

Even the wind and the sea do as he commands!

He commanded the wind and the sea to stop, and they stopped!

He controls even the wind and the sea!

sea: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as sea refers to the water of the Sea of Galilee. For this reason, the NIV translates this word as "waves." See how you translated this word in 4:39a.

General Comment on 4:41b

The clause even the wind and the sea obey him begins with the word "that" in the Greek text. The word "that" indicates that the clause even the wind and the sea obey him gives the reason for asking Who is this? It may be more natural in your language to have the reason clause first. For example:

Even the wind and the waves obey him, so who is this?

Mark 5:1

Section 5:1–20: Jesus freed a man whom many evil spirits controlled

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples arrived at the northeastern shore of Lake Galilee. This was a region where many Gentiles lived.

When Jesus and his disciples arrived, a man who was controlled by many evil spirits immediately came to Jesus. Jesus commanded the evil spirits to leave the man. When the evil spirits left, they went to control a large herd of pigs and destroyed those pigs.

"Uncleanness" is a theme in this story. The evil spirits that controlled the man were called "unclean" spirits. Tombs were "unclean." Jews also considered pigs to be "unclean." Jesus showed his power over evil spirits when he healed the man.

It is good if you translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus commanded many unclean spirits to leave a man

The deliverance of a man who was controlled by many unclean spirits

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:28–34 and Luke 8:26–39.

Paragraph 5:1–5

In this paragraph, the action in 5:1–2 is followed by some background information in 5:3–5. In some languages, it may be good to change the order of some of the information in these verses. See the suggestions in the General Comment on 5:2–6 at the end of 5:6b. The action of the story continues in 5:6.

5:1a

On the other side of the sea, they arrived

- ¶ Then Jesus and the disciples arrived at the other side of the lake
- ¶ Afterward they continued to cross Lake Galilee and arrived

5:1b in the region of the Gerasenes.

- at the region where the Gerasa people lived.
- at the area where people called the Gerasenes lived.

5:1a–b

This story happened immediately after the story about Jesus calming the storm on the lake at the end of Mark 4. The Greek text has a general connector here. You may want to begin this story in a way that shows the connection between the events. For example:

Then they went across...

Just after the storm, they went across...

On the other side of the sea, they arrived: Here Jesus and disciples continued the boat trip that they began in 4:36. They finished the remaining part of the trip and arrived at the other side of the lake. Your translation should indicate that they were continuing the trip, not that they were beginning it. For example:

They continued across the lake to the other side, where they arrived

They finished going to the other side of the lake and arrived

Jesus and his disciples arrived on the other side of Lake Galilee (GNT)

On the other side of the sea: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as On the other side of the sea is literally “to the other side of the lake.” They sailed from the northwest shore of the lake to the northeast shore. If your language requires or prefers that you indicate the direction of travel, indicate that they were sailing east.

the sea: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the sea refers to Lake Galilee. This is the same lake that was mentioned in many other passages, including 1:16a and 2:13. Refer to how you translated it there. Since the phrase the sea indicates a specific lake, in some languages you may need to give its name. For example:

Lake Galilee

they: The word they here refers to Jesus and his disciples. Refer to them at the beginning of this story in a natural way in your language.

the region of the Gerasenes: There is a textual issue in this verse: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have Gerasenes, people from the town of Gerasa (BSB, NIV, GNT, CEV, GW, JBP, NASB, NET, NCV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB). (2) Other Greek manuscripts have Gadarenes, people from the town of Gadara (KJV). (3) Other Greek manuscripts have Gergesenes, people from the town of Gergesa. It is recommended that you follow option (1). It has the support of some of the best manuscripts, and most English versions. However, commentaries are divided in which option they support. If the major language version in your area uses option (2) or (3), you may choose to follow it. Scholarly opinion is divided due to the geographical problem. Gerasa was more than 30 miles (55 kilometers) southeast of Lake Galilee, while Gadara was only about 6 miles southeast of the lake. The third variant, Gergesenes, may refer to the people from a small village on the northeast shore of the lake known today as Kersa or Kursi. (See the Jerusalem Perspective articles Gergesa: Site of the Demoniac’s Healing by Mendel Nun (no. 50, January/March 1996) and Gergesa, Gerasa, or Gadara? Where Did Jesus’ Miracle Occur? (no. 51, April/June 1996). For arguments in support of option (2), Gadara, see Consultant Notes for this passage in TW 4.) The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Gerasenes refers to people who lived in the city called Gerasa and the countryside around it. See the next note for discussion of a textual issue concerning this phrase. The Gerasenes were mostly non-Jewish people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

region/area of the Gerasa people

place where people called the Gerasenes lived

region of the city of Gerasa and around it

Mark 5:2

Section 5:1–20: Jesus freed a man whom many evil spirits controlled

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples arrived at the northeastern shore of Lake Galilee. This was a region where many Gentiles lived.

When Jesus and his disciples arrived, a man who was controlled by many evil spirits immediately came to Jesus. Jesus commanded the evil spirits to leave the man. When the evil spirits left, they went to control a large herd of pigs and destroyed those pigs.

“Uncleanness” is a theme in this story. The evil spirits that controlled the man were called “unclean” spirits. Tombs were “unclean.” Jews also considered pigs to be “unclean.” Jesus showed his power over evil spirits when he healed the man.

It is good if you translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus commanded many unclean spirits to leave a man

The deliverance of a man who was controlled by many unclean spirits

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:28–34 and Luke 8:26–39.

Paragraph 5:1–5

In this paragraph, the action in 5:1–2 is followed by some background information in 5:3–5. In some languages, it may be good to change the order of some of the information in these verses. See the suggestions in the General Comment on 5:2–6 at the end of 5:6b. The action of the story continues in 5:6.

5:2a

As soon as Jesus got out of the boat,

- When Jesus got out of the boat,
- Jesus and his disciples went/stepped out of the boat onto the shore.

As soon as Jesus got out of the boat: When Jesus got out of the boat, his disciples probably also got out of it. The author does not mention the disciples here, because Jesus is in focus. However, in some languages it may be confusing not to include the disciples. If that is true in your language, here are some ways to include them:

As soon as they got out of the boat

As soon as Jesus along with the disciples got out of the boat

As soon as Jesus and the disciples got out of the boat

Some languages may have a plural form that indicates a person and those with him. For example:

plural Jesus

Be alert for ways in your language to keep the focus on Jesus while still indicating that the disciples were also with him.

As soon as: In the Greek text, 5:2a begins with a word that indicates in this context that the man came as soon as Jesus arrived.

Here are some other ways to indicate this:

Just as Jesus was getting out of the boat (NET)

And when he had stepped out of the boat, immediately (NRSV)

When he was getting out of the boat, a man with an evil spirit quickly ran to him... (CEV)

5:2b–c

In some languages, it may be natural to combine the information in these verse parts with 5:3a. See the General Comment on 5:2b–3a at the end of 5:3a for an example of how to do this.

He was met by a man with an unclean spirit, who was coming from the tombs: This clause describes:

1. how a man met Jesus,
2. the problem the man had,
3. where he came from.

Consider what is a natural way in your language to introduce a new participant in a story. Also consider what is a natural order to give the details about him and what he does.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

There was a man there who had an evil spirit and lived among the tombs. He came immediately to meet Jesus.

immediately a man from the tombs with an unclean spirit met him (NRSV)

5:2b

He was met by a man with an unclean spirit,

- a man who was controlled by an evil spirit immediately met/confronted him,
- a man who was demon-possessed ran to Jesus

He was met by a man with an unclean spirit: While the BSB translates this clause as passive, it is active in Greek, and in some languages it may be more natural to translate it as active. For example, the NRSV says:

a man from the tombs with an unclean spirit met him

He was met by: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as met simply indicates that the man came to where Jesus was. The verb can be used for many contexts, including when people meet to oppose each other. The context implies that the unclean spirit in the man was hostile toward Jesus. Your translation should not imply that the man wanted to welcome Jesus or to greet him politely. It should also not imply that Jesus and the man had already decided to meet together. Some English versions simply say:

came to him (NCV)

came up to him (REB)

a man with an unclean spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as with an unclean spirit indicates that an unclean spirit controlled the man's thoughts and actions.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

controlled by an evil spirit (GW)

possessed by an evil spirit (NLT)

on whom an unclean spirit had fastened

on whom an unclean spirit was riding

Use an expression that is natural in your language to refer to an unclean spirit controlling a person. Refer to how you translated this same phrase in 1:23a. See also evil spirit in the Glossary for more information.

unclean spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as unclean spirit refers to a spirit that is evil and can control people's actions. The phrase unclean spirit refers to the same type of spirit as the Greek terms that are often translated as "demon" and "evil spirit."

Here are some other ways to translate unclean spirit:

- Use a general term in your language that refers to spirits that are evil and can control people. If there is one word with this meaning, you may not need a separate word such as "unclean." For example:

demon

- Use a specific term in your language that refers to a certain type of spirit. This spirit should be able to do what is described in this context. Do not use a term that refers to the spirit of a dead person.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

an evil/bad spirit

an impure spirit (NIV11) If you translate this as "unclean spirit" as the BSB does, be sure that your translation does not imply that the spirit was literally dirty.

Refer to how you translated this term in 1:23a. See also evil spirit in the Glossary for more information.

5:2c

who was coming from the tombs.

- after coming out from the tombs.
- from a nearby cave where dead bodies were placed/kept.

from the tombs: The man came to them from a place where there were tombs. This place was probably near the lake. Be sure that your translation does not imply that the man was a ghost.

The tombs were caves or small rooms that were cut out of a rock hillside. The people placed dead bodies in the tombs. Your translation should not imply that the man came up out of a grave that was dug down into the ground. It may be helpful to say something like:

out of caves where dead bodies were put

from the cemetery

Consider using a footnote to explain the burial practices of the Jews and other peoples who lived nearby. Here is an example of a possible footnote:

It was customary for Jews and nearby peoples to put the dead in natural caves or caves that were cut into rock hillsides.

Mark 5:3

Section 5:1–20: Jesus freed a man whom many evil spirits controlled

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples arrived at the northeastern shore of Lake Galilee. This was a region where many Gentiles lived.

When Jesus and his disciples arrived, a man who was controlled by many evil spirits immediately came to Jesus. Jesus commanded the evil spirits to leave the man. When the evil spirits left, they went to control a large herd of pigs and destroyed those pigs.

“Uncleanness” is a theme in this story. The evil spirits that controlled the man were called “unclean” spirits. Tombs were “unclean.” Jews also considered pigs to be “unclean.” Jesus showed his power over evil spirits when he healed the man.

It is good if you translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus commanded many unclean spirits to leave a man

The deliverance of a man who was controlled by many unclean spirits

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:28–34 and Luke 8:26–39.

Paragraph 5:1–5

In this paragraph, the action in 5:1–2 is followed by some background information in 5:3–5. In some languages, it may be good to change the order of some of the information in these verses. See the suggestions in the General Comment on 5:2–6 at the end of 5:6b. The action of the story continues in 5:6.

5:3–5

In 5:3–5, Mark gave background information. He gave more details about the man with the unclean spirit. Use a natural way in your language to indicate that 5:3–5 is background information.

Some of the information (especially 5:4) describes events that happened before the man came to Jesus. If you need to talk about these events in a different order in your language, the General Comment on 5:2–6 at the end of 5:6b gives a suggestion.

5:3a

This man had been living in the tombs

- This man was living in the tombs,
- As for this man, he had been using such burial caves for shelter.

This man had been living in the tombs: As mentioned in the notes on 5:2c, the tombs here were probably caves. The man probably lived right in these caves.

In some languages it is not natural to say that someone lived in the place where dead people are buried or their bones are kept. If that is true in your language, you may need to say that the man lived at that general place. For example:

among the tombs (ESV)

at the cemetery

at a place where dead bodies are put

See also the notes on “from the tombs” and “tombs” in 5:2c and the suggested footnote.

General Comment on 5:2b–3a

In 5:3a the author explained that the man was actually living in the tombs that are mentioned in 5:2c. So in some languages it may be natural to combine 5:2b–c with 5:3a. For example:

^{2b–3a} A man with an evil spirit who lived in the tombs immediately came out and met him.

5:3b

and could no longer be restrained, even with chains.

- and no one was able any longer to bind him. Even chains could not restrain him.
- People could not keep him tied any longer, not even with something as strong as a metal chain.

and could no longer be restrained, even with chains: This phrase indicates that no one could keep the man bound or chained. After anyone bound or chained him, he would free himself, as 5:4 describes.

The clause in 5:3b uses several negatives to emphasize that no one could keep the man bound. Use an emphatic expression in your language that emphasizes that it was impossible to successfully bind him. For example:

There was no way that people could restrain him at all any more, not even by chaining him!

Nobody could keep him tied with chains any more (GNT)

could no longer be restrained: While the BSB translates this clause as passive, it is active in Greek, and in some languages it may be more natural to translate it as active. For example, the NRSV says:

no one could restrain him any more

Mark 5:4

Section 5:1–20: Jesus freed a man whom many evil spirits controlled

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples arrived at the northeastern shore of Lake Galilee. This was a region where many Gentiles lived.

When Jesus and his disciples arrived, a man who was controlled by many evil spirits immediately came to Jesus. Jesus commanded the evil spirits to leave the man. When the evil spirits left, they went to control a large herd of pigs and destroyed those pigs.

“Uncleanness” is a theme in this story. The evil spirits that controlled the man were called “unclean” spirits. Tombs were “unclean.” Jews also considered pigs to be “unclean.” Jesus showed his power over evil spirits when he healed the man.

It is good if you translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus commanded many unclean spirits to leave a man

The deliverance of a man who was controlled by many unclean spirits

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:28–34 and Luke 8:26–39.

Paragraph 5:1–5

In this paragraph, the action in 5:1–2 is followed by some background information in 5:3–5. In some languages, it may be good to change the order of some of the information in these verses. See the suggestions in the General Comment on 5:2–6 at the end of 5:6b. The action of the story continues in 5:6.

5:4a

Though he was often bound with chains and shackles,

- For he had often been bound for a time with shackles on his feet and with chains on his hands,
- In the past they had tried many times to restrain him by binding his arms and feet with chains,

There is a Greek word at the start of 5:4a that indicates that the information in 5:4a explains the statement in 5:3b. Connect 5:4 to 5:3b in a way that is natural for explanations in your language. For example, the ESV says:

for he had often been bound with shackles and chains

Though: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Though is a simple connector that is often translated as “and.” In this context, the word shows a contrast between what 5:4a describes and what 5:4b describes. People wanted and expected the man to remain bound, but instead he broke the chains. In some languages it may be natural to translate the word as but and put it at the start of 5:4b in order to show the contrast. Connect 5:4a to 5:4b in a way that is natural in your language.

he was often bound with chains and shackles: This clause is passive. In some languages it may be more natural to make it active and supply a general subject such as “people.” For example, the NCV says:

Many times people had used chains to tie the man’s hands and feet

bound with chains and shackles: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as bound with chains and shackles is literally “with foot-shackles/irons and chains had been bound.” “Foot-shackles” or “irons” were metal objects that were placed around a person’s ankles to restrain his feet. In this context, “chains” refers to metal chains that were placed on a person’s wrists to restrain his arms.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

bound with fetters and chains (RSV)

bound/fettered his feet and chained his wrists

bound/tied his arms and feet with chains

5:4b

he had broken the chains and shattered the shackles.

- and he tore apart the chains and broke the shackles.
- but he snapped/broke the chains.

he had broken the chains and shattered the shackles:

This clause indicates that the man broke apart the chains on his hands and smashed the metal objects on his ankles. Use a vivid and clear way to describe these violent actions. If you use only one word for “chains” on hands and feet in 5:4a, you may need only one verb to describe breaking them here. For example, the NCV says:

^{4a}Many times people had used chains to tie the man’s hands and feet, ^{4b}but he always broke them off.

5:4c

Now there was no one with the strength to subdue him.

- No one was strong enough to control him.
- People could not restrain him because of his extreme strength.

Now there was no one with the strength to subdue him:

This statement is similar to the one in 5:3b, which says that no one could bind him any more. The statement here in 5:4c says specifically that no one was strong enough to control the man. The context implies that the unclean spirit in the man gave him abnormal strength.

Mark 5:5

Section 5:1–20: Jesus freed a man whom many evil spirits controlled

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples arrived at the northeastern shore of Lake Galilee. This was a region where many Gentiles lived.

When Jesus and his disciples arrived, a man who was controlled by many evil spirits immediately came to Jesus. Jesus commanded the evil spirits to leave the man. When the evil spirits left, they went to control a large herd of pigs and destroyed those pigs.

“Uncleanness” is a theme in this story. The evil spirits that controlled the man were called “unclean” spirits. Tombs were “unclean.” Jews also considered pigs to be “unclean.” Jesus showed his power over evil spirits when he healed the man.

It is good if you translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus commanded many unclean spirits to leave a man

The deliverance of a man who was controlled by many unclean spirits

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:28–34 and Luke 8:26–39.

Paragraph 5:1–5

In this paragraph, the action in 5:1–2 is followed by some background information in 5:3–5. In some languages, it may be good to change the order of some of the information in these verses. See the suggestions in the General Comment on 5:2–6 at the end of 5:6b. The action of the story continues in 5:6.

5:5a

Night and day in the tombs and in the mountains

- Continually, day and night, he was among the tombs and in the hills,
- Every day all the time among the burial caves and in the nearby hills,

Night and day: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Night and day here means “continually night and day.” It probably goes with the whole verse. That is, he never left this area of the hills and tombs and he continually cried out and hurt himself with stones.

Some English versions have made this meaning even more explicit:

Constantly, night and day (NASB)

Unceasingly, night and day (REB)

always, night and day (KJV)

You may have an idiom in your language for this that is different from the Greek idiom. It may also be more natural in some languages to say “day and night” rather than “night and day.”

in the tombs and in the mountains: The tombs were located in an area of hills or mountains. The tombs and the mountains were not two different locations.

5:5b

he kept crying out and cutting himself with stones.

- crying out in a loud voice and cutting himself with stones.
- he was habitually screaming and intentionally hurting himself by gashing himself with sharp stones.

he kept crying out and cutting himself with stones:

The forms of the Greek verbs that the BSB translates he kept crying out and cutting indicate that the man did these actions often. Your translation should indicate this.

crying out: The man probably cried out in anguish because the unclean spirit was tormenting him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

screaming (GNT)

howling (NRSV)

cutting himself with stones: The Greek word that the BSB and other English versions translate as cutting can also mean “bruise” (as in the RSV) or “hit” (as in the NLT96). There were many sharp stones in the mountains. If the man hit himself with them, he would both bruise and cut himself. However, if you must choose one of these meanings, it is probably best to choose the meaning “cut” or “gash.”

Mark 5:6**Section 5:1–20: Jesus freed a man whom many evil spirits controlled**

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples arrived at the northeastern shore of Lake Galilee. This was a region where many Gentiles lived.

When Jesus and his disciples arrived, a man who was controlled by many evil spirits immediately came to Jesus. Jesus commanded the evil spirits to leave the man. When the evil spirits left, they went to control a large herd of pigs and destroyed those pigs.

“Uncleanness” is a theme in this story. The evil spirits that controlled the man were called “unclean” spirits. Tombs were “unclean.” Jews also considered pigs to be “unclean.” Jesus showed his power over evil spirits when he healed the man.

It is good if you translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus commanded many unclean spirits to leave a man

The deliverance of a man who was controlled by many unclean spirits

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:28–34 and Luke 8:26–39.

Paragraph 5:6–10

In this paragraph, it is not always clear whether the text refers to the unclean spirit that controlled the man or to the man himself. Languages have different ways of referring to the actions and speech of people who are controlled by unclean spirits. Some languages use different pronouns or other forms to refer to people and spirits. Use natural ways in your language to refer to the unclean spirit and the man in each context.

5:6a**When the man saw Jesus from a distance,**

- ¶ When he saw Jesus from far away,
- ¶ When he was on the hillside, he saw Jesus on the lakeshore some distance away.

In this verse, Mark told the next event in the story. In 5:3–5, Mark gave background information about the man with the unclean spirit. In 5:2, Mark mentioned that the man came out of the tombs to meet Jesus. In 5:6, Mark told again about this meeting. He said that the man ran to meet Jesus.

Languages have different ways to begin the action of a story again after giving background information. Use a natural way in your language to do that here. In some languages, you may need to give the information in a different order. See the General Comment on 5:2–6 after 5:6b for a suggestion on how to reorder the verses.

When the man saw Jesus from a distance: When the man saw Jesus, the man was in or near the tombs that were in the hills. He could probably see the lake and the shore from where he was standing.

5:6b**he ran and fell on his knees before Him.**

- he ran to him, kneeled on the ground in front of him,
- Then he ran to where Jesus/he was and bowed low at the feet of Jesus/him to show respect.

fell on his knees before Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as fell on his knees means to kneel, bow, or lie flat in front of someone in order to show respect. In this context, the man was under the control of an unclean spirit. He kneeled before Jesus because the unclean spirit knew that Jesus’ power was greater than his.

If people do not bow or kneel to show respect in your culture, you may need to make the meaning of this action clear. For example:

he bowed/kneeled in front of Jesus to show respect

See how you translated the same expression at 3:11b.

General Comment on 5:2–6

In many languages, it is more natural to follow chronological order or to give background information first. In these languages, it may be necessary to reorder the information in these verses. Here is one example:

On that side of the lake ^{2b}there lived a man who had an evil spirit. ^{3a}He lived among tombs ^{5a}in the hills and there continually day and night ^{5b}he was screaming and cutting himself with stones. ^{4a}People had often tried to restrain him by binding him with chains on his wrists and iron shackles on his ankles, ^{4b}but he had always managed to snap the chains and break the shackles to get loose. ^{3b}So no one was able any longer to keep him bound ^{4c}for no one had enough strength to control him. ^{2a}As Jesus was getting out of the boat, ^{6a}this man saw Jesus from a long way off ^{6b}and ran ^{2c}from the tombs up to him ^{6b}and knelt before him.

Mark 5:7

Section 5:1–20: Jesus freed a man whom many evil spirits controlled

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples arrived at the northeastern shore of Lake Galilee. This was a region where many Gentiles lived.

When Jesus and his disciples arrived, a man who was controlled by many evil spirits immediately came to Jesus. Jesus commanded the evil spirits to leave the man. When the evil spirits left, they went to control a large herd of pigs and destroyed those pigs.

“Uncleanness” is a theme in this story. The evil spirits that controlled the man were called “unclean” spirits. Tombs were “unclean.” Jews also considered pigs to be “unclean.” Jesus showed his power over evil spirits when he healed the man.

It is good if you translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus commanded many unclean spirits to leave a man

The deliverance of a man who was controlled by many unclean spirits

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:28–34 and Luke 8:26–39.

Paragraph 5:6–10

In this paragraph, it is not always clear whether the text refers to the unclean spirit that controlled the man or to the man himself. Languages have different ways of referring to the actions and speech of people who are controlled by unclean spirits. Some languages use different pronouns or other forms to refer to people and spirits. Use natural ways in your language to refer to the unclean spirit and the man in each context.

5:7a

And he shouted in a loud voice,

- and shouted very loudly,
- The evil spirit in the man screamed/yelled,

he shouted in a loud voice: The Greek text says literally: “crying out with/in a great voice, he said.” Use an expression that would be natural in your language to describe a person who was shouting because an unclean spirit was controlling him.

he shouted: It was the man who was speaking here. However, it is clear from what he said that the unclean spirit was making him say these words. Consider how it would be natural to introduce these words in your language.

5:7b

“What do You want with me, Jesus, Son of the Most High God?

- “What connection/relation do you^(sing) and I have with each other, Jesus, Son of the Greatest/Highest God?
- “Jesus, son of God the Greatest One, do^(sing) not trouble me!

What do You want with me, Jesus, Son of the Most High God?:

The unclean spirit used both Jesus’ name and the title Son of the Most High God to address him. If this would not be natural in your language, you may need to use a different way to express the ideas. For example:

Jesus, you are the Son of the Most High God! What are you doing here? (EASY)

What do you want with me, Jesus? You are the Son of the Most High God!

You are Jesus, the Son of the Most High God! What do you want with me?

What do You want with me...?: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as What do you want with me...? is literally “What to me and to you?” This is an idiom. It means “What connection/relation do I have with you?” The commentaries and a detailed article by Nigel Turner (Grammatical Insights Into the Greek NT, pages 43–47) discuss the differences in meaning between “What do we have in common?”, “What cause of enmity/injustice is there between us?” and “What business do we have with each other?” However, when the rhetorical nature of the question is appreciated, the differences between these renderings of the question largely dissolve. A sense close to “leave me alone” works well in all contexts where this is found, whether the occasion is some issue of injustice between parties, a request that someone get involved in a matter he felt was not his business, or a plea, as here, on the part of demons that Jesus refrain from punishing them.

This is a rhetorical question that implies “we have no connection/relation” or “we have nothing in common.” It also implies a request or rebuke, that is, “since we have nothing in common, you should not trouble me.” In this context, the unclean spirit, in fear or panic, was pleading with Jesus not to cause him to leave the man. Here are some ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a question. For example:

What connection do we have with each other...?

Why are you troubling/disturbing me...?

Why are you interfering with me...?

- As a statement or a command. For example:

We certainly do not have anything in common with one another...!

Do not trouble me...!

Leave me alone...! (NET)

In some languages you may have an idiom that expresses this meaning. See how you translated the almost identical expression at 1:24a.

Son of...God: The Bible uses the title Son of...God to express the fact that Jesus has the same nature as God and that he comes from God. The title also indicates that the relationship between God and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship of human fathers and sons. God does not have a physical body, and he did not create/produce Jesus the way a human father produces a son. Jesus existed eternally as the Son with his Father.

See how you translated this expression at 1:1 and 3:11c.

the Most High God: The phrase the Most High God is a title for God that is used several times in the Old and New Testaments. It indicates that God is greater and more powerful than any other god, being, or power that exists. The title does not refer to literal height or size. In some languages there may be a special way to indicate that a phrase such as this is a title. The BSB uses capital letters to indicate this.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the Greatest/Highest God

God, the One who is more powerful than all other beings

the God who is so great that no one is great like him

God: **God:** The Greek word that the BSB translates as God refers here to the eternal spirit who created everything. He is more powerful than any other spirit, and he is perfectly good and wise. He deserves to be worshipped. Here are some ways to translate God:

- Use a name or title for God that people in your culture already use.
- Use a descriptive term that fits the truth about God that is revealed in the Bible. For example:

Creator

Great Spirit

Ruler of the universe

See how you translated God in 1:1. For more detailed information, see God in the Glossary.

5:7c

I beg You before God not to torture me!”

- Swear/take an oath before God that you will not torment/punish me!”
- Promise me in God’s name that you will not cause me to suffer. If you cause me to suffer, may God judge/punish you.”

I beg You before God not to torture me: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as I beg you before God is a very serious expression. It is used to tell someone to swear an oath that uses God’s name. It was common in ancient magic to appeal to the name of a greater spirit or power to assure the success of the magic. Here the unclean spirit in the man appealed to the highest name possible, God’s name. This implies that the person should promise to do something and agree that God would punish him if he did not do it. You may have a special expression in your language to tell someone to swear an oath or make a serious promise.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Promise me in God’s name that you won’t torture me! (CEV)

I beg you to take an oath before God that you will not torture me!

Please promise not to torture me and agree that God may punish you if you break that promise!

not to torture me: In this context, the word torture means “punish with pain, cause to suffer.”

Here are some other ways to translate it:

not to punish me

not to torment me

not to cause me to suffer

Mark 5:8

Section 5:1–20: Jesus freed a man whom many evil spirits controlled

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples arrived at the northeastern shore of Lake Galilee. This was a region where many Gentiles lived.

When Jesus and his disciples arrived, a man who was controlled by many evil spirits immediately came to Jesus. Jesus commanded the evil spirits to leave the man. When the evil spirits left, they went to control a large herd of pigs and destroyed those pigs.

“Uncleanness” is a theme in this story. The evil spirits that controlled the man were called “unclean” spirits. Tombs were “unclean.” Jews also considered pigs to be “unclean.” Jesus showed his power over evil spirits when he healed the man.

It is good if you translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus commanded many unclean spirits to leave a man

The deliverance of a man who was controlled by many unclean spirits

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:28–34 and Luke 8:26–39.

Paragraph 5:6–10

In this paragraph, it is not always clear whether the text refers to the unclean spirit that controlled the man or to the man himself. Languages have different ways of referring to the actions and speech of people who are controlled by unclean spirits. Some languages use different pronouns or other forms to refer to people and spirits. Use natural ways in your language to refer to the unclean spirit and the man in each context.

5:8–9a

For a suggestion about using indirect speech in these verses, see the General Comment on 5:8–9a at the end of the note on 5:9a.

5:8a

For Jesus had already declared,

- For Jesus had already said to him,
- The man/spirit said this because Jesus had just commanded

For Jesus had already declared: This verse describes what happened just before the man’s plea in 5:7. It explains the reason why the evil spirit begged Jesus not to torment him. In Greek, both the conjunction that is translated as For by the BSB and the imperfect verb tense show that Mark is giving a background explanation here. The BSB indicates this by using the connector For and the verb form had...declared. Use a natural way in your language to indicate that 5:8 explains what happened in 5:7.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

The man said this because Jesus had already told... (CEV)

For Jesus had said to him just before this...

See also the General Comment on 5:7–8 at the end of 5:8b for a suggested way to reorder 5:7–8.

The Greek text includes the phrase “to him.” The pronoun “him” probably refers to the unclean spirit, since Jesus directly addresses the spirit in 5:8b. Use a natural form in your language. (See the note on Paragraph 5:6–10.) For example, the NLT says:

For Jesus had already said to the spirit

As the BSB illustrates, in some languages it may not be necessary to make the word him explicit. For example:

He said that because Jesus had already commanded

5:8b

“Come out of this man, you unclean spirit!”

- “Evil spirit, come^(sing) out of this/that man!”
- the evil spirit to leave the man.

Come out of this man, you unclean spirit!: The words you unclean spirit indicate that Jesus spoke directly to the evil spirit in the man. In some languages it will be more natural to change the order of the words in this clause. For example, the GNT says:

Evil spirit, come out of this man!

Come out of this man: The verb that the BSB translates as Come out is a normal way in Greek to speak of a demon releasing control of a person. It indicates here that Jesus commanded the demon to leave the man and stop controlling him.

In some cultures, people do not think of demons as being in a person. If that is true in your language, it may not be natural to speak of them coming or going out of a person. Use a natural expression in your language for when a demon stops controlling a person.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Leave him!

Release him!

Translate this command in a way that fits the expression you used for the phrase “with an unclean spirit” in 5:2b–c. See also the note on “Come out of him” at 1:25b. See evil spirit in the Glossary for more information.

you unclean spirit: The BSB adds the word you in this phrase to show that the Greek form indicates that Jesus is speaking to the unclean spirit. In some languages it may not be natural to say both “you” and “unclean spirit.” Translate in a way that indicates that Jesus is speaking to the unclean spirit.

unclean spirit: See the note on 5:2b.

General Comment on 5:7–8

In 5:8, Jesus ordered the evil spirit to leave the man. This happened before the evil spirit begged Jesus not to torment him in 5:7. It may be more natural in your language to place these events in the order in which they happened. If that is true, you could combine these two verses and change the order. For example:

⁸Jesus said to him, “Evil spirit, come out of this man!” ⁷The man shouted with a loud voice, “Jesus, Son of the Most High God, what do you want with me? Promise to God that you will not torment me!”

Mark 5:9

Section 5:1–20: Jesus freed a man whom many evil spirits controlled

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples arrived at the northeastern shore of Lake Galilee. This was a region where many Gentiles lived.

When Jesus and his disciples arrived, a man who was controlled by many evil spirits immediately came to Jesus. Jesus commanded the evil spirits to leave the man. When the evil spirits left, they went to control a large herd of pigs and destroyed those pigs.

“Uncleanness” is a theme in this story. The evil spirits that controlled the man were called “unclean” spirits. Tombs were “unclean.” Jews also considered pigs to be “unclean.” Jesus showed his power over evil spirits when he healed the man.

It is good if you translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus commanded many unclean spirits to leave a man

The deliverance of a man who was controlled by many unclean spirits

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:28–34 and Luke 8:26–39.

Paragraph 5:6–10

In this paragraph, it is not always clear whether the text refers to the unclean spirit that controlled the man or to the man himself. Languages have different ways of referring to the actions and speech of people who are controlled by unclean spirits. Some languages use different pronouns or other forms to refer to people and spirits. Use natural ways in your language to refer to the unclean spirit and the man in each context.

5:9a

“What is your name?” Jesus asked.

- And Jesus asked him, “What is your^(sing) name?”
- Jesus asked him his name.

“What is your name?” Jesus asked: The pronoun your here could refer either to the man or to the evil spirit that was controlling him. The Greek text says that Jesus specifically asked “him” this question. The pronoun “him” could similarly refer either to the man or to the spirit. If you must choose, use a word that refers to the spirit, since the answer to Jesus’ question was a name that referred to the spirit. (See the note on Paragraph 5:6–10 for further discussion.) For example, the NIRV says:

Then Jesus asked the demon, “What is your name?”

General Comment on 5:8–9a

In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech to translate the quotes in these verses. For example:

For Jesus had just commanded the unclean spirit to leave the man. Then Jesus asked him what his name was.

5:9b

“My name is Legion,” he replied, “for we are many.”

- He replied, “My name is ‘Army’ because there are many of us.^(excl)”
- He answered, “We^(excl) are called ‘Thousands’ because there are so many of us.^(excl)”

My name is Legion...for we are many: In some languages, it may not be natural to say My name (singular), and then to say we are (plural). You may need to use either the singular or plural for both parts of this statement. For example:

Our name is Legion, for we are many

My name is Legion, for I speak for many unclean spirits who control this man.

My name is Legion, for there are many unclean spirits in this man.

Legion: The word Legion was the name of the largest unit of soldiers in the Roman army. A legion had between four thousand and six thousand soldiers. The unclean spirit called himself Legion because there were many unclean spirits along with him that were controlling the man.

Here are some ways to translate Legion in this context:

- Use a military word that describes a large group of soldiers. For example:

Army

Regiment

Thousands of Soldiers If it is natural in your language, this is the ideal option.

- Use a word that describes a large number. It should be large enough to go well with the two thousand pigs mentioned in 5:13. For example:

Hundreds/Thousands

- Use a word that describes a very large group of people. For example:

Crowd

Horde

Mob (GNT)

for we are many: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as for introduces an explanation of the unclean spirit's name. Indicate this in a natural way in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate for we are many:

since there are many of us

because our number is great

he replied: In the Greek text, the words that the BSB translates as he replied come before the unclean spirit's speech. The BSB has placed the phrase he replied in the middle of what the unclean spirit said. Place it where it is most natural in your language.

Mark 5:10

Section 5:1–20: Jesus freed a man whom many evil spirits controlled

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples arrived at the northeastern shore of Lake Galilee. This was a region where many Gentiles lived.

When Jesus and his disciples arrived, a man who was controlled by many evil spirits immediately came to Jesus. Jesus commanded the evil spirits to leave the man. When the evil spirits left, they went to control a large herd of pigs and destroyed those pigs.

"Uncleanness" is a theme in this story. The evil spirits that controlled the man were called "unclean" spirits. Tombs were "unclean." Jews also considered pigs to be "unclean." Jesus showed his power over evil spirits when he healed the man.

It is good if you translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus commanded many unclean spirits to leave a man

The deliverance of a man who was controlled by many unclean spirits

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:28–34 and Luke 8:26–39.

Paragraph 5:6–10

In this paragraph, it is not always clear whether the text refers to the unclean spirit that controlled the

man or to the man himself. Languages have different ways of referring to the actions and speech of people who are controlled by unclean spirits. Some languages use different pronouns or other forms to refer to people and spirits. Use natural ways in your language to refer to the unclean spirit and the man in each context.

5:10

And he begged Jesus repeatedly not to send them out of that region.

- And he pleaded repeatedly that Jesus would not send them out of the region.
- Then he begged Jesus earnestly, "Please do not send us^(excl) out of this area."

he begged Jesus repeatedly not to send them out of that region: In some languages, it may be more natural to use direct speech in this context. For example:

he begged Jesus repeatedly, "Do not send us out of this region."

he begged Jesus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as begged means to "plead for" something. It is a strong word that emphasizes how much the speaker desires what he is pleading for. This is an important word in this story. It is found here, in 5:12, 5:17, and 5:18b. Consider using the same word each time if that would be natural in your language.

repeatedly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as repeatedly means "strongly" or "greatly." In English "strongly" or "greatly" seems to describe quite well the common element present in all the contextual translations of Mark's adverbial πολλά: "frequently," "strictly," "solemnly," "sternly," "eagerly," "heartily," "violently," "unrestrainedly," etc. Here it indicates that the unclean spirit repeated the plea urgently. Use a natural expression in your language to indicate this. Here are some examples:

earnestly (NJB)

again and again (NIV)

them: The word them refers to all of the unclean spirits that were controlling the man.

region: The Greek word that the BSB translates as region here is the same word that it translates as "region" in 5:1a–b. See how you translated the word there.

Mark 5:11

Section 5:1–20: Jesus freed a man whom many evil spirits controlled

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples arrived at the northeastern shore of Lake Galilee. This was a region where many Gentiles lived.

When Jesus and his disciples arrived, a man who was controlled by many evil spirits immediately came to Jesus. Jesus commanded the evil spirits to leave the man. When the evil spirits left, they went to control a large herd of pigs and destroyed those pigs.

“Uncleanness” is a theme in this story. The evil spirits that controlled the man were called “unclean” spirits. Tombs were “unclean.” Jews also considered pigs to be “unclean.” Jesus showed his power over evil spirits when he healed the man.

It is good if you translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus commanded many unclean spirits to leave a man

The deliverance of a man who was controlled by many unclean spirits

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:28–34 and Luke 8:26–39.

5:11

There on the nearby hillside a large herd of pigs was feeding.

- ¶ A large group of pigs was eating/foraging in the hills a short distance away.
- ¶ While this was happening, a herd of domestic pigs was grazing/rooting on a hillside not far from there.

This verse gives background information that there was a herd of pigs grazing nearby. The herd of pigs is important in the story because Jesus allowed the unclean spirits to leave the man and enter the pigs. In some languages there may be a special way to introduce them into the story and to indicate that they were already grazing nearby. For example:

Now there was a large herd of pigs...

Use a natural way in your language to introduce this important background information.

a large herd of pigs: The phrase a large herd of pigs refers to a large group of pigs. The number of pigs is given in 5:13 as “about two thousand.” In some languages, it may be more natural to include that information here. See the General Comment on 5:13c–d at the end of 5:13d.

pigs: Animals known as pigs are also called “swine” in English, as in the RSV. These were domestic pigs. They were not wild pigs. Jews considered all pigs to be ritually unclean, and they did not eat their meat. If people in your area do not raise pigs or do not have a word for them, here are possible ways to translate pigs:

- Use a general expression for farm animals. For example:

livestock

domestic animals

- Use a general expression along with the word for pigs from another language. For example:

farm animals called “pigs”

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

farm animals that are ritually unclean

You might also want to include a picture of pigs in your translation, as long as that would not be offensive to your readers.

feeding: The word feeding indicates that the pigs were eating whatever food they could find on the hillside. If your language has a specific word that describes the way pigs eat, you should use that here. For example:

grazing

rooting

foraging

on the nearby hillside: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as on the nearby hillside is literally “there toward the hill.” Matthew 8:30 says the herd of pigs were “some distance away.” So the herd was not on the lakeshore where Jesus and the man with

the unclean spirit were. It was at a distance but close enough for Jesus and the man to see.

Mark 5:12

Section 5:1–20: Jesus freed a man whom many evil spirits controlled

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples arrived at the northeastern shore of Lake Galilee. This was a region where many Gentiles lived.

When Jesus and his disciples arrived, a man who was controlled by many evil spirits immediately came to Jesus. Jesus commanded the evil spirits to leave the man. When the evil spirits left, they went to control a large herd of pigs and destroyed those pigs.

“Uncleanness” is a theme in this story. The evil spirits that controlled the man were called “unclean” spirits. Tombs were “unclean.” Jews also considered pigs to be “unclean.” Jesus showed his power over evil spirits when he healed the man.

It is good if you translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus commanded many unclean spirits to leave a man

The deliverance of a man who was controlled by many unclean spirits

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:28–34 and Luke 8:26–39.

5:12a

So the demons begged Jesus,

- The evil spirits begged Jesus,
- The evil spirits pleaded with Jesus,
- The demons begged Jesus

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB here translates as *So* is a simple connector. It is often translated as “and” (as in the RSV). This word connects 5:11 to 5:12. It introduces what the demons asked because of the herd of pigs that was nearby.

The BSB shows this connection with the word *So*. Some English versions do not translate this word. You should connect these verses in a way that is natural in your language.

the demons begged: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as the demons begged is literally “they

begged.” You may need to provide a noun as the subject in your language, as the BSB does. If that is true, it is good to use a plural form of the same word that you used for “unclean spirit.” There is a textual issue here: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have they begged. In these manuscripts “they” refers to the demons. It does not specify all of the demons. For example, the CEV says: “the evil spirits begged” (BSB, NIV, RSV, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, JBP, NET, REB, NCV). (2) Other Greek manuscripts have “all the demons begged.” For example, the KJV says: “all the devils besought” (KJV). You should follow option (1). This issue is not mentioned in the UBS4 (page 136), which considers the reading “they begged” to be certain.

Notice that for the first time in the story, the Greek text uses a plural form to refer to the unclean spirits.

begged: The Greek word that the BSB translates as begged means to “plead for” something. It is used when a request is earnestly desired. The same word was also used in 5:10. It is probably good to translate it in the same way here.

5:12b

“Send us to the pigs, so that we may enter them.”

- “Send us^(excl) to the pigs so that we^(excl) may enter them.”
- “If we^(excl) must leave this man, may we^(excl) go and take control of the pigs over there on the hillside?”
- to allow them to go and take control of the pigs.

Send us to the pigs, so that we may enter them:

Here the unclean spirits begged Jesus to let them go to the pigs and control them. The two clauses *Send us to the pigs* and *so that we may enter them* express the same request. In Greek, these clauses are connected with a purpose connector. As the BSB translation indicates, the sentence is literally, “Send us into/among the pigs so that into them we may enter.” The demons are showing deference by explaining why they are making the request. It is a polite request that shows that the unclean spirits know that Jesus is superior to them. Use a natural way in your language to express the request in this context.

so that we may enter them: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *so that we may enter them* is a request that Jesus allow the unclean spirits to control the pigs as they had controlled the man. The unclean spirits were not implying that they preferred the pigs to the man. They were implying that if they were forced to leave the man, they wanted to enter the pigs.

In some languages it may be necessary to make that explicit. For example:

allow us to go into them if we cannot stay in this man

enter them: In some languages it may be more natural to use a different expression to describe an unclean spirit possessing or controlling an animal. Use a natural expression in your language. For example:

be upon them

ride on them

fasten upon them

General Comment on 5:12a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech in this context. For example:

the unclean spirits begged Jesus to send them among the pigs so that they could enter the pigs

Mark 5:13

Section 5:1–20: Jesus freed a man whom many evil spirits controlled

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples arrived at the northeastern shore of Lake Galilee. This was a region where many Gentiles lived.

When Jesus and his disciples arrived, a man who was controlled by many evil spirits immediately came to Jesus. Jesus commanded the evil spirits to leave the man. When the evil spirits left, they went to control a large herd of pigs and destroyed those pigs.

“Uncleanness” is a theme in this story. The evil spirits that controlled the man were called “unclean” spirits. Tombs were “unclean.” Jews also considered pigs to be “unclean.” Jesus showed his power over evil spirits when he healed the man.

It is good if you translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus commanded many unclean spirits to leave a man

The deliverance of a man who was controlled by many unclean spirits

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:28–34 and Luke 8:26–39.

5:13a

He gave them permission,

- He agreed that they could do this.
- He said to them, “Yes, you may go.”

This verse tells how Jesus responded to the unclean spirits’ request in 5:12. Some English versions (such as the ESV, NLT, and NRSV) introduce Jesus’ response with the connector “So” to indicate that Jesus agreed to their appeal. This reflects the presence of a connecting word in Greek. Connect 5:13 to 5:12 in a way that is natural in your language for this context.

He gave them permission: Jesus gave the unclean spirits permission to go to the pigs and control them. If your language prefers direct speech in this context, you may use it here. For example:

He said to them, “You may.”

He said to them, “Go.”

See Matthew 8:32.

5:13b

and the unclean spirits came out and went into the pigs,

- The evil spirits went out of the man and entered the pigs.
- So the evil spirits left the man and took control of the pigs.

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and connects 5:13a to 5:13b. It introduces what the unclean spirits did as a result of what Jesus had said to them in 5:13a. Other ways to express this connection in English are “so” (NLT96) or “with that” (NJB). Connect 5:13b to 5:13a in a way that is natural in your language.

the unclean spirits came out: The clause the unclean spirits came out indicates that the unclean spirits left the man and no longer controlled him. In some languages it may be necessary to include the man in this clause. For example, the GW says:

The evil spirits came out of the man

If it is not natural in your language to say that an unclean spirit is in a person, you may not want to say that he came out. Use the natural expression in your

language to describe what happens when an unclean spirit stops controlling a person. For example:

the unclean spirits released the man

the unclean spirits left the man

Refer to how you translated this expression in 1:26b. See also evil spirit in the Glossary.

5:13c

and the herd of about two thousand

- There were about two thousand pigs in the herd.
- The herd, which had about two thousand pigs,

the herd of about two thousand: See the General Comment on 5:13c–d after 5:13d for suggestions on where you might place the phrase of about two thousand.

5:13d

rushed down the steep bank into the sea and drowned in the water.

- They all stampeded down a steep slope/hill into the lake and died in the water.
- ran violently over the cliff. They plunged into the water and drowned.

rushed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rushed refers to fast movement. It implies movement that cannot easily be stopped after it has started. It could be translated simply as “ran.” However, if your language has a more intense term than “ran,” consider using it here.

the steep bank: The Greek word that the BSB translates as steep bank refers to a steep hill or cliff right at the edge of the lake. After the pigs started down this slope, it was impossible for them to stop.

drowned in the water: The word drowned indicates that the pigs died in the water.

General Comment on 5:13c–d

Consider where it would be most natural in your language to say that there were about two thousand pigs in the herd. This may be as a separate sentence at the beginning or end of 5:13c–d. For example:

There were about two thousand pigs in the herd. They rushed down the steep bank into the lake and drowned.

The herd rushed down the steep bank into the lake and were drowned. The number of the pigs was about two thousand.

Notice that the examples above use numerals to write the number of the pigs. Check whether people in your language prefer numerals or words here.

It is possible to move the comment about two thousand pigs to 5:11, where the herd was introduced. For example:

About two thousand pigs were feeding on the nearby hillside.

A large herd of pigs was feeding on the nearby hillside. The number of the pigs was about two thousand.

Mark 5:14

Section 5:1–20: Jesus freed a man whom many evil spirits controlled

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples arrived at the northeastern shore of Lake Galilee. This was a region where many Gentiles lived.

When Jesus and his disciples arrived, a man who was controlled by many evil spirits immediately came to Jesus. Jesus commanded the evil spirits to leave the man. When the evil spirits left, they went to control a large herd of pigs and destroyed those pigs.

“Uncleanness” is a theme in this story. The evil spirits that controlled the man were called “unclean” spirits. Tombs were “unclean.” Jews also considered pigs to be “unclean.” Jesus showed his power over evil spirits when he healed the man.

It is good if you translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus commanded many unclean spirits to leave a man

The deliverance of a man who was controlled by many unclean spirits

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:28–34 and Luke 8:26–39.

5:14a

Those tending the pigs ran off

- ¶ The pig herders fled
- ¶ The men who had been tending/guarding the pigs ran away in fear.

Those tending the pigs: The phrase that the BSB translates as Those tending the pigs refers to men who took care of the pigs as their job. Some languages will have a specific word for “pig herders.” Because they have not been mentioned previously, you may need to introduce them in some way before you tell what they did. For example:

The herders of the pigs were there. They now ran...

Some men were there tending the pigs. They ran...

ran off: The Greek word that the BSB translates as ran off means “they ran away” or “they fled.” The herdsmen ran away because they were frightened and upset by what had happened.

5:14b

and reported this in the town and countryside,

- and spread the news in the town and surrounding countryside,
- They ran and told people in the nearby town and surrounding area what had happened.

reported this: The phrase reported this indicates that the herdsmen told people about what had happened.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

reported everything that had happened (GW)

telling everyone about this (NCV)

in the town and countryside: The town is not identified by name. You could identify it as “the nearby town.” The countryside refers to the farms and small villages surrounding the town.

5:14c

and the people went out to see what had happened.

- and the people there went to see what had happened.
- So, many people who heard this went there to see for themselves what had happened.

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and connects 5:14b to 5:14c. In this context the people came to see Jesus as a result of the report spread by the herdsmen. So some English versions translate this conjunction as:

so (GW)

then (NRSV)

Connect 5:14c to 5:14b in a way that is natural in your language for this context.

the people went out: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as the people went out is literally “they came.” It indicates that the inhabitants of the town and countryside left their homes and villages and went down to the lakeshore.

Be careful not to translate in a way that implies that the people only went outside their houses to see what had happened.

In some languages it will be more natural to supply a subject like “people” or “everyone,” as many English versions do.

went out to see what had happened: This phrase indicates that people left the places where they were in order to go and see what had happened. They wanted to see for themselves what the herdsmen had told them about. Compare 5:15a, which indicates that they arrived where Jesus was.

Mark 5:15

Section 5:1–20: Jesus freed a man whom many evil spirits controlled

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples arrived at the northeastern shore of Lake Galilee. This was a region where many Gentiles lived.

When Jesus and his disciples arrived, a man who was controlled by many evil spirits immediately came to Jesus. Jesus commanded the evil spirits to leave the man. When the evil spirits left, they went to control a large herd of pigs and destroyed those pigs.

“Uncleanness” is a theme in this story. The evil spirits that controlled the man were called “unclean” spirits. Tombs were “unclean.” Jews also considered pigs to be “unclean.” Jesus showed his power over evil spirits when he healed the man.

It is good if you translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus commanded many unclean spirits to leave a man

The deliverance of a man who was controlled by many unclean spirits

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:28–34 and Luke 8:26–39.

5:15a

When they came to Jesus,

- They came to Jesus,
- When they reached the place where Jesus was,

When they came to Jesus: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates When they came to Jesus indicates that the people “arrived” at the place where Jesus was and came to him.

5:15b

they saw the man who had been possessed by the legion of demons sitting there,

- and they saw that the man who had been controlled by the army of evil spirits
- they saw the man whom thousands of evil spirits had formerly controlled.

5:15c

clothed and in his right mind;

- was now sitting there, was wearing clothes, and was sane.
- They saw that his mind was right/normal again. He was sitting calmly. And he was no longer naked but was wearing clothes.

5:15b–c

This part of the verse tells what the people saw. They saw that the man who had been controlled by evil spirits was now in his right mind. The text focuses on the great change in the man. Here are some ways to express this focus:

...they saw that the man who had once been controlled by the army/regiment of unclean spirits was now sitting there, wearing clothes, and in his right mind.

...they saw the man sitting calmly, wearing clothes, and in his right mind. He was the same man who had been controlled by the mob/horde of unclean spirits.

the man who had been possessed by the legion of demons: Refer to the man in a way that is natural in your language to describe someone whom an evil spirit had controlled. See the note on 5:2b. It may be necessary to indicate explicitly that at this time the unclean spirits no longer controlled the man. The

BSB indicates this with the verb form who had been possessed.

Here are some other ways to indicate it in English:

who once had been full of demons (CEV)

who used to have the many evil spirits (NCV)

legion of demons: Translate legion in the same way that you translated it at 5:9b. For demons, use the term that you have used throughout this story to refer to unclean spirits.

sitting there, clothed and in his right mind: When the people saw the man, he was:

1. sitting calmly,
2. wearing clothes,
3. in his right mind.

Of these three things, probably the fact that he was in his right mind is the most important. Consider whether it would be more natural in your language to place this first in the list rather than last. For example:

he was in his right mind, dressed, and sitting there calmly

sitting there: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sitting there indicates that the man was seated there peacefully. People saw by this that he was no longer wild and uncontrollable.

clothed: In this context the word clothed implies that before Jesus healed him, the man was naked. Luke 8:27 says this explicitly. In some languages it may be more natural to say this clearly, either here or when the man was first described in 5:2–5. For example, here you could say:

he was wearing clothes instead of being naked as he was before

in his right mind: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in his right mind means that the man was no longer insane. His mind was normal. In many languages this is expressed by an idiom. For example:

his mind was right/straight

his mind had returned

5:15d and they were afraid.

- And they became afraid.
- Seeing this caused them to fear Jesus.

and they were afraid: Although the people were looking at the rescued man, they were afraid of Jesus. When Jesus delivered the man from the unclean spirits, he showed that he had great supernatural power. This caused the people to be afraid of him. Translate they were afraid with the expression that you would use in your language to describe this feeling of “fear” or “dread.” See how you translated the similar words and emotion at 4:41a.

Mark 5:16

Section 5:1–20: Jesus freed a man whom many evil spirits controlled

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples arrived at the northeastern shore of Lake Galilee. This was a region where many Gentiles lived.

When Jesus and his disciples arrived, a man who was controlled by many evil spirits immediately came to Jesus. Jesus commanded the evil spirits to leave the man. When the evil spirits left, they went to control a large herd of pigs and destroyed those pigs.

“Uncleanness” is a theme in this story. The evil spirits that controlled the man were called “unclean” spirits. Tombs were “unclean.” Jews also considered pigs to be “unclean.” Jesus showed his power over evil spirits when he healed the man.

It is good if you translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus commanded many unclean spirits to leave a man

The deliverance of a man who was controlled by many unclean spirits

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:28–34 and Luke 8:26–39.

5:16a Those who had seen it

- Those who were eyewitnesses
- The men who had seen what happened
- Those who were there and saw what happened to the man

Those who had seen it: The phrase Those who had seen it refers to the people who saw Jesus deliver the man from the evil spirits. It also refers to the people who saw what happened to the pigs. These people were his disciples and the pig herders and maybe others who were not mentioned. Since the text does not specify exactly who saw what had happened, use a general expression. For example:

Those who had seen what happened (NLT)

eyewitnesses (REB)

5:16b described what had happened to the demon-possessed man

- described to the people who came what had happened to the man who was formerly controlled by evil spirits
- told the others in detail how Jesus healed/freed the man
- told the people who came all about it.

5:16c and also to the pigs.

- and also what had happened to the pigs.
- and also how the pigs had drowned.
- They also told them all about what happened to the pigs.

5:16b–c described what had happened to the demon-possessed man and also to the pigs: These verse parts mention two things that the eyewitnesses told the people. Some translations separate the two things with a dash. There is no dash in the Greek text, so you do not necessarily have to use one in your translation.

described what had happened... and also to the pigs: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as described means to tell fully and with some detail. Here in 5:16b–c the text indicates what the people told the others who had come to see what had happened. In some versions this information has already been given as the object of the verb “had seen” in 5:16a. Translate the whole verse in a natural way in your language. Here are some other examples in English:

Those who saw this told what had happened to the demon-possessed man and the pigs. (GW)

Everyone who had seen what had happened told about the man and the pigs. (CEV)

the demon-possessed man: See how you translated the similar expressions at 5:2b and 5:15b. If your expression is long, you might consider using a shorter expression to refer to the man throughout the rest of the story (5:18a and 5:20a). For example:

the man

the healed/freed man

Mark 5:17

Section 5:1–20: Jesus freed a man whom many evil spirits controlled

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples arrived at the northeastern shore of Lake Galilee. This was a region where many Gentiles lived.

When Jesus and his disciples arrived, a man who was controlled by many evil spirits immediately came to Jesus. Jesus commanded the evil spirits to leave the man. When the evil spirits left, they went to control a large herd of pigs and destroyed those pigs.

“Uncleanness” is a theme in this story. The evil spirits that controlled the man were called “unclean” spirits. Tombs were “unclean.” Jews also considered pigs to be “unclean.” Jesus showed his power over evil spirits when he healed the man.

It is good if you translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus commanded many unclean spirits to leave a man

The deliverance of a man who was controlled by many unclean spirits

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:28–34 and Luke 8:26–39.

5:17

And the people began to beg Jesus to leave their region.

- Then the people who were from there began to beg Jesus to leave that area.
- When they heard all that, they were even more afraid and said, “Please, we^(excl) beg you to leave our region.”

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And could also be translated as “Then” (NIV, NRSV). Here it introduces the people’s response to what the witnesses told them in 5:16. Connect 5:17 to 5:16b in a way that is natural in your language for this context.

the people began to beg Jesus to leave their region:

In some languages it may be more natural to use direct speech here. For example:

...the people began to say to Jesus, “Please leave our region!”

the people began to beg: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the people began to beg is literally “they began to beg.” The people who pleaded were people from the area who came to see what had happened. Many English versions supply a general subject such as “the people” to indicate this.

began to beg: In this context the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as began to beg probably indicates that the people made their request more than one time. It does not imply that the people began to beg but did not finish their request. If it is confusing in your language to use a verb like “began” here, you may leave this idea implicit. For example:

pleaded

begged repeatedly

The Greek word that the BSB translates as beg is similarly translated as “begged” in 5:10 and 5:12. If it is natural in your language, it is probably good to translate it in the same way here. See the note on 5:10.

their region: Translate region in the same way as you did at 5:1a–b and 5:10.

Mark 5:18

Section 5:1–20: Jesus freed a man whom many evil spirits controlled

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples arrived at the northeastern shore of Lake Galilee. This was a region where many Gentiles lived.

When Jesus and his disciples arrived, a man who was controlled by many evil spirits immediately came to Jesus. Jesus commanded the evil spirits to leave the man. When the evil spirits left, they went to control a large herd of pigs and destroyed those pigs.

“Uncleanness” is a theme in this story. The evil spirits that controlled the man were called “unclean” spirits.

Tombs were “unclean.” Jews also considered pigs to be “unclean.” Jesus showed his power over evil spirits when he healed the man.

It is good if you translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus commanded many unclean spirits to leave a man

The deliverance of a man who was controlled by many unclean spirits

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:28–34 and Luke 8:26–39.

5:18a

As He was getting into the boat,

- ¶ Just as Jesus was climbing into the boat,
- ¶ When Jesus was entering the boat to leave,

As He was getting into the boat: The phrase that the BSB translates as *As He was getting into the boat* introduces the event in the next part of the verse. This event happened while Jesus was getting into the boat to go back across the lake. Indicate this in a natural way in your language.

He: The pronoun *He* refers to Jesus.

5:18b

the man who had been possessed by the demons begged to go with Him.

- the man who had been controlled by evil spirits pleaded to go with Jesus and be with him.
- the healed man begged him, “Please let me go with you and be your^(sing) disciple.”

the man who had been possessed by the demons begged to go with Him: In some languages it may be more natural to use direct speech here. For example:

...the man who had had the unclean spirits begged Jesus, “Please let me be with you all the time.”

...the man who had been controlled by unclean spirits pleaded with him, “Please, may I go with you wherever you go?”

the man who had been possessed by the demons: This expression is similar to the one in 5:15b–c. Refer

to the note on 5:15b–c and to how you translated the expression there. If your expression is long, it may be more natural to use a shorter way to refer to the man here. For example:

the man

the healed/freed man

begged: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *begged* means to request or plead for something. In this context it indicates that the man earnestly desired to go with Jesus. The same word was used in 5:10, 5:12a, and 5:17. See the note on 5:10.

to go with Him: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *to go with Him* is more literally “to be with him.” Almost the same Greek phrase is used in 3:14 to describe the purpose for which Jesus chose his twelve disciples.

The man who was delivered from the unclean spirits begged Jesus to allow him to stay with him as the twelve disciples did. Consider how to express this meaning in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

to be with him

to stay with him

Him: The pronoun *Him* refers here to Jesus.

Mark 5:19

Section 5:1–20: Jesus freed a man whom many evil spirits controlled

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples arrived at the northeastern shore of Lake Galilee. This was a region where many Gentiles lived.

When Jesus and his disciples arrived, a man who was controlled by many evil spirits immediately came to Jesus. Jesus commanded the evil spirits to leave the man. When the evil spirits left, they went to control a large herd of pigs and destroyed those pigs.

“Uncleanness” is a theme in this story. The evil spirits that controlled the man were called “unclean” spirits. Tombs were “unclean.” Jews also considered pigs to be “unclean.” Jesus showed his power over evil spirits when he healed the man.

It is good if you translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus commanded many unclean spirits to leave a man

The deliverance of a man who was controlled by many unclean spirits

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:28–34 and Luke 8:26–39.

5:19a

But Jesus would not allow him.

- Jesus did not allow him to do this,
- But Jesus did not grant his request.
- Jesus said to him, “I do not want you to go with me.

5:19b

“Go home to your own people,” He said,

- but he said to him, “Go to your home and to your people
- Instead he replied, “Return to your home area, to your family and community
- Rather, go back to where you are from

5:19a–b

In Greek, this verse begins with a common conjunction that is often translated as “and” in English. It connects the man’s request to Jesus’ response. Because Jesus’ response contrasted with the man’s request, some English versions translate this conjunction as “But,” as the BSB does. In some languages it may be more natural to express this contrast later in the verse.

But Jesus would not allow him. “Go home to your own people,” He said: The phrase Jesus would not allow him indicates that Jesus did not give the man permission to come with him. Instead, he sent him on a mission back to his own people and area. Introduce what Jesus said in 5:19b in a way that is natural in your language.

Here is another way to translate this:

But Jesus would not allow it. Instead, he told the man, “Go home to your family...” (GW)

But instead Jesus told him that he wanted him to go home to his own people...

Notice that the second example uses indirect speech to express the way that Jesus did not allow the man to

come with him. If you do that, use a polite expression in your language.

Go home to your own people: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Go home to your own people is literally “Go to your home, to the yours.” The first part, “Go to your home” probably means that he should go to the area where his home had been and especially to his family. The second part, “to the yours,” probably means he should go back to be among his relatives and neighbors. It is recommended that you translate this in a way that indicates a more general group than just his family. For example, the NJB says:

Go home to your people

5:19c

“and tell them how much the Lord has done for you,

- and tell them how much the Lord has done to help you,
- and tell them what a great thing the Lord has done for you.
- and tell the people there that God has healed/freed you from the evil spirits.

and tell them how much the Lord has done for you:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as how much means “what great things.” The Lord had done something great and wonderful for the man.

the Lord: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Lord means “master, one who has authority over others.” Jesus was referring to God here.

In some languages, people may not naturally use a word that means “master” to refer to God. If speakers of your language do not understand that your word for “Lord” refers to God in this context, here are other ways to translate it:

- Use your word for God.
- Use your word for God and indicate that he is the Lord. For example:

God the Lord

Master God

If you include the word for God in your translation of Lord here, you may want to include a footnote to give the literal Greek meaning. For example:

Here the Greek text is literally “Lord.”

See Lord in the Glossary.

5:19d

and what mercy He has shown you.”

- and how much he has shown compassion to you.”
- Tell them that he has been very kind/good to you.”

and what mercy He has shown you: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as shown...mercy means to have compassion on or to show kindness to those who suffer or are poor.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

how kind he has been to you (GNT)

how merciful he has been (NLT)

how compassionately he has treated you

General Comment on 5:19c–d

The two clauses “how much the Lord has done for you” and “how he has had mercy on you” are very similar in meaning. In some languages it may be more natural to combine them or to express them in a different order. For example:

what the Lord in his mercy has done for you (REB)

^{19d}how the Lord was so merciful to you ^{19c}and did so much for you

Mark 5:20

Section 5:1–20: Jesus freed a man whom many evil spirits controlled

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples arrived at the northeastern shore of Lake Galilee. This was a region where many Gentiles lived.

When Jesus and his disciples arrived, a man who was controlled by many evil spirits immediately came to Jesus. Jesus commanded the evil spirits to leave the man. When the evil spirits left, they went to control a large herd of pigs and destroyed those pigs.

“Uncleanness” is a theme in this story. The evil spirits that controlled the man were called “unclean” spirits. Tombs were “unclean.” Jews also considered pigs to be “unclean.” Jesus showed his power over evil spirits when he healed the man.

It is good if you translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus commanded many unclean spirits to leave a man

The deliverance of a man who was controlled by many unclean spirits

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 8:28–34 and Luke 8:26–39.

5:20a

So the man went away

- And he left
- So the man went to his home area and did what Jesus said.

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So is a common connector that is often translated as “and” (RSV). In this context it introduces what the man did when Jesus told him to go home. He did what Jesus told him to do. Connect 5:20 to 5:19 in a natural way in your language.

the man went away: The words went away here indicate that the man obeyed Jesus and went to his home area and to his people. If your readers may not understand that the man obeyed Jesus’ command, you may want to make this explicit. For example:

So the man went to his home area. Then he began to proclaim throughout the Decapolis how much Jesus had done for him.

5:20b

and began to proclaim throughout the Decapolis

- and began to proclaim in the region called the Decapolis
- He even went throughout the area of the Ten Cities telling people

5:20c

how much Jesus had done for him.

- how much Jesus had done to help him.
- the great things that Jesus had done for him.

5:20b–c

and began to proclaim throughout the Decapolis:

The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as began to proclaim can also be translated simply as “told,” as in the GNT. Here Mark used the verb began to introduce an action that occurred not once but many times. It does not imply that the man began to proclaim but

did not finish proclaiming to people in the Decapolis. If it is confusing in your language to use a verb like “begin” here, you may leave this idea implicit, as the REB does:

The man went off and made known throughout the Decapolis what Jesus had done for him

proclaim: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as proclaim means to “tell” or “announce.” It is one of the common verbs that is used in the Bible for proclaiming the good news about Jesus. Use a verb that is natural for telling good news to people, especially for telling the good news about Jesus. Be sure that the word you use does not refer only to what a preacher does when speaking in church.

Decapolis: The name Decapolis means “The Ten Cities.” The Decapolis was a region to the east of Lake Galilee and the Jordan River. The place where this story happened was in the area of the Gerasenes, which was in the region of the Decapolis. In translation you could either:

- Transliterate the name, Decapolis, according to the sounds of your language. For example:

Dikapolise

- Translate the meaning of the name. For example, the GW says:

the Ten Cities

You may also want to include a map or footnote with an explanation. For example:

The region called the Decapolis, which means “the Ten Cities,” was a large area to the east of Lake Galilee and the Jordan River. Some Jews lived in this area, but most of the people living there were Gentiles.

5:20d

And everyone was amazed.

- And/So all the people there were astonished.
- As a result, all the people who heard him marveled at what he said.

And: The Greek word that the BSB translates as And introduces a clause that expresses the result of the man’s actions. This clause is also the conclusion of the

story. Use a natural way to express a concluding result in your language.

everyone was amazed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as was amazed means “marveled.” It refers to the feeling of wonder or awe that comes from seeing or hearing about something extraordinary or wonderful.

Mark 5:21

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a “legion” of “unclean” spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus’ daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cured a woman with chronic bleeding and gave life to a dead girl

The child of Jairus and the woman who touched the hem of Jesus’ clothing

A dead girl and a sick woman (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

5:21a

When Jesus had again crossed by boat to the other side,

- ¶ When Jesus had crossed back again in the boat to the other side of the lake,
- ¶ After that, Jesus with his disciples returned in the boat to the west side of Lake Galilee. When they arrived

When Jesus had again crossed by boat to the other side: At the beginning of this story Jesus crossed the lake to the other side. In some languages it may be most natural to make this statement a complete sentence. For example, the GNT says:

Jesus went back across to the other side of the lake.

When: The events of this story follow immediately after the story about the man whom Jesus freed in 5:1–20. Indicate this in a natural way in your language. In some languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. In other languages, it is natural to begin with a time word or phrase. For example:

After Jesus had again crossed...

As soon as Jesus had returned... (REB)

Jesus: The context implies that Jesus' disciples also went with him to the other side of the lake. Mark does not mention them here because Jesus is in focus. However, in some languages it may be confusing not to include the disciples. If that is true in your language, you may want to mention them. For example:

When Jesus and the disciples had crossed back over

When Jesus had crossed back over with the disciples

again crossed: The phrase again crossed indicates that Jesus and the disciples crossed the lake again in the opposite direction from which they had come. This time they traveled from the northeast side of the lake to the northwest side. (They probably arrived back at or near Capernaum.) In some languages it may be helpful to make this clear. For example:

crossed back over

returned to the other side

by boat: There is a minor textual issue in this verse. Most Greek manuscripts have “in the boat,” but a few omit this phrase. Almost all English versions include this phrase, except the GNT. The GNT may have omitted it for translation reasons, not textual ones. Most English versions specify that Jesus returned to the other side of the lake in the boat. In some languages, this fact may already be implied by the preceding expression “cross over again.” If that is true in your language, it may be more natural to make this phrase implicit. For example, the GNT has:

went back across to the other side of the lake

5:21b

a large crowd gathered around Him beside the sea.

- a large crowd gathered around him when he was near the lake.
- at/on the lakeshore, a big group of people came to him.

a large crowd gathered around Him beside the sea:

The phrase beside the sea gives the location for the following events. It indicates that Jesus was still by the lake when the crowd gathered around him. In some languages, it may be more natural to mention this location first. For example:

while he was by the lake, a large crowd gathered around him

at the lakeside a large crowd gathered around him (GNT)

Mark 5:22

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a “legion” of “unclean” spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead

body of Jairus' daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cured a woman with chronic bleeding and gave life to a dead girl

The child of Jairus and the woman who touched the hem of Jesus' clothing

A dead girl and a sick woman (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

5:22a

A synagogue leader named Jairus arrived,

- Then a man named Jairus who was one of the elders of the local synagogue came there.
- A certain man who was called Jairus also came. He was one of the leaders at the meeting place in that town.

A synagogue leader named Jairus: This phrase introduces Jairus as a new character in the story. Consider how to introduce him in a natural way in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

There was a man named Jairus who was one of the local synagogue elders. He also came there.

There was a man in the crowd who was one of the synagogue officials. His name was Jairus.

A synagogue leader: Each synagogue had one leader or more. These men were responsible to take care of the synagogue building and arrange the synagogue activities and services. Jairus was one of the men who was responsible for this at the synagogue in the town where Jesus was.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

one of the elders of the local synagogue

one of the men who was a leader at the synagogue in that town

If you are using footnotes for background information, you might use one here. For example:

Each synagogue had one or more leaders. These men were not priests or rabbis. They were responsible for taking care of the synagogue building and for arranging the worship services and other activities at the synagogue.

synagogue: A synagogue was a building where Jews gathered to pray, read scripture, teach their beliefs, and worship. The Jews also used the synagogue as a place to gather for cultural activities. There was only one temple (in Jerusalem), but each Jewish community had a synagogue.

Here are some other ways to translate synagogue:

prayer-house of the Jews

meeting-place of the Jews

worship building

house for gathering together

If you make explicit a phrase such as “of the Jews,” be sure that it does not imply that Jesus was not a Jew.

If the word synagogue is already known in your area, you may write it according to the sounds of your language. You may want to include a word or phrase to explain the meaning. For example:

sinagog house/building

Refer to how you translated this term at 1:21b. See synagogue in the Glossary.

arrived: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as arrived is literally “comes.” Using the present tense was a way of introducing an important new event. This word indicates here that Jairus came to the place where Jesus was, near the lake. Probably he went there because he wanted to speak to Jesus.

5:22b and seeing Jesus, he fell at His feet

- When he saw Jesus, he bowed down at his feet,
- As soon as he saw Jesus, he went and knelt face down in front of him to show his respect

seeing Jesus: The phrase seeing Jesus indicates when Jairus knelt down before him. One way to express the meaning of this phrase is as the GNT has done:

when he saw Jesus

he fell at His feet: The phrase he fell at His feet means that Jairus knelt in front of Jesus and lowered his face to the ground. It does not mean that he fell accidentally. Bowing down like this was a way to show respect and honor to someone of high position. See how you translated the similar expressions at 3:11b and 5:6b.

Mark 5:23

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a “legion” of “unclean” spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus’ daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cured a woman with chronic bleeding and gave life to a dead girl

The child of Jairus and the woman who touched the hem of Jesus’ clothing

A dead girl and a sick woman (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

5:23a and pleaded with Him urgently,

- and fervently begged him,
- and passionately pleaded with him,

pleaded with Him urgently: The Greek word that the BSB translates as pleaded indicates that the man greatly desired what he was pleading for. The same word has occurred at 1:40b, 5:10, 5:12, 5:17 and 5:18b. Here this verb is emphasized by the Greek word that the BSB translates as urgently. Use a natural expression in your language for this type of request. Here are some examples:

begged him earnestly (NJB)

pleaded fervently with him

5:23b “My little daughter is near death.

- “My young daughter is near death.
- “Teacher, my dear daughter is about to die.
- He told Jesus that his little girl was dying

My little daughter: In 5:42 the text indicates that Jairus’ daughter was twelve years old. When Jairus called her little, it was a term of affection. It did not mean that she was a very young child or that she was not tall. Use an appropriate term in your language for a daughter of that age. If the terms for “young daughter” in your language imply that she was younger than twelve, you may want to use a term of affection instead. For example:

my dear daughter

my much-loved female child

is near death: The Greek phraseA Greek idiom, literally: “to have finally.” that the BSB translates as is near death means to be very sick and almost dead. You may have an idiom or a euphemism for this in your language.

Here is another way to translate this:

is close to death

is about to die

5:23c

Please come and place Your hands on her,

- Please come^(sing) and place your^(sing) hands on her
- I humbly beg you^(sing) to come to my house and touch her
- and begged him to come and touch her

Please come and place Your hands on her: Jairus used a polite form in Greek for making a humble request. Use a form in your language that is polite and appropriate for this context. For example:

Would you please come...

I beg you to come...

I would be most grateful if you would come...

place Your hands on her: In that culture it was common for a healer to place his hands on the person who needed to be healed. Jesus often did this when he healed someone. He might touch the part of the body that needed healing. Use an appropriate way to express this in your language.

5:23d

so that she will be healed and live."

- so that she will recover and will continue to live."
- so that she will be saved from death/dying."
- so that she would be healed and not die.

so that she will be healed and live: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as so that she will be healed and live is literally "that she may be saved and may live." She was still alive at the time when her father said this. You may need to indicate this in some way in your language. In some languages it may be more natural to use a phrase that means "continue to live." In other languages it may be natural to use only one verb phrase. For example:

so that she will be saved from death

she will be healed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as healed is the same word that is commonly used in the Bible to mean "saved, rescued." In this context, it means "saved/rescued from illness" or "healed." It is a passive verb. If it is more natural in

your language to use an active verb, you may be able to translate this as:

she will get better

you^(sing) will heal her

If you have an expression that could be used for both "rescue from sins" and "rescue from an illness," consider using it here.

Mark 5:24

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a "legion" of "unclean" spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus' daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cured a woman with chronic bleeding and gave life to a dead girl

The child of Jairus and the woman who touched the hem of Jesus' clothing

A dead girl and a sick woman (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

5:24a

So Jesus went with him,

- And Jesus agreed and went with him.
- So Jesus went with Jairus toward his house, and his disciples went too.

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *So* is a simple connector that is often translated as “and,” as in the RSV. Here it connects Jairus’s request to Jesus’ response. Some English versions translate it as “So” here, because what Jesus did was the expected response to the man’s request in 5:23. Connect 5:24 to 5:23 in a natural way in your language.

Jesus: It is clear that Jesus’ disciples went with him (see 5:31). So in some languages it may be more natural to include them here. For example:

Jesus and the/his disciples went with him.

went with him: In this context the phrase went with him indicates that Jesus and his disciples started to go with Jairus toward his house. It does not indicate that they arrived there. The GNT says:

Then Jesus started off with him.

5:24b

and a large crowd followed and pressed around Him.

- Many people accompanied him/them and pressed against Jesus.
- Many people from that crowd went too. They surrounded Jesus closely so that their bodies pushed against him as they went.

a large crowd: This crowd did not necessarily include all the people in the crowd that was mentioned in 5:21. The BSB indicates this by referring to “a large crowd.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

a large group of people from that crowd

many people from the crowd

many people

followed and pressed around Him: The phrase followed and pressed around Him means that the people of the crowd were walking very close behind Jesus and

around him. They were so close that as they walked, they pressed against him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

followed along and kept crowding around (CEV)

followed Jesus and pushed very close around him (NCV)

Mark 5:25

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a “legion” of “unclean” spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus’ daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cured a woman with chronic bleeding and gave life to a dead girl

The child of Jairus and the woman who touched the hem of Jesus’ clothing

A dead girl and a sick woman (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 5:25–34

This paragraph begins a new story that happens before the story of Jairus ends. It describes how Jesus helped someone else before he arrived at Jairus' house. Introduce it in a way that is natural in your language for such a context.

5:25a**And a woman was there**

- ¶ Meanwhile, there was a woman among them
- ¶ In that crowd there was a woman

And a woman was there: This verse introduces a new story, that is, a new series of events. It is about how Jesus helped a certain woman. This verse introduces the woman and gives background information about her. Introduce the woman in a natural way in your language. For example:

There was a woman who... (GNT)

In the crowd was a woman who... (GW)

Meanwhile, a woman had come into the crowd. She...

5:25b–26b**had suffered from bleeding...had borne...had spent:**

The Greek verbs that the BSB translates as had suffered from bleeding, had borne, and had spent describe the woman's situation before she came to Jesus. These events happened over a period of time. Use appropriate forms in your language to refer to background events in a story.

5:25b**who had suffered from bleeding for twelve years.**

- who had endured chronic bleeding for twelve years.
- who had suffered from a female bleeding disorder for twelve years.

who had suffered from bleeding for twelve years:

The Greek clause that the BSB translates as who had suffered from bleeding is literally “being in a flow of blood.” It means that the woman had a sickness that caused her to bleed from her womb/uterus at times when it was not normal.

Consider if people in your culture would describe this condition with a euphemism. Use a phrase that would be clearly understood and yet would be suitable for public reading. Your translation should not imply that the bleeding was caused from a cut or wound.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

whose bleeding never stopped for twelve years

who had had a female disorder for twelve years

The woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. If you are using footnotes for background information, you may want to use one here. For example:

According to the law of Moses (Leviticus 15:19–30), a woman with menstrual bleeding or other bleeding from her womb was considered ritually unclean.

Mark 5:26**Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again**

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a “legion” of “unclean” spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus' daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cured a woman with chronic bleeding and gave life to a dead girl

The child of Jairus and the woman who touched the hem of Jesus' clothing

A dead girl and a sick woman (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 5:25–34

This paragraph begins a new story that happens before the story of Jairus ends. It describes how Jesus helped someone else before he arrived at Jairus' house. Introduce it in a way that is natural in your language for such a context.

5:26a

She had borne much agony under the care of many physicians

- She had suffered greatly/terribly from many doctors that she went to for treatment
- She consulted many doctors for help, but they caused her much suffering/trouble.

She had borne much agony under the care of many physicians: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as She had borne much agony under the care of many physicians indicates that doctors and their treatments had caused her much suffering. They probably caused both pain and financial loss.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Doctors that she went to for treatment caused her to suffer much

She had gone to many doctors, and they had not done anything except cause her a lot of pain. (CEV)

5:26b

and had spent all she had,

- and had paid them all that she had to give,
- She gave them what they demanded in payment for her treatment until she used up all her money.

and had spent all she had: This phrase indicates that the woman had already used all her resources to pay the doctors for her treatments. She may have paid in money or goods. She had nothing left that she could use to pay for more help.

General Comment on 5:26a–b

In some languages it may be natural to change the order of 5:26a and 5:26b. For example:

^{26b}She had spent all she had ^{26a}going to see many different doctors. She had endured a lot of different treatments....

^{26a}She had used up all her money ^{26b}on the painful treatments ordered/prescribed by many physicians

5:26c

but to no avail.

- and she did not become well.
- But her bleeding became worse

5:26d

Instead, her condition had only grown worse.

- Instead she became worse.
- and not better.

5:26c–d

but to no avail. Instead, her condition had only grown worse: The Greek phrases that the BSB translates as but to no avail and Instead show strong contrast. The woman had hoped that her condition would improve. But the opposite was true; her bleeding increased.

her condition had only grown worse: The woman's illness became more severe. This happened during a period of years before she came to Jesus. Use an appropriate verb form in your language.

Mark 5:27

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a "legion" of "unclean" spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus' daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cured a woman with chronic bleeding and gave life to a dead girl

The child of Jairus and the woman who touched the hem of Jesus' clothing

A dead girl and a sick woman (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 5:25–34

This paragraph begins a new story that happens before the story of Jairus ends. It describes how Jesus helped someone else before he arrived at Jairus' house. Introduce it in a way that is natural in your language for such a context.

5:27a

When the woman heard about Jesus,

- She had heard about the things that Jesus had done,
- When she heard that Jesus healed people, she decided that she must go to him.

When the woman heard about Jesus: The woman heard about Jesus at some time in the past. This was the reason that she joined the crowd. She hoped that she would be able to touch Jesus. The text does not indicate when she heard about Jesus.

In some languages you may need to make explicit what she had heard about Jesus. For example:

when she heard about the things that Jesus had done
There is a textual variant (that, as Edwards says on page 164, is supported by “a small but weighty number of manuscripts”) that is close to this model. If we are to supply an object for what the woman heard, it seems that staying close to the variant would be a good choice.

when she heard that Jesus healed people

5:27b–28

The woman's thought in 5:28 happened before her action in 5:27b. In some languages it may be more natural to reorder 5:27b and 5:28. See the General Comment on 5:27–28 after 5:28 for an example.

5:27b

she came up through the crowd behind Him and touched His cloak.

- and so she came close behind him in the crowd. Then she touched his outer garment.
- So she approached him from behind in the crowd so he would not notice her, and she touched his robe.

she came up through the crowd behind Him: The woman came to Jesus from behind Him because she did not want him to notice her.

and touched His cloak: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as touched is the main verb in 5:25–27. The text emphasizes the woman's action of touching Jesus' cloak. See the General Comment on 5:25–27 below about this.

cloak: The Greek word that the BSB translates as cloak refers to a long, loose outer garment like a coat or robe. If such a garment is not worn in your area, you may want to use a general expression. For example:

clothing

garment

Be careful not to use a term that would imply foreign or expensive clothing.

General Comment on 5:25–27

In 5:25–27, there are eight verbs. The first seven verbs are dependent forms. This indicates that the main action is “touched.” Mark emphasized the action of the woman touching Jesus' cloak. Here is a literal translation of the verbs:

...a woman being in a flow of blood..., and having suffered much..., and having spent all that she had, and not having benefited anything, but rather having come to the worse, hearing about Jesus, coming behind in the crowd, she touched his cloak.

Consider whether there is a natural way in your language to emphasize the action of touching Jesus' cloak.

Mark 5:28

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to

have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a “legion” of “unclean” spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus’ daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cured a woman with chronic bleeding and gave life to a dead girl

The child of Jairus and the woman who touched the hem of Jesus’ clothing

A dead girl and a sick woman (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 5:25–34

This paragraph begins a new story that happens before the story of Jairus ends. It describes how Jesus helped someone else before he arrived at Jairus’ house. Introduce it in a way that is natural in your language for such a context.

5:28

For she kept saying, “If only I touch His garments, I will be healed.”

- For she said to herself, “If I touch even his clothes, I will be healed.”
- She believed that even if she could touch only his clothing, his power would rescue/save her.
- She did this because she thought, “The only thing I need to do to get well is to touch his clothing.”

For: The word For in the BSB introduces the explanation for 5:27b. The woman touched Jesus’ cloak because she believed that this was all she needed to do in order to be healed. Use a natural way in your language to indicate that 5:28 is the reason for what the woman did in 5:27b.

she kept saying, “If only I touch His garments, I will be healed”: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as kept saying is literally “said.” This verb can refer to either spoken words or thoughts. The implication here is that the woman kept saying this to herself.

If you translate the words that follow as direct speech, be sure to use a verb that can introduce direct speech. In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech here. For example:

She thought that if she just touched his clothes, she would be healed.

only: The Greek word that the BSB translates as only indicates here that the only thing the woman needed to do to be healed was to touch Jesus’ clothes. She believed that Jesus’ power was so great that even touching his clothes would be enough to heal her. It was not necessary to actually touch a part of his body.

garments: The Greek word that the BSB translates as garments is the plural of the word that was translated as “cloak” in 5:27b. It refers to clothes in general.

healed: See the note on healed at 5:23d.

General Comment on 5:27–28

In some languages it may be more natural to combine these verses and change the order of some of the information. For example:

^{27a}The woman heard about Jesus, ²⁸and she thought, “If I just touch his clothes, I will be healed.” ^{27b}So she came behind him in the crowd and touched his cloak.

Mark 5:29

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a “legion” of “unclean” spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus’ daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

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The child of Jairus and the woman who touched the hem of Jesus’ clothing

A dead girl and a sick woman (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 5:25–34

This paragraph begins a new story that happens before the story of Jairus ends. It describes how Jesus helped someone else before he arrived at Jairus’ house. Introduce it in a way that is natural in your language for such a context.

5:29a

Immediately her bleeding stopped,

- Instantly her bleeding stopped,
- As soon as she touched it, her bleeding disorder ended/ceased,

her bleeding stopped: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as her bleeding stopped is literally “her spring/fountain of blood dried up.” See NJB: “the source of the bleeding dried up.” This is picturesque language and comes directly from the Greek translation of Leviticus 12:7. Consider if it is appropriate to use a euphemism in this context. Use a natural way in your language to indicate that the woman was healed from the condition that caused her bleeding.

5:29b

and she sensed in her body that she was healed of her affliction.

- and she sensed inside her body that she was relieved from her pain/affliction.
- and she felt something inside her body and knew that Jesus had healed her terrible disease.

and she sensed in her body: This clause indicates that the woman felt something happen inside her body, and it caused her to know that she had been healed.

that she was healed of her affliction: The Greek word that the BSB translates as affliction literally refers to a “whip” or “scourge” used for beating people. It is often used in a figurative way to refer to diseases, especially to diseases that cause great pain or suffering. It is used in that way here. If possible, use a word that refers to a sickness that causes suffering.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

painful disease

suffering (NIV)

Use a verb that is natural with your translation of affliction to translate the Greek word that the BSB translates as she was healed. For example:

she was healed from her disease

she was freed/rescued from her affliction

she was relieved from her pain/suffering

Mark 5:30

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a “legion” of “unclean” spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the

bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus' daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

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There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 5:25–34

This paragraph begins a new story that happens before the story of Jairus ends. It describes how Jesus helped someone else before he arrived at Jairus' house. Introduce it in a way that is natural in your language for such a context.

5:30a

At once Jesus was aware that power had gone out from Him.

- Immediately, Jesus perceived/knew that power to heal someone had gone out from him.
- And as soon as it happened, Jesus sensed that some of his power had just proceeded from him.

Jesus was aware: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as was aware is literally “knew in himself.” In some languages it may be natural to use a word like “sensed” or “perceived” to express this idea.

that power had gone out from Him: In this context the word power refers to Jesus' power to heal people or work other miracles. It does not refer to physical strength. You may want to make this clear. For example:

healing power

power to work/do miracles

Be careful not to imply that Jesus had no power left. One way to avoid that in English is:

Jesus realized that some power had gone out from him.

5:30b

Turning to the crowd,

- So he turned around in the crowd
- Then he turned and faced the people behind him

Jesus' action in 5:30b was in response to what he perceived in 5:30a. Some English versions make this clear by connecting 5:30b to 5:30a with the conjunction “so,” as in the GNT. Connect 5:30b to 5:30a in a way that is natural in your language.

Turning to the crowd: The phrase Turning to the crowd means that Jesus turned to face the many people who were behind him.

5:30c

He asked, “Who touched My garments?”

- and asked, “Who touched my robe?”
- and asked them, “Who touched my clothes/cloak?”
- and asked them who touched his clothes.

He asked, “Who touched My garments?”: The text does not indicate to whom Jesus spoke when he asked who touched his clothes. It is likely that he spoke to the people who were near him in the crowd. He wanted the person who touched him to tell him that. In some languages you may need to indicate to whom Jesus was speaking: For example:

asked those near him

asked the crowd behind him

garments: The Greek word that the BSB translates as garments is the same word that was used in 5:28.

General Comment on 5:30a–c

In 5:30a Mark explained what Jesus said and did in 5:30b–c. In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the order and give the action before the explanation. For example:

^{30b}Jesus turned around in the crowd ^{30c}and asked, “Who touched my clothes?” ^{30a}He did this because he realized that power had gone out from him.

Mark 5:31

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a “legion” of “unclean” spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus’ daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cured a woman with chronic bleeding and gave life to a dead girl

The child of Jairus and the woman who touched the hem of Jesus’ clothing

A dead girl and a sick woman (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 5:25–34

This paragraph begins a new story that happens before the story of Jairus ends. It describes how Jesus helped someone else before he arrived at Jairus’ house. Introduce it in a way that is natural in your language for such a context.

5:31a

His disciples answered, “You can see the crowd pressing in on You,

- His disciples replied, “You^(sing) can see that the crowd is pressing against you;
- His followers responded, “You^(sing) surely are aware of the crowd of people who surround and push against you on all sides.

His disciples answered: Some translations place the phrase his disciples answered after what they said. In the Greek text, it comes before the speech begins. Place it where it is most natural in your language.

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means “learners” who are in a relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Here are some other ways to translate disciples:

- Use a term that refers to people who learn from a teacher or an expert. It is helpful if the term also implies that the learners are often with their teacher. For example:

learners/students

apprentices Be careful not to use a term that would refer only to a student in a school or classroom.

- Use a term that refers to people who follow a teacher or leader by obeying his teaching. It is helpful if this term also implies learning from the teacher and actually following the teacher wherever he goes. For example:

followers

those who are committed/faithful (to a teacher/leader)

See how you translated this term in 2:15b. See also disciple in the Glossary.

answered: The Greek word that the BSB translates as answered is literally “said.” In some languages a word like “said” may be more natural than “answered” because the disciples did not really answer the question “Who touched me?”

pressing in on You: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as pressing in on is the same one that was

translated “pressed around” in 5:24b. See how you translated it there.

5:31b

and yet You ask, ‘Who touched Me?’”

- how can you ask, “Who touched me?” (NJB)
- It amazes/puzzles us that you ask who touched you!”

and yet You ask, ‘Who touched Me?’: In 5:31b the disciples asked a rhetorical question about Jesus’ real question in 5:30b. In their question the disciples repeated what Jesus had asked (but changed the words “my clothes” to the word Me).

The disciples used this rhetorical question to express their surprise at what Jesus had asked. There were so many people crowding around Jesus that his question seemed strange or unnecessary.

There are at least two ways to translate this rhetorical question.

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

And yet do you ask, “Who touched me?”

Why do you ask, “Who touched me?”

How can it be that you ask such a question as “Who touched me?”

- As a statement. For example:

It is very strange that you should ask “Who touched me?”

We do not understand why you ask “Who touched me?”

Use whichever form is most natural in your language for this kind of restatement.

In some languages it may be more natural to make 5:31b into an indirect question. For example, the CEV says:

How can you ask who touched you?

In some languages, “touching” a man or woman is a euphemism for sex. If this is true in your language, you may rephrase the disciples’ words to repeat the words that Jesus used in his question. For example:

...touched my clothes?

Mark 5:32

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a “legion” of “unclean” spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus’ daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cured a woman with chronic bleeding and gave life to a dead girl

The child of Jairus and the woman who touched the hem of Jesus’ clothing

A dead girl and a sick woman (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 5:25–34

This paragraph begins a new story that happens before the story of Jairus ends. It describes how Jesus helped someone else before he arrived at Jairus’ house. Introduce it in a way that is natural in your language for such a context.

5:32

But He kept looking around to see who had done this.

- Jesus continued to look around in order to see who had done this.
- But Jesus continued to look at the crowd in order to discover the woman who had touched him.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But is a simple connector that is often translated as “and” in English. In this context many English versions use “But” because there is a contrast between 5:32 and 5:31. In 5:31, the disciples implied that it was useless for Jesus to seek who touched him in the middle of a pressing crowd. But in 5:32, Jesus continued to try to discover who touched him. Connect these verses in a natural way to express the contrast in your language.

He kept looking around: The phrase kept looking around indicates that Jesus had already begun to look behind him in 5:30. The imperfect form of the verb may also be a contributing factor here. However, there are other imperfects in this passage (5:24, 30, 31) that English versions do not tend to translate in this way. Another way to say this in English is as the NJB has done:

he continued to look all around

Use a natural expression to express this meaning in your language.

He: The pronoun He refers to Jesus.

to see: The phrase to see expresses the purpose for which Jesus looked around. In this context it means “to discover” or “to know.”

who had done this: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as who had done this is literally “the one (feminine) who had done this.” (NASB has “the woman who had done this.”) English does not need to indicate here whether the person was male or female. If your language requires you to indicate this, it is recommended that you follow the Greek and use a feminine form.

Mark 5:33

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless

for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a “legion” of “unclean” spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus’ daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

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Paragraph 5:25–34

This paragraph begins a new story that happens before the story of Jairus ends. It describes how Jesus helped someone else before he arrived at Jairus’ house. Introduce it in a way that is natural in your language for such a context.

5:33

The order of the clauses of this verse is different in Greek than in most English versions. See the General Comment on 5:33a–c at the end of 5:33c for discussion of this issue.

5:33a

Then the woman, knowing what had happened to her,

- Then the woman, because she knew what had happened to her,
- The woman knew that she had been healed,
- The woman knew that Jesus’ power had healed her,

Then: The connector Then in the BSB introduces the woman's reaction as Jesus continued to look around to discover who touched him. She knew that she was the person whom he had healed. Although she was afraid, she came, bowed at Jesus' feet, and told him all about it. Introduce this verse in an appropriate way in your language.

knowing what had happened to her: This phrase expresses the reason that the woman came and bowed at the feet of Jesus. Some versions and commentaries understand "knowing what had happened to her" as the reason for her fear and trembling. See, for example, REB, NLT, JBP, TRT; Hooker, Stein, Strauss. We have interpreted the clause as connecting with the series of main verbs, "came ... fell ... told", judging that is more likely for a participial clause ("knowing ...") to modify the main verbs rather than another participial clause ("fearing and trembling"). This interpretation of the syntax is followed by GNT, NCV, T4T, and Cranfield. She knew that she had been healed (5:29). She knew she was the one that Jesus was seeking. And so she came to him, maybe with mixed feelings of fear, joy, and gratitude. Indicate in a natural way in your language that this gives the reason for her coming to Jesus. For example, the GNT says:

The woman realized what had happened to her,
so she came, trembling with fear,...

If you think it may not be clear what knowing what had happened to her refers to, consider making this explicit. For example, the NCV says:

knowing that she was healed

5:33b

came and fell down before Him

- came and bowed down at Jesus' feet,
- so she came close to Jesus and knelt face down before him.

came: The woman was already near Jesus in the crowd. In some languages it may be more natural to use a verb that means to come a short distance or to come close to a person. For example:

she approached him

she came just in front of him

fell down before Him: The phrase fell down before Him indicates that she kneeled or bowed down with

her face to the ground in front of Jesus to show respect. She did not fall accidentally. See how you translated the similar expression in 5:22b.

5:33c

trembling in fear, and she told Him the whole truth.

- and she admitted that she had touched him. As she did these things, she was shaking because she was afraid.
- Frightened and shaking, she told him all about what she had done and what had happened to her.

trembling in fear: The Greek words that the BSB translates as trembling in fear are literally "fearing and trembling." These words indicate that the woman was so afraid that she was shaking. These words describe what the woman felt during all of her actions in this verse: "came," "fell," and "told."

The text does not say the exact reason that the woman feared. This fear (or great awe) may have been due to being in the presence of the power of God and being the one blessed by receiving a great miracle. Or the fear may have been due the fact that her illness had made her ritually unclean. As an unclean person, she had broken the Jewish law by touching Jesus and also by being in the crowd. She may have been afraid that Jesus and the people would be angry. Because the biblical text does not make clear the reason for her fear, it is recommended that you do not make it explicit either in your translation.

told Him the whole truth: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as told Him the whole truth means that the woman admitted that she was the one who had touched Jesus. It may also imply that she also told Jesus about her illness.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

admitted/confessed that she had done this

told him the whole story (CEV)

told him what she had done (NLT)

General Comment on 5:33a–c

The order of the clauses of this verse is different in Greek than in most English versions. In Greek, the order of the clauses is:

The woman, fearing and trembling, knowing what had happened to her, came and fell before him, and said to him the whole truth.

Consider the order that would be most natural in your language.

Mark 5:34

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a “legion” of “unclean” spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus’ daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cured a woman with chronic bleeding and gave life to a dead girl

The child of Jairus and the woman who touched the hem of Jesus’ clothing

A dead girl and a sick woman (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 5:25–34

This paragraph begins a new story that happens before the story of Jairus ends. It describes how Jesus helped someone else before he arrived at Jairus’ house. Introduce it in a way that is natural in your language for such a context.

5:34a

“Daughter,” said Jesus, “your faith has healed you.

- But he told the woman, “Daughter/Sister, you^(sing) are well now because you trusted in me.
- Jesus said to her, “Dear woman, because you^(sing) had confidence that I could heal you, you have become well.
- Jesus spoke kindly to the woman. He said, “The reason you have been healed is because of your faith.

This verse in Greek begins with a conjunction that shows contrast. Jesus’ kind words in this verse contrast with the fear that the woman felt. The BSB and most English versions have not translated the Greek conjunction, though some translate it as “And” (RSV) or “But” (JBP). Connect these verses in a way that naturally shows contrast in your language.

Daughter: Jesus called the woman Daughter to show his kind concern for her and so to reassure her. Daughter was an appropriate term for a teacher like Jesus to use to speak kindly to a woman.

The word Daughter does not imply here that the woman was literally Jesus’ daughter. It also does not imply that she was much younger than Jesus. The text does not indicate whether she was younger or older. In some languages it may not be natural to use a word like Daughter here, or it may imply a wrong meaning. Use an appropriate term in your language for this context. If no term is appropriate, you may leave it implied. For example:

Jesus said to the woman, “You are now well...”

Refer also to the way you translated “son” in 2:5c.

your faith has healed you: The noun faith refers here to the action of believing and trusting Jesus. Your faith has healed you implies that the woman believed that Jesus would heal her. In some languages it may be more natural to translate faith as a verb. If that is true in your language, you may also need to make explicit who or what was believed.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

You trusted in me and that has healed you.

You are well because you believed that I could heal you.

See believe, meaning 3, in the Glossary.

has healed you: See the note on healed at 5:23d. The tense of the Greek verb here implies that the woman was healed in the past, when she touched Jesus' clothes. She was now well. Use the appropriate verb form in your language for this.

5:34b

Go in peace

- Go^(sing), and may God's peace be with you.
- You may return to your home with the peace that comes from God.

Go in peace: The phrase Go in peace was a common blessing that a Jewish person gave to someone who was leaving. It means "may you go with the peace that God gives." Jesus used this blessing here to reassure the woman.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Go and may God give you his peace.

You may go home now with the blessing of God's peace.

peace: In Jewish cultures the word peaceThe word "peace" here is a translation of the Hebrew word shalom (the word that Jesus probably spoke here). refers to serenity and the absence of conflict. It often indicates a relationship with God and all the benefits that come from that relationship, such as security, health, and prosperity. Here Jesus' blessing of peace focuses on health and the relationship with God that the woman had because she was no longer ritually impure.

5:34c

and be free of your affliction."

- You^(sing) are indeed completely healed from your pain/affliction."
- Your painful disease will not return."

be free: The Greek words that the BSB translates as be free are literally "be well." See the note on "she was healed" at 5:29b. You will probably want to use the same word or expression here. The woman was already healed when she touched Jesus' clothes in 5:27. However, Jesus spoke these words of healing to confirm what was already done and to assure her that she would remain healed.

Jesus spoke these words as a command. In some languages it may be difficult or unnatural to command someone to "be well."

Here are some other ways to translate this:

You are now well...

I pronounce you healed...

of your affliction: See the note on "of her affliction" at 5:29b.

Mark 5:35

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a "legion" of "unclean" spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus' daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cured a woman with chronic bleeding and gave life to a dead girl

The child of Jairus and the woman who touched the hem of Jesus' clothing

A dead girl and a sick woman (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 5:35–43

In this paragraph, Mark returned to the story about Jairus and his daughter. Use a natural way in your

language to focus again on the people who were introduced before the story about Jairus was interrupted in 5:25.

5:35a

While He was still speaking,

- ¶ While he was still saying this,
- ¶ Before Jesus finished speaking to the woman,

5:35b

messengers from the house of Jairus arrived

- some people arrived from the house of the synagogue elder/leader
- some messengers from the household of Jairus came to Jairus.

5:35a–b

While He was still speaking, messengers from the house of Jairus arrived: Jesus was still speaking to the woman whom he healed when some men came. Express this timing in a natural way in your language.

In some languages it may be helpful to mention who Jesus was speaking to. For example:

While Jesus was still speaking to her

As Jesus was still talking to the woman

messengers...arrived: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as messengers...arrived is literally, “they came.” The people who came may have been slaves, or they may have been friends or members of Jairus’ family. Translate this in a general way. For example:

some people (NJB)

some messengers (GNT)

some men (NIV)

from the house of Jairus: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as from the house of Jairus is literally “from the synagogue ruler.” The BSB and many other English versions supply from the house of because Jairus himself was already with Jesus. The BSB supplies the name Jairus to help identify him.

Consider what would be the most natural way in your language to refer to Jairus, the synagogue ruler, at this point in the story. In some languages it may be enough to simply say “Jairus.” In other languages it may be more natural to avoid using Jairus’ name here and to

simply say “the synagogue leader.” See the note on “A synagogue leader” at 5:22a.

5:35c

and said, “Your daughter is dead;

- and said, “Your daughter is dead.
- They told him, “Your daughter has just passed away.
- They told him that his daughter had died,

and said: The men were talking here to Jairus, who was still with Jesus. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

They said to Jairus

They told the synagogue leader

Some translations place the phrase they said after the words “Your daughter is dead.” In the Greek text, it comes before these words. Place it where it is most natural in your language.

Your daughter is dead: Use a natural expression in your language to tell someone that a family member has died. In many languages, there will be a euphemism for this.

5:35d

why bother the Teacher anymore?”

- Is there any need for you^(sing) to trouble the teacher any longer?”
- Perhaps you^(sing)/we^(incl) should not trouble the teacher any longer by asking him to come to the house.”
- and he should not bother the teacher any more.

why bother the Teacher anymore?: This is a rhetorical question. The men asked this question to suggest that Jairus should leave Jesus and should no longer expect Jesus to go to his house. They believed that Jesus could not do anything to help someone who had already died.

There are at least two ways to translate this suggestion:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

What reason is there to continue to trouble the teacher?

Do you need to bother the teacher any longer?

- As a statement. For example:

Perhaps you should not trouble the teacher any further.

Let us leave the teacher, now that there is no reason to disturb him.

There is no need to bother the teacher anymore. (NCV)

Use whichever form is most natural to express a suggestion of this kind in your language. In some languages it may be helpful to supply the implied information that is the reason for giving this advice:

It is too late to save your daughter. Do not bother the teacher any more.

bother: The Greek word that the BSB translates as bother here means “to trouble (someone).” The men assumed that Jesus was a busy teacher and that Jairus had troubled Jesus by asking him to heal his daughter. In this context, bother does not mean to do something purposely to annoy someone.

In some languages, there may be another word or phrase that expresses this sense more clearly. In other languages it may be helpful to make explicit the sense of bother. For example:

do not bother the teacher any longer by urging/ asking him to go to your house

the Teacher: The phrase the Teacher here refers to Jesus. The Greek word that the BSB translates as Teacher was a polite title for a Jewish religious leader. It was a title of respect for a Jewish man who had authority to teach the things about God. If you have another term in your language to refer to a religious leader or teacher, it may be appropriate to use it here.

See how you translated this term at 4:38c where “Teacher” is used as a term of address. Be careful not to use a term that can refer only to a school teacher.

Mark 5:36

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His

miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a “legion” of “unclean” spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus’ daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

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A dead girl and a sick woman (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 5:35–43

In this paragraph, Mark returned to the story about Jairus and his daughter. Use a natural way in your language to focus again on the people who were introduced before the story about Jairus was interrupted in 5:25.

5:36a

But Jesus overheard their conversation

- Jesus overheard what they said
- But Jesus had heard what they had said

But: In Greek this verse begins with a conjunction that often shows contrast. Though the words of 5:35b–c were spoken to Jairus, Jesus heard them. To show this, the BSB and some other English versions begin this verse with “But.” Connect these verses in a way that is natural in your language.

Jesus overheard their conversation: There are two ways to interpret the meaning of the Greek word that the BSB translates as overheard:

1. It means to “overhear.” Jesus heard the words spoken in 5:35b–c although they were not spoken to him. For example, the NJB says:

Jesus overheard what they said (BSB, NJB, NRSV, NASB, REB, GW, CEV, JBP)

1. It means to “ignore” something that is said. Here Jesus did not agree that he should not go to Jairus’ house because his daughter was dead. For example, the GNT says:

Jesus paid no attention to what they said (RSV, NIV, GNT, NET, NLT96, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The Greek word can mean both (1) and (2), and both are true in this context. But interpretation (2) implies interpretation (1).

5:36b and said to Jairus,

- and told the synagogue elder/leader,
- to Jairus. So he said to him,
- So he told Jairus

and said to Jairus: Here the Greek describes Jairus by his title. Consider again if it would be more natural in your language to refer to him by name (“Jairus”), as the BSB does, or by his title/function (“the synagogue leader”).

5:36c “Do not be afraid; just believe.”

- “Do^(sing) not fear. Instead just keep^(sing) believing.”
- “Do^(sing) not be distressed/afraid. Only continue^(sing) to trust me.”
- to not be afraid but to trust him.

Do not be afraid; just believe: These two expressions of encouragement contrast with each other. The first says what Jairus should not do; the second says what he should do. In some languages it may be natural to connect them with a word of contrast. For example:

Do not be afraid. Instead just believe.

Do not be afraid: Consider if “afraid” is the way people in your culture would describe the emotion that Jairus would have felt in this context. In some

languages it may be better to use a different expression. For example:

Do not be distressed/troubled

Do not despair

just believe: The Greek word that the BSB translates as believe means to be confident of something or to trust someone. In this verse, Jesus did not say explicitly what or who Jairus should believe. In this context, it probably means that Jairus should continue to believe that Jesus could help his daughter.

In some languages a verb like “believe” or “trust” requires an object. If that is true in your language, here are some examples for this context:

only keep trusting me

just continue to believe that I can save your daughter

Mark 5:37

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a “legion” of “unclean” spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus’ daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cured a woman with chronic bleeding and gave life to a dead girl

The child of Jairus and the woman who touched the hem of Jesus' clothing

A dead girl and a sick woman (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 5:35–43

In this paragraph, Mark returned to the story about Jairus and his daughter. Use a natural way in your language to focus again on the people who were introduced before the story about Jairus was interrupted in 5:25.

5:37a

And He did not allow anyone to accompany Him

- He/Jesus did not permit the people in the crowd to accompany him/them.
- He allowed only certain people to go with him to Jairus' house.

He did not allow anyone to accompany Him: The clause He did not allow anyone to accompany Him indicates that Jesus dismissed the crowd that was following him, including most of his disciples.

Him: The pronoun Him refers to Jesus, but Jairus (and probably the men who brought the message about his daughter's death) went with him too. In some languages, you may want to say "them" instead of Him to make this clear. In other languages it may be better to be even more specific:

He did not let anyone follow him and Jairus...

5:37b

except Peter, James, and John the brother of James.

- He allowed only Peter, James, and John the brother of James to come.
- They were Peter, James, and John (the younger brother of James).

John the brother of James: John was probably the younger brother of James. If your language must distinguish between older and younger brothers, use

the appropriate term in your language. See how you translated this at 1:19b and 3:17a.

General Comment on 5:37a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of information and mention first the people whom Jesus allowed to go with him. For example:

^{37b}He allowed only Peter, James, and John the brother of James to go with him and Jairus. ^{37a}He did not allow others in the crowd to go.

Mark 5:38

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a "legion" of "unclean" spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus' daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

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Jesus cured a woman with chronic bleeding and gave life to a dead girl

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A dead girl and a sick woman (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 5:35–43

In this paragraph, Mark returned to the story about Jairus and his daughter. Use a natural way in your language to focus again on the people who were introduced before the story about Jairus was interrupted in 5:25.

5:38a

When they arrived at the house of the synagogue leader,

- When they arrived with the synagogue elder at his home,
- When Jesus, Jairus, and the others arrived at Jairus' house,

5:38b

Jesus saw the commotion and the people weeping and wailing loudly.

- Jesus saw that people there were making a commotion. They were crying out and wailing loudly.
- Jesus heard noisy excitement and confusion. People were wailing grievously in mourning.

5:38a–b

Jesus saw the commotion and the people weeping and wailing loudly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as commotion refers here to noisy, confused activity. In some languages, it may be more natural to say that Jesus heard a commotion rather than saw a commotion.

weeping and wailing The verbs weeping and wailing describe the nature of the commotion. Use a natural way in your language to indicate this. For example:

Jesus saw the confusion and heard all the loud crying and wailing (GNT)

he saw noisy confusion and people weeping and wailing loudly (NET)

weeping and wailing loudly: The Greek words that the BSB translates as weeping and wailing loudly are very similar in meaning. The word weeping refers to crying as an outward expression of grief or sorrow. The word wailing refers to intense or loud weeping. It is emphasized by the word that the BSB translates as loudly.

Use words in your language that describe the way that people weep and cry out when they mourn over someone's death. If you have one word that describes

this kind of weeping and wailing, you could use it instead of two different words.

Mark 5:39

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a “legion” of “unclean” spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus' daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

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Jesus cured a woman with chronic bleeding and gave life to a dead girl

The child of Jairus and the woman who touched the hem of Jesus' clothing

A dead girl and a sick woman (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 5:35–43

In this paragraph, Mark returned to the story about Jairus and his daughter. Use a natural way in your language to focus again on the people who were introduced before the story about Jairus was interrupted in 5:25.

5:39a**He went inside and asked,**

- He entered the house and said to the mourners,
- He entered the house and told the mourners

He went inside: This phrase indicates that Jesus entered Jairus' house (or possibly the courtyard of the house).

and asked: The Greek includes the pronoun “them.” It refers to the people who were weeping and wailing in mourning.

5:39b**“Why all this commotion and weeping?”**

- “Is there any reason for you^(plur) to make all this commotion/noise and to wail like that?
- “You^(plur) do not need to mourn in this noisy way.
- to stop mourning in that noisy way,

Why all this commotion and weeping?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used it to tell the people that they did not need to make such commotion and to wail so intensely. It is hard to know for sure the strength of this rhetorical question and whether it is better described as rebuke. The parallel in Luke is softer: *Μὴ κλαίετε* “Do not weep.” Matthew has the harshest language: *Ἀναχωρεῖτε* “Go away!” In 5:39c Jesus gave the reason for his question. He said that the child was not really dead. There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why all this confusion? Why are you crying? (GNT)

Is there any reason to make such commotion and to wail so loudly?

Do you really need to mourn and wail with such a commotion?

- As a statement or a command. For example:

There is no need for you to make all this commotion or to wail like that.

Do not make such a commotion and do not cry.

Use whichever form is most natural to express this in your language.

weeping: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as weeping is the same word that it translated as “weeping” in 5:38a–b.

5:39c**The child is not dead, but asleep.”**

- The child has not died, but is only sleeping.”
- The girl is just sleeping. She is not dead.”
- because the girl was not dead. She was only asleep.

The child is not dead, but asleep: This statement gives the reason or explanation for Jesus' words in 5:39b. Indicate this in a natural way in your language. For example, the connector “For” is often used in English to introduce a reason like this:

For the child is not dead but asleep.

This statement should not be understood literally. Jesus did not mean that the girl was not actually dead. He did not mean that she was literally only sleeping or in a coma. He used the word “sleep” here to refer to the death of a person who will be raised back to life. (For example, see John 11:11–14 and 1 Thessalonians 5:10.) But these words should be translated literally because the mourners wrongly understood them literally.

You may want to include a footnote here to explain this. For example:

Jesus knew that the girl was dead. He said that she was sleeping because he knew that he would soon make her live again. Jesus also used the word “sleep” to talk about the death of Lazarus (John 11:11–14), another person whom he raised from the dead.

child: Here Jesus used a term that can refer to either a young boy or a young girl. Use a term that is appropriate for a twelve-year-old girl (see 5:42).

General Comment on 5:39b–c

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder 5:39b–c so that the reason for the exhortation is given first. For example:

^{39c}The child is not dead but only sleeping. ^{39b}So, you do not need to make such a commotion and to weep.

Mark 5:40

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a “legion” of “unclean” spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus’ daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cured a woman with chronic bleeding and gave life to a dead girl

The child of Jairus and the woman who touched the hem of Jesus’ clothing

A dead girl and a sick woman (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 5:35–43

In this paragraph, Mark returned to the story about Jairus and his daughter. Use a natural way in your language to focus again on the people who were introduced before the story about Jairus was interrupted in 5:25.

5:40a

And they laughed at Him.

- And they began to mock him.

- But when they heard that, they ridiculed him repeatedly, because they knew that she was dead.

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And is a simple connector. It introduces the way that the mourners responded to what Jesus said in 5:39c. When Jesus said that the child was not dead, they did not believe him. They also did not accept his suggestion in 5:39b that they did not need to mourn and weep. Instead, they laughed at him. Connect this verse to 5:39 in a way that is natural in your language.

they: Here they refers to the mourners that Jesus had just spoken to.

laughed at Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as laughed at means “to mock” or “to laugh at with scorn.” The mourners treated Jesus as if he were a fool, because they were sure that the girl was dead.

The form of the Greek verb here indicates that the people spoke many words to mock Jesus and not just one. Some English versions have translated this as “they began laughing at him” (NASB) which implies that they started and continued. If you have verb forms that distinguish between actions that happen once and actions that are repeated, use a form here that indicates that the action was repeated.

5:40b

After He had put them all outside,

- But after he sent them all out/away,
- After he commanded all the mourners to go out of the house,
- So he made all of them leave the house,

In Greek this sentence begins with a conjunction that often shows contrast. Here Jesus told the people who mocked him to leave the house. Some English versions introduce 5:40b with “But” to show the contrast. Other versions use “So” to indicate that 5:40b is a result of 5:40a. Connect these verses in a way that is natural in your language.

had put them all outside: The Greek word that the BSB translates as put...outside means “expel.” It indicates that Jesus forced the mourners to leave the house. The text does not indicate exactly how he did this. He probably spoke with authority and commanded them to leave. (See the command “Go out” in Matthew 9:24.)

Here are some other ways to translate this:

After Jesus had sent them all out of the house (CEV)

So he made all of them go outside. (GW)

he told/commanded them all to go outside (see the NLT96)

5:40c

He took the child's father and mother and His own companions,

- he took with him the child's parents and the three disciples who were with him
- and he led the child's parents and Peter, James, and John

He took: The phrase He took means that Jesus invited or beckoned the parents and the disciples to come with him. In some languages took can only be used of carrying an object.

Here are some other ways to express the correct meaning:

he invited/called/asked...

he led...

the child's father and mother: If you have used Jairus' name throughout this story, it may be natural in your language to include his name here. For example:

he took the child's parents, Jairus and his wife

His own companions: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as His own companions is literally "those with him." This refers to Peter, James, and John.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

and his three disciples (GNT)

and Peter, James, and John

5:40d

and went in to see the child.

- and entered the room where the child was.
- into the place where the body of the child was lying.

and went in to see the child: The word that the BSB translates as went in means to "enter." It implies that the dead child was in one of the rooms of the house. Some English versions have made this explicit. For example:

went into the room where the child was lying (GNT)

Other versions have left this meaning implied, since the exact location is not in focus here. For example:

went to where she was (CEV)

went to the child (GW)

Translate in a way that is appropriate for your language.

It is also implied from the context that the child was lying down, probably on her back. Some English versions make this explicit, others do not. This is actually a textual issue. Many manuscripts have the word "lying," many others do not. However, in either case it is implied, so it was decided to discuss this as a translation choice rather than a textual issue. Consider whether it is natural to make this explicit here in your language.

the child: Be sure that the word you use for child is not limited to a living child. In some languages, it may be necessary to use a different word or phrase that describes someone who has died. For example:

deceased child

body of the child

corpse

Mark 5:41

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a "legion" of "unclean" spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus' daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead

of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cured a woman with chronic bleeding and gave life to a dead girl

The child of Jairus and the woman who touched the hem of Jesus' clothing

A dead girl and a sick woman (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 5:35–43

In this paragraph, Mark returned to the story about Jairus and his daughter. Use a natural way in your language to focus again on the people who were introduced before the story about Jairus was interrupted in 5:25.

5:41a

Taking her by the hand, Jesus said,

- He took the child by her hand and said to her,
- He grasped the hand of the child's body and said to her in his/their own language,

Taking her by the hand: Some languages may express this idea in different ways. For example:

He grasped the girl's hand

He took her handSome languages would say literally "he handed her."

Be alert for natural ways to express this statement in your language.

5:41b

"Talitha koum!" which means, "Little girl, I say to you, get up!"

- "Talitha koum!" (Translated, this means, "Young girl, I say to you, 'Rise!'")

- "Talitha koum!" This means in our^(incl) language, "Young lady, stand up!"

"Talitha koum!" which means, "Little girl, I say to you, get up!": The words Talitha koum are not Greek words. They are probably from the language that Jesus and the little girl spoke as their mother tongue. For some reason Mark transliterated these words. It is recommended that you also transliterate them. (See the next note.) You may want to say that Jesus spoke to her "in his/their own language."

Talitha koum: Spell these words so that they can be pronounced in your language. Different English versions spell them in slightly different ways because there are some differences of spelling in Greek manuscripts.

which means: The words which means introduce the translation (meaning) of the words "talitha koum." Use a natural way in your language to introduce the translation of something in another language. Here are some other English examples:

"Talitha, koum!" (This means, "Young girl...") (NCV)

"Talitha, koum!" Translated in our language that would be, "Young girl..."

"Talitha, koum!" This means in our language, "Young girl..."

Little girl: Jesus used an affectionate term of address in his language to address the little girl. "Talitha" means "lamb" or "young one (feminine)." The Greek word that is given as the translation of this means "little lady" or "little girl." Use a word in your language that is appropriate for a twelve-year-old girl.

I say to you: Mark included this phrase in the Greek translation of what Jesus said. However it is only implied by the words "Talitha koum!" which literally mean "lamb/youth, arise!" Some English versions do not translate the phrase I say to you explicitly, because it is already implied that Jesus was speaking to the girl (NRSV). You may also choose to follow this example if it would be more natural in your language.

get up!: The Greek word that the BSB translates as get up can mean:

1. stand up from a lying or sitting position,
2. wake up from sleep,
3. live again after being dead.

All these meanings are appropriate in this context. However it is recommended that you translate meaning (a) “stand up.” This would also imply meaning (c), since a dead person cannot stand up. If you have a word that can be used for meaning (a), (c), and (b), it would be the best choice here. The English word “rise” is a good example of a word that can be used for all three meanings.

Mark 5:42

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a “legion” of “unclean” spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus’ daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cured a woman with chronic bleeding and gave life to a dead girl

The child of Jairus and the woman who touched the hem of Jesus’ clothing

A dead girl and a sick woman (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 5:35–43

In this paragraph, Mark returned to the story about Jairus and his daughter. Use a natural way in your language to focus again on the people who were introduced before the story about Jairus was interrupted in 5:25.

5:42a

Immediately the girl got up and began to walk around.

- Instantly, the girl rose and began to walk.
- Immediately, the little girl became alive again. She stood up and walked around the room.

the girl got up: The Greek word that the BSB translates as got up can either mean “to stand up” or “to rise from the dead.” The context shows that both of these things happened: she became alive again, and she stood up. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

...the little girl became alive again. She stood up...

5:42b

She was twelve years old,

- By the way, the girl had lived for twelve years.

She was twelve years old: This is background information. Many translations use parentheses to indicate this. Mark may have said this to explain that the girl was old enough to walk. The terms that have been used in the story to refer to her (“my little daughter,” “child,” and “little girl”) could also refer to a baby. Indicate it in a natural way in your language. For example:

By the way, the child/girl was twelve years old.

In some languages it may be more natural to mention the age of the girl elsewhere in the story, for example, at 5:40d, 5:41a, or 5:42a. The CEV says:

^{41a}He took the twelve-year-old girl by the hand

5:42c

and at once they were utterly astounded.

- When this happened, they were completely astonished.
- Those who saw this were utterly amazed.

and at once: The words and at once refer to the event of the little girl beginning to live again.

they were utterly astounded: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as they were utterly astounded is literally “they were astonished with great astonishment.” This clause describes an intense feeling of surprise mixed with fear or awe at the miracle that Jesus had just done. Translate it with an expression in your language that could describe how people would feel if they saw someone raised from the dead. You may have an idiom for this.

Mark 5:43

Section 5:21–43: Jesus healed a sick woman and caused a dead girl to live again

This section tells about two miracles that Jesus did. He healed a woman who had a sickness that caused her to have chronic bleeding. The story about this woman is told in the middle of the story about a dead girl whom he caused to live again. The situation was hopeless for both until Jesus miraculously helped them. His miracles showed the special power and authority that God had given to Jesus as the Messiah.

These stories include the idea of ritual impurity, just as in the story of the healing of the man with a “legion” of “unclean” spirits. Here, the woman was unclean according to the law of Moses because of the bleeding that was caused by her sickness. The dead body of Jairus’ daughter was also ritually unclean. But in spite of this, Jesus touched both of them. Instead of becoming unclean himself, he made them ritually clean by making them well.

Another important theme is faith. Jesus said that the woman who was bleeding was healed because of her faith. Then he encouraged Jairus to keep believing that God could make his daughter well, even after she died.

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus cured a woman with chronic bleeding and gave life to a dead girl

The child of Jairus and the woman who touched the hem of Jesus’ clothing

A dead girl and a sick woman (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:18–26 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 5:35–43

In this paragraph, Mark returned to the story about Jairus and his daughter. Use a natural way in your language to focus again on the people who were introduced before the story about Jairus was interrupted in 5:25.

5:43a

Then Jesus gave strict orders that no one should know about this,

- But he commanded them strictly not to tell other people about what had happened.
- Then Jesus sternly warned the parents not to spread the news that he had raised the girl from the dead,

Then: In Greek this verse begins with the common connector that is often translated as “and.” It introduces Jesus’ response to the amazement of those who had seen the miracle. Some English versions leave this connection implicit. The BSB shows that Jesus’ response was a consequence by translating this connector as Then. Since Jesus’ response was probably unexpected, some versions begin this verse with the word “but.” For example, the REB has:

but he gave them strict instructions

Translate the connection in a way that naturally fits this context in your language.

Jesus gave strict orders that no one should know about this: The statement Jesus gave strict orders that no one should know about this means that they should not “tell other people” or “spread the news” about what Jesus had done. Jesus’ command was probably given to the parents.

In some languages, it may be more natural to give Jesus’ command as direct speech. For example:

Jesus gave them stern instructions: “Do not tell anyone about this!”

Jesus earnestly commanded the parents: “You must not spread the news to other people that I caused your daughter to live again!”

5:43b

and He told them to give her something to eat.

- And he told the parents that they should bring her some food.
- He also told them that they should give the girl food.
- and he said, “Give^(plur) her something to eat.”

and He told them to give her something to eat: The pronoun *them* is not found in the Greek text. Jesus probably gave this instruction to the parents or to the mother. The parents may have called a servant to bring food for their daughter.

If your language prefers direct speech, you could use it here. For example:

...and he said, “Give her something to eat.” (GNT)

...and he told the parents, “Cause some food to be given to her so that she may eat.”

Mark 6:1

Section 6:1–6a: The people of Jesus’ hometown did not believe in him

When Jesus came to Nazareth, his hometown, he began to teach in the synagogue. The people were amazed by his wisdom and the miracles that he did. However, they thought that Jesus was only an ordinary person and a carpenter. So they refused to accept that God had given him such extraordinary wisdom and power. Instead, they rejected him and the words that he said.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Prophet Without Honor (NIV)

Jesus Is Rejected at Nazareth (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:53–58 and Luke 4:16–30. See also John 4:44, 6:42.

6:1a

Jesus went on from there

- ¶ Then Jesus went away from there
- ¶ After that, Jesus left that place.

This verse is the beginning of a new section. The events in this section happened sometime after the events in the preceding section. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories.

If it is natural in your language to begin a story with a time word or phrase, use an expression that is not too specific. For example:

After that

Then (JBP)

In some languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this part of the story in a natural way in your language.

Jesus went on from there: The clause *Jesus went on from there* does two things:

1. it connects this story with the preceding story in Mark 5
2. it introduces a new event.

there: The word *there* may refer to the house of the synagogue ruler (in 5:38) or to the town where Jesus was at the end of Mark 5. It is best to use a word or phrase that can include both, as the BSB and other English versions do. For example, the GNT says:

Jesus left that place

6:1b

and came to His hometown,

- and came to the town he had lived in while he was growing up.
- He went to the town where he had lived as a child.

hometown: In this context, the word that the BSB translates as *hometown* refers to the place where Jesus lived with his parents while he was young. This was Nazareth (see 1:9, 1:24).

It was not Bethlehem, where he was born. Therefore, you should not translate the word *hometown* as the town where he was born. It was also not the place where he normally lived (which was Capernaum; see 2:1; 3:19). You should also be careful not to translate this word in a way that could refer to land that he owned.

6:1c

accompanied by His disciples.

- His disciples went with him.
- His followers went along with him.

accompanied by His disciples: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as *accompanied by His disciples* is literally “his disciples followed him” (as in the RSV).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

his followers went with him (NCV)

with his disciples (CEV)

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means “learners” who are in a relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Here are some ways to translate disciple:

- Use a term that refers to someone who learns from a teacher or an expert. It is helpful if the term also implies that the learner is often with his teacher. For example:

learner/student

apprentice Be careful not to use a term that would refer only to a student in a school or classroom.

- Use a term that refers to someone who follows a teacher or leader by obeying his teaching. It is helpful if this term also implies learning from the teacher and actually following the teacher wherever he goes. For example:

follower

one who is committed/faithful (to a teacher/leader)

See disciple in the Glossary.

Mark 6:2

Section 6:1–6a: The people of Jesus’ hometown did not believe in him

When Jesus came to Nazareth, his hometown, he began to teach in the synagogue. The people were amazed by his wisdom and the miracles that he did. However, they thought that Jesus was only an ordinary person and a carpenter. So they refused to accept that God had given him such extraordinary wisdom and power. Instead, they rejected him and the words that he said.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Prophet Without Honor (NIV)

Jesus Is Rejected at Nazareth (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:53–58 and Luke 4:16–30. See also John 4:44, 6:42.

6:2a

When the Sabbath came,

- When the Sabbath day came/arrived,
- On the rest day,

When the Sabbath came: In many languages, people do not say that a day came.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

On the Sabbath day

When it was the Sabbath day

Sabbath: The word Sabbath is the name of the seventh and last day of the week for the Jews. The Sabbath was the special day in the week when the Jews rested and worshipped God. The Law of Moses said that the Jews must not do any work on that day (Deuteronomy 5:12–15).

Here are some other ways to translate Sabbath:

the Jewish rest day

the day for resting

the day to rest and worship God

If the word Sabbath is already known in your area, you may write it according to the sounds of your language. You may also want to include a phrase to explain the meaning. For example:

the Sabat, the Jews’ day for resting

Be careful that the term you choose is not confused with Sunday, the day when Christians worship. The Sabbath for the Jews began at sundown on Friday and went until sundown on Saturday. You may want to include a footnote to give more information. For example:

The Sabbath is a name for the seventh day of the week. It is the day when the Jews rested from work and worshipped God.

6:2b**He began to teach in the synagogue,**

- he began to teach God's message in the synagogue building,
- he taught the Scriptures to the people in the meeting place.

He began to teach in the synagogue: There is some implied information here. People gathered in the synagogue every Sabbath to worship. These were the people whom Jesus taught. In some languages you may need to say who he taught and what he taught. For example:

began to teach God's message

began to teach the Scriptures to the people there

Jesus did something similar in 1:21b and 1:21c. Look at your translation there for ideas about how to translate 6:2b.

began to teach: The Greek phrase that most English versions translate as began to teach may also be translated as "taught" (as in the CEV). Use a verb form that is natural in your language for this context.

synagogue: A synagogue was a building where Jews gathered to pray, read scripture, teach their beliefs, and worship. The Jews also gathered there for cultural activities. There was only one temple (in Jerusalem), but each Jewish community had a synagogue.

Here are some other ways to translate synagogue:

prayer-house of the Jews

meeting-place of the Jews

worship building

house for gathering together

If you make explicit a phrase such as "of the Jews," be sure that it does not imply that Jesus was not a Jew.

If the word synagogue is already known in your area, you may write it according to the sounds of your language. You may want to include a word or phrase to explain the meaning. For example:

sinagog house/building

You should translate synagogue here the same way you did in 1:21b. See synagogue in the Glossary.

6:2c**and many who heard Him were astonished.**

- and many of the people who heard him were surprised/astonished.
- Many of his listeners were astounded and offended/resentful,

many who heard Him: There is a textual issue in this verse. (1) Many Greek manuscripts lack the definite article *hoi* before *polloi* "many." Without the article, this phrase means "many (but not all) who heard him." This reading is followed by Textus Receptus and AGNT. (2) Some Greek manuscripts have *hoi polloi* "the many," with the definite article. With the article, the phrase means "the many who all heard him." It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions. There are different ways to interpret the word many:

1. It means many but not all of the people there were amazed. For example, the CEV says:

Many of the people who heard him were amazed (BSB, NIV, RSV, NJB, CEV, NLT, GW, NET)

1. It means that many people were there and all of them were amazed. For example, the GNT says:

Many people were there; and when they heard him, they were all amazed. (GNT, REB, NASB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most English versions. However, you may want to follow interpretation (2) if the major language version in your language area follows it. One argument in favor of interpretation (2) is that "many" may be a Semitic idiom meaning "all" (TRT page 68, Gundry, page 289). Others who support the interpretation "all of the many" include Lane page 201, UBS page 182, and Cranfield page 193. The first interpretation is supported by Alexander (page 141), Hiebert (page 138), Gould (page 103), Lenski (page 234), Bruce (page 184), Swete (page 111) and Taylor (page 299). Both interpretations are well supported by scholars.

In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit that many refers to "many of the people in the synagogue." For example:

many of the people listening to him there

were astonished: The Greek word that the BSB translates as astonished means “very surprised” or “amazed.” (The same word occurs in 1:22a.) The following verse (6:3) makes it clear that the people’s surprise here was mixed with resentment. They were displeased or offended that someone whom they considered to be an ordinary person should have such authority and power.

Be sure that your translation of astonished fits with the attitude of the people that is expressed in 6:3. In some languages it may be necessary to translate this word differently here than you did in 1:22. For example:

amazed and resentful

6:2d–3c

In 6:2d–6:3c, Mark records several rhetorical questions. These rhetorical questions express the surprise and resentment that the people felt when Jesus began to teach in the synagogue. The people knew Jesus only as a carpenter, so they were surprised that he was able to teach with such wisdom. They were also surprised that he was able to perform such mighty works. However, they did not believe that Jesus was qualified to do these things. Therefore, they were offended.

The meaning of these rhetorical questions is expressed in various ways in the Display. The Display also shows ways to express the direct quotations in 6:2d–6:3c in an indirect way. See the Display for 6:2d–6:3c.

6:2d

“Where did this man get these ideas?” they asked.

- They asked, “Where did this man learn these things?”
- and they said, “It’s unbelievable that a man such as this has learned all these things!”

Where did this man get these ideas?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses both surprise and offense/contempt. There are at least two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Where did he get all this? (GNT)

Where did this man get these things? (NIV)

- As a statement. For example:

We cannot believe that this man has learned all this!

It is unbelievable that this man has learned all these things/ideas!

Use whichever form is most natural to express this surprise, offense, and contempt in your language.

It may be necessary in some languages to include an idiom or phrase in order to express surprise and/or amazement. You could translate it:

What is this? Where did this one get/learn these things?

Impossible! Where did this one get/learn such things?

Where: Here the word Where helps to form the rhetorical question. The emphasis here is not on a place, as it usually is with the word where.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

How

From whom/By whose authority

It is unbelievable that...

this man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as this man is literally “this one.” The people knew Jesus’ name, but they called him “this one.” This shows their feeling of contempt. It shows that they did not accept Jesus as a teacher.

get: In Greek, there is no verb here. The clause is literally “from where this one these things?” The BSB has supplied the verb get to make the clause understandable in English.

In many languages it will be necessary to supply a verb, as English versions do. Here are some other possibilities:

know

learn

these ideas: The phrase these ideas refers to the wisdom with which Jesus taught. It also refers to the power by which he performed miracles.

they asked: In Greek the word that the BSB translates as they asked comes before the rhetorical question.

The BSB has placed this phrase after the rhetorical question. You should place these words where they are most natural in your language.

asked: If you translate the rhetorical question in 6:2d as a statement, you may need to use a different verb here. For example:

said

6:2e-f

What is this wisdom He has been given? And how can He perform such miracles?: There is a textual issue in this verse:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the conjunction and. For example the NASB says:

...what is this wisdom given to Him, and such miracles as these performed by His hands? (BSB, CEV, NLT, NASB, JBP, GNT, RSV, NET, REB, NCV) Among the versions that follow option (1), some versions connect the questions with the word “and” (BSB, CEV, NLT, NASB, JBP) and some versions omit a conjunction (GNT, RSV, NET, REB, NCV). For example, the NET says, “And what is this wisdom that has been given to him? What are these miracles that are done through his hands?”

1. Other Greek manuscripts have the conjunction in order that. This conjunction introduces the purpose or result of the wisdom he had received. For example, the KJV says:

...and what wisdom [is] this which is given unto him, that even such mighty works are wrought by his hands? (KJV, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), since it has the support of the majority of Greek manuscripts. Blight and Smith (page 124), Metzger (page 75), UBS4 (page 138), TRT (page 67) and Swanson (page 80). Also, the majority of the English versions follow this option.

The rhetorical questions in 6:2e and 6:2f are discussed separately below. For ways to combine these two questions into one sentence, see the General Comment on 6:2e-f after the note on 6:2f.

6:2e

“What is this wisdom He has been given?”

- Who gave him wisdom like this?
- He should not have wise understanding like this!

What is this wisdom He has been given?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses both surprise and unbelief. There are at least two ways to translate this rhetorical question.

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Who gave him this kind of wisdom...? (GW)

Where did he get all his wisdom...? (NLT)

- As a statement. For example:

He should not have this kind of wisdom!

We cannot believe that he has received all this wisdom!

Use whichever form is most natural to express this surprise and unbelief in your language.

this: The word this indicates that the people thought that the wisdom Jesus had was an extraordinary/unusual kind of wisdom. You could translate this as:

this kind of...

...like this

wisdom: The word wisdom in general means “the ability to understand events and know the right action.” In this context, it probably refers to understanding spiritual things. It is not simple knowledge learned from studying.

In some languages it may be necessary to translate wisdom with a phrase. For example:

wise understanding

right and just thinking

He: The Greek word that the BSB translates as He is literally “this one.” This is the same word as in 6:2d. The people knew Jesus’ name, but they called him “this one.” This shows their feeling of contempt. It shows again that they did not accept his spiritual authority.

given: The BSB follows the Greek text and translates the verb given as a passive verb. The passive form of the verb here shows that the people did not believe

that Jesus could have learned such wisdom on his own. They also were not willing to say from whom or where he received such wisdom. For this reason, it is recommended that you use the passive form in the translation if possible. But if it is not natural in your language to do this, you may want to use one of the following ideas:

Who gave him...?

Where did he get...?

He should not have...!

6:2f

And how can He perform such miracles?

- How does he do such miracles?
- He should not be able do mighty/amazing things such as these!

And how can He perform such miracles?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses both surprise and unbelief. There are at least two ways to translate this rhetorical question.

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

...and the ability to do such great miracles? (GW)

And where did he get the power to do miracles? (NCV)

- As a statement. For example:

He should not be able to do these types of miracles!

We cannot believe that he has the power to do such miracles!

Use whichever form is most natural to express this surprise and unbelief in your language.

He perform such miracles: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as He perform such miracles is more literally “such miracles happening through his hands.” This figure of speech means “miracles performed by him” or “miracles that Jesus did.” For example:

How does he perform miracles? (GNT)

...he even does miracles! (NIV)

miracles: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as miracles is literally powers. A miracle is an action which requires great power to accomplish. When a human being does a miracle, he must use greater power than human beings normally have. Jesus used God’s power to do miracles, and these miracles demonstrated that he came from God.

Here are some other ways to translate miracles:

mighty works

amazing acts done with/by God’s power

wonderful actions that only God can do

General Comment on 6:2e–f

In some languages it may be more natural to combine the two rhetorical questions in 6:2e–f into one question, such as in the examples below.

Who gave him this kind of wisdom and the ability to do such great miracles? (GW)

Where did he get all this wisdom and the power to perform such miracles? (NLT)

Mark 6:3

Section 6:1–6a: The people of Jesus’ hometown did not believe in him

When Jesus came to Nazareth, his hometown, he began to teach in the synagogue. The people were amazed by his wisdom and the miracles that he did. However, they thought that Jesus was only an ordinary person and a carpenter. So they refused to accept that God had given him such extraordinary wisdom and power. Instead, they rejected him and the words that he said.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Prophet Without Honor (NIV)

Jesus Is Rejected at Nazareth (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:53–58 and Luke 4:16–30. See also John 4:44, 6:42.

6:3a–b

In Greek, 6:3a–b is one sentence. The BSB follows the Greek structure and keeps it as one sentence. The NIV divides this into two sentences:

Isn't this the carpenter? Isn't this Mary's son and the brother of James, Joseph, Judas and Simon?

The meaning of this sentence can be expressed with one question, or with two as in the NIV. You should divide this section in the way that is most clear and natural in your language.

See the General Comment on 6:2d–3c after 6:3c and the General Comment on 6:3a–d after 6:3d for additional ways to divide and order this sentence.

6:3a

Isn't this the carpenter,

- Isn't this only the carpenter?
- After all, he is only a carpenter,

Isn't this the carpenter: This is a rhetorical question. It implies the answer “Yes, of course it is.” It functions as a strong statement that expresses surprise, displeasure, and contempt. The people were surprised and resentful that someone whom they knew only as a carpenter had such extraordinary wisdom and power. There are at least three ways to translate this:

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the NET says:

Isn't this the carpenter...?

- As a statement. For example, the NCV says:

He is just the carpenter....

- As a statement with a tag question. For example:

He is only a carpenter, right?

Use whichever form is most natural to express this surprise and resentment in your language.

this: Again the people used the expression “this one,” as in 6:2d. See the note on “this man” there. Here in 6:3a it again shows their lack of regard for Jesus.

carpenter: The Greek word that the BSB translates as carpenter refers to a builder. This person made things

with materials such as wood or stone. Use a general term that refers to that kind of person.

6:3b

the son of Mary and the brother of James, Joses, Judas, and Simon?

- Isn't this only Mary's son? Isn't this just the brother/sibling of James, Joseph, Judas, and Simon?
- whose mother Mary and whose younger brothers/siblings James, Joseph, Judas, and Simon we know.

the son of Mary and the brother of James, Joses, Judas, and Simon?:

This is a rhetorical question. It implies the answer “Yes, of course he is!” It functions as a strong statement. It also expresses surprise and contempt.

The people of Nazareth all knew Jesus' mother and brothers. They knew Jesus as just an ordinary person. They were offended that he had returned as a religious teacher and that he performed miracles. They did not welcome him. Instead, they took offense and refused to accept him.

There are at least three ways to translate this:

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the GNT says:

Isn't he...the son of Mary, and the brother of James, Joseph, Judas, and Simon?

- As a statement. For example, the NLT96 says:

He's...the son of Mary and brother of James, Joseph, Judas, and Simon.

- As a statement with a tag question. For example:

He is just/only Mary's son and the brother of James, Joseph, Judas, and Simon, isn't he?

Use whichever form is most natural to express this surprise, displeasure, and offense in your language.

the brother of James, Joses, Judas, and Simon:

Jesus was the older brother of these four men. If your language has separate words for older brother and younger brother, you should use older brother to refer to Jesus.

If your language does not have separate words for brother and sister, then you may use a term such as sibling. It is clear in this context that Jesus and the siblings mentioned here were men, so you may not need to specify male sibling.

6:3c**Aren't His sisters here with us as well?"**

- Don't his sisters live here among us?"
- Even his younger female siblings live here in town with us!"

Aren't His sisters here with us as well?: This is also a rhetorical question. It implies the answer "Yes, of course they are!" It functions as a strong statement of fact expressing surprise, displeasure, and offense. There are at least three ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the GNT says:

Aren't his sisters living here?

- As a statement. For example, the NCV says:

And his sisters are here with us.

- As a statement with a tag question. For example:

Even his sisters are living here with us, are they not?

Use whichever form is most natural to express this surprise and offense in your language.

sisters: If your language has separate words for "younger sisters" and "older sisters," you should use the term for "younger sisters" here. All of Jesus' brothers and sisters were younger than he was.

If your language does not have separate words for brother and sister, then you may use a term such as sibling. In this context you will need to specify that these were female younger-siblings.

General Comment on 6:2d-3c

In some languages, it may be natural to translate all of the rhetorical questions in Greek as questions. In other languages, it may be more natural to translate some of the rhetorical questions as questions and others as statements. For example, the NCV says:

^{2c}Many people heard him and were amazed, saying, ^{2d}"Where did this man get these teachings?"

^{2e}What is this wisdom that has been given to him?

^{2f}And where did he get the power to do miracles?

^{3a}He is just the carpenter, ^{3b}the son of Mary and the brother of James, Joseph, Judas, and Simon.

^{3c}And his sisters are here with us."

6:3d**And they took offense at Him.**

- And they rejected him.
- So they refused to respect/accept Jesus.

And they took offense at Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as took offense means "rejected," or "stopped believing." In this context it is also implied that the people were angry, upset or resentful.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

they would not accept him (NJB)

they were angry and rejected him

they turned against him (REB)

They were deeply offended and refused to believe in him. (NLT)

General Comment on 6:3a-d

If you translate 6:3a-c using rhetorical questions, check to see whether readers understand that they are not real questions. Some people might wrongly think that the people in Jesus' hometown asked these questions in order to identify Jesus. The real reason they asked these questions was to scoff at Jesus. One way to avoid this misunderstanding is to change the order, so that the statement about their attitude in 6:3d comes first. For example:

^{3d}They took offense at him, saying ^{3a}"Isn't this only the carpenter? ^{3b}Isn't this only Mary's son? Isn't this just the brother of James, Joseph, Judas and Simon, whom we all know? ^{3c}Don't his sisters live here among us?"

Mark 6:4**Section 6:1-6a: The people of Jesus' hometown did not believe in him**

When Jesus came to Nazareth, his hometown, he began to teach in the synagogue. The people were amazed by his wisdom and the miracles that he did. However, they thought that Jesus was only an ordinary person and a carpenter. So they refused to accept that God had given him such extraordinary wisdom and power. Instead, they rejected him and the words that he said.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Prophet Without Honor (NIV)

Jesus Is Rejected at Nazareth (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:53–58 and Luke 4:16–30. See also John 4:44, 6:42.

Paragraph 6:4–6a

This paragraph shows how Jesus responded to the people's rejection in 6:3e. He quoted a saying that they would recognize (6:4). He did not perform many miracles (6:5). In fact, he was amazed that they refused to believe (6:6a).

6:4a

Then Jesus said to them,

- ¶ Then Jesus said to them,
- ¶ And so Jesus told them,

Then Jesus said to them: Jesus said the words in 6:4–6b immediately after the people's rhetorical questions in 6:2d–3c. In some languages, it may be natural to begin this paragraph with a time word or phrase. For example, the BSB and the NLT both use the word "Then."

Then Jesus told them (NLT)

In other languages, no time word or phrase is necessary.

6:4b

"Only in his hometown, among his relatives, and in his own household is a prophet without honor."

- "Prophets are respected everywhere except in their own hometown and by their relatives and their family." (GNT)
- "People everywhere honor/respect a prophet. But in the prophet's own hometown, family and household, it is not like that."

Only in his hometown, among his relatives, and in his own household is a prophet without honor:

This was a saying or proverb that was familiar to the Jewish people at the time that Jesus lived. Jesus quoted this saying or proverb to show that people in his hometown treated him without honor. They did not believe that Jesus was a prophet or anyone important. Therefore they did not show him honor/respect.

in his hometown: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hometown is the same word that Mark used in 6:1b. This word refers to the town where a person lived with his parents while he was growing up.

among his relatives: The word relatives refers to the extended family and clan. These people are also called kinsmen.

in his own household: The phrase his own household refers to "his own family."

Here are some other ways to translate this:

in his own house (NIV)

among...his own family (REB)

is a prophet without honor: The Greek word that the BSB translates as honor refers to the praise and respect people give to someone who deserves it.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Translate the noun honor as a verb. For example, the Greek is literally:

a prophet is not dishonored except...

- State this in a positive way. For example, the NLT says:

A prophet is honored everywhere except...

- Use an active verb. For example:

People honor a prophet everywhere except...

prophet: A prophet is a man who speaks on behalf of God. He tells people what God has revealed to him, and he also gives them messages from God.

Here are some other ways to translate prophet:

a spokesman for God

a man who speaks God's words

God's message-speaker

When choosing a term for prophet, consider how you will translate other words which are similar in meaning such as "angel," "apostle," and "preacher."

While prophets did foretell the future, this was not their only function. Avoid using a word that focuses on telling the future.

See how you translated this word in 1:2a. See also prophet in the Glossary.

General Comment on 6:4b

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate the two terms “relatives” and “his own household” as one term. For example:

A prophet is respected/honored everywhere except in his own hometown, and among his own people.

Only the people of a prophet’s hometown and his family disrespect him.

Mark 6:5

Section 6:1–6a: The people of Jesus’ hometown did not believe in him

When Jesus came to Nazareth, his hometown, he began to teach in the synagogue. The people were amazed by his wisdom and the miracles that he did. However, they thought that Jesus was only an ordinary person and a carpenter. So they refused to accept that God had given him such extraordinary wisdom and power. Instead, they rejected him and the words that he said.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Prophet Without Honor (NIV)

Jesus Is Rejected at Nazareth (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:53–58 and Luke 4:16–30. See also John 4:44, 6:42.

Paragraph 6:4–6a

This paragraph shows how Jesus responded to the people’s rejection in 6:3e. He quoted a saying that they would recognize (6:4). He did not perform many miracles (6:5). In fact, he was amazed that they refused to believe (6:6a).

6:5

Many people did not believe in Jesus, but a few did. For this reason Jesus did only a few miracles in that area.

6:5a

So He could not perform any miracles there,

- He was not able to do any/many miracles among them,
- He could not do amazing and wonderful things among them,
- Because they did not believe in him, the only mighty acts he could do there

So He could not perform any miracles there: There are at least two issues to consider when translating 6:5a:

Issue 1:

There is some implied information here. It is implied that the reason Jesus was not able to perform any great miracles was because the people did not believe. You may want to make this information explicit in your translation if it is not clear from 6:6a. For example:

And because of their unbelief, he couldn’t do any mighty miracles (NLT96)

Because the people rejected him, he was not able to do any great miracle

Another way to make this clear would be to add a footnote. For example:

The reason that Jesus was not able to perform any great miracle was not because he did not have the power to do so. It was because the people refused to believe in him.

Issue 2:

The clause He could not perform any miracles there is hyperbole. It is clear in 6:5b that Jesus did a few miracles there. If the people will not understand that this is an exaggeration, you should say:

he could not perform many miracles there

he could not do more than a few miracles there

miracles: You should translate this word the same way you did in 6:2f.

there: The word there refers to Jesus’ hometown. It is mentioned in 6:1b and 6:4b. In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this as the NLT has done:

among them

6:5b

except to lay His hands on a few of the sick and heal them.

- except that he laid his hands on a few sick people and healed them.
- except only to heal a few sick people by laying his hands on them.
- were healing the diseases of a few sick people by touching them.

except to lay His hands on a few of the sick and heal them: The Greek grammar implies that Jesus healed the sick by means of laying his hands on them. One way to make this explicit in the translation is:

except to heal a few sick people by laying his hands on them

lay His hands: Here are some other ways to translate lay His hands:

put his hands

placed his hands

touched

This same phrase occurs in 5:23c. This expression is used when Jesus healed people and when he blessed the children.

General Comment on 6:5a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of 6:5a and 6:5b. For example:

^{5b} They did not believe in him. So he only healed a few people by laying his hands on them. ^{5a}Other than that, he could not do any miracles there.

Mark 6:6

Section 6:1–6a: The people of Jesus' hometown did not believe in him

When Jesus came to Nazareth, his hometown, he began to teach in the synagogue. The people were amazed by his wisdom and the miracles that he did. However, they thought that Jesus was only an ordinary person and a carpenter. So they refused to accept that God had given him such extraordinary wisdom and

power. Instead, they rejected him and the words that he said.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Prophet Without Honor (NIV)

Jesus Is Rejected at Nazareth (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 13:53–58 and Luke 4:16–30. See also John 4:44, 6:42.

Paragraph 6:4–6a

This paragraph shows how Jesus responded to the people's rejection in 6:3e. He quoted a saying that they would recognize (6:4). He did not perform many miracles (6:5). In fact, he was amazed that they refused to believe (6:6a).

6:6a

And He was amazed at their unbelief.

- And he was very surprised because they had no faith in him.
- He was astonished/amazed that they did not believe in him.

And He was amazed: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as amazed is similar in meaning to the word translated as “astonished” in 6:2c. But it is a different Greek word.

Jesus had done many miracles elsewhere in Galilee. So he might have expected the people in his hometown to believe in him. He was surprised when they did not believe in him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

He was greatly surprised (GNT)

and he was astonished (REB)

at their unbelief: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as at their unbelief means “because they did not believe.” The people's lack of faith caused Jesus to be amazed. That is, it was the reason for his amazement.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

He was amazed because they had no faith.

He was surprised that they had no faith.

unbelief: The word unbelief is an abstract noun. Some versions translate the phrase unbelief as “lack of faith.” The word “faith” is also an abstract noun. In some languages, it will be more natural to translate unbelief or “lack of faith” as a verbal phrase. For example:

they did not believe in him

Section 6:6b–13: Jesus sent the twelve apostles to different towns to preach and heal people

In this section Mark wrote that Jesus began to go around to various Jewish villages in order to teach the people. He also sent out his twelve apostles two by two into the villages. Jesus gave the apostles authority over evil spirits, and he gave them instructions for their journey. The apostles went out and preached that people should repent. They cast out demons and healed sick people.

The NIV starts a new section and paragraph at 6:6b. Some translations, such as the NASB and BSB, start the new section at 6:7. If you decide to do this, you should still make 6:6b a separate paragraph.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

Jesus Sends Out the Twelve (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:35; 10:5–15; Luke 8:1; 9:1–6.

6:6b

And He went around from village to village, teaching the people.

- ¶ Then Jesus went around teaching from one village to another.
- ¶ After this, Jesus went to the surrounding villages and taught the people God’s message.

And: A new part of the story begins in 6:6b. To show this, the BSB and many other English versions use the word And here. The NIV and other English versions use the word “Then.” You should begin this section and paragraph in a way that is natural in your language. In some languages, no time word or phrase is necessary.

He went around from village to village: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as went around from village to village is literally “went around the villages in a circle.” This describes the route/way that Jesus went after he left Nazareth. He went from one village to another throughout the area surrounding Nazareth.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Jesus went out to all the surrounding villages

Then Jesus went around to the villages (GW)

Use a phrase or expression that is most natural in your language to describe this kind of travel.

teaching the people: The purpose for which Jesus went from one village to another was to teach. The Greek grammar shows that his teaching was a continuous or ongoing activity.

The Greek word which the BSB translates as teaching the people is literally “teaching.” In some language, it may be necessary to say what he taught and whom he taught. For example, the BSB has added the phrase the people to indicate who Jesus was teaching. Here are some other examples:

teaching God’s message

teaching the Scriptures to the people

Mark 6:7

Section 6:6b–13: Jesus sent the twelve apostles to different towns to preach and heal people

In this section Mark wrote that Jesus began to go around to various Jewish villages in order to teach the people. He also sent out his twelve apostles two by two into the villages. Jesus gave the apostles authority over evil spirits, and he gave them instructions for their journey. The apostles went out and preached that people should repent. They cast out demons and healed sick people.

The NIV starts a new section and paragraph at 6:6b. Some translations, such as the NASB and BSB, start the new section at 6:7. If you decide to do this, you should still make 6:6b a separate paragraph.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

Jesus Sends Out the Twelve (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:35; 10:5–15; Luke 8:1; 9:1–6.

6:7

Before you translate 6:7, you should look at the main verbs. Mark used the verbs called, send, and giving to show the process of sending out the apostles. The

actions shown by these verbs are not in chronological order.

In some languages, it may be more natural to put the actions in the order in which they occurred. See the General Comment on 6:7–8a at the end of 6:8a for one way to rearrange the parts of this verse.

6:7a

Then Jesus called the Twelve to Him

- He called the twelve apostles/disciples to come to him,
- Then he gathered his twelve followers around him,

6:7b

and began to send them out two by two,

- and he sent them out to different places two by two,
- and he told/commanded them to go out to different places in groups of two.

6:7a–b

In some languages, it will be natural to begin this verse with a general time word, as in the BSB. For example, the CEV says:

Then he called together

Then Jesus called the Twelve to Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as called...to Him is literally “he summons to himself.” Jesus was gathering his twelve followers around him for a special purpose.

Here are some other ways you could express this:

Then he told the twelve to gather around him, and...

He gathered the twelve around him, and...

the Twelve: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as the Twelve refers to Jesus’ twelve closest disciples. (This same phrase occurs in 4:10a.) By the time Mark wrote his gospel, people probably knew Jesus’ special group of disciples as the Twelve. However, you may need to make explicit in your translation that this expression refers to Jesus’ disciples/apostles. For example:

the twelve apostles (GW)

the twelve disciples (GNT)

In 6:30a, it specifically identifies these twelve men as “apostles.” So you may want to say “apostles” here as well.

began to send them out: Jesus told the twelve apostles/disciples to go out to different villages. In some languages the verb *send* is only used for things, not for people. If it is not natural in your language to say that Jesus began to send them out, you may want to say that he told them to go out. Make sure that whatever word you choose refers to causing people to go somewhere, not by force but by command.

two by two: The phrase two by two means “in groups of two” or “in pairs.” Jesus did not send all twelve men together to the same place. He had them travel to different villages in groups of two men.

6:7c

giving them authority over unclean spirits.

- and he gave them authority/power to send evil spirits away from people.
- He gave them the power to command/cause evil spirits to come out of people.

giving them authority over unclean spirits: Jesus gave the twelve men authority to expel evil spirits in order to prepare them for their mission. Jesus did this before he sent them out. It may be necessary in the translation to make this clear. For example:

^{7b}he sent them out two by two ^{7c}after first giving them authority to expel evil spirits

authority over unclean spirits: The word *authority* refers to the right and power to do something. Jesus gave his twelve apostles the right and power to command the unclean spirits to no longer harm people. He gave them the power to command evil spirits to release people that they controlled.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the power/right to command evil spirits to leave people

authority to cast out evil spirits (NLT)

Be careful not to translate this in a way that might cause readers/hearers to think that Jesus gave his apostles the power to make the unclean spirits do things for them. You can probably translate the phrase *authority over unclean spirits* in a similar way to “have authority to drive out demons” in 3:15.

unclean spirits: The Greek words that the BSB translates as unclean spirits refer to spirits that are evil and can control people's actions. The phrase unclean spirits refers to the same type of spirits as the Greek terms that are often translated as "demons" and "evil spirits."

Here are some other ways to translate unclean spirits:

- Use a general term in your language that refers to spirits that are evil and can control people.
- Use a specific term in your language that refers to a certain type of spirit. These spirits should be able to do what is described in this context. Do not use a term that refers to the spirits of dead people.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

evil/bad spirits

unclean spirits Be sure that an expression like "unclean spirit" does not imply that the spirit is literally dirty.

See evil spirit in the Glossary for more information.

Mark 6:8

Section 6:6b–13: Jesus sent the twelve apostles to different towns to preach and heal people

In this section Mark wrote that Jesus began to go around to various Jewish villages in order to teach the people. He also sent out his twelve apostles two by two into the villages. Jesus gave the apostles authority over evil spirits, and he gave them instructions for their journey. The apostles went out and preached that people should repent. They cast out demons and healed sick people.

The NIV starts a new section and paragraph at 6:6b. Some translations, such as the NASB and BSB, start the new section at 6:7. If you decide to do this, you should still make 6:6b a separate paragraph.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

Jesus Sends Out the Twelve (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:35; 10:5–15; Luke 8:1; 9:1–6.

6:8a

He instructed them

- This is what he told them to do:
- He told/ordered them:
- He/Jesus told them

He instructed them: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as He instructed them is literally "He ordered them" (as in the NRSV). The CEV has another way to translate this:

He told them

General Comment on 6:7–8a

Jesus gave his twelve disciples instructions before he sent them out (6:7b). You may want to change the order of 6:7a–c so that the events are in the order in which they occurred. If that is true, here is one way you could connect 6:7a–c with 6:8a:

^{7a}He called the twelve to come to him ^{7c}and gave them authority over evil spirits. ^{7b}Then he sent them out in groups of two ^{8a}with these instructions: ^{8b}Take...

6:8b

to take nothing but a staff for the journey—

- "Take^(plur) only a walking stick for your^(plur) journey.
- "When you^(plur) travel, you may take a walking stick,
- not to take anything for the trip except a walking stick.

to take nothing but: The expression nothing but can also be translated as "only." For example:

Take only

The twelve disciples were to take very little with them when they went to the villages.

a staff: The word staff refers to a stick which a person could use to help him walk in difficult places. He also used it to protect himself against animals and snakes. The GNT has another way to say this:

a walking stick

for the journey: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as for the journey is literally "on the road." This implies that they would be traveling. This phrase makes it clear that Jesus "sent them out" (6:7b) to travel a distance from where they were. In 6:10 it becomes clear that the disciples would need a place to stay (sleep, eat) in the villages to which Jesus sent them. This could be because the villages were far away, or because they stayed there for a long time.

The NCV has another way to say this:

for your trip

6:8c

no bread, no bag, no money in their belts—

- Do not take^(plur) anything to eat, or a carrying bag, or money in your^(plur) pouch.
- but do not carry^(plur) food or a traveler's bag or money.
- He told them not to take any food or bag/sack or money.

no bread, no bag, no money in their belts: It may be necessary to repeat the verb “take” (6:8b) here. For example:

Take no bread...

But do not take bread or...

bread: The word bread refers to the main food of the Jewish people. If the people for whom you are translating do not eat bread, you could translate this as “food” (as in the CEV).

bag: The Greek word that the BSB translates as bag could mean either of two things:

1. A traveler's bag or sack. Such a bag was used to carry things that people needed on a trip.
2. A beggar's bag. This kind of bag was used to carry food or money that people gave to beggars.

Many English versions use a general word, and it is recommended that you also do this. If there is no general word for bag, choose something close to meaning (a).

money in their belts: Jews typically carried their money in cloth belts that they wrapped around their waist. Some ways to translate this are:

- Translate the Greek literally. You can do this if people in your area will understand the custom of carrying money in belts.
- Translate in a more general way. You can do this if people in your area will think it odd to carry money in belts. For example, the NLT says:

no money

- Use the common method of carrying money in your area. For example, the GNT says:

no money in your pockets

Mark 6:9

Section 6:6b–13: Jesus sent the twelve apostles to different towns to preach and heal people

In this section Mark wrote that Jesus began to go around to various Jewish villages in order to teach the people. He also sent out his twelve apostles two by two into the villages. Jesus gave the apostles authority over evil spirits, and he gave them instructions for their journey. The apostles went out and preached that people should repent. They cast out demons and healed sick people.

The NIV starts a new section and paragraph at 6:6b. Some translations, such as the NASB and BSB, start the new section at 6:7. If you decide to do this, you should still make 6:6b a separate paragraph.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

Jesus Sends Out the Twelve (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:35; 10:5–15; Luke 8:1; 9:1–6.

6:9

and to wear sandals, but not a second tunic.

- Wear sandals, but don't carry an extra shirt. (GNT)
- Wear sandals, but take only the clothes you are wearing. (NCV)
- They should wear sandals, but not take two shirts.

and to wear sandals, but not a second tunic: It is implied here that the disciples were not to take extra clothes. The NASB gives a fairly literal translation of the Greek: “but to wear sandals; and...not put on two tunics.” In other words, Jesus told them to wear what they had on, but not to take more clothing than that.

sandals: The word sandals refers to a type of shoe. The sandals people wore in that time were usually pieces of leather that made a shoe sole (bottom of the shoe). This leather sole was tied onto the foot with leather straps.

Translate this word as you did in 1:7c.

second tunic: The Greek word that the BSB translates as tunic refers to a long “shirt” or “undergarment” which covered the body from the shoulders to the knees. Both men and women wore this kind of garment next to the skin and then put an outer garment over it.

If you have a term for an undergarment that covers the body from the shoulders to the knees, you should use it here. But if you do not have such a term, you may want to use a general term. Here are some examples:

extra clothes

a change of clothes (GW)

shirt (GNT)

second: The Greek word that the BSB translates as second is literally “two.” For example, the RSV says:

two tunics

General Comment on 6:8–9

In Greek, 6:8b–9 is indirect speech. For example, the NET says:

^{8a}He instructed them ^{8b}to take nothing for the journey except a staff—^{8c}no bread, no bag, no money in their belts—⁹and to put on sandals but not to wear two tunics.

Some English versions, like the NIV, translate 6:8b–9 as direct speech. This is perhaps because 6:10–11 is direct speech. You should do whatever is more natural in your language.

Mark 6:10

Section 6:6b–13: Jesus sent the twelve apostles to different towns to preach and heal people

In this section Mark wrote that Jesus began to go around to various Jewish villages in order to teach the people. He also sent out his twelve apostles two by two into the villages. Jesus gave the apostles authority over evil spirits, and he gave them instructions for their journey. The apostles went out and preached that people should repent. They cast out demons and healed sick people.

The NIV starts a new section and paragraph at 6:6b. Some translations, such as the NASB and BSB, start the new section at 6:7. If you decide to do this, you should still make 6:6b a separate paragraph.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

Jesus Sends Out the Twelve (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:35; 10:5–15; Luke 8:1; 9:1–6.

6:10a

And He told them,

- He instructed them:

- Jesus told his disciples
- Jesus said to his disciples

And He told them: The BSB follows the Greek text by introducing what Jesus said in 6:10 with the clause And He told them. This marks the beginning of direct speech. (See the General Comment on 6:8–9 above.) Many English versions do not translate these words. This is because:

1. they also translate 6:8–9 as direct speech, and
2. in English it is sufficient to introduce Jesus’ words one time, as it was done in 6:8a.

You should begin 6:10 in a way that is clear and natural in your language.

6:10b

“When you enter a house,

- When you^(plur) go to stay at/in someone’s house
- If someone invites you^(plur) to stay in his home,
- Jesus also said that when they entered a village and someone invited them to enter his house,

When you enter a house: In Greek, this is literally “Wherever you enter a house” (as in the NRSV). This implies that each group of two disciples would go to a different village. It also implies that they would need to find a place to stay while they did the work that Jesus sent them there to do.

you enter a house: The clause you enter a house refers to “staying” or “sleeping” in that house.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Wherever you enter a house to sleep

Wherever you are welcomed (GNT)

In whatever house people invite you to stay

6:10c

stay there until you leave that area.

- remain there as his guest as long as you are in that town.
- make only that home your lodging while you^(plur) are in that village.
- they should stay in the same house until they left that town.

stay there until you leave that area: The clause stay there until you leave that area means that the disciples should stay in only one house in each town. They should not move from house to house.

Be careful not to translate this in a way that makes readers/hearers think that the disciples were to stay indoors and not leave the house.

that area: The Greek word that the BSB has translated as that area is literally “there.” If you follow the BSB and supply a word here, use a general word that can include villages.

General Comment on 6:10b–c

In some languages it may be natural to reorder 6:10b and 6:10c and mention the area/town/village at the beginning of what Jesus said. For example:

Stay there until you leave that area, when you enter a house.

when they went into an area, they were to stay at the same house all the time.

When you enter each village, be a guest in only one home. (NLT96)

Mark 6:11

Section 6:6b–13: Jesus sent the twelve apostles to different towns to preach and heal people

In this section Mark wrote that Jesus began to go around to various Jewish villages in order to teach the people. He also sent out his twelve apostles two by two into the villages. Jesus gave the apostles authority over evil spirits, and he gave them instructions for their journey. The apostles went out and preached that people should repent. They cast out demons and healed sick people.

The NIV starts a new section and paragraph at 6:6b. Some translations, such as the NASB and BSB, start the new section at 6:7. If you decide to do this, you should still make 6:6b a separate paragraph.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

Jesus Sends Out the Twelve (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:35; 10:5–15; Luke 8:1; 9:1–6.

6:11

Some Greek manuscripts have an extra sentence at the end of 6:11. The KJV follows these manuscripts and adds the following:

Verily I say unto you, It shall be more tolerable for Sodom and Gomorrha in the day of judgment, than for that city.

Many of the older Greek manuscripts do not include this sentence, and most English versions do not include it. The sentence is in Matthew 10:15, and scholars believe someone added it later to the parallel passage here in Mark 6:11. It is recommended that you should not include this sentence in your translation.

6:11a

If anyone will not welcome you or listen to you,

- If the people of any town will not welcome you^(plur) or listen to you,
- If you^(plur) come to a town where the people refuse to welcome you or to listen to your message,
- If the people there did not accept them or listen to their message,

And if any place will not welcome you: The clause will not welcome you means that nobody in the town invited the disciples to stay in their home. Also, nobody did anything to show the disciples that they wanted them to be in their town.

or listen to you: The clause listen to you refers to the people of a particular place refusing to listen to the disciples' message.

6:11b

shake the dust off your feet when you leave that place,

- shake the dust from your^(plur) feet when you leave
- brush off your^(plur) feet to remove the dust when you leave that place.
- the disciples should leave that town, and shake/brush the dust off their feet as they leave.

shake the dust off your feet when you leave that place: Here Jesus told the disciples to remove or shake off any dust that was sticking to their feet and sandals. They probably did this by shaking their feet or brushing off the dust with their hands. Consider how you would describe this kind of action in your language.

Shaking the dust off their feet was a cultural gesture that had a symbolic meaning. When a Jewish person shook the dust of a place off of his feet, it indicated that he did not have any relationship with the people in that place. It implied that the people were not God's people. In this context, it meant that the disciples were no longer responsible for what happened to those people. God would punish the people because they did not accept the disciples and their message.

The people would cause their own punishment, because they refused the message.

It is important to translate this gesture literally here in 6:11b. Then you can explain the meaning in the next phrase (6:11c).

Here are some other ways to translate this:

shake off the dust from the bottom of your feet
when you leave

when you leave, shake/brush/tap your feet to
remove the dust

your feet: If your language has specific words for the “lower leg and foot” or for the “sole of the foot,” you may use either of these expressions.

6:11c

as a testimony against them.”

- to warn them that they are now responsible for God punishing them.”
- This would show the people of that town that God would judge/punish them.

as a testimony against them: The phrase as a testimony against them gives the meaning of the symbol of shaking dust off one’s feet. When the apostles shook off the dust of a town from their feet, they were warning the people. They were saying that God would judge them if they did not repent.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

as a warning to them that God will judge/punish
them

as a sign to show them that they are responsible/
guilty

Mark 6:12

Section 6:6b–13: Jesus sent the twelve apostles to different towns to preach and heal people

In this section Mark wrote that Jesus began to go around to various Jewish villages in order to teach the people. He also sent out his twelve apostles two by two into the villages. Jesus gave the apostles authority over evil spirits, and he gave them instructions for their journey. The apostles went out and preached that people should repent. They cast out demons and healed sick people.

The NIV starts a new section and paragraph at 6:6b. Some translations, such as the NASB and BSB, start the new section at 6:7. If you decide to do this, you should still make 6:6b a separate paragraph.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

Jesus Sends Out the Twelve (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:35; 10:5–15; Luke 8:1; 9:1–6.

Paragraph 6:12–13

In this paragraph, the disciples went to various villages to do the things that Jesus sent them to do. They preached that people should repent. They expelled demons, and they healed people.

6:12a

So they set out

- ¶ So the disciples left
- ¶ After hearing Jesus’ instructions, the twelve followers went out into the villages
- So the disciples started out on their journey. They went to the various towns

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So the common conjunction that is often translated as “and.” Here, the BSB translates this word as So in order to show that it is connecting this paragraph with the preceding paragraph. Use a word or phrase that would show this connection in a natural way in your language. For example:

After hearing Jesus’ instructions, they went out

This paragraph logically follows 6:7b, where Jesus sent out the disciples two by two. In 6:11 Jesus was still giving them instructions. Mark was not telling about an event that had happened. Be careful not to imply here that the disciples went out from an unfriendly town that did not welcome them.

they set out: The Greek word that the BSB translates as they set out means that the disciples left Jesus and began to travel to various towns.

6:12b

and preached that the people should repent.

- and preached/announced to people the message that they should turn from their sins.
- to proclaim/announce that people must stop doing evil things and obey God.
- and told people, “You^(plur) must change your thoughts about your sinning and turn to God.”

preached: The Greek word that the BSB translates as preached also means “proclaimed,” “announced,” “told” something important. For example:

proclaimed (REB)

telling everyone (NLT)

This same word occurs in 1:4b.

that the people should repent: The phrase that the people should repent gives the content of what Jesus told the disciples to say.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

that all should repent (NRSV)

to repent of their sins and turn to God (NLT)

proclaimed the need for repentance (REB)

In some languages it may be more natural to express this phrase as a direct quote. For example:

...and told people, “You must repent.”

repent: The Greek word that the BSB translates as repent means for a person “to change his mind, heart, or will.” In the Bible, it refers specifically to changing the mind and heart about sin and about God. When a person repents, he is sorry for his past sins. He decides to stop sinning and obey God.

Here are some other ways to translate repent in this context:

change their thinking/mind/heart

reject their sins

In some languages, you may have an idiom for this type of change. For example:

turn from sin to God

leave their sinning behind

See how you translated this word in 1:15c.

Mark 6:13

Section 6:6b–13: Jesus sent the twelve apostles to different towns to preach and heal people

In this section Mark wrote that Jesus began to go around to various Jewish villages in order to teach the people. He also sent out his twelve apostles two by two into the villages. Jesus gave the apostles authority over evil spirits, and he gave them instructions for their journey. The apostles went out and preached that people should repent. They cast out demons and healed sick people.

The NIV starts a new section and paragraph at 6:6b. Some translations, such as the NASB and BSB, start the new section at 6:7. If you decide to do this, you should still make 6:6b a separate paragraph.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

Jesus Sends Out the Twelve (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:35; 10:5–15; Luke 8:1; 9:1–6.

Paragraph 6:12–13

In this paragraph, the disciples went to various villages to do the things that Jesus sent them to do. They preached that people should repent. They expelled demons, and they healed people.

6:13a

They also drove out many demons

- They were also causing demons to leave many people,
- They commanded demons to come out of people, and the demons obeyed.

They also drove out many demons: The Greek word that the BSB translates as drove out is literally “cast/throw out.” To “drive out” demons means to cause evil spirits to stop controlling a person. The apostles did this by commanding the spirits to leave.

Jewish people often spoke of demons as being in someone. Different cultures have different ways of speaking about people being controlled by demons and being released from the control of demons. Use a natural expression for this in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

sent many demons away

exorcized many evil spirits

freed many people who were controlled by evil spirits

See how you translated the same phrase “drove out many demons” in 1:34b.

demons: The Greek word that the BSB translates as demons refers to spirits that are evil and can control people’s actions. This Greek word refers to the same type of spirits as the Greek terms that are often translated as “evil spirits” and “unclean spirits.”

See the note on “unclean spirits” in 6:7c and evil spirit in the Glossary for more information.

6:13b and healed many of the sick,

- and made them well,
- and healed their sicknesses,

6:13c anointing them with oil.

- and they poured oil on many sick people.
- They also put drops of oil on the heads of many sick people.

**6:13b–c
and healed many of the sick, anointing them with oil:** The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as anointing them with oil means that the disciples were putting oil on sick people. The exact purpose of anointing the sick people with oil is not clear. Some scholars believe that the oil helped in some way to heal the sick people. However, more scholars believe that anointing the sick people with oil was a symbol to show that God was blessing the sick person and healing him or her.

Use whatever verb is natural in your language to say that the disciples placed a little bit of oil (probably a few drops) on a person (probably on the head).

Here are some other ways to translate this:

rubbed olive oil on many sick people and healed them (GNT)

healed many sick people, anointing them with olive oil. (NLT)

oil: The oil that people used for anointing was olive oil. It was a common vegetable oil from that country. Olive oil was also used for cooking, for burning in lamps, and for treating wounds. In many languages it is possible to use a word here that refers to a commonly used cooking oil.

Mark 6:14

Section 6:14–29: King Herod killed John the Baptizer

Here Mark interrupted his story of how Jesus sent his disciples to preach, expel demons, and heal people. The story about Jesus and his disciples starts again in 6:30. In Section 6:14–29, Mark inserted a different story. He told what King Herod thought about Jesus and why he thought these things. He told the story of how Herod killed John the Baptizer, and how Herod thought that Jesus must be John, alive again.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

The death of John the Baptist

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:1–12; Luke 9:7–9 (see also Luke 3:19–20).

Paragraph 6:14–16

This paragraph gives background information about the thoughts that different people had about Jesus. First, Mark showed how the information was connected to what he was telling about Jesus and his disciples. Then he told some of the wrong ideas that people had about who Jesus was, and who Herod thought Jesus was.

6:14a Now King Herod heard about this,

- ¶ Then King Herod heard about these things that Jesus was doing,
- ¶ There was a certain king whose name was Herod. He heard about all that Jesus was doing,

Now King Herod heard about this: The BSB uses Now as a way to introduce background information about a new person in the story. It is not used in its usual sense of “at this time.” Many languages need to introduce the beginning of a new story with a particular word or expression. For example:

Then people told Herod...

Several other English versions do not use a conjunction here to connect this section with the preceding one. They simply start this new section with Herod’s name. Translate in a way that is natural in your language.

This is the first time that King Herod is mentioned by name in Mark. You should use a way that is natural in your language to introduce background information about a new character. For example:

There was a certain king whose name was Herod.
He heard...

King Herod: King Herod was the government leader of the Jewish district of Galilee. If you use footnotes in your translation, you may want to add a footnote that gives more information about Herod. For example:

This Herod was Herod Antipas. He was one of the sons of Herod the Great, who ruled at the time that Jesus was born. His correct title was “tetrarch,” but in the minds of the people to whom Mark wrote, his rank/status was like that of a king.

King: The word King normally refers to a ruler over an independent country. Herod Antipas was only a ruler over a fourth of Palestine, and therefore he was not truly a king. But he acted like a king, and the people considered him a king because he was an important and powerful ruler.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

ruler (CEV)

chief leader

heard about this: The Greek word that the BSB translates as heard about this is literally “heard.” The Greek text does not have the direct object this with the verb heard. Most English versions supply an object that refers to the things Jesus and his disciples were doing in the preceding section. For example:

heard about Jesus (GW)

had heard about him (NJB)

heard about all this (GNT)

6:14b

for Jesus’ name had become well known,

- because many people now knew about Jesus.
- because many people knew about Jesus and were talking about him.

In 6:14b–6:15b Mark gives background information. The story about what Herod did resumes at 6:16. Indicate this in the way that is natural in your language.

for: The Greek word that the BSB translates as for introduces the reason that Herod had heard about Jesus. The reason that Herod heard about Jesus was because Jesus had become well known. Another way to translate this is with the word “because.” For example, the GNT says:

because Jesus’ reputation had spread everywhere

Jesus’ name had become well known: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Jesus’ name had become well known is an idiom. It means that many people had heard about Jesus and were talking about him. Because the news about his teaching and miracles had spread, his reputation had now become well known.

Here are some other ways you could translate this expression:

because he was now well known (NCV)

people everywhere were talking about him
(NLT96)

General Comment on 6:14a–b

In this verse, 6:14b expresses the reason for the result in 6:14a. In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of these clauses. For example:

^{14b}Jesus’ name had become well known. ^{14a}That is the reason why Herod heard about him.

^{14b}Jesus became so well-known that ^{14a}Herod the ruler heard about him. (CEV)

6:14c–15b

Although many people knew about Jesus, they did not understand who he really was. This passage tells the various wrong ideas that people had about who Jesus was. Some thought he was someone from Jewish history who had now come back to earth. Others thought that he was John the Baptist. These people thought that Jesus was able to do miracles because God had brought him back from the dead or from heaven.

6:14c

and people were saying,

- Some people were saying,
- Some of them were saying
- John who baptized people had died, and some people were saying

and people were saying: There is a textual issue here: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have Some were saying. This refers to the people. For example, the GNT says: “Some people were saying” (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NJB, ESV, NET, NASB, REB, GW, NLT, CEV, JBP, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have he said. This refers to Herod. For example, the KJV says: “and he said” (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1) as most English versions do. This fits the context better. The form of the verb were saying shows that people said these things, and other people kept repeating them. People did not just say them one time.

6:14d

“John the Baptist has risen from the dead!”

- “This is John the Baptizer. He has come back from the dead,
- that he was John who had baptized people. They said that after John died, God raised him to life again.
- that Jesus was John the Baptizer who was alive again.

John the Baptist has risen from the dead!: Mark leaves it implicit that these people were talking about Jesus when they said this. If you need to make this information explicit, you can say:

This must be John the Baptist come back to life again. (NLT96)

that Jesus was John the Baptist who had been raised from the dead

John the Baptist: John had baptized people who repented of their sins. As a result, he became known as “John the Baptist” or “John the Baptizer.”

Some languages have a verbal expression for John the Baptist. For example, “John the Baptizer” or “John who baptizes people.” If you use an expression like that, be sure that it does not imply that John was baptizing people at the time of this story. For example, you could say:

John who had baptized people

John who had been baptizing people

See also the notes on 1:4a.

the Baptist: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Baptist is used as a title for John in 1:4a. A similar form of this title is used in Matthew and Luke.

Matthew and Luke use the noun form in Greek (“the Baptist/Baptizer”). Mark usually uses the participle form (“the Baptizing One”). Use an appropriate form of your term for “baptize” for this title.

The verb “baptize” means to purify people with a special ritual that uses water. In some verses, the verbs “wash” and “clean” are used to translate the Greek verb “baptize.” Luke 11:38 says, “But the Pharisee was surprised to see that Jesus did not first wash (baptize) before the meal.” (The Greek verb here is baptizo, but English versions translate it as “wash.” The context refers to a ritual washing, not merely a removal of dirt.). Mark 7:4 and Matthew 23:25 both speak of washing/cleaning cups and other utensils. The verb in Mark is baptizo while the verb in Matthew is katharizo (clean). Again, a ritual cleansing is involved. Mark 7:4 says, “And there are many other traditions for them to observe, including the washing (baptizing) of cups, pitchers, kettles, and couches for dining.” Matthew 23:25 says, “You clean (katharizo) the outside of the cup and dish.” However, the above references do not indicate that “wash/cleanse” is the only meaning of the rite of baptism as practiced by John and by the early Christians. And certainly Jesus’ baptism of people with the Holy Spirit signified more than purification. In this context the ritual involved a purification from sin, not a removal of dirt. It was an initiation that marked the beginning of a person’s life as one of God’s pure people.

Here are some other ways to translate “baptize”:

- Use a descriptive term. For example:

ritually wash

initiate people in/with water

- Use a term for a similar ritual that is already used in your culture. You may need to indicate that here it has a special connection with God. For example:

purify people with God’s ceremonial bath

wash people in initiation water for God

- Use a term that is already accepted by the local churches.

See baptize, Meaning 1, in the Glossary.

Here are some other ways to translate the title John the Baptist:

John who baptized people

John who cleansed people for God

John the Ritual Purifier

John who initiated people with God's washing

has risen from the dead!: The phrase has risen from the dead is passive in Greek and reads more literally "has been raised from the dead." In some languages it may be necessary to use an active verb, as the BSB does. If this is true in your language, you could follow the example of the BSB or follow the one of the examples below and say:

John the Baptizer has come back to life

God raised John the Baptizer from the dead

from the dead!: The phrase from the dead means that John had been dead but was now alive again. It could also be expressed as "from death."

General Comment on 6:14c–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate 6:14c–d as indirect speech. For example:

Some people were saying that Jesus was John the Baptizer who had been raised from the dead.

General Comment on 6:14c–d

Mark told about John the Baptizer in 1:4–14, but he did not talk about John's death. In 6:17–29 Mark told the story of John's death in order to give the background for what he said here. Since your readers may not realize that John had died, you may need to make that information explicit. Here are several ways to do so:

- Use a footnote. For example:

King Herod had killed John (see Mark 6:17–29), and some people thought that John had later been raised from the dead.

- Start 6:14c–d this way:

John the Baptizer had died, and some people said...

- Make the information explicit within 6:14c–d, for example:

Some of them said that after John the Baptizer died, God raised him to life again.

6:14e

That is why miraculous powers are at work in him."

- so/therefore he has the power to do miracles."
- As a result he is able to do miraculous/wondrous things.

That is why miraculous powers are at work in him:

The word That here refers to 5:14d ("John the Baptist has been raised from the dead"). 5:14d is the reason for the result stated in this verse part, miraculous powers are at work in him. Some people thought that Jesus had miraculous powers because he was a prophet who had died and whom God had now resurrected. See the General Comment on 5:14d–e for some ways to express this relationship between 14d and 14e.

miraculous powers are at work in him: The clause miraculous powers are at work in him means that Jesus had the "power to perform miracles" (GNT). The people knew Jesus had this power, and so they described him as someone in whom these amazing powers were at work.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

that is why he was showing such miraculous powers (JBP)

That is why he can work these miracles. (NCV)

General Comment on 6:14d–e

Here are some other ways to express the relationship between 14d (the reason) and 14e (the result):

"^dBecause John the Baptizer has been raised from the dead, ^emiraculous powers are at work in him."

"^dJohn the Baptizer has been raised from the dead, ^eand so miraculous powers are at work in him."

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order and put the result first:

“eMiraculous powers are at work in this man^d because he is John the Baptizer and has been raised from the dead.”

Mark 6:15

Section 6:14–29: King Herod killed John the Baptizer

Here Mark interrupted his story of how Jesus sent his disciples to preach, expel demons, and heal people. The story about Jesus and his disciples starts again in 6:30. In Section 6:14–29, Mark inserted a different story. He told what King Herod thought about Jesus and why he thought these things. He told the story of how Herod killed John the Baptizer, and how Herod thought that Jesus must be John, alive again.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

The death of John the Baptist

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:1–12; Luke 9:7–9 (see also Luke 3:19–20).

Paragraph 6:14–16

This paragraph gives background information about the thoughts that different people had about Jesus. First, Mark showed how the information was connected to what he was telling about Jesus and his disciples. Then he told some of the wrong ideas that people had about who Jesus was, and who Herod thought Jesus was.

6:15a

Others were saying, “He is Elijah,”

- Other people were saying, “He is the prophet Elijah.”
- But other people were saying that Jesus was Elijah, the prophet of long ago.

In Greek, 6:15a has a conjunction that can be translated as “but.” For example, the RSV says:

But others said

This conjunction shows a contrast between what the people in 6:14 were saying and what the people in 6:15 were saying. Some versions do not translate this conjunction. You should begin 6:15a in a way that is natural in your language.

Others were saying, “He is Elijah”: Other people thought that Jesus was the prophet Elijah who had come back to earth. Elijah had lived hundreds of years before and was one of the greatest prophets in Israel’s history. Some people thought that he had come back to the earth as Jesus.

He is Elijah: Since readers may not know who Elijah is, it might be helpful to translate this as:

He is the prophet Elijah.

He is Elijah, the prophet of long ago.

If you are including footnotes or a glossary in your translation, you could use them to explain briefly who Elijah was. You could include the reference to the story about God taking Elijah to heaven in 2 Kings 2:1–11.

6:15b

and still others, “He is a prophet, like one of the prophets of old.”

- And still/yet other people said, “He is a prophet, like those prophets who lived long ago.”
- Still others thought he was a prophet like the other great prophets of the past. (NLT96)

and still others: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as and still others is literally “and others” or “but others.” The BSB adds the word still to show that this refers to a third group of people.

You should refer to this third group in a way that is natural in your language.

still others: In Greek there is a verb which means “were saying” after the Greek phrase that The BSB translates as still others. The BSB leaves the Greek word meaning “were saying” implied but some languages may need to follow the Greek and use these words. Do whatever would be most natural in your language. The verb meaning “were saying” that the BSB leaves untranslated here, is the same Greek verb which the BSB translates as “were saying” in 6:14c and 6:15a. If you choose to translate the verb meaning “were saying” here, you can use the same verb you used in 6:14c or a different verb with the same basic meaning.

He is a prophet, like one of the prophets of old:

The third group of people did not identify Jesus as a particular prophet. Instead, they said that he was like the ancient prophets. This seems to show that they did not believe that he was one of the ancient prophets now living again. Rather, they thought that he was a modern prophet who resembled those who had spoken to their people in the past.

prophets: The word prophets means men who speak on behalf of God. A prophet tells people what God has revealed to him, and he also gives them messages from God.

Here are some other ways to translate prophet:

a spokesman for God

a man who speaks God's words

God's message-speaker

When choosing a term for prophet, consider how you will translate other words which are similar in meaning such as "angel," "apostle," and "preacher."

While prophets did foretell the future, this was not their only function. Avoid using a word that focuses on telling the future.

See how you translated this word in 1:2a and 6:4b. See also prophet in the Glossary.

Mark 6:16

Section 6:14–29: King Herod killed John the Baptizer

Here Mark interrupted his story of how Jesus sent his disciples to preach, expel demons, and heal people. The story about Jesus and his disciples starts again in 6:30. In Section 6:14–29, Mark inserted a different story. He told what King Herod thought about Jesus and why he thought these things. He told the story of how Herod killed John the Baptizer, and how Herod thought that Jesus must be John, alive again.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

The death of John the Baptist

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:1–12; Luke 9:7–9 (see also Luke 3:19–20).

Paragraph 6:14–16

This paragraph gives background information about the thoughts that different people had about Jesus. First, Mark showed how the information was connected to what he was telling about Jesus and his disciples. Then he told some of the wrong ideas that people had about who Jesus was, and who Herod thought Jesus was.

6:16a

But when Herod heard this, he said,

- But when Herod heard what all the people were saying, he said,
- When Herod heard these opinions/ideas, he said that

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces who Herod thought Jesus was. This idea agrees with the first idea mentioned in 6:14d. It does not contrast with all the other ideas. So some English translations do not translate the conjunction But. The NCV, for example, leaves it untranslated. Connect Herod's idea in 6:16a to the other ideas in 6:14–15 in the way that is natural in your language.

when Herod heard this: Just as in 6:14a, the word this is not in the Greek. Most English versions add the word "this" or "it" to make the meaning clearer. The word this refers back to all the things the people were saying about who Jesus was. You may need to use a specific expression instead of this, such as:

when Herod heard their opinions

when Herod heard these ideas

when Herod heard what the people were saying

6:16b

"John, whom I beheaded, has risen from the dead!"

- "He is John the Baptizer! I myself had his head cut off, but he has come back to life!"
- "This is the man they beheaded at my orders, John the Baptizer! Now he's alive again!"
- Jesus was John the one who baptized people, whom he had killed by having his head cut off. He said that John had been raised from the dead.

John, whom I beheaded, has risen from the dead!:

Herod believed what the first group of people (6:14c) were saying. He had personal reasons to believe this, since he had given the order to kill John (6:17–29).

It is not explicitly stated that Herod thought that Jesus was John. You may need to make this clear. For example:

He is John the Baptist! I had his head cut off, but he has come back to life! (GNT)

Jesus must be John, the man I beheaded! He has been raised from the dead.

John: It may be necessary to say "John the Baptist" (as in the GNT) to make the reference clear.

In Greek, John's name is stated at the end of the clause "the man I beheaded." This emphasizes John

and makes him the focus of this passage. To emphasize John you could translate:

He is John the Baptist! (GNT)

This must be John! (CEV)

whom I beheaded: The phrase *whom I beheaded* here means that Herod had ordered someone to cut off John's head. Herod himself did not cut off John's head. One of his soldiers did that.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I caused his head to be cut off

I myself ordered him to be beheaded

I: In Greek, the word *I* is emphasized. If possible, you should make this word emphatic in your translation. For example:

It was I who had him beheaded!

has risen from the dead: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as *has risen from the dead* is more literally “has been raised from the dead,” as in the NIV. This is a passive clause. In some languages it may be more natural to use an active verb, as the BSB does. Here are some other ways to say this in active form:

he has come back to life

God raised him from the dead

Some languages use an impersonal third person plural “they” to show a passive. For example:

they raised him from the dead

from the dead: Not all Greek manuscripts include the phrase *from the dead*. Some manuscripts say “John, whom I beheaded, has been raised” (as in the RSV). But even in these texts, the idea of *from the dead* is clearly implied. So it is recommended that you include this phrase in your translation if it is natural.

General Comment on 6:16a–b

In some languages it may be natural to translate Herod's comments as indirect speech. For example:

Herod heard what the people were saying. He decided that John the Baptizer, whom he had beheaded, must have been raised from the dead.

Mark 6:17

Section 6:14–29: King Herod killed John the Baptizer

Here Mark interrupted his story of how Jesus sent his disciples to preach, expel demons, and heal people. The story about Jesus and his disciples starts again in 6:30. In Section 6:14–29, Mark inserted a different story. He told what King Herod thought about Jesus and why he thought these things. He told the story of how Herod killed John the Baptizer, and how Herod thought that Jesus must be John, alive again.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

The death of John the Baptist

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:1–12; Luke 9:7–9 (see also Luke 3:19–20).

Paragraph 6:17–20

This paragraph begins the story that explains what Herod said in 6:16 about killing John the Baptizer. The events in this story happened before the events in 6:14–16. Events like this are called background information.

The events within paragraph 6:17–20 are not all in chronological order. The exact order of all the events is not certain. However, it is clear that the events of 6:17a–b happened after the events of 6:17c. See the General Comment on 6:17–18 after 6:18b for a discussion of a possible way to reorder these verses.

6:17a

For Herod himself had ordered that John be arrested

- ¶ It was this same Herod who had ordered men to arrest John
- ¶ Herod himself had earlier given orders to arrest/capture John the Baptizer

For Herod himself: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *For* introduces background information for 6:16. This background information helps to explain why Herod thought that Jesus was John the Baptizer who was raised from the dead.

Here are some possible ways to introduce this background information:

For/Now this is what had previously happened, Herod himself...

Now it was this same Herod who... (NJB)

Some English translations do not explicitly translate this conjunction here. Introduce this background information in a way that is natural in your language.

Herod himself: In Greek, the word himself emphasizes Herod. Try to emphasize Herod in a natural way in your language. For example:

Herod himself (GNT)

It was this Herod who... (REB)

it was this same Herod who... (NJB)

had ordered that John be arrested: The Greek says literally “having sent, arrested John.” This implies that Herod sent men/soldiers to arrest John. To make this explicit you could say:

Herod gave orders to his soldiers to arrest John

6:17b and bound and imprisoned,

- and had caused him to be tied/chained and put in prison.
- and chained/tied him up in prison.

and bound and imprisoned: The phrase and imprisoned indicates that Herod had given orders to his soldiers to put John in prison. Herod himself did not personally put John in prison.

bound and imprisoned: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as bound and imprisoned is literally “bound him in prison” (as in the RSV). There are two ways to interpret this Greek phrase:

1. The word bound is used here in its specific sense. So this phrase means that Herod had John chained or tied and put into prison. For example, the GNT says:

he had him tied up and put in prison (BSB, NIV, NRSV, GNT, GW)

1. The word bound is used here in its general sense. So this phrase means that Herod had John “confined/locked/put into prison.” For example, the CEV says:

put him in prison (CEV, NCV, NLT, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

There are two ways to translate interpretation (1). You may say that John was first tied/chained and then put into prison (as in the GNT). Or you may say that he was put into prison and he was tied/chained while in the prison. The UBS (page 194) comments that the literal phrase “bound in prison” does not indicate that John was in prison, tied up. However, a number of commentators disagree and say that John was chained or tied up in the prison (Hiebert page 148, Lenski page 250, Cole page 65). It may be noted here that Paul was put in the stocks while in an inner jail cell (Acts 16:24). There is also no indication that John was untied after being put into prison. For example, the NJB says:

had him chained up in prison

imprisoned: In some languages the idea that Herod had John the Baptizer put in prison is expressed as a verb. For example:

caused him to be imprisoned

Other languages do not have a specific word for “prison.” These languages can express the idea of imprisoned as:

locked/tied in a room

6:17c on account of his brother Philip’s wife Herodias,

- This is the reason that Herod did these things: He had taken Herodias, who was his brother Philip’s wife,
- He did this in order to please Herodias, who was formerly his older brother Philip’s wife.

Here Mark began to give the background for what he said in 6:17a–b about Herod putting John in prison. This is not in chronological order. These events happened sometime before the events in 6:17a–b. See the General Comment on 6:17–18 at the end of 6:18b.

on account of his brother Philip’s wife Herodias: The phrase that the BSB translates as on account of his brother Philip’s wife Herodias in this context means “to appease Herodias,” that is, to make Herodias happy. Herod put John in prison because John had offended Herodias, and Herod wanted to show her that he was punishing John. You may need to make this explicit. For example:

for the sake of Herodias (RSV)

as a favor to Herodias (NLT)

his brother Philip's wife Herodias: Herodias had been married to Herod's older brother, whose name was Philip. Herodias was no longer married to Philip, so it may not be natural in your language to use the phrase Philip's wife. You may need to say:

Herodias, who had previously been married to Herod's older brother Philip

Herodias, who was formerly the wife of Philip, older brother of Herod

(She used to be his brother Philip's wife.) (GW)

Herodias: The word Herodias is the name of a woman. She is a new person in the story. If your language has a particular way to introduce new people into a story, you should use it here. You should write the name Herodias according to the spelling system that your language uses for a woman's name.

6:17d

whom Herod had married.

- and married her.
- Herod had taken her from his brother and married her.

whom Herod had married: Herod had taken Philip's wife away from him while Philip was still alive. Herod then married her.

Mark 6:18

Section 6:14–29: King Herod killed John the Baptizer

Here Mark interrupted his story of how Jesus sent his disciples to preach, expel demons, and heal people. The story about Jesus and his disciples starts again in 6:30. In Section 6:14–29, Mark inserted a different story. He told what King Herod thought about Jesus and why he thought these things. He told the story of how Herod killed John the Baptizer, and how Herod thought that Jesus must be John, alive again.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

The death of John the Baptist

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:1–12; Luke 9:7–9 (see also Luke 3:19–20).

Paragraph 6:17–20

This paragraph begins the story that explains what Herod said in 6:16 about killing John the Baptizer. The events in this story happened before the events in 6:14–16. Events like this are called background information.

The events within paragraph 6:17–20 are not all in chronological order. The exact order of all the events is not certain. However, it is clear that the events of 6:17a–b happened after the events of 6:17c. See the General Comment on 6:17–18 after 6:18b for a discussion of a possible way to reorder these verses.

6:18a

For John had been telling Herod,

- John had repeatedly said to Herod,
- Herod had put John in prison because John was saying to him

For: The word For introduces the reason for 6:17a–b, not for 6:17c–d.

^{17a}Herod had John arrested ^{17b}and put in prison...

^{18a}because John had been saying to Herod...

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Repeat part of 6:17a–b here in 6:18a. For example:

Herod had John put in prison because John had been saying to Herod...

- Leave out this connector, because it does not refer to what immediately precedes. Therefore its meaning may not be clear. For example, the GW says:

John had been telling Herod

- If you have a connector that can introduce the reason for something further back in the text, you could use it here.
- Rearrange the parts of 6:17. See the example from the CEV in the General Comment on 6:17–18 below.

John had been telling Herod: These words introduce what John said to Herod before Herod arrested John. The form of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as had been telling indicates that John said these things repeatedly.

6:18b

"It is not lawful for you to have your brother's wife!"

- “It’s not right, according to the Law of Moses, for you to marry your brother’s wife.”
- “You are not permitted/allowed to be married to your older brother’s wife.”
- that it was wrong for him to be married to his older brother’s wife.

It is not lawful for you to have your brother’s wife!:

The phrase not lawful means “not right according to the law.” Here, the reference is to the law of Moses. This is the law that God gave to Moses for the people of Israel (in Leviticus 18:16, 20:21). In this context, have your brother’s wife means to “be married to your brother’s wife.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

It’s not right for you to be married to your brother’s wife. (GW)

You are not permitted/allowed to have your older brother’s wife.

It is contrary to God’s laws/instructions to marry your older brother’s wife.

General Comment on 6:17–18

In some languages it may be natural to change the order of 6:17–18 to follow more closely the chronological order of events. You may want to follow the order of the CEV to make the story clearer:

^{17d}Herod had earlier married Herodias, ^{17c}the wife of his brother Philip. ^{18a}But John had told him, ^{18b}“It isn’t right for you to take your brother’s wife!” ^{17c}So, in order to please Herodias, ^{17a}Herod arrested John ^{17b}and put him in prison.

Mark 6:19

Section 6:14–29: King Herod killed John the Baptizer

Here Mark interrupted his story of how Jesus sent his disciples to preach, expel demons, and heal people. The story about Jesus and his disciples starts again in 6:30. In Section 6:14–29, Mark inserted a different story. He told what King Herod thought about Jesus and why he thought these things. He told the story of how Herod killed John the Baptizer, and how Herod thought that Jesus must be John, alive again.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

The death of John the Baptist

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:1–12; Luke 9:7–9 (see also Luke 3:19–20).

Paragraph 6:17–20

This paragraph begins the story that explains what Herod said in 6:16 about killing John the Baptizer. The events in this story happened before the events in 6:14–16. Events like this are called background information.

The events within paragraph 6:17–20 are not all in chronological order. The exact order of all the events is not certain. However, it is clear that the events of 6:17a–b happened after the events of 6:17c. See the General Comment on 6:17–18 after 6:18b for a discussion of a possible way to reorder these verses.

6:19a

So Herodias held a grudge against John

- Therefore, Herodias hated/resented John,
- As for Herodias, this made her feel continually angry/resentful toward John.
- So Herodias often thought about how much she hated/resented John.

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB here translates as So here introduces the result of what happened in 6:18. What John told Herod in 6:18 caused Herodias to act as she did in 6:19. For example:

^{18a}John was telling Herod, ^{18b}“It is not lawful for you to be married to your brother’s wife.” ^{19a}So/therefore, as a result, Herodias nursed a grudge against John...

Herodias: In the Greek text Herodias is emphasized. The NJB shows this clearly:

As for Herodias...

If you can emphasize Herodias in a natural way in your translation, you should do so.

held a grudge against John: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as held a grudge means “felt anger and hatred/resentment.” This is an inward attitude that Herodias had toward John over a period of time.

The BSB uses the English idiom held a grudge to express the meaning of this phrase. If you have an idiom in your language that expresses the same meaning, you should use it here. If not you should translate the meaning of this phrase. For example:

continued to feel anger and resentment/hatred towards John

continued to think about how much she resented/hated John

6:19b and wanted to kill him.

- and she wanted to kill him.
- She wanted to have someone kill him,

and wanted to kill him: Herodias probably did not think that she would kill John herself. But her position of power allowed her to command soldiers to kill John, or to have Herod command soldiers to kill John. If you need to make this explicit, you could follow one of these examples:

wanted John to be killed

wanted to have someone kill John

6:19c But she had been unable,

- But she could not kill him,
- but this was not possible,

But she had been unable: It may be necessary in the translation to make clear what Herodias was not able to do. For example:

She was not able to kill him

She was not able to have someone kill him

Mark 6:20

Section 6:14–29: King Herod killed John the Baptizer
Here Mark interrupted his story of how Jesus sent his disciples to preach, expel demons, and heal people. The story about Jesus and his disciples starts again in 6:30. In Section 6:14–29, Mark inserted a different story. He told what King Herod thought about Jesus and why he thought these things. He told the story of how Herod killed John the Baptizer, and how Herod thought that Jesus must be John, alive again.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

The death of John the Baptist

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:1–12; Luke 9:7–9 (see also Luke 3:19–20).

Paragraph 6:17–20

This paragraph begins the story that explains what Herod said in 6:16 about killing John the Baptizer. The events in this story happened before the events in 6:14–16. Events like this are called background information.

The events within paragraph 6:17–20 are not all in chronological order. The exact order of all the events is not certain. However, it is clear that the events of 6:17a–b happened after the events of 6:17c. See the General Comment on 6:17–18 after 6:18b for a discussion of a possible way to reorder these verses.

6:20a because Herod feared John

- since Herod greatly respected/revered John,
- because Herod would not allow it, since he was in awe of John.

because: The word because introduces the reason for 6:19c, that is, the reason Herodias was unable to have John killed. She probably could not do so without Herod's help/permission.

Herod feared John: The Greek verb that the BSB translates here as feared refers to a mixture of fear and awe/reverence. Herod revered or highly respected John, and he also feared him. In 6:20c it is clear that the reason for this fear and respect was that Herod considered John to be righteous and holy.

If your language has a word such as “awe” that refers to a very strong respect as well as fear, you may want to use it here. For example, the NJB says:

Herod was in awe of John

Another option is to use two different phrases. For example:

Herod feared and respected John

Herod's respect and fear for John was great

6:20b–c and protected him, knowing that he was a righteous and holy man.

The BSB changes the Greek order of the phrases in 6:20b–c. The RSV follows the Greek order. Compare the order of the phrases in the RSV and BSB below.

^{20a}For Herod feared John, ^{20c}knowing that he was a righteous and holy man, ^{20b}and kept him safe. (RSV)

^{20a}because Herod feared John ^{20b}and protected him, ^{20c}knowing that he was a righteous and holy man (BSB)

Another way to order these clauses is as the TRT has done:

^{20c}because Herod knew that John was a righteous and holy man, ^{20a}so he feared him ^{20b}and protected him

The Notes below and the Display have been reordered to follow the Greek text. You should follow the order that expresses the meaning most clearly and naturally in your language.

6:20b and protected him,

- Therefore/So he protected John.
- That is why Herod kept anyone from harming John.

6:20c (reordered) knowing that he was a righteous and holy man.

- because he knew that John was a good and holy man. (GNT)
- He knew that John did what was right and lived in a godly way.

knowing that he was a righteous and holy man: These words give the reason for Herod's fear and awe of John the Baptizer. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

because Herod knew that John was a righteous and holy man

If it is not natural in your language to begin both 6:20a and 6:20c with "because," you can start a new sentence here without a conjunction. For example:

He knew that John was a righteous and holy man.

righteous and holy man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as righteous refers to a person who lives according to God's standards. In other words, he consistently does what is right. This word also occurs in 2:17c.

Here are some other ways to translate a righteous... man:

a good...man (GNT)

a man who did what was right

holy: The word holy describes something or someone that is dedicated or set apart to the service of God. When it is used to describe a person, it also implies that the person is separated from sin. He is not sinless, but his life is morally pure and clean.

Here are some other ways to translate holy in this verse:

dedicated to serving God

godly/devout

morally clean/pure

and protected him: The clause and protected him gives the result of 6:19b–20a,c. Herodias wanted to kill John. But Herod would not allow it because he feared John. Therefore, he kept him safe.

Here are some other ways to connect 6:20b to the previous clauses:

...so he protected him. (GW)

Therefore, he kept him safe.

protected: The Greek word that the BSB translates as protected means "kept safe" or "preserved." John was in prison, but Herod did not allow Herodias to have him killed.

6:20d When he heard John's words, he was greatly perplexed;

- Every time Herod/he heard John preach/speak, he was very troubled,
- Whenever he had John brought before him so he could hear him preach, Herod felt disturbed/troubled and did not know what to do.

When he heard John's words: It is implied here that John preached to Herod on several occasions. You could make this explicit as follows:

Every time he heard John

Whenever Herod heard John

It is implied that someone brought John from the prison in order for John to speak to Herod. See 6:20d in the Display for one way to make this explicit.

he was greatly perplexed: There is a textual issue here: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have he was greatly disturbed/perplexed. For example, the NLT says: “Herod was greatly disturbed” (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NJB, ESV, NET, NASB, REB, GW, NLT, CEV, JBP, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have he did many things. For example, the KJV says: “he did many things” (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1) as most English versions do. The Greek word that the BSB translates as perplexed means “troubled” or “disturbed.” He was troubled because he was uncertain or confused about what to do.

It is implied that Herod was uncertain about what he should do in response to John’s teaching. Herod respected John very much, but he did not want to obey John’s teaching.

In Greek the word perplexed is intensified by a word the BSB translates as greatly. Use a word or expression here that shows that Herod was very troubled or disturbed.

6:20e

yet he listened to him gladly.

- but even so, he liked to listen to John.
- In spite of this, he would listen gladly to what John said.

yet he listened to him gladly: The word yet shows a contrast with the statement in 6:20d.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

^{20d}When he heard him, he was much perplexed,

^{20e}but he heard him gladly.

^{20d} Even though Herod was troubled/disturbed by John’s preaching, ^{20e}he liked to listen to him.

he listened to him gladly: The phrase he listened to him gladly means that Herod was willing and happy to hear John preach.

General Comment on 6:20d–e

It may be helpful in your language to reorder 6:20d–e and make explicit some of the implied information. For example:

Herod was disturbed whenever he talked with John, but even so, he liked to listen to him. (NLT96)

Even though Herod was disturbed by what John said, he was glad to listen to him. And he often did.

He liked to listen to him, although what he heard left him greatly disturbed. (REB)

Mark 6:21

Section 6:14–29: King Herod killed John the Baptizer

Here Mark interrupted his story of how Jesus sent his disciples to preach, expel demons, and heal people. The story about Jesus and his disciples starts again in 6:30. In Section 6:14–29, Mark inserted a different story. He told what King Herod thought about Jesus and why he thought these things. He told the story of how Herod killed John the Baptizer, and how Herod thought that Jesus must be John, alive again.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

The death of John the Baptist

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:1–12; Luke 9:7–9 (see also Luke 3:19–20).

Paragraph 6:21–29

The previous paragraph implied that Herodias had wanted to kill John for some time. In this paragraph, Mark told about a new development in the story: a banquet on Herod’s birthday. During this banquet, Herodias finally had a chance to have John killed.

6:21a–c

On Herod’s birthday, her opportunity arose. Herod held a banquet for his nobles....

This verse contains two time phrases, her opportunity arose and On Herod’s birthday. In some languages it may sound as if these two phrases refer to two different times or days. To avoid this misunderstanding, some English versions have made it clearer that these two phrases refer to the same time. For example:

Herodias found her opportunity when Herod on his birthday gave a banquet to his chief officials... (REB)

Finally Herodias got her chance. It was on Herod’s birthday, when he gave a feast for all the top government officials... (GNT)

In some languages it may be more natural to put the information about Herodias after the information about Herod’s birthday. For example:

^{21b}But one day, Herod gave a feast ^{21a}to celebrate the day of his birth. ^{21c}He invited his high officials.... ^{21a}And that was Herodias' chance to cause John to be killed. This is how it happened.

^{21a}After some time, Herod celebrated his birthday. ^{21c}He invited his high officials...^{21b}to join in the celebration/feast. ^{21a}During this feast, Herodias had an opportunity to have John killed.

6:21a

On Herod's birthday, her opportunity arose.

- ¶ Finally the right time came for Herodias to do what she wished. It was on Herod's birthday.
- ¶ But one day, there was an opportunity for Herodias to have John killed. Herod celebrated the day of the year on which he had been born

On Herod's birthday: Herod celebrated the day of the year on which he had been born. If people do not celebrate birthdays in your culture, you may need to make this information explicit.

Here are some other ways to translate the word birthday:

the day when another year of his life was finished

the day when a new year of his life started

the day of the year on which he had been born

her opportunity arose: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as her opportunity arose is literally "a suitable day came." This means that on a certain day, Herodias had an opportunity to have John killed. In many languages this will be best expressed by an idiom. For example:

the perfect time came (NCV)

Herodias had an opportunity

Herodias got her chance (GNT)

6:21b

Herod held a banquet

- On that day Herod gave a banquet/feast
- with a great feast.

Herod held a banquet: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Herod held a banquet means that Herod

ordered a feast to be given. This was a feast in Herod's honor. His servants prepared the food.

6:21c

for his nobles and military commanders and the leading men of Galilee.

- and invited his government chiefs, his army leaders, and the important citizens of Galilee.
- His guests were the men who led his government, the men who led his soldiers, and the important/influential men of the region of Galilee.

for his nobles and military commanders and the leading men of Galilee:

Herod invited three types of people to his birthday feast: nobles, military commanders, and leading men. (The notes below describe these types of people.) If it is difficult to find three distinct terms in your language, this could be expressed in a more general way, such as:

all his chiefs and the important men of Galilee

nobles: The term nobles refers to the government leaders under Herod. They were his closest political advisors. They could also be called the "chief men" or "great ones" or "high officials." The GNT calls them "top government officials."

military commanders: The term military commanders refers to men who led large numbers of soldiers. They were the leaders of Herod's army.

the leading men of Galilee: The leading men of Galilee were the "important men" of the region of Galilee. They were the ones who were influential among the people. They may not have had official position, but they were powerful because of their wealth, their relationships or other ways they had of influencing people. The GNT calls them "the leading citizens of Galilee."

Galilee: Galilee is a region in the northern part of the land where Jesus lived. See how you translated this word in 1:9a.

Mark 6:22

Section 6:14–29: King Herod killed John the Baptizer

Here Mark interrupted his story of how Jesus sent his disciples to preach, expel demons, and heal people. The story about Jesus and his disciples starts again in 6:30. In Section 6:14–29, Mark inserted a different story. He told what King Herod thought about Jesus and why he thought these things. He told the story of how Herod killed John the Baptizer, and how Herod thought that Jesus must be John, alive again.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

The death of John the Baptist

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:1–12; Luke 9:7–9 (see also Luke 3:19–20).

Paragraph 6:21–29

The previous paragraph implied that Herodias had wanted to kill John for some time. In this paragraph, Mark told about a new development in the story: a banquet on Herod's birthday. During this banquet, Herodias finally had a chance to have John killed.

6:22a

When the daughter of Herodias came and danced,

- During the feast, the daughter of Herodias came and danced.
- Herodias had a daughter. She came in and danced at the feast to entertain Herod and his guests.

When the daughter of Herodias came: This is the first time that the daughter of Herodias is mentioned. You may need to make some of the background information explicit in order to introduce this new person in a natural way. For example:

Herodias had a daughter. She came to Herod and his guests...

During the feast, a girl came in to dance. She was the daughter of Herodias.

the daughter of Herodias: The Greek word that the BSB translates as daughter here refers to the daughter of Herodias and her previous husband Philip. She was not the daughter of Herod.

and danced: A number of commentators say that this was the kind of dance that would sexually arouse a man. Use a word or phrase for danced in your language that is appropriate for this type of situation.

6:22b

she pleased Herod and his guests,

- Her dance pleased Herod and his guests.
- Herod and the men eating with him at the feast liked/enjoyed her dance.

she pleased Herod and his guests: The phrase she pleased Herod and his guests here indicates that the men enjoyed watching the young woman dance. She was attractive and sexually desirable. The GW has another way to say this:

Herod and his guests were delighted with her.

his guests: The word that the BSB translates as guests refers to the men in 6:21c.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

his dinner guests (NIV)

the people eating with him (NCV)

the men he had invited

6:22c

and the king said to the girl, “Ask me for whatever you wish,

- Then King Herod said to the girl, “Ask me to give you anything that you^(sing) want,
- So King Herod said to her, “What do you want? Tell me,
- Then King Herod told her to ask him for anything she wanted,

and the king said to the girl: In the Greek, there is no explicit connection between this and the preceding clause. If it is more natural in your language to use a connecting word here you could use a word such as and as the BSB does. The GNT gives another example of a possible connecting word to use:

So the king said to the girl

the king: The phrase the king refers to King Herod.

the girl: The phrase the girl refers to the daughter of Herodias. She was old enough to be married in that culture, probably between thirteen and eighteen years old. So a phrase like “young woman” may be appropriate.

In some languages it may also be natural to just use a pronoun like “her.”

Ask me for whatever you wish: You could also express this as:

Ask me to give you anything you want

6:22d

and I will give it to you.”

- and I will give it to you.^(sing)
- and I will give you^(sing) what you request.”
- and he would give it to her.

and I will give it to you: In some languages there may be a particular way to express this, such as:

and you shall have it

and it will be yours

Mark 6:23

Section 6:14–29: King Herod killed John the Baptizer

Here Mark interrupted his story of how Jesus sent his disciples to preach, expel demons, and heal people. The story about Jesus and his disciples starts again in 6:30. In Section 6:14–29, Mark inserted a different story. He told what King Herod thought about Jesus and why he thought these things. He told the story of how Herod killed John the Baptizer, and how Herod thought that Jesus must be John, alive again.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

The death of John the Baptist

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:1–12; Luke 9:7–9 (see also Luke 3:19–20).

Paragraph 6:21–29

The previous paragraph implied that Herodias had wanted to kill John for some time. In this paragraph, Mark told about a new development in the story: a banquet on Herod's birthday. During this banquet, Herodias finally had a chance to have John killed.

6:23a

And he swore to her,

- And he made a promise to her with/by an oath/vow:
- He swore to her that he would

And he swore to her: There is a textual issue in this verse. In some Greek manuscripts, this clause includes a Greek word that can mean “many times” or “solemnly.” This Greek word can intensify the oath or mean that the king used many oaths:

1. Most Greek manuscripts do not have this Greek word, and most English versions do not translate this word. (BSB, NIV, CEV, NJB, NLT, KJV, RSV, JBP, GW, NASB, NCV, REB, NET)
2. Other Greek manuscripts have this Greek word. This is followed by only a few English versions. For example, the GNT says:

With many vows he said to her... (NRSV, GNT)

You should follow option (1), since it has the support of the majority of manuscripts, including some of the oldest and most reliable manuscripts. Metzger (page 77), UBS4 (page 141), and Swanson (page 89). Also, most English versions follow this option.

he swore to her: Herod emphasized what he said in 6:22c–d by making an oath/vow to Herodias. The oath that Herod used was not written down. Use a general phrase for making an oath or a vow.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

he promised with a solemn oath

he promised with/by a vow/pledge

He swore an oath to her (GW)

In some languages it may be natural to translate the oath as direct speech. For example:

“I swear this to you,” he promised

6:23b

“Whatever you ask of me, I will give you,

- “I will give you^(sing) whatever you ask/request of me,
- give her anything she asked him to give her,

Whatever you ask of me, I will give you: Herod repeated what he said in 6:22c–d.

6:23c

up to half my kingdom!”

- even if it is as much as half of my land/country.”
- up to half of all the land/country that he ruled over.

up to half my kingdom: Here Herod added to what he said the first time in 6:22c–d. He made his promise sound much more generous by using the words up to half my kingdom. These words were probably a well-known saying to show generosity.

up to: The Greek word translated by the BSB as up to means “as much as” or “to the amount/extent of.”

half my kingdom: Herod did not really have the authority to give any of his kingdom to another person. However, he still said this, whether he meant it or not. If it is difficult to translate the expression half my kingdom in your language, you could say:

half of my land/country

half of all that I rule over

General Comment on 6:23a–c

In some languages it may be natural to translate what Herod promised using indirect speech. For example:

And he promised her with an oath to give her whatever she asked him, up to half his kingdom.

And he swore that he would give her whatever she asked him, up to half his kingdom.

Mark 6:24

Section 6:14–29: King Herod killed John the Baptizer

Here Mark interrupted his story of how Jesus sent his disciples to preach, expel demons, and heal people. The story about Jesus and his disciples starts again in 6:30. In Section 6:14–29, Mark inserted a different story. He told what King Herod thought about Jesus and why he thought these things. He told the story of how Herod killed John the Baptizer, and how Herod thought that Jesus must be John, alive again.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

The death of John the Baptist

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:1–12; Luke 9:7–9 (see also Luke 3:19–20).

Paragraph 6:21–29

The previous paragraph implied that Herodias had wanted to kill John for some time. In this paragraph, Mark told about a new development in the story: a banquet on Herod's birthday. During this banquet, Herodias finally had a chance to have John killed.

6:24a

Then she went out and asked her mother,

- Then she left and went and asked her mother,
- So she went out of that place/room and said to her mother,
- So she went and asked her mother

Then she went out: You may need to state explicitly that she went out “of that place” or out “of the room where they were feasting.”

6:24b

“What should I request?”

- “What shall/should I request?”
- “What do you^(sing) think I should ask the king to give me?”
- what she should request from the king.

What should I request?: The daughter of Herodias wanted her mother's advice. She wanted to know what her mother thought that she should ask for. So it may be natural to translate this as:

What should I ask the king to give me?

What do you think I should ask for? (CEV)

6:24c

And her mother answered, “The head of John the Baptist.”

- She answered, “Ask him for the head of John the Baptist.”
- Her mother answered, “Ask him to cut off the head of John the Baptizer and give it to you.”
- Her mother said that she should ask for the head of John who baptized people.

And her mother answered: You could say “Herodias” instead of the phrase her mother.

The BSB follows the order of the Greek and puts her mother answered before the answer. Some English versions place this phrase after the answer. You should put this phrase where it is most natural in your language.

The head of John the Baptist: In some languages it may be natural to translate Herodias' answer as a complete sentence. It may also be necessary to include some of the implied information from 6:27a and 6:27b. Herod would need to order someone to go and cut off John's head and then give it to the girl. Otherwise it may sound as if John's head had already been cut off. For example:

Ask him to give you the head of John the Baptist.

You should ask him to cut off the head of John the Baptist and give it to you.

John the Baptist: See the note on 6:14d.

Mark 6:25

Section 6:14–29: King Herod killed John the Baptizer

Here Mark interrupted his story of how Jesus sent his disciples to preach, expel demons, and heal people. The story about Jesus and his disciples starts again in 6:30. In Section 6:14–29, Mark inserted a different story. He told what King Herod thought about Jesus and why he thought these things. He told the story

of how Herod killed John the Baptizer, and how Herod thought that Jesus must be John, alive again.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

The death of John the Baptist

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:1–12; Luke 9:7–9 (see also Luke 3:19–20).

Paragraph 6:21–29

The previous paragraph implied that Herodias had wanted to kill John for some time. In this paragraph, Mark told about a new development in the story: a banquet on Herod's birthday. During this banquet, Herodias finally had a chance to have John killed.

6:25a

At once the girl hurried back to the king with her request:

- Immediately, the girl hurried back to the king and asked,
- So the girl returned quickly to the king and told him

At once the girl hurried back to the king: This clause indicates that the daughter left her mother immediately, and she quickly returned to the place where the feast was taking place. In some languages it may be more natural to combine into one expression the related ideas that the girl returned At once and that she hurried. For example:

So the girl hurried back to the king (NLT)

At once the girl went back to the king (NCV)

In other languages both expressions will be necessary to communicate the girl's eagerness and haste. Think of a natural way to express this idea in your language.

with her request: In some languages, it may be more natural to use the verb "requested/asked" instead of the noun request.

In English and some other languages, the verb "request/ask" is implicit in the words "I want you to..." (in 6:25b). Therefore, you could translate this part of 6:25a as "she said..."

6:25b

"I want you to give me the head of John the Baptist on a platter immediately."

- "I want/desire the head of John the Baptizer. Have it brought to me right away on a platter/tray."
- that she wanted the head of John the Baptizer brought to her right away on a carrying plate/tray.

I want you to give me the head of John the Baptist on a platter immediately: The Greek word that the BSB translates as immediately also means "right now" or "at once." This word has a similar meaning to the word translated as "At once" in 6:25a, but it is a different Greek word.

John the Baptist: See the note on 6:14c–d.

on a platter: The word platter refers to a large, flat plate usually used to carry food. But here the platter is only a means for carrying the head. It does not imply that the head was served as food.

If people in your area will think that the term platter indicates serving the head as food, you may want to use a more general term. An example is:

carrying tray

If the purpose of bringing the head on a platter is not clear in your area, you may want to include a footnote. An example is:

Herodias wanted the head on a platter so she could see that John had been killed. The head would then be thrown away.

Use whatever parts of the above footnote you think would be helpful for the readers of your translation.

Mark 6:26

Section 6:14–29: King Herod killed John the Baptizer

Here Mark interrupted his story of how Jesus sent his disciples to preach, expel demons, and heal people. The story about Jesus and his disciples starts again in 6:30. In Section 6:14–29, Mark inserted a different story. He told what King Herod thought about Jesus and why he thought these things. He told the story of how Herod killed John the Baptizer, and how Herod thought that Jesus must be John, alive again.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

The death of John the Baptist

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:1–12; Luke 9:7–9 (see also Luke 3:19–20).

Paragraph 6:21–29

The previous paragraph implied that Herodias had wanted to kill John for some time. In this paragraph, Mark told about a new development in the story: a banquet on Herod's birthday. During this banquet, Herodias finally had a chance to have John killed.

6:26a-c

There is a contrast between 6:26a and 6:26b-c. English versions show this contrast by using words such as “but” and “although” and by arranging the order of the clauses in several ways. For example:

^{26a}The king deeply regretted his promise. ^{26b}But because of his oath and his guests, ^{26c}he didn’t want to refuse her. (GW)

^{26a}Although it grieved the king deeply, ^{26c}he did not want to reject her request ^{26b}because of his oath and his guests. (NET)

6:26a**The king was consumed with sorrow,**

- At this the king felt very sad/upset.
- The king was very sorry for what he had said. (CEV)
- Although this request made the king very sad,

The king was consumed with sorrow: The Greek term that the BSB translates as was consumed with sorrow means “very sad” or “greatly distressed.” King Herod was distressed because he did not want to kill a prophet whom he respected (6:20a-b).

In some languages, it may be necessary to make explicit the immediate cause of his distress. This was the girl’s request and the promise that he had made. For example:

The king was greatly distressed about her request

The king deeply regretted his promise. (GW)

The king was very sorry for what he had said. (CEV)

6:26b**but because of his oaths and his guests,**

- But because he had made oaths and because his dinner guests had heard him,
- But since he did not want to break the promises he had made in front of his guests,
- since he had promised/sworn with an oath to give her whatever she asked for and those at the feast with him had heard him,

but: The word but is not in the Greek. The BSB has added it to show the contrast between 6:26a and 6:26b-c.

because of his oaths and his guests: The Greek text refers to two things that made Herod decide to

have someone kill John: his oaths and his guests. But these were not two separate, unconnected things. His guests had heard his oaths. Use the proper connecting words to make clear how these things together influenced Herod. For example:

because he had made oaths and because his dinner guests had heard them

...he did not want to break the promise he had made in front of his guests. So...

oaths: The Greek noun that the BSB here translates as oaths has a related meaning to the Greek verb translated as “swore” in 6:23a. But the Greek word is different. If you translated the word “swore” with a noun in 6:23a and the word oaths here as a noun, it is recommended that you use a singular form in 6:23a and a plural form in 6:26b. The NIV, NJB, and some other English versions do this.

guests: The Greek word that the BSB translates as guests has the same root as the word in 6:22b. These were the people whom Herod had invited. They were eating and drinking with him at the feast. Use a term that is natural in your language. Here are some examples:

those he had invited

those who were eating and drinking at the feast with him

6:26c**he did not want to refuse her.**

- he did not want to refuse to give her what she requested.
- he did not want to say to her, “No, I will not give you what you ask.”

he did not want to refuse her: The words to refuse her indicate that Herod did not want to refuse to give Herodias’ daughter what she requested. In some languages it may be necessary to make some of the implied information explicit. For example:

he did not want to reject her request

he did not want to refuse to give her what she had asked for

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a direct quote. For example:

...he did not want to say to her, “No, I will not give you what you ask.”

Mark 6:27

Section 6:14–29: King Herod killed John the Baptizer

Here Mark interrupted his story of how Jesus sent his disciples to preach, expel demons, and heal people. The story about Jesus and his disciples starts again in 6:30. In Section 6:14–29, Mark inserted a different story. He told what King Herod thought about Jesus and why he thought these things. He told the story of how Herod killed John the Baptizer, and how Herod thought that Jesus must be John, alive again.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

The death of John the Baptist

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:1–12; Luke 9:7–9 (see also Luke 3:19–20).

Paragraph 6:21–29

The previous paragraph implied that Herodias had wanted to kill John for some time. In this paragraph, Mark told about a new development in the story: a banquet on Herod’s birthday. During this banquet, Herodias finally had a chance to have John killed.

6:27a

So without delay, the king commanded that John’s head be brought in. He sent an executioner,

- So Herod immediately ordered/commanded an executioner to go to the prison, cut off John’s head, and bring it to him.
- Therefore Herod immediately commanded a soldier, “Go and cut off the head of John the Baptizer, and bring it to me.”

So: The BSB uses the connecting word *So* to introduce the result of 6:26b–c. Some English versions do not use a connecting word here. If it is natural in your language to use a connecting word here, choose a word that shows that 6:27a is the result of 6:26b–c. For example:

Therefore he immediately...

without delay, the king commanded that John’s head be brought in. He sent an executioner: The words the King refer to Herod so you may need to translate 6:27a this way:

So Herod immediately commanded an executioner to go to the prison, cut off John’s head, and bring it to him.

executioner: The Greek word that the BSB translates as executioner refers to a soldier. This soldier was ready to obey his commander’s orders, including the order to execute (kill) a prisoner.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

soldier (NCV)

guard (CEV)

6:27b

who went and beheaded him in the prison.

- The man/executioner went to the prison and cut off John’s head.
- The soldier went to the prison, where he cut off John’s head.

who went and beheaded him in the prison: The executioner went to the prison, and there he cut off John’s head. Some languages have different words for “cut” depending on the instrument used. If this is true in your language, you should use a verb meaning to cut completely off with something like a sword or machete.

Mark 6:28

Section 6:14–29: King Herod killed John the Baptizer

Here Mark interrupted his story of how Jesus sent his disciples to preach, expel demons, and heal people. The story about Jesus and his disciples starts again in 6:30. In Section 6:14–29, Mark inserted a different story. He told what King Herod thought about Jesus and why he thought these things. He told the story of how Herod killed John the Baptizer, and how Herod thought that Jesus must be John, alive again.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

The death of John the Baptist

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:1–12; Luke 9:7–9 (see also Luke 3:19–20).

Paragraph 6:21–29

The previous paragraph implied that Herodias had wanted to kill John for some time. In this paragraph, Mark told about a new development in the story: a banquet on Herod’s birthday. During this banquet, Herodias finally had a chance to have John killed.

6:28a**The man brought John's head on a platter**

- Then he put it on a tray and brought it
- Then he returned to where Herod was, carrying his/ John's head on a tray

The man brought John's head on a platter: The executioner placed the head on a flat tray (see 6:25b) and carried it back to the girl (6:28b). In some languages it may be more natural to make some of this information explicit, or to include it in the same sentence as 6:28b. For example:

Then he placed John's head on a tray/platter and brought it to the girl.

on a platter: The word platter is the same term as in 6:25b.

6:28b**and presented it to the girl,**

- to the girl,
- and gave the head to Herodias' daughter.

and presented it to the girl: The word that the BSB translates as presented means "gave," as in the RSV. It is the same word that the BSB translates as "gave" in 6:28c. The executioner (not Herod) gave the head of John the Baptizer to the girl, Herodias' daughter.

6:28c**who gave it to her mother.**

- and she carried it out and gave it to her mother.
- She then went and gave it to her mother.

who gave it to her mother: The daughter took John's head to her mother, who was in another room, and gave it to her. Your translation should not imply that the mother was in the same room as the men. To make this clear, you may want to say:

and she went and gave it to her mother

Mark 6:29**Section 6:14–29: King Herod killed John the Baptizer**

Here Mark interrupted his story of how Jesus sent his disciples to preach, expel demons, and heal people. The story about Jesus and his disciples starts again in 6:30. In Section 6:14–29, Mark inserted a different story. He told what King Herod thought about Jesus and why he thought these things. He told the story of how Herod killed John the Baptizer, and how Herod thought that Jesus must be John, alive again.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

The death of John the Baptist

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:1–12; Luke 9:7–9 (see also Luke 3:19–20).

Paragraph 6:21–29

The previous paragraph implied that Herodias had wanted to kill John for some time. In this paragraph, Mark told about a new development in the story: a banquet on Herod's birthday. During this banquet, Herodias finally had a chance to have John killed.

6:29a**When John's disciples heard about this,**

- When John's disciples heard that this had happened,
- John's followers heard that he was dead, so

When John's disciples heard about this: Here the story shifts to a new set of people, John's disciples. John the Baptizer also had disciples, just as Jesus did (see 2:18d). The BSB follows the order of the Greek by introducing John's disciples in 6:29a. Here are some other examples of ways to introduce them:

When John's disciples heard this

John's disciples heard this, so...

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means "learners" who are in a relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

students/learners

apprentices

followers

See how you translated this term at 2:15b and 6:1c. See also disciple in the Glossary for more information.

this: The word this refers to the fact that John had been killed. You may need to make this explicit in your translation. For example:

When John's disciples heard that John was dead

When John's disciples heard that this had happened

6:29b they came

- they came/went to Herod/Herod's soldiers

they came: John's disciples probably came to Herod or to Herod's soldiers and asked for the body. Your translation should not imply that they came and took the body without permission.

6:29c and took his body

- and asked for John's dead body. They took it away

and took his body: The Greek word that the BSB translates as body refers specifically to a corpse, that is, a dead body.

6:29d and placed it in a tomb.

- and placed it in a tomb.
- and entombed/buried him.

and placed it in a tomb: The Greek word that the BSB translates as tomb refers to a cave where people could bury someone who had died. The main idea here is that John's disciples honored their dead master in the customary way of burial. If people do not put the dead in caves in your culture, you could use a general verb such as "entombed" or "buried" (GNT).

Your language may have an appropriate idiom, such as "laid it to rest" in English.

General Comment on 6:29, 6:7

This verse ends a long section of background information about the death of John the Baptizer. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate that the background information has ended. You may need to repeat what was happening before the background information began. For example:

It was sometime after John the Baptizer was buried that Jesus sent his apostles to different villages.

This example mentions that Jesus sent his apostles to different villages (6:7), because in 6:30, the apostles returned to Jesus.

Mark 6:30

Section 6:30–44: Jesus did a miracle to feed more than five thousand people

Here Mark resumed the story about Jesus and his twelve apostles. In this section the twelve apostles came back to Jesus and told him about their mission in the Jewish villages. Then Jesus and the apostles went away to find a quiet place to rest. But crowds of people came there to see Jesus. Jesus taught the crowds of people and then did a miracle in order to give them all food to eat.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Feeds the Five Thousand (NIV)

The Feeding of the Five Thousand (NET)

Jesus fed five thousand people in a miraculous way

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:13–21; Luke 9:10–17; John 6:1–14. See also a similar story, where Jesus fed four thousand people, in Matthew 15:32–39 and Mark 8:1–10.

Paragraph 6:30–32

In 6:6b–13 Jesus sent out his twelve apostles in groups of two to preach, to expel demons, and to heal sick people. Here in 6:30–32, the apostles returned from their mission and told Jesus what had happened. Then Jesus invited them to a quiet place away from the crowds so that they could rest.

6:30a

Meanwhile, the apostles gathered around Jesus

- ¶ After some time, the apostles rejoined Jesus/him
- ¶ When the twelve apostles that Jesus sent out returned to him,

The events in 6:30–32 began sometime after Jesus sent the twelve apostles out in 6:6b–13. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between the time the disciples went out and the time they came back to report to Jesus in 6:30. Also, Mark interrupted the story about Jesus and the twelve apostles to tell a different story (about John the Baptist and Herod).

Your language may have a particular way to show that a story is starting again after an interruption to tell

about something else. If so, you could use it here. One way to do this in English is:

When Jesus' apostles returned from the villages, they...

Meanwhile, the apostles gathered around Jesus: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the apostles gathered around Jesus implies that they first returned to Jesus. In some languages, it may be natural to make this explicit. For example, the GNT says:

the apostles returned and met with Jesus

apostles: The Greek word that English versions translate as apostles means “those who are sent.” Here it refers to the people whom Jesus sent with authority to accomplish a mission or a particular task.

Some ways to translate “apostles” are:

- Translate the meaning of the Greek word apostles. For example:

people sent to speak/act for him

special messengers

representatives

men with authority from Jesus

- Indicate the role or function of apostles. For example:

chief leaders of Jesus' work

people who are in charge of Jesus' work

Be careful to choose different terms for “apostle,” “angel,” “elder,” and “prophet.”

This is the second time in Mark that the twelve disciples are called apostles. (The first time is in 3:14b.) See also apostle in the Glossary.

Mark usually referred to Jesus' twelve closest followers as “disciples” rather than apostles. He may have chosen the word apostles here since they had returned from the mission that Jesus sent them on in 6:7.

gathered around Jesus: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as gathered around also means “assembled” or “met.” The twelve apostles had been apart from each other and from Jesus. They had gone in groups of two to many villages. Now they came back together again.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

rejoined Jesus (NJB)

returned and met with Jesus (GNT)

6:30b

and brought Him news of all they had done and taught.

- and reported to him all that they had done and all that they taught to the people.
- they told him everything that they had done and everything that they had taught to the people.

and brought Him news of all they had done and taught: In 6:12–13 Mark told what the twelve men did after Jesus sent them out. Here in 6:30b they came back and told Jesus about all these things.

all they had done: The general phrase all they had done includes expelling demons and healing sick people.

all they had...taught: In 6:12 it says that they “preached that the people should repent.” Here in 6:30b, Mark says that they taught, that is, they instructed or directed people. Preaching and teaching are similar, but if you have two different verbs, you should use a different one here from the one you used for “preached.”

If you need to say whom the disciples taught, you can say:

all that they had taught to the people

Mark 6:31

Section 6:30–44: Jesus did a miracle to feed more than five thousand people

Here Mark resumed the story about Jesus and his twelve apostles. In this section the twelve apostles came back to Jesus and told him about their mission in the Jewish villages. Then Jesus and the apostles went away to find a quiet place to rest. But crowds of people came there to see Jesus. Jesus taught the crowds of people and then did a miracle in order to give them all food to eat.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Feeds the Five Thousand (NIV)

The Feeding of the Five Thousand (NET)

Jesus fed five thousand people in a miraculous way

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:13–21; Luke 9:10–17; John 6:1–14. See also a similar story, where Jesus fed four thousand people, in Matthew 15:32–39 and Mark 8:1–10.

Paragraph 6:30–32

In 6:6b–13 Jesus sent out his twelve apostles in groups of two to preach, to expel demons, and to heal sick people. Here in 6:30–32, the apostles returned from their mission and told Jesus what had happened. Then Jesus invited them to a quiet place away from the crowds so that they could rest.

6:31

The BSB follows the Greek order of the phrases in 6:31. The NIV changes the order. Compare the order of the phrases in the BSB and NIV below.

^{31a}And he said to them, ^{31b}“Come with Me privately to a solitary place, ^{31c}and let us rest for a while.”
^{31d}For many were coming and going, ^{31e}and they had no leisure even to eat. (BSB)

^{31d}Then, because so many people were coming and going ^{31e}that they did not even have a chance to eat, ^{31a}he said to them, ^{31b}“Come with me by yourselves to a quiet place ^{31c}and get some rest.” (NIV)

You should arrange the phrases in 6:31 in a way that is natural in your language.

6:31a

And He said to them,

- Jesus said to the twelve apostles,
- So he said to them,
- So he told just his apostles

And: In Greek this verse begins with the common conjunction that is often translated as “and.” The BSB uses And as a transition word here and the NIV uses “Then” as a transition word. In 6:30 the apostles came

back to Jesus and reported what they had done. Here, the word And introduces what happened next in the story.

The CEV uses “But” here to contrast Jesus and the apostles in 6:30 with all the people coming and going in 6:31.

Use a natural way in your language to make this transition and introduce the next event in the story.

He said to them: You may need to use a noun for one or both of the pronouns He and them. For example:

Jesus said to the apostles

6:31b

“Come with Me privately to a solitary place,

- “Come with me, just you(plur) yourselves. We(incl) will go to a secluded/remote place
- “Let us go off by ourselves to some place where we will be alone (GNT)
- to come with him to a quiet place

privately: Many people besides the twelve apostles were followers of Jesus. But the words privately make it clear that he was inviting just the small group of twelve, who especially needed some rest.

a solitary place: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as a solitary place is literally “a lonely place” (as in the RSV). This was a private or desolate area where there were no people. It was a place where Jesus and his followers could be alone and rest.

The BSB also translates this phrase as “a solitary place” in 1:35b. See how you translated it there.

6:31c

and let us rest for a while.”

- so that we(incl) can rest a little.”
- and you can rest a while.” (GNT)
- to get some rest.

and let us rest for a while: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as let us rest for awhile means “rest for a little while.” This phrase shows the purpose for which Jesus invited the twelve to go away with him. You may need to make this clear by saying:

in order to rest a while

Notice that the GNT has “you can rest a while.” In some languages it may be possible to use the pronoun “you(plur)” if it implies that Jesus was showing concern for his followers. It should not imply that

Jesus intended to keep working or teaching while the apostles rested. In some languages it may be more natural to use the pronoun *we*^(incl) to show that Jesus intended to rest along with the apostles. Both options are given in the Display (6:31c). Consider what would be appropriate in your language for this situation.

6:31d

For many people were coming and going,

- Then, since so many people were coming and going to see/visit them,
- There were crowds of people coming/arriving to see Jesus and the apostles and leaving again.

For many people were coming and going: The word *For* introduces the reason that Jesus told his apostles to get away and rest in 6:31d–e. It may be more natural in your language to follow the Greek order and give the reason (6:31a–b) after the result (6:31d–e). If so, you should follow the order of the BSB.

many people were coming and going: The clause *many people were coming and going* describes a state of constant activity. Many people were coming to see Jesus and the apostles. As they were leaving, there were always other people coming.

6:31e

and they did not even have time to eat.

- they did not even have time to eat; so
- Because of this, it was so busy that Jesus and his apostles did not get/have the opportunity to eat.

and they did not even have time to eat: The clause *they did not even have time to eat* means that Jesus and his disciples did not have time to eat because they were too busy because of all the people who came to see them.

Mark 6:32

Section 6:30–44: Jesus did a miracle to feed more than five thousand people

Here Mark resumed the story about Jesus and his twelve apostles. In this section the twelve apostles came back to Jesus and told him about their mission in the Jewish villages. Then Jesus and the apostles went away to find a quiet place to rest. But crowds of people came there to see Jesus. Jesus taught the crowds of people and then did a miracle in order to give them all food to eat.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Feeds the Five Thousand (NIV)

The Feeding of the Five Thousand (NET)

Jesus fed five thousand people in a miraculous way

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:13–21; Luke 9:10–17; John 6:1–14. See also a similar story, where Jesus fed four thousand people, in Matthew 15:32–39 and Mark 8:1–10.

Paragraph 6:30–32

In 6:6b–13 Jesus sent out his twelve apostles in groups of two to preach, to expel demons, and to heal sick people. Here in 6:30–32, the apostles returned from their mission and told Jesus what had happened. Then Jesus invited them to a quiet place away from the crowds so that they could rest.

6:32

So they went away in a boat by themselves to a solitary place.

- So Jesus and the twelve apostles started to cross the lake by themselves in a boat to a secluded place.
- So they started out in a boat by themselves to a lonely place. (GNT)
- So they got in a boat and started to go there.

So: The BSB uses the word *So* to introduce the result of what Jesus had said.

they went away in a boat by themselves to a solitary place: Jesus and the twelve apostles used a boat to cross part of Lake Galilee in order to leave the crowds behind. The “many” mentioned in 6:33a saw them before they arrived at the solitary place. So it may be clearer to translate this as the GNT has done:

they started out in a boat

they: The pronoun *they* refers to Jesus and the twelve apostles.

a boat: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *a boat* is literally “the boat” (as in the RSV). This may imply that it was the same boat they had used before (see 5:21a). But it is probably best to follow the example of the BSB and many other English versions and say *a boat*. You could also say that they went “by boat.”

boat: The boats used on Lake Galilee were small boats used for fishing and travel across the lake. They could hold from about four to fifteen people. People used

sails or oars (long paddles) to cause the boats to move across the water. If you do not have a word for boat in your language, here are some translation options:

- Use a phrase that describes the function of a boat. For example:

a vehicle for crossing water

something for carrying people on top of water

- Use the word for a specific kind of boat in your culture. For example:

canoe

a solitary place: The phrase a solitary place is the same Greek phrase that the BSB translates as “a solitary place” in 6:31c. It refers to a desolate area where few people lived.

In some languages, it may sound unnatural to repeat this phrase since it is also in 6:31c. If that is true in your language, you can leave this phrase implicit. For example:

So they got in a boat and started to go there.

Mark 6:33

Section 6:30–44: Jesus did a miracle to feed more than five thousand people

Here Mark resumed the story about Jesus and his twelve apostles. In this section the twelve apostles came back to Jesus and told him about their mission in the Jewish villages. Then Jesus and the apostles went away to find a quiet place to rest. But crowds of people came there to see Jesus. Jesus taught the crowds of people and then did a miracle in order to give them all food to eat.

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There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:13–21; Luke 9:10–17; John 6:1–14. See also a similar story, where Jesus fed four thousand people, in Matthew 15:32–39 and Mark 8:1–10.

Paragraph 6:33–38

Many people saw Jesus and the twelve apostles leaving and followed them. Jesus had compassion on them and taught them. When evening came, the apostles wanted Jesus to send the crowds away, because there was nothing for the people to eat. The apostles did not know any way to feed so many people.

6:33a

But many people saw them leaving and recognized them.

- ¶ But many people saw them going there and knew/recognized who they were,
- ¶ As Jesus and the twelve apostles were going/leaving in the boat, many people on the shore saw them and recognized them.

But: In 6:33, something unexpected happened. Jesus and the twelve apostles had started to go to an isolated place, but before they got there, the crowds saw them. Some English versions signal this unexpected development with a conjunction such as But (BSB, NIV, NJB). Use a natural way in your language to begin an unexpected or contrasting development in a story.

many people saw them leaving and recognized them: There is a textual issue here that concerns the subject(s) of the clause. (1) Most Greek manuscripts and the UBS4 (page 142) have no explicit subject of the verb “saw.” The only explicit subject of the entire clause is “many.” For example, the NRSV has: “Now many saw them going and recognized them.” (BSB, NRSV, REB, GW, NCV, NET, CEV, NIV, NLT). (2) The Textus Receptus adds the words *hoi ochloi* “the crowds/people” as the subject of “saw.” For example, the KJV has: “And the people saw them departing, and many knew him.” (KJV, possibly NASB, which also has “the people”). In Greek this clause literally says “saw them leaving and recognized many.” The word many can be interpreted in two ways:

1. The word many is the subject of both the verbs “saw” and “recognized.” Many people saw them, and all of those many people recognized them. For example, the NCV has:

But many people saw them leave and recognized them. (BSB, NCV, NRSV, GW, NLT, CEV, GNT, NET, REB)

1. The word many is the subject of only the verb “recognized.” The verb “saw” has an implied indefinite subject, such as “people.” People saw them leaving, and many but not all of those people recognized them. For example, the NJB has:

But people saw them going, and many recognised them (NJB, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most English versions.

many people saw them leaving: The word many refers to many people “from all the towns” (6:33b) along the shore of the lake. It also refers to some of the people who had been coming and going to see Jesus in 6:31a. These people saw Jesus and his apostles “leave/depart” or “start out” in the boat to go toward their destination.

recognized: The word that the BSB translates as recognized means here that many people were able to identify the people who were riding in the boat.

Here is another way to translate this:

knew

them: There is a textual issue here: (1) In most Greek manuscripts, the verb recognized has no object. The object has to be supplied from the context. Most English versions have the word “them.” (2) The Textus Receptus adds the word “him” after “recognized,” so the KJV has “recognized him.” (3) A few Greek manuscripts add the word “them” after “recognized.” Most English versions have “recognized them,” but this wording is based on the context, not on the Greek text that they followed. The pronoun them probably refers to Jesus and his disciples. In this context, people were standing on the shore and looking out at the boat that was leaving. The boat contained Jesus and the twelve disciples. It seems probable that the people recognized Jesus and the disciples as a group, rather than recognizing only Jesus.

6:33b

They ran together on foot from all the towns

- so they went from all the towns and ran ahead by land (GNT)
- So they ran along the paths from every nearby town,

They ran together on foot: The BSB phrase ran together on foot is a literal translation of the Greek. It may not be natural to translate the phrase ran

together on foot literally, since a person always uses his feet to run.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

hurried together on foot

ran ahead together on land

ran together

from all the towns: The phrase from all the towns refers to all the towns in that area. Another way to say this is “all the nearby towns.”

6:33c

and arrived before them.

- and arrived at the place ahead of Jesus and his disciples. (GNT)
- and they arrived at the place where the boat was going before Jesus and his followers got there.

Mark 6:34

Section 6:30–44: Jesus did a miracle to feed more than five thousand people

Here Mark resumed the story about Jesus and his twelve apostles. In this section the twelve apostles came back to Jesus and told him about their mission in the Jewish villages. Then Jesus and the apostles went away to find a quiet place to rest. But crowds of people came there to see Jesus. Jesus taught the crowds of people and then did a miracle in order to give them all food to eat.

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Paragraph 6:33–38

Many people saw Jesus and the twelve apostles leaving and followed them. Jesus had compassion on them and taught them. When evening came, the apostles wanted Jesus to send the crowds away, because there was nothing for the people to eat. The apostles did not know any way to feed so many people.

6:34

It is important to understand how the parts of this verse fit together. The main idea of the verse is that Jesus had compassion on the people (6:34b). The reason why he felt compassion is that they were like sheep without a shepherd (6:34c). The result of his compassion is that he taught them (6:34d).

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder some of the parts of this verse. See the General Comment on 6:34b–c after 6:34c for one way to do this.

6:34a

When Jesus stepped ashore and saw a large crowd,

- When Jesus got out of the boat, he saw many people
- So the boat arrived at the shore and Jesus got out. He found a huge crowd there,

When Jesus stepped ashore: The Greek word that the BSB translates as When Jesus stepped ashore is literally “having got out.” This refers to the boat arriving at the shore and Jesus getting out of the boat. You may need to include some implied information to make this clear in your language. Here are some examples:

When Jesus landed (NIV)

Jesus got out of the boat (GNT)

The boat arrived at the shore and Jesus got out

and saw a large crowd: The people who were running there from all the nearby towns had become a large group of over five thousand people (6:44).

6:34b

He had compassion on them,

- and he cared about them,
- and he pitied them,

He had compassion on them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as had compassion means “had understanding and pity” or “felt sympathy.” Jesus understood the people and their troubles.

Here are some ways to express this:

he...felt sorry for them (GW)

he felt sympathy for them

You may have an idiomatic way to translate this term. In English, some examples are:

his heart was filled with pity for them (GNT)

his heart went out to them (REB)

The noun compassion may also be translated by a verb. For example:

he cared

he pitied

See how you translated the phrase “Moved with compassion” in 1:41a.

6:34c

because they were like sheep without a shepherd.

- because they were like sheep without a shepherd/herder to guide and care for them.
- because they were like domestic animals called sheep that had no one to lead/herd them and take care of them.

because: The word because introduces the reason why Jesus felt compassion on the people.

Here is another way to translate this:

The reason is, they were like sheep

Some English versions leave a specific reason word implied. For example, the GW says:

They were like sheep

Introduce this reason in a way that is natural in your language.

they were like sheep without a shepherd: The clause they were like sheep without a shepherd is a figure of speech. It compares the people to sheep without a shepherd. A shepherd is someone who cares for sheep. The people were like sheep without a shepherd because they had no leaders who really cared for them.

Here are some ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Translate the figure of speech without making explicit how the people were like sheep with no shepherd. For example:

they were like sheep that had no herder/leader

- Translate the figure of speech and make explicit how the people were like sheep with no shepherd. For example:

they had no one to properly lead them and care for them, just like sheep without a shepherd/herder

In this context, the word sheep is used to describe the people, so it is possible to translate the meaning without the comparison. For example:

because they had no leader to care for them

However if possible, it is good to keep the comparison with sheep, because sheep are an important figure of speech in many places in the Bible. See the note on “shepherd” later in this part of the verse.

sheep: The word sheep refers to domestic animals that are raised for meat and for wool. In some languages there may not be a word for “sheep.” If that is true in your language, you may borrow the word for “sheep” and indicate its meaning with a general word such as “herd/flock” or “animals.” For example:

animals called sheep

herd/flock of sheep

If people are not familiar with sheep in your area, it is suggested that you insert a picture in your translation.

shepherd: As stated in the preceding notes, a shepherd is a person who takes care of sheep. If there is no word for shepherd in your language, you may be able to use a descriptive phrase. For example:

person who cares for sheep

If your language has a general word for someone who takes care of animals, you may be able to use it here. However, the word should describe a person who stays with the animals and cares for them, as biblical shepherds do. In some places a herder may take the animals to a pasture, then leave them tied there for

the day. If that is true in your area, the word for that herder will not fit this context, and a descriptive phrase will be more accurate.

You may want to add a footnote in your translation to give more information about shepherds. For example:

A shepherd is someone who takes care of sheep. He leads them to water and good pastures and protects them from wild animals. Shepherds were common in Jewish culture. They were frequently used in the Bible to illustrate how God takes care of his people. For example, see Psalm 23.

General Comment on 6:34b–c

In this verse, 6:34c expresses the reason for the result in 6:34b. In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of these clauses. For example:

^{34c}They were like sheep without a shepherd.

^{34b}That is why he had compassion on them.

6:34d

And He began to teach them many things.

- So he/Jesus taught them many things.

And He began to teach them: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as And he began to teach them shows a transition in the story. Jesus and the disciples had come to rest, but instead, Jesus began to teach the people who had run to him. See how you translated the words “began to teach” in 6:2b.

many things: The Greek word that the BSB translates as many things can have at least two meanings. English versions interpret it in two different ways here:

1. It means many things. For example, the GNT says:

So he began to teach them many things. (BSB, NIV, KJV, RSV, GNT, NASB, REB, NLT, CEV, NET, NCV, JBP)

1. It means for a long while. For example, the GW says:

So he spent a lot of time teaching them. (NJB, GW)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), as the majority of English versions do. There is some meaning in common, since it would take time to teach many things.

In some languages it may not be natural to express the object of teach as a “thing.” If that is true in your language, you may be able to say:

he taught them much

Use an expression in your language that fits naturally with a word like “teach.”

Mark 6:35

Section 6:30–44: Jesus did a miracle to feed more than five thousand people

Here Mark resumed the story about Jesus and his twelve apostles. In this section the twelve apostles came back to Jesus and told him about their mission in the Jewish villages. Then Jesus and the apostles went away to find a quiet place to rest. But crowds of people came there to see Jesus. Jesus taught the crowds of people and then did a miracle in order to give them all food to eat.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Feeds the Five Thousand (NIV)

The Feeding of the Five Thousand (NET)

Jesus fed five thousand people in a miraculous way

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:13–21; Luke 9:10–17; John 6:1–14. See also a similar story, where Jesus fed four thousand people, in Matthew 15:32–39 and Mark 8:1–10.

Paragraph 6:33–38

Many people saw Jesus and the twelve apostles leaving and followed them. Jesus had compassion on them and taught them. When evening came, the apostles wanted Jesus to send the crowds away, because there was nothing for the people to eat. The apostles did not know any way to feed so many people.

6:35a

By now the hour was already late.

- By then it was already mid/late afternoon,
- When it was late in the day, (NCV)

By now the hour was already late: The phrase that the BSB translates as By now the hour was already late is literally “a late hour was already coming.” It was probably mid or late afternoon, sometime after 3:00 o’clock but before sunset. According to verse 6:36, there was still time for them to go and buy food.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

When it was getting late (GNT)

Late in the afternoon (NLT)

If your language has an idiom for this time of day, it would be good to use it here.

6:35b

So the disciples came to Jesus

- so/and his disciples came to him.
- his followers approached him.

So: The word So is not in Greek. The BSB has added this word to connect 6:35a and 6:35b. Connect these verse parts in a way that is natural in your language.

the disciples came to Jesus: In this context, the words came to Jesus mean that the disciples approached Jesus to speak to him. The disciples were already with Jesus. They were probably sitting or standing close to Jesus as he taught. They did not come to him from a distance.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

his disciples came near to him

his disciples approached him

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means “learners” who are in a relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

See how you translated this term at 2:15b and 6:1c. See also disciple in the Glossary.

6:35c–36c

For an example of how to translate this text as indirect speech, see the General Comment on 6:35c–36c at the end of 6:36c.

6:35c

and said, “This is a desolate place,

- They said to him, “This place/area is remote/isolated,
- They said, “No one lives around here, (GW)

and said: In Greek, the word that the BSB translates as said occurs before “This is a remote place.” The BSB has placed it before these words. The NIV has placed

said after these words. You should put the word said where it is most natural in your language.

This is a desolate place: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a desolate place indicates a place where few people lived. It was a place that was far from any town or village. The BSB translates this same word as “a solitary place” in 6:32.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

This is a lonely place

No one lives around here (GW)

6:35d and the hour is already late.

- and it is already late in the day.
- and it is already mid/late afternoon.

and the hour is already late: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the hour is already late is almost the same Greek phrase as in 6:35a. You should translate it in a similar way here.

Mark 6:36

Section 6:30–44: Jesus did a miracle to feed more than five thousand people

Here Mark resumed the story about Jesus and his twelve apostles. In this section the twelve apostles came back to Jesus and told him about their mission in the Jewish villages. Then Jesus and the apostles went away to find a quiet place to rest. But crowds of people came there to see Jesus. Jesus taught the crowds of people and then did a miracle in order to give them all food to eat.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Feeds the Five Thousand (NIV)

The Feeding of the Five Thousand (NET)

Jesus fed five thousand people in a miraculous way

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:13–21; Luke 9:10–17; John 6:1–14. See also a

similar story, where Jesus fed four thousand people, in Matthew 15:32–39 and Mark 8:1–10.

Paragraph 6:33–38

Many people saw Jesus and the twelve apostles leaving and followed them. Jesus had compassion on them and taught them. When evening came, the apostles wanted Jesus to send the crowds away, because there was nothing for the people to eat. The apostles did not know any way to feed so many people.

6:36a Dismiss the crowd

- Please, dismiss^(sing) the people
- We suggest that you^(sing) send the crowds away.

Dismiss the crowd: The Greek clause that the BSB translates literally as Dismiss the crowd is in the form of a command. The disciples were suggesting to Jesus what they thought was a reasonable thing to do. They were not speaking harshly to Jesus. They were not forcing Jesus to do something.

If students use the form of a command in your language to make a suggestion to their teacher, you may translate this literally. But if it would be rude in your culture for a student to speak in this way to his teacher, you may need to use a more respectful form. For example:

Please send the crowds away...

We suggest that you send the crowds away...

Dismiss...: The word Dismiss in this context refers to telling the crowd that it was time for them to go home. Be careful not to translate this in a way that sounds like getting rid of people who are not wanted. You could use a verb such as:

send away/release

urge (them) to go

6:36b so they can go to the surrounding countryside and villages

- so that they may/will go to farms and villages around here
- Then the people can go to the nearest farms or villages

so they can go: The Greek word that the BSB translates as so can also be translated as: “in order that.” This word introduces the purpose for 6:36a.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

that they may go (NASB)

to go (RSV)

countryside: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as countryside can also be translated as “farms” (as in the GNT). This refers to places where a small group of people lived and where there was food. This same word occurs in 5:14b.

villages: The Greek word that the BSB translates as villages refers to small towns or villages.

6:36c
and buy themselves something to eat.”

- and buy something to eat.”
- to buy themselves some food.”

and buy themselves something to eat: There is a textual issue here: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have so...they may buy themselves what they may eat. For example, the GNT says: “in order to buy themselves something to eat” (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NJB, ESV, NET, NASB, REB, GW, NLT, CEV, JBP, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have and buy themselves bread, for they have nothing to eat. For example, the KJV says: “and buy themselves bread; for they have nothing to eat” (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1) as most English versions do. The Greek says literally “so they may buy themselves what they may eat.”

Here is another way to translate the phrase something to eat:

some food

General Comment on 6:35c–36c

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate 6:35c–36c as indirect speech. For example:

^{35c}They told him that the area was remote and ^{36d}that the day was almost over. ^{36a}Therefore he should send the people away ^{36b}so that they could go to the surrounding farms and villages ^{36c}and buy themselves something to eat.

Mark 6:37

Section 6:30–44: Jesus did a miracle to feed more than five thousand people

Here Mark resumed the story about Jesus and his twelve apostles. In this section the twelve apostles came back to Jesus and told him about their mission in the Jewish villages. Then Jesus and the apostles went away to find a quiet place to rest. But crowds of people came there to see Jesus. Jesus taught the crowds of people and then did a miracle in order to give them all food to eat.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Feeds the Five Thousand (NIV)

The Feeding of the Five Thousand (NET)

Jesus fed five thousand people in a miraculous way

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:13–21; Luke 9:10–17; John 6:1–14. See also a similar story, where Jesus fed four thousand people, in Matthew 15:32–39 and Mark 8:1–10.

Paragraph 6:33–38

Many people saw Jesus and the twelve apostles leaving and followed them. Jesus had compassion on them and taught them. When evening came, the apostles wanted Jesus to send the crowds away, because there was nothing for the people to eat. The apostles did not know any way to feed so many people.

6:37a

But Jesus told them, “You give them something to eat.”

- But Jesus said to them, “You^(plur) yourselves give them something to eat.”
- Jesus responded, “It is you^(plur) who must give them food.”
- But Jesus told his disciples that it was they themselves who should give the people food.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces what Jesus said. What he said was not what the disciples expected him to say. If you have a connecting word that can be used in this way, use it here. Otherwise you could start 6:37 without a connecting word. For example:

He replied... (NJB)

“You yourselves...” (GNT)

You give them something to eat: The pronoun You is emphatic in the Greek. It is also plural. The BSB has added the word something to make the English natural.

Here are some ways to translate Jesus’ words here:

You yourselves give them something to eat! (GNT)

It is you who must feed them!

6:37b–c

In the Greek, 6:37b–c is a single rhetorical question. See the General Comment on 6:37b–c at the end of 6:37c for ways to reorder the parts of this question.

This rhetorical question expresses both surprise and mild rebuke. The disciples were astonished that Jesus asked them to feed so many people. The request also seemed foolish. They did not know how they could buy enough food to feed so many people.

Here are several ways to translate this expression:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you expect us to go and spend two hundred denarii on bread to feed all these people?

- As a statement. For example:

Surely you do not think we should go and spend two hundred silver coins on food in order to feed all these people!

- As a tag question. For example:

Surely you do not think we should go and spend two hundred silver coins on food in order to feed all these people, do you?

- As one exclamatory statement and one rhetorical question. For example, the NIV says:

That would take eight months of a man’s wages! Are we to go and spend that much on bread and give it to them to eat?

- As a rhetorical question followed by an exclamatory statement. For example, the NLT96 says:

“With what?” they asked. “It would take a small fortune to buy food for all this crowd!”

Use a form that is natural to express surprise and rebuke in your language.

6:37b

They asked Him, “Should we go out and spend two hundred denarii

- They asked him, “Do you want us to take two hundred silver coins and spend it all on bread
- They said, “That much bread would cost as much as two hundred days’ wages! Do you really want us to go and spend that much money on bread
- The disciples said to Jesus, “But that would take an extremely large amount of money! How do you^(sing) expect us to buy enough bread/food

Should we go out and spend two hundred denarii:

The disciples thought that Jesus wanted them to buy food for all the people. They estimated how much money they would need to buy enough food to feed the large crowd. See the next note.

two hundred denarii: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as two hundred denarii refers to two hundred silver Roman coins called “denarii.” Workers in Jesus’ time earned about twenty-five of these coins each month, so it would take about eight months for a worker to earn two hundred of them. Some English versions, such as the BSB, translate this literally as “two hundred denarii.” The BSB translates this Greek phrase as “eight months of a man’s wages” and the NIV11 translates it as “more than half a year’s wages” in order to show how long it took for a worker to earn two hundred denarii.

Most readers today will not know how much money “two hundred denarii” refers to. The main idea is that it was a large sum of money, probably much more than the disciples were able to pay.

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase two hundred denarii:

two hundred silver coins (GNT)

almost a year’s wages (CEV)

We would all have to work a month to earn enough money (NCV)

a small fortune (NLT96)

You should avoid translating this phrase with a term for the particular kind of currency used in your area, for two reasons:

1. It would not be historically accurate.
2. When the value of your currency changes your translation would become outdated.

6:37c

to give all of them bread to eat?"

- so that we can give it to them to eat?
- and come and give it to them to eat?"
- to feed them?"

to give all of them bread to eat: The pronoun them refers to the crowd of people.

The clause to give all of them bread to eat functions as a purpose clause. The purpose for spending two hundred denarii on bread would be to feed the people. So in many languages it may be natural to translate this as:

so that we can give it to them to eat

in order to feed them

bread: Bread was the most common and inexpensive food at that time. In this context, the word bread probably refers to round loaves of flat bread. The Greek word is plural here and in 6:38a. It could be translated as “loaves,” or “loaves of bread” in both places. Some languages may use a plural form of bread like “breads.”

If there is no word that people know for bread, you may translate bread as “food” (as in the NLT). However, in 6:38c the disciples counted units (loaves) of bread. If you use a generic word such as “food” here, you should consider whether it is natural in your language to count units or servings of it.

You should not substitute a different kind of food, because these verses are talking about an event that actually happened. Refer to how you translated bread in 2:26b.

In some areas, people may not be familiar with bread. In other areas, they may consider bread to be a snack rather than a staple food. If this is true in your area, you may want to add a footnote. For example, the TRT has this footnote:

Bread and fish were the main foods for the Jews. These loaves of bread were round, thick and flat in shape. Five of them would be enough to feed about two people one meal.

General Comment on 6:37b–c

It may be more natural in your language to give the cost of the bread at the beginning or end of these verse parts. For example:

They said to him, “That would take eight months of a man’s wages! Are we to go and spend that much on bread and give it to them to eat?” (NIV)

They asked, “Do you want us to feed them by going and buying bread at the cost of two hundred silver coins?”

Mark 6:38

Section 6:30–44: Jesus did a miracle to feed more than five thousand people

Here Mark resumed the story about Jesus and his twelve apostles. In this section the twelve apostles came back to Jesus and told him about their mission in the Jewish villages. Then Jesus and the apostles went away to find a quiet place to rest. But crowds of people came there to see Jesus. Jesus taught the crowds of people and then did a miracle in order to give them all food to eat.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Feeds the Five Thousand (NIV)

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Jesus fed five thousand people in a miraculous way

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:13–21; Luke 9:10–17; John 6:1–14. See also a similar story, where Jesus fed four thousand people, in Matthew 15:32–39 and Mark 8:1–10.

Paragraph 6:33–38

Many people saw Jesus and the twelve apostles leaving and followed them. Jesus had compassion on them and taught them. When evening came, the apostles

wanted Jesus to send the crowds away, because there was nothing for the people to eat. The apostles did not know any way to feed so many people.

6:38a

“Go and see how many loaves you have,” He told them.

- Jesus told them, “Go and find out how many loaves there are.”
- Jesus asked the disciples, “How many loaves of bread do you^(plur) have? Go look!”

Go and see how many loaves you have: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Go and see how many loaves you have is more literally “How many loaves do you have? Go. see.” It is a question and two commands. The question is a real question, not a rhetorical question. Jesus wanted his disciples to find out how much bread they already had.

You may need to introduce this as a separate speech from the question that Jesus asked in 6:37a. For example:

Then Jesus told them, “Go see.”

Go and see: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Go and see is literally “Go see.” Jesus wanted the disciples to go and find out how much bread they had.

see: In this context, the disciples were to see how much bread they had. To make this clear, you may need to translate with a verb such as “look,” “find out,” or “count.”

loaves: This is the same Greek word that the BSB translates as “bread” in 6:37d. You can probably translate it the same way here. It refers to pieces or units of bread, probably cooked in a round shape like buns or rolls.

In Greek, the word is plural both here and in 6:37d. In English, there is not a plural form of “bread” that can be counted, so the BSB uses the word loaves here. If it is natural to say “breads” in your language, you can do that here. Otherwise, you may need to say something like:

units of bread

loaves of bread

He told them: The BSB puts the words He told them after what Jesus said. In Greek, this comes first in

6:38a. Put the verb of speech where it is natural in your language.

6:38b

And after checking, they said,

- When they learned how many they had, they said,
- The disciples went and looked. Then they told Jesus,
- The disciples looked around and counted how many there were.

6:38c

“Five—and two fish.”

- “There are five loaves of bread, and also two fish.”
- “We have five breads. We also have two dried fish.”

Five: The BSB literally translates the one Greek word Five here. In some languages, it will be more natural to say “five loaves of bread.” For example, the GW says:

Five loaves of bread

and two fish: Jesus had not asked them to look for other kinds of food. But when they went to see how many loaves of bread there were, they also found two fish. Since this is new information, you may need to introduce it in a particular way in your language. For example:

We also found two fish.

fish: This was probably a small kind of fresh-water fish from the nearby lake, the Lake of Galilee. If your language has a specific word for fish that is already cooked or dried or salted so that it is ready to eat, you should use it here. Otherwise, you should use a general term for fish.

Mark 6:39

Section 6:30–44: Jesus did a miracle to feed more than five thousand people

Here Mark resumed the story about Jesus and his twelve apostles. In this section the twelve apostles came back to Jesus and told him about their mission in the Jewish villages. Then Jesus and the apostles went away to find a quiet place to rest. But crowds of people came there to see Jesus. Jesus taught the crowds of people and then did a miracle in order to give them all food to eat.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

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Jesus fed five thousand people in a miraculous way

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:13–21; Luke 9:10–17; John 6:1–14. See also a similar story, where Jesus fed four thousand people, in Matthew 15:32–39 and Mark 8:1–10.

Paragraph 6:39–44

Jesus told the disciples to have all the people sit down. Then he did a miracle in order to give food to all of them to eat. There was more food left after they ate than there had been before they ate.

6:39a

Then Jesus directed them

- ¶ Then Jesus commanded the disciples
- ¶ After that Jesus told his followers

Then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Then introduces the next step in a sequence of closely related events. Use a word or expression that does this in your language. For example:

After that

And then

Jesus directed them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as directed means “commanded,” “ordered,” or “urged.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

he gave orders

he told them

them: In the Greek text, the pronoun them is ambiguous. There are two ways to interpret this word:

1. It refers to the disciples. For example, the GNT says:

Jesus then told his disciples to make all the people divide into groups and sit down on the green grass. (BSB, GNT, NIV, NJB, KJV, REB, NCV, NRSV, CEV)

1. It refers to the crowd. For example, the NLT96 says:

Then Jesus told the crowd to sit down in groups on the green grass. (NLT, RSV, NASB, NET, GW, JBP)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Jesus commanded the crowds indirectly, by telling his disciples to tell the crowds to sit down. However, there is strong support in commentaries and English versions for both interpretations. Luke and John told this same story in their Gospels, and in those books the Greek follows interpretation (1). See Luke 9:14 and John 6:10. Matthew also told this story in his Gospel. Matthew 14:19 says that Jesus “directed the crowds to sit down,” which follow interpretation (2). So it appears that Jesus commanded the crowds indirectly, through the disciples.

6:39b

to have the people sit in groups on the green grass.

- to tell all the people to sit down in groups on the soft/fresh grass where they were.
- to organize the people into groups and have them sit on the ground.
- “Tell all the people to sit down on the grass in groups.”

to have the people sit in groups: The command to have all the people sit means “to cause them to sit down.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

to tell them to sit down in groups

to seat them in groups

to organize them into groups and tell them to sit down

on the green grass: The place where everyone was standing was a grassy area. Jesus wanted them to sit down where they were, that is, on the grass where they were standing. He was not telling them to go looking for grass to sit down on.

If grass is uncommon in your area, you may want to use a general term. For example:

on the ground

green grass: The term green grass refers to short grass that is fresh (green). It was not dry, brown grass.

General Comment on 6:39a–b

In some languages it may be natural to translate 6:39b using direct speech. For example:

Then Jesus said to his disciples, “Tell all the people to sit down in groups on the grass.”

Mark 6:40**Section 6:30–44: Jesus did a miracle to feed more than five thousand people**

Here Mark resumed the story about Jesus and his twelve apostles. In this section the twelve apostles came back to Jesus and told him about their mission in the Jewish villages. Then Jesus and the apostles went away to find a quiet place to rest. But crowds of people came there to see Jesus. Jesus taught the crowds of people and then did a miracle in order to give them all food to eat.

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Paragraph 6:39–44

Jesus told the disciples to have all the people sit down. Then he did a miracle in order to give food to all of them to eat. There was more food left after they ate than there had been before they ate.

6:40**So they sat down in groups of hundreds and fifties.**

- So the people sat down, some in groups of one hundred people and some in groups of fifty people.
- So his followers did what Jesus said, and the people formed groups of one hundred and groups of fifty, and they all sat down.

So they sat down: There is implied information here. The disciples first did what Jesus said (that is, told the people to sit down). Then the people sat down.

If you need to include the implied information, you could say:

So the disciples did what Jesus said, and the people sat down

in groups of hundreds and fifties: Some of the groups had one hundred people, and other groups had fifty people. There was probably enough space between the groups for someone to walk through.

Mark 6:41**Section 6:30–44: Jesus did a miracle to feed more than five thousand people**

Here Mark resumed the story about Jesus and his twelve apostles. In this section the twelve apostles came back to Jesus and told him about their mission in the Jewish villages. Then Jesus and the apostles went away to find a quiet place to rest. But crowds of people came there to see Jesus. Jesus taught the crowds of people and then did a miracle in order to give them all food to eat.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Feeds the Five Thousand (NIV)

The Feeding of the Five Thousand (NET)

Jesus fed five thousand people in a miraculous way

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:13–21; Luke 9:10–17; John 6:1–14. See also a similar story, where Jesus fed four thousand people, in Matthew 15:32–39 and Mark 8:1–10.

Paragraph 6:39–44

Jesus told the disciples to have all the people sit down. Then he did a miracle in order to give food to all of them to eat. There was more food left after they ate than there had been before they ate.

6:41a**Taking the five loaves and the two fish**

- Jesus took the five loaves of bread and the two fish.
- Then Jesus took/held in his hands the five loaves of bread and the two dried fish.

Taking the five loaves and the two fish: One of the disciples gave Jesus the loaves and fish, and Jesus took them.

loaves...fish: Use the same word for loaves that you used in 6:38a and the same word for fish that you used in 6:38c.

6:41b

and looking up to heaven,

- He looked up toward the sky/heaven

and looking up to heaven: Jesus looked up toward the sky/heaven because he was about to thank God. Jewish people commonly looked upward toward heaven while they prayed.

heaven: The Greek word that the BSB translates as heaven here refers to the sky as a symbol of God's dwelling place. Since Jesus literally looked upward at the sky, you could translate the word heaven here with the usual word for sky. You do not have to use a special term that refers to the place where God lives.

6:41c

Jesus spoke a blessing and broke the loaves.

- and thanked God and broke/tore the loaves of bread.
- and said "Thank you" to God for the food. Then he tore/divided the loaves of bread into large pieces

Jesus spoke a blessing: There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Jesus spoke a blessing:

1. It refers to thanking God for the food. For example, the NCV says:

he thanked God for the food (NIV, GNT, JBP, NET, NCV)

1. It refers to blessing the food. For example, the CEV says:

blessed the food (BSB, RSV, NLT, NASB, GW, CEV, REB, KJV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). As a custom, Jews praised God and thanked him for the food that he provided for them. If you need to make some of the implicit information clear, you could say:

He gave thanks to God for the food

In some languages the meaning of Jesus giving thanks for the food needs to be expressed with a direct quote. For example:

He said "Thank you."

See bless, Meaning 4, in the Glossary.

and broke the loaves: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as broke the loaves refers to tearing the bread into large pieces. This was the normal way a meal was begun. Use a term in your language that refers to dividing bread. Here is an example:

and tore/divided the loaves

6:41d

Then He gave them to His disciples to set before the people.

- Then he gave it/them to his disciples for them to give/distribute to the people.
- and gave the pieces to his followers. He told them, "Pass these out among the people."

Then He gave them to His disciples: The words Then he gave them to his disciples refer to Jesus giving the pieces of bread to his disciples.

disciples: See the note at 6:1c.

to set before the people: This is a purpose clause. Jesus gave the bread to his disciples so that they would give it to the people.

set before the people: The words set before the people imply that the disciples were to go out among the groups of people to give them the bread. They may have carried the bread in baskets and set the baskets in front of each group of people. Then the people could pass the bread around.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

distribute to the people (GNT)

give to the people (NCV)

6:41e

And He divided the two fish among them all.

- He also divided the two fish among/for all the people.
- In the same way, he divided and distributed the two fish among all the people.

And He divided the two fish among them all: The words divided...among them all imply a similar process to the one in 6:41b–c for breaking and distributing the bread. For example:

He also divided the two fish, so that everyone could have some.

Some languages may need to make it more explicit that Jesus distributed the fish the same way he did the bread. In other words, he asked his disciples to pass the pieces of fish among the groups of people. Here is one example:

In the same way, he divided and distributed the two fish among the people.

Mark 6:42

Section 6:30–44: Jesus did a miracle to feed more than five thousand people

Here Mark resumed the story about Jesus and his twelve apostles. In this section the twelve apostles came back to Jesus and told him about their mission in the Jewish villages. Then Jesus and the apostles went away to find a quiet place to rest. But crowds of people came there to see Jesus. Jesus taught the crowds of people and then did a miracle in order to give them all food to eat.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Feeds the Five Thousand (NIV)

The Feeding of the Five Thousand (NET)

Jesus fed five thousand people in a miraculous way

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:13–21; Luke 9:10–17; John 6:1–14. See also a similar story, where Jesus fed four thousand people, in Matthew 15:32–39 and Mark 8:1–10.

Paragraph 6:39–44

Jesus told the disciples to have all the people sit down. Then he did a miracle in order to give food to all of them to eat. There was more food left after they ate than there had been before they ate.

6:42

They all ate and were satisfied,

- They all ate as much as they wanted. (NJB)
- Everyone ate all the bread and fish that they wanted.
- Everyone ate until they were full.

They all ate and were satisfied: In 6:41 Jesus gave thanks for the food, and then he had his disciples distribute it to all the people. In 6:42 They all ate and were satisfied. Mark did not explain when or how the five loaves of bread and two fish became enough to feed so many people until they were satisfied. If it is not clear to people in your area that Jesus caused the food to multiply, you could include some implied information. For example:

Jesus multiplied the food so that everyone ate and was satisfied

Jesus did a miracle so that everyone had enough to eat

all ate and were satisfied: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as all ate and were satisfied means that the whole crowd of people had all the food that they wanted to eat.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Everyone ate and had enough. (GNT)

They all ate as much as they wanted. (NJB)

ate: The people ate both the bread (6:41b) and the fish (6:41d). Be careful not to translate 6:42 in a way that makes it seem that they only ate fish.

Mark 6:43

Section 6:30–44: Jesus did a miracle to feed more than five thousand people

Here Mark resumed the story about Jesus and his twelve apostles. In this section the twelve apostles came back to Jesus and told him about their mission in the Jewish villages. Then Jesus and the apostles went away to find a quiet place to rest. But crowds of people came there to see Jesus. Jesus taught the crowds of people and then did a miracle in order to give them all food to eat.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Feeds the Five Thousand (NIV)

The Feeding of the Five Thousand (NET)

Jesus fed five thousand people in a miraculous way

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:13–21; Luke 9:10–17; John 6:1–14. See also a similar story, where Jesus fed four thousand people, in Matthew 15:32–39 and Mark 8:1–10.

Paragraph 6:39–44

Jesus told the disciples to have all the people sit down. Then he did a miracle in order to give food to all of them to eat. There was more food left after they ate than there had been before they ate.

6:43

and the disciples picked up twelve basketfuls of broken pieces of bread and fish.

- Afterward/Then, they picked up the food that remained and filled twelve baskets with the pieces of bread and fish.
- After everyone had finished eating the disciples gathered the broken pieces of bread and fish that remained. These pieces filled twelve baskets.

It may be natural in some languages to begin a new sentence here. It may also be natural to include a time word. For example:

Then (GNT)

After that

After they were finished eating

the disciples picked up: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as the disciples picked up is literally “they picked up.” There are several ways to interpret the word “they”:

1. It refers to the disciples. For example, the CEV says:

Jesus’ disciples picked up (BSB, NIV, GNT, CEV, NCV)

1. It refers to the crowd. Looking back to the previous clause (6:24), “they picked up” would grammatically refer to the crowd.
2. It refers to the disciples and the crowd.

Many English versions translate this literally as “they.” It is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow. You may also translate this in a similar way, unless your readers will understand that only the crowd picked up the food. If your readers will under-

stand that the disciples did not participate, then you should follow interpretation (1) and explicitly say “the disciples.”

picked up: The Greek word that the BSB translates as picked up means to lift up and carry away. In this context it probably indicates that the disciples gathered or collected pieces of uneaten food from the crowd. They probably did not pick up crumbs from the ground.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

They collected (NJB)

They filled

twelve basketfuls: The amount of food that the disciples collected was enough to fill twelve baskets. We do not know what kind of baskets they used. They might have been small, wicker baskets normally used by travelers or larger baskets used to carry produce to and from the marketplace. BAGD (page 563) and Louw & Nida (page 71) define *kophinos* as a large basket for carrying food and produce. This view is followed by France (page 268), Swete (page 135) and Taylor (page 325). But Lenski (page 269), Hiebert (page 162) and Lane (page 231) take this basket to refer to a small wicker basket normally used by Jewish laborers and travelers to carry their food and other essentials during the day. It seems unlikely that the crowd would have run from the various towns along the lake carrying large produce baskets. If these were large baskets, they may have been in the boat used by Jesus and his disciples. If possible, use a general word for “basket.”

If you need to use a specific word, use a word that refers to a somewhat smaller or medium-sized basket suitable for carrying food.

of broken pieces of bread and fish: The Greek word that the BSB translates as broken pieces of bread is literally “fragments/pieces.” The BSB has added the information that these were fragments of bread. The fish are mentioned separately in the Greek. They were also broken fragments. The broken pieces probably refer to pieces of bread and fish that the people did not eat when the food was distributed. They were not crumbs or pieces of food that fell from the people’s mouths as they were eating.

The CEV has another way to translate this phrase:

leftover bread and fish

Mark 6:44

Section 6:30–44: Jesus did a miracle to feed more than five thousand people

Here Mark resumed the story about Jesus and his twelve apostles. In this section the twelve apostles came back to Jesus and told him about their mission in the Jewish villages. Then Jesus and the apostles went away to find a quiet place to rest. But crowds of people came there to see Jesus. Jesus taught the crowds of people and then did a miracle in order to give them all food to eat.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Feeds the Five Thousand (NIV)

The Feeding of the Five Thousand (NET)

Jesus fed five thousand people in a miraculous way

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:13–21; Luke 9:10–17; John 6:1–14. See also a similar story, where Jesus fed four thousand people, in Matthew 15:32–39 and Mark 8:1–10.

Paragraph 6:39–44

Jesus told the disciples to have all the people sit down. Then he did a miracle in order to give food to all of them to eat. There was more food left after they ate than there had been before they ate.

6:44

And there were five thousand men who had eaten the loaves.

- There were five thousand men who had eaten the food.
- Five thousand men had eaten the loaves of bread and fish!

And there were five thousand men: Matthew 14:21 says that besides the five thousand men who ate the food, there were women and children there who also ate. But Mark did not mention the women and children. When you translate 6:44, you should use a term that refers to men, as most English versions do.

men: The Greek word that the BSB translates as men refers to adult males who were married or were old enough to get married. It does not refer to younger male children.

In some languages the word for “men” may refer only to married men, while another word like “males” may refer to males of all ages, whether adults or children. If that is true in your language, you may need to use one or more terms that describe adult males (married or unmarried, but not children). For example:

unmarried-men and older-men

Mark 6:45

Section 6:45–52: Jesus walked on the water of the lake

This section tells about another miracle that showed Jesus’ power. After he fed the five thousand men, Jesus urged his disciples to get into their boat and go to the other side of the lake. Then during the night he came to them while they were still in the boat on the lake. He walked to them on the surface of the water and climbed into the boat with them.

There are several ways to divide this section into paragraphs:

1. Two paragraphs (as in the GNT)

6:45–50a

6:50b–52

1. Three paragraphs (as in the BSB, NIV, RSV, CEV, NLT)

6:45–46

6:47–50a

6:50b–52

1. One paragraph (as in the NJB, NET, ESV)

6:45–52

You should divide this section into paragraphs in a way that is natural in your language. The Notes and Display follow option (a).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

Jesus walks on the water

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:22–23 and John 6:15–21.

6:45a

Immediately Jesus made His disciples get into the boat

- ¶ Immediately after that, Jesus urged/told his disciples to get into the boat
- ¶ At once, Jesus insisted that his followers get into the boat.

Immediately: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Immediately connects this story with the previous story about feeding five thousand men. Mark used this word to show that this new story follows right after the previous one. These events began immediately after the previous events.

In your translation, introduce this new story in a way that makes it clear that this is what happened next. Also make it clear that another story is beginning.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Immediately after this (NLT)

As soon as they had finished (REB)

Jesus made His disciples get into the boat:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as made here means “compelled,” “commanded” or “strongly urged.” This word implies that the disciples were hesitant to go. But it does not imply that Jesus had to use force to get them to leave. Gould pages 120–121: “This language expresses haste and urgency, for which, however, Mt. and Mk. give no reason. But the fourth Gospel states a fact, which would certainly account for this urgency, telling us that the people were about to come and seize him to make him a king (J. 6:15). According to this, Jesus knew that his disciples would side with the multitude in this design, and therefore dismisses them with this abruptness and imperative-ness.”

The NLT has another way to translate this clause:

Jesus insisted that his disciples get back into the boat

disciples: This is the same word as in 6:41d. See the note at 6:1c.

boat: The boat mentioned here is probably the same boat that Jesus and the disciples had ridden in to

come to this place. See the note at 6:32 for a more complete description of this type of boat.

6:45b

and go on ahead of Him to Bethsaida,

- and go on ahead of him to the other side of the lake, to Bethsaida,
- He told them to go on ahead of him to the town of Bethsaida on the other side of the lake.

go on ahead of Him to Bethsaida: There is a textual issue in this verse:

1. Almost all Greek manuscripts have “go on ahead to the other side to Bethsaida.” For example the NRSV says:

go on ahead to the other side, to Bethsaida (GNT, RSV, NJB, ESV, JBP, NCV, NLT, NET, NASB, KJV)

1. A few Greek manuscripts have only “go on ahead to Bethsaida.” They do not have the phrase “to the other side.” For example, the NIV says:

go on ahead of him to Bethsaida (BSB, NIV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), since it has the support of the majority of manuscripts. Also, nearly every English version follows this option. The phrase “on the other side” was most likely omitted in some manuscripts because of the geographical difficulties presented with this reading. Bethsaida was under the rule of Philip the tetrarch, and therefore was east of the Jordan River. (Metzger page 79, Blight and Smith page 143)

Bethsaida: The word Bethsaida is the name of a town northeast of the Lake of Galilee.

6:45c

while He dismissed the crowd.

- while he sent the crowd away.
- Then he told the crowd to go home.
- He stayed there and said to the crowd, “You may/ should go home now.”

while He dismissed the crowd: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as He dismissed the crowd indicates that Jesus sent the crowd of people away. These are the people whom he fed in 6:30–44.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

while he sent the crowd away (GNT)

while he gave all the people permission to leave

It is implied that Jesus did not get into the boat with the disciples. He stayed behind on the land to dismiss the crowd. In some languages it may be natural to follow the NCV and make this explicit:

He stayed there to send the people home.

In some languages it may be natural to translate what Jesus said as direct speech. For example:

...while he stayed behind and said to the crowd,
“You may/should go home now.”

Mark 6:46

Section 6:45–52: Jesus walked on the water of the lake

This section tells about another miracle that showed Jesus’ power. After he fed the five thousand men, Jesus urged his disciples to get into their boat and go to the other side of the lake. Then during the night he came to them while they were still in the boat on the lake. He walked to them on the surface of the water and climbed into the boat with them.

There are several ways to divide this section into paragraphs:

1. Two paragraphs (as in the GNT)

6:45–50a

6:50b–52

1. Three paragraphs (as in the BSB, NIV, RSV, CEV, NLT)

6:45–46

6:47–50a

6:50b–52

1. One paragraph (as in the NJB, NET, ESV)

6:45–52

You should divide this section into paragraphs in a way that is natural in your language. The Notes and Display follow option (a).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

Jesus walks on the water

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:22–23 and John 6:15–21.

6:46a

After bidding them farewell,

- After leaving them,
- After Jesus said good-bye to the crowd,

After bidding them farewell: The Greek word that the BSB translates as After bidding...farewell also means “having left.” For example:

After leaving them (NIV)

And after he had taken leave of them (ESV)

them: The pronoun them refers to the crowd. Jesus left the crowd.

6:46b

He went up on the mountain to pray.

- he went up on the mountain to pray.
- he climbed up into the mountainous area around the lake to pray.

He: The pronoun He refers to Jesus.

went up on the mountain: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as on the mountainside is literally “to the mountain” (as in the NET). This indicates that Jesus went somewhere higher on the mountain. It does not indicate how far up he was. For this reason, some versions translate this as “on a mountainside.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

went up a mountain (GW)

went up into the hills (NLT)

mountain: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mountain means “high country” or “mountain.” Some versions translate this word as “mountain” while others translate it as “hill.”

This mountain was on the edge of the Sea of Galilee. The Sea of Galilee is surrounded by a steep bank and

low mountains on many sides. These mountains are not as high as other mountains in the area.

to pray: The phrase to pray indicates the purpose and reason that Jesus went up the mountainside. He probably went there because there were no other people on the mountain. He could pray to God for some hours, and no one would come to disturb him.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as pray means “speak to God.” Some languages may use different words to refer to specific kinds of prayer, such as requests, thanks, or praise. Here you should use a word or expression that has a general meaning. Avoid a term that may imply magical or meaningless words.

Mark 6:47

Section 6:45–52: Jesus walked on the water of the lake

This section tells about another miracle that showed Jesus’ power. After he fed the five thousand men, Jesus urged his disciples to get into their boat and go to the other side of the lake. Then during the night he came to them while they were still in the boat on the lake. He walked to them on the surface of the water and climbed into the boat with them.

There are several ways to divide this section into paragraphs:

1. Two paragraphs (as in the GNT)

6:45–50a

6:50b–52

1. Three paragraphs (as in the BSB, NIV, RSV, CEV, NLT)

6:45–46

6:47–50a

6:50b–52

1. One paragraph (as in the NJB, NET, ESV)

6:45–52

You should divide this section into paragraphs in a way that is natural in your language. The Notes and Display follow option (a).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

Jesus walks on the water

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:22–23 and John 6:15–21.

6:47a

When evening came, the boat was in the middle of the sea,

- When it was already dark/night, the boat was somewhere in the middle of the lake,
- When the sun went down, the boat in which the disciples were crossing the sea was far from land.

When evening came: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as When evening came indicates that it was probably between 6:00 p.m. and 9:00 p.m. The sun had probably already gone down.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Later that evening (CEV)

That night (NCV)

The word evening also occurs in 1:32a.

the boat was in the middle of the sea: The Greek word that the BSB translates as middle indicates that the boat was far away from the shore.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the boat was far out on the sea (NJB)

the boat was somewhere in the middle of the lake (CEV)

In some languages, it will be more natural to indicate that the disciples were in the boat. For example, the NLT says:

the disciples were in their boat in the middle of the lake

6:47b

and Jesus was alone on land.

- and/but Jesus was alone on the land.
- But as for Jesus, he was still by himself on the mountain.

and Jesus was alone on land: There is a contrast between Jesus being on land and the disciples being in the boat. Some English versions indicate this contrast with the word “while.” For example, the GNT says:

while Jesus was alone on land

In some languages, there may be a special way to indicate this kind of contrast. For example:

and/but as for Jesus, he was alone on the land

on land: Jesus was on land, but not on the shore. He was still up on the mountain (6:46b). In some languages, a literal translation of on land may imply that Jesus was at the shore of the lake and was no longer on the mountainside. If that is true in your language, you may want to indicate Jesus’ location more specifically. For example:

and as for Jesus, he was still on the mountain, alone

General Comment on 6:47a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of 6:47a and 6:47b. In this way, the parts of 6:46 and 6:47 that are about Jesus can be together. For example, the CEV says:

^{46b}...and [Jesus] went up on the side of a mountain to pray. ^{47a}Later that evening ^{47b}he was still there by himself, and ^{47a}the boat was somewhere in the middle of the lake.

Mark 6:48

Section 6:45–52: Jesus walked on the water of the lake

This section tells about another miracle that showed Jesus’ power. After he fed the five thousand men, Jesus urged his disciples to get into their boat and go to the other side of the lake. Then during the night he came to them while they were still in the boat on the lake. He walked to them on the surface of the water and climbed into the boat with them.

There are several ways to divide this section into paragraphs:

1. Two paragraphs (as in the GNT)

6:45–50a

6:50b–52

1. Three paragraphs (as in the BSB, NIV, RSV, CEV, NLT)

6:45–46

6:47–50a

6:50b–52

1. One paragraph (as in the NJB, NET, ESV)

6:45–52

You should divide this section into paragraphs in a way that is natural in your language. The Notes and Display follow option (a).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

Jesus walks on the water

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:22–23 and John 6:15–21.

6:48a

He could see that the disciples were straining to row,

- He saw the disciples working hard to row the boat,
- He looked down and saw that his followers were struggling to move the boat forward,

He could see that the disciples: According to 6:46b, Jesus went up on the mountain to pray. Here the context implies that Jesus paused in his praying and looked out toward the lake to see how the disciples were doing. Even though it was night, there was probably enough moonlight for Jesus to see the disciples on the lake. Only a few commentators think that this was a “supernatural seeing from afar.” (Clarke quoted in *Mark: A Portrait of the Servant* by Hiebert, page 165.) In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit some of this information.

In some languages there are also specific words for “look downward” and “look from a distance.” If your language uses specific words like these, it may be appropriate to use one of them here. For example:

When Jesus looked down at the disciples, he saw that they were straining...

straining to row: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as straining to row is more literally “distressed while rowing.” It indicates that the disciples were working/straining very hard to try to move the boat forward.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

having trouble rowing the boat

struggling hard to row the boat (NCV)

6:48b

because the wind was against them.

- because the wind was blowing against/at them.
- because there was a strong wind blowing the wrong way.

the wind was against them: The phrase the wind was against them indicates that the wind was blowing against the front of the boat. The wind was so strong that the disciples were not able to move the boat across the lake.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the wind was blowing towards them

the wind was meeting them

they were going against the wind (GW)

General Comment on 6:48a–b

In some languages it may be natural to put the information that the disciples were rowing in 6:48b. For example, the CEV says:

^{48a}He could see that the disciples were struggling hard, ^{48b}because they were rowing against the wind.

General Comment on 6:48a–b

In this verse, 6:48b expresses the reason for the result in 6:48a. In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of these clauses. For example:

^{48b}The wind was blowing against them; ^{48a}that is why they were straining at the oars. Jesus saw all this.

6:48c

About the fourth watch of the night,

- As the night was ending
- Before dawn/daybreak

About the fourth watch of the night: The fourth watch of the night was the period between 3:00 and 6:00 in the morning. At that time, people considered night to be from 6:00 p.m. to 6:00 a.m. The Romans divided the night into four periods of time. Each period was three hours long. Soldiers took turns guarding (watching) for one period. So the fourth watch was the three-hour period before dawn.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Not long before morning (CEV)

between three and six o'clock in the morning (GNT)

As the night was ending (NET)

Before dawn/daybreak

If your language has a specific expression or idiom for this time of day, consider using it here.

6:48d

Jesus went out to them, walking on the sea.

- he went toward them, walking on the lake/water.
- he went down the mountain and walked on the surface of the water to approach them.

Jesus went out to them: Jesus had been up on the mountain. Before he could walk out to the disciples, he first had to walk downhill to the shore. In some languages it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

he walked/went down the mountain and went out to them

walking on the sea: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as walking on the sea indicates that Jesus was walking on top of the water. This was a miracle.

In some languages, verbs such as walking are also used to mean “swimming,” and prepositions such as on can also mean “in.” If this is true in your language, you will need to clarify what Jesus was doing. For example:

walking on the surface of the water

6:48e**He intended to pass by them,**

- He was going to pass by them; (REB)
- He looked as though he intended/wanted to continue walking past them.

He intended to pass by them: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as He intended to pass by them is literally “He wanted to go past them.” Jesus was walking as though he intended to walk past the boat without stopping. A note on 6:48 in the NET says, “The statement ‘he wanted to pass by them’ is somewhat difficult to understand. There are at least two common interpretations: (1) it refers to the perspective of the disciples, that is, from their point of view it seemed that Jesus wanted to pass by them; or (2) it refers to a theophany and uses the language of the Greek Old Testament (LXX) when God “passed by” Moses at Sinai (cf. Exod 33.19, 22). According to the latter alternative, Jesus is “passing by” the disciples during their struggle, in order to assure them of his presence with them. See W. L. Lane, *Mark* (NICNT), 236.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

He intended to pass by them (NASB)

He was going to pass by them (REB)

He would have passed by them

Mark 6:49**Section 6:45–52: Jesus walked on the water of the lake**

This section tells about another miracle that showed Jesus’ power. After he fed the five thousand men, Jesus urged his disciples to get into their boat and go to the other side of the lake. Then during the night he came to them while they were still in the boat on the lake. He walked to them on the surface of the water and climbed into the boat with them.

There are several ways to divide this section into paragraphs:

1. Two paragraphs (as in the GNT)

6:45–50a

6:50b–52

1. Three paragraphs (as in the BSB, NIV, RSV, CEV, NLT)

6:45–46

6:47–50a

6:50b–52

1. One paragraph (as in the NJB, NET, ESV)

6:45–52

You should divide this section into paragraphs in a way that is natural in your language. The Notes and Display follow option (a).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

Jesus walks on the water

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:22–23 and John 6:15–21.

6:49a**but when they saw Him walking on the sea,**

- but when they saw him walking on top of the lake,
- But when they saw him walking on the surface of the lake/water,

6:49b**they cried out,**

- They shouted/called out in fear
- They screamed

6:49a–b

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here indicates a contrast. The contrast is between what Jesus intended to do (6:48d) and what actually happened.

they cried out: The clause they cried out is a result of 6:49c (“thinking he was a ghost”). It is also a result of 6:50a (“they all saw Him and were terrified”). See the General Comments at the end of the note on 6:50a for other ways to express these relationships.

cried out: The Greek word that the BSB translates as cried out is the sound someone makes when afraid. Another way to translate this word is “scream.” For example:

and they started screaming (CEV)

they screamed in terror (NLT96)

6:49c**thinking He was a ghost—**

- they thought that he was a ghost.
- they thought that he was a ghost/spirit, because they did not recognize him.
- they thought, “It is a ghost!”

thinking He was a ghost: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a ghost refers to a phantom. The word is often used when people see a vision or form of a dead person, but his body is not actually there. This Greek word is different from the Greek word that means “spirit.” The disciples probably thought that the spirit of a dead person was appearing to them in a form that they could see. Use the natural term in your language to describe this.

In some languages, it may be more natural to put what the disciples thought into direct speech. For example, the GNT says:

“It’s a ghost!” they thought...

Mark 6:50**Section 6:45–52: Jesus walked on the water of the lake**

This section tells about another miracle that showed Jesus’ power. After he fed the five thousand men, Jesus urged his disciples to get into their boat and go to the other side of the lake. Then during the night he came to them while they were still in the boat on the lake. He walked to them on the surface of the water and climbed into the boat with them.

There are several ways to divide this section into paragraphs:

1. Two paragraphs (as in the GNT)

6:45–50a

6:50b–52

1. Three paragraphs (as in the BSB, NIV, RSV, CEV, NLT)

6:45–46

6:47–50a

6:50b–52

1. One paragraph (as in the NJB, NET, ESV)

6:45–52

You should divide this section into paragraphs in a way that is natural in your language. The Notes and Display follow option (a).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

Jesus walks on the water

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:22–23 and John 6:15–21.

6:50a**for they all saw Him and were terrified.**

- because they were all terrified when they saw him.
- in terror because of what they saw.

for: The Greek word that the BSB translates as for introduces the reason that the disciples were terrified.

they all saw Him and were terrified: The disciples were terrified when they saw Him, that is, Jesus. However, since they did not know that what they saw was Jesus, it may be natural to translate this as:

they were all terrified at what they saw

they were all terrified at the sight

General Comment on 6:49c–50a

In these verses, 6:50a expresses the reason for the result in 6:49c. In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of these clauses. For example:

^{50a}They all saw him and were terrified, ^{49c}so they cried out.

^{50a}They all saw him and were terrified, ^{49c}that is why they screamed.

General Comment on 6:49a–50a

Verse 6:49b (they thought he was a ghost) and 6:50a (they saw Jesus and were terrified) both give the reason why the disciples cried out. In some languages it may be natural to put these two verse parts together. For example:

^{49a}But when they saw him walking on the lake,
^{49c}they starting screaming/yelling ^{49b}because they
 thought he was a ghost ^{50a}and were terrified at
 the sight.

^{49a}But when they saw him walking on the lake,
^{49b}they thought he was a ghost ^{50a}and were terri-
 fied at the sight. ^{49c}So they started screaming/
 yelling....

^{49a}But when they saw him walking on the
 lake, ^{50a}they were all terrified ^{49c}and screamed,
^{49b}because they thought he was a ghost.

6:50b

But Jesus spoke up at once:

- ¶ He said to them at once,
- ¶ But Jesus immediately said to them,

But Jesus spoke up at once: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But indicates contrast. Here the contrast is between the fact that the disciples were afraid and the fact that Jesus spoke to them to reassure them. Some English versions, such as the NIV, do not translate this word. You should show this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

Jesus spoke up at once: The expression Jesus spoke up at once was a natural way in Greek to introduce what someone said.

Use an expression for introducing what someone says that is natural in your language. For example:

But Jesus said to them at once

Jesus immediately spoke. He said to them...

6:50c

“Take courage! It is I. Do not be afraid.”

- “Be courageous! It is I. Do not fear.”
- “Be brave! I am Jesus, not a ghost. Stop feeling afraid.”

Take courage: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Take courage means “be courageous,” or “be firm / resolute in the face of danger.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Have courage! (NCV)

Don’t worry! (CEV)

Calm down! (GW)

It is recommended that you translate this word using the expression in your language for encouraging people who are facing danger.

It is I: In some languages it might not make sense for a speaker to make the obvious comment It is I. It may be more natural for the speaker to refer to himself by name. For example:

I am Jesus.

Mark 6:51

Section 6:45–52: Jesus walked on the water of the lake

This section tells about another miracle that showed Jesus’ power. After he fed the five thousand men, Jesus urged his disciples to get into their boat and go to the other side of the lake. Then during the night he came to them while they were still in the boat on the lake. He walked to them on the surface of the water and climbed into the boat with them.

There are several ways to divide this section into paragraphs:

1. Two paragraphs (as in the GNT)

6:45–50a

6:50b–52

1. Three paragraphs (as in the BSB, NIV, RSV, CEV, NLT)

6:45–46

6:47–50a

6:50b–52

1. One paragraph (as in the NJB, NET, ESV)

6:45–52

You should divide this section into paragraphs in a way that is natural in your language. The Notes and Display follow option (a).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

Jesus walks on the water

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:22–23 and John 6:15–21.

6:51a

Then He climbed into the boat with them,

- Then he got into the boat with them,
- Then he stepped into the boat with them,

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then (and the RSV as “And”) here introduces what happened next in the story.

climbed into the boat: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as climbed into the boat means that Jesus “got into the boat.” For example, the NCV says:

Then he got into the boat with them

Use an expression in your language that is usually used for stepping into a boat.

6:51b

and the wind died down.

- and the wind became calm.
- and the wind stopped blowing.

the wind died down: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as a figure of speech the wind died down is literally “the wind stopped.” This means that the wind stopped blowing. The NCV has another way to translate this:

the wind became calm

Use an expression that is natural in your language.

6:51c

And the disciples were utterly astounded,

- They were very amazed about everything they had experienced,
- They were completely surprised/confused and amazed at what happened,

utterly astounded: The Greek phraseThere are some textual issues in 6:51. Most Greek manuscripts include an adjectival phrase between the words “very amazed” that means “exceedingly” or “utterly.” This phrase reinforces the degree of the disciples’ amazement. Most English versions follow these manuscripts. Other manuscripts include a phrase in addition after the word “amazed” that means “and wondered.” Thus the “phrase “amazed and wondered” are a doublet that serves to again reinforce the disciples’ amazement. For example, the KJV says “they were sore amazed

in themselves beyond measure, and wondered.”The renderings of all these manuscripts have basically the same meaning. that the BSB translates as utterly astounded means “extremely surprised” or “completely amazed.” This is a very emphatic phrase. It also includes the idea that the disciples were “very confused.” They were not able to think clearly.

It is recommended that you emphasize that the disciples were very amazed with an appropriate expression in your language. For example:

greatly amazed (NCV)

utterly astounded (REB)

Mark 6:52

Section 6:45–52: Jesus walked on the water of the lake

This section tells about another miracle that showed Jesus’ power. After he fed the five thousand men, Jesus urged his disciples to get into their boat and go to the other side of the lake. Then during the night he came to them while they were still in the boat on the lake. He walked to them on the surface of the water and climbed into the boat with them.

There are several ways to divide this section into paragraphs:

1. Two paragraphs (as in the GNT)

6:45–50a

6:50b–52

1. Three paragraphs (as in the BSB, NIV, RSV, CEV, NLT)

6:45–46

6:47–50a

6:50b–52

1. One paragraph (as in the NJB, NET, ESV)

6:45–52

You should divide this section into paragraphs in a way that is natural in your language. The Notes and Display follow option (a).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

Jesus walks on the water

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 14:22–23 and John 6:15–21.

6:52a

for they had not understood about the loaves,

- because they had also not understood the miracle about the loaves.
- because they had not understood what the miracle of the loaves showed about Jesus.

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *for* here introduces an explanation. Mark explained why the disciples were completely amazed that Jesus could walk on water.

Some English versions do not translate this word.

Translate *for* using a word that shows that you are explaining why the disciples were amazed and surprised.

they had not understood about the loaves: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as *they had not understood about the loaves* indicates that the disciples did not understand who Jesus was. They did not understand that the miracle of the bread showed that Jesus had divine power. In some languages it may be necessary to make some of this implied information explicit. For example:

they had not understood the real meaning of the feeding of the five thousand (GNT)

They still didn't understand the significance of the miracle of the multiplied loaves (NLT96)

Although they had seen Jesus multiply the loaves of bread, they still did not understand what that meant about his power

6:52b

but their hearts had been hardened.

- Their minds were closed.
- They should have understood, but they were too stubborn.

but: There is a textual issue in this verse:

1. Some Greek manuscripts begin this clause with a conjunction that means “but rather” or “in-

stead.” This is the reading that the UBS4 follows (page 144). For example:

but their hearts were hardened (RSV)

Instead, their minds were closed. (GW) (RSV, NASB, ESV, NET, GW)

1. Other Greek manuscripts begin this clause with a conjunction that means “for” or “because.” For example, the NCV has:

because their minds were closed (BSB, NCV, KJV)

When you translate 6:52b, you may either:

- Leave the conjunction implied, as do the NIV, REB, NJB, GNT, NLT, and JBP.
- Follow option (1) above. In order to translate option (1), you may have to repeat some information or make some information explicit. For example:

Instead of understanding, their hearts were hardened

They should have understood, but their hearts were hardened

their hearts had been hardened: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as *their hearts had been hardened* is an idiom. This idiom refers to people who are too stubborn to understand spiritual truth. It does not refer to a lack of intelligence. In this context the disciples had seen Jesus do many miracles, but they still did not understand what his miracles showed about him. The idiom implies that the disciples should have understood that.

You can translate this idiom in two ways:

General Comment on 6:52a–b

- Use a figure of speech from your language that refers to people being too stubborn to understand something. For example, here are some other English idioms:

Their minds were closed (CEV)

They had not opened their hearts.

- Translate the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

They were too stubborn to understand.

In some languages, it will be more natural to change the order of these phrases. For example, the CEV has:

^{52b}Their minds were closed, ^{52a}and they could not understand the true meaning of the loaves of bread.

Mark 6:53

Section 6:53–56: Jesus healed sick people in the region of Gennesaret

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples all landed in the region of Gennesaret. People recognized Jesus and brought sick people to him from many places in that area and he healed them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus heals the sick at Gennesaret

Healing at Gennesaret

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 14:34–36.

6:53a

When they had crossed over,

- ¶ When they had crossed over the lake,
- ¶ After Jesus and the disciples had gone to the other side of the lake,

When they had crossed over: The clause When they had crossed over connects this story to the previous one. These new events took place after Jesus and his disciples had traveled by boat to the other side of the lake. You may need to make some of this explicit in your translation. For example:

Jesus and his disciples finished crossing the lake. Then....

6:53b

they landed at Gennesaret and moored the boat.

- they came to land at the region of Gennesaret and let down the anchor there.
- they arrived at the region of Gennesaret and tied the boat there.

they landed: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as they landed is literally “they came to land” (as in

the GNT). This indicates that Jesus and his disciples ended their journey on the water and arrived at the edge of the lake. The NCV translates this as:

they came to shore

at Gennesaret: The word Gennesaret was the name of an area on the northwest shore of Lake Galilee south of the town of Capernaum. It is also the name of a village in that area. It is not possible to tell whether the village or the area is meant here.

If it is acceptable in your language, do not specify whether it is a region or a town. If you must make it clear which one it is, it is recommended that you say “area” or “region.” This is more accurate, because the activity in 6:53–56 happens throughout that area.

moored the boat: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as moored refers to bringing the boat into harbor and preventing it from moving. The disciples did this near the shore or on shore so that they could get out on land. There are several ways to translate this:

- Translate it as anchored. The word anchored refers to the action of lowering the anchor (a heavy weight) to the bottom of the lake. A rope connected the anchor to the boat. This was done in order to keep the boat from drifting on the water. For example, the NLT96 says:

they anchored the boat

- Translate it as moored or tied. The word moor refers to tying a boat to a dock or pole put in the ground close to shore. People do this in order to keep the boat from drifting on the water. For example:

they...moored to the shore (RSV)

they tied up the boat (GNT)

- Translate it in a general way that leaves the specific method of fastening the boat implied. For example, the CEV says:

they brought the boat to shore

Mark 6:54

Section 6:53–56: Jesus healed sick people in the region of Gennesaret

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples all landed in the region of Gennesaret. People recognized Jesus and

brought sick people to him from many places in that area and he healed them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus heals the sick at Gennesaret

Healing at Gennesaret

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 14:34–36.

6:54a

As soon as they got out of the boat,

- As they got out of the boat, immediately
- When they got out of the boat,

6:54b

the people recognized Jesus

- people recognized Jesus.
- the people there saw Jesus and immediately knew who he was.

6:54a–b

As soon as they got out of the boat, the people recognized Jesus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *As soon as* can also be translated as “immediately” (as in the NET) or “at once” (as in the GNT).

Some English versions put this word at the beginning of the sentence (such as the NIV and BSB). Other versions put this word in the second part of the sentence, following the order of the Greek text. For example, the NCV says:

When they got out of the boat, people immediately recognized Jesus.

You should translate this in a way that is natural in your language.

the people recognized Jesus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *recognized* means that when the people saw Jesus, they knew who he was.

Mark 6:55

Section 6:53–56: Jesus healed sick people in the region of Gennesaret

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples all landed in the region of Gennesaret. People recognized Jesus and brought sick people to him from many places in that area and he healed them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus heals the sick at Gennesaret

Healing at Gennesaret

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 14:34–36.

6:55a–b

The events described in this verse occurred over a period of time and involved different groups of people. The people who recognized Jesus (6:54b) hurried to tell others in nearby towns that Jesus had arrived. Those people then told others that Jesus had arrived, until the news spread throughout the whole region. In each place that people heard the news, the people there carried the sick from their village to wherever Jesus was.

6:55a

and ran through that whole region

- They ran/hurried to all the surrounding towns in that region,
- They ran throughout the whole area to tell the inhabitants that Jesus was there.

ran through that whole region: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as *ran through* that means “ran about” or “hurried around.” The people probably did not literally run the entire way. Rather, they hurried or went quickly to the nearby towns and told the people that Jesus had come. From there the news spread to all the towns and villages in that area.

The NJB has another way to translate this clause:

they started hurrying all through the countryside

6:55b

carrying the sick on mats to wherever they heard He was.

- and they, along with others, carried the sick people on mats to wherever they heard that he was.
- Those who heard the news placed the sick people on stretchers/mats and carried them to the place where they heard people say that Jesus had gone.

carrying the sick on mats: People put the sick people on mats in order to carry them to wherever Jesus was.

mats: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *mats* refers to a stretcher or pallet that was strong enough

to use for carrying a person. It would probably be sturdier than the type of woven mat that is used in many places in the world.

This word also occurs in 2:4c.

to wherever they heard He was: Jesus was traveling from place to place and teaching people about the kingdom of God. Whenever people heard that Jesus was in a certain place, they carried their sick people to him.

they heard: The word that the BSB translates as they heard is literally “they were hearing.” It indicates that people kept hearing new reports of where Jesus had gone.

Mark 6:56

Section 6:53–56: Jesus healed sick people in the region of Gennesaret

After the storm, Jesus and his disciples all landed in the region of Gennesaret. People recognized Jesus and brought sick people to him from many places in that area and he healed them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus heals the sick at Gennesaret

Healing at Gennesaret

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 14:34–36.

6:56

And wherever He went—villages and towns and countrysides—they laid the sick in the marketplaces: The BSB uses dashes on both sides of the phrase villages and towns and countrysides. These dashes indicate the places where Jesus went. He went into villages, towns and the countryside.

In some languages, dashes are not common. It may be more natural to follow the GW:

Whenever he would go into villages, cities, or farms

6:56a

And wherever He went—villages and towns and countrysides—

- Whether he went into villages, or towns, or the countryside,

- He/Jesus went into villages, towns, and farm areas. Wherever he went,

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And connects 6:56a to 6:55b. It shows that the story continues. Many English versions do not translate this conjunction explicitly here. You should connect 6:56a to 6:55b in the way that is natural in your language.

countrysides: The Greek noun that the BSB translates as countrysides also means “farms” (as in the GNT). Here it refers to the rural areas as opposed to villages and towns.

6:56b

they laid the sick in the marketplaces

- they put the sick people in the marketplaces.
- people laid sick people in the open areas.

in the marketplaces: The Greek word that the BSB translates as marketplaces refers to large, open areas where people came to buy and sell things. Another way to translate this word is with a general expression. For example, the NJB says:

in the open spaces

6:56c

and begged Him just to let them touch the fringe of His cloak.

- They begged him to allow the sick people to touch even the hem/edge of his cloak,
- They pleaded with him/Jesus saying, “Please let this sick person touch at least the border of your clothes.”

and begged Him just to let them touch the fringe of His cloak: This clause is indirect speech. In some languages it may be more natural to translate what the people said to Jesus as direct speech. For example:

They begged Jesus, “Please allow this sick person to touch at least the edge of your clothes.”

them: The pronoun them refers to the sick people. If you use a direct quote, as above, consider whether a singular noun such as “sick person” may be more appropriate. Each group of people who carried a sick person may have begged Jesus to let the sick person whom they carried touch Jesus.

the fringe: Some ways to translate the Greek word that the BSB translates as fringe are:

- Translate it generally as hem, border, or edge of a garment. For example, the GNT says:

the edge of his cloak

- Translate it specifically as the fringe or tassel of a garment. Jewish men wore an outer garment with a fringe or tassel consisting of four blue and white threads. These hung down from the four corners of a Jewish man's outer garment to remind him to keep the commandments. Guelich note on Mark 6:56 (page 357). (See Numbers 15:38–39.)

For example, the NLT says:

the fringe of his robe

cloak: The Greek word that the BSB translates as cloak refers to a long, outer garment.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

robe

garment

clothes

This same word occurs in 5:27b–28. You should translate it here as you did there.

6:56d

And all who touched Him were healed.

- and all who touched him became healthy.
- What happened was that everyone who touched him was no longer sick.

all who touched Him: The sick touched either Jesus himself or his clothes.

were healed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as were healed is passive. If your language would not use a passive here, you can say:

became well/healthy

were no longer sick

If you need to say who healed the people, you can say:

God healed everyone who touched Jesus.

God removed the sicknesses of all who touched Jesus.

Mark 7:1

Section 7:1–23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean

This section (7:1–23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1–5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God's law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6–13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God's sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person's inner being (7:14–23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1–20 and Luke 11:37–39.

Paragraph 7:1–5

In the first paragraph of this section, Mark introduced the topic of ritual uncleanness. He did this by telling an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They rebuked him because his disciples had not followed the Jewish tradition of washing their hands in a special way before they ate.

In the middle of this paragraph (7:2b–4), Mark explained some of these Jewish traditions. He did this so that his readers would understand why the Pharisees and other Jewish leaders were upset with Jesus and questioned him.

In Greek, 7:2–5 forms one long sentence. The RSV has a long sentence in 7:3–4, and the BSB has a long sentence in 7:1–2. In your translation, use sentences that are a normal length in your language.

7:1a**Then the Pharisees and some of the scribes who had come from Jerusalem**

- ¶ Later, the Pharisees and some of the teachers of the law who came from Jerusalem
- ¶ The Pharisees and some of the experts in the law came/arrived from the city of Jerusalem.

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then introduces what the religious leaders did next after the events in Mark 6. Here are some other ways to begin this story:

One day (NLT)

After this

You should begin this story in a way that is natural in your language.

the Pharisees: The Pharisees were a Jewish religious group or party. It was very important to them to obey all of the Jewish religious laws very carefully and in detail. Here are some ways to translate this word:

- Transliterate the word Pharisees according to the sounds of your language and indicate that it refers to people. For example:

Farisi members

Parise adherents

- Transliterate the word Pharisees and indicate that it refers to a group of people with certain beliefs. For example:

people belonging to the Parise religious sect/
group

members of the religious group called the Farasi

You may also want to include an explanation of Pharisees in the glossary of your translation.

the scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes refers to men who copied the laws of Moses by hand in New Testament times. Besides copying the Scripture, their main task were to study, interpret, and teach the laws of Moses and related Jewish laws and traditions.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

the teachers of the Law of Moses (CEV)

the teachers of religious law (NLT)

the experts in the law (NET)

See how you translated this word in 1:22c and 3:22a. See also teacher of the law in the Glossary.

who had come from Jerusalem: The phrase who had come from Jerusalem can be understood in two ways:

1. It refers to both the Pharisees and the teachers of the law. Both groups came from Jerusalem. For example, the NLT says:

One day some Pharisees and teachers of religious law arrived from Jerusalem (NASB, NLT, NCV)

1. It refers only to the teachers of the law. Only the teachers of the law came from Jerusalem. This implies that the Pharisees were already there. For example, the ESV says:

Now when the Pharisees gathered to him, with some of the scribes who had come from Jerusalem (ESV, REB)

The Greek text and many English versions are ambiguous. If possible, you should also leave it ambiguous. If you must choose, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This fits the parallel passage in Matthew 15:1.

7:1b**gathered around Jesus,**

- and gathered around Jesus.
- They came to where Jesus was and stood around him.

gathered around Jesus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gathered around indicates that the Pharisees and teachers of the law came to where Jesus was. They wanted to see him.

Mark 7:2**Section 7:1–23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean**

This section (7:1–23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees

and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1–5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God's law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6–13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God's sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person's inner being (7:14–23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1–20 and Luke 11:37–39.

Paragraph 7:1–5

In the first paragraph of this section, Mark introduced the topic of ritual uncleanness. He did this by telling an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They rebuked him because his disciples had not followed the Jewish tradition of washing their hands in a special way before they ate.

In the middle of this paragraph (7:2b–4), Mark explained some of these Jewish traditions. He did this so that his readers would understand why the Pharisees and other Jewish leaders were upset with Jesus and questioned him.

In Greek, 7:2–5 forms one long sentence. The RSV has a long sentence in 7:3–4, and the BSB has a long sentence in 7:1–2. In your translation, use sentences that are a normal length in your language.

7:2a

and they saw some of His disciples eating with hands that were defiled—

- They noticed that some of his disciples were eating food with hands that were not clean,
- They saw that some of his followers were eating while their hands were ceremonially unclean.

and they saw: The Greek word that the BSB translates as saw in this context means “observed” or “noticed” (as in the GNT). The Pharisees observed what was happening around Jesus and quickly noticed a problem.

some of His disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means “learners” who are in a relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament, disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Here are some other ways to translate disciples:

- Use a term that refers to people who learn from a teacher or an expert. It is helpful if the term also implies that the learners are often with their teacher. For example:

learners/students

apprentices Be careful not to use a term that would refer only to a student in a school or classroom.

- Use a term that refers to people who follow a teacher or leader by obeying his teaching. It is helpful if this term also implies learning from the teacher and actually following the teacher wherever he goes. For example:

followers

those who are committed/faithful (to a teacher/leader)

See disciple in the Glossary.

eating: In some languages it may be necessary to indicate what they were eating. In the Greek, there is a word that often refers to “bread” specifically, but this word also can refer to food more generally. In some languages, it may be necessary to explicitly state what they were eating. Translate in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

eating food

ate a meal

defiled: The Greek word that the BSB translates as defiled means “unclean” or “desecrated.” Here defiled has a figurative meaning and means “unfit before God”. The literal meaning of “dirty” is not intended. You can translate this as:

ritually impure

not proper before God

7:2b that is, unwashed.

- which means they did not ceremonially wash their hands.
- This means that they had not washed their hands according to the Jewish custom.

that is, unwashed: There is a textual issue here that concerns the phrase that the KJV translates as “they found fault”: (1) Some Greek manuscripts do not include this phrase. For example, the NET says: “And they saw that some of Jesus’ disciples ate their bread with unclean hands, that is, unwashed” (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NET, NCV, GW, NASB, CEV, REB, GNT, ESV, JBP). (2) Other Greek texts include the phrase “they found fault” at the end of the verse. For example the KJV says: “And when they saw some of his disciples eat bread with defiled, that is to say, with unwashen, hands, they found fault” (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1) as the majority of English versions do. The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as that is shows that the next word or phrase explains what came before it. In this case, unwashed explains “defiled” in 7:2a. In some languages it may be natural to show this by saying:

meaning that they had not gone through a ceremonial washing (JBP)

because they ate without washing their hands (GW)

unwashed: One of the rituals/practices of the Pharisees and other Jewish people was to wash/rinse their hands before meals. They poured water over each hand in a certain way, and then they considered their hands to be ceremonially clean.

The ceremonial laws of the Old Testament did not require people to wash their hands in this way. The Jewish people had added these customs to the rules of the Old Testament.

If people in your area will not understand that the word “wash” refers to a ceremonial cleaning, you may want to add the implied meaning. For example:

they did not ceremonially wash/rinse their hands

they did not wash their hands in the way/manner that the Pharisees had commanded

If people in your area would still be uncertain about the purpose of the ceremonial washing, you may want to add a footnote. Here is an example:

One of the traditions of the Jews was to wash their hands in a certain way before they ate. They believed that this was necessary in order to remain ceremonially clean and acceptable to God. But the Old Testament did not say that it was necessary to wash before every meal in order to be acceptable to God.

Mark 7:3

Section 7:1–23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean

This section (7:1–23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1–5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God’s law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6–13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God’s sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person’s inner being (7:14–23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1–20 and Luke 11:37–39.

Paragraph 7:1–5

In the first paragraph of this section, Mark introduced the topic of ritual uncleanness. He did this by telling an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They rebuked him because his disciples had not followed the Jewish tradition of washing their hands in a special way before they ate.

In the middle of this paragraph (7:2b–4), Mark explained some of these Jewish traditions. He did this so that his readers would understand why the Pharisees and other Jewish leaders were upset with Jesus and questioned him.

In Greek, 7:2–5 forms one long sentence. The RSV has a long sentence in 7:3–4, and the BSB has a long sentence in 7:1–2. In your translation, use sentences that are a normal length in your language.

7:3–4

7:3–4 is background information. These verses are Mark's explanation of the Jewish custom of ceremonial hand-washing. Mark explained this custom to help his Gentile audience understand the story better. Some other translations have parentheses around these verses. You should use whatever is natural in your language to show that these verses are explanatory background information.

7:3a

Now in holding to the tradition of the elders,

- By doing this, they carefully follow the tradition of the elders.
- They do this to carefully obey the teachings/customs of their ancestors.

Now: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now introduces background information about ceremonial hand-washing. Here is another way to translate it:

For (RSV)

in holding to the tradition of the elders: The phrase in holding to the tradition of the elders may be connected to 7:3b–c in various ways:

- It may express the purpose or motivation for ceremonially washing their hands. For example:

in order to keep the traditions of the elders

in obedience to ancient tradition (REB)

- It may express the result of ceremonially washing their hands. For example, the NRSV says:

thus observing the tradition of the elders

- The clause relationship may be left implicit. For example, the GW starts a new sentence:

They follow the traditions of their ancestors.

You may follow any of these options. See the General Comment on 7:3a–c below.

holding: The Greek word the BSB translates as holding literally means to “grab hold of, seize, hold tightly.” Here Mark used this word in a figurative sense to mean “following” or “obeying.” Mark used this word to show that the Pharisees and those like them closely followed the traditions or customs of the Jewish elders.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

carefully following

obey (CEV)

the tradition of the elders: The phrase the tradition of the elders refers to the religious rules that the Pharisees taught. Over the years, the Pharisees made many religious rules/laws. The Pharisees said that following these rules was as important as following the law of Moses. People called these added rules the tradition of the elders.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the rules of the elders

the teachings of their forefathers

elders: The word elders refers here to Jewish religious leaders of previous generations who taught these rules to the Jews of following generations. Some examples of other ways to say elders are:

ancestors (GNT)

forefathers

7:3b-c

the Pharisees and all the Jews do not eat until they wash their hands ceremonially: There is a textual issue in this verse:

1. Most Greek manuscripts have a Greek idiom that literally means with a fist. This refers to washing in a specific, ceremonial or customary way. For example the GNT says:

they do not eat unless they wash their hands in the proper way (BSB, NIV, GNT, GW, CEV, NET, JBP, NCV, NLT, NJB)

1. Some Greek manuscripts have a word that literally means often or thoroughly. For example, the NRSV says:

[they] do not eat unless they thoroughly wash their hands (NRSV, KJV, NASB)

1. Some Greek manuscripts do not have either expression. For example, the RSV says:

do not eat unless they wash their hands (RSV, REB, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), since it has the support of the majority of manuscripts. These include some of the oldest and most reliable manuscripts. Also, most English versions follow this option.

7:3b

the Pharisees and all the Jews do not eat

- (For the Pharisees and all the other Jews do not eat
- All the Jewish people, especially those who belong to the Pharisee group do not eat food

the Pharisees and all the Jews: The Pharisees were themselves Jews. So in some languages it may be necessary to translate this as:

For the Pharisees, as well as the rest of the Jews (GNT)

The Jews, especially the Pharisees (NLT)

Pharisees: The Pharisees were a Jewish religious group or party. See the note on Pharisees at 7:1a.

all: The word all in this context is a hyperbole. Mark did not mean that all Jews without exception followed the ritual hand-washing regulations. He meant that this was a custom that was generally followed by

Jews. Gundry (page 349) identifies “all” specifically as a hyperbole. Several commentators mention that the common people would not have followed these regulations very carefully. However, it was common among authors of that time to make generalizations of this nature, especially when writing to people of other backgrounds (France page 281, Guelich pages 363–364, Lane page 245, Lenski page 283).

If your language uses hyperbole, you may be able to use a word like all. If people in your area will not understand this as hyperbole, you may want to refer to the Jews in general, as the NLT does.

the Jews: The word Jews here refers to the followers of the Jewish religion. The word comes from the name of their ancestor Judah, the great-grandson of Abraham.

If you do not have a word in your language for Jews, you could form a word based on the Hebrew name “Yehuda” (Judah). You could also borrow the term from a major language translation used in your area. Use the form or phrase your language naturally uses for names of tribes called after a common ancestor. For example:

Yahudi (Arabic)

do not eat: In some languages it may be natural to provide an explicit object for the verb eat. See the note on eating at 7:2a.

7:3c

until they wash their hands ceremonially.

- unless/until they ceremonially wash their hands in the proper way.
- until/before they have ritually washed their hands according to custom.

until they wash their hands ceremonially: This phrase states what the Jews always did before they ate their meals. They always washed their hands first.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

until they have first ceremonially washed their hands

[never eat] before washing their hands in a special way (NCV)

ceremonially: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as ceremonially is an idiom that literally means “with a fist.” It refers to washing in a specific,

ceremonial way. However, scholars are not certain of the actual method of washing that is described here. This idiom occurs only here in the New Testament. Proposed meanings include: “turning one fist inside the hollow of the other hand,” “up to the wrist/elbow,” and “with a handful of water.” Hiebert (pages 171–175) gives a good summary of these methods. There are at least two ways to translate this idiom:

General Comment on 7:3b–c

- Give the general meaning of this idiom. For example:

[they] do not eat unless they give their hands a ceremonial washing (NIV)

[they] do not eat unless they perform a ritual washing (NET)

- Describe a specific method that Jewish people used when they washed. For example:

[they] never eat without washing their arms as far as the elbow (NJB)

[they] do not eat until they have poured water over their cupped hands (NLT)

In some languages it may be natural to translate these verse parts using a positive statement. For example:

^{3b}The Pharisees and all the Jews ^{3c}always ceremonially wash their hands ^{3b}before they eat

General Comment on 7:3a–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder the information in these verse parts. For example, the GNT has:

^{3b}For the Pharisees, as well as the rest of the Jews, ^{3a}follow the teaching they received from their ancestors: ^{3b}they do not eat ^{3c}unless they wash their hands in the proper way...

Mark 7:4

Section 7:1–23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean

This section (7:1–23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees

and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1–5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God’s law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6–13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God’s sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person’s inner being (7:14–23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1–20 and Luke 11:37–39.

Paragraph 7:1–5

In the first paragraph of this section, Mark introduced the topic of ritual uncleanness. He did this by telling an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They rebuked him because his disciples had not followed the Jewish tradition of washing their hands in a special way before they ate.

In the middle of this paragraph (7:2b–4), Mark explained some of these Jewish traditions. He did this so that his readers would understand why the Pharisees and other Jewish leaders were upset with Jesus and questioned him.

In Greek, 7:2–5 forms one long sentence. The RSV has a long sentence in 7:3–4, and the BSB has a long sentence in 7:1–2. In your translation, use sentences that are a normal length in your language.

7:4a–b

And on returning from the market, they do not eat unless they wash: In Greek this verse is literally, “and from the market unless they wash they do not eat.” In this context scholars interpret the phrases from the market and unless they wash in different ways. As a result, there are two ways to interpret the verse:

1. The phrase from the market means when they come from the market. A few Greek manuscripts actually include the words “when they come.” However, there are many more manuscripts that do not include these words, and these include the oldest and most reliable manuscripts. (Metzger page 80, Swanson page 105.) The UBS4 (page 145) follows the manuscripts that do not include “when they come,” giving this decision an A rating, indicating that the text is virtually certain. It is probable that the English versions that have “When they come” translate that way for stylistic rather than textual reasons, that is, they are trying to express interpretation (2) in natural English. The verse means that when they come from the market, they do not eat unless they wash themselves first. For example, the NET says:

And when they come from the marketplace, they do not eat unless they wash. (BSB, NIV, RSV, GW, NET, NASB, KJV, NJB, ESV)

1. The phrase from the marketplace refers to something that comes from the market. The verse means that when they buy something from the market, they do not eat it unless they wash it first. The NLT follows the view that they do not eat anything from the market until they immerse their hands in water. For example, the NRSV says:

and they do not eat anything from the market unless they wash it (GNT, NRSV, CEV, JBP, REB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

Here are some other ways to translate this:

After they come from the market, they always ritually wash themselves before they eat.

When they come home from the marketplace, they do not eat until they purify themselves with a ritual washing.

7:4a

And on returning from the market,

- When they buy something from the marketplace,
- When they buy some food at/in the marketplace/bazaar,

market: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as market means a large, open area where people

came to buy and sell things. The word market means the same thing as “marketplace.”

The plural of this term, “marketplaces,” was first used in 6:56b. You could use the singular form of that term here.

7:4b

they do not eat unless they wash.

- they do not eat the food until they have washed their hands properly.
- they always wash according to the custom/ritual before they eat it.

they do not eat unless they wash: As in 7:3b–c, it may be natural to translate this as a positive statement:

they always wash before they eat

they must wash before they eat

they do not eat: In some languages a verb like eat needs to indicate what is eaten. If that is true in your language, use a general term like “food” or “anything.” For example:

they do not eat any food

they: The pronoun they refers to the Pharisees and other Jewish people.

unless they wash: The phrase unless they wash gives a necessary condition. In this context, it means that the Jews believed that they ought to wash their hands before they ate. And so this is what they always did.

they wash: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wash refers to a ceremonial washing. There is a textual issue here: (1) Most Greek manuscripts have a verb that literally means “they baptize/immerse/wash themselves.” This refers to a ceremonial washing. The NCV says: “they never eat it until they wash themselves in a special way” (BSB, NIV, NET, GW, KJV, REB, NCV, NLT). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have a verb that literally means, “they sprinkle themselves.” The NJB has: “they never eat without first sprinkling themselves” (NJB, JBP, NASB, RSV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). It has the support of the majority of Greek manuscripts and English versions. It is given a B rating in the UBS4 (page 145), indicating that the text is almost certain. However, both words have almost the same meaning in this context. to make people ritually pure. The form of the verb here means “they wash themselves.” Scholars are not certain whether “they wash themselves” refers to washing their whole

body or just their hands. Use a general term, if possible.

Some ways to translate “they wash themselves” are:

- Use an expression that emphasizes that it is a ritual or ceremonial washing. For example:

they wash themselves in a special way (NCV)

they cleanse themselves (NASB)

- Use a general expression like wash. For example:

they do not eat unless they wash (NET)

they never eat without first washing (REB)

7:4c

And there are many other traditions for them to observe,

- They also carefully follow many other traditions about the proper way
- There are also many other customs of their ancestors that they follow/obey

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And here introduces some more information on the same theme. Some English versions (like the GW) do not explicitly translate this conjunction. Others translate it with the word “also.” For example, the CEV says:

They also follow a lot of other teachings

Connect the information of 7:4c with 7:4a and 7:4b in a way that is natural in your language.

many other traditions: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as many other traditions is literally “many other.” The BSB has supplied the word traditions to make the sense more clear.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

many other rules (GNT)

many other things (NASB)

many other unwritten laws (NCV)

for them to observe: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as observe includes the same Greek word as the word that was translated as “holding” in 7:3c. It

means that the Pharisees and others Jews very carefully “followed” or “obeyed” their traditions. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

they observe (NIV)

they follow (GNT)

7:4d

including the washing of cups, pitchers, kettles, and couches for dining.

- to wash cups, pitchers, and pots/kettles.)
- as to how they should wash cups, jugs, and cooking pots.

the washing of cups, pitchers, kettles, and couches

for dining: There is a textual issue in this verse. Some Greek manuscripts include a phrase that the GNT translates as “and beds.” This phrase probably referred to couches where people reclined to eat their meals.

1. Some Greek manuscripts do not have “and beds” at the end of the list. For example, the CEV says:

such as washing cups, pitchers, and bowls (NIV, RSV, CEV, NCV, NASB, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB, JBP)

1. Other Greek manuscripts have “and beds.” For example, the GNT says:

to wash cups, pots, copper bowls, and beds (BSB, GNT, NET, GW, KJV, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). However, if the national language version follows option (2), you may choose to translate “and beds.” Although option (1) has the support of the oldest and most reliable manuscripts, there is also strong support for option (2).

Whichever option you choose, you should consider putting the other option in a footnote. Both options have about equal manuscript support. (UBS4 page 145, Swanson page 105). The Greek phrase translated “and beds” may have been originally rejected because it did not seem to fit in this list of items. However, there is strong possibility that the beds referred to here were not sleeping mats, but rather dining couches on which people sat or reclined to eat a meal. In this case, it would have been appropriate for Mark to include it here in this list of items. (Metzger pages 80–81, Blight

and Smith page 152). The NIV, NRSV, CEV, and NLT put “and beds” in a footnote.

If people in your area do not recline to eat their meals, you may want to translate the phrase “and couches” with a different term. For example:

and seats

cups: The word cups refers to containers used for drinking water or other liquids.

pitchers: The word pitchers refers to containers from which water or other liquids are poured into cups. Some other words for pitchers are “pots” (as in the GNT) or “jugs” (as in the JBP).

kettles: The Greek word that the BSB translates as kettles refers to containers made of brass. Another word for kettles is “pots” (as in the NCV). The size and use of the container is not clear. Use a word in your language that refers to metal containers/pots used for cooking food.

Mark 7:5

Section 7:1–23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean

This section (7:1–23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1–5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God’s law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6–13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God’s sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person’s inner being (7:14–23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1–20 and Luke 11:37–39.

Paragraph 7:1–5

In the first paragraph of this section, Mark introduced the topic of ritual uncleanness. He did this by telling an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They rebuked him because his disciples had not followed the Jewish tradition of washing their hands in a special way before they ate.

In the middle of this paragraph (7:2b–4), Mark explained some of these Jewish traditions. He did this so that his readers would understand why the Pharisees and other Jewish leaders were upset with Jesus and questioned him.

In Greek, 7:2–5 forms one long sentence. The RSV has a long sentence in 7:3–4, and the BSB has a long sentence in 7:1–2. In your translation, use sentences that are a normal length in your language.

7:5

Verses 7:3–7:4 is background information about the tradition of ceremonial washing among the Jews. Verse 7:5 now continues the main story from 7:2b. Some languages have a way to show that the author has finished giving background information and has now resumed the main story. If that is true in your language, you should use that here.

7:5a

So the Pharisees and scribes questioned Jesus:

- So the Pharisees and teachers of the law asked/questioned Jesus,
- Because they saw that their customs were not followed, the people of the Pharisee group and the experts in the law said to Jesus,

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So here introduces what the Pharisees and teachers of the law said. They said this as a result of what they saw in 7:2. Here is another way to show this connection:

Because of what they saw

Other English versions do not have a conjunction here. You should connect 7:5 to 7:2 in a way that is natural in your language.

the Pharisees: See the note on Pharisees at 7:1a.

scribes: See the note on scribes at 7:1a. See also teacher of the law in the Glossary.

questioned: The word questioned here introduces a rhetorical question. It is not a request for information. Use a natural way in your language to introduce the speech that follows.

7:5b–c

Why do Your disciples not walk according to the tradition of the elders? Instead, they eat with defiled hands: In the Greek 7:5b–c is a single rhetorical question. The BSB divides the question into one rhetorical question and one statement. The RSV translates it more literally:

Why do your disciples not live according to the tradition of the elders, but eat with hands defiled?

This rhetorical question functions as a rebuke. The Jewish leaders were rebuking Jesus because he allowed his disciples to eat without first ritually washing their hands.

Here are several ways to translate this rebuke:

- As one or two rhetorical questions. For example:

Why is it that your disciples do not follow the teaching handed down by our ancestors, but instead eat with ritually unclean hands? (GNT)

Why don't your disciples obey what our ancestors taught us to do? Why do they eat without washing their hands? (CEV)

- As a statement. For example:

Your disciples should follow the teaching handed down by our fathers/elders instead of eating with unclean hands.

Your disciples should follow our ancestors' customs! They should not eat with unclean hands!

- As one question and one statement. For example, the GW says:

Why don't your disciples follow the traditions taught by our ancestors? They are unclean because they don't wash their hands before they eat!

Use whichever form is most natural to express this rebuke in your language.

7:5b

“Why do Your disciples not walk according to the tradition of the elders?”

- “Why do your^(sing) disciples not follow/obey the traditions of our^(incl) ancestors?
- “Your^(sing) disciples are not following the customs of our^(incl) ancestors!
- “Your^(sing) followers are doing wrong! They have abandoned/rejected the traditions of the elders.

Why do Your disciples not walk according to the tradition of the elders: The phrase walk according to...tradition means “follow a set of rules” or “obey some customs” that tell how people should live.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Why is it that your disciples do not follow the teaching handed down by our ancestors...? (GNT)

Why don't your disciples obey what our ancestors taught us to do? (CEV)

disciples: See how you translated this term at 2:15b and 7:2a. See also disciple in the Glossary for more information.

the tradition of the elders: The phrase the tradition of the elders refers to the religious rules that the Pharisees taught.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the rules of the elders

the teachings of their forefathers

See the note at 7:3a.

elders: The word elders refers here to Jewish religious leaders of previous generations who taught these rules to the Jews of following generations.

Here are some examples of other ways to say elders:

ancestors (GNT)

forefathers

See the note at 7:3a.

7:5c

Instead, they eat with defiled hands.”

- Why do they eat with ceremonially unclean hands?”

- They eat their food without washing their hands in the proper way!”
- They should/must ritually wash their hands as our^(incl) forefathers/ancestors taught us before they eat!”

Instead: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *Instead* indicates a strong contrast. The contrast is between what the Jewish leaders did and what Jesus’ followers did.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

Why do your disciples not live according to the tradition of the elders, but eat with unwashed hands? (NET)

Why is it that your disciples do not follow the teaching handed down by our ancestors, but instead eat with ritually unclean hands? (GNT)

Other versions do not translate this conjunction. Instead, the rhetorical question is expressed as two questions. For example, the CEV says:

Why don’t your disciples obey what our ancestors taught us to do? Why do they eat without washing their hands?

You should use the form that is most natural in your language.

defiled: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *defiled* means “unclean,” or “desecrated.” This is the same Greek word as in 7:2a. You should translate it the same way in both places.

Mark 7:6

Section 7:1–23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean

This section (7:1–23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1–5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God’s law in order to follow their own traditions

(7:6–13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God’s sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person’s inner being (7:14–23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1–20 and Luke 11:37–39.

Paragraph 7:6–13

In this paragraph, Jesus responded to the rebuke of the Pharisees and teachers of the law. But he did not explain to them directly why his disciples did not follow the tradition of the Jewish ancestors. Instead he told them that they fulfilled a prophecy from Isaiah about people who followed human traditions rather than God’s laws (7:6–8). He then gave a specific example of one of God’s laws that they prevented people from obeying. They did this by insisting that people follow the traditions of the ancestors (7:9–13) instead of God’s law.

7:6a

Jesus answered them, “Isaiah prophesied correctly about you hypocrites,

- ¶ He replied/said, “Isaiah spoke correctly/truly when he made known these words from God about you^(plur) who are hypocrites.
- ¶ Jesus answered them, “God’s message that Isaiah said/prophesied long ago definitely/clearly applies to you^(plur) who pretend to be righteous people.

Jesus answered them: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *Jesus answered them* is literally “And he said to them” (as in the RSV). Jesus was replying to the rhetorical question in 7:5. Because of this, a verb such as “replied” or “answered” may be more natural in some languages.

Isaiah: Isaiah is the name of a prophet. He lived many years before the time of Jesus. See how you translated Isaiah and “prophet” in 1:2a.

prophesied correctly about you: In this context, the verb prophesied means “gave a message from God.” This message (quoted from Isaiah 29:13) originally described the people living in Isaiah’s time. Jesus said that Isaiah prophesied about you (the Pharisees and teachers of the law). He meant that Isaiah’s message described the character of the Jewish leaders of Jesus’ time very accurately.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

make known the words from God about you

God’s message that Isaiah said about you

See prophet in the Glossary.

hypocrites: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hypocrites refers literally to actors. Actors are like hypocrites because what they appear to be is not what they really are. Hypocrites often:

1. acted in a way that did not fit what they said they believed.
2. believed that they honored God, but they did not truly love and honor him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

false servants of God (TRT)

people who only say they are righteous

In some languages people may use an idiom for this idea.

7:6b as it is written:

- This is what God caused him to write:
- It is just like he wrote in God’s book:

it is written: Jesus often used the expression it is written when he quoted the Old Testament Scriptures. Some things to consider when you translate this expression are:

- Your language may already have a formula that is used to introduce a quotation from sacred writings. Consider if you could use that formula here, possibly with slight modification.
- In some languages you will need to make explicit that the quotation comes from Scripture. For example:

This is what is written in God’s word.

- If your language would express this using an active verb, you could say something like:

As we/people read in the Scriptures

This is what God caused him to write

See how you translated this expression in 1:2a.

General Comment on 7:6a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to combine or reorder some of the phrases in these verse parts. For example:

What Isaiah said/prophesied in God’s written words about hypocrites like you is true/correct

Isaiah was right when he prophesied about you hypocrites in Scripture (GW)

Notice that the GW has made implicit the phrase “as it is written.” For an English audience, the phrase “in Scripture” implies that the prophecy was written, so both phrases are not necessary. Express this information in a natural way in your language.

7:6c–7b

These words are quoted from Isaiah 29:13.

7:6c–d

These people honor Me with their lips, but their hearts are far from Me: In Greek, the phrase with their lips occurs in a position of emphasis. The word order indicates that the main contrast is between external worship (with their lips) and internal reality (their hearts). In some languages, it may be possible to express this contrast by saying:

These people, it is only with their lips/words that they honor me, but their hearts are far from me.

Express this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

7:6c

‘These people honor Me with their lips,

- ‘It is only with their mouths/words that these people praise me,
- ‘You^(plur) people speak well about me,

These people: When Isaiah originally spoke these words, the phrase These people referred to the Jewish people who acted like this. Jesus said that the Phar-

isees were also the people that Isaiah had spoken about.

The people to whom Jesus spoke and to whom Isaiah spoke were all Jewish. So in some languages it may be natural to translate this as:

You^(plur) people

honor Me with their lips: The phrase honor Me with their lips is a figure of speech (metonymy) in which their lips stands for “their words.” This means that the Pharisees honored/praised God with their words.

If this figure of speech is not clear or natural in your language, you may:

- Substitute a similar figure of speech. For example:

These people praise me with their mouths/
tongues

- Omit the figure of speech and express the meaning directly. For example:

You praise me in what you say

These people show honor to me with words (NCV)

Me: Jesus was quoting from the book of Isaiah, which was quoting the words of God. So the pronoun Me refers to God. In some languages it may be necessary to use indirect speech in order to make this clear. See the General Comment on 7:6b–7b after 7:7b for an example.

7:6d

but their hearts are far from Me.

- but in their hearts/thoughts they are not close to me.
- but they do not mean what they say.
- but you^(plur) do not really love me or think about me.

but their hearts are far from me: This clause contrasts what the people say (7:6c) and their true, inner attitude toward God.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

All of you praise me with your words, but you never really think about me. (CEV)

You say that you want to honor me, but you do not care about what truly honors me.

their hearts: In the New Testament, the word heart refers figuratively to the mind, emotions, and will of a person. It refers to the part of a person that he uses to think, feel, and make decisions. In some languages people refer figuratively to this part of a person as his mind, throat, liver, or stomach. They are not referring literally to that physical part of the body. You should use the expression in your language that is natural to refer to this spiritual part of a person.

far from Me: The words far from Me are a figurative expression that means that the people had turned away from God. They had turned away:

1. with their minds and did not think of God,
2. with their will and did not obey God,
3. with their emotions and did not love God.

In your translation, try to find an expression that implies or suggests all of these things.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

but their minds/livers/stomachs are far from me

but in their hearts/throats/thoughts, they have turned away from me

but they do not mean what they say

If one term expresses only part of the meaning, you may be able to use a combination of terms. For example:

they do not truly love me or think about me

Mark 7:7

Section 7:1–23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean

This section (7:1–23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1–5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God’s law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6–13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God’s sight is not caused by external

things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person's inner being (7:14-23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1-20 and Luke 11:37-39.

Paragraph 7:6-13

In this paragraph, Jesus responded to the rebuke of the Pharisees and teachers of the law. But he did not explain to them directly why his disciples did not follow the tradition of the Jewish ancestors. Instead he told them that they fulfilled a prophecy from Isaiah about people who followed human traditions rather than God's laws (7:6-8). He then gave a specific example of one of God's laws that they prevented people from obeying. They did this by insisting that people follow the traditions of the ancestors (7:9-13) instead of God's law.

7:7a

They worship Me in vain;

- They bow before me uselessly.
- They praise me without any result.
- The ceremonies you^(plur) perform to try to please me are useless/worthless,

They: When Isaiah spoke, the word They referred to the Jewish people who did not worship God properly. In this context, the word They refers to the Pharisees and teachers of the law. If you have used a second-person pronoun ("you people") in 7:6b, it will probably be best to continue using the second person (you) here.

worship: The Greek word that the BSB translates as worship means to express devotion and reverence for God or for other gods or idols. Some of the ways that people worship God are giving offerings and sacrifices, praying, bowing down or kneeling to show respect and submission, serving him obediently, and speaking or singing about him.

In this context the meaning of worship is similar to the meaning of honor in 7:6c.

Here are some other ways to translate worship in this context:

They serve/worship me

Their reverence of me (NJB)

Me: The word Me again refers to God.

in vain: The Greek word that the BSB translates in vain means "to no purpose," "uselessly," or "without result." For example:

It is no use for them to worship me (GNT)

Their worship of me is worthless. (NCV)

7:7b

they teach as doctrine the precepts of men.'

- Their teachings are only/merely rules taught by men.'
- They teach only their man-made rules instead of my laws.'
- because you^(plur) replace what God commands with your own laws/ideas.'"

The clause in 7:7b explains the manner in which people were not honoring God and how they were worshiping without purpose. Some translations make this clear by adding a connecting word. For example:

for they teach as doctrines the commandments of men (REB)

because their teachings are rules made by humans (GW)

they teach as doctrine the precepts of men: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as they teach as doctrine the precepts of men indicates that the Pharisees and teachers of the law taught their own man-made rules instead of the laws that came from God. For example:

The things they teach are nothing but human rules. (NCV)

for they replace God's commands with their own man-made teachings (NLT96)

they teach: The pronoun they refers to the Pharisees and scribes.

General Comment on 7:6b–7b

In some languages, it will be more natural to translate the passage from Isaiah as an indirect quote. This will mean changing the pronoun “me” to “God” or “him.” For example:

^{6b}It is written that God said that ^{6c}these people honor God/him with their lips, ^{6d}but their hearts are far from him. ^{7a}They worship him in vain; ^{7b}their teachings are but rules taught by men.

Mark 7:8

Section 7:1–23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean

This section (7:1–23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1–5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God's law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6–13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God's sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person's inner being (7:14–23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1–20 and Luke 11:37–39.

Paragraph 7:6–13

In this paragraph, Jesus responded to the rebuke of the Pharisees and teachers of the law. But he did not explain to them directly why his disciples did not follow the tradition of the Jewish ancestors. Instead he told them that they fulfilled a prophecy from Isaiah about people who followed human traditions rather than God's laws (7:6–8). He then gave a specific example of one of God's laws that they prevented people from obeying. They did this by insisting that people follow the traditions of the ancestors (7:9–13) instead of God's law.

7:8a

You have disregarded the commandment of God

- You^(plur) have stopped obeying what God commands
- Then Jesus said to them, “You^(plur) have abandoned what God says

The quote from the book of Isaiah ended at the end of 7:7b. Verse 7:8a begins Jesus' own words. Here he addressed the Pharisees and the scribes directly. In some languages, it will be necessary to indicate explicitly that Jesus was no longer quoting from the Old Testament. For example:

And you are truly doing what Isaiah wrote about, because you have let go...

Then Jesus continued, “In the same way, you have let go...”

You have disregarded the commandment of God:

The expression have disregarded means “have stopped obeying” or “have abandoned” the commandments of God. For example, the NCV says:

You have stopped following the commands of God

The Pharisees and scribes had stopped following God's law at sometime in the past. At the time Jesus was speaking, they were still not following it. So in some languages it may be natural to use the present tense here. For example:

You abandon the commandments of God (GW)

you ignore God's law (NLT)

7:8b

to keep the tradition of men.”

- and are obeying the teachings/traditions of men.”

- and are carefully following the customs of your^(plur) ancestors.”

to keep the tradition of men: There is a textual issue here that concerns the words “[as] the washing of pots and cups: and many other such like things ye do.” (1) Some Greek manuscripts do not include these words. For example, the NLT says: “For you ignore God’s law and substitute your own tradition” (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NET, NCV, GW, NASB, CEV, REB, GNT, ESV, JBP).” (2) Other Greek texts include these words at the end of the verse. For example the KJV says: “For laying aside the commandment of God, ye hold the tradition of men, [as] the washing of pots and cups: and many other such like things ye do” (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1) as the majority of English versions do. The expression to keep literally means “to grab” or “to seize.” Jesus used this word in a figurative sense. He meant that the Pharisees and teachers of the law carefully followed and obeyed the tradition of men. They believed that this tradition was very important. They insisted that people obey it. The same Greek word occurs in 7:3a and 7:4c.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

you follow only human teachings (NCV)

obey what humans have taught (CEV)

tradition: The Greek word that the BSB translates as tradition is the same word as in 7:3a. Another word for tradition is “customs.”

Mark 7:9

Section 7:1–23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean

This section (7:1–23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1–5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God’s law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6–13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God’s sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful

things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person’s inner being (7:14–23).

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Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1–20 and Luke 11:37–39.

Paragraph 7:6–13

In this paragraph, Jesus responded to the rebuke of the Pharisees and teachers of the law. But he did not explain to them directly why his disciples did not follow the tradition of the Jewish ancestors. Instead he told them that they fulfilled a prophecy from Isaiah about people who followed human traditions rather than God’s laws (7:6–8). He then gave a specific example of one of God’s laws that they prevented people from obeying. They did this by insisting that people follow the traditions of the ancestors (7:9–13) instead of God’s law.

7:9a

He went on to say,

- Then he continued saying:
- Jesus also said to them,

He went on to say: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as He went on to say here introduces more things that Jesus said. You should introduce these words of Jesus in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Then he said (NLT)

He also said to them (NET)

He added (GW)

7:9b

“You neatly set aside the command of God

- “You^(plur) think you have very clever ways to abandon the commandments of God
- “You^(plur) ignore the commands/laws of God

You neatly set aside the command of God: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as neatly is a figure of speech. It means the opposite of what it says. Jesus was being sarcastic as he rebuked the proud Jewish leaders for doing wrong.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Use words that keep the sarcasm. For example:

You have a clever way of rejecting God's law (GNT)

- Omit the figure of speech. For example:

You set aside the commands of God

You reject God's laws (NLT96)

- Translate the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

You are foolish to reject God's law

You are doing wrong when you reject God's commands

set aside the command of God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as set aside also means "reject" or "ignore." This word refers to the way the Pharisees and teachers of the law rejected and disobeyed God's commands. For example:

You cleverly ignore the commands of God (NCV)

You reject God's laws (NLT96)

7:9c

to maintain your own tradition.

- to follow your^(plur) own traditions!
- so that you^(plur) can keep your^(plur) own customs/teachings!

to maintain your own tradition: When you translate the verb maintain, you should use a verb that naturally goes with the word tradition. For example:

so that you can follow your own teachings (CEV)

in order to keep your own traditions (GW)

tradition: The Greek word that the BSB translates as tradition means "those things that are taught or commanded which are passed on from one generation to another."

Mark 7:10

Section 7:1-23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean

This section (7:1-23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1-5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God's law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6-13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God's sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person's inner being (7:14-23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1-20 and Luke 11:37-39.

Paragraph 7:6-13

In this paragraph, Jesus responded to the rebuke of the Pharisees and teachers of the law. But he did not explain to them directly why his disciples did not follow the tradition of the Jewish ancestors. Instead he told them that they fulfilled a prophecy from Isaiah about people who followed human traditions rather than God's laws (7:6-8). He then gave a specific example of one of God's laws that they prevented people from obeying. They did this by insisting that people follow the traditions of the ancestors (7:9-13) instead of God's law.

7:10a-b

7:10a contains a quote from Exodus 20:12 and Deuteronomy 5:16. 7:10b contains a quote from Exodus 21:17 and Leviticus 20:9. If you use footnotes, you may want to refer to these verses in a footnote.

7:10a

For Moses said, ‘Honor your father and your mother’

- For example, Moses taught, ‘Respect your^(sing) father and mother,’
- This is one example. The prophet Moses said/commanded, ‘Honor your^(plur) mother and father.’

For Moses said: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For introduces the next words of Jesus. He gave a clear example of the way the Pharisees and other leaders ignored God’s command. Moses taught people to obey God’s commands. For example, the GW says:

For example, Moses said

Moses said: Moses said the following sentence when he gave God’s message to the people of Israel. Later, he wrote it down. It was a command from God.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Moses commanded (GNT)

Moses gave you this law from God (NLT)

Honor your father and your mother: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Honor means to show respect to someone through words and actions. For example, the GNT says:

Respect your father and your mother

This same word Honor occurs in 7:6c.

your: Moses was speaking to all the people of Israel. What he said applied to each of them individually. Consider if it is more natural to use the singular or the plural pronoun “your” in this situation.

father and...mother: In some languages it is more natural to say “mother and father.” Translate the words of this phrase in the order that is natural in your language.

7:10b

and ‘Anyone who curses his father or mother must be put to death.’

- and he also said, ‘Anyone who says evil things about his father or mother must be executed/killed.’
- He also said/commanded ‘If any person insults his mother or father, that person must die.’

Anyone who: The words Anyone who begin a general statement. In some languages, it may be more natural to say “He who” or “If you.” For example, the GNT says:

If you curse your father or your mother

curses his father or mother: The Greek word that the BSB translates as curses means “speaks evil of,” “reviles,” or “insults.” For example:

He who speaks evil of father or mother (RSV)

Whoever insults his father or mother (NET)

Here the word curses does not mean “to put a curse on someone.”

Jesus quoted from what Moses said to show that it was very important to honor one’s parents according to the Jewish law.

must be put to death: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as must be put to death means “must be killed.” This is a passive phrase.

If your language uses only active verbs, here are some other ways to translate this:

must die

it is necessary to kill that person

Mark 7:11

Section 7:1-23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean

This section (7:1-23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1-5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God’s law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6-13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true

uncleanness in God's sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person's inner being (7:14-23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1-20 and Luke 11:37-39.

Paragraph 7:6-13

In this paragraph, Jesus responded to the rebuke of the Pharisees and teachers of the law. But he did not explain to them directly why his disciples did not follow the tradition of the Jewish ancestors. Instead he told them that they fulfilled a prophecy from Isaiah about people who followed human traditions rather than God's laws (7:6-8). He then gave a specific example of one of God's laws that they prevented people from obeying. They did this by insisting that people follow the traditions of the ancestors (7:9-13) instead of God's law.

7:11-12

In the BSB, 7:11-12 forms one long sentence. It follows the Greek structure and includes a quotation within a quotation within Jesus' words. In many languages it will be impossible to use these embedded quotations. See the General Comment on 7:11-12 at the end of 7:12 for ways to restructure these verses.

7:11a

But you say that

- But you^(plur) Pharisees and teachers of the law say that
- But here is what you^(plur) Pharisees and experts in the law do.
- But you^(plur) Pharisees and teachers of the law say/teach something different.

But you say: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as But you say contrasts with "Moses said" in 7:10. Jesus emphasized that Moses taught God's commands, but the Pharisees and teachers of the law taught human traditions. Not only did they abandon God's laws, they also taught people to do the same thing.

In many languages it will be difficult to translate 7:11b-7:12 as the content of the verb say. It may be more natural to introduce their teaching in a more general way. For example:

Your teaching is quite different.

You teach/say the opposite.

What the Pharisees and teachers of the law were saying is stated in 7:12. They were forbidding people to help their parents. In some languages, forbidding or not permitting something is referred to as something that is done rather than said. So in those languages you may need to translate this as:

But this is what you do.

you: The pronoun you is emphatic in the Greek text. It refers to the Pharisees.

7:11b

if a man says to his father or mother,

- if a person says to his father or mother:
- If/when anyone says to his mother or father,
- If someone says to his mother and father

if a man says to his father or mother: The Greek word that the BSB translates as if introduces a condition. The Pharisees and teachers of the law said that if people said these words, they did not have to obey God's law.

a man: The words a man refer to anyone. For example, the GW says:

If a person

7:11c

'Whatever you would have received from me is Corban'

- 'Whatever gift you^(sing) might have received from me is Corban'
- 'I cannot help you^(sing) because I have vowed to give to God that which I would have given to you,^(sing)'
- that he has vowed to give to God the help/gift that he would have given to them,^(dual)

Whatever you would have received from me: The Greek phrase the BSB translates as Whatever you would have received from me is literally "whatever by me you might have benefited."

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Anything I have which might have been used for your benefit (REB)

Whatever help you would have received from me (NET)

if people have something they could use to help their father or mother (GNT)

Whatever you would have received: The phrase Whatever you would have received refers to practical help such as money or food. It also refers to any other gift that would make life easier for the person's parents.

Corban: The word that the BSB transliterates as Corban is a Hebrew word. It refers to "something set aside as a gift for God." Therefore, other people could not use it.

According to Jewish tradition, a Jew could announce that something was Corban or dedicated to God. When he did that, the person to whom he announced it would not be allowed to use that thing. Even though the thing belonged to God, the Jew did not have to give that thing as an offering. He could keep it for himself. Jesus knew that the Pharisees and teachers of the law did this for a selfish reason. They did it in order to keep things for themselves and avoid caring for their parents.

You can translate Corban in two ways.

- Transliterate the word Corban. For example, the GNT says:

This is Corban.

- Do not include the word Corban and just make the meaning clear. For example, the NLT says:

For I have vowed to give to God what I would have given to you. If you do this you will not have to translate 7:11d separately.

7:11d (that is, a gift devoted to God),

- which means, a gift that belongs to God,
- so this gift is only for God,
- it is only God's, not theirs.

that is, a gift devoted to God: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as that is, a gift devoted to God is literally "which is a gift/offering." This phrase is in

parentheses in the BSB. This shows that Mark wrote these words to explain the meaning of "Corban." You should make this clear in a way that is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

that is, a gift for God (NET)

that is, an offering to God (NRSV)

which means, it belongs to God (GNT)

Mark 7:12

Section 7:1-23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean

This section (7:1-23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1-5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God's law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6-13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God's sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person's inner being (7:14-23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1-20 and Luke 11:37-39.

Paragraph 7:6-13

In this paragraph, Jesus responded to the rebuke of the Pharisees and teachers of the law. But he did not explain to them directly why his disciples did not

follow the tradition of the Jewish ancestors. Instead he told them that they fulfilled a prophecy from Isaiah about people who followed human traditions rather than God's laws (7:6–8). He then gave a specific example of one of God's laws that they prevented people from obeying. They did this by insisting that people follow the traditions of the ancestors (7:9–13) instead of God's law.

7:12

he is no longer permitted to do anything for his father or mother.

- then from then on he is not allowed to do his duty to help his father and mother.
- then you^(plur) no longer allow that person to help his mother or father as God's commandment teaches.
- When that happens, starting from then, you^(plur) do not allow/permit him to do anything for his parents.

Here Jesus gives the effect or result of the condition stated in 7:11b–d. You should connect 7:11 with 7:12 in the way that is natural in your language. For example, the NIV says:

then you no longer let him do anything

he is no longer permitted to: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as he is no longer permitted to means:

you no longer allow/permit him

he is forbidden from that moment (NJB)

Jesus was rebuking the Pharisees and teachers of the law. He told them that they were responsible for people disobeying God's commands. They did not allow people to do what God had told them to do.

do anything: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as do anything refers to any practical help the person might give his parents. This included money or food to make their lives easier.

General Comment on 7:11–12

In many languages it may be necessary to break up this sentence into two or more shorter sentences. For example:

^{11a}But this is your teaching: ^{11b}Suppose a man says to his father or mother, ^{11c–d}“I have dedicated my belongings to God and cannot use it to help you.”

¹²Then you do not permit him to use those things to help them.

Mark 7:13

Section 7:1–23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean

This section (7:1–23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1–5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God's law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6–13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God's sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person's inner being (7:14–23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1–20 and Luke 11:37–39.

Paragraph 7:6–13

In this paragraph, Jesus responded to the rebuke of the Pharisees and teachers of the law. But he did not explain to them directly why his disciples did not follow the tradition of the Jewish ancestors. Instead he told them that they fulfilled a prophecy from Isaiah about people who followed human traditions rather than God's laws (7:6–8). He then gave a specific example of one of God's laws that they prevented people from obeying. They did this by insisting that people follow the traditions of the ancestors (7:9–13) instead of God's law.

7:13a

Thus you nullify the word of God by the tradition you have handed down.

- In this way, you^(plur) destroy the authority of God's word/command by means of the tradition you^(plur) have taught to people.
- By doing/saying this, the customs that you pass on to people cause what God said to become worthless.

Thus: The BSB and other translations add a word like Thus to help readers understand that Jesus summarized his main point in this sentence. Use an expression in your language that shows that Jesus summarized what he was saying. For example, the NJB says:

In this way

you nullify the word of God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as nullify also means “cancel” or “disregard.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the teaching you pass on to others cancels out the word of God (GNT)

you have destroyed the authority of God's word (GW)

you ignore God's commands (CEV)

you are rejecting what God said (NCV)

the word of God: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the word of God refers here to the commands in God's law that Jesus quoted in 7:10a–b.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

God's word

God's commands

what God has said

God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as God refers here to the eternal spirit who created everything. He is more powerful than any other spirit, and he is perfectly good and wise. He deserves to be worshiped. Here are some ways to translate God:

- Use a name or title for God that people in your culture already use.

- Use a descriptive term that fits the truth about God that is revealed in the Bible. For example:

Creator

Great Spirit

Ruler of the universe

Choose a term that is acceptable to the believers and churches in your area. For more detailed information, see God in the Glossary.

by the tradition: The Greek word that the BSB translates as by shows that the Pharisees and teachers of the law used their traditions to nullify the authority of God's message.

Here are some other ways to express this:

for the sake of your tradition (NJB)

Your traditions...cause God's commands to be disobeyed.

tradition: A tradition is a custom. It is an accepted way of thinking and behaving. Traditions can be helpful or harmful. They can be based on beliefs that are true or beliefs that are not true.

If in your culture, traditions are always considered to be good, it may be necessary to say:

harmful tradition

you have handed down: The expression handed down refers to teaching or instructing people about traditions from one generation to the next. For example:

which you teach people (NCV)

you pass on to others (GNT)

7:13b

And you do so in many such matters.”

- And you^(plur) do many other things that are just like that.”
- In addition to this, you^(plur) habitually teach people to do many other things that result in God's word/law not being obeyed.”

And: The Greek word that the BSB translates as And introduces a summary of other things that the Jewish leaders did. These things are similar to the example that Jesus gave in 7:10a–13a. Connect what Jesus said in 7:13a to what he said in 7:13b in a way that is natural in your language. See the examples at the end of the next note.

you do so in many such matters: The phrase you do so in many such matters means that the Pharisees and teachers of the law habitually substituted their rules for God’s laws. Jesus had given one example (in 7:11–12). They did or taught many similar things.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

You do a lot of other things that are just as bad.
(CEV)

And this is only one example among many others.
(NLT)

Mark 7:14

Section 7:1–23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean

This section (7:1–23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1–5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God’s law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6–13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God’s sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person’s inner being (7:14–23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1–20 and Luke 11:37–39.

Paragraph 7:14–16

In this paragraph, Jesus again spoke to the crowd. He explained to them that what defiles a person is not something external like food that goes into a person’s body. Rather, what defiles a person in God’s sight are the sinful things that come from inside him. Jesus implied that the Pharisees and teachers of the law were wrong to focus on external rituals such as hand-washing.

7:14a

Once again Jesus called the crowd to Him and said,

- ¶ Then Jesus called the crowd to him again and said,
- ¶ After answering the Pharisees and teachers of the law, Jesus again called all the other people in the crowd to come to him. He said,

The part of the story that starts in 7:14 probably began immediately after 7:1–13. In some languages, it is natural to begin a new part of a story with a time word or phrase. If your language is like that, use an expression here that is not too specific. For example:

Then (GNT)

After that

In other languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this part of the story in a natural way in your language.

Once again Jesus called the crowd to Him: There is a textual issue here: (1) Some Greek texts have the word again. For example, the NET says: “he called the crowd again” (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NET, NCV, GW, NASB, CEV, REB, GNT, ESV, JBP).” (2) Other Greek texts have the word all. For example the KJV says: “he called all the crowd” (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1) as the majority of English versions do. The Greek word that the BSB translates as Once again shows that Jesus began to speak to the people in the crowd, as he had done earlier. These people were there when the Pharisees and teachers of the law questioned him and he responded to their question.

Jesus called the crowd to Him: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Jesus called the crowd to Him means that Jesus invited the crowd to gather around him. He did this because he wanted to talk to them.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Jesus called the crowd together again... (CEV)

Jesus called to the crowd to come and hear. (NLT)

7:14b

“All of you, listen to Me and understand:

- “Listen carefully to me, everyone of you, and try to understand this.
- “Each of you, listen to what I am saying and think carefully about the meaning of what I am going to tell you.

All of you, listen to Me and understand: The expression All of you, listen to Me and understand indicates that:

1. Jesus intended to say something important to the crowd.
2. He strongly urged the people to listen carefully to what he said.

Each part of what Jesus said adds emphasis. Listen to me means “concentrate on what I am saying.” The phrase All of you makes clear that what he said was so important that each person should listen. The word understand emphasizes that everyone should think carefully about the meaning of what Jesus was about to say.

Use an expression in your language that people say when they want others to give careful attention and think about the meaning of what they hear. For example:

Pay attention and try to understand what I mean.
(CEV)

Hear me, all of you, and understand (RSV)

Mark 7:15

Section 7:1–23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean

This section (7:1–23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1–5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored

God’s law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6–13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God’s sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person’s inner being (7:14–23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1–20 and Luke 11:37–39.

Paragraph 7:14–16

In this paragraph, Jesus again spoke to the crowd. He explained to them that what defiles a person is not something external like food that goes into a person’s body. Rather, what defiles a person in God’s sight are the sinful things that come from inside him. Jesus implied that the Pharisees and teachers of the law were wrong to focus on external rituals such as hand-washing.

7:15

In this verse Jesus spoke to the crowd in the form of a parable (7:17b). According to 7:18a, the disciples did not understand what this parable meant.

When you translate this verse, you may need to make some of the meaning explicit in order to avoid a wrong meaning. Some of the English versions have done this. But be careful not to explain the entire meaning of the parable. Otherwise your readers will not understand why Jesus needed to explain the meaning to his disciples in 7:18b–22. Read this whole section carefully before deciding what information needs to be made explicit here in 7:15.

7:15a–b

Nothing that enters a man from the outside can defile him;

- Nothing that comes from outside a person can cause him to be impure before God by entering into him.
- Food that a person puts into his body cannot defile him.

- People do not become unfit/defiled before God because of what they eat.

7:15a

Nothing that enters a man from the outside: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Nothing that enters a man from the outside is a general expression that refers indirectly here to any kind of food. Some versions make this clear. For example, the CEV says:

the food that you put into your mouth

enters...from the outside: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as enters...from the outside refers to eating.

a man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a man is used in a general sense here to refer to anyone, whether male or female. So GW translates this as:

a person

7:15b

can defile him: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as can defile him means “can cause him to become unclean/defiled.” For example, the EASY says:

People do not become unclean because of things that go into their bodies from outside

This word is used in a figurative sense meaning “unfit before God.” Here it is not used in its literal sense of “dirty.” See how you translated “defiled” in 7:2a.

General Comment on 7:15a–b

In some languages, it may not be natural to speak of food entering a person or coming from the outside. It may be necessary to reorder the parts of this sentence or to make one or both of these ideas implicit. For example:

Nothing that goes into a person from the outside can make him unclean. (GW)

There is nothing people put into their bodies that makes them unclean. (NCV)

The food that you put into your mouth doesn't make you unclean and unfit to worship God. (CEV)

You are not defiled by what you eat (NLT96)

7:15c

but the things that come out of a man, these are what defile him.”

- But it is what comes out of a person's heart/mind that causes him to become impure.”
- Instead, the bad things that a person causes to come out from his heart/mind are what defile him.”
- They become unfit before God by what they do and say.”

but: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as but indicates a strong contrast.

Here are some other ways of expressing this contrast:

Rather (NIV)

no,... (REB)

Some languages show the contrast without using a word like but or rather. The ideas in the sentences show the contrast clearly. For example, the NCV says:

There is nothing people put into their bodies that makes them unclean. People are made unclean by the things that come out of them.

Express the contrast in these sentences in a way that is natural in your language.

the things that come out of a man: The phrase the things that come out of a man is a general expression. In 7:21–22 Jesus explained that he was talking about actions and words that express a person's inner thoughts.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- With a general statement. For example, the NCV says:

People are made unclean by the things that come out of them.

- With a more specific statement. For example:

Instead, the bad things that come out of a person's heart/mind are what defile him.

you are defiled by what you say and do (NLT96)

Remember that Jesus was using a parable here and the disciples did not understand what it meant. So in

translating this phrase, be careful not to make explicit all of the meaning from Jesus' explanation in the next few verses.

defile him: See the note in 7:2a.

Mark 7:16

Section 7:1–23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean

This section (7:1–23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1–5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God's law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6–13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God's sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person's inner being (7:14–23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1–20 and Luke 11:37–39.

Paragraph 7:14–16

In this paragraph, Jesus again spoke to the crowd. He explained to them that what defiles a person is not something external like food that goes into a person's body. Rather, what defiles a person in God's sight are the sinful things that come from inside him. Jesus implied that the Pharisees and teachers of the law were wrong to focus on external rituals such as hand-washing.

7:16

[Most English versions do not translate this verse. See the Notes on 7:16.]

There is a textual issue here. It concerns the verse that the NASB translates as: "If any man has ears to hear, let him hear."

1. Some Greek manuscripts do not include this verse. (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, CEV, NCV, NLT, NET, JBP, NASB, NRSV, REB)
2. Other Greek manuscripts include this verse. For example, the GW says:

¹⁶Let the person who has ears listen! (GW, NASB, NJB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), since it has the support of some of the oldest and most reliable manuscripts. Although 7:16 is present in the majority of manuscripts, it is absent from the oldest and most reliable manuscripts. (Metzger page 81, Swanson page 109) If you follow this option, it is good to include this verse as a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Some Greek manuscripts include 7:16, which says: "If any man has ears to hear, let him hear."

If the major language version in your area includes this verse in the text, you may want to include it in brackets, as the NASB does.

If you put 7:16 in a footnote, here are several ways to number the verses:

- Put the number 16 after the number 15. For example, the CEV says:

^{15–16}The food that you put into your mouth doesn't make you unclean...

- Put in the number 16 after the last word of 15, and have the footnote marker after it. For example, the NCV says:

¹⁵"...There is nothing people put into their bodies that makes them unclean. People are made unclean by the things that come out of them." ¹⁶ ‡
¹⁷When Jesus left the people...

- Do not include the number 16. Put the footnote after verse 15. For example, the NLT96 says:

¹⁵"...You are not defiled by what you eat; you are defiled by what you say and do! ‡ " ¹⁷Then Jesus went into a house...

For advice on translating this verse, see how you translated the similar text in 4:23.

Mark 7:17

Section 7:1–23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean

This section (7:1–23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1–5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God's law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6–13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God's sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person's inner being (7:14–23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1–20 and Luke 11:37–39.

7:17a

After Jesus had left the crowd and gone into the house,

- ¶ Then Jesus left the crowd and entered the house,
- ¶ After Jesus finished teaching, he left the crowd and entered the house where they were staying.

After Jesus had left the crowd and gone into the house: In some languages, it may be more natural to make 7:17a into a separate sentence. For example:

Then he left the crowd and entered the house

After he finished teaching, he left the crowd and entered the house

7:17b

His disciples inquired about the parable.

- and his disciples asked him about this saying.
- His followers asked him the meaning of what he had said.

His disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means “learners” who are in a relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Here are some other ways to translate disciples:

students/learners

apprentices

followers

See how you translated this term at 2:15b and 7:2a. See also disciple in the Glossary for more information.

parable: In this context the word parable describes what Jesus said to the people in 7:14–16. The Greek word that the BSB translates as parable is used to describe different types of wise speech like proverbs, illustrations, and metaphors. You will need to read 7:14–16 carefully. Then consider how you would describe this type of speech in your language.

Here are some other ways that English versions have translated parable in this context:

his disciples asked him to explain this saying (GNT)

his disciples asked him about this illustration (GW)

his disciples asked him what he meant by the statement he had made (NLT96)

Mark 7:18

Section 7:1–23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean

This section (7:1–23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1–5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God's law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6–13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God's sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person's inner being (7:14–23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1–20 and Luke 11:37–39.

7:18a

“Are you still so dull?” He asked.

- He asked them, “You too? Do you fail to understand?”
- He said to them, “So, you are just like the others. You do not understand me either!”

The Greek clause that the BSB translates as *Are you still so dull?* is more literally “Then are you also without understanding?” (as in the RSV). For the discussion in 7:18a, the RSV, which is more literal, is used.

(RSV:) Then are you also without understanding?:

This is a rhetorical question. Jesus asked this question to rebuke his disciples. He rebuked them because not only had the crowd not understood, even his own disciples had not understood him.

There are at least two ways to translate this rebuke.

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the NRSV says:

Then do you also fail to understand?

- As a statement. For example:

You also fail to understand like the others!

Use whichever form is most natural to express this rebuke in your language.

(RSV:) Then: The Greek word that the RSV translates as *Then* also means “thus” or “so.” Here Jesus used this conjunction to emphatically introduce his question. In English, a word like “so” works well here.

You should do whatever is natural in your language to emphasize this rebuke.

(RSV:) you: The Greek pronoun that the RSV translates as *you* is emphatic. It emphasizes the comparison with the crowd.

(RSV:) also: Greek word that the RSV here translates as *also* means “also,” “in addition,” “in the same way,” or “even.” The word also compares the disciples to the people in the crowd.

(RSV:) without understanding: The Greek word that the RSV translates as *without understanding* means “without insight, foolish.” Jesus implied here that the disciples should have understood what he meant. Jesus did not imply that the disciples were not intelligent. He implied that they were not using their intelligence to understand spiritual truth.

7:18b–19c

In the Greek, 18b–19c is one rhetorical question. The first part of the rhetorical question is a rebuke. In the last part, Jesus taught his disciples. The BSB has therefore divided 18b–19c into one question and two statements.

7:18b

“Do you not understand?”

- Don’t you understand what I said before,
- Certainly you know
- Understand this!

Do you not understand?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses a rebuke. Jesus rebuked his disciples because they still did not understand who he really was.

There are at least two ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the NIRV says:

Don't you see?

- As a statement. For example:

You still do not understand.

Use whichever form is most natural to express this rebuke in your language.

7:18c

Nothing that enters a man from the outside can defile him,

- that something that goes into a person from the outside does not defile him before God?
- that food that someone puts into his body cannot make that person unclean.
- Food that people eat does not cause God to consider them to be impure.

defile: The Greek word that the BSB translates as defile in this context refers to being impure and unfit in the sight of God. See the note in 7:15b.

Mark 7:19

Section 7:1–23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean

This section (7:1–23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1–5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God's law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6–13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God's sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person's inner being (7:14–23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1–20 and Luke 11:37–39.

7:19a

because it does not enter his heart, but it goes into the stomach

- For it does not go into his heart but into his stomach/belly,
- The food does not go into his heart/mind. It goes into his stomach,

because: The Greek word that the BSB translates as because introduces the explanation that Jesus gave the disciples. He explained the reason why food did not make people impure before God. In some languages, a conjunction is not necessary here.

it: The pronoun it refers to the thing/food “that enters a man from the outside” (in 7:18b).

does not enter his heart: In this context, the word heart refers figuratively to the mind, emotions, and will of a person. It refers to the part of a person that he uses to think, feel, and make decisions. In some languages people refer figuratively to this part of a person as his mind, throat, liver, or stomach. They are not referring literally to that physical part of the body. You should use the expression in your language that is natural to refer to this spiritual part of a person. See how you translated “hearts” in 7:6d.

but it goes into the stomach: The Greek word that the BSB translates as stomach is used literally to refer to the part of the body where food goes after it is swallowed. It includes not only the stomach but also the intestines.

If stomach refers to the spiritual part of a person in your language, you can use some other word that is part of the process of eating. For example:

his mouth

his intestines

7:19b

and then is eliminated.”

- and then it passes out of his body.”
- and then it goes into the toilet.”

and then is eliminated: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as is eliminated is literally “goes out into the latrine.” The BSB uses a euphemism here for the literal Greek words. (A euphemism is a figure of

speech that substitutes acceptable words for words that people do not want to use when they talk.)

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- As a euphemism. For example:

Then it goes out of the body. (NCV)

and is eliminated (NASB)

- Literally. For example:

and then into a toilet (GW)

and goes out into the sewer (NRSV)

Translate this idea in a way that is appropriate in your language.

General Comment on 7:19a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the information in 7:19a–b. For example:

For it goes into his stomach/belly, and then it is excreted. It does not go into his heart/mind.

7:19c

(Thus all foods are clean.)

- When he said this, Jesus was announcing that no food would make a person unclean.
- By saying this, Jesus meant that people could now consider all foods to be ritually clean/pure.

(Thus all foods are clean.): The BSB puts this sentence in parentheses to show that Mark made this comment, not Jesus. Mark was explaining what Jesus meant when he said the words in 7:19a–b. In some languages it may not be necessary to use parentheses. The CEV translates without parentheses and says:

By saying this, Jesus meant that all foods were fit to eat.

all foods are clean: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as all foods are clean is literally “cleansing all foods.” Mark wanted his readers to understand that Jesus’ parable meant that people could now regard all foods as ritually clean. They did not need to consider any food as ritually unclean.

clean: The Greek word that the BSB translates as clean has the figurative meaning of “ceremonially clean”

or “acceptable to use as food.” Here clean does not have a literal meaning. It is not the usual meaning of washing things to remove dirt from them.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

By saying this, Jesus declared all foods acceptable. (GW)

When Jesus said this, he meant that no longer was any food unclean for people to eat. (NCV)

Mark 7:20

Section 7:1–23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean

This section (7:1–23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1–5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God’s law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6–13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God’s sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person’s inner being (7:14–23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1–20 and Luke 11:37–39.

7:20a

He continued:

- He continued speaking:
- Then he said/added:

He continued: The Greek word that the BSB translates as He continued is literally “he was saying” (as in the NASB). This word indicates that Jesus continued to speak to his disciples.

7:20b

“What comes out of a man, that is what defiles him.

- “That which comes from within a person is really what causes him to be unclean to God.
- “It is the bad things that a person causes to come out from his heart/mind that defile him.
- “What people think, say, and do is what causes them to be impure/unfit before God.

What comes out of a man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as What comes out of a man refers to the words that people say and the actions that people do. These are the things that defile them. See the note on 7:15c.

If a literal translation of this phrase is not clear, it is possible to put the phrase “from the heart” in 7:21a here in 7:20. For example, the CEV says:

What comes from your heart

a man: Here, the phrase a man is used in a figurative sense to refer to “a person.” For example, the GW says:

a person

that is what defiles him: This is the same phrase as in 7:15a–b, and you should probably translate it in the same way.

Mark 7:21

Section 7:1–23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean

This section (7:1–23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1–5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God’s law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6–13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God’s sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going

into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person’s inner being (7:14–23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1–20 and Luke 11:37–39.

7:21a

For from within the hearts of men

- For a person’s heart/mind is the source of
- Here are some of the things that come from within people’s hearts/minds:

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For is a conjunction that introduces a phrase that explains 7:20. Some versions do not use a conjunction. For example, the CEV says:

Out of your heart come evil thoughts, vulgar deeds, stealing, murder

You should connect 7:20 with 7:21 in a natural way in your language that makes it clear that 7:21 explains 7:20.

from within the hearts of men: The phrase from within the hearts of men refers to the unseen, inner part of a person that thinks, feels and makes decisions. Some languages refer to this part of a person as the throat, stomach, or liver. Use the expression that is natural in your language for this idea. See how you translated “heart” in 7:19a.

Some translations express the idea with two phrases. For example, the NIV says:

from within, out of men’s hearts

men: Here, the word men is used in a figurative sense to refer to “people.” For example, the NLT says:

out of a person’s heart

7:21b

come evil thoughts, sexual immorality, theft, murder,

- harmful/wicked thoughts, immoral sexual behaviors, stealing, murdering,
- they think about doing what is wrong, they commit sexual sins, they steal, they kill,

come evil thoughts, sexual immorality, theft, murder: There are two ways to understand the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as evil thoughts here:

1. The term evil thoughts is a specific term. It is part of the list together with the next terms. They are all things that come out of the heart. For example, the RSV says:

come evil thoughts, fornication, theft, murder...
(BSB, RSV, NIV, NLT, NASB, GW, CEV, NET, REB, KJV, NCV, ESV)

1. The term evil thoughts is a general term. The next terms are specific examples of that generic term. The NJB indicates this with a colon:

that evil intentions emerge: fornication, theft, murder... (NJB, JBP, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). But if the major language version in your area follows interpretation (2), you may want to follow that.

evil thoughts: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as evil thoughts also means “evil ideas,” “evil reasonings,” or “evil plans.” For example, the NET says:

evil ideas

sexual immorality: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sexual immorality is a general term that refers to all sexual sin. Use the proper term or terms to cover the meaning of this Greek word.

theft: The Greek word that the BSB translates as theft refers to a person taking things that do not belong to him. Another word for theft is “stealing.”

murder: The Greek word that the BSB translates as murder literally means “kill” (as in the GNT). In this context, it refers to the illegal or unlawful ending of someone’s life. It does not refer to executing a criminal or killing an enemy soldier in battle.

7:21c

adultery,

- adultery,
- have sexual relations with someone who is not their husband or wife,

Some English versions place the term adultery in 7:22 instead of in 7:21. For example, the NET says:

evil ideas, sexual immorality, theft, murder,
²²adultery

You may want to follow what your major language version does here.

adultery: The Greek word that the BSB translates as adultery refers to a specific type of sexual sin. It refers to sexual relations between a man and a woman, when at least one of them is married to another person. If your language has an expression which refers to that behavior, you will want to use that term.

In some languages, there is one term that covers the meaning of both “adultery” and “sexual immorality.” If this is true in your language, use your term once in either 7:21b or 7:21c.

Mark 7:22**Section 7:1–23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean**

This section (7:1–23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1–5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God’s law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6–13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God’s sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person’s inner being (7:14–23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1–20 and Luke 11:37–39.

7:22a

greed, wickedness,

- wanting to get many things to satisfy their own desires, meanness/cruelty to others,
- they strongly desire more and more possessions, they do wicked/harmful things to others,

greed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as greed refers to “wanting more than one already has.” The word often has sexual connotations. It may also imply that one person takes advantage of another person in order to satisfy his own desires. Louw & Nida (page 758) define *pleonexiai* as “exploitation,” taking advantage of someone else out of greed. This is the sense in which the word is used in several other passages that refer to sexual greed. UBS (page 233), Cranfield (page 241) and Lane (page 257) all mention the connotations of sexual sin, and Hiebert (page 182) mentions self-gratification as a motive for the plural “acts of selfish grasping.” Most English versions translate this word as in the BSB. If your language has a word or expression that has more of the connotations of the Greek word, you should use it here.

wickedness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wickedness refers to “doing wicked deeds.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

evil actions (NCV)

meanness (CEV)

7:22b

deceit, debauchery,

- lying, improper and shameless sexual actions,
- they tell lies and trick people, they do sexual actions openly with no shame,

deceit: The Greek word that the BSB translates as deceit refers to “lying” and “tricking people.”

debauchery: The Greek word that the BSB translates as debauchery is a general term that refers to “improper sexual behavior that is done in front of people without shame.”

7:22c

envy, slander,

- envy, speaking evil about other people,
- they resent other people for having good things that they themselves want, they insult people before/to others,

envy: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates here as envy is literally “evil eye.” This is a Hebrew idiom that probably means here “envy” or “jealousy.” Several commentaries say that this idiom may refer to stinginess, the opposite of generosity (Wessel page 681, Guelich page 379, Gundry page 356, Lane page 257, France page 293). However, most of these commentaries also say that envy, jealousy or covetousness are alternate meanings. Hiebert (page 182), Cranfield (page 242) and UBS (page 233) all define the word as envy. Louw & Nida (page 760) give both meanings: “envy” for Mark 7:22 and “stingy” for Matthew 20:15. All versions have either envy or jealousy. It refers to a person feeling resentful because someone else has something that he wants. It does not refer to casting evil spells.

Other languages also have idioms to express the idea of envy or jealousy.

slander: The Greek word translated slander means to “speak evil about someone,” or to “speak insultingly about someone.”

7:22d

arrogance, and foolishness.

- pride, and moral foolishness.
- they think that they are better than everyone else, and they do what God considers foolish/senseless.

arrogance: The Greek word that the BSB translates as arrogance refers to a proud and arrogant attitude. An arrogant person considers himself to be better and more important than other people. Other words that express this idea in English are “pride” or “haughtiness.”

foolishness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as foolishness refers to doing things that are morally foolish or senseless. It does not refer here to being intellectually stupid. In some languages the idea of moral foolishness may need to be expressed in different ways. For example:

they show their lack of wisdom

acting foolishly in God’s sight

they do things without thinking about whether God approves of those actions

General Comment on 7:21–22

Different versions translate the words in this list in various ways. Use the versions to help you find an expression that makes the meaning clear in your language. Many languages will need to translate these nouns as verbal expressions. If you do this, you may also need to use more than one sentence. For example:

^{21b} They think about doing evil deeds, they do sexual acts that are immoral, they steal, and they murder other people. They marry and then have sex with someone to whom they are not married. ^{22a}They desire things that do not belong to them, they do harmful things to other people, ^{22b}and they trick other people. They do sexual sins without shame, ^{22c}they are envious, and they speak evil about other people. ^{22d}They think they are more important than everyone else, and they do foolish things.

Many languages use idioms, metaphors, or euphemisms to talk about some of these actions. Some languages may have one expression that covers two of these terms. Translate these words with expressions that are natural in your language.

Mark 7:23

Section 7:1–23: Jesus explained what makes a person unclean

This section (7:1–23) deals with the difference between ritual uncleanness and real moral uncleanness. Ritual uncleanness is external, but real uncleanness involves the inner being of a person. Mark introduced this topic by describing an incident in which the Pharisees and teachers of the law rebuked Jesus. They did this because his disciples ate without first performing the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish tradition (7:1–5).

Jesus did not respond to their rebuke directly. Instead, he gave an example of how these leaders ignored God's law in order to follow their own traditions (7:6–13). Jesus then explained to the crowd that true uncleanness in God's sight is not caused by external things. It is not caused by things such as food going into the body. True uncleanness is caused by sinful things that a person does or says. Those things come from a person's inner being (7:14–23).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ritual uncleanness is not what causes God to consider a person unclean

Jesus teaches about what defiles a person

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 15:1–20 and Luke 11:37–39.

7:23a

All these evils come from within,

- All these evil behaviors come from inside the mind/heart of a person
- All these evil thoughts, words, and actions that people do come from their mind/heart.

All these evils: The word evils refers to the list of evil things that people think, say, and do in 7:21–22.

within: The word within refers to the inner part of man. It has the same meaning here as the word “heart” in 7:21a. You may translate this with the same expression. For example, the CEV says:

All of these come from your heart

7:23b

and these are what defile a man.”

- and cause a person to be unacceptable to God.”
- These are what defile them.”

In some languages it may be more natural to start 7:23b with a new sentence. For example:

These things are what make a person unclean/defiled.

defile a man: Here are some other ways to translate defile a man:

cause a person to become unclean

make a man ‘unclean’ (NIV)

defile: This is the same word as in 7:15b and 7:20b. You should probably translate it in the same way.

a man: Here, the phrase a man refers to “a person.” It does not refer only to a male. For example, the GW says:

a person

Mark 7:24

Section 7:24–30: A Gentile woman begged Jesus to heal her daughter

In the previous section, Jesus explained what made people unclean. In this section, he expelled an evil spirit from the daughter of a Gentile woman. Jews thought that they became ritually unclean if they associated with a Gentile. So Jesus showed by his actions that this Jewish tradition about Gentiles was no longer valid.

Mark did not mention the disciples in this story or the following story. But we know from the parallel passage in Matthew that the disciples went with Jesus to Tyre.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Gentile woman had humble faith in Jesus

Jesus helped a woman who was not a Jew

A woman's faith

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 15:21–28.

7:24a

Jesus left that place and went to the region of Tyre.

- ¶ Jesus left that place and went/walked to the area near the city of Tyre.
- ¶ After that, Jesus and his disciples left there and went to the region around the city called Tyre.

The story in 7:24–30 began sometime after the story in 7:14–23 ended. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories. In some languages, it is natural to begin a story with a time word or phrase. If your language is like that, use an expression here that is not too specific. For example:

Then (GNT)

After that

In other languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this story in a natural way in your language.

Jesus left: The disciples were with Jesus in 7:23. Mark's next mention of the disciples is in 8:1. Mark does not say that the disciples accompanied Jesus on the trip to Tyre, but Matthew makes this information explicit. If it is confusing in your language to not mention the disciples here, you can say:

Jesus and his disciples left

that place: The words that place refer to the area near Lake Galilee where Jesus had been speaking to the crowds in 7:14–23.

went to: In many languages, a general phrase such as went to will be clear. If you need to make more information explicit in your language, you can say that Jesus walked northwest to go to the vicinity of Tyre.

region of Tyre: The region of Tyre means the area near the city called Tyre. The city called Tyre was on the coast of the Mediterranean Sea, northwest of Lake Galilee.

Tyre: There is a textual issue here. Some Greek manuscripts have "Tyre." Others have "Tyre and Sidon."

1. Some Greek manuscripts have Tyre. They do not have "and Sidon." For example, the NRSV says:

went away to the region of Tyre (BSB, NIV, GNT, CEV, NCV, NLT, NET, JBP, GW, NASB, NJB, NRSV, REB)

1. Other Greek manuscripts have Tyre and Sidon. For example, the RSV says:

went away to the region of Tyre and Sidon (RSV, KJV, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) as most English versions do. UBS4 (page 147) omits the words "and Sidon" and gives Tyre an A rating. See also Swanson (page 112).

7:24b

Not wanting anyone to know He was there, He entered a house,

- He went into a house and did not want anyone to know that he was staying there.
- When he/they arrived there, he/they found a house where he/they could stay. Jesus did not want anyone to know that he/they was staying there,

Not wanting anyone to know He was there: The word there refers to the specific house that Jesus entered.

He did not want anyone to know that he was staying there.

He entered a house: The phrase He entered a house contains implied information. It implies that Jesus arrived in the area, located a house belonging to someone there, and arranged for himself and his disciples to stay there. In some languages it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

where he stayed in someone's house (CEV)

He found a house to stay in (REB)

General Comment on 7:24b

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the information in this part of the verse. For example, the NIV says:

He entered a house and did not want anyone to know it

7:24c

but was unable to escape their notice.

- But he could not keep people from knowing where he was.
- but he could not stay hidden. (NCV)
- but they found out anyway. (CEV)

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but indicates that there is a contrast between 7:24b and 7:24c. Some other versions use the word “yet.” For example, the NIV says:

yet

You should show this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

was unable to escape their notice: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as was unable to escape their notice indicates that people outside of Israel also recognized Jesus, and he was not able to stay privately in a home.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he could not pass unrecognized (NJB)

he could not stay hidden (NCV)

they found out anyway (CEV)

Mark 7:25

Section 7:24–30: A Gentile woman begged Jesus to heal her daughter

In the previous section, Jesus explained what made people unclean. In this section, he expelled an evil spirit from the daughter of a Gentile woman. Jews thought that they became ritually unclean if they associated with a Gentile. So Jesus showed by his actions that this Jewish tradition about Gentiles was no longer valid.

Mark did not mention the disciples in this story or the following story. But we know from the parallel passage in Matthew that the disciples went with Jesus to Tyre.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Gentile woman had humble faith in Jesus

Jesus helped a woman who was not a Jew

A woman's faith

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 15:21–28.

7:25a

Instead, a woman whose little daughter had an unclean spirit

- A woman whose young daughter was under the power of an evil spirit,
- A certain woman had a female child who was controlled/possessed by a demon.

Instead: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Instead indicates a strong contrast. The contrast is between how Jesus wanted no one to know he was there and how the woman soon heard where he was.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

But (ESV)

In fact (NIV)

Other versions do not translate this conjunction. You should connect 7:25 to 7:24 in a way that is natural in your language.

a woman whose little daughter had an unclean spirit: Here, a new person is introduced into the story. Mark gives more information about her in 7:26a–b. You should introduce this new person in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

there was a woman there whose little daughter
had an unclean spirit. She...

See the General Comment on 7:25a–26b at the end of 7:26b for suggestions on how to do this by changing the order of the verse parts.

little daughter: The Greek word that the BSB translates as little daughter is a term of endearment. It implies that the woman loved her daughter very much. It does not imply that the daughter was not tall.

There is only one other place in the New Testament where this Greek word occurs. In that verse (Mark 5:23), it refers to Jairus' daughter, who was twelve years old.

If your language requires you to specify the approximate age of the girl, use a term that refers to an unmarried girl of the age of puberty or younger.

If your language does not use a specific word meaning “daughter,” you may use a descriptive term that uses the word “child.” For example:

her child who was a young-lady/female

In the following verses that use the word “daughter,” you may then be able to shorten this expression to “child.”

had an unclean spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as had an unclean spirit indicates that an evil spirit controlled the girl's thoughts and actions.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

controlled by an unclean spirit

had an evil spirit in her (NCV)

on whom an evil spirit had fastened

on whom an unclean spirit was riding

Use an expression that is natural in your language to refer to an unclean spirit controlling a person. See evil spirit in the Glossary for more information.

unclean spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as unclean spirit refers to a spirit that is evil and can control people's actions. The phrase unclean spirit refers to the same type of spirit as the Greek terms that are often translated as “demon” and “evil spirit.” In this context the evil spirit that possessed the girl is called a “demon” in 7:26c.

Here are some other ways to translate unclean spirit:

- Use a general term in your language that refers to spirits that are evil and can control people. If there is one word with this meaning, you may not need a separate word like “evil.” For example:

demon

- Use a specific term in your language that refers to a certain type of spirit. This spirit should be able to do what is described in this context. Do not use a term that refers to the spirit of a dead person.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

an evil/bad spirit

an unclean spirit Be sure that an expression like “unclean spirit” does not imply that the spirit is literally dirty.

See evil spirit in the Glossary for more information.

7:25b

soon heard about Jesus,

- as soon as she heard the talk about him being there,
- This woman heard that he was there.

soon heard about Jesus The phrase soon heard about Jesus contains implied information. It implies that the woman learned that Jesus was in the area. In some languages it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

heard that he was there (EASY)

heard where Jesus was (CEV)

7:25c

and she came and fell at His feet.

- came to him and bowed down at his feet.

- She immediately came to Jesus and knelt face down in front of him to show her respect.

fell at His feet: The phrase fell at His feet means that the woman humbly got on her knees in front of Jesus and lowered her face to the ground. Bowing down like this was a way to show respect and honor to someone of high position.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

knelt down (CEV)

bowed down (GW)

This word does not indicate that the woman stumbled or tripped and then fell down.

See how you translated the similar expressions in 5:22b and 5:33b.

Mark 7:26

Section 7:24–30: A Gentile woman begged Jesus to heal her daughter

In the previous section, Jesus explained what made people unclean. In this section, he expelled an evil spirit from the daughter of a Gentile woman. Jews thought that they became ritually unclean if they associated with a Gentile. So Jesus showed by his actions that this Jewish tradition about Gentiles was no longer valid.

Mark did not mention the disciples in this story or the following story. But we know from the parallel passage in Matthew that the disciples went with Jesus to Tyre.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Gentile woman had humble faith in Jesus

Jesus helped a woman who was not a Jew

A woman's faith

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 15:21–28.

7:26a

Now she was a Greek woman

- The woman was a Gentile
- The woman was not a Jew.

she was a Greek woman: The word that the BSB literally translates as Greek indicates that the woman was a Gentile (as in the RSV), not a Jew. This word normally refers to someone who spoke the Greek language and was of Greek culture. It does not necessarily indicate that the person was from Greece. This woman was not from Greece, as 7:26b indicates.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

- As the specific term Greek. For example, the CEV says:

The woman was Greek

- As the generic term Gentile. For example, the NLT says:

she was a Gentile

- As the term non-Jew.

she was a non-Jew

7:26b

of Syrophenician origin,

- who was born in the Phoenicia area of the province of Syria.
- She was born in the province of Syria in the region/area called Phoenicia.

of Syrophenician origin: The word Syrophenician refers to a part of the province of Syria called Phoenicia. This was where the city of Tyre was located. For example, the CEV says:

born in the part of Syria known as Phoenicia

General Comment on 7:25a–26b

In some languages it may be necessary for all background information to be ordered first in the story. For example:

^{26a}There was a certain Gentile woman there ^{26b}who had been born in Syrian Phoenicia. ^{25a}She had a daughter who was possessed by an evil spirit. ^{25b}As soon as the woman heard about Jesus, ^{25c}she immediately came to him and fell at his feet.

7:26c

and she kept asking Jesus to drive the demon out of her daughter.

- She begged Jesus to cause/force the demon to leave her daughter.
- She repeatedly asked Jesus to send/exorcise the demon out of her child/daughter.

she kept asking: The form of the Greek word that the BSB translates as she kept asking indicates that the woman asked again and again. She did not only ask once. She repeatedly asked Jesus to cause the demon to leave.

drive the demon out: The Greek word that the BSB translates as drive...out is literally “cast/throw out.” To drive...out demons means to cause evil spirits to stop controlling a person. See the notes at 1:34b and 6:13a for translation suggestions.

demon: The Greek word that the BSB transliterates as demon refers to the same being as the term “unclean spirit” in 7:25a. You may need to use the same term in this context as you used there. See evil spirit in the Glossary.

Mark 7:27

Section 7:24–30: A Gentile woman begged Jesus to heal her daughter

In the previous section, Jesus explained what made people unclean. In this section, he expelled an evil spirit from the daughter of a Gentile woman. Jews thought that they became ritually unclean if they associated with a Gentile. So Jesus showed by his actions that this Jewish tradition about Gentiles was no longer valid.

Mark did not mention the disciples in this story or the following story. But we know from the parallel passage in Matthew that the disciples went with Jesus to Tyre.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Gentile woman had humble faith in Jesus

Jesus helped a woman who was not a Jew

A woman's faith

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 15:21–28.

7:27a–b

In these verses Jesus replied to the Gentile woman with a parable. You can translate this figurative language in several ways:

- Maintain the figurative language. For example, the NCV says:

It is not right to take the children's bread and give it to the dogs. First let the children eat all they want.

- Maintain the figurative language and make the meaning clear. For example:

First I should help my own family, the Jews. It isn't right to take food from the children and throw it to the dogs. (NLT96)

First allow me to give my own people, the Jews, what they need. Otherwise, it is like taking bread from children and throwing it to dogs.

- Make the figure clear without using figurative language.

I should help the people of Israel first before the people of other nations.

If possible, you should keep the figurative language and follow one of the first two examples. In some languages it may be helpful to introduce Jesus' words by indicating that he answered in a figurative way. For example:

Jesus answered with an illustration/parable

7:27a

“First let the children have their fill,” He said.

- He told her, “First, allow the children to eat all that they want to eat,
- Jesus told her, “First allow me to feed the children, the people of my own nation as much as they want.
- Jesus told her to let him first feed the children of his own family, the Jews as much as they wanted,

First: The Greek word that the BSB translates as First in this context means “first in time.” It indicates “The first thing to do is...”

let: The Greek word that the BSB translates as let means “allow.” The verb form is second person singular. It is worded as a request to the woman with the implied subject “you.” It indicates that she should allow the children (Jews) to be satisfied first before Jesus granted her own request. In some languages it

may be more natural to phrase this request in another way. For example:

First, allow the children to eat...

Let us first feed the children. (GNT)

children: The word children is used here in a figurative way to refer to the people of Israel, the Jews. Jesus was a Jew. This word does not refer only to literal children.

have their fill: Another way to say have their fill is “eat until they are satisfied.”

He said: In Greek, the phrase that the BSB translates as He said comes at the beginning of 7:27a. The BSB has changed the order. You should place this phrase where it is most natural in your language.

7:27b

“For it is not right to take the children’s bread and toss it to the dogs.”

- because it is not proper/appropriate to take the children’s bread/food and toss it to dogs.”
- It is not good/proper that I should take their food away from them and throw it to the foreign/Gentile dogs.”
- because it would not be proper to take the children’s bread and toss it to dogs.

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For introduces the reason that Jesus gave for not healing the woman’s daughter immediately. He at first refused because it is not right to give the children’s food to dogs.

Many versions do not translate the word For. For example, the GW says:

First, let the children eat all they want. It’s not right to take the children’s food and throw it to the dogs.

You should indicate this reason in a way that is natural in your language.

it is not right: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as not right literally means “not good,” or “not proper.” It does not mean that it is sinful or morally wrong.

children’s bread: The figurative expression that the BSB translates as children’s bread refers to things that will benefit the people of Israel. In this context it refers

specifically to the help that Jesus gave to people by healing them.

bread: Bread was the main food of the people who lived in that area at the time of Jesus. Here the word bread is used in a figurative sense to refer to all food. If the people in your area do not commonly eat bread, it may be natural to follow the GW:

It’s not right to take the children’s food

and toss it to the dogs: The Greek word that the BSB translates as dogs is used figuratively to refer to people who were not Jewish. When Jewish people referred to someone as a dog, they were insulting him.

General Comment on 7:27a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of 7:27a and 7:27b. For example:

^{27b}It is not right to take the children’s bread and toss it to the dogs. ^{27a}That is the reason why I ask you to first let the children eat all they want.

Mark 7:28

Section 7:24–30: A Gentile woman begged Jesus to heal her daughter

In the previous section, Jesus explained what made people unclean. In this section, he expelled an evil spirit from the daughter of a Gentile woman. Jews thought that they became ritually unclean if they associated with a Gentile. So Jesus showed by his actions that this Jewish tradition about Gentiles was no longer valid.

Mark did not mention the disciples in this story or the following story. But we know from the parallel passage in Matthew that the disciples went with Jesus to Tyre.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Gentile woman had humble faith in Jesus

Jesus helped a woman who was not a Jew

A woman’s faith

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 15:21–28.

7:28a

“Yes, Lord,” she replied,

- She replied, “Yes, Lord,
- She answered him, “I understand/agree, Lord,

Yes, Lord: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have “Yes” before “Lord.” For example, the RSV says:

Yes, Lord (BSB, NIV, RSV, NCV, NLT, NET, JBP, KJV, NASB, NJB, ESV)

1. Other Greek manuscripts have only “Lord” or “sir.” For example, the GNT says:

Sir (GNT, CEV, GW, NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1).

Yes: The word Yes indicates that the woman understood what Jesus meant. She agreed with Jesus.

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “master,” or “one who has authority over others.” People used this word as a polite title when they spoke to an elder or someone in authority. However, the Jews also used this same title to refer to God. The Gentile woman may have been using it in a similar way to address Jesus as a person who had authority from God. Use a term in your language that could be used in a similar way.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Master

Chief

Owner

Sovereign

In some languages it may be necessary to add a word like “my” before such an address. For example:

my Chief/Sovereign

See Lord, Context 3, in the Glossary.

she replied: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as she replied is literally “she answered and said to him” (as in the NASB). In Greek, this phrase comes before “Yes, Lord.” You should place this phrase where it is most natural in your language.

7:28b

“even the dogs under the table eat the children’s crumbs.”

- but even dogs under the table eat the scraps/crumbs that the children drop.”
- even the dogs eat the crumbs that the children drop from the table.”

even the dogs: The Greek word that the BSB translates as even is used to emphasize that those who were not children were allowed to eat some of the children’s food.

under the table: In some languages, it may not be natural to say explicitly that the dogs are under the table. This information may be understood without being stated. If that is the case in your language, you may leave this phrase implied.

children’s crumbs: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as children’s crumbs literally indicates the small pieces of food that fall down while children are eating.

Here are some other ways to translate children’s crumbs:

the children’s leftovers (GNT)

some of the children’s scraps (GW)

crumbs that children drop from the table (CEV)

crumbs from the children’s plates (NLT96)

Mark 7:29

Section 7:24–30: A Gentile woman begged Jesus to heal her daughter

In the previous section, Jesus explained what made people unclean. In this section, he expelled an evil spirit from the daughter of a Gentile woman. Jews thought that they became ritually unclean if they associated with a Gentile. So Jesus showed by his actions that this Jewish tradition about Gentiles was no longer valid.

Mark did not mention the disciples in this story or the following story. But we know from the parallel passage in Matthew that the disciples went with Jesus to Tyre.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Gentile woman had humble faith in Jesus

Jesus helped a woman who was not a Jew

A woman's faith

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 15:21–28.

7:29a

Then Jesus told her, “Because of this answer, you may go.

- Then he told her, “Because of your answer, you may go home.
- Then Jesus told her, “On account of your good answer, you may go home in peace.
- Jesus said, “You have spoken well! Go home now.

Then Jesus told her: Jesus replied to the woman.

Because of this answer: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Because of this answer means “on account of” or “for the sake of” your answer.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

And because you have answered so well (NLT96)

Because of your answer (NCV)

That's true! (CEV)

you may go: The words you may go indicate that Jesus was giving the woman permission to leave. He was implying that he was giving her what she was asking for. He was not rebuking her. In some languages it may be necessary to make this more explicit. For example:

you may go in peace

you may go home satisfied/relieved

7:29b

The demon has left your daughter.”

- The demon has gone out of your daughter.”
- I have already caused the evil spirit to leave your daughter.”

The demon: The words The demon refer to the evil spirit that controlled the woman's daughter. See how you translated the word demon in 7:26c. See also evil spirit in the Glossary.

has left: The Greek word that the BSB translates as has left indicates that the demon had already stopped controlling the woman's daughter. Here it implies that Jesus caused the demon to leave her, and she was no longer troubled by the demon. This is the same Greek word as the word that the BSB translates as “came out” in 1:26b.

Mark 7:30

Section 7:24–30: A Gentile woman begged Jesus to heal her daughter

In the previous section, Jesus explained what made people unclean. In this section, he expelled an evil spirit from the daughter of a Gentile woman. Jews thought that they became ritually unclean if they associated with a Gentile. So Jesus showed by his actions that this Jewish tradition about Gentiles was no longer valid.

Mark did not mention the disciples in this story or the following story. But we know from the parallel passage in Matthew that the disciples went with Jesus to Tyre.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Gentile woman had humble faith in Jesus

Jesus helped a woman who was not a Jew

A woman's faith

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 15:21–28.

7:30a

And she went home

- Then she went home
- So, the woman left Jesus and went home.

And: The Greek word that the BSB translates as And introduces what happened next as a result of the events of the previous verses. Some English versions leave this connection implied. In some languages it may be natural to indicate the connection in some way. Use a natural way in your language to express a concluding event that is the result of previous actions in the story. For example, the NIRV says:

So she went home

7:30b and found her child lying on the bed,

- and found/saw her child resting and lying on the bed,
- She found/saw her child/daughter lying peacefully on her bed.

7:30c and the demon was gone.

- and the demon was gone.
- Jesus had caused the evil spirit to go out of her.
- She realized that the demon had left/released her daughter.

7:30b–c found: The Greek word that the BSB translates as found indicates that the woman saw her daughter. This word does not imply that the woman's daughter was lost.

lying on the bed: The phrase lying on the bed indicates that the daughter was resting. She was lying peacefully on the bed. She was no longer suffering from the demon. This phrase does not imply that the daughter was still sick. If this is not clear in your language, you may have to say:

resting and lying on the bed

lying peacefully on the bed

Mark 7:31

Section 7:31–37: Jesus healed a man who could not hear or talk

In the previous section, Jesus helped a Gentile woman. In this section, he traveled to another Gentile area, called the Decapolis, where he had been before (5:1–20). As soon as he entered the area, some people asked him to heal a man who was unable to hear or talk.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other headings for this section:

The healing of a man who could not hear or talk

Jesus healed a man who was deaf and had a speech defect

Jesus heals a man who was deaf and could not speak clearly

There are no direct parallel passages for this section. Some similar terms are used in Matthew 15:29–31.

7:31

This verse describes the route that Jesus took from the region of Tyre to the Sea of Galilee and the Decapolis. This trip is also mentioned in Matthew 15:21.

The exact route is not clear. There is a textual issue in this verse: (1) Some Greek manuscripts indicate that Jesus left Tyre and went through Sidon to the Sea of Galilee.” (UBS4 page 148, Swanson page 115. Most English versions also follow this option: BSB, NIV, GNT, NCV, NLT, NET, JBP, GW, NASB, NJB, NRSV, REB.) (2) Other Greek manuscripts indicate that Jesus left both Tyre and Sidon and went to the Sea of Galilee.” This is a more general description. (The KJV follows this option.) It is recommended that you follow option (1), since it is supported by some of the oldest and most reliable manuscripts. See the note on 7:31c.

7:31a

Then Jesus left the region of Tyre

- ¶ Then Jesus left the region of Tyre.
- ¶ After this, Jesus and his disciples left the area around the city of Tyre.

Then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Then introduces the next story. Use a natural way in your language to begin this new section.

Jesus: It is implied that Jesus' disciples were traveling with him. In some languages people might assume that because the disciples are not mentioned in this verse, they were not with Jesus. If that is true in your language, you may want to make it explicit that Jesus' disciples were with him. For example:

Jesus and his disciples

See how you translated the similar situations in 5:2a and 5:21a.

left: The Greek word that the BSB translates as left means “went out, left.” Because Jesus had been to the Sea of Galilee in the Decapolis previously (see 5:1–20), some English versions use a phrase such as “returned from” (RSV). However, he went to Sidon before returning to the Sea of Galilee, so it may be better to use “left” rather than “returned.”

the region of Tyre: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the region of refers here to the “territory” or “area” of Tyre. The same Greek phrase is used in 7:31c, where the BSB translates it as “the region of.”

Here are some other ways to translate the region of Tyre:

the area around Tyre (NCV)

the region around Tyre (CEV)

See also the note on 7:31a.

Tyre: Tyre was the name of a non-Jewish city. It was north of the country of Israel on the shore of the Mediterranean Sea.

7:31b

and went through Sidon

- He walked through the region of Sidon
- He/They traveled through the region of Sidon.

and went through Sidon: After Jesus and his disciples left Tyre, they went north and traveled through the region of Sidon. Sidon was in the opposite direction from Galilee. Be careful not to translate this phrase in a way that implies that Jesus went straight to Galilee through Sidon.

Sidon: The word Sidon here probably refers to the region that surrounded the city of Sidon.

7:31c

to the Sea of Galilee and into the region of the Decapolis.

- and then went through the area called Decapolis to Lake Galilee.
- Then he/they went through the area around the Ten Towns until he/they arrived at Lake Galilee.

to the Sea of Galilee and into the region of the Decapolis: The Greek phrases that the BSB translates as to the Sea of Galilee and into the region of the Decapolis are literally “to the Sea of Galilee in the midst of (or: through) the regions of Decapolis.” The Greek preposition usually means “in the midst of” or “between,” but it can also mean “through” (BAGD page 507, μέσος #2). Since Lake Galilee is at the far northwestern edge of the Decapolis region, not in the middle of it, most scholars (TRT, page 94) have taken it to mean “through” or “by way of.” These phrases have been interpreted in several ways:

1. Jesus went through the region of Decapolis on his way to the Sea of Galilee. He may have circled around through the Decapolis and approached the lake on its southeastern side. This view is supported by the UBS (page 240), Hiebert (page 187), France (pages 301–302), Lane (page 265) and Wessel (page 683). The NIV Study Bible (page 1506) also provides a map with his route. However, a map in the NASB indicates a route straight south from Sidon, then around through the Decapolis from the west, ending up on the eastern side of the lake. It is

impossible to know with certainty what route Jesus actually took. For example, the GNT has:

to Lake Galilee, going by way of the territory of the Ten Towns (NJB, GNT, CEV, GW)

1. Jesus went to a part of the Sea of Galilee that was in the region of the Decapolis. The route he took is ambiguous. For example, the REB has:

to the Sea of Galilee, well within the territory of the Decapolis (RSV, REB, NCV)

1. Jesus went to the Sea of Galilee and then continued into the region of Decapolis. He may have walked south along the shore of Lake Galilee until he reached the region of Decapolis. For example, the NLT has:

to the Sea of Galilee and the region of the Ten Towns (BSB, NIV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow either interpretation (1) or (2). The Display follows interpretation (1).

to the Sea of Galilee: The phrase the Sea of Galilee refers to a large lake with fresh water. The GNT and the CEV have:

Lake Galilee

See how you translated this expression in 1:16a.

the region of: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the region of is the same expression that it translated as “the region of” in 7:31a. Translate it in a natural way in your language.

the Decapolis: The Greek word that the BSB transliterates as Decapolis literally means “ten cities.” This word refers to a group of ten non-Jewish cities. See how you translated this word in 5:20b.

Mark 7:32

Section 7:31–37: Jesus healed a man who could not hear or talk

In the previous section, Jesus helped a Gentile woman. In this section, he traveled to another Gentile area, called the Decapolis, where he had been before (5:1–20). As soon as he entered the area, some people asked him to heal a man who was unable to hear or talk.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other headings for this section:

The healing of a man who could not hear or talk

Jesus healed a man who was deaf and had a speech defect

Jesus heals a man who was deaf and could not speak clearly

There are no direct parallel passages for this section. Some similar terms are used in Matthew 15:29-31.

7:32a-c

In this verse some people brought to Jesus a man who was deaf and had a speech defect. The Greek text does not specify the cause of these disabilities, but they were probably caused by disease or injury. Lane, page 266. Your translation should not imply that the man was demon-possessed.

7:32a

Some people brought to Him a man who was deaf

- After he arrived there, some people brought to him a man who was deaf
- While he/Jesus was there, some people came to him with a man who could not hear

In Greek this verse begins with the common connector that is often translated as “and.” It introduces what happened after Jesus and his disciples arrived near the Sea of Galilee. Use a natural way in your language to connect 7:31 and 7:32. For example:

There (NIV)

While he was there (NCV)

Some people brought: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Some people brought is literally “they brought.” In 7:33, these people are referred to as “a crowd.” In some languages it may be more natural to use the same term here. Use a term that is natural in your language to introduce this group of people.

to Him: The pronoun Him refers to Jesus.

a man who was deaf: The word deaf means “unable to hear.”

7:32b

and hardly able to speak,

- and had a speech defect.
- and could not talk clearly.

and hardly able to speak: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hardly able to speak literally means “to speak with difficulty.” It indicates here that the man was unable to speak clearly. He was probably not completely mute, but other people could not understand his speech easily. There are two interpretations: (1) He had a speech impediment; (2) He could not speak intelligibly. Many commentaries support each view, but all the English versions on TW support (1).

Here are some other ways to translate this:

could not talk plainly (NCV)

had difficulty speaking (NET)

had a speech defect (GW)

General Comment on 7:32a-b

The deaf man is in focus in this story. Because of this, it may be more natural to introduce him before you introduce the people who brought him. For example:

A certain man was there. He was deaf and could hardly speak. Some people brought him to Jesus.

A man who was deaf and could hardly talk was brought by some people to Jesus.

7:32c

and they begged Jesus to place His hand on him.

- They pleaded with Jesus to lay his hand on the man so that he would be healed.
- They earnestly asked Jesus to touch the man to heal him.
- And they begged him saying, “Touch this man and heal him.”

they: The pronoun they refers to the same people who brought the man to Jesus.

begged: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as begged indicates that the people made an earnest request.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

earnestly asked

pleaded

Refer to how you translated this same word in 5:10. The same verb *parakaleō* is also used in 5:17–18 and 5:23a, but in the latter verse an intensifying word is added.

Jesus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Jesus is literally “him,” as in the RSV. The BSB uses the word Jesus so that it is clear that the people are speaking with Jesus, not with the deaf man. Refer to Jesus in a way that is natural in your language.

to place His hand on him: The people asked Jesus to place His hand on him in order to heal the man. If the purpose of their request is not clear in your language, it may be necessary to make this information explicit. For example, the NLT says:

to lay his hands on the man to heal him

place His hand: The text does not say where Jesus should place His hand. In some languages it may be more natural to use a general expression. For example, the CEV says:

to touch him

Mark 7:33

Section 7:31–37: Jesus healed a man who could not hear or talk

In the previous section, Jesus helped a Gentile woman. In this section, he traveled to another Gentile area, called the Decapolis, where he had been before (5:1–20). As soon as he entered the area, some people asked him to heal a man who was unable to hear or talk.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other headings for this section:

The healing of a man who could not hear or talk

Jesus healed a man who was deaf and had a speech defect

Jesus heals a man who was deaf and could not speak clearly

There are no direct parallel passages for this section. Some similar terms are used in Matthew 15:29–31.

7:33a

So Jesus took him aside privately, away from the crowd,

- So Jesus took the man off alone, away from the others.
- Jesus led the man a short distance away so that he could heal him privately.

So: The word So in the BSB introduces what Jesus did first as a result of the crowd’s request. Other English versions use the connector “And” to introduce this result. Other translations do not use any connector. Use a natural way in your language to introduce this event.

took him aside privately, away from the crowd: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as took him aside privately, away from the crowd is literally “took him aside from the crowd off alone.” Notice that the Greek uses three expressions to emphasize that Jesus wanted to be alone with the man:

1. took him aside,
2. from the crowd,
3. off alone.

Some English versions also use three expressions. For example:

taking him aside from the multitude privately
(RSV)

took him away from the crowd to be alone with him
(GW)

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine these three expressions into two. For example, the NIV says:

took him aside, away from the crowd

crowd: This crowd refers to the same group of people who brought the man to Jesus.

7:33b–34

These verses describe the actions that Jesus did as he healed the man. In some languages there are special ways to describe procedures like this. For example, special connectors like “next” or special verb forms may be used. Use natural ways in your language to tell about these actions.

7:33b

and put His fingers into the man’s ears.

- Then he put his fingers into the man’s ears.
- Then Jesus stuck his fingertips into the man’s ear holes.
- He touched the openings of the man’s ears with his fingertips.

This part of the verse tells the first action that Jesus did as he healed the man. In some languages it may be helpful to use a connector to introduce this action.

put His fingers into the man's ears: This phrase probably indicates that Jesus used his fingertips to touch the openings of the man's ears.

7:33c

Then He spit and touched the man's tongue.

- Next, he spit on one of his fingers and touched the man's tongue.
- Then he put his saliva on his finger and touched the man's tongue with it.

Then: The word Then introduces the second action that Jesus did as he healed the man. In some languages there may be a special connector to use here, but in other languages a connector may not be needed. Do what is natural in your language.

He spit: It is not clear from the text where Jesus spit. Scholars suggest two possibilities:

1. Jesus spit on his own finger or fingers. For example, the NLT96 says:

Then, spitting onto his own fingers

1. Jesus spit on the ground.

Most English versions do not specify where Jesus spit. However, if it is important in your language to indicate a location, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation has more support in the commentaries. The word "fingers" was the direct object in the previous clause, so many commentators assume "fingers" to be the implied direct object in this clause.

and touched the man's tongue: Jesus probably used his own spittle to touch the man's tongue. In some languages it may be necessary to make this information explicit. For example:

he touched the man's tongue with his own spittle

General Comment on 7:33b–c

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate that Jesus used the same finger that he spit on to touch the man's tongue. For example:

Jesus spit on his own finger and used it to touch the man's tongue.

Mark 7:34

Section 7:31–37: Jesus healed a man who could not hear or talk

In the previous section, Jesus helped a Gentile woman. In this section, he traveled to another Gentile area, called the Decapolis, where he had been before (5:1–20). As soon as he entered the area, some people asked him to heal a man who was unable to hear or talk.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other headings for this section:

The healing of a man who could not hear or talk

Jesus healed a man who was deaf and had a speech defect

Jesus heals a man who was deaf and could not speak clearly

There are no direct parallel passages for this section. Some similar terms are used in Matthew 15:29–31.

7:34a

And looking up to heaven,

- Next, Jesus looked up to heaven
- And Jesus looked toward heaven.

And looking up to heaven: The Greek word that the BSB translates as heaven here refers to the sky as a symbol of God's dwelling place. Since Jesus literally looked upward at the sky, you could translate the word heaven here with the usual word for sky. You do not have to use a special term that refers to the place where God lives.

7:34b

He sighed deeply and said to him, "Ephphatha!" (which means, "Be opened!").

- and sighed. He said to the man, "Ephphatha!" "Ephphatha" means, "Be^(sing) opened!"
- and groaned. He spoke to the man in the man's own language, saying "Efata!" meaning, "Ears, open^(dual/plur) up!"
- He gave a sigh, and commanded the man's ears to be healed. He said to him, "Efata!" which means, "Open!^(plur)"

sighed deeply: The phrase sighed deeply indicates the sympathy that Jesus felt as he healed the man. Your translation should not imply the use of magic. The GNT has:

gave a deep groan

said to him, “Ephphatha!”: The word Ephphatha was a word from the Aramaic language. It is not a magic word. Aramaic was probably the man’s native language. It is recommended that you transliterate this word, using the sounds of your language. For example:

Efata!

You might want to include background information about Aramaic in a footnote: For example:

The word “Ephphatha” is Aramaic, a language widely spoken in the region of Palestine during the time of Jesus.

(which means, “Be opened!”): Mark uses the phrase (which means “Be opened!”) to provide the translation of Ephphatha to his readers. The BSB has used parentheses here. Other English versions do not use parentheses. It is probably not necessary to use parentheses in your translation.

Be opened: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Be opened is an idiom. It implies that Jesus was commanding the man’s ears or his hearing to begin to function properly. This command is in the singular form because it is directed to the man. In other languages it may be more natural to use a plural or dual form that is directed to the ears. Use a natural form of the verb in your language for this context.

Notice that the next verse parts, 7:35a and 7:35b, describe the results of Jesus’ command. The man’s ears were opened, that is, they were healed. His tongue was also loosened, though the verb Be opened does not seem to explicitly apply to the tongue.

In some languages people may not understand the meaning of the idiom Be opened. If that is true in your language, you may want to consider one of these options:

- Indicate the meaning of the idiom before you introduce the word “Ephphatha.” For example:

Jesus commanded the man’s ears to hear again. He said, “Ephphatha!” which means, “Open up!”

- Include a footnote to explain the meaning of the idiom Be opened. For example:

Here “Be opened” means “Hear!” or “Be healed!”

Because the word “Ephphatha” literally means “be opened,” do not substitute a word with a different meaning for the definition itself.

Mark 7:35

Section 7:31–37: Jesus healed a man who could not hear or talk

In the previous section, Jesus helped a Gentile woman. In this section, he traveled to another Gentile area, called the Decapolis, where he had been before (5:1–20). As soon as he entered the area, some people asked him to heal a man who was unable to hear or talk.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other headings for this section:

The healing of a man who could not hear or talk

Jesus healed a man who was deaf and had a speech defect

Jesus heals a man who was deaf and could not speak clearly

There are no direct parallel passages for this section. Some similar terms are used in Matthew 15:29–31.

7:35a

Immediately the man’s ears were opened

- Immediately, the man’s ears became well.
- Instantly the man was able to hear (NCV)

Immediately: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have a word that means “immediately.” It occurs before “the man’s ears were opened.” The NIV has:

At this... (BSB, NIV, GNT, CEV, NCV, NLT, NET, GW, KJV, NRSV, REB)

1. Other Greek manuscripts do not have this word that means “immediately.” (RSV, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), since it has the majority of manuscript support. UBS4 (pages 148–149), Swanson, page 116. Also, most English versions follow this option.

the man’s ears were opened: In this context the man’s ears were opened is an idiom. It means “the

man was able to hear.” Translate this phrase in a way that is natural for your language.

7:35b

and his tongue was released, and he began to speak plainly.

- He was also able to move his tongue freely and speak plainly.
- and to use his tongue so that he spoke clearly.

his tongue was released: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as his tongue was released is literally “the bond of his tongue was loosened.” This phrase is an idiom. It means that the man became able to speak clearly. Translate this idiom in a natural way in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

his speech defect was removed

he was able to move his tongue freely

and he began to speak plainly: The word and in the BSB introduces what happened when the man’s tongue was released. In some languages it may be more natural to express this event as a result. For example, the NCV has:

so that he spoke clearly

speak plainly: The phrase speak plainly contrasts with “could hardly talk” in 7:32. The man was completely healed. He could speak clearly so that those around him understood what he said.

Here are some other ways to translate speak plainly:

talk without any trouble (GNT)

speak clearly (NCV)

Mark 7:36

Section 7:31–37: Jesus healed a man who could not hear or talk

In the previous section, Jesus helped a Gentile woman. In this section, he traveled to another Gentile area, called the Decapolis, where he had been before (5:1–20). As soon as he entered the area, some people asked him to heal a man who was unable to hear or talk.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other headings for this section:

The healing of a man who could not hear or talk

Jesus healed a man who was deaf and had a speech defect

Jesus heals a man who was deaf and could not speak clearly

There are no direct parallel passages for this section. Some similar terms are used in Matthew 15:29–31.

7:36a

Jesus ordered them not to tell anyone.

- ¶ Then Jesus ordered the crowd not to tell anyone what had happened.
- ¶ And then Jesus told the people not to say anything about what he had done.
- ¶ Jesus said to the people, “Do not tell anyone what has happened.”

There is implied information at the beginning of this verse. In 7:33a Jesus took the man aside before he healed him. In 7:36a, Jesus and the man were with the people again. The Greek text introduces this verse with a connector that the GNT translates as “Then.” In some languages it may be necessary to use a phrase that includes the implied information. For example:

When Jesus and the man were with the people again

Jesus ordered: The Greek word that the BSB translates as ordered is the same word that the BSB has translated as “gave strict orders” in 5:43a.

them: The pronoun them refers to the same crowd who brought the man to Jesus (7:32–33).

not to tell anyone: Jesus was telling the crowd not to tell other people what he had just done. You may want to include this information as some English versions do. For example:

not to tell anyone about what happened (NCV)

not to say anything about what he had done (CEV)

not to speak of it to anyone (GNT)

General Comment on 7:36a

It may be more natural in your language to put Jesus' command into direct speech. For example:

Jesus commanded the crowd, "Do not say anything to others about what has happened."

7:36b**But the more He ordered them,**

- But as he repeatedly ordered them not to tell anyone,
- He told them again and again not to say anything about the miracle,

7:36c**the more widely they proclaimed it.**

- they repeatedly told others what he/Jesus had done.
- but the people talked about it to others even more.

7:36b–c

But: Here the Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *But* indicates contrast. In 7:36a Jesus told the crowd what they should not do. This part of the verse tells what happened instead. Express the contrast in a natural way in your language.

the more He ordered them: Jesus repeatedly told the crowd not to tell others about the miracle that they had just witnessed.

the more widely they proclaimed it: The people continued to tell others what had happened.

the more...the more:

Here are some other ways to translate the more...the more in 7:36b–c:

as he repeatedly ordered them...they repeatedly told others about it

he told them and told them...and they talked about it and talked about it

Mark 7:37**Section 7:31–37: Jesus healed a man who could not hear or talk**

In the previous section, Jesus helped a Gentile woman. In this section, he traveled to another Gentile area, called the Decapolis, where he had been before (5:1–20). As soon as he entered the area, some people asked him to heal a man who was unable to hear or talk.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other headings for this section:

The healing of a man who could not hear or talk

Jesus healed a man who was deaf and had a speech defect

Jesus heals a man who was deaf and could not speak clearly

There are no direct parallel passages for this section. Some similar terms are used in Matthew 15:29–31.

7:37a**The people were utterly astonished**

- The people were completely amazed.
- And everyone was totally astounded.

In Greek, 7:37 begins with the common conjunction that is often translated as "and," as in the GNT. Here it introduces the result of 7:36 and the conclusion of this section. The BSB and some other English versions do not use a connector. Do what is natural for your language in this context.

The people were utterly astonished: In this phrase the BSB has supplied the word *people*, which is not in the Greek text. It is not clear exactly which people were amazed. Here are the options:

1. the crowd of people who witnessed the miracle,
2. the people who heard about the miracle, (GNT)
3. both the crowd and those who later heard about it.

Option (c) is the most likely option, but all three are possible. Most English versions use a general expression like "they" or "people." If it is natural in your language, it is recommended that you also use a general term that could imply any of the options.

were utterly astonished: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *were utterly astonished* is literally "were amazed beyond measure."

Here are some other ways to translate *utterly astonished*:

completely amazed (GNT)

astonished beyond measure (RSV)

their admiration was unbounded (NJB)

This phrase utterly astonished is very similar to the phrase in 6:51. You may be able to translate in a similar way here.

7:37b

and said, “He has done all things well!”

- They said, “Jesus does all things well.
- They said to each other, “Wow! Everything that Jesus does is wonderful!
- They talked to each other about how Jesus did everything well,

He has done all things well: In this context the phrase all things refers to the other spectacular miracles that Jesus had done in the past and to the one that he had just done for the man who could not hear or speak.

well: The word well here describes the way in which Jesus performed miracles. The people were amazed at what he was able to do. It may be natural to show this amazement by using a more emphatic word than the English well. For example:

...terrific/brilliant way!

...wonderfully!

7:37c

He makes even the deaf hear and the mute speak!”

- He makes deaf people hear, and he makes people who cannot talk able to speak!”
- Even deaf people, he removes/heals their deafness, and people who are mute, he heals/removes their muteness.”
- even healing people who were deaf and people who could not speak.

He makes even the deaf hear and the mute speak:

This phrase indicates that Jesus healed people who were deaf and he also healed people who were mute. As a result, the deaf people could hear and the mute people could speak. The GNT translates this as:

He even causes the deaf to hear and the dumb to speak

He makes even: The Greek word that the BSB translates as even here connects 7:37b and 7:37c. There is implied information that is connected to the word even. It is:

In addition to the other spectacular things/miracles Jesus has done, he even makes...

Connect 7:37b and 7:37c in a way that is natural for your language.

the deaf...and the mute: These phrases probably refer to different groups of people, that is, those who could not hear and those who could not speak. There is a textual difference here. (1) The UBS4 (page 149) and Majority texts have an article before the words translated as “deaf” and “dumb.” With this reading, the phrase refers to two groups of people. (2) Other manuscripts omit the article. With this reading, the phrase refers to one group of people, those who are both deaf and dumb. It is recommended that you follow textual option (1), along with most English versions.

the mute: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as mute is not the same word that was used in 7:32b. The word that was used there indicates a speech defect. The word used here means “unable to speak.”

General Comment on 7:37a–c

In this section Jesus fulfilled the prophecy in Isaiah 35:5–6. You may want to include a cross reference to these verses in your translation.

Mark 8:1

Section 8:1–10: Jesus did a miracle to feed four thousand people

In the previous section, Jesus healed a man who was deaf and could not speak clearly. People quickly spread the news about this miracle throughout the Decapolis area. As a result, many other people came to Jesus. Most of these people were probably Gentiles. They stayed with Jesus for three days. This section is about how Jesus felt compassion for them and miraculously fed them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Feeds Four Thousand People (GNT)

Jesus multiplied a small amount of food to feed four thousand people

Jesus fed four thousand people in a miraculous way

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 15:32–39.

8:1a

In those days the crowd once again became very large,

- ¶ About this time many people again gathered, so that there was a large crowd.
- ¶ Not long afterward, many people again came to Jesus.

In those days: The phrase In those days refers to the days soon after Jesus healed the man in 7:31–37. Jesus and his disciples were still in the area of the Decapolis.

Here are some other ways to translate In those days:

About this time (NLT)

Not long afterward (GNT)

Translate In those days in a way that connects this section to the previous event in 7:31–37. Your translation should not imply that Jesus fed the crowd on several days.

the crowd once again became very large: The words the crowd once again became very large indicate that large crowds had gathered around Jesus at other times. Examples are mentioned in 6:33–34 and 7:33.

8:1b

and they had nothing to eat.

- Because they had nothing to eat,
- They had no food to eat,

and they had nothing to eat: This clause gives the reason for Jesus' action in 8:1c. The BSB indicates this with the connector and. Use a natural way in your language to connect this reason with the result in 8:1c.

they had nothing to eat: The Greek text does not say why the crowd had nothing to eat. They may have brought food and eaten it all or they may not have brought any food with them. Your translation should allow for both possibilities.

8:1c

Jesus called the disciples to Him and said,

- Jesus called his disciples together and said to them,
- so Jesus called his followers together and told them,

Jesus called the disciples to Him and said: This phrase indicates that Jesus called his disciples together to talk to them. It does not imply that he called them to him from a distant place. The disciples

traveled with Jesus wherever he went. They were last mentioned in 7:17.

the disciples: The words the disciples refer to the special group of twelve men that Jesus had chosen to follow him (3:13–19).

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means “learners” who are in a relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Here are some other ways to translate disciples:

- Use a term that refers to people who learn from a teacher or an expert. It is helpful if the term also implies that the learners are often with their teacher. For example:

learners/students

apprentices Be careful not to use a term that would refer only to a student in a school or classroom.

- Use a term that refers to people who follow a teacher or leader by obeying his teaching. It is helpful if this term also implies learning from the teacher and actually following the teacher wherever he goes. For example:

followers

those who are committed/faithful (to a teacher/leader)

See how you translated this term at 2:15b and 7:17b. See disciple in the Glossary.

Mark 8:2

Section 8:1–10: Jesus did a miracle to feed four thousand people

In the previous section, Jesus healed a man who was deaf and could not speak clearly. People quickly spread the news about this miracle throughout the Decapolis area. As a result, many other people came to Jesus. Most of these people were probably Gentiles. They stayed with Jesus for three days. This section is about how Jesus felt compassion for them and miraculously fed them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Feeds Four Thousand People (GNT)

Jesus multiplied a small amount of food to feed four thousand people

Jesus fed four thousand people in a miraculous way

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 15:32–39.

8:2a

“I have compassion for this crowd,

- “I feel very sorry for these people,
- “I pity these people,
- “I care about this crowd.

I have compassion for this crowd: The Greek word that the BSB translates as have compassion means “have understanding and pity” or “feel sympathy.” A person with compassion wants to help. Jesus knew that the people would have difficulty returning home because of their hunger, so he felt sympathy and wanted to help them.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

I feel sorry for these people (GNT)

I sympathize with these people

You may have an idiomatic way to translate this term. The JBP has one example in English:

My heart goes out to this crowd

This same verb occurs in 6:34b.

this crowd: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as this crowd refers to the large crowd that was mentioned in 8:1a.

8:2b

because they have already been with Me three days

- because they have been here with me for three days,
- For it has been three days that they have been with me,

8:2c

and have nothing to eat.

- and they do not have anything to eat.
- and they have no food with them.

8:2b–c

In 8:2c Jesus told his disciples the reason that he felt compassion for the people: “they...have nothing to eat.” In 8:2b Jesus mentioned that they had been with him for three days. That fact was background information.

As you translate the connection between 8:2a and 8:2b, your translation should not imply that Jesus felt sorry for the people only because they had been with him for three days (8:2b). If a reason connector would imply this in your language, you may decide to use no connector, as the NIV does:

I have compassion for these people; they have already been with me three days and have nothing to eat.

See the General Comment on 8:2a–c at the end of this note for more information on how to translate the connections.

they have already been with Me three days and have nothing to eat: The Greek text does not say how long the people were without food. Some people may have been without food for the whole three days.

Others may have brought food with them but eaten it all. Since most English versions are vague about this, it is good to translate 8:2c in a general way. For example:

they don’t have anything to eat (CEV)

they have no food

General Comment on 8:2a–c

In some languages it may be necessary to change the order of these verse parts so that you can express the connections between the clauses in a natural way. Here are some ways to do this in English:

^{2b} Because these people have already been with me for three days ^{2c}and have nothing to eat, ^{2a}I feel very sorry for them.

^{2b}These people have already been with me for three days. ^{2c}They have nothing to eat, ^{2a}so I feel very sorry for them.

Notice that the reason or result connectors are underlined in the examples. Translate this verse in a way that is natural in your language.

Mark 8:3

Section 8:1–10: Jesus did a miracle to feed four thousand people

In the previous section, Jesus healed a man who was deaf and could not speak clearly. People quickly spread the news about this miracle throughout the Decapolis area. As a result, many other people came to Jesus. Most of these people were probably Gentiles. They stayed with Jesus for three days. This section is about how Jesus felt compassion for them and miraculously fed them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Feeds Four Thousand People (GNT)

Jesus multiplied a small amount of food to feed four thousand people

Jesus fed four thousand people in a miraculous way

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 15:32–39.

8:3–4

There is implied information that connects 8:3 and 8:4. In 8:3 Jesus implied that he wanted to feed the crowd before he sent them home. In 8:4 the disciples implied that they thought that it would be impossible to feed the crowd. In some languages it may be necessary to make this connection more explicit. For example, the GNT translates 8:3a as:

³If I send them home without feeding them...

In other languages it may be more natural to put the implied information after 8:3 or near the beginning of 8:4. For example:

^{3b-c}“If I send them home hungry, they will collapse on the way. Some have come a great distance. We should feed them.” ⁴His disciples answered, “Do you want us to feed them? Where could anyone...?”

8:3a

If I send them home hungry,

- If I send them back to their homes while they are still hungry,
- If I tell them to go home without feeding them,
- I do not want to dismiss them unless I feed them,

8:3b

they will faint along the way.

- they will faint along the road,
- they will become exhausted on their way home.
- because then they will faint before they reach their homes.

8:3a–b

If I send them home hungry, they will faint along the way: This clause expresses a situation that Jesus was thinking about. It was not something that would actually happen.

Here is another way to translate this:

I do not want to send them home hungry because then they might collapse

Languages often have special ways to express imagined situations like this. Use a natural way in your language.

send them home: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as send means to “send away, dismiss.” To send them home means “to tell them to return to their homes.” In some languages it may be natural to use a phrase like “cause them to go home.” Be careful not to imply that Jesus intended to force people to go to their homes.

they will faint: The Greek word that the BSB translates as faint means “to become weary, weak, exhausted.” It refers to being unable to complete the journey because of hunger.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

collapse (NIV)

become exhausted (GW)

along the way: The phrase along the way refers to the journey that the people would make in order to return to their homes.

8:3c

For some of them have come a great distance.”

- because some of them have traveled a great distance.”
- For some of them live far from here.”

For some of them have come a great distance:

Jesus was saying that some people in the crowd had traveled several hours or days from their homes to be with him. This statement implies that they would also have to travel a long distance in order to return to their homes.

General Comment on 8:3a–c

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the parts of this verse. For example:

^{3c}Some of these people have come from far places.

^{3a}If I send them home hungry, ^{3b}they will collapse on the way.

Mark 8:4

Section 8:1–10: Jesus did a miracle to feed four thousand people

In the previous section, Jesus healed a man who was deaf and could not speak clearly. People quickly spread the news about this miracle throughout the Decapolis area. As a result, many other people came to Jesus. Most of these people were probably Gentiles. They stayed with Jesus for three days. This section is about how Jesus felt compassion for them and miraculously fed them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Feeds Four Thousand People (GNT)

Jesus multiplied a small amount of food to feed four thousand people

Jesus fed four thousand people in a miraculous way

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 15:32–39.

8:4a

His disciples replied,

- And his disciples replied,
- But Jesus’ followers said,
- The disciples replied that

In Greek, 8:4 begins with a common conjunction that the RSV translates as “and.” In this context it introduces the disciples’ response to what Jesus had said. They objected to his implied suggestion that they needed to feed the people. In some languages it may be natural to use a conjunction like “but” to introduce it. Translate in a natural way in your language for this context.

His disciples replied: The word replied introduces the disciples’ response to what Jesus had just said. In some languages it may be more natural to use a different verb like “said.”

disciples: See the note on 8:1c.

8:4b

“Where in this desolate place could anyone find enough bread

- “But how could anyone find enough bread in this wilderness
- “No one will be able to find enough food here in this isolated place
- in that remote place no one would be able to find enough food

8:4c

to feed all these people?”

- to feed all of them?”
- to satisfy all of these people!”
- to satisfy so many people.

8:4b–c

Where in this desolate place could anyone find enough bread to feed all these people?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses an objection. The disciples implied that it would be impossible to find enough food in that remote place to feed that large crowd. There are at least two ways to translate this objection:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Where in this desert can anyone find enough food to feed all these people? (GNT)

Can anyone possibly find enough food in this wilderness to feed all these people?

How can anyone provide these people with bread in this remote place? (REB)

- As a statement. For example:

No one could ever find enough bread to feed all these people here in this uninhabited place!

It is impossible to find enough food in this remote place to feed all these people!

Use whichever form is most natural to express this sort of emphatic objection in your language.

in this desolate place: The Greek word that the BSB translates as desolate place indicates a place where few people lived. It was a place that was far from any town or village.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

in this remote place (NIV)

in this place where no one lives (GW)

in the wilderness (NLT)

This same word occurs in 6:35c. For more information, see the note on “wilderness” in 1:3a.

could anyone find enough bread: The Greek word that the BSB translates as bread is literally “loaves.” It refers to loaves of bread, the main food of the Jewish people. If the people for whom you are translating do not eat bread, you could use a general term here, such as “food.” For example, the CEV says:

Where can we find enough food to feed such a crowd?

However, you may need to use a more specific term in 8:6 and 8:9. See how you translated bread in 6:37.

to feed all these people: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to feed can also mean “to satisfy, fill.” This same word also occurs in 8:8a where it is translated as “satisfied.” Some other versions translate to feed as “to satisfy” Here in 8:4, as well. For example:

Where can someone get enough bread in this desolate place to satisfy these people? (NET)

How can one satisfy these people with bread here in the wilderness? (NKJV)

Consider translating to feed as “to satisfy” here if it would be natural in your language.

Mark 8:5

Section 8:1–10: Jesus did a miracle to feed four thousand people

In the previous section, Jesus healed a man who was deaf and could not speak clearly. People quickly spread the news about this miracle throughout the Decapolis area. As a result, many other people came to Jesus. Most of these people were probably Gentiles. They stayed with Jesus for three days. This section is about how Jesus felt compassion for them and miraculously fed them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Feeds Four Thousand People (GNT)

Jesus multiplied a small amount of food to feed four thousand people

Jesus fed four thousand people in a miraculous way

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 15:32–39.

8:5a

“How many loaves do you have?” Jesus asked.

- Jesus replied, “How many loaves of bread do you have?”
- Jesus replied, “How much food do you^(plur) have?”
- But Jesus replied by asking them how many loaves of bread they had,

Jesus did not answer the disciples’ objection. Instead, he asked them a specific question about how much food they had. In some languages it may be helpful to include a connector here to indicate that Jesus did not answer as the disciples expected him to. For example:

But Jesus asked them

See the note on “Jesus asked” at the end of the notes for this verse.

How many loaves do you have?: This is a real question, not a rhetorical question. Jesus wanted his disciples to find out how much bread they already had.

loaves: The word loaves is the same word in Greek as the word that the BSB translates as “bread” in 8:4b. It

refers to pieces or units of bread, probably cooked in a round shape like buns or rolls.

In Greek, the word is plural both here and in 8:4b. In English, there is not a plural form of “bread” that can be counted, so the BSB uses the word loaves here. If it is natural to say “breads” in your language, you can do that here. Otherwise, you may need to say something like:

How many loaves of bread do you have? (NLT96)

How much bread do you have? (GNT)

See how you translated “bread” and loaves in 6:37c and 6:38a.

Jesus asked: In the Greek text, Jesus asked comes before the question. The BSB places it after the quotation. Place it where it is natural in your language. See the General Comment on 8:5a–b for a suggestion about indirect speech.

8:5b

“Seven,” they replied.

- They answered, “Seven loaves of bread.”
- They said, “We^(excl) have seven rolls/pieces of bread.”
- and they told him that they had seven.

Seven: The BSB literally translates the one Greek word “seven” here. In some languages, it will be more natural to say “seven loaves of bread.” For example, the GNT says:

Seven loaves.

If you translated “loaves” in 8:5a with a general word for food, you will then need to use a specific word for bread here. Use a term that can be counted and divided. For example, the CEV says:

Seven small loaves of bread.

In some languages it may be more natural to express their answer as a complete sentence. For example:

We have seven loaves of bread.

they replied: The BSB places the words they replied after the disciples’ reply. In Greek these words come before the reply. Place them where it is natural in your language.

General Comment on 8:5a–b

It may be more natural in some languages to express Jesus’ question in indirect speech. For example, the CEV says:

Jesus asked them how much food they had.

In some languages it may also be more natural to express the disciples’ response in indirect speech. For example:

They told him that they had seven loaves of bread.

Mark 8:6

Section 8:1–10: Jesus did a miracle to feed four thousand people

In the previous section, Jesus healed a man who was deaf and could not speak clearly. People quickly spread the news about this miracle throughout the Decapolis area. As a result, many other people came to Jesus. Most of these people were probably Gentiles. They stayed with Jesus for three days. This section is about how Jesus felt compassion for them and miraculously fed them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Feeds Four Thousand People (GNT)

Jesus multiplied a small amount of food to feed four thousand people

Jesus fed four thousand people in a miraculous way

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 15:32–39.

Paragraph 8:6–10

In this paragraph, Jesus told the crowd to sit down. He said a prayer of thanksgiving for the bread and the fish. Then he asked the disciples to give the food to the people. Jesus performed a miracle by feeding four thousand people with seven loaves of bread and a few fish.

8:6a

And He instructed the crowd to sit down on the ground.

- ¶ Then he instructed the crowd to sit down on the ground.
- ¶ So Jesus directed the people to sit down.
- ¶ Jesus told the crowd, “Sit down on the ground,” and they sat down.

And: In Greek, 8:6 begins with a common conjunction that the BSB translates as And. Here it introduces what Jesus did next. Some other English versions do not translate this word.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

Then (NET)

So (NLT)

He instructed the crowd to sit down: The Greek word that the BSB translates as instructed is literally “gives orders.” It indicates that Jesus was giving instructions to the large crowd. Your translation of the word instructed should not suggest that Jesus was speaking harshly to the people.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

told the crowd to sit down (NIV11)

directed the crowd to sit down (NET)

In some languages it may be more natural to use a causative expression for this phrase. For example:

caused the people to sit down

to sit down: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sit down is literally to “recline.” Jewish people usually lay on one side when they ate. You may want to use the usual position that people use when they eat in your culture, as most English versions do.

on the ground: Jesus told the people to sit on the ground because he was about to give them food. Because they were in the wilderness, they had to sit on the ground. In some languages it may be unnecessary to specify that they sat on the ground, since it may be clear from the context. If that is true in your language, you may leave this phrase implicit. For example:

He told the people to sit down

8:6b

Then He took the seven loaves, gave thanks

- When Jesus had taken the seven loaves of bread, he gave thanks,
- After that, he took the seven rolls of bread from the disciples and thanked God for the bread.
- Then he took/held in his hands the seven loaves of bread, and said “thank you” to God.

8:6b–c

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then is literally “and.” It introduces the part of the verse that tells what Jesus did after the people sat down. Connect 8:6b–c to the previous event in a natural way in your language.

He took the seven loaves, gave thanks and broke them: In Greek, the actions in 8:6b, took the seven loaves and gave thanks, prepare for the main actions in 8:6c. In some languages it may be more natural to translate the actions in 8:6b as an independent sentence, as the BSB and many other versions do. For example, the CEV says:

...he took the seven loaves and blessed them. He then broke the loaves....

He took the seven loaves: The clause He took the seven loaves indicates that Jesus took the loaves from the disciples. Then he held them while he gave thanks for them.

the seven loaves: The phrase the seven loaves refers to the loaves that were mentioned in 8:5a. See how you translated loaves there.

gave thanks: Jesus thanked God for the bread that he had. In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit that Jesus thanked God. For example:

gave thanks to God (GNT)

thanked God for them (NLT)

See how you translated “spoke a blessing” in 6:41. The Greek word that is used there is not the same word as the one used here, but it has a similar meaning. See also bless, Meaning 4, in the Glossary.

8:6c

and broke them, and gave them to His disciples

- and then he divided the bread and gave the pieces to the disciples
- Then he tore/broke the bread into pieces and gave the pieces to his followers,
- He broke/divided the loaves of bread and gave them to his disciples, saying,

and broke them: The phrase and broke them means that Jesus tore the bread into pieces. The word them refers to the loaves of bread. The bread was like flat cakes that someone could easily break or tear into pieces. Use a term in your language that refers to dividing bread. For example:

and tore/divided the loaves in two

See how you translated broke in 6:41c.

and gave them to His disciples: Jesus gave the pieces of bread to his disciples so that they could feed the people.

8:6d

to set before the people. And they distributed them to the crowd.

- to distribute/serve to the people, and that is what they did.
- who distributed it/them to the people/crowd.
- “Give this bread to the people,” and the disciples distributed it to the people.

to set before the people. And they distributed them to the crowd: The phrase to set before the people implies that the disciples were to go out among the groups of people to give them the bread.

In some languages it may be more natural to combine the two phrases in this part of the verse. For example:

to serve to the people (GW)

who passed them out to the crowd (CEV)

who distributed the bread to the crowd (NLT)

Translate in a clear way that does not sound redundant or unnatural.

Mark 8:7

Section 8:1–10: Jesus did a miracle to feed four thousand people

In the previous section, Jesus healed a man who was deaf and could not speak clearly. People quickly spread the news about this miracle throughout the Decapolis area. As a result, many other people came to Jesus. Most of these people were probably Gentiles. They stayed with Jesus for three days. This section is about how Jesus felt compassion for them and miraculously fed them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Feeds Four Thousand People (GNT)

Jesus multiplied a small amount of food to feed four thousand people

Jesus fed four thousand people in a miraculous way

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 15:32–39.

Paragraph 8:6–10

In this paragraph, Jesus told the crowd to sit down. He said a prayer of thanksgiving for the bread and the fish. Then he asked the disciples to give the food to the people. Jesus performed a miracle by feeding four thousand people with seven loaves of bread and a few fish.

8:7a

They also had a few small fish,

- They also had a few small fish. (GNT)
- And there were also a few little dried/cooked fish.

They also had a few small fish: The word also indicates that the fish were another item of food that the disciples had, in addition to the loaves of bread mentioned in 8:6.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

They had a few small fish as well. (NIV)

And they had a few small fish (RSV)

fish: The word that the BSB translates as fish refers here to fresh-water fish that have been salted, dried or cooked so that they are ready to eat. See how you translated this word in 6:38c.

8:7b

and Jesus blessed them

- So Jesus also thanked God for these fish
- Jesus spoke to God again and said “thank you” for the fish.

and Jesus blessed them: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as blessed means “to give thanks.” If blessed does not have this meaning

in your language, then you should use an expression that has the meaning “give thanks,” as in 8:6b.

them: The pronoun them refers here to the fish. There is a textual issue in this verse: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have “having blessed them,” in which “them” refers to the fish (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, CEV, NCV, NLT, NET, GW, NASB, NRSV, REB, JBP). (2) Other Greek manuscripts have “having blessed,” without including “them” (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1), since the majority of manuscripts, including the oldest and most reliable, follow it. Also, most English versions follow this option.

8:7c

and ordered that these be set before them as well.

- and told his disciples to distribute them throughout the crowd.
- and told his followers to serve all the pieces of the fish to the people.
- Then he told the disciples, “Serve/give all these pieces of fish to the people.”

and ordered that these be set before them as well:

Jesus gave his disciples instructions about what to do with the fish. There is implied information here. Jesus probably broke the fish into pieces, as he had broken the bread, so that the disciples could give it to the crowd. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate this in some way. For example:

he broke them in pieces and told the disciples to distribute them

and told the disciples to distribute pieces of the fish

In some languages you may need to make explicit to whom the disciples were distributing the fish. For example:

and told the disciples to distribute them to the crowd/people

that these be set before them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as be set before is another form of the word that is translated as “set before” in 8:6d. You can use a similar expression here. It indicates that the disciples were to give portions of fish to people throughout the crowd.

as well: The phrase as well refers back to Jesus giving thanks for the bread and having the disciples distribute it in 8:6b–d.

Mark 8:8

Section 8:1–10: Jesus did a miracle to feed four thousand people

In the previous section, Jesus healed a man who was deaf and could not speak clearly. People quickly spread the news about this miracle throughout the Decapolis area. As a result, many other people came to Jesus. Most of these people were probably Gentiles. They stayed with Jesus for three days. This section is about how Jesus felt compassion for them and miraculously fed them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Feeds Four Thousand People (GNT)

Jesus multiplied a small amount of food to feed four thousand people

Jesus fed four thousand people in a miraculous way

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 15:32–39.

Paragraph 8:6–10

In this paragraph, Jesus told the crowd to sit down. He said a prayer of thanksgiving for the bread and the fish. Then he asked the disciples to give the food to the people. Jesus performed a miracle by feeding four thousand people with seven loaves of bread and a few fish.

8:8a

The people ate and were satisfied,

- The people ate as much as they wanted.
- Everyone ate all the bread and fish that they wanted.
- Everyone ate until they were full.

The people ate: The Greek word that the BSB translates as The people ate is literally “they ate.” Use a natural subject in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Everybody ate (GNT)

They all ate (NEB)

All the people ate (NCV)

ate and were satisfied: The word satisfied indicates that the people ate all the food they wanted to eat.

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase ate and were satisfied:

ate and had enough (GNT)

ate as much as they wanted (NJB)

ate until they were full (NLT96)

8:8b

and the disciples picked up seven basketfuls of broken pieces that were left over.

- Then the disciples picked up the left over pieces of food, and there were seven large baskets of them.
- And when the remaining bread and fish was collected, the pieces filled seven large baskets.

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and here introduces what happened next in the story. The NCV translates it as “Then” and the NIV translates it as “Afterward.” Connect 8:8b to 8:8a in a way that is natural in your language.

the disciples picked up seven basketfuls of broken pieces that were left over: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as the disciples picked up seven basketfuls of broken pieces that were left over is literally “there was an abundance of pieces, seven baskets.” This clause refers to the pieces of bread and fish that were left after the crowd ate. It emphasizes how much food Jesus had provided for the people.

The BSB has supplied the phrase the disciples picked up to indicate how the baskets were filled.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the leftovers filled seven large baskets (CEV)

when the scraps were picked up, there were seven large baskets of food left over (NLT96)

basketfuls: The type of basket that the Greek text refers to here is larger than the baskets that are mentioned in 6:43. Use an expression here that refers to large baskets. For example:

seven large baskets (CEV)

of broken pieces that were left over: The broken pieces refer to pieces of bread and fish that the people did not eat. They were not crumbs. See how you translated broken pieces in 6:43.

Mark 8:9

Section 8:1–10: Jesus did a miracle to feed four thousand people

In the previous section, Jesus healed a man who was deaf and could not speak clearly. People quickly spread the news about this miracle throughout the Decapolis area. As a result, many other people came to Jesus. Most of these people were probably Gentiles. They stayed with Jesus for three days. This section is about how Jesus felt compassion for them and miraculously fed them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Feeds Four Thousand People (GNT)

Jesus multiplied a small amount of food to feed four thousand people

Jesus fed four thousand people in a miraculous way

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 15:32–39.

Paragraph 8:6–10

In this paragraph, Jesus told the crowd to sit down. He said a prayer of thanksgiving for the bread and the fish. Then he asked the disciples to give the food to the people. Jesus performed a miracle by feeding four thousand people with seven loaves of bread and a few fish.

8:9a

And about four thousand men were present.

- There were four thousand people in the crowd that day.
- And there were about four thousand people who ate.

And about four thousand men were present: The Greek word that the BSB translates as four thousand men is literally “four thousand.” Here the phrase refers to people in general, not only to males.

General Comment on 8:8–9a

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the information in verses 8:8a–b and 8:9a. For example:

Everybody ate and had enough—there were about four thousand people. Then the disciples took up seven baskets full of pieces left over. (GNT)

The crowd of about four thousand people ate all they wanted, and the leftovers filled seven large baskets. (CEV)

8:9b

As soon as Jesus had dismissed the crowd,

- When Jesus had dismissed the people,
- After the people ate, Jesus told them that they should go to their homes.

As soon as Jesus had dismissed the crowd: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *As soon as Jesus had dismissed the crowd* indicates that after the people had eaten as much as they wanted, Jesus told them to return to their homes. Your translation should not imply that Jesus was being rude or hostile toward the people. This is similar to the expression “send them home” in 8:3. Also, see how you translated “dismissed the crowd” in 6:45.

Mark 8:10

Section 8:1–10: Jesus did a miracle to feed four thousand people

In the previous section, Jesus healed a man who was deaf and could not speak clearly. People quickly spread the news about this miracle throughout the Decapolis area. As a result, many other people came to Jesus. Most of these people were probably Gentiles. They stayed with Jesus for three days. This section is about how Jesus felt compassion for them and miraculously fed them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Feeds Four Thousand People (GNT)

Jesus multiplied a small amount of food to feed four thousand people

Jesus fed four thousand people in a miraculous way

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 15:32–39.

Paragraph 8:6–10

In this paragraph, Jesus told the crowd to sit down. He said a prayer of thanksgiving for the bread and the fish. Then he asked the disciples to give the food to the people. Jesus performed a miracle by feeding four thousand people with seven loaves of bread and a few fish.

8:10a

He got into the boat with His disciples

- he and his disciples got into the boat they had used previously.
- Then he rode with his followers in a/the boat

He got into the boat with His disciples: In some languages it may be more natural to say:

Jesus and his disciples got into a boat (GW)

the boat: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *the boat* refers to a specific boat. It is clear from the preceding context (7:31–37) that Jesus and his disciples had walked overland on their journey to Lake Galilee. He did not use a boat on this journey. Therefore, the boat may refer to a specific boat that Jesus had used on other occasions in the past. For example, see 6:45–54.

It may be confusing in your language to refer to a specific boat here when no boat was mentioned in the preceding paragraphs. If that is true, here are some options to consider:

- Refer to a specific boat and add a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

This boat may have been the same boat that Jesus and his disciples used when they went to Bethsaida (Mark 6:45–54).

- Refer to a specific boat and add a short identifying phrase in the text. For example:

the boat that they had used previously

- Use a general word for boat. For example:

a boat (GNT)

His disciples: See how you translated this term at 2:15b and 8:1c. See also disciple in the Glossary for more information.

8:10b

and went to the district of Dalmanutha.

- They went across the lake to the area of Dalmanutha.
- and they went/traveled to the region of Dalmanutha.

and went to the district of Dalmanutha: The exact location of Dalmanutha is not known. Some scholars think it may be another name for the town of Magadan, also called Magdala. This town was located on the western side of Lake Galilee. You might want to include this information in a footnote.

Mark 8:11

Section 8:11–13: The Pharisees asked Jesus for a sign from heaven

According to 8:10, Jesus and his disciples traveled in a boat to the region of Dalmanutha. Some time after they arrived, some Pharisees came to Jesus. We do not know the specific time or place. They demanded that he show them a sign from heaven, but Jesus refused and left their area.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The demand of the Pharisees for a sign from heaven

The Pharisees demand a miraculous sign

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 16:1–4.

8:11a

Then the Pharisees came and began to argue with Jesus,

- ¶ There were some Pharisees who came to Jesus and began to argue with him.
- ¶ Some Pharisees approached Jesus and began to dispute with him.

Then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Then introduces the next story. It is uncertain exactly when this story happened in relation to the previous story. Mark 8:10 mentions that Jesus and the disciples went to Dalmanutha, and the parallel in Matthew

also occurs in the section following Jesus' arrival in Magadan (perhaps another name for Dalmanutha). However, Wessel (page 688), Hiebert (page 194) and Lane (page 276) all feel that there is no explicit connection. Gundry (page 401), Edwards (page 235) and France (page 311) understand Dalmanutha as the likely setting, but Hiebert (page 194) and Lenski (page 320) mention the possibility that the Pharisees had come from Capernaum or that Jesus had gone to Capernaum. This may be the reason why many English versions do not translate this word here. If you need to make a time or place connection explicit in your language, try to use a general expression.

the Pharisees came: The phrase the Pharisees came indicates here that some of the Pharisees came to Jesus. It does not mean that all of the Pharisees came. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate this. For example, the GNT says:

Some Pharisees came to Jesus

Pharisees: The Pharisees were a Jewish religious group or party. It was very important to them to obey all of the Jewish religious laws very carefully and in detail. Here are some ways to translate this word:

- Transliterate the word Pharisees according to the sounds of your language and indicate that it refers to people. For example:

Farisi members

Parise adherents

- Transliterate the word Pharisees and indicate that it refers to a group of people with certain beliefs. For example:

people belonging to the Farise religious sect/
group

members of the religious group called the Farasi

You may also want to include an explanation of Pharisees in the glossary of your translation. Refer to how you translated Pharisees in 2:16a and 7:5a.

and began to argue with Jesus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as argue with means “question” or “debate” in this context. The Pharisees were opposed to Jesus. So they did not want information from him,

and they did not want to have a friendly conversation with him.

Here are some other ways to translate argue with:

question (NIV)

dispute (NKJV)

8:11b

testing Him by demanding from Him a sign from heaven.

- They demanded that he show them a miraculous sign from God/heaven. They were demanding this in order to test him.
- They wanted to trap him, so they asked him to perform a miracle to show that God had given him his authority/power.
- They said, “If you^(sing) are truly from God, perform a miracle to show it.”

testing Him: The phrase testing Him indicates the purpose for the next clause. The Pharisees wanted to test Jesus. That is the reason they asked him to show them a sign. The Greek text places the purpose phrase at the end of this verse, as in the RSV. Place it where it is natural in your language.

testing: The Greek word that the BSB translates as testing refers here to an attempt to cause someone to make a mistake, often by tricking him. In this context the Pharisees tried to cause Jesus to say or do something that would make the people think that he was not from God. Their purpose was to discredit Jesus so that people would not listen to him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Hoping to trap him...

They wanted to discredit him, so they...

demanding from Him a sign from heaven: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as demanding means “requesting.” It can be used for either a polite request or a demand. Use an appropriate verb in your language.

In some languages it may be necessary to express this request as a direct quote. For example, the NLT96 says:

...they demanded, “Give us a miraculous sign from heaven to prove yourself.”

a sign from heaven: The phrase a sign from heaven here means “a sign from God.” Some commentaries (Lenski page 321, Gould page 144, etc.) interpret “from heaven” to mean “in the skies/space.” That is, the Pharisees were asking for a celestial phenomenon rather than a miracle on earth to serve as attestation that Jesus’ teaching came from God. No major English version explicitly follows this interpretation. The Pharisees did not believe that Jesus had power from God. They asked him to do a special miracle to prove that his power came from God. They thought he would not be able to do this.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

a special miracle to show that his power came from God

a miracle to show that God approved of him (GNT)

See heaven, Meaning 3, in the Glossary.

sign: The word sign refers to a miracle that has a meaning. In this context, the Pharisees wanted Jesus to perform a miracle that would prove that his power came from God.

Mark 8:12

Section 8:11–13: The Pharisees asked Jesus for a sign from heaven

According to 8:10, Jesus and his disciples traveled in a boat to the region of Dalmanutha. Some time after they arrived, some Pharisees came to Jesus. We do not know the specific time or place. They demanded that he show them a sign from heaven, but Jesus refused and left their area.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The demand of the Pharisees for a sign from heaven

The Pharisees demand a miraculous sign

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 16:1–4.

8:12a

Jesus sighed deeply in His spirit and said,

- Jesus sighed with intense feeling and said,

- Distressed by their unbelief, he groaned and said to them,

Jesus sighed deeply in His spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as sighed deeply in His spirit is literally “having sighed-deeply in his spirit.” The words in His spirit indicate that Jesus sighed because of the strong emotions that he felt in his inner being. In this context, he sighed because he was feeling disturbed and disappointed over the Pharisees’ attitude. The Greek verb that is used here is a more intense form of the verb that was translated as “sighed deeply” in 7:34b.

In some languages a literal translation of the words in His spirit would wrongly imply that Jesus had another spirit that he was communicating with. In other languages it would sound unnatural. If this is true in your language, you may leave these words implicit. Be sure to communicate the idea of strong emotion in a way that is natural in your language.

8:12b

“Why does this generation demand a sign?”

- “Why do the people who are living now/today demand to see a sign from heaven?”
- “You^(plur) people should not be asking to see a miracle that shows that God is the one who has given me power.

Why does this generation demand a sign?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus asked this question to rebuke the Pharisees because they asked Jesus to perform a special miracle just to satisfy them. There are at least two ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the NCV says:

Why do you people ask for a miracle as a sign?

- As a statement. For example:

You people should not be asking for a miraculous sign.

Use whichever form is most natural to express this rebuke in your language.

this generation: In this context, the phrase this generation refers to the adults who lived at the same time as Jesus. It does not refer only to the Pharisees who were arguing with him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the people of this day (GNT)

these people (GW)

you people of this generation

a sign: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sign is the same word that it translated as “sign” in 8:11b. It refers to the sign from heaven that the Pharisees demanded to see.

8:12c

Truly I tell you,

- Here is the truth about that:
- I sincerely/earnestly declare to you that

Truly I tell you: Jesus used the phrase Truly I tell you to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. It indicates that the statement was important and totally reliable, and that people should listen carefully to it. Jesus used this phrase eight times in Mark. Sometimes it introduces a serious warning or prediction. Here this phrase introduces the fact that Jesus refused to give the Pharisees a sign.

See how you translated this expression in 3:28a. In some languages you may need to translate the phrase differently in different contexts. Do not translate in a way that implies that Jesus had not been telling the truth at other times.

Here are some ways that English versions have translated the phrase in this context:

I can guarantee this truth: (GW)

No, I tell you! (GNT)

I assure you (NLT96)

I can promise you that (CEV)

8:12d

no sign will be given to this generation.”

- no miraculous sign will be shown to you.^(plur)
- I will not do any miracle to show you that God has given me power.”

no sign will be given to this generation: The clause no sign will be given to this generation indicates that the adults who were alive at that time would not be given a miraculous sign. This clause is passive. Jesus was saying that he refused to perform a special miracle for the Pharisees. In some languages you may need to use an active verb and supply a subject. For example, the NLT says:

I will not give this generation any such sign.

Mark 8:13

Section 8:11–13: The Pharisees asked Jesus for a sign from heaven

According to 8:10, Jesus and his disciples traveled in a boat to the region of Dalmanutha. Some time after they arrived, some Pharisees came to Jesus. We do not know the specific time or place. They demanded that he show them a sign from heaven, but Jesus refused and left their area.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The demand of the Pharisees for a sign from heaven

The Pharisees demand a miraculous sign

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 16:1–4.

8:13a

And He left them, got back into the boat,

- Then Jesus left them. He and his disciples got back into the boat
- So Jesus left the Pharisees and returned to the boat with his followers.

And He left them, got back into the boat: The phrases He left them and got back into the boat here indicate that Jesus walked away from the Pharisees and stepped into the boat. Jesus' disciples also walked to the boat and entered it with him. In some languages you may need to include this information about the disciples. For example:

he and his disciples left them and got back into the boat

he left them and got back into the boat with his disciples

8:13b

and crossed to the other side.

- and crossed over to the other side of the lake.
- Then they went/rode to the other side of the lake.

crossed to the other side: The phrase crossed to the other side indicates that Jesus and his disciples rode in the boat to go to the other side of the Sea of Galilee.

Mark 8:14

Section 8:14–21: Jesus warned his disciples about the Pharisees and Herod

In the previous story, the Pharisees again showed that they did not believe in Jesus. In this story, Jesus warned his disciples about them and about King Herod. He told the disciples to be careful about their “leaven,” or “yeast.” Yeast is a substance that spreads throughout bread dough and causes it to rise.

In this story Jesus used yeast as a metaphor, but the disciples thought he referred to literal yeast. The Jews often spoke of yeast as a figure of speech to refer to any influence that spread rapidly. In this context it is clear that the ways that the Pharisees and King Herod influenced people were harmful. Other Gospels make two of these ways explicit:

1. In Luke 12:1, the yeast of the Pharisees was hypocrisy.
2. In Matthew 16:12 the yeast of the Pharisees was their teaching.

In this context the “yeast” of the Pharisees may have been their stubborn refusal to believe in him. The Pharisees had asked Jesus for a sign from God in order to discredit him. Herod also had refused to believe John the Baptist and had ordered his soldiers to kill him. Jesus warned his disciples that they should not be like the Pharisees and King Herod, who did not understand who he was, or believe in him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Beware of the attitudes of the Pharisees and Herod that spread like yeast

The yeast of the Pharisees and Herod

The disciples did not yet understand what Jesus' miracles showed about him

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 16:5–11. Luke 12:1 also contains a reference to the yeast of the Pharisees.

8:14a**Now the disciples had forgotten to take bread,**

- ¶ The disciples had forgotten to bring enough bread for their trip.
- ¶ Now Jesus' followers had forgotten to bring enough food along.

Now: In Greek, this verse begins with the common conjunction that is often translated as “and.” In this context, it introduces background information for the conversation in 8:15–21. The BSB translates the conjunction as *Now* because that is a common way to introduce background information in English. Some English versions do not use a connector here. Use a natural way in your language to introduce background information at the beginning of a new section. In some languages it may be helpful to repeat the information from 8:13b that they were crossing the lake:

They were crossing the lake. The disciples had forgotten to bring bread...

the disciples: See how you translated this term at 2:15b and 8:1c. See also *disciple* in the Glossary for more information.

had forgotten to take bread: The disciples apparently had forgotten to bring enough bread for their trip when they got back into the boat in 8:13.

bread: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *bread* can also refer to food in general. In this context, it refers specifically to bread. Later in the story this will be important, since Jesus refers to yeast, which is used to make bread. See how you translated *bread* in 8:4b–c.

8:14b**except for one loaf they had with them in the boat.**

- In fact, they only had one loaf/bread with them in the boat.
- There was only one loaf of bread in the boat.

except for one loaf: The word *loaf* refers to a single large unit or piece of bread. There was one loaf of bread in the boat when they arrived at the region of Dalmanutha in 8:10.

See how you translated “loaves” in 8:5a and 6:38.

Mark 8:15**Section 8:14–21: Jesus warned his disciples about the Pharisees and Herod**

In the previous story, the Pharisees again showed that they did not believe in Jesus. In this story, Jesus

warned his disciples about them and about King Herod. He told the disciples to be careful about their “leaven,” or “yeast.” Yeast is a substance that spreads throughout bread dough and causes it to rise.

In this story Jesus used yeast as a metaphor, but the disciples thought he referred to literal yeast. The Jews often spoke of yeast as a figure of speech to refer to any influence that spread rapidly. In this context it is clear that the ways that the Pharisees and King Herod influenced people were harmful. Other Gospels make two of these ways explicit:

1. In Luke 12:1, the yeast of the Pharisees was hypocrisy.
2. In Matthew 16:12 the yeast of the Pharisees was their teaching.

In this context the “yeast” of the Pharisees may have been their stubborn refusal to believe in him. The Pharisees had asked Jesus for a sign from God in order to discredit him. Herod also had refused to believe John the Baptist and had ordered his soldiers to kill him. Jesus warned his disciples that they should not be like the Pharisees and King Herod, who did not understand who he was, or believe in him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Beware of the attitudes of the Pharisees and Herod that spread like yeast

The yeast of the Pharisees and Herod

The disciples did not yet understand what Jesus' miracles showed about him

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 16:5–11. Luke 12:1 also contains a reference to the yeast of the Pharisees.

8:15a**“Watch out!” He cautioned them.**

- Jesus cautioned them, “Watch out!”
- Jesus earnestly warned them

8:15b**“Beware of the leaven of the Pharisees and of Herod.”**

- Guard yourselves against the yeast of the Pharisees and the yeast of Herod.”

- to beware of the yeast of both the Pharisees and King Herod.

8:15a-b

Notice that the BSB begins this verse with words that Jesus spoke. In some languages it will be necessary to identify Jesus as the speaker first. See the note on “He cautioned them” below. See also the General Comment on 8:15a-b.

Watch out!...Beware: The Greek verbs that the BSB translates as Watch out and Beware have the same meaning here. They are both a command and a warning. They indicate that people should be alert to guard themselves against some danger or evil. In this context the specific danger is mentioned in 8:15b.

Jesus used these two verbs with the same meaning to emphasize the warning that he was giving them. In some languages it may not be natural to use two verbs like this. If that is true in your language, you may need to emphasize the warning in another way. For example:

Jesus earnestly cautioned them, “Watch out for the yeast of the Pharisees and of Herod.”

Jesus warned them, “Be very careful to avoid the yeast of the Pharisees and Herod.”

He cautioned them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as cautioned is literally “was ordering, commanding.” Many English versions translate it as “warned” here because his command was a warning. Translate He cautioned them in a way that is natural in your language. The form of the Greek verb indicates that Jesus probably warned them more than once. He may have spoken for some time about his warning.

In the Greek text, the phrase He cautioned them occurs before Jesus’ actual words. The BSB puts this phrase in the middle of Jesus’ words. Place it where it would naturally occur in your language.

the leaven of the Pharisees and of Herod: The text does not say in what way the leaven was related to the Pharisees and Herod. However, Jesus implied that the influence of the Pharisees and Herod was similar in some way to leaven.

In some languages it may be necessary to make the meaning slightly more explicit. For example:

the leaven/yeast that the Pharisees spread, and the leaven/yeast that Herod spreads

the leaven that comes from the Pharisees, and the leaven that comes from Herod

Remember that the disciples did not understand what Jesus meant. They thought he was talking about literal leaven. So you should not explain the meaning of leaven in the verse itself. You may want to include a footnote to give more information. For example:

The Jews used “leaven/yeast” as an idiom to refer to the spread of any influence, whether it be good or bad. Jesus used it here to refer to the bad influence that the Pharisees’ and Herod’s unbelief had on many people. This suggested footnote is a shortened form of the footnote that appears in the TRT (page 100).

leaven: The Greek word that the BSB translates as leaven refers to a substance that makes bread dough rise. A person mixes this substance with water and flour. Then it spreads throughout the flour and makes the dough expand. The dough is then baked into bread.

If people in your area are not familiar with making dough rise, here are some other ways to translate leaven:

- Use an expression that describes the leaven/yeast. For example:

what spreads to make bread rise

bread-expanding substance

- Use a term from the national language and indicate its meaning. For example:

yeast that spreads to make bread swell

- Borrow a word and explain it in a footnote. Here is an examples of a possible footnote:

Leaven is something that spreads in flour dough and causes it to rise so that after the dough is baked it is soft to eat.

the Pharisees: In biblical times, the Pharisees were a Jewish religious group. See how you translated Pharisees in 8:11a.

Herod: The name Herod here refers to Herod Antipas, the ruler of Galilee. He was first mentioned in Mark in 6:14a. See how you translated “King Herod” there.

General Comment on 8:15a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech for Jesus' words here. For example:

Jesus warned them earnestly to beware of the leaven of the Pharisees and Herod.

Mark 8:16**Section 8:14–21: Jesus warned his disciples about the Pharisees and Herod**

In the previous story, the Pharisees again showed that they did not believe in Jesus. In this story, Jesus warned his disciples about them and about King Herod. He told the disciples to be careful about their “leaven,” or “yeast.” Yeast is a substance that spreads throughout bread dough and causes it to rise.

In this story Jesus used yeast as a metaphor, but the disciples thought he referred to literal yeast. The Jews often spoke of yeast as a figure of speech to refer to any influence that spread rapidly. In this context it is clear that the ways that the Pharisees and King Herod influenced people were harmful. Other Gospels make two of these ways explicit:

1. In Luke 12:1, the yeast of the Pharisees was hypocrisy.
2. In Matthew 16:12 the yeast of the Pharisees was their teaching.

In this context the “yeast” of the Pharisees may have been their stubborn refusal to believe in him. The Pharisees had asked Jesus for a sign from God in order to discredit him. Herod also had refused to believe John the Baptist and had ordered his soldiers to kill him. Jesus warned his disciples that they should not be like the Pharisees and King Herod, who did not understand who he was, or believe in him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Beware of the attitudes of the Pharisees and Herod that spread like yeast

The yeast of the Pharisees and Herod

The disciples did not yet understand what Jesus' miracles showed about him

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 16:5–11. Luke 12:1 also contains a reference to the yeast of the Pharisees.

8:16a**So they began to discuss with one another the fact**

- They discussed what Jesus had said with each other. They said,
- Talking this over among themselves, they decided

So they began to discuss with one another: The pronoun they here refers to Jesus' disciples. The disciples talked with one another about the meaning of what Jesus had just said.

8:16b**that they had no bread.**

- “He said this because we^(incl) did not bring any bread.”
- that Jesus had said this because they did not have any bread.

the fact that they had no bread: In this part of the verse, the disciples tried to explain to themselves why Jesus said the words in 8:15. They thought he was talking about real yeast and real bread. In some languages it may be necessary to make this more explicit. For example:

that he had said that because they had no bread.

General Comment on 8:16a–b

In the Greek the disciples' words are in indirect speech. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this verse using direct speech. For example:

They discussed this with one another and said, “It is because we have no bread.” (NIV)

The disciples began to say to each other, ‘Jesus is saying that because we do not have any bread.’ (EASY)

Mark 8:17**Section 8:14–21: Jesus warned his disciples about the Pharisees and Herod**

In the previous story, the Pharisees again showed that they did not believe in Jesus. In this story, Jesus warned his disciples about them and about King Herod. He told the disciples to be careful about their “leaven,” or “yeast.” Yeast is a substance that spreads throughout bread dough and causes it to rise.

In this story Jesus used yeast as a metaphor, but the disciples thought he referred to literal yeast. The Jews often spoke of yeast as a figure of speech to refer to any influence that spread rapidly. In this context it is clear that the ways that the Pharisees and King Herod influenced people were harmful. Other Gospels make two of these ways explicit:

1. In Luke 12:1, the yeast of the Pharisees was hypocrisy.
2. In Matthew 16:12 the yeast of the Pharisees was their teaching.

In this context the “yeast” of the Pharisees may have been their stubborn refusal to believe in him. The Pharisees had asked Jesus for a sign from God in order to discredit him. Herod also had refused to believe John the Baptist and had ordered his soldiers to kill him. Jesus warned his disciples that they should not be like the Pharisees and King Herod, who did not understand who he was, or believe in him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Beware of the attitudes of the Pharisees and Herod that spread like yeast

The yeast of the Pharisees and Herod

The disciples did not yet understand what Jesus’ miracles showed about him

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 16:5–11. Luke 12:1 also contains a reference to the yeast of the Pharisees.

8:17a

Aware of their conversation, Jesus asked them,

- ¶ Knowing what they were talking about, Jesus asked them, (NCV)
- ¶ Jesus knew what they were saying among themselves, so he said to them,

Aware of their conversation, Jesus asked them: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *Aware of their conversation* is literally “and knowing.” It refers back to the disciples’ conversation in 8:16. Jesus knew that they were talking about the fact that they had not brought any more bread with them in the boat. Refer to that conversation in a natural way in your language.

The text does not say how Jesus knew, so your translation should also not say specifically how he knew.

8:17b

“Why are you debating about having no bread?”

- “Why are you talking about not having bread? (NCV)
- “Surely, you^(plur) are not saying/thinking that I warned you^(plur) because you^(plur) have no bread.

Why are you debating about having no bread?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses rebuke. In some languages it may be necessary to include implied information as you translate this rhetorical question.

Jesus scolded his disciples for thinking that the reason he was warning them in 8:15 was because they did not bring bread. In 8:19–20 he reminded them that he had multiplied small amounts of bread to feed large crowds of people. When he spoke about the leaven of the Pharisees and of Herod, he was warning against their dangerous influence or attitude. Clearly, Jesus expected his disciples to think about the danger of the Pharisees and Herod, not about bread.

There are at least two ways to translate this rebuke.

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why should you think that I was warning you about not having any bread?

Should you be arguing about having no bread after my warning?

- As a statement. For example:

It is not your lack of bread that you should be discussing now!

My warning should not cause you to talk about having no bread!

Whether you have bread with you has nothing to do with what I just told you!

Use whichever form is most natural to express this rebuke in your language.

8:17c

Do you still not see or understand?

- Won’t you ever learn or understand? (NLT96)
- By now you^(plur) should be able to understand who I am!

Do you still not see or understand?: This is a rhetorical question that is asking two things:

1. Do you still not see...? (“perceive” in the RSV)
2. Do you still not...understand?

Jesus asked this to rebuke his disciples because they did not understand him. The question does not imply that the disciples were not intelligent or that they were unable to understand ordinary things. There are at least two ways to translate this rebuke.

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the GNT says:

Don’t you know or understand yet?

- As a statement. For example:

You should have perceived and understood by now!

Use whichever form is most natural to express this rebuke in your language.

see or understand: The Greek verbs that the BSB translates as see and understand are literally “perceive” and “understand,” as in the RSV. The text uses two verbs with almost the same meaning to emphasize this meaning. In this context the verbs emphasize that the disciples did not understand. Jesus’ question implies that they should have understood.

It may not be natural in your language to repeat verbs with the same meaning here. If that is true, you may indicate the emphasis here in a different way. For example:

Do you^(plur) still not yet understand?

Do you^(plur) still not understand at all?

By now you^(plur) should be able to understand!

understand: Throughout this story, Jesus did not specifically state what his disciples did not understand. The text implies that by that time they should have been able to understand that he was God’s Son, the Messiah. It is recommended that you leave this information unstated. However, in some languages a verb like “understand” requires an object. If that is true in your language, you may need to express the idea in a general way. For example:

understand who I am

perceive the truth

8:17d

Do you have such hard hearts?

- How can your^(plur) minds be so closed?
- Do you^(plur) not want to understand?
- Surely your^(plur) minds are not so dull!

Do you have such hard hearts?: Here Jesus used another rhetorical question to rebuke his disciples. This question has the same meaning as the question in 8:17c. There are at least two ways to translate this rebuke.

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the NCV says:

Are your minds closed?

- As a statement. For example:

Your hearts/minds must be hardened/closed.

Use whichever form is most natural to express this rebuke in your language. See the General Comment on 8:17c–d for a suggestion about how to combine these verse parts.

such hard hearts: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as such hard hearts is an idiom. It is used when people are too stubborn to understand spiritual truth. It does not refer to a lack of intelligence. Jesus rebuked his disciples because they saw him do many miracles but still did not understand what his miracles showed about him. You can translate this idiom in two ways:

- Use a figure of speech from your language that refers to a refusal to understand. For example, here are some other English idioms:

Are your minds so dull? (GNT)

Are your minds still closed? (CEV)

Why do you refuse to open your hearts?

- Translate the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

Do you not want to comprehend this?

Why do you refuse to understand like that?

The phrase such hard hearts is very similar to the phrase “their hearts had been hardened” in 6:52. See how you translated it there.

General Comment on 8:17c–d

The rhetorical questions in 8:17c and 8:17d have almost the same meaning. In some languages it may be more natural to combine these questions. For example:

Have you made your hearts so hard that you still cannot understand?

Have you closed your minds so that you still cannot perceive the truth about me?

Mark 8:18

Section 8:14–21: Jesus warned his disciples about the Pharisees and Herod

In the previous story, the Pharisees again showed that they did not believe in Jesus. In this story, Jesus warned his disciples about them and about King Herod. He told the disciples to be careful about their “leaven,” or “yeast.” Yeast is a substance that spreads throughout bread dough and causes it to rise.

In this story Jesus used yeast as a metaphor, but the disciples thought he referred to literal yeast. The Jews often spoke of yeast as a figure of speech to refer to any influence that spread rapidly. In this context it is clear that the ways that the Pharisees and King Herod influenced people were harmful. Other Gospels make two of these ways explicit:

1. In Luke 12:1, the yeast of the Pharisees was hypocrisy.
2. In Matthew 16:12 the yeast of the Pharisees was their teaching.

In this context the “yeast” of the Pharisees may have been their stubborn refusal to believe in him. The Pharisees had asked Jesus for a sign from God in order to discredit him. Herod also had refused to believe John the Baptist and had ordered his soldiers to kill him. Jesus warned his disciples that they should not be like the Pharisees and King Herod, who did not understand who he was, or believe in him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Beware of the attitudes of the Pharisees and Herod that spread like yeast

The yeast of the Pharisees and Herod

The disciples did not yet understand what Jesus’ miracles showed about him

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 16:5–11. Luke 12:1 also contains a reference to the yeast of the Pharisees.

8:18a

‘Having eyes, do you not see?’

- You^(plur) have eyes, so why can you not see?
- You have eyes, but you don’t really see. (NCV)
- You^(plur) have eyes but you do not seem to learn from what you see.

8:18b

And having ears, do you not hear?’

- You^(plur) have ears, so why can you not hear?
- You have ears, but you don’t really listen. (NCV)
- You have ears, but do you^(plur) think about what you^(plur) hear?

8:18a–b

The BSB puts single quotes around the words Having eyes, do you not see? And having ears, do you not hear?. This shows that it may be a quote from Jeremiah 5:21. Many English translations do not put quote marks around these words. That is because Jesus does not state that he is quoting from Jeremiah, and the quotation is not exact. Consider how you might mark a possible quotation in your language. If you do not use quote marks, you could refer to Jeremiah 5:21 in a footnote.

Having eyes, do you not see? And having ears, do you not hear?: This is a rhetorical question that has two parts. Both parts have the same meaning, and they function as a rebuke. In some languages it may be more natural to translate the two parts as separate sentences. In other languages it may be more natural to combine them.

Here are some ways to translate this rhetorical question.

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the CEV says:

Are your eyes blind and your ears deaf?

- As a statement. For example:

You have eyes and ears, but you cannot see or hear.

Use whichever form is most natural to express this rebuke in your language.

do you not see?...do you not hear?: In this context the phrases do you not see and do you not hear are used in a figurative way. The disciples saw things, but they did not learn from what they saw. They heard things, but they did not learn from what they heard. In some languages it may be necessary to make this meaning more explicit. For example:

You have eyes; did you not learn from what you saw? You have ears; did you not think about what you heard?

8:18c–19b

In Greek, 8:18c–19b are expressed as one question. In some languages it may be more natural to use two or more questions, as the BSB has done. There are also different ways to divide the questions. For example:

And do you not remember? When I broke the five loaves for the five thousand, how many baskets full of broken pieces did you take up? (RSV)

Don't you remember when I broke the five loaves for the five thousand people? How many baskets full of leftover pieces did you take up? (GNT)

Connect the ideas in these questions in a natural way in your language.

8:18c

And do you not remember?

- How can you^(plur) not remember?
- Certainly you^(plur) must remember!

And do you not remember?: This is a rhetorical question. The BSB translates it as an introductory question for the questions in 8:19 and 8:20. Together, these questions imply that the disciples should have remembered when Jesus fed the crowds of five thousand men (6:30–44) and four thousand people (8:1–10). Jesus asked this question to rebuke the disciples because they were speaking as if they did not remember those miracles. There are at least three ways to translate this rebuke.

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the NET says:

Don't you remember?

- As a statement. For example:

Surely you remember....

You should be able to remember!

- As a tag question. For example:

You can still remember, can't you?

Use whichever form is most natural to express this rebuke in your language.

Mark 8:19

Section 8:14–21: Jesus warned his disciples about the Pharisees and Herod

In the previous story, the Pharisees again showed that they did not believe in Jesus. In this story, Jesus warned his disciples about them and about King Herod. He told the disciples to be careful about their “leaven,” or “yeast.” Yeast is a substance that spreads throughout bread dough and causes it to rise.

In this story Jesus used yeast as a metaphor, but the disciples thought he referred to literal yeast. The Jews often spoke of yeast as a figure of speech to refer to any influence that spread rapidly. In this context it is clear that the ways that the Pharisees and King Herod influenced people were harmful. Other Gospels make two of these ways explicit:

1. In Luke 12:1, the yeast of the Pharisees was hypocrisy.
2. In Matthew 16:12 the yeast of the Pharisees was their teaching.

In this context the “yeast” of the Pharisees may have been their stubborn refusal to believe in him. The Pharisees had asked Jesus for a sign from God in order to discredit him. Herod also had refused to believe John the Baptist and had ordered his soldiers to kill him. Jesus warned his disciples that they should not be like the Pharisees and King Herod, who did not understand who he was, or believe in him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Beware of the attitudes of the Pharisees and Herod that spread like yeast

The yeast of the Pharisees and Herod

The disciples did not yet understand what Jesus' miracles showed about him

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 16:5–11. Luke 12:1 also contains a reference to the yeast of the Pharisees.

8:19a

When I broke the five loaves for the five thousand,

- When I divided the five loaves of bread for the five thousand men,
- When I divided/tore five loaves of bread into pieces to feed five thousand men,

In this verse Jesus referred to the story in 6:30–44 about how he fed five thousand men.

I broke the five loaves for the five thousand: This phrase indicates that Jesus divided or tore five small loaves of bread into pieces to feed five thousand men (6:44). See how you translated broke in 6:41.

the five loaves: The phrase the five loaves refers to five units or pieces of bread. The loaves were probably in a round shape, like rolls or buns. See how you translated the five loaves in 6:38.

8:19b

how many basketfuls of broken pieces did you collect?"

- how many baskets did you^(plur) fill up with the remaining pieces?"
- how many baskets did you^(plur) use to carry the leftovers?"

how many basketfuls of broken pieces did you collect: This question emphasizes the fact that Jesus multiplied the bread to feed the crowd. The disciples picked up leftover pieces and filled baskets with them. See how you referred to "basketfuls" in 6:43.

General Comment on 8:19a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the order of these two verse parts. For example:

^{19b}How many baskets of leftovers did you pick up

^{19a}when I fed those five thousand people with only five small loaves of bread?

If you do reverse the order of the verse parts here in 8:19, you should follow the same type of reordering for 8:20.

8:19c

"Twelve," they answered.

- They answered, "Twelve baskets."
- They said, "We used twelve baskets to carry them."

"Twelve," they answered: The disciples answered Jesus' question with the number Twelve. It refers to the number of baskets that the disciples filled with the bread and fish that remained after the people ate. In some languages it may be more natural to translate the disciples' answer with a complete sentence:

They told him, "We filled twelve baskets."

they answered: The BSB places the words they answered after the disciples' reply. In Greek these words come before the reply. Place them where it is natural in your language.

Mark 8:20

Section 8:14–21: Jesus warned his disciples about the Pharisees and Herod

In the previous story, the Pharisees again showed that they did not believe in Jesus. In this story, Jesus warned his disciples about them and about King Herod. He told the disciples to be careful about their "leaven," or "yeast." Yeast is a substance that spreads throughout bread dough and causes it to rise.

In this story Jesus used yeast as a metaphor, but the disciples thought he referred to literal yeast. The Jews often spoke of yeast as a figure of speech to refer to any influence that spread rapidly. In this context it is clear that the ways that the Pharisees and King Herod influenced people were harmful. Other Gospels make two of these ways explicit:

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In this context the "yeast" of the Pharisees may have been their stubborn refusal to believe in him. The Pharisees had asked Jesus for a sign from God in order to discredit him. Herod also had refused to believe John the Baptist and had ordered his soldiers to kill him. Jesus warned his disciples that they should not be like the Pharisees and King Herod, who did not understand who he was, or believe in him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Beware of the attitudes of the Pharisees and Herod that spread like yeast

The yeast of the Pharisees and Herod

The disciples did not yet understand what Jesus' miracles showed about him

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 16:5–11. Luke 12:1 also contains a reference to the yeast of the Pharisees.

8:20a

“And when I broke the seven loaves for the four thousand,

- “Also, when I divided the seven loaves of bread for the four thousand people,
- Jesus said, “And when I tore/divided seven loaves of bread into pieces to feed four thousand people,

In this verse Jesus referred to the story in 8:1–10 about how he fed four thousand people. This part of the verse is very similar to 8:19a. See the notes there.

broke the seven loaves: The phrase broke the seven loaves refers to when Jesus divided or tore the bread into pieces in 8:6. See how you translated broke in 6:41 and 8:6c.

See how you referred to the seven loaves in 8:5a.

for the four thousand: The phrase for the four thousand indicates that Jesus fed four thousand people. See the notes at 8:9a.

8:20b

how many basketfuls of broken pieces did you collect?”

- how many large baskets did you^(plur) fill up with the remaining pieces?”
- how many large baskets did you^(plur) need to put the leftovers in?”

This part of the verse is very similar to 8:19b. See the notes there.

how many basketfuls of broken pieces: See how you referred to “basketfuls” in 8:8b.

8:20c

“Seven,” they said.

- The replied, “Seven large baskets.”
- They said, “We needed seven large baskets to carry them.”

“Seven,” they said: See the note on the similar expression in 8:19c. See also how you translated this same expression in 8:5b.

Mark 8:21

Section 8:14–21: Jesus warned his disciples about the Pharisees and Herod

In the previous story, the Pharisees again showed that they did not believe in Jesus. In this story, Jesus warned his disciples about them and about King Herod. He told the disciples to be careful about their “leaven,” or “yeast.” Yeast is a substance that spreads throughout bread dough and causes it to rise.

In this story Jesus used yeast as a metaphor, but the disciples thought he referred to literal yeast. The Jews often spoke of yeast as a figure of speech to refer to any influence that spread rapidly. In this context it is clear that the ways that the Pharisees and King Herod influenced people were harmful. Other Gospels make two of these ways explicit:

1. In Luke 12:1, the yeast of the Pharisees was hypocrisy.
2. In Matthew 16:12 the yeast of the Pharisees was their teaching.

In this context the “yeast” of the Pharisees may have been their stubborn refusal to believe in him. The Pharisees had asked Jesus for a sign from God in order to discredit him. Herod also had refused to believe John the Baptist and had ordered his soldiers to kill him. Jesus warned his disciples that they should not be like the Pharisees and King Herod, who did not understand who he was, or believe in him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Beware of the attitudes of the Pharisees and Herod that spread like yeast

The yeast of the Pharisees and Herod

The disciples did not yet understand what Jesus' miracles showed about him

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 16:5–11. Luke 12:1 also contains a reference to the yeast of the Pharisees.

8:21

Then He asked them, “Do you still not understand?”

- So he said to them, “Why do you^(plur) still not understand?”

- So Jesus said to them, “And you^(plur) still do not understand who I am!”
- Then Jesus responded, “Surely, you^(plur) should understand the truth by this time!”

Do you still not understand?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses a rebuke. Jesus rebuked his disciples because they still did not understand who he really was. There are at least two ways to translate this rebuke.

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you not yet understand? (RSV)

Don't you understand even yet? (NLT96)

- As a statement. For example:

Surely, you should understand by this time!

Use whichever form is most natural to express this rebuke in your language.

understand: The disciples did not understand who Jesus really was. This is implied information. See the note in 8:17c for more information on how to translate understand.

Mark 8:22

Section 8:22–26: Jesus healed a blind man at Bethsaida

Jesus and his disciples left the Pharisees at the region of Dalmanutha and got back into their boat. In this section, they had crossed the Sea of Galilee and landed at the village of Bethsaida on the northeast shore of the lake. As soon as they arrived, some people brought a blind man to Jesus so that Jesus would heal him.

The main people in this story are Jesus and the blind man. The meaning lines of the Display sometimes use the nouns “Jesus” and “the man,” sometimes the pronouns “he” or “him,” to refer to them. In some languages it may be more natural to refer to them in different ways in some of these situations. Refer to Jesus and the blind man in a way that is natural in your language.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The healing of a blind man at Bethsaida

A blind man healed at Bethsaida

There are no direct parallel passages for this section. Some similar terms are used in John 9:6–7.

8:22a

When they arrived at Bethsaida,

- ¶ Then Jesus and his disciples came to the village of Bethsaida.
- ¶ When Jesus and his followers arrived at the small town of Bethsaida,

The events in 8:22–26 happened sometime after the events in 8:14–21 ended. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories. In some languages, it is natural to begin a story with a time word or phrase. If your language is like that, use an expression here that is not too specific. For example:

Sometime later

After that

In other languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this story in a natural way in your language.

When they arrived: The pronoun they refers to Jesus and his disciples.

at Bethsaida: Bethsaida was the name of a village on the northeast shore of the Sea of Galilee. See how you translated Bethsaida in 6:45.

8:22b

some people brought a blind man

- Some people brought to him a man who was blind,
- some townspeople led/guided a blind man to him.

some people: The Greek form that the BSB translates as some people is literally “they.” Mark did not say who these people were. They were apparently residents of Bethsaida. In many languages it will be helpful to supply a general subject like some people, as the BSB does.

brought a blind man: In this context the verb brought indicates that people led, escorted or accompanied a blind man to the place where Jesus was. Use an expression in your language that is appropriate for guiding someone who is blind.

8:22c**and begged Jesus to touch him.**

- and they begged him to touch the man so that he would be healed.
- They pleaded with Jesus to heal the blind man by touching him.
- They begged Jesus, “Touch and heal this blind man.”

begged Jesus to touch him: The people wanted Jesus to touch the blind man in order to heal him. In some languages it may be necessary to make that information explicit. For example:

begged Jesus to touch him and heal him

begged Jesus to touch him so that he would be healed

begged: The word begged means “pleaded” for something. It indicates that the people earnestly desired the request they were making. See how you translated begged in 7:32c.

to touch him: The text does not say which part of the man’s body Jesus was asked to touch. If your translation requires you to provide this information, you could say:

touch his eyes

Mark 8:23**Section 8:22–26: Jesus healed a blind man at Bethsaida**

Jesus and his disciples left the Pharisees at the region of Dalmanutha and got back into their boat. In this section, they had crossed the Sea of Galilee and landed at the village of Bethsaida on the northeast shore of the lake. As soon as they arrived, some people brought a blind man to Jesus so that Jesus would heal him.

The main people in this story are Jesus and the blind man. The meaning lines of the Display sometimes use the nouns “Jesus” and “the man,” sometimes the pronouns “he” or “him,” to refer to them. In some languages it may be more natural to refer to them in different ways in some of these situations. Refer to Jesus and the blind man in a way that is natural in your language.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The healing of a blind man at Bethsaida

A blind man healed at Bethsaida

There are no direct parallel passages for this section. Some similar terms are used in John 9:6–7.

8:23a**So He took the blind man by the hand**

- So Jesus took the blind man by the hand
- Then Jesus held one of the blind man’s hands

8:23b**and led him out of the village.**

- and led him out of the village.
- and guided him out of the small town.

8:23a–b

So: In Greek, 8:23 begins with a common conjunction that the BSB translates as So. It introduces Jesus’ response to the request of the people. He did not respond directly, but by his action he showed that he was willing to do as they asked. Connect this verse to the preceding one in a natural way in your language.

He took the blind man by the hand and led him:

Jesus took the blind man’s hand to lead him so that he would know where to go and would not stumble. In some cultures people may have a different way to lead blind people. For example, a person may hold one end of a cane and the blind man hold the other. If the way that Jesus led the blind man would seem odd in your culture, you may need to use a more general expression. For example:

Jesus led the blind man along

led him out of the village: Jesus led the man to a place outside the village, away from the people who had brought him. This is very similar to what he did with the deaf man in 7:33.

8:23c**Then He spit on the man’s eyes**

- Jesus/he spit on the man’s eyes
- Next, Jesus spit into the man’s eyes

Then He spit on the man’s eyes: This part of the verse indicates that Jesus actually spit into the man’s eyes. He did this as part of the process of healing him. In some cultures people may not understand the purpose of this action. In some areas it may express a wrong

meaning like contempt, or it may be considered too offensive. If that is true in your area, here are some options for translation:

- Use a more indirect expression. For example:

Then, putting spittle on his eyes (NJB)

Then Jesus put some of his own spittle on the man's eyes

- Indicate the purpose of the action. For example:

Then Jesus spit into the man's eyes to heal them/him

8:23d and placed His hands on him.

- and placed his hands on him.
- and laid his hands on the man to heal him.

and placed His hands on him: The Greek text does not say where on the man Jesus put his hands. However, it is likely that Jesus covered the man's eyes, since that is what he did in 8:25. If your translation requires that you specify a location, you can say that he covered the man's eyes.

8:23e “Can you see anything?” He asked.

- He asked the man, “Can you^(sing) see anything now?”
- Then he asked him, “What do you^(sing) see?”
- Then Jesus asked him if he could see anything.

“Can you see anything?” He asked: In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech here. For example, the CEV says:

He...asked him if he could see anything.

Can you see anything?: This is a real question. Jesus was asking the blind man whether he could now see anything. The GNT says:

Can you see anything?

He asked: There is implied information here. Jesus took his hands off the man's eyes before he asked him the question in this verse. Be sure that this is clear in your translation.

Mark 8:24

Section 8:22–26: Jesus healed a blind man at Bethsaida

Jesus and his disciples left the Pharisees at the region of Dalmanutha and got back into their boat. In this section, they had crossed the Sea of Galilee and landed at the village of Bethsaida on the northeast shore of the lake. As soon as they arrived, some people brought a blind man to Jesus so that Jesus would heal him.

The main people in this story are Jesus and the blind man. The meaning lines of the Display sometimes use the nouns “Jesus” and “the man,” sometimes the pronouns “he” or “him,” to refer to them. In some languages it may be more natural to refer to them in different ways in some of these situations. Refer to Jesus and the blind man in a way that is natural in your language.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The healing of a blind man at Bethsaida

A blind man healed at Bethsaida

There are no direct parallel passages for this section. Some similar terms are used in John 9:6–7.

8:24a The man looked up and said, “I can see the people,

- The man looked up and said, “Yes, I can see people;
- He looked around and replied, “I can see people.
- The man looked up and said that he could see people,

The man looked up: Before the man was able to answer Jesus, he looked around. The expression does not indicate that he looked up into the sky. The NLT translates this as:

The man looked around.

and said, “I can see the people: Here the man responded to Jesus' question in 8:23e. Be sure that your translation of the response fits with the question. For example:

he said, “Yes, I see people...”

and replied, “I can see people...”

Use a natural response in your language.

I can see the people: The text does not indicate which people the man saw. He was outside the village, but the disciples were there, and there may have been other people passing by also.

people: The Greek word that the BSB translates as people refers to people in general, either male or female.

8:24b
but they look like trees walking around.”

- they look like they are trees that are walking.”
- But I cannot see them very clearly. They are like trees that are walking around.”
- but that they looked like trees walking.

but: The conjunction that the BSB translates as but literally means “that.” The BSB uses this conjunction because there is an implied contrast between this statement and the statement in 8:24a. No one expects people to look like trees. In some languages it may be natural to make this contrast explicit.

they look like trees walking around: The man was not able to see clearly. The people walking by looked to him like big blurry shapes moving around. It may also be necessary to make explicit why the man thought the people looked like trees. For example, the NLT says:

...but I can't see them very clearly. They look like trees walking around.

Mark 8:25

Section 8:22–26: Jesus healed a blind man at Bethsaida

Jesus and his disciples left the Pharisees at the region of Dalmanutha and got back into their boat. In this section, they had crossed the Sea of Galilee and landed at the village of Bethsaida on the northeast shore of the lake. As soon as they arrived, some people brought a blind man to Jesus so that Jesus would heal him.

The main people in this story are Jesus and the blind man. The meaning lines of the Display sometimes use the nouns “Jesus” and “the man,” sometimes the pronouns “he” or “him,” to refer to them. In some languages it may be more natural to refer to them in different ways in some of these situations. Refer to Jesus and the blind man in a way that is natural in your language.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The healing of a blind man at Bethsaida

A blind man healed at Bethsaida

There are no direct parallel passages for this section. Some similar terms are used in John 9:6–7.

8:25a

Once again Jesus placed His hands on the man's eyes,

- ¶ Jesus placed his hands on the man's eyes a second time.
- ¶ Then again Jesus laid his hands over the man's eyes,

Once again Jesus placed His hands on the man's eyes: Jesus repeated what he did in 8:23d. The man probably closed his eyes as Jesus laid his hands on the man's eyes. Your translation should not suggest that Jesus left his hands over the man's eyes.

8:25b–d

See the General Comment on 8:25b–d after 8:25d for a discussion of how these verse parts relate to each other.

8:25b

and when he opened them

- Then the man looked around intently
- and this time the man stared. (CEV)

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and introduces an event that happened immediately after the events in 8:25a. Connect 8:25b to 8:25a in a way that is natural in your language. Consider whether or not it is natural to begin a new sentence here.

he opened them: There is a textual issue here. (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the expression that the BSB translates as he opened them. For example, the GNT says: “the man looked intently.” (2) Other Greek manuscripts have the phrase that the KJV translates as “he made him look up.” For example the KJV says: “and made him look up” (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1) as the majority of English versions do. There are two main ways to interpret the Greek expression that the BSB translates as he opened them:

1. It means that he looked intently. For example, the NLT96 says:

the man stared intently (GNT, RSV, REB, NASB, NLT96, CEV)

1. It means that he saw clearly. For example, the GW says:

the man saw clearly (NJB, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The majority of English versions follow this interpretation. It also seems to fit more easily with the other two similar verbs in 8:25c and 8:25d. See the note on 8:25b–d for further discussion.

8:25c **his sight was restored,**

- and his sight was completely restored.
- His eyes were healed, (CEV)

his sight was restored: The phrase his sight was restored indicates that the man's eyes were healed and he was able to see again. It implies that the man could see at an earlier time in his life, but then became blind in some way.

8:25d **and he could see everything clearly.**

- He could see everything clearly.
- and he was able to see everything plainly.

and he could see everything clearly: There is a textual issue here. (1) Some Greek texts have the meaning everything. For example, the NLT says: “everything” (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NET, NCV, GW, NASB, CEV, REB, GNT, ESV, JBP). (2) Other Greek texts have the meaning everyone. For example the KJV says: “every man” (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1) as the majority of English versions do. After the man was cured in 8:25c, he could see everything well.

General Comment on 8:25b–d

Each part of 8:25b–d contains an expression that describes an aspect of the man becoming able to see again. These three verse parts express the climax of the story. Express it in an exciting and natural way in your language. Be sure that your translation describes the sequence of events in a natural way. The NCV has one way to describe the sequence in English:

^{25b}the man opened his eyes wide ^{25c}and they were healed, ^{25d}and he was able to see everything clearly

The clauses his sight was restored and he could see everything clearly (8:25c) both indicate that the blind

man was completely healed. These clauses emphasize this amazing miracle. Express this emphasis in a natural way in your language. For example, here is another way to translate 8:25b–d:

He looked intently and was able to see everything with perfect clarity!

Mark 8:26

Section 8:22–26: Jesus healed a blind man at Bethsaida

Jesus and his disciples left the Pharisees at the region of Dalmanutha and got back into their boat. In this section, they had crossed the Sea of Galilee and landed at the village of Bethsaida on the northeast shore of the lake. As soon as they arrived, some people brought a blind man to Jesus so that Jesus would heal him.

The main people in this story are Jesus and the blind man. The meaning lines of the Display sometimes use the nouns “Jesus” and “the man,” sometimes the pronouns “he” or “him,” to refer to them. In some languages it may be more natural to refer to them in different ways in some of these situations. Refer to Jesus and the blind man in a way that is natural in your language.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The healing of a blind man at Bethsaida

A blind man healed at Bethsaida

There are no direct parallel passages for this section. Some similar terms are used in John 9:6–7.

8:26a **Jesus sent him home**

- Jesus sent him to his house,
- And/Then Jesus told the man to go to his home

In Greek, 8:26 begins with the common conjunction that is often translated as “and.” Here it introduces what happened after Jesus healed the man. Connect 8:25 and 8:26 in a natural way in your language.

Jesus sent him home: After Jesus healed the man of his blindness, he told the man to go home. The translation should not sound like Jesus was treating the man in a harsh way.

See the General Comment on 8:26a–b for another translation suggestion.

8:26b

and said, “Do not go back into the village.”

- saying, “Do not go^(sing) back into the village.”
- and ordered him not to return to the village.

Do not go back into the village: There is a textual issue here. (1) Some Greek texts have the meaning “Don’t go into the village.” For example, the GW says: “Don’t go into the village” (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NET, NCV, GW, NASB, CEV, REB, GNT, ESV, JBP). (2) Other Greek texts have the meaning “nor tell anyone in the village.” For example the KJV says: “nor tell [it] to any in the town” (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1) as the majority of English versions do. Jesus did not want the man to tell the people in the village about the miracle. That is the reason he told him to return to his home without entering the village.

General Comment on 8:26a–b

Languages have different ways to use direct and indirect speech. In some languages it may be more natural to use direct speech in both 8:26a and 8:26b. For example, the CEV says:

Jesus said to him, “You may return home now, but don’t go into the village.”

In other languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech in both parts of the verse. For example:

Then Jesus sent him home and told him not to go into the village.

Mark 8:27

Section 8:27–30: Peter declared that Jesus is the Christ

After Jesus healed the blind man in Bethsaida, he and his disciples left the region of Galilee and traveled north. They went to the towns around the city of Caesarea Philippi, which was near the northern border of Israel.

As they were traveling, Jesus asked his disciples what people were saying about who he was. This question concerned his spiritual identity; that is, whether God had sent him and what his mission was. He then asked the disciples what they themselves thought about him. Peter replied that Jesus was the Christ, the Messiah. Jesus then ordered them not to tell others who he was.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Peter’s declaration that Jesus is the Christ

Peter believes that Jesus is the Christ

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 16:13–16 and Luke 9:18–21.

8:27a

Then Jesus and His disciples went on

- ¶ Then Jesus and his disciples set out from Bethsaida
- ¶ After that, Jesus and his followers left Bethsaida and went

Then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Then introduces the next story. This story (found in 8:27–30) began sometime after the story in 8:22–26 ended. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories. In some languages, it is natural to begin a story with a time word or phrase. If your language does that, use an expression here that is not too specific. For example:

After that

Sometime later

His disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means “learners” who are in a relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

students/learners

apprentices

followers

See how you translated this term at 2:15b and 8:1c. See also disciple in the Glossary for more information.

went on: The Greek word that the BSB translates as went on literally means “went out.” Jesus and his disciples left or “went out” from the town of Bethsaida in Galilee. The NLT makes explicit that they left Galilee. It has:

left Galilee and went up to the villages near Caesarea Philippi

Your translation of 8:27a should not imply that Jesus and his disciples arrived in Caesarea Philippi before the events of 8:27c. Some English versions have made this clear by using a different verb. For example:

set out for the villages of Caesarea Philippi (REB)

left for the villages round Caesarea Philippi (NJB)

8:27b

to the villages around Caesarea Philippi.

- to go to the villages near the city of Caesarea Philippi.
- to the towns around the city of Caesarea Philippi.

to the villages around Caesarea Philippi: The phrase villages around Caesarea Philippi refers to the villages or towns that were near the city called Caesarea Philippi.

Caesarea Philippi: Caesarea Philippi was a city that was near the northern border of Israel. Although it was in Israel, the majority of people there were not Jews. They worshiped pagan gods. The name Caesarea Philippi distinguished this city from another city called Caesarea on the coast of Israel north of Joppa.

8:27c

On the way, He questioned His disciples:

- As they were walking, Jesus asked them,
- While they were traveling, he asked his disciples,

On the way, He questioned His disciples: Jesus asked his disciples the question in 8:27d while he was traveling with them. They may have been traveling northward from Galilee or else traveling between towns in the area around Caesarea Philippi. Since we do not know their exact location, translate it in a general way.

8:27d

“Who do people say I am?”

- “Who do people say that I am?”
- “What are people saying about me?”

Who do people say I am?: The question Who do people say I am? is asking more than who Jesus’ parents were, where he grew up, or what his name was. Jesus knew that the people who saw him do miracles had an opinion about how he got such power. The disciples’ response shows that the people believed that Jesus was a prophet, perhaps the great prophet Elijah or John the Baptist. Translate the question in 8:27d in a way that fits with the response in 8:28.

people: The Greek word that the BSB translates as people refers to people in general. Jesus was probably referring to people in the crowds who came to listen to him.

say: In this context the verb say refers to what the people thought or believed, as well as to what they said. In some languages it may be more natural to use a verb like “think” or “believe” here.

Mark 8:28

Section 8:27–30: Peter declared that Jesus is the Christ

After Jesus healed the blind man in Bethsaida, he and his disciples left the region of Galilee and traveled north. They went to the towns around the city of Caesarea Philippi, which was near the northern border of Israel.

As they were traveling, Jesus asked his disciples what people were saying about who he was. This question concerned his spiritual identity; that is, whether God had sent him and what his mission was. He then asked the disciples what they themselves thought about him. Peter replied that Jesus was the Christ, the Messiah. Jesus then ordered them not to tell others who he was.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Peter’s declaration that Jesus is the Christ

Peter believes that Jesus is the Christ

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 16:13–16 and Luke 9:18–21.

8:28

In this verse the disciples indicated that the people thought that Jesus was a prophet. All of the people whom they mentioned were prophets who had already died.

8:28a**They replied, “Some say John the Baptist;**

- The disciples answered, “Some say that you are John the Baptizer;
- They told him, “Some people think/believe that you are John who baptized people.

Some say John the Baptist: In this part of the verse the disciples answered Jesus’ question in a natural way. They left some information implied because the meaning was clear from his question. In some languages it may be natural to make some or all of the information explicit. For example:

Some of the people say that you are John the Baptist

John the Baptist: This man, John, was called the Baptist because he baptized people. See how you translated John the Baptist in 6:14d and 6:25b.

8:28b**others say Elijah;**

- others say that you are the prophet Elijah.
- Other people think/believe that you are Elijah the prophet;

others say Elijah: In this part of the verse the disciples again left some information in their answer implied. In some languages it may be natural to make this information explicit. For example:

Other people say that you are Elijah

Elijah: Elijah was a prophet who lived more than five hundred years before Jesus. If people in your area do not know about Elijah, you may want to:

- Include some implied information in the text. For example:

Elijah the prophet

- Include a footnote to give information about him. Here is an example of a footnote:

Elijah was a prophet who lived more than five hundred years before Jesus. Jews thought that Elijah would return before the Messiah. They based this belief on Malachi 4:5–6.

8:28c**and still others, one of the prophets.”**

- And others say that you are one of the other prophets.”
- but others think/believe that you are another one of the prophets.”

and still others, one of the prophets: The word still here indicates that the disciples were mentioning a third group of people who had another opinion. In this part of the verse the disciples again left some of the information in their reply implied. In some languages it may be necessary to make this information explicit, as in the previous two verse parts. For example:

and some other people say that you are one of the prophets

one of the prophets: In this context the prophets refers to men whom God sent in Old Testament times to speak his messages to people. Many of them did miracles that showed that God was with them. The Jews knew many stories of these men and what they had done by God’s power. Some of the Jews thought that Jesus was one of these prophets. Since Elijah was also a prophet, it may be natural to translate this as:

one of the other prophets

prophets: The word prophets refers to men who speak on behalf of God. A prophet tells people what God has revealed to him, and he also gives them messages from God.

Here are some other ways to translate prophets:

spokesmen for God

men who speak God’s words

God’s message-speakers

When choosing a term for prophets, consider how you will translate other words which are similar in meaning such as “angel,” “apostle,” and “preacher.”

While prophets did foretell the future, this was not their only function. Avoid using a word that focuses on telling the future.

See how you translated this word in 1:2a and 6:4. See also prophet in the Glossary for more information.

Mark 8:29

Section 8:27–30: Peter declared that Jesus is the Christ

After Jesus healed the blind man in Bethsaida, he and his disciples left the region of Galilee and traveled north. They went to the towns around the city of Caesarea Philippi, which was near the northern border of Israel.

As they were traveling, Jesus asked his disciples what people were saying about who he was. This question concerned his spiritual identity; that is, whether God had sent him and what his mission was. He then asked the disciples what they themselves thought about him. Peter replied that Jesus was the Christ, the Messiah. Jesus then ordered them not to tell others who he was.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Peter's declaration that Jesus is the Christ

Peter believes that Jesus is the Christ

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 16:13–16 and Luke 9:18–21.

8:29a

“But what about you?” Jesus asked.

- Then he asked them, “But what about you?^(plur)
- And Jesus then asked his disciples what they thought:

8:29b

“Who do you say I am?”

- Who do you^(plur) say that I am?”
- “But who do you^(plur) yourselves think/believe that I am?”

8:29a–b

In this verse Jesus asked his disciples to tell him their own beliefs about who he was.

But what about you?...Who do you say I am?: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as But what about you?...Who do you say I am? is more literally “But you,^(plur) who do you^(plur) say I am?” The pronoun you is repeated for emphasis. It emphasizes the difference between the people's opinions and the disciples' opinions.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

But you,...who do you say I am? (NJB)

But who do you yourselves say I am?

say: Here the word say again means “think” or “believe.” See the note on say at 8:27d.

Jesus asked: The BSB has placed the phrase Jesus asked in the middle of Jesus' question to his disciples. In the Greek text it comes before the speech begins. Place it where it is most natural in your language.

8:29c

Peter answered, “You are the Christ.”

- Peter replied, “You^(sing) are the Christ, the one sent by God!”
- Peter answered, “You^(sing) are the Messiah!”

the Christ: The phrase the Christ is used here as a title. It is not just one of Jesus' names. The Jews used this title to refer to the special person whom God had appointed and promised to send as king and savior. The title the Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew title “the Messiah,” and the two titles have the same meaning.

Here are some other ways to translate the Christ:

- Transliterate it. For example:

Krais

Karisiti

- Transliterate it and indicate in some way that it is a title. For example:

the Christ

the Kirisita

- Transliterate Christ and include a phrase that explains the meaning. For example:

Christ, the appointed one

Cristo, the savior God promised

the Christ who comes from God

If you do not indicate the meaning of the Christ in the text, you may want to include a footnote to explain

the meaning of the Christ. Or you may want to explain the meaning in a glossary. For example:

The title “the Christ” refers to the King and Savior whom God had promised to send.

See also Christ in the Glossary.

Mark 8:30

Section 8:27–30: Peter declared that Jesus is the Christ

After Jesus healed the blind man in Bethsaida, he and his disciples left the region of Galilee and traveled north. They went to the towns around the city of Caesarea Philippi, which was near the northern border of Israel.

As they were traveling, Jesus asked his disciples what people were saying about who he was. This question concerned his spiritual identity; that is, whether God had sent him and what his mission was. He then asked the disciples what they themselves thought about him. Peter replied that Jesus was the Christ, the Messiah. Jesus then ordered them not to tell others who he was.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Peter’s declaration that Jesus is the Christ

Peter believes that Jesus is the Christ

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 16:13–16 and Luke 9:18–21.

8:30

And Jesus warned them not to tell anyone about Him.

- And Jesus ordered them not to tell others about him.
- Then Jesus commanded the disciples that they should tell no one this about him at that time.

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And introduces what Jesus said next. Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. Other English versions, such as the GNT, translates it as “Then.” Connect this verse to 8:29 in a natural way in your language.

Jesus warned them: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as warned in this context means “commanded.”

Here are some other ways English versions have translated Jesus warned them:

Jesus ordered them (GNT)

he gave them strict orders (NJB)

he charged them (RSV)

not to tell anyone about Him: Jesus told the disciples not to tell anyone what Peter had said about Jesus. What Peter said was true, but it was not the right time for all the people to hear that Jesus was the Messiah. Your translation should not suggest that Jesus denied that he was the Messiah.

General Comment on 8:30

It may be more natural in your language to put Jesus’ warning to the disciples in direct speech. For example, the GNT says:

Then Jesus ordered them, “Do not tell anyone about me.”

Mark 8:31

Section 8:31–33: Jesus told his disciples that he must suffer, die, and live again

In the preceding section, Peter declared that Jesus was the Messiah, the Christ. In this section, Jesus explained to the disciples what would happen to him as the Messiah. In contrast to what the disciples thought that Jesus would do as their Messiah, God had planned for him to suffer, die, and live again.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus tells his disciples about his coming death and resurrection

Jesus told his disciples that people would kill him but he would live again after three days

Jesus speaks about his death

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 16:21–23 and Luke 9:22–23.

8:31a

Then He began to teach them

- ¶ Then Jesus began to teach them
- ¶ Then Jesus began to tell his disciples
- ¶ Jesus then gave his followers a new teaching. He said,

Then: In Greek, this verse begins with the common conjunction that is often translated as “and.” The BSB translates it as Then. However, some English versions, such as the NIV, do not translate this conjunction. In this context it introduces what Jesus did next. Connect this verse to 8:30 in a natural way in your language.

He began to teach them: The phrase He began to teach them indicates that Jesus began to teach his disciples about a new topic. Because this is the start of a new section and a new paragraph, it may be natural to refer explicitly to Jesus and his disciples:

Jesus began to teach his disciples

8:31b

that the Son of Man must suffer many things

- that it was necessary for the Son of Man to suffer in many ways.
- that it was God’s will/plan that he, the Son of Man, must suffer many terrible things.
- “Certain things must happen to me, the Son of Man: I must endure many sufferings.

that the Son of Man must suffer many things: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as the Son of Man must suffer is literally “it is necessary for the Son of Man to suffer.” This statement implies that the suffering was necessary because it was God’s will or plan. It was something that must happen that was beyond the control of human beings.

the Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is literally “the Son of the human/person.” Jesus used this phrase as a title for himself. He used this title to imply that:

1. he was a true human being, and he represented all people.
2. he came from God and had authority from God.

Try to use an expression that implies both meanings. Here are some other expressions that translators have used:

the Man whom God Sent

the True Man from God/Heaven

the Representative of Mankind

The Older Brother of All People

In some cases, an unusual title may correctly suggest a deeper meaning. For example:

the Child of a Person

the One who was Born as a Human

Translators have also used expressions that are more literal. These more literal expressions may be appropriate where readers are familiar with a literal title in another version.

In some languages it may be necessary to use a form like “I” or “me” to indicate that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

me, the Son of Man

I who became man/human

See how you translated Son of Man at 2:10a and 2:28.

must: The Greek word that the BSB translates as must applies to all the following verbs in this verse: “suffer,” “be rejected,” “be killed,” and “rise again.” The verb indicates that it was necessary for all these things to happen because God had planned for them to happen. Be sure to indicate that in some way in your language.

suffer many things: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as suffer many things indicates that Jesus would have to suffer in various ways. It also implies that the suffering was terrible and was not just for a short time.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

suffer a lot (GW)

undergo many sufferings

suffer many terrible things (NLT)

8:31c

and be rejected by the elders, chief priests, and scribes,

- It was necessary for him to be rejected by the elders, the chief priests, and the teachers of the law
- He must endure rejection by the Jewish leaders, leading priests, and experts in the law,
- It must happen that our elders, most important priests, and experts in the law will refuse to accept me,

be rejected: To be rejected means to “(someone) refuses to accept (something).” In this verse it means that the groups of Jewish leaders would refuse to believe that Jesus was their Messiah.

by the elders, chief priests, and scribes: These three groups together represented all the leaders of the Jews. The elders were the civil leaders or rulers. They were generally older men. The chief priests were the leading priests, and the scribes were the experts in the religious law.

chief priests: A Jewish priest was a man who offered sacrifices to God on behalf of the people. He also performed other rituals for them. The phrase the...chief priests refers to the leaders among these priests.

Here are some other ways to translate chief priests:

the leading/ruling priests

the elders among the Jewish sacrificers

the most prominent priests

See how you translated “priest” in 1:44b.

scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes is sometimes translated as “teachers of the law,” as in the NIV. The original work of these men was to copy the laws of Moses by hand. In New Testament times, their main task was to study, interpret, and teach the law of Moses and related Jewish laws and traditions.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

the teachers of the Law of Moses (CEV)

the teachers of religious law (NLT)

the experts in the law (NET)

See how you translated this in 1:22c and 7:5a. Also, see teacher of the law in the Glossary for more information.

8:31d and that He must be killed

- and be put to death
- and it must happen that people will kill him
- and that I must be killed.

He must be killed: This is a passive clause. The pronoun He refers to Jesus as the Son of Man, and the focus is still on him. In some languages it may be necessary to use an active verb. If this is true in your language, you may have another way to indicate that the focus is on Jesus. For example:

he must die by the hand/action of men

it must happen that people will kill him

killed: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as killed means “to cause a person to die.” In this context people would kill Jesus. They would execute him, though he had done nothing wrong. Use an appropriate verb for this in your language. For example, the GNT and NJB say:

put to death

8:31e and after three days rise again.

- and come to life again on the third day.
- and three days later, he will become alive again.
- Then it must happen that after three days I will live again.”

and after three days: The expression after three days refers to three days after Jesus’ death. The Jews counted any part of a day as a whole day. The day on which Jesus died was counted as one day. The complete day that he was in the tomb was counted as the second day. The part of the day before he rose from the dead was counted as the third day.

rise again: The phrase rise again refers to the Son of Man (Jesus) becoming alive again after he died. Be sure that the expression you use does not imply that Jesus did not really die but revived after almost dying. Use an expression that clearly refers to literal death and to a real return to life.

Here are some other ways to translate rise again:

he will rise to life (GNT)

and then rise from the dead (NCV)

In some languages it will not be possible to use a word such as “rise,” because it may refer only to standing up.

Here are some other ways to translate the correct meaning:

he will live again

he will become alive again

Use an expression that communicates this meaning clearly in your language.

General Comment on 8:31a–c

It may be more natural in your language to put what Jesus taught his disciples into direct speech, as the GNT has done:

Then Jesus began to teach his disciples: “The Son of Man must suffer much and be rejected by the elders, the chief priests, and the teachers of the Law. He will be put to death, but three days later he will rise to life.”

Mark 8:32

Section 8:31–33: Jesus told his disciples that he must suffer, die, and live again

In the preceding section, Peter declared that Jesus was the Messiah, the Christ. In this section, Jesus explained to the disciples what would happen to him as the Messiah. In contrast to what the disciples thought that Jesus would do as their Messiah, God had planned for him to suffer, die, and live again.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus tells his disciples about his coming death and resurrection

Jesus told his disciples that people would kill him but he would live again after three days

Jesus speaks about his death

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 16:21–23 and Luke 9:22–23.

8:32a

He spoke this message quite frankly,

- Jesus spoke clearly to his disciples about these things,
- Jesus told them bluntly/frankly that these things would and must happen.

He spoke this message quite frankly: This phrase means that Jesus clearly told his disciples that he would suffer, die, and live again. He also clearly said that those things must happen. He concealed nothing but spoke boldly about it.

8:32b

and Peter took Him aside

- So Peter took Jesus a short distance from the others
- But when Peter heard what he said, he led Jesus aside to speak alone with him

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *and* here introduces what Peter did in response to what Jesus had said. The GNT has “So” to indicate this. In some languages a different connector may be more appropriate. For example:

When Peter heard this...

But Peter...

Connect this part of the verse to the preceding one in a natural way in your language.

Peter took Him aside: Peter wanted to correct Jesus privately, so he led him a short distance away from the other disciples.

8:32c

and began to rebuke Him.

- and began to reproach him.
- and told him to stop saying those things.

began to rebuke Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *rebuke* means “scold” or “reproach.” Peter reproached Jesus because of what Jesus had said. Peter did not want the Messiah to suffer and die, so he told Jesus not to say these things about himself. See how you translated “rebuke” in 1:25 and “warned them sternly” in 3:12, where Jesus rebukes evil spirits.

You may want to include a footnote here about what the Jews expected their Messiah to be like. For example:

The Jews expected their Messiah to be a great king who would defeat all their enemies. They did not expect him to suffer and die.

Mark 8:33

Section 8:31–33: Jesus told his disciples that he must suffer, die, and live again

In the preceding section, Peter declared that Jesus was the Messiah, the Christ. In this section, Jesus explained to the disciples what would happen to him as the Messiah. In contrast to what the disciples thought that Jesus would do as their Messiah, God had planned for him to suffer, die, and live again.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus tells his disciples about his coming death and resurrection

Jesus told his disciples that people would kill him but he would live again after three days

Jesus speaks about his death

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 16:21–23 and Luke 9:22–23.

8:33a

But Jesus, turning and looking at His disciples,

- But Jesus turned back and looked at the disciples.
- But turning around, Jesus looked at his followers

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *But* here introduces a contrast between Peter's rebuke in 8:32 and Jesus' response in 8:33b–c. Introduce this response in a natural way in your language.

Jesus, turning and looking at His disciples: After Peter rebuked Jesus, Jesus turned and looked at his other disciples. He wanted them to hear what he would say to Peter. In some languages it may be more natural to make this an independent clause. For example, the NLT96 says:

Jesus turned and looked at his disciples.

His disciples: See how you translated this term at 2:15b and 8:10a. See also *disciple* in the Glossary for more information.

8:33b

rebuked Peter and said, “Get behind Me, Satan!”

- Then he rebuked Peter and said, “Get away from me, Satan!”
- and reproached Peter, saying, “Those thoughts are from Satan; I will not listen to them!”

rebuked Peter and said: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *rebuked* is another form of the same word that was translated as “rebuke” in 8:32c. Jesus rebuked Peter sternly. The NCV shows another way to say this:

Then he told Peter not to talk that way. He said...

In some languages it may be natural to use only one verb of speech here instead of both *rebuked* and *said*. For example:

he said to Peter sternly

Get behind Me, Satan!: Jesus rebuked Peter with the words *Get behind Me, Satan!* The phrase *Get behind Me* is an idiom. It usually means “go away from me.” In this context Jesus was implying that the things that Peter said in his rebuke came from Satan. He was tempting Jesus not to follow God's plan, and Jesus emphatically rejected that idea. See Matthew 4:1–10, where Satan tempted Jesus in a similar way.

In some languages it may be confusing for Jesus to call Peter “Satan.” If that is true in your language, you may need to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

What you are saying is from Satan; I will not listen to it!

The context shows that when Jesus used the phrase *Get behind Me*, he was rejecting the ideas that Peter had expressed. He was not literally ordering Peter to go away. If a literal translation would be confusing in your language, you may be able to say:

That idea from Satan should go/be far from me!

Satan: The word *Satan* is the Hebrew name of the chief or leader of all the evil spirits. In Hebrew his name means “enemy.” He is the enemy of God and God's people.

Here are some other ways to translate *Satan*:

- Use a local name or idiom that refers to the chief of all demons.
- Use a descriptive phrase such as:

the chief/leader of the evil spirits

the spirit enemy of God

- Transliterate the name Satan. If this word is not already known in your area, you may also want to add a descriptive phrase. For example:

Satanas, the ruler of demons

Shaitan If you transliterate Satan or borrow a word from another language, be sure that it communicates the biblical meaning to people in your culture. It is important to check this in each biblical context.

Try to use a term that will be acceptable to churches in the area. It is suggested that you also add a footnote or glossary entry that further explains who Satan is. For example:

Satan is the leader of all the evil spirits or demons. Once he was an angel in heaven, but he rebelled against God. God expelled him from heaven, and now he tempts people on earth. Here are other names for Satan that are used in the Bible: “Beelzebul,” “the Devil,” “the Evil One,” “the Enemy,” and “the Tempter.”

See how you translated this word in 1:13a and 4:15b.

8:33c

For you do not have in mind the things of God, but the things of men.”

- You^(sing) are not thinking as God thinks, but as men think!”
- You are not considering God’s interests/purposes. You are considering human interests/purposes!”

For you do not have in mind the things of God, but the things of men: The Greek word that the BSB translates as have in mind means “have an opinion about (something),” “think about (something) in a certain way,” or “consider (something).” Here Jesus indicated that Peter was not considering the things of God. He was considering the things of men. Jesus also implied that Peter’s opinion was different from God’s opinion.

The NJB has another way to translate this:

You are thinking not as God thinks but as human beings do.

In some languages it may be natural to put the positive statement first. For example:

Your thoughts are men’s thoughts, not God’s!

you: The pronoun you here refers to Peter and not to Satan. Be sure that this is clear in your translation.

the things of God, but the things of men: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the things of God is a general expression. In this context it refers to thoughts, desires, and interests that God has. The phrase the things of men is similar. It refers to people’s thoughts, desires, and interests. In this context Jesus contrasted the things of God and the things of human beings. He implied that what God thinks and desires is different from what people think and desire.

God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as God refers here to the eternal spirit who created everything. He is more powerful than any other spirit, and he is perfectly good and wise. He deserves to be worshiped.

Here are some other ways to translate God:

- Use a name or title for God that people in your culture already use.
- Use a descriptive term that fits the truth about God that is revealed in the Bible. For example:

Creator

Great Spirit

Ruler of the universe

Choose a term that is acceptable to the believers and churches in your area. For more detailed information, see God in the Glossary.

men: The Greek word that the BSB translates as men means “people.” It does not refer only to males.

Mark 8:34

Section 8:34–9:1: Jesus spoke about what a person must do to be his disciple

In the preceding section Jesus was speaking to his disciples. In this section Jesus called the crowd of people who were there to come and listen to him also. So in these verses Jesus was speaking to the crowd,

as well as to his disciples. This meant that most of the people to whom Jesus spoke were not his followers. Many of them may have been part of the people whom Jesus described in 8:38b as “this adulterous and sinful generation.”

The requirements for being/becoming a disciple are given in 8:34. The phrases in 8:34b–d are arranged in the form of a chiasm: (A) wants to come after Me, (B) must deny himself, (B') take up his cross, (A') follow Me. The expressions in (A) and (A') both refer to following Jesus as a disciple, but they are not redundant. Actually obeying Jesus and following him as a disciple (A') involves more than simply wanting to become his disciple (A). Similarly, (B) and (B') both involve denying oneself, but picking up and carrying one's cross (B') is a specific and extreme example of self-denial. The next verses (8:35–38) each explain why a person who wants to follow Christ must obey the commands given in 8:34. Each reason involves a choice between the present and the future. A person who chooses to avoid death and shame in the present life will be shamed in the future at the final judgment. He will forfeit true life with God. By contrast, a person who chooses to follow Christ may lose his present life but he will gain true life with God.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told people how to be his true disciples

What It Means to Follow Jesus (GW)

Following Jesus (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 16:24–28 and Luke 9:23–27. See also Luke 14:27, 17:33; John 12:25.

8:34a

Then Jesus called the crowd to Him along with His disciples,

- ¶ Then Jesus called the crowd to come closer to his disciples,
- ¶ Then he invited the many people who were nearby to come and listen to him, along with his followers.

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then and the RSV as “And” here introduces the next event in the story. After Jesus spoke to his disciples,

he called the crowd to him. Connect 8:34a to 8:33 in a way that is natural in your language.

Jesus called the crowd to Him along with His disciples:

Jesus called the crowd of people to come closer to him and join the disciples. He did this so that they could clearly hear what he wanted to tell them. Remember that Jesus' disciples were already near him in 8:33.

the crowd: This is the first time that the crowd is mentioned in this section. Apparently there was a large group of people nearby who wanted to hear what Jesus said. Introduce the crowd in a natural way for your language.

His disciples: See how you translated disciples in 2:15b and 8:33a. See also disciple in the Glossary.

8:34b–38

In these verses Jesus talked about anyone and everyone who wanted to be his disciple. Indicate this in a natural way in your language. In some languages it may be more natural to use a different subject than the BSB does. Here are examples from 8:34b–c:

If people want to follow me, they must give up the things they want. (NCV)

If any of you want to be my followers, you must forget about yourself. (CEV)

8:34b

and He told them, “If anyone wants to come after Me,

- and he said, “If any of you^(plur) truly want/desire to be/become my disciples,
- He said to them, “Anyone who wants to be/become my follower

If anyone wants to come after Me: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as If anyone wants to come after Me is literally “If anyone desires after me to follow.” It refers to anyone who wanted to follow Jesus as his disciple.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

If any want to become my followers (NRSV)

Anyone who desires/decides to be my disciple

Another form of the word “follow” is used in 8:34d.

wants: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as wants means “desires to,” “wishes to” or “wants to.” In this context, it may imply “truly wants to.”

8:34c-d

he must deny himself and take up his cross and follow Me: The Greek phrases that the BSB translates as must deny himself and take up his cross and follow Me are three indirect commands. A person who desires to be one of Jesus’ disciples must do three things:

1. He must deny himself,
2. he must take up his cross, and
3. he must follow Jesus as a disciple.

Indicate in a natural way in your language that a person must do each of these actions in order to be a follower of Jesus. There are differences of interpretation here that are not reflected in English versions. For example: 1) The phrase “take up his cross and follow me” can mean “be ready to suffer and follow me to death.” Notice that this view does not interpret the last verb “follow” as an actual action but a readiness for that action. 2) The phrase “and follow me” is a reason for the suffering, e.g. TRT: “willing/ready to suffer and even die for following Me” (page 107). These two views contrast with the view taken in these notes that there are three requirements for discipleship: self-denial, willingness to die, and obedience or continued following (see also Luke 9:23).

8:34c

he must deny himself

- you^(plur) must reject/refuse your own desires
- must give up his own plans and interests.

he must deny himself: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as deny himself means “reject one-self.” A disciple must do what his master wants him to do, whether or not it is what the disciple himself wants to do. Disciples of Jesus must give up the right to fulfill their own ambitions.

Here are some other ways to translate deny himself:

forget yourself (GNT)

put aside your selfish ambition (NLT96)

renounce self (REB)

refuse his own desires

8:34d

and take up his cross and follow Me.

- and pick up your cross and follow me.
- He must even be ready/willing to carry his cross and then follow me.
- He must also be ready to die for me. Finally, he must actually follow me as my disciple.

take up his cross: The phrase take up his cross refers to the way that Roman soldiers executed criminals. They forced a condemned criminal to pick up a large wooden cross. He had to carry it to the place where he would be put to death. Then the soldiers nailed him on the cross to die.

When Jesus used this phrase, he knew that the Romans would soon force him to carry a literal cross. But in this context, he used the phrase figuratively. Jesus meant that anyone who wanted to become his disciple had to be willing to suffer and die in order to obey him. This is the predominant view among the commentators. However, in his comment on Luke 9:23, which has “take up his cross daily,” Marshall (page 373) advances another view, which makes a lot of sense in light of Paul’s concept of dying to self. He says that a person who picked up his cross was already condemned to die. He knew he was as good as dead. So what Jesus means is that a disciple must daily reckon himself to be dead and follow/obey his master’s desires, not his own.

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase take up his cross:

- Translate the figure of speech literally and add a footnote that explains the meaning. Here is a sample footnote:

In the time of Jesus, a person who was condemned to be nailed to a cross was forced to carry the cross. He carried it to the place where he would be nailed to it. So what Jesus means here is that a person who wants to be his follower must be ready to suffer and die in order to follow Jesus.

- Omit the figure of speech and translate the meaning directly. For example, the TRT says:

be willing/ready to suffer and even die If you follow this option, consider adding a footnote that gives Jesus’ literal words.

cross: A cross refers to two large wooden boards or beams that were attached to each other. Roman soldiers used crosses to kill criminals. They nailed or tied a criminal to these wooden beams, then set them

upright. They did this in order to cause the criminal to die slowly and painfully.

The word cross comes from the fact that the beams were crossed and attached. This made the shape of a + or † (or sometimes a T).

In many languages there may be no word for cross. If that is true in your language, you may need to use a descriptive phrase. For example:

board/wood of death

crossed-beam(s) of death

a tree for killing people

a stake/plank to which they fasten/nail someone to kill him

follow Me: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as follow Me indicates that a person who wants to become a disciple must actually start following Jesus as a disciple. He must continually obey Jesus as his master.

Refer to the note on 8:34d. See also the note on “follow me” in 1:17a.

Mark 8:35

Section 8:34–9:1: Jesus spoke about what a person must do to be his disciple

In the preceding section Jesus was speaking to his disciples. In this section Jesus called the crowd of people who were there to come and listen to him also. So in these verses Jesus was speaking to the crowd, as well as to his disciples. This meant that most of the people to whom Jesus spoke were not his followers. Many of them may have been part of the people whom Jesus described in 8:38b as “this adulterous and sinful generation.”

The requirements for being/becoming a disciple are given in 8:34. The phrases in 8:34b–d are arranged in the form of a chiasm: (A) wants to come after Me, (B) must deny himself, (B') take up his cross, (A') follow Me. The expressions in (A) and (A') both refer to following Jesus as a disciple, but they are not redundant. Actually obeying Jesus and following him as a disciple (A') involves more than simply wanting to become his disciple (A). Similarly, (B) and (B') both involve denying oneself, but picking up and carrying one's cross (B') is a specific and extreme example of self-denial. The next verses (8:35–38) each explain why a person who

wants to follow Christ must obey the commands given in 8:34. Each reason involves a choice between the present and the future. A person who chooses to avoid death and shame in the present life will be shamed in the future at the final judgment. He will forfeit true life with God. By contrast, a person who chooses to follow Christ may lose his present life but he will gain true life with God.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told people how to be his true disciples

What It Means to Follow Jesus (GW)

Following Jesus (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 16:24–28 and Luke 9:23–27. See also Luke 14:27, 17:33; John 12:25.

8:35–37

life: The Greek word that the BSB translates as life is literally “soul.” It is used in two different ways in these verses:

1. It refers to a person's life on this earth, that is, to the person's physical life that ends when he or she dies. It is used in this way in 8:35a and 8:35b, where the BSB translates it as “life.”
2. It refers to a person's spiritual life. It is used in this way in 8:36b and 8:37, where the BSB translates it as “soul.” The pronoun “it” in 8:35a and 8:35b also refers to a person's spiritual life. A person's spiritual life is his true life or eternal life with God.

Notice that because of these two different meanings, you may need to translate the word in different ways in your language. The following notes will give suggestions for each context.

8:35a

For whoever wants to save his life will lose it,

- Do this because you^(plur) who try to protect/guard your life on this earth will lose/forfeit true life,
- If a person does not do this because he wants to save/preserve his physical/earthly life, he will lose the opportunity to gain spiritual/eternal life with God.

For: The word that the BSB translates as For introduces the reason or explanation for Jesus' commands

in 8:34. A person should obey these commands because whoever avoids following Christ because he wants to save his physical life will not gain true life with God. However, a person who becomes a disciple and dies because of it will experience true life with God.

In some languages, it may be more natural to use a phrase to express this connection. For example:

The reason is, whoever wants...

The reason why a person should do this is that whoever wants...

Because whoever doesn't follow Me because he wants... (TRT)

In other languages an explicit connecting word or phrase may not be needed. Show this connection in a way that is natural in your language.

whoever wants to save his life: The phrase whoever wants to save his life refers here to a person who wants to protect his physical life in the world. He does not want to die for Jesus. He is not willing to become a disciple by denying himself and being ready to die (8:35b).

Here are some other ways to translate this:

whoever wants to protect his own life

if you want to guard your life on this earth

whoever tries to save himself so that he will not have to die for me

his life...it: In this part of the verse, the word life and the pronoun it refer to two different meanings of "life." The word life refers to a person's physical life in this world. The pronoun it refers to a person's eternal life with God.

will lose it: The phrase lose it refers to losing true life, that is, life with God that lasts forever. The person will fail to experience that life either here on earth or in heaven after he dies. He will eventually lose his physical life because no one can live forever. He will also lose the opportunity to gain true life with God.

In some languages, a literal translation of "lose" may imply that a person misplaces something and is unable to find it. It may also imply that a person who

already has eternal life will lose it. Be careful to avoid both these implications.

Here are some other ways to express the correct meaning:

will forfeit true life

will lose the opportunity to gain eternal life

will not gain life with God

8:35b

but whoever loses his life for My sake and for the gospel will save it.

- but you^(plur) who give your life because of me and because of the gospel will have true life.
- But a person who dies because he believes in me and the good news about me will gain/experience spiritual/eternal life with God.

whoever loses his life: The phrase whoever loses his life refers to anyone who loses his physical life, that is, who dies or is killed.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

But if you give up your life (NLT)

But if people kill you

But if you die

for My sake: The phrase for My sake gives a reason for which a disciple must be willing to die. He must be ready to die because of his faith in Christ and his desire to obey Christ.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

because you believe in me

on account of his loyalty to me

because of his following/serving me

Be careful not to translate the phrase for My sake in the sense of "for my benefit" or "in my place." That is often the correct meaning in the context of Christ dying for us. It is not correct in the context of a disciple dying for Christ.

and for the gospel: This phrase gives a related reason for which a disciple must be willing to die. He must be ready to die because he tells other people about the gospel. The TRT has another way to translate this phrase:

because he is teaching others the good news about me

the gospel: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the gospel means “the good news.” In Mark, this phrase refers to the good news about Jesus Christ and the kingdom of God.

Here are some other ways to translate gospel:

good/sweet news

good news about Jesus Christ

good news from God

message/report that causes joy

Be sure that the term you choose does not refer only to a news report or to a story that is not true.

will save it: The pronoun it refers to a person’s eternal life with God, as in 8:35a. The person who gives up his earthly life for Jesus will save himself from spiritual death. He will gain true life with God forever.

Here are some other ways to translate will save it:

will find/have true life (NLT96, NCV)

will have life

will gain/experience life that is forever

General Comment on 8:35a–b

In some languages it may be unnatural or impossible to translate “life” as a noun here. It also may not be natural to refer to it as something that can be lost or kept.

Here is an example of how to translate life as a verb:

For whoever is determined to keep on living on this earth will not be able to live forever with God. Whoever is willing to die because he believes in

me and wants to tell others the good news about me, will live forever with God.

Mark 8:36

Section 8:34–9:1: Jesus spoke about what a person must do to be his disciple

In the preceding section Jesus was speaking to his disciples. In this section Jesus called the crowd of people who were there to come and listen to him also. So in these verses Jesus was speaking to the crowd, as well as to his disciples. This meant that most of the people to whom Jesus spoke were not his followers. Many of them may have been part of the people whom Jesus described in 8:38b as “this adulterous and sinful generation.”

The requirements for being/becoming a disciple are given in 8:34. The phrases in 8:34b–d are arranged in the form of a chiasm: (A) wants to come after Me, (B) must deny himself, (B’) take up his cross, (A’) follow Me. The expressions in (A) and (A’) both refer to following Jesus as a disciple, but they are not redundant. Actually obeying Jesus and following him as a disciple (A’) involves more than simply wanting to become his disciple (A). Similarly, (B) and (B’) both involve denying oneself, but picking up and carrying one’s cross (B’) is a specific and extreme example of self-denial. The next verses (8:35–38) each explain why a person who wants to follow Christ must obey the commands given in 8:34. Each reason involves a choice between the present and the future. A person who chooses to avoid death and shame in the present life will be shamed in the future at the final judgment. He will forfeit true life with God. By contrast, a person who chooses to follow Christ may lose his present life but he will gain true life with God.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told people how to be his true disciples

What It Means to Follow Jesus (GW)

Following Jesus (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 16:24–28 and Luke 9:23–27. See also Luke 14:27, 17:33; John 12:25.

8:36a**What does it profit a man to gain the whole world,**

- For do you gain anything if you own everything in the entire world
- After all, it does a person no good to get everything in this world

8:36b**yet forfeit his soul?**

- but lose your opportunity to have true life with God? Of course not!
- if he does not have/gain life that is forever.

8:36a–b

In Greek, this verse begins with the same conjunction that the BSB translates as “For” in 8:35a. See the note there. Also see the note on Paragraph 8:34–9:1. Here in 8:36a, the conjunction introduces another reason why a person should deny himself and be ready to die as a disciple. The reason is that it is useless for a person to gain everything in this world and then forfeit eternal life with God.

Some English versions indicate this connection by using the word “For” (as in the RSV).

Here is another way to indicate this connection:

Here is another reason

Connect this verse to 8:35 in a natural way in your language. In some languages a connector may not be needed.

What does it profit a man to gain the whole world, yet forfeit his soul?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus asked this question to emphasize something that everyone should know to be true: It is worth nothing for someone to gain the whole world if they forfeit their true life with God. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the REB says:

What does anyone gain by winning the whole world at the cost of his life?

- As a statement. For example, the NCV says:

It is worth nothing for them to have the whole world if they lose their souls.

Use whichever form is most natural in your language to emphasize the recognized fact that Jesus was teaching here.

What does it profit: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as does it profit means “benefit, help, be of use to.” The expected answer to the question is “there will be no profit.”

to gain the whole world: The phrase to gain the whole world literally means to own the world and everything in it. This is a hyperbole. It refers to being very successful in earning money and obtaining material goods.

Here are some other ways to translate gain the whole world:

win the whole world (GNT)

own the whole world (CEV)

This figure of speech emphasizes that even the whole world is worthless compared to the worth of a person's soul. If a literal translation gives a wrong meaning in your language, you may need to express the emphasis in another way. For example:

obtain immense riches

be the wealthiest person in the world

forfeit his soul: In this context the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as forfeit his soul means to fail to obtain eternal life with God.

soul: The Greek word that the BSB translates as soul refers to the same thing as the word “it” in 8:35a and 8:35b. The word soul refers here to eternal life or true life with God.

Mark 8:37**Section 8:34–9:1: Jesus spoke about what a person must do to be his disciple**

In the preceding section Jesus was speaking to his disciples. In this section Jesus called the crowd of people who were there to come and listen to him also. So in these verses Jesus was speaking to the crowd, as well as to his disciples. This meant that most of the people to whom Jesus spoke were not his followers. Many of them may have been part of the people whom Jesus described in 8:38b as “this adulterous and sinful generation.”

The requirements for being/becoming a disciple are given in 8:34. The phrases in 8:34b–d are arranged in the form of a chiasm: (A) wants to come after Me, (B) must deny himself, (B') take up his cross, (A') follow

Me. The expressions in (A) and (A') both refer to following Jesus as a disciple, but they are not redundant. Actually obeying Jesus and following him as a disciple (A') involves more than simply wanting to become his disciple (A). Similarly, (B) and (B') both involve denying oneself, but picking up and carrying one's cross (B') is a specific and extreme example of self-denial. The next verses (8:35–38) each explain why a person who wants to follow Christ must obey the commands given in 8:34. Each reason involves a choice between the present and the future. A person who chooses to avoid death and shame in the present life will be shamed in the future at the final judgment. He will forfeit true life with God. By contrast, a person who chooses to follow Christ may lose his present life but he will gain true life with God.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told people how to be his true disciples

What It Means to Follow Jesus (GW)

Following Jesus (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 16:24–28 and Luke 9:23–27. See also Luke 14:27, 17:33; John 12:25.

8:37

Or what can a man give in exchange for his soul?

- For what can a person give to God that would buy his eternal life? Nothing!
- Is it possible for someone to pay God in order to get eternal life? No!
- And besides that, there is nothing a person can give to God that would be a fair exchange for getting spiritual/eternal life with him.

Or: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates here as Or is often translated as “For,” as in the RSV. As in 8:36a, this conjunction introduces another reason why a person should deny himself and be ready to die as a disciple (8:34). Here this conjunction introduces a question that is similar to the question in 8:36. So this conjunction probably connects 8:37 to 8:36 and 8:34.

Many English versions do not have a connector here.

Here are some other ways to express the connection:

Indeed (NRSV)

To put it another way (TRT)

Introduce the verse in your language in a way that clearly communicates the connection with the preceding verse or verses.

what can a man give in exchange for his soul?:

This is a rhetorical question that expects a negative answer. Jesus asked this question to emphasize that no one is able to pay enough to buy true life with God. There is nothing that a person can give to God that would be a fair exchange for his eternal life. There are at least two ways to translate this.

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the NJB says:

And indeed, what can anyone offer in exchange for his life?

- As a statement. For example:

They could never pay enough to buy true life with God.

Use whichever form is most natural in your language to emphasize a fact that everyone should know is true.

Mark 8:38

Section 8:34–9:1: Jesus spoke about what a person must do to be his disciple

In the preceding section Jesus was speaking to his disciples. In this section Jesus called the crowd of people who were there to come and listen to him also. So in these verses Jesus was speaking to the crowd, as well as to his disciples. This meant that most of the people to whom Jesus spoke were not his followers. Many of them may have been part of the people whom Jesus described in 8:38b as “this adulterous and sinful generation.”

The requirements for being/becoming a disciple are given in 8:34. The phrases in 8:34b–d are arranged in the form of a chiasm: (A) wants to come after Me, (B) must deny himself, (B') take up his cross, (A') follow Me. The expressions in (A) and (A') both refer to following Jesus as a disciple, but they are not redundant. Actually obeying Jesus and following him as a disciple (A') involves more than simply wanting to become his disciple (A). Similarly, (B) and (B') both involve denying oneself, but picking up and carrying one's cross (B') is a specific and extreme example of self-denial. The next verses (8:35–38) each explain why a person who

wants to follow Christ must obey the commands given in 8:34. Each reason involves a choice between the present and the future. A person who chooses to avoid death and shame in the present life will be shamed in the future at the final judgment. He will forfeit true life with God. By contrast, a person who chooses to follow Christ may lose his present life but he will gain true life with God.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told people how to be his true disciples

What It Means to Follow Jesus (GW)

Following Jesus (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 16:24–28 and Luke 9:23–27. See also Luke 14:27, 17:33; John 12:25.

8:38

This verse shows a contrast between the sinful and unfaithful people who were alive then and the holy angels who will be with the Son of Man when he comes. Express this contrast in a natural way in your language.

8:38a–b

If anyone is ashamed of Me and My words in this adulterous and sinful generation: There are different ways to understand how the phrase in this adulterous and sinful generation connects with its context:

1. This phrase is connected to the verb is ashamed. It describes the situation or time in which any follower of Christ might be ashamed. He is ashamed in an adulterous and sinful generation in front of people of that generation. For example, the CEV has:

Don't be ashamed of me and my message among these unfaithful and sinful people! (NIV, GNT, RSV, NET, NLT, REB)

1. This phrase is connected to the word anyone. It describes who is ashamed. For example, the NJB has:

if anyone in this sinful and adulterous generation is ashamed of me and of my words (NJB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). For ways to reorder these verse parts, see the General Comment on 8:38a–b at the end of the note on 8:38b.

8:38a

If anyone is ashamed of Me and My words

- For if anyone is ashamed of me and of what I teach
- If any of you refuse to acknowledge me as your master and to follow my teachings because you are afraid that

In Greek, 8:38 begins with a conjunction that the RSV translates as “For.” This conjunction introduces the fact that a person who chooses to avoid shame in the present life will be shamed at the final judgment. The BSB and some other English versions do not translate this conjunction. Connect this verse to the context in a natural way in your language.

If anyone is ashamed of Me and My words: This clause describes a person who refuses to become Jesus' disciple and follow his teachings because he feels ashamed in front of other people. He is unwilling to acknowledge that he follows Jesus because he is afraid that others will mock him.

In your translation, avoid suggesting that Jesus might have done something wrong that would cause someone to be ashamed.

Here are some other ways to translate If anyone is ashamed of Me and My words:

If anyone is ashamed to become my disciple and to believe/obey my words

If anyone is not willing to acknowledge me as his master and to obey what I teach because people would humiliate him

My words: The phrase My words refers to what Jesus has said, that is, to his teachings.

8:38b

in this adulterous and sinful generation,

- during this time now when people are unfaithful to God and are evil,
- the unfaithful and sinful people of this time will mock/harm you,

this adulterous and sinful generation: Jesus used the word adulterous here in a figurative way. He described the people who were alive at that time as adulterous because they had abandoned their covenant relationship with God. They were unfaithful

to God, as a woman who commits adultery is unfaithful to her husband.

In some languages this figure of speech may be misunderstood to refer literally to sexual sin. If that is true in your language, here are other options for translation:

- Use a simile. For example:

you people living today who are unfaithful to God
like an adulterous/unfaithful wife

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example, the CEV says:

these unfaithful and sinful people

this...generation: In this context, the phrase this... generation refers to all the adults who lived at the same time as Jesus. So he was not referring to only the people listening to him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the people of this day

the people who live now

See how you translated generation in 8:12b.

General Comment on 8:38a–b

In some languages it may be necessary to translate the idea of “unfaithful” with a verb phrase. It may also be necessary to reorder the parts of this verse. For example:

^{38b}The people who are living now have left/abandoned their belief in God. They are thoroughly sinful. ^{38a}If anyone is ashamed to acknowledge me and my words ^{38b}among such people...

8:38c

the Son of Man will also be ashamed of him

- then the Son of Man will be ashamed of him
- then I, the Son of Man, will deny that you are my follower

the Son of Man will also be ashamed of him: This part of the verse indicates that Jesus, the Son of Man, will be ashamed of any person who was ashamed to be known as his follower. In this context, for Jesus to be ashamed of someone does not mean that Jesus will feel embarrassed. It means that Jesus will deny that

such a person belongs to him. He will be unwilling to say that such a person was his disciple. See how you translated ashamed in 8:38a.

the Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is literally “the Son of the human/person.” It is a title that Jesus often used to refer to himself. It implies that:

1. he was a true human being, and he represented all people.
2. he came from God and had authority from God.

Here are some other ways to translate this title:

the Man whom God Sent

the True Man from God/Heaven

the Representative of Mankind

The Older Brother of All People

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate explicitly that Jesus was referring to himself here. For example:

I, the Son of Man

See the note on 8:31b for more information.

8:38d

when He comes in His Father’s glory with the holy angels.”

- when he comes with/showing the greatness of his heavenly Father, accompanied by the holy angels.”
- when I return to earth with God’s angels as my companions. At that time I will show/have the dazzling splendor of God my Father.”
- This will happen when I come back to earth with the angels whom God will send. Then everyone will see my radiant majesty that is the same as my Father’s.”

when He comes in His Father’s glory: The phrase when He comes in His Father’s glory refers to the time when Jesus will return to earth. He will come with the same glory that God his Father has.

in His Father’s glory: The phrase in His Father’s glory means here that Jesus will have or show the glory of his Father. When people see him, they will recognize the same power, greatness and brightness that his Father has.

Father: God is called the Father of Jesus because Jesus has the same nature as God. This way to refer to God also indicates that the relationship between God and Jesus is similar in some way to the relationship of human fathers and sons. God does not have a physical body, and he did not create/produce Jesus in the way a human father produces a son.

glory: In the Old Testament, God's glory often refers to the impressive bright light that people saw when God was present with them. This brightness symbolized how powerful and majestic God was. When it is applied to Jesus in the New Testament, the word glory sometimes refers in general to his divine character or attributes. Sometimes, as here, the word glory refers specifically to his power and greatness or to his dazzling brightness.

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase in his Father's glory:

with the majesty/greatness of his Father

showing the brightness and power of my Father

See also the word glory in the Glossary for more information.

when He comes...with the holy angels: This phrase indicates that Jesus will come back to earth accompanied by angels who are sent with him by God.

holy angels: The Greek word that the BSB translates as angels means "messengers." The phrase holy angels refers to spirit beings who serve God. Sometimes he sends them as messengers or has them serve him in other ways. In this context God will send them to accompany Jesus.

The angels are holy because they are dedicated to God. They are also holy because they are pure. In some languages the term for angels already includes one of these ideas.

Here are some other ways to translate holy angels:

- Use a descriptive word or phrase. For example:

messengers from God/heaven

good/holy spirit-beings

- Use a local term that fits the biblical meaning.
- In some areas the churches may already be using a borrowed term or a transliterated word for "angel."

If you use this term, you may need to indicate the meaning and add the idea of holy. For example:

an angelos messenger from God

a sacred angelos spirit

Be sure that your term for "angel" is different from your terms for "prophet" and "apostle." See angel, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for a chart that shows the differences in these three terms.

General Comment on 8:38d

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of words or phrases in this verse. For example, the GW says:

when he comes with the holy angels in his Father's glory

It may also be helpful to start 8:38d with a new sentence. For example:

This will happen when he comes

General Comment on 8:38a–d

In 8:38a, Jesus referred to himself with forms like "me" and "my." In 8:38c–d he purposely used different forms and spoke of himself as the "Son of Man" and "he." If this is confusing in your language, you may need to continue to use forms like "me" and "my" in the whole verse, as the NLT96 does:

If a person is ashamed of me and my message in these adulterous and sinful days, I, the Son of Man will be ashamed of that person when I return in the glory of my Father with the holy angels.

Mark 9:1

Section 8:34–9:1: Jesus spoke about what a person must do to be his disciple

In the preceding section Jesus was speaking to his disciples. In this section Jesus called the crowd of people who were there to come and listen to him also. So in these verses Jesus was speaking to the crowd, as well as to his disciples. This meant that most of the people to whom Jesus spoke were not his followers. Many of them may have been part of the people whom Jesus described in 8:38b as "this adulterous and sinful generation."

The requirements for being/becoming a disciple are given in 8:34. The phrases in 8:34b–d are arranged in the form of a chiasm: (A) wants to come after Me, (B) must deny himself, (B') take up his cross, (A') follow Me. The expressions in (A) and (A') both refer to following Jesus as a disciple, but they are not redundant. Actually obeying Jesus and following him as a disciple (A') involves more than simply wanting to become his disciple (A). Similarly, (B) and (B') both involve denying oneself, but picking up and carrying one's cross (B') is a specific and extreme example of self-denial. The next verses (8:35–38) each explain why a person who wants to follow Christ must obey the commands given in 8:34. Each reason involves a choice between the present and the future. A person who chooses to avoid death and shame in the present life will be shamed in the future at the final judgment. He will forfeit true life with God. By contrast, a person who chooses to follow Christ may lose his present life but he will gain true life with God.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told people how to be his true disciples

What It Means to Follow Jesus (GW)

Following Jesus (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 16:24–28 and Luke 9:23–27. See also Luke 14:27, 17:33; John 12:25.

9:1a

Then Jesus said to them, “Truly I tell you,

- And Jesus said to them, “You can rely on this truth:
- Then Jesus said to them, “I assure you^(plur) that

Then Jesus said to them: The word *them* refers to the disciples and the people in the crowd. See 8:34.

Truly I tell you: Jesus used the phrase *Truly I tell you* to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. It indicates that the statement was important and totally reliable, and people should listen carefully to it. Sometimes it introduces a serious warning or prediction. Here Jesus predicted the coming of the kingdom of God.

See how you translated this expression at 3:28a and 8:12c. In some languages you may need to translate

the phrase differently in different contexts. Do not translate in a way that implies that Jesus had not been telling the truth at other times.

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase in this context:

I tell you the truth (NIV)

I can guarantee this truth (GW)

I assure you (NLT)

I can promise you that...

9:1b

there are some standing here who will not taste death

- some of you^(plur) people who are standing here will not die
- some of you^(plur) here today will not die

there are some standing here: The phrase *there are some standing here* refers to some of Jesus' disciples or people in the crowd that Jesus was talking to.

will not taste death: The phrase *will not taste death* is an idiom. It means they “will not die” until they have seen the kingdom of God.

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a positive statement, as the NCV has done:

will see the kingdom of God come with power before they die

9:1c

before they see the kingdom of God arrive with power.”

- before you^(plur) see that God's kingdom has arrived in a new and powerful way.”
- until you experience that God has established his rule over his people with power.”

before they see the kingdom of God arrive with power: This clause indicates that people will see God establish his rule in a way that shows his power.

Scholars have different ideas about what event Jesus referred to here. He may have been referring to:

1. the time when several of his disciples would see God glorify Jesus on the mountain at the Transfiguration (Mark 9:2–13),

2. the time when Jesus would die, and God would powerfully raise him from the dead (Mark 15–16),
3. the time when the Holy Spirit would come with power (Acts 2:1–4).

It is recommended that you translate this expression in a general way so that any or all of these events could fulfill Jesus' words.

they see the kingdom of God arrive with power:

In some cultures it may not be natural to speak of a kingdom “arriving” and people “seeing” it. In your translation of this clause, you will need to be especially careful to test the implications with local speakers. Do not use a phrase that would imply that God was not already sovereign or that he was not ruling powerfully before this time. Jesus was referring to a new way that God would show his power as he establishes his kingdom and rules as king.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

before they see God establishing his dominion in a powerful way

before they experience God ruling with power

kingdom of God: The phrase kingdom of God refers to God's activity of ruling and caring for his people as their king. It does not refer to a land or country that he rules over.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- As a noun. For example:

God's rule/reign

God's kingship

God's chieftaincy

God's government

- As a verbal expression:

God rules his people

God cares for his people as king

See how you translated kingdom of God in 1:15b. Also, see kingdom of God, Context 3, in the Glossary for more information.

Mark 9:2

Section 9:2–13: Three disciples saw Jesus' glory

In 8:27–30 Peter stated that Jesus was the Christ. In 8:31–38 Jesus told the disciples about his future suffering, death, and resurrection. Then in 9:2–13 God caused Jesus to be glorified for a short time. Peter, James, and John saw this.

During that time, Moses and Elijah appeared and talked with Jesus. Peter suggested building shelters for Jesus, Moses, and Elijah. God showed these disciples that Jesus was greater than the great prophets Moses and Elijah, because Jesus was God's Son.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God shows three disciples who Jesus really is

Jesus shone brightly

The glory of Jesus was shown to three disciples

The change of/in Jesus' appearance

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:1–12 and Luke 9:28–36.

9:2a

After six days Jesus took with Him Peter, James, and John,

- ¶ Six days later, Jesus took with him Peter, James, and John
- ¶ About a week later, Peter, James, and John went with Jesus

After six days: The phrase After six days indicates that six days passed after the events in Mark 8:27–9:1. Then the events of this paragraph began. The GNT says:

Six days later

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as:

A week later

Jesus took with Him Peter, James, and John: In this context, the phrase took with Him implies that Jesus asked Peter, James, and John to go with him. They

went willingly with Jesus. In some languages, it may be more natural to say:

Jesus told Peter, James and John to go along with him

took: The verb that the BSB translates as took is closely connected to the verb “led” in 9:2b. In some languages it may be natural to use only that verb here. For example:

Jesus led Peter, James, and John up...

with Him: The words with Him may be left implied in some languages. For example, the NCV says:

he took Peter, James and John

9:2b and led them up a high mountain

- and led/brought them to the top of a high mountain,
- and they followed him up a high mountain
- and they climbed together up a high mountain.

led them up: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as led...up indicates that the disciples followed Jesus up the mountain.

In some languages, it may be more natural to say:

they followed him up

they climbed together up

up a high mountain: The text does not indicate that the men went to the very top of the mountain. They went up high enough to get away from other people. No one knows which mountain the men climbed. If they were still near Caesarea Philippi, the mountain was probably about 2,800 meters (9,000 feet) high. However, some scholars believe that they were at a different location where the mountain was less than 600 meters (1,850 feet) high. If your language uses different words for mountains of different heights, you may choose one of these locations and use an expression for a mountain of that height.

9:2c by themselves.

- where they were entirely alone. (JBP)
- No other people were there.

by themselves: The Greek words that the BSB translates as by themselves are literally “themselves alone.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

No one else was there. (NLT96)

where they were all alone (NIV)

where they were entirely alone (JBP)

9:2d There He was transfigured before them.

- While there, he was changed/transformed in front of them,
- Suddenly/Then God changed Jesus’ appearance while they watched.
- As they looked at him, his appearance changed,

There He was transfigured before them: The BSB supplies the word There to connect 9:2c and 9:2d. The Greek text has the common conjunction that is often translated as “and,” as in the RSV. Use a natural way in your language to connect these parts of the verse. For example:

Then

Suddenly

The phrase that the BSB translates as before them indicates that the three disciples saw Jesus as he was transfigured. Some English versions use this phrase as an introductory clause or phrase. For example:

As the men watched (NLT)

There in their presence (NJB)

He was transfigured: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as was transfigured here means “was transformed/changed in appearance.” This transformation was good and glorious. Jesus shone very brightly. Matthew and Luke explain more of the changes. Matthew says that Jesus’ face shone like the sun.

Many cultures have terms to describe a major change in appearance. Often these changes have supernatural causes and purposes. If you consider using one of these terms, be sure that it does not communicate a wrong meaning. Jesus did not begin to look like some-

one else, and he did not become a different being. His appearance did not change in any bad way.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

his whole appearance was changed

The verb is passive. The implied subject is God: God transfigured Jesus. However, the focus is on what happened to Jesus and not on who did it.

If a passive verb is not natural in your language here, you may use an active verb. For example:

God changed Jesus' whole appearance.

Jesus' appearance became very different.

Jesus' appearance changed in front of them. (GW)

Mark 9:3

Section 9:2-13: Three disciples saw Jesus' glory

In 8:27-30 Peter stated that Jesus was the Christ. In 8:31-38 Jesus told the disciples about his future suffering, death, and resurrection. Then in 9:2-13 God caused Jesus to be glorified for a short time. Peter, James, and John saw this.

During that time, Moses and Elijah appeared and talked with Jesus. Peter suggested building shelters for Jesus, Moses, and Elijah. God showed these disciples that Jesus was greater than the great prophets Moses and Elijah, because Jesus was God's Son.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God shows three disciples who Jesus really is

Jesus shone brightly

The glory of Jesus was shown to three disciples

The change of/in Jesus' appearance

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:1-12 and Luke 9:28-36.

9:3a

His clothes became radiantly white,

- and his clothes became shining white, (GNT)
- Even his clothes had a different appearance. They became glistening and intensely white.
- and as for his clothes, they became extremely white and bright.

His clothes became radiantly white: Jesus' clothes also changed in appearance. They became very bright. In Greek, the focus in this part of the verse is on the phrase His clothes.

Here are some other ways to express this emphasis:

Even his clothes changed. They became dazzling white.

As for his clothes, they became dazzling white.

radiantly white: There is a textual issue here that concerns the phrase that the KJV translates as "as snow." (1) Some Greek texts do not include this phrase. For example, the NET says: "radiantly white" (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NET, NCV, GW, NASB, CEV, REB, GNT, ESV, JBP). (2) Other Greek texts include this phrase. For example the KJV says: "exceeding white as snow" (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1) as the majority of English versions do. The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as radiantly white is literally "shining exceedingly white." This phrase probably indicates a very bright whiteness that was even shining, almost like a light.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

glistening, intensely white (RSV)

shining white (GNT)

dazzling white (NIV)

Your language may have a figure of speech to describe something that is "shining exceedingly white." If so, you may use it here.

9:3b

brighter than any launderer on earth could bleach them.

- far whiter than any earthly bleach could ever make them. (NLT)
- No one on the earth could bleach/wash them that white.
- Their whiteness had no equal in this world.

brighter than any launderer on earth could bleach them: The expression brighter than any launderer on earth could bleach them indicates that Jesus' clothes were whiter than anyone on earth could make them. No one could make them so white by washing them, even with the strongest bleach.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

exceedingly white, as no launderer on earth can whiten them (NASB)

whiter than any bleach on earth could make them (CEV)

whiter than anyone in the world could bleach them (NIV)

bleach: The word bleach refers to a process that removes color and stains and makes clothes more white. It is a process different than washing with soap. The Greek word in this verse that the BSB translates as “launderer” refers to a person who bleaches clothes.

If people in your area are not familiar with the process of bleaching, you may want to use a general expression. For example:

whiter than any person could wash them

Mark 9:4

Section 9:2–13: Three disciples saw Jesus' glory

In 8:27–30 Peter stated that Jesus was the Christ. In 8:31–38 Jesus told the disciples about his future suffering, death, and resurrection. Then in 9:2–13 God caused Jesus to be glorified for a short time. Peter, James, and John saw this.

During that time, Moses and Elijah appeared and talked with Jesus. Peter suggested building shelters for Jesus, Moses, and Elijah. God showed these disciples that Jesus was greater than the great prophets Moses and Elijah, because Jesus was God's Son.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God shows three disciples who Jesus really is

Jesus shone brightly

The glory of Jesus was shown to three disciples

The change of/in Jesus' appearance

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:1–12 and Luke 9:28–36.

9:4a

And Elijah and Moses appeared before them,

- Suddenly, Elijah and Moses appeared before them
- Suddenly, the three disciples saw the prophets Elijah and Moses,

9:4a–b

And Elijah and Moses appeared before them, talking with Jesus: The Greek clauses here indicate that Elijah and Moses were already talking with Jesus when the disciples saw them. The context also implies that Elijah, Moses, and Jesus were still talking when Peter interrupted them in 9:5a. Try to translate in a way that allows for either of these two meanings.

Elijah and Moses: Elijah and Moses were both Old Testament prophets who lived many years before Jesus. But God brought them to the mountain to talk with Jesus.

If people in your area will not know that Elijah and Moses lived long before Jesus, you may want to include some implied information. For example:

Elijah and Moses, prophets of long ago

appeared: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as appeared is literally “was seen.” This form of the verb is often used to describe beings who appear in a supernatural manner. Here, this verb indicates that the disciples suddenly saw Elijah and Moses. The disciples did not see them coming from a distance. For this reason, it is possible to translate this as:

Elijah and Moses suddenly appeared to them

They suddenly saw Elijah and Moses

them: The pronoun them refers to the three disciples. However, your translation should not imply that Elijah and Moses suddenly became visible to the three disciples but not to Jesus. Clearly, Jesus saw them as well as the three disciples. In some languages you may be able to leave the word them implicit. For example, the NLT says:

Then Elijah and Moses appeared

9:4b talking with Jesus.

- talking to/with Jesus.
- and they were talking with Jesus.

talking with Jesus: The Greek grammar probably indicates that Elijah and Moses were already talking with Jesus when the disciples saw them. The grammar could also indicate that Elijah, Moses, and Jesus were still talking when Peter interrupted them (9:5a). Try to translate in a way that allows for either of those two meanings.

Mark 9:5

Section 9:2–13: Three disciples saw Jesus' glory

In 8:27–30 Peter stated that Jesus was the Christ. In 8:31–38 Jesus told the disciples about his future suffering, death, and resurrection. Then in 9:2–13 God caused Jesus to be glorified for a short time. Peter, James, and John saw this.

During that time, Moses and Elijah appeared and talked with Jesus. Peter suggested building shelters for Jesus, Moses, and Elijah. God showed these disciples that Jesus was greater than the great prophets Moses and Elijah, because Jesus was God's Son.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God shows three disciples who Jesus really is

Jesus shone brightly

The glory of Jesus was shown to three disciples

The change of/in Jesus' appearance

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:1–12 and Luke 9:28–36.

9:5a

Peter said to Jesus, "Rabbi, it is good for us to be here."

- ¶ Peter said to Jesus, "Rabbi/Teacher, it is good that we^(incl) are here.
- ¶ So Peter spoke up and said to Jesus, "Sir/Teacher, our^(excl) being/presence here is really good.

Peter said: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Peter said is literally "Peter answered and said."

This indicates that Peter responded to the situation of Jesus talking with Elijah and Moses.

In some languages it may not be natural to "answer" a situation. Because of that, many English versions use only the verb "said" here.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Peter spoke up and said (GNT)

Then Peter said to Jesus (NET)

Rabbi: The word Rabbi is a transliteration of a Hebrew word that means "my great one." At the time when Mark wrote this gospel message, people used this word as a title of respect for an important religious teacher or leader. It does not refer to a school teacher.

If you do not have a word that expresses this idea of a religious teacher, you can simply use the word "teacher" or "master." If possible, use a word that implies that the teacher is respected. For example:

Teacher

my teacher/master

Use an expression in your language that is natural and shows proper respect.

The parallel passages for this verse are in Matthew 17:4 and Luke 9:33. Matthew used a Greek title that means "Lord." Luke used a Greek title that means "Master." Both "Lord" and "Master" were used in the same way as "Rabbi."

it is good for us to be here: The phrase it is good for us to be here expresses Peter's feelings. He felt that it was good, wonderful or fortunate that they were there to see and experience this amazing event.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

it is good that we are here (REB)

our presence here is really good

how wonderful that we are here

us: There are two ways to interpret the pronoun us here:

1. It refers to the three disciples only. It means:

“It’s good for us^(excl) disciples to be here.”

1. It refers to the three disciples and Jesus. It means:

“It’s good for all of us^(incl) to be here together.”

You should translate ambiguously if your language allows you to do so. If you need to choose an exclusive or inclusive “us,” you should choose interpretation (1). Peter’s statement was probably closely connected to his plan in 9:5b to put up shelters for Jesus, Moses, and Elijah. (See the next note.) Your translation should not imply that Peter meant to exclude Jesus and the prophets in any offensive way.

9:5b

Let us put up three shelters—one for You, one for Moses, and one for Elijah.”

- We^(excl) will make three shelters, one for you,^(sing) one for Moses, and one for Elijah.”
- I would like for us^(excl) to make three huts/booths, one for you,^(sing) one for Moses, and one for Elijah.”

Let us put up: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Let us put up expresses a suggestion. It is not a request for permission.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

We shall make

I would like for us to make

us: The pronoun us refers to only Peter, James, and John here. Peter did not expect Jesus (or Moses or Elijah) to help them to make the shelters.

put up: The Greek word that the BSB translates as put up is literally “make.” Peter was suggesting that he, James, and John build a shelter from materials that were there on the mountain.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

build

make (NJB)

three shelters: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as shelters:

1. It refers to temporary shelters made from branches, leaves, and other things that were easy to find. They were used for shade or to block the wind. The NET says:

three shelters (NIV, NJB, CEV, NET, JBP, REB, NLT)

1. It refers to tents. Tents are made out of cloth or animal skins. They were used to block the rain or the wind. God’s worship tent in the Old Testament was made of skins. The NCV says:

three tents (GNT, GW, NCV, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

Mark 9:6

Section 9:2–13: Three disciples saw Jesus’ glory

In 8:27–30 Peter stated that Jesus was the Christ. In 8:31–38 Jesus told the disciples about his future suffering, death, and resurrection. Then in 9:2–13 God caused Jesus to be glorified for a short time. Peter, James, and John saw this.

During that time, Moses and Elijah appeared and talked with Jesus. Peter suggested building shelters for Jesus, Moses, and Elijah. God showed these disciples that Jesus was greater than the great prophets Moses and Elijah, because Jesus was God’s Son.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God shows three disciples who Jesus really is

Jesus shone brightly

The glory of Jesus was shown to three disciples

The change of/in Jesus’ appearance

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:1–12 and Luke 9:28–36.

9:6a–b

For they were all so terrified that Peter did not know what else to say.

- For the disciples were terribly frightened, so Peter did not know what to say.
- He said that because he and the other two disciples were terrified and did not know what to say or do.

For an example of how to reorder this verse, see the General Comment on 9:5a–6b at the end of 9:6b.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *For* introduces the reason for Peter's statement in 9:5. Peter said these things because he did not really know what to say. Indicate this reason in a natural way in your language.

In some languages, it may be natural to begin this verse with a clause that refers to the spoken words of 9:5. For example:

He said this because he didn't really know what else to say. (NLT)

He said those words for he did not know what else to say.

they were all so terrified: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *they were all so terrified* is literally "for they were very afraid."

This phrase gives the reason for 9:6a. Peter did not know what to say (9:6a) because he and the others were very frightened (9:6b). The NCV says:

because he and the others were so frightened

Since 9:6a and 9:6b both express a reason, you may need to use a different way to indicate the reason here. See the General Comment below for translation examples.

they: The pronoun *they* refers to Peter, James, and John.

so terrified: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as *so terrified* refers to strong fear.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

so frightened (NIV)

terribly afraid (NLT96)

did not know what else to say: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as *say* is literally "respond." When Peter saw Jesus transfigured and talking to Elijah and Moses, he did not know what to do or say.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

didn't know how to respond (GW)

did not know what to say about what he had seen

General Comment on 9:5a–6b

In Greek, 9:5 is the result of 9:6a (the reason), and 9:6a is the result of 9:6b (the reason). Both 9:6a and 9:6b begin with the same Greek conjunction that introduces a reason. For example, the RSV says:

⁵And Peter said to Jesus, "Master..." ^{6a}For he did not know what to say, ^{6b}for they were exceedingly afraid.

In some languages, it may be natural to leave one or both of these conjunctions implicit. For example:

⁵Peter said to Jesus, "Teacher..." ^{6a}Peter did not know what to say, ^{6b}because he and the others were so frightened. (NCV)

⁵Peter said to Jesus, "Rabbi..." ^{6a}(Peter didn't know how to respond. ^{6b}He and the others were terrified.) (GW)

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses so that the events are talked about in the order in which they occurred. For example:

^{6b}They were very frightened, ^{6a}so Peter did not know how to respond, ⁵so he said to Jesus, "Rabbi..."

^{6b}They were very frightened, ^{6a}and Peter did not know how to respond, ⁵so he said to Jesus, "Rabbi..."

In other languages it may be natural to change the order of 9:6a and 9:6b and make both the reason for 9:5. For example, the CEV says:

⁵Peter said to Jesus, "Teacher..." ^{6b}For they were afraid, ^{6a}and he did not know what to say.

Mark 9:7

Section 9:2–13: Three disciples saw Jesus' glory

In 8:27–30 Peter stated that Jesus was the Christ. In 8:31–38 Jesus told the disciples about his future suffering, death, and resurrection. Then in 9:2–13 God caused Jesus to be glorified for a short time. Peter, James, and John saw this.

During that time, Moses and Elijah appeared and talked with Jesus. Peter suggested building shelters for Jesus, Moses, and Elijah. God showed these disci-

ples that Jesus was greater than the great prophets Moses and Elijah, because Jesus was God's Son.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God shows three disciples who Jesus really is

Jesus shone brightly

The glory of Jesus was shown to three disciples

The change of/in Jesus' appearance

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:1-12 and Luke 9:28-36.

9:7a

Then a cloud appeared and enveloped them,

- Then a cloud came/arrived and covered/overshadowed them,
- Then a cloud developed/formed and covered them with its shadow.

a cloud: The cloud represents the presence of God. Use a general expression that could refer to any type of cloud. If your language has only specific terms for each kind of cloud, use the term that would be appropriate here. In some languages the term for a white, puffy, fair-weather cloud would fit this context.

appeared: In this context, the Greek verb that the BSB translates as appeared means "came" or "appeared." For example, the NJB says:

came

Another way to translate this is:

formed (NASB)

enveloped them: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as enveloped:

1. It means cast its shadow or overshadowed. The cloud passed between them and the sun, and they were in its shadow. For example, the GNT says:

covered...with its shadow (RSV, GNT, NJB, NASB, GW, NLT, NET, JBP, REB, KJV, ESV)

1. It means surrounded or enveloped. They were on a mountain. So when the cloud came, it surrounded them so that they were in the middle of the cloud. It was like being in a fog. For example, the NIV says:

enveloped (NIV, BSB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most English versions. Some English versions such as NJB "covering them in shadow" and NCV "covered them" may be ambiguous or may have essentially the same meaning as "enveloped." Even so, most English versions do support interpretation (1). However, many commentaries support interpretation (2). Both Louw & Nida (page 177 #14.62) and BDAG (page 378) say that the cloud may function more like a covering than a shadow. Several scholars support the view that the cloud "enveloped" or "surrounded" only Jesus, Moses and Elijah. Several other scholars feel that the cloud probably covered the whole mountaintop and enveloped all six people. Following this interpretation the word them refers to Jesus, Moses, Elijah, Peter, James, and John.

General Comment on 9:7a

There are several ways to translate the two verbs "appeared" and "overshadowed":

- In some languages, these ideas are expressed by two or more verbs. For example, the GNT says:

Then a cloud appeared and covered them with its shadow

- In other languages, it may be possible to translate these ideas as one verb. Or it may be possible to make the verb "appeared" implicit. For example, the NLT says:

Then a cloud overshadowed them

9:7b

and a voice came from the cloud:

- and a voice spoke from the cloud saying,
- They heard God speaking from the cloud. He said,

a voice came from the cloud: The voice was the voice of God. In some languages it may be more natural to say that God was speaking rather than that his voice came. For example:

God spoke from the cloud.

They heard God speaking from the cloud.

You may need to introduce the words that the voice said in 9:7c with a verb like “say” at the end of this clause. For example:

a voice spoke from the cloud saying

9:7c

“This is My beloved Son. Listen to Him!”

- “This is my much-loved Son. Listen^(plur) to what he says!”
- “This is my Child, and I love him. Listen to him and obey him!”

This is My beloved Son: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as This is My beloved Son is literally “This is my Son, the loved-one.” The word This refers to Jesus. The words “the loved-one” indicate that Jesus was God the Father’s dear son. It may be more natural in your language to use a different way to translate “the loved-one.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

This is my Son, the Beloved. (NJB)

This is my dearly-loved Son. (JBP)

This is my Son, and I love him. (CEV)

This is my Son, whom I love. (NIV)

My beloved Son: Here the words My...Son indicate that Jesus has the same nature as God. They also indicate that the relationship between God and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship of human fathers and sons. God does not have a physical body, and he did not create/produce Jesus the way a human father produces a son. Jesus existed eternally as the Son with his Father.

In some areas people may not understand the way My...Son is used in this context. If that is true in your area, you may wish to include a footnote. For example:

God is the Father of Jesus the Son in a different way than human males are fathers of their sons. The Bible uses the word Son to express the fact that Jesus has the same nature as God. It also indicates that the relationship between God and

Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship of human fathers and sons.

See how you translated Son in 1:1.

In languages where there is no single word for Son, many translators have used a more general expression, such as:

my child

my male child

If you decide to use “my male child,” be sure that this expression does not imply that God had another child who was female.

Listen to Him: The verb Listen implies obeying as well as hearing. If people in your area will not understand that the word Listen implies “obey,” you may want to include this implied information. For example:

Listen to him and obey him!

Mark 9:8

Section 9:2–13: Three disciples saw Jesus’ glory

In 8:27–30 Peter stated that Jesus was the Christ. In 8:31–38 Jesus told the disciples about his future suffering, death, and resurrection. Then in 9:2–13 God caused Jesus to be glorified for a short time. Peter, James, and John saw this.

During that time, Moses and Elijah appeared and talked with Jesus. Peter suggested building shelters for Jesus, Moses, and Elijah. God showed these disciples that Jesus was greater than the great prophets Moses and Elijah, because Jesus was God’s Son.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God shows three disciples who Jesus really is

Jesus shone brightly

The glory of Jesus was shown to three disciples

The change of/in Jesus’ appearance

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:1-12 and Luke 9:28-36.

9:8a

Suddenly, when they looked around,

- Then as they looked around, they suddenly
- When the disciples looked around, they suddenly/unexpectedly

Suddenly: There are two interpretations as to which verb the word Suddenly is connected:

1. The word Suddenly is connected with the verb saw. They looked around, then they suddenly saw that Elijah and Moses were already gone. This interpretation is made clear in Matthew. The disciples were at first afraid to look up. When Jesus touched them and they looked around, they suddenly noticed that Elijah and Moses were no longer there. For example, the NJB says:

Then suddenly, when they looked around, they saw no one (BSB, NIV, NJB, NRSV, NET, KJV, GW, ESV)

1. The word Suddenly is connected with the verb looked around. As soon as the disciples heard the voice, they suddenly looked around. For example, the NCV says:

Suddenly Peter, James, and John looked around (GNT, RSV, NASB, CEV, NCV, JBP)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

they: The pronoun they refers to the three disciples. For example, the NCV says:

Peter, James, and John

looked around: The verb looked around means “looked in several different directions.” Although the disciples expected to see Moses and Elijah, they only saw Jesus. Use a natural expression for that meaning.

9:8b

they saw no one with them except Jesus.

- no longer saw anyone with them except Jesus. (NIV)
- saw/noticed that only Jesus was there with them.

they saw no one with them except Jesus: The words saw no one...except Jesus indicates that Elijah and Moses were gone and the disciples saw only Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Moses and Elijah were gone, and they saw only Jesus with them (NLT)

they saw only Jesus (CEV)

but they saw only Jesus there alone with them (NCV)

Mark 9:9

Section 9:2-13: Three disciples saw Jesus’ glory

In 8:27-30 Peter stated that Jesus was the Christ. In 8:31-38 Jesus told the disciples about his future suffering, death, and resurrection. Then in 9:2-13 God caused Jesus to be glorified for a short time. Peter, James, and John saw this.

During that time, Moses and Elijah appeared and talked with Jesus. Peter suggested building shelters for Jesus, Moses, and Elijah. God showed these disciples that Jesus was greater than the great prophets Moses and Elijah, because Jesus was God’s Son.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God shows three disciples who Jesus really is

Jesus shone brightly

The glory of Jesus was shown to three disciples

The change of/in Jesus’ appearance

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:1-12 and Luke 9:28-36.

9:9a

As they were coming down the mountain,

- ¶ While Jesus and the disciples were coming down the mountain,
- ¶ Then Jesus and the disciples descended the mountain. On the way

As they were coming down the mountain: This clause links this paragraph to the previous paragraph (9:5-8). It also indicates that Jesus, Peter, James, and John were part way down the mountain when they had the following conversation.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

On their way down the mountain (GW)

While they descended the mountain

As Jesus and his disciples were coming down the mountain (CEV)

they: The pronoun they refers to Jesus, Peter, James, and John.

mountain: The word mountain refers to the same mountain as in 9:2b. See how you translated this word in 9:2b.

9:9b–c

9:9b–c has an indirect quote. See the General Comment on 9:9b–c at the end of 9:9c for examples of how to translate this as a direct quotation.

9:9b

Jesus admonished them not to tell anyone what they had seen

- he/Jesus commanded them not to tell anyone the things they had just seen
- Jesus told them that they were not to tell anybody else about what they had seen.
- Jesus ordered them, “Don’t tell anyone what you have seen, (GNT)

Jesus admonished them: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as admonished means “commanded” or “ordered.” Jesus said something to the disciples and expected them to obey. For example:

Jesus commanded them (NCV)

Jesus ordered them (GNT)

he warned them (JBP)

not to tell anyone: In some languages it might be more natural to use a positive expression here. For example:

to be silent about

what they had seen: The phrase what they had seen refers to what the disciples had seen when Jesus was transfigured (9:2–8).

Another way to translate this is:

the miraculous/marvelous things that they had just seen on the mountain

9:9c

until the Son of Man had risen from the dead.

- until he the Son of Man had died and lived again.
- They were to keep quiet about it until after the Son of Man had come back to life.
- until I the Son of Man have risen from death.”

until: The word until indicates that after Jesus died and had risen from the dead, the disciples could tell what they had seen.

In some languages, it may be more natural to begin a new sentence here. For example, the GW says:

They were to wait until the Son of Man had come back to life.

the Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is literally “the Son of the human/person.” Jesus used this title to imply that:

1. he was a true human being, and he represented all people.
2. he came from God and had authority from God.

Try to use an expression that implies both meanings.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the Man whom God Sent

the True Man from God/Heaven

the Representative of Mankind

The Older Brother of All People

In some cases, an unusual title may correctly suggest a deeper meaning. For example:

the Child of a Person

the One who was Born as a Human

Translators have also used expressions that are more literal. These more literal expressions may be appropriate where readers are familiar with a literal title in another version.

In some languages it may be necessary to use an appropriate form to indicate that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

He told them not to tell anyone what they had seen until he, the Son of Man, had been raised from death.

“Do not tell anyone what you have seen until I, the Son of Man, have risen from death.”

had risen from the dead: The phrase had risen from the dead refers to a future event when God would cause Jesus to live again. This phrase implies that Jesus would die first.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

until the Son of Man came back to life

until after the Son of Man had risen from the dead (NRSV)

General Comment on 9:9b–c

The BSB has translated 9:9b–c as an indirect quotation. In some languages it may be more natural to use a direct quote here. For example, the GNT says:

Jesus ordered them, “Don’t tell anyone what you have seen, until the Son of Man has risen from death.”

Mark 9:10

Section 9:2–13: Three disciples saw Jesus’ glory

In 8:27–30 Peter stated that Jesus was the Christ. In 8:31–38 Jesus told the disciples about his future suffering, death, and resurrection. Then in 9:2–13 God caused Jesus to be glorified for a short time. Peter, James, and John saw this.

During that time, Moses and Elijah appeared and talked with Jesus. Peter suggested building shelters for Jesus, Moses, and Elijah. God showed these disciples that Jesus was greater than the great prophets Moses and Elijah, because Jesus was God’s Son.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God shows three disciples who Jesus really is

Jesus shone brightly

The glory of Jesus was shown to three disciples

The change of/in Jesus’ appearance

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:1–12 and Luke 9:28–36.

9:10a

So they kept this matter to themselves,

- They kept the information to themselves,
- So the disciples did not tell anyone about what happened on the mountain,
- They obeyed his order, (GNT)

In some languages, it may be natural to indicate result here. For example, the CEV says:

So they kept it to themselves.

So they: The pronoun they refers to Peter, James, and John.

kept this matter to themselves: The phrase kept this matter to themselves is an idiom. This idiom indicates that the disciples did not tell anyone about what had happened. Jesus had told them not to tell anyone, and they obeyed him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

kept the information to themselves

observed the warning faithfully (NJB)

did not tell anyone about what happened on the mountain

9:10b

discussing what it meant to rise from the dead.

- and they started to discuss what he meant about dying and living again.
- but they began to debate/talk about what Jesus meant by “coming back to life.”
- but among themselves they started discussing the matter, “What does this ‘rising from death’ mean?” (GNT)

There is an implied contrast between 9:10a and 9:10b. The contrast is between what the disciples did not talk about (what they had seen on the mountain), and

what they did talk about. Some English versions make this contrast explicit. For example, the NCV has:

but they discussed

Make this contrast clear in a way that is natural in your language.

discussing: The word discussing means “talking about something to understand it” or “talking about something to try to agree about it.” The disciples were trying to understand what Jesus meant.

The Greek tense of the verb probably indicates that they discussed this for some time.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

began to talk about

started to debate about

what it meant to rise from the dead: God had caused several people in the Old Testament to come alive again after they had died. The disciples knew those stories. But they probably believed that Jesus as the Christ would not die. So they were trying to understand how to rise from the dead applied to Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

what he meant about rising from the dead (NCV)

what he meant by “come back to life” (GW)

how “rising from the dead” applied/referred to Jesus

to rise from the dead: Use the same phrase for to rise from the dead that you used in 9:9c. If you need to change the verb form, make sure it is clear that the disciples are referring to what Jesus had just said.

General Comment on 9:10b

The BSB translates 9:10b as an indirect quote. However, in some languages a direct quote would be more natural. For example, the GNT says:

they started discussing the matter, “What does this ‘rising from death’ mean?”

Mark 9:11

Section 9:2–13: Three disciples saw Jesus’ glory

In 8:27–30 Peter stated that Jesus was the Christ. In 8:31–38 Jesus told the disciples about his future suffering, death, and resurrection. Then in 9:2–13 God caused Jesus to be glorified for a short time. Peter, James, and John saw this.

During that time, Moses and Elijah appeared and talked with Jesus. Peter suggested building shelters for Jesus, Moses, and Elijah. God showed these disciples that Jesus was greater than the great prophets Moses and Elijah, because Jesus was God’s Son.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God shows three disciples who Jesus really is

Jesus shone brightly

The glory of Jesus was shown to three disciples

The change of/in Jesus’ appearance

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:1–12 and Luke 9:28–36.

9:11a

And they asked Jesus,

- Then they asked him,
- The disciples asked Jesus,

9:11b

“Why do the scribes say that Elijah must come first?”

- “Why do the teachers of law say that it is necessary for Elijah to come first?”
- “Don’t the experts in the Law of Moses say that Elijah must come before the Christ/Messiah comes?”

9:11a–b

Why do the scribes say that Elijah must come first?:

This is a real question. The disciples asked this question because they were confused. They had just seen Elijah on the mountain. They knew that Jesus was the Christ. They also knew about the prophecy that Elijah would come to preach before the Christ came. So they did not understand the prophecy in relation to Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

Why do the teachers of religious law insist that Elijah must return before the Messiah comes? (NLT)

Are the teachers of the law correct in saying that it is necessary that Elijah come first before the Messiah comes? And if so, why has he not yet come?

the scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the scribes refers to men who studied, interpreted, and taught the law of Moses. They are called scribes because the original work of these men was to copy the laws of Moses by hand. In New Testament times, this was no longer their main task. Instead, it was to teach the law. Here are some other ways to translate this term:

teachers of the law of Moses (CEV)

teachers of religious law (NLT)

experts on the law

See how you translated this phrase in 1:22c or 8:31c. See teacher of the law in the Glossary.

Elijah must come first: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as must is literally “it is necessary.” The Scripture said that Elijah would come first. Therefore, it was necessary for him to come.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

it is necessary for Elijah to come first

it is required that Elijah come first

come: In this context, the verb come means “return to earth.” God took Elijah directly to heaven before the prophecy, but the prophecy indicates that he would come back to Israel. For example:

come to earth again

return to Israel

first: In this context, the word first means “before the Christ comes.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

before the Christ does

before the Christ comes

Mark 9:12

Section 9:2–13: Three disciples saw Jesus’ glory

In 8:27–30 Peter stated that Jesus was the Christ. In 8:31–38 Jesus told the disciples about his future suffering, death, and resurrection. Then in 9:2–13 God caused Jesus to be glorified for a short time. Peter, James, and John saw this.

During that time, Moses and Elijah appeared and talked with Jesus. Peter suggested building shelters for Jesus, Moses, and Elijah. God showed these disciples that Jesus was greater than the great prophets Moses and Elijah, because Jesus was God’s Son.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God shows three disciples who Jesus really is

Jesus shone brightly

The glory of Jesus was shown to three disciples

The change of/in Jesus’ appearance

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:1–12 and Luke 9:28–36.

9:12a

He replied, “Elijah does indeed come first,

- He answered, “Indeed, Elijah must come first
- Jesus replied, “They are right to say that Elijah comes before the Christ/Messiah

9:12b

and he restores all things.

- to cause everything to be right/good again.
- and will put everything in order again. (GW)
- and makes every issue/matter the way it should be.

9:12a–b

Elijah does indeed come first, and he restores all things: The clause Elijah does indeed come first, and he restores all things indicates that Elijah comes before the Christ. Then Elijah restores all things.

The present tense of the word restores is used here to refer generally to an event happening. The tense does not indicate here whether the event has already happened, is happening now, or will someday happen.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Elijah must come first and restore all things.

Elijah will/shall come first and restore all things.

indeed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as indeed indicates that the speaker agrees but will later say something in contrast (9:13). In this context, Jesus agreed that Elijah must come first (9:11b), but later explained that John the Baptist fulfilled the prophecy about Elijah (9:13).

Here are some other ways to translate this:

To be sure (NIV)

certainly (CEV)

restores all things: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as restores means “return something to a previously good condition,” “heal,” or “put something back in proper order.” The original prophecy in Malachi 4:5–6 referred to restoring good relationships between parents and children. Here Jesus was referring to the work of Elijah that John the Baptist did. John the Baptist taught people to repent. This restored their relationship with God so that they would be prepared for the Messiah to come.

Here are some other ways to express the meaning of restores all things in this context:

will put everything in order again (GW)

to set everything right again (NJB)

make everything the way it should be (NCV)

Several versions have a general phrase “will get everything ready” (as in the GNT). But it may be better to use an expression that focuses more on the specific meaning of “restore.”

all things: The Greek word that the BSB translates as all things is literally “all.” It refers here to every situation in human society that needs to be restored or made right. It especially refers to people’s relation-

ships with each other and with God. It does not refer to physical objects.

9:12c–d

Why then is it written that the Son of Man must suffer many things and be rejected?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus asked this question to cause the disciples to think further on this topic. The disciples still did not understand that Jesus must suffer and be rejected. There are at least two ways to translate this meaning:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

yet how is it that the scriptures say about the Son of man that he must suffer grievously and be treated with contempt? (NJB)

Yet why do the Scriptures say that the Son of Man will suffer much and be rejected? (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

Then consider the Scriptures that say that the Son of Man must endure much suffering and be rejected.

Then explain how the Scriptures say that I the Son of Man will suffer much and be rejected.

Use whichever form is most natural in your language to cause someone to think further on a topic.

Son of Man: See the note at 9:9c.

9:12c

Why then is it written that

- If that is true, how should we understand what God caused to be written that says that
- Then consider that the written words of God say that

Why...is it written: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Why is literally “how” or “in what sense.” The phrase that the BSB translates as it is written refers to Scripture. It asks: “How should we understand the Scriptures that say that the Son of Man must suffer much and be rejected?” For example, the NJB says:

...how is it that the scriptures say...?

See also the notes on 1:2a and 7:6b, where similar expressions occur.

See the General Comment on 9:12c–d after 9:12d for ways to use more than one sentence to express the information in this question.

9:12d

the Son of Man must suffer many things and be rejected?

- it is necessary that the Son of Man must endure great suffering and be rejected?
- I the Son of Man must suffer much and the people will consider me to be of no value.

suffer many things: The word suffer refers to what Jesus experienced when people did bad things to him. The Greek word that the BSB translates as many things here is the same phrased translated as “many things” in 8:31a.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

experience/endure great hardship

suffer a lot (GW)

See how you translated this expression in 8:31b.

be rejected: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as be rejected means here “be treated with contempt” (as in the RSV) or “be considered as worthless.” It has a similar meaning to the different verb that is used in 8:31c.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

be looked down on

be counted as useless

The clause be rejected is passive. In some languages it may be more natural in to use an active verb here. For example, the NCV says:

people will treat him as if he were nothing

General Comment on 9:12c–d

In some languages it may be necessary to use more than one sentence to express the information in 9:12c–d. For example:

What then is the meaning of this that is written in God’s Word? It says that it is necessary that the Son of Man endure great hardship. People will also reject/despise him.

You also need to consider the written words of God that are about me, the Son of Man. It says that I must suffer much and that people will count me as worthless.

Mark 9:13

Section 9:2–13: Three disciples saw Jesus’ glory

In 8:27–30 Peter stated that Jesus was the Christ. In 8:31–38 Jesus told the disciples about his future suffering, death, and resurrection. Then in 9:2–13 God caused Jesus to be glorified for a short time. Peter, James, and John saw this.

During that time, Moses and Elijah appeared and talked with Jesus. Peter suggested building shelters for Jesus, Moses, and Elijah. God showed these disciples that Jesus was greater than the great prophets Moses and Elijah, because Jesus was God’s Son.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God shows three disciples who Jesus really is

Jesus shone brightly

The glory of Jesus was shown to three disciples

The change of/in Jesus’ appearance

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:1–12 and Luke 9:28–36.

9:13a

But I tell you that Elijah has indeed come,

- But I tell you^(plur) that Elijah has already come,
- I assure you that someone like Elijah has already come;

But: The Greek conjunction here introduces a contrast with what Jesus had just said. In 9:12a Jesus agreed with part of what the teachers of the law said. Here he said something that disagrees with another part of what the teachers of the law said. This verse does not state what the teachers of the law said. They were probably saying that the prophecy about Elijah had not yet been fulfilled. Translate the connection in a way that indicates that Jesus disagreed with them here.

I tell you: Jesus often used the words I tell you to begin a statement that he wanted to emphasize. It

indicates that the statement was important and that people should listen carefully to it. Some other ways to show this emphasis are:

- Use a phrase before Jesus' statement. For example:

Let me tell you this

Listen

I assure you

- Use an emphatic word within Jesus' statement. For example:

Elijah has certainly come

If you have another way in your language to emphasize an important statement, consider using it here.

Elijah has indeed come: John the Baptist fulfilled the prophecy about Elijah coming and restoring all things. The historical Elijah did not come and restore all things. You may want to:

- Use a simile and include implied information here. For example:

someone like Elijah has already come

a person already came and fulfilled that prophecy about Elijah

- Use a footnote to explain. For example:

According to Matthew 17:13, the disciples understood that Jesus was referring here to John the Baptist. But the teachers of the law were probably expecting the prophet Elijah to return from heaven and fulfill the prophecy.

9:13b

and they have done to him whatever they wished,

- but they badly mistreated him just as they desired.
- yet people did every evil thing to him that they pleased,

they have done to him whatever they wished: The words they have done to him whatever they wished imply that people did all the evil and hurtful things to John that they wanted to. This included killing him.

If people in your area will think the people did only good things to John, you may want to include some implied information. For example:

they did all the evil things that they wanted to do to him

they badly mistreated him, just as they desired

they: The pronoun they refers to John's enemies. This included Herod and Herod's wife (6:17–20) and perhaps some of the leaders of the Jews (Matthew 3:7). If the pronoun they is not natural here in your language, you may want to use a general expression.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

people (GNT)

some/certain people

there were those/people who...

9:13c

just as it is written about him."

- This is exactly what is written/predicted in the Scriptures about him."
- just like God caused to be written about him."

just as it is written about him: The clause it is written is a common way that people in the New Testament used to refer to the Old Testament. The Old Testament Scriptures predicted these things about John in his role as Elijah.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

as the Scriptures said it would happen (NCV)

just as the Scriptures predicted (NLT)

The phrase as it is written also occurs in 7:6b.

Mark 9:14

Section 9:14–29: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a boy

Earlier Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. The disciples divided into groups of two and went and did those things (6:7–13). But here, when Jesus came down from the mountain with Peter, James, and John, he saw the

other disciples arguing with the teachers of the Jewish law. They were arguing because the disciples were not able to make an evil spirit leave a man's son.

When the evil spirit saw Jesus, it took control of the boy. Then Jesus caused the evil spirit to leave him. A large crowd of people was there and saw all these things.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Healing of a Boy with an Evil Spirit (NIV)

A boy was freed from an evil spirit

The Disciples' Failure to Heal (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:14–21 and Luke 9:37–43.

9:14a

When they returned to the other disciples,

- ¶ When they came/returned to the other disciples,
- ¶ When Jesus and his three followers came down the mountain,

9:14a–b

When they returned to the other disciples, they saw: There is a textual issue here. (1) Some Greek manuscripts have plural verb endings. The implied subject of these verbs is Jesus and the three disciples who went up the mountain with him. For example, the GNT says: “When they joined the rest of the disciples, they saw” (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, JBP, REB, NCV, ESV). (2) Other Greek manuscripts have singular verb endings. The implied subject of these verbs is Jesus. For example, the KJV says: “when he came to [his] disciples, he saw” (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). Since a new paragraph begins here, it may be natural to indicate who the word they refers to. For example:

When Jesus and the three disciples came to the other disciples, they saw...

returned to the other disciples: In 9:9a, Jesus and his disciples were descending the mountain. It is implied that they finished descending the mountain and then came to the place where the other disciples were. In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit some of this implied information. For example:

When Jesus and his three disciples had come down the mountain, they reached/approached the place where the other disciples were.

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means “learners” who are in a relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Some ways to translate disciples are:

- Use a term that refers to people who learn from a teacher or an expert. It is helpful if the term also implies that the learners are often with their teacher. For example:

learners/students

apprentices Be careful not to use a term that would refer only to a student in a school or classroom.

- Use a term that refers to people who follow a teacher or leader by obeying his teaching. It is helpful if this term also implies learning from the teacher and actually following the teacher wherever he goes. For example:

followers

those who are committed/faithful (to a teacher/leader)

See how you translated this term at 8:34a. See also disciple in the Glossary for more information.

9:14b

they saw a large crowd around them,

- they saw a large crowd standing around them,
- they saw/found a large group of people surrounding the other followers.

they saw: In the phrase that the BSB translates as they saw, the word they again refers to Jesus and the three disciples who were with him on the mountain.

around them: The word them here refers to the other disciples who had not gone up the mountain with Jesus.

9:14c

and scribes arguing with them.

- and some teachers of the Law of Moses were arguing/discussing with them.
- There were also some experts in the law there who were arguing/discussing with them.

scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes is the same word as in 9:11a–b.

In this context the phrase scribes refers to some of the teachers of the law. It does not refer to all of them. In some languages you may need to make this explicit. For example:

and some teachers of religious law (NLT)

There were also teachers of the law who

arguing: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as arguing can also mean “discussing” (as in the RSV in 9:16). It is not known whether the disciples and the teachers of the law were angrily arguing or calmly discussing. If possible, use an expression that allows for either meaning.

with them: The pronoun them here again refers to the disciples who had not gone up the mountain with Jesus.

Mark 9:15

Section 9:14–29: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a boy

Earlier Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. The disciples divided into groups of two and went and did those things (6:7–13). But here, when Jesus came down from the mountain with Peter, James, and John, he saw the other disciples arguing with the teachers of the Jewish law. They were arguing because the disciples were not able to make an evil spirit leave a man’s son.

When the evil spirit saw Jesus, it took control of the boy. Then Jesus caused the evil spirit to leave him. A large crowd of people was there and saw all these things.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Healing of a Boy with an Evil Spirit (NIV)

A boy was freed from an evil spirit

The Disciples’ Failure to Heal (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:14–21 and Luke 9:37–43.

9:15a

As soon as all the people saw Jesus,

- Immediately, when all the people in the crowd saw Jesus,
- When all the people in the crowd saw Jesus/him, immediately

9:15b

they were filled with awe

- they were very amazed
- they felt great surprise/awe

9:15c

and ran to greet Him.

- and ran/hurried to welcome him.
- and ran to him and greeted him.

9:15a–c

As soon as all the people saw Jesus, they were filled with awe: Verse 9:15a–c indicates that the people were very surprised when they saw Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

When the whole crowd saw him, they were immediately overcome with awe (NRSV)

The whole crowd saw Jesus, and they were immediately amazed.

As soon as: The Greek word that the BSB translates as As soon as indicates that the reaction of the crowd was the next event that happened. In some languages the meaning of “as soon as” or “immediately” may be left implied. For example, the GW says:

All the people were very surprised to see Jesus

Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language.

they were filled with awe: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as they were filled with awe indicates a strong reaction. The reaction can be positive or negative. It depends on the context. Elsewhere in Mark this Greek verb is used to refer to sorrow (14:34a) and alarm/fear (16:5d). A different form of the same verb is used in 1:27a to refer to shock or amazement.

In this context, this verb probably refers to great surprise or amazement. The people were surprised or amazed because they did not expect to see Jesus right then. This verb may also refer to a feeling of amaze-

ment. The people were perhaps amazed because Jesus' face or clothes were still shining faintly. Mark did not say why the people were surprised or awed. So you should not make explicit the reason for their reaction.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

were greatly surprised (GNT)

were overcome with awe (REB)

were struck with amazement (NJB)

were filled/overcome with surprise and awe

In some languages it may be natural to use a metaphor or idiom to express great surprise or awe.

ran to greet Him: The people ran to Jesus in order to greet him. They wanted to greet him by speaking words of welcome. In some languages it may not be natural to say that a crowd of people ran. If that is true in your language, you may use a more general word. For example, the CEV says:

everyone hurried over to greet him

Mark 9:16

Section 9:14–29: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a boy

Earlier Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. The disciples divided into groups of two and went and did those things (6:7–13). But here, when Jesus came down from the mountain with Peter, James, and John, he saw the other disciples arguing with the teachers of the Jewish law. They were arguing because the disciples were not able to make an evil spirit leave a man's son.

When the evil spirit saw Jesus, it took control of the boy. Then Jesus caused the evil spirit to leave him. A large crowd of people was there and saw all these things.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Healing of a Boy with an Evil Spirit (NIV)

A boy was freed from an evil spirit

The Disciples' Failure to Heal (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:14–21 and Luke 9:37–43.

9:16

“What are you disputing with them?” He asked.

- He asked, “What are you^(plur) teachers of the law arguing about with my disciples?”
- He asked them, “What are all of you^(plur) discussing?”
- He asked them what they were discussing with the others.

What are you disputing with them?: The pronoun you probably refers to the teachers of the law. The pronoun them probably refers to the disciples.

If possible, translate the pronouns you and them in a general way that refers to two groups (as in the BSB). It may also be possible to leave the pronouns untranslated. For example, the NLT says:

What is all this arguing about?

disputing: This is the same Greek word here as in 9:14c. Translate this word the same way you did in 9:14c.

He asked: The BSB places the words He asked after Jesus' question. In Greek, these words occur before the question. Place the words He asked where it is natural in your language.

Mark 9:17

Section 9:14–29: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a boy

Earlier Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. The disciples divided into groups of two and went and did those things (6:7–13). But here, when Jesus came down from the mountain with Peter, James, and John, he saw the other disciples arguing with the teachers of the Jewish law. They were arguing because the disciples were not able to make an evil spirit leave a man's son.

When the evil spirit saw Jesus, it took control of the boy. Then Jesus caused the evil spirit to leave him. A large crowd of people was there and saw all these things.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Healing of a Boy with an Evil Spirit (NIV)

A boy was freed from an evil spirit

The Disciples' Failure to Heal (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:14–21 and Luke 9:37–43.

9:17a

Someone in the crowd replied,

- A man answered him from the crowd, (NJB)

Someone in the crowd replied: This person was somewhere in the crowd that had run to greet Jesus.

9:17b

“Teacher, I brought You my son, who has a spirit that makes him mute.

- “Teacher, I brought my son to you. He has an evil spirit in him and is not able to speak.
- “Sir/Teacher, an evil spirit has possessed my son. It prevents him from talking. So I brought him here to you.

Teacher: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Teacher was a polite title for a Jewish religious leader. It was a title of respect for a Jewish man who had authority to teach the things about God. In some languages the appropriate way to address a religious teacher may be:

Sir Teacher

Sir

Master

Be careful not to use a term that can refer only to a school teacher.

This same word occurs in 4:38c.

I brought You my son, who has a spirit that makes him mute: It might be more natural in your language to reorder this sentence to have the background information first. For example:

My son is possessed by a spirit that has robbed him of speech. I brought him to you.

The son's condition is also the implied reason why the man brought him to Jesus. In some languages it may be more natural to make this reason explicit. For example:

I brought my son to you, because he is possessed by an evil spirit that has made him mute.

I brought You my son: The father brought his son to Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

I brought my son to you (RSV)

I came with my son to you.

son: The word son here probably refers to a boy who was less than thirteen years old and more than three years old. If your language has a term with that meaning, you could use it here.

who has a spirit that makes him mute: This expression indicates that the spirit controlled the boy and caused him to be unable to speak.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

A demon keeps him from talking. (CEV)

he has a spirit that makes him unable to speak (NRSV)

He has an evil spirit in him that stops him from talking. (NCV)

has a spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as has a spirit is literally “having a spirit.” This phrase indicates that an evil spirit controlled the boy's thoughts and actions.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

has an evil spirit in him (GNT)

possessed by a spirit (NIV)

on whom an evil spirit had fastened

on whom an evil spirit was riding

Use an expression that is natural in your language to refer to an evil spirit controlling a person. A similar phrase occurs in 7:25a.

a spirit: The Greek word that the BSB translates as spirit refers to a spirit that is evil and can control

people's actions. Here the word spirit refers to the same type of spirit as the Greek terms that are often translated as "evil spirit," "unclean spirit," and "demon."

Here are some other ways to translate spirit:

- Use a general term in your language that refers to a spirit that is evil and can control people.
- Use a specific term in your language that refers to a certain type of spirit. This spirit should be able to do what is described in this context. Do not use a term that refers to the spirit of a dead person.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

an evil/bad spirit

an unclean spirit Be sure that an expression like "unclean spirit" does not imply that the spirit is literally dirty.

See how you translated "unclean spirit" in 1:23a. See also evil spirit in the Glossary for more information.

Mark 9:18

Section 9:14–29: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a boy

Earlier Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. The disciples divided into groups of two and went and did those things (6:7–13). But here, when Jesus came down from the mountain with Peter, James, and John, he saw the other disciples arguing with the teachers of the Jewish law. They were arguing because the disciples were not able to make an evil spirit leave a man's son.

When the evil spirit saw Jesus, it took control of the boy. Then Jesus caused the evil spirit to leave him. A large crowd of people was there and saw all these things.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Healing of a Boy with an Evil Spirit (NIV)

A boy was freed from an evil spirit

The Disciples' Failure to Heal (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:14–21 and Luke 9:37–43.

9:18a

Whenever it seizes him,

- Whenever it grabs him,
- When the evil spirit controls him,

Whenever it seizes him: The verb that the BSB translates as seizes refers to the spirit suddenly and forcefully making the boy do things.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Whenever the spirit grabs him

Whenever the spirit overcomes him

When the evil spirit takes control of him

9:18b

it throws him to the ground.

- it causes him to fall down, shaking violently.
- it causes him to have seizures.

it throws him to the ground: The Greek word that the BSB translates as throws...to the ground means "cause to fall with violent shaking." This action is similar to a seizure caused by epilepsy. The evil spirit caused the boy to fall to the ground with violent shaking. This expression does not refer to the demon physically throwing the boy. Another way to translate this is:

causes him to have seizures

9:18c

He foams at the mouth,

- Foam comes out of his mouth,
- My son foams at the mouth,

He foams at the mouth: Use the expression in your language that describes what happens when a person has an epileptic fit/seizure and white foam/bubbles come out of his mouth.

He: The pronoun He refers to the boy.

9:18d

gnashes his teeth, and becomes rigid.

- he grinds his teeth and becomes stiff all over,
- and he grinds his teeth together and becomes stiff and does not move.

gnashes his teeth: The word gnashes refers to forcefully grinding one's teeth together. For example, the NET has:

grinds his teeth

and becomes rigid: The Greek word that the BSB translates as becomes rigid is an idiom. In this context it indicates that the boy became stiff and could not move. For example, the GNT has:

becomes stiff all over

9:18e

I asked Your disciples to drive it out,

- I asked your disciples to cause the evil spirit to leave,
- I asked your followers to force the demon to go out of him,

to drive it out: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to drive it out is literally “to cast/throw out the spirit.” To drive...out an evil spirit means to cause the evil spirit to stop controlling a person.

Jewish people often spoke of evil spirits as being in someone. Different cultures have different ways of speaking about people being controlled by evil spirits and being released from the control of evil spirits. Use a natural expression for this in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

force the evil spirit out of the boy

cause the evil spirit to leave

exorcize the evil spirit

send the evil spirit away

free the boy from the control of the evil spirit

Similar phrases occur in 1:34b and 3:15.

9:18f

but they were unable.”

- but they were unable to do it.”
- but they did not have the power/ability to do that.”

but they were unable: The Greek word that the BSB translates as were unable means not to “have power” or not to “be able.” The disciples were not able to drive out the evil spirit. The GW shows another way to translate this clause:

but they didn’t have the power to do it

Mark 9:19

Section 9:14–29: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a boy

Earlier Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. The disciples divided into groups of two and went and did those things (6:7–13). But here, when Jesus came down from the mountain with Peter, James, and John, he saw the other disciples arguing with the teachers of the Jewish law. They were arguing because the disciples were not able to make an evil spirit leave a man’s son.

When the evil spirit saw Jesus, it took control of the boy. Then Jesus caused the evil spirit to leave him. A large crowd of people was there and saw all these things.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Healing of a Boy with an Evil Spirit (NIV)

A boy was freed from an evil spirit

The Disciples’ Failure to Heal (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:14–21 and Luke 9:37–43.

9:19a

“O unbelieving generation!” Jesus replied.

- In response Jesus said, “O generation who does not believe!
- Jesus said to them, “You people who do not believe in God,

O unbelieving generation!: The phrase O unbelieving generation here indicates that Jesus was speaking directly to the people. It also indicates emotion. Jesus was disturbed that the people living at that time did not believe in him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

You unbelieving generation! (NET)

What an unbelieving generation! (REB)

unbelieving: The words that the BSB translates as unbelieving likely indicates that the people were not believing/trusting in God. In some languages it may be necessary to make that explicit. For example:

You people have no faith in God.

generation: The Greek word that the BSB translates as generation refers to the adults who are alive during the same period of time. The text does not specify exactly who Jesus referred to in this context. He may have referred specifically to the crowd and the scribes, who were mentioned in 9:14b–c. He may even have been thinking of the disciples. You should translate unbelieving generation with a phrase that refers in general to the people who were present. For example:

You people have no faith. (NCV)

You faithless people! (NLT)

See also the notes on 8:12b and 8:38b.

Jesus replied: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Jesus replied is literally “Having answered them, he said....” There is a textual issue here. (1) Some Greek manuscripts have Jesus replied to them. For example, the GNT says: “Jesus said to them” (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, JBP, REB, NCV, ESV). (2) Other Greek manuscripts have Jesus replied to him. This indicates that Jesus responded to the father. For example, the KJV says: “He answereth him” (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). You can translate this as “Jesus replied to them” or simply “Jesus replied.” Here, the word “answered” means “responded.” Jesus responded to the man’s statement about the disciples. He was probably also responding to the entire crowd who was arguing (9:16). He was not speaking directly to the boy’s father. So it may be more natural to say:

Jesus said to them (GNT)

Jesus said (CEV)

Jesus responded

The BSB places the words Jesus replied in the middle of Jesus’ spoken words. In Greek, these words occur at the beginning of 9:19. Place these words where it is natural in your language.

9:19b–c

you?...you?: The forms of the word you here are plural.

9:19b

“How long must I remain with you?”

- How much longer must I be with you? (NET)

- I have stayed with you and your lack of faith long enough already!

How long must I remain with you?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus expressed his frustration and anger. Jesus was frustrated that the disciples and the other people there did not have faith in him. He wondered how long he would have to remain on the earth before they trusted him. There are at least two ways to translate this frustration:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

How much longer must I be with you? (NET)

How long must I be with you until you believe? (NLT96)

- As a statement. For example:

Staying with you is so difficult!

I have been with you such a long time and yet you still do not believe!

9:19c

How long must I put up with you?

- How long must I endure you?
- I have endured you and your lack of faith long enough already!”

How long must I put up with you?: This is another rhetorical question. Jesus probably used this second rhetorical question to emphasize how frustrated he was. Jesus was frustrated because the disciples and the people did not believe in him. He wondered how much longer he would have to endure their lack of faith. There are at least two ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

How much longer must I endure you? (NET)

How long must I wait for you to believe?

- As a statement. For example:

Having patience with you is so difficult!

I have to endure your unbelief for such a long time!

Use whichever form is most natural to express this rebuke in your language.

put up with: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as the English idiom put up with means “endure,” “bear with” or “be patient with.” For example the NET says:

How much longer must I endure you?

9:19d

Bring the boy to Me.”

- Bring the boy here.”
- Then he said, “Bring the boy here to me.”

In some languages, it may be natural to begin 9:19d with “Then he said...”

the boy: In this context the word boy refers to a male probably less than thirteen years old and more than three years old.

Mark 9:20

Section 9:14–29: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a boy

Earlier Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. The disciples divided into groups of two and went and did those things (6:7–13). But here, when Jesus came down from the mountain with Peter, James, and John, he saw the other disciples arguing with the teachers of the Jewish law. They were arguing because the disciples were not able to make an evil spirit leave a man’s son.

When the evil spirit saw Jesus, it took control of the boy. Then Jesus caused the evil spirit to leave him. A large crowd of people was there and saw all these things.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Healing of a Boy with an Evil Spirit (NIV)

A boy was freed from an evil spirit

The Disciples’ Failure to Heal (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:14–21 and Luke 9:37–43.

9:20a

So they brought him,

- So they brought/took him.

- Then the people brought the boy to him.

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So here is translated as “And” in the RSV. It introduces the people’s response to Jesus’ command. Introduce this response in a way that is natural in your language. In some languages, no conjunction is necessary (as in the GNT).

they brought him: The word they refers to some of the people in the crowd. It may also refer to some of the disciples. If possible, do not make they specific. Another way to say this is:

Some of the people came with the boy to him.

brought: In this context, the Greek verb that the BSB translates as brought implies that they helped the boy go to Jesus. They may have carried him, led him by the hand, or simply escorted him. If it is not natural in your language to use a word such as brought or “took,” use another expression with a general meaning. For example:

they came with the boy to him

they helped the boy to go to him

9:20b

and seeing Jesus, the spirit immediately threw the boy into a convulsion.

- When the spirit saw Jesus, it immediately caused the boy to shake uncontrollably.
- As soon as the evil spirit in the boy saw Jesus, it caused him to shake violently.

9:20c

He fell to the ground and rolled around, foaming at the mouth.

- He fell and rolled around on the ground, and foamed at the mouth.
- The boy collapsed on the ground and rolled and rolled, and foam came out of his mouth.

9:20b–c

the spirit: The word spirit refers to the evil spirit that possessed the boy. It is the same word as in 9:17b.

threw...into a convulsion: The Greek phrase the BSB translates as threw...into a convulsion means “convulse,” or “cause to shake violently.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

it made the boy shake all over (CEV)

it made the boy lose control of himself (NCV)

it caused the child to shake violently

This same phrase is translated as “threw...into convulsions” in 1:26a.

Mark 9:21

Section 9:14–29: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a boy

Earlier Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. The disciples divided into groups of two and went and did those things (6:7–13). But here, when Jesus came down from the mountain with Peter, James, and John, he saw the other disciples arguing with the teachers of the Jewish law. They were arguing because the disciples were not able to make an evil spirit leave a man’s son.

When the evil spirit saw Jesus, it took control of the boy. Then Jesus caused the evil spirit to leave him. A large crowd of people was there and saw all these things.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Healing of a Boy with an Evil Spirit (NIV)

A boy was freed from an evil spirit

The Disciples’ Failure to Heal (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:14–21 and Luke 9:37–43.

9:21a

Jesus asked the boy’s father, “How long has this been with him?”

- Jesus asked the boy’s father, “How long has he had this condition?”
- “How long has this been happening?” Jesus asked the boy’s father. (NLT)

How long has this been with him?: This is a real question. Jesus asked how many months or years the boy had had this problem. This question does not ask how many seconds or minutes the boy had been convulsing on this occasion.

Here is another way to translate this question:

When did these convulsions begin?

9:21b

“From childhood,” he said.

- He answered, “Ever since he was an infant.
- The man answered, “This began when he was a small child.

From childhood: The Greek word that the BSB translates as childhood also means “infancy.” It can refer all the way back to the time when a child was a newborn baby.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Since he was very small/young

Ever since he was a little child

Ever since he was born

he said: The BS places the words he said in the middle of the father’s response. In Greek, these words occur at the beginning of 9:21b. Place the words he said where it is natural in your language.

Mark 9:22

Section 9:14–29: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a boy

Earlier Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. The disciples divided into groups of two and went and did those things (6:7–13). But here, when Jesus came down from the mountain with Peter, James, and John, he saw the other disciples arguing with the teachers of the Jewish law. They were arguing because the disciples were not able to make an evil spirit leave a man’s son.

When the evil spirit saw Jesus, it took control of the boy. Then Jesus caused the evil spirit to leave him. A large crowd of people was there and saw all these things.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Healing of a Boy with an Evil Spirit (NIV)

A boy was freed from an evil spirit

The Disciples’ Failure to Heal (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:14–21 and Luke 9:37–43.

9:22a

“It often throws him into the fire or into the water, trying to kill him.

- The spirit often throws him not only into fire, but also into water, trying to kill him.
- The evil spirit often tries to kill him by causing him to fall into fire or into water.

It often throws him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as It...throws him here means that the spirit had forcefully caused the boy to fall. It does not mean that the spirit threw the boy in the way in which a person throws a stone. It might be more natural in your language to use the word “fall” here. For example:

It has often caused him to fall

into the fire or into the water: The Greek words that the BSB translates as into the fire or into the water are literally “both into fire and into water.” The Greek grammar emphasizes both fire and water. For example:

both into the fire and into the water (NASB)

not only into the fire, but into the water as well

9:22b

But if You can do anything,

- If you are able to do anything to help,
- But if you can do something for him,

But: The word But indicates the contrast between 9:22a and 9:22b. There is a contrast between what the demon was doing to the boy and what the father hoped. He hoped that Jesus could force the demon to leave.

In some languages it is not natural to contrast a statement with a request. If that is true in your language, you may leave this contrast implicit. For example, the CEV says:

Please have pity and help us if you can!

Indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

if You can do anything: The phrase if You can do anything indicates that the father was not sure that

Jesus could help the boy. He asked for any kind of help for the boy, even if it only helped him a little.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

if you are able to do anything (NRSV)

If you can do anything for him (NCV)

9:22c

have compassion on us and help us.”

- have compassion and help us^(excl) now.”
- have mercy on us^(excl) and help us.^(excl)”

have compassion on us: The Greek word that the BSB translates as have compassion means “to have pity.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Have mercy on us (NLT)

have compassion on us (NET)

feel sorry for us

us: The pronoun us probably refers to the man and his son. But it may refer to the man’s entire family.

Mark 9:23

Section 9:14–29: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a boy

Earlier Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. The disciples divided into groups of two and went and did those things (6:7–13). But here, when Jesus came down from the mountain with Peter, James, and John, he saw the other disciples arguing with the teachers of the Jewish law. They were arguing because the disciples were not able to make an evil spirit leave a man’s son.

When the evil spirit saw Jesus, it took control of the boy. Then Jesus caused the evil spirit to leave him. A large crowd of people was there and saw all these things.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Healing of a Boy with an Evil Spirit (NIV)

A boy was freed from an evil spirit

The Disciples' Failure to Heal (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:14–21 and Luke 9:37–43.

9:23a

“If You can?” echoed Jesus.

- Jesus said, “You said, ‘if you are able to!’—
- Jesus asked. “Why do you doubt that I can do anything?
- Jesus replied, “You should not doubt that I can do this!

9:23b

“All things are possible to him who believes!”

- All things can be done for the one who believes.” (NRSV)
- Anything is possible if a person believes/trusts in me.”

9:23a–b

If You can?: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as If You can? is literally, “the ‘if you can.’” It indicates that Jesus was repeating the words “If you can” that the man had said to him in 9:22b. It also indicates that Jesus was about to respond to these words. Use a natural way in your language to indicate that Jesus was repeating the man’s words.

The phrase If you can also expresses a mild rebuke. It indicates that the man should not doubt that Jesus could help him.

Some ways to translate If you can in this context are:

- As an introductory phrase. For example:

Jesus said to the father, “You said, ‘If you can!’” (NCV)

As for your words ‘If you can,’ know/realize that everything is possible...

- As a rhetorical question. In some languages it may be necessary to use a pronoun like “I” to show that Jesus was talking about himself. For example:

Why do you doubt/question that I can do anything about this?

- As a statement or command. For example:

As for whether I can do anything...

You should not doubt that I can do this.

echoed Jesus: The phrase that the BSB translates as echoed Jesus is more literally “Jesus said to him.” The BSB places these words in the middle of what Jesus said. It also puts the subject Jesus after the verb echoed. In Greek, these words occur before the question. Place the words echoed Jesus where it is natural in your language and in a natural word order.

All things are possible to him who believes: In this context the phrase All things are possible means that anything can be done or anything may happen if a person believes. For example, the NRSV says:

All things can be done for the one who believes.

The phrase to him who believes refers to anyone who believes. For example, the NLT says:

if a person believes

In some languages it may be necessary to express the clause All things are possible to him who believes in a more active way. If that is true in your language, you may need to supply God or Jesus as the subject. For example:

I/God can do anything for the person who believes.

believes: In this context, the word believes refers to believing in Jesus. A person who believes is one who trusts that Jesus can do all things. This person is confident that Jesus has the power to help him or her.

Here are some other ways to translate believes:

relies/depends on me

trusts in me

has confidence that I can do all things

Your language may use an idiom for this meaning. See believe, Meaning 3, in the Glossary.

Mark 9:24

Section 9:14–29: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a boy

Earlier Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. The disciples divided into groups of two and went and did those things (6:7–13). But here, when Jesus came down from

the mountain with Peter, James, and John, he saw the other disciples arguing with the teachers of the Jewish law. They were arguing because the disciples were not able to make an evil spirit leave a man's son.

When the evil spirit saw Jesus, it took control of the boy. Then Jesus caused the evil spirit to leave him. A large crowd of people was there and saw all these things.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Healing of a Boy with an Evil Spirit (NIV)

A boy was freed from an evil spirit

The Disciples' Failure to Heal (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:14–21 and Luke 9:37–43.

9:24a

Immediately the boy's father cried out, "I do believe;

- As soon as he said that, the boy's father cried out, "I do believe;
- When he heard that, the boy's father immediately said loudly, "I do believe/trust that you are able to help.

Immediately: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Immediately indicates that the father said this right after Jesus finished talking in 9:23b. It probably is also used to emphasize the words that follow.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Right away (CEV)

at once (GNT)

instantly (NLT)

the boy's father cried out: There is a textual issue here. (1) Some Greek manuscripts have "cried out and said, I believe." For example, the NET says: "the father of the boy cried out and said, 'I believe'" (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NJB, ESV, NET, NASB, REB, GW, NLT, CEV, JBP, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have "cried out and said in tears, Lord, I believe." The KJV follows these manuscripts. For example: "the father of the child cried out, and said with tears, Lord, I believe" (KJV). It is recom-

mended that you follow option (1) and the majority of English versions. Do not include these words. The Greek word the BSB translates as cried out means "shouted loudly." Another way to translate this is:

shouted (CEV)

I do believe: Translate the word believe in the same way that you translated it in 9:23b. The man was saying that he trusted Jesus to help/heal his son. Your language may have a verb, expression, or idiom with that meaning.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

I have faith/confidence in you

I trust that you are able to help/heal my son

9:24b

help my unbelief!"

- help me not to doubt!" (NLT96)
- Help me to believe more!" (JBP)

help my unbelief: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as help my unbelief means that man claimed that he believed (9:24a), but he had doubts. So he wanted to believe more fully.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

help me not to doubt! (NLT96)

Help me to believe more! (JBP)

my unbelief: The word unbelief means "lack of faith." The man did not completely believe that Jesus could help the boy. He had some doubts.

General Comment on 9:24a–b

The man said, "I do believe; help my unbelief!" He claimed to believe, but he also knew that he doubted Jesus. The GNT shows another way to translate this:

I do have faith, but not enough. Help me have more!

Mark 9:25

Section 9:14–29: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a boy

Earlier Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. The disciples

divided into groups of two and went and did those things (6:7-13). But here, when Jesus came down from the mountain with Peter, James, and John, he saw the other disciples arguing with the teachers of the Jewish law. They were arguing because the disciples were not able to make an evil spirit leave a man's son.

When the evil spirit saw Jesus, it took control of the boy. Then Jesus caused the evil spirit to leave him. A large crowd of people was there and saw all these things.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Healing of a Boy with an Evil Spirit (NIV)

A boy was freed from an evil spirit

The Disciples' Failure to Heal (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:14-21 and Luke 9:37-43.

9:25a

When Jesus saw that a crowd had come running,

- ¶ When Jesus saw that many more people were running to that place and joining the crowd,
- ¶ Jesus saw that even more of a crowd was rushing/hurrying to watch them.

a crowd had come running: The clause a crowd had come running refers to many more people running to the place where Jesus was talking with the boy's father (9:17-24). They were joining the crowd that was already there. This clause does not refer to the people who were already there (9:14-15).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

even more of a crowd was gathering

many more people were running there and joining the crowd

9:25b

He rebuked the unclean spirit. "You deaf and mute spirit," He said,

- he rebuked the evil spirit, "Spirit of deafness and muteness,
- He spoke strongly against the demon by saying, "You^(sing) spirit that makes people unable to hear or speak,

He rebuked: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rebuked here means that Jesus spoke strongly and sternly against the spirit. For example:

spoke sternly to (REB)

spoke strongly against

The words that Jesus said to rebuke the evil spirit are in the following sentence.

the unclean spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the unclean spirit refers to the same spirit that was mentioned in 9:17-24. This spirit was controlling the boy's actions. Here the word unclean spirit refers to the same type of spirit as the Greek terms that are often translated as "evil spirit," and "demon." You should use the same expression or use an expression that clearly refers to the spirit that was mentioned in 9:17b. For example:

that spirit that was controlling the boy

the evil spirit

See evil spirit in the Glossary.

You deaf and mute spirit: The phrase deaf and mute describes what the spirit did to the boy. The spirit itself was not deaf and mute. It caused the boy to be deaf and unable to speak.

This phrase indicates that Jesus was speaking directly to the spirit, calling him deaf and mute spirit. The BSB supplies the pronoun You to indicate rebuke. This is good English style.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Spirit of deafness and muteness (NLT96)

You spirit that makes people unable to hear or speak (NCV)

If it is not natural in your language to call a spirit by a name like this, you may translate the phrase as a statement. For example:

You are a spirit of deafness and muteness.

You are a spirit that makes people unable to hear or speak.

He said: The BSB places the phrase He said in the middle of Jesus' words. In Greek, this phrase occurs before Jesus' words. Place the phrase He said where it is natural in your language.

9:25c

"I command you to come out

- I order you,^(sing) leave him
- I demand/require you^(sing) to go away from that boy

I command you: The clause I command you introduces the commands that follow. It also emphasizes those commands.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I demand/require you to do this:

I order you to (GNT)

to come out: The word that the BSB translates as come out is a normal way in Greek to speak of a demon releasing control of a person. It indicates here that Jesus commanded the demon to leave the boy and stop controlling him.

In some cultures, people do not think of demons as being in a person. If that is true in your language, it may not be natural to speak of them coming or going out of a person. Use a natural expression in your language for when a demon stops controlling a person.

Here are some other ways you could translate this:

Leave him!

Release him!

Translate this command in a way that fits the expression you used for the phrase "has a spirit" in 9:17b.

9:25d

and never enter him again."

- and never again return to him."
- and never come back to him."

and never enter him again: The phrase never enter him again is a command for the spirit to leave the boy alone. The spirit was never to control the boy again in the future.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and never return to him

and never come back to him

Mark 9:26

Section 9:14–29: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a boy

Earlier Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. The disciples divided into groups of two and went and did those things (6:7–13). But here, when Jesus came down from the mountain with Peter, James, and John, he saw the other disciples arguing with the teachers of the Jewish law. They were arguing because the disciples were not able to make an evil spirit leave a man's son.

When the evil spirit saw Jesus, it took control of the boy. Then Jesus caused the evil spirit to leave him. A large crowd of people was there and saw all these things.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Healing of a Boy with an Evil Spirit (NIV)

A boy was freed from an evil spirit

The Disciples' Failure to Heal (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:14–21 and Luke 9:37–43.

9:26a

After shrieking and convulsing him violently, the spirit came out.

- The spirit screamed, caused the boy to shake uncontrollably, and left him.
- Then the evil spirit yelled, made the boy shake violently, and then came out of him.

After: The Greek word that the BSB translates as After mean "and." In some languages, it may be natural to begin 9:26 with a time word, as the BSB does. For example, the NLT begins with the word "Then."

shrieking: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as shrieking means "shouted" or "screamed" without using words. The sound was probably similar to a scream of pain.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

screamed (NLT)

yelled

and convulsing him violently: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as convulsing him violently means “caused the boy to shake greatly.” It has the same meaning as in 9:20b, but with the added word “greatly,” or “very” here.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

it made the boy shake violently

it caused the child to shake very much

the spirit: The BSB has supplied the words the spirit. Some English versions use a pronoun. Refer to the unclean spirit in a way that is natural in your language.

came out: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as came out is the same verb as in 9:25c. It means “left” or “went away.”

9:26b

The boy became like a corpse, so that many said, “He is dead.”

- He appeared to be dead, and so many people were saying, “He is dead.”
- The boy looked so much like a dead person that many people said that he had died.

The boy became like a corpse, so that many said, “He is dead.”: Verse 9:26b tells what happened when the spirit first left the boy. The boy lay still and quiet, and people thought that he was dead.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

The boy appeared to be dead, so many people were saying, “He is dead.”

He looked dead; in fact, many said, “He is dead!”

In some languages it may be natural to translate the people’s words as indirect speech. For example:

He lay as still as a corpse, and people started saying that he was dead.

Mark 9:27

Section 9:14–29: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a boy

Earlier Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. The disciples

divided into groups of two and went and did those things (6:7–13). But here, when Jesus came down from the mountain with Peter, James, and John, he saw the other disciples arguing with the teachers of the Jewish law. They were arguing because the disciples were not able to make an evil spirit leave a man’s son.

When the evil spirit saw Jesus, it took control of the boy. Then Jesus caused the evil spirit to leave him. A large crowd of people was there and saw all these things.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Healing of a Boy with an Evil Spirit (NIV)

A boy was freed from an evil spirit

The Disciples’ Failure to Heal (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:14–21 and Luke 9:37–43.

9:27a

But Jesus took him by the hand and helped him to his feet,

- But Jesus took the boy’s hand and lifted him,
- But he was not dead. Jesus took the boy by the hand and helped him

But: The word But indicates a contrast between what the people said and what actually happened. The boy had not died. It might be more natural in your language to state this explicitly. For example:

But he was not dead.

Jesus took him by the hand: The phrase took him by the hand means that Jesus grasped one of the boy’s hands in order to help him to stand up. In some languages, this idea may be expressed with a single verb. See how you translated the almost identical phrase in 1:31a.

helped him to his feet: The phrase helped him to his feet shows that Jesus helped the boy stand up. It does not mean that Jesus picked him up from the ground.

9:27b

and he stood up.

- and he stood/got up.
- so that he was able to stand.

and he stood up: The phrase he stood up may indicate that the boy was able to stand with no one supporting him.

General Comment on 9:27a–b

In some languages, it may be necessary to combine parts of 9:27a and 9:27b. This will avoid the false meaning that Jesus helped the boy stand up and then the boy stood up again.

Here are some other ways to translate these two phrases:

^{27a}helped him up, ^{27b}and he was able to stand (NJB)

^{27a–b}and helped him to stand up (NCV)

Mark 9:28

Section 9:14–29: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a boy

Earlier Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. The disciples divided into groups of two and went and did those things (6:7–13). But here, when Jesus came down from the mountain with Peter, James, and John, he saw the other disciples arguing with the teachers of the Jewish law. They were arguing because the disciples were not able to make an evil spirit leave a man's son.

When the evil spirit saw Jesus, it took control of the boy. Then Jesus caused the evil spirit to leave him. A large crowd of people was there and saw all these things.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Healing of a Boy with an Evil Spirit (NIV)

A boy was freed from an evil spirit

The Disciples' Failure to Heal (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:14–21 and Luke 9:37–43.

9:28a

After Jesus had gone into the house,

- ¶ When Jesus went into a house
- ¶ Later, after Jesus and his disciples had gone into a house,

In some languages, it will be natural to begin this paragraph with a time word, as the BSB does. For example:

Afterward (NLT)

Later

After Jesus had gone into the house: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as After Jesus had gone into the house refers to Jesus entering a house. The house was probably one that Jesus and the disciples stayed in that night.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

When Jesus went into a house (GW)

Then Jesus went indoors (REB)

It is implied that the disciples had gone into the house with Jesus. For example, the NLT says:

when Jesus was alone in the house with his disciples

9:28b

His disciples asked Him privately,

- with his disciples, and they were alone together, they asked him,
- his followers asked him in private,
- his disciples came to him privately and asked him

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means “learners” who are in a relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

students/learners

apprentices

followers

See how you translated this term at 2:15b or 9:14a–b. See also disciple in the Glossary.

privately: The word privately here refers to a time when Jesus was alone with his disciples. The crowd was no longer present.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

when they were by themselves

when they were alone

9:28c

“Why couldn’t we drive it out?”

- “Why were we^(excl) not able to force it to leave?”
- “Why were we^(excl) not able to cause the evil spirit to come out of the boy?”
- the reason that they were not able to cause the evil spirit to leave the boy.

Why couldn’t we drive it out?: This is a real question. The disciples wanted Jesus to tell them why they had not been able to force the spirit to leave the boy.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

Why couldn’t we force that evil spirit out? (NCV)

Why could we not cause the evil spirit to stop harming/controlling the boy?

drive...out: The Greek word that the BSB translates as drive...out is literally “cast/throw out.” This is the same word as in 9:18e. You should translate it the same way as you did there.

it: The pronoun it refers to the evil spirit that was last mentioned in 9:26a. Refer back to the evil spirit here in a natural way in your language.

Mark 9:29

Section 9:14–29: Jesus expelled an evil spirit from a boy

Earlier Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. The disciples divided into groups of two and went and did those things (6:7–13). But here, when Jesus came down from the mountain with Peter, James, and John, he saw the other disciples arguing with the teachers of the Jewish law. They were arguing because the disciples were not able to make an evil spirit leave a man’s son.

When the evil spirit saw Jesus, it took control of the boy. Then Jesus caused the evil spirit to leave him. A large crowd of people was there and saw all these things.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Healing of a Boy with an Evil Spirit (NIV)

A boy was freed from an evil spirit

The Disciples’ Failure to Heal (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:14–21 and Luke 9:37–43.

9:29

Jesus answered, “This kind cannot come out, except by prayer.”

- He replied, “That kind of spirit can only be forced to leave if you pray.”
- Jesus replied, “Only by praying first will you be able to cause a spirit like this kind/type of spirit to come/go out.”
- Jesus told them that they could not cause a spirit like that to leave unless they asked/begged God to force it to leave.

This kind cannot come out, except by prayer: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as cannot come out, except by prayer indicates that only praying to God can cause that type of demon to leave a person and stop controlling him. The ESV translates this as:

This kind cannot be driven out by anything but prayer.

This kind: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as This kind refers to the type of unclean spirit that was controlling the boy. This kind or type of unclean spirit apparently had much power to control people. In many languages it may be natural to follow the model of the NCV and say:

That kind of spirit

come out: The verb come out here means “be forced to leave.”

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

can be forced out (GW)

can be cast out (NLT)

The same verb occurs in 9:25c.

by prayer: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as by prayer refers to praying to God. In this context it refers specifically to requesting or asking God to cause the demon to leave.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

through prayer (NRSV)

by asking/begging God to cause the demon to leave

prayer: There is a textual issue in this verse:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the word prayer. For example, the CEV says:

Only prayer can force out that kind of demon.
(RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, JBP, REB, NCV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the words prayer and fasting. For example, the KJV says:

This kind can come forth by nothing, but by prayer and fasting. (KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1).

Mark 9:30

Section 9:30–32: Jesus predicted his death a second time

In 8:31 Jesus told his disciples that his enemies would kill him and that God would cause him to live again. Here in 9:30–32, Jesus told his disciples the same thing again. But they still did not understand what he was talking about.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus again predicted that he would die and come back to life

Death and resurrection foretold a second time

Jesus again tells his disciples that he will be killed but then God will raise him from the dead

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:22–23 and Luke 9:43–45.

9:30a

Going on from there,

- ¶ Jesus and his disciples went from there
- ¶ Then Jesus and his followers left that area/place

The story in 9:30–32 began sometime after the story in 9:14–29 ended. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories. In some languages, it is natural to begin a story with a time word or phrase. If your language is like that, use an expression here that is not too specific. For example:

Then (NCV)

After that

In other languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this story in a natural way in your language.

Going on from there: The phrase Going on from there refers to Jesus and his disciples traveling away from the place where they were in the preceding story. This could be specifically the house where Jesus was (9:28) or the general area at the base of the mountain (9:9, 14). You should translate the words there in a way that refers generally to the preceding story. For example:

where they were

that region (NLT)

9:30b

they passed through Galilee.

- and were traveling through the region of Galilee.
- and began to go/walk through Galilee.

they passed through Galilee: The words they passed through Galilee give the setting for the events in 9:30–32. The Greek tense indicates that the events in 9:30–32 happened while they were passing through Galilee, not after they passed through. You should make this clear in your translation. For example:

and began to go through Galilee (NASB)

and were traveling through Galilee

they: The word they refers to Jesus and his disciples. If you started a new section here, you may want to make

“Jesus and his disciples” explicit instead of using the pronoun They.

Galilee: Galilee was a region, district, or province in the northern part of the country of Israel. If you need to make clear the kind of place Galilee was, see how you translated the word Galilee in 1:9a.

The word Galilee also occurs in 1:14b, 1:16a, 1:28, 1:39a, 3:7b, 6:21b, and 7:31b. Consider if it is necessary to continue to say explicitly that Galilee was a region or district.

9:30c

But Jesus did not want anyone to know,

- Jesus did not want other people to know where they were,
- But Jesus did not want anyone else to know that,

But Jesus did not want anyone to know: It might be more natural in your language to have the negative in the know clause instead of in the want clause. For example:

Jesus wanted no one to know where they were.

anyone: The word anyone refers to people other than the disciples. It may be natural to translate this as:

anyone else

to know: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as to know means that Jesus wanted no one to know his exact location.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

to know it (NRSV)

to know where they were going

Mark 9:31

Section 9:30–32: Jesus predicted his death a second time

In 8:31 Jesus told his disciples that his enemies would kill him and that God would cause him to live again. Here in 9:30–32, Jesus told his disciples the same thing again. But they still did not understand what he was talking about.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus again predicted that he would die and come back to life

Death and resurrection foretold a second time

Jesus again tells his disciples that he will be killed but then God will raise him from the dead

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:22–23 and Luke 9:43–45.

9:31a

because He was teaching His disciples.

- because he was teaching his disciples privately,
- because he was teaching only his followers.

because He was teaching His disciples: Jesus wanted to teach his disciples privately. You may want to include that implied information. For example:

he was teaching only his disciples

he was teaching his disciples privately

General Comment on 9:30c–31a

In these verses, 9:31a expresses the reason for the result in 9:30c. In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of these clauses. For example:

^{31a}He was teaching his disciples. ^{30c}That is why he did not want anyone to know where they were.

^{31a} As they were going, Jesus began to teach his disciples privately. ^{30c}So he did not want anyone to know where they were.

9:31b

He told them,

- saying to them, (RSV)
- Jesus taught them,
- This/Here is what he taught them,

He told them: The phrase He told them introduces what Jesus was teaching. You should translate 9:31b in a way that clearly connects the statement “because he was teaching his disciples” (9:31a) with the content of what Jesus was teaching (9:31c–e).

Here are some other ways to make this connection clear:

^{31a}for he was teaching his disciples, ^{31b}saying to them (RSV)

^{31a}for he was teaching his disciples ^{31b}and telling them (NET)

^{31a}because he was teaching his disciples. ^{31b}This is what he taught them:

9:31c–e

See the General Comment on 9:31c–e after 9:31e for a way to translate 9:31c–e as indirect speech.

9:31c

“The Son of Man will be delivered into the hands of men.

- “The Son of Man is about to be turned/handed over to the control of evil men/people.
- “Someone will soon betray/deliver me, the Son of Man, to the power/authority of my enemies,

The Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as The Son of Man is literally “the Son of the human/person.” It is a title that Jesus often used to refer to himself. It implies that:

1. he was a true human being, and he represented all people.
2. he came from God and had authority from God.

Some ways to translate this title are:

the Man whom God Sent

the True Man from God/Heaven

the Representative of Mankind

The Older Brother of All People

In some languages it may be necessary to use a form like “I” or “me” to indicate that Jesus was referring to himself here. For example:

I, the Son of Man

I who became man/human

The phrase The Son of Man also occurs in 9:9c and 9:12d. You should translate it here as you did there.

will be delivered: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as will be delivered refers to something that would definitely happen in the near future.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

will soon be betrayed

is now to be handed over (REB)

delivered: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as delivered means “given into the power of someone else.” It often refers to a person being delivered to his enemies. This expression could have two meanings here:

1. Judas would give Jesus into the power of his enemies.
2. God would cause Jesus to be given into the power of people. Then they would kill him and so fulfill God’s plan.

It is possible that both meanings are meant. If possible, translate this in a general way that allows both meanings. For example:

is about to be betrayed

will soon be put/placed into the power of his enemies

This is a passive verb. If possible, avoid saying who did this action. If it is necessary in your language to say who did it, use an expression that allows either God and Judas to be understood. For example:

someone is going to betray

See how you translated the active verb “betrayed” in 3:19.

into the hands of men: The phrase into the hands of men is a figure of speech. It means “under the power of people.” In this context, this expression refers to Jesus being under the power of people who will harm him. In some languages, this expression is implied in the verb. It does not need to be explicitly translated.

The CEV has:

over to people

Do not translate this in a way that means people will protect him. In some languages it may be necessary to

make it clear that these people wish to do him harm.
For example:

into the power of his/my enemies

9:31d

They will kill Him,

- They will kill him,
- and they will kill me.

Him: Jesus was still referring to himself here. Continue to indicate that in a natural way in your language. For example, if you used a form like “I” with “Son of Man” in 9:31c, you will probably use a form like “me” rather than Him here.

9:31e

and after three days He will rise.”

- and three days after he dies, he will rise from the dead.”
- But three days later I will live again.”

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and here introduces what happens next. What happens next is not what normally happens. Also, there is some contrast to people killing Jesus (9:31d) and him rising from death (9:31e). So some other ways to connect 9:31e to 9:31d are:

however (GNT)

But (CEV)

after three days: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as after three days is literally “when he is killed, after three days” (as in the RSV). Jesus would come alive again three days after people killed him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Three days later (GNT)

three days after being killed (NRSV)

See how you translated this phrase in 8:31e.

He will rise: The Greek word that the BSB translates as He will rise means “he will live again.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

he will rise from the dead (NLT)

he will come back to life (GW)

he will become alive again

See how you translated a similar clause in 8:31c.

He: Jesus was still referring to himself here. Continue to indicate this in a natural way in your language. For example, if you used a form like “I” with “Son of Man” in 9:31c, you should continue to use a form like “I” here, rather than He.

General Comment on 9:31c–e

In some languages it may be more natural to translate 9:31c–e as indirect speech. For example, the CEV says:

^{31a}because he was teaching the disciples ^{31b}that ^{31c}the Son of Man would be handed over to people ^{31d}who would kill him. ^{31e}But three days later he would rise to life.

Mark 9:32

Section 9:30–32: Jesus predicted his death a second time

In 8:31 Jesus told his disciples that his enemies would kill him and that God would cause him to live again. Here in 9:30–32, Jesus told his disciples the same thing again. But they still did not understand what he was talking about.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus again predicted that he would die and come back to life

Death and resurrection foretold a second time

Jesus again tells his disciples that he will be killed but then God will raise him from the dead

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 17:22–23 and Luke 9:43–45.

9:32a

But they did not understand this statement,

- But they did not understand his words,
- But the disciples did not understand what that teaching meant,

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But here indicates a contrast. The contrast is between 9:31c–e and 9:32a. Jesus told the disciples that people would betray him and kill him, and he would rise again. But the disciples still did not understand this.

they did not understand: The pronoun they refers to Jesus' disciples. If people in your area will think that they refers to the people who will kill Jesus (9:31d), you may want to clearly indicate the disciples here. For example:

the disciples did not understand

this statement: The Greek words that the BSB translates as this statement is literally “the saying.” This expression refers back to what Jesus said in 9:31.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

what this teaching meant (GNT)

what he said (NIV)

9:32b

and they were afraid to ask Him about it.

- and they were afraid to ask him what he meant.
- and they were afraid to ask him, “What do you^(sing) mean?”

they were afraid to ask Him about it: The pronoun it refers to what Jesus said in 9:31. You may need to translate this to make it clear. For example:

and they were afraid to ask him what it meant

and they were afraid to ask him, “What do you mean?”

Mark 9:33

Section 9:33–37: Jesus told his disciples that they must be humble

A person's status in society was important in Jewish society. While they traveled to Capernaum, the disciples argued among themselves about which one of them was the highest in status in Jesus' ministry (9:34).

Some of them probably thought that Peter was highest in status. They based this on his confession and the statements that Jesus made about him (8:28–30; Matthew 16:17–19). James and John may have thought that they themselves should be highest (10:35–40). But

a high status often causes a person to become proud. So Jesus showed that being truly humble was the way to become high in status in the society of God's kingdom.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Greatness in the Kingdom (GW)

Who Is the Greatest? (NIV)

The followers of Jesus must be humble

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 18:1–5 and Luke 9:46–48.

9:33a

Then they came to Capernaum.

- ¶ Then/Later they came to Capernaum.
- ¶ And so Jesus and his disciples arrived in the town of Capernaum,
- When/After Jesus and his followers arrived in Capernaum

The story in 9:33–37 began sometime after the story in 9:30–32 ended. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories. In some languages, it is natural to begin a story with a time word or phrase. If your language is like that, use an expression here that is not too specific. For example:

Then (BSB)

After/When

In other languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this story in a natural way in your language.

Then they came to Capernaum: There is a textual issue here. (1) Some Greek manuscripts have “They.” For example, the GNT says: “They came to Capernaum” (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, JBP, REB, NCV). (2) Other Greek manuscripts have “He.” For example, the KJV says: “And he came to Capernaum” (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The pronoun they refers to Jesus and his disciples. Since this is a new story, you may want to refer to them here with a specific phrase. For example:

Jesus and his disciples

Capernaum: Capernaum was the name of a small town with probably fewer than two thousand people. If this place name will not be clear to your readers, you may need to say:

to the town of Capernaum

See how you translated Capernaum in 1:21a or 2:1a.

9:33b

While Jesus was in the house, He asked them,

- After they/he entered the house, he asked them,
- and after going indoors Jesus asked his disciples, (GNT)
- and entered the house where they usually stayed, Jesus asked them

While Jesus was in the house, He asked them: There is some implicit information in this verse. It is implied that the disciples went into the house with Jesus. You may need to make this fact explicit, since this is the beginning of a new story. For example:

When they went into a house there, he asked them (NCV)

And when they were indoors he asked them (JBP)

They entered the house there. When inside, he asked them...

in the house: The words the house probably refer to the house that Jesus usually stayed in when he lived in Capernaum (1:35, 7:17). It may have been Simon and Andrew's house (1:29) or a rented house.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the house where they usually stayed

a house

indoors (GNT)

9:33c

“What were you discussing on the way?”

- “What were you^(plur) arguing about while we were on the road?”
- “What were you^(plur) arguing about among yourselves while walking here?”

- what they^(excl) had been arguing about on the way.

What were you discussing: Some Greek manuscripts include the words “among yourselves” in this part of the verse, as in the KJV. Other Greek manuscripts do not include these words. But the context implies “among yourselves.” In some languages it may be more natural to include “among yourselves” in the translation.

discussing: The Greek word that the BSB translates as discussing also means “arguing” or “debating.” For example, the NIV11 says:

What were you arguing about on the road?

on the way: The phrase on the way refers to the fact that Jesus and his disciples were walking along the road before they arrived in Capernaum.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

on the road (NIV11)

while traveling/walking here

Mark 9:34

Section 9:33–37: Jesus told his disciples that they must be humble

A person's status in society was important in Jewish society. While they traveled to Capernaum, the disciples argued among themselves about which one of them was the highest in status in Jesus' ministry (9:34).

Some of them probably thought that Peter was highest in status. They based this on his confession and the statements that Jesus made about him (8:28–30; Matthew 16:17–19). James and John may have thought that they themselves should be highest (10:35–40). But a high status often causes a person to become proud. So Jesus showed that being truly humble was the way to become high in status in the society of God's kingdom.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Greatness in the Kingdom (GW)

Who Is the Greatest? (NIV)

The followers of Jesus must be humble

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 18:1–5 and Luke 9:46–48.

9:34a

But they were silent,

- But they did not answer him,
- They said nothing, (NJB)

But: The conjunction But indicates a contrast. The contrast is that Jesus expected the disciples to answer his question, but the disciples did not answer.

In some languages, no conjunction is necessary here. For example, the GW says:

They were silent.

they were silent: The phrase they were silent indicates that the disciples did not answer Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

they would not answer him (GNT)

They said nothing (NJB)

9:34b

for on the way they had been arguing

- because while they were walking on the road, they had argued
- because they were ashamed to tell him that while walking they had argued among themselves

for: The conjunction for introduces the reason that the disciples were quiet. In some languages, it will be more natural to put 9:34b before 9:34a. See the General Comment on 9:34a–c below for an example.

on the way: The BSB uses the phrase on the way to translate the same Greek phrase that is translated as “on the way” in 9:33c. You may want to use the same phrase in both places. If it is more natural in your language, you can omit this second mention of it.

they had been arguing about: It is implied that the disciples were ashamed of the topic that they had been arguing about. So they did not want to answer Jesus. You may need to make this information explicit. For example:

they did not want Jesus to know that they had argued about...

they were ashamed to tell him that they had argued concerning...

9:34c

about which of them was the greatest.

- about who was the greatest/highest in rank/status.
- about which of them was most important.

which of them: The context implies that the word which of them refers to which one among the disciples. The NIV11 translates this as:

who

the greatest: The word greatest refers to having the highest status. The disciples wanted to know who among them was the most important person.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the most important

greatest in rank

highest in status/name

more important than all the others

General Comment on 9:34a–c

In this verse, 9:34b–c expresses the reason for the result in 9:34a. In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of these clauses. For example:

^{34b}But they were ashamed to tell him that on the road, they had argued ^{34c}about who was the greatest. ^{34a}So they kept quiet.

^{34b}On the road, they had argued ^{34c}about who was the greatest. ^{34a}So they kept quiet out of shame.

Mark 9:35

Section 9:33–37: Jesus told his disciples that they must be humble

A person's status in society was important in Jewish society. While they traveled to Capernaum, the disciples argued among themselves about which one of them was the highest in status in Jesus' ministry (9:34).

Some of them probably thought that Peter was highest in status. They based this on his confession and the statements that Jesus made about him (8:28–30; Matthew 16:17–19). James and John may have thought that they themselves should be highest (10:35–40). But a high status often causes a person to become proud. So Jesus showed that being truly humble was the way to become high in status in the society of God's kingdom.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Greatness in the Kingdom (GW)

Who Is the Greatest? (NIV)

The followers of Jesus must be humble

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 18:1–5 and Luke 9:46–48.

9:35a

Sitting down, Jesus called the Twelve and said,

- Jesus sat down, called/summoned the Twelve to come and listen, and said,
- So Jesus sat down to teach and told his twelve disciples to gather around him. He said to them,

Sitting down: The words Sitting down indicate that Jesus was getting ready to teach. It does not mean that Jesus was tired or wanted to rest. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

Sitting down to teach

So Jesus sat down to teach

Jesus called the Twelve: The word called indicates that Jesus summoned the disciples to come and listen.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

told the twelve disciples to gather around him (CEV)

summoned the twelve disciples

called the Twelve to him (NJB)

the Twelve: The phrase the Twelve refers to Jesus' twelve disciples. The GNT says:

the twelve disciples

See how you translated this phrase in 4:10a.

9:35b

“If anyone wants to be first,

- “If anyone among you wants to be first in importance,
- “If there is one of you who wants to be the greatest/biggest person,
- “Anyone who wants to have the highest rank/status among you,

9:35c

he must be the last of all

- he must put himself as the very last,
- he must make himself the very least/lowest/smallest,
- must become the least/lowest in rank,

9:35d

and the servant of all.”

- and he must be like a servant toward all people.”
- that is, he must serve everyone else.”

9:35b–d

If anyone wants to be first, he must be the last of all and the servant of all: The words first and last refer to ranking or status. They refer to the most and least important person. These words do not refer to time (like the first one to come) or location (like the first one in a line).

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Whoever wants to be first must place himself last of all and be the servant of all. (GNT)

Whoever wants to be the most important person must take the last place and be a servant to everyone else. (GW)

If you want the place of honor, you must become a slave and serve others! (CEV)

anyone: The word anyone implies anyone among you. A follower of Christ who wants to become the leader of other believers must take the position of the least important servant. He must serve his companions.

the servant of all: The expression the servant of all refers to serving or helping other people. It does not refer to taking a job as a servant.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

serve all others

be like a servant of everyone else

Mark 9:36

Section 9:33–37: Jesus told his disciples that they must be humble

A person's status in society was important in Jewish society. While they traveled to Capernaum, the disciples argued among themselves about which one of them was the highest in status in Jesus' ministry (9:34).

Some of them probably thought that Peter was highest in status. They based this on his confession and the statements that Jesus made about him (8:28–30; Matthew 16:17–19). James and John may have thought that they themselves should be highest (10:35–40). But a high status often causes a person to become proud. So Jesus showed that being truly humble was the way to become high in status in the society of God's kingdom.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Greatness in the Kingdom (GW)

Who Is the Greatest? (NIV)

The followers of Jesus must be humble

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 18:1–5 and Luke 9:46–48.

9:36a

Then He had a little child stand among them.

- And he took a child, and put him in the midst of them. (RSV)
- Then he brought/caused a child to stand among them.

Then He had a little child stand among them: The words that the BSB translates as He had a little child stand literally means “taking a little child, he made

him stand.” These words indicate that Jesus led a nearby child into the group of disciples. He did this perhaps by placing his hands on the child's shoulders or by taking the child by the hand. For example:

He went and led a child among them

The child probably lived in that house. According to Matthew 18:2, Jesus called the child. Your translation should not imply that Jesus went somewhere else to find a child.

had...stand among them: The verb that the BSB translates as had...stand here indicates that Jesus told the child to stay standing in one place. Jesus may have done this with words or gestures.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

put him in the midst of them (RSV)

placed him standing among them

a little child: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a little child refers to a young child, one probably under the age of ten years. Try to use a general term that can refer to either a young boy or a young girl. If you must choose between a boy or girl, you should probably use a word that refers to a young boy.

General Comment on 9:36a

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine the ideas in the phrase “He took a little child” and the phrase “and had him stand among them,” as the BSB does. For example, the CEV says:

Then Jesus had a child stand near him.

9:36b

Taking the child in His arms, He said to them,

- He put his arms around the child and said to them,
- He embraced/hugged the child and said to his disciples,

Taking the child in His arms: The phrase Taking the child in His arms probably means that Jesus hugged the boy or put his arm or arms around him. This was a way of showing that Jesus loved and valued him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

He put his arms around the child (GW)

and embraced (NJB)

Mark 9:37

Section 9:33–37: Jesus told his disciples that they must be humble

A person's status in society was important in Jewish society. While they traveled to Capernaum, the disciples argued among themselves about which one of them was the highest in status in Jesus' ministry (9:34).

Some of them probably thought that Peter was highest in status. They based this on his confession and the statements that Jesus made about him (8:28–30; Matthew 16:17–19). James and John may have thought that they themselves should be highest (10:35–40). But a high status often causes a person to become proud. So Jesus showed that being truly humble was the way to become high in status in the society of God's kingdom.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Greatness in the Kingdom (GW)

Who Is the Greatest? (NIV)

The followers of Jesus must be humble

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 18:1–5 and Luke 9:46–48.

9:37a

“Whoever welcomes one of these little children in My name welcomes Me,

- “Whoever receives one of these little children on my behalf, receives me,
- “Anyone who welcomes and helps a child like this one for my sake, it is the same as welcoming me.
- “If a person shows hospitality/kindness to a child like this one because of me, it is really/actually me that he is honoring.

Whoever welcomes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as welcomes is literally “receives” (as in the RSV). It refers to helping people by accepting them into your home and giving them food and drink.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Whoever receives (RSV)

Whoever accepts (NCV)

Whoever welcomes and helps

Whoever shows hospitality to

in My name: The phrase in My name probably modifies the verb “welcomes” (as in the GNT). It indicates that someone welcomes and helps others because he is a follower of Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

welcomes...on my behalf (NLT)

welcomes...for my sake (JBP)

welcomes Me: The verb welcomes is the same verb that was used earlier in the verse, but it is used in a figurative way here. By welcoming a child, you honor Jesus.

If people in your area will think that the words welcomes Me only refer to literally welcoming Jesus himself, you may want to include some implied information. For example:

it is the same as welcoming me

it is like he is welcoming me

honors me

The word Me is emphasized in the Greek. If your language has a natural way to emphasize the word Me, you may want to do so. For example:

It is I that he is welcoming.

9:37b

and whoever welcomes Me welcomes not only Me, but the One who sent Me.”

- and whoever receives me does not only receive me, but also the one who sent me.”
- And he is welcoming more than me. He is welcoming my Father who sent me.”
- If a person honors me, he is really/actually honoring God who sent me.”

and whoever welcomes Me welcomes not only Me, but the One who sent Me: This expression indicates that welcoming Jesus is like welcoming God.

welcomes not only Me, but the One who sent Me: In this context the expression welcomes not only Me means “does not welcome only me.” When someone welcomes Jesus, he also welcomes the one who sent Jesus. For example, the GNT says:

welcomes not only me but also the one who sent me

the One who sent Me: The phrase the One who sent Me refers to God. If people in your area will not understand that this phrase refers to God, you may need to make this explicit. For example:

my Father who sent me (NLT)

God who sent me

Mark 9:38

Section 9:38–41: Jesus told who is for him and who is against him

In this section, the disciple John told Jesus that he and the other disciples had tried to stop a man from expelling demons in Jesus’ name. They did this because the man was not one of the twelve disciples. Jesus then taught them that many people other than the twelve disciples were following him. He said that all of these people will be rewarded for what they do in his name.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section heading:

Jesus told who is on his side and who is on the side against him

Whoever Is Not Against Us Is For Us (NIV)

On using the name of Jesus (NJB)

The parallel passage for this section is in Luke 9:49–50.

9:38a

John said to Him, “Teacher,

- ¶ Then John said, “Teacher,

- ¶ The disciple John said to Jesus, “Teacher,

This is the beginning of a new story. It may be necessary in your language to introduce a new story in some way. For example, the NCV has:

Then John said...

John said to Him: Some Greek manuscripts say “John answered” (as in the KJV). This indicates that John responded to Jesus’ words and deeds in 9:33–37. Other Greek manuscripts say said. Many English versions use the verb said here, and it is recommended that you do the same.

John: Here the name John refers to one of Jesus’ twelve disciples. It does not refer to John the Baptist. If people in your area will think that this name refers to John the Baptist, you may want to include some implied information. For example:

the disciple John

See how you translated the name John in 9:2a.

Teacher: The disciples and others often called Jesus Teacher. This was a polite title for a Jewish religious leader. It was a title of respect for a Jewish man who had authority to teach the things about God. It does not mean “school teacher.” See how you translated this term of address in 4:38c and 9:17b.

9:38b

we saw someone else driving out demons in Your name,

- we^(excl) saw a man forcing demons out of people by using the power/authority of your^(sing) name,
- we^(excl) saw a man causing demons to leave people through your^(sing) power.

driving out demons: The Greek word that the BSB translates as driving out is literally “casting/throwing out.” This is the same word as in 9:18e. The term driving out demons means to cause demons to stop controlling a person.

Jewish people often spoke of demons as being in someone. Different cultures have different ways of speaking about people being controlled by demons and being released from the control of demons. Use a natural expression for this in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

forcing demons out (GW)

causing demons to leave people

sending demons away

exorcizing demons

freeing people who were controlled by demons

See how you translated the similar phrase “drove out demons” in 1:34b.

demons: The Greek word that the BSB translates as demons refers to spirits that are evil and can control people’s actions. The word demons refers to the same type of spirits as the Greek terms that are often translated as “evil spirits” and “unclean spirits.”

Here are some other ways to translate demons:

- Use a general term in your language that refers to spirits that are evil and can control people.
- Use a specific term in your language that refers to a certain type of spirit. These spirits should be able to do evil things. Do not use a term that refers to the spirits of dead people.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

evil/bad spirits

unclean spirits Be sure that an expression like “unclean spirits” does not imply that the spirits are literally dirty.

See how you translated the word demons in 1:34b or 7:26c. See evil spirit in the Glossary for more information.

in Your name: The phrase in Your name indicates using the power or authority of Jesus to do something.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

by using the power and authority of your name
(GW)

through your power

as your representative

9:38c–d

and we tried to stop him, because he does not accompany us: Some Greek manuscripts have a dif-

ferent wording and a different order of the clauses in 9:38c–d. But the meaning is the same in each.

9:38c

and we tried to stop him,

- and we^(excl) tried to stop him,
- We^(excl) were forbidding him to do that,

and we tried to stop him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as tried to stop is literally “were preventing” or “were forbidding.” The tense indicates that the disciples tried to make the man stop. They did this with words. They did not try to physically restrain him. Probably more than one of the disciples told him to stop. But the man probably continued to cast out demons.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

we tried to stop him (NJB)

we tried to hinder him (NASB)

we were forbidding him to do that

We told him to stop (NCV)

to stop him: It is implied that they tried to make him stop using Jesus’ name to cast out demons. If your language needs to say what was stopped, you could say:

to stop doing that

to stop driving/casting out demons using your name

9:38d

because he does not accompany us.”

- because he is not associated with us.^(incl)
- because he does not belong to our^(incl) group.”

he does not accompany us: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as he does not accompany us is literally “he was not following us.” The word us probably refers to Jesus and the twelve disciples.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he doesn’t belong to our group (GNT)

he is not associated with us

General Comment on 9:38c–d

It might be more natural in your language to put the reason (9:38d) before the result (9:38c). For example:

^{38d}He was not one of us, ^{38c}so we tried to stop him.

^{38d}He was not one of us; ^{38c}that is why we tried to stop him.

Mark 9:39

Section 9:38–41: Jesus told who is for him and who is against him

In this section, the disciple John told Jesus that he and the other disciples had tried to stop a man from expelling demons in Jesus' name. They did this because the man was not one of the twelve disciples. Jesus then taught them that many people other than the twelve disciples were following him. He said that all of these people will be rewarded for what they do in his name.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section heading:

Jesus told who is on his side and who is on the side against him

Whoever Is Not Against Us Is For Us (NIV)

On using the name of Jesus (NJB)

The parallel passage for this section is in Luke 9:49–50.

9:39a

“Do not stop him,” Jesus replied.

- But Jesus said, “Do not stop^(plur) him.
- Jesus answered, “Do not stop people like him from doing that,

There is a contrast between what the disciples did in 9:38 and what Jesus said in 9:39. Some versions such as the RSV show this contrast with the word “But.” Translate the contrast in a natural way in your language.

Do not stop him: The command Do not stop is in the present tense in the Greek. In this context, this tense indicates a general principle: “Do not be stopping (people like) him.” You should translate this as a general principle. For example:

Do not stop people like him.

stop him: As in 9:38c, it may be necessary to say explicitly what action was stopped. Use an expression that is similar to the expression in 9:38c. For example:

stop him from doing that

try to prevent him from driving out demons

Jesus replied: In some languages it might be more natural to translate the phrase Jesus replied as “Jesus answered.” Jesus responded to what John said.

In Greek, these words occur at the beginning of 9:38 (as in the RSV). The BSB places the words Jesus replied in the middle of Jesus' response. Place the words Jesus replied where it is natural in your language.

9:39b

“For no one who performs a miracle in My name

- For no one who does a miracle using the power/ authority of my name
- because if someone does a miracle through the power of my name,

9:39c

can turn around and speak evil of Me.

- will then be able to insult me soon afterward.
- he cannot quickly change/turn and say evil things about me.

9:39b–c

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For means “because.” This conjunction introduces the reason for not stopping the man. For example:

because no one... (GNT)

See the General Comment on 9:39a–c below for an example of how to change the order of this verse.

no one who performs a miracle in My name can turn around and speak evil of Me: Another way to say this is:

Anyone who does a miracle in my name will not be able to say anything bad about me soon afterward.

miracle: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as miracle is literally “power.” A miracle is an action which requires great power to accomplish. When a human being does a miracle, he must use greater

power than human beings normally have. The disciples used God's power to do miracles, and these miracles demonstrated that God was working through them.

Here are some other ways to translate miracle:

mighty work

amazing act done with/by God's power

wonderful action that only God can do

The plural form of this word occurs in 6:2f.

in My name: The phrase in My name has the same meaning as the similar phrase "in your name" in 9:38b. It refers to using the power or authority of Jesus to do something. Translate it in a similar way as you did there.

can turn around: The Greek word that the BSB translates as can turn around is literally "quickly."

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

readily (JBP)

soon afterward (GNT)

in the next moment (NIV11)

speak evil of Me: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as speak evil of means "revile," "insult," or "say something bad about." For example:

speak evil of me (RSV)

say evil things about me (GNT)

say anything against me (JBP)

insult me

General Comment on 9:39a–c

In some languages, it will be more natural to put 9:39b–c before 9:39a. For example:

^{39b}A person who does a miracle in my name

^{39c}cannot in the next moment say anything bad about me. ^{39a}So, do not stop him.

Mark 9:40

Section 9:38–41: Jesus told who is for him and who is against him

In this section, the disciple John told Jesus that he and the other disciples had tried to stop a man from expelling demons in Jesus' name. They did this because the man was not one of the twelve disciples. Jesus then taught them that many people other than the twelve disciples were following him. He said that all of these people will be rewarded for what they do in his name.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section heading:

Jesus told who is on his side and who is on the side against him

Whoever Is Not Against Us Is For Us (NIV)

On using the name of Jesus (NJB)

The parallel passage for this section is in Luke 9:49–50.

9:40

For whoever is not against us is for us.

- If a person does not oppose us,^(incl) he agrees with us.
- Whoever is not our^(incl) enemy is our friend.

For: Verse 9:39b–c is the reason for 9:39a. But 9:40 states a more general reason for the principle in 9:39b–c. The BSB shows this with the conjunction For. Translate this conjunction with that meaning.

For a way to change the order of 9:39–40, see the General Comment on 9:39–40 below.

whoever is not against us is for us: This expression states that there are two groups of people:

1. those who are for Jesus, and
2. those who are against him.

All people are in one or the other group. So if someone is not against us, then he is for us. The pronoun us refers to Jesus and the disciples.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the man who is not against us is on our side (JBP)

whoever does not oppose us stands with us

the person who is not our enemy is our friend

General Comment on 9:39–40

In some languages, it may be more natural to put the general reason (9:40) before the specific reason (9:39b–c). It may also be more natural to put the specific reason (9:39b–c) before the result (9:39a). For example:

⁴⁰Whoever is not against us is for us. ^{39b}So no one who does a miracle in my name ^{39c}can in the next moment say anything bad about me. ^{39a}So/ Therefore, do not stop him.

Mark 9:41

Section 9:38–41: Jesus told who is for him and who is against him

In this section, the disciple John told Jesus that he and the other disciples had tried to stop a man from expelling demons in Jesus' name. They did this because the man was not one of the twelve disciples. Jesus then taught them that many people other than the twelve disciples were following him. He said that all of these people will be rewarded for what they do in his name.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section heading:

Jesus told who is on his side and who is on the side against him

Whoever Is Not Against Us Is For Us (NIV)

On using the name of Jesus (NJB)

The parallel passage for this section is in Luke 9:49–50.

9:41a

Indeed, if anyone gives you even a cup of water

- anyone who gives to you^(plur) a cup of water to drink
- if someone gives even a drink of water to you^(plur)

Indeed: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Indeed is often translated as “For” (as in the RSV). This conjunction probably indicates that 9:41 is an example that explains the principle in 9:40. Some versions do not translate this word. You should connect 9:40 and 9:41 in a way that is natural in your language.

if anyone gives you even a cup of water: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as gives you even a cup of water is literally “give to drink a cup of water.” The BSB has left the words “to drink” implied.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

anyone who gives to you even only a cup of water to drink

if a person gives a small thing like a cup of water for you to drink

You should translate this phrase in a natural way in your language.

When someone gives a believer some water to drink, that deed is a small act of kindness. That deed is used as an example here. The person who gives water to a believer shows that he is “for Christ” (9:40), even if only in a small way.

you: The pronoun you here refers to the disciples. But it refers generally to any believer. The pronoun you is plural in Greek, but this does not indicate that many people have to share one cup of water. So in some languages it may be natural to translate the you as singular. Use an expression that refers generally to any believer.

a cup of water: The word cup indicates a small amount of water. It is perhaps a mouthful or two of water. You may want to use a container of that size that is usually used for drinking water in your area. Or you can just refer to a single drink of water. For example, the GNT says:

a drink of water

9:41b

because you bear the name of Christ,

- because you^(plur) belong to me, the Christ/Messiah,
- because you^(plur) are called the disciples of the Christ/Messiah,

because: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the words in name. The next Greek word then means “that.” The phrase “in name that” is an idiom that means “on the basis that” or “because.” For example:

because (RSV)

on the understanding that (RSV, GNT, The GNT substitutes the word “Christ” with the pronoun “me.” NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, NET, REB, NCV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the words in my name. The next Greek word then means “because.” For example, the NIV says:

in my name because (NIV, KJV, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1).

you bear the name of Christ: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as you bear the name of Christ is literally “you are Christ’s.” Believers have a relationship with Christ and he is head or leader of that relationship. Jesus referred to himself as the Christ here.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

you^(plur) are Christ’s people

you belong to me, the Christ

because you are followers of the Messiah (REB)

Christ: The Jews used the title Christ to refer to the special person whom God had appointed and promised to send as king and savior. The title Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word “Messiah,” and the two words have the same meaning.

In this context you may need to indicate that Jesus was using this title to refer to himself. Here are some ways to translate Christ in this context:

- Transliterate it according to the sounds of your language. For example:

Krais

me, Karisiti

- Transliterate it and indicate in some way that it is a title. For example:

the Christ

me, the Kirisita

- Transliterate Christ and include a phrase that explains the meaning. For example:

Christ, the appointed one

Cristo, the savior God promised

me, the Christ who comes from God

If you do not indicate in the text that Jesus was referring to himself as the Christ, you may want to include a footnote to explain this. For example:

Jesus referred here to himself as the “Christ.” The title “Christ” refers to the King and Savior whom God had promised to send.

See how you translated this word in 1:1 and 8:29c. See also Christ in the Glossary.

9:41c

truly I tell you,

- I tell you truly that
- I assure you that

truly I tell you: Jesus used the phrase truly I tell you to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. It indicates that the statement was important and totally reliable, and that people should listen carefully to it. Jesus used this phrase eight times in Mark. Jesus also used the words “I tell you” to emphasize something. The words “Truly I tell you” are even more emphatic than “I tell you.”

See how you translated this phrase in 9:1a. In some languages you may need to translate the phrase differently in different contexts. Do not translate in a way that implies that Jesus had not been telling the truth at other times.

Here are some ways that English versions have translated the phrase in this context:

I can guarantee this truth: (GW)

I assure you (GNT)

See the General Comment on 9:41a–d after 9:41d for examples of other ways to order the parts of this verse.

9:41d

he will never lose his reward.

- he will surely not fail to receive his reward.

- he will certainly receive a reward.
- God will surely do good to that person for doing that.

he will never lose his reward: This statement is a figure of speech which has two negative ideas: never and lose. Jesus used these two negative ideas to emphasize the opposite meaning. This positive meaning may be expressed as:

will truly get his reward (NCV)

will surely be rewarded (CEV)

The words will never lose do not refer to a person placing his reward somewhere and then later not being able to find it.

reward: The Greek word that the BSB translates as reward can mean “wages” or “recompense” or “reward.” It can be either positive or negative depending on what a person deserves. In this context it refers to something good that God will give to the person mentioned in 9:41a. God will give a reward because that person gave a cup of water to a believer. You may need to make it explicit that God will give the reward. For example:

God will surely reward him.

General Comment on 9:41a–d

In some languages it may be more natural to place the phrase “I tell you the truth” in a different position in the verse. For example:

If anyone gives you even a cup of water because you belong to the Messiah, I tell you the truth, that person will surely be rewarded. (NLT)

For example, if someone gives even a drink of water to you because you believe in me, the Christ, God will certainly reward that person. I can assure you this is absolutely true.

Place this phrase where it is natural in your language.

Mark 9:42

Section 9:42–50: Jesus gave various warnings

In this section, Jesus warned his disciples about several things. A believer should not cause another person to sin (9:42). A believer should not allow causes of sin to remain in his own life (9:43–48). Jesus warned

believers that they would suffer because they follow him (9:49).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warned his followers with various sayings

Various warnings

Temptations to Sin (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 18:6–9 and Luke 17:1–2.

Paragraph 9:42–48

The Greek text does not indicate how much time occurred between the previous paragraph and this one. Both paragraphs include things that Jesus said, but he may have said them on separate occasions. The BSB begins this section with the word “But.” If you need an expression to introduce this paragraph, you should use a general expression that does not indicate time. For example:

Jesus also said

9:42

This verse compares two terrible situations:

1. death in the sea with a millstone tied around the neck, and
2. causing a childlike believer to sin.

The verse indicates that option (b) is much worse than option (a). A person should prefer to drown rather than to cause a childlike believer to sin. This probably implies that the punishment for (b) is much worse than drowning. The implied punishment or penalty is mentioned in several commentaries. For example, Lane (page 345) says, “In such an eventuality, Jesus implies, the punishment incurred will be so severe it would have been better for a man if he had been drowned before he could have committed so grievous an offense.”

Languages can indicate this comparison in various ways. Some other ways are:

- One thing is bad. Another thing is worse. For example:

^{42b}It is a bad punishment for someone to be thrown into the sea with a millstone tied around his neck. ^{42a}But if anyone causes one of these little ones who believe in me to sin he will receive a worse punishment.

- One thing is bad. The other is good in comparison. For example:

^{42a}If anyone causes one of these little ones who believe in me to sin, that is very bad and the punishment will be severe. ^{42b}It is good in comparison to have a millstone tied around his neck and be thrown into the sea.

You should translate this comparison in a way that is natural in your language.

9:42a

But if anyone causes one of these little ones who believe in Me to stumble,

- ¶ “If someone causes one of these little ones who believe in me to sin,
- ¶ “If anyone causes one of these humble believers to sin, that is very bad.

if anyone: The Greek words that the BSB translates as if anyone are the same as the words in 9:41. There the BSB translates these words as “if anyone” and the NASB translates them as “whoever.” You may want to use the same expression here as in 9:41.

causes...to stumble: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as causes...to stumble is used with a figurative meaning.

This verb can be interpreted in two ways:

1. The verb refers to causing a believer to sin. For example, the NET says:

If anyone causes one of these little ones who believe in me to sin (RSV, NIV, CEV, NET, NCV, ESV)

1. The verb refers to causing a believer to stop believing. For example, the GNT says:

If anyone should cause one of these little ones to lose faith in me (GNT, NLT96, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

stumble: As mentioned above, the Greek word that the BSB here translates as stumble is used in a figurative sense to refer to offending or disobeying God.

A person can stumble by doing or thinking something that God does not approve of. He can sin by not doing what God wants him to do. It is helpful to translate the verb stumble with a general term that can include any offense against God.

these little ones who believe in Me: The phrase little ones literally refers to children. Here Jesus used the phrase these little ones who believe in Me figuratively. He referred to childlike believers. They are like children because they are innocent and weak in certain ways. They need protection and help. The expression these little ones can refer to people of any age, both children and adults.

If people in your area will think that the words these little ones only refer to literal children, you may want to:

- Include some implied information. For example:

one of these childlike believers

one of these innocent/vulnerable people who believes in me

- Include a footnote For example:

The phrase “one of these little ones who believe in me” refers to a childlike follower of Jesus (Mark 9:35–37, Matthew 18:4–5).

believe: To believe in Jesus means for a person “to entrust himself to Jesus,” that is, “to place himself in the complete care of Jesus.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

rely/depend on

trust in

have faith in

have confidence in

Your language may use an idiom for this meaning. See also believe, Meaning 2, in the Glossary.

9:42b

it would be better for him to have a large millstone hung around his neck

- it would be better for him if, with a large millstone tied to his neck,
- His punishment for that will be worse than if, with a huge stone hung from/around his neck,

it would be better for him: This is a comparison. The consequences for a person who causes a believer to sin (9:42a) are so bad that drowning in the sea (9:42b) is better. See some ways to translate this comparison at 9:42a–b above.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

it would be preferable for him

in comparison, it would be good for him

a large millstone: A millstone is a heavy stone used for grinding grain to make flour. The Greek words are literally “a donkey millstone.” This stone was probably over 200 kilograms (450 pounds) and circular with a hole in the middle. A donkey pushed a bar tied to the stone to cause it to rotate and grind the grain. The very large millstone pictured below probably weighed over 500 kilograms.

If people in your area do not use stones to grind grain, you may want to use a general term for a stone of this size.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

a heavy stone (CEV)

a large stone (NCV)

hung around his neck: This clause is a passive. Someone tied the stone to the neck of the person before he was thrown into the sea. If a passive clause is not natural in your language, use an active clause with a general reference to a person or people doing the action. For example:

which someone tied around his neck

which they tied around his neck

Here is another way to translate this:

hung from his neck

If possible, keep the focus on the person who had the stone tied around his neck.

9:42c

and to be thrown into the sea.

- he were thrown into the sea than that he cause someone to sin.
- someone/they threw him into the sea and he drowned.

to be thrown into the sea: The implied result of being thrown into the sea is that the person dies/drowns. For example:

be thrown into the sea and drown

This clause is passive. It is not stated who threw the person. Passive clauses are not natural in some languages. If that is true in your language, use an active clause with a general reference to a person or people doing the action. For example:

if someone threw him into the sea

if they threw him into the sea

If possible, keep the focus on the person being thrown.

be thrown: In Greek the form of the verb here probably indicates that being thrown into the sea was to happen before causing someone to sin. The person would die in the sea, and that would prevent him from causing the childlike believer to sin. For example:

he had been cast into the sea (NASB)

he were thrown into the sea...so that he could not do that

General Comment on 9:42b–c

The event in 9:42c occurs before the event in 9:42b. It might be more natural in your language to have the event in 9:42c before the event in 9:42b in your translation. For example:

it would be better for him if someone were to
^{42c}place a large millstone around his neck and
^{42b}throw him into the sea

Mark 9:43

Section 9:42–50: Jesus gave various warnings

In this section, Jesus warned his disciples about several things. A believer should not cause another person to sin (9:42). A believer should not allow causes

of sin to remain in his own life (9:43–48). Jesus warned believers that they would suffer because they follow him (9:49).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warned his followers with various sayings

Various warnings

Temptations to Sin (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 18:6–9 and Luke 17:1–2.

Paragraph 9:42–48

The Greek text does not indicate how much time occurred between the previous paragraph and this one. Both paragraphs include things that Jesus said, but he may have said them on separate occasions. The BSB begins this section with the word “But.” If you need an expression to introduce this paragraph, you should use a general expression that does not indicate time. For example:

Jesus also said

9:43–48

In these verses Jesus spoke about people in general. He used singular forms of pronouns like “you” and “your.” In some languages it may be more natural to use plural forms or other forms. For example:

If your^(plur) hand causes you^(plur) to sin, cut^(plur) it off.

If our hand causes us to sin, we should cut it off.

In 7:20–23 Jesus had already taught his disciples that all sin originates in a person’s heart/mind. Here in 9:43–48 he focused on particular parts of the body that people use when they sin. He used the hand, foot and eye as figures of speech. These parts of the body stand for what people do, where people go and what people look at. When he said that a person should cut off/out parts of his body, he meant that a person should do everything possible to keep himself from sinning. This might even require extreme self-sacrifice.

9:43a

If your hand causes you to sin, cut it off.

- If one of your^(sing) hands causes you to sin, cut it off.
- If you are tempted to use your^(sing) hand to sin, cut it off.
- Remove and throw away any cause of sin! Reject it as completely as if you were cutting off a hand that causes you to sin.

If your hand causes you to sin, cut it off: In this context, the hand is a figure of speech. The hand represents sins that a person commits with his hand.

Here is another way to express this figure of speech:

If you are tempted to use your hand to sin, cut it off.

If people in your area will think that this verse only refers to literally cutting off a hand, you may want to:

- Indicate that this is figurative language. For example:

If as a figurative example your hand causes you to sin, cut it off.

- Include the non-figurative meaning and use a simile. For example:

Remove and throw away any cause of sin! Reject it as completely as if you were cutting off a hand that causes you to sin.

- Include a footnote to explain. For example:

In this verse and the next two verses Jesus talked about parts of the body that we use when we sin. He used the hand, foot and eye as symbols that stand for what we do, where we go and what we look at. When he said that we should remove our hand, foot or eye, he meant that we should do everything possible to keep ourselves from sinning

9:43b–c

It is better for you to enter life crippled than to have two hands and go into hell: This is a comparison.

Here are some ways that languages may show this comparison:

- One situation is better than the other (as in the BSB).
- One situation is worse than the other. For example:

Having two hands and going to hell is worse than having one hand and going to heaven.

It may seem hard to enter heaven with one hand missing, but it is far worse to keep both hands and enter hell.

- One situation is good. The other situation is bad. For example:

If you go to heaven, even if you have only one hand, that is good. But if you keep two hands and go to hell, that is bad.

9:43b

It is better for you to enter life crippled

- It is better for you^(sing) to go/begin to live in heaven crippled/disabled
- It may seem hard to enter heaven with one hand missing,
- If you^(sing) go to heaven, even if you^(sing) have only one hand, that is good.

enter life: In this context the word life refers to eternal life in heaven with God. If people in your area will think that the word life refers only to life on earth, you may want to include some implied information. For example:

enter heaven (NLT96)

go to live forever where God dwells

crippled: The Greek word that the BSB translates as crippled describes a person who has a hand or foot that is deformed or abnormal. In this context it refers to someone who has had a hand cut off.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

disabled (GW)

without a hand (GNT)

with only one hand

9:43c

than to have two hands and go into hell,

- than to enter hell with two hands,
- but it is far worse to keep both hands and enter hell.
- But if you have two hands and go to hell, that is bad.

two hands: In the parable, having two hands indicates that the person has not removed the cause of sin in his life. Therefore, he has not truly repented before God.

If people in your area will not understand the meaning of the figurative expression two hands, you may want to:

- Include some implied information in the text. For example:

two hands because you did not repent

- Include a footnote. For example:

In this parable, having two hands or two feet indicates that the person has not removed the cause of sin in his life.

hell: The word hell refers to the place of eternal punishment where unbelievers will go after the final judgment. The devil and his angels will also go there.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

place of eternal punishment

place of unending fire

9:43d

into the unquenchable fire.

- where the fire can never be put out.
- There the fire is never extinguished.

the unquenchable fire: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as the unquenchable fire describes hell (9:43b). The word unquenchable refers to a fire that will never end. No one will ever put it out or extinguish it.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

into the fire that can never be put out (NJB)

where the fire never goes out (NIV11)

Mark 9:44

Section 9:42–50: Jesus gave various warnings

In this section, Jesus warned his disciples about several things. A believer should not cause another person to sin (9:42). A believer should not allow causes of sin to remain in his own life (9:43–48). Jesus warned

believers that they would suffer because they follow him (9:49).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warned his followers with various sayings

Various warnings

Temptations to Sin (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 18:6–9 and Luke 17:1–2.

Paragraph 9:42–48

The Greek text does not indicate how much time occurred between the previous paragraph and this one. Both paragraphs include things that Jesus said, but he may have said them on separate occasions. The BSB begins this section with the word “But.” If you need an expression to introduce this paragraph, you should use a general expression that does not indicate time. For example:

Jesus also said

9:44

[Most English versions do not translate this verse. See the Notes on 9:44.]

There is a textual issue here. Mark 9:44 was added in some of the later Greek manuscripts. It repeats Mark 9:48. It is good to include this verse only as a footnote, as many English versions do.

Here is an example footnote:

Only some of the later Greek manuscripts include 9:44, which reads: where “their worm does not die, and the fire is not quenched.”

If the major language version in your area includes this verse in the text, you may want to include it in brackets. The NASB does this.

If you put 9:44 in a footnote, here are several ways to number the verses:

- Put the number 44 after the number 43. For example:

^{43–44}...where the fire never goes out. ⁴⁵And if your foot...

- Put in the number 44 after the last word of 9:43, and have the footnote marker after it. For example:

⁴³...where the fire never goes out. ⁴⁴ ‡ ⁴⁵And if your foot...

- Do not include the number 44. For example:

⁴³...where the fire never goes out. ⁴⁵And if your foot...

- Put the number 44 at the beginning of 43d. For example, the NJB says:

⁴³And if your hand should be your downfall, cut it off; it is better for you to enter into life crippled, than to have two hands and go to hell, into the fire that ⁴⁴can never be put out.

For notes on how to translate “where ‘their worm does not die, and the fire is not quenched,’ ” see 9:48a and 9:48b.

Mark 9:45

Section 9:42–50: Jesus gave various warnings

In this section, Jesus warned his disciples about several things. A believer should not cause another person to sin (9:42). A believer should not allow causes of sin to remain in his own life (9:43–48). Jesus warned believers that they would suffer because they follow him (9:49).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warned his followers with various sayings

Various warnings

Temptations to Sin (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 18:6–9 and Luke 17:1–2.

Paragraph 9:42–48

The Greek text does not indicate how much time occurred between the previous paragraph and this one. Both paragraphs include things that Jesus said, but he may have said them on separate occasions. The BSB begins this section with the word “But.” If you need an expression to introduce this paragraph, you should use a general expression that does not indicate time. For example:

Jesus also said

9:45a**If your foot causes you to sin, cut it off.**

- Likewise, if one of your^(sing) feet causes you to sin, cut it off.
- In the same way, if you are tempted to use your^(sing) foot to sin, cut it off.
- Remove and throw away any cause of sin! Reject it as completely as if you were cutting off a foot that causes you to sin.

If your foot causes you to sin, cut it off: This verse is a figurative example with the same meaning as 9:43a. You should translate it in a similar way to 9:43a.

- If you indicated that 9:43a was a figurative example, you should do so here. For example:

If as a figurative example your foot causes you to sin, cut it off.

- If you included the non-figurative meaning and made the metaphor into a simile in 9:43a, you should do that here also. For example:

Remove and throw away any cause of sin! Reject it as completely as if you were cutting off a foot that causes you to sin.

- If you included a footnote at 9:43a to explain the meaning, you do not need another footnote here. The footnote at 9:43a refers to both verses.

9:45b–c

It is better for you to enter life lame than to have two feet and be thrown into hell: This is a comparison like 9:42b–c.

Here are some ways that languages may show this comparison:

- One situation is better than the other (as in the BSB).
- One situation is worse than the other. For example:

Having two feet and going to hell is worse than having one foot and going to heaven.

It may seem hard to enter heaven with one foot missing, but it is far worse to keep both feet and enter hell.

- One situation is good. The other situation is bad. For example:

If you go to heaven, even if you have only one foot, that is good. But if you keep two feet and go to hell, that is bad.

9:45b**It is better for you to enter life lame**

- It is better for you^(sing) to go/begin to live in heaven crippled/disabled
- It may seem hard to enter heaven with one foot missing,
- If you^(sing) go to heaven, even if you have only one foot, that is good.

enter life: The phrase enter life was also used in 9:43b. In these verses it refers to eternal life in heaven with God.

Here are some other ways to translate enter life:

enter heaven (NLT96)

go to live forever where God dwells

lame: The Greek word that the BSB translates as lame describes someone who is lame or cannot walk well. In this context it specifically refers to someone who has had a foot cut off.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

lame (GW)

without a foot (GNT)

missing one foot

9:45c**than to have two feet and be thrown into hell.**

- than to be thrown into hell with two feet,
- but it is worse to keep both feet, and cause yourself to be thrust into hell.

- But if you have two feet and God throws you into hell, that is bad.

be thrown into hell: This clause is passive. The focus here is on the pronoun “you” from 9:45b. If a passive clause is not natural in this context in your language, you may want to use an active clause. If you need to supply a subject, the implied subject should be God. For example:

God will throw you into hell

If possible, keep the focus on the pronoun “you.”

into hell: There is a textual issue here:

1. The earliest Greek manuscripts have the words into hell here. Most English versions follow these manuscripts. For example, the RSV says:

into hell (NIV, GNT, RSV, NJB, ESV, NET, NASB, REB, GW, NLT, JBP, NCV)

1. Some later Greek manuscripts have into hell into the unquenchable fire. For example, the CEV says:

into the fires of hell that never go out (KJV, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). You should translate only the words into hell here.

hell: See the note on hell at 9:43c for ways to translate this word.

Mark 9:46

Section 9:42–50: Jesus gave various warnings

In this section, Jesus warned his disciples about several things. A believer should not cause another person to sin (9:42). A believer should not allow causes of sin to remain in his own life (9:43–48). Jesus warned believers that they would suffer because they follow him (9:49).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warned his followers with various sayings

Various warnings

Temptations to Sin (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 18:6–9 and Luke 17:1–2.

Paragraph 9:42–48

The Greek text does not indicate how much time occurred between the previous paragraph and this one. Both paragraphs include things that Jesus said, but he may have said them on separate occasions. The BSB begins this section with the word “But.” If you need an expression to introduce this paragraph, you should use a general expression that does not indicate time. For example:

Jesus also said

9:46

[Most English versions do not translate this verse. See the Notes on 9:46.]

There is a textual issue here. It is the same textual issue as in 9:44. See the advice there and do the same thing here.

Mark 9:47

Section 9:42–50: Jesus gave various warnings

In this section, Jesus warned his disciples about several things. A believer should not cause another person to sin (9:42). A believer should not allow causes of sin to remain in his own life (9:43–48). Jesus warned believers that they would suffer because they follow him (9:49).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warned his followers with various sayings

Various warnings

Temptations to Sin (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 18:6–9 and Luke 17:1–2.

Paragraph 9:42–48

The Greek text does not indicate how much time occurred between the previous paragraph and this one. Both paragraphs include things that Jesus said, but he may have said them on separate occasions. The BSB begins this section with the word “But.” If you need an expression to introduce this paragraph, you should

use a general expression that does not indicate time. For example:

Jesus also said

9:47a

And if your eye causes you to sin, pluck it out.

- Likewise, if one of your^(sing) eyes causes you to sin, pull/take it out.
- Remove and throw away any cause of sin! For instance, if your eye tempts you, reject that temptation as completely as if you were plucking out that eye.

And if your eye causes you to sin, pluck it out: This verse is a figurative example with the same meaning as 9:43a and 9:45a. You should translate it in the same way as you did 9:43a.

- If you indicated that 9:43a was a parable or figurative example, you should do that here also. For example:

If as a figurative example your eye causes you to sin, pluck it out.

- If you included the non-figurative meaning and made the parable a simile in 9:43a, you should do that here also. For example:

Remove and throw away any cause of sin! Reject it as completely as if you were plucking out an eye that causes you to sin.

- If you include a footnote at 9:43a to explain the meaning, you do not need another footnote here. The footnote at 9:43a refers to all three verses.

pluck...out: The Greek word that the BSB translates as pluck...out means “take out” or “remove.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

tear it out (NJB)

remove it and throw it away

9:47c

than to have two eyes and be thrown into hell,

- than to be thrown into hell with two eyes,
- But it is truly hard to have two eyes, and because of them to cause yourself to be thrust into hell.

- But if you^(sing) have two eyes and God throws you into hell, that is bad.

9:47b–c

It is better for you to enter the kingdom of God with one eye than to have two eyes and be thrown into hell:

There is a textual issue here that is similar to the one in 9:45c. (1) Some Greek manuscripts end the verse with the words “into hell.” For example, the GNT says: “be thrown into hell” (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, JBP, REB, NCV). (2) Other Greek manuscripts have the words “of fire” after the phrase “into hell.” For example, the KJV says: “to be cast into hell fire” (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). It is not necessary to include the word “fire.” This is a comparison like 9:43b–c and 9:45b–c. Do the same thing here as you did there.

9:47b

It is better for you to enter the kingdom of God with one eye

- It is better for you^(sing) with your one eye to enter the kingdom of God
- It may seem hard to have only one eye when you enter the place where God rules.
- If you^(sing) go to heaven, where God is the king/chief, even if you have only one eye, that is good.

enter the kingdom of God: In this context, the phrase the kingdom of God refers to God ruling his people and caring for them completely when they live with him after they die. It has a similar meaning as the parallel phrase “enter life” in 9:43b and 9:45b. It also contrasts with “hell” in 9:43c and 9:45c.

Here are some other ways to translate kingdom of God in this context:

enter the place where God rules people

go to live under God’s reign in heaven

at the time when God rules you in heaven

See also kingdom of God, Context 1, in the Glossary.

God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as God refers here to the eternal spirit who created everything. He is more powerful than any other spirit, and he is perfectly good and wise. He deserves to be worshiped.

Here are some other ways to translate God:

- Use a name or title for God that people in your culture already use.

- Use a descriptive term that fits the truth about God that is revealed in the Bible. For example:

Creator

Great Spirit

Ruler of the universe

Choose a term that is acceptable to the believers and churches in your area. For more detailed information, see God in the Glossary.

Mark 9:48

Section 9:42–50: Jesus gave various warnings

In this section, Jesus warned his disciples about several things. A believer should not cause another person to sin (9:42). A believer should not allow causes of sin to remain in his own life (9:43–48). Jesus warned believers that they would suffer because they follow him (9:49).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warned his followers with various sayings

Various warnings

Temptations to Sin (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 18:6–9 and Luke 17:1–2.

Paragraph 9:42–48

The Greek text does not indicate how much time occurred between the previous paragraph and this one. Both paragraphs include things that Jesus said, but he may have said them on separate occasions. The BSB begins this section with the word “But.” If you need an expression to introduce this paragraph, you should use a general expression that does not indicate time. For example:

Jesus also said

9:48a–b

Verse 9:48 describes suffering in hell. Some versions put single quotes around this verse. This shows that it is a quote from Isaiah 66:24.

9:48a

where ‘their worm never dies,

- where ‘the worms/maggots that eat them never die,
- In hell worms that eat the body never die, (GW)

where ‘their worm never dies: The expression their worm refers to worms that eat the bodies of dead people. It figuratively refers to suffering in hell. The phrase never dies indicates that the suffering never ends.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

There ‘the worms that eat them never die’ (GNT)

In hell worms that eat the body never die (GW)

where the maggots never die (NLT)

9:48b

and the fire is never quenched.’

- and the fire that burns them is never put out.’
- and the fire never stops burning.’ (CEV)

the fire is never quenched: The expression the fire refers to fire that burns people. It also refers to pain caused by the fire burning them. The phrase is never quenched indicates that the fire is never put out. It also indicates that the suffering never ends.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

the fire that burns them is never put out (GNT)

and the fire never stops burning (CEV)

Mark 9:49

Section 9:42–50: Jesus gave various warnings

In this section, Jesus warned his disciples about several things. A believer should not cause another person to sin (9:42). A believer should not allow causes of sin to remain in his own life (9:43–48). Jesus warned believers that they would suffer because they follow him (9:49).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warned his followers with various sayings

Various warnings

Temptations to Sin (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 18:6–9 and Luke 17:1–2.

Paragraph 9:49–50

In these verses, there are three different sayings about salt. Salt had many functions for the Jewish people. Each of these sayings refers to a different use of salt.

1. (9:49) God commanded his people to put salt on all their sacrifices (Leviticus 2:13). Salt became a symbol of the eternal nature of the covenant between God and his people.
2. (9:50a) People used salt to keep food from spoiling. They also used it to make food taste better.
3. (9:50b–d) When people entered into an agreement or covenant, they ate salt (or a meal that included salt) together.

9:49

For everyone will be salted with fire.

- ¶ All who follow me will be salted with fire.
- ¶ I say this because everyone will experience suffering/difficulties just like we/people put salt on our/their sacrifices and then burn them.
- ¶ Everyone will be purified by fire as a sacrifice is purified by salt. (GNT)

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as “For” connects 9:49 to the previous verse. In this context it indicates that 9:49 in some way explains the previous verses. All believers should remove causes of sin because they will all experience suffering of some kind. Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. You should introduce 9:49 in a way that is natural in your language.

You may want to refer back to 9:43–48 in a general way or refer to the general principle taught in those verses. For example:

I say that because

Remove causes of sin because

everyone will be salted with fire: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek texts have: “For everyone will be salted with fire.” (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, REB, NET, GW, CEV, JBP, NCV, ESV)
2. Other Greek texts have: “For everyone shall be salted with fire, and every sacrifice shall be salted with salt.” (KJV, GNT) The GNT appears to follow option (2). However, there is a possibility that it actually follows option (1) and makes explicit its interpretation of those manuscripts.)

It is recommended that you follow option (1).

The expression everyone will be salted with fire is very difficult. Bible scholars have interpreted it in different ways. However, most scholars believe that Jesus’ words figuratively referred to Jewish sacrifices which were always salted (see Leviticus 2:13). Most of these sacrifices were also burned with fire. Fire here is an image of the suffering or hardships that all disciples would experience. This suffering would make them more holy and help them to rely more on God.

In many languages, it will not be easy to translate salted with fire literally. In languages where it can be translated, it may not be easily understood. Another problem is that your culture may use salt and fire figuratively to mean different things than they meant to the Jews. If that is true, you may want to:

- Translate this expression in a way that explains the metaphor. For example:

Just as every sacrifice/food is salted, everyone passes through fires of suffering.

Everyone will experience suffering/difficulties that will be like going through fire.

Everyone will be like a sacrifice that is salted and then burned.

Everyone will be purified by fire as a sacrifice is purified by salt. (GNT)

Everyone will be purified with/by the fire of suffering. If you follow one of these models for translation, you may want to include a footnote giving the literal Greek text. For example:

Literally: “For everyone will be salted with fire.”

- Explain this expression in a footnote. For example:

The expression “salted with fire” probably refers figuratively to Jewish sacrifices which were always salted (see Leviticus 2:13). Most of these sacrifices were burned with fire. Fire here is an image of the suffering or hardships that all disciples would experience. These hardships would make them more holy and cause them to rely more on God.

everyone: The word everyone refers to all of Jesus’ followers. You may want to make this clear by saying:

all my followers

all of you^(plur)

will be salted: This is a passive clause. If it is more natural in your language to use an active verb here, you may be able to say:

Just as people salt every sacrifice, so God will cause everyone to pass through fires of suffering.

Everyone will be like a sacrifice on which a person puts salt and then burns.

God will purify everyone with fire as a person purifies a sacrifice with salt.

God will purify everyone with/by the fire of suffering.

with fire: The phrase with fire is emphasized in the Greek. If you have a natural way to emphasize this phrase, you may want to do so. For example:

it is with/by fire that everyone will be salted

fire: Notice that fire in this verse does not have the same meaning as “fire” in 9:48b. This verse means that all followers of Jesus will experience suffering of some kind because they belong to him. This verse does not mean that everyone will experience the fire of hell. Your translation should make the different meaning clear either in text or in a footnote. See the notes and examples above.

Mark 9:50

Section 9:42–50: Jesus gave various warnings

In this section, Jesus warned his disciples about several things. A believer should not cause another person to sin (9:42). A believer should not allow causes of sin to remain in his own life (9:43–48). Jesus warned believers that they would suffer because they follow him (9:49).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warned his followers with various sayings

Various warnings

Temptations to Sin (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 18:6–9 and Luke 17:1–2.

Paragraph 9:49–50

In these verses, there are three different sayings about salt. Salt had many functions for the Jewish people. Each of these sayings refers to a different use of salt.

1. (9:49) God commanded his people to put salt on all their sacrifices (Leviticus 2:13). Salt became a symbol of the eternal nature of the covenant between God and his people.
2. (9:50a) People used salt to keep food from spoiling. They also used it to make food taste better.
3. (9:50b–d) When people entered into an agreement or covenant, they ate salt (or a meal that included salt) together.

9:50a

Salt is good,

- Salt is a good thing.
- Salt is useful,

In this verse, the metaphor is changed from the process of putting salt on something (9:49) to salt itself.

Salt is good: The Greek word that the BSB translates as good can also mean “useful.” Here Jesus meant that salt was useful or valuable for flavoring or for preserving food.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Salt is a good thing (NJB)

Salt is good for seasoning. (NLT)

There are good uses for salt.

9:50b

but if the salt loses its saltiness, with what will you season it?

- But if it loses its taste/flavor, how can you^(plur) make it salty again?
- but if it becomes unable to salt things, you certainly cannot restore it!

but if the salt loses its saltiness, with what will you season it?: This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes a negative statement: If salt loses its salty taste, you certainly cannot make it salty again. Translate this expression in a way that emphasizes the negative statement.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the GW says:

if salt loses its taste, how will you restore its flavor?

- As a statement. For example, the NCV says:

if the salt loses its salty taste, you cannot make it salty again

- As a tag question. For example:

if the salt loses its salty taste, you cannot make it salty again, can you?

but if the salt loses its saltiness: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as loses its saltiness is literally “becomes saltless.” Salt that has “become saltless” has lost its ability to make food taste better.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

if it loses its taste/flavor

if the salt becomes unsalty (NASB)

9:50c

Have salt among yourselves,

- You must have the qualities of salt among yourselves (NLT)
- Cause your attitudes/deeds to be like the usefulness/goodness of salt
- Be^(plur) good disciples like the good effect of salt on food,

Have salt among yourselves: The expression Have salt among yourselves refers figuratively to attitudes that believers have. Bible scholars have many opinions about which specific attitudes this expression refers to. You may want to:

- Refer to the figurative use of salt in a general way. For example:

You must have the qualities of salt among yourselves. (NLT)

May your^(plur) attitudes and deeds have a salty taste/flavor

Make your mind/attitudes beneficial like salt

- In the text of your translation, explain the metaphor in a general way. For example:

Have^(plur) that good effect of the gospel to others like salt to food

Be^(plur) good disciples like the usefulness of salt for food

9:50d

and be at peace with one another.”

- and live in peace with one another.” (GNT)
- and live in harmony/unity with one another.”

be at peace with one another: In this context, the Greek verb that the BSB translates as be at peace means “seek or keep peace” with other people. It refers to promoting unity, harmony, and friendliness. People who live at peace in this way will not quarrel and fight with each other.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

live in harmony together

have unity among yourselves

Mark 10:1

Section 10:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce

Some Pharisees came to Jesus. They wanted to try to make him say something wrong that would damage his reputation. That is why they asked Jesus about his teaching on divorce. Some Pharisees taught that a man could divorce his wife for any reason. Other Pharisees taught that a man could only divorce his wife if she committed sexual sin. Jesus agreed with the second group of Pharisees, but he added that God created marriage and he does not like divorce.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus answered a question about divorce

Divorce (NIV)

Jesus' teaching about divorce

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:1–9 and Luke 16:18.

10:1a

Then Jesus left that place

- ¶ Then Jesus left that area
- ¶ After leaving there/Capernaum, Jesus and his disciples

Then: This verse is the beginning of a new section and story. The events in this section happened sometime after the events in the preceding section. The BSB introduces this story with the word Then. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories.

If it is natural in your language to begin a story with a time word or phrase, use an expression that is not too specific. For example:

Later

After that

In some languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this story in a natural way in your language.

Jesus left that place: The Greek words that the BSB translates as Jesus left that place are literally “having

arisen (from) there.” In this context, the phrase “having arisen” probably refers to beginning his journey.

It is clear from 10:10b that the disciples were with Jesus. In some languages it may be clearer to make this explicit here at the beginning of the story. For example:

Jesus and his disciples began their journey

When/After Jesus and his followers left there

that place: The phrase that place refers to the town of Capernaum (9:33).

10:1b

and went into the region of Judea, beyond the Jordan.

- and went into the regions of Judea and beyond the Jordan.
- went to the province of Judea, and crossed the Jordan River. (GNT)
- went to the region of Judea and also/then to the region on the other side of the Jordan River.

went into the region of Judea, beyond the Jordan:

The Greek words that the BSB translates as the region of Judea, beyond the Jordan is literally “the regions of Judea, beyond the Jordan.” There is a textual issue in 10:1b: (1) Many Greek manuscripts have “and across/beyond the Jordan.” For example, the GNT says: “and crossed the Jordan River” (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NJB, ESV, NET, NASB, REB, CEV, NLT, NCV, JBP). (2) Some manuscripts have “through the other side of the Jordan.” For example, the KJV says: “by the farther side of Jordan” (KJV, GW). It is recommended that you follow option (1). But if the major language version in your area follows the manuscripts which have “by way of the other side,” you may want to follow that. These words probably indicate that Jesus went to two places:

1. The region of Judea, which is west of the Jordan River.
2. A region east of the Jordan River. The Greek and the BSB refer to this eastern region as beyond the Jordan.

The events of 10:2–31 probably take place in the region east of the Jordan River. You may be able to make this clear by saying:

went into the region of Judea and arrived in the region beyond the Jordan

Judea: The word Judea is the name of a region. This was the region surrounding the city of Jerusalem. See how you transliterated this name in 3:7c.

beyond the Jordan: The Greek word that the BSB translates as beyond also means “across” (as in the NIV). The CEV shows another way to say this:

to the other side of the Jordan River

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this word as a verb. For example, the GNT says:

crossed the Jordan River

the Jordan: The word Jordan refers to the “Jordan River.” It may be more natural in your language to indicate that. For example, the GNT says:

the Jordan River

10:1c

Again the crowds came to Him

- Once again crowds gathered round him, (REB)
- As before, various large groups of people came and gathered to him,

Again the crowds came to Him: The word Again indicates that as on previous occasions, crowds also came this time. The word Again does not indicate that the same crowds came. For example:

Once again crowds gathered round him (REB)

As always there were the crowds. (NLT96)

the crowds: The Greek word that the BSB translates as crowds is plural. This plural word may indicate:

1. a very large crowd/group of people,
2. several large groups of people, or
3. different crowds at different times.

Use an expression in your language that allows for one or more of these meanings.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

a very large crowd

various large groups of people

many people

came to Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as came refers to coming together into a group. All these crowds gathered around Jesus. The REB says:

gathered round him

10:1d

and He taught them, as was His custom.

- and as usual he taught them. (NLT)
- and he taught them, as he always did. (GNT)

as was His custom: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as as was His custom is literally “again as he was accustomed [to].” It indicates that Jesus usually or habitually taught the crowds, and he did so on this occasion also.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

as usual (NLT)

as he always did (GNT)

Some languages can express this idea by a habitual form of the verb “teach.”

Mark 10:2

Section 10:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce

Some Pharisees came to Jesus. They wanted to try to make him say something wrong that would damage his reputation. That is why they asked Jesus about his teaching on divorce. Some Pharisees taught that a man could divorce his wife for any reason. Other Pharisees taught that a man could only divorce his wife if she committed sexual sin. Jesus agreed with the second group of Pharisees, but he added that God created marriage and he does not like divorce.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus answered a question about divorce

Divorce (NIV)

Jesus’ teaching about divorce

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:1–9 and Luke 16:18.

10:2a**Some Pharisees came to test Him.**

- Some Pharisees came and tested Jesus.
- Some Pharisees came/approached Jesus and tried to cause him to say something wrong.

Pharisees: The Pharisees were a Jewish religious group or party. It was very important to them to obey all of the Jewish religious laws very carefully and in detail. Here are some ways to translate this word:

- Transliterate the word Pharisees according to the sounds of your language and indicate that it refers to people. For example:

Farisi members

Parise adherents

- Transliterate the word Pharisees and indicate that it refers to a group of people with certain beliefs. For example:

people belonging to the Farise religious sect/
group

members of the religious group called the Farasi

You may also want to include an explanation of Pharisees in the glossary of your translation.

to test Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as test here refers to trying to cause Jesus to say something that would turn people against him. The Pharisees tested Jesus by asking the question that follows. They hoped that Jesus would answer their question and say something that was against the Law of Moses. If he did this, they could accuse him of saying something wrong.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

in order to test him

to test him with a question

to try to trap him

See how you translated the word testing in 8:11b.

10:2b

“Is it lawful for a man to divorce his wife?” they inquired.

- They asked, “Is it permitted in the Law of Moses for a man to divorce his wife?”
- They asked him, “Does our^(incl) Law allow for a man/husband to end the marriage with his wife?”

“Is it lawful...?”: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Is it lawful...? is literally “Is it permitted...?” The Pharisees were asking if Jewish law permitted a man to divorce his wife.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Is it permitted in/by the Law of Moses...?

...does our Law allow...? (GNT)

See how you translated this expression in 2:26c.

for a man to divorce his wife: In Jewish culture, it was rare for a woman to try to divorce her husband. So you should use the specific terms for “man/husband” and “wife” here. Do not use a general expression such as “for someone to divorce his or her spouse.”

divorce: The Greek word that the BSB translates as divorce literally means to “send away.” This means that the husband gave his wife a certificate saying that he was divorcing her (10:4b). He could then force her to leave his house. In Jewish culture, this was the legal way to divorce a wife.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

send away

break the marriage agreement

Mark 10:3**Section 10:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce**

Some Pharisees came to Jesus. They wanted to try to make him say something wrong that would damage his reputation. That is why they asked Jesus about his teaching on divorce. Some Pharisees taught that a man could divorce his wife for any reason. Other Pharisees taught that a man could only divorce his wife if she committed sexual sin. Jesus agreed with the second group of Pharisees, but he added that God created marriage and he does not like divorce.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus answered a question about divorce

Divorce (NIV)

Jesus' teaching about divorce

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:1–9 and Luke 16:18.

10:3

“What did Moses command you?” He replied.

- He replied, “What did Moses command/tell you^(plur) to do?”
- He/Jesus asked in reply, “What law did Moses give to us^(incl) Jews long ago?”

What did Moses command you?: This is the sort of question a teacher might ask a student. Jesus already knew the answer, but he wanted the Pharisees to tell him what they knew. He was asking them to tell him what commands/laws about divorce were in the first five books of the Old Testament scriptures. These are the books that Moses wrote.

The GNT shows another way to translate this:

What law did Moses give you?

you: When Jesus used the word you here, he was referring to you Jewish people. Although Moses wrote down God's laws many centuries earlier, these laws also applied to the Jews of Jesus' generation. In some languages, using the word “you” may wrongly imply that Moses literally gave a command to the Pharisees. It may also wrongly imply that Jesus was not a Jew.

In order to avoid these wrong meanings, Here are some other ways to translate this question:

What does the Law of Moses say about that? (CEV)

What did Moses command us^(incl) Jews long ago?

He replied: The BSB places the words He replied after Jesus' question. In Greek, these words occur before the question. Place the words He replied where it is natural in your language.

Jesus did not answer the Pharisees' question here. Instead he asked them about what the Scriptures said. It may be more natural in your language to indicate that he asked a question in reply. For example:

In response he asked, “What did Moses command you?”

Jesus answered with a question, “What law did Moses give you?” (GNT)

Mark 10:4

Section 10:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce

Some Pharisees came to Jesus. They wanted to try to make him say something wrong that would damage his reputation. That is why they asked Jesus about his teaching on divorce. Some Pharisees taught that a man could divorce his wife for any reason. Other Pharisees taught that a man could only divorce his wife if she committed sexual sin. Jesus agreed with the second group of Pharisees, but he added that God created marriage and he does not like divorce.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus answered a question about divorce

Divorce (NIV)

Jesus' teaching about divorce

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:1–9 and Luke 16:18.

10:4a

They answered,

- They replied,

10:4b

“Moses permitted a man to write his wife a certificate of divorce

- “Moses allowed a man to give his wife a legal divorce paper
- “According to Moses' law, a man/husband was permitted to write a letter/paper that said, ‘I divorce you.’ He could then give this paper to his wife

10:4a–b

Moses permitted: Here the name Moses represents the law that Moses wrote. The Greek word that the BSB translates as permitted means “allowed.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Moses allowed (RSV)

Moses' law permitted

Moses gave permission (GNT)

a certificate of divorce: The phrase certificate of divorce refers to a legal document/paper stating that a certain woman is no longer married to a certain man.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

an official letter of divorce (NLT96)

a paper stating/confirming that he had divorced his wife

General Comment on 10:4b

It is implied that the man gave the certificate of divorce to the woman. It may be more natural in your language to include that implied information. For example:

Moses permitted a man to write a certificate of divorce, and give it to her.

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate certificate of divorce as a direct quote. For example:

According to Moses' law, a man could give his wife a paper that said, "I divorce you."

10:4c and send her away."

- and then send her away."
- and force her to leave his house."

send her away: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as send...away is the same verb that was translated as "divorce" in 10:2b. The BSB uses the expression send her away to refer to the final action of the divorce.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

to divorce her (NRSV)

force her to leave

When you translate these two phrases in 10:4b and 10:4c, be careful not to imply that the man divorced his wife twice.

Mark 10:5

Section 10:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce

Some Pharisees came to Jesus. They wanted to try to make him say something wrong that would damage his reputation. That is why they asked Jesus about his teaching on divorce. Some Pharisees taught that a man could divorce his wife for any reason. Other Pharisees taught that a man could only divorce his wife if she committed sexual sin. Jesus agreed with the second group of Pharisees, but he added that God created marriage and he does not like divorce.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus answered a question about divorce

Divorce (NIV)

Jesus' teaching about divorce

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:1–9 and Luke 16:18.

10:5

But Jesus told them, "Moses wrote this commandment for you because of your hardness of heart.

- Jesus replied, "Because you^(plur) are very stubborn, Moses wrote that law for you.
- Jesus answered, "You^(plur) are always stubborn against God, so Moses wrote that law/command for you.
- Then Jesus said to them, "Moses wrote this/that law because you people always refuse to obey God.

Moses wrote this commandment for you because of your hardness of heart: The phrase because of your hardness of heart is a reason phrase. The clause Moses wrote this commandment for you is a result clause. In some languages, it is more natural to put the reason clause first. For example:

Because of your hardness of heart, Moses wrote this commandment for you.

Your hearts were hard, so Moses wrote you this law.

Moses wrote this commandment for you: The phrase this commandment refers here to what the

Pharisees said in 10:4b–c. They said that Moses permitted a man to write his wife a certificate of divorce and send her away. Here Jesus spoke of this permission as a commandment that Moses wrote for the people.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Moses wrote that command for you (NCV)

Moses wrote you this law (NIV)

Moses wrote this permission as a law for you

this commandment: The phrase this commandment refers to the law in 10:4. Use a natural expression that refers back to 10:4.

you: The pronoun you is plural and refers to the Pharisees. But Moses lived fifteen hundred years before Jesus, and his law was for Jews of all generations. So it may be necessary to translate this as:

you and your ancestors

It may also be possible to leave the phrase “for you” implicit here. For example, the NLT says:

He wrote this commandment only as a concession to your hard hearts.

- You may also want to include a footnote. For example:

Moses wrote this law fifteen hundred years before the time of Jesus. His law was for the Jews of that time as well as future generations.

because of your hardness of heart: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as your hardness of heart is an idiom. It means “you were stubborn” or “you were not willing to change.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Use an equivalent idiom in your language that means “stubborn.”
- Translate the meaning directly. For example:

because you were stubborn (NCV)

because of your stubbornness (REB)

because you refused to accept God’s teaching

because you always refuse to obey God

Mark 10:6

Section 10:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce

Some Pharisees came to Jesus. They wanted to try to make him say something wrong that would damage his reputation. That is why they asked Jesus about his teaching on divorce. Some Pharisees taught that a man could divorce his wife for any reason. Other Pharisees taught that a man could only divorce his wife if she committed sexual sin. Jesus agreed with the second group of Pharisees, but he added that God created marriage and he does not like divorce.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus answered a question about divorce

Divorce (NIV)

Jesus’ teaching about divorce

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:1–9 and Luke 16:18.

10:6

However, from the beginning of creation, ‘God made them male and female.’

- But at the beginning when God created everything, ‘he made them male and female.’
- But it is written that when God made the world, he made a man and a woman.

However: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as However indicates a contrast. The contrast is between the law that Moses wrote because of people’s stubbornness (10:5) and God’s original intention for people (10:6–9). Indicate this contrast in a natural way in your language.

from the beginning of creation:

Here are some other ways to translate this:

when God made the world (NCV)

at the beginning when God created everything

‘God made them male and female’: The BSB puts single quote marks around God made them male and female. This is because these words are a direct quote from the Greek translation of Genesis 1:27. If you usually put quote marks around a quote from the Old Testament, you may want to put quote marks around these words, as the BSB does. Another way to show that this is a quote from the Old Testament is to say:

It is written that God made them male and female.

Some versions do not indicate specifically that these are quotes, but they give the verse references in a footnote. You may want to give the Old Testament references in a footnote, whether or not you mark the quotes.

them: The pronoun them refers to the first human beings. Some ways to translate this are:

- Translate the pronoun them literally. If you do this, you may want to make explicit what them refers to. For example:

when God created the world, he created people and made them male and female

- Omit the pronoun them. For example, the CEV says:

God made a man and a woman

Mark 10:7

Section 10:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce

Some Pharisees came to Jesus. They wanted to try to make him say something wrong that would damage his reputation. That is why they asked Jesus about his teaching on divorce. Some Pharisees taught that a man could divorce his wife for any reason. Other Pharisees taught that a man could only divorce his wife if she committed sexual sin. Jesus agreed with the second group of Pharisees, but he added that God created marriage and he does not like divorce.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus answered a question about divorce

Divorce (NIV)

Jesus’ teaching about divorce

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:1–9 and Luke 16:18.

10:7a–10:8a

The words in 10:7–10:8a are a quotation from Genesis 2:24. You may want to give this reference in a footnote.

10:7a

‘For this reason a man will leave his father and mother

- ‘For this reason, a man will leave his parents
- And that is why a man will leave his mother and father

For this reason:

Here are some other ways to translate For this reason:

That is why (REB)

Because of this

So (NCV)

Jesus probably used the phrase For this reason to connect to the previous statement. But the phrase For this reason is a direct quote from the Greek translation of Genesis 2:24. In Genesis, these words refer back to Genesis 2:23c: “she was taken out of man.” God made the first woman from the rib of the first man (Genesis 2:22). So the two started from “one flesh.” Jesus may have implied this reason as well.

a man will leave his father and mother: The Greek word that the BSB translates as leave refers to the man leaving his parents’ household and starting a new household with his wife.

10:7b

and be united to his wife,

- and be joined to his wife, (RSV)
- and God will unite/join him with his wife,
- and marry a woman,

and be united to his wife: There is a textual issue in this verse:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the words “and be united to his wife.” (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, CEV, NRSV, GW, JBP, KJV, NET, NCV, NLT, REB, ESV)
2. Other Greek manuscripts do not have these words. (NASB, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). However, if the major language version follows option (2), you may want to follow that.

be united to his wife: The Greek words that the BSB translates as *be united to* means “be joined with,” “cling to,” or “associate with.” It has a general meaning here that includes the idea of sexual intercourse. Use an expression that expresses a general sense of “join with.” For example:

be joined to his wife (RSV)

be united together by God with his wife

This clause is passive. 10:9 indicates that God is the one who joins the man and the woman together, but the focus here is on the man. If a passive clause is not natural in your language here, you may use an active clause. For example:

God will unite him with his wife

will live with his wife

gets married (CEV)

If possible, keep the focus on the man.

Mark 10:8

Section 10:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce

Some Pharisees came to Jesus. They wanted to try to make him say something wrong that would damage his reputation. That is why they asked Jesus about his teaching on divorce. Some Pharisees taught that a man could divorce his wife for any reason. Other Pharisees taught that a man could only divorce his wife if she committed sexual sin. Jesus agreed with the second group of Pharisees, but he added that God created marriage and he does not like divorce.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus answered a question about divorce

Divorce (NIV)

Jesus’ teaching about divorce

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:1–9 and Luke 16:18.

10:8a and the two will become one flesh.’

- and the two persons will become united as one body/person.’
- the two of them will become as one.
- and the man and the woman, who are two people, will become like one person.

the two will become one flesh: The phrase *the two* refers to a man and his wife. The words *become one flesh* is a figure of speech here. It indicates that the husband and wife will become united as one person or being.

In some languages, it is not natural to refer to a man and woman becoming one flesh. If that is true in your language, you may want to indicate the meaning in another way. For example:

the two will become as united as if they were in one body

the two of them will become like one person

10:8b So they are no longer two, but one flesh.

- So they are no longer two individuals/people but united as one.
- So the man and his wife are no longer two separate people, but rather they are united into a unit.

Jesus stopped quoting from Scripture at the end of 10:8a and began to speak his own words again. Make this clear in your translation.

So they are no longer two, but one flesh: This part of the verse expresses the same principle as in 10:8a. The word *two* refers to two people, two separate individuals. The phrase *but one flesh* indicates that they are united as one flesh. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

So they are no longer two individuals, but are united into one flesh.

So they are no longer two separate persons only, but are united as one body/person.

Mark 10:9

Section 10:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce

Some Pharisees came to Jesus. They wanted to try to make him say something wrong that would damage his reputation. That is why they asked Jesus about his teaching on divorce. Some Pharisees taught that a man could divorce his wife for any reason. Other Pharisees taught that a man could only divorce his wife if she committed sexual sin. Jesus agreed with the second group of Pharisees, but he added that God created marriage and he does not like divorce.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus answered a question about divorce

Divorce (NIV)

Jesus' teaching about divorce

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:1–9 and Luke 16:18.

10:9

Therefore what God has joined together, let man not separate."

- Therefore, the people whom God has joined together, no human being should separate/divide."
- This means that no one should separate the man and woman whom God has joined together."

Therefore: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Therefore indicates that 10:9 is the conclusion of what Jesus said in 10:6–8. Another way to translate this is "So."

what God has joined together: The phrase what God has joined together refers to the married man and woman. In some languages it may be natural to translate it as:

the people whom God has joined together

The Greek word that the BSB translates as joined together is literally "yoked together." It means "joined as a pair." The verb could be used of two oxen working together to pull a plow. It is also used of a man and woman who are joined as marriage partners. It implies that they are united with common goals.

Here is another way to translate this:

God has united them

let man not separate: The phrase let man not separate is an indirect command. Jesus was saying that no one should separate a husband and wife and end their marriage.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

man must not separate (NEB)

human beings must not divide (NJB)

must not be split/broken by anyone

man: The word man refers in general to any person, including the married man or woman. This is not the same Greek word for "man" as the word in 10:2b. It contrasts with "God" in the previous phrase.

separate: The word separate refers to divorce.

General Comment on 10:9

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses in this verse. For example:

Therefore, no one should separate what God has joined together.

And no one should separate a couple that God has joined together. (CEV)

Mark 10:10

Section 10:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce

Some Pharisees came to Jesus. They wanted to try to make him say something wrong that would damage his reputation. That is why they asked Jesus about his teaching on divorce. Some Pharisees taught that a man could divorce his wife for any reason. Other Pharisees taught that a man could only divorce his wife if she committed sexual sin. Jesus agreed with the second group of Pharisees, but he added that God created marriage and he does not like divorce.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus answered a question about divorce

Divorce (NIV)

Jesus' teaching about divorce

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:1–9 and Luke 16:18.

10:10a

When they were back inside the house,

- ¶ Later, in the house, (NCV)
- ¶ Later, when he/Jesus was alone with his followers in a house,

When they were back inside the house: The phrase When they were back inside the house refers to some time after the conversation in 10:1–9. It probably refers to later that day when Jesus and the disciples were in a house together away from the crowds and the Pharisees.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Later, in the house (NCV)

Later, when he was alone with his disciples in the house (NLT)

back: The Greek word that the BSB translates as back is more literally “again.” There are two ways to interpret this word:

1. It goes with 10:10b and refers to the disciples again asking Jesus about divorce. For example, the NCV says:

his followers asked Jesus again about the question of divorce (RSV, NJB, NASB, KJV, NLT, NCV, JBP, ESV)

1. It goes with 10:10a and refers to Jesus and his disciples being in the house again. For example, the NET says:

In the house once again (BSB, NIV, GNT, NET, REB, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). However, if a major language version in your area follows interpretation (2), you may follow that. Both interpretations are well supported.

The Pharisees had asked Jesus about divorce. Here the disciples also asked about divorce. The word again does not mean that the disciples had previously asked Jesus about divorce. The disciples wanted to know more about his teaching in 10:1–9.

Here are some other ways to translate the word again:

the disciples also asked Jesus about this

the disciples asked Jesus more about this

the house: The words the house do not refer to any particular house that has been mentioned before. It may be more natural in your language to use an expression that does not refer to a particular house. For example:

a house

indoors (REB)

10:10b

the disciples asked Jesus about this matter.

- the disciples began asking him again/further about that teaching.
- they also were asking him about what he said earlier.

the disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means “learners” who are in a relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

students/learners

apprentices

followers

See how you translated this term at 2:15b. See also disciple in the Glossary for more information.

asked Jesus: The Greek form of the verb asked here probably indicates that several disciples asked Jesus questions.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the disciples were asking him further about that teaching

the disciples began questioning Him about this again (NASB)

about this matter: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as about this matter refers to the issue of divorce.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

about this issue

about what he had said (CEV)

about the question of divorce (NCV)

Mark 10:11

Section 10:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce

Some Pharisees came to Jesus. They wanted to try to make him say something wrong that would damage his reputation. That is why they asked Jesus about his teaching on divorce. Some Pharisees taught that a man could divorce his wife for any reason. Other Pharisees taught that a man could only divorce his wife if she committed sexual sin. Jesus agreed with the second group of Pharisees, but he added that God created marriage and he does not like divorce.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus answered a question about divorce

Divorce (NIV)

Jesus' teaching about divorce

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:1–9 and Luke 16:18.

10:11a

So He told them,

- He replied,

10:11b

“Whoever divorces his wife and marries another woman commits adultery against her.

- “Whoever divorces his wife and marries someone else commits adultery against her. (NLT)
- “If a man divorces his wife and marries another woman, he is sinning by being unfaithful to his first wife.

10:11a–b

So He told them: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as So he told them introduces the answer to the question that the disciples asked Jesus in 10:10. Introduce it in a natural way in your language.

Whoever divorces his wife and marries another woman commits adultery against her: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as commits adultery refers to a certain type of sexual sin. It refers to sexual relations between a man and a woman, when at least one of them is married to another person.

When a man divorces his wife, God still considers their marriage to be valid. So when he marries another woman, he has been unfaithful to his first wife and sinned. God considers this sin to be adultery. This same term occurs in 7:21c.

In some languages the usual term for commits adultery is very specific. For example, it may refer only to a man having sexual relations with another man's wife. If that is true in your language, you should indicate that divorce and remarriage is the same as the sin of adultery. For example:

If a man divorces his wife and marries someone else, he has been unfaithful to her. It is the same as adultery.

A person who divorces his wife and marries someone else does a bad thing to his wife. It is the sin of adultery.

against her: The pronoun her refers to the first wife. The man who divorces his wife and remarries is committing adultery by taking a second wife. That is a sin against the first wife. It injures her and is an offense against God. It violates God's will for married people.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Whoever divorces his wife and marries another woman commits adultery with her and so sins against his first wife.

Whoever divorces his wife and marries another woman commits adultery and behaves immorally/unfaithfully to/toward his first wife.

Mark 10:12

Section 10:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce

Some Pharisees came to Jesus. They wanted to try to make him say something wrong that would damage his reputation. That is why they asked Jesus about his teaching on divorce. Some Pharisees taught that a man could divorce his wife for any reason. Other Pharisees taught that a man could only divorce his wife if she committed sexual sin. Jesus agreed with the second group of Pharisees, but he added that God created marriage and he does not like divorce.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus answered a question about divorce

Divorce (NIV)

Jesus' teaching about divorce

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:1–9 and Luke 16:18.

10:12

And if a woman divorces her husband and marries another man, she commits adultery.”

- And a woman who divorces her husband and remarries commits adultery.”
- And if a woman divorces her husband and marries another man, she sins by being unfaithful to her first husband.”

And if a woman divorces her husband and marries another man, she commits adultery: The same rule applies for a woman as for a man. When a woman divorces her husband, God still considers their marriage to be valid. So when she marries another man, she has been unfaithful to her first husband and sinned. It is the same as committing adultery.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

And if a woman divorces her husband and remarries, she has been unfaithful to him. It is the same as adultery.

Also, a woman who divorces her husband and marries another man violates God's marriage laws. She has done the same sin as adultery.

Mark 10:13

Section 10:13–16: Jesus blessed little children

Some people brought their children for Jesus to bless them. The disciples probably thought that Jesus was too important to bless children. So they prevented the people from bringing the children. But Jesus wanted to bless them. He allowed the children to come to him.

Jesus used the things that happened with these children to teach that God accepts people who are humble. The people whom God rules should be like little children: they should humbly accept God's rule in their lives.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus and Little Children (NET)

Some little children were brought to Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:13–15 and Luke 18:15–17.

10:13a

Now people were bringing the little children to Jesus

- ¶ People were bringing their little children to Jesus
- ¶ One day, some people were bringing their young children to Jesus.

10:13b

for Him to place His hands on them,

- so that he could touch their heads and bless them,
- They wanted him to place his hands on them and ask God to bless them.

10:13a–b

Now: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now indicates that the story in 10:13–16 began sometime after the story in 10:10–12 ended. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories. In some languages, it is natural to begin a story with a time word or phrase. If your language is like that, use an expression here that is not too specific. For example:

One day (NLT)

Then (JBP)

In other languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this story in a natural way in your language.

people were bringing the little children to Jesus:

The form of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as were bringing indicates that parents brought their children to Jesus over a period of time. They did not all come at the same time.

the little children: The Greek word that the BSB translates as little children is used to refer to children of many different ages. It can refer to children from a newborn baby to a child thirteen years old. The parallel passage in Luke uses a word which refers only to very young children. Translate this expression using a general expression for children that can include babies and young children.

for Him to place His hands on them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as place His hands on is more literally “touch,” and it refers to giving a blessing. In Jewish culture, parents often brought a young child to a religious leader for him to bless the child. To bless the child, the religious leader would place his hands on the child’s head and pray for him. (For a discussion of the word “bless,” see the note on 10:16b.)

If people in your area will not understand what the phrase place His hands on refers to, you may want to add some implied information. For example:

People were bringing little children to Jesus to have him place his hands on their heads and bless them.

People were bringing little children to Jesus, wanting him to place his hands on them and ask God to bless them.

**10:13c
and the disciples rebuked those who brought them.**

- but the disciples scolded the people. (GNT)
- But the followers told the people to stop bothering him.

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and indicates a contrast. The contrast is between 10:13b and 10:13c. The parents were bringing their children to Jesus, but the disciples did not want this to happen.

the disciples rebuked those who brought them: In this context, the word rebuked refers here to telling people that they are wrong for doing a certain action. The disciples thought that the people were wrong

because they interrupted Jesus and asked him to bless the children.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the disciples spoke sternly to them (NRSV)

the disciples scolded the people (GNT)

his disciples told the people to stop bothering him (CEV)

See how you translated the word rebuke in 8:32c.

Mark 10:14

Section 10:13–16: Jesus blessed little children

Some people brought their children for Jesus to bless them. The disciples probably thought that Jesus was too important to bless children. So they prevented the people from bringing the children. But Jesus wanted to bless them. He allowed the children to come to him.

Jesus used the things that happened with these children to teach that God accepts people who are humble. The people whom God rules should be like little children: they should humbly accept God’s rule in their lives.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus and Little Children (NET)

Some little children were brought to Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:13–15 and Luke 18:15–17.

10:14a But when Jesus saw this, He was indignant

- When Jesus saw this, he became angry.
- Jesus saw that and was very displeased.

He was indignant: The word indignant means “angry” or “upset.” Jesus was upset or angry because the disciples told the parents not to bring the children to him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

he became angry (CEV)

he was greatly displeased (NKJV)

**10:14b
and told them,**

- He/Jesus said to them,
- So he/Jesus said to his followers,

10:14c

“Let the little children come to Me, and do not hinder them!”

- “Allow the little children to come to me and do not stop them,
- “Do not forbid the children to come to me. Permit them to come,

10:14b–c

Let the little children come to Me, and do not hinder them!: There are two commands in this part of the verse: Let the little children come to Me and do not hinder them. These commands have similar meanings. Jesus repeated his meaning in two different ways to emphasize what he said.

In some languages it may be more natural to give the negative command first. For example:

Do not forbid the children to come to me. Allow them to come....

In other languages it may be more natural to combine the two commands. For example, the GW has:

Don’t stop the children from coming to me.

Translate these two commands in a natural way in your language.

Let: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Let means “allow” or “permit.” For example:

Allow the little children to come to me.

hinder: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as hinder means “forbid” or “stop.”

Here are some other ways to translate this command:

do not stop them (GNT)

do not forbid their coming to me

10:14d

For the kingdom of God belongs to such as these.

- for it is people who are trustful/trusting like these children who will live in the kingdom of God.
- because God rules people like this.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces the reason for Jesus’ commands to his disciples in 10:14c. Another way to translate this conjunction is “because.”

the kingdom of God belongs to such as these: The phrase kingdom of God refers to God’s activity of ruling and caring for his people as their king. It does not refer to a land or country that he rules over. It refers to the relationship that he has with his people. He leads, protects, and cares for them. They obey, trust, and submit to him as their king.

The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the kingdom of God belongs to such as these means “people like this have the right/privilege to be included in the group of people whom God rules.” It does not mean that such people own the kingdom of God. See also kingdom of God, Context 2, in the Glossary.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Children like these are part of the kingdom of God. (GW)

...it is people like these children who will live under God’s chieftaincy.

...it is people like these children who are citizens of the kingdom of God.

...God cares for little ones like these as their king.

such as these: The phrase such as these means “people like these children.” It probably refers to people who are humble and depend on God. They are like children who depend on their parents. In some languages it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

...because the kingdom of God belongs to people who depend on God like these children depend on their parents.

...for it is people who are trustful/trusting like these children who will live in the kingdom of God.

General Comment on 10:14c–d

In these verses, 10:14d expresses the reason for the result in 10:14c. In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of these clauses. For example:

^{14d}The kingdom of God belongs to little children as these, ^{14c}so let them come to me, and do not hinder them.

Mark 10:15

Section 10:13–16: Jesus blessed little children

Some people brought their children for Jesus to bless them. The disciples probably thought that Jesus was too important to bless children. So they prevented the people from bringing the children. But Jesus wanted to bless them. He allowed the children to come to him.

Jesus used the things that happened with these children to teach that God accepts people who are humble. The people whom God rules should be like little children: they should humbly accept God's rule in their lives.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus and Little Children (NET)

Some little children were brought to Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:13–15 and Luke 18:15–17.

10:15a

Truly I tell you,

- I tell you the truth, (NIV)
- I assure you that
- Listen, because this is important/true:

Truly I tell you: Jesus often used the words that the BSB translates as Truly I tell you to begin a statement that he wanted to emphasize. It indicates that the statement was important and totally reliable, and that people should listen carefully to it. Jesus used this phrase eight times in Mark. Sometimes it introduces a serious warning or prediction. Here it introduces Jesus' warning that whoever does not receive the kingdom of God like a child will never enter it. Jesus also used the words "I tell you." The words "Truly I tell you" are even more emphatic than "I tell you."

Here are some other ways to translate this:

I tell you the truth (NIV)

I can guarantee this truth (GW)

I solemnly assure you

I promise you that (CEV)

If you have another way in your language to emphasize an important statement that is totally reliable, consider using it here.

See how you translated this phrase in 3:28a or 9:41c. In some languages you may need to translate the phrase differently in different contexts. Do not translate in a way that implies that Jesus had not been telling the truth at other times.

10:15b

anyone who does not receive the kingdom of God like a little child will never enter it."

- anyone who will not accept the kingdom of God as a child does will not belong to it."
- no one will be included in the kingdom of God unless he welcomes God's rule in his life like a child does."
- if anyone will not let God rule him like a child lets his parents rule him, he will never enter the kingdom of God."

anyone who does not receive the kingdom of God like a little child will never enter it:

In this context, the word receive means "accept" or "submit to." A person must be willing to accept God's rule in his life and to be part of the community of people who accept his rule. That person must be humble and depend on God, like little children depend on their parents.

The word enter figuratively refers to belonging to God's kingdom. If a person is not willing for God to rule over him, God will not allow that person to belong to His kingdom. See also kingdom of God, Context 1, in the Glossary.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

...whoever does not accept God's ruling over him the way a child accepts it, he absolutely will not be included in God's kingdom.

...people who do not submit to God like children will not become his people in his Kingdom.

not...never: In some languages, two negatives such as this may be confusing. Here are some ways you might translate this phrase without using two negatives:

...God will accept into his kingdom only those people who will accept his rule as if they were children.

...no one will be included in the kingdom of God unless he welcomes God's rule in his life like a child does.

Mark 10:16

Section 10:13–16: Jesus blessed little children

Some people brought their children for Jesus to bless them. The disciples probably thought that Jesus was too important to bless children. So they prevented the people from bringing the children. But Jesus wanted to bless them. He allowed the children to come to him.

Jesus used the things that happened with these children to teach that God accepts people who are humble. The people whom God rules should be like little children: they should humbly accept God's rule in their lives.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus and Little Children (NET)

Some little children were brought to Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:13–15 and Luke 18:15–17.

10:16a

And He took the children in His arms,

- Then/And he put his arms around the children,
- After he said that, Jesus hugged each of the children.

And: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as And introduces what Jesus did after he finished speaking in 10:15. The CEV translates it as:

Then

Connect this verse to 10:15 in a way that is natural in your language.

He took the children in His arms: The expression took...in His arms indicates that Jesus put his arm or arms around the each of the children or gave them a hug.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Jesus put his arms around the children (GW)

Then he embraced them (NJB)

See how you translated the same verb in 9:36b.

10:16b

placed His hands on them, and blessed them.

- placed his hands on each of them and blessed them. (GNT)
- He put his hands on each of their heads in turn, and asked God to show them kindness.

The form of the Greek verbs used here indicates that Jesus did these things to each of the children in turn. He did not put his hands on all the children and bless them at the same time.

placed His hands on them: The expression placed His hands on them probably indicates that Jesus touched the head of each child in turn.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

placed his hands on each of them (GNT)

put his hands on each of their heads in turn

blessed them: The phrase blessed them here means that Jesus asked God to do good to the children.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

asked God to bless them

asked God to show kindness to them

In some languages it may be natural to use a direct quote here. For example:

said to God, "Bless this child."

See bless, Meaning 1, in the Glossary.

Mark 10:17

Section 10:17–31: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of God

A young man asked Jesus how he could obtain eternal life. Jesus gave an answer that was well known to Jews. He told the man to obey God's commands. The man said that he had been obeying God's commands since he was a child.

Jesus then told the young man that he still needed to do one thing (10:21). He needed to give away his riches and follow Jesus. But the young man did not follow Jesus' advice. The man was rich (10:22). He valued his riches too highly to give them up to follow Jesus.

Jesus used the young man as an example to explain that it is hard for rich people to devote themselves to God and his kingdom (10:23–25). He said that unless God makes it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter heaven (10:27).

Jesus promised that those who had left their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (10:29–31).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus taught that riches make it difficult to obtain eternal life

A Rich Young Man's Question (NCV)

The rich young man (NJB)

Riches hinder rather than help in seeking to enter the kingdom of God

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:16–30 and Luke 18:18–30.

10:17a

As Jesus started on His way,

- ¶ As Jesus started to leave, (NCV)
- ¶ After that, Jesus and his disciples were beginning a journey when

The events in the story in 10:17–31 happened sometime after the events in 10:13–16. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories. In some languages, it is natural to begin a story with a time word or phrase. If this is true in

your language, use an expression here that is not too specific. For example:

Then

After that

In other languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this story in a natural way in your language.

As Jesus started on His way: The expression As Jesus started on His way indicates that Jesus began a journey. Soon after he started, the events in 10:17b occurred.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

As Jesus started to leave (NCV)

He was beginning a journey when

Jesus: Here the Greek text is literally the pronoun “he” (as in the RSV). The pronoun “he” refers to Jesus. Since this is the beginning of a new section, it may be natural in your language to use the name Jesus here.

It is clear from 10:23 that Jesus' disciples were with him. In some languages it may be clearer to make this information explicit here at the beginning of the story. For example:

Jesus and his disciples

10:17b

a man ran up and knelt before Him.

- there was a man who ran to him. He knelt before him
- a man ran to him and knelt before him to show respect.

a man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a man is literally “one.” It refers to a man who is mentioned here for the first time in this story. Introduce him in a natural way in your language.

ran up: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as ran up is literally “ran.” It indicates that the man ran to Jesus. The BSB has supplied the word up to make the clause sound more natural in English.

knelt before Him: The expression knelt before Him means to kneel or bow down in front of someone to show respect. It often indicates also that a person wanted to make an earnest request.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

knelt before him to show humility

bowed low before him

A similar expression occurs in 5:22b and 5:33b.

10:17c

“Good Teacher,” he asked, “what must I do to inherit eternal life?”

- and asked, “Good/Righteous teacher, what shall I do to receive eternal life?”
- The man asked, “Sir/Teacher, you are a good/upright person. What deed should I do so that God will give me eternal life?”

Good Teacher: The phrase Good Teacher means “teacher who is morally good, upright, or holy.” It does not refer to a teacher who teaches well.

In some languages it may not be natural to use a description like “good” as part of a person’s title when you are addressing that person. If that is true in your language, you may want to put the word “good” in a different phrase. For example:

Sir teacher, you are a good person.

Teacher: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Teacher was a polite title for a Jewish religious leader. It was a title of respect for a Jewish man who had authority to teach the things about God. In some languages the appropriate way to address a religious teacher may be:

Sir Teacher

Sir

Master

Be careful not to use a term that can refer only to a school teacher. See how you translated this word in 4:38c or 9:17b.

he asked: The BSB places the words he asked in the middle of the man’s words. In Greek, he asked occurs before the man’s words. Put the words he asked in a place that is natural in your language.

what must I do to inherit eternal life?: This is a real question. The man was asking what religious duty or deed he should perform in order to receive eternal life.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

...what can I do to have eternal life? (CEV)

...what deed should I do so that I may live eternally?

to inherit: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as inherit means “acquire, obtain.” The man wanted to know what deed would cause God to give him eternal life in heaven.

Here is another way to translate this:

so that I may receive

In some languages, it may be necessary to say from whom the man expected to obtain eternal life. If that is true in your language, you may need to supply the information that it is God who gives that life. For example:

so that God will give me eternal life

eternal life: The word eternal refers to something that does not end. The phrase eternal life refers to life in heaven with God.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

unending life

life that never ends

In some languages, a literal translation of eternal life would wrongly mean that the man hoped to live forever without dying. If that is true in your language, it may be necessary to supply some implied information. For example:

unending life in heaven

to live forever with God after I die

In some languages, it may be best to translate life as a verb. For example:

to live eternally/forever

so that God will cause me to live forever in heaven

Mark 10:18

Section 10:17–31: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of God

A young man asked Jesus how he could obtain eternal life. Jesus gave an answer that was well known to Jews. He told the man to obey God's commands. The man said that he had been obeying God's commands since he was a child.

Jesus then told the young man that he still needed to do one thing (10:21). He needed to give away his riches and follow Jesus. But the young man did not follow Jesus' advice. The man was rich (10:22). He valued his riches too highly to give them up to follow Jesus.

Jesus used the young man as an example to explain that it is hard for rich people to devote themselves to God and his kingdom (10:23–25). He said that unless God makes it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter heaven (10:27).

Jesus promised that those who had left their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (10:29–31).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus taught that riches make it difficult to obtain eternal life

A Rich Young Man's Question (NCV)

The rich young man (NJB)

Riches hinder rather than help in seeking to enter the kingdom of God

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:16–30 and Luke 18:18–30.

10:18a

“Why do you call Me good?” Jesus replied.

- Jesus answered, “Why do you^(sing) say that I am a good person?
- Jesus replied, “Tell me what you^(sing) mean by calling me righteous/upright.

Why do you call Me good?: This is a rhetorical question. It is a mild rebuke. It probably indicates that Jesus wanted the man to think about what it meant to

say that Jesus was good. He wanted the man to think about who Jesus was.

There are at least two ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

What do you mean when you say that I am good?

What is your reason for saying that I am good?

- As a statement. For example:

You should consider what you mean when you say that I am good.

Use whichever form is most natural to express this rebuke in your language.

Jesus replied: The BSB places the words Jesus replied in the middle of Jesus' response. In Greek, Jesus replied comes before the rhetorical question. Put the words Jesus replied in a place that is natural in your language.

10:18b

“No one is good except God alone.

- Absolutely no one is good but God only.
- Only God is truly good/righteous.

No one is good except God alone: The expression No one is good except God alone means “God is the only one who is truly good.” Jesus was not saying here that he himself was sinful. He was encouraging the rich man to think about what he meant when he called Jesus “good.”

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

Absolutely no one is good but God only.

Only God is truly good. (NLT)

General Comment on 10:18a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of 10:18a and 10:18b. For example:

Jesus answered, ^{18b}“No one is good except God alone. ^{18a}So why do you call me good?”

Mark 10:19

Section 10:17–31: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of God

A young man asked Jesus how he could obtain eternal life. Jesus gave an answer that was well known to Jews. He told the man to obey God's commands. The man said that he had been obeying God's commands since he was a child.

Jesus then told the young man that he still needed to do one thing (10:21). He needed to give away his riches and follow Jesus. But the young man did not follow Jesus' advice. The man was rich (10:22). He valued his riches too highly to give them up to follow Jesus.

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The rich young man (NJB)

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There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:16–30 and Luke 18:18–30.

10:19a

You know the commandments:

- You^(sing) know the commands/laws of God:
- You^(sing) know what God commanded. He commanded:

the commandments: The phrase the commandments here refers to the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20) and more generally to the Law of Moses (the first five books of the Old Testament).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the commands/laws of God

what God commanded

10:19b

'Do not murder, do not commit adultery,

- 'Do not murder, do not commit adultery,
- 'You must not kill someone unlawfully. You must not be unfaithful to your spouse.

murder: The word murder refers to the deliberate, wrongful killing of a human being.

See how you translated this word in 7:21b.

commit adultery: The Greek word that the BSB translates as commit adultery refers to a specific type of sexual sin. It refers to sexual relations between a man and a woman, when at least one of them is married to another person.

See how you translated this expression in 10:11a–b.

10:19c

do not steal, do not bear false witness,

- do not steal, do not lie in court,
- You must not rob others. You must not tell lies about others.

steal: The word steal refers to taking something that belongs to someone else without permission.

bear false witness: The expression bear false witness refers to telling a lie in a law court. This command forbids anyone to tell a lie in order to help a guilty person to avoid punishment. It also forbids anyone to tell a lie in order to cause an innocent person to receive punishment. The expression can also refer to telling lies in any situation.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

testify falsely (NLT)

tell lies about others (CEV)

10:19d

do not cheat others, honor your father and mother.”

- do not cheat anyone, respect your father and your mother.”
- You must not get things dishonestly. You must honor your parents.”

cheat others: The phrase cheat others means “deceive others in order to obtain their possessions.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

defraud (NIV)

gain someone’s things deceitfully

get things dishonestly

honor your father and mother: The word honor means “respect” or “revere.” This expression includes obeying your parents when you are young and helping your parents when they are old. The GNT has:

respect your father and your mother

See how you translated this expression in 7:10a.

Mark 10:20

Section 10:17–31: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of God

A young man asked Jesus how he could obtain eternal life. Jesus gave an answer that was well known to Jews. He told the man to obey God’s commands. The man said that he had been obeying God’s commands since he was a child.

Jesus then told the young man that he still needed to do one thing (10:21). He needed to give away his riches and follow Jesus. But the young man did not follow Jesus’ advice. The man was rich (10:22). He valued his riches too highly to give them up to follow Jesus.

Jesus used the young man as an example to explain that it is hard for rich people to devote themselves to God and his kingdom (10:23–25). He said that unless God makes it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter heaven (10:27).

Jesus promised that those who had left their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (10:29–31).

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus taught that riches make it difficult to obtain eternal life

A Rich Young Man’s Question (NCV)

The rich young man (NJB)

Riches hinder rather than help in seeking to enter the kingdom of God

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:16–30 and Luke 18:18–30.

10:20

“Teacher,” he replied, “all these I have kept from my youth.”

- He said, “Teacher, ever since I was young I have obeyed all those commandments.”
- The man said, “Teacher, all of those laws/commands I have followed from childhood onward.”

Teacher: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Teacher is the same word as in 10:17c. It was a polite title for a Jewish religious leader.

he replied: The BSB places the phrase he replied in the middle of the man’s words. In Greek, these words occur at the beginning of 10:20. Put the words he replied in a place that is natural in your language.

all these: The word these refers to the commands in 10:19. It may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

all of these commands

This phrase is emphasized in the Greek text. If you have a natural way to emphasize this phrase, you may want to do so.

I have kept: In this context, the phrase have kept means “obeyed.” For example, the GNT says:

I have obeyed

from my youth: The expression from my youth means “from childhood onward.” The young man began to obey the commands when he was a young boy and continued to obey them to the present time. The GNT translates this as:

ever since I was young

Mark 10:21

Section 10:17–31: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of God

A young man asked Jesus how he could obtain eternal life. Jesus gave an answer that was well known to Jews. He told the man to obey God's commands. The man said that he had been obeying God's commands since he was a child.

Jesus then told the young man that he still needed to do one thing (10:21). He needed to give away his riches and follow Jesus. But the young man did not follow Jesus' advice. The man was rich (10:22). He valued his riches too highly to give them up to follow Jesus.

Jesus used the young man as an example to explain that it is hard for rich people to devote themselves to God and his kingdom (10:23–25). He said that unless God makes it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter heaven (10:27).

Jesus promised that those who had left their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (10:29–31).

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus taught that riches make it difficult to obtain eternal life

A Rich Young Man's Question (NCV)

The rich young man (NJB)

Riches hinder rather than help in seeking to enter the kingdom of God

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:16–30 and Luke 18:18–30.

10:21a

Jesus looked at him, loved him,

- Jesus looked straight at him with love (GNT)
- Jesus looked at him affectionately.

Jesus looked at him, loved him: Jesus looked at this man and felt love for him. The word loved indicates that Jesus felt strong affection and concern for the man. Use a natural expression in your language for this word.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Jesus looked straight at him with love (GNT)

Jesus felt genuine love for this man as he looked at him. (NLT96)

In some languages there may be an idiom to express this. For example, the REB says:

As Jesus looked at him, his heart warmed to him.

looked: The Greek word that the BSB translates as looked means “looked intently” or “fixed his gaze upon.” It indicates that Jesus was considering the man carefully. Use an expression with that meaning.

The verb does not mean “stare.” It does not imply anger or any bad feeling. If “look intently” implies anger or bad feeling in your culture, you should use a different expression.

10:21b

and said to him, “There is one thing you lack:

- and said, “You need only one thing. (GNT)
- He said, “There is one thing/deed you^(sing) still need to do.

There is one thing you lack: The phrase There is one thing you lack means “There is one more thing that you need to do.” This refers back to the young man's original question in 10:17c.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

You need only one thing. (GNT)

There is one deed you still need to do to inherit/ have eternal life.

The phrase one thing is emphasized in the Greek text. If you have a natural way to emphasize this phrase, you may want to do so. Here is an example:

There is only one thing you need to do.

10:21c

Go, sell everything you own and give to the poor,

- Go and sell all you have and give the money to the poor, (NLT96)
- Go,^(sing) sell everything you^(sing) own and give the money to poor people.

Go, sell: The word Go introduces the command sell. It implies that the man should return to his home or property so that he can sell it. The NCV says:

Go and sell

sell everything you own and give to the poor: These words imply that the man should sell everything he owned and give the money that he received to the poor. In some languages it may be necessary to make that explicit. For example:

sell everything you own and give the money/proceeds to poor people

the poor: The phrase the poor refers to people who have little money and few material possessions.

**10:21d
and you will have treasure in heaven.**

- and you^(sing) will have rewards in heaven.
- Then you^(sing) will receive true/spiritual riches in the place where God lives.

and: 10:21d is the result of 10:21c. If the man did as Jesus told him in 10:21c, he would have treasure in heaven.

Here are some other ways to translate this connection:

Then you will have...

If you do that, you will have...

you will have treasure in heaven: When a believer serves God, God gives him a reward. That reward is called here treasure in heaven. Your translation should not imply that God simply takes the same money that was given to the poor and puts it in heaven. One way to avoid that wrong meaning is to indicate that the reward is a result of giving to the poor. For example:

As a result, God will reward you with treasure in heaven.

treasure: The word treasure usually refers to valuable things such as money, jewels, and precious items. But in this context, it refers to true spiritual riches. It also implies that these riches are stored safely. The term you use should not only indicate money.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

what is truly valuable

true wealth/riches that are stored away

heaven: Here the word heaven refers to the place where God lives. This is also the place where believers will live with God after they die. See how you translated this word in 1:11a or 7:34a. See heaven, Meaning 2, in the Glossary.

**10:21e
Then come, follow Me.”**

- Then come to me and follow me.”
- After you^(sing) do that, come and be my disciple.”

Then: There is a textual issue in 10:21e. Some Greek manuscripts have a phrase that means “take up the cross.” (1) Some Greek manuscripts do not have this phrase. For example, the GNT says: “then come and follow me” (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NJB, ESV, NET, NASB, REB, GW, NLT, CEV, JBP, NCV). (2) Some later Greek manuscripts have the phrase “take up the cross.” For example, the KJV says: “and come, take up the cross, and follow me” (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). However, if the major language version in your area has this phrase, you can put it in a footnote. The word Then indicates that after the man sold his things and gave the money to the poor, then he was to follow Jesus.

follow Me: The expression follow Me is meant both literally and figuratively. It is a metaphor for learning from Jesus and being his disciple. Disciples usually followed their teachers wherever they went and lived with them. The Greek form indicates an ongoing action. Use a form that is natural in your language.

If people in your area will not understand the figurative language, you may want to use nonfigurative language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

learn from me

be learning from me to do God’s will

be my disciple

See how you translated this expression in 1:17a.

Mark 10:22

Section 10:17–31: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of God

A young man asked Jesus how he could obtain eternal life. Jesus gave an answer that was well known to Jews. He told the man to obey God's commands. The man said that he had been obeying God's commands since he was a child.

Jesus then told the young man that he still needed to do one thing (10:21). He needed to give away his riches and follow Jesus. But the young man did not follow Jesus' advice. The man was rich (10:22). He valued his riches too highly to give them up to follow Jesus.

Jesus used the young man as an example to explain that it is hard for rich people to devote themselves to God and his kingdom (10:23–25). He said that unless God makes it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter heaven (10:27).

Jesus promised that those who had left their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (10:29–31).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus taught that riches make it difficult to obtain eternal life

A Rich Young Man's Question (NCV)

The rich young man (NJB)

Riches hinder rather than help in seeking to enter the kingdom of God

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:16–30 and Luke 18:18–30.

10:22a

But the man was saddened by these words

- But at this command, the man's face/expression showed that he had become sad.
- When the man heard that, he looked disappointed.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But indicates a contrast. The contrast is between what Jesus told the man to do and what the man did.

Here is another way to translate this:

However

Other translations leave the contrast implicit. Express this contrast in a natural way in your language.

the man was saddened: The phrase the man was saddened means that the man was disappointed at what Jesus said. Use an expression with that meaning. Also, this is a passive clause. If a passive clause is not natural in your language here, you may use an active clause.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

gloom spread over his face (GNT)

the man immediately went from happy to sad

by these words: The phrase by these words indicates that the man was responding to what Jesus said.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

at this statement (NET)

When he heard this (NRSV)

by Jesus' response

10:22b–c

and went away in sorrow, because he had great wealth.

- He felt sorrow as he went away, because he was a very wealthy man.
- He did not want to sell all of the many things he owned, so he left very unhappy.

10:22b

and went away in sorrow: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as went away in sorrow means that as the man left Jesus, he felt sad. He felt sorrowful or disappointed because Jesus had not told him that he would easily obtain eternal life. He was not willing to sell all his possessions.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

and he went away sorrowful (RSV)

He went away sad (NIV)

and he left unhappily

10:22c

because he had great wealth: The conjunction *because* introduces the reason that the man went away sad. But there is some implied information here. The man did not want to sell all he had because he loved his possessions. He wanted to keep them more than he wanted to receive eternal life with God. In some languages it may be necessary to suggest this or make some of this explicit. For example:

because he did not want to give away his great wealth

because it was hard for him to think of selling his many valuable possessions

he had great wealth: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as great wealth is literally “many possessions” (as in the NRSV). The Greek word meaning “possessions” is general and includes land, houses, money, jewels, and other goods.

Here are some other ways to translate he had great wealth:

he had many possessions (NRSV)

he was rich (NCV)

he owned many things

General Comment on 10:22b–c

In these verses, 10:22c expresses the reason for the result in 10:22b. In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of these clauses. For example:

^{22c}he had great wealth, ^{22b}that is why he went away in sorrow.

^{22c}he had great wealth, ^{22b}so he went away in sorrow.

Mark 10:23**Section 10:17–31: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of God**

A young man asked Jesus how he could obtain eternal life. Jesus gave an answer that was well known to Jews. He told the man to obey God’s commands. The man said that he had been obeying God’s commands since he was a child.

Jesus then told the young man that he still needed to do one thing (10:21). He needed to give away his riches and follow Jesus. But the young man did not follow Jesus’ advice. The man was rich (10:22). He valued his riches too highly to give them up to follow Jesus.

Jesus used the young man as an example to explain that it is hard for rich people to devote themselves to God and his kingdom (10:23–25). He said that unless God makes it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter heaven (10:27).

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

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A Rich Young Man’s Question (NCV)

The rich young man (NJB)

Riches hinder rather than help in seeking to enter the kingdom of God

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:16–30 and Luke 18:18–30.

Paragraph 10:23–27

The events in 10:23–31 probably happened immediately after the events in 10:17–22. In some languages, it is natural to begin this part of the story with a time word or phrase. For example, the NET has “Then.”

In other languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this part of the story in a natural way in your language.

10:23a

Then Jesus looked around and said to His disciples,

- ¶ Then Jesus looked around at his disciples and said to them,

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *Then* indicates that the conversation in 10:23–27 began immediately after the events in 10:20–22. In some languages, it is natural to begin this part of the story with a time word or phrase like *Then*.

In other languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this part of the story in a natural way in your language.

Jesus looked around: The verb phrase looked around probably indicates that Jesus looked at each of the disciples. He probably did this to make sure that all of them were ready to listen to him. The REB says:

Jesus looked round at his disciples

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means “learners” who are in a relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

students/learners

apprentices

followers

See how you translated this word at 2:15b or 10:10b. See also disciple in the Glossary.

10:23b

“How hard it is for the rich to enter the kingdom of God!”

- “Rich people will enter the kingdom of God only with great difficulty!”
- “It is very hard/difficult for people who have many possessions to submit to God’s rule/reign!”
- “It is very difficult for people who have many possessions to belong to God’s people and be under his rule.”

How hard it is for the rich to enter the kingdom of God!: This expression is an exclamation.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

It is very hard/difficult for rich people to enter the kingdom of God!

Rich people will enter the kingdom of heaven only with great difficulty!

enter the kingdom of God: The phrase kingdom of God refers to God’s activity of ruling and caring for

his people as their king. It does not refer to a land or country that he rules over. It refers to the relationship that he has with his people. He leads, protects, and cares for them. They obey, trust, and submit to him as their king.

The phrase enter the kingdom of God refers to becoming one of the people of God and beginning to live under his rule.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

be included in the kingdom of God

submit to God’s rule/reign

belong to God’s people and be under His rule

The expression enter the kingdom of God does not just mean “go to heaven” or “enter heaven” after one dies. It involves belonging/submitting to God in this life. See also kingdom of God, Context 1, in the Glossary.

Mark 10:24

Section 10:17–31: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of God

A young man asked Jesus how he could obtain eternal life. Jesus gave an answer that was well known to Jews. He told the man to obey God’s commands. The man said that he had been obeying God’s commands since he was a child.

Jesus then told the young man that he still needed to do one thing (10:21). He needed to give away his riches and follow Jesus. But the young man did not follow Jesus’ advice. The man was rich (10:22). He valued his riches too highly to give them up to follow Jesus.

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Paragraph 10:23–27

The events in 10:23–31 probably happened immediately after the events in 10:17–22. In some languages, it is natural to begin this part of the story with a time word or phrase. For example, the NET has “Then.”

In other languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this part of the story in a natural way in your language.

10:24a

And the disciples were amazed at His words.

- The disciples were surprised by his words.
- The followers were astonished at what he said.
- When the disciples heard this, they were amazed.

amazed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as amazed means “astonished” or “surprised.”

Jews of that time thought that riches were a blessing from God. So the disciples were surprised that Jesus said that it was hard for a rich person to enter God's kingdom. If people in your area will not understand the reason that the disciples were amazed, you may want to include a footnote. Here is an example:

The Jewish people of that time thought that riches showed that God favored a person. Therefore, they thought that a rich person would easily get into heaven. But Jesus taught that riches often hindered a person's relationship with God because he relied on his riches and not on God.

at His words: The phrase at His words refers to what Jesus said in 10:23b. It may be more natural in your language to use a verb to translate that meaning. For example:

The disciples were amazed at what he said.

When the disciples heard that, they were amazed.

10:24b

But Jesus said to them again,

- But Jesus told them again,
- But Jesus repeated the teaching,

But: The disciples were amazed at this teaching and may have had difficulty accepting it. In contrast, Jesus repeated the teaching and applied it generally to all people.

Jesus said to them again: The word again indicates here that Jesus said something similar in 10:23b. But the teaching here is more general than in 10:23b. Jesus emphasized the teaching by repeating it. Use an expression with that meaning. For example:

Jesus told them again (CEV)

Jesus reiterated

Jesus insisted (REB)

10:24c

“Children, how hard it is to enter the kingdom of God!

- “Children, people will enter the kingdom of God only with great difficulty!
- “Young men, it is very difficult for anyone to submit to God's rule/reign!

Children: Jesus addressed the disciples with the term Children. This term showed that Jesus cared about his disciples. Jesus may also have used this term to imply that he was like a father whose children failed to understand his teaching. Use an expression with that meaning. If a literal translation might be unnatural or misunderstood, you may need to say something like:

My children (GNT)

Dear children (NLT)

You who are like my children

My dear young men

how hard it is to enter the kingdom of God!: There is a textual issue in this verse. In some later Greek manuscripts, this clause includes the words “for those who trust in riches.” These additional words make 10:24c like 10:23b. (1) Some Greek manuscripts do not have

the words “those who trust in riches.” For example, the GNT says: “My children, how hard it is to enter the Kingdom of God!” (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NLT, CEV, GW, JBP, NET, REB, NCV, ESV). (2) Other Greek manuscripts have “those who trust in riches.” For example, the KJV says: “Children, how hard is it for them that trust in riches to enter into the kingdom of God!” (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). But if the major language version in your area follows option (2), you may want to put the added words in a footnote. For example: Some later Greek manuscripts add the words “those who trust in riches.” The earlier Greek manuscripts do not have these words. This clause has the same meaning as 10:23b, except that it does not include the words “for the rich.”

Mark 10:25

Section 10:17–31: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of God

A young man asked Jesus how he could obtain eternal life. Jesus gave an answer that was well known to Jews. He told the man to obey God’s commands. The man said that he had been obeying God’s commands since he was a child.

Jesus then told the young man that he still needed to do one thing (10:21). He needed to give away his riches and follow Jesus. But the young man did not follow Jesus’ advice. The man was rich (10:22). He valued his riches too highly to give them up to follow Jesus.

Jesus used the young man as an example to explain that it is hard for rich people to devote themselves to God and his kingdom (10:23–25). He said that unless God makes it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter heaven (10:27).

Jesus promised that those who had left their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (10:29–31).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus taught that riches make it difficult to obtain eternal life

A Rich Young Man’s Question (NCV)

The rich young man (NJB)

Riches hinder rather than help in seeking to enter the kingdom of God

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:16–30 and Luke 18:18–30.

Paragraph 10:23–27

The events in 10:23–31 probably happened immediately after the events in 10:17–22. In some languages, it is natural to begin this part of the story with a time word or phrase. For example, the NET has “Then.”

In other languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this part of the story in a natural way in your language.

10:25a

It is easier for a camel to pass through the eye of a needle

- A camel can go through the hole in a needle more easily
- It is less hard/difficult for a very large animal to go/pass through a tiny hole

10:25b

than for a rich man to enter the kingdom of God.”

- than a rich person can enter God’s kingdom.”
- than for people who have many possessions to submit to God’s rule/reign!”

10:25a–b

It is easier for a camel to pass through the eye of a needle than for a rich man to enter the kingdom of God: This is a comparison that illustrates what Jesus had just said in 10:23b–24c. Jesus compared a difficult thing (a rich man entering the kingdom of God) to an impossible thing (a camel passing through the eye of a needle). This comparison shows that it is also impossible for a rich man to enter the kingdom of God.

It may be more natural in your language to translate the comparison in another way. For example:

It is more difficult for a rich man to go into the kingdom of God than for a camel to pass through the eye of a needle.

However difficult it is for a camel to pass through the eye of a needle, it is even more difficult for a rich man to enter the kingdom of God.

a camel: The camel is a large, four-legged animal. A camel weighs about 600 kilograms (1300 pounds). It is two meters (6.5 feet) tall at the shoulder. It carries people and cargo. It was one of the largest animals common in Israel.

If camels are not known in your area, here are some ways to translate it:

- Write the word camel according to the sounds of your language and add a descriptive phrase. For example:

a large animal called a camel

- Borrow the word that means camel from another language. If this word is not well known, you may want to add a descriptive phrase.
- Use only a descriptive phrase instead of the word camel. For example:

a large animal

You may want to include a picture of a camel in your translation. You may also want to include a footnote to give more information. For example:

Literally “a camel.” A camel is a large four-legged animal that weighs about 600 kilograms and is about two meters tall at the shoulder. It was one of the largest animals in Israel.

the eye of a needle: The phrase the eye of a needle refers to the small hole in a sewing needle. The thread passes through this hole. Jesus used this phrase as an example of a very small hole. Use an expression for this that is natural in your language. For example:

the hole of a needle

a sewing needle hole

Mark 10:26

Section 10:17–31: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of God

A young man asked Jesus how he could obtain eternal life. Jesus gave an answer that was well known to Jews. He told the man to obey God’s commands. The man said that he had been obeying God’s commands since he was a child.

Jesus then told the young man that he still needed to do one thing (10:21). He needed to give away his riches and follow Jesus. But the young man did not follow Jesus’ advice. The man was rich (10:22). He valued his riches too highly to give them up to follow Jesus.

Jesus used the young man as an example to explain that it is hard for rich people to devote themselves to

God and his kingdom (10:23–25). He said that unless God makes it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter heaven (10:27).

Jesus promised that those who had left their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (10:29–31).

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The rich young man (NJB)

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There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:16–30 and Luke 18:18–30.

Paragraph 10:23–27

The events in 10:23–31 probably happened immediately after the events in 10:17–22. In some languages, it is natural to begin this part of the story with a time word or phrase. For example, the NET has “Then.”

In other languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this part of the story in a natural way in your language.

10:26a

They were even more astonished

- Then the disciples were even more surprised than before,
- When his followers heard this, they were even more astonished.

They were even more astonished: The phrase even more astonished means “even more surprised than they had been before.” This refers back to the fact that the disciples were amazed in 10:24a.

The clause They were even more astonished expresses the result of what Jesus said in the previous sentence. In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit the reason for this result. For example:

When they heard this, the disciples were more astonished than ever.

10:26b

and said to one another, “Who then can be saved?”

- and said to one another, “In that case, who can possibly be saved?”
- They said to each other, “If it is like that, then we^(excl) do not know how God will rescue any people from their sins so that they can enter his kingdom!”

said to one another: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have to one another. The disciples spoke aloud to each other. For example, the NIV says:

said to each other (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NRSV, GW, CEV, JBP, NET, REB, NCV, KJV)

1. Other Greek manuscripts have to him. The disciples spoke to Jesus. For example, the RSV says:

said to him (RSV, NASB, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). But if the major language version follows option (2), you may want to follow that.

Who then can be saved?: This is probably a rhetorical question. It is an emphatic way of saying “If that is true, we do not understand how anyone can be saved!” It expresses the disciples’ surprise at what Jesus said in 10:25. It does not express a strong belief that God will not save anyone.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

How can anyone ever be saved? (CEV)

Can it be that anyone will be saved?

- As a statement. For example:

Then we do not know how anyone can possibly be saved!

then: In this context, the Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as then means “in that case” or “if that is so/true.”

be saved: The verb be saved is passive. If it is more natural in your language to use an active verb and supply a subject, you may say:

Who then will God save?

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as be saved means “to be rescued or preserved from harm.” In this context it refers to being allowed to enter the kingdom of God (10:23–25).

In some languages, it may be necessary to make explicit what the person was saved from. For example:

saved from being shut out of God’s kingdom

rescued from judgment and allowed to enter God’s kingdom

Mark 10:27

Section 10:17–31: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of God

A young man asked Jesus how he could obtain eternal life. Jesus gave an answer that was well known to Jews. He told the man to obey God’s commands. The man said that he had been obeying God’s commands since he was a child.

Jesus then told the young man that he still needed to do one thing (10:21). He needed to give away his riches and follow Jesus. But the young man did not follow Jesus’ advice. The man was rich (10:22). He valued his riches too highly to give them up to follow Jesus.

Jesus used the young man as an example to explain that it is hard for rich people to devote themselves to God and his kingdom (10:23–25). He said that unless God makes it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter heaven (10:27).

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There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:16–30 and Luke 18:18–30.

Paragraph 10:23–27

The events in 10:23–31 probably happened immediately after the events in 10:17–22. In some languages, it is natural to begin this part of the story with a time word or phrase. For example, the NET has “Then.”

In other languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this part of the story in a natural way in your language.

10:27a

Jesus looked at them and said,

- Looking at them, Jesus said, (NASB)
- Jesus looked sincerely/earnestly at them and said,

Jesus looked at them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as looked at means “look intently at” or “fix one’s gaze upon.” This is the same word as in 10:21a. This action adds emphasis or seriousness to the words that follow. Translate in a way that indicates that the following words (10:27b–c) are serious.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Jesus looked straight at them (GNT)

Jesus looked at them intently. (NLT)

The verb looked does not imply anger or any bad emotion. If “look intently” implies anger or a bad emotion in your culture, you should use a different expression that implies seriousness.

10:27b

“With man this is impossible, but not with God.

- “With/For mankind/humans, that deed is impossible, but not with/for God.
- “People are not able to rescue themselves and enter his kingdom, but God is able to rescue them so that they can enter there.

10:27c

For all things are possible with God.”

- With/For God, all things are possible!”
- God is able to do all things!”

10:27b–c

With man this is impossible, but not with God. For all things are possible with God: In this context the clause With man this is impossible means “human beings cannot do this,” that is, “human beings cannot save themselves.” The clause but not with God means “it is not impossible for God to do this,” that is, “God is able to save them.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

This is something people cannot do, but God can. God can do all things. (NCV)

This is impossible for human beings but not for God; everything is possible for God. (GNT)

It’s impossible for people [to save themselves], but it’s not impossible for God to save them. Everything is possible for God. (GW)

this: The word this refers to the act of saving people from being excluded from the kingdom of God, as in 10:26b. If this meaning will not be clear to people in your area, you may translate this in a similar way as you translated “saved” in 10:26b. For example:

For human beings, saving themselves is impossible.

As for people, they are not able to rescue themselves from judgment so that they can enter the kingdom of God.

all things: In this context the phrase all things refers to any deed that God approves of. God can do anything that he desires to do, including saving people.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

all deeds

everything (GNT)

Mark 10:28

Section 10:17–31: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of God

A young man asked Jesus how he could obtain eternal life. Jesus gave an answer that was well known to Jews. He told the man to obey God’s commands. The

man said that he had been obeying God's commands since he was a child.

Jesus then told the young man that he still needed to do one thing (10:21). He needed to give away his riches and follow Jesus. But the young man did not follow Jesus' advice. The man was rich (10:22). He valued his riches too highly to give them up to follow Jesus.

Jesus used the young man as an example to explain that it is hard for rich people to devote themselves to God and his kingdom (10:23–25). He said that unless God makes it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter heaven (10:27).

Jesus promised that those who had left their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (10:29–31).

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

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A Rich Young Man's Question (NCV)

The rich young man (NJB)

Riches hinder rather than help in seeking to enter the kingdom of God

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:16–30 and Luke 18:18–30.

Paragraph 10:28–31

The rich young man was not willing to sell all his possessions and give the money to the poor in order to follow Jesus (10:22). But the disciples had left all their possessions and family to follow Jesus. Jesus told them that God would indeed reward them for this (10:29–31).

10:28

Peter began to say to Him, "Look, we have left everything and followed You."

- ¶ Peter said to him, "Look, we^(excl) have left everything to follow you.^(sing)"
- ¶ Peter said, "What about us?^(excl) We^(excl) have left everything to follow you.^(sing)"

- ¶ Then Peter said to him, "Indeed, we^(excl) have abandoned all that we^(excl) owned to follow you^(sing) as your disciples."

Peter began to say to Him: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as Peter began to say to Him indicates that Peter started a conversation with Jesus. Many English versions simply translate the Greek phrase with a verb that means "said" (as in the NIV).

Look, we have left everything and followed You: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Look indicates that Peter wanted Jesus to especially notice and listen to his statement. This word can be difficult to translate in a natural way in English, so some English versions do not translate it. For example, the NIV has:

We have left everything to follow you!

Also, the word we is emphasized in Greek. If there is a natural way in your language to emphasize the word we, you may want to do so. For example:

Look, as for us, we have left everything and followed you.

What about us? We have left everything to follow you. (REB)

have left everything: The Greek word that the BSB translates as have left means "left behind" or "abandoned." This word indicates that the disciples thought that following Jesus was more important than keeping their possessions. Whether they gave away their possessions or just left them with relatives is not known.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

abandoned everything we owned

put aside all that we owned

and followed You: The Greek word that the BSB translates as and introduces the purpose for which the disciples left everything. They left everything in order to follow Jesus. Some English versions use a word like "to" to indicate that following Jesus was the purpose for which the disciples left everything. Connect the clauses in a natural way in your language.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

to follow you (NIV)

The expression followed You is meant both literally and figuratively. The disciples did literally follow Jesus wherever he went. They also figuratively “followed him” in the sense that they learned from him and were his disciples. If people in your area will not understand the figurative language, you may want to use nonfigurative language. For example:

and followed you as your disciples

and followed you and learned from you

See how you translated this expression in 1:17a or 10:21e.

Mark 10:29

Section 10:17–31: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of God

A young man asked Jesus how he could obtain eternal life. Jesus gave an answer that was well known to Jews. He told the man to obey God’s commands. The man said that he had been obeying God’s commands since he was a child.

Jesus then told the young man that he still needed to do one thing (10:21). He needed to give away his riches and follow Jesus. But the young man did not follow Jesus’ advice. The man was rich (10:22). He valued his riches too highly to give them up to follow Jesus.

Jesus used the young man as an example to explain that it is hard for rich people to devote themselves to God and his kingdom (10:23–25). He said that unless God makes it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter heaven (10:27).

Jesus promised that those who had left their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (10:29–31).

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The rich young man (NJB)

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There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:16–30 and Luke 18:18–30.

Paragraph 10:28–31

The rich young man was not willing to sell all his possessions and give the money to the poor in order to follow Jesus (10:22). But the disciples had left all their possessions and family to follow Jesus. Jesus told them that God would indeed reward them for this (10:29–31).

10:29a

“Truly I tell you,” Jesus replied,

- Jesus replied, “Truly, I tell you,^(plur)
- Jesus said, “I assure you^(plur) that
- Jesus answered, “Listen, because this is important/true.

Truly I tell you: Jesus used the phrase Truly I tell you to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. It indicates that the statement was important and totally reliable, and that people should listen carefully to it. Jesus used this phrase eight times in Mark. Sometimes it introduces a serious warning or prediction. Here it introduces Jesus’ promise that his disciples would receive a great reward for leaving things to follow him.

In some languages you may need to translate the phrase differently in different contexts. Do not translate in a way that implies that Jesus had not been telling the truth at other times.

Here are some ways that English versions have translated the phrase in this context:

I tell you the truth (NIV)

I can guarantee this truth (GW)

I assure you (NLT)

See how you translated this phrase in 3:28a or 10:15a.

Jesus replied: The BSB places the words Jesus replied after the words “Truly I tell you.” In Greek, these words occur at the beginning of 10:29. Place the words Jesus replied where it is natural in your language.

10:29b–30a

no one who has left home or brothers or sisters... will fail to receive a hundredfold: These verse parts have two negatives:

1. no one
2. will fail to receive

These two negatives are an emphatic way to say, “anyone...will certainly receive.” For example:

anyone who has left home or brothers or sisters...
will certainly receive a hundredfold...

Several English versions have translated it in this way (GNT, NLT, GW, CEV, NCV).

10:29b

“no one who has left home or brothers or sisters or mother or father or children or fields

- nobody leaves home or brothers or sisters or mother or father or children or property (JBP)
- anyone who has left his home or his brothers or his sisters or his mother or his father or his children or his land
- If anyone leaves his house or his land, his siblings, his parents or his children

no one who has left home or brothers or sisters or mother or father or children or fields: There is a textual issue here. It concerns the word “wife.” (1) Some Greek manuscripts do not include this word. For example, the NCV says: “houses brothers, sisters, mother, father, children, or farms” (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, JBP, REB, NCV). (2) Other Greek manuscripts include the words “and wife” after “father.” For example, the KJV says: “house, or brethren, or sisters, or father, or mother, or wife, or children, or lands” (KJV) It is strongly recommended that you follow option (1) and not include the word “wife” in your translation here. The verb left means “left behind” or “abandoned.” This is the same word as in 10:28. Jesus included family, as well as possessions, in the list of things that someone might leave behind to serve God. In this context, leaving family members probably implies being away from them for a long period of time.

brothers or sisters: The words brothers and sisters refers generally to all siblings: older and younger, male and female. Use the words which include all these siblings.

fields: The word fields usually refers to land where people grow food. But this word can also refer to land in general. Here this word probably refers to any land which someone owns.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

lands (RSV)

family/clan-land

10:29c

for My sake and for the gospel

- for my sake and the gospel’s sake
- for me and the gospel
- because of me and the good news,

for My sake and for the gospel: The phrase for My sake and for the gospel means “in order to serve me and the cause of my gospel.” This person leaves home and family in order to serve Jesus and tell more people about his gospel.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

for my sake and the gospel’s (JBP)

because of me and the Good News (GW)

for me and for the good news (CEV)

gospel: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gospel means “good news” (as in the GNT). In Mark, this word refers to the good news about Jesus Christ and the kingdom of God.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

good/sweet news

good news about Jesus Christ

good news from God

message/report that causes joy

Be sure that the term you choose does not refer only to a news report or to a story that is not true.

See how you translated this word in Mark 1:1.

Mark 10:30

Section 10:17–31: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of God

A young man asked Jesus how he could obtain eternal life. Jesus gave an answer that was well known to Jews. He told the man to obey God’s commands. The man said that he had been obeying God’s commands since he was a child.

Jesus then told the young man that he still needed to do one thing (10:21). He needed to give away his riches and follow Jesus. But the young man did not follow Jesus' advice. The man was rich (10:22). He valued his riches too highly to give them up to follow Jesus.

Jesus used the young man as an example to explain that it is hard for rich people to devote themselves to God and his kingdom (10:23–25). He said that unless God makes it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter heaven (10:27).

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The rich young man was not willing to sell all his possessions and give the money to the poor in order to follow Jesus (10:22). But the disciples had left all their possessions and family to follow Jesus. Jesus told them that God would indeed reward them for this (10:29–31).

10:30a

will fail to receive a hundredfold in the present age

- without getting back a hundred times over, now in this present life.
- will certainly receive a hundred times as much here in this life.
- he will indeed receive in this life much, much more than the value of what he left.

will fail to receive: See the note on 10:29b–30a for translation suggestions.

a hundredfold: The phrase a hundredfold represents in general the great reward that God will give those who leave their family and possessions to serve him. It does not indicate that for each item left behind, the believer will receive exactly one hundred of that same item.

If people in your area will understand the words a hundredfold in only a literal way, you may want to:

- Include some implied information. For example:

one hundred times more than the worth of what he left behind

- Include a footnote. For example:

The phrase “a hundredfold” represents in general the great reward God will give those who serve him in this way.

in the present age: The phrase in the present age refers to the present time. People will receive rewards while they are still living on this earth.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

now in this time (RSV)

here in this life (GW)

10:30b–c

The BSB has placed dashes around 10:30b–c. These verse parts list some examples of things that people who leave their family and possessions will receive. In your translation, it may not be necessary to use dashes. Indicate in a way that is natural in your language that this is a list of examples.

10:30b

houses and brothers and sisters and mothers and children and fields,

- He will receive homes and brothers and sisters, mothers and children and land,
- For example, they will receive more houses, siblings, mothers, children, and lands/fields.

houses and brothers and sisters and mothers and children and fields:

This list refers to examples of the rewards. This list does not indicate that if someone had one house, he will now receive a hundred houses.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

He will receive more houses and siblings and mothers, and children and fields

for example: more houses, brothers, sisters, mothers, children, and fields

10:30c

along with persecutions—

- though he will also be persecuted,
- Along with that, people will try to harm them because they follow me.

along with persecutions: In this context the phrase along with persecutions indicates that along with rewards, a person who follows Jesus will also experience persecutions.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and with them, persecutions (NIV)

People will also make them suffer for being my disciples.

though they will also be mistreated (CEV)

persecutions: The word persecutions refers to actions that harass, harm, or oppress people. This word comes from the verb that means “deliberately harm someone” or “do evil to someone.” In this context it indicates that people will do evil to the followers of Jesus because of their commitment to him.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

harassments

sufferings that people cause them because they are faithful to me

but people will persecute/oppress them

See how you translated this word in 4:17c.

10:30d

and in the age to come, eternal life.

- and in the next world, he will receive eternal life.
- Finally, they will live forever in the world to come.

and in the age to come, eternal life: This is the final part of a long sentence. In some languages it may be best to translate it as a separate sentence:

In the age to come he will also receive eternal life.

in the age to come: The phrase in the age to come refers to the time after a person has finished living on earth and is living in heaven.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

in the next world (JBP)

in the world to come (NLT)

in the future

eternal life: The word eternal refers to something that does not end. The phrase eternal life refers to life with God that lasts forever.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

unending life

life that never ends

See how you translated this phrase in 10:17c.

General Comments on 10:29–30

In these verses Jesus spoke in general about the people who left home and family for him. Peter and the other disciples were among those people whom Jesus was talking about. So in some languages it may be more natural to use the word “you.” For example:

Jesus said to the disciples, “Truly I tell you^(plur), none of you^(plur) who have left home, brothers, parents, children, or fields for the sake of the kingdom of God will fail to receive many times as much in this age...and in the age to come you^(plur) will receive eternal life.”

In some languages it may be more natural to use more than one sentence. For example:

Jesus said to the disciples, “Truly I tell you^(plur), some of you^(plur) have left your homes or fields. Some have left brothers, parents, or children. Anyone who has done this for the sake of the kingdom of God will certainly receive many times as much in this age. You will receive many more homes and fields and many more brothers, sisters, mothers, and children. Then in the age to come you^(plur) will receive eternal life.”

Mark 10:31

Section 10:17–31: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of God

A young man asked Jesus how he could obtain eternal life. Jesus gave an answer that was well known to Jews. He told the man to obey God's commands. The man said that he had been obeying God's commands since he was a child.

Jesus then told the young man that he still needed to do one thing (10:21). He needed to give away his riches and follow Jesus. But the young man did not follow Jesus' advice. The man was rich (10:22). He valued his riches too highly to give them up to follow Jesus.

Jesus used the young man as an example to explain that it is hard for rich people to devote themselves to God and his kingdom (10:23–25). He said that unless God makes it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter heaven (10:27).

Jesus promised that those who had left their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (10:29–31).

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

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Riches hinder rather than help in seeking to enter the kingdom of God

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 19:16–30 and Luke 18:18–30.

Paragraph 10:28–31

The rich young man was not willing to sell all his possessions and give the money to the poor in order to follow Jesus (10:22). But the disciples had left all their possessions and family to follow Jesus. Jesus told them that God would indeed reward them for this (10:29–31).

10:31a

But many who are first will be last,

- But many who are first now will be last then,

- But many people who are high/great now will be made low/humble then,

10:31b

and the last will be first.”

- and many who are last now will then be first.”
- and many people who are low/humble now will then become high/great.”

10:31

But many who are first will be last: Many people who are rich or famous or powerful will not use those blessings for God's kingdom in the present age. Therefore, they will receive little or no reward (10:30a) in eternity. They will have a position of low status in eternity. That is how many who are first will be last.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

many who are now first will be last (GNT)

many who are high/great now will become low/humble

Many who have the highest place now will have the lowest place in the future. (NCV)

and the last will be first: Some words from the previous clause are implied but not repeated here. The complete clause would be:

Many people who are now last will be first in eternity.

Many people who have little earthly riches or fame or power use the little they have for God's kingdom in the present age. Therefore they will have great reward (10:30a) and a position of high status in heaven. This is how many who are last will be first.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

...many who are now last will be first. (GNT)

...many who are low/humble now will become high/great.

...many who have the lowest place now will have the highest place in the future. (NCV)

Mark 10:32

Section 10:32–34: Jesus predicted his death a third time

Jesus told his disciples in 8:31 and 9:31 that people would kill him and that he would rise from the dead after three days. In 10:32–34, Jesus again told the disciples that these things would happen to him. This time he gave more details about how it would happen.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

For the Third Time Jesus Foretells That He Will Die and Come Back to Life (GW)

Jesus continues his journey toward suffering and death in Jerusalem

Refer to your section title for 9:30–32. If you used a phrase that means “the second time” there, you should use a phrase that means “the third time” here.

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 20:17–19 and Luke 18:31–34.

10:32a

As they were going up the road to Jerusalem, Jesus was walking ahead of them.

- ¶ As they were going to Jerusalem, Jesus led the way.
- ¶ Jesus and his disciples continued on the road going up to Jerusalem. Jesus was walking ahead of them.
- ¶ Jesus preceded his followers on the road, and they continued going uphill toward Jerusalem.

The events in this section happened sometime after the event in the preceding section. At the beginning of that section in 10:17, Jesus started on his journey. The events in this section happened while he was on the journey. Indicate this in a natural way in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

And they were on the road (RSV)

They were now on the way up to Jerusalem (NLT)

As Jesus and the people with him were on the road to Jerusalem (NCV)

As they were going up the road to Jerusalem: Jesus and his disciples had already begun to travel toward Jerusalem (see 10:17 and 10:23). It may be natural in your language to indicate this in some way. For example:

As they continued going up the road to Jerusalem

they: The pronoun they refers to Jesus’ disciples. You may need to make this explicit in your translation. Since Jesus was with them, some versions include Jesus along with the disciples as those referred to as they. For example, the GNT says:

Jesus and his disciples

going up the road to Jerusalem: When the writers of the Bible said that people were going to Jerusalem, they usually said that they were going up to Jerusalem. This is because the city of Jerusalem was higher than most parts of the land of Israel. It was located in the mountains at an altitude of about 800 meters above sea level.

In some languages, it is natural to speak of going up or down when traveling on a road. In other languages, this may not be natural, or it may not be understood. If that is true in your language, you may use a more general expression. For example:

were going on the road to Jerusalem

Jerusalem: Jerusalem was the most important city to the Jewish people. The temple where they worshiped God was there. The high priest and many other religious, government, and military leaders lived there. In some languages you may want to include a footnote with some of this information.

See how you translated this city name in 1:5a.

Jesus was walking ahead of them: The phrase Jesus was walking ahead of them means that Jesus was walking first along the road, and the others were behind him.

10:32b

The disciples were amazed,

- His disciples were amazed,
- The followers were surprised that he was going there,

10:32c

but those who followed were afraid.

- and the others who followed them were fearful about it.
- and the other people who were following them felt frightened/apprehensive about what would happen.

10:32b–c

The disciples were amazed, but those who followed were afraid: The phrases The disciples and those who followed refer to two different groups of people. There is a textual issue here. As a result, English versions interpret the relationship between the phrases the disciples and those who followed in either of two ways: (1) The phrases refer to two different groups of people. For example, the GW says: “His disciples were shocked.... The others who followed were afraid.” (BSB, NIV, GW, GNT, NASB, NJB, RSV, REB, NET, NLT, CEV, NCV, ESV). (2) The phrases both refer to the same group of people. For example, the KJV says: “they were amazed, and as they followed, they were afraid” (KJV). Most English versions follow the Greek manuscripts on which interpretation (1) is based. It is recommended that you follow option (1), as most English versions do. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this more explicit than the BSB does. For example, the GW says:

His disciples were shocked.... The others who followed were afraid.

disciples: The word disciples here refers to the twelve men whom Jesus chose as apostles in 3:14–18. See how you translated this word at 2:15b. See also disciple in the Glossary.

amazed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as amazed means “astonished” or “very surprised.” Apparently the disciples were amazed that Jesus was going to a place where there might be danger to him. In some languages it may be necessary to say why they were amazed. For example:

His disciples were shocked [that he was going to Jerusalem]. (GW)

those who followed were afraid: The text does not say why the people who followed were afraid. It was probably for the same reason that the disciples were astonished. They realized that it might be dangerous to go to Jerusalem.

those who followed: The phrase those who followed refers to other people (beside the twelve disciples) who were traveling with him. In this context, they were literally following Jesus on the road. Jesus led

the way, his disciples came behind him, and those who followed were behind the disciples.

General Comment on 10:32a–c

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the parts of this verse. For example, the CEV says:

^{32b}The disciples were confused ^{32a}as Jesus led them toward Jerusalem, ^{32c}and his other followers were afraid.

10:32d**Again Jesus took the Twelve aside**

- Once more Jesus took the twelve disciples aside from the crowd
- As he had done before, Jesus told/invited his twelve followers to come so he could talk with them alone

10:32e**and began to tell them what was going to happen to Him:**

- and told them what was going to happen to him.
- and tell them what was going to happen to him.

10:32d–e

Again: The word AgainThe Greek word that the BSB translates as Again is connected grammatically with the verb that the BSB translates as took...aside. But the BSB and a number of other English versions translate 10:32d in a way that includes the words began to tell them what was going to happen to him in what Jesus did again. applies to the whole action in 10:32d–e. It indicates that Jesus again took the disciples aside and taught them privately about what was going to happen to him. He had done this earlier, in 9:30–32.

Jesus took the Twelve aside: The phrase took...aside means “led away from the other people.” Jesus led his twelve disciples away from the crowd who were following them. He wanted to speak with his disciples privately.

In some languages the natural way to translate took...aside would be with an indirect quote. For example:

Jesus told the twelve disciples to come with him so he could be alone with them

the Twelve: The phrase the Twelve refers to the twelve disciples whom Jesus had selected as his special helpers. See how you translated this phrase in 4:10a.

and began to tell them what was going to happen to Him: This clause summarizes Jesus’ speech in 10:33–

34. Jesus told his disciples about what was going to happen to him in Jerusalem.

Mark 10:33

Section 10:32–34: Jesus predicted his death a third time

Jesus told his disciples in 8:31 and 9:31 that people would kill him and that he would rise from the dead after three days. In 10:32–34, Jesus again told the disciples that these things would happen to him. This time he gave more details about how it would happen.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

For the Third Time Jesus Foretells That He Will Die and Come Back to Life (GW)

Jesus continues his journey toward suffering and death in Jerusalem

Refer to your section title for 9:30–32. If you used a phrase that means “the second time” there, you should use a phrase that means “the third time” here.

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 20:17–19 and Luke 18:31–34.

10:33a

“Look, we are going up to Jerusalem,

- He said, “See,^(plur) we^(incl) are going up to Jerusalem,
- He told them, “Listen^(plur) carefully! We^(incl) are on our way up to Jerusalem.

Look: The word that the BSB translates as Look introduces something that is important or unexpected and indicates that the listener should give it special attention.

This Greek word is not easy to translate into English, so some English version do not translate it here (see the NIV). Other versions translate it as “Behold” or “Listen.” Consider whether there is an expression in your language that has a similar function.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Listen carefully.

Take note of this:

See how you translated this word in 1:2b–c, where the BSB translated it as “Behold.”

we are going up to Jerusalem: The pronoun we refers to Jesus and his disciples. Jesus meant, “You^(plur) and I are going up to Jerusalem.”

10:33b

and the Son of Man will be delivered over

- and there the Son of Man will be delivered into the power of
- When we^(incl) get there, someone will betray me, the Son of Man,

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and introduces what would happen after Jesus and his disciples arrived in Jerusalem.

Here are some other ways to introduce this in English:

then

where (GNT)

there

the Son of Man will be delivered over: The clause the Son of Man will be delivered over is passive. In some languages it is more natural to use an active clause here. For example:

someone will deliver over the Son of Man

Jesus did not say at this time who would deliver him over, so you should use a general subject such as “they” or “someone.”

the Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is literally “the Son of the human/person.” Jesus used this title to imply that:

1. he was a true human being, and he represented all people.
2. he came from God and had authority from God.

Try to use an expression that implies both meanings. Avoid a title that explicitly identifies Jesus as the Messiah.

Here are some other expressions that translators have used:

the Man whom God Sent

the True Man from God/Heaven

the Representative of Mankind

The Older Brother of All People

In some cases, an unusual title may correctly suggest a deeper meaning. For example:

the Child of a Person

the One who was Born as a Human

Translators have also used expressions that are more literal. These more literal expressions may be appropriate where readers are familiar with a literal title in another version.

In some languages it may be necessary to use a form like “I” or “me” to indicate that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

me, the Son of Man

I who became man/human

See how you translated this phrase in 2:10a.

will be delivered over: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as delivered over here means to give someone to his enemies so that they can do whatever they want to him. One of Jesus’ disciples later betrayed Jesus by leading his enemies to him so that they could gain control over him.

The verb will be delivered over is passive. In languages that do not use passive verbs, you may change to an active verb with a general or indefinite subject. For example:

someone will deliver me, the Son of Man, over to the chief priests...

Do not specify Judas or one of the disciples, because Jesus had not yet made known who would betray him. Be careful not to use a term that implies that someone would betray Jesus by spiritual means such as magic. Also do not use an expression that would imply that Jesus was guilty.

10:33c
to the chief priests and scribes.

- the chief priests and the teachers of the law.
- to the religious leaders and the experts in the Law of Moses.

to the chief priests and scribes: The chief priests and scribes together were the religious leaders of the Jews.

chief priests: A Jewish priest was a man who offered sacrifices to God on behalf of the people. He also performed other rituals for them. The phrase chief priests refers to the leaders among these priests.

Here are some other ways to translate chief priests:

the leading/ruling priests

the elders among the Jewish sacrificers

the most prominent priests

This term first occurs in Mark in 8:31c. See how you translated it there.

scribes: The scribes were the experts in the religious law. Their main task was to study, interpret, and teach the law of Moses and other Jewish laws and traditions.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

teachers of the Law of Moses (CEV)

teachers of religious law (NLT)

experts on the law

See how you translated this in 1:22c and 9:14c. See teacher of the law in the Glossary.

10:33d

They will condemn Him to death

- They will condemn him to die
- They will say that I must be put to death,

They will condemn Him to death: The Greek word that the BSB translates as condemn here means to judge someone and say that he is guilty. In the context of a trial, the court decides that the person has done something that is against the law. The phrase condemn...to death here means to declare that the guilty person should be punished by being put to death.

10:33e

and will deliver Him over to the Gentiles,

- and will deliver him into the power of the Gentiles,
- and they will give me to the Gentiles to punish/execute me.

and will deliver Him over to the Gentiles: In this context the verb deliver...over indicates that the Jews would transfer Jesus to a Gentile (Roman) court for punishment. They did this because the Roman rulers did not allow the Jews to execute anyone. The Jews had to ask the Romans to execute anyone whom they had condemned to death.

Him: The pronoun Him refers to “the Son of Man” (10:33b). So Jesus was referring to himself when he used the word Him. In some languages you may need to indicate this by using a form like “me” instead of Him.

Gentiles: The word Gentiles refers to any non-Jewish people. In this context it refers to the Romans, who were ruling Israel at that time.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

non Jews

foreigners (CEV)

the non-Jewish people (NCV) An advantage of a term such as “foreigners” is that it may be easy to translate. A disadvantage is that the same term cannot be used to translate “Gentiles” in other contexts. For example, in Paul’s letters to churches in Gentile areas, the Gentiles were obviously not foreigners.

- Use a loan word from a major language translation in your area. This may be an appropriate option if many people are already familiar with the term. If you choose this option, it is recommended that you also add a footnote. A sample footnote is:

All people who were not Jews were called Gentiles.

Mark 10:34

Section 10:32–34: Jesus predicted his death a third time

Jesus told his disciples in 8:31 and 9:31 that people would kill him and that he would rise from the dead after three days. In 10:32–34, Jesus again told the disciples that these things would happen to him. This time he gave more details about how it would happen.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

For the Third Time Jesus Foretells That He Will Die and Come Back to Life (GW)

Jesus continues his journey toward suffering and death in Jerusalem

Refer to your section title for 9:30–32. If you used a phrase that means “the second time” there, you should use a phrase that means “the third time” here.

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 20:17–19 and Luke 18:31–34.

10:34a

who will mock Him and spit on Him

- who will mock/ridicule him, spit on him,
- The Gentiles will make fun of me, spit on me to shame me,

who will: The phrase who will introduces four things that the Gentiles would do to Jesus. The Gentiles would do these four things in order to punish Jesus after the Jewish leaders condemned him.

mock Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mock means “to ridicule someone (sometimes by imitating the person in a distorted way).” The Gentiles would try to humiliate or shame Jesus in order that other people would not respect him.

Him: The pronoun Him occurs four times in 10:34a. It refers to “the Son of Man” (10:33b). So Jesus was referring to himself when he used the word Him. You should translate it here the same way you translated it in 10:33d.

spit on Him: In Jewish culture, spitting on a person, especially in the face, was one of the worst ways to insult him. It implies that the person is completely worthless. If spitting on someone does not imply this in your culture, you may need to make this explicit. For example:

spit on him to shame him

10:34b

and flog Him and kill Him.

- whip him, and kill him.
- beat me with a whip, and cause me to die.

flog Him: The word flog means to beat with a whip. The Romans used a whip with leather thongs and a

wooden handle. They tied sharp pieces of lead to the leather thongs. When they beat a man with this whip, it could badly cut his back with just a few strokes. They would do this to Jesus.

kill Him: The Romans would punish Jesus by killing him as though he were a criminal.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

put him to death

execute him

10:34c

And after three days He will rise again.”

- On the third day he will come back to life.”
- But after three days I will live again.”

And: Here, the word that the BSB translates as And is a simple connector. The GNT translates it as “but,” because it is natural in English to indicate the contrast between “kill” in 10:34a and “rise” in 10:34b. Some English versions do not use a connector (see the NIV). Connect 10:34a and 10:34b in a natural way in your language.

after three days: When the Jews counted time, they counted part of a day as a whole day. Jesus’ followers would bury him on the first day, and he would be in the grave during all of the second day. God would cause him to live again on the third day. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as the NCV has done:

on the third day

He will rise again: The phrase He will rise again means “He will live again” or “He will come back to life.” Jesus was continuing to refer to himself as the Son of Man, and so in some languages it will be necessary to indicate that. For example:

I will live again.

Mark 10:35

Section 10:35–45: James and John asked Jesus for great honor in his kingdom

In this section, Jesus taught his disciples that they should serve other people. They should not expect other people to honor them. James and John asked for special honor in Jesus’ kingdom. The other disciples became angry that James and John asked for that

honor. Jesus responded by teaching them all how his followers should act. They should serve others rather than try to rule over them. Jesus said that even he himself came to serve others and to sacrifice himself for them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Teaches about Serving Others (NLT)

The Places Of Honor In God’s Kingdom (TRT)

What James and John requested

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 20:20–28 and Luke 22:24–27.

10:35a

Then James and John, the sons of Zebedee, came to Jesus

- ¶ After that, James and John, the sons/children of Zebedee, approached Jesus.

Then: This verse is the beginning of a new section. The events in this section probably happened immediately after the events in the preceding section. The BSB introduces this story with the word Then.

Here are some other ways to translate this in English:

Soon after that

After that

In some languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this story in a natural way in your language.

James and John, the sons of Zebedee: James and John were two of Jesus’ disciples. See how you translated the names James, John, and Zebedee in 1:19b.

came to Jesus: The word that the BSB translates as Jesus is more literally “him” (see the NIV). The BSB uses the word Jesus here because it is natural in English to use a person’s name at the beginning of a new section. Refer to Jesus in a way that is natural in your language.

came: James and John were already near Jesus (see 10:32d). You should not translate the verb came in a way that implies that they arrived from far away.

Here are some other ways to translate came:

approached (NJB)

came forward (RSV)

10:35b

and declared, “Teacher, we want You to do for us whatever we ask.”

- They said, “Teacher, please do for us^(excl) what we are going to ask you^(sing) to do.”
- They^(dual) said, “Sir/Master, will you^(sing) please do something for us?^(dual/excl)”
- They^(dual) asked him to do them a special favor.

Teacher: James and John addressed Jesus as Teacher. The disciples and others often addressed Jesus this way. It was a title of respect for a Jewish man who had authority to teach the things about God. Use a proper term for that meaning. In some languages the appropriate way to address a religious teacher may be:

Sir Teacher

Sir

Master

Be careful not to use a term that can refer only to a school teacher. This word also occurs in 4:38c.

we want You to do for us whatever we ask: James and John used these words to introduce their request. They wanted Jesus to agree to do what they would request.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

We want you to do us a favour. (NJB)

we want you to do for us whatever we ask (NET)

In some languages it may be more natural to express this as a question. For example, the CEV says:

Teacher, will you do us a favor?

Mark 10:36

Section 10:35–45: James and John asked Jesus for great honor in his kingdom

In this section, Jesus taught his disciples that they should serve other people. They should not expect other people to honor them. James and John asked for special honor in Jesus’ kingdom. The other disciples became angry that James and John asked for that honor. Jesus responded by teaching them all how his followers should act. They should serve others rather than try to rule over them. Jesus said that even he himself came to serve others and to sacrifice himself for them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Teaches about Serving Others (NLT)

The Places Of Honor In God’s Kingdom (TRT)

What James and John requested

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 20:20–28 and Luke 22:24–27.

10:36

“What do you want Me to do for you?” He inquired.

- Jesus asked them, “What do you want me to do for you?”
- “What is it?” Jesus asked them. (GNT)
- Jesus asked them^(dual) what they wanted him to do.

What do you want Me to do for you?: This question indicates that Jesus wanted James and John to tell him their specific request. He did not want to agree to something before he had heard it. In translating this question, be careful not to imply that Jesus was already agreeing to their request.

The GNT uses a shorter response to the men that is more natural in English:

What is it?

Translate this question in a natural way in your language.

He inquired: In Greek, the words that the BSB translates as He inquired come before Jesus’ question. They are literally, “he said to them.” This phrase also

includes the Greek conjunction *de*. Introduce Jesus' question in the way that is most natural in your language.

Mark 10:37

Section 10:35–45: James and John asked Jesus for great honor in his kingdom

In this section, Jesus taught his disciples that they should serve other people. They should not expect other people to honor them. James and John asked for special honor in Jesus' kingdom. The other disciples became angry that James and John asked for that honor. Jesus responded by teaching them all how his followers should act. They should serve others rather than try to rule over them. Jesus said that even he himself came to serve others and to sacrifice himself for them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Teaches about Serving Others (NLT)

The Places Of Honor In God's Kingdom (TRT)

What James and John requested

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 20:20–28 and Luke 22:24–27.

10:37

They answered, “Grant that one of us may sit at Your right hand and the other at Your left in Your glory.”

- They answered him, “When you^(sing) begin to rule in glory, please allow/cause us^(excl) to rule next to you, one at your right side and the other at your left side.”
- They^(dual) said, “In your glorious kingdom, we^(dual/excl) want to sit in the places of honor next to you.^(sing) One of us^(dual/excl) could sit at your right hand and the other at your left hand.”
- They^(dual) told him that they wanted to sit right beside him and rule with him at the time when people would honor him as their ruler.

They answered: The words *They answered* introduce the specific request of James and John. Introduce it in a natural way in your language.

Grant that one of us may sit at Your right hand and the other at Your left in Your glory: Here James and John were asking Jesus to give them positions of honor when he himself would rule in honor.

In the culture at that time, the king or person having the greatest authority sat on a throne. The person with the next greatest authority after the king sat at the king's right side. The person next in authority after him sat at the king's left side. James and John wanted Jesus to give them those places of greatest honor next to him and to let them rule over others.

Here are some ways to make this clear:

...we want to sit in places of honor next to you...
one at your right and the other at your left.
(NLT96)

...let us sit beside you to rule with you.

...we want to rule over people with you, one of us sitting at your right side and the other one on your left.

in Your glory: The phrase in *Your glory* refers to the time when Jesus would rule over others as the Messiah. Some versions make explicit the idea of ruling (as a king in his kingdom). For example:

When you sit on your throne in your glorious Kingdom (GNT)

in your glory in your kingdom (NCV)

The phrase in *Your glory* could also be expressed with a verb. For example:

when people honor you

and they honor you

Mark 10:38

Section 10:35–45: James and John asked Jesus for great honor in his kingdom

In this section, Jesus taught his disciples that they should serve other people. They should not expect other people to honor them. James and John asked for special honor in Jesus' kingdom. The other disciples became angry that James and John asked for that honor. Jesus responded by teaching them all how his

followers should act. They should serve others rather than try to rule over them. Jesus said that even he himself came to serve others and to sacrifice himself for them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Teaches about Serving Others (NLT)

The Places Of Honor In God's Kingdom (TRT)

What James and John requested

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 20:20-28 and Luke 22:24-27.

10:38a

“You do not know what you are asking,” Jesus replied.

- Jesus said, “You do not realize what you are asking me for.
- But Jesus answered, “You^(dual/plur) do not really understand what your request implies/means.
- But/Then Jesus told them^(dual) that they did not really understand what they were asking for.

In the Greek text, 10:38a begins with a conjunction that connects the request in 10:37 with Jesus' answer in this verse. Connect the verses in the way that is most natural in your language.

You do not know what you are asking: Jesus indicated here that James and John did not know the meaning or significance of their request. They did not realize that the people who receive the places of honor in Jesus' kingdom are people who suffer for Jesus. You may need to make explicit what James and John did not understand. For example:

You do not understand what your request means.

You do not realize what you are asking me for.

Jesus replied: The BSB places the phrase Jesus replied at the end of this part of the verse. In the Greek text the phrase occurs at the beginning of the verse. Place this information where it is natural in your language.

10:38b-c

Notice that 10:38b-c is one long question. In some languages it may be more natural to translate it as two questions. For example, the GW says:

Can you drink the cup that I'm going to drink? Can you be baptized with the baptism that I'm going to receive?

In the Greek text, there is no connector between Jesus' statement in 10:38a and his question in 10:38b-c. However, in some languages it may be necessary to indicate the connection in some way. For example:

For...

Indeed...

Can you drink the cup I will drink, or be baptized with the baptism I will undergo?: In this question Jesus used two figures of speech to refer to suffering:

1. drinking from the cup (of suffering),
2. being baptized with a baptism (of suffering).

Jesus' question helped James and John to consider whether they could endure suffering like his as well as share his glory. The question does not mean that if people take communion and are baptized, they will share in Jesus' glory.

10:38b

“Can you drink the cup I will drink,

- Can you drink the same cup full of suffering that I will drink?
- For indeed, can you^(dual/plur) suffer with me, as though we^(incl) drank suffering from the same cup?
- He asked them^(dual) whether they^(dual) could endure the suffering that he would experience.

Can you drink the cup I will drink: The expression drink the cup is a complex figure of speech. The cup represents the contents of the cup. The expression drink the cup compares undergoing an experience with drinking the contents of a cup. In this context, Jesus used this figure of speech to refer to the suffering that he would undergo. In the Bible, the Greek and Hebrew words that some English versions translate as cup sometimes refer to something that people had to experience. It could be something good (Psalm 116:13) or something bad (Isaiah 51:17). If a figure of speech like this is not clearly understood in your language, some other ways to translate it are:

- Retain the metaphor but make explicit the meaning of cup. For example, the GNT says:

Can you drink the cup of suffering that I must drink?

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make the meaning of cup explicit. For example:

Can you suffer with me, as though we drank suffering from the same cup?

- State the meaning directly. For example:

Can you endure the suffering that I will experience?

The word “cup” is used as a figure of speech in various places in both the Old and New Testaments. If it is not possible to use this figure of speech in your language, you may want to add a footnote that gives the literal meaning.

Here is a sample footnote:

What Jesus literally said was, “Can you drink the cup that I drink?” In the Bible, “drinking the cup” was an illustration/comparison of undergoing an experience.

I will drink: Jesus referred here to sufferings that he would endure in the near future. In some languages it may be necessary to make that clear. For example, the CEV says:

that I must soon drink from

10:38c or be baptized with the baptism I will undergo?”

- Can you be baptized with suffering as I will be baptized?”
- Can you^(dual/plur) endure anguish with me, as though we^(incl) were being baptized in suffering?”
- He also asked them^(dual) whether they^(dual) were ready to go through the same terrible hardship that he must experience.

or: The word or introduces another way to express the same meaning as in 10:38b. Jesus was not using or to give James and John a choice between alternatives. You may need to use a different connection to make this clear. For example:

that is...

be baptized with the baptism I will undergo: The expression be baptized with the baptism I will undergo has a figurative meaning of being immersed or overwhelmed by something. It refers to Jesus’ suffering and death. It does not refer to a literal baptism with water.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

Can you be baptized with suffering as I will be baptized?

Can you go through suffering with me, as though we were being baptized in suffering?

Can you receive/accept the baptism of suffering that I must receive/accept?

See the next note on baptism. See also the General Comment on 10:38b–c below.

baptism: The Greek word that the BSB translates as baptism is sometimes used figuratively to describe an experience that is overwhelming. In this context it refers to the terrible suffering that Jesus would endure. In some languages it may not be possible to use the same term that you used for baptism in water. Here are some other ways to translate in this context:

- Use an expression that is similar to the one for baptism but does not necessarily require water. For example:

Can you endure the purifying initiation that I must endure?

- Use an expression that is similar to the one you used for baptism but make the meaning explicit. For example:

Can you endure the purifying bath of suffering that I must endure?

- Translate the meaning without the figure of baptism. For example:

Can you endure the overwhelming agony that I must endure?

See how you translated this word in 1:4c. Also see baptism, Meaning 2, in the Glossary.

General Comment on 10:38b–c

In 10:38b–c there are two different metaphors that express the same meaning. In some languages it may be clearer to state the meaning directly once and then give the two metaphors. For example:

Can you^(dual) suffer the way I am going to suffer?
For I must suffer as though I am drinking suffering
from a cup or being baptized in suffering.

Are you^(dual) willing to suffer as I am going to
suffer? That is, can you drink from the same cup
with me and experience the same baptism with
me?

Another possibility is to use both a question and a
statement to express the meaning directly. For exam-
ple:

Can you^(dual) pass through the bitter experience
that I must pass through? For I must suffer
greatly.

Mark 10:39

Section 10:35–45: James and John asked Jesus for great honor in his kingdom

In this section, Jesus taught his disciples that they should serve other people. They should not expect other people to honor them. James and John asked for special honor in Jesus' kingdom. The other disciples became angry that James and John asked for that honor. Jesus responded by teaching them all how his followers should act. They should serve others rather than try to rule over them. Jesus said that even he himself came to serve others and to sacrifice himself for them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Teaches about Serving Others (NLT)

The Places Of Honor In God's Kingdom (TRT)

What James and John requested

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 20:20–28 and Luke 22:24–27.

10:39a

“We can,” the brothers answered.

- They answered, “Yes, we can.”
- They^(dual) said, “Yes, we^(dual/excl) are able to suffer in the same way as you.”
- James and John said that they could.

We can: This is an ellipsis, that is, information is left out of the sentence. You may need to supply the implied information in the statement. Use only as much as is necessary and natural in your language. For example:

Yes, we can suffer with you.

We are able to suffer in the same way as you.

the brothers answered: In the Greek text the phrase that the BSB translates as the brothers answered occurs at the beginning of this verse. Place it where it is natural in your language.

10:39b

“You will drink the cup that I drink,” Jesus said,

- Jesus said to them, “The cup from which I must drink, you will indeed drink,
- Then Jesus said to them,^(dual) “You^(dual/plur) will certainly suffer with me, as though we^(incl) drank from the same cup,
- Jesus told them that they^(dual) would indeed suffer like he would suffer

10:39c

“and you will be baptized with the baptism that I undergo.

- and the baptism that I must endure, you^(dual/plur) certainly will endure,
- and endure anguish with me, as though we^(incl) were being baptized in suffering.
- and experience the terrible hardship that he would experience.

10:39b–c

You will drink the cup that I drink...and you will be baptized with the baptism that I undergo: The two parts of Jesus' response here are parallel to the two parts of his question in 10:38b–c. Again he used the same two metaphors for suffering. If you have made some meaning explicit in 10:38b–c, it may not be necessary to repeat it all here. For example, the GNT says:

^{38b}Can you drink the cup of suffering that I must drink?...^{39c}You will indeed drink the cup I must drink...

the cup...the baptism: In Greek there is emphasis on these two phrases, the cup and the baptism. The NJB shows this emphasis by putting these words at the beginning of the clauses:

The cup that I shall drink you shall drink, and with the baptism with which I shall be baptised you shall be baptised

See also 10:39 in the RSV. Consider whether there is a natural way to show this emphasis in your language. The GNT uses the word “indeed” to give general emphasis to Jesus’ response.

Jesus said: In the Greek text the phrase that the BSB translates as Jesus said occurs at the beginning of this sentence. Place it where it is natural in your language.

General Comment on 10:39c–d

If it is not possible to translate 10:39c–d with the metaphors of the cup and baptism, you could translate the meaning without using metaphors. For example:

You^(dual) will indeed pass through the bitter experience that I must pass through. For you must suffer greatly, as I will.

Mark 10:40

Section 10:35–45: James and John asked Jesus for great honor in his kingdom

In this section, Jesus taught his disciples that they should serve other people. They should not expect other people to honor them. James and John asked for special honor in Jesus’ kingdom. The other disciples became angry that James and John asked for that honor. Jesus responded by teaching them all how his followers should act. They should serve others rather than try to rule over them. Jesus said that even he himself came to serve others and to sacrifice himself for them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Teaches about Serving Others (NLT)

The Places Of Honor In God’s Kingdom (TRT)

What James and John requested

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 20:20–28 and Luke 22:24–27.

10:40a

But to sit at My right or left is not Mine to grant.

- but the seats at my right hand or my left are not mine to grant/give/assign.
- However, I do not have the authority to decide who will receive those places of honor beside me.
- He also said that he was not the one to decide who would sit at his right side or his left side,

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But indicates a contrast between 10:39c–d and 10:40a. In Greek the verb form that the BSB translates as to sit is emphasized. This emphasis and the conjunction but show a contrast between 10:39c–d and 10:40a. James and John would certainly suffer like Jesus, but Jesus would not promise to give them the places of honor.

to sit at My right or left is not Mine to grant: Jesus was saying here that he did not have the authority to decide who would rule with him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

I do not have the right to choose who will sit at my right and my left. (GNT)

I don’t have the authority to grant you a seat at my right or left. (GW)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as direct or indirect speech: For example:

...it is not I who will say “Sit here next to me.”

...it is not I who will say who will sit there and rule with me.

to sit at My right: In some languages it may be natural to use a noun form instead of the verb to sit. This noun may be singular or plural. For example:

a seat at my right or my left

as for seats at my right hand or my left (NJB)

is not Mine to grant: The Greek word that the BSB translates as grant means “give.” In this context it refers to giving someone the seats of authority next to him. This statement implies that someone else will

decide who will have those seats of authority. The next part of the verse makes that explicit.

10:40b

These seats belong to those for whom they have been prepared.”

- These seats/places will be given/assigned to the people for whom they have been made ready.”
- God has prepared those places for the people he has chosen.”
- because God had decided which people would have those places of honor.

These seats belong to those for whom they have been prepared: The Greek says literally “but for those it has been prepared.” This is an ellipsis, that is, information is left out of the sentence. The BSB and most other versions supply some of the information that the Greek leaves implicit. This will be explained in the following notes.

Jesus did not say who would sit in the places of honor. But he indicated that those places had been prepared for certain people. This implies that God had already chosen the ones whom he will honor by allowing them to sit beside Jesus. The NLT makes this explicit:

God has prepared those places for the ones he has chosen.

These seats: The phrase These seats refers to the positions on either side of Jesus that were mentioned in 10:40a.

belong to those for whom: The BSB has supplied the phrase belong to in order to make a complete English sentence. This helps to express what the sentence implies, that is, God has decided which people should have the right to sit next to Jesus. The phrase belong to does not indicate here that the people own those seats.

they have been prepared: This is a passive clause. Jesus did not say who prepared the places of honor. However, his statement implies that God has prepared them. If it is necessary in your language to translate this as an active clause, you could state that God has prepared these places. For example, the GNT says:

It is God who will give these places to those for whom he has prepared them.

prepared: God has prepared the places of honor beside Jesus in the sense that he has decided who will

have them. In some languages it may be necessary to say this in a different way. For example, the CEV says:

But it isn't for me to say who will sit at my right side and at my left. That is for God to decide.

Mark 10:41

Section 10:35–45: James and John asked Jesus for great honor in his kingdom

In this section, Jesus taught his disciples that they should serve other people. They should not expect other people to honor them. James and John asked for special honor in Jesus' kingdom. The other disciples became angry that James and John asked for that honor. Jesus responded by teaching them all how his followers should act. They should serve others rather than try to rule over them. Jesus said that even he himself came to serve others and to sacrifice himself for them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Teaches about Serving Others (NLT)

The Places Of Honor In God's Kingdom (TRT)

What James and John requested

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 20:20–28 and Luke 22:24–27.

10:41a

When the ten heard about this,

- ¶ The other ten disciples heard about this request
- ¶ When the ten other followers discovered what James and John had asked, (NLT)

The events in this paragraph probably happened soon after the event in the preceding paragraph. Connect the events in this paragraph with the preceding event in a natural way in your language.

the ten: The phrase the ten refers to the other disciples besides James and John. Mark often referred to the disciples as “the twelve,” but here he was not speaking of all of them. It may be helpful in your language to use a more specific expression. For example, the CEV says:

the ten other disciples

heard about this: The other ten disciples learned somehow that James and John had asked Jesus to give them places of special honor. You may need to make explicit what the disciples had heard. For example, the NLT96 says:

discovered what James and John had asked

10:41b

they became indignant with James and John.

- and were angry with James and John.
- they were annoyed/irritated with them.^(dual)

they became indignant with James and John: The other ten disciples were indignant with James and John because of their request to Jesus. The similar passage in Luke 22:24 mentions that there was an argument among the disciples about who would be the greatest. It is likely that the other disciples were angry that James and John had asked Jesus for positions that would make them the greatest.

became indignant: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as became indignant means to be angry or indignant against something that is considered wrong or unfair. In this context Jesus' other disciples were angry because they thought that James and John were trying to gain an advantage that would be unfair. Use an expression or idiom that is appropriate for this situation.

Mark 10:42

Section 10:35–45: James and John asked Jesus for great honor in his kingdom

In this section, Jesus taught his disciples that they should serve other people. They should not expect other people to honor them. James and John asked for special honor in Jesus' kingdom. The other disciples became angry that James and John asked for that honor. Jesus responded by teaching them all how his followers should act. They should serve others rather than try to rule over them. Jesus said that even he himself came to serve others and to sacrifice himself for them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Teaches about Serving Others (NLT)

The Places Of Honor In God's Kingdom (TRT)

What James and John requested

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 20:20–28 and Luke 22:24–27.

10:42a

So Jesus called them together and said,

- So Jesus called them all together to him and said, (GNT)
- Jesus called his twelve followers to him. He told them,

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So is a common connector that is often translated as “and.” It introduces what Jesus did after the disciples became angry. It indicates that Jesus' action was a result of their anger. Some English versions do not use a connector. Connect the events in a natural way in your language.

Jesus called them together: This statement implies that Jesus asked his twelve disciples, including James and John, to come to him so that he could speak to them all together.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

called them to him (RSV)

called them all together to him (GNT)

10:42b

“You know that those regarded as rulers of the Gentiles lord it over them,

- “As you^(plur) know, those whom the Gentiles consider to be their rulers have absolute power over them,
- “You^(plur) have seen that those who rule over the peoples of the world exercise control over them.

10:42c

and their superiors exercise authority over them.

- and their great leaders tell them what to do.
- Indeed, their chief men delight to use their authority to make people obey them.
- and love to give them orders.

10:42b–c

Jesus' statement in 10:42b has almost the same meaning as the one in 10:42c. This is a parallelism. The Jews commonly used such parallelism to emphasize an idea. Notice the similar parts of these statements:

^{42b}You know that those regarded as rulers of the Gentiles lord it over them,

^{42c}and their superiors exercise authority over them.

Jesus repeated these ideas in order to emphasize them. You should show this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language. In some languages it may be more natural to translate the similar parts together. For example:

You know that those who are considered to be rulers in this world use their authority to lord it over the people under them.

those regarded as rulers: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as those regarded as rulers is literally “those having a reputation to rule.” There are several ways to interpret this phrase. The most likely interpretation is that Jesus was referring to people whom others consider to be leaders.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

those they call their rulers (NJB)

those who are recognized as rulers (NASB)

rulers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rulers refers to people who govern other people. It is a general expression that can refer to either good or bad rulers.

the Gentiles: The word Gentiles refers to any non-Jewish people. The GNT says “the heathen.” See how you translated this word in 10:33e.

lord it over them: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as lord it over them means “rule over them.” In this context it refers to exercising control over others in a domineering or dictatorial way. Jesus indicated that Gentile rulers generally acted in this way.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

have absolute power over people (GW)

like to order their people around (CEV)

them: In both 10:42b and 10:42c the word them refers to the people whom the rulers are governing.

and: In most English versions, the two parallel clauses in 10:42b–c are joined with the word and. In some languages a word like and may not be appropriate to join two statements with very similar meanings. Connect these statements in a natural way in your language.

Here are some other connectors that could be used here:

yes

indeed

in fact

their superiors: The phrase their superiors is literally “their great ones.” You should translate this with a term that refers to leaders or to “great men” (as in the RSV, NJB). The phrase their superiors refers to the same people as “those regarded as rulers.” If a literal translation would suggest that these are two different groups, it may be necessary to translate this simply as “they.”

exercise authority over them: The expression exercise authority over them has almost the same meaning as the expression lord it over them. It means “to rule over people,” perhaps with the idea of ruling them harshly or oppressing them.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

enforce their authority over people

use their authority to make people obey them

authority: The word authority means “the right to control, the power to rule.” See how you translated this word in 1:22b.

Mark 10:43

Section 10:35–45: James and John asked Jesus for great honor in his kingdom

In this section, Jesus taught his disciples that they should serve other people. They should not expect other people to honor them. James and John asked for special honor in Jesus’ kingdom. The other disciples became angry that James and John asked for that honor. Jesus responded by teaching them all how his followers should act. They should serve others rather than try to rule over them. Jesus said that even he himself came to serve others and to sacrifice himself for them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Teaches about Serving Others (NLT)

The Places Of Honor In God's Kingdom (TRT)

What James and John requested

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 20:20–28 and Luke 22:24–27.

10:43a

But it shall not be this way among you.

- Among you this is not to happen. (NJB)
- But you^(plur) must not act like that.

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But indicates that there is a contrast between the way the rulers of the Gentiles lead people (10:42) and the way Jesus' disciples should lead (10:43–44). The GNT introduces this contrast with the word “however.” The NIV does not use a connector but begins the verse with “Not so” to indicate the contrast. You should indicate the contrast in 10:43 in the way that is most natural in your language.

it shall not be this way among you: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as it shall not be this way among you is more literally “it is not thus among you.” This statement is expressed as a fact. It indicates that leadership among the disciples of Jesus is different from leadership among the Gentiles. This statement also expresses a difference that should exist. It was like a command that Jesus was giving them.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

It shall not be so with you... (REB)

But don't act like them. (CEV)

But among you it should be quite different.
(NLT96)

10:43b–44

As in 10:42b–c, in 10:43b–44 there are two statements that have almost the same meaning. However, the statement in 10:44 is more emphatic. Notice the similar parts of these statements:

^{43b}Instead, whoever wants to become great among you must be your servant,

⁴⁴and whoever wants to be first must be the slave of all.

Here is another way to translate these statements:

If any of you wants to be great, he must serve everyone. And if anyone wants to be greatest among you, he must be the slave of you all.

Notice that these ideas contrast with the ones in 10:42b–c.

10:43b

Instead, whoever wants to become great among you must be your servant,

- No, any of you who wants to become great must be a servant to the others,
- Rather, among you^(plur) the one who wants to be a leader must serve the others.

Instead: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Instead introduces a contrast. Leaders among Jesus' disciples should not act like the Gentile leaders (10:43a). Rather, they should act like servants (10:43b). The NJB introduces this contrast with the word “No.” Many versions do not have a connector here, since the contrast was already introduced in 10:43a. Do what is natural in your language for this context.

whoever wants to become great: The Greek word that the BSB translates as great is similar to the word that was translated as “high officials” in 10:42. The RSV shows this similarity in English:

^{42c}...their great men exercise authority over them.

^{43b}...but whoever would be great among you...

Here becoming great implies becoming a leader among the disciples. The way to become a leader among them contrasted with the way to become a leader among the Gentiles.

Here are some ways to translate whoever wants to become great in this context:

any of you who wants to become a leader

if one of you wants to lead the others

among you: The Greek words that the BSB translates as among you are the same words that were used

in 10:43a and are repeated here. Jesus was referring to his disciples. He meant that among the disciples whoever wanted to lead them must first be a servant to the others. He was not referring to someone who was not a disciple who might want to be a leader or ruler over them.

must be your servant: Jesus taught that if one of the disciples wanted to be great, he must show his concern for the other disciples by helping them and serving them.

servant: The Greek word that the BSB translates as servant means someone who “serves,” “helps” or “works” for another person. This is a different Greek word than the word that is translated as “slave” in 10:44.

Mark 10:44

Section 10:35–45: James and John asked Jesus for great honor in his kingdom

In this section, Jesus taught his disciples that they should serve other people. They should not expect other people to honor them. James and John asked for special honor in Jesus’ kingdom. The other disciples became angry that James and John asked for that honor. Jesus responded by teaching them all how his followers should act. They should serve others rather than try to rule over them. Jesus said that even he himself came to serve others and to sacrifice himself for them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Teaches about Serving Others (NLT)

The Places Of Honor In God’s Kingdom (TRT)

What James and John requested

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 20:20–28 and Luke 22:24–27.

10:44

and whoever wants to be first must be the slave of all.

- and anyone who wants to be the leader must be like a humble slave to all people.
- Indeed/Yes, the one who wants to lead the others must serve all of them like a slave.

and: In most English versions, the parallel clauses in 10:43b and 10:44 are joined with the word and. In some languages a word like and may not be appropriate to join two statements with very similar meanings. Connect these statements in a natural way in your language.

Here are some other connectors that could be used here:

yes

indeed

in fact

whoever wants to be first: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as first here means “the leader of all the others.” It is a more emphatic term than the word that is translated as “great” in 10:43b.

must be the slave of all: Jesus was saying that a disciple who wants to be the leader must serve all the others like a slave. He did not mean that his disciples should literally become slaves. But they should have a humble attitude and be willing to serve others as slaves do.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

must be like a servant for everyone

must serve all his companions

slave: The word slave refers to someone who was owned by another person. He worked for his owner/master without receiving pay. He had no rights of his own (or very few rights).

In some cultures, slaves may not be known. In other cultures, the word for slave may imply different customs than in biblical culture. If that is true in your language, some ways to translate this are:

person who belonged to someone else

owned person

person who serves someone

worker/servant

Mark 10:45

Section 10:35–45: James and John asked Jesus for great honor in his kingdom

In this section, Jesus taught his disciples that they should serve other people. They should not expect other people to honor them. James and John asked for special honor in Jesus' kingdom. The other disciples became angry that James and John asked for that honor. Jesus responded by teaching them all how his followers should act. They should serve others rather than try to rule over them. Jesus said that even he himself came to serve others and to sacrifice himself for them.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Teaches about Serving Others (NLT)

The Places Of Honor In God's Kingdom (TRT)

What James and John requested

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 20:20–28 and Luke 22:24–27.

10:45a

For even the Son of Man did not come to be served, but to serve,

- For the Son of Man himself did not come in order to be served like a great ruler. Instead, he came to serve others
- I say this because I myself, the Son of Man, came to this world to serve others. I did not come so that others would serve me.

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For introduces the basis or reason for what Jesus said in 10:43–44. In other words, those who follow Jesus should serve others because even Jesus himself came to serve.

even the Son of Man: In Greek, the phrase that the BSB translates as even the Son of Man indicates an emphatic contrast with what people normally expected. Jesus as the Son of Man was the greatest leader, and it would be normal for people to serve him. Instead, he came so that he would serve people. The BSB shows this emphatic contrast with the word even. The NJB shows it as follows:

For the Son of man himself

the Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is literally “the Son of the human/person.” It is a title that Jesus often used to refer to himself. It implies that:

1. he was a true human being, and he represented all people.
2. he came from God and had authority from God.

Here are some other ways to translate this title:

the Man whom God Sent

the True Man from God/Heaven

the Representative of Mankind

The Older Brother of All People

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate explicitly that Jesus was referring to himself here. For example:

I, the Son of Man

Refer to how you translated this phrase in 10:33b. You should translate it here as you did there.

did not come to be served, but to serve: When the Son of Man (Jesus) came to earth, he did not come as a great king that people should serve. He did not come to lord it over people, like the rulers he described in 10:42b.

When you translate 10:45a, make sure your translation does not imply that the Son of Man did not come. It may be clearer to translate as follows:

came to serve, not to be served

came to serve others, not so that others would serve him

did not come to...but to...: In this context the expression come to refers to Jesus' purpose for coming to the world, that is, to his work in the world. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate that in some way. For example:

did not come to this world to...but to...

(my) work is not to...but to...

10:45b

and to give His life as a ransom for many.”

- and to give his life to set many others free.” (JBP)
- Indeed, I came to die in order to rescue/redeem many people from their sin.”

and to give His life as a ransom for many: The phrase to give His life means “to die willingly for (others), to voluntarily die to benefit (others).” Jesus willingly and freely came to die as a sacrifice for people’s sins. When Jesus died, he freed from sin the people who would trust in him.

ransom: The Greek word that the BSB translates as ransom refers to something that is given to release or free someone else. For example, someone might give a sum of money as a ransom in order to set a slave or a prisoner free. Similarly, Jesus gave his life in order to set people free from their sin. His death was the ransom that released or redeemed people from their sin.

In some languages it may be natural to translate the noun ransom with a verb. For example:

to redeem many people (GNT)

to set many others free (JBP)

to rescue many people (CEV)

for many: The phrase for many means “on behalf of many people.” Because of the prevalence of languages that use a verb phrase for “ransom,” the notes have not said anything about the literal meaning of the Greek word translated here as “for.” The word literally means “opposite,” and in this context means “in place of,” or “as a substitute for” (UBS page 336, Hendriksen pages 414–415, Lenski page 463, Lane page 383).

Here are some other ways to translate this:

for the sake of many people

so that many people may be saved

Mark 10:46

Section 10:46–52: Jesus healed a blind man named Bartimaeus

As Jesus and his disciples continued their journey to Jerusalem, they came to Jericho. When they left that

city, Bartimaeus, a blind beggar, asked Jesus to heal him and make him able to see. Jesus healed Bartimaeus and told him that the reason Bartimaeus could now see was because he had believed in Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other headings for this section:

Jesus Gives Sight to Bartimaeus (GW)

Jesus Heals a Blind Man (NCV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:27–31, 20:29–34 and Luke 18:35–43.

10:46

This verse introduces a new section. It gives background information about what was happening before the first action of the story begins in 10:47. Be sure to express this background information in the order and way that is natural in your language. See the General Comment on 10:46a–c after 10:46c for suggestions.

10:46a

Next, they came to Jericho.

- ¶ After that, they came to the town/city of Jericho.
- ¶ Soon after that, Jesus and his disciples came to the town of Jericho.

10:46b

And as Jesus and His disciples were leaving Jericho with a large crowd,

- As Jesus and his disciples and a large crowd of other people were leaving the town/city,
- When they were leaving there, with a large group of people following them,
- Then they left with many people. As they were walking along,

10:46a–b

Next: The events in this section probably happened soon after the events in the preceding section. The BSB introduces this story with the word Next.

Here are some other ways to introduce this section:

Then (NIV)

Soon after that

After that

In some languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this story in a natural way in your language.

they came to Jericho. And as Jesus and His disciples were leaving Jericho: In this verse Jesus and his disciples came to Jericho and then left it. The events in this story happened while they were leaving the city of Jericho. Be sure that this is clear in your translation.

they: Since this is a new section, you may need to make clear to whom the pronoun they refers. For example:

Jesus and his disciples

Notice that Jesus and his disciples are specifically mentioned in 10:46b. If you use a phrase to refer to them here, you may not need to repeat the whole phrase again in 10:46b.

Jericho: Jericho is a town or city that is between Jerusalem and the Jordan River. It is located about 24 kilometers (12.5 miles) northeast of Jerusalem. Since this is the only time that Jericho is mentioned in the book of Mark, you may need to identify it more clearly. For example, The NCV has:

the town of Jericho

His disciples: This is the same word as in 10:23a.

10:46c

a blind beggar named Bartimaeus, the son of Timaeus, was sitting beside the road.

- a blind beggar named Bartimaeus was sitting beside the road. He was the son of Timaeus.
- a blind man was sitting by the side of the road. He was begging the people who passed to give him money. He was the son of Timaeus and was named Bartimaeus.
- a man named Bartimaeus was begging by the side of the road. He was a blind man and was the son of Timaeus.

a blind beggar named Bartimaeus, the son of Timaeus: This long phrase introduces an important person in this section. It gives information about him. You may need to put some of this information in separate sentences. For example:

A blind man named Bartimaeus was there. He was the son of Timaeus.

See the following notes for other examples.

the son of Timaeus: The Greek says literally “the son of Timaeus Bartimaeus.” There are two ways to interpret the phrase here:

1. It identifies Bartimaeus as the son of Timaeus. For example, the RSV says:

a blind beggar, the son of Timaeus (BSB, RSV, GNT, KJV, GW, NASB, NCV, CEV, ESV, NET)

1. It explains the meaning of the Aramaic name Bartimaeus. For example, the NIV says:

(that is, the Son of Timaeus) (NIV, NJB, JBP, REB, NLT)

Both interpretations have good support in versions and commentaries. There is not a great difference of meaning between them. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as the majority of English versions do.

a blind beggar named Bartimaeus...was sitting beside the road: There is a textual issue here. It concerns whether the text describes Bartimaeus as a beggar or as a person begging (as an action at that time). There is not a great difference in meaning. You should refer to Bartimaeus and what he was doing at the beginning of this story in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

There was a blind man named Bartimaeus sitting beside the road. He was begging.

Bartimaeus, a blind beggar, was sitting beside the road.

beggar: The word beggar indicates here that Bartimaeus was humbly requesting something. In some languages it is necessary to indicate what he was requesting and whom he was requesting it from. For example:

a blind man named Bartimaeus, the Son of Timaeus, was sitting beside the road and was begging the people who passed by on the road to give him money/something.

General Comment on 10:46a-c

Languages have different ways to express background information at the beginning of a story and to introduce new people. Use a natural way in your language to do this here.

Here is one way to do this in English:

^{46a}Jesus and his disciples came to the city of Jericho. ^{46b}When they left the city, there was a large crowd with them. As they walked along, ^{46c}they saw a man sitting by the roadside. His name was Bartimaeus, and he was the son of Timaeus. He was a blind man, so he sat and begged the people who passed by to give him money.

Mark 10:47

Section 10:46–52: Jesus healed a blind man named Bartimaeus

As Jesus and his disciples continued their journey to Jerusalem, they came to Jericho. When they left that city, Bartimaeus, a blind beggar, asked Jesus to heal him and make him able to see. Jesus healed Bartimaeus and told him that the reason Bartimaeus could now see was because he had believed in Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other headings for this section:

Jesus Gives Sight to Bartimaeus (GW)

Jesus Heals a Blind Man (NCV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:27–31, 20:29–34 and Luke 18:35–43.

10:47a

When he heard that it was Jesus of Nazareth,

- When Bartimaeus heard that Jesus from the town of Nazareth was passing by,
- Bartimaeus heard the crowd passing and learned that Jesus the Nazarene was coming,

When he heard that it was Jesus of Nazareth: This clause implies that Bartimaeus heard the noise of the crowd who was following Jesus. He knew that someone important was coming. Some people told him that it was Jesus who was coming. You may need to supply some of this information in your translation. For example:

When he heard that Jesus of Nazareth was passing by

When Bartimaeus heard that Jesus from Nazareth was nearby (NLT96)

Jesus of Nazareth: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Jesus of Nazareth is literally “Jesus the Nazarene.” There were probably many men in the country of the Jews who had the name Jesus. So in order to show which Jesus this was, people had begun to call him “Jesus the Nazarene.” This means “Jesus from the town of Nazareth.”

Nazareth: Nazareth was a town or city in Galilee. See how you wrote this word in 1:9a.

10:47b

he began to cry out, “Jesus, Son of David, have mercy on me!”

- he began to shout, “Jesus the Son of David, be merciful to me!”
- so he called out saying, “Jesus, descendant of David, show kindness to me!”

he began to cry out: This phrase introduces the words that Bartimaeus shouted to Jesus. He shouted in order to cause Jesus to notice him. His shout was a plea to Jesus. The word began may indicate that Bartimaeus shouted his plea a number of times.

Jesus, Son of David: The phrase Son of David refers to a descendant of King David. The Jewish people used this phrase as a title for the Messiah. It does not refer to one of David’s own children. In fact, Jesus was born hundreds of years after King David died. If people may think that David was Jesus’ father or that David was still alive, you may need to add a footnote in your translation. You can base the footnote on the first sentences of this note. You could also make the meaning of Son of David clearer by translating it as follows:

descendant of King David

have mercy on me: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as have mercy on me means “show compassion to me.” Bartimaeus wanted Jesus to show kindness, pity, or compassion to him. He specifically wanted Jesus to heal him, but he made this specific request later (10:51b).

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Be merciful to me!

Show compassion to me!

Pity me!

mercy: The word mercy means compassion for those who suffer or are in physical need.

See how you translated the word mercy in 5:19d.

Mark 10:48

Section 10:46–52: Jesus healed a blind man named Bartimaeus

As Jesus and his disciples continued their journey to Jerusalem, they came to Jericho. When they left that city, Bartimaeus, a blind beggar, asked Jesus to heal him and make him able to see. Jesus healed Bartimaeus and told him that the reason Bartimaeus could now see was because he had believed in Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other headings for this section:

Jesus Gives Sight to Bartimaeus (GW)

Jesus Heals a Blind Man (NCV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:27–31, 20:29–34 and Luke 18:35–43.

10:48a

Many people admonished him to be silent,

- Many of the people scolded him and told him to be quiet. (GNT)
- Many of the people told him, “Do not shout like that! Be quiet!”

Many people: The phrase Many people probably refers to people who were in the large crowd that accompanied Jesus out of Jericho (10:46b).

admonished him to be silent: The people scolded Bartimaeus by telling him to stop calling out for help. In some languages it may be natural to use direct speech here. For example:

rebuked him. “Be quiet!” they said.

10:48b

but he cried out all the louder, “Son of David, have mercy on me!”

- But he just kept shouting even louder, “Son of David, be merciful to me!”
- Then he shouted even more, “Jesus, descendant of David, show kindness to me!”

but: The word but indicates a contrast between what the people told Bartimaeus to do and what he actually

did. They told him to be quiet, but he shouted even more. Express the contrast in a natural way in your language.

he cried out all the louder, “Son of David, have mercy on me!”: The phrase cried out all the louder means “shouted even louder than before.” For “Son of David, have mercy on me!” see the notes on 10:47b.

Mark 10:49

Section 10:46–52: Jesus healed a blind man named Bartimaeus

As Jesus and his disciples continued their journey to Jerusalem, they came to Jericho. When they left that city, Bartimaeus, a blind beggar, asked Jesus to heal him and make him able to see. Jesus healed Bartimaeus and told him that the reason Bartimaeus could now see was because he had believed in Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other headings for this section:

Jesus Gives Sight to Bartimaeus (GW)

Jesus Heals a Blind Man (NCV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:27–31, 20:29–34 and Luke 18:35–43.

10:49a

Jesus stopped and said,

- When Jesus heard him, he stopped walking and said to some of the people,
- Then Jesus halted and said,

Jesus stopped: The phrase Jesus stopped means “Jesus stopped walking,” “Jesus halted,” or “Jesus stood still.” The text implies that Jesus stopped because he heard the blind man shouting. In some languages it may be necessary to make that explicit. For example:

When Jesus heard him, he stopped

and said: It is not clear to whom Jesus spoke here. It may have been to some of his disciples or to some of the people in the crowd. If it is necessary in your language to indicate this, use a general expression, such as:

and said to some of the people

10:49b “Call him.”

- “Tell^(plur) him to come here.”
- “Call^(plur) that man to come to me.”

Call him: The words Call him indicate that Jesus wanted people to tell Bartimaeus to come to him. You may need to make that meaning more explicit here. For example, the NCV says:

Tell the man to come here.

General Comment on 10:49a–b

In some languages it may be natural to translate Jesus’ words here with indirect speech. For example:

Jesus stopped and told his followers to summon the man.

10:49c So they called the blind man.

- So some of the people called the blind man.
- So they did. They said to the blind man,

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So is the common conjunction that is often translated as “and.” Here it introduces the people’s response to what Jesus told them to do in 10:49b. The BSB uses the word So to indicate that their response is the result of his command. The RSV says “And.” Introduce the people’s response in a natural way in your language.

they called the blind man: Here Mark indicates that the people obeyed Jesus’ command to call Bartimaeus. In 10:49c Mark quoted what they said to him. Introduce these words in a way that is natural in your language.

they: The word they refers either to some of Jesus’ disciples or to some of the people in the crowd. Refer to them in a general way, as the BSB does with they or with a word like “people.”

called: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as called is the same verb that Jesus used in 10:49a. It means to summon a person who may be some distance away.

10:49d “Take courage!” they said. “Get up! He is calling for you.”

- They said, “Take^(sing) courage! Get up! Jesus says ‘Come.’”
- “Don’t be afraid! Come on! He is calling for you.” (CEV)

The people who called the blind man said three things to him. See the following notes.

Take courage!: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Take courage means literally “have courage” (as in the NET).

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Take heart. (RSV)

Don’t be afraid! (CEV)

Be brave!

If there is an idiom in your language to express the way the people were encouraging Bartimaeus, you could use it here. For example:

Good news!

they said: In the Greek text the phrase that the BSB translates as they said occurs at the beginning of this sentence. Place it where it is natural in your language.

Get up!: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Get up means “Stand up” or “Rise.” Bartimaeus was sitting by the road when the people told him to get up. This command is related to the information that Jesus was calling him. They wanted Bartimaeus to get up quickly so that he could go to Jesus.

He is calling for you: Jesus had told the people to call the blind man. He implied that they should tell the blind man to come to him. The people were the messengers, but Jesus himself was inviting the man to come. In some languages it may be more natural to use a direct or indirect quote here. For example:

He says, “Come.”

He says that you may come.

Mark 10:50

Section 10:46–52: Jesus healed a blind man named Bartimaeus

As Jesus and his disciples continued their journey to Jerusalem, they came to Jericho. When they left that city, Bartimaeus, a blind beggar, asked Jesus to heal him and make him able to see. Jesus healed Bartimaeus and told him that the reason Bartimaeus could now see was because he had believed in Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other headings for this section:

Jesus Gives Sight to Bartimaeus (GW)

Jesus Heals a Blind Man (NCV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:27–31, 20:29–34 and Luke 18:35–43.

10:50a

Throwing off his cloak,

- Then the blind man threw off his outer garment,
- So the man tossed aside his robe,

Throwing off his cloak: The blind man's actions in this verse imply that he hurried. He took off his cloak and dropped it without being careful about where it fell. He did this in order to move more quickly to Jesus.

cloak: The Greek word that the BSB translates as cloak refers to a long, loose outer garment like a coat or robe. Your translation of this word should refer to a garment that a person could remove in public without being inappropriate. For example:

coat (NCV)

robe

In some languages it may be necessary to use a descriptive phrase. For example:

his long over-shirt

his outer clothing

See how you translated this word in 5:27b.

10:50b

Bartimaeus jumped up and came to Jesus.

- quickly stood, and came to Jesus.
- got up quickly, and went to Jesus.

Bartimaeus jumped up: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as jumped up means to stand up very quickly. The text implies that Bartimaeus was seated when he jumped to his feet. In some languages it is not natural to use a verb like “jump” when a person is seated.

Here are some other ways to express the meaning:

quickly stood

got up as fast as he could

and came to Jesus: Because Jesus is the main person in the story, you may be able to use the verb came to Jesus as in the Greek and the BSB. If not, use the verb “went” or whatever is natural in your language in such a context.

Mark 10:51

Section 10:46–52: Jesus healed a blind man named Bartimaeus

As Jesus and his disciples continued their journey to Jerusalem, they came to Jericho. When they left that city, Bartimaeus, a blind beggar, asked Jesus to heal him and make him able to see. Jesus healed Bartimaeus and told him that the reason Bartimaeus could now see was because he had believed in Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other headings for this section:

Jesus Gives Sight to Bartimaeus (GW)

Jesus Heals a Blind Man (NCV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:27–31, 20:29–34 and Luke 18:35–43.

10:51a

“What do you want Me to do for you?” Jesus asked.

- Then Jesus said to him, “What do you want me to do for you?”
- Jesus asked what Bartimaeus wanted him to do for him.

What do you want Me to do for you?: In Greek, the question that Jesus asked Bartimaeus here is similar to the one that he asked James and John in 10:36. If it is natural in your language, you may translate in a similar way here.

Jesus asked: In Greek the phrase that the BSB translates as Jesus asked occurs at the beginning of this verse. It introduces Jesus' words. Place this phrase where it is natural in your language.

In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech for this part of the verse. For example:

Jesus asked Bartimaeus what his request was.

10:51b**“Rabboni,” said the blind man, “let me see again.”**

- The blind man replied, “Teacher, let me be able to see.”
- The blind man answered, “Sir/Teacher, please heal me so that I can see.”

Rabboni: The word Rabboni is a Hebrew word that is used several times in Mark. The literal meaning of “Rabbi” in Hebrew is “my great one.” Here in 10:51b the text uses a slightly different form. Both forms refer to a person who taught people about God and his ways. People often used the word as a title to show respect when they spoke to such a religious teacher. See how you translated this word in 9:5a.

said the blind man: This phrase indicates that Bartimaeus was answering Jesus. In some languages it may be more natural to use a verb like “answered” or “replied.”

In the Greek text the phrase that the BSB translates as said the blind man occurs at the beginning of this sentence. Place it where it is natural in your language.

let me see again: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as let me see again is literally “so that I may see.” The man was politely requesting Jesus to do something for him. He was begging Jesus to make him able to see. Translate this in an appropriate way in your language. For example, the NIV says:

I want to see

see again: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as see again can imply either “be able to see for the first time” or “be able to see again.” The text does not say whether this man had been able to see and then became blind or whether he was born blind. It is good not to specify this in your translation.

Mark 10:52**Section 10:46–52: Jesus healed a blind man named Bartimaeus**

As Jesus and his disciples continued their journey to Jerusalem, they came to Jericho. When they left that city, Bartimaeus, a blind beggar, asked Jesus to heal him and make him able to see. Jesus healed Bartimaeus and told him that the reason Bartimaeus could now see was because he had believed in Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other headings for this section:

Jesus Gives Sight to Bartimaeus (GW)

Jesus Heals a Blind Man (NCV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 9:27–31, 20:29–34 and Luke 18:35–43.

10:52a**“Go,” said Jesus, “your faith has healed you.”**

- Jesus said, “You may go. You are now well because of your faith/belief in me.”
- Jesus said, “You are free to go home. I have healed you because you believed in me.”

Go: Jesus said Go in order to tell the man that he was free to leave, because his request had been granted. Be careful not to translate this in a way that sounds as if Jesus was rejecting the man.

said Jesus: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as said Jesus is literally “and Jesus said to him.” In Greek this phrase occurs at the beginning of this verse. Translate it in a natural way and place it where it is natural in your language.

your faith has healed you: This clause contains a figure of speech. The abstract noun faith is spoken of as if it performed an action. This expression means here that Jesus had healed the man’s blindness because of his faith.

The noun faith refers here to the action of believing and trusting Jesus. Your faith has healed you implies that the blind man believed that Jesus would heal him. In some languages, it may be more natural to translate faith as a verb. If that is true in your language, you may also need to make explicit who or what was believed.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Your eyes are healed because of your faith. (CEV)

...you are healed because you believed. (NCV)

You trusted in me and that has healed you.

You are well because you believed that I could heal you.

See 5:34a, where the same Greek phrase occurs. See also believe, Meaning 3, in the Glossary.

10:52b**And immediately he received his sight**

- And instantly the blind man could see! (NLT96)

- As soon as Jesus said that, Bartimaeus's blindness was removed.

And immediately: In this context immediately means as soon as Jesus spoke the words in 10:52a.

he received his sight: The phrase he received his sight means "the blind man became able to see."

10:52c

and followed Jesus along the road.

- Then he followed Jesus down the road. (NLT96)
- and he joined in following Jesus.

and followed Jesus along the road: The blind man began to walk along the road to Jerusalem with Jesus and the rest of the crowd. The verb followed may also imply that he became one of Jesus' disciples.

In some languages it may be more natural to make the phrase along the road implicit. It may also be more natural to make explicit that Bartimaeus was following Jesus along with others. For example:

and he joined the others who were following Jesus

Mark 11:1

Section 11:1–11: People gladly welcomed Jesus to Jerusalem

When Jesus entered Jerusalem in this section, many people were very excited. He entered Jerusalem as a gentle and humble king would enter a city. Many people praised him in a way that showed that they wanted him to be their king (11:8). Some people believed that he was the Messiah that the Jews had been awaiting for many generations.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus' Triumphal Entry into Jerusalem (NRSV)

Many people celebrate as Jesus enters Jerusalem

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:1–11 and Luke 19:28–40. See also John 12:12–19.

11:1a

As they approached Jerusalem

- ¶ As Jesus and his disciples approached Jerusalem, (NLT)

- ¶ When Jesus and his followers were coming closer to the city of Jerusalem,

11:1a–b

The clause in 11:1a–b is background information. It introduces the main action in 11:1c. See the General Comment on 11:1a–b below for ways to translate this background information.

As they approached Jerusalem: The words As they approached Jerusalem connect the story in this paragraph with the preceding story. In 10:46 Jesus and his disciples, along with a crowd of people, left Jericho. They walked along the road from Jericho and were now getting close to the city of Jerusalem.

Here is another way to translate this:

As Jesus and his followers were coming closer to Jerusalem (NCV)

they: Since this is a new section, you may need to identify the pronoun they as "Jesus and his disciples."

11:1b

and came to Bethphage and Bethany at the Mount of Olives,

- they came to Bethphage and Bethany near the Mount of Olives.
- they arrived at the towns/villages of Bethphage and Bethany on the Mount of Olives.

came to Bethphage and Bethany at the Mount of Olives: Bethphage and Bethany were the names of two small towns/villages. In Jesus' time they may both have had fewer than two hundred inhabitants.

In this context the words came to probably indicate that Jesus and the others were approaching one of these two towns. They had not yet entered these towns. In some languages, this information may need to be made explicit. For example, the GNT says:

near the towns of Bethphage and Bethany

These towns were near Jerusalem and on the side of the Mount of Olives. So they can be described as near the top of the Mount of Olives or at/on the side of the Mount of Olives. For example, the NJB says:

they were approaching Jerusalem, at Bethphage and Bethany, close by the Mount of Olives

It might be helpful to include a footnote here in your translation. For example:

Bethphage and Bethany are villages on the side of the Mount of Olives. They are closer than two miles to Jerusalem. The Mount of Olives is east of Jerusalem.

the Mount of Olives: The phrase the Mount of Olives names a hill on the east side of the city of Jerusalem. It is not a high mountain. It is only about sixty meters (two hundred feet) higher than Jerusalem.

People called it the Mount of Olives because it had olive trees growing on it. If olive trees are not known in your area, here are some ways to translate it:

- Write the word Olives according to the sounds of your language and add a descriptive phrase. For example:

Hill where the fruit called olive grows

Hill of the trees called olive

Olive Mountain/Hill

- Borrow the word that means Olives from another language. If this word is not well known, you may want to add a descriptive phrase.

Olives: The word Olives can refer to trees of a certain type or to the fruits that grow on those trees. Here in 11:1b it refers to a kind of tree on which the olive fruit grows.

The olive fruit grows on trees. It is small and round with a hard seed inside. The olive was an essential food in ancient times. It was pressed into oil that was used in cooking and in some rituals. The oil was also used as fuel for lamps and in medicine and cosmetics.

General Comment on 11:1a–b

The background information in 11:1a–b is part of a longer sentence in Greek. The BSB ends this sentence at the end of 11:2. In some languages it may be necessary to use a separate sentence or sentences for the background information. For example:

As Jesus and his followers were coming closer to Jerusalem, they came to the towns of Bethphage and Bethany near the Mount of Olives. (NCV)

When Jesus and his companions came close to the city of Jerusalem, they arrived near the outlying villages of Bethphage and Bethany. These villages were on/near Olive Mountain.

11:1c

Jesus sent out two of His disciples

- Jesus sent two of his disciples ahead,
- As they arrived there, Jesus told two of his followers

Jesus sent out two of His disciples: Jesus told two disciples to go ahead of him to do a particular task. Use an appropriate verb in your language for telling people to go and do something.

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means “learners” who are in a special relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament a disciple referred specifically to a person who was learning from a religious teacher. A disciple often lived with his teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Here are some other ways to translate disciples:

- Use a term that refers to someone who learns from a teacher or an expert. It is helpful if the term also implies that the learner is often with his teacher. For example:

learners/students

apprentices Be careful not to use a term that would refer only to a student in a school or classroom.

- Use a term that refers to someone who follows a teacher or leader by obeying his teaching. It is helpful if this term also implies learning from the teacher and actually following the teacher wherever he goes. For example:

followers

those who are committed/faithful (to a teacher/leader)

See disciple in the Glossary.

Mark 11:2

Section 11:1–11: People gladly welcomed Jesus to Jerusalem

When Jesus entered Jerusalem in this section, many people were very excited. He entered Jerusalem as a gentle and humble king would enter a city. Many people praised him in a way that showed that they wanted

him to be their king (11:8). Some people believed that he was the Messiah that the Jews had been awaiting for many generations.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus' Triumphal Entry into Jerusalem (NRSV)

Many people celebrate as Jesus enters Jerusalem

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:1-11 and Luke 19:28-40. See also John 12:12-19.

11:2a

and said to them, “Go into the village ahead of you,

- telling them: “Go^(dual/plur) to the village ahead of you.
(dual/plur)
- to go before him to the next village.

and said to them: The phrase and said to them introduces the words which Jesus said to his disciples when he told them to go ahead of him.

Here is another way to translate and said to them:

with these instructions

Be careful not to translate this as if Jesus sent them off and then told them what to do.

Go into the village ahead of you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as village refers to a small community rather than a city (such as Jerusalem). The village could have been Bethphage, Bethany, or another small town. You should not be specific.

General Comment on 11:1c–2a

In some languages it may be natural to combine 11:1c with 11:2a as follows:

^{1c}Jesus told/caused two of his disciples to go ahead ^{2a}until they came to the next village.

11:2b

and as soon as you enter it,

- Just as you^(dual/plur) enter it,
- He said that as soon as they arrived in the village

and as soon as you enter it: The Greek word that the BSB translates as as soon as is literally “immediately.”

Many versions translate it as “just as.” For example, the NIV says:

and just as you enter it,

11:2c

you will find a colt tied there,

- you will find a colt tied there
- they would find a young donkey tied/tethered there

you will find a colt tied there: The word there is not in the Greek text. The BSB has supplied it to make it clear that the disciples would find the colt as soon as they entered the village (11:2b). You may not need to use the word there in your translation. For example, the GNT says:

you will find a colt tied up

colt: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a colt refers to either a young horse or a young donkey. The parallel passages in Matthew and John (Matthew 21:2, John 12:14-15) make it clear that this was a young donkey. The Greek text of Matthew 21:5 indicates that this was a male donkey. Here the Greek word refers to a young donkey which is big enough for a man to ride or big enough to carry a load.

If donkeys are not known in your language area, you might simply say:

a young (male) riding animal

You should not use a term that refers to an animal that was recently born or that is less than a year old.

tied: People tied their animals to a tree or post so they would not walk away when no one was using them. One end of the rope was tied around the animal's neck. The other end was tied to a post.

In some languages it may be necessary to say what the animal is tied to and with what. For example:

tied by a cord to a post

11:2d

on which no one has ever sat.

- that no one has yet/ever sat on.
- that has never carried a rider before.

on which no one has ever sat: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as on which no one has ever sat is literally “which no one has ever ridden” (as in the NIV).

Here is another possible way to translate this:

which has never carried a person

11:2e

Untie it and bring it here.

- Untie the colt and lead it here.
- They should untie the young donkey and come back with it to him/Jesus.

Untie it and bring it here: Jesus told the disciples to bring the colt to him. They would probably bring it by leading it along at the end of its rope.

Mark 11:3

Section 11:1–11: People gladly welcomed Jesus to Jerusalem

When Jesus entered Jerusalem in this section, many people were very excited. He entered Jerusalem as a gentle and humble king would enter a city. Many people praised him in a way that showed that they wanted him to be their king (11:8). Some people believed that he was the Messiah that the Jews had been awaiting for many generations.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus' Triumphal Entry into Jerusalem (NRSV)

Many people celebrate as Jesus enters Jerusalem

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:1–11 and Luke 19:28–40. See also John 12:12–19.

11:3a

If anyone asks, 'Why are you doing this?'

- Someone may ask you, "Why you are doing that?"
- Jesus told them that if someone asked them why they were taking the young donkey,

If anyone asks: The clause If anyone asks refers to an event that might happen when the disciples went to take the donkey. Someone might ask the disciples why they were taking the donkey. This event had not yet happened when Jesus said this.

Here is another way to translate the phrase:

Someone may ask you

Why are you doing this?: This is both a real and rhetorical question. People might ask the reason why the disciples were untying the colt. They would ask this because they knew that the colt did not belong to the disciples. They would disapprove of what the disciples did. It may be clearer to use an indirect quotation here. For example, the GNT translates 11:3a as follows:

And if someone asks you why you are doing that

11:3b

tell him, 'The Lord needs it

- If so, say, 'Because the Lord needs it.
- they should tell that person that it was because the Lord needed it.

tell him, 'The Lord needs it: The words tell him introduce what Jesus wanted the disciples to say to anyone who might ask why they were taking the colt. It may be clearer to use an indirect quotation. For example, the GNT translates 11:3b as follows:

say that the Master needs it

See also the General Comment on 11:3b–c below.

Lord: The word Lord means "master," or "the one who has authority over others." See how you translated this word in 1:3b. Also, see Lord, Context 2, in the Glossary.

11:3c

and will return it shortly.'"

- He will send it back here soon.'"
- They should say that the Lord would send it back soon.

and will return it shortly: There is a textual issue in this verse:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the word again. The versions that follow these manuscripts understand 11:3c to refer to what Jesus would do. He would soon send the donkey again/back to the owners. For example, the NET says:

^{3b}The Lord needs it ^{3c}and will send it back here soon. (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, CEV, ESV, JBP, NASB, NET, NJB, NLT, REB)

1. Other Greek manuscripts do not have the word again. The versions that follow these manuscripts understand 11:3c to refer to what the donkey's

owner would do as a result of Jesus' request. The donkey's owner would immediately send the donkey to the Lord. For example, the GW says:

^{3b}say that the Lord needs it. ^{3c}That person will send it here at once. (KJV, GW, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). However, if the national language version in your area follows option (2), then you may want to follow it.

If you follow option (2), you may want to consider putting option (1) in a footnote. For example:

Some Greek manuscripts have the word "again/back." These manuscripts indicate that Jesus would soon send the donkey back to the owners.

General Comment on 11:3b–c

In 11:3b–c, Jesus told the disciples how they should answer anyone who asked them why they were taking the colt. The words "The Lord needs it" in 11:3b answer the question "why?" The words "and will send it back here shortly" in 11:3c do not answer the question. They give additional information. For this reason, you may need to make these into separate sentences. For example:

^{3b}Because the Lord needs it. ^{3c}He will send it back here soon.

Mark 11:4

Section 11:1–11: People gladly welcomed Jesus to Jerusalem

When Jesus entered Jerusalem in this section, many people were very excited. He entered Jerusalem as a gentle and humble king would enter a city. Many people praised him in a way that showed that they wanted him to be their king (11:8). Some people believed that he was the Messiah that the Jews had been awaiting for many generations.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus' Triumphal Entry into Jerusalem (NRSV)

Many people celebrate as Jesus enters Jerusalem

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:1–11 and Luke 19:28–40. See also John 12:12–19.

11:4a

So they went

- The two disciples went there
- So they went to the village,

So they went: The phrase So they went means that the two disciples (11:1c) went ahead to the next village (11:2a). They did this in response to what Jesus had told them to do.

11:4b

and found the colt outside in the street, tied at a doorway.

- and found a colt in the open street, tied at a doorway.
- and there they found the young donkey outside along the street, tied near a doorway.
- and found the young donkey. Someone had tied it outside at a doorway along the street.

and found the colt outside in the street: The phrase the colt outside in the street means that the colt was outdoors, along one of the village roads. The NJB says "in the open street." This indicates that the colt was in plain view in a public place. It was not in the middle of the street. Another way to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as street is "crossroads," that is, a place where two roads intersect. The KJV follows this interpretation and translates as, "in a place where two ways met." However, almost all other English versions interpret the Greek word as meaning simply street. It is recommended that you do the same in your translation.

the colt: The words the colt refer to the colt that Jesus mentioned in 11:2c. As mentioned in the note on 11:2c, Matthew 21:2 and John 12:14–15 make it clear that this colt was a young donkey. Refer to it in a natural way in your language.

tied at a doorway: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as at a doorway could also be translated as "to a door" (see the GNT). The donkey was probably either tied to the doorpost or to a post near the door of a house. It is also possible that doorway refers to the gate where people entered the town. So make your translation of a doorway as general as you can in your language.

tied: The word tied is a passive verb. Here it describes the donkey. In some languages it may be natural to use an active verb. For example:

someone had tied it

If it is necessary in your language to say to what the colt was tied, be as general as possible. For example:

tied to something

tied to a post

11:4c

They untied it,

- As they were untying it, (GNT)
- While these two disciples were untying the donkey,

They untied it: The disciples began to untie the colt. They had not finished untying it when some people interrupted them, as 11:5 describes.

Mark 11:5

Section 11:1–11: People gladly welcomed Jesus to Jerusalem

When Jesus entered Jerusalem in this section, many people were very excited. He entered Jerusalem as a gentle and humble king would enter a city. Many people praised him in a way that showed that they wanted him to be their king (11:8). Some people believed that he was the Messiah that the Jews had been awaiting for many generations.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus' Triumphal Entry into Jerusalem (NRSV)

Many people celebrate as Jesus enters Jerusalem

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:1–11 and Luke 19:28–40. See also John 12:12–19.

11:5

and some who were standing there asked, “Why are you untying the colt?”

- some people were standing there and asked, “What are you doing? Why are you untying that colt?”
- some people standing nearby said, “Why are you^(dual/plur) untying that colt? You should not do that!”
- some people standing nearby asked them why they^(dual) were untying the colt.

and some who were standing there asked: Luke 19:33 identifies the people whom Mark calls some as the owners of the colt. Here in Mark, the word some refers to the people standing nearby. You should not say specifically that they owned the colt. This probably refers to just a few people, rather than to a crowd.

Why are you untying the colt?: This is both a real and rhetorical question. The people wanted to know the reason why the disciples were untying the colt. They were also rebuking the disciples for doing something that they should not do.

You should try to translate this question in a way that shows disapproval. For example:

What are you doing? Why are you untying that colt? (NCV)

Why are you^(dual) untying that colt? You should not do that!

Mark 11:6

Section 11:1–11: People gladly welcomed Jesus to Jerusalem

When Jesus entered Jerusalem in this section, many people were very excited. He entered Jerusalem as a gentle and humble king would enter a city. Many people praised him in a way that showed that they wanted him to be their king (11:8). Some people believed that he was the Messiah that the Jews had been awaiting for many generations.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus' Triumphal Entry into Jerusalem (NRSV)

Many people celebrate as Jesus enters Jerusalem

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:1–11 and Luke 19:28–40. See also John 12:12–19.

11:6a

The disciples answered as Jesus had instructed them,

- They said the words that Jesus had told them to say,
- The two disciples told the people who had asked the question what Jesus had said.

- They^(dual) replied as Jesus had told them to, “The Lord has need of it.”

The disciples answered as Jesus had instructed them: The disciples said the words that Jesus had told them to say (see 11:3).

In your language, you may need to explicitly say who answered whom. For example:

The two disciples answered the people who asked the question as Jesus had told them to answer.

11:6b and the people gave them permission.

- and the people allowed them to go away with the colt.
- So/Then the people let/allowed them to take the young donkey and go.

the people gave them permission: The phrase the people gave them permission indicates that the people accepted what the disciples said. They allowed the disciples to go. They did not object or protest any more.

You may need to make it explicit that the people let the disciples take the colt and go. For example:

the people let them go away with the colt

Mark 11:7

Section 11:1–11: People gladly welcomed Jesus to Jerusalem

When Jesus entered Jerusalem in this section, many people were very excited. He entered Jerusalem as a gentle and humble king would enter a city. Many people praised him in a way that showed that they wanted him to be their king (11:8). Some people believed that he was the Messiah that the Jews had been awaiting for many generations.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus’ Triumphal Entry into Jerusalem (NRSV)

Many people celebrate as Jesus enters Jerusalem

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:1–11 and Luke 19:28–40. See also John 12:12–19.

11:7a–c

Then they led the colt to Jesus and threw their cloaks over it, and He sat on it: There are three clauses in 11:7:

1. they led the colt to Jesus,
2. they threw their cloaks over it,
3. Jesus sat on the colt.

In Greek the clauses in 11:7a–c are all independent. It may be more natural in your language to translate them that way. For example, the GNT says:

They brought the colt to Jesus, threw their cloaks over the animal, and Jesus got on.

11:7a

Then they led the colt to Jesus

- Then they took the colt to Jesus (NJB)
- The two disciples led the young donkey to Jesus

they: The word they refers to the two disciples who went to find the donkey.

11:7b

and threw their cloaks over it,

- and threw their cloaks on its back, (NJB)
- and spread/put their outer garments over its back.

threw their cloaks over it: The verb threw here has the sense of “placed” or “spread” their cloaks upon it. That is, the disciples laid their cloaks over the donkey’s back to make a comfortable place for Jesus to sit.

cloaks: The Greek word that the BSB translates as cloaks describes the robe-like outer garment worn by Jewish men. They put the cloaks on the donkey’s back so that it would be more comfortable for Jesus to sit on.

If men in your culture do not wear a second, outer garment, you should translate cloaks in a general way. For example:

outer clothing/garments

extra clothes

Be careful to translate this in a way that does not imply that the disciples were naked after they put their cloaks on the donkey.

See how you translated this word in 5:27 and 6:56.

11:7c**and He sat on it.**

- and he mounted it. (NJB)
- Then Jesus sat on the garments on the donkey's back.

He sat on it: The pronoun it refers to the donkey. Jesus sat on the donkey's back.

Mark 11:8**Section 11:1–11: People gladly welcomed Jesus to Jerusalem**

When Jesus entered Jerusalem in this section, many people were very excited. He entered Jerusalem as a gentle and humble king would enter a city. Many people praised him in a way that showed that they wanted him to be their king (11:8). Some people believed that he was the Messiah that the Jews had been awaiting for many generations.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus' Triumphal Entry into Jerusalem (NRSV)

Many people celebrate as Jesus enters Jerusalem

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:1–11 and Luke 19:28–40. See also John 12:12–19.

Paragraph 11:8–10

This paragraph continues the story about Jesus coming to Jerusalem, riding on a young donkey. You may need to make it explicit in your translation of 11:8–10 that he was riding the young donkey.

The people honored Jesus and shouted out words of joy and praise. See the General Comment on 11:9–10 at the end of 11:10b for advice about how to translate what the people were shouting.

11:8a**Many in the crowd spread their cloaks on the road,**

- ¶ Many people spread their cloaks on the road in front of Jesus to honor him,
- ¶ As Jesus rode the donkey toward Jerusalem, many people honored him by spreading their cloaks on the road ahead of him.

Many in the crowd spread their cloaks on the road:

The people placed their cloaks on the road in front of

Jesus for the donkey to walk on. This was a way to show Jesus honor. If people in your language group do not know this custom, you should make the meaning explicit. For example:

people spread their cloaks on the road in front of Jesus in order to show him honor

Or you may want to include a footnote to explain the meaning of what they were doing. For example, you could say:

Jews in Jesus' time used to spread their cloaks on the road in front of important people to honor them.

cloaks: Use the same word for cloaks here that you used in 11:7b.

11:8b**while others spread branches they had cut from the fields.**

- and other people spread on the road leafy branches which they had cut in the fields.
- Others honored him by laying leafy branches which they had cut from nearby trees.
- Other people cut leafy branches from trees beside the road and honored him by putting them on the road.

while others spread branches they had cut from the fields:

All the people mentioned in 11:8 were honoring Jesus. Some honored him by spreading their garments on the road (11:8a), and others honored him by spreading branches in the road (11:8b). Make sure that it is clear in your translation that all these people were honoring Jesus.

You may need to rearrange the order of the clauses here in 11:8b. First, they cut branches in the fields, then they placed or spread the branches in the road to honor Jesus. For example:

while others cut branches in the fields and placed/ spread them on the road

branches they had cut from the fields: Some Greek manuscripts have “branches they had cut from the trees” (see the KJV), rather than branches they had cut in the fields. Most English versions follow the Greek manuscripts that say...cut in the fields. It is recommended that you follow the majority of English versions. However, it is implied that the branches were cut from trees in the field. So if it is necessary to

be specific in your language, you could translate this expression as follows:

branches that they had cut from trees in the fields

branches: The Greek word that the BSB translates as branches is a general word. In the parallel passage in John 12:13 the text specifies that these were palm fronds. This “greenery” (as in the NJB) would lie flat on the road and would not cause the donkey to stumble. The people spread this greenery and their cloaks to form a carpet on the road. This was a sign of welcome and honor for an important person.

In some languages a word like “branches” may imply large parts of a tree. Use an appropriate word in your language to describe the palm fronds that the people were using to form a carpet for Jesus.

from the fields: The Greek word that the BSB translates as fields can refer to either cultivated land or to the countryside. Here it probably refers to the area near the sides of the road. In some languages this may need to be made explicit. In some languages it may be more natural to leave the phrase from the fields implicit. For example:

branches they had cut from trees near the road

Mark 11:9

Section 11:1–11: People gladly welcomed Jesus to Jerusalem

When Jesus entered Jerusalem in this section, many people were very excited. He entered Jerusalem as a gentle and humble king would enter a city. Many people praised him in a way that showed that they wanted him to be their king (11:8). Some people believed that he was the Messiah that the Jews had been awaiting for many generations.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus’ Triumphal Entry into Jerusalem (NRSV)

Many people celebrate as Jesus enters Jerusalem

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:1–11 and Luke 19:28–40. See also John 12:12–19.

Paragraph 11:8–10

This paragraph continues the story about Jesus coming to Jerusalem, riding on a young donkey. You may need to make it explicit in your translation of 11:8–10 that he was riding the young donkey.

The people honored Jesus and shouted out words of joy and praise. See the General Comment on 11:9–10 at the end of 11:10b for advice about how to translate what the people were shouting.

11:9a

The ones who went ahead and those who followed were shouting: “Hosanna!”

- The people who walked ahead of Jesus and behind him were shouting, “Hosanna!”
- Some people walked ahead of Jesus and some followed behind. As they walked, they shouted joyfully, “Praise God!”
- Everyone was exclaiming/cheering “Praise God!” Some of them were walking ahead of him and others were walking behind him.

The ones who went ahead and those who followed were shouting: “Hosanna!”:

The phrase The ones who went ahead and those who followed indicates that a crowd of people surrounded Jesus. Some people walked before Jesus. Other people walked behind Jesus. This was the normal thing that people did to announce that an important person had arrived. They did this to welcome and honor him.

This is the first mention of The ones who went ahead and those who followed. So you may need to put this new information in a separate sentence. For example:

Some people walked ahead of Jesus and some followed behind. They were all shouting “Hosanna!”

Everyone was shouting “Praise God!” Some of them were walking ahead of Jesus and others were walking behind him.

were shouting: The form of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as were shouting indicates a repeated action. They were shouting their praises again and again. You could translate the verb as:

were continually shouting

shouted again and again

Make sure that it is clear in your translation that the people were joyful, not angry. Here are some ways to do this:

- Supply a word such as “joyfully.”
- Translate shouted with a verb that includes that idea, such as “cheered.”

Hosanna: The word Hosanna originally meant “Save!” or “Save us now!” But by Jesus’ time, the phrase had become a general shout of joy and praise. Some ways to translate this word are:

- Translate it with a word or phrase that people use when they shout to indicate joy and praise. For example, the NLT says:

Praise God! If you choose this option but your national language version has Hosanna, you could include a footnote that says that the Greek is literally “Hosanna.”

- Write the word as Hosanna, according to the spelling system of your language. This is what most English versions do. If people do not know what the word means, you could include a footnote. For example:

“Hosanna” was a word in the language that the Jews spoke during the time when Jesus lived on earth. It meant “Praise God!”

11:9b

“Blessed is He who comes in the name of the Lord!”

- The one who comes in the name of the Lord God has his/God’s blessing/favor!
- And they shouted, “God is pleased with the one who comes with his authority!”
- They were also shouting, “The one who comes as the Lord’s spokesman/representative is favored by God!”

Blessed is He who comes in the name of the Lord!:

The expression Blessed is He who comes in the name of the Lord can be interpreted in two ways:

1. It is a statement of praise and means “the one who comes is blessed” or “God has blessed the one who comes.” For example, the BSB says:

Blessed is He who comes in the name of the Lord!
(BSB, NIV, RSV, GW, REB, NJB, NET, NASB, KJV, ESV)

1. It is a wish or request and means “May the one who comes be blessed” or “May God bless....” For example, the GNT says:

God bless him who comes in the name of the Lord!
(GNT, CEV, NCV, JBP)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This saying was primarily a shout of praise rather than a request. Here the people were praising God with words from Scripture (Psalm 118:26).

Blessed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Blessed describes someone for whom God has done good things. God has blessed and favored that person, so he can be described as blessed.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

God has blessed/favored

God has done good things for

God is with

See bless, Meaning 2, in the Glossary.

He who comes: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as He who comes is literally “the coming one.” This was a title that referred to the Messiah. The people were quoting from Psalm 118:26. They may not have been intentionally referring to Jesus when they said this. See the General Comment on 11:9–10 below.

in the name of the Lord: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in the name of the Lord means “as the representative of the Lord.” It describes a person whom God had sent to be his messenger or spokesman.

the Lord: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as the Lord means “master, one who has authority over others.” Here it refers to God. It is a translation of God’s personal name in Hebrew.

Here are some other ways to translate Lord:

Master/Chief

Ruler

In some languages people may not naturally use a word that means “master” to refer to God. If speakers of your language do not understand that your word for “Lord” refers to God in this context, here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use your word for God.

- Use your word for God and indicate that he is the Lord. For example:

God the Lord

Master God

If you include the word for God in your translation of Lord, you may want to include a footnote to give the literal Greek meaning. For example:

Here the Greek text is literally “Lord.”

See Lord, Context 2, in the Glossary.

Mark 11:10

Section 11:1–11: People gladly welcomed Jesus to Jerusalem

When Jesus entered Jerusalem in this section, many people were very excited. He entered Jerusalem as a gentle and humble king would enter a city. Many people praised him in a way that showed that they wanted him to be their king (11:8). Some people believed that he was the Messiah that the Jews had been awaiting for many generations.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus’ Triumphal Entry into Jerusalem (NRSV)

Many people celebrate as Jesus enters Jerusalem

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:1–11 and Luke 19:28–40. See also John 12:12–19.

Paragraph 11:8–10

This paragraph continues the story about Jesus coming to Jerusalem, riding on a young donkey. You may need to make it explicit in your translation of 11:8–10 that he was riding the young donkey.

The people honored Jesus and shouted out words of joy and praise. See the General Comment on 11:9–10 at the end of 11:10b for advice about how to translate what the people were shouting.

11:10a

“Blessed is the coming kingdom of our father David!”

- God favors the coming kingdom that is like the kingdom of our father David!
- God is pleased that a new king will rule as King David our ancestor did!
- A king like our ancestor David is coming to reign with/under God’s blessing/favor!

Blessed is the coming kingdom of our father David!:

There is a textual issue here. Some Greek manuscripts repeat the clause “in the name of the Lord” from 11:9b. (1) Most English versions follow the Greek manuscripts that do not repeat this phrase. For example, the RSV says: “Blessed is the kingdom of our father David that is coming!” (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NJB, ESV, NET, NASB, REB, GW, NLT, CEV, JBP, NCV). (2) The KJV follows the manuscripts that repeat the clause in the name of the Lord. For example: “Blessed [be] the kingdom of our father David, that cometh in the name of the Lord.” (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1) and do not include this clause here. Verse 11:10a is an expression of praise. It is parallel to the one in 11:9b. In some languages it may be possible to use parallel expressions in these two verse parts. For example:

^{9b}God has blessed/favored the one who comes in the name of the Lord! ^{10a}He has blessed/favored the coming kingdom of our father David!

In many languages it may be necessary to use a different expression in 11:10a than in 11:9b. For example:

^{9b}God has done good things for the one who comes in his name. ^{10a}The coming kingdom of our father David is worthy of praise!

See bless, Meaning 2, in the Glossary.

the coming kingdom of our father David: The word kingdom refers here to a king’s activity of ruling, to his rule. It does not refer mainly to the country or territory that he rules. See how you translated this word in 3:24a.

The word kingdom refers here to the rule of the king. The word coming indicates here that the rule/reign was being established. The people probably implied that Jesus was coming into Jerusalem as the king to establish his kingdom.

Here are some other ways to say the coming kingdom:

the kingdom that is being established

the rule/government that is beginning

the kingdom that will be/exist

Most Jews were expecting a time when a new king (the Messiah) would rule. He would be a descendant of King David, who had lived long before. In this context they were praising Jesus as that king who was coming to rule.

Be careful not to translate this in a way that means that David himself was coming to rule. You may need to make this clear by translating as follows:

the coming kingdom/time that will be like the time when our father David ruled

...the time when a new king will rule. This time will be like when our father David was king.

You may want to add a footnote reference to 2 Samuel 7:11–13. There God promised King David that he would make one of David’s descendants a king who would rule God’s people forever.

our father David: The phrase our father David means “our ancestor David.” David was one of the great kings of Israel who had lived many years before the time that Jesus was on the earth.

11:10b

“Hosanna in the highest!”

- Praise God in heaven!”
- Praise God, who lives in heaven!”
- May God, who lives in heaven, be praised!”

Hosanna in the highest!: The exact meaning of the phrase Hosanna in the highest is not clear. Most English versions translate it as an expression of praise to God.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Translate in the highest as “heaven,” and add it to an expression of praise to God. For example:

Praise the one in heaven

Praise to God in heaven! (NCV)

Praise God who is/lives in heaven

- Translate in the highest as “God.” For example, the GNT says:

Praise be to God! (GNT)

Hosanna: You should translate the expression Hosanna the same way you did in 11:9a.

General Comment on 11:9–10

Notice that the BSB puts separate quotation marks around each of the four exclamations that the people shouted in 11:9a–10b. This indicates that different people were shouting different words of joy and praise. Other versions like the GNT put only one set of quotation marks around all of 11:9a–10b. If you use quotation marks in your translation, you will need to decide where to put them. You will need to decide what is the clearest and most natural way to mark the four things that the people shouted.

Mark 11:11

Section 11:1–11: People gladly welcomed Jesus to Jerusalem

When Jesus entered Jerusalem in this section, many people were very excited. He entered Jerusalem as a gentle and humble king would enter a city. Many people praised him in a way that showed that they wanted him to be their king (11:8). Some people believed that he was the Messiah that the Jews had been awaiting for many generations.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus’ Triumphal Entry into Jerusalem (NRSV)

Many people celebrate as Jesus enters Jerusalem

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:1–11 and Luke 19:28–40. See also John 12:12–19.

11:11a

Then Jesus entered Jerusalem and went into the temple courts.

- ¶ Then Jesus entered Jerusalem and went to the temple.
- ¶ When Jesus arrived in the city of Jerusalem, he went to the temple courtyards.

Then: The BSB uses Then as a connecting word to introduce the next part of the story. Another way to translate this is “So” (see the NLT.) In some languages, it may not be natural to begin this part of the story with a word that introduces a new event. Translate in the way that is natural for your own language.

Jesus entered Jerusalem and went into the temple

courts: This sentence indicates that Jesus entered the city of Jerusalem and then went to a particular place in the city, that is, the temple. You may need to make this clear in your translation. The translation should not imply that he went to two different locations, Jerusalem and the temple. For example:

Jesus entered the city of Jerusalem, where he went to the temple.

When Jesus arrived in Jerusalem, he entered the temple area.

went into the temple courts: The Greek word that the BSB translates as temple courts normally refers to the temple building and the walls and courtyards that surrounded it. In this context, this word refers to the large outer courtyard and not to the temple building itself. Only members of the tribe of Levi were allowed to enter the inner parts of the temple. Jesus was not from the tribe of Levi.

In some languages, some of this information may need to be made explicit. For example:

went into the courtyard of the temple

went to the outside/outdoor area of the temple

temple: The Greek word that the BSB translates as temple refers to the temple building and the walls and courtyards that surrounded it. The temple was in Jerusalem and was the most important place where Jews worshiped God.

Here are some other ways to translate the word temple:

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

house/building of God

house/place of sacrifice

holy/sacred house

- If your language has a word for “temple,” consider using it. But you may need to modify it by saying:

temple of the Jews/Lord

big/great temple

Be sure to use a different term from the one you have chosen for “synagogue” (in 1:21b). There was only one temple, but there were many synagogues throughout the land of Israel where the Jews met regularly for worship.

See temple, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information about the temple and how to translate it.

11:11b**He looked around at everything,**

- He looked at everything there,
- He looked at one thing and then another, everywhere there.

He looked around at everything: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as He looked around at everything could also be expressed as follows:

He looked at one thing and then another, everywhere in the temple

11:11c**but since it was already late,**

- and then, because it was late in the afternoon,
- It was already late in the day,

but since it was already late: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as but since it was already late is literally “the hour now being late.” The BSB makes explicit what the Greek grammar implies: that this clause is the reason for the following one.

late: The word late in this context means late in the day, probably between six and eight o’clock in the evening. There was probably still enough daylight for the short walk from Jerusalem to Bethany. You could translate this as:

late afternoon

evening

toward sunset

11:11d**He went out to Bethany with the Twelve.**

- he and his twelve disciples went to Bethany.
- so he and his twelve followers left Jerusalem and went to the village of Bethany.

He went out: The words He went out indicate that Jesus left the city of Jerusalem. He did not just leave the temple courtyards. You may need to make this explicit in your translation.

to Bethany: Jesus went from Jerusalem to a nearby village called Bethany. Bethany was about three kilometers (two miles) away from Jerusalem. Jesus spent the night there.

with the Twelve: The phrase the Twelve refers to Jesus' twelve disciples. They went with him to Bethany. Translate the term the Twelve the same way you did in 4:10a.

Mark 11:12

Section 11:12-14: Jesus cursed a fruitless fig tree

The events in this section took place the day after Jesus entered Jerusalem on a colt (11:1-11). Later that day, Jesus and his disciples had gone from Jerusalem to the nearby village of Bethany to spend the night (11:11). The next day, they went back to Jerusalem. This story occurs that day as they were walking back to Jerusalem.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus condemns a fig tree

The fig tree with no fruit

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:18-19 and Luke 13:6-9.

11:12a

The next day, when they had left Bethany,

- ¶ When Jesus and his disciples left Bethany the next morning, (CEV)
- ¶ On the following day, when Jesus and his followers were leaving the village of Bethany,

11:12b

Jesus was hungry.

- Jesus/he was/felt hungry.
- Jesus wanted to eat something.

11:12a-b

The next day: The phrase The next day refers to the day after the events in 11:1-11 took place. Another way to translate this phrase is as in the NLT:

The next morning

when they had left Bethany: Jesus and his disciples went from the village of Bethany back to Jerusalem. Since this is a new section, you may need to make some of this information explicit. For example:

as Jesus and his disciples were leaving the village of Bethany

had left: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as had left means “went out.” The RSV translates it as “came out” and the GNT says “coming back from.” Jesus was returning from Bethany to Jerusalem. Use the verb in your language that would be most natural in this context.

Mark 11:13

Section 11:12-14: Jesus cursed a fruitless fig tree

The events in this section took place the day after Jesus entered Jerusalem on a colt (11:1-11). Later that day, Jesus and his disciples had gone from Jerusalem to the nearby village of Bethany to spend the night (11:11). The next day, they went back to Jerusalem. This story occurs that day as they were walking back to Jerusalem.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus condemns a fig tree

The fig tree with no fruit

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:18-19 and Luke 13:6-9.

11:13a

Seeing in the distance a fig tree in leaf,

- He saw in the distance a fig tree covered with leaves, (GNT)
- Some distance away he could see a fig tree with leaves on it,

Seeing in the distance a fig tree in leaf: This clause has new information. Therefore, it may be more natural in your language to make it the main clause of the sentence instead of a background clause. For example:

Jesus saw a fig tree in leaf in the distance.

in the distance: The phrase in the distance is general. The tree was close enough that Jesus could see that it was covered with leaves. But it was far enough away that he could not see whether it had any fruit. Translate this phrase with a general expression that means a (short) distance away.

fig tree: A fig tree was a common and important tree in Israel. Fig trees normally produced small, edible fruit called “figs.”

If speakers of your language are not familiar with the fig tree, here are some other ways to translate it:

tree with a fruit called “fig”

fruit tree

in leaf: The phrase in leaf means that the tree had leaves on it. Fig trees lose all their leaves at a certain season of the year, and at another time of the year they grow new leaves.

11:13b

He went to see if there was any fruit on it.

- so he went to see if he could find any figs on it. (GNT)
- and he approached it to see if there was fruit on it.

He went to see if there was any fruit on it: This clause indicates that Jesus went close to the tree because he wanted to see if there was fruit on it.

any fruit on it: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as any fruit is literally “anything” (as in the RSV). It is recommended that you make it explicit in your translation that Jesus was looking for figs or fruit, as most English versions do. If you translate literally with a general word like “anything,” readers may think that Jesus wanted to see if he could find a bird or animal in the tree.

11:13c

But when He reached it, He found nothing on it except leaves,

- But when he came to it, he found only leaves, (GNT)
- When he arrived at the tree, he saw that it had produced/grown only leaves. There was no fruit,

But when He reached it: The words reached it here mean “arrived at the tree.” They do not mean that he stretched out his arm toward the tree.

He found nothing on it except leaves: Jesus did not find any fruit on the tree, only leaves. Jesus expected to find the early fruit that the tree produces before the mature fruit that develops later. People who were poor or hungry would eat these early figs. If a tree did

not produce these early figs, it was a sign that mature figs would not grow later.

11:13d

since it was not the season for figs.

- because it was not the season/time for ripe figs.
- because it was not the time of the year for figs/fruit to be ripe.

since it was not the season for figs: The word since introduces the reason Jesus found nothing but leaves on the tree: it was not the season. This means that it was not the right time of the year to find mature fruit on the tree. (But Jesus did expect to find the early fruit.)

If your language must be specific about the season, you should say that it was not yet the season for ripe figs (mature fruit). In other words, there were no full, ripe figs because that season had not yet come. It was not because the season had passed.

It may be helpful to add a footnote to explain why Jesus expected to find fruit on the tree when it was not the season for figs. For example:

It was not the season for ripe figs. However, because there were leaves on the tree, there should have been early figs that people could eat. The tree had produced no fruit at all, even when early figs were expected.

General Comment on 11:13c–d

In 11:13c–d, 11:13d expresses the reason for the result in 11:13c. In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of these clauses. For example:

^{13d} But it was not the season for figs. ^{13c}That is why, when he reached the tree, he found nothing but leaves.

^{13d} But it was not the season for figs. ^{13c}So, when he reached the tree, he found nothing but leaves.

Mark 11:14

Section 11:12–14: Jesus cursed a fruitless fig tree

The events in this section took place the day after Jesus entered Jerusalem on a colt (11:1–11). Later that day, Jesus and his disciples had gone from Jerusalem to the nearby village of Bethany to spend the night (11:11). The next day, they went back to Jerusalem. This story occurs that day as they were walking back to Jerusalem.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus condemns a fig tree

The fig tree with no fruit

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:18–19 and Luke 13:6–9.

11:14a

Then He said to the tree, “May no one ever eat of your fruit again.”

- Then he spoke to the tree and said, “Tree, may no one eat figs from you again.”
- Jesus said to the fig tree, “No one shall ever eat figs from you again!” (GNT)
- He commanded that the tree never again bear any fruit.

Then He said to the tree: Jesus spoke directly to the fig tree. This is unusual, so you may need to make it clear that he was speaking to the tree. He was not speaking to the people who were with him. For example:

And he addressed the fig tree (NJB)

Then he spoke to the tree and said, “Tree...”

May no one ever eat of your fruit again: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as May no one ever eat of your fruit again means that the tree would never again produce fruit. It does not mean that the tree would produce fruit but no one would be able to eat it. One way to make this clear is to say:

May no one eat figs from you again. You shall never again produce fruit!

Jesus pronounced judgment on the fig tree. He did not ask or wish that it not bear fruit. He commanded it never to bear fruit again. He was making a very strong statement. The result was that the fig tree died (11:20). You may need to translate the command as a statement, as in the GNT:

No one shall ever eat figs from you again!

It may be clearer in your language to use an indirect quote here. For example:

So he commanded that the tree never again bear any fruit.

11:14b

And His disciples heard this statement.

- And his disciples heard him say that.
- Jesus’ followers heard what he said to the fig tree.

And His disciples heard this statement: Jesus’ disciples were close enough to hear what Jesus said to the fig tree. Be careful not to translate this in a way that means that Jesus said it to them.

This statement is important for connecting this with the rest of the story about the fig tree in 11:20.

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means “learners” who are in a special relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. Disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

students/learners

apprentices

followers

See how you translated this term at 2:15b and 11:1c.

Mark 11:15

Section 11:15–19: Jesus expelled the buyers and sellers from the temple courtyard

Jesus and his disciples arrived in the city of Jerusalem again. Jesus went back to the temple, where he had looked around at everything the day before. This time he showed his disapproval of the people there who were buying, selling, and exchanging people’s money. He overturned their tables and commanded other people to stop carrying things through the temple area. He quoted Scripture to show that what they were doing was wrong.

The Jewish leaders did not like what Jesus did. They were afraid of the influence he had on the crowds of people. They looked for a way to kill Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Goes to the Temple (GNT)

Jesus Cleanses the Temple (ESV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:10–17 and Luke 19:45–48. See also John 2:13–22.

Paragraph 11:15–17

When Jesus arrived in Jerusalem, it was the time of the year when the Jews celebrated a festival called the Passover. Many people came to Jerusalem at Passover time to offer sacrifices to God.

11:15a

When they arrived in Jerusalem, Jesus entered the temple courts

- ¶ When they came to Jerusalem, Jesus went into the temple courtyard (GW)
- ¶ When Jesus and his disciples arrived in Jerusalem, Jesus went to the area surrounding the temple.

When they arrived in Jerusalem: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as When they arrived in Jerusalem is literally “And they came to Jerusalem” (as in the RSV). The previous section tells about what happened as Jesus and his disciples were walking from Bethany to Jerusalem. This section begins with their arrival in Jerusalem.

Here are some other ways to translate these introductory words:

On reaching Jerusalem (NIV)

When Jesus and his disciples arrived in Jerusalem

Jesus entered the temple courts: The Greek word that the BSB translates as temple courts is literally “temple,” as in most English versions. The temple consisted of the temple building and the walls and courtyards that surrounded it. People did not meet inside the temple building because only the priests could go there.

In this context some English versions have made this clear by translating the Greek word as “temple area” (NIV) or temple courts (BSB). You may want to do this also if your word or phrase for “temple” would

make readers think that Jesus entered the temple building.

Some ways to translate the term temple courts are:

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

courtyard of the house of God

area around the house of sacrifice

courtyard of the holy/sacred house

- If your language has a word for “temple,” consider using it here. But you may need to modify it by saying:

courtyard of the temple of the Lord/Jews

big/great temple courtyard

There are more translation examples in the note on “temple” in 11:11a. See how you translated the word there.

See also the word temple, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information about the temple and how to translate it.

11:15b

and began to drive out those who were buying

- and began chasing away the people who were buying things
- He began to force the people who were buying things to offer to God to leave.

11:15c

and selling there.

- and the people who were selling things there.
- He also forced others who were selling these things there to leave.

11:15b–c

and began to drive out: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as began to drive out means that Jesus began to force some people to leave. For example, the CEV says:

began chasing out

those who were buying and selling there: The phrase those who were buying and selling there refers to people who were in the temple courts buying and selling items for sacrifice. Merchants had begun to use

the outer temple courtyard as a place to sell the things that people needed in order to make sacrifices.

It is implied that Jesus drove out these people and their customers because they should not have been buying and selling inside the temple courtyard. You may need to make this clear. For example:

he forced certain people to leave because they were buying and selling there

You should make it clear in your translation that those who were buying (the customers) and those who were...selling (the merchants) were different groups of people. In some languages, it may be more natural to mention those who were...selling before those who were buying.

those who were buying: In some languages, it may be more natural to say what the people bought. For example:

those who were buying things

those who were buying things to sacrifice

those who were buying animals to sacrifice/offer to God

those who were...selling: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as those who were...selling is literally “the ones selling.” This refers to merchants who sold things in the temple area. They sold animals, wine, oil, and salt and other things that people needed for sacrifices.

The courtyard was the only part of the temple that Gentiles (non-Jews) were allowed to enter to worship God. The merchants were making this place like a marketplace so that it was difficult for people to pray and worship there. Many commentators also believe that the merchants charged too much for the things that they sold.

You may prefer to add a footnote with this information. See the General Comment below.

General Comment on 11:15b–c

If your readers would find it confusing that people bought and sold things in the temple, it may be helpful to use a footnote. For example:

If someone needed to buy an animal to offer as a sacrifice to God in the temple, these merchants

would sell it to him. They also sold other things that people needed for the sacrifices, such as wine, oil, and salt. Jesus did not want them to buy and sell things in the temple. He wanted the temple courts to be a place where people could pray.

11:15d

He overturned the tables of the money changers

- He turned over the tables where people exchanged money
- He knocked over/down the tables of those who changed money.

11:15e

and the seats of those selling doves.

- and the benches/chairs of the people who sold doves,
- He also knocked over/down the seats/chairs of those who sold pigeons,

11:15d–e

He overturned the tables...and the seats: The Greek word that the BSB translates as overturned means “turned upside down” or “knocked down.” Jesus turned the tables and benches upside down to show that these things did not belong in the temple courtyard.

the tables of the money changers: The phrase the tables of the money changers refers to small tables where these merchants piled their coins.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the tables at which people exchanged coins

the tables where people traded coins

the money changers: The money changers were merchants who exchanged Roman and Greek coins for Jewish coins. The Roman and Greek coins had images on them. These images were offensive to Jews. So the Jewish leaders did not permit people to use these coins to pay the temple tax or buy animals for sacrifice. They were required to use Jewish coins. The people who came to Jerusalem paid a temple tax once a year. The temple tax was due just before Passover. This provided money to maintain the temple and the temple area. Many also needed to buy an animal or something to give the priest to offer as a sacrifice. But some coins had images on them of gods or of people whom other people worshipped as gods. The Jewish religious leaders would not allow people to use those kinds of coins as part of worship in the temple area.

So these businessmen would take these coins with the images and exchange them for Judean coins that the Jewish religious leaders would accept. These businessmen made a profit doing this. It may be helpful to have a footnote in your translation that explains this.

the seats of those selling doves: The phrase the seats of those selling doves refers to the places where the merchants who sold doves sat. They sold doves to people who could not afford to bring a larger animal, such as a sheep or a goat, for a sacrifice.

seats: The Greek word that the BSB translates as seats also means “chairs” (as in the NET) or “benches” (as in the NIV).

doves: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as doves describes a family of birds that are called either “dove” or “pigeon” in English. (See the note at 1:10c.) These birds were used for sacrifices by people who could not afford more expensive animals such as sheep or cows.

Mark 11:16

Section 11:15–19: Jesus expelled the buyers and sellers from the temple courtyard

Jesus and his disciples arrived in the city of Jerusalem again. Jesus went back to the temple, where he had looked around at everything the day before. This time he showed his disapproval of the people there who were buying, selling, and exchanging people’s money. He overturned their tables and commanded other people to stop carrying things through the temple area. He quoted Scripture to show that what they were doing was wrong.

The Jewish leaders did not like what Jesus did. They were afraid of the influence he had on the crowds of people. They looked for a way to kill Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Goes to the Temple (GNT)

Jesus Cleanses the Temple (ESV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:10–17 and Luke 19:45–48. See also John 2:13–22.

Paragraph 11:15–17

When Jesus arrived in Jerusalem, it was the time of the year when the Jews celebrated a festival called the Passover. Many people came to Jerusalem at Passover time to offer sacrifices to God.

11:16

And He would not allow anyone to carry merchandise through the temple courts.

- and he would not let anyone carry anything through the Temple courtyards. (GNT)
- and he commanded people to stop carrying things/ loads through the area around the temple.
- and he commanded people carrying loads through the temple courtyards, “Stop doing that!”

In 11:15 Jesus stopped the activities of three groups of people:

1. people who were buying (11:15b),
2. people who were selling (11:15c–d),
3. people who were changing money (11:15d).

Here in 11:16, he stopped the activities of a fourth group of people: people who used the temple courtyard as a pathway to carry things through. Passing through the temple courtyard may have been a shorter route from one part of the city to another. But when people did that, they showed that they did not respect the place of worship. There are multiple interpretations of what this verse “and would not allow anyone to carry merchandise through the temple courts” might refer to: (1) The court was not to be used as a shortcut by merchants bringing goods from the Mount of Olives to the city itself. (France page 444, TRT page 148, UBS page 351, among others) (2) No vessel of any kind (no food or drink) was to be carried within the temple unless it had been prepared for sacrifice. (Evans page 173, Josephus 2.8.106, 2.8.109) (3) No trader was to be allowed in the temple (TRT page 148).

He would not allow anyone to carry merchandise through the temple courts: This means that Jesus stopped people from carrying things through the temple courtyards. He probably did this by commanding them to stop. Translate this in the way that is most natural in your language. For example:

commanded people to stop

commanded people, “Stop...”

prohibited people

merchandise: The Greek word that the BSB translates as merchandise is a very general word. It could be translated literally as “things” or as “anything” (as in the RSV). This Greek word is sometimes translated with a more specific meaning, according to the context. For example, in John 19:29 the BSB translates this same Greek word as a “jar” of wine vinegar. Because the context here does not suggest a specific meaning, it is recommended that you use as general a term as possible. For example:

carry anything (GNT)

carry loads

temple courts: The Greek word that the BSB translates as temple courts is the same word as in 11:15a, where the BSB translated it as “temple courts.” You can probably use the same term in both verses. See temple, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information about the temple and how to translate it.

Mark 11:17

Section 11:15–19: Jesus expelled the buyers and sellers from the temple courtyard

Jesus and his disciples arrived in the city of Jerusalem again. Jesus went back to the temple, where he had looked around at everything the day before. This time he showed his disapproval of the people there who were buying, selling, and exchanging people’s money. He overturned their tables and commanded other people to stop carrying things through the temple area. He quoted Scripture to show that what they were doing was wrong.

The Jewish leaders did not like what Jesus did. They were afraid of the influence he had on the crowds of people. They looked for a way to kill Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Goes to the Temple (GNT)

Jesus Cleanses the Temple (ESV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:10–17 and Luke 19:45–48. See also John 2:13–22.

Paragraph 11:15–17

When Jesus arrived in Jerusalem, it was the time of the year when the Jews celebrated a festival called the Passover. Many people came to Jerusalem at Passover time to offer sacrifices to God.

11:17a

Then Jesus began to teach them, and He declared, “Is it not written:

- He taught them and asked, “Do you not know what God caused to be written?”
- He then taught the people: “It is written in the Scriptures that God said, (GNT)
- And he told them that they should know what it says in God’s word about the temple:

Then Jesus began to teach them, and He declared:

In Greek, the two verbs that the BSB translates as teach and declared are in a form that sometimes shows continuing action. For example, the NRSV says:

He was teaching and saying...

The NIV shows this with the word “as”:

as he taught

The significance of the continuing form may be that Jesus said these things while he was chasing away those who were desecrating the temple court. However, you may also translate 11:17a simply as a way to introduce what Jesus taught. For example, the GNT says:

He then taught the people

them: It is not clear to whom the pronoun them refers. Jesus’ disciples and others probably watched as he chased away those who did not respect the temple. He probably taught those who were watching him, and any of the people he chased who were still close enough to hear him.

It is recommended that you use a general expression for those he taught, such as them or “the people” (GNT).

Is it not written...?: This is a rhetorical question. The negative form of the question implies that the answer is “Yes, it certainly is written.” Jesus asked this question to rebuke the merchants and others because they disregarded Scripture about the purpose of the temple. He rebuked them by emphasizing what every Jewish person should know from the Scriptures: God

intended the temple to be a house of prayer for people of all nations.

There are at least two ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the REB says:

Does not scripture say...?

- As a statement. For example, the NCV says:

It is written in the Scriptures

Use whichever form is most natural to express this rebuke in your language.

The expression *Is it not written* or “it is written” is often used in the New Testament to refer to the writings of the Old Testament. Some English versions make this information explicit:

It is written in the Scriptures that God said (GNT)

The Scriptures say (CEV)

See also the notes on 1:2a and 7:6b, where similar expressions occur.

11:17b

‘My house will be called a house of prayer for all the nations’?

- God said, ‘People will call my holy house a place where all the peoples come to pray.’
- ‘My Temple will be called a house of prayer for the people of all nations.’” (GNT)
- that God’s house was to be a place where people from all countries pray.

‘My house will be called a house of prayer for all the nations’: Here Jesus was quoting from Isaiah 56:7. God had said that he intended for his temple to be a place where people from all nations would pray to him and worship him. You might want to include a footnote reference to this Old Testament passage.

In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech for the Old Testament quotation. For example:

...he said to them, “It is written that God’s house will be called a house of prayer. But you have made it a den of robbers.”

In some languages it may be more natural to use direct speech for both Jesus’ words and the Old Testa-

ment quotation. If that is true in your language, be careful to show this by the way you punctuate the verse.

My house: Here the expression *My house* refers to the temple in Jerusalem. In the Old Testament, “the house of God” was a common way to refer to the temple. In some languages it may be necessary to use an expression which is more explicit than *My house*. For example:

My temple (GNT)

This place where people come to worship me

You should use an expression here that is different from the expressions you used for synagogue and church.

My: The pronoun *My* refers to God. Make sure that in your translation it is clear that it does not refer to Jesus or Isaiah. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example, the GNT says:

God said, “My Temple...”

will be called: This is a passive verb form. It could also be expressed as an active verb. For example:

People will call...

The verse Jesus quoted from Isaiah was what God said would be true. Isaiah wrote about what would happen in the future. People would call the temple “a house of prayer” because this is what it would be. Jesus quoted this as a command. He expected people to treat the temple as a “house of prayer for all nations.”

a house of prayer for all the nations: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as a house of prayer refers here to a place where people from all nations can pray. This means a place where all ethnic groups can speak to God, praise him, thank him, and make requests of him.

It does not refer to a house where people pray for all nations. It may be helpful to include a reference to God. For example:

a place where people from all nations pray to me

a place where people from all ethnic groups can speak to me

The word for house in this expression can be more general than the word in the previous expression “My house.”

all the nations: The Greek word that the BSB translates as nations refers to ethnic groups, that is, to groups of people, rather than to political states or countries. The word often refers specifically to Gentiles, that is, people other than Jewish people. But here it refers in general to Jews and Gentiles, that is, to all the peoples of the earth.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

people from all nations (NCV)

people from all ethnic groups (TRT)

Use a natural expression in your language that refers to all groups of people on the earth.

11:17c

But you have made it ‘a den of robbers.’”

- But you^(plur) have made it like a den/cave full of robbers.”
- Jesus continued, “But you^(plur) are using it as a robbers’ meeting/gathering place.”
- But they had turned it into a hideout for thieves.

This part of the verse is not part of the quotation from Isaiah. Jesus himself directly condemned what was happening in the temple. You may need to make this clear by translating as follows:

Jesus continued...

But you: The words But you introduce an emphatic contrast to God’s purpose for the temple that Jesus stated in 11:17b. The pronoun you refers to the people who were buying, selling, exchanging money, and carrying things through the temple courtyard. Jesus indicated that their actions violated God’s purpose for the temple. Express this contrast in a natural way in your language.

have made it: The phrase that the BSB translates as have made it here indicates that the people treated God’s temple as if it were a meeting place for robbers. They cheated people in God’s own temple.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

You are using it as...

But you have turned it into... (GNT)

‘a den of robbers.’: The phrase a den of robbers is a metaphor. Jesus was comparing a den of robbers to the temple. You may need to make this clear by translating as follows:

But you have made it like a den of robbers.

But you are using the temple as a place for robbers.

Jesus was quoting this phrase from Scripture to describe how the people were acting toward the temple and toward God. They were like robbers in two ways:

1. They cheated people by charging them too much when they sold them things.
2. They cheated the people by using the temple courts as a marketplace, so that they were not able to pray there as God wanted.

The phrase a den of robbers is from Jeremiah 7:11. Some English versions, including the BSB, punctuate the phrase den of robbers as a quotation. Consider if you want to do this in your translation. You may also want to include a footnote reference to Jeremiah 7:11.

den: The Greek word that the BSB translates as den describes a “cave” or “hole” large enough for people to enter. There were many caves in that area. It was common for robbers to use these caves as places to live or hide.

In your translation, you could use an expression for a place where there are many thieves or a place where thieves hide. If you do not have a particular expression for this, you could describe this as:

a hideout for robbers

a place where robbers meet

robbers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as robbers refers to men who attacked people who were traveling from one place to another. They would beat them and steal from them. Sometimes they would kill them.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

brigands

highwaymen

bandits

Mark 11:18

Section 11:15–19: Jesus expelled the buyers and sellers from the temple courtyard

Jesus and his disciples arrived in the city of Jerusalem again. Jesus went back to the temple, where he had looked around at everything the day before. This time he showed his disapproval of the people there who were buying, selling, and exchanging people's money. He overturned their tables and commanded other people to stop carrying things through the temple area. He quoted Scripture to show that what they were doing was wrong.

The Jewish leaders did not like what Jesus did. They were afraid of the influence he had on the crowds of people. They looked for a way to kill Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Goes to the Temple (GNT)

Jesus Cleanses the Temple (ESV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:10–17 and Luke 19:45–48. See also John 2:13–22.

11:18a

When the chief priests and scribes heard this,

- ¶ The chief priests and the scribes heard what had happened.
- ¶ When the chief priests and the experts in the Law of Moses heard what Jesus had said and done,

When the chief priests and scribes heard this: The word this indicates that the Jewish leaders heard what had happened. They heard what Jesus had said and done. They probably did not all hear directly the things Jesus said at the temple, but they all heard reports about what had happened.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

The chief priests and the scribes heard about this

When the chief priests and scribes heard what had happened

the chief priests and scribes: The chief priests and the scribes were two groups who were the leaders of the Jews. The chief priests were the leading priests, and the scribes were the experts in the law of Moses.

See how you translated these expressions in 8:31c.

chief priests: A Jewish priest was a man who offered sacrifices to God on behalf of the people. He also performed other rituals for them. The phrase chief priests refers to the leaders among these priests.

Here are some other ways to translate chief priests:

the leading/ruling priests

the elders among the Jewish sacrificers

the most prominent priests

See how you translated “priest” at 1:44b.

scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes refers to men who studied, interpreted, and taught the law of Moses. This word is sometimes translated as “teachers of the law,” as in the NIV. That is because the original work of these men was to copy the laws of Moses by hand. In New Testament times, this was no longer their main task.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

teachers of the Law of Moses (CEV)

teachers of religious law (NLT)

experts in the law

See teacher of the law in the Glossary.

11:18b

they looked for a way to kill Him.

- So they began to look for a way to bring about his death,
- they started to look for a way to kill him.
- they said to each other, “Let us find a way to kill him.”

they looked for a way to kill Him: The GNT makes explicit the logical connection between 11:18b and what precedes it in 11:18a:

...so they began looking for some way to kill Jesus.

looked for a way: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as looked for a way is literally “they were seeking how.” In other words, the religious leaders tried to find an opportunity to have Jesus put to death.

looked: The form of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as looked shows a continuing action. For example, the NRSV says:

they kept looking

to kill Him: The Jewish leaders did not plan to kill Jesus with their own hands. They wanted the Roman rulers to order their soldiers to kill Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

to bring about his death (REB)

to cause him to be killed/executed

to have him put to death

11:18c–d

For they were afraid of Him, because the whole crowd was astonished at His teaching: There are two reason clauses in 11:18c–d. For a way to change the order of these clauses, see the General Comment on 11:18a–d below.

11:18c

For they were afraid of Him,

- because they were afraid of him.
- They were afraid of him,

For they were afraid of Him: The phrase they were afraid of him means that the chief priests and the teachers of the law were afraid of Jesus. They were not afraid that Jesus would do something to them. Rather, they feared and resented him because he was popular with the people and influenced them. The religious leaders wanted to kill Jesus so that the people would not follow him.

11:18d

because the whole crowd was astonished at His teaching.

- They were afraid because all the people were astonished at/by his teaching.
- because many people listened in amazement to what he taught.

because the whole crowd was astonished at His teaching: This clause indicates the reason why the religious leaders feared Jesus (11:18c). It was because

of his influence on the people. For example, the GW says:

because he amazed all the crowds with his teaching

the whole crowd: The phrase the whole crowd may be a specific reference to the people who saw Jesus chase the merchants out of the temple. But it probably refers to the people in general. It does not mean literally that every person was amazed at Jesus’ teaching. You should translate the phrase in a way that refers generally to many people. See how you translated this phrase in 2:13b, where the BSB translates it as “All the people.”

astonished: The Greek word that the BSB translates as astonished also means “amazed” (as in the NIV). See how you translated this word in 1:22a.

His teaching: The phrase His teaching refers to everything Jesus taught the people. It does not only refer to the things he taught from Scripture as he chased people from the temple.

General Comment on 11:18a–d

There are two reason clauses in 11:18c–d. The clause “for they feared him” gives the reason that the religious leaders wanted to kill Jesus (11:18b). The clause “because the whole crowd was amazed at his teaching” gives the reason that they feared him. In some languages, it is more natural to change the order of these clauses so that the reason clauses come first. For example:

^{18d}The whole crowd was amazed at Jesus’ teaching. ^{18c}So the chief priests and teachers of the law were afraid of him. ^{18a}That is why, when they heard about this, ^{18b}they began to look for a way to kill him.

Mark 11:19

Section 11:15–19: Jesus expelled the buyers and sellers from the temple courtyard

Jesus and his disciples arrived in the city of Jerusalem again. Jesus went back to the temple, where he had looked around at everything the day before. This time he showed his disapproval of the people there who were buying, selling, and exchanging people’s money. He overturned their tables and commanded other people to stop carrying things through the temple area. He quoted Scripture to show that what they were doing was wrong.

The Jewish leaders did not like what Jesus did. They were afraid of the influence he had on the crowds of people. They looked for a way to kill Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Goes to the Temple (GNT)

Jesus Cleanses the Temple (ESV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:10–17 and Luke 19:45–48. See also John 2:13–22.

11:19

And when evening came, Jesus and His disciples went out of the city.

- ¶ When it was late afternoon, Jesus and his disciples left the city.

And when evening came: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as when evening came is literally “when it became late.” This is similar to the clause that the BSB translates as “it was already late” in 11:11c. It was probably about the same time of day, not long before sunset, in both verses.

Be sure to use a natural expression in your language for saying that it became a particular time of the day.

Jesus and His disciples went out of the city: There is a textual issue in this verse:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have “they went out.” For example, the RSV says:

And when evening came they went out of the city.
(NIV, GNT, RSV, ESV, GW, NASB, NET, NCV, NLT, REB)

1. Other Greek manuscripts have “he went out.” For example, the NJB says:

And when evening came he went out of the city.
(KJV, JBP, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), as most English versions do. Also, it is understood from the context that both Jesus and his disciples went out of the city. For example, the GNT says:

Jesus and his disciples left the city.

Mark 11:20

Section 11:20–26: Jesus used the withered fig tree as an example

The events in this section took place the morning after Jesus chased the merchants from the temple. On his way to Jerusalem the previous day, Jesus had spoken to a fig tree. He had said that no one would ever eat fruit from it again (11:12–14). In this section, 11:20–26, it was the next day. Jesus and his disciples were again walking from Bethany back to Jerusalem. They saw the same fig tree, which was now completely withered. It had died.

Jesus used the withered fig tree as an example to teach his disciples to trust God to do great things. Commentators think that what happened to the fig tree had a deeper meaning. The various interpretations include: (1) The withering of the fig tree at Jesus’ command was a symbol of God’s judgment on Jerusalem and the temple. (Kaiser, Evans page 182) thinks the judgment was of the temple.) France (page 444) mentions this interpretation but disagrees with it. That indicates that it might be good to check Kaiser on this matter, too. (2) The withering of the fig tree at Jesus’ command was a symbol of the coming judgment of Israel. It doesn’t seem necessary to give so much support for this. Lane (page 406) writes in his commentary: “Mark may have had in mind the passage from Hosea 9:16: The people of Israel are stricken. Their roots are dried up; they will bear no more fruit. And if they give birth, I will slaughter their beloved children. [NLT]” (3) The withering of the fig tree at Jesus’ command symbolized that the means of approaching God through worship at the temple was replaced so that now people would approach God through Jesus. (Edwards writes: “the fig tree thus symbolizes the temple: as the means of approach to God, the temple is fundamentally—‘from the roots’—replaced by Jesus as the center of Israel” page 346) He implied that he was able to make the fig tree wither because he trusted God. He told the disciples that their prayers would be answered if they trusted God. God would forgive their sins if they forgave others.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Power of Faith (NCV)

A Lesson from the Fig Tree (CEV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:19–22 and Matthew 6:14–15. See also Matthew 17:20, 18:35, and Luke 17:6.

11:20a

As they were walking back in the morning,

- ¶ Early next morning, as they passed by, (REB)
- ¶ While Jesus and his disciples were walking early in the morning, (GW)

As they were walking back in the morning: The Greek word that the BSB translates as in the morning is literally “early.” The context shows that this refers to the morning after the events in 11:12–19 (see 11:19).

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Next morning (NJB)

Early next morning (GNT)

As they were walking back: The pronoun they refers to Jesus and his disciples. You may need to make this clear since this is the beginning of a new section. For example, the GW says:

While Jesus and his disciples were walking

11:20b

they saw the fig tree withered from its roots.

- they saw the fig tree. It was dried up all the way to/ from its roots.
- they saw the fig tree again. It was completely dried up.

they saw the fig tree: The phrase the fig tree refers to the same fig tree that Jesus had cursed in 11:14. It may be helpful here to identify this as the same fig tree. For example:

they saw the fig tree again

they passed by the fig tree he had cursed (NLT)

However, 11:21 makes this clear, so most English versions do not make this explicit in 11:20b.

withered from its roots: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as withered from its roots indicates that the whole tree had dried up and was completely dead. In some languages it may be more natural to say:

withered down to the roots

You may need to make it clear that it was more than just the roots that had withered. For example, the CEV says:

completely dried up, roots and all

Mark 11:21

Section 11:20–26: Jesus used the withered fig tree as an example

The events in this section took place the morning after Jesus chased the merchants from the temple. On his way to Jerusalem the previous day, Jesus had spoken to a fig tree. He had said that no one would ever eat fruit from it again (11:12–14). In this section, 11:20–26, it was the next day. Jesus and his disciples were again walking from Bethany back to Jerusalem. They saw the same fig tree, which was now completely withered. It had died.

Jesus used the withered fig tree as an example to teach his disciples to trust God to do great things. Commentators think that what happened to the fig tree had a deeper meaning. The various interpretations include: (1) The withering of the fig tree at Jesus’ command was a symbol of God’s judgment on Jerusalem and the temple. (Kaiser, Evans page 182) thinks the judgment was of the temple.) France (page 444) mentions this interpretation but disagrees with it. That indicates that it might be good to check Kaiser on this matter, too. (2) The withering of the fig tree at Jesus’ command was a symbol of the coming judgment of Israel. It doesn’t seem necessary to give so much support for this. Lane (page 406) writes in his commentary: “Mark may have had in mind the passage from Hosea 9:16: The people of Israel are stricken. Their roots are dried up; they will bear no more fruit. And if they give birth, I will slaughter their beloved children. [NLT]” (3) The withering of the fig tree at Jesus’ command symbolized that the means of approaching God through worship at the temple was replaced so that now people would approach God through Jesus. (Edwards writes: “the fig tree thus symbolizes the temple: as the means of approach to God, the temple is fundamentally—‘from the roots’—replaced by Jesus as the center of Israel” page 346) He implied that he was able to make the fig tree wither because he trusted God. He told the disciples that their prayers would be answered if they trusted God. God would forgive their sins if they forgave others.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Power of Faith (NCV)

A Lesson from the Fig Tree (CEV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:19–22 and Matthew 6:14–15. See also Matthew 17:20, 18:35, and Luke 17:6.

11:21a

Peter remembered it and said,

- Peter remembered what Jesus had done/said and said to him,

Peter remembered it and said: The phrase Peter remembered indicates that Peter remembered what Jesus had said to the fig tree. If the verb remembered needs a direct object in your language, you could translate as follows:

Peter remembered what Jesus had said

and Peter, recalling what had happened, said to him (REB)

11:21b

“Look, Rabbi! The fig tree You cursed has withered.”

- “Look, Teacher! The fig tree that you^(sing) cursed/condemned has dried up!”
- “Teacher, look at that! The fig tree that you^(sing) commanded never to produce fruit again is dead!”

Look: The word Look is used as an exclamation here to draw attention to what follows. Peter wanted Jesus to notice that the fig tree had withered. In this context it probably also expresses Peter’s surprise. Use a natural way to express this in your language.

Rabbi: The word Rabbi is a transliteration of a Hebrew word that means “my great one.” At the time when Mark wrote this gospel message, people used this word as a title of respect for an important religious teacher or leader. It does not refer to a school teacher.

If you do not have a word that expresses this idea of a religious teacher, you can simply use the word “teacher” or “master.” If possible, use a word that implies that the teacher is respected. For example:

Teacher

my teacher/master

Use an expression in your language that is natural and shows proper respect. See how you translated this word in 9:5a.

The fig tree You cursed has withered: The word cursed refers to the words that Jesus spoke to the fig tree in 11:14. To curse someone or something is to call on God or the gods to harm that person or thing. Many languages will have a technical term for this that comes from the practices of traditional religion. In your translation, do not use a word that implies that Jesus had used magic or sorcery.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the tree to which you said, “May no one ever eat fruit from you again,” has withered

the tree that you commanded never to produce fruit again has withered

Mark 11:22

Section 11:20–26: Jesus used the withered fig tree as an example

The events in this section took place the morning after Jesus chased the merchants from the temple. On his way to Jerusalem the previous day, Jesus had spoken to a fig tree. He had said that no one would ever eat fruit from it again (11:12–14). In this section, 11:20–26, it was the next day. Jesus and his disciples were again walking from Bethany back to Jerusalem. They saw the same fig tree, which was now completely withered. It had died.

Jesus used the withered fig tree as an example to teach his disciples to trust God to do great things. Commentators think that what happened to the fig tree had a deeper meaning. The various interpretations include: (1) The withering of the fig tree at Jesus’ command was a symbol of God’s judgment on Jerusalem and the temple. (Kaiser, Evans page 182) thinks the judgment was of the temple.) France (page 444) mentions this interpretation but disagrees with it. That indicates that it might be good to check Kaiser on this matter, too. (2) The withering of the fig tree at Jesus’ command was a symbol of the coming judgment of Israel. It doesn’t seem necessary to give so much support for this. Lane (page 406) writes in his commentary: “Mark may have had in mind the passage from Hosea 9:16: The people of Israel are stricken. Their roots are dried up; they will bear no more fruit. And if they give birth, I will slaughter their beloved chil-

dren. [NLT]"(3) The withering of the fig tree at Jesus' command symbolized that the means of approaching God through worship at the temple was replaced so that now people would approach God through Jesus. (Edwards writes: "the fig tree thus symbolizes the temple: as the means of approach to God, the temple is fundamentally—"from the roots"—replaced by Jesus as the center of Israel" page 346) He implied that he was able to make the fig tree wither because he trusted God. He told the disciples that their prayers would be answered if they trusted God. God would forgive their sins if they forgave others.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Power of Faith (NCV)

A Lesson from the Fig Tree (CEV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:19–22 and Matthew 6:14–15. See also Matthew 17:20, 18:35, and Luke 17:6.

Paragraph 11:22–26

In 11:22–26, Jesus taught his disciples about trusting in God and praying. It may not be clear why he started doing this after Peter's remark about the fig tree. You should make it clear in your translation that what Jesus said in the following paragraph was a response to Peter's remark. Jesus used what happened to the fig tree as an example of the great things that can happen when people trust God.

11:22

"Have faith in God," Jesus said to them.

- ¶ Jesus answered them, "Have^(plur) faith/trust in God.
- ¶ In response, Jesus said to his disciples, "You^(plur) need to trust/believe in God.
- ¶ Jesus responded by telling his followers that they must trust God:

Have faith in God: The expression Have faith in God here is a command. It means that the people should believe that God can and will do whatever they ask him for in prayer.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

Have confidence in God

Trust God

Believe that God will do what you ask

See believe, Meaning 3, in the Glossary.

Jesus said to them: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Jesus said to them is literally "Jesus answering said to them." You may need to make it clear that Jesus was speaking to all the disciples, not just to Peter.

The BSB places the words Jesus said to them in the middle of what Jesus said. In Greek, these words occur at the beginning of 11:22. Place the words Jesus said to them where it is natural in your language.

Mark 11:23

Section 11:20–26: Jesus used the withered fig tree as an example

The events in this section took place the morning after Jesus chased the merchants from the temple. On his way to Jerusalem the previous day, Jesus had spoken to a fig tree. He had said that no one would ever eat fruit from it again (11:12–14). In this section, 11:20–26, it was the next day. Jesus and his disciples were again walking from Bethany back to Jerusalem. They saw the same fig tree, which was now completely withered. It had died.

Jesus used the withered fig tree as an example to teach his disciples to trust God to do great things. Commentators think that what happened to the fig tree had a deeper meaning. The various interpretations include: (1) The withering of the fig tree at Jesus' command was a symbol of God's judgment on Jerusalem and the temple. (Kaiser, Evans page 182) thinks the judgment was of the temple.) France (page 444) mentions this interpretation but disagrees with it. That indicates that it might be good to check Kaiser on this matter, too. (2) The withering of the fig tree at Jesus' command was a symbol of the coming judgment of Israel. It doesn't seem necessary to give so much support for this. Lane (page 406) writes in his commentary: "Mark may have had in mind the passage from Hosea 9:16: The people of Israel are stricken. Their roots are dried up; they will bear no more fruit. And if they give birth, I will slaughter their beloved children. [NLT]"(3) The withering of the fig tree at Jesus' command symbolized that the means of approaching God through worship at the temple was replaced so that now people would approach God through Jesus. (Edwards writes: "the fig tree thus symbolizes the temple: as the means of approach to God, the temple is fundamentally—"from the roots"—replaced by Jesus as the center of Israel" page 346) He implied that he was able to make the fig tree wither because he

trusted God. He told the disciples that their prayers would be answered if they trusted God. God would forgive their sins if they forgave others.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Power of Faith (NCV)

A Lesson from the Fig Tree (CEV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:19–22 and Matthew 6:14–15. See also Matthew 17:20, 18:35, and Luke 17:6.

Paragraph 11:22–26

In 11:22–26, Jesus taught his disciples about trusting in God and praying. It may not be clear why he started doing this after Peter's remark about the fig tree. You should make it clear in your translation that what Jesus said in the following paragraph was a response to Peter's remark. Jesus used what happened to the fig tree as an example of the great things that can happen when people trust God.

11:23a

“Truly I tell you

- Truly I tell you,^(plur)
- Listen^(plur) carefully, because this is important.
- “I assure you,^(plur)

Truly I tell you: There is a textual issue at the beginning of 11:23. Some Greek manuscripts begin this verse with a conjunction that is often translated as “For” or “Because.” (1) Most English versions follow the Greek manuscripts that do not include this conjunction. For example, the RSV says: “Truly, I say to you” (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NJB, ESV, NET, NASB, REB, GW, NLT, CEV, JBP, NCV). (2) The KJV follows the Greek manuscripts that include the conjunction For. For example: “For verily I say unto you,” (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1) and the manuscripts that do not include this conjunction. Jesus often used the words that the BSB translates as Truly I tell you to begin a statement that he wanted to emphasize. It indicates that the statement was important and totally reliable, and that people should listen carefully to it. Jesus used this phrase eight times in Mark. Here it introduces Jesus' assurance that God will answer prayer.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

I tell you the truth (NLT)

I assure you (GNT)

I can guarantee this truth (GW)

Be careful that the way you translate the expression Truly I tell you does not imply that other times Jesus did not tell the truth.

See how you translated this phrase in 10:15a.

11:23b

that if anyone says to this mountain,

- whoever speaks to this mountain and says,
- Someone might even say to this mountain,
- a person can even command this mountain

11:23c

‘Be lifted up and thrown into the sea,’

- ‘Mountain, be removed! Be tossed into the sea!’
- ‘Away with you! Jump/leap into the sea!’
- to pull itself up and throw itself into the sea.

11:23b–c

Jesus used the idea of commanding a mountain to throw itself into the sea as an example of something that seems impossible. It seemed impossible that a fig tree would dry up at a person's command. It seemed even more impossible that a mountain would throw itself into the sea at a person's command.

if anyone says to this mountain: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as if anyone says is literally “whoever says” (as in the RSV). Use an expression that can refer to anyone. One way to do this in English is to use the word “you” here. For example, the NCV says:

you can say to this mountain

to this mountain: The phrase this mountain refers to a mountain that Jesus and his disciples could see. Jesus may have been referring to the Mount of Olives where they were standing.

Be lifted up and thrown into the sea: This is a command that is addressed directly to the mountain, as though the mountain were a person that could hear and obey. It is like the command that Jesus gave to the fig tree in 11:14. But Jesus did not actually command a mountain to throw itself into the sea. He gave an example of what a person could say.

In some languages, it may be more natural to use indirect speech here. For example, the CEV says:

you can tell this mountain to get up and jump into the sea

Be lifted up and thrown: There are two commands here: Be lifted up and thrown. The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Be lifted up is literally “be taken away.”

Here are some other ways to express these commands:

Be pulled up and thrown (NJB)

Go, throw yourself (NIV)

11:23d-e and has no doubt in his heart but believes that it will happen: In 11:23d-e, Jesus used two expressions that have a similar meaning. One is a negative expression and the other is a positive expression:

1. He must not doubt in his heart, but
2. he must believe that it will happen.

Be careful to use a form in your language that shows that these two conditions are parallel and similar in meaning. They are necessary conditions that a person must fulfill before the mountain will obey his command.

11:23d and has no doubt in his heart

- and has no doubts in his heart/mind,
- If that person does not fail to trust God’s power,
- If that person does not doubt in his mind/heart that God will make it happen,

has no doubt: The word doubt indicates that a person is uncertain or wavers in his belief. He is not convinced that a certain thing will happen. He questions it in his mind.

Here are some other ways to translate has no doubt:

does not question whether it will happen

does not worry that it may not happen

does not think, “This may not really happen”

in his heart: In the New Testament, the word heart refers figuratively to the part of a person that makes him able to think and feel. It includes the mind, will, and emotions. In some languages people refer to this part of a person as the mind, throat, liver, or stomach.

You should use whichever word or phrase is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate in his heart:

inwardly

in your mind (NCV)

See how you translated the word heart in 7:19a.

In this context it may be more natural in some languages to make implicit the phrase in his heart. It may already be implied by the word doubt. For example:

and has no uncertainty

doesn’t doubt (GW)

11:23e but believes that it will happen,

- but trusts that what he says/commanded will happen,
- but believes that God will cause what he says to happen,
- but has confidence that it will be true,

but believes that it will happen: The verb believes here means that a person has confidence that God can and will do what the person trusts him to do. The person has confidence the God can and will act, even in extraordinary ways, in response to his need. In this context the person should believe that the mountain would get up and throw itself into the sea at his command.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

believes/trusts that it will happen

has confidence in God that he will cause what he said to happen

See how you translated the word “believes” in 9:23a-b. See also believe, Meaning 3, in the Glossary.

that it will happen: The word it refers to the command to the mountain “Go, throw yourself into the sea” in 11:23c.

11:23f it will be done for him.

- then it will happen for his sake.
- then God will do it for him.

- then God will indeed lift the mountain and throw it into the sea for him.

it will be done for him: There is a textual issue at the end of 11:23. Some Greek manuscripts have the clause “whatever he says” at the end of 11:23. (1) Most English versions follow the Greek manuscripts that do not include this clause. For example, the GNT says: “it will be done for him” (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NJB, ESV, GW, NLT, CEV, JBP, NCV). (2) The KJV follows the Greek manuscripts that include the clause whatever he says. For example: “he shall have whatsoever he saith” (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1) and the manuscripts that do not include this clause. The Greek clause that the BSB translates as it will be done for him is literally “it will be for him.” In some languages it is possible to express this as:

it will happen/occur for him

it will be so for his sake

In other languages, the meaning can be expressed with a passive clause, as in the BSB. If you need to express this as an active clause, you can say:

God will cause it to be so for his sake.

God will make it happen for him.

it will be done: The clause it will be done is the result of the conditions in 11:23d–e being met. In other words:

- ^{23d} if the person who commands the mountain to throw itself into the sea does not doubt, and
- ^{23e} if he believes that what he commanded will happen,
- ^{23f} then it will happen.

If you use a word or expression such as “then” to introduce a result in your language, you should use that expression here.

it: The pronoun it refers to the thing that the person with faith commanded. If you need to express this more explicitly, you can say:

God will cause the mountain to throw itself into the sea for him.

General Comment on 11:23a–f

In Greek and in the BSB, 11:23 is a long sentence with many clauses. You will probably need to break it into shorter sentences in your translation. You may also

need to change the order of the clauses to make the meaning clear. For example, the GW says:

^{23a}I can guarantee this truth: ^{23f}This is what will be done for ^{23d}someone who doesn’t doubt ^{23e}but believes what he says will happen: ^{23b}He can say to this mountain, ^{23c}“Be uprooted and thrown into the sea,” ^{23f}and it will be done for him.

Mark 11:24

Section 11:20–26: Jesus used the withered fig tree as an example

The events in this section took place the morning after Jesus chased the merchants from the temple. On his way to Jerusalem the previous day, Jesus had spoken to a fig tree. He had said that no one would ever eat fruit from it again (11:12–14). In this section, 11:20–26, it was the next day. Jesus and his disciples were again walking from Bethany back to Jerusalem. They saw the same fig tree, which was now completely withered. It had died.

Jesus used the withered fig tree as an example to teach his disciples to trust God to do great things. Commentators think that what happened to the fig tree had a deeper meaning. The various interpretations include: (1) The withering of the fig tree at Jesus’ command was a symbol of God’s judgment on Jerusalem and the temple. (Kaiser, Evans page 182) thinks the judgment was of the temple.) France (page 444) mentions this interpretation but disagrees with it. That indicates that it might be good to check Kaiser on this matter, too. (2) The withering of the fig tree at Jesus’ command was a symbol of the coming judgment of Israel. It doesn’t seem necessary to give so much support for this. Lane (page 406) writes in his commentary: “Mark may have had in mind the passage from Hosea 9:16: The people of Israel are stricken. Their roots are dried up; they will bear no more fruit. And if they give birth, I will slaughter their beloved children. [NLT]” (3) The withering of the fig tree at Jesus’ command symbolized that the means of approaching God through worship at the temple was replaced so that now people would approach God through Jesus. (Edwards writes: “the fig tree thus symbolizes the temple: as the means of approach to God, the temple is fundamentally—‘from the roots’—replaced by Jesus as the center of Israel” page 346) He implied that he was able to make the fig tree wither because he trusted God. He told the disciples that their prayers would be answered if they trusted God. God would forgive their sins if they forgave others.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Power of Faith (NCV)

A Lesson from the Fig Tree (CEV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:19–22 and Matthew 6:14–15. See also Matthew 17:20, 18:35, and Luke 17:6.

Paragraph 11:22–26

In 11:22–26, Jesus taught his disciples about trusting in God and praying. It may not be clear why he started doing this after Peter's remark about the fig tree. You should make it clear in your translation that what Jesus said in the following paragraph was a response to Peter's remark. Jesus used what happened to the fig tree as an example of the great things that can happen when people trust God.

11:24a

Therefore I tell you, whatever you ask for in prayer,

- Therefore I tell you^(plur) that whatever you ask for when you pray,
- So I assure you^(plur) of this: if you ask/beg God for anything,

Therefore I tell you: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as *Therefore I tell you* introduces the lesson to be learned from 11:23. Jesus' example in 11:23 is the basis for what he told his disciples in 11:24. In other words, God will do great things for those who trust him (11:23). That is the reason that they should believe when they pray. Then they will receive what they ask God for (11:24).

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

That is why I tell you (JBP)

For this reason I tell you (NET)

whatever you ask for in prayer: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as *whatever you ask for in prayer* is literally “everything that you pray and ask.” There are two ways to understand the use of the two verbs “pray” and “ask”:

1. The two verbs are expressing one action: praying, that is, “asking God in prayer.” For example, the CEV says:

Everything you ask for in prayer (BSB, CEV, NIV, RSV, ESV, KJV, REB, GW, NLT, NCV)

1. The two verbs are expressing two different actions: praying and asking. For example, the NJB says:

everything you ask and pray for (NJB, GNT, NASB, NET, JBP)

Most English versions follow interpretation (1), and it is recommended that you do so. You may need to express this with only one verb in your translation. For example:

whatever you pray for (GW)

everything you ask/beg God for

everything you request from God

11:24b

believe that you have received it,

- believe that you^(plur) have already received it,
- believe that you^(plur) will certainly receive it,

believe that you have received it: There is a textual issue here. (1) Some Greek manuscripts use a form of the verb *receive* that implies a past action. For example, the GNT says: “believe that you have received it” (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, ESV, NET, NASB, REB, GW, NLT, NCV, JBP). (2) Other Greek manuscripts use a form of the verb *receive* that implies a present action. For example, the KJV says: “believe that ye receive [them]” (KJV). Whether the verb is in the past or the present tense, it may be difficult to understand this phrase unless it is translated using the future tense. The clause *believe that you have received it* is a command. It is also a condition. If a person believes... (11:24b), then he will receive (11:24c). This is similar to what Jesus said in 11:23d–e.

The form of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as *have received* often refers to an event in the past. In this context many scholars think that it refers to believing that a future event is certain to happen. Use a natural way in your language to express this. For example:

believe that you will certainly receive it

believe that you are sure to receive it

believe that God has already granted your request

believe: The Greek word that the BSB translates as believe is the same word as in 11:23e. Translate it here as you did there. See believe, Meaning 3, in the Glossary.

11:24c

and it will be yours.

- then it will happen for you.^(plur)
- and then God will indeed give it to you.^(plur)

and it will be yours: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as and it will be yours is literally “and it will be for you.” This is very similar to 11:23f. If possible, use the same expression here that you used in 11:23f.

and: As in 11:23f, 11:24c shows the result of meeting the conditions in the previous clauses. You may need to connect 11:24c to what precedes with a word that introduces a result, such as “then,” rather than and.

it will be yours: You may need to make explicit that God will answer the prayer and give what is asked for. For example:

God will give it to you.

Mark 11:25

Section 11:20–26: Jesus used the withered fig tree as an example

The events in this section took place the morning after Jesus chased the merchants from the temple. On his way to Jerusalem the previous day, Jesus had spoken to a fig tree. He had said that no one would ever eat fruit from it again (11:12–14). In this section, 11:20–26, it was the next day. Jesus and his disciples were again walking from Bethany back to Jerusalem. They saw the same fig tree, which was now completely withered. It had died.

Jesus used the withered fig tree as an example to teach his disciples to trust God to do great things. Commentators think that what happened to the fig tree had a deeper meaning. The various interpretations include: (1) The withering of the fig tree at Jesus’ command was a symbol of God’s judgment on Jerusalem and the temple. (Kaiser, Evans page 182) thinks the judgment was of the temple.) France (page 444) mentions this interpretation but disagrees with it. That indicates that it might be good to check Kaiser on this matter, too. (2) The withering of the fig tree at Jesus’ command was a symbol of the coming judgment of Israel. It doesn’t seem necessary to give so much support for this. Lane (page 406) writes in his

commentary: “Mark may have had in mind the passage from Hosea 9:16: The people of Israel are stricken. Their roots are dried up; they will bear no more fruit. And if they give birth, I will slaughter their beloved children. [NLT]” (3) The withering of the fig tree at Jesus’ command symbolized that the means of approaching God through worship at the temple was replaced so that now people would approach God through Jesus. (Edwards writes: “the fig tree thus symbolizes the temple: as the means of approach to God, the temple is fundamentally—‘from the roots’—replaced by Jesus as the center of Israel” page 346) He implied that he was able to make the fig tree wither because he trusted God. He told the disciples that their prayers would be answered if they trusted God. God would forgive their sins if they forgave others.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Power of Faith (NCV)

A Lesson from the Fig Tree (CEV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:19–22 and Matthew 6:14–15. See also Matthew 17:20, 18:35, and Luke 17:6.

Paragraph 11:22–26

In 11:22–26, Jesus taught his disciples about trusting in God and praying. It may not be clear why he started doing this after Peter’s remark about the fig tree. You should make it clear in your translation that what Jesus said in the following paragraph was a response to Peter’s remark. Jesus used what happened to the fig tree as an example of the great things that can happen when people trust God.

11:25a

And when you stand to pray,

- And whenever you stand praying,
- Also, whenever you speak/talk to God,

And: Here Jesus added another important teaching about prayer. Some English versions indicate this with the word And. Other versions indicate it by starting a new paragraph. In some languages it may be necessary to supply a word such as “also” or “moreover.” These may help to make clear that Jesus is now teaching about a different aspect of prayer.

when you stand to pray: The main idea here is pray. The expression stand to pray refers to the fact that

in Jesus' time people usually stood when they prayed. Jesus was not teaching here that a person must stand to pray.

If the word stand causes people to misunderstand the meaning of what Jesus taught here, you should state the meaning more directly. For example, the GW says:

Whenever you pray

In some languages it may be helpful to include a footnote about this issue. For example:

The Greek text literally says “when you stand to pray.” People in that culture often stood when they prayed. In this verse Jesus was talking about praying in general. He did not refer only to the times when people are standing to pray.

pray: The Greek word that the BSB translates as pray means “talking to God.” In certain verses, some languages may use different words to refer to specific kinds of prayer, such as requests, thanks, or praise. Here you should use a word or expression that has a general meaning such as “speaking” or “talking.” Avoid a term that may imply magical or meaningless words.

11:25b

if you hold anything against another, forgive it,

- if you have a grievance against anyone, forgive him, (REB)
- stop being resentful toward any person against whom you^(plur) have a complaint.
- if you feel that another person has done wrong to you,^(plur) forget the wrong that person has done.

if you hold anything against another, forgive it:

The BSB states Jesus' command, forgive it, after the condition, if you hold anything against another. In the Greek, the command occurs first, then the condition: “forgive if you have something against someone.” You should use the order that is most natural in your language.

In some languages it may be more natural to express the meaning of if you hold anything against another in another way. For example, the following examples do not express it as a condition:

forgive anything you have against anyone (GW)

forgive anyone you are holding a grudge against (NLT)

if you hold anything against another: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as hold anything against another is very general. It refers to any way that another person may have offended you. It includes anything that a person did that you may resent. It also includes quarrels with another person or complaints about him or her. Try to use a general expression that refers to problems of this kind with another person. For example:

if you have a grievance against anyone (REB)

if you are angry with someone (NCV)

forgive: In this context the word forgive is a command. It means that a person must stop being angry, hateful, or resentful toward anyone who has offended him. The person must also decide not to take revenge for the offense.

Here are some other ways to translate forgive in this context:

pardon

erase the guilt of someone

forget/cancel the wrong/injury

In some languages, the idea of forgive is expressed by an idiom.

11:25c

so that your Father in heaven will forgive your trespasses as well.”

- in order that God, your^(plur) Father in heaven will forgive your trespasses as well.”
- so that your^(plur) Father who lives in heaven will forgive your trespasses, too.”
- Then your Father in heaven will forgive your failures.” (GW)

so that: The Greek word that the BSB translates as so that introduces the purpose for 11:25b. In other words, a person should forgive others (11:25b) in order that God may forgive that person's sins (11:25c). Use an expression here that introduces a purpose. In some languages it is difficult to distinguish purpose from future result. If that is true in your language, you may be able to use an expression that introduces a result. For example, the CEV says:

Then your Father in heaven will forgive your sins.

your Father in heaven will forgive your trespasses as well: The clause your Father in heaven will forgive your trespasses as well is similar to the preceding clause “forgive him” (11:25b). The BSB and many other versions make the similarity explicit by translating a word in the Greek text as “as well” or “also.” Other versions leave this similarity implicit. For example, the NIV says:

...your Father in heaven may forgive you your sins.

It may be helpful to make the similarity between 11:25b and 11:25c explicit. If that is true in your language, you may use a word like “also,” as the NET does.

your Father in heaven: The expression your Father in heaven refers to God. Here the word heaven refers to the place where God lives.

heaven: See how you translated the word heaven in 1:11a. See also heaven, Meaning 2, in the Glossary.

will forgive your trespasses as well: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as will forgive can also be translated as “may forgive.” For example, the NIV says:

may forgiveA note in the NET Bible here says, “Although the Greek subjunctive mood, formally required in a subordinate clause introduced by ἵνα (hina), is traditionally translated by an English subjunctive (e.g., ‘may,’ so KJV, NAB, NIV, NRSV), changes in the use of the subjunctive in English now result in most readers understanding such a statement as indicating permission (‘may’ = ‘has permission to’) or as indicating uncertainty (‘may’ = ‘might’ or ‘may or may not’). Thus a number of more recent translations render such instances by an English future tense (‘will,’ so GNT, CEV, NLT, NASB 1995 update). That approach has been followed here.”

The phrase will forgive your trespasses as well means that God will choose not to punish you for the evil things that you have done and thought. God will cancel your guilt and treat you as though you have not offended him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

will also pardon you for your sins

will also erase your guilt

will forget/cancel your sins

trespasses: The word trespasses refers to offenses against God. Trespasses include acts, thoughts, and attitudes that are not what God wants or approves. In Greek, the verb that English versions translate as sin is also a term that is used in archery to mean “miss the target.” When a person sins, he “misses” the target, that is, he fails to reach God’s standard. A person can also offend God by not doing what God wants him to do.

It is helpful to translate trespasses with a general term that can include any offense against God. Here are problems to avoid:

1. The term should not imply that only serious crimes like murder or stealing are trespasses. Other offenses like gossip and greed are also trespasses.
2. The term should not include accidents or mistakes that are not against God’s will.

Here are some other ways to translate trespasses:

sins (NIV)

offenses against God

evil deeds

In some languages it may be natural to translate trespasses with a phrase that includes a verb. For example:

wrong things that you have done

Although the Greek word here is different than the word in 1:4d that the BSB translates as “sin,” the concept is the same and you may want to use the same word here.

Mark 11:26

Section 11:20–26: Jesus used the withered fig tree as an example

The events in this section took place the morning after Jesus chased the merchants from the temple. On his way to Jerusalem the previous day, Jesus had spoken to a fig tree. He had said that no one would ever eat fruit from it again (11:12–14). In this section, 11:20–26, it was the next day. Jesus and his disciples were again walking from Bethany back to Jerusalem. They saw the same fig tree, which was now completely withered. It had died.

Jesus used the withered fig tree as an example to teach his disciples to trust God to do great things. Commentators think that what happened to the fig tree had a deeper meaning. The various interpretations include: (1) The withering of the fig tree at Jesus' command was a symbol of God's judgment on Jerusalem and the temple. (Kaiser, Evans page 182) thinks the judgment was of the temple.) France (page 444) mentions this interpretation but disagrees with it. That indicates that it might be good to check Kaiser on this matter, too. (2) The withering of the fig tree at Jesus' command was a symbol of the coming judgment of Israel. It doesn't seem necessary to give so much support for this. Lane (page 406) writes in his commentary: "Mark may have had in mind the passage from Hosea 9:16: The people of Israel are stricken. Their roots are dried up; they will bear no more fruit. And if they give birth, I will slaughter their beloved children. [NLT]" (3) The withering of the fig tree at Jesus' command symbolized that the means of approaching God through worship at the temple was replaced so that now people would approach God through Jesus. (Edwards writes: "the fig tree thus symbolizes the temple: as the means of approach to God, the temple is fundamentally—"from the roots"—replaced by Jesus as the center of Israel" page 346) He implied that he was able to make the fig tree wither because he trusted God. He told the disciples that their prayers would be answered if they trusted God. God would forgive their sins if they forgave others.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Power of Faith (NCV)

A Lesson from the Fig Tree (CEV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:19–22 and Matthew 6:14–15. See also Matthew 17:20, 18:35, and Luke 17:6.

Paragraph 11:22–26

In 11:22–26, Jesus taught his disciples about trusting in God and praying. It may not be clear why he started doing this after Peter's remark about the fig tree. You should make it clear in your translation that what Jesus said in the following paragraph was a response to Peter's remark. Jesus used what happened to the fig tree as an example of the great things that can happen when people trust God.

11:26

[Most English versions do not translate this verse. See the Notes on 11:26.]

There is a textual issue here. Mark 11:26 was added in some of the later Greek manuscripts. However, the best manuscripts do not include these words. It is good to include this verse only as a footnote, as many English versions do.

Here is an example footnote:

Only some of the later Greek manuscripts include 11:26, which reads: "But if you do not forgive, neither will your Father who is in heaven forgive your sins."

If the major language version in your area includes this verse in the text, you may want to include it in brackets. The NASB does this.

Here are several possibilities for numbering the verses without including the words of 11:26 in the text:

- At the end of 11:25, include a footnote, and have the number 26 in the footnote (as the example above).
- At the beginning of 11:25, put the numbers 25–26, but include only a footnote about 11:26. For example, the CEV says:

^{25–26}Whenever you stand up to pray

- Put the number 26 in the text with only a footnote marker, no text. For example, the NCV says:

26 ‡

- Put the content of 11:25a–b after the number 25 in the text. Put the content of 11:25c after the number 26 in the text. For example, the NJB says:

²⁵And when you stand in prayer, forgive whatever you have against anybody, ²⁶so that your Father in heaven may forgive your failings too.

Mark 11:27

Section 11:27–33: The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus' authority

Jesus and his disciples arrived in Jerusalem for the third time in three days. This time the Jewish leaders confronted him directly. They questioned Jesus about his right to do the things he had been doing. They did not believe that God had authorized Jesus to do and say what he did.

Jesus responded by asking the Jewish leaders a question. He asked them who gave John the Baptist his authority. The Jewish leaders did not want to answer Jesus' question. If they answered, they would either appear to agree that God had sent John the Baptist or show that they did not believe that God sent him. So they refused to answer. Jesus then refused to answer their question, because he knew that they would not accept his answer.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Authority of Jesus (NET)

A Question about Jesus' Authority (CEV)

Leaders Doubt Jesus' Authority (NCV)

The Jewish leaders did not believe that Jesus came with God's authority

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:23–27 and Luke 20:1–8.

11:27a

After their return to Jerusalem,

- ¶ After Jesus and his disciples returned to Jerusalem.
- ¶ Then Jesus and his followers returned to the city of Jerusalem

The events in this section probably occurred immediately after those in 11:20–25. In 11:20–25 Jesus and his disciples walked to Jerusalem in the morning. In 11:27 they arrived in Jerusalem. In some languages, it may be natural to begin this section with a time word. For example:

Then

After their: The pronoun *their* refers to Jesus and his disciples. In some languages, it will be natural to make this explicit.

return to Jerusalem: The word *return* indicates that Jesus and his disciples had already been to Jerusalem. In fact, this was the third time they had gone to Jerusalem in three days.

The first time was in 11:11 when Jesus entered Jerusalem riding on a donkey. The second time was the next day (11:12, 11:15) when they walked from Bethany to Jerusalem. The third time began the next morning (11:20) when they started walking to Jerusalem. So here in 11:27 they return to the city.

11:27b

Jesus was walking in the temple courts,

- They went again to the temple, and while Jesus was walking in the temple courtyard,
- and went again to the temple. While Jesus was walking in the temple area/yard,

Jesus was walking in the temple courts: When Jesus and his disciples arrived in Jerusalem, they again went to the courtyard of the temple. In some languages, it may be natural to add the implied information that they went to the temple. For example:

...and went again to the temple. While Jesus was walking in the temple courtyard...

temple courts: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *temple courts* is literally “temple” (as in most English versions). The temple consisted of the temple building and the walls and courtyards that surrounded it. Here “temple” refers specifically to the courtyard. People did not meet inside the temple building because only the priests could go there.

See how you translated this word in 11:16. Also see *temple*, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information about the temple and how to translate it.

11:27c

and the chief priests, scribes, and elders came up to Him.

- the chief priests, scribes, and elders approached him.
- the leaders of the Jewish people approached him. They were the chief priests, the experts in the Law of Moses, and the elders of the people.

All three of these terms (“chief priests”, “scribes”, and “elders”) also occur in 8:31c.

the chief priests: The chief priests were the leading priests. This same term occurs in 11:18a.

scribes: The scribes were the experts in the religious law. See how you translated this term in 11:18a.

See teacher of the law in the Glossary.

and elders: The elders were the civil leaders or rulers. They were generally older men. See how you translated this term in 8:31c.

came up to Him: They came to Jesus while he was in the temple courtyard.

Mark 11:28

Section 11:27–33: The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus' authority

Jesus and his disciples arrived in Jerusalem for the third time in three days. This time the Jewish leaders confronted him directly. They questioned Jesus about his right to do the things he had been doing. They did not believe that God had authorized Jesus to do and say what he did.

Jesus responded by asking the Jewish leaders a question. He asked them who gave John the Baptist his authority. The Jewish leaders did not want to answer Jesus' question. If they answered, they would either appear to agree that God had sent John the Baptist or show that they did not believe that God sent him. So they refused to answer. Jesus then refused to answer their question, because he knew that they would not accept his answer.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Authority of Jesus (NET)

A Question about Jesus' Authority (CEV)

Leaders Doubt Jesus' Authority (NCV)

The Jewish leaders did not believe that Jesus came with God's authority

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:23–27 and Luke 20:1–8.

11:28a–b

“By what authority are You doing these things?” they asked. “And who gave You the authority to do them?”: These two questions have almost the same meaning. The Jewish leaders asked Jesus these questions in order to challenge his authority. They did not believe that God had authorized him to do what he was doing. So by their questions they were implying that God had not sent him. They used two questions to emphasize this challenge.

If it is not natural in your language to ask about Jesus' authority in two different ways, you may want to combine these questions. For example:

Who told you that you could do these things?

Who authorized you to speak and act like this?
(the Message version)

11:28a

“By what authority are You doing these things?” they asked.

- “What right/permission do you have to do the things you have done?” they asked.
- They said to him, “What authority do you have to do these things? (NCV)
- They demanded that he tell them what authority he had for doing the things he had done,

By what authority: The phrase By what authority means “What right/permission do you have to...?” This question suggests that Jesus needed to have permission to do what he did. It implies that he needed permission from someone who was more important than he was.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

What gives you the right...? (GW)

What right do you have...? (CEV)

authority: The word authority refers to the moral or legal right to do something. This word also occurs in 1:22b and 10:42b–c.

doing these things: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as doing these things refers to the things that Jesus had been saying and doing. It may refer specifically to what Jesus said and did when he chased the customers, merchants and people who exchanged money out of the temple courtyard. It may refer to everything that Jesus had done and taught in the preceding few days. Or it may refer to everything Jesus had said and done throughout his ministry. Try to translate in a way that allows for all these possibilities. For example:

the things that you have said and done

Be careful that your translation of this question does not refer to what Jesus was doing when they

approached him (11:27b). They were not asking him what authority he had to walk in the temple area.

they asked: The BSB places the words they asked in the middle of the two questions. In Greek, these words occur at the beginning of 11:28. Place the words they asked where it is natural in your language.

11:28b

“And who gave You the authority to do them?”

- “Who gave you the authority to say and do all this?”
- Who sent you with this kind of authority?”
- and who had given him the right to do it.

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And connects the two questions in 11:28a and 11:28b. These questions have almost the same meaning. Some versions, including the GNT, do not use a conjunction here. Connect the questions in a natural way in your language.

who gave You the authority to do them?: This question is similar to the question in 11:28a. They wanted Jesus to say whether God or some human authority had given him the right to speak and act as he had been doing. The leaders themselves did not actually believe that anyone had given Jesus such a right.

Here is another possible way to translate this question:

Who sent you with this kind of authority?

Mark 11:29

Section 11:27–33: The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus’ authority

Jesus and his disciples arrived in Jerusalem for the third time in three days. This time the Jewish leaders confronted him directly. They questioned Jesus about his right to do the things he had been doing. They did not believe that God had authorized Jesus to do and say what he did.

Jesus responded by asking the Jewish leaders a question. He asked them who gave John the Baptist his authority. The Jewish leaders did not want to answer Jesus’ question. If they answered, they would either appear to agree that God had sent John the Baptist or show that they did not believe that God sent him. So they refused to answer. Jesus then refused to answer their question, because he knew that they would not accept his answer.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Authority of Jesus (NET)

A Question about Jesus’ Authority (CEV)

Leaders Doubt Jesus’ Authority (NCV)

The Jewish leaders did not believe that Jesus came with God’s authority

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:23–27 and Luke 20:1–8.

11:29a

“I will ask you one question,” Jesus replied,

- “I will ask you a question.” Jesus replied,
- “First, I will ask you just one question.” Jesus said to them,

When Jews debated, they often answered one question by asking another question. This was what Jesus did here. Jesus knew the answer to his question. He was not seeking information.

I will ask you one question:

Here are some other ways to translate this:

I have just one question to ask you. (CEV)

I’ll ask you a question. (GW)

Jesus replied: The Greek word that the BSB translates as replied is literally “said.” It introduces what Jesus said to the Jewish leaders. His response is not a direct answer to their question.

The BSB places the words Jesus replied in the middle of what Jesus said. In Greek, these words occur at the beginning of 11:29. Place the words Jesus replied where they are natural in your language.

11:29b

“and if you answer Me, I will tell you by what authority I am doing these things.

- Then, if you answer me, I will tell you what authority I have to do these things.
- “If you answer my question, then I will answer yours. I will tell you who has given me the right to do these things.

and if you answer Me, I will tell you by what authority I am doing these things: Jesus said that he would answer the leaders' question if they would first answer his question. Another way to say this in English is:

If you answer me, then I will tell you...

by what authority I am doing these things: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as by what authority...these things is the same phrase as in 11:28a. You should translate it the same way in both places.

General Comment on 11:29a–b

It may be more natural in your language to change the order of 11:29a–b. For example:

Jesus replied, ^{29b}“I will tell you by what authority I do these things ^{29a}if you answer one question.”

Mark 11:30

Section 11:27–33: The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus' authority

Jesus and his disciples arrived in Jerusalem for the third time in three days. This time the Jewish leaders confronted him directly. They questioned Jesus about his right to do the things he had been doing. They did not believe that God had authorized Jesus to do and say what he did.

Jesus responded by asking the Jewish leaders a question. He asked them who gave John the Baptist his authority. The Jewish leaders did not want to answer Jesus' question. If they answered, they would either appear to agree that God had sent John the Baptist or show that they did not believe that God sent him. So they refused to answer. Jesus then refused to answer their question, because he knew that they would not accept his answer.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Authority of Jesus (NET)

A Question about Jesus' Authority (CEV)

Leaders Doubt Jesus' Authority (NCV)

The Jewish leaders did not believe that Jesus came with God's authority

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:23–27 and Luke 20:1–8.

11:30a

John's baptism—was it from heaven or from men?

- When John baptized people, did his authority come from God in heaven or from people?
- Who sent John to baptize people? Was it God or human beings?
- Did John baptize people because God sent him to do it, or because human beings sent him?

John's baptism—was it from heaven or from men?:

This question means, “Who gave John the authority to baptize people? Did God give it to him or did men give it to him?” This question has a similar meaning to the one that the Jewish leaders asked Jesus.

The BSB, like the Greek text, has placed the phrase John's baptism at the beginning of the question. This gives it emphasis as the new topic. Your language may have a different way to do this. Translate the question in a natural way in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Did John's right to baptize come from heaven or from humans? (GW)

Was the baptism of John from heaven or from men? (RSV)

John's baptism: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as John's baptism indicates that John baptized people. It does not indicate that someone else baptized John. You may need to express this phrase in a different way. For example:

When John baptized

The verb “baptize” means to purify people with a special ritual that uses water. In some verses, the verbs “wash” and “clean” are used to translate the Greek verb “baptize.” Luke 11:38 says, “But the Pharisee, noticing that Jesus did not first wash (baptize) before the meal, was surprised.” (The Greek verb here is baptizo, but English versions translate it as “wash.” The context refers to a ritual washing, not merely a removal of dirt.). Mark 7:4 and Matthew 23:25 both speak of washing/cleaning cups and other utensils. The verb in Mark is baptizo while the verb in

Matthew is *katharizo* (clean). Again, a ritual cleansing is involved. Mark 7:4 says, “And there are many other traditions for them to observe, including the washing (baptizing) of cups, pitchers, kettles, and couches for dining.” Matthew 23:25 says, “You clean (*katharizo*) the outside of the cup and dish.” However, the above references do not indicate that “wash/cleanse” is the only meaning of the rite of baptism as practiced by John and by the early Christians. And certainly Jesus’ baptism of people with the Holy Spirit signified more than purification.

Here are some other ways to translate the word baptism or “baptized” in this context:

- Use a descriptive term. For example:

When John washed people ritually

John’s purifying initiation

- Use a term for a similar ritual that is already used in your culture. You may need to indicate that in this context it has a special connection with God. For example:

When John purified people with God’s ceremonial bath

John’s washing people in initiation water

- Use a term that is already accepted by the local churches. This term may have been borrowed from the national language or transliterated from Greek or English.

See the notes on “baptizer” and “baptism” in 1:4a. See also baptize, Meaning 1, in the Glossary. Also see how you translated this term in 1:4c.

from heaven: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as from heaven implies “from God.” The Jews often referred indirectly to God in order to show their great respect for his name. You may need to make it explicit in your translation that the phrase from heaven refers to God. For example:

from God (GNT)

See heaven, Meaning 3, in the Glossary.

from men: The phrase from men is used here as the opposite of the phrase “from heaven.” It means “from human beings” (as in the GNT). In other words, it

refers to people in general, not just to males. If John’s authority to baptize came from men, it meant that he was only following a human ritual or practice. It meant that he had not been sent by God to baptize.

11:30b Answer Me!”

- Tell/Answer me!”
- Answer my question!”

Answer Me!: The phrase Answer me indicates that Jesus expected a response from the Jewish leaders.

In some languages, a command like this may sound rude or harsh. If this is true in your language, use a form that is not rude. For example:

^{30b}Tell me, ^{30a}John’s baptism—was it from heaven, or from men?

^{30b}This is my question. ^{30a} Who gave John his authority to baptize people? Was it God or people?

In some languages it may not be necessary to explicitly state the phrase Answer Me. This expectation may be implied by the context. For example, the CEV says:

Who gave John the right to baptize? Was it God in heaven or merely some human being?

Mark 11:31

Section 11:27–33: The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus’ authority

Jesus and his disciples arrived in Jerusalem for the third time in three days. This time the Jewish leaders confronted him directly. They questioned Jesus about his right to do the things he had been doing. They did not believe that God had authorized Jesus to do and say what he did.

Jesus responded by asking the Jewish leaders a question. He asked them who gave John the Baptist his authority. The Jewish leaders did not want to answer Jesus’ question. If they answered, they would either appear to agree that God had sent John the Baptist or show that they did not believe that God sent him. So they refused to answer. Jesus then refused to answer their question, because he knew that they would not accept his answer.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Authority of Jesus (NET)

A Question about Jesus' Authority (CEV)

Leaders Doubt Jesus' Authority (NCV)

The Jewish leaders did not believe that Jesus came with God's authority

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:23–27 and Luke 20:1–8.

11:31a

They deliberated among themselves what they should answer:

- They deliberated this matter among themselves and said,
- The leaders deliberated with each other how to answer him. They said to each other,
- The chief priests, the teachers of the Law of Moses, and the elders asked one another, “How shall we answer his question?”

They deliberated among themselves what they should answer: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as They deliberated among themselves what they should answer is more literally “And they were reasoning with each other, saying.” The verb “reasoning” and “saying” refer to the same action. The following verses tell what the leaders said to each other in their discussion. In some languages, it is not necessary to have both “reasoning” and “saying” here. Here are some other ways to translate this:

They started to argue among themselves (GNT)

They talked to each other about it. They said (NIRV)

They deliberated among themselves: The Greek word that the BSB translates as They deliberated is literally “they were discussing.” If you need to make explicit what they were discussing, you could say:

They deliberated among themselves how they should answer him

They were deliberating the matter among themselves

You could also use direct speech here. For example:

They asked one another, “How shall we answer his question?”

They: The pronoun They refers to “the chief priests, the scribes and the elders” in 11:27c. You may need to refer to them specifically rather than use a pronoun here.

11:31b–32a

The Jewish leaders discussed how they should answer Jesus. They imagined what would happen if they gave each possible answer. So one way to express 11:31b–32a would be to use the “if...then” form. For example:

^{31b} If we say... ^{31c} then he will ask... ^{32a} but if we say...

The thought in 11:32a is interrupted, so there is not a “then” clause in 11:32b.

11:31b

“If we say, ‘From heaven,’

- “If we^(incl) answer, ‘From God in heaven,’
- “If we say it was from heaven, (NLT)
- If we say that John baptized with authority from God,

The Jewish leaders considered one possible answer that they could give Jesus.

If we say, ‘From heaven’: There is a textual issue in this part of the verse. In some Greek manuscripts, this part of the verse starts with the question “What shall we say?”:

1. Some Greek manuscripts do not have the question “What shall we say?” For example, the NLT says:

If we say it was from heaven (BSB, NIV, RSV, NJB, NET, NASB, GW, NLT, CEV, JBP, NCV, ESV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the question “What shall we say?” For example, the GNT says:

What shall we say? If we answer, “From God,” (GNT, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), as the majority of English versions do.

The phrase ‘From heaven’ is a quote within another quote. The BSB shows this with single quote marks around ‘From heaven.’

In some languages it may be necessary to express 11:31b as an indirect quotation. For example:

If we say that his authority came from heaven...

If we say that John's baptism was from heaven...

If we say it was from heaven... (NLT)

You may need to supply words such as "his authority" or "John's baptism" to make their reply into a complete sentence. If that is true, use wording that agrees with what you used in 11:30a.

From heaven: The phrase From heaven refers to God, as in 11:30a. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

If we answer, "John's baptism was from God..." (NCV)

See heaven, Meaning 3, in the Glossary.

11:31c

He will ask, 'Why then did you not believe him?'

- then he will ask us^(incl), 'Why then did you^(plur) not believe him?'
- then he will ask us why we^(incl) did not believe John.
- then he will ask us why we did not believe/trust what John said.

He will ask: The pronoun He refers to Jesus. The Jewish leaders began to imagine here what Jesus would say if they said that John's authority was from God. The words He will ask introduce what they believed Jesus would say to them.

'Why then did you not believe him?': The question Why then did you not believe him? is a quote within another quote. The BSB shows this with single quotes around this question. In some languages it may be necessary to express this as an indirect quotation. For example:

...then he will ask us why we did not believe him.

believe him: Here the phrase believe him means "believe what John said."

Here are some other ways to translate this:

accept that what he said was true

agree with what John said

See also believe, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

Mark 11:32

Section 11:27–33: The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus' authority

Jesus and his disciples arrived in Jerusalem for the third time in three days. This time the Jewish leaders confronted him directly. They questioned Jesus about his right to do the things he had been doing. They did not believe that God had authorized Jesus to do and say what he did.

Jesus responded by asking the Jewish leaders a question. He asked them who gave John the Baptist his authority. The Jewish leaders did not want to answer Jesus' question. If they answered, they would either appear to agree that God had sent John the Baptist or show that they did not believe that God sent him. So they refused to answer. Jesus then refused to answer their question, because he knew that they would not accept his answer.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Authority of Jesus (NET)

A Question about Jesus' Authority (CEV)

Leaders Doubt Jesus' Authority (NCV)

The Jewish leaders did not believe that Jesus came with God's authority

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:23–27 and Luke 20:1–8.

11:32a

But if we say, 'From men'..."

- But if we^(incl) say, 'From men,' then what?"
- But if we say that John baptized only with authority from humans, what would happen?"
- But we cannot say that John's authority came only from people."

The Jewish leaders considered another possible answer that they could give Jesus.

But if we say: There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as if we say here:

1. It is a conditional statement. For example, the GNT says:

if we say (BSB, GNT, NIV, NCV, KJV, NET, GW, JBP)

1. It is a question. For example, the RSV says:

shall we say...? (RSV, NJB, NLT, REB, NASB, ESV)

The Greek can be interpreted either way. There is good support in commentaries and versions for both ways of expressing 11:32a. You should follow the choice that is most natural in your language. The Display follows interpretation (1).

‘From men’...: The phrase From men is a quote within another quote. The BSB shows this with single quotes. In some languages it may be necessary to express this as an indirect quotation. For example:

But if we say that it came from people...

But if we say that John’s authority came from people...

In the BSB, as in the Greek, 11:32a is not grammatically complete. In some languages you may be able to indicate an incomplete thought as the BSB does, with an ellipsis character (three periods). Another possibility is to supply the implicit information in what the Jewish leaders began to say. For example:

But we cannot say, “It was from men.”

From men: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as From men refers to the source of John’s right or authority to baptize people. It means that the source of his authority was only human. It came from people, not from God.

See how you translated the phrase From men in 11:30a.

11:32b–c

they were afraid of the people, for they all held that John truly was a prophet: The NIV and the GNT put this sentence in parentheses. The parentheses make it clear that Mark was explaining why the Jewish leaders did not want to answer “From men.”

The Jewish leaders did not believe that John’s authority had come from God. But they did not want to say what they really believed, because they were afraid of the people.

You may use parentheses to set this explanation apart, if that is a clear and natural way to do it in your language. But it is not always necessary to use

parentheses. See also the General Comment on 11:32a–c at the end of the notes on 11:32c.

11:32b

they were afraid of the people,

- They were afraid of the people,
- They could not answer that way, because they were afraid of the people,
- They were afraid that the people would cause trouble if they said that,

they were afraid of the people: The Jewish leaders were afraid that the people might kill them.

According to the Law of Moses, people who spoke against God or a prophet of God should be killed by stoning. The Jewish leaders were afraid to tell the truth about what they thought of John’s authority to baptize. They were afraid that when the ordinary people heard their opinion, they would be very angry at them and would kill them. See Luke 20:6. This information could be included in a footnote in your translation.

11:32c

for they all held that John truly was a prophet.

- because everyone believed that John was a real prophet.
- who all believed that John had been a true prophet from God.
- because so many of the people were convinced that John had really been a prophet.

for: The word for introduces background information about the reason that the Jewish leaders were afraid of the people. There is implied information in the clause. The people believed that John was a prophet, so they would be angry if the leaders said that he did not get his authority from God. In some languages a word like “for” or “because” may not communicate the right meaning without the implied information. See the General Comment on 11:32a–c below for a different way to express the connection.

they all held: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as held is used in a figurative way here. It means “to hold (or have) an opinion about something.” So to hold that John was a prophet means to “consider/believe” that John was a prophet.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

everyone was convinced (GNT)

everyone thought (NLT96)

everyone believed

they all: The phrase they all is an exaggeration. Mark used this word to emphasize the fact that many people believed John was a prophet. We know that not every person believed that John was a prophet. The Jewish leaders themselves did not believe it.

John truly was a prophet: John was dead at the time the Jewish leaders had this discussion. But even after John died, the people still believed that he had been a prophet. Translate the clause John truly was a prophet in a way that is natural in your language to show that this was what people thought about John. For example:

John had really been a prophet.

prophet: A prophet is a man who speaks a message that God has told him to speak. In this context, the fact that the people believed that John was a prophet meant that they believed that his authority came from God. God had sent him to preach and to baptize people.

See how you translated this word in 1:2a. See also prophet in the Glossary.

General Comment on 11:32a–c

You may be able to express the meaning of 11:32a–c more clearly if you make the whole verse an explanation without direct quotations. For example:

But the leaders did not want to say that John's authority was only from humans. Most/many of the people believed that John was a prophet, and the leaders were afraid of what the people might do.

Another possibility is to make 11:32a and 11:32c part of what the Jewish leaders said, as a direct quotation. For example, the CEV says:

“On the other hand, these people think that John was a prophet. So we can't say that it was merely some human who gave John the right to baptize.”

Mark 11:33

Section 11:27–33: The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus' authority

Jesus and his disciples arrived in Jerusalem for the third time in three days. This time the Jewish leaders confronted him directly. They questioned Jesus about

his right to do the things he had been doing. They did not believe that God had authorized Jesus to do and say what he did.

Jesus responded by asking the Jewish leaders a question. He asked them who gave John the Baptist his authority. The Jewish leaders did not want to answer Jesus' question. If they answered, they would either appear to agree that God had sent John the Baptist or show that they did not believe that God sent him. So they refused to answer. Jesus then refused to answer their question, because he knew that they would not accept his answer.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Authority of Jesus (NET)

A Question about Jesus' Authority (CEV)

Leaders Doubt Jesus' Authority (NCV)

The Jewish leaders did not believe that Jesus came with God's authority

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:23–27 and Luke 20:1–8.

11:33a

So they answered, “We do not know.”

- So they answered Jesus, “We do not know that/it.”
- So the leaders answered Jesus, “We do not know who sent John to baptize people.”
- So they told Jesus that they did not know the answer to his question.

So they answered: The word So in the BSB introduces the results of the discussion that the Jewish leaders had. They decided to tell Jesus that they did not know the answer to his question. Introduce this part of the verse in a natural way in your language. The NLT says:

So they finally replied

We do not know: There is some implied information here. The implied information is “where John's authority to baptize came from.” In some languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit. If so, refer to John's baptism using the same phrase that you used in 11:30a. For example:

We do not know where John got his authority to baptize people.

11:33b
And Jesus replied, “Neither will I tell you by what authority I am doing these things.”

- And Jesus replied, “Neither will I tell you what authority I have to do the things I have done.”
- And Jesus replied, “Then I will not tell you what authority I have to do these kinds of things.”
- Then Jesus said that he would not tell them, either, what right he had to do those things.

And Jesus replied, “Neither will I tell you by what authority I am doing these things”: Jesus’ response indicates that he was refusing to answer the question that the Jewish leaders had asked him in 11:28a. They had asked, “By what authority are you doing these things?” You should translate Jesus’ response here in 11:33b in a way that corresponds with the way you translated their question.

Neither: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Neither refers to the fact that Jesus refused to answer a question. The Jewish leaders had also refused to answer a question. Jesus had said in 11:29b that he would only answer their question if they answered his question. In some languages there is a special way to make this reference clear. For example:

Then I will not tell you...

So I, likewise, will not tell you...

authority: The word authority means “the right to do something.”

See how you translated this word in 1:22b and 11:28a.

Mark 12:1

Section 12:1–12: Jesus told a parable about some evil grape farmers

In 11:28 the Jewish religious leaders asked Jesus two questions about his authority. In this section Jesus used a parable to answer those question in an indirect way. The Jewish leaders showed that they understood this parable by the way they responded in 12:12.

Jesus’ parable was about a man who owned a grape farm. He told some men to farm it for him and to give him a share of the profit. However, the men refused to give the owner his share. They even mistreated his servants who came to collect the money. When the owner sent his own son, they killed him.

Jesus used the people in the parable to represent the Jewish religious leaders and their actions toward God and toward himself, God’s son. Here are the most likely meanings of the different people and things in the parable:See Ray Summers, Commentary on Luke: Jesus, the Universal Savior, 1972, on the parallel passage in Luke 20:9–19.

	The owner of the grape farm	represents	God
	The grape farm	represents	Israel and its people
	The grape farm-ers	represent	the Jewish religious leaders
	The servants	represent	God’s messen-gers or prophets
	The son	represents	Jesus

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the vineyard and its farmers

The Parable of the Tenants in the Vineyard (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:33–46 and Luke 20:9–19.

12:1a
Then Jesus began to speak to them in parables:

- ¶ Then Jesus spoke to them by using parables. He said,
- ¶ After that, Jesus continued to speak to the leaders. He told them this parable:

At the end of chapter 11, Jesus was talking with the Jewish religious leaders. 11:32 implies that other people also listened to what Jesus said to the leaders. In this verse he continued to talk to the Jewish religious leaders, and told them a parable.

Then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Then introduces what happened next in the narrative.

Here are some other ways to introduce this section:

After he said this

So

Jesus began to speak to them in parables: Jesus taught and answered questions by telling simple, meaningful stories. Here he indirectly answered the religious leaders' questions by telling the parable recorded in verse 1b-9c.

In some languages a verb like began might imply that Jesus started to speak in parables but he did not finish. It might also imply that Jesus had not been speaking to them and that he now began to speak, using parables. If either of these wrong meanings would be implied in your language, you may want to translate only the main verb “spoke.” For example, the GNT says:

Jesus spoke to them in parables

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Jesus began to use parables as he spoke to them.

Jesus said this, he told them a parable.

Jesus continued speaking to the Jewish leaders.
He told them this parable.

The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in parables refers to the teachings of Jesus. The plural form, parables, probably indicates that during that time Jesus told more than one parable. See the similar passage in Matthew 21:23-22:14, which includes two other parables. In this chapter Mark included only one parable. It may be confusing to your readers to use the plural “parables” when there is only one parable here. If that is true, you may use the singular “parable.” For example:

Jesus told them a parable

Some languages may require a verb like “saying” or “he said” to introduce the parable. For example:

Jesus told them a parable, saying:

to them: The word them refers to the chief priests, the scribes, and the elders, who were mentioned in 11:27. In some languages, it may be more natural to refer to them specifically. For example:

to the religious leaders

parables: The Greek word that the BSB translates as parables is literally “comparisons.” Parables teach a lesson or truth by showing how it is like something that people already know. In this section Jesus told a parable that was a symbolic story. You should read this story and use a natural term in your language to describe it.

See parable, Type 3, in the Glossary.

12:1b

“A man planted a vineyard.

- “A man planted a grape farm.
- “Once a man planted a grape garden.
- “There was a certain man. One day, he told his servants to plant grape plants/vines in a field.

A man planted a vineyard: Jesus introduced his story with the clause A man planted a vineyard. The man is a very important person in the story. The clause tells what the man did first. Introduce this story in a way that is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to introduce this story:

Once there was a man who planted a vineyard
(GNT)

There was a certain man. One day, he planted a grape farm.

planted a vineyard: The man planted a grape farm. He was apparently a rich man with many servants, so he probably did not plant this farm himself. He ordered his servants to do the work. In some languages it may be necessary to make this clear. For example:

his servants planted a grape farm

vineyard: A vineyard is a farm where grape vines grow and produce grapes. Grapes are a small sweet fruit that people commonly grew in ancient Israel. They used them to make wine.

Here are some other ways to translate vineyard:

grape farm

field of grape vines

In some languages there may not be a word for “vineyard” or for “grape.” If this is true in your language, here are two other options to consider:

- Borrow the word for “grape” from another language and add a general expression that describes what a grape farm is. For example:

farm for producing a fruit called grapes

farm for raising fruit from grape vines

- Use a general word for fruit that would fit in this context. For example:

farm to produce a fruit used to make wine

You may also want to add a footnote. For example:

The fruit called “grape” grows on a vine. The fruit is used for making wine.

Grapes and vineyards are spoken of literally and figuratively in many places in the Bible. You may want to look at these other contexts as you decide how to translate these words. Here are other passages that also refer to vineyards: Isaiah 5:1-7, Genesis 9:20, Matthew 20:1, and Luke 20:9. And here are some passages that refer to grapes: Genesis 40:10-11, Isaiah 5:2, and Matthew 7:16.

12:1c-f

This part of the verse describes how the man carefully prepared his grape farm. He did this so that it would produce a good profit for him.

12:1c

He put a wall around it,

- Then he built a barrier/wall around it,
- After that, he fenced/hedged the field to protect it.

He put a wall around it: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as put...around indicates that the man made a barrier along the borders of his grape farm. Some languages may naturally express the phrase put a wall around with a verb. For example:

he enclosed it with a wall

he built a wall around it

Use an appropriate expression in your language.

wall: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wall refers to a barrier that encloses an open area. People built walls to keep thieves and wild animals out of a farm or garden. The Greek word could refer

to almost any kind of barrier, including a fence, wall, or hedge. According to Alexander (page 317), it was a thick hedge of thorn plants. It could be made of stone, wood, thorn bushes, or anything else that would form an adequate barrier. In your translation you may want to use the kind of barrier that is common in your area.

12:1d

dug a wine vat,

- and made/dug a place for squeezing and collecting the juice from the grapes.
- Then he hollowed out a hole/place in the rock for pressing/squeezing the juice out of the grapes,

dug a wine vat: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as dug a wine vat is literally “dug a trough.” In this context, it is implied that the trough is part of a winepress. That is the reason most English versions use the word “winepress.” For example, the NIV says:

dug a pit for the winepress

A wine vat, or winepress, consisted of two “pits” or “troughs” that people usually carved out of a large stone. They put the grapes in the larger trough and stepped on them to press out the juice. The juice then ran down into a smaller lower trough/pit or “vat,” where it was collected to be made into wine. People normally carved a winepress out of a large rock, but sometimes they dug it out of the ground and lined it with bricks. The larger “pit” was probably shaped like a shallow basin (Lenski page 506). According to TRT (page 155), the small pit or vat for collecting the wine was probably 3-5 feet across (1-1.5 meters across) and 2-3 feet deep (0.6-1 meters deep).

dug: The verb dug describes the way people made a hole in the stone for the winepress. In some languages a different verb may be more appropriate. For example:

hollowed out

carved

chipped

Use a natural verb in your language to describe this.

a wine vat: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wine vat probably refers specifically to the smaller hole/trough/vat in the rock in which the grape juice was collected. However, some scholars think that it stands for the whole winepress.

Your readers may not be familiar with the kind of winepress that was used by the Jews in the time of Jesus. If that is true, you may need to make explicit some of the details. Translations in English and other languages have done this in different ways. For example:

dug a pit for pressing out the grape juice (NLT)

carved out a place in the rock for collecting the juice when the grapes were squeezed

made a hollow to catch the new grape water

Try to make explicit only enough details for your readers to understand the main idea of digging a winepress. You may want to include additional details in a footnote. Remember that your translation of this phrase needs to fit smoothly into the story as a whole.

12:1e and built a watchtower.

- and built a guard tower.
- He also built a tall place where men could stand and guard the farm.

watchtower: A watchtower was a tall structure that farmers built so that they could watch the grape farm. The tower was often made of stones. On top of the tower, there was usually a small shelter. From there, a man could see the whole farm and guard it from thieves and wild animals.

Here are some other ways to translate watchtower:

a high platform for guards

a tall shelter where people could watch the garden

12:1f Then he rented it out to some tenants

- Then he leased the grape farm to some tenant farmers,
- Then he told some men that they could take care of the garden if they gave him some of the fruit/profits.

Then he rented it out to some tenants: After the owner finished preparing the grape farm, he rented it to some men. This implies that these men would take care of the farm, pick its fruit, and sell it. They would keep some of the money and the owner would get the rest of the money. The owner did not give the grape

farm to them or sell it to them. The farm still belonged to the owner. He allowed the farmers to use it to make money for themselves and for him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Then he leased the land to some farmers (NCV)

Then he made an agreement with some men that they would care for the grape farm in exchange for a share of the harvest

tenants: The Greek word that the BSB translates as tenants is more literally “farmers.” This refers to people who take care of gardens. The BSB refers to them as tenants because these farmers had agreed to rent the land from the landowner and give him some of the profits as payment. Here are some other ways you may wish to translate this noun:

vine dressers

land-workers

12:1g and went away on a journey.

- and he traveled far from there.
- After that, he went on a long trip.

and went away on a journey: The Greek word that the BSB translates as went away on a journey indicates that the man traveled far from home and stayed away for some time. This may imply that he went to another country.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

went into another country (RSV)

went abroad (NJB)

If you wish to specify “another country” in your translation, you may do so. Otherwise, translate this phrase in a way that indicates that the man was gone for a long time. He did not go on just a short trip. For example:

traveled to a far place/town

Mark 12:2

Section 12:1–12: Jesus told a parable about some evil grape farmers

In 11:28 the Jewish religious leaders asked Jesus two questions about his authority. In this section Jesus used a parable to answer those question in an indirect way. The Jewish leaders showed that they understood this parable by the way they responded in 12:12.

Jesus' parable was about a man who owned a grape farm. He told some men to farm it for him and to give him a share of the profit. However, the men refused to give the owner his share. They even mistreated his servants who came to collect the money. When the owner sent his own son, they killed him.

Jesus used the people in the parable to represent the Jewish religious leaders and their actions toward God and toward himself, God's son. Here are the most likely meanings of the different people and things in the parable: See Ray Summers, Commentary on Luke: Jesus, the Universal Savior, 1972, on the parallel passage in Luke 20:9–19.

The owner of the grape farm	represents	God
The grape farm	represents	Israel and its people
The grape farm-ers	represent	the Jewish religious leaders
The servants	represent	God's messengers or prophets
The son	represents	Jesus

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the vineyard and its farmers

The Parable of the Tenants in the Vineyard (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:33–46 and Luke 20:9–19.

12:2a

At harvest time, he sent a servant to the tenants

- When the grapes were ripe, he sent one of his servants to the tenant farmers
- When it was time to harvest the grapes, the owner told one of his slaves to go to the grape farm

At harvest time: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as At harvest time is literally “in the season of harvest.” In this context it refers to the time when the grapes were ripe and the farmers picked them. According to France (page 459), it took four years from the time when a new vineyard was planted to the time of the first harvest.

he sent a servant: The owner of the grape farm chose one of his servants to go to the farmers who were leasing his farm. In this context the servant was probably a man.

servant: The Greek word that the BSB translates as servant means “slave,” as in the RSV. This word refers to someone who was owned by another person. He worked for his owner/master without receiving pay. He had no rights of his own (or very few rights).

In some cultures, slaves may not be known. In other cultures, the word for slave may imply different customs than in biblical culture.

If that is true in your language, here are some other ways to translate this:

person who belonged to someone else

owned person

person who serves someone

worker/servant

See how you translated this word in 9:35b–d.

to the tenants: The Greek word that the BSB translates as tenants here is the same word that was translated as “tenants” in 12:1f.

12:2b

to collect his share of the fruit of the vineyard.

- to get from them some of the fruit/profit from the grape farm.
- to collect his share of the profits from the men who were farming it and bring it to him.

to collect his share of the fruit of the vineyard: The owner and the farmers had already agreed that the farmers would give the owner part of the grape harvest.

his share of the fruit of the vineyard: The phrase his share of the fruit of the vineyard refers to the owner's share of the grape harvest. It could have been money

or it could have been some of the juice or wine that was made from the grapes.

Mark 12:3

Section 12:1–12: Jesus told a parable about some evil grape farmers

In 11:28 the Jewish religious leaders asked Jesus two questions about his authority. In this section Jesus used a parable to answer those question in an indirect way. The Jewish leaders showed that they understood this parable by the way they responded in 12:12.

Jesus’ parable was about a man who owned a grape farm. He told some men to farm it for him and to give him a share of the profit. However, the men refused to give the owner his share. They even mistreated his servants who came to collect the money. When the owner sent his own son, they killed him.

Jesus used the people in the parable to represent the Jewish religious leaders and their actions toward God and toward himself, God’s son. Here are the most likely meanings of the different people and things in the parable:See Ray Summers, Commentary on Luke: Jesus, the Universal Savior, 1972, on the parallel pas- sage in Luke 20:9–19.

	The owner of the grape farm	represents	God
	The grape farm	represents	Israel and its people
	The grape farm-ers	represent	the Jewish reli- gious leaders
	The servants	represent	God’s messen- gers or prophets
	The son	represents	Jesus

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this sec- tion:

The parable of the vineyard and its farmers

The Parable of the Tenants in the Vineyard (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:33–46 and Luke 20:9–19.

12:3a

But they seized the servant, beat him,

- But after the servant arrived the farmers grabbed him, and beat him
- The slave left and came to the grape farm. When he gave the owner’s message to the men, they took him and beat him.

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But is a simple connector that is often translated as “and.” Here it introduces the next event. Some English ver- sions do not use a connector. The BSB uses But to indicate that this verse contrasts with what the owner expected in 12:2. Connect this verse to 12:2 in a natural way in your language.

In some languages it may be natural to say explicitly that the action in this verse happened after the ser- vant arrived at the grape farm. For example:

But after the servant arrived

they seized the servant: The grape farmers grabbed the servant and probably held him while they beat him. When the grape farmers mistreated the owner’s servant, they showed that they refused to do what the owner asked them to do. In some languages it may be helpful to make it explicit that they refused to do what the owner told them. For example:

But the tenants refused. They grabbed the ser- vant...

beat him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as beat means to hit or whip repeatedly in a way that causes bruises.

12:3b

and sent him away empty-handed.

- and sent him back without giving him anything.
- Then they made him return to the owner with noth- ing at all.

sent him away empty-handed: The phrase sent him away empty-handed indicates that the men sent the slave back to his master without giving him any share of the harvest.

empty-handed: The word empty-handed is an idiom. It means “with nothing.” You may have a different idiom that would be appropriate in this context.

Mark 12:4

Section 12:1–12: Jesus told a parable about some evil grape farmers

In 11:28 the Jewish religious leaders asked Jesus two questions about his authority. In this section Jesus

used a parable to answer those question in an indirect way. The Jewish leaders showed that they understood this parable by the way they responded in 12:12.

Jesus' parable was about a man who owned a grape farm. He told some men to farm it for him and to give him a share of the profit. However, the men refused to give the owner his share. They even mistreated his servants who came to collect the money. When the owner sent his own son, they killed him.

Jesus used the people in the parable to represent the Jewish religious leaders and their actions toward God and toward himself, God's son. Here are the most likely meanings of the different people and things in the parable: See Ray Summers, Commentary on Luke: Jesus, the Universal Savior, 1972, on the parallel passage in Luke 20:9–19.

	The owner of the grape farm	represents	God
	The grape farm	represents	Israel and its people
	The grape farmers	represent	the Jewish religious leaders
	The servants	represent	God's messengers or prophets
	The son	represents	Jesus

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the vineyard and its farmers

The Parable of the Tenants in the Vineyard (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:33–46 and Luke 20:9–19.

12:4a

Then he sent them another servant,

- Then the owner sent another of his servants to the grape farmers.
- After the first servant returned, the owner sent another servant to bring him his share of the harvest from the men.

Then he sent them another servant: There is implied information here. It is implied that the first servant returned to the owner of the grape farm and told him what had happened. After that the owner sent another

servant to the grape farmers to try to get his share of the harvest.

12:4b

and they struck him over the head and treated him shamefully.

- They hit that man repeatedly on his head with a stick/cane and humiliated him.
- When that servant came to the farmers, they beat him on the head and mistreated him.

and they struck him over the head: There is a textual issue in 12:4b. Some Greek manuscripts have the phrase “having stoned him” at the beginning of this clause. (1) Some Greek manuscripts do not have this phrase. For example, the RSV says: “they wounded him in the head” (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NJB, NET, NASB, REB, ESV, GW, NLT, CEV, JBP, NCV). (2) Other Greek manuscripts have the phrase they cast stones. For example, the KJV says: “and at him they cast stones, and wounded [him] in the head” (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The Greek word that the BSB translates as struck...over the head implies that the grape farmers hit the servant repeatedly on the head. It may also mean that they wounded him in the head. Some languages use different words for hitting with the fist and hitting with a hard object. If that is true in your language, you may use a word that means “hit/beat with a cane or stick.”

and treated him shamefully: The phrase treated him shamefully indicates that the grape farmers mistreated the owner's servant and insulted him. They acted and spoke in a way that humiliated the servant. By doing this, the grape farmers showed that they also did not respect his master, the owner of the grape farm.

Mark 12:5

Section 12:1–12: Jesus told a parable about some evil grape farmers

In 11:28 the Jewish religious leaders asked Jesus two questions about his authority. In this section Jesus used a parable to answer those question in an indirect way. The Jewish leaders showed that they understood this parable by the way they responded in 12:12.

Jesus' parable was about a man who owned a grape farm. He told some men to farm it for him and to give him a share of the profit. However, the men refused to give the owner his share. They even mistreated his servants who came to collect the money. When the owner sent his own son, they killed him.

Jesus used the people in the parable to represent the Jewish religious leaders and their actions toward

God and toward himself, God's son. Here are the most likely meanings of the different people and things in the parable: See Ray Summers, Commentary on Luke: Jesus, the Universal Savior, 1972, on the parallel passage in Luke 20:9–19.

The owner of the grape farm	represents	God
The grape farm	represents	Israel and its people
The grape farmers	represent	the Jewish religious leaders
The servants	represent	God's messengers or prophets
The son	represents	Jesus

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the vineyard and its farmers

The Parable of the Tenants in the Vineyard (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:33–46 and Luke 20:9–19.

12:5a

He sent still another, and this one they killed.

- After that, the owner sent another servant, and this servant they killed.
- When that servant returned, the owner sent another servant, but as for that third servant, the men killed him.

In Greek this verse begins with the simple connector that is often translated as “and.” The story implies that the events of this verse happened sometime after the events of 12:4. The servant in 12:4 probably returned to his owner, and then the owner sent another servant. See 12:5a in the Display.

He sent still another: The clause He sent still another indicates that the owner again sent another servant to bring his share of the harvest to him. He had already sent more than one of his servants. The English word still or “yet” emphasizes this.

Here is another way to translate this:

So the owner sent a servant a third time

and this one they killed: In Greek the word order emphasizes this particular servant. The BSB and RSV express this emphasis by putting the phrase “this one” first in the clause. The normal order in English would be, “and they killed him,” as in the CEV. Consider how to emphasize this servant in a natural way in your language.

12:5b

He sent many others;

- After that, the owner sent many others of his servants to the grape farmers.
- The owner continued to send many other servants, but the men who were farming his land kept on acting in the same way.

He sent many others: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as He sent many others is literally “and many others.” The BSB has supplied the words He sent to make the meaning clear. The owner sent many more of his servants to the grape farmers to try to get his share of the grape harvest. The NRSV translates this as:

And so it was with many others

12:5c

some they beat and others they killed.

- The farmers beat some of them repeatedly, and they killed others.
- They beat some of the owners' servants and killed others of his servants.

some they beat and others they killed: In this part of the verse the normal word order in English would be, “They beat some and killed others,” as in the CEV. The BSB has followed the Greek word order here. Use a natural order in your language.

beat: The Greek word that the BSB translates as beat means to strike, whip, or beat repeatedly. Refer to how you translated this same word in 12:3a.

Mark 12:6

Section 12:1–12: Jesus told a parable about some evil grape farmers

In 11:28 the Jewish religious leaders asked Jesus two questions about his authority. In this section Jesus used a parable to answer those question in an indirect way. The Jewish leaders showed that they understood this parable by the way they responded in 12:12.

Jesus' parable was about a man who owned a grape farm. He told some men to farm it for him and to give him a share of the profit. However, the men refused

to give the owner his share. They even mistreated his servants who came to collect the money. When the owner sent his own son, they killed him.

Jesus used the people in the parable to represent the Jewish religious leaders and their actions toward God and toward himself, God's son. Here are the most likely meanings of the different people and things in the parable: See Ray Summers, *Commentary on Luke: Jesus, the Universal Savior*, 1972, on the parallel passage in Luke 20:9-19.

	The owner of the grape farm	represents	God
	The grape farm	represents	Israel and its people
	The grape farmers	represent	the Jewish religious leaders
	The servants	represent	God's messengers or prophets
	The son	represents	Jesus

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the vineyard and its farmers

The Parable of the Tenants in the Vineyard (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:33-46 and Luke 20:9-19.

12:6a

Finally, having one beloved son,

- Finally, the owner had only one more person to send to the grape farmers. It was his son; and the owner loved him very much.
- There was only one other person for the owner to send. That person was his own beloved son.

Finally The word Finally implies that after the owner sent his son, he would not send anyone else to the grape farmers. Here is another way to translate this:

Last of all

having one beloved son: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as having one beloved son is more literally “still one having, a beloved son.” It indicates that the owner had only one more person whom he could

send to the grape farmers. He had no more servants to send. He had only his son. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate the sequence of events more clearly. For example:

After that, the only one left to send...

In some languages it may be more natural to express the meaning of this clause with a negative statement. For example:

He had now no one left to send except his beloved son (REB)

beloved son: The owner had a special love for his son. This does not mean that the owner had other sons whom he did not love. This may have been his only son. Many times in the Old Testament the expression “beloved son” means “only son.” (UBS page 366)

12:6b

he sent him to them.

- In the end, he sent him.
- The owner decided to send him as his final messenger to the men.

he sent him to them: The owner decided to send his son to the farmers.

12:6c

‘They will respect my son,’ he said.

- He thought, ‘The grape farmers will treat my son with proper respect.’
- He said in his thoughts, ‘They will surely honor my son and give him what they owe me.’
- He thought that they would surely respect his son.

They will respect my son: The owner thought that surely the grape farmers would respect his son. The farmers knew that the owner had given his son complete authority to represent him. He expected that they would respect the son and give him the share of the harvest that they owed the father. There is also an implied contrast with the servants, whom the farmers had not respected. It means:

they will respect my son even though they did not respect my servants

he said: The verb that the BSB translates as he said identifies what the owner said or thought about sending his son. It is not clear whether the owner spoke his thought aloud to someone else or simply thought it in his own mind. In Greek, the verb appears at the

beginning of 12:6c. The BSB has changed the order. You should place this phrase where it is most natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- saying (RSV)
- thinking (NJB)
- saying to himself (JBP)

See the General Comment on 12:6b–c for a suggestion about indirect speech.

General Comment on 12:6b–c

In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech here. For example:

He sent him last of all, saying/thinking that they would respect his son.

Mark 12:7

Section 12:1–12: Jesus told a parable about some evil grape farmers

In 11:28 the Jewish religious leaders asked Jesus two questions about his authority. In this section Jesus used a parable to answer those question in an indirect way. The Jewish leaders showed that they understood this parable by the way they responded in 12:12.

Jesus’ parable was about a man who owned a grape farm. He told some men to farm it for him and to give him a share of the profit. However, the men refused to give the owner his share. They even mistreated his servants who came to collect the money. When the owner sent his own son, they killed him.

Jesus used the people in the parable to represent the Jewish religious leaders and their actions toward God and toward himself, God’s son. Here are the most likely meanings of the different people and things in the parable: See Ray Summers, Commentary on Luke: Jesus, the Universal Savior, 1972, on the parallel passage in Luke 20:9–19.

	The owner of the grape farm	represents	God
	The grape farm	represents	Israel and its people
	The grape farmers	represent	the Jewish religious leaders

	The servants	represent	God’s messengers or prophets
	The son	represents	Jesus

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

- The parable of the vineyard and its farmers
- The Parable of the Tenants in the Vineyard (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:33–46 and Luke 20:9–19.

12:7a

But the tenants said to one another,

- But when the son arrived, the renters/farmers said to each other,
- Instead, when they saw the son, the men who had agreed to farm for him said to one another,

Verses 12:7–8 tell what happened after the son arrived at the grape farm. However, the text in 12:7a does not actually say that the son arrived. In some languages it may be necessary to make that explicit. For example:

But when the son arrived

But the tenants said to one another: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces a contrast with what the owner thought in 12:6c. Instead of respecting the owner’s son, the farmers told each other that they should kill him (12:7c). Indicate this contrast in a natural way in your language.

12:7b

‘This is the heir.

- ‘This is the one who will inherit the grape farm.
- ‘This is the owner’s only son. When the owner dies, he will get the farm.

This is the heir: Here the tenants indicated that the owner’s son was his heir. The Greek word that the BSB translates as heir refers to the person who would own his father’s property after his father died.

12:7c

Come, let us kill him, and the inheritance will be ours.’

- Let us^(incl) kill him, and as a result, the grape farm will belong to us.^(incl)

- Listen, let us kill him, so we will be able to keep/own his father's property/estate.'
- Let us kill him, and we will get the farm.'

Come: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as Come indicates that the farmers encouraged each other to unite and kill the heir. It does not refer to moving toward something. Consider whether you have an expression in your culture that members of a group might use to encourage each other to do something. In some languages it may be more natural not to translate this word.

let us kill him: The grape farmers said the words let us kill him to encourage each other to kill the owner's son.

and the inheritance will be ours: This phrase expresses what the farmers thought would happen if they killed the son. It seems that the farmers were not thinking clearly about the probable results of their killing the heir. Perhaps when they saw the son coming they thought that the owner had already died and that the son was coming to claim the grape farm for himself (Gundry pages 686–687). Some scholars indicate that it was customary at that time that, when men had farmed land for three (or perhaps four) years or more, they could claim that it was their land if there was no one else to claim it (France page 461). So the farmers thought that if they killed the son (apparently the only son), they would become the owners of the grape farm. In some languages you may wish to make this clear by following this example:

If we do, then the inheritance will be ours.

the inheritance: The Greek word that the BSB translates as inheritance refers to the grape farm, which the son would receive when his father died. To “inherit” something means to own it when the previous owner, usually a parent, dies.

Mark 12:8

Section 12:1–12: Jesus told a parable about some evil grape farmers

In 11:28 the Jewish religious leaders asked Jesus two questions about his authority. In this section Jesus used a parable to answer those question in an indirect way. The Jewish leaders showed that they understood this parable by the way they responded in 12:12.

Jesus' parable was about a man who owned a grape farm. He told some men to farm it for him and to give him a share of the profit. However, the men refused to give the owner his share. They even mistreated his

servants who came to collect the money. When the owner sent his own son, they killed him.

Jesus used the people in the parable to represent the Jewish religious leaders and their actions toward God and toward himself, God's son. Here are the most likely meanings of the different people and things in the parable: See Ray Summers, Commentary on Luke: Jesus, the Universal Savior, 1972, on the parallel passage in Luke 20:9–19.

	The owner of the grape farm	represents	God
	The grape farm	represents	Israel and its people
	The grape farmers	represent	the Jewish religious leaders
	The servants	represent	God's messengers or prophets
	The son	represents	Jesus

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the vineyard and its farmers

The Parable of the Tenants in the Vineyard (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:33–46 and Luke 20:9–19.

12:8a

So they seized the son, killed him,

- So they grabbed him and killed him,
- They all agreed to do this, so they seized the son and murdered him.

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So is the simple connector that is often translated as “and.” It introduces what the grape farmers did as a result of what they had discussed. They did what they had decided to do. Connect 12:7 and 12:8 in a natural way in your language. In some languages a connector may not be needed.

they seized the son: The farmers seized the son in order to kill him.

Here are some other ways to translate seized the son:

grabbed him (NLT)

took him (NIV)

took hold of him

killed him: The farmers murdered the son. This was an illegal act. If there is an expression in your language that refers specifically to murder, it would be appropriate here.

12:8b
and threw him out of the vineyard.

- and they threw his body/corpse out of the grape farm.
- Then they threw his dead body outside the farm.

and threw him out of the vineyard: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as threw him out indicates that the farmers threw the son’s body out of the grape farm.

Proper burial was very important to the Jewish people. The farmers threw the son’s body out of the grape farm and did not give him a proper burial. This showed that they completely rejected the owner of the grape farm.

Mark 12:9

Section 12:1–12: Jesus told a parable about some evil grape farmers

In 11:28 the Jewish religious leaders asked Jesus two questions about his authority. In this section Jesus used a parable to answer those question in an indirect way. The Jewish leaders showed that they understood this parable by the way they responded in 12:12.

Jesus’ parable was about a man who owned a grape farm. He told some men to farm it for him and to give him a share of the profit. However, the men refused to give the owner his share. They even mistreated his servants who came to collect the money. When the owner sent his own son, they killed him.

Jesus used the people in the parable to represent the Jewish religious leaders and their actions toward God and toward himself, God’s son. Here are the most likely meanings of the different people and things in the parable: See Ray Summers, Commentary on Luke: Jesus, the Universal Savior, 1972, on the parallel passage in Luke 20:9–19.

	The owner of the grape farm	represents	God
	The grape farm	represents	Israel and its people

	The grape farm-	represent	the Jewish religious leaders
	The servants	represent	God’s messengers or prophets
	The son	represents	Jesus

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the vineyard and its farmers

The Parable of the Tenants in the Vineyard (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:33–46 and Luke 20:9–19.

12:9a
What then will the owner of the vineyard do?

- ¶ So what do you^(plur) think that the owner of the grape farm will do?
- ¶ Now then, this is what the owner of the grape garden will do.

What then will the owner of the vineyard do?: This is a rhetorical question. It makes the hearers think about what the owner in the parable should do. Although the people probably knew the answer to the question, Jesus answered it himself. Jesus used this question to direct attention to the obvious conclusion of his parable. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Jesus then asked, “What do you think the owner of the vineyard will do?”

- As a statement. For example:

Now then, here is what the owner of the vineyard will do.

Use whichever form is most natural in your language to direct attention to the conclusion of a story or parable.

then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as then connects Jesus’ question in this part of the verse to the parable he had just told. This question causes the hearers to consider what should be the conclusion of Jesus’ story. Some English versions use a result connector like “so” to do this. Other versions begin a new

quote here. Consider how you would indicate such a result or conclusion in your language. Some ways to do this were given in the examples above.

12:9b

He will come and kill those tenants,

- He will come and kill those evil farmers,
- He will come/go to his farm and cause others to kill those wicked men/farmers.

He will come: The words He will come indicate that the owner will go to his grape farm where the farmers are. In some languages it may be more natural to say, “He will go.” Make sure that you use come and “go” in a consistent way in this story. Use them in a way that is natural in your language for this context. You may also need to make explicit where the owner would go. For example:

He will come/go to his grape farm and kill those farmers

and kill those tenants: Jesus probably implied that the owner would cause other people to punish the grape farmers by killing them. So in some languages it may be better to translate this as:

and cause others to kill those grape farmers

tenants: The word tenants continues to refer to the farmers who had agreed to take care of the grape farm for the owner.

12:9c

and will give the vineyard to others.

- and he will put other people in charge of the grape farm.
- Then he will give others the responsibility of taking care of the grape garden.

and will give the vineyard to others: This phrase will give the vineyard to others indicates that the owner would choose different people to take care of his grape farm for him. It does not indicate that the owner would give the farm away. He still would be the owner. After the owner killed the evil farmers, he would lease the farm to men who would be more faithful to him.

Mark 12:10

Section 12:1–12: Jesus told a parable about some evil grape farmers

In 11:28 the Jewish religious leaders asked Jesus two questions about his authority. In this section Jesus used a parable to answer those question in an indirect

way. The Jewish leaders showed that they understood this parable by the way they responded in 12:12.

Jesus’ parable was about a man who owned a grape farm. He told some men to farm it for him and to give him a share of the profit. However, the men refused to give the owner his share. They even mistreated his servants who came to collect the money. When the owner sent his own son, they killed him.

Jesus used the people in the parable to represent the Jewish religious leaders and their actions toward God and toward himself, God’s son. Here are the most likely meanings of the different people and things in the parable: See Ray Summers, Commentary on Luke: Jesus, the Universal Savior, 1972, on the parallel passage in Luke 20:9–19.

	The owner of the grape farm	represents	God
	The grape farm	represents	Israel and its people
	The grape farm-ers	represent	the Jewish religious leaders
	The servants	represent	God’s messen-gers or prophets
	The son	represents	Jesus

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the vineyard and its farmers

The Parable of the Tenants in the Vineyard (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:33–46 and Luke 20:9–19.

12:10a–11

In these verses Jesus quoted Psalm 118:22–23. He quoted this Scripture to refer to himself. The stone was a metaphor that referred to him. The Jewish leaders were like the builders who rejected the stone. They rejected Jesus, but God would reveal that Jesus was the Messiah, like the stone that would make the building stand.

It may be helpful to include a footnote in your translation to explain that Jesus compared himself to the stone in this verse.

Have you never read this Scripture...?: This clause introduces a rhetorical question. Jesus used this clause in two ways:

1. He used it to introduce a Scripture that illustrated the meaning of his story.
2. He used it to rebuke the leaders for whom he told his story. The question implied that the leaders should have thought about what this Scripture meant. Their actions implied that they did not understand it or accept its meaning.

There are at least two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Didn't you ever read this in the Scriptures? (NLT)

Why have you never understood this that is written in the Word of God?

- As a statement. For example, the NCV says:

Surely you have read this Scripture:

Use the form that is most natural in your language for this context.

this Scripture: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Scripture is used in a special way in the New Testament. It refers to words that God directed someone to write. Such writings had authority because God guided a person to write them. In the New Testament the word Scripture almost always refers to something that was written in the Old Testament.

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase this Scripture:

this statement from God's written words

this word/message of God that they/someone wrote

The word Scripture is similar to the phrase "it is written" in 9:13c.

12:10a

Have you never read this Scripture:

- Have you not read what is written in this scripture? It says,
- Surely you have read this scripture. It reads,

12:10b

'The stone the builders rejected has become the cornerstone.'

- 'The stone that the builders refused to use has become the cornerstone of the building.
- 'The stone that the builders rejected as not good enough for the building has become the most important stone in it.
- 'God has made the rock that the builders did not want the most important rock for making the house strong.

The stone the builders rejected: The word builders refers in general to people who construct a building. Some scholars have suggested that the stone refers to a stone in the temple. Since the text does not specify the type of building, it is good to use a general word in your translation. However, if you must make it explicit, you can use a word for "house." The temple is sometimes referred to as "God's house." The builders in this verse used stones as building material. They thought that one of the stones was not good to use in the building, so they rejected it.

Here is another way to say this:

When the builders were choosing stones to build with, they rejected one of the stones

The stone: The Jews used stones to build most of their houses. It was the most common building material. It may be difficult to translate this verse if people in your area do not use stones to build houses. In that case, you may need to write a footnote to explain that people commonly used stones to build houses in Jesus' country. You could also make it explicit in the translation that stones were used for building houses. For example:

While they were building a house, the builders decided not to use a certain stone. That very stone became the most important one in the house.

An illustration that shows men building a house with stones and a stone foundation could also be helpful to readers. Because the New Testament writers often referred to Jesus as a "stone," it is good to maintain this metaphor in your translation.

the builders rejected: The builders chose only the stones that they thought were good quality. But they did not realize that they rejected the best stone. Jesus implied that the Jewish leaders, who rejected him as their Messiah, were acting like the foolish builders.

has become the cornerstone: The Greek text does not say how the rejected stone became the most important stone in the building. In some languages it may be necessary to supply that information. If that is true in your language, you should indicate that God did it.

the cornerstone: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the cornerstone literally means “head of the corner.” Scholars interpret this phrase in different ways:

- 1. It refers to a stone in the corner of the foundation. For example, the NJB says:

the cornerstone (BSB, NLT, KJV, NASB, RSV, REB, NET, GW, NCV, ESV, NJB, JBP)

- 1. It refers to a capstone, a stone at the top center of an arched door. For example, the NIV says:

the capstone (NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). However, both interpretations indicate that the stone was a vitally important one. This was the stone that made the whole building strong. In some languages it may therefore be good to indicate that point clearly. Here are some other ways to translate this:

the most important stone of all (CEV)

the stone that makes the whole building strong

the stone that supports the rest of the building

See also 12:10 in the GNT.

Mark 12:11

Section 12:1–12: Jesus told a parable about some evil grape farmers

In 11:28 the Jewish religious leaders asked Jesus two questions about his authority. In this section Jesus used a parable to answer those question in an indirect way. The Jewish leaders showed that they understood this parable by the way they responded in 12:12.

Jesus’ parable was about a man who owned a grape farm. He told some men to farm it for him and to give him a share of the profit. However, the men refused to give the owner his share. They even mistreated his servants who came to collect the money. When the owner sent his own son, they killed him.

Jesus used the people in the parable to represent the Jewish religious leaders and their actions toward God and toward himself, God’s son. Here are the most likely meanings of the different people and things in the parable:See Ray Summers, Commentary on Luke: Jesus, the Universal Savior, 1972, on the parallel passage in Luke 20:9–19.

	The owner of the grape farm	represents	God
	The grape farm	represents	Israel and its people
	The grape farm-ers	represent	the Jewish religious leaders
	The servants	represent	God’s messen-gers or prophets
	The son	represents	Jesus

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the vineyard and its farmers

The Parable of the Tenants in the Vineyard (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:33–46 and Luke 20:9–19.

12:11
This is from the Lord, and it is marvelous in our eyes?”

- The Lord did this, and we^(incl) are amazed at it!”
- The Lord caused this to happen, and it is something wonderful to us!^{!(incl)}”

This is from the Lord: This statement means that God is the one who took the rejected stone and made it the most important one in the building.

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “master” or “the one who has authority over others.” Here in 12:11 it refers to God. It is a translation of God’s personal name in Hebrew.

Here are some other ways to translate Lord:

Master/Chief

Ruler

In some languages people may not naturally use a word that means “master” to refer to God. If speakers of your language do not understand that your word for “Lord” refers to God in this context, here are other ways to translate it:

- Use your word for God.
- Use your word for God and indicates that he is the Lord. For example:

God the Lord

Master God

If you include the word for God in your translation of Lord, you may want to include a footnote to give the literal Greek meaning. For example:

Here the Greek text is literally “Lord.”

See Lord, Context 2, in the Glossary.

and it is marvelous in our eyes: The word marvelous means “amazing and wonderful.” Both Jesus and the person who wrote Psalm 118 referred here to what God had done to the stone that represented the Messiah. People were amazed that God did something great with something that men considered worthless. The one whom the Jews rejected as Messiah was the one whom God appointed as Messiah.

in our eyes: This means “as we understand it” or “in our judgment.” It does not refer to literally seeing it with the eyes. The NCV has another way to say this:

it is wonderful to us

Mark 12:12

Section 12:1–12: Jesus told a parable about some evil grape farmers

In 11:28 the Jewish religious leaders asked Jesus two questions about his authority. In this section Jesus used a parable to answer those question in an indirect way. The Jewish leaders showed that they understood this parable by the way they responded in 12:12.

Jesus’ parable was about a man who owned a grape farm. He told some men to farm it for him and to give him a share of the profit. However, the men refused to give the owner his share. They even mistreated his servants who came to collect the money. When the owner sent his own son, they killed him.

Jesus used the people in the parable to represent the Jewish religious leaders and their actions toward God and toward himself, God’s son. Here are the most likely meanings of the different people and things in the parable:See Ray Summers, Commentary on Luke: Jesus, the Universal Savior, 1972, on the parallel passage in Luke 20:9–19.

	The owner of the grape farm	represents	God
	The grape farm	represents	Israel and its people
	The grape farm-ers	represent	the Jewish religious leaders
	The servants	represent	God’s messengers or prophets
	The son	represents	Jesus

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the vineyard and its farmers

The Parable of the Tenants in the Vineyard (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 21:33–46 and Luke 20:9–19.

12:12a
At this, the leaders sought to arrest Jesus,

- ¶ Then the Jewish leaders tried to find a way to arrest Jesus,
- ¶ After Jesus said these things, the chief priests, the teachers of the law, and the elders wanted to take him into custody.

the leaders sought: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the leaders sought is literally “they sought,” as in the NKJV. The BSB uses the phrase the leaders sought to refer clearly to the chief priests, the scribes, and the elders, who were last mentioned in 11:27. Refer to these leaders in a way that is natural in your language.

sought to arrest Jesus: The religious leaders tried to think of a way to arrest Jesus secretly so the people would not know about it. Otherwise, the people who followed Jesus might cause a riot by trying to defend him.

arrest: The Greek word that the BSB translates as arrest has several meanings. Here it means “seize, capture,” and it implies that the leaders wanted to take Jesus away for trial and punishment.

12:12b

for they knew that He had spoken this parable against them.

- because they realized that Jesus was speaking against them when he told the story about the evil grape farmers.
- They knew that the evil men in Jesus’ story represented them.

for: The Greek word that the BSB translates as for introduces the reason why the religious leaders wanted to arrest Jesus.

they knew that He had spoken this parable against them:

The Jewish leaders understood that Jesus had told the story of the grape farm as a warning to them. Jesus may also have given the metaphor of the stone as a warning to them. Jesus meant that when they rejected him, they rejected the one whom God had sent. They understood that Jesus meant that God would certainly punish them if they did not repent. This was why they wanted to arrest Jesus.

In some languages it may be necessary to express the meaning more explicitly. For example, in 12:12a–b, the NLT96 says:

The Jewish leaders wanted to arrest him for using this illustration because they realized he was pointing at them—they were the wicked farmers in his story.

See parable, Type 3, in the Glossary for how to translate parable in this context.

12:12c

But fearing the crowd,

- But they were afraid to do anything to Jesus because the many people there favored him.
- But they did not arrest him because they were afraid of what the crowd would do if they did.

But fearing the crowd: This phrase explains why the Jewish religious leaders did not arrest Jesus yet. (See 12:12a.) They were afraid that the many other people there might riot and try to help Jesus. They knew that the people respected Jesus and that many people believed his teaching.

The leaders had wanted or tried to arrest Jesus, but they did not do it yet. In some languages it may

be necessary to make that information explicit. For example:

But they did not arrest him because they were afraid of the people

12:12d

they left Him and went away.

- So they went away and left Jesus.

they left Him and went away: The leaders left Jesus because they were afraid to arrest him.

General Comment on 12:12a–d

In some languages it may be necessary to change the order of the parts in this verse. For example, the REB says:

^{12b}They saw that the parable was aimed at them
^{12a}and wanted to arrest him; ^{12c}but they were afraid of the people, ^{12d}so they left him alone and went away.

Mark 12:13

Section 12:13–17: Jewish leaders tried to trick Jesus with a question about paying taxes

The chief priests, the scribes, and the elders mentioned in 11:27 sent men to trick Jesus. They tried to trap him into saying something that they could use to cause trouble for him. The leaders sent men from two different groups, the Pharisees and the Herodians. These groups had plotted together against Jesus before in 3:6.

The men asked Jesus, “Should the Jews pay taxes to the Roman Emperor Caesar or not?” The word “Caesar” was the title that the Roman people gave to their highest ruler, the emperor. The Romans worshipped their emperor as a god. The Romans ruled the Jews and forced them to pay taxes. Although the Herodians and the Pharisees agreed to oppose Jesus, they disagreed about whether a person should pay taxes to the Roman emperor. The Herodians wanted the Romans to continue to rule the Jews, so they supported paying taxes. The Pharisees did not want the Romans to rule, and they were against paying taxes to them.

The men’s question was difficult because either a “yes” or a “no” answer would cause problems for Jesus. If Jesus answered, “Yes, the Jews should pay taxes to the Romans,” he would displease the Jews. If he answered, “No, they should not pay,” he would displease the Roman government. But Jesus answered

wisely and avoided the trap that the Jewish leaders had set for him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Paying Taxes to Caesar (ESV)

The Question about Paying Taxes (GNT)

Jewish leaders ask Jesus about paying taxes

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 22:15–22 and Luke 20:20–26.

12:13a

Later, they sent some of the Pharisees and Herodians

- ¶ After that the Jewish leaders sent some of the Pharisees and some of Herod's supporters to Jesus
- ¶ Sometime later, the leaders told some members of the Pharisee sect and some followers of Herod to go and talk to Jesus.

Later: This verse is the beginning of a new story. The events in this story happened sometime after the events in the preceding section. The BSB introduces this story with the word Later. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories.

If it is natural in your language to begin a story with a time word or phrase, use an expression that is not too specific. For example:

Then

After that

Next (NJB)

In some languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this story in a natural way in your language.

they sent some: The word they refers to the chief priests, the scribes, and the elders, who were mentioned in 11:27. In this context the phrase they sent some indicates that they told people to go to Jesus for a particular purpose.

Pharisees: The Pharisees were a Jewish religious group or party. It was very important to them to obey all of the Jewish religious laws very carefully and in detail. Here are some ways to translate this word:

- Transliterate the word Pharisees according to the sounds of your language and indicate that it refers to people. For example:

Farisi members

Parise adherents

- Transliterate the word Pharisees and indicate that it refers to a group of people with certain beliefs. For example:

people belonging to the Farise religious sect/
group

members of the religious group called the Farasi

You may also want to include an explanation of Pharisees in the glossary of your translation.

Herodians: The Herodians were a political group that supported a ruler whose name was Herod. The New Testament often refers to Herod as a king, but he functioned more as a governor than as a king. The Roman government appointed him.

The Herodians were against Jesus because they were afraid that Jesus might defeat Herod and become the ruler himself. See the note on Herodians in 3:6b.

12:13b

to catch Jesus in His words.

- so that they could trick him into saying something wrong.
- They told them to try to make Jesus say something that they could use to accuse him.

to catch Jesus in His words: This phrase expresses the purpose for which the Jewish leaders sent the Pharisees and Herodians to Jesus. They wanted to trick Jesus into saying something that would make either the Roman authorities or the Jewish people angry. Then the Jewish leaders would have an excuse to arrest him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to trick Jesus into saying something wrong (CEV)

to try to trap Jesus into saying something for which he could be arrested (NLT96)

to trap him with questions (GNT)

Mark 12:14

Section 12:13–17: Jewish leaders tried to trick Jesus with a question about paying taxes

The chief priests, the scribes, and the elders mentioned in 11:27 sent men to trick Jesus. They tried to trap him into saying something that they could use to cause trouble for him. The leaders sent men from two different groups, the Pharisees and the Herodians. These groups had plotted together against Jesus before in 3:6.

The men asked Jesus, “Should the Jews pay taxes to the Roman Emperor Caesar or not?” The word “Caesar” was the title that the Roman people gave to their highest ruler, the emperor. The Romans worshipped their emperor as a god. The Romans ruled the Jews and forced them to pay taxes. Although the Herodians and the Pharisees agreed to oppose Jesus, they disagreed about whether a person should pay taxes to the Roman emperor. The Herodians wanted the Romans to continue to rule the Jews, so they supported paying taxes. The Pharisees did not want the Romans to rule, and they were against paying taxes to them.

The men’s question was difficult because either a “yes” or a “no” answer would cause problems for Jesus. If Jesus answered, “Yes, the Jews should pay taxes to the Romans,” he would displease the Jews. If he answered, “No, they should not pay,” he would displease the Roman government. But Jesus answered wisely and avoided the trap that the Jewish leaders had set for him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Paying Taxes to Caesar (ESV)

The Question about Paying Taxes (GNT)

Jewish leaders ask Jesus about paying taxes

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 22:15–22 and Luke 20:20–26.

12:14a

“Teacher,” they said,

- So they went to him and said, “Teacher,
- When the Pharisees and the supporters of Herod came to Jesus, they said to him, “Sir Teacher,

Teacher: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Teacher was a polite title for a Jewish religious leader. It was a title of respect for a Jewish man who had authority to teach the things about God. In some languages the appropriate way to address a religious teacher may be:

Sir Teacher

Sir

Master

Be careful not to use a term that can refer only to a school teacher.

they said: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as they said is more literally “and having come, they said to him.” This phrase connects the introduction to the section in 12:13 with what the men said to Jesus in 12:14. Also, in Greek this phrase occurs at the beginning of this verse. Place it where it is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

When the men came to Jesus, they said to him...

So the men went to Jesus and said...

Connect 12:13 and 12:14 in a natural way in your language.

they: The word they refers to the men from the Pharisee group and the Herodian group.

12:14b

“we know that You are honest

- we know that you are an honest man. (NCV)
- we^(excl) know that you^(sing) tell the truth.

we know that You are honest: Here the people who came to Jesus expressed their confidence that Jesus was an honest person.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

we know that you tell the truth (GW)

we know that you are honest (CEV)

honest: The Greek word that the BSB translates as honest literally means “truthful.” So the word honest refers to a person who tells the truth.

**12:14c
and seek favor from no one.**

- You^(sing) do not let people affect what you do or say,
- You^(sing) do not allow people to influence you,

seek favor from no one: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as seek favor from no one is literally “it is not a concern to you about anyone.” This phrase is closely connected here to the word “honest” in 12:14b. It indicates that Jesus did not allow people to affect his decisions about what was right or wrong. He did and taught what was right, even if he knew that some people would accuse him of doing something wrong.

In some languages there may be an idiom to express this. Do not use an expression that implies that Jesus did not love people or have mercy on them. See the General Comment on 12:14b–e at the end of 12:14e for translation examples.

**12:14d
Indeed, You are impartial**

- because you^(sing) do not care about anyone’s status.
- and you^(sing) view/treat everyone the same way.

Indeed: The BSB uses the word Indeed to connect 12:14c and 12:14d. The way you connect these clauses in your language will depend on how you translate the whole verse. See the General Comment on 12:14b–e at the end of 12:14e for translation suggestions.

You are impartial: In Greek this phrase is literally “for you do not look at the face of men.” This is an idiom. It means that Jesus treated people fairly. He did not favor the rich or powerful people more than other people.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

You pay no attention to anyone’s status (GNT)

You ignore their position/greatness.

You pay no attention to who they are (NIV)

Be careful not to imply that Jesus was impolite or disrespectful. The CEV avoids this implication as follows:

You treat everyone with the same respect, no matter who they are.

General Comment on 12:14c–d

In your language it may be easier to reverse the order of 12:14c–d. For example:

^{14d}You do not care whether others consider men/people as important, ^{14c}so you do not let them influence you.

**12:14e
and teach the way of God in accordance with the truth.**

- Instead, you^(sing) teach the truth about the way God wants people to live.
- When you^(sing) teach people about God, you tell the truth about what he wants them to do.

and teach the way of God in accordance with the truth: The Greek word that the BSB translates as and connects this part of the verse with 12:14c–d. In Greek it indicates a contrast. Jesus did not consider people’s status and favor some of them more than others. Instead, he taught the way of God by telling the truth. Express this contrast in a natural way in your language. See the General Comment on 12:14b–e for translation suggestions.

the way of God: In the context of the question about paying taxes, the phrase the way of God refers primarily to what God wants people to do.

in accordance with the truth: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in accordance with the truth means “truthfully.” This statement indicates that Jesus taught the truth about how people should live to please God. The people who said this had been sent to trick Jesus, so they did not speak truthfully themselves.

General Comment on 12:14b–e

There is a contrast between 12:14c–d and 12:14e. For example, the GNT shows the contrast by using the word “but”:

^{14b}Teacher, we know that you tell the truth,
^{14c}without worrying about what people think.
^{14d}You pay no attention to anyone’s status, ^{14e}but teach the truth about God’s will for people.

In some languages it may not be necessary to make the contrast explicit, because the context implies it.

Notice that 12:14b and 12:14e have similar meanings, and 12:14c and 12:14d have similar meanings. In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of these verse parts. For example:

^{14b}We know that you are a man of integrity ^{14e}and sincerely teach the ways of God. ^{14d}You are impartial ^{14c}and do not consider anyone's status.

12:14f

Is it lawful to pay taxes to Caesar or not?

- Does our law permit us^(incl) Jews to pay taxes to the Caesar/Emperor in Rome or not?
- Is it against the law of us^(incl) Jews to pay tax money to the Roman government?

After the men praised Jesus insincerely in 12:14a–e, they asked him a question. They implied that because he was an honest man, he would give them a true answer. In some languages this implied connection may need to be made explicit. In other languages a conjunction will not be needed.

Here are some other ways to translate the connection:

So we ask you, does our^(incl) law permit us to pay taxes...

Tell us whether our^(incl) law permits us to pay taxes...

Is it lawful to pay taxes to Caesar or not?: The question in this verse asks for a choice between two alternatives. The men who asked the question expected Jesus to say either that it was right to pay taxes to Caesar, or that it was not right.

Is it lawful...?: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *Is it lawful...?* indicates that the men who asked this question were thinking of what the Jewish law allowed. They were not thinking of the Roman law, which clearly required Jewish people to pay the Roman tax. In some languages it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

Is it against our Law to pay taxes...? (GNT)

Does the Law of Moses permit us^(incl) to pay taxes...?

Will we break the law of us^(incl) Jews if we pay tax...?

taxes: The word taxes refers to money that a person had to pay to the government. The Roman government required each adult male in their conquered countries to pay taxes to them. Judea, where Jesus was staying, was one of the places that the Romans had conquered.

Caesar: The word Caesar was a title for the supreme ruler over the city of Rome. He also ruled over all the countries that the people of Rome had conquered, including the country of the Jews. The word “Caesar” was borrowed from the Latin language. At this time the Caesar’s name was Tiberius. At the time of Jesus’ birth, Caesar Augustus was the ruler. The word Caesar is equivalent to the title “Emperor.” It is not a personal name.

Here are some other ways to translate the title Caesar:

- Use an equivalent title. For example:

the Emperor/King in Rome

the Roman Emperor (GNT)

the high chief

- Use a more general term. For example:

the government of the Romans that rules us

the ruler in the city of Rome

- Use a transliterated term. For example:

the Caesar If you use this option, you may want to add a footnote. For example:

“Caesar” was the title for the ruler of the people in the city of Rome. He also ruled over all the countries that Rome had conquered, including the country of the Jews.

12:14g

Should we pay them or not?”

- Should we^(incl) pay the taxes or should we not pay them?”
- Should we^(incl) give them the money? Or should we refuse to give it to them?”

Notice that some English versions, including the NIV, put this part of the verse at the beginning of 12:15. You

may want to check the major language version in your area before you decide where to begin 12:15.

Should we pay them or not?: This question has the same meaning as the one in 12:14f. The men repeated the question to try to make sure that Jesus would give a clear and direct answer.

Mark 12:15

Section 12:13–17: Jewish leaders tried to trick Jesus with a question about paying taxes

The chief priests, the scribes, and the elders mentioned in 11:27 sent men to trick Jesus. They tried to trap him into saying something that they could use to cause trouble for him. The leaders sent men from two different groups, the Pharisees and the Herodians. These groups had plotted together against Jesus before in 3:6.

The men asked Jesus, “Should the Jews pay taxes to the Roman Emperor Caesar or not?” The word “Caesar” was the title that the Roman people gave to their highest ruler, the emperor. The Romans worshipped their emperor as a god. The Romans ruled the Jews and forced them to pay taxes. Although the Herodians and the Pharisees agreed to oppose Jesus, they disagreed about whether a person should pay taxes to the Roman emperor. The Herodians wanted the Romans to continue to rule the Jews, so they supported paying taxes. The Pharisees did not want the Romans to rule, and they were against paying taxes to them.

The men’s question was difficult because either a “yes” or a “no” answer would cause problems for Jesus. If Jesus answered, “Yes, the Jews should pay taxes to the Romans,” he would displease the Jews. If he answered, “No, they should not pay,” he would displease the Roman government. But Jesus answered wisely and avoided the trap that the Jewish leaders had set for him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Paying Taxes to Caesar (ESV)

The Question about Paying Taxes (GNT)

Jewish leaders ask Jesus about paying taxes

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 22:15–22 and Luke 20:20–26.

12:15a

But Jesus saw through their hypocrisy

- But Jesus knew that they were not being sincere,
- Jesus realized that they had a deceitful purpose for asking him the question.

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But connects the men’s question with Jesus’ response. The response contrasted with what the men expected. Use a natural way in your language to express this contrast.

Jesus saw through their hypocrisy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as saw through is more literally “knowing.” Jesus knew the men were asking the questions in 12:14f and 12:14g only because they wanted to trap him. They pretended to be sincere, but they were actually trying to get Jesus into trouble by making him give a wrong answer.

hypocrisy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hypocrisy indicates that a person is different from how people think he is. He appears to have a certain purpose or attitude, but actually he has a very different purpose or attitude. People do not know that purpose or attitude. The men who questioned Jesus appeared to be sincerely concerned about whether it was right to pay taxes to Caesar. However, what they really wanted was to trap Jesus. See how you translated the related word “hypocrites” in 7:6a.

12:15b

and said, “Why are you testing Me?”

- He asked, “Why are you^(plur) trying to trick me into saying something wrong?”
- So he said to them, “You^(plur) should not be trying to trap me in order to accuse me!”

Jesus asked the question in this part of the verse because he knew that these men were not sincere. In some languages it may be natural to indicate a result connection. For example:

So he asked them

Why are you testing Me?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus asked this question to rebuke the Pharisees and the Herodians. He knew that they were trying to trick him and he knew why they were trying to trick him. They wanted him to say something that would cause trouble for him. There are at least two ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question, as in the BSB.
- As a statement. For example:

You should not be trying to trick/test me!

You are trying to trap me into saying something wrong!

Use whichever form is most natural to express a rebuke in your language.

testing: The Greek word that the BSB translates as testing has almost the same meaning as the phrase that was translated “catch him in his words” in 12:13. The men were testing Jesus. They tried to make him say something that would cause trouble for him. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate the reason that the men were testing him. For example:

Why are you testing me to cause trouble for me?

Why are you trying to trick me into saying something that you can accuse me with?

12:15c

Bring Me a denarius to inspect.”

- Bring me a denarius coin so I can see it.”
- Then he said, “Show me one of the coins that people use to pay the tax.”

Bring Me a denarius to inspect: In some languages the two verb phrases Bring Me a denarius to inspect can be expressed with a single verb. For example, the CEV has:

Show me a coin!

Consider how your language would naturally express this request.

denarius: A denarius was a Roman coin that was made of silver. It was used by the Jews to pay their taxes to the Roman government. The denarius had the name and the image of Caesar on it.

Here are some other ways to translate denarius:

- Use a more general term or a descriptive phrase. For example:

Roman coin/money

coin used for paying taxes

- Use a borrowed word along with a general term. For example:

denarius coin

Mark 12:16

Section 12:13–17: Jewish leaders tried to trick Jesus with a question about paying taxes

The chief priests, the scribes, and the elders mentioned in 11:27 sent men to trick Jesus. They tried to trap him into saying something that they could use to cause trouble for him. The leaders sent men from two different groups, the Pharisees and the Herodians. These groups had plotted together against Jesus before in 3:6.

The men asked Jesus, “Should the Jews pay taxes to the Roman Emperor Caesar or not?” The word “Caesar” was the title that the Roman people gave to their highest ruler, the emperor. The Romans worshipped their emperor as a god. The Romans ruled the Jews and forced them to pay taxes. Although the Herodians and the Pharisees agreed to oppose Jesus, they disagreed about whether a person should pay taxes to the Roman emperor. The Herodians wanted the Romans to continue to rule the Jews, so they supported paying taxes. The Pharisees did not want the Romans to rule, and they were against paying taxes to them.

The men’s question was difficult because either a “yes” or a “no” answer would cause problems for Jesus. If Jesus answered, “Yes, the Jews should pay taxes to the Romans,” he would displease the Jews. If he answered, “No, they should not pay,” he would displease the Roman government. But Jesus answered wisely and avoided the trap that the Jewish leaders had set for him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Paying Taxes to Caesar (ESV)

The Question about Paying Taxes (GNT)

Jewish leaders ask Jesus about paying taxes

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 22:15–22 and Luke 20:20–26.

12:16a

So they brought it, and He asked them,

- When they brought a coin, he asked them,

- So they brought/showed him a coin. Then Jesus asked them,

12:16b**“Whose image is this? And whose inscription?”**

- “Tell me whose picture and whose name/title are on this denarius coin.”
- “Whose face/image is drawn/stamped on this coin, and whose name/title is written on it?”

12:16a–b

So they brought it: The word it refer to the denarius that Jesus asked the people to bring him in 12:15c.

He asked them, “Whose image is this? And whose inscription?”: Jesus asked these questions to prepare the people for what he wanted to teach them. Jesus knew the answer to these questions. However, he still expected them to answer it and they did.

image: The Greek word that the BSB translates as image means “likeness” or “representation.” Each denarius had a picture of the emperor’s head on it. This image symbolically marked all the denarius coins as belonging to the emperor.

Here are some other ways to translate image:

face (GNT)

head (RSV)

picture (NLT)

portrait (NIV)

inscription: The inscription on a coin is the writing on it. This writing included the name of the emperor.

Here are some other ways to translate inscription:

name (GNT)

title (RSV)

In some languages it may more natural to combine these two questions into one sentence, as many English versions have done. For example:

Whose likeness and inscription is this? (RSV)

Whose picture and title are stamped on it? (NLT)

Whose face and name are these? (GNT)

12:16c**“Caesar’s,” they answered.**

- They said, “Those of Caesar.”
- They answered, “It has the face and the name/title of the Roman emperor.”

Caesar’s: They answered that the coin had on it the image of the Roman emperor Caesar (a picture of his head and face) and his name or title. See how you translated Caesar in 12:14f.

In some languages it may be necessary to write this answer as a complete sentence. For example:

The picture and name of Caesar are on it.

they answered: The BSB puts the phrase they answered after the people’s answer. The Greek text places it before their answer. You may place this information where it is natural in your language.

Mark 12:17**Section 12:13–17: Jewish leaders tried to trick Jesus with a question about paying taxes**

The chief priests, the scribes, and the elders mentioned in 11:27 sent men to trick Jesus. They tried to trap him into saying something that they could use to cause trouble for him. The leaders sent men from two different groups, the Pharisees and the Herodians. These groups had plotted together against Jesus before in 3:6.

The men asked Jesus, “Should the Jews pay taxes to the Roman Emperor Caesar or not?” The word “Caesar” was the title that the Roman people gave to their highest ruler, the emperor. The Romans worshipped their emperor as a god. The Romans ruled the Jews and forced them to pay taxes. Although the Herodians and the Pharisees agreed to oppose Jesus, they disagreed about whether a person should pay taxes to the Roman emperor. The Herodians wanted the Romans to continue to rule the Jews, so they supported paying taxes. The Pharisees did not want the Romans to rule, and they were against paying taxes to them.

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It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Paying Taxes to Caesar (ESV)

The Question about Paying Taxes (GNT)

Jewish leaders ask Jesus about paying taxes

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 22:15–22 and Luke 20:20–26.

12:17a

Then Jesus told them,

- Then Jesus said to them,
- Jesus told them,

12:17a–b

Then Jesus told them: This part of the verse introduces Jesus' response to the men's answer in 12:16c. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate the connection between the men's answer and this response.

Here are some other ways to make this connection explicit:

Jesus told them, "Then give to Caesar..."

Then Jesus said, "Since that is true, then here is my answer to your question: Give to Caesar..."

12:17b–c

Give to Caesar what is Caesar's, and to God what is God's: In Greek the parts of 12:17b–c occur in a different order. The order is literally:

The things of Caesar give to Caesar and the things of God give to God.

In Greek this order keeps the reader's attention on the word "Caesar," the same word that Jesus' questioners used in 12:16c. In some languages it may also be natural to follow this order. For example:

What belongs to Caesar, give to Caesar, and what belongs to God, give to God.

12:17b

"Give to Caesar what is Caesar's,

- "Well then, give to Caesar what rightfully belongs to him,
- "Here then is my answer: Give to the Roman emperor what you^(plur) owe to him,

Give to Caesar what is Caesar's: The word that the BSB translates as Give means to give or pay to someone what you owe them. According to Louw & Nida (page 575 #57.153), the Greek word means: "to make a payment, with the implication of such a payment being in response to an incurred obligation." Jesus said that people should give or pay to the emperor and to his Roman government what rightfully belonged to them. This would include obeying the Roman law and paying the Roman tax.

Notice that Jesus did not say explicitly that they should pay this tax. He wanted them to draw this conclusion from what they themselves had asked and answered. So in your translation, you should not make explicit what people should give to the Emperor.

12:17c

and to God what is God's."

- and give to God what rightfully belongs to him."
- and give to God whatever you^(plur) owe to him."

and to God what is God's: People should also give to God what rightfully belongs to him, and do what his law requires.

In some languages it may be helpful to repeat the verb here:

and give to God what is God's

12:17d

And they marveled at Him.

- They were completely surprised at how well/cleverly he answered them.
- Because of this answer, the people who had questioned him were utterly astonished.

And: In Greek this part of the verse begins with the Greek conjunction is often translated as And, as in the BSB. Here it introduces the result of Jesus' clever reply. Some English versions leave this connection implicit. For example the CEV says:

The men were amazed at Jesus.

Other versions make the connection explicit by putting the last part of this sentence first. See the following note and examples on the phrase "at him."

they marveled: The Greek word that the BSB translates as marveled emphasizes that the Pharisees and Herodians were very surprised. You may have an idiom in your language that is used to describe complete amazement. If so, you may want to use that idiom here.

at Him: They were very surprised at what Jesus had said. Specifically, they were surprised that Jesus had avoided their trap by his clever answer. The cause of their amazement can be made clear in various ways. For example:

The men were amazed at what Jesus said. (NCV)

They were completely amazed at how Jesus had gotten out of their trap. (TRT)

Other versions change the order of the sentence so that the last part comes first. For example:

His reply completely amazed them. (NLT)

When they heard Jesus' answer, they were utterly astonished.

Consider how to express this statement clearly in your language.

Mark 12:18

Section 12:18–27: Other leaders asked Jesus about people living again after they die

The Jewish leaders continued to challenge Jesus. In this section some Sadducees asked Jesus a question to try to show that the things he taught were wrong. Like the Pharisees, the Sadducees were a group of Jewish leaders with certain religious beliefs. Many of the Sadducees were priests. They did not believe that God would cause anyone who had died to live again.

Jesus believed and taught that God does cause people who have died to live again. The Sadducees tried to use this belief to trick Jesus in 12:18–27. They told a story to ridicule these beliefs that Jesus taught. The story was not true, but they used it to ask a question. They thought that if a person believed that people who died could live again, there was no sensible answer to the question.

The Sadducees based their story on the Jewish custom that is described in Deuteronomy 25:5–6. This Scripture teaches that if a woman did not have any children by her husband before he died, his brother was required

to marry her. Their first child would have the name of his dead brother and would be his heir. This custom was called the levirate. Jewish people considered the first son that the widow bore after marrying the brother of her dead husband to be the son of her dead husband, not the son of the man who was now her husband. This meant that this son and his descendants would carry on the dead man's family and family name through future generations. Any sons born after this to the woman and her living husband would carry on the name of the living husband for future generations. In that way, the dead man's family and family name could continue through future generations. Since the Scripture taught this custom, the Sadducees believed that they could prove from Scripture that Jesus was wrong.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The question about the resurrection

The Sadducees Ask About the Resurrection (ESV)

Do people rise from the dead?

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 22:23–33 and Luke 20:27–40.

Paragraph 12:18–23

In this paragraph the Sadducees explained a Jewish custom. Then they told a story and used it to ask Jesus a question about life after death. They hoped that the question would be too difficult for Jesus to answer. They planned to ridicule the idea of life after death.

12:18a

Then the Sadducees,

- ¶ After that, some men who were from the group named Sadducees
- ¶ Later, some people who belonged to the Sadducee group/party

12:18b

who say there is no resurrection, came to Jesus

- came to him. Sadducees teach that people do not live again after they die.
- came to Jesus. The Sadducee group believed that God does not cause people to live again after they die.

12:18a–b

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then here introduces the beginning of a new story. Matthew 22:23 indicates that this event happened on the same day as the events in the preceding section. The Greek text of Mark does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories.

If it is natural in your language to begin a story with a time word or phrase, use an expression that is not too specific. For example:

Later

After that

In some languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this story in a natural way in your language.

the Sadducees, who say there is no resurrection, came to Jesus: Here the author introduced the Sadducees into the story and gave background information about them. The Sadducees were a Jewish religious group who had certain beliefs. They did not believe in the resurrection. Some of these Sadducees came to Jesus.

Languages have different ways to introduce people in a story. Use a way that is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Then some members of the Sadducee group came to Jesus. The Sadducee group does not believe that people who die can live again.

Then Jesus was approached by some Sadducees—religious leaders who say there is no resurrection from the dead. (NLT)

Some languages have a special word or form to indicate background information. Some languages have another word or form to indicate a return to the events in the story. Use a natural way to do this in your language.

the Sadducees: The Sadducees were a Jewish religious group or party. They taught that the first five books of the Old Testament were more important than the other books. They did not believe that angels or spirits existed (Acts 23:8). Here are some ways to translate this word:

- Transliterate the word Sadducees according to the sounds of your language and indicate that it refers to a group of people. For example:

Sadusi members

Saduce adherents

- Transliterate the word Sadducees and indicate that it refers to a group of people with certain beliefs. For example:

people belonging to the Sadusi religious group

members of the Jewish group called the Saduceo

It is recommended that you translate Sadducees in a similar way as you translated “Pharisees” in 2:16a.

who say there is no resurrection: The Sadducees believed that God does not cause people to live again after they die. They also taught this belief to other people. In this context the verb say refers to what the Sadducees believed and taught. For example:

The Sadducees did not believe that people would live again after they die.

say: The verb say is in the present tense because at the time Mark was writing, the Sadducees were still saying this. In some languages a literal translation may suggest that the Sadducees still say this today. Consider if it would be more natural to translate this with a different form of the verb.

resurrection: Many Jewish people believed in the resurrection. Some scholars think that the term resurrection refers to a time in the future when God will cause all people who have died to live again. This term does not imply that a person will live again as a different person or as an animal. It implies that when God causes people to live again, everyone will have the same identity that they had before they died.

You will want to carefully check your translation of this term to make sure that it does not communicate a wrong meaning.

12:18c**and questioned Him:**

- These men asked Jesus a question about that.
- They knew that Jesus disagreed with them about that, so they asked him a question to discredit him.

and questioned Him: The question that the Sadducees asked was not sincere. They asked it to ridicule the idea that people can live again after they die. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate some of this implied information. For example:

Sadducees, who did not believe, as Jesus did, that there will be a resurrection

See also the Display for 12:18c.

General Comment on 12:18a–c

It might be more natural in your language to reorder this verse. For example:

The Jewish leaders called Sadducees did not believe that people rise to life after death. So some of them came to Jesus and asked him a difficult question.

Then some of the Jewish leaders called Sadducees went to Jesus. They asked him a question because they did not believe, as Jesus did, that people can live again after they die.

Mark 12:19

Section 12:18–27: Other leaders asked Jesus about people living again after they die

The Jewish leaders continued to challenge Jesus. In this section some Sadducees asked Jesus a question to try to show that the things he taught were wrong. Like the Pharisees, the Sadducees were a group of Jewish leaders with certain religious beliefs. Many of the Sadducees were priests. They did not believe that God would cause anyone who had died to live again.

Jesus believed and taught that God does cause people who have died to live again. The Sadducees tried to use this belief to trick Jesus in 12:18–27. They told a story to ridicule these beliefs that Jesus taught. The story was not true, but they used it to ask a question. They thought that if a person believed that people who died could live again, there was no sensible answer to the question.

The Sadducees based their story on the Jewish custom that is described in Deuteronomy 25:5–6. This Scripture teaches that if a woman did not have any children by her husband before he died, his brother was required to marry her. Their first child would have the name of his dead brother and would be his heir. This custom was called the levirate. Jewish people considered the first son that the widow bore after marrying the

brother of her dead husband to be the son of her dead husband, not the son of the man who was now her husband. This meant that this son and his descendants would carry on the dead man's family and family name through future generations. Any sons born after this to the woman and her living husband would carry on the name of the living husband for future generations. In that way, the dead man's family and family name could continue through future generations. Since the Scripture taught this custom, the Sadducees believed that they could prove from Scripture that Jesus was wrong.

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12:19a

“Teacher, Moses wrote for us that

- They said, “Teacher, there is a law that Moses gave to us^(incl) in the Scriptures that
- They said, “Sir Teacher, Moses wrote a/this law for us^(incl) Jews. He said that

Teacher: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Teacher was a polite title for a Jewish religious leader. It does not mean “school teacher.” See how you translated this word in 4:38c and 12:14a.

Moses wrote for us that: This phrase introduces a specific law that God gave the Jews. Moses wrote this law for them in Deuteronomy 25:5–10. The word us here includes Jesus, because he also was a Jew.

In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit that what Moses wrote was a law. It may also be necessary to clarify that the phrase for us refers to the Jews in general. It does not refer only to the

Sadducees of Jesus' time. Here is one way to clarify these things:

Our^(incl) law that Moses wrote says

Moses wrote this law for us Jews:

Moses: Moses was one of the greatest leaders of the Jews. He lived long before Jesus was born. He wrote God's laws for the Jews. That is why the first five books of the Old Testament are often called "the Law of Moses."

12:19b

if a man's brother dies and leaves a wife but no children,

- if a man's married brother dies without having any children,
- this is what a man must do for his married brother who dies before fathering a child.

if a man's brother dies and leaves a wife but no children: This clause describes a situation that might happen. A married man might die without having any children. Moses wrote a law that would apply to the wife and the man's brother in this situation.

12:19c

the man is to marry his brother's widow

- that man must marry the widow
- He must marry the widow

the man is to marry his brother's widow: The phrase the man here refers to a man whose brother died. The passage in Deuteronomy does not indicate whether one brother was older or younger than the other. If there were several brothers and one died, it is reasonable to assume that the oldest of the remaining brothers should marry the widow. But this is not clear in Moses' writings.

his brother's widow: A widow is a woman whose husband has died. If she remarries, she is no longer a widow.

12:19d

and raise up offspring for him.

- and have a son/descendant who will preserve that dead brother's name.
- and have a child who will be considered the dead man's child.
- and father an heir for his dead brother.

and raise up offspring for him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as offspring is literally "seed." Here it refers to a son and his descendants. When the

brother and the widow had their first son, that son would inherit the dead brother's name and land. In this way the dead brother would also have descendants and his family could continue.

You may want to make explicit in your translation that only the first child would be considered the child of the dead brother. For example:

Their first son would then be thought of as the son of the dead brother. (CEV) If the living brother had other children by his brother's widow, those children would be considered as children of the living brother.

It may be helpful in your translation to have a footnote to briefly explain this custom. For example:

In ancient Israel there was a custom that if a man married and then died childless, one of his brothers should marry his widow. The first son that the widow bore in her new marriage would be considered the son of her dead husband. This son would act as the heir to the name and property of the first husband. The details of this custom are in Deuteronomy 25:5-10.

for him: The pronoun him refers to the dead brother. Here are some other ways to translate the phrase for him:

who will carry on the brother's name (NLT)

who will be considered the dead man's child

who will be his brother's heir

Mark 12:20

Section 12:18–27: Other leaders asked Jesus about people living again after they die

The Jewish leaders continued to challenge Jesus. In this section some Sadducees asked Jesus a question to try to show that the things he taught were wrong. Like the Pharisees, the Sadducees were a group of Jewish leaders with certain religious beliefs. Many of the Sadducees were priests. They did not believe that God would cause anyone who had died to live again.

Jesus believed and taught that God does cause people who have died to live again. The Sadducees tried to use this belief to trick Jesus in 12:18–27. They told a story to ridicule these beliefs that Jesus taught. The

story was not true, but they used it to ask a question. They thought that if a person believed that people who died could live again, there was no sensible answer to the question.

The Sadducees based their story on the Jewish custom that is described in Deuteronomy 25:5–6. This Scripture teaches that if a woman did not have any children by her husband before he died, his brother was required to marry her. Their first child would have the name of his dead brother and would be his heir. This custom was called the levirate. Jewish people considered the first son that the widow bore after marrying the brother of her dead husband to be the son of her dead husband, not the son of the man who was now her husband. This meant that this son and his descendants would carry on the dead man's family and family name through future generations. Any sons born after this to the woman and her living husband would carry on the name of the living husband for future generations. In that way, the dead man's family and family name could continue through future generations. Since the Scripture taught this custom, the Sadducees believed that they could prove from Scripture that Jesus was wrong.

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There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 22:23–33 and Luke 20:27–40.

Paragraph 12:18–23

In this paragraph the Sadducees explained a Jewish custom. Then they told a story and used it to ask Jesus a question about life after death. They hoped that the question would be too difficult for Jesus to answer. They planned to ridicule the idea of life after death.

12:20a

Now there were seven brothers.

- Well, let's^(incl) suppose there were seven men who were brothers.
- Once there lived seven male siblings.

Now there were seven brothers: In this verse the Sadducees began to tell Jesus a story that described a situation that might have happened. It was not a true story about actual people. The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now introduces their story. It is not a time word here. Use a natural way in your language to begin a story that did not actually happen and to introduce the participants. For example:

Once there were seven brothers (GNT)

Well, suppose there were seven brothers (NLT)

seven brothers: The number seven was a favorite number with the Jews. The Sadducees probably used this number of brothers to make the story more interesting and to emphasize their point. They thought that if God caused all people to live again, the woman could not be married to all seven husbands at the same time. Therefore, they implied that God's law which said that a man should marry his brother's widow showed that people would not live again after they died.

12:20b

The first one married and died, leaving no children.

- The first brother got married but died without having any children.
- The oldest sibling married a woman and had no children when he died.

The first one married: The first one in this context implies the oldest brother, who would normally be the first one to marry.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

The first brother married/took a wife/woman

the oldest got married (GNT)

died, leaving no children: The husband died and his wife had no children by him. Again here, and in 12:21b and 12:22a, the Greek term that the BSB translates as children is literally "seed." He died without fathering a child. There is nothing in the story that suggests why the man died. So your translation should not imply that the woman caused the husband to die.

Mark 12:21

Section 12:18–27: Other leaders asked Jesus about people living again after they die

The Jewish leaders continued to challenge Jesus. In this section some Sadducees asked Jesus a question

to try to show that the things he taught were wrong. Like the Pharisees, the Sadducees were a group of Jewish leaders with certain religious beliefs. Many of the Sadducees were priests. They did not believe that God would cause anyone who had died to live again.

Jesus believed and taught that God does cause people who have died to live again. The Sadducees tried to use this belief to trick Jesus in 12:18–27. They told a story to ridicule these beliefs that Jesus taught. The story was not true, but they used it to ask a question. They thought that if a person believed that people who died could live again, there was no sensible answer to the question.

The Sadducees based their story on the Jewish custom that is described in Deuteronomy 25:5–6. This Scripture teaches that if a woman did not have any children by her husband before he died, his brother was required to marry her. Their first child would have the name of his dead brother and would be his heir. This custom was called the levirate. Jewish people considered the first son that the widow bore after marrying the brother of her dead husband to be the son of her dead husband, not the son of the man who was now her husband. This meant that this son and his descendants would carry on the dead man's family and family name through future generations. Any sons born after this to the woman and her living husband would carry on the name of the living husband for future generations. In that way, the dead man's family and family name could continue through future generations. Since the Scripture taught this custom, the Sadducees believed that they could prove from Scripture that Jesus was wrong.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The question about the resurrection

The Sadducees Ask About the Resurrection (ESV)

Do people rise from the dead?

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 22:23–33 and Luke 20:27–40.

Paragraph 12:18–23

In this paragraph the Sadducees explained a Jewish custom. Then they told a story and used it to ask Jesus a question about life after death. They hoped that the

question would be too difficult for Jesus to answer. They planned to ridicule the idea of life after death.

12:21a

Then the second one married the widow,

- The second brother married his dead brother's widow,
- Then the next oldest sibling married his/the widow,

Then the second one married the widow: The second oldest brother then married his dead brother's widow. Some languages distinguish between older brothers and younger brothers. If that is true in your language, you may specify that this brother was younger than the brother who had died.

If your language does not normally use the word second to refer to a brother, you can say:

The next brother married the widow

12:21b

but he also died and left no children.

- but he also died without having any children.
- but that brother died too and fathered no children.

but he also died and left no children: This second brother died also without having any children.

12:21c

And the third did likewise.

- The same thing happened with the third brother
- The third/next brother also married her and died without having any children.

And the third did likewise: Then the third oldest brother married the widow but also died without having any children.

If your language does not normally use the word third to refer to a brother, you can say:

And the next brother did likewise.

Mark 12:22

Section 12:18–27: Other leaders asked Jesus about people living again after they die

The Jewish leaders continued to challenge Jesus. In this section some Sadducees asked Jesus a question to try to show that the things he taught were wrong. Like the Pharisees, the Sadducees were a group of Jewish leaders with certain religious beliefs. Many of the Sadducees were priests. They did not believe that God would cause anyone who had died to live again.

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12:22a

In this way, none of the seven left any children.

- and with all seven brothers. The woman did not bear a child for any of them.
- All the other brothers married the same woman, one after another, and all of them died without any of the seven brothers having any children.

In this way: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *In this way* is the common conjunction that is often translated as “and.” The BSB uses this phrase to introduce a summary statement. See the following note. Connect this verse to the preceding one in a natural way in your language for this context.

none of the seven left any children: This statement implies that after the third brother died, all the other brothers, one after another, married the same woman. None of them had children with her, and they all died. In some languages there may be an idiom to indicate this or a special way to summarize it. For example:

Things continued happening like this...

This continued with all seven of them. (NLT)

12:22b

And last of all, the woman died.

- At the end, the woman also died.
- After the seven brothers died, the widow died too.

And last of all, the woman died: This is the last part of the story. After the seven brothers had died, the woman also died.

Mark 12:23

Section 12:18–27: Other leaders asked Jesus about people living again after they die

The Jewish leaders continued to challenge Jesus. In this section some Sadducees asked Jesus a question to try to show that the things he taught were wrong. Like the Pharisees, the Sadducees were a group of Jewish leaders with certain religious beliefs. Many of the Sadducees were priests. They did not believe that God would cause anyone who had died to live again.

Jesus believed and taught that God does cause people who have died to live again. The Sadducees tried to use this belief to trick Jesus in 12:18–27. They told a story to ridicule these beliefs that Jesus taught. The story was not true, but they used it to ask a question. They thought that if a person believed that people who died could live again, there was no sensible answer to the question.

The Sadducees based their story on the Jewish custom that is described in Deuteronomy 25:5–6. This Scripture

teaches that if a woman did not have any children by her husband before he died, his brother was required to marry her. Their first child would have the name of his dead brother and would be his heir. This custom was called the levirate. Jewish people considered the first son that the widow bore after marrying the brother of her dead husband to be the son of her dead husband, not the son of the man who was now her husband. This meant that this son and his descendants would carry on the dead man's family and family name through future generations. Any sons born after this to the woman and her living husband would carry on the name of the living husband for future generations. In that way, the dead man's family and family name could continue through future generations. Since the Scripture taught this custom, the Sadducees believed that they could prove from Scripture that Jesus was wrong.

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12:23

The Sadducees finished their sad story in 12:22. In 12:23 they asked Jesus the question that they had prepared. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate that the Sadducees have finished their story and will now ask Jesus a question. The BSB includes the word “then” in the middle of the question to indicate this. Here are some other ways to say this:

So tell us, whose wife will she be... (NLT)

So now, whose wife will she be...

12:23a

In the resurrection, then, whose wife will she be?

- At the time when dead people live again, whose wife will she be?
- So tell us,^(excl) which man will be her husband at the time when God will raise dead people to life?

In the resurrection: There is a textual issues in 12:23a. After the word resurrection, some Greek manuscripts have the phrase “when they are raised.” (1) Some Greek manuscripts do not have this phrase. For example, the CEV says: “When God raises people from death, whose wife will this woman be?” (NIV, RSV, NLT, NCV, GW, CEV). (2) Other manuscripts have the phrase when they are raised. For example, the NET says: “In the resurrection, when they rise again, whose wife will she be?” (GNT, KJV, NASB, NET, NJB, REB, JBP). The BSB follows the manuscripts that include when they are raised, but it translates the phrases “In the resurrection” and “when they rise again” together as one phrase. In your translation, you could follow the option that is most clear and natural in your language. The resurrection refers to the time when God will cause people who have died to live again. The Sadducees did not believe that this would ever happen. They referred to it in this story only to make belief in a resurrection look foolish.

whose wife will she be: The Sadducees asked Jesus to say which of the seven men would be her husband when God caused people to live again. The Sadducees thought that there was no good answer to this question.

12:23b

For all seven were married to her.”

- After all, she had married all seven men!”
- We^(excl) ask this because she was the wife of all seven men!”

For: The Greek connector that the BSB translates as For introduces an explanation of 12:23a. Some English versions use “since” or “after all” here or do not use a connector. Use a natural way to connect 12:23a and 12:23b in your language.

all seven were married to her: The Sadducees referred here to the seven brothers who had married the one woman. The Sadducees implied that this would create an impossible situation in the resurrection. They believed that no woman could have seven husbands at the same time.

General Comment on 12:23a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of information in this verse. For example:

^{23b} So , because all seven brothers had married the woman, ^{23a}whose wife will she be when dead people live again?

Mark 12:24

Section 12:18–27: Other leaders asked Jesus about people living again after they die

The Jewish leaders continued to challenge Jesus. In this section some Sadducees asked Jesus a question to try to show that the things he taught were wrong. Like the Pharisees, the Sadducees were a group of Jewish leaders with certain religious beliefs. Many of the Sadducees were priests. They did not believe that God would cause anyone who had died to live again.

Jesus believed and taught that God does cause people who have died to live again. The Sadducees tried to use this belief to trick Jesus in 12:18–27. They told a story to ridicule these beliefs that Jesus taught. The story was not true, but they used it to ask a question. They thought that if a person believed that people who died could live again, there was no sensible answer to the question.

The Sadducees based their story on the Jewish custom that is described in Deuteronomy 25:5–6. This Scripture teaches that if a woman did not have any children by her husband before he died, his brother was required to marry her. Their first child would have the name of his dead brother and would be his heir. This custom was called the levirate. Jewish people considered the first son that the widow bore after marrying the brother of her dead husband to be the son of her dead husband, not the son of the man who was now her husband. This meant that this son and his descendants would carry on the dead man's family and family name through future generations. Any sons born after this to the woman and her living husband would carry on the name of the living husband for future generations. In that way, the dead man's family and family name could continue through future generations. Since the Scripture taught this custom, the Sadducees believed that they could prove from Scripture that Jesus was wrong.

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The question about the resurrection

The Sadducees Ask About the Resurrection (ESV)

Do people rise from the dead?

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 22:23–33 and Luke 20:27–40.

Paragraph 12:24–27

In this paragraph Jesus answered the Sadducees' question. There are two parts to Jesus' answer. He explained that:

1. When people live again after they have died, they will be like the angels, who do not marry. (12:25)
2. In one of the books of Moses, God indicated that the great ancestors of the Jewish people were still alive with him. This showed that he does cause people to live again after they die. (12:26–27)

Then Jesus told the Sadducees that they were wrong not to believe that dead people can live again (12:27).

12:24a

Jesus said to them, “Aren’t you mistaken,

- ¶ Jesus answered them, “Do you^(plur) not realize that you are wrong about people not living again after they die?
- ¶ Jesus answered, “You^(plur) are mistaken for two reasons:

12:24b

because you do not know the Scriptures

- It is because you^(plur) do not know what the Scriptures say,
- you^(plur) do not understand the Scriptures that tell about people living again after they die.

12:24c

or the power of God?

- and you^(plur) do not know about the power of God.
- You^(plur) also do not understand that God has the power to cause dead people to live again.
- and you do not know what God is able to do.

12:24a–c

Jesus said to them: The phrase Jesus said to them introduces Jesus' answer to the Sadducees. His response begins with a rhetorical question. Use a natural way in your language to introduce it.

Aren’t you mistaken, because you do not know...?:

This part of the sentence is the beginning of a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the fact that the Sadducees were mistaken because they did not know certain things.

See the discussion and examples in the next note. Use a natural way in your language to introduce the reason that the Sadducees were wrong.

Aren't you mistaken...?: Jesus used this rhetorical question in two ways:

1. to rebuke the Sadducees by telling them they were wrong.
2. to explain to them why they were wrong.

Here are some ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a rhetorical question or as more than one question. For example:

Is not this why you are wrong...? (RSV)

Why don't you understand? Don't you know...? (NCV)

- As a statement or as more than one statement. For example:

Surely the reason why you are wrong is that... (NJB)

You are completely wrong! You don't know... (CEV)

- As both a statement and a question. For example:

How wrong you are! And do you know why? It is because... (GNT)

mistaken: The word mistaken indicates that the Sadducees were wrong about what they believed. They wrongly believed that God does not cause dead people to live again. Another way to translate this is:

You are wrong about what you believe

because you do not know: The phrase because you do not know introduces the reasons why the Sadducees were mistaken. See the General Comment on 12:24a-c for a suggestion about giving these reasons first.

you do not know the Scriptures or the power of God: The pronoun you refers to the Sadducees. They knew something about the Scriptures and the power of God, but they did not understand them. The NASB says:

you do not understand the Scriptures or the power of God

not know the Scriptures: Here the phrase the Scriptures refers to the books of the Old Testament. The

Sadducees did not understand that these Scriptures teach that God causes dead people to live again.

not know...the power of God: The phrase the power of God refers to God's ability to do whatever he wants to do. In this context the Sadducees did not believe that God has the power to cause people to live again after they die.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

you do not know...how powerful God is.

you do not understand what God is able to do.

General Comment on 12:24a-c

In some languages it may be more natural to state a reason before a result. If that is true in your language, you may want reverse the order of the parts of this verse. You may put the reasons (24b-c) before the result (24a). For example:

^{24b}You do not know the Scriptures ^{24c}or the power of God! ^{24a}That is the reason why you are so wrong.

Mark 12:25

Section 12:18-27: Other leaders asked Jesus about people living again after they die

The Jewish leaders continued to challenge Jesus. In this section some Sadducees asked Jesus a question to try to show that the things he taught were wrong. Like the Pharisees, the Sadducees were a group of Jewish leaders with certain religious beliefs. Many of the Sadducees were priests. They did not believe that God would cause anyone who had died to live again.

Jesus believed and taught that God does cause people who have died to live again. The Sadducees tried to use this belief to trick Jesus in 12:18-27. They told a story to ridicule these beliefs that Jesus taught. The story was not true, but they used it to ask a question. They thought that if a person believed that people who died could live again, there was no sensible answer to the question.

The Sadducees based their story on the Jewish custom that is described in Deuteronomy 25:5-6. This Scripture teaches that if a woman did not have any children by her husband before he died, his brother was required to marry her. Their first child would have the name of his dead brother and would be his heir. This custom was called the levirate. Jewish people considered the first son that the widow bore after marrying the brother of her dead husband to be the son of her

dead husband, not the son of the man who was now her husband. This meant that this son and his descendants would carry on the dead man's family and family name through future generations. Any sons born after this to the woman and her living husband would carry on the name of the living husband for future generations. In that way, the dead man's family and family name could continue through future generations. Since the Scripture taught this custom, the Sadducees believed that they could prove from Scripture that Jesus was wrong.

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The Sadducees Ask About the Resurrection (ESV)

Do people rise from the dead?

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 22:23-33 and Luke 20:27-40.

Paragraph 12:24-27

In this paragraph Jesus answered the Sadducees' question. There are two parts to Jesus' answer. He explained that:

1. When people live again after they have died, they will be like the angels, who do not marry. (12:25)
2. In one of the books of Moses, God indicated that the great ancestors of the Jewish people were still alive with him. This showed that he does cause people to live again after they die. (12:26-27)

Then Jesus told the Sadducees that they were wrong not to believe that dead people can live again (12:27).

12:25a

When the dead rise,

- When people who have died live again,
- At the time when God will give life to dead people,

When the dead rise: The phrase When the dead rise refers to the time when God will cause people who have died to live again.

the dead: The phrase the dead refers to dead people in general, whether they were good or bad.

12:25b

they will neither marry nor be given in marriage.

- neither men nor women will marry.

- people will not be/get married,

they will neither marry nor be given in marriage:

Jesus' statement here indicates that people whom God causes to live again will not marry one another. No one in that future life will get married. The statement has two parts:

1. they will neither marry, which means that men will not seek wives or marry them,
2. nor be given in marriage, which means that women will not be given to men to marry.

These two parts have almost the same meaning. In some languages it may be good to state the meaning only once. For example:

they...will not marry (GNT)

they don't marry (GW)

be given in marriage: This phrase refers to a custom that was common in Jewish culture. A father arranged a marriage for his daughter. If a man had other female relatives who were dependent on him, he could also arrange marriages for them.

In cultures where this custom is well known, there may be a special way to speak about it. Consider whether you can use this way in your translation.

The phrase be given in marriage is passive. In some languages it may be necessary to make it active. For example:

no one will give his daughter to anyone to marry.

women will not marry.

12:25c

Instead, they will be like the angels in heaven.

- Instead, they will live like the angels who are in heaven.
- just as the angels who live in heaven do not marry.

Instead, they will be like the angels in heaven: A literal translation of the Greek here is: "but they are like angels in the heavens." The Greek word that the BSB translates as Instead is often translated as "but," as in the RSV. It connects this part of the verse with 12:25b. This connection implies that the angels do not marry. They are not like people on earth who do marry. The context in the parallel passage in Luke 20:35-36 seems to imply a broader meaning: the people who live again will be like the angels because neither they nor the

angels will die or marry. Express the connection in a natural way in your language. See the General Comment on 12:25b–c for examples.

angels in heaven: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as angels in heaven means “messengers from heaven” or “messengers who live in heaven.” The word angels refers here to spirit beings who serve God. The word heaven refers to the place where God lives. See heaven, Meaning 2, in the Glossary.

Sometimes God sends an angel to tell a message to human beings. He also sends angels to serve him in other ways. Some ways to translate this term are:

- Use a descriptive word or phrase. For example:

messengers from heaven/God

good/holy spirit-beings who are in heaven

- Use a local term that fits the biblical meaning.
- Use a loan word from a major language. If the meaning of the word is not well-known, you may want to indicate the meaning in some way. For example:

angelos messengers in heaven

sacred angelos spirits from God

See how you translated this word in 1:13c. See also angel, Meaning 1, in the Glossary.

If you use a descriptive phrase such as “messengers from God,” make sure that it contrasts with terms that are similar in meaning, like “prophet” or “apostle.” A “prophet” is also God’s messenger, and “apostle” literally means “one who is sent.” Each one of these words should have a unique term in your language.

General Comment on 12:25b–c

Verse 25 tells about people who live again after they die. 12:25b says that these people do not marry. 12:25c says that they are like the angels. This implies that the angels do not marry.

Here are some ways to translate this connection:

When the dead come back to life, they don’t marry. Rather, they are like the angels in heaven. (GW)

When dead people live again, they will be like the angels in heaven, who do not marry.

Mark 12:26

Section 12:18–27: Other leaders asked Jesus about people living again after they die

The Jewish leaders continued to challenge Jesus. In this section some Sadducees asked Jesus a question to try to show that the things he taught were wrong. Like the Pharisees, the Sadducees were a group of Jewish leaders with certain religious beliefs. Many of the Sadducees were priests. They did not believe that God would cause anyone who had died to live again.

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Then Jesus told the Sadducees that they were wrong not to believe that dead people can live again (12:27).

12:26a

But concerning the dead rising,

- Now concerning those who are dead rising to life,
- Now I want to speak to you^(plur) about dead people living again.

See the General Comment on 12:26a–d in 12:26d for a suggestion about how to reorder these parts of the verse.

But concerning the dead rising: The phrase But concerning the dead rising introduces the second part of what Jesus said to the Sadducees. The BSB indicates this by using the word But and a comma after the word rising. Here Jesus began to prove from the Scriptures that God causes dead people to live again.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

As for the resurrection of the dead (REB)

Now I will talk about whether dead people will live again

the dead rising: The phrase the dead rising refers to dead people living again after they die. In some languages it may be necessary to say who will cause the dead to live again. If that is true in your language, you should say “God.” For example:

God raising people who have died

God causing people who have died to live again

12:26b

have you not read about the burning bush in the Book of Moses,

- surely you^(plur) have read in the book of Moses, in the story about the burning bush,
- Don't you remember reading about this in the book that Moses wrote? In the story about what happened at the burning bush,
- Think again about what Moses wrote in his book. In the passage where God speaks from the burning bush,

have you not read about the burning bush in the Book of Moses...?: This clause is the beginning of a rhetorical question. Jesus used this clause in two ways:

1. to rebuke the Sadducees because they should have understood that God raises dead people to life. Jesus knew that the Sadducees had read this story, but their actions showed that they did not understand what it implied.
2. to remind them about what God said to Moses at the burning bush.

There are at least two ways to translate this clause:

- As a rhetorical question, as in the BSB.
- As a statement. For example:

You speak as if you have never read in the book of Moses...

Use whichever form is most natural to express this passage in your language.

about the burning bush: The phrase the burning bush refers to the story in Exodus 3:6 about the bush that was on fire but did not burn up. Here are some other ways to translate this:

in the passage about the bush (GW)

what is written about the burning bush

bush: The word bush here refers to a shrub, a plant smaller than a tree. The word refers here to only one plant. It does not refer a large area of uninhabited land.

the Book of Moses: The Book of Moses refers to the writings of Moses in the Old Testament. Jesus was referring specifically to the story in Exodus chapter 3.

12:26c

how God told him,

- that God said to him,
- God spoke to him and said,
- God says that

how God told him: The Greek words that the BSB translates as how God said to him introduce what God told Moses in the Scripture passage concerning the burning bush. The word how does not indicate the way God spoke to Moses.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

where God said... (GW)

it says that God told Moses... (NCV)

There it is written that God said to Moses... (GNT)

12:26d

‘I am the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob’?

- ‘I am God for Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob.’
- ‘I am the God who cares for your ancestors, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob.’
- he is the God whom Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob worship.

I am the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob:

In this verse God identified himself as the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. These three men had died long before Moses was born. But when God spoke to Moses, he indicated that he was still their God. This implied that he still related to them and that they still existed. In Hebrew thinking, God was the God of the whole person, both body and spirit. (Hendriksen pages 487-488). A person’s spirit belongs to God even after the person’s body has died. That implies a promise that God would some day raise that person’s body and cause it to live again.

In some languages it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

Long after Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob had died on earth, God told Moses, I am the God of your ancestors Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. (based on the TRT)

the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob: In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit in what sense God is the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. He is one who cares for them as their God, the God whom they worship and serve. God is faithful to them as his people. For example:

I am the God whom Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob worship.

I am the God who cares for Abraham, Isaac and Jacob.

I am the God who is acknowledged by Abraham, Isaac and Jacob.

Notice that the verbs in the examples above use present tense. This rightly implies that God was still caring for Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, and that they were still worshiping him. Use an appropriate form in your language to indicate this. If you have translated the books of Exodus and Acts, consider how you translated this phrase in Exodus 3:6 and Acts 3:13.

General Comment on 12:26c–d

In some languages it may be natural to translate God’s words to Moses as indirect speech. For example:

In the passage where God speaks to Moses from the burning bush, God says that he is still the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob.

General Comment on 12:26a–d

In some languages it may be helpful to change the order of some information in this verse. For example, the verse below begins with a general statement. It says that what Moses wrote showed that dead people rise again. Then the verse gives the details of how what Moses wrote showed this. For example:

^{26b}But in the book that Moses wrote, he spoke of ^{26a}dead people living again. ^{26c}In the passage about the burning bush, he quoted God. God said, ^{26d}“I am the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob.”

Mark 12:27

Section 12:18–27: Other leaders asked Jesus about people living again after they die

The Jewish leaders continued to challenge Jesus. In this section some Sadducees asked Jesus a question to try to show that the things he taught were wrong. Like the Pharisees, the Sadducees were a group of Jewish leaders with certain religious beliefs. Many of the Sadducees were priests. They did not believe that God would cause anyone who had died to live again.

Jesus believed and taught that God does cause people who have died to live again. The Sadducees tried to use this belief to trick Jesus in 12:18–27. They told a story to ridicule these beliefs that Jesus taught. The story was not true, but they used it to ask a question.

They thought that if a person believed that people who died could live again, there was no sensible answer to the question.

The Sadducees based their story on the Jewish custom that is described in Deuteronomy 25:5–6. This Scripture teaches that if a woman did not have any children by her husband before he died, his brother was required to marry her. Their first child would have the name of his dead brother and would be his heir. This custom was called the levirate. Jewish people considered the first son that the widow bore after marrying the brother of her dead husband to be the son of her dead husband, not the son of the man who was now her husband. This meant that this son and his descendants would carry on the dead man's family and family name through future generations. Any sons born after this to the woman and her living husband would carry on the name of the living husband for future generations. In that way, the dead man's family and family name could continue through future generations. Since the Scripture taught this custom, the Sadducees believed that they could prove from Scripture that Jesus was wrong.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The question about the resurrection

The Sadducees Ask About the Resurrection (ESV)

Do people rise from the dead?

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 22:23–33 and Luke 20:27–40.

Paragraph 12:24–27

In this paragraph Jesus answered the Sadducees' question. There are two parts to Jesus' answer. He explained that:

1. When people live again after they have died, they will be like the angels, who do not marry. (12:25)
2. In one of the books of Moses, God indicated that the great ancestors of the Jewish people were still alive with him. This showed that he does cause people to live again after they die. (12:26–27)

Then Jesus told the Sadducees that they were wrong not to believe that dead people can live again (12:27).

12:27a

He is not the God of the dead, but of the living.

- He is not God for dead people. He is God for people who are alive!
- He does not call himself the God who cares for dead bodies. He is a God whose people are alive!
- Since God says that these people who have died are worshiping him, then they must still be alive.

He is not the God of the dead, but of the living:

At the time that Moses wrote the book of Exodus, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob were already dead. They had all been dead for almost two thousand years. Jesus was saying here that the statement in 12:26d implies that Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob were still alive in some sense. Even though their bodies had died, they still lived and God was still their God. Therefore, Jesus implied, God was able to make their bodies live again. This implies that our spirits also continue to live even after our bodies die.

The Sadducees believed that people do not continue to exist after they die. In this verse Jesus implied that if it were true that dead people no longer existed, God would not identify himself as their God.

In some languages it may be confusing to translate the clause "He is not the God of the dead" in a literal way. It may wrongly imply that God no longer cares for people who have died. God does care for people who worshiped him and who have died. Here are possible ways to translate 12:27a to avoid this wrong meaning:

He is not the God of people who no longer exist!
He is the God of people who still exist!

He is not the God of the dead: Jesus indicated here that God is not the God of people who have died and ceased to exist. If a person no longer exists, he does not have a god. Jesus explained to the Sadducees that they were wrong when they said that a person does not exist after his body dies. You may need to put a footnote in your translation to explain this strange belief of the Sadducees and how Jesus showed that there is life after death.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

He is not the God of people who have died

He does not say to the dead, "I am your God"

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *but* shows that there is a contrast between being God

of dead people and God of living people. Use a natural way in your language to show this contrast. Another way to say this in English is:

He is not the God of the dead. Rather, he is the God of the living.

of the living: God continues to be the God of his people, even of those who have died. He continues to relate to them as their God, and he will make their bodies alive again in the future. In some languages it may be helpful or even necessary to repeat the words “he is the God” in the second clause. (See the example above).

General Comment on 12:26–27

It is important for you to avoid two possible wrong meanings in 12:26–27. One wrong meaning could be that Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob did not really die. The other wrong meaning could be that God is the God only of people who have not died physically. So your translation may need a note to explain that God is the God of his people even after their bodies have died.

12:27b

You are badly mistaken!”

- You^(plur) are very wrong!”
- You^(plur) have made a terrible mistake to not believe that God raises dead people to life!”

You are badly mistaken: Jesus was saying that the Sadducees were very wrong to claim that dead people will not become alive again.

mistaken: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mistaken is the same word that was translated as “mistaken” in 12:24a–c. If it is natural in your language, you can translate it in the same way here.

Mark 12:28

Section 12:28–34: Jesus taught people which command is the most important

A scribe asked Jesus which was the greatest commandment in the law. Jesus said that there are two great commands: love the Lord your God with all your heart, and love your neighbor as yourself.

The scribe in this section may have been honestly seeking the truth. Or he may have been trying to discredit Jesus by asking him a difficult question. Mark 12:34 may imply that the man truly wanted to know the answer. In the parallel passage in Matthew 22:34–40, a scribe asked this same question to test Jesus. Nothing in this section in Mark suggests that the

scribe was testing Jesus. It would be good to translate this section so that either interpretation is possible.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Most Important Commandment (CEV, NLT)

God’s greatest command is to love him and our neighbors

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 22:34–40. Mark 12:30–31 is also parallel to Luke 10:27.

12:28a

Now one of the scribes had come up and heard their debate.

- ¶ One of the teachers of the law was there listening to their debate/discussion.
- ¶ One of the experts in the law had come there and heard what Jesus and the Sadducees were discussing with each other.

Now one of the scribes had come up and heard: The scribe had approached or arrived at the place where Jesus was. He had heard the discussion between Jesus and the Sadducees.

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate that the scribe had arrived before the discussion took place. This may be done in several ways. For example:

One of the teachers of religious law was standing there listening to the debate. (NLT)

One of the teachers of the Law of Moses came up while Jesus and the Sadducees were arguing. (CEV)

scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes refers to men who studied, interpreted, and taught the law of Moses. These men are called scribes because their original work was to copy the laws of Moses by hand. In New Testament times, this was no longer their main task. This word is sometimes translated as “teachers of the law,” as in the NIV.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

teachers of the Law of Moses. (CEV)

teachers of religious law. (NLT)

experts on the law.

See how you translated this in 11:27c. Also see teacher of the law in the Glossary.

their: The Greek word that the BSB translates as their refers to the Sadducees and Jesus. In 12:18–27 they had been talking about whether or not God raised dead people to life.

debate: The Greek word that the BSB translates as debate refers to an “argument” or “disagreement” about something.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

argument (GW)

disagreement

12:28b

Noticing how well Jesus had answered them,

- When he realized that Jesus had answered their question well,
- When he noticed that Jesus had wisely answered their question,
- He heard Jesus reply well/wisely to the Sadducees, so

Noticing how well Jesus had answered them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Noticing is literally “seeing.” Here it means “realizing.” The scribe realized that Jesus had wisely answered the Sadducees’ question. The NLT says:

He realized that Jesus had answered well.

General Comment on 12:28a–b

In some languages it may be necessary to reorder some of the information in 12:28a–b so that the order of events is clear. In the examples below, the action of coming closer to Jesus occurs after 12:28b:

^{28a}A teacher of the law heard their arguing. ^{28b}He realized that Jesus’ answer was good/correct, ^{28a}so he approached...

^{28a}A teacher of the law was standing there listening to their discussion. ^{28b}When he observed that Jesus’ answer to them was good, ^{28a}he went closer to Jesus...

12:28c

he asked Him, “Which commandment is the most important of all?”

- the teacher of the law asked Jesus, “Which command of God is the most important one?”
- he asked him/Jesus, “Which of the commands that God gave to Moses is more important than all the others?”
- he asked Jesus to tell him the commandment that was most important.

he asked Him: This phrase expresses a result of 12:28b. Some English versions use a connector like “so” here to indicate the connection. Others do not use a connector. Use a natural way to show the connection in your language.

he...Him: The pronoun he refers to the scribe. The pronoun Him refers to Jesus.

asked: The text does not indicate here whether the scribe asked his question in order to trick Jesus. Your translation also should not indicate this.

Which commandment is the most important of all:

This question implies that Jesus should consider all the commands that God had given his people. Then Jesus should say which command was the most important. Jewish religious leaders often discussed which of God’s commands was the most important. They would say “Which is heavier (more important)?” or “Which is lighter (less important)?” (Keener, page 169). They did not imply that some commands were not important. All were important, but some were more important than others.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

Which commandment is the most important of all? (GNT)

What is the most important commandment? (CEV)

In some languages it may be helpful to include the implied information that the commandments were from God. For example:

God gave us many commandments. Which one is the most important?

Which commandment: The phrase Which commandment asks about all the commands that God gave to his people. The scribe may have meant any command in the Old Testament. However, he probably referred primarily to the Law of Moses, the first five books of

the Old Testament. The word “command” has the same meaning in English as commandment. It has the same meaning as “law.” In some languages there may not be separate words for “law” and “commandment.” In such languages, this phrase may be translated as:

Which law

commandment: The word commandment here refers to what God told the Jewish people to do and also to what he told them not to do. In some languages it may be necessary to use a more explicit expression for this idea. For example:

God told us what we should do and what we should not do.

is the most important of all: The Greek word that the BSB translates as important is literally “first.” In this context it means “first in importance” or “more important than all the rest.” In some languages it may be difficult to express this comparison. If that is true in your language, you may be able to say:

is important surpassing all the others?

Mark 12:29

Section 12:28–34: Jesus taught people which command is the most important

A scribe asked Jesus which was the greatest commandment in the law. Jesus said that there are two great commands: love the Lord your God with all your heart, and love your neighbor as yourself.

The scribe in this section may have been honestly seeking the truth. Or he may have been trying to discredit Jesus by asking him a difficult question. Mark 12:34 may imply that the man truly wanted to know the answer. In the parallel passage in Matthew 22:34–40, a scribe asked this same question to test Jesus. Nothing in this section in Mark suggests that the scribe was testing Jesus. It would be good to translate this section so that either interpretation is possible.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Most Important Commandment (CEV, NLT)

God’s greatest command is to love him and our neighbors

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 22:34–40. Mark 12:30–31 is also parallel to Luke 10:27.

12:29a–12:30

This is the most important: ‘Hear.... Love...: This clause introduces the command that follows. The most important refers to the command to love the Lord in 12:30. Introduce it in a natural way in your language.

Here is another way to translate this:

The most important is, ‘Listen...you must love... (GW)

Your translation should not imply that most important refers only to the command to Hear in 12:29b. The word Hear emphasizes the statement that follows. In some languages a command to “hear” may cause readers to misunderstand what Jesus said in this context. If that is true in your language, you may need to leave it implicit. For example, the CEV says:

The most important one says: “People of Israel, you have only one Lord and God.³⁰ You must love him....”

12:29a

Jesus replied, “This is the most important:

- Jesus answered, “The most important command that God gave in the Scriptures is this:
- Jesus said, “Here is the command/law that is more important than the others:

the most important: The phrase the most important is literally “the first,” as in the RSV. It refers to the most important command. See how you translated the phrase “the most important” in 12:28.

12:29b

‘Hear O Israel, the Lord our God, the Lord is One.

- ‘Listen, people of Israel, the Lord our^(incl) God is the only Lord.
- ‘You^(plur) people from Israel, listen: the Lord God whom we^(incl) worship is the only Lord.

In this verse Jesus quoted from Deuteronomy 6:4. This passage (Deuteronomy 6:4) was called by the Jews the “Shema,” which is based on the Hebrew word meaning “hear.” The religious Jews repeated it twice every day as the basis of their faith (UBS, page 382). If you use footnotes, you may want to cross-reference that verse.

Hear O Israel: The words Hear O Israel introduce something very important that Moses was about to tell the people of Israel about God.

Here are some other ways to introduce this:

Listen, Israel! (GNT)

Israel people, listen to me

Introduce Moses' words in a way that emphasizes that what he was about to say was very important.

the Lord our God, the Lord is One: The words the Lord our God, the Lord is one indicate that the Lord our God is unique, there is no other God like him. Jesus quoted these words from the LXX, the Greek translation of the Old Testament. In the Hebrew text of this verse, both occurrences of the word that the BSB translates here as Lord refer to the personal name of God. In English, people sometimes write that name as Yahweh or Jehovah. It also implies that he is the only God that Israel worships.

Here are some other ways to translate the Lord our God, the Lord is one:

The Lord our God is the only Lord. (GNT)

The Lord is our God, and he is the only one like himself.

God the Lord is the only God. He is the only one whom we worship.

In some languages it is not possible to use the title "Lord" by itself. If that is true in your language, you may be able to say "our Lord." For example:

The Lord God who is our Lord is the only/unique one.

See Lord, Context 2, in the Glossary.

our God: In some languages it may be necessary to make the meaning of our God more explicit. For example:

the God whom we worship

the God who cares for us

This "we" includes all the people of Israel.

God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as God refers here to the eternal spirit who created everything. He is more powerful than any other spirit, and he is perfectly good and wise. He deserves to be worshiped. Here are some ways to translate God:

- Use a name or title for God that people in your culture already use.
- Use a descriptive term that fits the truth about God that is revealed in the Bible. For example:

Creator

Great Spirit

Ruler of the universe

- Use a borrowed word from the national or trade language Bible.

Choose a term that is acceptable to the believers and churches in your area. For more detailed information, see God in the Glossary.

Mark 12:30

Section 12:28-34: Jesus taught people which command is the most important

A scribe asked Jesus which was the greatest commandment in the law. Jesus said that there are two great commands: love the Lord your God with all your heart, and love your neighbor as yourself.

The scribe in this section may have been honestly seeking the truth. Or he may have been trying to discredit Jesus by asking him a difficult question. Mark 12:34 may imply that the man truly wanted to know the answer. In the parallel passage in Matthew 22:34-40, a scribe asked this same question to test Jesus. Nothing in this section in Mark suggests that the scribe was testing Jesus. It would be good to translate this section so that either interpretation is possible.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Most Important Commandment (CEV, NLT)

God's greatest command is to love him and our neighbors

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 22:34–40. Mark 12:30–31 is also parallel to Luke 10:27.

12:30a–c

In this verse Jesus was quoting from Deuteronomy 6:5, but he added the phrase “with all your mind” (see 12:30c). Both in Deuteronomy and here, the text indicates that a person should love God by devoting himself completely to God. For ways to translate this verse, see the General Comment on 12:30a–c at the end of 12:30c.

12:30a

Love the Lord your God

- Love the Lord your^(sing) God with your whole self. That is,
- You^(plur) must each love completely the Lord who is your God.

Love the Lord your God: In Greek and Hebrew the form of this statement can be translated as either a command or a future event. In this context it is a command. For example:

you must love the Lord your God (NJB)

It is written in a singular form. This command is spoken to a group of people, and it applies to each person in the group. Use a natural way in your language to express such a command. In some languages you may need to use a plural form. See 12:30a in the Display.

Love: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as Love refers to loving God. It means “to be devoted to him, to cherish him.” A person who loves God will value and reverence him with gratitude and affection. He will want to please God because he loves God. He will want to think about the things that God is interested in.

the Lord your God: The phrase the Lord your God refers to the same Lord as the phrase “the Lord our God” in 12:29.

See the notes in 12:29b for translation suggestions. See Lord, Context 2, in the Glossary.

12:30b–c

with all your heart...soul...mind...strength: The four Greek terms that the BSB translates as heart, soul, mind, and strength function together here to refer to a person’s entire being. Each of these terms is also preceded by the word all. This emphasizes that everyone should completely devote himself to loving the Lord. A person should use all his will, emotions, ability, and intelligence to love the Lord in every way that is possible.

In some languages it may be helpful to make this clear by supplying a summary phrase. For example:

with all your being: heart, soul, mind, and strength

In Greek these terms have many similarities. For example, the words translated as “heart” and “soul” both refer to a person’s inner being or inner life. The words translated as “heart” and “mind” are also very similar. Both are the source of a person’s thoughts and decisions. The Hebrew word for “heart” denotes primarily the mental faculties (mind and will) but also includes the emotions. So the primary meaning of the Hebrew word (mind and will) is synonymous with the word “mind” used here (Hooker 1991 page 287, Hendricksen pages 492–493). The Greek word for “heart” denotes the center of a person’s inner life. It includes his thinking, feeling and decision-making.

It is important to understand that these terms are not intended to describe distinct parts of a human being. They function together to describe all of a person’s personality and abilities. In some languages, there may be more or less than four terms to describe this. Use natural terms in your language.

12:30b

with all your heart and with all your soul

- love him with all your^(sing) determination/will and feelings,
- You^(plur) must use all your being and all your emotions to love him.

heart: The Greek word that the BSB translates as heart refers to the part of a person that has feelings and makes decisions. This includes a person’s intentions, purposes, thoughts and attitudes. See how you translated this word in 7:19a.

soul: The Greek word that the BSB translates as soul refers to a person’s inner self or life. It includes his personality, his thinking and his feeling. The same Greek word occurs in 8:36a–b, but it may have a different focus in that context.

12:30c

and with all your mind and with all your strength.’

- with all your^(sing) understanding, and with all your strength.’
- You^(plur) must use all your thinking and all your power to love him.’

mind: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mind refers to a person’s intellect or understanding, his ability to think and reason.

strength: The Greek word that the BSB translates as strength refers to a person's ability to do something. It may also include his physical strength or power.

General Comment on 12:30a–c

In some languages it may not be possible to speak of loving God with various things. Here are some other ways to express this meaning:

You must concentrate all your thoughts/mind, intelligence and strength in loving God who is your Lord.

You must love the Lord your God in all of your life. In everything you think or feel or do, you must show that you love him very much.

Mark 12:31

Section 12:28–34: Jesus taught people which command is the most important

A scribe asked Jesus which was the greatest commandment in the law. Jesus said that there are two great commands: love the Lord your God with all your heart, and love your neighbor as yourself.

The scribe in this section may have been honestly seeking the truth. Or he may have been trying to discredit Jesus by asking him a difficult question. Mark 12:34 may imply that the man truly wanted to know the answer. In the parallel passage in Matthew 22:34–40, a scribe asked this same question to test Jesus. Nothing in this section in Mark suggests that the scribe was testing Jesus. It would be good to translate this section so that either interpretation is possible.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Most Important Commandment (CEV, NLT)

God's greatest command is to love him and our neighbors

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 22:34–40. Mark 12:30–31 is also parallel to Luke 10:27.

12:31a

The second is this:

- And this is the second most important of God's commands/laws:

- The next command/law that is more important than others is this:

The second is this: Here Jesus introduced the second most important of God's commands. Here are some other ways to introduce this in English:

The second most important commandment is this: (GW)

Here is God's command that is the next in importance:

Introduce it in a natural way in your language.

12:31b

'Love your neighbor as yourself.'

- 'Love^(sing) your fellow man as you love yourself.'
- 'You^(plur) must love other people in the same way that you love yourselves.'

In this part of the verse Jesus was quoting from Leviticus 19:18. If you use footnotes, you may want to cross-reference this verse.

Love your neighbor as yourself: In both Hebrew and Greek, this command is in a singular form, like the command in 12:30. This indicates that it is a command to each person, but it applies to all people. Jesus made a general statement about how people should treat each other.

Languages have different ways to express commands like this. In some languages it may be more natural to use words like "we" and "our" or "they" and "their." For example:

We^(incl) must love our fellow men in the same way that we love ourselves.

People must love their neighbors in the same way that they love themselves.

Love: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as Love is the same word that was used in 12:30a. In this context it refers to the concern and affection that people should have toward other people. They should treat them kindly and seek to help them.

Consider the most appropriate term to describe this type of love. Some languages may have an idiom for it. It is possible that you may need to use different expressions to refer to love for people and love for God.

your neighbor: The word neighbor is singular, but it refers to any and all neighbors. In some languages it may be more natural to use a plural form to express this. The word neighbor means “someone who lives nearby.” It was also used to refer to people who were of the same social group or who spoke the same language. To the Jews the phrase “Love your neighbor” meant to love your fellow Jew.

In his teaching Jesus expanded the meaning of neighbor. To Jesus, the phrase “Love your neighbor” meant to love anyone you meet. (See Luke 10:27–37.) In some languages you may want to include a footnote about this.

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase your neighbor:

others (CEV)

your fellow people

12:31c

No other commandment is greater than these.”

- There is no other command of God that is more important than these two commands.”
- God has given no greater command than these two commands.”
- These are the greatest commandments of all.”

No other commandment is greater than these: This clause indicates that no other command of God is greater than the two commands that were mentioned in 12:30 and 12:31. In this context the word greater means “more important.” In Matthew 22:40 Jesus said that all the Jewish Scriptures are based on these two commands.

Here is another way to translate this sentence:

Those two commands are more important than any others. (TRT)

Mark 12:32

Section 12:28–34: Jesus taught people which command is the most important

A scribe asked Jesus which was the greatest commandment in the law. Jesus said that there are two great commands: love the Lord your God with all your heart, and love your neighbor as yourself.

The scribe in this section may have been honestly seeking the truth. Or he may have been trying to discredit Jesus by asking him a difficult question. Mark

12:34 may imply that the man truly wanted to know the answer. In the parallel passage in Matthew 22:34–40, a scribe asked this same question to test Jesus. Nothing in this section in Mark suggests that the scribe was testing Jesus. It would be good to translate this section so that either interpretation is possible.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Most Important Commandment (CEV, NLT)

God’s greatest command is to love him and our neighbors

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 22:34–40. Mark 12:30–31 is also parallel to Luke 10:27.

12:32a

“Right, Teacher,” the scribe replied.

- ¶ The man said, “Teacher, you have spoken wisely.
- ¶ The teacher of the law said to Jesus, “Teacher, you have answered my question well.

“Right, Teacher,” the scribe replied: The scribe recognized that Jesus had answered his question well.

Right: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Right is literally, “Good!” The word means “fine, good, excellent.” It expresses agreement and satisfaction with Jesus’ answer. Use a natural expression in your language.

Teacher: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Teacher was a polite title for a Jewish religious leader. It was a title of respect for a Jewish man who had authority to teach the things about God. In some languages the appropriate way to address a religious teacher may be:

Sir Teacher

Sir

Master

Be careful not to use a term that can refer only to a school teacher.

the scribe replied: In Greek the words that the BSB translates as the scribe replied occur at the beginning of this verse. They introduce the man’s response to

Jesus. Put the information in a natural place in your language.

the scribe: The phrase the scribe refers to the scribe who was first mentioned in 12:28. Refer back to him here in a natural way in your language.

12:32b

“You have stated correctly that God is One

- You are correct to say that there is only one God,
- You speak the truth when you say that the Lord is the only God,

12:32c

and there is no other but Him,

- and that there is no other god except him.
- and that no other god exists.

12:32b–c

You have stated correctly that God is One: The scribe indicated here that Jesus was correct when he said that there is only one God. The teacher recognized that this statement agreed with what is written in God’s law.

God is One and there is no other but Him: In Greek this statement is literally, “there is one and there is not another except him.” Here the scribe referred back to the verse that Jesus quoted in 12:29b. He expressed the statement in two parts that are connected with “and” in English. The GNT has:

only the Lord is God

and...there is no other god but he.

The two parts of this statement have the same meaning. The more literal versions (that read in 12:32b “he is one” or “God is one”) stay close to the structure of the Greek and could be interpreted either as “God is one God, not many” or as “God is the only God.” But the contemporary versions that translate in such a way as to make the meaning clearer all support the meaning here of “God is the only God.” The meaning is repeated to emphasize that God is the only one like himself. There is no one else who is worthy to be worshiped as God.

there is no other but Him: The scribe may have been quoting Deuteronomy 4:35 in this part of the verse.

Mark 12:33

Section 12:28–34: Jesus taught people which command is the most important

A scribe asked Jesus which was the greatest commandment in the law. Jesus said that there are two great commands: love the Lord your God with all your heart, and love your neighbor as yourself.

The scribe in this section may have been honestly seeking the truth. Or he may have been trying to discredit Jesus by asking him a difficult question. Mark 12:34 may imply that the man truly wanted to know the answer. In the parallel passage in Matthew 22:34–40, a scribe asked this same question to test Jesus. Nothing in this section in Mark suggests that the scribe was testing Jesus. It would be good to translate this section so that either interpretation is possible.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Most Important Commandment (CEV, NLT)

God’s greatest command is to love him and our neighbors

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 22:34–40. Mark 12:30–31 is also parallel to Luke 10:27.

12:33

In this verse the scribe repeated the meaning of what Jesus said. Notice that the scribe repeated what Jesus said in a slightly different way. Both Jesus and the teacher were expressing the meaning of Deuteronomy 6:5. Here are the lists that were used in Deuteronomy and by Jesus and the teacher: Deuteronomy: heart, soul, strength Teacher: heart, mind, strength Jesus: heart, soul, mind, strength He emphasized that it was very important. In Greek he did this in one long sentence. In some languages it may be more natural to use a different way to express the meaning. For example:

And you must love God with all your heart and with all your mind and with all your strength. You must love your neighbor as you love yourself. It is more important to do this than to offer all burnt offerings and other sacrifices to God.

See the General Comment on 12:33a–d at the end of 12:33d for another suggestion.

12:33a**and to love Him with all your heart and with all your understanding**

- God wants people to love him with all their determination/will and with all their understanding.
- God wants us^(incl) to love him with all our being and with all our intelligence.

to love Him with all your heart: In Greek this phrase is literally “to love him from the whole of the heart.” It is almost the same expression that was used in 12:30a–b. You could translate in a similar way here.

with all your understanding: In Greek this is literally “from the whole of the intelligence.” The Greek word that the BSB translates as understanding means “the ability to understand something.” It is a different word than the one Jesus used in 12:30c that the BSB translated as “mind.” However, these two words have almost the same meaning in this context.

12:33b**and with all your strength,**

- He wants people to love him with all their ability,
- God wants us^(incl) to love him with all our power/strength,

and with all your strength: The Greek word that the BSB translates as strength is the same Greek word that is used in 12:30c. It refers to a person’s ability to do something. It may also include his physical strength or power.

12:33c**and to love your neighbor as yourself,**

- and to love other people as they love themselves.
- and to love our^(incl) fellow men in the same way that we love ourselves.

and to love your neighbor as yourself: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as love your neighbor as yourself refers to loving another person in the same way that you love yourself. This has the same meaning as the same expression in 12:31b.

12:33d**which is more important than all burnt offerings and sacrifices.”**

- Obeying these two commands is more important than to offer to God all the burnt offerings and sacrifices that our^(incl) law requires.”
- It is more important that we^(incl) obey these two commands than to give to God all the burnt offerings and sacrifices that we offer.”

This part of the verse implies that the scribe agreed with Jesus’ statement in 12:31c.

which is more important than: Here the scribe indicated that he was comparing two important commands in the law:

1. It is important for a person to love God and his neighbor very much, and
2. It is important for a person to offer burnt offerings and sacrifices.

Of these two commands, it is more important for a person to love God and his neighbor. In some languages it may be difficult to express this comparison with a phrase like “more...than.” Use a natural way in your language. See the General Comment on 12:33a–d for a suggestion.

all burnt offerings and sacrifices: In the Old Testament God commanded the Jews to burn whole animals as offerings and to also offer other sacrifices to him. The phrase all burnt offerings and sacrifices contains implied information. The word all implies “all that the law requires” or “all that we have been offering.”

burnt offerings: The Greek word that the BSB translates as burnt offerings is literally “whole burnt offerings.” This refers to animals that the priests sacrificed to God and completely burned up on the altar.

Here are some other ways to translate burnt offerings:

sacrificing animals to God by burning them

to burn animals as a sacrifice to God

and sacrifices: The word that the BSB translates as sacrifices is a general term that refers to different kinds of offerings. Here it includes other kinds of animal sacrifices (besides the burnt offerings). It also includes other things that people offered to God, such as wheat, oil and wine.

If you need a more general way to translate the word sacrifices, you could say something like:

other things that people give/offer to God

Here is one way to translate this whole phrase:

to offer on the altar animals and other sacrifices to God (GNT)

The focus here is not on specific kinds of offerings. If it awkward to describe a “whole burnt offering” in your language, consider using a more general term. For example:

all the animals and sacrifices we offer to God
(NCV)

all the sacrifices and offerings that we could possibly make (CEV)

You may also want to add a footnote containing some of the preceding information about offerings and sacrifices.

General Comment on 12:33a–d

In some languages it may be helpful to change the order of some of the verse parts. It may also be helpful to include implied information. For example:

It is important to offer God all burnt offerings and sacrifices that he has commanded. But it is more important that we love him with all our heart, all our understanding, and all our strength. It is also more important to love our neighbor as ourselves.

Translate this verse in a way that is clear and natural in your language.

Mark 12:34

Section 12:28–34: Jesus taught people which command is the most important

A scribe asked Jesus which was the greatest commandment in the law. Jesus said that there are two great commands: love the Lord your God with all your heart, and love your neighbor as yourself.

The scribe in this section may have been honestly seeking the truth. Or he may have been trying to discredit Jesus by asking him a difficult question. Mark 12:34 may imply that the man truly wanted to know the answer. In the parallel passage in Matthew 22:34–40, a scribe asked this same question to test Jesus. Nothing in this section in Mark suggests that the scribe was testing Jesus. It would be good to translate this section so that either interpretation is possible.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Most Important Commandment (CEV, NLT)

God's greatest command is to love him and our neighbors

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 22:34–40. Mark 12:30–31 is also parallel to Luke 10:27.

12:34a

When Jesus saw that the man had answered wisely, He said,

- When Jesus heard him speak so wisely, he said to him,
- Jesus noticed that the man had shown real wisdom in his answer, so he told him,

When Jesus saw that the man had answered wisely: Jesus realized that the scribe had spoken wisely.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

When Jesus heard how wisely the man answered (GW)

Realizing how much the man understood... (NLT)

Jesus noticed how wise his answer was (GNT)

The man's answer showed that he was wise, so Jesus said to him

12:34b

“You are not far from the kingdom of God.”

- “You are close to entering the kingdom of God.”
- “You are almost ready to be one of the people whom God rules.”

You are not far from the kingdom of God: Here Jesus praised the man for the attitude and belief that he expressed in 12:32–33. The phrase not far from the kingdom of God indicates the man was almost ready to submit to God's rule and become one of the people whom God cares for as king. It does not refer to the location of the man or of the kingdom.

Here are some other ways to translate You are not far from the kingdom of God:

You are almost ready to know/acknowledge God as your king

You are almost prepared to submit to God's rule/ chieftaincy

You are nearly ready to become one of the people whom God rules.

See the note on 9:47b for discussion of a similar context.

kingdom of God: The phrase kingdom of God refers to God's activity of ruling and caring for his people as their king. It does not refer to a land or country that he rules over. It refers to the relationship that he has with his people. He leads, protects, and cares for them. They obey, trust, and submit to him as their king.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- As a noun. For example:

God's rule/reign

God's kingship

God's chieftaincy

God's government

- As a verbal expression:

God ruling his people

God caring for his people as king

See also kingdom of God, Context 1, in the Glossary.

12:34c

And no one dared to question Him any further.

- And after that, no one was bold enough to question Jesus further.
- From that time on, no one had the courage to ask Jesus any more tricky/difficult questions.

no one dared to question Him: People were afraid to test Jesus with any more hard or tricky questions. They realized that he was very skillful at answering questions wisely. In the remainder of the book of Mark, Jesus' disciples did ask him more questions, and some of them were rhetorical. But from this point on there is no record in Mark that anyone asked Jesus any more questions to try to trick him. When Jesus said "you are not far from the kingdom," that seems to indicate that the man's agreement in 12:32–33 with Jesus' answer showed that the man was asking a sincere question in 12:28. Or perhaps it meant that the man could state what a Jewish person should do but did not personally do that himself. On the other hand, no one dared ask Jesus any more questions. Why? Perhaps this indicates that the man's question was not sincere after all, but tricky.

dared: The word dared indicates that no one felt bold enough to ask Jesus any more difficult questions. They felt unable to trick him because he had answered every question so wisely.

any further: The phrase any further refers to the time period that began when Jesus said the words in 12:34a–b and continued into the future.

Mark 12:35

Section 12:35–37: The Christ is greater than King David

In this section Jesus was still teaching in the courtyard of the temple. Many people listened to him there. When he taught, he asked them about the Christ (Messiah) and his relationship to King David. Jesus asked this because he wanted the people to think about two things that the Scriptures say about the Messiah:

1. The Scriptures prophesied that the Messiah (Christ) would be a descendant of King David.
2. In the Scriptures King David called the Messiah "Lord." This showed that the Messiah would be much greater than King David.

To Jewish people, it was difficult to explain how these two things could agree. They thought that an ancestor must be greater than his descendant. Jesus wanted them to know that the Messiah would be much greater than the earthly ruler that they expected him to be. He would be greater than David. The Messiah would be a descendant of David and would be a great ruler, but he would also share the throne of God. This section introduction includes a summary of statements by N. Geldenhuys, *The Gospel of Luke*, 1951; and Ray Summers, *Commentary on Luke*, 1972; and G. B Caird, *Saint Luke*, 1963.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Question about the Messiah (GNT)

Whose Son Is the Christ? (ESV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 22:41–46 and Luke 20:41–44.

12:35a

While Jesus was teaching in the temple courts,

- ¶ When Jesus was teaching in the courtyard of the house of sacrifice/God,

- ¶ While Jesus was teaching God's word to people in the area around the temple building,

While: This verse is the beginning of a new section. The events of this section probably happened soon after the events of the preceding section. In 11:27 Mark mentioned that Jesus was in the temple courts. In this section he was still teaching people there. Introduce the section in a natural way in your language.

Jesus was teaching: In 12:37 Mark indicated that a large crowd was listening to Jesus. Jesus was teaching them about God. In some languages it may be necessary to say whom Jesus was teaching and what he was teaching them. For example:

Jesus was teaching God's word to people

temple courts: The Greek word that the BSB translates as temple courts is literally "temple," as in most English versions. The temple consisted of the temple building itself and the walls and courtyards that surrounded it. Here "temple" refers specifically to the courtyard. People did not meet inside the temple building because only the priests could enter it.

Some English versions have made this clear by translating "temple" as temple courts (BSB, NIV, NET) or "temple courtyard" (GW). You may want to do this also if your word for "temple" would imply that Jesus and the crowd were inside the temple building.

Here are some other ways to translate the term temple courts:

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

courtyard of the house of God

courtyard of the house of sacrifice

holy/sacred house courtyard

- If your language has a word for "temple," you could use it here. But you may need to modify it by saying something like:

courtyard of the temple of the Jews/Lord

big/great temple courtyard

See how you translated this word in 11:16. See temple, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information about the temple and how to translate it.

12:35b–c

How can the scribes say that the Christ is the Son of David?: Jesus asked this question in order to encourage the people who were listening to him to think carefully about who the Messiah was. It was not difficult for any Jew to understand that the Messiah was (or was to be) a descendant of King David. What was difficult was to be able to understand how David could refer to his own descendant as his Lord. He wanted them to realize that the Messiah was even greater than they thought.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

What do you understand the experts in the law to mean when they teach that the Christ is David's son?

The teachers of the law say that the Messiah is David's son. What do they mean when they say that?

Jesus wanted people to think about how this related to another Scripture that he quoted in 12:36b–d. Translate the question so that it will connect well with that verse also. For example:

The reason I ask this question is because David himself...

12:35b

He asked, "How can the scribes say

- he asked them, "Can you explain what the teachers of the Law of Moses mean by saying
- he said to the people, "What do the experts in the law mean when they say,

He asked: Jesus asked the people who were listening to him. In some languages it may be necessary to make that explicit. See the 12:35b in the Display.

the scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes refers to men who studied, interpreted, and taught the law of Moses. These men are called scribes because their original work was to copy the laws of Moses by hand. In New Testament times, this was no longer their main task. This word is sometimes translated as "teachers of the law," as in the NIV.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

teachers of the Law of Moses (CEV)

teachers of religious law (NLT)

experts on the law

See teacher of the law in the Glossary.

say: In this context the verb say refers to something that the scribes taught people about the Christ. They said it often in their teaching.

12:35c

that the Christ is the Son of David?

- that the Christ is a descendant of King David?
- ‘The Messiah will be the descendant of King David’?

the Christ: The Jews used the title Christ to refer to the special person whom God had appointed and promised to send as king and savior. The title Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word “Messiah,” and the two words have the same meaning.

Here are some other ways to translate Christ:

- Transliterate it according to the sounds of your language. For example:

Krais

Karisiti

- Transliterate it and indicate in some way that it is a title. For example:

the Christ

the Kirisita

- Transliterate Christ and include a phrase that explains the meaning. For example:

Christ, the appointed one

Cristo, the savior God promised

the Christ who comes from God

If you do not indicate the meaning of Christ in the text, you may want to include a footnote. For example:

The word/title “Christ” refers to the King and Savior whom God had promised to send.

See how you translated the word Christ in 1:1. See also Christ in the Glossary.

Son of David: The phrase Son of David is another title for the Messiah. It refers to the Messiah as a descendant of King David. The word Son here means “descendant.” It does not mean that the Messiah would be David’s own son. David had been the king of Israel a thousand years before Jesus lived on earth. The GNT makes this clear by translating the phrase as:

the descendant of David

Mark 12:36

Section 12:35–37: The Christ is greater than King David

In this section Jesus was still teaching in the courtyard of the temple. Many people listened to him there. When he taught, he asked them about the Christ (Messiah) and his relationship to King David. Jesus asked this because he wanted the people to think about two things that the Scriptures say about the Messiah:

1. The Scriptures prophesied that the Messiah (Christ) would be a descendant of King David.
2. In the Scriptures King David called the Messiah “Lord.” This showed that the Messiah would be much greater than King David.

To Jewish people, it was difficult to explain how these two things could agree. They thought that an ancestor must be greater than his descendant. Jesus wanted them to know that the Messiah would be much greater than the earthly ruler that they expected him to be. He would be greater than David. The Messiah would be a descendant of David and would be a great ruler, but he would also share the throne of God. This section introduction includes a summary of statements by N. Geldenhuys, *The Gospel of Luke*, 1951; and Ray Summers, *Commentary on Luke*, 1972; and G. B Caird, *Saint Luke*, 1963.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Question about the Messiah (GNT)

Whose Son Is the Christ? (ESV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 22:41–46 and Luke 20:41–44.

12:36a**Speaking by the Holy Spirit, David himself declared:**

- David himself, as he spoke with the power of the Holy Spirit, said,
- Even David, when the Holy Spirit of God caused him to speak, said,

Speaking by the Holy Spirit, David himself declared:

This part of the verse introduces what King David said. The Spirit of God enabled King David to say this. David then wrote it in Psalm 110. Jesus was quoting here from Psalm 110:1.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

The Holy Spirit inspired David to say (GNT)

It was David himself who said, when inspired by the Holy Spirit (REB)

David, guided by the Holy Spirit, said (GW)

Speaking by the Holy Spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Speaking by the Holy Spirit is literally “by/in the Holy Spirit.” The BSB has supplied the word Speaking. The phrase by the Holy Spirit indicates that the Holy Spirit helped and guided David when he spoke.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

inspired by the Holy Spirit (RSV)

The Holy Spirit inspired David to say (GNT)

Holy Spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Holy Spirit refers to the Spirit of God. The Holy Spirit is God, together with God the Father and God the Son. The Holy Spirit is Spirit in the sense that he is a living being who does not have a physical body. He is Holy in the sense that he is God and unique from every other being. He is perfect in every way and is completely pure and sinless.

Here are some other ways to translate Holy Spirit:

Spirit/Breath of/from God

Holy/Sacred Spirit

Do not imply that the Holy Spirit is like the ghost of a dead person or that God has died.

See how you translated this term in 1:8b.

David himself: Here the word himself emphasizes David. David himself spoke about the Messiah and called him “lord.” Express that emphasis in a natural way in your language. In some languages this emphasis may be implied by the context. Some English versions leave it implicit.

12:36b**‘The Lord said to my Lord,**

- ‘The Lord God said to my Lord,
- ‘The Lord God told my Lord the Messiah

The Lord said to my Lord: This clause indicates that God spoke to the Messiah. In some languages it may be necessary to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

The Lord said to my Master

the Lord God said to my lord

The Lord: The phrase The Lord refers to God. It is a translation of God’s personal name in Hebrew. Here are some other ways to translate Lord:

Master/Chief

Ruler

In some languages people may not naturally use a word that means “master” to refer to God. If speakers of your language do not understand that your word for “Lord” refers to God in this context, here are other ways to translate it:

- Use your word for God.
- Use your word for God and indicates that he is the Lord. For example:

God the Lord

Master God

If you include the word for God in your translation of Lord, you may want to include a footnote to give the literal Greek meaning. For example:

Here the Greek text is literally “Lord.”

See Lord, Context 2, in the Glossary.

my Lord: The phrase that the BSB translates as my Lord means “my lord” or “my master.” Here are some other ways to translate my lord:

my chief

my ruler

See Lord, Context 3, in the Glossary.

12:36c

“Sit at My right hand

- “Sit down at my right side and join me in ruling,
- to sit in the position of honor and authority next to him,

Sit at My right hand: In Jewish culture, if a king asked someone to sit beside him on the right, it symbolized both honor and authority. It meant that the king wanted people to honor this person in a special way. It also meant that this person had authority to rule along with the king.

In this context, God was telling the Messiah to take this position of honor and to rule along with him (God). The meaning “authority to co-rule” is mentioned by several commentators. Edwards (page 376) explains that in the context of the Psalm, the king of Israel was crowned as God’s vice-regent. His power at God’s right hand symbolized his authority to rule. In some languages, it may be necessary to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

Sit here in the place of honor at my right side

Sit down here at the right to join me in ruling

If you do not make this implied information explicit in the text itself, you may want to add a footnote that explains the meaning.

12:36d

until I put Your enemies under Your feet.”

- and I will completely defeat/overcome your enemies.”
- while he caused all who hated the Messiah to submit completely to him.’

until: The Greek word that the BSB translates as until here means “during the time that” or “while.” The word until does not imply here that the Messiah would stop sitting at God’s right side after God had defeated his enemies.

I put Your enemies under Your feet: God spoke in a figurative way here. This clause describes a king who sits on his throne and rests his feet on the back or neck of an enemy king. Some Greek manuscripts have “under your feet” here, and other Greek manuscripts have “your footstool” here. But both phrases have basically the same meaning. This action indicates that he has conquered the enemy king and completely controls him and his people. God was promising to do this to the enemies of the Messiah.

If the phrase under Your feet is not understood in your language, here are some other ways to translate this:

while I put your enemies completely under your control

while I humble your enemies and make them like a stool for your feet

Mark 12:37

Section 12:35–37: The Christ is greater than King David

In this section Jesus was still teaching in the courtyard of the temple. Many people listened to him there. When he taught, he asked them about the Christ (Messiah) and his relationship to King David. Jesus asked this because he wanted the people to think about two things that the Scriptures say about the Messiah:

1. The Scriptures prophesied that the Messiah (Christ) would be a descendant of King David.
2. In the Scriptures King David called the Messiah “Lord.” This showed that the Messiah would be much greater than King David.

To Jewish people, it was difficult to explain how these two things could agree. They thought that an ancestor must be greater than his descendant. Jesus wanted them to know that the Messiah would be much greater than the earthly ruler that they expected him to be. He would be greater than David. The Messiah would be a descendant of David and would be a great ruler, but he would also share the throne of God. This section introduction includes a summary of statements by N. Geldenhuys, *The Gospel of Luke*, 1951; and Ray Summers, *Commentary on Luke*, 1972; and G. B Caird, *Saint Luke*, 1963.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Question about the Messiah (GNT)

Whose Son Is the Christ? (ESV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 22:41–46 and Luke 20:41–44.

12:37a

David himself calls Him ‘Lord.’

- King David himself called him ‘Lord,’
- Since in that passage even King David referred to the Messiah as Lord,

David himself calls Him ‘Lord’: David was a great king. Yet he referred to the Messiah as his Lord. So Jesus implied that the Messiah must be even greater than King David. In some languages it may be helpful to make it explicit that David was a king, a very important man:

King David himself called him ‘Lord.’

See Lord, Context 2, in the Glossary.

David himself: See the note on “David himself” in 12:36a for translation suggestions.

12:37b

So how can He be David’s son?”

- so how can the Messiah be David’s descendant?”
- how can he also be David’s descendant?”
- can he be merely David’s descendant?”

So how can He be David’s son?: Here Jesus asked the people a question that was similar to the one that he asked in 12:35c. Even though Jesus knew the answer to his own question, he wanted his listeners to think about who the Messiah was.

The answer to this question is that the Messiah was both a descendant of David and David’s Lord. This suggests that the Messiah must be God as well as man. Jesus did not imply here that the Messiah was not David’s descendant. You may need to include a footnote here to show what Jesus was implying.

12:37c

And the large crowd listened to Him with delight.

- The large number of people who were there were delighted as they listened to him.
- The many people who heard Jesus enjoyed listening to him teach.

the large crowd: There were very many people listening to Jesus at that time.

listened to Him with delight: The Greek word that the BSB translates as with delight is literally “gladly” or “happily.” It means that the people felt pleasure or delight when they listened to Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

The large crowd enjoyed listening to Jesus teach.
(CEV)

A large crowd was listening to Jesus gladly. (GNT)

General Comment on 12:35–37

Notice that in these verses the BSB uses a quote which comes within another quote which itself comes in Jesus’ speech that Mark quoted. In 12:35b Mark began to quote the words of Jesus. In 12:36b Jesus began to quote what the psalm writer said. Then the psalm writer told what God himself had said (12:36c–d).

In some languages it may be confusing to use three sets of quote marks. If this is a problem in your language, you may be able to change some of the direct quotes to indirect quotes. See the second meaning line for each verse part in the Display for 12:35a–37c. Another solution may be to indent the Old Testament quotation and to use a colon instead of quotation marks. For example:

Because David himself said what the Holy Spirit caused him to speak, and this is what he said.

The Lord God said to my Lord: Sit here in the place of honor at my right side...

Mark 12:38

Section 12:38–40: Jesus warned the people about the teachers of the law

In this section Jesus continued to teach people in the temple courtyard. He warned the people about the teachers of the law (or “scribes”). He told them that the scribes were very proud. They wanted people to notice them and to admire and praise them. Jesus warned the people not to follow the bad example of these scribes or act the way they acted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus denounces the teachers of the law

Beware of the Scribes (ESV)

There are parallel passages for Mark 12:38–40 in Matthew 23:1–8 and Luke 20:45–47.

12:38a

In His teaching Jesus also said,

- ¶ While Jesus was teaching the people, he said,
- ¶ Jesus continued to teach the people. He said,

In His teaching Jesus also said: Jesus had been teaching the people. While he was teaching, he said what is in 12:38–40.

12:38b

“Watch out for the scribes.

- “Be careful of the teachers of the law.
- “Beware that you do not think/act like the experts in the law.

Watch out for the scribes: Here Jesus warned the people to be careful not to follow the example of the scribes.

Here are some other ways to translate this warning:

Be careful not to act like the scribes.

Do not follow the example of the scribes.

Do not let the scribes deceive you.

Watch out: In this context the words Watch out imply that the scribes did or said things that could harm the people. If the people followed their example, they would not please God.

the scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes refers to men who studied, interpreted, and taught the law of Moses. These men are called scribes because their original work was to copy the laws of Moses by hand. In New Testament times, this was no longer their main task. This word is sometimes translated as “teachers of the law,” as in the NIV.

See how you translated scribes in 12:35b.

See also teacher of the law in the Glossary.

12:38c

They like to walk around in long robes,

- They enjoy walking around in long, fancy robes in public places,
- They like people to see them wearing expensive clothes,

They like to walk around in long robes: In Greek, this part of the verse does not begin a new sentence. It is literally “the ones desiring to walk about.” This has led to two interpretations: (1) This is a nonrestrictive clause. It describes the scribes as a group. This interpretation is followed by most versions and commentaries and in the notes. (2) This is a restrictive clause. Jesus was warning people about a particular group of the scribes, specifically, those who liked to walk around in flowing robes, etc. This interpretation is followed by the NASB, NJB and JBP. It is also supported by UBS (page 390) and others. The Greek word that the BSB translates as long robes refers to fancy, expensive clothes. The scribes liked to wear these clothes to show how important they were. The text implies that they like to walk around so that many people could see them. If you must say where the scribes walked, you could supply “in public places” or “where people can see them.”

12:38d

to receive greetings in the marketplaces,

- and they love for people in the markets to speak to them respectfully.
- and they like people to greet them with honor in the marketplaces.

to receive greetings: The scribes wanted people to greet them with respect and honor. In some languages it may be more natural to express the verb to receive greetings as a direct quote. For example:

for people to speak to them, saying, “Good morning, sir.”

If you use a direct quote here, use a respectful greeting that is common in your language.

in the marketplaces: The Greek word that the BSB translates as marketplaces refers to large, open areas where many people came to buy and sell things. See how you translated this word in 7:4a.

Mark 12:39

Section 12:38–40: Jesus warned the people about the teachers of the law

In this section Jesus continued to teach people in the temple courtyard. He warned the people about the teachers of the law (or “scribes”). He told them that the scribes were very proud. They wanted people to notice them and to admire and praise them. Jesus warned the people not to follow the bad example of these scribes or act the way they acted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus denounces the teachers of the law

Beware of the Scribes (ESV)

There are parallel passages for Mark 12:38–40 in Matthew 23:1–8 and Luke 20:45–47.

12:39a

and to have the chief seats in the synagogues

- They like to sit in the places of honor in the synagogue buildings,
- They like to sit where the most important men sit in the Jewish meeting places

and to have the chief seats in the synagogues:

When the people gathered to worship in the synagogues, the scribes loved to sit in the places where the most important men sat. They were happy when others treated them as important people.

the chief seats: There was a bench in front of the Jewish synagogue that was in the shape of a half circle. It was large enough for several men to sit on it. When men sat on this bench, they faced the rest of the people in the room. The people could easily see them. People considered the men who sat on that bench to be important.

synagogues: A synagogue was a building where Jews gathered to pray, read scripture, teach their beliefs, and worship. The Jews also gathered there for cultural activities. There was only one temple (in Jerusalem), but each Jewish community had a synagogue.

Here are some other ways to translate synagogue:

prayer-house of the Jews

meeting-place of the Jews

worship building

house for gathering together

If you make explicit a phrase such as “of the Jews,” be sure that it does not imply that Jesus was not a Jew.

If the word synagogue is already known in your area, you may write it according to the sounds of your

language. You may want to include a word or phrase to explain the meaning. For example:

synagog house/building

Consider using a footnote that contains some of the information above. See synagogue in the Glossary.

12:39b

and the places of honor at banquets.

- and they love for people to treat them as guests of honor at feasts.
- and at fancy dinners.

and the places of honor at banquets: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the places of honor means “the seats for the most honored guests” or “the best seats.” These were the seats that were nearest the host.

banquets: The word banquets refers here to feasts where people gathered to eat and celebrate together.

Mark 12:40

Section 12:38–40: Jesus warned the people about the teachers of the law

In this section Jesus continued to teach people in the temple courtyard. He warned the people about the teachers of the law (or “scribes”). He told them that the scribes were very proud. They wanted people to notice them and to admire and praise them. Jesus warned the people not to follow the bad example of these scribes or act the way they acted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus denounces the teachers of the law

Beware of the Scribes (ESV)

There are parallel passages for Mark 12:38–40 in Matthew 23:1–8 and Luke 20:45–47.

12:40

There is a contrast in this verse. The scribes cheated widows. Then these same scribes prayed long prayers to impress people. Express this contrast clearly in your language. For example:

They rob widows by taking their houses and then say long prayers to make themselves look good. (GW)

But they shamelessly cheat widows out of their property, and then, to cover up the kind of people they really are, they make long prayers in public. (NLT96)

12:40a

They defraud widows of their houses,

- They consume the property/estate of widows.
- They cheat and take the homes/property of widows.
- They deceitfully/dishonestly take possession of everything that belongs to widows.

They defraud widows of their houses: The clause that the BSB translates as They defraud widows of their houses is literally “they devour widows’ houses.” This is a Greek idiom. The idiom means that the scribes often tried to get as much money as they could from widows. They probably persuaded the widows to give them generous gifts. They used their status as scribes for their own profit, and this resulted in harm for some poor widows.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

They take advantage of widows and rob them of their homes (GNT)

They rob widows by taking their houses.

But they shamelessly cheat widows out of their property. (NLT96)

widows: Women whose husbands have died are called widows.

houses: The word houses is a figure of speech. It includes not only the homes of the widows, but their money and other possessions too.

12:40b

and for a show make lengthy prayers.

- And then, to pretend that they are righteous, they pray long prayers publicly.
- And then, they pray for a long time to make people think they are good.

and for a show make lengthy prayers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as show means “pretense.” The scribes were pretending to be righteous and to love God. They prayed long prayers in public so

that people would hear them. The teachers did this in order to impress people so that the people would think that the teachers were righteous.

make lengthy prayers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as make...prayers is literally “praying.” It refers to speaking to God. The phrase make lengthy prayers indicates that when the teachers prayed in public, they prayed for a long time. In some languages it is necessary to translate prayers as a verb. For example:

pray for a long time

Some languages may use different words to refer to specific kinds of prayer, such as requests, thanks, or praise. Here you should use a word or expression that has a general meaning.

12:40c

These men will receive greater condemnation.”

- These men will receive a heavier punishment than other people will.”
- God will punish these people more than he will punish others.”

These men will receive greater condemnation: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as These men will receive greater condemnation includes an implied comparison. The clause implies that other people will receive less condemnation. In some languages it may be necessary to make the comparison explicit. For example:

They will be punished more severely than other people.

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate who will punish the scribes. If that is true in your language, you should indicate that God will punish them. For example:

God will punish them more severely than he will punish others.

These men: The Greek word that the BSB translates as These men is literally “these.” It refers to the scribes who cheat widows and make long prayers.

Mark 12:41

Section 12:41–44: Jesus praised a poor widow who gave all that she had to God

In this section, a poor widow gave everything she had as an offering to God. Jesus praised her for doing this. He contrasted what many rich people were doing with what she did. This contrast is an example of the difference between those who truly worship God and those who only pretend to worship him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Widow's Offering (ESV, GNT)

A poor widow gave a generous gift to/for the temple

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 21:1–4.

12:41a

As Jesus was sitting opposite the treasury,

- ¶ Then Jesus sat down across from the place in the temple area where people gave their offerings to God.
- ¶ After that, Jesus sat near the place where people offered money to God.
- ¶ Later Jesus sat in the temple facing the boxes where people put money as an offering for God.

The events in this section probably happened sometime after Jesus taught people in the temple area in the preceding sections. If you need to begin this section with a time word or phrase in your language, use a general expression. For example:

Later

After that

As Jesus was sitting opposite the treasury: The word opposite indicates that Jesus sat where he could see the place where people came to give offerings to God. From his seat he could watch the people as they gave their offerings.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

As Jesus sat facing the temple offering boxes

Jesus was sitting in the temple courts near the collection boxes.

the treasury: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the treasury is used twice in this verse. In 12:41b the BSB translates this phrase as “it.” This treasury was one of several boxes or receptacles where people could put money as an offering for God. They were located in a special place in the temple courtyard, not in the temple building itself. Use a natural word or phrase in your language to describe this treasury. For example:

the place where the temple money boxes were

the place where people offered money to God

12:41b

He watched the crowd putting money into it.

- He watched the people as they put their money into the money boxes.
- He observed as people came one by one and dropped their money into the boxes.

He watched the crowd putting money into it: Jesus watched the people putting money into special boxes that religious leaders had placed there to receive their offering. The people came individually and dropped coins into the boxes. They gave this money as an offering to God. Later the priests used it to pay for keeping the temple clean and in good condition.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

watched the crowd putting money into the collection boxes

watching people put in their gifts (CEV)

Notice that the example from the CEV does not repeat the word “treasury,” because it is already clear from the context. Translate this verse in a way that is clear but not redundant in your language.

putting: The word putting refers here to the action of placing offerings into offering boxes. Each box had an opening where people dropped in their coins, so several English versions use some form of the word “dropping” here. In some languages there may be an idiom to describe giving offerings. In many languages it will be good to use a general word like “putting” or “placing,” as most English versions do.

money: The Greek word that the BSB translates as money refers here to copper or bronze coins. These coins were not as valuable as gold or silver coins. Some people may have put the more valuable silver or even gold coins into the treasury. But the Greek word used here refers to the less valuable copper and bronze coins. Most English versions use a general word like “money” or “coins” to translate this word. This fits with 12:41c, which indicates that many rich people gave large amounts of money.

it: The Greek word that the BSB translates as it is the same word as “the treasury” in 12:41a. See the note there. See temple, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information about the temple and how to translate it.

In some languages, it will be natural to say “it.” In other languages it will be natural to repeat the word or phrase from 12:41a here. For example:

...watched the multitude putting money into the treasury. (RSV)

12:41c

And many rich people put in large amounts.

- Many rich people dropped in a lot of money.
- Many rich people came, and each put a lot of money into the boxes.

And many rich people put in large amounts: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as put in refers to the action of placing offerings into offering boxes. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Many rich people tossed/dropped in large amounts.

...many rich people were giving a lot of money. (CEV)

...many that were rich cast in much. (GW)

large amounts: The Greek term that the BSB translates as large amounts literally means “a large quantity.” This phrase refers to the large value of the gifts. This may imply that the rich people put in silver and even gold coins, which were worth more than copper and bronze coins. Putting in a lot of coins or several big coins would fit in well with the attitude of the religious leaders, many of whom were rich. They were happy to make a lot of noise in their giving so that many people would observe their generosity.

Mark 12:42

Section 12:41–44: Jesus praised a poor widow who gave all that she had to God

In this section, a poor widow gave everything she had as an offering to God. Jesus praised her for doing this. He contrasted what many rich people were doing with what she did. This contrast is an example of the difference between those who truly worship God and those who only pretend to worship him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Widow’s Offering (ESV, GNT)

A poor widow gave a generous gift to/for the temple

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 21:1–4.

12:42a

Then one poor widow came

- Then a poor widow arrived at that place.
- Then a woman who was poor and whose husband had died came into that area,

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then is often translated in English versions as “And,” as in the RSV. The BSB uses Then because the widow gave her two coins after the rich people in 12:41c gave large amounts of money. Some English versions begin 12:42 with “but,” and some versions have no conjunction here. Connect 12:41 and 12:42 in a natural way in your language.

poor widow: A widow is a woman whose husband has died. Widows were often very poor.

12:42b

and put in two small copper coins,

- She put in two tiny copper coins,
- and she dropped two very little coins into a money box as her offering to God.

put in: The context implies that the widow put the coins into one of the same collection boxes where the rich people had put their gifts. The BSB has not made this explicit. In some languages you may need to make explicit the place where the widow put the coins. See the second meaning line in the Display for 12:42b for a way to do this.

two small copper coins: The Greek word that the BSB translates as small copper coins refers to the smallest type of coin that people used at that time. The name of this copper coin was leptos. It would take 128 of these coins to pay a laborer to work for one day. It is not clear whether this was a Roman coin or a Jewish coin. You may have a word for a very small coin that you could use here, such as “penny” in English.

12:42c

which amounted to a small fraction of a denarius.

- each of which were worth only part of a penny.
- The coins were not valuable at all.

which amounted to a small fraction of a denarius:

The value of one of the coins that the widow gave was so small that together two of these coins were only worth a small fraction of a denarius.

Here is another way to translate this:

each worth not even a small fraction of a denarius

a small fraction of a denarius: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a small fraction of a denarius is more literally “a quadrans,” as in the NASB. A “quadrans” was a Roman coin that was worth about one-eighth of a denarius. It would take 64 of these “quadrans” coins to equal one day’s wage for a laborer. Two of the small copper coins that the widow gave were worth one “quadrans.” Use a term in your language that refers to a small amount of money. For example:

a fraction of a penny (NIV)

only a few pennies (NIRV)

Mark 12:43

Section 12:41–44: Jesus praised a poor widow who gave all that she had to God

In this section, a poor widow gave everything she had as an offering to God. Jesus praised her for doing this. He contrasted what many rich people were doing with what she did. This contrast is an example of the difference between those who truly worship God and those who only pretend to worship him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Widow’s Offering (ESV, GNT)

A poor widow gave a generous gift to/for the temple

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 21:1–4.

12:43a

Jesus called His disciples to Him and said,

- Then Jesus told his disciples to come close to him. He said to them,
- Jesus saw this and called his followers to gather around him. When they did, he said,

Jesus called His disciples to Him and said: There is implied information here. Jesus saw what the poor widow gave to God. In some languages it may be helpful to make this explicit. For example:

When Jesus saw this, he called his disciples to him and said

Use a natural way in your language to connect this verse with 12:42.

called: The word called does not indicate that Jesus shouted to his disciples. They were probably right there with him. He asked them to come near to him so that he could tell them something.

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means “learners” who are in a relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

students/learners

apprentices

followers

See how you translated this term at 2:15b. See also disciple in the Glossary for more information.

12:43b

“Truly I tell you,

- “I tell you the truth, (NIV)
- “I assure you that

- “I tell you this:

Truly I tell you: Jesus often used the phrase that the BSB translates as Truly I tell you to begin a statement that he wanted to emphasize. When he began a statement with these words, he was asking people to listen closely.

Here are some other ways to show this emphasis:

Listen to this!

I tell you this:

I assure you

See how you translated this phrase in 3:28a. In addition to the translation options given there, you may be able to use an emphatic word within Jesus’ statement. For example:

This widow has truly/really put in more than all the others.

this poor widow has put more than all the others into the treasury: Here Jesus used a figurative way to praise the widow and her gift. She did not literally give more than the others, but what she gave had more value to God than all the other gifts. Jesus explained the reason for that in 12:44. She was more generous than the others, because she gave all that she had. This made her gift more valuable than all the other gifts, even though the actual amount was much less than the other people gave.

If people in your language do not understand the meaning correctly, you may want to express the meaning literally. For example:

What this poor widow gave has more value to God than all the money that the others have given.

more than all the others: This phrase implies that the widow gave more than all of the others put together. Most English versions translate this Greek word literally as “all.” Several commentators also suggest that “all the others put together” could have been Jesus’ meaning. However, another possible interpretation would be that the widow gave more than any of the other people. Turner & Bock (vol 2, page 15) supports this interpretation.

the others: The phrase the others refers to the other people who put money into the treasury.

12:43c

this poor widow has put more than all the others into the treasury.

- this poor widow has put more money into the offering boxes than all the other people did.
- what this poor widow gave to God is worth more than all the money that the other people gave.
- the money that this poor widow put into the boxes has more value to God than the money that all of the other people put in combined.

Mark 12:44

Section 12:41–44: Jesus praised a poor widow who gave all that she had to God

In this section, a poor widow gave everything she had as an offering to God. Jesus praised her for doing this. He contrasted what many rich people were doing with what she did. This contrast is an example of the difference between those who truly worship God and those who only pretend to worship him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Widow’s Offering (ESV, GNT)

A poor widow gave a generous gift to/for the temple

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 21:1–4.

12:44a

For they all contributed out of their surplus,

- I say this because they gave some of their surplus/extra money,
- What I mean is that they are rich and gave only some of what they did not need.

For: The Greek connector that the BSB translates as For introduces an explanation of 12:43. Some English versions do not use a connector. Use a natural way to connect 12:43 and 12:44 in your language.

they all contributed out of their surplus: This clause indicates that all of the rich people gave some money to God, but they still had plenty of money left. They had all the money they needed for food, clothes, and other things, even after they gave their offering. They did not give God any money that they really needed.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

They gave only what they did not need. (NCV)

they gave a tiny part of their surplus. (NLT)

12:44b

but she out of her poverty has put in all she had to live on.”

- but she is poor and gave everything that she had. She put in all the money that she could have used for her needs!”
- But even though this widow is poor, she gave all that she had left, even what she needed to survive!”

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but indicates a contrast with the previous clause. Try to make the contrast between the widow and the rich givers very clear in your language.

she out of her poverty has put in all she had: This clause indicates that the poor widow did not have any extra money. She did not even have enough money to buy the things that she really needed. She gave everything that she had to God.

out of her poverty: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as out of her poverty is literally “out of her lack.” “Lack” is the opposite of abundance. The phrase means that the woman did not have all the things that she needed. Try to use a word or phrase that contrasts with the wealth or abundance of the other givers. In some languages it may be necessary to follow the CEV and make this into a separate clause:

she is very poor

put in all she had to live on: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as put in all that she had to live on is more literally “put in all, as much as she had, her whole life.” This clause emphasizes that the widow gave everything that she had that she needed to survive. Use an emphatic way to express this in your language. For example, the NIV says:

put in everything—all she had to live on

all she had to live on: The phrase all she had to live on refers to the money that the widow could have used to buy food. She had no other savings.

Mark 13:1

Section 13:1–8: Jesus told his disciples that enemies would destroy the temple

In 11:27 Jesus entered the temple courts, and he and his disciples probably remained there through chapter 12. Then they left the temple (13:1), and one of the disciples exclaimed about how beautiful the temple was. Jesus told him that the Jews’ enemies would one day destroy the temple. The other disciples overheard this conversation. Some of them came to Jesus with some questions about what he had said. Jesus told them to be prepared for times of trouble in the future.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Jerusalem temple would soon be destroyed

The destruction of the temple and the coming times of trouble

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:1–8 and Luke 21:5–11.

13:1–2

Jesus left the temple with his disciples. Only one disciple is mentioned in 13:1–2, but it is clear from 13:3–4 that other disciples were there. They also heard the conversation between Jesus and that disciple.

13:1a

As Jesus was leaving the temple,

- ¶ As he/Jesus was leaving the temple,
- ¶ Jesus was going out of the temple area with his disciples,
- ¶ Then Jesus and his disciples/followers left the temple courtyard. As they were leaving,

As Jesus was leaving the temple: The following verses (13:2–3) show that Jesus was not alone as he left the temple courtyard. It may therefore be necessary to say:

As Jesus and his disciples were leaving the temple courtyard

Jesus was leaving the temple courts with his disciples

If you choose to use the word “disciples” here, translate it the same way as you did in 12:43a.

temple: In this context, the word temple refers to the large, outer courtyard of the temple. It does not refer to the temple building itself. (The temple consisted of the temple building and the walls and courtyards that surrounded it. People did not meet inside the temple building because only the priests could go there.)

If people understand the word temple to refer only to the temple building, you may need to use a term like “temple courtyard” (as in the GW).

Here are some ways to translate the term temple in this context:

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

courtyard of the house of God

courtyard of the house of sacrifice

holy/sacred house courtyard

- If your language has a word for “temple,” consider using it. But you may need to modify it by saying:

courtyard of the temple of the Jews/Lord

big/great temple courtyard

Translate this term as you did in 12:35a. See temple, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information about the temple and how to translate it.

13:1b

one of His disciples said to Him, “Teacher, look at

- one of his disciples said to him, “Teacher, look!
- and one of his followers exclaimed, “Teacher, look!
- one of them exclaimed, “Teacher, look at

one of His disciples: If you mentioned the disciples in 13:1a, you could now use the word “them.” For example:

one of them

said to Him: The disciple’s words in 13:1b–c are an exclamation. In some languages it may be more natural to use a different verb like “exclaimed,” as in the REB.

Teacher, look: The NIV translates this phrase as “Look, Teacher!” You should place the word Teacher in the position that is most natural in your language.

Teacher: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Teacher was a polite title for a Jewish religious leader.

It was a title of respect for a Jewish man who had authority to teach the things about God. In some languages the appropriate way to address a religious teacher may be:

Sir Teacher

Sir

Master

Be careful not to use a term that can refer only to a school teacher.

See how you translated this term in 12:32a.

look: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as look means “look” or “see.” It draws attention to what follows.

13:1c

the magnificent stones and buildings!”

- What huge stones the builders used! What beautiful buildings!”
- These are extremely beautiful buildings! These are enormous stones!”
- these tremendous stones and buildings!” (NET)

at the magnificent stones and buildings!: The clause at the magnificent stones and buildings! is an exclamation. Other languages express exclamations in different ways. For example:

Look at these massive stones! Look at these magnificent buildings!

These are extremely massive stones! These are extremely magnificent buildings!

You should express these exclamations in a way that is natural in your language.

magnificent: The Greek word is literally “what type/manner of.” In a context like this, it shows admiration and means something like “how great.” For example:

huge (REB)

massive (NIV)

wonderful (RSV)

beautiful (GW)

stones: The word stones refers to the stone blocks of which the temple was made. Workers had to cut these stones to be the right shape for the building.

Here is another way to translate this:

What huge stones the builders used!

In some languages it may be helpful to mention the buildings before mentioning the stones. See the General Comment below for an example.

buildings: The word buildings refers to the temple building itself, the other buildings in the temple courtyards, and the outer walls.

General Comment on 13:1c

In some languages it may be natural to mention the buildings before mentioning the stones of which the buildings were made. For example:

What magnificent buildings! What massive stones they are built with!

Mark 13:2

Section 13:1–8: Jesus told his disciples that enemies would destroy the temple

In 11:27 Jesus entered the temple courts, and he and his disciples probably remained there through chapter 12. Then they left the temple (13:1), and one of the disciples exclaimed about how beautiful the temple was. Jesus told him that the Jews' enemies would one day destroy the temple. The other disciples overheard this conversation. Some of them came to Jesus with some questions about what he had said. Jesus told them to be prepared for times of trouble in the future.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Jerusalem temple would soon be destroyed

The destruction of the temple and the coming times of trouble

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:1–8 and Luke 21:5–11.

13:2a

“Do you see all these great buildings?” Jesus replied.

- Jesus replied, “You^(sing) see these great buildings?
- Jesus said to him, “Yes indeed, look^(sing) at these great buildings.
- Jesus said, “As for these great buildings that you^(sing) see,

Do you see all these great buildings?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used it to introduce a new fact. This fact is in 13:2b: the temple and its buildings will be completely destroyed. The rhetorical question focuses attention on the fact as surprising and dreadful. There are at least three ways to translate it:

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the BSB and the NIV say:

Do you see all these great buildings?

- As a repetition of what the disciple said in 13:1. For example, the NLT says:

Yes, look at these great buildings.

- As a clause that introduces a new thought about a subject. For example:

As for these big buildings which you are looking at now...

Use a form that is natural in your language.

you: The word you refers to the disciple who exclaimed about the beauty of the temple. The form in Greek is singular.

Jesus replied: The BSB places the expression Jesus replied at the end of the sentence:

“Do you see all these great buildings?” Jesus replied.

In Greek, this expression occurs at the beginning of 13:2a, before Jesus' words. Place it where it is natural in your language.

13:2b

“Not one stone here will be left on another;

- I tell you,^(sing) not one stone of these buildings will remain in its present place.
- But, I tell you,^(sing) enemies will not leave one stone in its present place.

- not one of its stones will remain on top of another.

In some languages, it may be clearer to put 13:2b after 13:2c. See the General Comment on 13:2b–c below.

Not one stone here will be left on another: The phrase Not one stone here will be left on another means that all the stones in the temple would be knocked to the ground. No stone would remain on top of another stone. This indicates that the temple would be completely demolished.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Not one stone will remain in its present place.

In some languages it may be necessary to say who would not leave one stone on another. Jesus did not say who it was, but it is clear from the context that it would be the enemies of the Jews.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Enemies/soldiers will not leave one stone in its present place.

Enemies will knock down all the stones.

13:2c

every one will be thrown down.”

- They will all be destroyed.”
- They will cause them all to fall down.”
- Every stone will be thrown/pushed down on the ground.”

Jesus restated here what he had just said in 13:2b in order to emphasize it.

every one will be thrown down: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as every one will be thrown down here means “every stone will be torn from its place.” It indicates that soldiers would push to the ground every stone that was on top of another. For example, the NET says:

All will be torn down!

In some languages it may be necessary to say explicitly who would tear the stones down. For example:

They will cause them all to fall down.

Your enemies will knock them all down.

General Comment on 13:2b–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of 13:2b and 13:2c. For example:

^{2c}Every stone will be thrown/pushed down. ^{2b}Not one stone will remain on another!

Mark 13:3

Section 13:1–8: Jesus told his disciples that enemies would destroy the temple

In 11:27 Jesus entered the temple courts, and he and his disciples probably remained there through chapter 12. Then they left the temple (13:1), and one of the disciples exclaimed about how beautiful the temple was. Jesus told him that the Jews’ enemies would one day destroy the temple. The other disciples overheard this conversation. Some of them came to Jesus with some questions about what he had said. Jesus told them to be prepared for times of trouble in the future.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Jerusalem temple would soon be destroyed

The destruction of the temple and the coming times of trouble

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:1–8 and Luke 21:5–11.

Paragraph 13:3–4

After Jesus and his disciples left the temple, they went down into a valley and climbed up the other side onto the Mount of Olives. Jesus sat down, and from there he could look across the valley to the temple.

13:3a

While Jesus was sitting on the Mount of Olives

- ¶ Soon after, Jesus was sitting on the Mount of Olives
- ¶ Then Jesus went over to the Mount of Olives and sat down

While Jesus was sitting on the Mount of Olives: This part of the verse gives the location for the rest of this chapter.

Here is another way to translate this:

Soon after, Jesus was sitting on the Mount of Olives

It may also be natural to make explicit the fact that Jesus went/walked over to the Mount of Olives. For example:

Then Jesus went over to the Mount of Olives and sat down

the Mount of Olives: The Mount of Olives was a hill on the east side of Jerusalem. This hill had olive trees growing on it. The summit/top of this hill was higher than the hill on which the temple was built. So someone who was on the top of the Mount of Olives could see the temple on the other hill. Mark first introduced the expression the Mount of Olives in 11:1b. See how you translated it there.

13:3b opposite the temple,

- across the valley from the temple.
- facing the temple.

opposite the temple: The word opposite indicates that the temple was “across the valley from” or “facing” the Mount of Olives. When Jesus sat on the Mount of Olives, he would be able to see the temple and the whole city of Jerusalem.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

facing the Temple (NJB)

across the valley from the Temple (NLT)

temple: The Greek word that the BSB translates as temple is the same word as in 13:1a. If you translated this word as “temple courtyard” in 13:1a, you can translate it here as simply “temple.” See temple, Meaning 1, in the Glossary.

13:3c Peter, James, John, and Andrew asked Him privately,

- Peter, James, John, and Andrew came to him privately and asked him,
- Peter, James, John, and Andrew went over to him when no one else was with him and said to him,

Peter, James, John, and Andrew asked Him privately: The four disciples Peter, James, John and Andrew came to Jesus as he was sitting on the Mount of Olives (13:3a). They wanted to ask him about what he had said in 13:2. The word privately indicates that

they did not want anyone else to hear their question. The four disciples probably sat close to Jesus. His other disciples also may have been nearby but not close enough to hear what was said.

In some languages it may be natural to mention that the four disciples came/went near to Jesus. For example:

Peter, James, John, and Andrew went over to talk to Jesus privately. They asked him....

Peter, James, John, and Andrew came to Jesus when no one else was with him and asked him...

Mark 13:4

Section 13:1–8: Jesus told his disciples that enemies would destroy the temple

In 11:27 Jesus entered the temple courts, and he and his disciples probably remained there through chapter 12. Then they left the temple (13:1), and one of the disciples exclaimed about how beautiful the temple was. Jesus told him that the Jews’ enemies would one day destroy the temple. The other disciples overheard this conversation. Some of them came to Jesus with some questions about what he had said. Jesus told them to be prepared for times of trouble in the future.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Jerusalem temple would soon be destroyed

The destruction of the temple and the coming times of trouble

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:1–8 and Luke 21:5–11.

Paragraph 13:3–4

After Jesus and his disciples left the temple, they went down into a valley and climbed up the other side onto the Mount of Olives. Jesus sat down, and from there he could look across the valley to the temple.

13:4a “Tell us, when will these things happen?”

- “Tell us,^(excl) when will these things happen/occur?
- “When will they do this? Please tell us about it.

Tell us: The disciples were politely addressing Jesus, their respected teacher. They did not demand information. Express the phrase Tell us in a way that shows respect. For example:

Tell us,^(excl) we beg

Teacher, please tell us

when will these things happen?: Here, the phrase when will these things happen? refers back to what Jesus said in 13:2. The question means, “when will the temple/buildings be destroyed?” If in 13:2b or 2c you supplied a subject such as “enemy” or “soldiers,” you may need to translate this as:

...when will they do this?

these things: The Greek word that the BSB translates as these things refers mainly to the destruction of the temple that Jesus talked about in 13:2. It also may include other events connected with the destruction. In some languages you may need to use a more specific word or phrase. For example:

...when will these events occur?

13:4b

And what will be the sign that they are about to be fulfilled?”

- What will be the sign that they are about to happen?”
- What will show that these events will soon happen?”

And what will be the sign: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sign refers to a signal or indication that something is true or that something will happen. In this context the sign would be a warning. The disciples believed that God would warn his people when these terrible events were about to happen. See how you translated sign in 8:11b.

Here are some other ways to translate what will be the sign:

...what will happen to show that.... (GNT)

What will we see, so that we may know...?

that they are about to be fulfilled?: The phrase they are about to be fulfilled is literally “that they will very-

soon be-accomplished.” It indicates that these events would soon happen. The word “be-accomplished” is different from the one that means “fulfilled.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

that they will happen soon

that they are going to happen (NCV)

that they are about to take place (CEV)

If you used the subject “they” (to represent soldiers/enemies) in the previous verse part, you may need to use it here also:

What will be the sign that they are about to do these acts/actions?

Mark 13:5

Section 13:1–8: Jesus told his disciples that enemies would destroy the temple

In 11:27 Jesus entered the temple courts, and he and his disciples probably remained there through chapter 12. Then they left the temple (13:1), and one of the disciples exclaimed about how beautiful the temple was. Jesus told him that the Jews’ enemies would one day destroy the temple. The other disciples overheard this conversation. Some of them came to Jesus with some questions about what he had said. Jesus told them to be prepared for times of trouble in the future.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Jerusalem temple would soon be destroyed

The destruction of the temple and the coming times of trouble

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:1–8 and Luke 21:5–11.

Paragraph 13:5–8

In this paragraph, Jesus warned his disciples that terrible events would occur sometime after he died and before he returned to earth. He told them to be careful not to let anyone deceive them, because false messiahs would come. There would also be wars, famines, and earthquakes.

13:5

Jesus began by telling them, “See to it that no one deceives you.”

- ¶ Jesus answered them, “Be^(plur) careful so that no one deceives you.
- ¶ Jesus answered them, “Take^(plur) care and do not let anyone deceive you who are my disciples.
- ¶ He replied, “Be^(plur) alert and do not let anyone cause you^(plur) to believe something false.

Jesus began by telling them: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as began by telling them is literally “began to say.” Here it may indicate that Jesus was beginning a long speech, and he began with the words in 13:5.

In some languages it may not be natural to use a word like “began.” Several English versions translate the verb simply as said, as the NIV does. Consider how you would introduce a long speech in your language.

See to it that no one deceives you: The clause See to it that no one deceives you means that the disciples should be careful so that no one would be able to deceive them. It implies that other people would try to deceive them, but that the disciples should not believe them.

See to it: The Greek word that the BSB translates as See to it is a key word in this chapter. It literally means “See” or “Watch.” It indicates that the disciples should be alert. They should beware of what was happening around them. The same Greek word occurs in 13:9a, 13:23a, and 13:33a where the BSB translates it each time as “Be on your guard.”

deceives: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as deceives means “fools/tricks” or “causes [someone] to believe something that is not true.” The specific way that people might deceive the disciples is mentioned in 13:6. In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit what Jesus did not want his disciples to believe. If that is true in your language, you may want to use a general expression. For example:

deceives you^(plur) into believing something that is not true

See the General Comment on 13:5–6 after the note on 13:6c for further discussion.

you: The pronoun you refers back to the four disciples who were talking to Jesus. However, Jesus’ words apply to all of the people who followed him then and in the future.

Mark 13:6

Section 13:1–8: Jesus told his disciples that enemies would destroy the temple

In 11:27 Jesus entered the temple courts, and he and his disciples probably remained there through chapter 12. Then they left the temple (13:1), and one of the disciples exclaimed about how beautiful the temple was. Jesus told him that the Jews’ enemies would one day destroy the temple. The other disciples overheard this conversation. Some of them came to Jesus with some questions about what he had said. Jesus told them to be prepared for times of trouble in the future.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Jerusalem temple would soon be destroyed

The destruction of the temple and the coming times of trouble

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:1–8 and Luke 21:5–11.

Paragraph 13:5–8

In this paragraph, Jesus warned his disciples that terrible events would occur sometime after he died and before he returned to earth. He told them to be careful not to let anyone deceive them, because false messiahs would come. There would also be wars, famines, and earthquakes.

13:6

In some languages it may be more natural to state 13:6 before giving the command in 13:5. See the reordered verses in the General Comment on 13:5–6 after the note on 13:6c.

13:6a

Many will come

- For many people will come/appear,
- I say this because there will be many men who will say untrue things,

This verse gives the reason why Jesus said “See to it that no one deceives you” in 13:5.

Many will come: The word Many here means “Many people” (as in the NCV) or “Many men,” as in the GNT. The phrase will come introduces them as people who will do (or say) things in the future. It does not indicate that they will come to any particular place.

Here is another way to translate this:

There will be many men who will come...

13:6b

in My name, claiming, 'I am He,'

- using my title 'the Christ', and each one claiming about himself: 'I am the one.'
- and each one will state/say falsely that he himself is the Christ/Messiah.

in My name, claiming, 'I am He': The phrase in my name, claiming, 'I am He' indicates that people would say that they were "the Christ" or "the Anointed One." They would say (falsely) that they were the Savior promised by God, the One whom the Jews were waiting for. Actually, it was Jesus who was the Christ.

I am He: In the Greek, the word I is emphatic and the word He implies "the Christ/Messiah." When translating the words I am He, you may:

- Use direct speech. For example:

claiming 'I am he' (NIV)

and each one will say, 'I, I am the Christ/Messiah'

- Use indirect speech. For example:

each one will claim that it is he who is the Christ/Messiah

and they will all say that they are the Christ/Messiah

If you use the word "Christ" or "Messiah" here, use the same expression that you used in 12:35c.

13:6c

and will deceive many.

- When they say this, they will deceive many people.
- They will cause many people to believe their lies.

and will deceive many: The subject of this clause is "Many (people)" in 13:6a. The people who will come and claim to be the Christ (13:6a-b) will deceive many other people. In this context the word deceive implies that people will believe the lies that the deceivers are telling them. They will believe that these men are truly the Messiah. It may be clearer to start a new sentence in this part of the verse. For example:

When they say this, they will deceive many people into thinking that they are truly the Messiah.

By saying this, they will trick many people into believing them.

General Comment on 13:5-6

In some languages, it may be more natural to place Jesus' command in 13:5 at the end of 13:6. For example:

⁵Jesus said to them, ^{6a}"Many people will come ^{6b}using my title, and will claim, 'I am the Christ/Messiah.' ^{6c}They will deceive many people. ⁵But see to it that no one deceives you...."

Mark 13:7

Section 13:1-8: Jesus told his disciples that enemies would destroy the temple

In 11:27 Jesus entered the temple courts, and he and his disciples probably remained there through chapter 12. Then they left the temple (13:1), and one of the disciples exclaimed about how beautiful the temple was. Jesus told him that the Jews' enemies would one day destroy the temple. The other disciples overheard this conversation. Some of them came to Jesus with some questions about what he had said. Jesus told them to be prepared for times of trouble in the future.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Jerusalem temple would soon be destroyed

The destruction of the temple and the coming times of trouble

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:1-8 and Luke 21:5-11.

Paragraph 13:5-8

In this paragraph, Jesus warned his disciples that terrible events would occur sometime after he died and before he returned to earth. He told them to be careful not to let anyone deceive them, because false messiahs would come. There would also be wars, famines, and earthquakes.

13:7a

When you hear of wars and rumors of wars,

- When you^(plur) hear about wars and the news of battles,
- You^(plur) will also hear that peoples/tribes/countries are fighting each other and you will hear reports about the fights,

In this verse Jesus mentioned another event that would happen before the end (13:7d): there will be wars. Connect 13:7a to 13:7c in a way that is natural in your language.

In some languages it may be more natural to place 13:7b before 13:7a. See the General Comment on 13:7a–b at the end of 13:7b for a suggestion.

When you hear of wars: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as When you hear of wars is literally “When you hear wars.” There are two ways to interpret this clause:

1. It indicates that the disciples would hear about wars. For example:

When you hear about wars (NCV) (BSB, NIV, CEV, GW, RSV, NASB, KJV, NCV, NET, NLT, REB, JBP, ESV)

1. It indicates that the disciples would hear the “sound” or “noise” of wars. If you can hear the sound of fighting, that indicates that it is taking place close by. For example, the GNT says:

when you hear the noise of battles close by (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

you hear of wars: The phrase you hear of implies that people would tell the disciples about the wars. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

People will tell you of wars and you will hear reports about battles

wars: The word wars refers to battles. These battles usually involve different groups of people, for example, countries, cities, or tribes. In some languages it may be necessary to express the word wars as a verb and indicate who is fighting. For example:

people(s) fighting each other

hear of wars and rumors of wars: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as rumors means “news” or “reports.” The phrase rumors of wars indi-

cates that the disciples would hear reports about wars that were happening.

The phrases of wars and rumors of wars have similar meanings. Some scholars believe that the word rumors implies that the wars were far away or that they had not yet begun. Since the text is not specific about this, it is good to translate in a general way. For example:

You will hear about wars and receive news of wars

13:7b do not be alarmed.

- do^(plur) not be afraid/terrified.
- but do^(plur) not be troubled/disturbed.

do not be alarmed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as alarmed means to be both frightened and surprised.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

do not be terrified

do not be upset

Jesus was telling the disciples not to be frightened when they heard about people fighting in various places.

General Comment on 13:7a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of 13:7a and 13:7b. For example:

^{7b}Do^(plur) not be afraid/terrified ^{7a}when you hear about wars and receive news of battles.

13:7c These things must happen,

- Such things/events must occur,
- These wars must take place,
- People will most certainly fight against each other,

These things: The phrase These things refers to the wars of 13:7a. In some languages, it will be necessary to refer back to them in a different way. For example:

these events

these wars

must happen: In this context the phrase must happen indicates that it is unavoidable that people will fight against each other.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

these things must come (NLT96)

These things will have to happen first (CEV)

These wars must take place.

People will most certainly fight against each other

13:7d

but the end is still to come.

- but it is not yet the end of the world.
- but this does not indicate that everything will end soon.

but: The Greek connector that the BSB translates as but indicates that 13:7c contrasts with 13:7d. The wars that were mentioned in 13:7c might cause the disciples to expect that the end would come immediately. However, 13:7d indicates that the end would come sometime after those wars. Show this contrast in a natural way in your language.

the end is still to come: The phrase the end is still to come means that the world would continue to exist for some time. It would not end immediately after the disciples heard about the wars in 13:7c.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

those wars are not the end

the end will not happen immediately

the end: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as the end here may refer specifically to the end of the temple. However, it also refers more generally to the end of this age of the world (see Matthew 24:3, 24:6).

In some languages you may need to specify what will end. If that is true in your language, it is good to translate the general meaning that will include the more specific one. For example:

but this does not indicate that everything will end soon

but it is not the end of the world yet

Mark 13:8

Section 13:1–8: Jesus told his disciples that enemies would destroy the temple

In 11:27 Jesus entered the temple courts, and he and his disciples probably remained there through chapter 12. Then they left the temple (13:1), and one of the disciples exclaimed about how beautiful the temple was. Jesus told him that the Jews' enemies would one day destroy the temple. The other disciples overheard this conversation. Some of them came to Jesus with some questions about what he had said. Jesus told them to be prepared for times of trouble in the future.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Jerusalem temple would soon be destroyed

The destruction of the temple and the coming times of trouble

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:1–8 and Luke 21:5–11.

Paragraph 13:5–8

In this paragraph, Jesus warned his disciples that terrible events would occur sometime after he died and before he returned to earth. He told them to be careful not to let anyone deceive them, because false messiahs would come. There would also be wars, famines, and earthquakes.

13:8a

Nation will rise against nation,

- Countries will fight each other; (GNT)
- People in one country will fight against people in another country,
- People from one ethnic group are going to attack people from another ethnic group,

Nation will rise against nation: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Nation means “the people of one country.” In this context it is also possible to translate nation as “tribe” or “ethnic group.”

rise against: The expression rise against means “start to make war against” or “attack.”

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

Countries will fight each other (GNT)

People from one tribe will attack people from another tribe.

13:8b

and kingdom against kingdom.

- kingdoms will attack one another. (GNT)
- and the people from one kingdom/region will fight against the people of another kingdom/region.
- and people who are under one ruler/chief will fight against people who are under another ruler/chief.

and kingdom against kingdom: The phrase and kingdom against kingdom implies the verb that the BSB translates as “will rise” in 13:8a. In many languages it is necessary to supply this verb or another verb with the same meaning here in 13:8b, as well. For example:

kingdoms will attack one another (GNT)

and the people of one kingdom will march against those of another

kingdom: A kingdom is the territory that a king rules. Here it refers to the people who live in the kingdom.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

and people who are under one ruler/chief will fight against people who are under another ruler/ chief

General Comment on 13:8a–b

The statements in 13:8a and 13:8b are very similar. In some languages it may be natural to combine these statements. For example, the CEV says:

Nations and kingdoms will go to war against each other.

13:8c

There will be earthquakes in various places,

- The earth will shake violently in various places.
- In many parts of the world earthquakes will happen,

There will be earthquakes in various places: The Greek word that the BSB translates as earthquakes refers to sudden and violent movements of the ground. When the ground shakes like this, it often destroys buildings. Jesus said that the earth would shake

at different times and in different places. He implied that this would cause much damage and suffering.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The earth will shake violently in various places.

In various places earthquakes will happen.

in various places: This phrase means “in different places” or “in many parts of the world.”

13:8d

as well as famines.

- There will also be famines.
- and there will be long times when there is no food for people to eat.

as well as famines: The Greek word that the BSB translates as famines refers to prolonged periods when people do not have enough food to eat. They become very hungry and many die of hunger.

The word famines should be distinguished from annual periods when food is usually in short supply. It should also be distinguished from the daily experience of hunger which shows someone that it is time to eat again.

Here is another way to translate this:

...and some people will die of hunger.

13:8e

These are the beginning of birth pains.

- These sufferings are like the first pains of childbirth.
- These events are like the first pains of a woman before she gives birth. They show that greater sufferings are coming.

These are the beginning of birth pains: The clause These are the beginning of birth pains is a metaphor. The word These refers to the terrible events that Jesus predicted in 13:6–8. They would be like the pains that a woman first feels when her child is about to be born. These pains increase until the moment when the child is born. In the same way, these terrible events would be a sign that there would be even more severe suffering in the future. See 13:14–22.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

These sufferings are like the first pains of childbirth.

These events are like the first pains of a woman before she gives birth. They show that greater suffering is coming.

Mark 13:9

Section 13:9–13: Jesus warned his disciples that people would persecute them

In 13:9–13 Jesus warned his disciples that people would persecute them because they were his followers. They would suffer persecution from their fellow Jews (13:9a–c) and from other people (13:9d–e). He told them to always be prepared for opposition or persecution.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples must remain firm in their faith

The disciples must follow Christ even if others cause them to suffer for it

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:9–14 and Luke 21:12–19.

13:9

Because this is a new paragraph, you may need to remind readers that Jesus was still speaking to his disciples. For example:

Jesus continued speaking to his disciples. He said...

13:9a

So be on your guard.

- ¶ “As for you, you^(plur) must always be watching/careful.
- ¶ Jesus continued speaking. He said, “My disciples, be careful/watchful.
- ¶ “As for you,^(plur) always be alert because people will oppose you.

So be on your guard: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as So be on your guard is literally “you yourselves be looking/watching.” This phrase emphasizes the pronoun “you.” The same Greek verb occurs in 13:5, 13:23a, and 13:33a.

Here is another way to translate this:

As for you,^(plur) you must always be/stay watching.

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate what to watch out for. For example:

Always watch^(plur) out for people who will oppose you.

The idea be on your guard is a theme of this chapter. To make the theme clear, it is natural in some languages to use the same words in each verse where this expression occurs. In other languages it is natural to use similar expressions (synonyms) instead. Express this theme in a way that is natural in your language.

13:9b

You will be delivered over to the councils

- They will hand some of you^(plur) over to the local councils/courts,
- For/Because your^(plur) enemies will arrest some of you and accuse you before the town leaders/judges,

Verse 13:9b–e gives the reasons for Jesus’ warning in 13:9a. The Greek has no conjunction at the beginning of 13:9b, but this connection is implied. The RSV expresses the connection as:

for they will deliver you up

Connect 13:9b to 13:9a in the most natural way in your language.

You will be delivered over: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as You will be delivered over is literally “they will hand you over.” The Greek uses an active verb, but the BSB translates it with a passive verb.

In many languages it may be natural to use an active clause here, as the Greek text does. For example:

They will hand some of you over to stand trial

They will arrest some of you and accuse you

The people who would hand over the disciples would be certain Jews. They would say that the disciples were guilty of some crime against the Jewish religion. In some languages it may also be necessary to use a noun for the subject, instead of a form like “they.” For example:

Your enemies will hand you over

You: The Greek text uses a plural form here. It refers to some of the disciples. It probably does not imply that

all the disciples would suffer in this way. If necessary, you may make this explicit:

Some of you

delivered over: The Greek word that the BSB translates as delivered over here means “delivered into the power and control of the authorities.” The word implies that the enemies would accuse the disciples of something, and that the authorities would try them in court. In 13:12a the BSB translates this same Greek word as “betray.”

councils: The Greek word that the BSB translates as councils refers to the groups of Jewish elders/leaders who served as judges in civil and criminal affairs. The Jews had these councils/groups in all their towns.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in the local councils/courts

before the town leaders/judges

13:9c and beaten in the synagogues.

- and they will cause people to whip you^(plur) in the synagogue buildings.
- and they will order people to beat you^(plur) in the meeting places.

beaten: The word beaten means “and you will be beaten.” The Greek word means “beat repeatedly with a whip.” The Romans used whips that had leather thongs and a wooden handle. They tied sharp pieces of metal into the leather thongs. When they beat a man with this whip, it could badly cut him up with just a few strokes. They beat him both on his back and on his chest.

There is a similar Greek word that the BSB translates as “flog” in 10:34b. See how you translated the term there.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

and they will cause people to whip you

and they will order people to beat you

synagogues: The synagogues were buildings where Jews gathered to pray, read scripture, teach their beliefs, and worship. The Jews also gathered there for cultural activities. There was only one temple (in

Jerusalem), but each Jewish community had a synagogue.

Here are some other ways to translate synagogue:

prayer-house of the Jews

meeting-place of the Jews

worship building

house for gathering together

If you make explicit a phrase such as “of the Jews,” be sure that it does not imply that Jesus was not a Jew.

If the word synagogue is already known in your area, you may write it according to the sounds of your language. You may want to include a word or phrase to explain the meaning. For example:

sinagog house/building

Consider using a footnote that contains some of the information above. See synagogue in the Glossary.

13:9d–e

The BSB changes the order of the Greek phrases in 13:9d–e. The NLT follows the Greek order:

^{9e}You will stand trial before governors and kings

^{9d}because you are my followers.

The meaning is the same in the two versions. You should order these phrases in the way that is most natural in your language.

13:9d

On My account

- Because of me,
- Because you^(plur) follow me,
- Because you^(plur) are my disciples,

On My account: The phrase On My account means “because of me,” “because you are loyal to me” or “because you follow me.” For example:

because of me (CEV)

because you follow me (NCV)

13:9e

you will stand before governors and kings

- you^(plur) will stand trial before governors and kings.
- you^(plur) will be forced to go before governors and rulers who will judge you.

you will stand before governors and kings: In this context, the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as stand before means “to stand in the presence of a judge in order to be accused and judged.” The text implies that people will bring the disciples to rulers to be judged. In some languages it may be necessary to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

you will stand trial (NLT)

you will be forced to stand (NCV)

people will bring you to governors and kings and accuse you

before governors and kings: The words governors and kings are names for two types of rulers. See the next notes for specific details.

governors: A “governor” was a man who was appointed by a greater leader, or by the government of a country, to rule a particular area. For example, Pilate was governor of Judea (Mark 15:1). He was a Roman, appointed by the Roman emperor to govern the Jews. If you have translated the Gospel of Luke, see how you translated the word “governor” in Luke 2:2a–b.

In some languages there may be a borrowed word that is already used to describe such a ruler. If there is no such word in your language, you may need to use a more general term such as:

leaders

kings: The word kings refers to rulers of a country or other area. Kings normally have absolute power within the areas that they rule. Often, a king inherits his position from his father. A king was considered more important than a governor.

The word “king” is used to refer to King Herod in 6:22c. If you used the word “king” there, you should use a plural form of the same word here.

Here are some other ways to translate kings:

rulers

chiefs

13:9f as witnesses to them.

- Then you^(plur) will witness to them about me.
- As a result, you^(plur) will be able to tell them the good news about me,

as witnesses to them: The phrase as witnesses to them indicates that this persecution would give the disciples an opportunity to testify to their faith in Jesus. They would do this in front of governors and kings.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to tell them the Good News (GNT)

As a result, you will be able to tell them the good news about me.

Mark 13:10

Section 13:9–13: Jesus warned his disciples that people would persecute them

In 13:9–13 Jesus warned his disciples that people would persecute them because they were his followers. They would suffer persecution from their fellow Jews (13:9a–c) and from other people (13:9d–e). He told them to always be prepared for opposition or persecution.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples must remain firm in their faith

The disciples must follow Christ even if others cause them to suffer for it

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:9–14 and Luke 21:12–19.

13:10 And the gospel must first be proclaimed to all the nations.

- Furthermore, the good news about me must be preached to people in all nations before the end of the world.
- and in all nations you^(plur) and others who believe in me must proclaim the good news to people before the end comes.

- And also, before everything ends, people must announce the good news to all tribes/nations in the world.

In 13:9 Mark wrote about the disciples being persecuted. In 13:10 he showed that persecution could give the disciples opportunities to preach the gospel. They would be able to preach not only to the Jews but to all the nations.

And: In Greek this verse begins with the common conjunction that is often translated as And, as in the BSB. Scholars differ about exactly what connection this verse has to the context. However, it is clear that it introduces more information about being witnesses (13:9f). Here are some ways to connect 13:9 and 13:10:

- Do not use a conjunction.
- Use a general conjunction or another way to introduce additional information. For example:

Furthermore

And also

Connect the verses in a natural way in your language.

the gospel: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gospel means “good news.” In Mark, this word refers to the good news about Jesus Christ and the kingdom of God.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

good/sweet news

good news about Jesus Christ

good news from God

message/report that causes joy

Be sure that the term you choose does not refer only to a news report or to a story that is not true.

See how you translated this word in Mark 1:1.

must...be proclaimed: This is a passive phrase. In some languages it may be more natural to use an active clause and supply a subject. For example:

my disciples must proclaim/preach

proclaimed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as proclaimed means announced something important. Here it refers specifically to telling the gospel to other people.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

announced

told/spoken

first: In this context, the word first means “before the end.” Jesus mentioned “the end” in 13:7d. The notes on that verse explained that “the end” could refer to both the end of the temple and the end of the world. Therefore you should translate first in a general way. For example:

before the end comes (GNT)

before these things happen (NCV)

all the nations: The phrase all the nations represents the people of all nations. In some languages this may need to be made explicit. For example:

to people in every nation

Even before the destruction of the temple, Paul and others were spreading the gospel to many different ethnic groups. They preached throughout all the world that people knew about at that time (see Romans 16:26 and Colossians 1:6, 23).

nations: The Greek word that the BSB translates as nations refers to “ethnic groups” or “people groups.” In New Testament times it referred to smaller groups than we think of today when we use the English word nations.

Mark 13:11

Section 13:9–13: Jesus warned his disciples that people would persecute them

In 13:9–13 Jesus warned his disciples that people would persecute them because they were his followers. They would suffer persecution from their fellow Jews (13:9a–c) and from other people (13:9d–e). He told them to always be prepared for opposition or persecution.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples must remain firm in their faith

The disciples must follow Christ even if others cause them to suffer for it

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:9–14 and Luke 21:12–19.

13:11a

But when they arrest you and hand you over,

- Whenever they arrest you^(plur) and accuse you,
- Whenever they bring/take you^(plur) to court and hand you over to the judges in this way,
- If they hand some of you over to be judged in this way,

But when they arrest you and hand you over: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as But when they arrest you and hand you over is literally “and when they lead you, handing you over.”

arrest you and hand you over: The two verbs translated arrest and hand you over describe the action of taking the disciples to the authorities so that the authorities can judge them. The same Greek verb for hand you over was also used in 13:9b. You may want to use the same verb here that you used there. Describe the action in a natural way in your language.

13:11b

do not worry beforehand what to say.

- do^(plur) not be anxious ahead of time about speaking.
- do^(plur) not ask yourself, ‘What should I say?’ before they tell you to speak.
- when they have not yet told you to speak, do not ask yourself, ‘What can I say?’

do not worry beforehand what to say: The phrase do not worry beforehand indicates that the disciples should not be anxious about what they will say. The phrase what to say refers to what they should say at their trial.

The two verbs do not worry and say can be ordered in two ways:

Do^(plur) not worry beforehand about what you will say.

Before you^(plur) are told to speak in court, do not be anxious about speaking.

If you have no direct way to say “be anxious” or “be worried,” you may need to express this in direct speech. For example:

Do not ask yourself, “Whatever can I say?” before they tell you to speak.

beforehand: The word beforehand indicates that the disciples should not worry before the trial started or before the judge gave them permission to speak. You can translate this as either a single word or a phrase. For example, the GNT says:

ahead of time

In some languages it may be more natural to put the time word or phrase before the instruction not to worry. For example:

Before they tell you to speak, do not ask yourself, “Whatever can I say?”

Translate in a way that is most natural in your language.

13:11c

Instead, speak whatever you are given at that time,

- Say^(plur) whatever God tells you when that time comes,
- At the right/appointed time, just say^(plur) what God puts into your mind/heart.

Instead, speak whatever you are given: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Instead, speak whatever you are given is literally “but whatever is given you, say^(plur) that.” In this clause Jesus told his disciples what they should do instead of worrying, which he told them not to do in 13:11b. Use a natural way to express this in your language.

In Greek, the clause begins with the word “but.” In the BSB it begins with the word “Instead.” It is also possible to start the sentence with no conjunction. For example, the NCV says:

Say whatever is given you to say

whatever you are given: The phrase whatever you are given you is a passive phrase that means “what God gives you.” If you need to use an active verb, you could say:

what God tells you (NLT)

what God puts into your^(plur) mind/heart

at that time:

Here is another way to translate this:

when the time comes (NJB)

when that time comes

13:11d

for it will not be you speaking,

- for the words that you^(plur) will speak will not be your own words,
- I say that because you will not be speaking your own thoughts.
- Do^(plur) that, because the words that you will speak will not come from you.

13:11e

but the Holy Spirit.

- but the Holy Spirit's words.
- No! You will speak what the Holy Spirit enables you to speak.
- They will come from the Holy Spirit.

13:11d-e

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces the reason for what Jesus commanded in 13:11c.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

because (NJB)

I say this because

In some languages, it may not be necessary to translate this word. It may be left implicit.

it will not be you speaking, but the Holy Spirit: The words but the Holy Spirit is not a complete clause. The complete sentence would be:

...it will not be you speaking, but the Holy Spirit who will be speaking.

This sentence does not imply that the disciples would be silent. It implies that they would speak whatever the Holy Spirit guided them to speak.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

...the words you speak will not be yours; they will come from the Holy Spirit. (GNT)

You will not be speaking your own thoughts. No! You will speak thoughts that the Holy Spirit gives you.

In some languages, it may be more natural to place the positive statement before the negative statement. For example:

...you will be speaking words that the Holy Spirit will give you. The words will not come from you.

Holy Spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Holy Spirit refers to the Spirit of God. The Holy Spirit is God, together with God the Father and God the Son. The Holy Spirit is Spirit in the sense that he is a living being who does not have a physical body. He is Holy in the sense that he is God and unique from every other being. He is perfect in every way and is completely pure and sinless.

Here are some other ways to translate Holy Spirit:

Spirit/Breath of/from God

Holy/Sacred Spirit

Do not imply that the Holy Spirit is like the ghost of a dead person or that God has died.

The term Holy Spirit also occurs in 1:8b, 3:29a, and 12:36a. See how you translated this term there.

Mark 13:12

Section 13:9-13: Jesus warned his disciples that people would persecute them

In 13:9-13 Jesus warned his disciples that people would persecute them because they were his followers. They would suffer persecution from their fellow Jews (13:9a-c) and from other people (13:9d-e). He told them to always be prepared for opposition or persecution.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples must remain firm in their faith

The disciples must follow Christ even if others cause them to suffer for it

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:9–14 and Luke 21:12–19.

Paragraph 13:12–13

In this paragraph Jesus gave another example of something that would happen at the future time he was talking about. In 13:9 and 13:11, Jesus said that his disciples/followers would be betrayed by people outside their own families. Here in 13:12, he warned that the situation would become even worse: his followers would be betrayed by family members too.

In Greek 13:12 is introduced by the common conjunction that is often translated as “and.” In some languages it may be necessary to indicate more specifically how this paragraph is related to the context. For example:

Be watchful also because

At that time

13:12a

Brother will betray brother to death,

- ¶ “At that time some people will be betrayed by their own brothers to the authorities to be killed.
- ¶ “Be watchful also because people will cause the authorities to arrest their own siblings who believe in me. Then the authorities will kill them.

Brother will betray brother: In this context the word brother is used in a literal way. It does not refer here to a fellow Christian. The clause Brother will betray brother indicates that the brother who does not believe in Jesus will betray his brother who does believe in Jesus.

This is a general statement, which includes both brothers and sisters. Your language may have a word like “sibling” which includes male and female. There may also be different words for older and younger siblings. In some languages it may be necessary to express this phrase in the plural. For example:

People will betray their brothers and sisters because they follow me

Older siblings will betray their younger siblings who believe in me, and younger siblings will betray their older siblings who believe in me

It may not be necessary to add the clause “and younger brothers will betray their older siblings.” That meaning can be understood from the first part of the sentence.

betray: The Greek word that the BSB translates as betray means “to hand over to the authorities.” The same Greek word occurs in 13:9b (here the BSB translates it as “will be delivered over”) and in 13:11a (here the BSB translates it as “hand you over”). This means that people would cause the authorities to arrest their brothers and sisters who were disciples of Jesus. These same people would also speak against their brothers and sisters in court. As a result, the believing brothers and sisters would be put to death.

to death: The context implies that the killing would be a legal act, an execution.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

and they will cause the authorities to kill them

so that the authorities will kill them

If your language uses passive verbs, you could say:

and they will have them killed/executed

13:12b

and a father his child.

- A father will betray his child and cause him to be killed/executed.
- Parents will do the same to their children.

The Greek sentence continues from 13:12a, but in some languages, it may be good to begin a new sentence here.

and a father his child: The words and a father his child imply words from the previous clause:

and a father will betray his child to death.

This statement indicates that the unbelieving father will betray the believing child. Again, it is a general statement that includes fathers and mothers (see 13:12c, where the word “parents” occurs). In some languages it may be more natural to express this phrase in the plural. For example:

and fathers and mothers will betray their children and cause others to kill them

and parents will hand over their children, so that others will kill them

In some languages, it may be possible simply to say:

and fathers/parents will do the same to their children

13:12c

Children will rise against their parents

- Children will oppose their father and mother
- Children will turn against their mothers and fathers

Children will rise against their parents: The phrase rise against indicates that the children act in a hostile way toward their parents. It can also be translated as “rebel,” “oppose,” “combat,” or “turn against.”

parents: The Greek word that the BSB translates as parents is literally “begetters.” It refers to a person’s mother and father, specifically to the woman who bore the child and the man who fathered the child.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

their father and mother

their mothers and fathers

Use the expression that is most natural in your language.

13:12d

and have them put to death.

- and cause them to be killed.
- and cause other people to kill/execute them.

and have them put to death: The phrase and have them put to death means “and cause them to be killed/executed.”

Here is another way to translate this:

and cause other people to kill/execute them

Mark 13:13

Section 13:9–13: Jesus warned his disciples that people would persecute them

In 13:9–13 Jesus warned his disciples that people would persecute them because they were his followers. They would suffer persecution from their fellow Jews (13:9a–c) and from other people (13:9d–e). He told them to always be prepared for opposition or persecution.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples must remain firm in their faith

The disciples must follow Christ even if others cause them to suffer for it

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:9–14 and Luke 21:12–19.

Paragraph 13:12–13

In this paragraph Jesus gave another example of something that would happen at the future time he was talking about. In 13:9 and 13:11, Jesus said that his disciples/followers would be betrayed by people outside their own families. Here in 13:12, he warned that the situation would become even worse: his followers would be betrayed by family members too.

In Greek 13:12 is introduced by the common conjunction that is often translated as “and.” In some languages it may be necessary to indicate more specifically how this paragraph is related to the context. For example:

Be watchful also because

At that time

13:13a

You will be hated by everyone because of My name,

- Everyone will hate you^(plur) because you follow me,
- And people everywhere will hate you^(plur) because you are faithful to me.

You will be hated by everyone: This phrase uses a passive verb. Use an active or a passive verb, whichever is more natural in your language.

everyone: The phrase everyone means “all people.” Here Jesus used hyperbole (deliberate exaggeration) for emphasis. He did not literally mean every person in every place.

If this hyperbole will not be correctly understood in your language, here are some other ways to translate this:

Many people

People everywhere

because of My name: This phrase is very similar to the phrase in 13:9d.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

because you follow me (NCV)

for your allegiance to me (REB)

13:13b

but the one who perseveres to the end will be saved.

- but if you^(plur) continue to follow me to the end of your life, you will be saved.
- But God will deliver from his judgment those of you^(plur) who remain faithful to me until your life is finished.”

but the one who perseveres: The phrase that the BSB translates as the one who perseveres here refers to anyone who remains faithful to Jesus. It does not refer to a specific person so in some languages it is natural to use another general form like “you,” “whoever,” or “people who.” For example:

But if you keep on being faithful (CEV)

but those people who keep their faith (NCV)

but whoever endures (REB)

perseveres: The verb that the BSB translates as perseveres indicates that a person continues to be loyal to Jesus even though people hate him and cause him to suffer. In some languages it may be necessary to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

continues to be faithful to me

to the end: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to the end probably means “to the end of his life.” All English versions have the literal “to the end.” There are three ways to interpret this phrase: (1) to the end of one’s life; (2) completely, as long as it takes; (3) to the end of the suffering. Since the first and second interpretations largely overlap, the notes have given only the first interpretation.

will be saved: The verb will be saved is passive. In some languages it may be more natural to use an active expression. For example:

God will save you^(plur)

be saved: The Greek word that the BSB translates as be saved means “to be rescued or preserved from harm.” In this context it refers to being rescued from God’s judgment and allowed to enter heaven.

In some languages, it may be necessary to make explicit what people are saved from. For example:

rescued from God’s judgment

saved from judgment and allowed to enter heaven

Do not indicate here that people would be saved from physical death. In 13:12 Jesus indicated that some disciples would indeed die because of persecution.

The expression be saved also occurs in 10:26b.

General Comment on 13:13a–b

The BSB uses the pronoun “you” in 13:13a and “the one” in 13:13b. These pronouns refer to the same group of people. In some languages it may be natural to use the same pronoun in both verse parts, as the CEV has done:

Everyone will hate you because of me. But if you keep on being faithful right to the end, you will be saved.

Mark 13:14

Section 13:14–23: Jesus told what will happen when the horrible thing defiles God’s temple

In this section Jesus told about a horrible thing that would defile God’s temple. Then God and his people would no longer meet there, and it would be left desolate (13:14). Jesus told his disciples that when they saw that defiling horror, they must flee. It would be a time of great misery for them. Some people would falsely claim to be a prophet or Christ himself. Jesus warned that his disciples must be careful not to believe people who made those claims.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warned his disciples about the future distress

The coming time of great trouble

The detestable thing that causes people to abandon the temple

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:15–28 and Luke 21:20–24.

Paragraph 13:14–20

The speech that Jesus began in 13:5 continues in this paragraph. In some languages it may be helpful to remind the listeners or readers from time to time who is speaking. For example:

Jesus continued to say to his disciples

13:14a–b

In Greek 13:14a–b is a clause that introduces the rest of the sentence. However, it contains a lot of new information. In some languages it may be clearer and more natural to translate this as one or more separate sentences. Consider how to introduce the information in a natural way in your language. For example:

^{14a}Some day you will see the abomination ^{14b}that causes desolation standing where it does not belong.

^{14a}One day there will appear/come the abomination ^{14b}that causes desolation. It will be standing where it should not be.

See the General Comment on 13:14a–d at the end of 13:14d for more translation suggestions.

13:14a

So when you see the abomination of desolation

- ¶ “One day you^(plur) will see the detestable thing/person that causes the temple to be abandoned.
- ¶ Jesus continued to say to his disciples, “You^(plur) will see the offensive/horrible thing that defiles the temple and causes people to desert it.

This verse quotes words from a prophecy in the book of Daniel. The prophecy occurs in Daniel 9:27, 11:31, 12:11. You could put a footnote with these references in your translation.

the abomination of desolation: The phrase the abomination of desolation is a quotation from the book of Daniel. In Daniel these words occur in several verses.

The verses indicate that an idol would be placed in the temple of the true God in Jerusalem. This would defile the temple and cause it to be abandoned. Daniel’s prophecy came true in 167 B.C. when a ruler defiled the temple with an idol.

Jesus indicated here that an event like the event in Daniel’s prophecy would happen again. There are two events that the abomination of desolation may refer to here:

1. It may refer to the time when the Roman army defiled the temple in A.D. 70. Soon after that, the temple was destroyed.
2. It may refer to the time when the antichrist will come to the temple. This has not yet happened. See 2 Thessalonians 2:3–10.

It is probable that Jesus’ prophecy refers to both events. The prophecy was fulfilled in A.D. 70, and it will again be fulfilled in the future.

In your translation, use an expression that readers could understand as referring to both events. If you must choose between the two options, it is recommended that you choose option (a).

abomination: The word abomination refers to something that is hated intensely because it is disgusting and detestable. In this context it is also hated because it defiles a sacred place.

of desolation: The phrase of desolation indicates that the abominable thing or person causes a certain place to be left desolate. It causes people to abandon the place and stay away from it.

The text in Mark does not state that this place is the temple. However, this is clear from the parallel passage in Matthew and from the book of Daniel, which many of Mark’s readers knew.

In some languages it may be necessary to specify what is desolated. For example:

that causes the temple to become deserted/abandoned

that spoils/defiles the temple, so that people have to abandon it

If you do not make “the temple” explicit in your translation, you may want to include a footnote to explain this. For example:

The place that would become desolate is the temple in Jerusalem.

13:14b**standing where it should not be**

- It/He will be standing in the place where it/he has no right to be.”
- It will be erected in a place where it ought not to be.”

standing: In some languages a verb like standing may not be used about an idol or statue. It may be used only for a person. Try to use a word that could also refer to an idol or statue or other religious symbol. For example:

erect/upright

where it should not be: This phrase probably refers to the holy place in the temple (as in Matthew 24:15). Mark does not give these details. If you wish to make a footnote here you could say:

The phrase “where it does not belong” probably refers to the Holy Place in the temple. See Matthew 24:15.

13:14c**(let the reader understand),**

- Note to the reader: understand^(sing) what this means!
- (Everyone who reads this must consider it so that he will understand what it means!)

(let the reader understand): The clause let the reader understand is a command. This command interrupts the thought that begins in 13:14a–b and finishes in 13:14e.

reader: The word reader may be understood in two ways:

1. Mark is making a comment to any person who reads his Gospel. For example, the GNT says:

(Note to the reader: understand what this means!) (GNT, NCV, NLT) These versions indicate that they follow interpretation (1) by the way they use quotation marks. For example, the GNT puts closing quotation marks at the end of the phrase “where he should not be.” The note in parentheses have no quotation marks. After this note, the next sentence begins with quotation marks, showing that Mark is beginning again to quote Jesus’ words.

1. Jesus is making a comment to any person who reads the book of Daniel.

Many English versions are ambiguous. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Most commentaries follow this view. Mark wanted his readers to understand the new and terrible meaning now given to the words “the abomination of desolation.”

Here are two ways to translate this phrase:

(Note to the reader: understand what this means!) (GNT)

Everyone who reads this must try to understand! (CEV)

Consider whether you have a special way in your language for an author to make a comment like this to readers. Notice that this phrase let the reader understand is also found in Matthew 24:15. See the General Comment on 13:14a–d for a suggestion about reordering.

13:14d**then let those who are in Judea flee to the mountains.**

- “When that time comes, those who are in the region of Judea must run away to the mountains.
- “When you^(plur) see that abominable thing, then those of you my disciples living in the towns of Judea at that time must escape to the mountains.

then: The word then indicates that the thought in 13:14a–b resumes after the interruption of 13:14c. In some languages it may be good to repeat information from 13:14a. For example:

When you^(plur) see this abomination, then...

let those who are in Judea flee to the mountains:

The clause let those who are in Judea flee to the mountains is a command. Jesus was saying that his followers who lived in the region of Judea must/should flee. They should leave the towns of that region and seek safety in more remote places in the mountains.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

those who are in Judea must flee/escape to the mountains

those of you who are living in the towns of Judea must run away to hide in the mountains

General Comment on 13:14a–d

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of some of the parts of this verse. For example:

^{14c}Let the reader understand what I am about to write: ^{14a}One day you will see the abomination ^{14b}standing in the temple where it should not be ^{14a}so that it causes the temple to be abandoned. ^{14d}Then those in Judea must flee to the mountains.

Mark 13:15

Section 13:14–23: Jesus told what will happen when the horrible thing defiles God's temple

In this section Jesus told about a horrible thing that would defile God's temple. Then God and his people would no longer meet there, and it would be left desolate (13:14). Jesus told his disciples that when they saw that defiling horror, they must flee. It would be a time of great misery for them. Some people would falsely claim to be a prophet or Christ himself. Jesus warned that his disciples must be careful not to believe people who made those claims.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warned his disciples about the future distress

The coming time of great trouble

The detestable thing that causes people to abandon the temple

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:15–28 and Luke 21:20–24.

Paragraph 13:14–20

The speech that Jesus began in 13:5 continues in this paragraph. In some languages it may be helpful to remind the listeners or readers from time to time who is speaking. For example:

Jesus continued to say to his disciples

13:15–16

The commands in 13:15–16 mean that a person should not delay at all. He should not take the time to enter his house to pick up his belongings. He must escape

to the mountains at once. To show that the commands apply to the moments before running away, it may be helpful to begin 13:15 in this way:

There must be no delay.

Do ^(plur) not dawdle.

13:15a

Let no one on the housetop

- The person who is on the flat roof of his house
- If anyone is on his roof/housetop,
- If you ^(plur) are sitting on the upstairs verandah/porch of your house,

Let no one on the housetop: In some languages it may be more natural to translate this in a positive way, as the REB has done:

If anyone is on the roof of his house, [he must not....]

If you have used a plural form in 13:14d, it may be more natural to continue to use plural forms here. For example:

If you ^(plur) are on the roof of your house, [you must not....]

on the housetop: Jewish houses had flat roofs. People often would sit on their roof in the cool evening and talk with neighbors who also were on their roofs. There were steps outside the house, leading to the flat roof.

It may be helpful to put a picture or a footnote here in your translation to show that Jewish houses had flat roofs.

Here are some other ways to express this:

on the flat roof of his house

on his flat housetop

on the upstairs porch/verandah of your ^(plur) house

13:15b

go back inside to retrieve anything from his house.

- must not go down into the house to collect anything.
- he should not enter the house to pick up his belongings before fleeing.

- you^(plur) must just flee, and not waste time going into your house to fetch your belongings.

go back inside: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as go back inside here means “go down into the house.” The man would have to go down from the roof by means of the outside stairway in order to flee. Jesus warned him not to waste time by going inside the house.

to retrieve anything from his house: A person might want to take his valuable possessions out of the house. Jesus emphasized that he must not delay in order to pick up his belongings. He must escape immediately.

General Comment on 13:15a–b

In some languages the command in this part of the verse may be difficult to understand because of the implied information about rooftops and outside stairways. It may also be awkward to make this implied information explicit in the text. If that is true in your language, you may want to use a more general statement. For example:

The person who is outside his house must not delay by entering the house to get his belongings.

If you use this option, you may want to add the literal translation in a footnote, along with an explanation about rooftops.

General Comment on 13:15a–b

In 13:15a–b Jesus told the disciples what they should not do. In some languages it may be necessary to add what they should do. For example:

you must just flee

Mark 13:16

Section 13:14–23: Jesus told what will happen when the horrible thing defiles God’s temple

In this section Jesus told about a horrible thing that would defile God’s temple. Then God and his people would no longer meet there, and it would be left desolate (13:14). Jesus told his disciples that when they saw that defiling horror, they must flee. It would be a time of great misery for them. Some people would falsely claim to be a prophet or Christ himself. Jesus warned that his disciples must be careful not to believe people who made those claims.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warned his disciples about the future distress

The coming time of great trouble

The detestable thing that causes people to abandon the temple

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:15–28 and Luke 21:20–24.

Paragraph 13:14–20

The speech that Jesus began in 13:5 continues in this paragraph. In some languages it may be helpful to remind the listeners or readers from time to time who is speaking. For example:

Jesus continued to say to his disciples

13:16

And let no one in the field return for his cloak.

- The person who is out in the fields must not go back home to get his cloak.
- Those who are working in the fields must not go back to the house to fetch their coats.
- If you^(plur) are in the fields, do not go back home to collect your jackets.

And let no one in the field return: This clause is a command.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

No one in the field should go back.

If you^(plur) are in the field, do not go back.

in the field: The phrase in the field implies “working in the field.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

No one who is working in the field

If you^(plur) are working in the field

field: The word that the BSB translates as field refers to cultivated land or land where animals could graze.

return: The verb return implies “go back home” or “return to his house.”

for his cloak: The Greek word that the BSB translates as cloak was an outer garment like a coat. People wore cloaks, especially at night, to keep warm.

Mark 13:17

Section 13:14–23: Jesus told what will happen when the horrible thing defiles God’s temple

In this section Jesus told about a horrible thing that would defile God’s temple. Then God and his people would no longer meet there, and it would be left desolate (13:14). Jesus told his disciples that when they saw that defiling horror, they must flee. It would be a time of great misery for them. Some people would falsely claim to be a prophet or Christ himself. Jesus warned that his disciples must be careful not to believe people who made those claims.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warned his disciples about the future distress

The coming time of great trouble

The detestable thing that causes people to abandon the temple

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:15–28 and Luke 21:20–24.

Paragraph 13:14–20

The speech that Jesus began in 13:5 continues in this paragraph. In some languages it may be helpful to remind the listeners or readers from time to time who is speaking. For example:

Jesus continued to say to his disciples

13:17

How miserable those days will be for pregnant and nursing mothers!

- How difficult it will be for women who are pregnant and for those who are breast-feeding babies at that time!

- What a terrible time it will be for women who are pregnant and for those who are breast-feeding babies! It will be very difficult for them to flee.
- In those days, pity the women who are expecting babies or who are nursing infants, because they will have great difficulty in running away!

How miserable those days will be for pregnant and nursing mothers!:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as How miserable is an exclamation that expresses pity. Jesus expressed compassion for the suffering that many women would experience. It would be a bad time for them, because it would be very difficult for them to run and escape.

Here are some other ways to translate How miserable:

How terrible (GNT)

How horrible (GW)

It will be an awful time (CEV)

those days: The phrase those days refers to the time when the abomination of desolation would stand where it should not, in the temple.

Here is another way to translate this:

at that time

pregnant and nursing mothers: In some cultures, it may be natural to use euphemisms for the phrases pregnant women and nursing mothers. It is important to use expressions that are acceptable and appropriate for someone to say or read in public.

pregnant: Another way to say pregnant women is:

women who are expecting babies (CEV)

nursing mothers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as nursing mothers refers to mothers who are breast-feeding their young children.

Mark 13:18

Section 13:14–23: Jesus told what will happen when the horrible thing defiles God’s temple

In this section Jesus told about a horrible thing that would defile God’s temple. Then God and his people would no longer meet there, and it would be left desolate (13:14). Jesus told his disciples that when they saw that defiling horror, they must flee. It would be a time

of great misery for them. Some people would falsely claim to be a prophet or Christ himself. Jesus warned that his disciples must be careful not to believe people who made those claims.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warned his disciples about the future distress

The coming time of great trouble

The detestable thing that causes people to abandon the temple

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:15–28 and Luke 21:20–24.

Paragraph 13:14–20

The speech that Jesus began in 13:5 continues in this paragraph. In some languages it may be helpful to remind the listeners or readers from time to time who is speaking. For example:

Jesus continued to say to his disciples

13:18–19a

In some languages, it may be more natural to place the command to pray (13:18) as a conclusion after 13:19a. See the General Comment on 13:18–19a at the end of 13:19a.

13:18

Pray that this will not occur in the winter.

- Pray^(plur) to God that this will not take place in the cold/rainy season.
- You^(plur) must ask/request God earnestly that this event will not happen in the season of bad weather, when it is difficult to flee/travel.

Pray: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Pray means “speak to God.” Some languages use different words to refer to specific kinds of prayer, such as requests, thanks, or praise. If your language has different words for pray, here you should use the word that means “request.” For example:

Ask/Beg God

Request from/of God

Avoid a term that may imply magical or meaningless words.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as Pray implies a repeated action. You could say:

You^(plur) must pray earnestly

Continue ^(plur) to ask/beg God

this: The word this refers either to the time of fleeing (13:14d) or to the time of suffering caused by the abominable person (13:14a–b). If you need to make the word this more explicit, you can say:

this event

this suffering

will not occur in the winter: The Greek word that the BSB translates as winter refers to the season of bad weather. It is the season when the rains and cold would make it difficult to flee and find food and shelter.

Here is another way to translate this:

in the rainy/cold/bad season

If readers cannot easily understand why Jesus said “not...in winter,” you could make the reason explicit:

when it is difficult to travel

Mark 13:19

Section 13:14–23: Jesus told what will happen when the horrible thing defiles God’s temple

In this section Jesus told about a horrible thing that would defile God’s temple. Then God and his people would no longer meet there, and it would be left desolate (13:14). Jesus told his disciples that when they saw that defiling horror, they must flee. It would be a time of great misery for them. Some people would falsely claim to be a prophet or Christ himself. Jesus warned that his disciples must be careful not to believe people who made those claims.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warned his disciples about the future distress

The coming time of great trouble

The detestable thing that causes people to abandon the temple

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:15–28 and Luke 21:20–24.

Paragraph 13:14–20

The speech that Jesus began in 13:5 continues in this paragraph. In some languages it may be helpful to remind the listeners or readers from time to time who is speaking. For example:

Jesus continued to say to his disciples

13:19a

For those will be days of tribulation

- I say that, because in those days people will suffer very severely/much
- For there will be many troubles at that time.

For:

It may be more natural to say:

I say that because...

In some languages, it will be more natural to put the basis for praying before the command to pray in 13:18. See the General Comment below for an example.

those will be days of tribulation: The phrase those will be days of tribulation refers to days of much trouble or a time of severe distress or suffering.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

because those will be days of distress (NIV)

because in those days people will suffer severely

because at that time there will be very much/
many troubles

General Comment on 13:18–19a

In some languages it may be more natural to place the command “Pray...” (13:18) after the basis given in 13:19a. For example:

^{19a}In those days people will suffer very severely.

¹⁸So pray^(plur) that this painful time will not happen in winter.

^{19a}There will be many troubles at that time. ¹⁸That is the reason why you^(plur) should pray that this painful time will not happen in winter.

13:19b

unmatched from the beginning of God’s creation until now,

- more than people have suffered since the beginning when God created the world,
- They will be far worse than the sufferings that people have seen/known ever since the time that God created the world.

unmatched: The word unmatched means “unlike” or “not the same as.” In this context it implies that the sufferings to which Jesus referred would be worse than any previous sufferings that people had ever experienced. For example, the GNT says:

The trouble of those days will be far worse.

from the beginning of God’s creation: The phrase the beginning refers to the time when God created the world. Refer to your translation of Genesis 1:1.

until now: The word now refers to the time at which Jesus was speaking.

13:19c

and never to be seen again.

- and more than people will ever suffer again.
- Also they will be far worse than any sufferings that people will experience/undergo in the future.

and never to be seen again: This clause began in 13:19a, so in its complete form it would be “and those days of distress will never be seen again.” Some English versions begin a new sentence here.

never...again: The expression never...again refers to the future time after the time of suffering that Jesus was talking about.

Here is another way to translate this:

and people will never again suffer in the same degree/measure

Mark 13:20

Section 13:14–23: Jesus told what will happen when the horrible thing defiles God's temple

In this section Jesus told about a horrible thing that would defile God's temple. Then God and his people would no longer meet there, and it would be left desolate (13:14). Jesus told his disciples that when they saw that defiling horror, they must flee. It would be a time of great misery for them. Some people would falsely claim to be a prophet or Christ himself. Jesus warned that his disciples must be careful not to believe people who made those claims.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warned his disciples about the future distress

The coming time of great trouble

The detestable thing that causes people to abandon the temple

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:15–28 and Luke 21:20–24.

Paragraph 13:14–20

The speech that Jesus began in 13:5 continues in this paragraph. In some languages it may be helpful to remind the listeners or readers from time to time who is speaking. For example:

Jesus continued to say to his disciples

13:20a–b

If the Lord had not cut short those days, nobody would be saved: In 13:20a–b, Jesus spoke as though the Lord had already cut short the days. It was common in Old Testament prophecy to refer to future events as if they had already happened. That implied that the events were sure to happen, because God had already decided that they would happen. See the NCV example below.

In the Greek text the sentence begins with the word *If* and the expression is negative: *had not cut short*. Many English versions translate it with a negative expression. It is also possible to express this sentence in a positive way, as in the NCV:

God has decided to make that terrible time short. Otherwise, no one would go on living.

The NCV has supplied the verb “has decided,” which is implied in the Greek statement.

13:20a

If the Lord had not cut short those days,

- If the Lord had not lessened the number of those days,
- If the Lord had not decided to reduce that time of suffering,
- God has decided to make that time of trouble end quickly.

If the Lord: The expression the Lord refers here to “God,” as in the NCV. See the two terms you used to translate “the Lord” in 12:36b. One term referred to Jesus and the other term referred to God. Use the same term for the Lord (God) here in 13:20a that you used in 12:36b. See *Lord*, Context 2, in the Glossary.

had not cut short those days: The expression *cut short those days* is an idiom. It refers to reducing the time of suffering. Jesus was not talking about shortening the length of each day.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

make that time of suffering end sooner

make that terrible time shorter

reduce that time (GW)

13:20b

nobody would be saved.

- no one would continue to live.
- not a single person would survive.
- Otherwise, everyone would die.

nobody would be saved: In the context of 13:14–20, the Greek word that the BSB translates as *be saved* refers to being saved from physical distress/sufferings. Many English versions translate this with a word or phrase that means “survive.” It is recommended that you use a similar word.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

continue to live

not die

13:20c

But for the sake of the elect, whom He has chosen, He has cut them short.

- But because of his own/selected people, those whom he has chosen, he will shorten the time.
- He will lessen the number of those days in order to help the people whom he has chosen.

But for the sake of the elect, whom He has chosen:

The phrase for the sake of the elect means “because of the elect.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

But because of the elect, whom he chose (NET)

But...to help the people he has chosen. (NCV)

the elect, whom He has chosen: The phrases the elect and whom He has chosen have the same meaning.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Use two expressions with the same meaning. For example:

the selected people, the ones whom he has chosen

his chosen people, those whom he has selected

- Use only one expression with this meaning. For example:

his chosen people (GNT)

those whom he has chosen (GW)

the elect: The expression the elect refers to the people whom God has chosen. Mark was referring here to Christians, that is, to people who trust in Jesus. However, he did not say that explicitly. He used the phrase the elect as a title to refer to them.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the elected/chosen people

the selected people

the people whom God elected/chose

In this context the text does not specify the purpose for which the people were chosen. In some languages a verb like “chose” or “elect” requires a purpose. If that is true in your language, you may need to supply a general purpose. For example:

the people whom God chose to be his own

He has cut them short: The clause He has cut them short means “The Lord has shortened those days.” This means that the Lord has decided to make the length of time that his people will suffer shorter. This is the positive way to say, “If he had not cut short those days” in 13:20a.

Mark 13:21

Section 13:14–23: Jesus told what will happen when the horrible thing defiles God’s temple

In this section Jesus told about a horrible thing that would defile God’s temple. Then God and his people would no longer meet there, and it would be left desolate (13:14). Jesus told his disciples that when they saw that defiling horror, they must flee. It would be a time of great misery for them. Some people would falsely claim to be a prophet or Christ himself. Jesus warned that his disciples must be careful not to believe people who made those claims.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warned his disciples about the future distress

The coming time of great trouble

The detestable thing that causes people to abandon the temple

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:15–28 and Luke 21:20–24.

13:21a

At that time

- ¶ “During that time,
- ¶ “In those days of distress/suffering,

At that time: The phrase At that time refers to the time of extreme suffering that Jesus has been talking about (13:19).

13:21b**if anyone says to you,**

- if someone says to you,^(plur)
- some people might say to you^(plur)

if anyone says to you: This clause is a condition, that is, something that might happen. Express this condition in a natural way in your language.

Here is another way to translate this:

someone might say to you (NCV)

13:21c**‘Look, here is the Christ!’ or ‘There He is!’**

- ‘Look, here is the Christ!’ or ‘Look, there he is!’
- that the Messiah has come to this place or that place.

In 13:21c, the Greek uses direct speech. In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech. See the General Comment on 13:21c below.

Look: The word Look is used to get the attention of the hearers. It indicates to the hearers that the information that follows is important. In some languages people may use a word like “Hey!” or “Say!” It is similar to the word “behold” in 1:2b–c. You may want to translate these two words the same way.

here is the Christ: The expression here is the Christ indicates that someone is pointing out a person as the Messiah.

the Christ: The phrase the Christ is used here as a title. In this verse it does not refer to Jesus. The people were pointing to someone else as the Christ. The Jews used the title Christ to refer to the special person whom God had appointed and promised to send as king and savior. The title Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word “Messiah,” and the two words have the same meaning.

Some ways to translate Christ are:

- Transliterate it according to the sounds of your language. For example:

Krais

Karisiti

- Transliterate it and indicate in some way that it is a title. For example:

the Christ

the Kirisita

- Transliterate Christ and include a phrase that explains the meaning. For example:

Christ, the appointed one

Cristo, the savior God promised

the Christ who comes from God

If you do not indicate the meaning of Christ in the text, you may want to include a footnote. For example:

The word/title “Christ” refers to the King and Savior whom God had promised to send.

See how you translated the Christ in 12:35c. See also Christ in the Glossary.

or: The word or is not in the Greek. In the Greek there is no joining word. The BSB has added this word because it is good English style. Another way to join the two exclamations in English is with “and.”

There He is!: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as There He is! is spoken by a different person from the person mentioned in 13:21b. One way to translate this is to introduce the phrase in the following way:

...or if someone else says, ‘Look, there he is!’

And others might say, ‘There he is!’

General Comment on 13:21c

In some languages, it may be more natural to use indirect speech here. For example:

If people say that the Messiah has come to this place or that place

13:21d**do not believe it.**

- do^(plur) not believe it/him.
- But you^(plur) must not believe what they say.

do not believe it: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as do not believe it is literally “do not believe,” without an object. In some languages, as in English, it

is necessary to specify what they should not believe. The BSB supplies the word *it*, but some other versions say “him” (NASB) or “them” (NCV). In some languages it may be natural to say:

do^(plur) not believe what they say

See also *believe*, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

General Comment on 13:21a–d

In some languages it may be more natural to place the verb phrase “do not believe” (13:21d) immediately after the phrase “At that time” (13:21a). For example, the GW says:

^{21a}At that time ^{21d}don’t believe ^{21b}anyone who tells you, ^{21c}‘Here is the Messiah!’ or ‘There he is!’

Mark 13:22

Section 13:14–23: Jesus told what will happen when the horrible thing defiles God’s temple

In this section Jesus told about a horrible thing that would defile God’s temple. Then God and his people would no longer meet there, and it would be left desolate (13:14). Jesus told his disciples that when they saw that defiling horror, they must flee. It would be a time of great misery for them. Some people would falsely claim to be a prophet or Christ himself. Jesus warned that his disciples must be careful not to believe people who made those claims.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warned his disciples about the future distress

The coming time of great trouble

The detestable thing that causes people to abandon the temple

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:15–28 and Luke 21:20–24.

13:22a

For false Christs and false prophets will appear

- For people will appear and falsely claim to be Messiahs or prophets.

- Because people who will falsely say that they are Messiahs and prophets will come to various places and at various times.

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *For* introduces the basis for the command in 13:21d. In some languages it may be more natural to arrange the information in 13:21–22 in a different order. See the General Comment on 13:21–22 at the end of 13:22d.

false Christs and false prophets will appear: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *false Christs* refers to people who say that they are the Messiah but are not. The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *false prophets* refers to people who say that they are God’s prophets but are not.

false prophets: The term *false prophets* refers to people who claimed to speak messages from God but did not really receive their messages from God. They were not true prophets.

Some languages may not have a word for *false* or “*untrue*” that can naturally be used with “*prophet*.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

those who are not true prophets

lying prophets

people who claim/pretend to be God’s prophets
(but really are not)

See how you translated “*prophet*” in 1:2a. Also see *prophet* in the Glossary.

will appear: The phrase *will appear* means that these people will begin to speak in public. They will not suddenly become visible by doing some miracle or magic. Different individuals will appear at various times and in various places. The CEV says this another way:

will come

13:22b

and perform signs and wonders

- They will perform/work signs and miracles,
- They will do many kinds of miracles,
- They will show signs and do amazing deeds,

and perform signs and wonders: The Greek words that the BSB translates as *signs and wonders* both refer to actions that require great power to accomplish. The text does not mention how these false Christs

and false prophets would be able to do such powerful actions. They may have used power from evil spirits or from Satan.

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase perform signs and wonders:

- As two words/phrases. For example:

show signs and do amazing deeds

- As one word/phrase. For example:

do/work many kinds of miracles

signs: The word signs refers to miracles that have a meaning. The word “sign” also occurs in 8:11b and 8:12d. See how you translated it there.

wonders: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as wonders refers to an amazing action or event that indicates something.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

amazing deeds/signs

portents

13:22c

that would deceive even the elect,

- in order to deceive the people whom God has chosen/elected,
- in order to try to lead astray God’s chosen people,
- in order to try to cause you^(plur) people whom God has chosen, to go astray,

that would deceive: The Greek word that the BSB translates as that would deceive means “to lead astray” or “to cause to believe lies.” This word also occurs in 13:5 and 13:6c. See how you translated it there.

the elect: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the elect refers to the people whom God has elected or chosen. This word also occurs in 13:20c. See how you translated it there.

In some languages, it may be natural to use a word like “those” or “the previously mentioned” to refer back to a group of people. Consider whether that is the right thing to do here. For example:

deceive those people that God has chosen

deceive the previously mentioned people that God has chosen

13:22d

if that were possible.

- if that is possible.

In Greek the phrase in 13:22d occurs in the middle of 13:22c, as in the RSV. The NIV introduces this phrase with a dash, while the BSB and GNT use a comma. You may use the order and punctuation that is natural in your language.

if that were possible: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as if that were possible implies that something will not be possible. It will not be possible for these false Christs and false prophets to deceive God’s chosen people.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

if that is possible

if they can do so

General Comment on 13:21–22

Another way to arrange 13:21–22 is to place the conclusion “So...do not believe him” nearer the end. For example:

^{21a}At that time ^{22a}false Christs and false prophets will appear ^{22b}and perform signs and miracles ^{22c}to deceive the elect, if they can. ^{21b}So, if anyone says to you, ^{21c}Look, here is the Messiah!’ or if anyone says ‘Look, there he is!’ ^{21d}do not believe him.

Mark 13:23

Section 13:14–23: Jesus told what will happen when the horrible thing defiles God’s temple

In this section Jesus told about a horrible thing that would defile God’s temple. Then God and his people would no longer meet there, and it would be left desolate (13:14). Jesus told his disciples that when they saw that defiling horror, they must flee. It would be a time of great misery for them. Some people would falsely claim to be a prophet or Christ himself. Jesus warned that his disciples must be careful not to believe people who made those claims.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warned his disciples about the future distress

The coming time of great trouble

The detestable thing that causes people to abandon the temple

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:15–28 and Luke 21:20–24.

13:23a

So be on your guard;

- So you^(plur) must be on your guard.
- So/Therefore as for you,^(plur) watch^(plur) out for what will happen.

So: This verse concludes Jesus' statement in 13:21–22. The BSB introduces it with the word So. Use a natural way in your language to connect this conclusion to the context.

be on your guard: In the Greek, this sentence begins with an emphatic form of the word “you,^(plur)” which the BSB and the other versions do not translate. Here is the meaning:

as for you, ^(plur) be on your guard

The Greek word that the BSB translates as be on your guard means “be/remain watching.” This word also occurs in 13:5, 13:9a, and 13:33a. See how you translated it in 13:9a. Jesus was telling his disciples to be aware of future hardships and dangers. In some languages you may need to specify what to guard yourselves from. For example:

be^(plur) on your guard about what will happen

13:23b

I have told you everything in advance.

- I have warned you^(plur) about all these events before they happen.
- I have just now warned you^(plur) about all these events before they happen.

I have told you everything in advance: The Greek word that the BSB translates as told...in advance means “warned” or “forewarned.” For example, the NCV says:

I have warned you about all this before it happens.

Some readers may wrongly think that Jesus was reminding the disciples of an earlier time when he warned them. However, he was referring to the warnings that he has just given. Try to make this clear in your language. For example:

I have just now told you everything ahead of time.

With these words I am telling you everything ahead of time.

General Comment on 13:23a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to place the conclusion of 13:23a after 13:23b. For example:

^{23b}I have told you about all these events before they happen. ^{23a}So you, my disciples, must be on your guard.

Mark 13:24

Section 13:24–27: Jesus told his disciples about his return to earth

In the preceding section Jesus told about some terrible events that would happen. In 13:24–27 he told about other future events which would be even more terrible. Then he said that the Son of Man would come “in clouds with great power and glory.” This phrase is also found in Daniel 7:13, a passage that speaks of the Son of Man coming in glory. Jesus used the title “the Son of Man” here to refer to himself.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The coming of the Son of Man

The Son of Man will receive great glory

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:29–31 and Luke 21:25–28.

13:24a

But in those days, after that tribulation:

- ¶ “But in those days, after that time of distress/trouble,
- ¶ “And then, after the people have suffered greatly,
- ¶ “After that time of great suffering is finished,

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *But* indicates a contrast. It is not clear exactly what the contrast is. Here are two possibilities:

1. The contrast is between the distress of the people in Judea (in 13:19–22) and the powerful coming of the Son of man (in 13:24–26).
2. The contrast is between the false Christs (13:22) and the coming of the true Christ. (13:26)

It is good not to make the contrast too explicit in your translation.

in those days, after that tribulation: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *in those days, after that tribulation* refers back to the events that Jesus described in 13:14–22. This was the time when the abomination of desolation would appear and when the people of Judea would have to flee.

after that tribulation:

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

after that time of trouble (GNT)

after that time of suffering (CEV)

after the people have suffered

13:24b–25b

Some scholars think that 13:24b–25b refers to future events that will happen before Christ returns. Other scholars think these verses use figurative language to describe the terrible events that happened during the destruction of the temple and Jerusalem around A.D. 70.

In 13:24b–25b Jesus used words from several Old Testament verses, but he did not quote any of these verses exactly. There are different ways to indicate this in your translation:

- Indent these words and use poetry format for them. For example, the NRSV has:

the sun will be darkened,

and the moon will not give its light,

²⁵and the stars will be falling from heaven,

and the powers in the heavens will be shaken.

- Use a different font. For example, the NET uses italics and the NASB uses bold type.
- Use either single quotation marks (NCV) or double quotation marks (CEV).

Some English versions use a combination of these options. For example, the BSB uses quotation marks and also indents the words. Some versions do not use any of these options, but have a footnote to tell the verses that Jesus quoted from. The words in 13:25b are not found in any particular Old Testament passage. Therefore, the footnote should be placed at the end of the words in 13:25a.

Here is an example footnote:

See Isaiah 13:10 and 34:4, Joel 2:10, and Amos 8:9.

The sun will be darkened: The phrase *will be darkened* is a passive phrase. However, it does not necessarily imply a subject.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

The sun will become dark

The sun will no longer shine

The sun will stop shining

and the moon will not give its light: The phrase *will not give its light* has the same meaning as the phrase *will be darkened*. In some languages it may be more natural to combine the phrases about the sun and the moon. For example:

the sun and the moon will both stop shining

the sun will stop shining in the day; the moon will stop shining at night

13:24b

‘The sun will be darkened, and the moon will not give its light;

- ‘the sun will become dark, and the moon will not shine.
- ‘The sun will stop shining in the day; the moon will stop shining at night.

Mark 13:25

Section 13:24–27: Jesus told his disciples about his return to earth

In the preceding section Jesus told about some terrible events that would happen. In 13:24–27 he told about other future events which would be even more terrible. Then he said that the Son of Man would come “in clouds with great power and glory.” This phrase is also found in Daniel 7:13, a passage that speaks of the Son of Man coming in glory. Jesus used the title “the Son of Man” here to refer to himself.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The coming of the Son of Man

The Son of Man will receive great glory

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:29–31 and Luke 21:25–28.

13:25a

the stars will fall from the sky,

- The stars will fall out of the sky,
- The stars will fall,

the stars will fall from the sky: The clause the stars will fall from the sky indicates that the stars will fall out of their positions in the sky. It is not clear whether they will fall all the way to the earth.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

The stars will fall out of the sky

The stars will fall from their positions in the sky

In some languages it may be unnaturally redundant to say that stars fall from the sky. If that is true in your language, you may make the phrase from the sky implicit. For example:

The stars will fall

13:25b

and the powers of the heavens will be shaken.’

- and all these things that shine in the sky will be shaken.’

- and these heavenly lights will shift violently out of their positions.’

and the powers of the heavens: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as powers of the heavens is probably a poetic way to refer to the stars and other lights in the sky. It may also refer figuratively to spiritual forces that controlled the stars and other heavenly lights. These forces include Satan and his evil spirits. This interpretation is mentioned as a possibility by UBS (page 414), TRT (page 180), and others. Greek writers sometimes referred to these lights as the “armies” or “powers” of the heavens. Other scholars understand “powers in the heavens” to refer to the stars as the armies of heaven. Still others, including Edwards (page 402), speak of the other heavenly bodies as being included.

In most languages it will not be possible to find an expression that refers both to stars and to powerful beings in the sky. If that is true in your language, you may use an expression that refers to the stars or to all the lights in the sky. You may also want to add a footnote that gives the figurative meaning along with an explanation. For example:

Literally, the “powers” or “armies” in the sky. This phrase probably refers figuratively to the stars and other lights in the sky. It may also refer to evil spirits. Many people thought that evil spirits controlled the stars.

heavens: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as heavens means “in the sky.” This is the same Greek word as the word that the BSB translates as “sky” in 13:25a. It does not refer to heaven where God lives. For example, the CEV says:

in the sky

See also heaven, Meaning 1, in the Glossary.

will be shaken: The phrase will be shaken means “will be shaken violently/strongly,” so that they fall from their positions.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

will be driven from their courses (GNT)

The verb is passive. In some languages it may not be natural to use a passive verb here. If that is true in your language, here are some options to consider:

- Choose a verb that does not need to indicate an actor. For example:

will move/shift chaotically

- Use an impersonal expression. For example:

something will force [the heavenly bodies] from their normal places

- Supply God as the actor. This option should only be used if it is necessary. For example:

and God will violently shake all these things in the sky

Mark 13:26

Section 13:24–27: Jesus told his disciples about his return to earth

In the preceding section Jesus told about some terrible events that would happen. In 13:24–27 he told about other future events which would be even more terrible. Then he said that the Son of Man would come “in clouds with great power and glory.” This phrase is also found in Daniel 7:13, a passage that speaks of the Son of Man coming in glory. Jesus used the title “the Son of Man” here to refer to himself.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The coming of the Son of Man

The Son of Man will receive great glory

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:29–31 and Luke 21:25–28.

13:26a

At that time they will see the Son of Man

- ¶ “At that time people will see me the Son of Man
- ¶ “Then I, the Son of Man, will appear.

At that time: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as At that time is literally “And then,” as in the RSV. This phrase introduces a very important event in Jesus’ prophecy: the Son of Man will appear in power and glory. Introduce it in a natural way in your language.

they will see the Son of Man: The pronoun they refers to people in general, so you could say:

people will see the Son of Man

It is the Son of Man who is in focus, not the people. In some languages it may be natural to translate in a way that does not mention who will see him. For example:

the Son of Man will be seen (CEV)

the Son of Man will appear (GNT)

the Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is literally “the Son of the human/person.” Jesus used this title to imply that:

1. he was a true human being, and he represented all people.
2. he came from God and had authority from God.

Try to use an expression that implies both meanings.

Here are some other ways to translate this title:

the Man whom God Sent

the True Man from God/Heaven

the Representative of Mankind

The Older Brother of All People

In some cases, an unusual title may correctly suggest a deeper meaning. For example:

the Child of a Person

the One who was Born as a Human

Translators have also used expressions that are more literal. These more literal expressions may be appropriate where readers are familiar with a literal title in another version.

In some languages it may be necessary to use a form like “I” or “me” to indicate that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

me, the Son of Man

I who became man/human

See how you translated this term in 2:10a and 9:9c.

13:26b

coming in the clouds with great power and glory.

- coming in clouds toward the earth. They will see my great power and glory/godlikeness.
- I will be arriving surrounded by clouds. I will show my sovereign power and bright majesty.

coming in the clouds with great power and glory:

The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as coming in the clouds also occurs in Daniel 7:13 and in Mark 14:62. There is another statement about Jesus' coming in 8:38: "when he comes in his Father's glory with the holy angels."

In the Old Testament a cloud often symbolized God's presence, power, and glory. The verses in Daniel indicate that the clouds were near the throne of God, and Mark 14:62 indicates that Jesus comes on clouds of heaven. Some scholars believe that the clouds refer to God's presence in heaven. The phrase "coming in the clouds" then refers to the time when the Son of Man ascended to heaven after his work on earth was finished. Then he was enthroned with God. There is support for this view in the parallel passage in Daniel. However, most scholars believe that the passages in Mark refer to Jesus' coming back from heaven to earth.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

as he comes surrounded by clouds and with majestic power and glory

coming with clouds, showing his power and glory

coming: The word coming can also be translated as "arriving" or "approaching."

If you need to supply a destination for the verb coming, you may use "toward the earth" or "downward" or a similar expression. For example:

coming downward in clouds

coming toward the earth

in the clouds: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

surrounded by clouds

on the clouds (NLT)

with great power and glory: The word great describes both power and glory. The whole phrase means "with great power and great glory." In some languages it may be necessary to use a different expression for the word great each time. For example:

his power will be very great and his glory will be very bright

with...power: In this context power refers to both the authority and the ability to judge and to rule over all people.

and glory: The Greek word that the BSB translates as glory here refers to the shining radiance that often displayed God's greatness (see Exodus 16:10, 40:34). The light and brightness of the Son of Man show that he is great in the same way that God himself is great. See how you translated the word glory in 10:37. You may need to translate it differently here, since the context is different.

Mark 13:27

Section 13:24–27: Jesus told his disciples about his return to earth

In the preceding section Jesus told about some terrible events that would happen. In 13:24–27 he told about other future events which would be even more terrible. Then he said that the Son of Man would come "in clouds with great power and glory." This phrase is also found in Daniel 7:13, a passage that speaks of the Son of Man coming in glory. Jesus used the title "the Son of Man" here to refer to himself.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The coming of the Son of Man

The Son of Man will receive great glory

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:29–31 and Luke 21:25–28.

13:27

This verse indicates that when the Son of Man returns in glory, his angels will go all over the world and gather God's people. If you interpret 13:26 to refer to the time when Jesus ascended to heaven, you can

interpret 13:27 as follows: It would indicate that the angels would begin to gather people from all over the world to become people of God. This would be a fulfillment of the prophecy in 13:10, “the gospel must first be proclaimed to all the nations.” See also Deuteronomy 30:4 and Zechariah 2:10.

13:27a

And He will send out the angels

- Then I will send out my angels
- I will order my angels to go out into the world,

See how you translated the title “the Son of Man” in 13:26a. If you translated it as “I, the Son of Man,” you will need to continue to use the pronoun “I” instead of “he” in 13:27a.

And: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as And is literally two conjunctions: “And then.” This phrase introduces what happens next in a series of events. You should connect 13:26d and 13:27a in a way that is natural in your language. It may not be necessary to use a conjunction.

He...the angels: The word He refers to the Son of Man. The phrase the angels probably refers to the angels who will come with the Son of Man, as Mark 8:38 indicates.

angels: The Greek word that the BSB translates as angels means “messengers.” It refers here to spirit beings who serve God. Sometimes God sends an angel to tell a message to human beings. He also sends angels to serve him in other ways.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

- Use a descriptive word or phrase. For example:

messengers from God/heaven

good/holy spirit-beings

- Use a local term that fits the biblical meaning.
- Use a loan word from a major language. If the meaning of the word is not well-known, you may want to indicate the meaning in some way. For example:

angelos messengers from God

sacred angelos spirits

See how you translated this word in 1:13c. See also angel, Meaning 1, in the Glossary.

If you use a descriptive phrase such as “messengers from God,” make sure that it contrasts with terms that are similar in meaning like “prophet” or “apostle.” A “prophet” is also God’s messenger, and “apostle” literally means “one who is sent.” Each of these words should have a unique term in your language.

will send out: In this context the phrase will send out indicates that the Son of Man will give the angels instructions to go and do something. In some languages it may be necessary to state the place where the Son of Man will send the angels. For example:

he will send his angels all around the earth (NCV)

he will send his angels out into the world

See the General Comment on 13:27a–d at the end of 13:27d.

13:27b

to gather His elect

- and cause them to go and gather together the people whom I have chosen.
- so that they might bring to me those whom I have chosen to be my own people.

to gather: The verb gather means “gather together.” In this context it indicates that the Son of Man will gather people to/around himself. He will do this by sending the angels to bring them to him. It is good to use a word or phrase that can describe bringing people together as one group.

His elect: The expression His elect refers to the people whom the Son of Man has elected or chosen.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the elected/chosen people

the selected people

the people whom he elected/chose

In the context of 13:26a, His elect here refers to the people that the Son of Man has chosen. In 13:20c and 13:22c, Jesus refers to the elect that the Lord God has chosen. Since God and Jesus are one, the expressions refer to the same people. See how you translated the term “elect” in 13:20c and 13:22c.

13:27c

from the four winds,

- They will gather them from everywhere,
- They will bring them from all places/countries,

In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here.

from the four winds: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as from the four winds is an idiom. It means “from the north, south, east, and west,” that is from all over the earth.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

from all over the world (NLT)

all around the earth (NCV)

There may be an idiom in your language to express this meaning.

13:27d

from the ends of the earth to the ends of heaven.

- bringing them from every part of the world.
- and that includes all the farthest places on earth.

from the ends of the earth to the ends of heaven:

This long expression repeats the idea found in 13:27c. It emphasizes completeness, meaning “from absolutely all over the world/earth.” Consider how to translate 13:27c–d in an emphatic way that will not sound redundant in your language. See the General Comment on 13:27c–d for suggestions.

heaven: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as heaven refers to the sky. Here, the word heaven combined with the word “earth” is simply a way to refer to the whole world/earth. It does not mean “where God dwells,” nor does it imply that the angels will gather people who are “in the sky.” See heaven, Meaning 1, in the Glossary.

General Comment on 13:27a–d

In this verse Jesus told about the instructions that he himself would give the angels. In some languages it may be natural to use direct speech for these instructions. Jesus referred to himself as the Son of Man. It may be necessary to indicate this by using forms like “I,” “me,” and “my,” instead of “he,” “him,” and “his.” For example:

I will send out my angels, saying, “Go out into the world and bring to me the people whom I have chosen. Go and fetch them from every place, from the farthest places on earth.”

General Comment on 13:27c–d

The meaning of 13:27c and 13:27d have the same meaning, but 13:27c is expressed in a more figurative way.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- State the meaning twice. For example, the NCV says:

^{27c}Then he will send his angels all around the earth to gather his chosen people ^{27d}from every part of the earth and from every part of heaven.

- State the meaning only once, combining 13:27c–d. For example, The CEV says:

^{27c–d}He will send his angels to gather his chosen ones from all over the earth.

Consider whether you have an idiom or an emphatic way to express the meaning in your language.

Mark 13:28

Section 13:28–31: Jesus used fig trees as an example

In this section, Jesus used an example to help his disciples understand what he was teaching them. In his example, he reminded them about what happens to fig trees. At the end of the cold season, fig trees begin to produce buds and leaves. When people see that happen, they know that summer is near. In the same way, when the disciples see the events in 13:14–27 happen, they will know that Jesus will soon return.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Lesson from a Fig Tree (CEV)

The Parable of the Fig Tree (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:32–35 and Luke 21:29–33. See also Matthew 5:18 and Luke 16:17.

Paragraph 13:28–31

At the beginning of this section, Jesus continued to speak to his disciples. In some languages it may be helpful to remind readers of this. For example:

Jesus continued to teach his disciples. He said...

13:28a**Now learn this lesson from the fig tree:**

- ¶ “Now think^(plur) about the fig tree and learn a lesson from it.
- ¶ “Consider^(plur) fig trees and learn something from the way they grow.
- ¶ “Learn^(plur) something from the illustration/story of the fig tree.

Now: The Greek conjunction that the BSB here translates as Now introduces a new topic. In this context it is not a time word. Introduce this new topic in a way that is natural in your language.

learn this lesson from the fig tree: In some languages people do not speak of learning from inanimate things like fig trees. If this is true in your language, it may be necessary to express the meaning in a different way. For example:

consider/study^(plur) the fig tree and learn something from the way it grows

lesson: The Greek word that the BSB translates as lesson is literally “parable” (as in the NASB). This Greek word can mean “parable,” “proverb,” “saying,” “illustration,” “story,” or “metaphor.” The context determines which of these meanings is appropriate. Jesus’ words about the fig tree are more like an illustration or example.

the fig tree: In this context Jesus was speaking about all fig trees. He was not referring to any particular tree. Be sure to use an appropriate form in your language. For example:

learn^(plur) something from the illustration about fig trees.

The fig tree In the Bible, the fig tree often represents the nation of Israel. In 11:13–14, 20–23, the fig tree seems to be a picture of the temple, the central place of Jewish worship. was a very common tree in Israel. Fig trees normally produced small, edible fruit called figs. The trees were completely bare in winter and then sprouted buds, leaves, and figs in the spring.

If speakers of your language are not familiar with the fig tree, here are some other ways to translate it:

tree with a fruit called ‘fig’

fruit tree

The expression fig tree also occurs in 11:13a. See how you translated it there.

13:28b**As soon as its branches become tender and sprout leaves,**

- As soon as its branches bud and its leaves begin to sprout,
- When its branches sprout and start putting out leaves,
- When the sap flows in its branches and new leaves appear,

As soon as its branches become tender and sprout leaves:

This part of the verse introduces what happens when a fig tree develops new leaves after the winter season.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

When its branches become green and tender and it starts putting out leaves (GNT)

When its branches become green and soft and new leaves appear (NCV)

its branches: The Greek word that the BSB translates as branches is also used in 4:32b. See how you translated it there.

become tender: In this context the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as become tender describes what happens to a branch before summer begins. Sap begins to flow through the branch, and it becomes more flexible. It is then ready to bud and sprout leaves. Consider whether you have special terms to describe this in your language.

and sprout leaves: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as sprout leaves also means “its leaves begin to come out/grow.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and new leaves appear (NCV)

and start putting out leaves (CEV)

You should express this in a way that is natural in your language.

13:28c**you know that summer is near.**

- you^(plur) know that summer will soon be here.

- everyone knows/expects that the rainy/growing season is approaching.

you know: The word you here is plural and means “people in general.” Jesus, who was speaking, also knew when summer was near. So in some languages it may be more natural to say “we know.”

Here is another way to express this:

everyone knows

that summer is near: In the area where Jesus lived, summer is the time when plants and crops grow. It is also the hottest time of the year.

In this context, the word summer indicates that the tree will soon start growing leaves and fruit. It is more important to find a natural expression in your language for the growing season than to say whether the weather is hot or cold.

Here are some other ways to express this:

that the rainy season is near

that the growing season is approaching

Mark 13:29

Section 13:28–31: Jesus used fig trees as an example

In this section, Jesus used an example to help his disciples understand what he was teaching them. In his example, he reminded them about what happens to fig trees. At the end of the cold season, fig trees begin to produce buds and leaves. When people see that happen, they know that summer is near. In the same way, when the disciples see the events in 13:14–27 happen, they will know that Jesus will soon return.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Lesson from a Fig Tree (CEV)

The Parable of the Fig Tree (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:32–35 and Luke 21:29–33. See also Matthew 5:18 and Luke 16:17.

Paragraph 13:28–31

At the beginning of this section, Jesus continued to speak to his disciples. In some languages it may be helpful to remind readers of this. For example:

Jesus continued to teach his disciples. He said...

13:29a

So also, when you see these things happening,

- It is the same for you.^(plur) When you see these events happening,
- Likewise, you^(plur) too, when you see these events that I have just told you about taking place,

So also: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So also means “thus, in this way.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Even so (NIV)

Likewise

In the same way (GNT)

when you see these things happening: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as when you see was also used in 13:14a. There it was followed by the phrase “the abomination of desolation.” Here the text does not use a specific phrase. The phrase these things probably refers back to 13:14–23 (the abomination that causes desolation and the time of suffering when people would have to flee).

In this context it is good to translate with a general phrase that can refer back to those verses. For example:

these things

these events

13:29b

know that He is near, right at the door.

- you^(plur) know that the time is near. It is about to happen.
- you^(plur) know that the time for my coming will soon arrive. It will not be long now.

know that He is near: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as He is near does not specify what is near. The phrase could refer to either an event (“it”) or a

person. There are at least two ways to interpret this phrase: Scholars say that the fall of Jerusalem and the temple is a small picture of a much larger picture, namely, the end of the world. In prophetic writing, a phrase may have more than one meaning.

1. It means “he is near” or “his return is near.” He refers to the Son of Man mentioned in 13:26 or to his return. For example:

he is near (RSV)

his return is very near (NLT) (BSB, RSV, NJB, GW, JBP, NASB, NET, ESV)

1. It means “it is near.” It refers to another event about which Jesus had been speaking. This event could be the end of the world or the coming destruction of the temple. The REB says:

the end is near

Except for the ones listed above, other English versions translate in a general way with either “it” or “the time” (NIV, KJV, GNT, CEV, NCV). They are ambiguous about whether they are referring to Jesus’ return or to a different event.

If possible, you should translate in such a way that either interpretation may be understood. If you need to be specific, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

near: In this context the word near refers to being near in time. It indicates that Jesus or his return would soon come. Use a word that will fit with your translation of the subject (“He” in the BSB).

right at the door: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as right at the door is an idiom. It means “almost here” or “about to happen.” This idiom strengthens the previous word “near.” There may be a suitable idiom in your language with that meaning that you could use here. Another way to translate this is with a negative expression. For example:

it/he is not far in the future

Mark 13:30

Section 13:28–31: Jesus used fig trees as an example
In this section, Jesus used an example to help his disciples understand what he was teaching them. In his example, he reminded them about what happens to fig trees. At the end of the cold season, fig trees

begin to produce buds and leaves. When people see that happen, they know that summer is near. In the same way, when the disciples see the events in 13:14–27 happen, they will know that Jesus will soon return.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Lesson from a Fig Tree (CEV)

The Parable of the Fig Tree (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:32–35 and Luke 21:29–33. See also Matthew 5:18 and Luke 16:17.

Paragraph 13:28–31

At the beginning of this section, Jesus continued to speak to his disciples. In some languages it may be helpful to remind readers of this. For example:

Jesus continued to teach his disciples. He said...

13:30a

Truly I tell you,

- What I tell you^(plur) is true.
- You^(plur) can be absolutely sure that

Truly I tell you: Jesus often used the words Truly I tell you to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. He was asking people to listen with extra attention. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

You can be sure that... (CEV)

I tell you the truth... (NIV)

See how you translated this phrase in 3:28a.

13:30b

this generation will not pass away

- The people of this generation certainly will not all die
- some of the people who are here now will still be alive

this generation will not pass away: The expression pass away is a figure of speech called a euphemism. Jesus used it to refer to death. In this context it

indicates that the people of this generation will not all die.

In some languages, it may be more natural to make this negative statement a positive statement. For example, the CEV says:

some of the people of this generation will still be alive when...

It is possible to reorder 13:30b–c. See the General Comment on 13:30b–c below.

this generation: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as this generation means “people alive at this time.”

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

the people now living (GNT)

the present generation (REB)

See also 8:12, where the same expression occurs. Some scholars argue that the phrase “this generation” refers not to the generation alive in Jesus’ day but to the generation that will see the signs of the end times. Other suggest that the phrase means “this race”; that is, the race of Jewish people. It is recommended that you translate literally.

13:30c **until all these things have happened.**

- before all these events take place.
- when all these events happen.

until all these things have happened: If you have translated the verb in 13:30b as “will not pass away,” it may be more natural to say “before” here instead of until. For example:

[this generation will not pass away] before all these events take place.

If you have translated the verb in 13:30b as “will still be alive,” it may be more natural to say “when” here instead of until. For example:

[some of the people of this generation will still be alive] when all these events happen.

all these things: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as all these things is a repetition of some words in 13:4a. In that verse the disciples asked Jesus:

“when will these things happen?” There, the disciples clearly referred to the destruction of the temple. Here in 13:30c, the same phrase probably refers to all the events that Jesus said would happen before the temple was destroyed. It is good to remember that the temple was destroyed in A.D.70. However, this may also happen again at the end of the world, and it may be a picture of the end of the world.

You should translate the phrase all these things literally, because different people have different ideas about which events in chapter 13 the phrase refers to. If you wish, you could put a footnote here and say:

The phrase “all these things” is also found in 13:4, where it refers to the destruction of the temple.

General Comment on 13:30b–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to place 13:30c before 13:30b. For example:

^{30c}all these events will happen ^{30b}before the people now living have all died.

Mark 13:31

Section 13:28–31: Jesus used fig trees as an example

In this section, Jesus used an example to help his disciples understand what he was teaching them. In his example, he reminded them about what happens to fig trees. At the end of the cold season, fig trees begin to produce buds and leaves. When people see that happen, they know that summer is near. In the same way, when the disciples see the events in 13:14–27 happen, they will know that Jesus will soon return.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Lesson from a Fig Tree (CEV)

The Parable of the Fig Tree (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 24:32–35 and Luke 21:29–33. See also Matthew 5:18 and Luke 16:17.

Paragraph 13:28–31

At the beginning of this section, Jesus continued to speak to his disciples. In some languages it may be helpful to remind readers of this. For example:

Jesus continued to teach his disciples. He said...

13:31

In 13:31 Jesus compared two things that are very reliable:

1. Heaven and earth were likely to continue to exist for a long time. People could not easily imagine that heaven and earth would ever come to an end. In the Old Testament “heaven and earth” were often spoken of as being especially enduring and firm. (See Isaiah 51:6 and Jeremiah 31:35–36.)
2. The words of Jesus were certain to continue to exist forever.

In 13:31 Jesus indicated that what he said was more reliable than heaven and earth were. This implies that the things he said would certainly happen.

13:31a

Heaven and earth will pass away,

- The sky and the earth will cease to exist,
- The universe will not endure/last forever,
- Even when the heavens and the earth end,

Heaven and earth: The expression Heaven and earth refers to the sky and the earth. For example:

The sky and the earth (CEV)

Earth and sky (NCV)

This phrase refers to the entire physical universe. It includes all the material things that God created.

Here, the word Heaven does not refer to the place where God lives. That heaven will never pass away. See heaven, Meaning 1, in the Glossary.

will pass away: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as will pass away means “will come to an end” or “will cease to exist.” For example:

will be destroyed (NCV)

will disappear (NLT)

Another way to translate this is to use a negative. For example:

will not last forever (CEV)

13:31b

but My words will never pass away.

- but my words will never cease to exist.
- but the words that I have said will endure/last forever.
- what I have said will remain true.

My words: The expression My words refers to everything that Jesus ever spoke and taught. This includes what he had just said about the events that would happen in the future.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

the words I have said (NCV)

that which I have said

will never pass away: The phrase will never pass away means that Jesus’ words will never be proved false. They will never be forgotten.

In Greek this is a negative phrase. In some languages it may be necessary to use a positive phrase. For example:

but my words will remain strong/true forever.

pass away: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as pass away is the same verb that is used in 13:31a. It may not be possible to use the same verb in 13:31a and 13:31b, but try to make the contrast clear between these two verse parts.

Mark 13:32

Section 13:32–37: Jesus told his disciples to be ready for his coming

In this section Jesus told his disciples that no one knows the day or hour when he will come in glory. He exhorted his disciples that they should be ready at all times for his coming.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told his disciples, “Be ready for me to return”

No one knows when Jesus will return to earth

Jesus’ disciples must watch for his coming

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 21:34–36.

13:32a

No one knows about that day or hour,

- ¶ “No one knows the day or the hour/time of my return,
- ¶ “But as for the time when God’s Son will return to earth, nobody knows which day it will be or the hour/time of the day.
- ¶ “No person knows exactly when that final hour of that final day will come/occur.

There is a contrast between 13:32a and 13:29b:

1. People can know when it is almost time for Jesus to return, (13:29)
2. but no one can know the exact day when he will return. (13:32)

In 13:30–31 Jesus said other things before he said the second part of the contrast in (b).

Some English versions have the conjunction “but” at the beginning of 13:32, as in the RSV. However in some languages, using only a conjunction may wrongly imply that the contrast is with 13:31. If that is true in your language, here are two options to consider:

- Leave the contrast implied, as the BSB does.
- Indicate the contrast more specifically in some way. For example, the NET puts the contrasting words near the beginning of the sentence:

But as for that day or that hour, no one knows it

You should show the contrast in a natural way in your language.

No one knows about that day or hour: There are three ways to interpret the clause No one knows about that day or hour here:

1. It means that no one knows the time when Jesus will return in power and glory.
2. It means that no one knows the time when people will suffer terribly.
3. It means that no one knows the time when the temple will be destroyed.

English versions are ambiguous. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and the majority of Bible scholars. The Old Testament often uses the expression “that day” to refer to the day that the Lord will come in glory to judge his people. See Isaiah 2:11, 17, 20; Amos 5:18; 8:3, 9, 13; 9:11; Micah 4:6, 5:10. So the clause No one knows about that day or hour means:

But no one knows the day or hour when the Son of God will return

However, no one knows the day or hour when I will return

hour: The word hour refers to a time during the day or night. If it is difficult to translate the word hour, you can say:

But no one knows that day or the time of that day

But no one knows when that day will come/be or exactly when during that day

Jesus may return during the daylight hours or during the night. Do not imply in your translation that Jesus will return during the daytime.

13:32b

not even the angels in heaven, nor the Son,

- not even the angels in heaven, nor the Son,
- Not even the angels in heaven know, nor the Son of God knows.
- Not even the angels before God know, nor do I the Son know.

not even the angels in heaven: The clause not even the angels in heaven implies information from the previous clause. The meaning is: “not even the angels in heaven know.”

not even: The words not even indicate something unexpected. People might have expected that the angels would know when Jesus would come, but even they do not know the time of his return.

angels: The Greek word that the BSB translates as angels means “messengers.” It refers here to spirit beings who serve God. Sometimes God sends an angel to tell a message to human beings. He also sends angels to serve him in other ways.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

- Use a descriptive word or phrase. For example:

messengers from God/heaven

good/holy spirit-beings

- Use a local term that fits the biblical meaning.
- Use a loan word from a major language. If the meaning of the word is not well-known, you may want to indicate the meaning in some way. For example:

angelos messengers from God

sacred angelos spirits

See how you translated this word in 1:13c. See also angel, Meaning 1, in the Glossary.

in heaven: The words in heaven refer to the place where God is ruling over his creation. People might expect angels there to know secrets, but even they do not know. See heaven, Meaning 2, in the Glossary.

nor the Son: The phrase nor the Son implies information from the 13:32a. The meaning is “not even the Son knows the day or the hour.” When Jesus was still on earth, even he himself did not know when he would return to earth.

the Son: The phrase the Son refers to Jesus. Here, this phrase could refer to one of two possible titles for Jesus:

1. the Son of God God the Father is mentioned in the same sentence, in 13:32c. Mark identifies Jesus as “the Son of God” in 1:1. In addition, God the Father calls him “my Son” in 1:11 and 9:7.
2. the Son of Man Everywhere else in Mark’s Gospel Jesus refers to himself as the Son of Man, so some scholars (e.g., Lane) think that he is doing the same here.

If you can simply say “the Son” by itself, then do so. In that way it will not be necessary to choose between the two possibilities mentioned above. If you must be specific, then choose (a). The majority of Bible scholars support this possibility.

The Bible uses the title “Son of God” to express the fact that Jesus has the same nature as God and that he comes from God. God does not have a physical body, and he did not create/produce Jesus the way a human father produces a son. Jesus existed eternally as the Son with his Father.

For translation suggestions and some further information, see the note on “my son” in 9:7c.

13:32c

but only the Father.

- but only the Father knows.
- Only God the Father knows.
- It is only God the/my Father who knows.

but only the Father: Only God, the heavenly Father of Jesus, has always known when his Son will return in glory.

the Father: It is Jesus who uses the expression the Father, so it may be necessary in some languages to say:

his Father

my Father

God my/the Father

You may need to repeat the verb “know” in the last part of this verse. For example:

only the Father knows (GNT)

only God my/his Father knows

In addition, you could emphasize the subject the Father. For example:

it is only God my/the/his Father who knows

General Comment on 13:32a–c

Another way to arrange verse 13:32 is to start with the fact that only the Father knows. For example:

^{32a}As for the time of that event ^{32c}God the/my Father is the only one who knows when it will take place. Other than him, ^{32a}no one knows the day or hour when it will take place. ^{32b}The angels in heaven do not know, and even I, the Son of God, do not know.

Mark 13:33

Section 13:32–37: Jesus told his disciples to be ready for his coming

In this section Jesus told his disciples that no one knows the day or hour when he will come in glory. He exhorted his disciples that they should be ready at all times for his coming.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told his disciples, “Be ready for me to return”

No one knows when Jesus will return to earth

Jesus' disciples must watch for his coming

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 21:34–36.

13:33a

Be on your guard and stay alert!

- Be^(plur) on your guard! Be^(plur) alert/vigilant!
- Be always watchful! Keep aware at all times!

Be on your guard and stay alert!: There is a textual issue in this verse. Some Greek manuscripts have a third command that means “Pray!”:

1. Most Greek manuscripts do not have this third command. Most English versions follow these manuscripts. (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, GW, NLT, CEV, JBP, NCV, NET, NASB, NJB, REB, ESV)
2. Other Greek manuscripts have a third command that means “Pray.” For example, the KJV says:

Take ye heed, watch and pray (KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), since it has stronger manuscript support. Most English versions follow this option. However, you should also check the major language version in your area. If it follows option (2), then you may want to follow it or include it in a footnote.

Be on your guard: The Greek verb that the BSB translates here as Be on your guard also occurs in 13:5, 13:9a, and 13:23a. In this context, it means “Stay watching.”

stay alert: The Greek word that the BSB translates as stay alert literally means “Stay awake.” It implies that they should be aware of what is happening and be ready for Jesus' coming.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

be^(plur) vigilant

be^(plur) ready (CEV)

In some languages it may be possible to use an idiom here.

13:33b

For you do not know when the appointed time will come.

- You^(plur) do not know when that time will arrive.

- For/because you^(plur) do not know when I will return.

In 13:33b Jesus told the disciples the reason that they needed to “be on... guard.” They needed to be on guard because they did not know when Christ would return.

For: The Greek text introduces the reason with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For. Use a natural way in your language to indicate that 13:33b is the reason for 13:33a.

you do not know: The pronoun you is plural and refers to the disciples. However, it is not only the disciples who did not know. No one else knows either.

when the appointed time will come: The words the appointed time refer to “that day or hour” in 13:32a. It is the time when Jesus, the Messiah, will return again to earth.

will come: In some languages, the verb will come can only refer to people or other beings. It cannot refer to events. If that is true in your language, you can use the verb “will happen,” or “will be complete.” For example:

when that time will happen/occur

when that time will be complete

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase the appointed time more explicitly:

when the Son of Man will return

when I will return to earth

Mark 13:34

Section 13:32–37: Jesus told his disciples to be ready for his coming

In this section Jesus told his disciples that no one knows the day or hour when he will come in glory. He exhorted his disciples that they should be ready at all times for his coming.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told his disciples, “Be ready for me to return”

No one knows when Jesus will return to earth

Jesus' disciples must watch for his coming

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 21:34–36.

13:34

In this verse Jesus used a short parable or illustration to teach his disciples about how they should act while he was away from them. What follows is an explanation. It explains that his disciples should watch for the Son of Man to come like servants watch for their master to come back from a trip. Another way to express that connection is:

The coming of the Son of Man can be illustrated by the story of a man going on a long trip. (NLT)

In this parable Jesus used present forms of the verbs. In some languages it may be natural for the verbs in such a story to be in the past tense. See the General Comment on 13:34a–e at the end of 13:34e for an example of how to translate it in this way.

13:34a

It is like a man going on a journey

- It is like a man who goes on a journey/trip.
- His/My departure and return will be like a certain man. This man went away from his home.

It is like a man: In the Greek text, the phrase that the BSB translates as It is like a man is literally “like a man.” The BSB has supplied the words It is to provide a subject and verb for the sentence, since it is necessary for good English grammar. For example:

It's like a man... (NIV)

It will be like a man... (GNT)

Another way to say this is:

Listen to this story/illustration. There was a man...

In some languages it may be necessary to have a more specific subject like “my coming.” For example:

My coming will be like...

a man: The man is the main character of this parable. You should introduce this man in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

a certain man

The context shows that the man owned a house and had servants or slaves.

going on a journey: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as going on a journey refers to going away temporarily on a journey. He will come back. The GW has another way to translate the whole phrase “It is like a man going on a journey”:

It is like a man who went on a trip.

13:34b

who left his house,

- When that man is about to leave his house,
- Before that man went, while he was leaving his house like that,

13:34c

put each servant in charge

- he puts his servants in charge.
- he first entrusted the work of the house to his servants.

13:34b–c

who left his house, put each servant in charge: The man put his servants in charge before he left. In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the verbs. For example:

When he is about to leave his house, he puts his servants in charge

When that man was leaving his house like that, he put his servants in charge

put each servant in charge: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates with the English idiom put...in charge is literally “gave authority” (as in the KJV).

Here are some other ways to translate this:

...he entrusts the work of the house to his servants.

...he gave instructions to his servants, saying “Take care of everything.”

In some languages it may be necessary to specify what the servants were put in charge of. In some languages you may need to supply a general expression like “everything” or “the house.” For example:

he puts his servants in charge of all the tasks

he tells his servants to take care of his/the house

servant: The Greek word that the BSB translates as servant means “slave” (as in the NET). This word refers to people who were owned by another person. They worked for their owner/master without receiving pay. They had no rights of their own (or very few rights).

In some cultures, slaves may not be known. In other cultures, the word for slave may imply different customs than in biblical culture. If that is true in your language, here are some other ways to translate this:

people who belonged to someone else

owned people

people who serve someone

workers/servants

13:34d of his own task,

- He gives to each servant his own task to do
- He told each servant what to do,

of his own task: The clause of his own task means that the master gave work to each servant. In some languages it may be natural to translate this with a separate clause or sentence. For example:

He gave to each servant his own task to do.

He assigned work to each one (GW)

13:34e and instructed the doorkeeper to keep watch.

- and orders the guard to be alert.
- and then he gave orders to the doorkeeper that he should keep watch.
- and then he commanded the guard: ‘Do^(sing) keep watch over the/my house.’”

and instructed the doorkeeper to keep watch: The task that the master gave to the doorkeeper was to keep watch.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

and ordered the one at the door to keep watch

and instructed the guard to stay alert

In some languages, it may be natural to translate tells...to keep watch as direct speech. For example:

He told the doorkeeper: “You are to keep watch over my house.”

instructed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as instructed is literally “commanded” or “ordered.”

the doorkeeper: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the doorkeeper refers to the servant who stayed at the door to guard the house. He did not allow enemies to enter. He also unlocked the door for his master and for whomever his master wanted to enter.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

one at the door (NIV)

gatekeeper (NLT)

guard (GW)

to keep watch: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to keep watch means “be alert.” The master wanted the servant to keep awake and watch for his return. The servant should also stay alert to see that no enemy entered the house during his master’s absence. The form of the verb keep watch indicates that the action should be continuous.

General Comment on 13:34a–e

In some languages it may be natural for a speaker to use the past tense when telling a short story or illustration like this one. For example, the GW says:

As he left home, he put his servants in charge. He assigned work to each one and ordered the guard to be alert.

Mark 13:35

Section 13:32–37: Jesus told his disciples to be ready for his coming

In this section Jesus told his disciples that no one knows the day or hour when he will come in glory. He exhorted his disciples that they should be ready at all times for his coming.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told his disciples, “Be ready for me to return”

No one knows when Jesus will return to earth

Jesus’ disciples must watch for his coming

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 21:34–36.

13:35a

Therefore keep watch,

- Therefore you^(plur) should keep watch,
- So Jesus said to his disciples: “Therefore you^(plur) too/ likewise must be alert,

At the end of 13:34e, Jesus finished giving the word picture or illustration of the man who left on a journey. In 13:35a he again addressed the disciples.

Therefore keep watch: Jesus spoke the words Therefore keep watch to his disciples. They are not words that the man in the story spoke to the doorkeeper. The form of the Greek verb keep watch is plural, so it is certain that Jesus was speaking to the disciples. The NLT has one way to make this clear:

You, too, must keep watch!

In some languages it may be necessary to supply an introductory phrase to indicate this. For example:

So Jesus, finishing his story, said to his disciples: “Therefore keep^(plur) watch.”

keep watch: The Greek verb translated as keep watch or “be alert” is the same verb that is found in 13:34e. It will occur again at the end of 13:37.

13:35b

because you do not know when the master of the house will return—

- because you^(plur) do not know when the owner of the house will come back.
- because you^(plur) do not know when I, the master of the house, will come back.

because you do not know when the master of the house will return: The Greek word that the BSB translates as because introduces the reason that Jesus told the disciples to keep watch constantly. The reason is that they did not know when he would return.

you do not know: The phrase you do not know repeats what Jesus told them in 13:33b. You may need to make

it clear that it was not only the disciples who did not know when Jesus would return. You may want to use a phrase that could include others. For example:

because no one knows when the owner of the house will come back

the master of the house: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the master is often used in the Gospels when they addressed Jesus. So the disciples would understand that Jesus was the master of the house from the parable. You may need to make this plain to the listener/reader. For example:

because you^(plur) do not know when I, the owner/ master of the house, will come back

General Comment on 13:35a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of 13:35a and 13:35b. For example:

So Jesus, said to his disciples: ^{35b}“You do not know when the owner of the house will come back. ^{35a}That is why you must keep watch.”

13:35c

whether in the evening, at midnight,

- He may come back in the evening or at midnight,
- I, the owner of the house might come back after sundown or in the middle of the night,
- I, the owner of the house might come back at 6 p.m. or at 12 p.m.

In the Jewish culture, people did not usually travel at night. Thieves were out at that time and people avoided travel because it was dangerous. Jesus was saying to the disciples that he would come at a time that they did not expect him to come.

whether in the evening, at midnight: The phrases in the evening and at midnight are possible times that the owner might return. The BSB uses a dash to introduce these times. You may need to begin a new sentence here. For example:

The owner of the house might come back in the evening or at midnight.

I, the owner of the house, might come back in the evening or at midnight.

It could be in the evening or at midnight or at dawn or in the morning. (GW)

in the evening: The phrase in the evening indicates the time period after sundown starting from about six o'clock until about nine o'clock.

Here is another way to translate this:

after sundown

at midnight: The phrase at midnight indicates a time in the middle of the night from about twelve o'clock to about three o'clock.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

late at night

in the middle of the night

13:35d when the rooster crows, or in the morning.

- or when roosters crow/cry or at dawn.
- or early in the morning or at sunrise.
- or at 3 a.m. or at 6 a.m.

when the rooster crows: The phrase when the rooster crows indicates a time before sunrise, from about three o'clock until six o'clock in the morning.

Here are some ways to translate this:

- Translate it literally. For example:

at the time that roosters crow/cry

- Translate it as a general period of time. For example:

in the morning while it is still dark (CEV)

early in the morning

as the night was ending

- Translate it as an exact time. For example:

three o'clock in the morning

in the morning: The phrase in the morning indicates a time period in the early morning after sunrise. It starts at about six o'clock and continues until about nine o'clock.

Here are some ways to translate this:

- Translate it literally. For example, the NCV has:

when the sun rises

- Translate it as a general period of time. For example:

in the morning (RSV)

at sunrise (GNT)

at dawn (NIV)

- Translate it as an exact time. For example:

six o'clock in the morning

Mark 13:36

Section 13:32–37: Jesus told his disciples to be ready for his coming

In this section Jesus told his disciples that no one knows the day or hour when he will come in glory. He exhorted his disciples that they should be ready at all times for his coming.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told his disciples, “Be ready for me to return”

No one knows when Jesus will return to earth

Jesus’ disciples must watch for his coming

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 21:34–36.

13:36a–b

Otherwise, he may arrive without notice and find you sleeping: In the Greek text, the sentence that begins in 13:35a continues in 13:36. The Greek is literally “Keep watch...so that, if he comes suddenly, he will not find you sleeping.”

In some languages it may be necessary to repeat the verb “keep watch” at the beginning of 13:36. For example:

Keep watch, ^(plur) therefore so that, if he comes suddenly, he does not find you sleeping.

13:36a

Otherwise, he may arrive without notice

- If he comes without warning,
- He will certainly come without warning, so keep watch.
- Watch, so that, if I come unexpectedly,

he may arrive without notice: In this context the Greek word translated as arrive without notice means “unexpectedly.” Jesus will not send a message to tell anyone the exact time that he will return.

The NLT expresses this meaning as:

when he arrives without warning

If you said in 13:35b “I, the master of the house,” then you should continue to use “I” in this verse, as well.

13:36b

and find you sleeping.

- he should not find that you^(plur) are sleeping/unprepared.
- Then he will see that you^(plur) are ready for him.
- I do not find you^(plur) unprepared like someone asleep.

and find you sleeping: A master who saw his doorkeeper sleeping would be angry and punish him. The doorkeeper was supposed to guard the entry to the house. That was his responsibility.

sleeping: The word sleeping is part of the extended metaphor here. Jesus was talking about people who are not ready or not prepared to do what is needed. Such people are like those who are sleeping, because sleeping people are not ready for action. Find out if listeners/readers will understand what the word sleeping indicates here. If necessary, you could translate the meaning of sleeping. For example:

do not let him find you unprepared like someone sleeping

do not let him/me find you unprepared/unready for him/me

Mark 13:37

Section 13:32–37: Jesus told his disciples to be ready for his coming

In this section Jesus told his disciples that no one knows the day or hour when he will come in glory. He exhorted his disciples that they should be ready at all times for his coming.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told his disciples, “Be ready for me to return”

No one knows when Jesus will return to earth

Jesus’ disciples must watch for his coming

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 21:34–36.

13:37a

And what I say to you, I say to everyone:

- What I say to you,^(plur) I say to every one of my disciples:
- That which I say to you,^(plur) I say to all my followers everywhere:
- The words that I say to you,^(plur) it is to all disciples that I say it:

And what I say to you, I say to everyone: Here Jesus returned to the main theme of the paragraph. The main theme is the need to watch, stay ready, and do the tasks that the master has assigned, until he returns.

you: The pronoun you is plural. It refers to the four disciples mentioned in 13:3: Peter, James, John, and Andrew. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate this. For example:

That which I say to you disciples

I say to everyone: The Greek pronoun that the BSB translates as everyone can also be translated as “all,” as in the RSV. This word refers to all present and future disciples of Jesus. You could say:

I say to all my disciples

In the Greek, the word everyone is emphasized. To emphasize it, you could add the word “everywhere.” For example:

I say to all my disciples everywhere

it is not just to you that I say it, I say it to all my disciples

13:37b Keep watch!”

- ‘Watch!’^(plur)”
- ‘Be prepared constantly for me/my return!’”
- ‘Be alert all the time for my return from heaven!’”

Keep watch!: The form of the Greek word that the BSB translates as Keep watch! indicates that the activity does is not an activity that happens once. The disciples should continually expect the return of Jesus from heaven. They should always be ready for him. You may need to make more of this meaning explicit. For example:

Watch^(plur) continually.

Be alert^(plur) constantly for my return from heaven!

Mark 14:1

Section 14:1–2: The Jewish leaders plotted to arrest Jesus

This section gives background information for the events that follow in 14:3–9 and 14:10–11.

In chapter 13 Jesus taught people about how enemies would destroy the temple in Jerusalem. In chapter 14 Mark continued the story of Jesus’ life. He told about the events that occurred just before people killed Jesus. The background material in 14:1–2 introduces this part of the story. It also gives background information about events that happened later, such as Judas’ betrayal (14:10–11) and Jesus’ arrest and death by crucifixion (14:43–15:15).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The leaders of the Jews planned to kill Jesus

People search for a way to kill Jesus

The Jewish leaders wanted to secretly seize Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:1–5; Luke 22:1–2; and John 11:45–53.

14:1a

Now the Passover and the Feast of Unleavened Bread were two days away,

- ¶ Two days before the Festival of Passover and the Festival of Unleavened Bread,
- ¶ It was two days until the Jews would celebrate the festivals that they call “Death Passed Us By” and “Unrisen Bread.”

Now the Passover and the Feast of Unleavened Bread were two days away: This clause gives the time setting for the next events. It indicates that the events in the following verses happened two days before the Passover and the Feast began. This kind of background information can be introduced in various ways. For example:

It was two days before the Passover and the Feast... (RSV)

Two days were still lacking until the Jews celebrated the Passover and the Feast...

Introduce this background information in a way that is natural in your language.

the Passover and the Feast of Unleavened Bread:

The Passover and the Feast of Unleavened Bread refer to two important feasts or festivals that the Jews celebrated once every year. The Jews ate a special Passover meal on the same evening that they started celebrating the Feast of Unleavened Bread. For this reason, many people considered these two festivals to be a single combined festival.

In translating these festivals, you may:

- Make explicit that there were two festivals. For example:

the festival called Passover and the festival called Unleavened Bread

- Use a combined term. For example:

the Festival of Passover and Unleavened Bread (GNT)

the Passover: Passover is the name of a Jewish festival. It celebrates the time that God's angel passed over/by the houses of the Jews without harming them. See the suggested footnote below for more details.

Here are some other ways to translate Passover:

the Passover festival/celebration

festival called Passed-By and left safe

"Death did not harm us" feast

You may want to include a footnote and cross-reference here about this feast. For example:

The Feast of Passover was a festival that reminded the Jews of the time when God freed their ancestors from slavery in Egypt. See Exodus 12:1–27.

the Feast of Unleavened Bread: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the Feast of Unleavened Bread is literally "unleavened bread." The BSB has supplied the words the Feast of. As mentioned above, you should indicate in a natural way in your language that Unleavened Bread is the name of another Jewish feast.

The term Unleavened Bread refers to a festival that the Jews celebrated each year for seven days. During these days they ate unleavened bread. (Unleavened bread is thin, flat bread made without yeast. Yeast is what causes bread to rise.)

When God delivered the Jews' ancestors from Egypt, they had to leave very quickly. They did not have time to make their bread with yeast and wait until it rose. The purpose of the Feast of Unleavened Bread was to help the Jews remember this and thank God for what he had done for them. You may want to put some of this background information in a footnote or glossary entry to help your readers understand more about this feast.

Here are some other possible ways to translate this:

Feast of bread made without yeast

Feast of bread made without raising-agent

Feast when people eat bread with no yeast

See how you translated "leaven" in 8:15.

14:1b and the chief priests and scribes

- the chief priests and the teachers of the Law of Moses
- The leaders of the priests and the experts in the law

the chief priests: A Jewish priest was a man who offered sacrifices to God on behalf of the people. He also performed other rituals for them. The phrase the chief priests refers to the leaders among these priests.

Here are some other ways to translate the chief priests:

the leading/ruling priests

the elders among the Jewish sacrificers

the most prominent priests

The term chief priests first occurs in Mark in 8:31c.

scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes is sometimes translated as "teachers of the law" (as in the NIV). The original work of these men was to copy the laws of Moses by hand. In New Testament times, their main task was to study, interpret, and teach the law of Moses and related Jewish laws and traditions.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

teachers of the Law of Moses (CEV)

teachers of religious law (NLT)

the experts on the law

people who teach the law of the Jews

See how you translated this term in 12:38b. Also, see teacher of the law in the Glossary for more information.

14:1c were looking for a covert way to arrest Jesus

- continued discussing how they could seize Jesus secretly
- were searching for a way that they could have Jesus arrested

were looking for a covert way to arrest Jesus: The words were looking for a covert way to arrest Jesus

indicate that the Jewish leaders were trying to think of a plan to arrest Jesus secretly. They did not want other people to know about they planned to do.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

discussing how they might arrest Jesus in secret and kill him

were trying to find a way to arrest Jesus by stealth and kill him (NET)

arrest: The Greek word that the BSB translates as arrest means “seize,” “capture,” or “take away to trial or punishment.”

14:1d and kill Him.

- and kill him.
- and have him killed without the people finding out.

and kill Him: The Jewish leaders did not plan to kill Jesus themselves. They wanted the Romans to execute Jesus in the way that Romans executed criminals.

Here are some other ways to show this in your translation:

and have him put to death (NJB)

and cause him to be executed

General Comment on 14:1a–d

In some languages it may be helpful to break 14:1 into two sentences. For example:

It was two days before the Feast of the Passover and the Feast of Unleavened Bread. The chief priests and the teachers of the law were looking for a secret way to seize Jesus and have him killed.

Mark 14:2

Section 14:1–2: The Jewish leaders plotted to arrest Jesus

This section gives background information for the events that follow in 14:3–9 and 14:10–11.

In chapter 13 Jesus taught people about how enemies would destroy the temple in Jerusalem. In chapter 14 Mark continued the story of Jesus’ life. He told about the events that occurred just before people killed Jesus. The background material in 14:1–2 intro-

duces this part of the story. It also gives background information about events that happened later, such as Judas’ betrayal (14:10–11) and Jesus’ arrest and death by crucifixion (14:43–15:15).

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The leaders of the Jews planned to kill Jesus

People search for a way to kill Jesus

The Jewish leaders wanted to secretly seize Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:1–5; Luke 22:1–2; and John 11:45–53.

14:2a

“But not during the feast,” they said,

- They were saying, “We should not do this during the feast
- However, they also said to each other, “Let’s not arrest him during the feast days.
- But they decided to wait until people had returned home after/from the feast

In Greek, 14:2a begins with a phrase that the RSV translates as “for they said.” The BSB puts the phrase “they said” in the middle of Jesus’ words. Place it where it is natural in your language. See the General Comment on 14:2a–b for a suggestion about indirect speech. The form of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as “said” indicates that the leaders probably said the statement in 14:2 several times during their discussions.

The conjunction that the RSV translates as “for” introduces some additional things that the chiefs priests and teachers of the law were thinking and saying. There is also a contrast here. The Jewish leaders wanted to arrest and kill Jesus (14:1c–d), but they did not want to do it immediately (14:2a). Some English versions indicate this contrast with a conjunction such as “But.” For example:

But they said (NCV)

However, they said (GW)

Some English versions do not translate the conjunction. You should connect 14:2a to 14:1c–d in a way that is natural in your language.

not during the feast: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as not during the feast is an ellipsis. In some languages it may be necessary to supply the missing parts of the clause from 14:1c–d. For example:

We must not arrest and kill him during the feast

We should not do this during the festival

the feast: The feast here probably refers to all of the eight days when the people celebrated both the festival of Passover and Unleavened Bread.

14:2b

“or there may be a riot among the people.”

- so that the people do not riot.”
- If we arrest him now, the people might become angry with us and protest violently.”
- in order to avoid rioting.

or there may be a riot among the people: This clause expresses a situation that the leaders intended to avoid.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

so that the people will not riot

in order to avoid a violent protest

because the people will riot (CEV)

During the feast there were many more people in Jerusalem than usual. They had come to the city to celebrate Passover and the Feast of Unleavened Bread. Many of these visitors to Jerusalem supported Jesus (see 11:8–10). The Jewish leaders were afraid to arrest Jesus during the feast. They thought that if they arrested Jesus, these visitors would be very angry and might even fight against them.

riot: A riot is a violent protest. In this context it means that a large number of people would gather and act in a disorderly way. They would do this to show their anger against the Jewish leaders because they caused Jesus to be arrested.

If your language does not have a specific term for riot, you may be able to use a descriptive phrase. For example:

the people might gather and show their anger against us.

We do not want the people to cause a disturbance

the people may act in a disorderly and violent way

General Comment on 14:2a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech in this verse. For example:

They told each other that they should not arrest him during the feast or the people might riot.

They decided to avoid the danger of popular protests by waiting for the feast to end and the crowds to go away. Then they would arrest him.

Mark 14:3

Section 14:3–9: A woman honored Jesus by pouring perfume on his head

In this section, Mark told how a woman honored Jesus. She did this by pouring very expensive perfume on his head while he was eating with some friends. Jesus said that what the woman did prepared his body for burial. Her action contrasted sharply with the way the Jewish leaders were plotting to arrest and kill Jesus in the previous section (14:1–2). It also contrasted with Judas’ offer to betray Jesus in the next section (14:10–11).

The events in this section happened in Bethany, which was near Jerusalem on the slope of the Mount of Olives. Before 14:3, the last reference to Jesus’ location was in 13:3, which tells us that “Jesus was sitting on the Mount of Olives.” Mark 11:11–12 indicates that Jesus stayed in Bethany at night and went to Jerusalem during the day.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A woman pours perfume on Jesus’ head

A woman honors Jesus at Bethany

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:6–13 and John 12:1–8.

14:3a**While Jesus was in Bethany**

- ¶ Jesus was in Bethany (GNT)
- ¶ Meanwhile, Jesus was in the village of Bethany.

14:3b**reclining at the table in the home of Simon the Leper,**

- eating in the house of a man who was called Simon the Leper.
- He and others went to eat at the house of that Simon whose leprosy had been cured. While they were eating,

14:3a–b

While Jesus was in Bethany reclining at the table in the home of Simon the Leper: The clause While Jesus was in Bethany introduces a new story that contrasts with the story in 14:1–2. While the chief priests and elders were plotting against him in 14:1–2, Jesus was in Bethany in the home of a friend. Begin this story in a natural way in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Meanwhile, Jesus was in Bethany at the home of Simon, a man who had leprosy. (NLT96)

Jesus was eating in Bethany at the house of Simon (CEV)

From 14:4a we know that Jesus was not eating alone. In some languages it may be more natural to indicate that here. For example:

Jesus and others

Bethany: Bethany was a village on the eastern slope of the Mount of Olives. It was about four kilometers from Jerusalem.

reclining at the table: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as reclining at the table is literally just “reclining” or “lying.” In this context it probably means that Jesus was lying on his side, on a low couch or cushion. His head was propped on one elbow. This was one of the positions that people of Jesus’ time used when they ate, especially if it was a special meal. However, the position is not in focus here. According to Louw & Nida people in Bible times ate in different positions. (1) They reclined on a couch or cushions facing a low table; (2) they sat on chairs around a table; and (3) they sat on cushions around a table.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Keep the position and add an explanatory phrase. For example:

reclining at the table (NIV)

lying on his side eating

- Use a position that people normally use for eating in your culture. For example, the RSV says:

as he sat at the table

- Omit the position and just say what Jesus was doing. For example, the GNT says:

While Jesus was eating

See also the notes on 2:15a, where the BSB translates a similar Greek word as “dining.”

In some languages it may be natural to first mention that Jesus was eating, and then introduce what happened while he was eating. For example:

Jesus was in Bethany, eating at the home of Simon the Leper. While he was eating...

Simon the Leper: The phrase Simon the Leper refers to a man named Simon who had been sick with the disease called “leprosy.” The name Simon was a common name, so people probably added the phrase the Leper to identify him.

According to Jewish law, lepers were not allowed to visit with healthy people or to eat with them. For this reason, most scholars believe that Simon was already healed from his leprosy. In some languages it may be best to indicate this explicitly. For example:

Simon, whose leprosy was healed

a man called Simon, who once had been a leper

Simon, a man who had suffered from a dreaded skin disease (GNT)

Leper: A Leper is a person who has a skin disease called “leprosy.” The Greek word that many English versions translate as “leprosy” refers to a variety of dreaded skin diseases. This same word occurs in 1:40a.

14:3c**a woman came with an alabaster jar**

- A woman arrived carrying a beautiful jar made of alabaster stone
- a certain woman entered the house. She brought/ carried a bottle made from a kind of stone called alabaster.

a woman came with an alabaster jar: This clause indicates that a woman came to the place where Jesus was. She was carrying a beautiful jar.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

a woman came in carrying a bottle made of alabaster

a certain woman brought a lovely/expensive stone vial

a woman: Mark does not indicate who this woman was. Introduce her into the story in a natural way in your language.

alabaster jar: An alabaster jar was a small, expensive container like a vial or bottle. It was made from a beautiful white and yellow stone called alabaster that came from Egypt.

Here are some other ways to translate the word alabaster:

- Borrow the word from a major language version and add a descriptive phrase. For example:

a flask/bottle made of alabaster

a jar/bottle made of a beautiful stone called alabaster If you use this option, be careful that the descriptive phrase fits smoothly into the story and does not distract the reader with unnecessary details. Interesting but unnecessary details can be put in a footnote if desired.

- Use a descriptive phrase that describes the significance of “alabaster” in the context. For example:

a beautiful bottle/vial

- Use a general term. For example:

a bottle (REB, GW)

You should not substitute a different locally-known material for “alabaster,” because this verse is describing a historical incident.

14:3d**of expensive perfume, made of pure nard.**

- that was filled with perfume. The perfume was very expensive because it was pure/genuine nard.
- This jar was filled with perfume. The perfume was made from pure nard oil, so its price was very high.

of expensive perfume, made of pure nard: The Greek word that the BSB translates as perfume refers here to a sweet-smelling oil. This particular perfume cost a lot of money.

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase of very expensive perfume, made of pure nard:

filled with a very expensive sweet-smelling oil made from pure nard

...filled with perfume. The price of this perfume was very high because it was made from pure/undiluted nard oil.

made of pure nard: The Greek word that most English versions translate as pure probably indicates that the nard was not diluted or mixed with anything else. It was one hundred percent nard. The nard would be very expensive because it was pure.

nard: The word nard is the name of the oil from a plant called spikenard or nard.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Borrow the term and spell it according to the sounds of your language. For example:

nardi

narade

- Borrow the term and add a descriptive phrase. For example:

an oil called nard

a good-smelling oil called nard

14:3e**She broke open the jar**

- The woman broke the jar

- She broke/snapped the mouth/neck of the bottle

She broke open the jar: The woman intentionally broke or snapped the narrow neck of the jar in order to open it and easily pour out the perfume. Opening the jar in this way may also have indicated that she intended to pour out all the perfume. A number of commentaries say that breaking the bottle also indicated that it could not be used again. None of the commentaries used in preparing these notes clarified whether there were alternate ways of opening sealed alabaster perfume flasks or whether such flasks could be resealed, so it is difficult to know whether the woman's intention was to keep the flask from being reused. It may be necessary to make some of the implied information explicit so that your readers understand why the woman broke the jar. For example:

She broke open the jar (NLT)

She opened the flask/bottle by breaking off its neck

She snapped/broke off the neck/lip of the bottle

Your translation should not imply that the woman smashed the entire jar or that she broke it over Jesus' head. It should also not imply that she broke it accidentally. In some languages it may be too awkward to clearly explain how the woman broke the jar. If that is true in your language, consider translating in a general way. For example:

She opened the bottle (GW)

14:3f

and poured it on Jesus' head.

- and poured the perfume on Jesus' head. (GNT)
- so that she could pour out all the perfume onto Jesus' head to honor him.

and poured it on Jesus' head: In Jewish culture people often poured oil on the head of an important guest. This showed courtesy and hospitality toward him. When the woman poured perfume on Jesus' head, she honored him in a greater way than guests were normally honored. In that culture women did not interrupt men who were eating except to serve them more food. So the woman showed special courage in pouring this expensive perfume on Jesus' head during the meal. The woman did not use ordinary anointing oil. She poured all the expensive perfume on Jesus.

In some cultures people may be confused by the action of pouring perfume on the head of a guest. It may express a wrong meaning. If this is true in your language, it may be necessary to indicate the purpose of the action. For example:

poured the perfume on his head to honor him

Mark 14:4

Section 14:3–9: A woman honored Jesus by pouring perfume on his head

In this section, Mark told how a woman honored Jesus. She did this by pouring very expensive perfume on his head while he was eating with some friends. Jesus said that what the woman did prepared his body for burial. Her action contrasted sharply with the way the Jewish leaders were plotting to arrest and kill Jesus in the previous section (14:1–2). It also contrasted with Judas' offer to betray Jesus in the next section (14:10–11).

The events in this section happened in Bethany, which was near Jerusalem on the slope of the Mount of Olives. Before 14:3, the last reference to Jesus' location was in 13:3, which tells us that "Jesus was sitting on the Mount of Olives." Mark 11:11–12 indicates that Jesus stayed in Bethany at night and went to Jerusalem during the day.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A woman pours perfume on Jesus' head

A woman honors Jesus at Bethany

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:6–13 and John 12:1–8.

14:4a

Some of those present, however, expressed their indignation to one another:

- Some of the people there were angry with the woman and said to one another,
- As for some of the people, they were upset by what the woman did, so they said to one another,
- Some of the people there became angry with her. They complained to one another

This part of the verse introduces how the other guests responded to what the woman did. Introduce it in a natural way in your language. See the Display for 14:4a.

Some of those present: The phrase Some of those present refers to other people who were also at Simon's house with Jesus. They were guests in Simon's house. Introduce them in a natural way in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Some of the people there (GNT)

Some of the other people there

expressed their indignation to one another: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as expressed their indignation to one another is literally "were indignant to themselves." In this context the phrase indicates that the people there criticized what the woman had done. They were angry about it and they told one another that they did not approve of what she had done. The phrase does not indicate that each guest was saying these things to himself in his own mind.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Some were annoyed/angry with the woman and said to one another

Some who were there became upset and said to each other

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate that it was what the woman did that caused the people to become indignant or angry. For example:

Some were upset by what the woman did and said to one another

The pouring out of perfume made some of the guests angry

14:4b

"Why this waste of perfume?"

- "Why did she waste such expensive perfume like this?"
- "How could she pour out this expensive perfume on Jesus like that? She has wasted it!"
- that she had wasted the perfume,

Why this waste of perfume?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses surprise and anger. The guests thought that the woman had wasted the perfume by pouring it on Jesus. There are at least three ways to translate this:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why did she waste such expensive perfume like this?

How could she pour all this costly perfume on Jesus and waste it like that?

- As a critical statement or exclamation. For example:

What a waste!

She should never have wasted this costly perfume!

Use whichever form is most natural in your language to express surprise and anger in this context.

Mark 14:5

Section 14:3–9: A woman honored Jesus by pouring perfume on his head

In this section, Mark told how a woman honored Jesus. She did this by pouring very expensive perfume on his head while he was eating with some friends. Jesus said that what the woman did prepared his body for burial. Her action contrasted sharply with the way the Jewish leaders were plotting to arrest and kill Jesus in the previous section (14:1–2). It also contrasted with Judas' offer to betray Jesus in the next section (14:10–11).

The events in this section happened in Bethany, which was near Jerusalem on the slope of the Mount of Olives. Before 14:3, the last reference to Jesus' location was in 13:3, which tells us that "Jesus was sitting on the Mount of Olives." Mark 11:11–12 indicates that Jesus stayed in Bethany at night and went to Jerusalem during the day.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A woman pours perfume on Jesus' head

A woman honors Jesus at Bethany

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:6–13 and John 12:1–8.

14:5a

It could have been sold for over three hundred denarii

- It was worth more than the money that a worker earns in a year. She should have sold it and used the money
- She could have sold it for more money than a worker receives for a year's work.
- which she should have sold for an extremely large amount of money

In Greek this verse begins with a conjunction that the RSV translates as “for.” It introduces a statement explaining why the people thought that the woman had wasted the perfume when she poured it on Jesus. Most English versions do not translate the conjunction. Introduce this explanatory statement in a natural way in your language.

It could have been sold for over three hundred denarii: This statement describes an action that did not happen. The perfume was not sold. Instead, the woman poured it out on Jesus. The guests thought that it would have been better to sell it and get the money than to pour the perfume on Jesus. Consider whether your language has a special way to describe something that people would like to happen that actually did not happen.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Rather it should have been sold.

It would have been better had she simply sold it.

over three hundred denarii: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as over three hundred denarii is literally “more than three hundred denarii.” A denarius was a Roman coin made of silver. It was the average daily wage, so it would take a worker about twelve months to earn three hundred denarii.

Most readers today will not know how much money “three hundred denarii” refers to. The main idea is that it was a large sum of money.

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase more than a year's wages:

three hundred silver coins (GNT)

more than a person earns in a year

a small fortune (NLT96)

You should avoid translating this phrase with a term for the particular kind of currency used in your area, for two reasons:

1. It would not be historically accurate.
2. If the value of your currency changes, your translation will become outdated.

Refer to how you translated the similar expression “two hundred denarii” in 6:37b.

14:5b

and the money given to the poor.”

- to help poor people.”
- Then she could have divided the money among poor people.”
- so that she could give it to the poor people.

and: The word and introduces a result of selling the perfume and getting the money.

the money given to the poor: It was a custom for the Jews to give gifts to poor people during Passover. If the woman had sold the perfume, she could have used the money that she received to help poor people. See how you translated the similar idea in 10:21c.

General Comment on 14:5a–b

The verbs in these two verse parts are passives. In some languages it may be necessary to express them as active verbs. The implied subject may be the woman or anyone in general. For example:

She could have sold it for more than a year's wages and given the money from the sale to poor people.

We could have sold this perfume for more than three hundred silver coins and given the money to the poor! (CEV)

14:5c

And they scolded her.

- Then they turned to the woman and strongly/ severely scolded her.
- Because of their anger, they then severely criticized the woman.
- So they began to angrily scold that woman.

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And introduces how the people responded to

the woman because they were indignant. After they expressed their indignation to one another (14:4a–b, 14:5a–b), they then rebuked the woman openly and directly.

Here are some other ways to connect 14:5c to 14:4a–14:5b:

Then

So (CEV)

Because of their anger

they scolded her: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as they scolded her means in this context that they showed anger by rebuking the woman.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

And they criticized her harshly. (GNT)

So they rebuked the woman strongly/severely.

Then they showed their anger by rebuking the woman.

Mark 14:6

Section 14:3–9: A woman honored Jesus by pouring perfume on his head

In this section, Mark told how a woman honored Jesus. She did this by pouring very expensive perfume on his head while he was eating with some friends. Jesus said that what the woman did prepared his body for burial. Her action contrasted sharply with the way the Jewish leaders were plotting to arrest and kill Jesus in the previous section (14:1–2). It also contrasted with Judas' offer to betray Jesus in the next section (14:10–11).

The events in this section happened in Bethany, which was near Jerusalem on the slope of the Mount of Olives. Before 14:3, the last reference to Jesus' location was in 13:3, which tells us that "Jesus was sitting on the Mount of Olives." Mark 11:11–12 indicates that Jesus stayed in Bethany at night and went to Jerusalem during the day.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A woman pours perfume on Jesus' head

A woman honors Jesus at Bethany

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:6–13 and John 12:1–8.

14:6a

But Jesus said, "Leave her alone;

- ¶ But Jesus said, "Leave^(plur) her in peace.
- ¶ Jesus, however, said, "Stop^(plur) causing her trouble!
- ¶ While they were criticizing the woman like this, Jesus said, "Stop^(plur) rebuking her!

But Jesus said: This verse begins with the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as But Jesus said. The conjunction But introduces what Jesus said to the people who were criticizing the women. His words contrast with what they said. In some languages it may be more natural to introduce Jesus' speech by repeating some information from the previous paragraph. For example:

While they were criticizing the woman in this way, Jesus said:

Leave her alone: In this context the command Leave her alone means "stop rebuking her" or "stop bothering her." It does not mean "go away and leave her by herself."

In some languages it may be best to translate this command in a positive way. For example:

Leave her in peace!

14:6b

why are you bothering her?

- Why are you^(plur) troubling her?
- Do not distress^(plur) her.
- You^(plur) should not be causing trouble for her!

why are you bothering her?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus asked this question to rebuke those who were scolding the woman. There are at least three ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the NCV says:

Why are you^(plur) troubling her?

- As a statement. For example:

You^(plur) should not trouble her.

- As a command. For example:

Do not trouble^(plur) her.

Stop^(plur) troubling her.

Use whichever form is most natural to express this rebuke in your language.

are you bothering: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as are...bothering is literally “cause trouble/distress.”

14:6c

She has done a beautiful deed to Me.

- She has done a lovely act for me.
- The act/thing that she has done to/for me is very good.
- Her pouring perfume on me is a good act/thing to do.

She has done a beautiful deed to Me: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as She has done a beautiful deed to Me is literally “she has done a good work to me.” In this context “good” means morally good, fitting or noble. It implies that the woman had acted in a very loving and generous way toward Jesus. She had greatly honored him by dedicating all the expensive perfume to him.

In some languages it may not be natural to describe an action as being beautiful. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The act/thing that she has done for/to me is very good.

Her pouring perfume on me is a good act/thing.

to Me: In this context the words to me may also be understood as “to benefit me,” that is, “for me.” For example:

She has done a fine and beautiful thing for me.
(GNT)

Mark 14:7

Section 14:3–9: A woman honored Jesus by pouring perfume on his head

In this section, Mark told how a woman honored Jesus. She did this by pouring very expensive perfume on his head while he was eating with some friends. Jesus said that what the woman did prepared his body for

burial. Her action contrasted sharply with the way the Jewish leaders were plotting to arrest and kill Jesus in the previous section (14:1–2). It also contrasted with Judas’ offer to betray Jesus in the next section (14:10–11).

The events in this section happened in Bethany, which was near Jerusalem on the slope of the Mount of Olives. Before 14:3, the last reference to Jesus’ location was in 13:3, which tells us that “Jesus was sitting on the Mount of Olives.” Mark 11:11–12 indicates that Jesus stayed in Bethany at night and went to Jerusalem during the day.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A woman pours perfume on Jesus’ head

A woman honors Jesus at Bethany

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:6–13 and John 12:1–8.

14:7a

The poor you will always have with you,

- For poor people will be among you^(plur) forever,
- There will always be poor people among you.^(plur)
- you^(plur) will always have needy people around,

In Greek this verse begins with a conjunction that is usually translated as “for” (as in the RSV). The BSB has left this conjunction implied. In this context it introduces an explanation for Jesus’ statement that the woman had done a good thing.

Here is another way to introduce this explanation:

The reason I say this is, poor people will always be...

Introduce this explanation in a way that is natural in your language.

The poor you will always have with you: This clause means, “There will always be poor people among you.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Poor people will always be around/with/among you.

Always there will be poor people around/among/ with you.

14:7b

and you can help them whenever you want.

- and you^(plur) can help them whenever you want to.
- Whenever you^(plur) want to do good things for them, you will be able to do so.
- and you^(plur) can benefit them whenever you^(plur) choose.

and you can help them whenever you want: In Greek the phrase that the BSB translates as whenever you want occurs in an emphatic position in the sentence. In English this emphasis or focus may be expressed by putting this phrase first. For example, the GNT says:

and any time you want to, you can help them

Use an order that is natural in your language to focus the reader's attention on the time phrase.

help them: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as help them is literally “do good to them.” It is a general expression that means to benefit them or help them.

14:7c

But you will not always have Me.

- But as for me, you^(plur) will not always have me here with you^(plur).
- But it is not much longer that I will be here among you^(plur).
- As for me, you^(plur) will have me among you for a very short time.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces a contrast with the previous verse part. Express this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

you will not always have Me: In Greek the word Me is the first word in this clause. This emphasizes the fact that in contrast to the poor, Jesus would not be among his disciples much longer. There was little time left for people to show Jesus honor and love.

Here are some other ways to express this statement:

As for me, I will be among you^(plur) only for a short time.

But you will not always/forever have me to be/ remain with you.^(plur)

Mark 14:8

Section 14:3–9: A woman honored Jesus by pouring perfume on his head

In this section, Mark told how a woman honored Jesus. She did this by pouring very expensive perfume on his head while he was eating with some friends. Jesus said that what the woman did prepared his body for burial. Her action contrasted sharply with the way the Jewish leaders were plotting to arrest and kill Jesus in the previous section (14:1–2). It also contrasted with Judas' offer to betray Jesus in the next section (14:10–11).

The events in this section happened in Bethany, which was near Jerusalem on the slope of the Mount of Olives. Before 14:3, the last reference to Jesus' location was in 13:3, which tells us that “Jesus was sitting on the Mount of Olives.” Mark 11:11–12 indicates that Jesus stayed in Bethany at night and went to Jerusalem during the day.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A woman pours perfume on Jesus' head

A woman honors Jesus at Bethany

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:6–13 and John 12:1–8.

14:8a

She has done what she could

- This woman has done the thing that she was able to do.
- This woman did the only thing she could do for me. (NCV)

She has done what she could: The Greek statement that the BSB translates as She has done what she could is literally “What she had, she did.” This statement implies that the woman did what she was able to do for him. She used what she had to honor Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

This woman has done the thing that she was able to do.

This woman did the only thing she could do for me (NCV)

She: It may be clearer to restate the pronoun She as “This woman.”

14:8b
to anoint My body in advance

- She has already poured perfume on me
- Even while I am still alive/living, she has poured perfume on me,

14:8c
of My burial.

- and prepared my body for burial.
- as though she were preparing me to be buried.

14:8b–c
to anoint My body in advance of My burial: This woman anointed Jesus body by pouring her costly perfume on Jesus to honor him. This action was similar to what the Jews did to prepare dead bodies for burial. Jesus knew that he would die two days later, and he accepted the woman’s action as preparation for his burial. She may not have known the full meaning of what she did. In your translation you should not imply that her own purpose was to prepare Jesus for burial. See the examples in the next note.

in advance of My burial: When the Jews prepared someone’s body for burial, they often put perfume or scented oil on it. (See Mark 16:1.)

in advance: The words in advance refer here to the time before Jesus would die and be buried.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

She has already poured perfume on me to prepare my body for burial.

While I am still alive/living, she has poured perfume on me, preparing me for my burial.

Just as perfume would be put on me to honor me when I die, now while I am alive, she has put it on me.

burial: Jews were often buried in tombs that were cut from rocks. Poor Jews were buried in graves in the ground. We know that Jesus was buried in a tomb (cave) carved from rock (15:46). It is good to avoid being too specific about how Jesus thought that people would bury him. For example:

to prepare my body for burial

General Comment on 14:8a–c

In some languages it may be more natural to use a different order for the parts of this verse. For example:

^{8b}This woman poured perfume on my head before I died, ^{8c}to prepare my body for being buried. ^{8a}That is what she was able to do for me.

Mark 14:9

Section 14:3–9: A woman honored Jesus by pouring perfume on his head

In this section, Mark told how a woman honored Jesus. She did this by pouring very expensive perfume on his head while he was eating with some friends. Jesus said that what the woman did prepared his body for burial. Her action contrasted sharply with the way the Jewish leaders were plotting to arrest and kill Jesus in the previous section (14:1–2). It also contrasted with Judas’ offer to betray Jesus in the next section (14:10–11).

The events in this section happened in Bethany, which was near Jerusalem on the slope of the Mount of Olives. Before 14:3, the last reference to Jesus’ location was in 13:3, which tells us that “Jesus was sitting on the Mount of Olives.” Mark 11:11–12 indicates that Jesus stayed in Bethany at night and went to Jerusalem during the day.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A woman pours perfume on Jesus’ head

A woman honors Jesus at Bethany

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:6–13 and John 12:1–8.

14:9a
And truly I tell you,

- You^(plur) can be confident of this truth:
- I assure you^(plur) that

And truly I tell you: Jesus often used the words truly I tell you to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. The clause truly I tell you also occurs in Mark 3:28, 8:12, 9:1, 9:41, 10:15, 11:23, 12:43, 13:30, 14:18, 14:25, 14:30. It indicates that the statement was important and totally reliable, and that people should

listen carefully to it. In this context it introduces a promise that Jesus made about the woman.

In some languages you may need to translate the phrase differently in different contexts. Do not translate in a way that implies that Jesus had not been telling the truth at other times.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

I assure you (GNT)

You can be confident of this

I can guarantee this truth (GW)

14:9b

wherever the gospel is preached in all the world,

- everywhere that the good news is preached all over the world,
- wherever in all the world people will tell the good news,

wherever the gospel is preached in all the world:

Here in all the world refers to the whole earth. It implies specifically to all the places where people live throughout the world.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

in every place in the world where people tell the good news

in the whole world wherever the good news is proclaimed

the gospel is preached: The clause the gospel is preached is passive. In some languages it may be more natural to make it active and include a subject like “people” or “they.” You may also want to use the future tense since Jesus is telling about what will take place later on. For example:

people will preach/tell the good news about me

gospel: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gospel means “good news.” In Mark, this word refers to the good news about Jesus Christ and the kingdom of God.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

good/sweet news

good news about Jesus Christ

good news from God

message/report that causes joy

Be sure that the term you choose does not refer only to a news report or to a story that is not true.

See how you translated this term in 1:1.

preached: The Greek word that the BSB translates as preached means to publicly tell people something important. In Mark, it usually refers to speaking about God and his kingdom to a group or crowd of people. The word should not only refer to what a preacher does in church.

Here are some other ways to translate preach:

announced

proclaimed

told

14:9c

what she has done will also be told in memory of her.”

- they will also tell what she has done, and people will remember her.”
- what this woman has done will be told, and so she will be remembered.”

This part of the verse indicates that Jesus’ followers will preach the good news about him throughout the world. The good thing that the woman did for Jesus will be told as part of sharing that good news. People who hear the good news about Jesus will also hear about the woman and her good deed, and they will remember her.

what she has done will also be told: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as what she has done will also be told is passive. In some languages it may be more natural to make it active. For example:

they will also tell about what she has done

in memory of her: The phrase in memory of her gives the result of telling about the woman’s act. Many people will remember her.

Here is another way to translate this:

and people will remember her (NCV)

Mark 14:10

Section 14:10–11: Judas told the chief priests that he would betray Jesus to them

This section continues the story from 14:1–2 about how the Jewish leaders wanted to arrest Jesus. In this section, one of Jesus' own disciples, Judas, agreed to betray Jesus and help the leaders arrest him.

Section 14:1–2 and Section 14:10–11 are similar in the theme of plotting to kill Jesus and in vocabulary. The chief priests and scribes were seeking to arrest Jesus in a sly and secret way. In the same way, Judas was seeking an opportunity to hand him over when not many people were around.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Judas agreed to betray Jesus to his enemies

Judas' agreement to betray Jesus

Judas Iscariot went and arranged to give Jesus to those who wanted to arrest him

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:14–16 and Luke 22:3–6.

14:10a

Then Judas Iscariot, one of the Twelve,

- ¶ Then Judas Iscariot, one of the twelve disciples,
- ¶ After this, Judas Iscariot, one disciple among the twelve disciples,

Then: In Greek this verse begins with the common connector that is often translated as “and.” In this context it introduces the next event in the story. This event probably occurred soon after the events in 14:3–9. Connect this section with the previous one in a natural way in your language.

Judas Iscariot: The name Judas Iscariot first appears in Mark 3:19. You should write it in the same way here.

one of the Twelve: The phrase one of the Twelve indicates that Judas belonged to the group of Jesus' twelve special disciples or apostles. The phrase the Twelve was first used in 4:10a.

In many languages, it will be necessary to specify “disciple(s)” or “apostle(s)” in one or more places. For example:

Judas Iscariot, one disciple / apostle among the twelve disciples/apostles

The information that Judas was one of the twelve disciples may be placed after 14:10b to emphasize that Judas was a traitor. See the General Comment on 14:10a–b below for an example.

14:10b

went to the chief priests to betray Jesus to them.

- went to the chief priests and offered to turn Jesus over to them.
- went to the chief priests in order to talk to them about helping them to seize Jesus.
- went to the chief priests and said “I want to help you^(plur) to arrest Jesus.”

went to the chief priests to betray Jesus to them:

Judas went to the chief priests in order to offer to help them arrest Jesus when no crowd was present.

chief priests: A Jewish priest was a man who offered sacrifices to God on behalf of the people. He also performed other rituals for them. The phrase chief priests refers to the leaders among these priests.

Here are some other ways to translate chief priests:

the leading/ruling priests

the elders among the Jewish sacrificers

the most prominent priests

See how you translated this term in 8:31c and 14:1b.

betray Jesus to them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as betray generally means “hand over or deliver to someone else's control or authority.” In this context, the implied information is that Judas offered to betray Jesus. Judas would complete the action of betraying Jesus when Judas actually led the guards to him so that they could arrest him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

went to the chief priests in order to make an agreement with them about helping them to seize/arrest Jesus

...went to the chief priests. He told them that he wanted to deliver Jesus into their control.

General Comment on 14:10b

In some languages it may be natural to translate this verse part using direct speech. For example:

...went to the chief priests and said, “I want to help you to arrest Jesus.”

General Comment on 14:10a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of information in this verse. For example:

^{10a}Then Judas Iscariot ^{10b}went to the chief priests in order to talk to them about helping them to seize Jesus. He did that even though ^{10a}he was one of the twelve disciples!

Mark 14:11**Section 14:10–11: Judas told the chief priests that he would betray Jesus to them**

This section continues the story from 14:1–2 about how the Jewish leaders wanted to arrest Jesus. In this section, one of Jesus’ own disciples, Judas, agreed to betray Jesus and help the leaders arrest him.

Section 14:1–2 and Section 14:10–11 are similar in the theme of plotting to kill Jesus and in vocabulary. The chief priests and scribes were seeking to arrest Jesus in a sly and secret way. In the same way, Judas was seeking an opportunity to hand him over when not many people were around.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Judas agreed to betray Jesus to his enemies

Judas’ agreement to betray Jesus

Judas Iscariot went and arranged to give Jesus to those who wanted to arrest him

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:14–16 and Luke 22:3–6.

14:11a**They were delighted to hear this,**

- They were delighted to hear Judas’s offer to betray Jesus,
- What he told them made them very happy.
- When they heard what he said, they were very pleased.

They were delighted to hear this: In some languages it may be necessary to say explicitly why the Jewish leaders were delighted. For example:

They were delighted to hear that he was willing to betray Jesus

In Greek the phrase that the BSB translates as to hear this comes at the beginning of the verse. In some languages it may be more natural to follow this order. For example:

Having heard his words, they were delighted

When they heard what he had to say, they rejoiced

14:11b**and they promised to give him money.**

- and they promised that when he did that, they would give him money.
- They assured/promised Judas that they would pay him for his help in arresting Jesus.

and they promised to give him money: The Jewish leaders told Judas that they would give him money if he betrayed Jesus. In this context their statement implies that they would give him the money if/when he was successful in helping them arrest Jesus. You may need to make some of this information explicit. For example:

They told him that if he enabled them to arrest Jesus, they would give him money.

They promised that they would give him money for doing that.

14:11c**So Judas began to look for an opportunity to betray Jesus.**

- So Judas went away and began to look for a good way to give/betray Jesus to them.
- Then Judas agreed, and as a result, he began to look for a chance to hand Jesus over to them.

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So here is the simple connector that is often translated as “and.” It introduces what happened as a result of the events in the previous verse part. Express this connection in a natural way in your language.

Judas began to look for an opportunity to betray

Jesus: The phrase began to look for an opportunity indicates that Judas began to look for the right time and manner to betray Jesus as he had agreed to do. In some languages there may be an idiom to express this idea.

to betray Jesus: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as betray is the same verb that is translated as “betray” in 14:10b. Consider whether in your language it would be more natural to use the same word here.

Mark 14:12**Section 14:12–21: Jesus celebrated the Passover Festival with his disciples**

In the previous section, 14:10–11, Judas began to look for a way to betray Jesus. In this section, Jesus and his disciples celebrated the Passover Festival together. People often celebrated the Festival of Passover with their families. Jesus celebrated it with his twelve closest disciples.

Normally, a teacher’s disciples prepared the celebration. But on this occasion Jesus had already arranged for a place to eat and for the food. Then he sent two of his disciples to make the final preparations. That evening as they were eating the Passover meal, Jesus told them that one of them would betray him.

Scholars have different views about when Jesus ate the Passover feast, but these views will probably not affect the way you translate the verses.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus and the disciples celebrated the Passover

Jesus Eats the Passover Meal with His Disciples (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:17–25, Luke 22:7–14, and John 13:21–30.

14:12a**On the first day of the Feast of Unleavened Bread,**

- ¶ It was the first day of the Feast/Festival of Unleavened Bread.
- ¶ Then the first day of the festival called “Bread without Yeast” arrived.

On the first day of the Feast of Unleavened Bread:

This verse begins a new part of the story about Jesus.

Most English versions begin this part of the story with the time phrase On the first day. In this context the first day refers to the day number one of the seven-day Feast of Unleavened Bread.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

It was now the first day of the Feast of Unleavened Bread (NCV)

When the first day of the Unleavened Bread Feast arrived

the Feast of Unleavened Bread: The phrase The Feast of Unleavened Bread refers to the festival during which the Jews ate only unleavened bread. Unleavened bread is bread made without yeast.

See how you translated this festival in 14:1a.

14:12b**when the Passover lamb was to be sacrificed,**

- This was the day when they/people sacrificed lambs for the festival called Passover,
- It was the day when it was the custom for each family to offer a young sheep to God to celebrate the festival called “Death Passed Us By.”

when the Passover lamb was to be sacrificed: The words that the BSB translates as when the Passover lamb was to be sacrificed are literally “when the Passover lamb was being sacrificed.” The tense of the verb indicates that this was the normal custom of the Jews. The first day of Unleavened Bread was the day when each family brought a lamb to the priest at the temple. The priest would kill the lamb and the family would eat it as part of the Passover feast that night.

In some languages a literal translation of Passover lamb may convey the wrong meaning that only one lamb was sacrificed for all the Jews. So it may be necessary to use the plural form. For example:

when they/Jews sacrifice their lambs for the Passover feast

the day the lambs for the Passover meal were killed (GNT)

Passover: The term Passover refers to one of the Jewish festivals. The Jewish people celebrated Passover to remember how the Lord delivered their ancestors from death. The angel of death “passed over” their homes

and did not kill their children. See the note on 14:1a for more details.

sacrificed: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as sacrificed means to offer or dedicate an animal to God by killing it. Here the focus of the word sacrificed is more on slaughtering or killing the lamb than on offering or dedicating it. Some languages require a long expression to translate the word “sacrifice.” If that is true in your language, it may be better to use a general term such as “slaughter” or “kill.” For example:

the day the lambs for the Passover meal were killed (GNT)

General Comment on 14:12a–b

The information in 14:12a–b is background information. It tells about what normally happened at the time of Passover and the Feast of Unleavened Bread. In some languages it may be necessary to use more than one sentence to express this information. For example:

It was the first day of the feast when the Jews ate unraised bread. On that day families customarily slaughtered a lamb for the feast called Passover. It was on that day of the feast that the disciples of Jesus...

14:12c

Jesus’ disciples asked Him,

- and Jesus’ disciples asked him,
- On that day, the followers of Jesus came/went to him and asked him

Jesus’ disciples asked Him: In some languages it may be necessary to introduce the disciples’ question by indicating that they came to Jesus. For example:

Jesus’ disciples came to him and asked

Jesus’ disciples gathered and approached Jesus. They asked him...

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means “learners” who are in a relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

students/learners

apprentices

followers

See how you translated this term at 2:15b. See also disciple in the Glossary for more information.

asked: The Greek word that the BSB translates as asked is a general verb that can be used to introduce any type of speech. In this context it introduces a question. Use a verb that is natural in your language.

14:12d–e

Where do You want us to prepare for You to eat the Passover?: The Old Testament required the Jews to celebrate the Passover in Jerusalem. Since Jesus and the disciples did not live in Jerusalem, they needed to arrange for a place there to eat the Passover meal. The question in this verse implies “where in Jerusalem do you want us to prepare for the Passover meal?”

14:12d

“Where do You want us to prepare

- “Where do you^(sing) want us^(excl) to go and prepare
- where he wanted them to go to prepare the food

want us to prepare: The words want us to prepare indicate here that the disciples expected Jesus to give them instructions about arranging for the Passover. Then he would send them to make arrangements with his authority. In some languages there may be a special expression to use in a situation like this. For example:

Where do you want to send us^(excl) to prepare...to eat the Passover?

What instructions do you have for us^(excl) about where to arrange for our^(incl) Passover celebration?

us: The pronoun us refers to the disciples. It does not include Jesus.

14:12e

for You to eat the Passover?”

- so that you^(sing) eat the Passover supper?”
- that they^(incl) would eat for the ‘Death Passed Us By’ feast.

for You to eat the Passover: In Greek, the form that the BSB translates as You is singular, but Jesus and the disciples would eat the Passover together. The disciples probably used a singular form because they

were focusing on Jesus as their leader. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate in some way that the disciples would also eat the Passover meal. For example:

Where do you^(sing) want us^(excl) to go to prepare food so that we^(incl) can eat the Passover supper?

eat the Passover: The phrase eat the Passover refers to eating the special meal that people ate when they celebrated the Passover festival.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

eat the food of the Festival of Passover

the Passover meal (GW)

Passover: See how you translated this term in 14:1a.

Mark 14:13

Section 14:12–21: Jesus celebrated the Passover Festival with his disciples

In the previous section, 14:10–11, Judas began to look for a way to betray Jesus. In this section, Jesus and his disciples celebrated the Passover Festival together. People often celebrated the Festival of Passover with their families. Jesus celebrated it with his twelve closest disciples.

Normally, a teacher's disciples prepared the celebration. But on this occasion Jesus had already arranged for a place to eat and for the food. Then he sent two of his disciples to make the final preparations. That evening as they were eating the Passover meal, Jesus told them that one of them would betray him.

Scholars have different views about when Jesus ate the Passover feast, but these views will probably not affect the way you translate the verses.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus and the disciples celebrated the Passover

Jesus Eats the Passover Meal with His Disciples (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:17–25, Luke 22:7–14, and John 13:21–30.

14:13a

So He sent two of His disciples and told them,

- ¶ So he sent two of his disciples with these instructions:
- ¶ So Jesus sent two of his followers to Jerusalem. This is what he told them:
- ¶ Then Jesus instructed/told two of his disciples,

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So and the RSV as “And” here introduces what Jesus did in response to the question that his disciples asked. Express this connection in a way that is natural in your language. In some languages it may be natural to use a phrase or clause. For example:

When they asked that, Jesus sent...

He sent two of His disciples and told them: Before Jesus sent his disciples to Jerusalem, he spoke the words that follow in 14:13b–15c. In some languages it may be natural to make this more explicit. For example:

So Jesus sent two of his disciples to Jerusalem with the following instructions:

In some languages a verb like sent may not be necessary, since it is implied when Jesus gave them instructions. For example:

So he told two of his disciples to prepare everything. He said to them:

14:13b

“Go into the city,

- “Go to the city,
- “You two go^(dual/plur) into the city of Jerusalem. When you^(dual/plur) arrive there,

Go into the city: The phrase the city refers to Jerusalem. Jesus and his disciples were staying in Bethany about four kilometers away.

14:13c

and a man carrying a jug of water will meet you.

- and a man will meet you. He will be carrying a large jar/jug of water.
- you will see a man there carrying a jar/pitcher full of water. When he meets you,
- you^(dual/plur) will meet a man going along with water in a jar/pitcher.

and: The word and introduces what will happen after the disciples enter the city.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

There...

When you have gone into the city...

When you have arrived in the city...

a man carrying a jug of water: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a man refers to an adult male. Normally only women carried water. They carried the water in jars on their heads. When men carried water, they used a container made of skin/leather. If the disciples saw a man carrying water in a jar, they would know that he was the man that they were looking for. He would show them the right house.

carrying: Use a general word for carrying if possible. It is most likely that a man in that society would carry a water jar on his shoulder. If your language requires you to be specific, you may use a term for carrying on the shoulder. However, if people in your culture normally carry water on their heads, you may use the normal expression for this.

jug of water: The phrase jug of water refers to an earthenware or clay jar, pitcher or jug containing water. If your language has a word that means “water jar/pitcher,” you can use it here. If people do not carry water in jugs in your culture, you may use a more general expression like “container of water.”

will meet you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as meet does not specify whether the man had planned to meet them. Try to leave this ambiguous in your language.

14:13d

Follow him,

- Follow/Accompany him.
- Go/Walk^(dual/plur) along behind/with him

Follow him: In this context the phrase Follow him means “go behind” or “go with.” It does not indicate that they should follow him at a distance without his knowledge. If a word like Follow would imply this in your language, you may need to use a different verb. For example:

Take the same path with him.

Mark 14:14

Section 14:12–21: Jesus celebrated the Passover Festival with his disciples

In the previous section, 14:10–11, Judas began to look for a way to betray Jesus. In this section, Jesus and his disciples celebrated the Passover Festival together. People often celebrated the Festival of Passover with their families. Jesus celebrated it with his twelve closest disciples.

Normally, a teacher’s disciples prepared the celebration. But on this occasion Jesus had already arranged for a place to eat and for the food. Then he sent two of his disciples to make the final preparations. That evening as they were eating the Passover meal, Jesus told them that one of them would betray him.

Scholars have different views about when Jesus ate the Passover feast, but these views will probably not affect the way you translate the verses.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus and the disciples celebrated the Passover

Jesus Eats the Passover Meal with His Disciples (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:17–25, Luke 22:7–14, and John 13:21–30.

14:14a

and whichever house he enters, say to the owner,

- At the house where he enters, say to the owner:
- to the house where he enters/goes. There, say to the owner of that house,
- When he enters a house, find the owner and tell him that

and whichever house he enters, say to the owner:

This part of the verse indicates that the man with the water jar would enter a house that someone else owned. Jesus told his disciples to follow the man with the water jar to that house, enter it, and talk to the owner. In some languages there may be a special way to introduce these facts. For example:

He will enter a house. Say to the owner of the house...

Follow him to the house where he enters/goes.
There say to that houseowner...

when he goes into a house, say to the owner...
(CEV)

14:14b–c

In this part of the verse Jesus told his disciples the question to ask the owner of the house. Jesus expressed the question using words like “I” and “my,” as if he himself would be there to ask the question. In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech for this question. See the General Comment on 14:14a–c in the note on 14:14c for an example.

Where is My guest room, where I may eat the Passover with My disciples?: Jesus asked this rhetorical question to express a request. He wanted the owner of the house to show his disciples the room where he and his disciples would eat the Passover meal. There are at least two ways to translate this request:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Could you show us the room where my disciples
and I will eat the Passover meal?

- As a request. For example:

Please show us the guest room where my disci-
ples and I may eat the Passover meal.

Use an appropriate way to express this request in your language.

General Comment on quotation marks

The words in this verse are translated by most English versions as a quote within a quote within a quote. This is three levels of quotation. For a suggestion on translation as an indirect quotation see the General Comment on 14:14a–c in the note on 14:14c.

In American English, the first direct quotation is indicated by enclosing the quoted words with double quotes (“”). A quotation within the quoted words is marked by using single quotes (‘’). A third level of quotation is usually marked by double quotes. For example:

Jesus said, “Tell him, ‘The teacher asks: “Where is...?” ’ ”

The BSB, NIV, and GNT do not mark the third level of quotation. Marking only two levels of quotation is probably easier for most readers to follow.

Jesus said, “Tell him, ‘The teacher asks: Where is...?’ ”

British practice is to mark the first quotation with single quotes (‘), then double quotes for the quote within a quote (“”), and so on.

Whichever method you use for marking quotations in your language, use it consistently. See how you treated a quote within a quote in 13:21.

14:14b

‘The Teacher asks: Where is My guest room,

- ‘Our^(excl) teacher asks you:^(sing) Where is the room reserved/prepared for me,
- ‘The Teacher wants you to show us the room that he has arranged to use
- your teacher wants him to show you the room

The Teacher: Jesus used the title The Teacher to tell his disciples how to refer to him when they spoke to the house owner. In some languages it may be more natural to say:

Our^(excl) teacher

Teacher: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Teacher was a title of respect for a Jewish religious leader. When the two disciples used this title, the owner of the house knew that they were referring to Jesus. See how you translated this term in 4:38c.

asks: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as asks is a general word meaning “says.” Introduce the request that follows in a way that is natural in your language. In some languages the verb may require an object like “you.^(sing)”

My guest room: In this context the phrase My guest room means “the room that you have reserved for me to use.” The phrase does not indicate that Jesus owned the room. It implies that Jesus had made arrangements beforehand with the owner of the house to use the room for the Passover meal.

Here are some other ways to translate my guest room:

the room reserved/prepared for me

the room that I arranged for

guest room: The Greek word that the BSB translates as guest room refers to a large room. People often used such a room as a dining room when they had guests. In some languages it may be better not to include a word like guest. For example, the GNT says:

Where is the room where my disciples and I will eat the Passover meal?

If you include a word like guest, be sure that it does not imply that Jesus was a stranger. The context indicates that the house owner knew Jesus.

14:14c where I may eat the Passover with My disciples?’

- so that I might eat the Passover meal with my disciples?’
- where he can eat with his followers to celebrate the festival of “Death Passed Us By.”

eat the Passover: See the note on 14:12d–e for a discussion of this expression.

General Comment on 14:14a–c

In this verse Jesus told his disciples what they should say. He told them how they should report his message to the owner of the house. Consider how people tell others to give messages to different people in your language. In some languages it may be necessary to use indirect speech for one or more of the quotations. For example:

Then say to the man who owns the house, “The Teacher wants you to show us the room where he can eat the Passover meal with his disciples.”

Then tell the man who owns the house that I, the Teacher, am asking where I can eat the Passover meal with my disciples.

Mark 14:15

Section 14:12–21: Jesus celebrated the Passover Festival with his disciples

In the previous section, 14:10–11, Judas began to look for a way to betray Jesus. In this section, Jesus and his disciples celebrated the Passover Festival together. People often celebrated the Festival of Passover with their families. Jesus celebrated it with his twelve closest disciples.

Normally, a teacher’s disciples prepared the celebration. But on this occasion Jesus had already arranged for a place to eat and for the food. Then he sent two

of his disciples to make the final preparations. That evening as they were eating the Passover meal, Jesus told them that one of them would betray him.

Scholars have different views about when Jesus ate the Passover feast, but these views will probably not affect the way you translate the verses.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus and the disciples celebrated the Passover

Jesus Eats the Passover Meal with His Disciples (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:17–25, Luke 22:7–14, and John 13:21–30.

14:15a

And he will show you a large upper room,

- Then the owner will show you a big room up above,
- He will lead you^(dual/plur) to a large room upstairs in the house.

And: In Greek this verse begins with the common conjunction that is often translated as “And” (as in the BSB). Here it introduces the event that Jesus said would happen next. Some English versions leaves this conjunction implied. Connect the events in a natural way in your language.

Here are some other ways to connect 14:15 to 14:14:

Then (GNT)

After you ask him that

he will show you a large upper room: The clause he will show you implies that he will take or lead the disciples to the room. In some languages it may be necessary to make this information explicit. For example:

He will lead you to a large room upstairs

The owner will take you upstairs and show you (CEV)

a large upper room: The phrase a large upper room implies that the owner’s house had a large room that

was built on top of the main part of the house. In some cultures this custom may be unknown. If this is unknown in your culture, you may want to consider one of these options:

- Use a descriptive phrase:

a large room built on the roof of the house.

- Use a more general expression that does not specify that the room was upstairs:

a large room in the house

14:15b

furnished and ready.

- ready for us^(incl)/you to use with everything we/you need.
- All things for having a feast are there.

furnished and ready: The phrase furnished and ready indicates that the room already had everything that the disciples needed for the meal. These things would include the table, places to sit, and dishes. Translate this expression in a general way. For example:

ready for you to use (CEV)

all things for having a feast were there

complete with utensils/furnishings

14:15c

Make preparations for us there.”

- Prepare the Passover meal for us^(incl) there.”
- So that is where you^(dual/plur) will go to make the food for us^(incl) to eat for the ‘Death Passed Us By’ feast.”

Make preparations for us there: In this context, the words Make preparations means “Get ready for the Passover meal.” The NCV makes this explicit:

Prepare the food for us there.

Mark 14:16

Section 14:12–21: Jesus celebrated the Passover Festival with his disciples

In the previous section, 14:10–11, Judas began to look for a way to betray Jesus. In this section, Jesus and his disciples celebrated the Passover Festival together. People often celebrated the Festival of Passover with

their families. Jesus celebrated it with his twelve closest disciples.

Normally, a teacher’s disciples prepared the celebration. But on this occasion Jesus had already arranged for a place to eat and for the food. Then he sent two of his disciples to make the final preparations. That evening as they were eating the Passover meal, Jesus told them that one of them would betray him.

Scholars have different views about when Jesus ate the Passover feast, but these views will probably not affect the way you translate the verses.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus and the disciples celebrated the Passover

Jesus Eats the Passover Meal with His Disciples (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:17–25, Luke 22:7–14, and John 13:21–30.

14:16a

So the disciples left

- ¶ So the disciples left Jesus
- ¶ Then those two disciples set out.

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So is the common conjunction that is often translated as “And” (as in the RSV). Here it connects what the disciples did in 14:16 to what Jesus said in 14:13–15. Some English versions express this with the word “then”. Connect these verses in a natural way in your language.

the disciples left: In some languages it may be necessary to supply an object for the verb left. For example:

The disciples left Jesus

The disciples left that place

They went to do what Jesus told them to do.

14:16b

and went into the city,

- and went to the city.
- They^(dual) went up to that/the city of Jerusalem,

and went into the city: The words the city refer to Jerusalem. Refer back to it in a natural way in your language. For example:

went to the city of Jerusalem

went to that city

14:16c

where they found everything as Jesus had described.

- There they^(dual) found all things to be just as Jesus had told them.
- and everything happened just as Jesus had said.

where they found everything as Jesus had described: This part of the verse indicates that everything happened just as Jesus had said it would. The man with the water pot met the disciples and they found the right house. They saw that the room had everything that they needed.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Everything happened as Jesus had said (NCV)

When they arrived in the city, they saw that everything was as Jesus had told them it would be.

14:16d

And they prepared the Passover.

- So they prepared what they were going to eat for the feast of Passover.
- Then they^(dual) got ready the things to eat for the feast called “Death Passed Us By.” After that, they returned to Jesus and the other disciples.

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And here introduces what happened as a result of 14:16c. The disciples found everything as Jesus said, so they prepared the Passover. Some English versions translate this conjunction as “then” or “so.” Connect these verse parts in a way that is natural in your language.

they prepared the Passover: The two disciples prepared the Passover meal. They set out the unleavened bread and the wine, prepared the bitter herbs and sauce, and perhaps roasted the Passover lamb.

Passover: The Passover was mentioned in 14:14. Refer back to it in a natural way in your language. In some languages you may not have to repeat the full phrase for Passover. For example:

They prepared the feast.

They got ready the things to eat for the feast.

After the two disciples prepared the Passover meal, they returned to Jesus and the other disciples, as the text implies in 14:17. In some languages it may be necessary to make that explicit. For example:

and then returned to Jesus and the other disciples

Mark 14:17

Section 14:12–21: Jesus celebrated the Passover Festival with his disciples

In the previous section, 14:10–11, Judas began to look for a way to betray Jesus. In this section, Jesus and his disciples celebrated the Passover Festival together. People often celebrated the Festival of Passover with their families. Jesus celebrated it with his twelve closest disciples.

Normally, a teacher’s disciples prepared the celebration. But on this occasion Jesus had already arranged for a place to eat and for the food. Then he sent two of his disciples to make the final preparations. That evening as they were eating the Passover meal, Jesus told them that one of them would betray him.

Scholars have different views about when Jesus ate the Passover feast, but these views will probably not affect the way you translate the verses.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus and the disciples celebrated the Passover

Jesus Eats the Passover Meal with His Disciples (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:17–25, Luke 22:7–14, and John 13:21–30.

Paragraph 14:17–21

This paragraph describes the final meal that Jesus ate with his twelve disciples before he died. At this meal, Jesus revealed that one of the twelve would betray him. He knew that Judas was the person who would betray him, but none of the other disciples knew.

In Middle Eastern culture, when a man eats a meal with another man, he must not then turn against him

and harm him. But Judas did that. He behaved as though Jesus were his friend and then deliberately betrayed him. Jesus warned that Judas would be judged for what he did (14:21).

14:17a

When evening came,

- ¶ When it was dark,
- ¶ That evening,

When evening came: The phrase When evening came refers to sometime after sunset. It was the custom of the Jews to eat the Passover meal at night. It is good to use a general term in your language that refers to a time after dark.

Here are some other ways to translate the beginning of this paragraph:

That evening

When it was dark

After the sun had set

14:17b

Jesus arrived with the Twelve.

- Jesus arrived there with the twelve disciples.
- Jesus came into the city and arrived at the place to eat the feast with his twelve followers.

Jesus arrived with the Twelve: The word arrived indicates that Jesus and the disciples came to the place where they would eat the Passover meal.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

arrived there

arrived at the house

came into the city and arrived at the place to eat the feast

the Twelve: The phrase the Twelve refers to Jesus' twelve closest disciples. It includes the two disciples who made the preparations in 14:13–16. See how you translated this term in 14:10a.

Mark 14:18

Section 14:12–21: Jesus celebrated the Passover Festival with his disciples

In the previous section, 14:10–11, Judas began to look for a way to betray Jesus. In this section, Jesus and his disciples celebrated the Passover Festival together. People often celebrated the Festival of Passover with their families. Jesus celebrated it with his twelve closest disciples.

Normally, a teacher's disciples prepared the celebration. But on this occasion Jesus had already arranged for a place to eat and for the food. Then he sent two of his disciples to make the final preparations. That evening as they were eating the Passover meal, Jesus told them that one of them would betray him.

Scholars have different views about when Jesus ate the Passover feast, but these views will probably not affect the way you translate the verses.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus and the disciples celebrated the Passover

Jesus Eats the Passover Meal with His Disciples (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:17–25, Luke 22:7–14, and John 13:21–30.

Paragraph 14:17–21

This paragraph describes the final meal that Jesus ate with his twelve disciples before he died. At this meal, Jesus revealed that one of the twelve would betray him. He knew that Judas was the person who would betray him, but none of the other disciples knew.

In Middle Eastern culture, when a man eats a meal with another man, he must not then turn against him and harm him. But Judas did that. He behaved as though Jesus were his friend and then deliberately betrayed him. Jesus warned that Judas would be judged for what he did (14:21).

14:18a

And while they were reclining and eating,

- While they were eating together,
- They sat down and started to eat. While they were eating,

they were reclining and eating: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as reclining, refers to “reclining” or “lying” by a table in order to eat. In this context it probably means that Jesus and his disciples were lying on one side, on a low couch or cushion. Their heads were propped on one elbow. This was one of the positions that people of Jesus’ time used when they ate, especially if it was a special meal.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Keep the position and add an explanatory phrase. For example:

reclining at the table (NIV)

lying on their sides eating

- Use a position that people normally use when they eat in your culture. For example, the REB says:

they sat at supper

- Omit the position and just say what Jesus and his disciples were doing. For example, the CEV says:

Jesus and the twelve disciples were eating together

This same phrase occurs in 14:3a–b. You should translate it here as you did there.

14:18b

Jesus said, “Truly I tell you, one of you who is eating with Me will betray Me.”

- he said, “I tell you truly, one of you^(plur) will give me into the hands/power of people who want to kill me. That one is eating this meal with me.”
- Jesus said, “I assure you that one of you^(plur) will help my enemies capture me. He is even eating with me now.”

Truly I tell you: Jesus often used the words Truly I tell you to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. The clause Truly I tell you also occurs in 3:28a, 8:12, 9:1, 9:41, 10:15, 11:23, 12:43, 13:30, 14:9, 14:25, 14:30. His words indicate that the statement was important and totally reliable, and that people should listen carefully to it.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

I can guarantee this truth (GW)

You can be certain that...

In some languages you may need to translate the phrase differently in different contexts. Do not translate in a way that implies that Jesus had not been telling the truth at other times. See how you translated this phrase in 14:9a.

one of you who is eating with Me: In this context the phrase one of you who is eating with Me indicates that a person who was eating with Jesus at that moment would later betray him. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

he will be one who is now eating with me

eating with Me: In Jewish culture eating together implied friendship and loyalty. In some languages there may be an idiom for eating with someone that would be appropriate in this context. In one language, it is “to mix up hands with a person.”

one of you...will betray Me: Jesus told his twelve disciples that one of them would hand Jesus over to his enemies.

The word betray means “to deliver a person into the control of someone else.” Here are some other ways to translate Jesus’ statement in this context:

one of you will give me into the hands of the people who want to kill me

one of you will help my enemies capture me

one of you will turn against me (NCV)

This same word occurs in 14:10b.

Mark 14:19

Section 14:12–21: Jesus celebrated the Passover Festival with his disciples

In the previous section, 14:10–11, Judas began to look for a way to betray Jesus. In this section, Jesus and his disciples celebrated the Passover Festival together. People often celebrated the Festival of Passover with their families. Jesus celebrated it with his twelve closest disciples.

Normally, a teacher’s disciples prepared the celebration. But on this occasion Jesus had already arranged for a place to eat and for the food. Then he sent two of his disciples to make the final preparations. That

evening as they were eating the Passover meal, Jesus told them that one of them would betray him.

Scholars have different views about when Jesus ate the Passover feast, but these views will probably not affect the way you translate the verses.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus and the disciples celebrated the Passover

Jesus Eats the Passover Meal with His Disciples
(GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:17–25, Luke 22:7–14, and John 13:21–30.

Paragraph 14:17–21

This paragraph describes the final meal that Jesus ate with his twelve disciples before he died. At this meal, Jesus revealed that one of the twelve would betray him. He knew that Judas was the person who would betray him, but none of the other disciples knew.

In Middle Eastern culture, when a man eats a meal with another man, he must not then turn against him and harm him. But Judas did that. He behaved as though Jesus were his friend and then deliberately betrayed him. Jesus warned that Judas would be judged for what he did (14:21).

14:19a

They began to be grieved

- Then they were sad,
- When they heard these words, they felt sorrow/grief,

In this verse Mark told how the disciples responded to what Jesus said in 14:18. They were sad. The Greek text does not have a connector here, but in some languages it may be natural to make the connection explicit.

Here are some other ways to express the connection between 14:18 and 14:19:

Then they were sad.

When Jesus' disciples heard that, they were sad.

This word grieved them.

They began to be grieved: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as They began to be grieved is literally “They began to be sad.” Mark’s use of the verb “began” is complex. In this context it does not imply that the disciples began to be sad but then soon lost their sadness. If it is confusing in your language to use a verb like “begin” here, you may leave this idea implicit.

grieved: The word grieved can also be translated as “sorrowful,” “distressed,” or “sad.” This word was also used in 10:22.

14:19b

and to ask Him one after another,

- and they said to him one by one,
- and they took turns saying to him,

14:19c

“Surely not I?”

- “It is not I, is it?”
- “You do not mean me, do you?”

14:19b–c

and to ask Him one after another, “Surely not I?”:

The disciples were grieved and horrified by what Jesus had just said. They did not know to which one of them Jesus was referring. Each of them asked him, “Surely I am not the one who will betray you, am I?” This is a question that hopes for the answer, “No, you are not the one.”

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

Surely, not I? (NRSV)

You don’t mean me, do you?

one after another: Each disciple asked in turn and not all together at one time.

Mark 14:20

Section 14:12–21: Jesus celebrated the Passover Festival with his disciples

In the previous section, 14:10–11, Judas began to look for a way to betray Jesus. In this section, Jesus and his disciples celebrated the Passover Festival together. People often celebrated the Festival of Passover with their families. Jesus celebrated it with his twelve closest disciples.

Normally, a teacher’s disciples prepared the celebration. But on this occasion Jesus had already arranged for a place to eat and for the food. Then he sent two of his disciples to make the final preparations. That

evening as they were eating the Passover meal, Jesus told them that one of them would betray him.

Scholars have different views about when Jesus ate the Passover feast, but these views will probably not affect the way you translate the verses.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus and the disciples celebrated the Passover

Jesus Eats the Passover Meal with His Disciples (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:17–25, Luke 22:7–14, and John 13:21–30.

Paragraph 14:17–21

This paragraph describes the final meal that Jesus ate with his twelve disciples before he died. At this meal, Jesus revealed that one of the twelve would betray him. He knew that Judas was the person who would betray him, but none of the other disciples knew.

In Middle Eastern culture, when a man eats a meal with another man, he must not then turn against him and harm him. But Judas did that. He behaved as though Jesus were his friend and then deliberately betrayed him. Jesus warned that Judas would be judged for what he did (14:21).

14:20a

He answered, “It is one of the Twelve—

- He replied, “It is one of you twelve disciples,
- He replied, “One of you, my own twelve followers will do it,

He answered, “It is one of the Twelve: Here Jesus was speaking directly to the twelve disciples. In many languages it is necessary to indicate that explicitly, perhaps with a word like “you.” For example:

“It is one of you, my twelve disciples,” he replied

He answered: Place the words He answered where it is natural in your language.

14:20b

the one who is dipping his hand into the bowl with Me.

- a person who is dipping his bread into the same dish with me.

- one who is eating from this dish with me.

the one who is dipping his hand into the bowl with Me:

The Greek clause that the BSB translates as the one who is dipping his hand into the bowl with Me is literally “one who dips into the bowl with me.” (The BSB has supplied the word hand.) When Jesus and the disciples ate the meal, they dipped pieces of bread into a bowl that contained a sauce of some kind. They all shared the same bowl of sauce.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

one who dips with Me in the bowl (NASB)

one who dips bread into the bowl with me (NIV)

one who dips his bread in the dish with me (GNT)

one who dips his hand with me into the bowl (NET)

one...who is eating from this dish with me (CEV)

All of them ate from the same bowl, so Jesus’ statement does not identify which disciple would betray him. His statement indicated that the person who would betray him was one of his close friends.

Mark 14:21

Section 14:12–21: Jesus celebrated the Passover Festival with his disciples

In the previous section, 14:10–11, Judas began to look for a way to betray Jesus. In this section, Jesus and his disciples celebrated the Passover Festival together. People often celebrated the Festival of Passover with their families. Jesus celebrated it with his twelve closest disciples.

Normally, a teacher’s disciples prepared the celebration. But on this occasion Jesus had already arranged for a place to eat and for the food. Then he sent two of his disciples to make the final preparations. That evening as they were eating the Passover meal, Jesus told them that one of them would betray him.

Scholars have different views about when Jesus ate the Passover feast, but these views will probably not affect the way you translate the verses.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus and the disciples celebrated the Passover

Jesus Eats the Passover Meal with His Disciples (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:17-25, Luke 22:7-14, and John 13:21-30.

Paragraph 14:17-21

This paragraph describes the final meal that Jesus ate with his twelve disciples before he died. At this meal, Jesus revealed that one of the twelve would betray him. He knew that Judas was the person who would betray him, but none of the other disciples knew.

In Middle Eastern culture, when a man eats a meal with another man, he must not then turn against him and harm him. But Judas did that. He behaved as though Jesus were his friend and then deliberately betrayed him. Jesus warned that Judas would be judged for what he did (14:21).

14:21

This verse indicates that Jesus would die, just as the Scriptures said he would. It expresses a contrast: Judas fulfilled God's plan when he betrayed Jesus, but it was an evil action that he freely chose to do. In your translation you should avoid the wrong impression that God forced Judas to betray Jesus. See the note on 14:21c.

14:21a

The Son of Man will go

- For the Son of Man must go to his death,
- Someone will indeed betray me, the Son of Man, and I will die.

In Greek this verse begins with a conjunction that often indicates reason or cause. The RSV translates it as “for” here. In this context it probably indicates that this part of the verse explains something about what Jesus said in 14:18 and 14:20. In some languages this connection may be implied without using a connector.

Here is another way to express this connection:

This will happen because the Son of Man must/ will go

The Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as The Son of Man is literally “the Son of the human/person.” Jesus used this title to imply that:

1. he was a true human being, and he represented all people.
2. he came from God and had authority from God.

Try to use an expression that implies both meanings. Here are some other expressions that translators have used:

the Man whom God Sent

the True Man from God/Heaven

the Representative of Mankind

The Older Brother of All People

In some cases, an unusual title may correctly suggest a deeper meaning. For example:

the Child of a Person

the One who was Born as a Human

Translators have also used expressions that are more literal. These more literal expressions may be appropriate where readers are familiar with a literal title in another version.

In some languages it may be necessary to use a form like “I” or “me” to indicate that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

me, the Son of Man

I who became man/human

This same term occurs in 2:10a and 13:26a.

will go: Jesus used the phrase will go to speak about his dying in an indirect way. He wanted to spare his disciples the pain that they would feel if he spoke directly about his death. If you have a way to talk about dying using a euphemism like this, you may be able to use it here. Otherwise, you can speak directly about Jesus' death. For example:

I, the Son of Man, will die

14:21b

just as it is written about Him,

- as they wrote about him in God's word.
- That is what it says in the written words of God.

just as it is written about Him: Jesus was not referring here to how he would die. Rather, he was referring

to the fact that the prophets had already written that he would die. He may have been thinking of such Old Testament passages as Isaiah chapter 53. In some languages it may be necessary to put the phrase just as it is written about Him at the beginning of the sentence. For example:

Just as it is written of the Son of Man, so he will die.

Just as it is written of me, the Son of Man, so will I die.

it is written: The phrase it is written is a special phrase that the Jews used to refer to the Old Testament. The phrase is passive. It does not focus on the person who wrote the words. The phrase implies that God is the one who caused the words to be written. In some languages it may be necessary to make the meaning of this phrase more explicit. For example:

as the Scriptures say (GNT)

as it says in the written words of God

That is exactly what God caused to be written

as someone wrote in God's Word

See also 1:2a and 7:6b.

14:21c

but woe to that man by whom He is betrayed!

- But how terrible it will be for that man who hands me, the Son of Man, over to be killed!
- Even though God's word says the Son of Man will die, suffering will come on that man who betrays me.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but introduces a contrast between 14:21a–b and 14:21c. In 14:21a–b the text indicates that it was written in the Scripture that Jesus must die, and that what is written there must happen. 14:21c implies that although those things must happen, the person who betrays Jesus will endure a terrible future. Most English versions use but to introduce the contrast.

Here is another way to express this connection:

Even though God's word says that the Son of Man will die

woe to that man: The word woe is an exclamation. It emphasizes suffering, trouble, or disaster. In this context Jesus expressed his sorrow and pity about the terrible suffering or judgment that would come to the person who betrayed him. This exclamation is not a curse or a threat. Jesus did not wish that Judas would have to endure the trouble and suffering.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

But suffering will come on that man...!

But how bad it will be for that man...!

But it is going to be terrible for the one who betrays me. (CEV)

that man by whom He is betrayed: The phrase that man by whom He is betrayed refers to the person who would betray Jesus. Jesus knew that the person was Judas, but this phrase does not indicate that he was pointing him out to the other disciples.

is betrayed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as is betrayed is the same word as in 14:18b. Translate here as you did there.

14:21d

It would be better for him if he had not been born."

- That man's situation would be better if he had not been born."
- Concerning this man, if no one had given birth to him, that would be good/better."

It would be better for him if he had not been born:

This clause expresses a comparison between two situations for Judas:

1. betraying Jesus, and
2. not being born.

If Judas had not been born, he would not have betrayed Jesus. That would have been much better than what actually happened. Consider how in your language you talk about situations that never happened. Here are some other ways to express this in English:

It would have been better for this man to have never been born at all.

Mark 14:22

Section 14:22–26: Jesus gave his disciples bread and wine with a special meaning

When a Jewish family ate the Passover meal, specifically during the third part of the Passover meal (see the discussion of the different parts of the Passover meal in 14:17–21), the head of the household broke some bread and offered it to his family. Then he explained how certain foods in the meal reminded them of the time when God delivered their ancestors from slavery.

In this section Jesus broke pieces of bread, gave them to his disciples, and said to them, “This is my body.” When Jesus said this, he gave the Passover bread new meaning. Later on, after the main meal, Jesus took a cup of wine and gave it to his disciples for them to drink from. He said, “This is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many.” When he said this, he gave new meaning to the Passover wine.

Jesus identified the bread and wine with himself. He told his followers to continue to take bread and wine together to remember him and that he died for them (see Luke 22:19 and 1 Corinthians 11:24–26). Christians now have several names for this ritual: “The Lord’s Supper,” “Communion,” and “the Eucharist.” Almost all Christian churches observe this ritual.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Lord’s Supper

Jesus gives new meaning to the bread and wine

Jesus instituted the Eucharist/Communion

Jesus’ last meal with his disciples

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:26–30; Luke 22:14–20, 39; and 1 Corinthians 11:23–25.

14:22a

While they were eating,

- ¶ While they were still eating,
- ¶ As Jesus and his followers were eating,

While they were eating: The event in 14:22b began while Jesus and his disciples were still eating the Passover meal.

14:22b

Jesus took bread, spoke a blessing and broke it,

- Jesus took bread and thanked God for it. Then he broke/tore the bread
- Jesus picked up some bread from the table. When he had said “Thank you” to God for it, he tore/divided it into pieces.

14:22b–c

Jesus took bread, spoke a blessing and broke it, and gave it to the disciples, saying: These verse parts have four verbs that describe four things that Jesus did. Connect these actions in a natural way in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Jesus took a loaf of bread and asked God’s blessing on it. Then he broke it in pieces and gave it to the disciples, saying... (NLT96)

...he took bread, and after giving thanks he broke it, gave it to them, and said... (NET)

[As they ate,] he took bread. He gave thanks for it. Then he broke it. He gave it to his disciples. He said...

See how you translated similar ideas in 6:41c and 8:6b–c. You may be able to use some of the same expressions here.

took bread: The phrase took bread indicates here that Jesus picked up a piece of bread from the table. In some languages some of the implied information may need to be made explicit. For example:

took some bread in his hands (CEV)

picked up some bread from the table (TRT)

bread: The bread that the Jews ate at Passover was flat and round. It was made without yeast.

spoke a blessing: The Greek word that the BSB translates as spoke a blessing is literally “having blessed.” In this context it means that Jesus praised God and thanked him for the bread that he provided for them. It may refer to a traditional Hebrew blessing that the Jews used to praise God for bread. This blessing can be translated as, “Blessed are You, O Lord our God, King of the universe, who brings forth bread from the earth.”

Here are some other ways to translate spoke a blessing:

having said the blessing (REB)

thanked God for it (NCV)

blessed God because of the bread

said a prayer, praising God for the bread

The same Greek word occurs in 6:41. See *bless*, Meaning 4, in the Glossary.

In some languages it may be more natural to use a direct quote to express the meaning of spoke a blessing. For example:

He said to God, “We bless you, O God”

broke it: In this context the verb broke indicates that Jesus tore or divided the flat bread into two or more pieces with his hands.

In some languages, there is one verb that includes both “break off a piece of food” and “give it (to another to eat.)” If this is true in your language, it may be appropriate to use it here. See how you translated “broke” in 6:41c and 8:6c.

14:22c and gave it to the disciples, saying,

- and gave/handed it to his disciples. He said,
- Then he gave/passed the bread to his followers, saying to them,

gave it to the disciples: After Jesus broke the bread, he distributed it among the disciples. Jesus may have broken the bread in half and given the two halves to two disciples, who then broke them in pieces for the other disciples. Or, he may have given one small piece to each disciple.

saying: In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit that Jesus was speaking to the disciples. It may also be more natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

He said to them

14:22d “Take it; this is My body.”

- “Take^(plur) this bread and eat^(plur) it, for this is my body.”
- “Here is my body; receive^(plur) and eat^(plur) it.”

Take it: In this context the phrase Take it means “Take this bread” or “Take some of this bread.” It implies that they should also eat it. In some languages it may be necessary to make that explicit. For example:

Take some of this bread and eat it.

this is My body: The word this refers to the bread that Jesus had given his disciples. Churches have different views about exactly what the words this is my body imply. Because of this, it is probably best to translate literally.

body: The word body here refers to Jesus’ living body. Be careful not to use a word that means corpse. In some languages the closest equivalent of body may be an expression such as “flesh/meat and bones” or a word such as “myself.” These suggestions come from the UBS (page 439), which also advocates a literal translation of the phrase “This is my body.” They reflect the realities of languages in which there is no appropriate word for “body.”

Mark 14:23

Section 14:22–26: Jesus gave his disciples bread and wine with a special meaning

When a Jewish family ate the Passover meal, specifically during the third part of the Passover meal (see the discussion of the different parts of the Passover meal in 14:17–21), the head of the household broke some bread and offered it to his family. Then he explained how certain foods in the meal reminded them of the time when God delivered their ancestors from slavery.

In this section Jesus broke pieces of bread, gave them to his disciples, and said to them, “This is my body.” When Jesus said this, he gave the Passover bread new meaning. Later on, after the main meal, Jesus took a cup of wine and gave it to his disciples for them to drink from. He said, “This is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many.” When he said this, he gave new meaning to the Passover wine.

Jesus identified the bread and wine with himself. He told his followers to continue to take bread and wine together to remember him and that he died for them (see Luke 22:19 and 1 Corinthians 11:24–26). Christians now have several names for this ritual: “The Lord’s Supper,” “Communion,” and “the Eucharist.” Almost all Christian churches observe this ritual.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Lord's Supper

Jesus gives new meaning to the bread and wine

Jesus instituted the Eucharist/Communion

Jesus' last meal with his disciples

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:26–30; Luke 22:14–20, 39; and 1 Corinthians 11:23–25.

14:23a

Then He took the cup,

- Later, he took a cup of wine.
- After that, he also took a cup containing the juice of grapes.

Then: In Greek this verse begins with the simple connector that is often translated as “and.” The BSB uses the word Then here because it introduces the next event. Use a natural expression in your language for introducing the next event in a story. For example:

Then

After that

He took the cup: The Greek words that the BSB translates as He took the cup are literally “having taken a cup.” This cup was full of wine. This wine reminded the Jews of the lamb's blood that their ancestors put over their doors so that their firstborn sons would be saved from death. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example, the NLT says:

he took a cup of wine.

Wine is a drink made from the fermented juice of grapes. If you need to mention “wine,” use the same word as in 2:22a.

It is a historical fact that they drank wine. However, the fact that it was fermented is not in focus. So you can also translate this as:

he took a cup filled with juice made from a fruit called grapes

In some areas, people do not have a drink made from the fermented juice of grapes. If that is true in your

area, you may need to use a more general expression. For example:

cup of fermented fruit juice

cup: The type of cup that Jesus used was probably made from clay. It may have been like a bowl. The disciples present would drink in turn from the same cup.

In your translation you may use a term that refers to the type of container that people normally drink from. Some examples are: a glass, a gourd or a metal container.

14:23b

gave thanks, and gave it to them,

- When he had thanked God for it, he gave/handed it to them,
- After he said thank you to God for it, he offered/ passed the cup/wine to his followers.

gave thanks: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as gave thanks indicates here that Jesus thanked God for the wine. He also did that for the bread in 14:22. This is not the same Greek verb that Mark used in 14:22. See the note in 14:22b–c for a discussion of the different Greek verb used in that verse.

and gave it to them: The Greek verb that the BSB translates here as gave is the same word that it translated as “gave” in 14:22c. It indicates that Jesus gave or handed his disciples the cup so that they would drink some of the wine in it.

Here are some other verbs that may be appropriate here:

gave

handed

passed

Use a word that is natural in your language for this kind of action.

14:23c

and they all drank from it.

- and the disciples all drank some of it.
- They then passed it from one to the other, and they all drank some of the wine.

and they all drank from it: Each of the disciples took the cup one by one, and each person drank some of

the wine in the cup. In some languages some of this implied information may need to be made explicit. For example:

They all passed it around and drank some of the wine.

Mark 14:24

Section 14:22–26: Jesus gave his disciples bread and wine with a special meaning

When a Jewish family ate the Passover meal, specifically during the third part of the Passover meal (see the discussion of the different parts of the Passover meal in 14:17–21), the head of the household broke some bread and offered it to his family. Then he explained how certain foods in the meal reminded them of the time when God delivered their ancestors from slavery.

In this section Jesus broke pieces of bread, gave them to his disciples, and said to them, “This is my body.” When Jesus said this, he gave the Passover bread new meaning. Later on, after the main meal, Jesus took a cup of wine and gave it to his disciples for them to drink from. He said, “This is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many.” When he said this, he gave new meaning to the Passover wine.

Jesus identified the bread and wine with himself. He told his followers to continue to take bread and wine together to remember him and that he died for them (see Luke 22:19 and 1 Corinthians 11:24–26). Christians now have several names for this ritual: “The Lord’s Supper,” “Communion,” and “the Eucharist.” Almost all Christian churches observe this ritual.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

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Jesus gives new meaning to the bread and wine

Jesus instituted the Eucharist/Communion

Jesus’ last meal with his disciples

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:26–30; Luke 22:14–20, 39; and 1 Corinthians 11:23–25.

14:24a

He said to them,

- Jesus said to them,
- Then Jesus said,
- Jesus told them,

He said to them: In Greek this verse begins with the phrase that the BSB translates as “He said to them.” The BSB puts this phrase at the beginning of 14:24 and the NIV puts it at the end of 14:24. Place it where it is natural in your language. See the General Comment on 14:24a–d at the end of 14:24c for ways to reorder the parts of this verse.

14:24b–d

This is My blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many:

The words My blood...which is poured out for many refer to the fact that Jesus would bleed and die a sacrifice. The phrase blood of the covenant indicates that he would bleed and die in this way so that the new covenant could begin. When God made a covenant with his people in the Old Testament, God told them to sacrifice an animal. He told them to sprinkle the animal’s blood on themselves. That would cause the covenant to begin. Through Jesus’ death, God was making a new covenant with his people. When Jesus died as a sacrifice for them, his blood would cause the new covenant to begin. This covenant was God’s promise and agreement to save those who trust in Jesus as the sacrifice for their sins. This is a promise from a stronger person (God) to a weaker person (man). It is similar to the promise God gave to Abraham (Genesis 15:18). The “new covenant” is different from the Old Testament covenants that depended on two people or groups each fulfilling their part of an agreement (KBT). An example of an Old Testament covenant is the agreement between God and Israel at Mount Sinai when God gave the Ten Commandments to Israel. In English, people call this agreement at Mount Sinai “the old covenant” or “the old agreement” or “the old testament.”

Here is one way to make some of this information explicit:

This wine is my blood. My blood will be poured out as a sacrifice on behalf of many people. It will confirm the covenant that God is making with his people.

blood of the covenant: The phrase of the covenant indicates that the covenant will be confirmed by Jesus’ blood. It indicates that the covenant is ratified, sealed or put into effect by means of the blood that Jesus shed when he died.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

which confirms the covenant between God and his people (NLT)

that ratifies/seals God's new covenant

and with it God makes his agreement (CEV)

It causes God's agreement with his people to go into effect

Many translators find an illustration helpful to understand the phrase "blood of the covenant." The relationship between a signature and a proposed law is similar to the "blood of the covenant." A proposed law cannot go into effect until a government leader signs it. In the same way, God's new covenant did not take effect until Jesus' blood "signed" or ratified it. See "covenant" in the Glossary.

14:24b

"This is My blood

- "Here is my blood.
- "This wine is my blood.

This is My blood: The word This refers to the wine that Jesus gave his disciples to drink. The phrase my blood refers to the blood that Jesus would shed when he died on the cross.

Churches have different views about exactly what the words This is my blood imply. Because of this, it is probably good to translate this clause literally.

14:24c

of the covenant,

- This blood ratifies/seals God's new covenant with people.
- This blood causes God's agreement with his people to begin.
- By this blood, God makes a covenant with his people.

the covenant: The Greek word that the BSB translates as covenant means "agreement." As part of this agreement, Jesus sacrificed his life to atone for people's sins. Because of this sacrifice, God agreed or promised that he would forgive the people who trust in Jesus.

There is a textual issue in 14:24b that concerns the phrase the covenant:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have only covenant. This is followed by most English versions. (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, CEV, GW, ESV, NASB, NET, NJB, NLT, REB)
2. Other Greek manuscripts have new covenant. This is followed by several English versions. (KJV, JBP, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This is the most likely text. However, the meaning of the word "new" is implied by the context. It may be good to include it if you need it to express the meaning in the most natural way in your language.

14:24d

which is poured out for many.

- It is being poured out for many people."
- It will flow out for many people."
- It will be shed when I am killed as a sacrifice in order to atone for many people."
- _____

which is poured out: The Greek word that the BSB translates as poured out here refers to blood flowing freely from the body of a person or animal. The Jews often used this expression as an idiom to refer to a violent death or to dying as a sacrifice. In this context it indicates that Jesus was sacrificing his own blood, his life, to atone for our sins.

In this context the phrase poured out also associates Jesus' blood with wine. People can pour wine out of a cup, and Jesus would bleed as he suffered and died the next day. In some languages a verb like "pour" may only be used of pouring liquids from containers. Use a verb that is appropriate to describe the way a person bleeds. Since Jesus had not yet died at the time he said it, you may need to translate this as a future event. For example:

will flow out

for many: The phrase for many means "on behalf of many people."

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

for the sake of many people

so that many people may be saved

many: There are different ways to interpret the word many here. It is a Semitic (Hebrew/Aramaic) idiom that can mean "all people." Some scholars think that this refers to every one of the many people who trust Jesus as the sacrifice for their sins. Other scholars think that "all people" refers to everyone who has ever lived.

Because churches disagree about the meaning, it is recommended that you follow most English versions and translate it literally as "many" or "many people." You may also want to consult the major language version in your area.

General Comment on 14:24a–d

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the parts of this verse. For example:

^{24b}This wine is my blood. ^{24d}My blood will be poured out as a sacrifice on behalf of many people. ^{24c}It will confirm the covenant that God is making with his people, ^{24a}Jesus said to them.

Mark 14:25

Section 14:22–26: Jesus gave his disciples bread and wine with a special meaning

When a Jewish family ate the Passover meal, specifically during the third part of the Passover meal (see the discussion of the different parts of the Passover meal in 14:17–21). the head of the household broke some bread and offered it to his family. Then he explained how certain foods in the meal reminded them of the time when God delivered their ancestors from slavery.

In this section Jesus broke pieces of bread, gave them to his disciples, and said to them, “This is my body.” When Jesus said this, he gave the Passover bread new meaning. Later on, after the main meal, Jesus took a cup of wine and gave it to his disciples for them to drink from. He said, “This is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many.” When he said this, he gave new meaning to the Passover wine.

Jesus identified the bread and wine with himself. He told his followers to continue to take bread and wine together to remember him and that he died for them (see Luke 22:19 and 1 Corinthians 11:24–26). Christians now have several names for this ritual: “The Lord’s Supper,” “Communion,” and “the Eucharist.” Almost all Christian churches observe this ritual.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Lord’s Supper

Jesus gives new meaning to the bread and wine

Jesus instituted the Eucharist/Communion

Jesus’ last meal with his disciples

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:26–30; Luke 22:14–20, 39; and 1 Corinthians 11:23–25.

14:25a

Truly I tell you,

- “I can guarantee this truth: (GW)
- “I assure you^(plur) that

Truly I tell you: Jesus often used the words Truly I tell you to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. The clause Truly I tell you occurs in Mark 3:28a, 8:12, 9:1, 9:41, 10:15, 11:23, 12:43, 13:30, 14:9, 14:18, 14:30. It indicates that the statement was important and totally reliable, and that people should listen carefully to it.

See how you translated this phrase in 14:9a.

14:25b

I will no longer drink of the fruit of the vine

- I will never again drink wine
- after this I will drink no more juice of grapes

14:25c

until that day when I drink it anew in the kingdom of God.”

- until the day/time when I will drink the new wine in the kingdom of God.”
- before/until I can drink a new kind of wine in the place where God will rule.”

14:25b–c

I will no longer drink of the fruit of the vine until that day when I drink it anew in the kingdom of God:

Jesus used a very emphatic statement here: “I definitely will not drink again....” He meant that from that time on, he would not drink any more wine. He would not drink it until the future day or “time” or “occasion” when he would drink it in God’s kingdom.

Here is another way to translate this:

From now on I will not drink any wine until I drink...in God’s kingdom (CEV)

of the fruit of the vine: The phrase of the fruit of the vine is a figure of speech that refers to wine. The figure comes from the fact that wine is made from grapes, and grapes are a fruit that grows on a vine. In many languages, a literal translation of this figure of speech will be meaningless. Unless your language uses a similar figure of speech, it may be best to use whatever term you used for “wine” in verses such as 14:23a. For example:

wine

juice made from a fruit called grapes

drink it anew: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates here as drink it anew is literally “drink it new” (as in the RSV). Scholars have interpreted this phrase in different ways:

1. It refers to drinking a new kind of wine. For example, the GNT says:

drink the new wine (GNT, NJB, GW, CEV)

1. It refers to drinking wine in a new way. For example:

drink it in a new way (BSB, NIV)

1. It refers to drinking wine with a new meaning.

You may follow any of these interpretations. The meaning lines in the Display follow interpretation (1). If you follow interpretation (1), make sure that the expression you use refers to a new kind of wine, not newly fermented wine.

in the kingdom of God: The phrase kingdom of God refers to God’s activity of ruling and caring for his people as their king. It does not refer to a land or country that he rules over. It refers to the relationship that he has with his people. He protects, delivers, and cares for them. They obey, trust, and submit to him as their king.

In this context the phrase in the kingdom of God refers to the time when God rules as king in a new way. Scholars differ as to what time this implies. Two viewpoints about this are: (a) It refers to a future time when God will rule completely, and everyone and everything will submit to him as king. At that time Jesus will celebrate with his people. (b) It refers to the time that began after Jesus rose from the dead and will continue forever. Jesus is ruling now with God and celebrates with his people. so you should translate in a general way.

Here are some other ways to translate in the kingdom of God in this context:

in God’s rule/reign

when God has established his rule/chieftaincy

when God’s government has begun

when God protects/delivers his people as their king

See how you translated this phrase in 1:15b. See kingdom of God, Context 2, in the Glossary.

Mark 14:26

Section 14:22–26: Jesus gave his disciples bread and wine with a special meaning

When a Jewish family ate the Passover meal, Specifically during the third part of the Passover meal (see the discussion of the different parts of the Passover meal in 14:17–21). the head of the household broke some bread and offered it to his family. Then he explained how certain foods in the meal reminded them of the time when God delivered their ancestors from slavery.

In this section Jesus broke pieces of bread, gave them to his disciples, and said to them, “This is my body.” When Jesus said this, he gave the Passover bread new meaning. Later on, after the main meal, Jesus took a cup of wine and gave it to his disciples for them to drink from. He said, “This is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many.” When he said this, he gave new meaning to the Passover wine.

Jesus identified the bread and wine with himself. He told his followers to continue to take bread and wine together to remember him and that he died for them (see Luke 22:19 and 1 Corinthians 11:24–26). Christians now have several names for this ritual: “The Lord’s Supper,” “Communion,” and “the Eucharist.” Almost all Christian churches observe this ritual.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Lord’s Supper

Jesus gives new meaning to the bread and wine

Jesus instituted the Eucharist/Communion

Jesus’ last meal with his disciples

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:26–30; Luke 22:14–20, 39; and 1 Corinthians 11:23–25.

14:26a

And when they had sung a hymn,

- Then, they sang a song of praise to God.
- When Jesus had said that, they sang psalms to praise God,

And: The Greek word that the BSB translates as And is the most common Greek connector. Here it introduces a new event. Introduce the new event in a natural way in your language. For example:

Then they sang a hymn

In some languages a connector may not be needed, but you may want to include a connecting phrase to introduce the next event. For example:

They sang a hymn. When they were finished...

when they had sung a hymn: The BSB uses a special verb form had sung to indicate that this event happened before the event in 14:26b. Use a natural verb form in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Then they sang a hymn and went out... (NLT)

After singing a hymn, they went out... (NET)

they: The pronoun they refers to Jesus and the disciples.

a hymn: A hymn is a song of praise to God. In this context Jesus and the disciples probably sang a psalm (song) from the Old Testament. You may want to include a footnote stating that it was a custom to sing psalms at the Passover meal. They sang Psalms 113–114 before the meal and Psalms 115–118 after the meal.

14:26b

they went out to the Mount of Olives.

- After that, they left and went to the Mount of Olives.
- and afterwards, they left the room/city and went to the hill with olive trees.

they went out to the Mount of Olives: The clause they went out to the Mount of Olives indicates that Jesus and the disciples left Jerusalem. Then they crossed a valley and climbed up to the Mount of Olives. Another way to translate this is:

Then they left Jerusalem and crossed over to the Mount of Olives.

the Mount of Olives: Mark speaks of the Mount of Olives, a hill with olive trees on it. It was located just outside of the city of Jerusalem. See how you translated the Mount of Olives in 11:1b and 13:3a.

Mark 14:27

Section 14:27–31: Jesus predicted that Peter would deny him

In this section Jesus told his disciples what would happen. He predicted that his disciples would desert him and run away and that Peter would deny him. Jesus told his disciples that he would be killed and then he would rise from death. He assured them that after the resurrection he would meet them in Galilee. Peter insisted that he would never deny Jesus, but in 14:66–72 Peter denied him, just as Jesus had predicted.

The text does not say exactly where Jesus and his disciples had this conversation. In 14:26 Jesus and the disciples “went out to the Mount of Olives.” In 14:32 “they went to a place called Gethsemane.” It is likely that in 14:27–31 Jesus and the disciples were talking as they walked to Gethsemane.

The BSB creates a new paragraph for each speaker. You may follow this style, or you may prefer to have one paragraph for the whole section.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples of Jesus say that they will not leave/abandon him

Jesus’ prediction that Peter would lie about being his disciple

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:31–35; Luke 22:31–34; and John 13:36–38.

14:27a

Then Jesus said to them, “You will all fall away,

- ¶ Jesus said to them, “All of you will run away and leave me, (GNT)
- ¶ Jesus said to his disciples, “All of you will soon desert/abandon me,

Then Jesus said to them: The BSB follows the order of the Greek and places the words Jesus said to them after “You will all fall away.” The NIV reverses the order of these phrases. Place the words Jesus said to them where it is natural in your language.

You will all fall away: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as You will all fall away is an idiom. In this context, it means that the disciples will stop being loyal to Jesus and will abandon him. The meaning of this Greek verb varies according to the context. In

Mark it also occurs in 4:17d, 6:3d and 9:42–47. Here in 14:27a, it means that the disciples will not remain loyal and will want to separate themselves from Jesus to avoid his fate.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

you will run away and leave me (GNT)

all of you will desert me. (NLT)

You will all: The words You...all refer to all of Jesus' eleven closest disciples. He was speaking to them after the twelfth disciple, Judas, had already left.

**14:27b
for it is written:**

- because it is written in God's word:
- I say this because God says in his written words,
- I know this will happen because God caused these words to be written:

for: The word for introduces an explanation. This part of the verse explains how Jesus knew that the disciples would abandon him. In some languages it may be necessary to introduce this explanation more explicitly. For example:

I say this because it is written...

I know this because it is written...

it is written: Jesus often used the expression it is written when he quoted the Old Testament Scriptures. Here he referred to Zechariah 13:7, which records the prophecy that Jesus quoted.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the Scriptures say (CEV)

it is written in God's word (TRT)

there is a written word of God that says

This same expression occurs in 14:21b.

14:27c–d

'I will strike the Shepherd, and the sheep will be scattered': This expression is a metaphor. In this metaphor, the topics of both parts are left implicit. God will strike or "kill" the shepherd. The shepherd represents the leader of his people. When that hap-

pens, the sheep will scatter. The sheep represent his people.

Zechariah wrote these words hundreds of years before Jesus was born. The words in Zechariah were a prophecy about what would happen to Jesus and his disciples. These words predict that when Jesus was killed, his disciples would run away and stop following him.

In some languages, 14:27a may make it clear that Jesus used the metaphor of the shepherd and the sheep to refer to himself and his disciples.

If the meaning is not clear, here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Make one or more of the implied topics explicit. For example:

I will kill the one who shepherds my people, and they will be scattered.

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make one or more of the implied topics explicit. For example:

I will kill the one who leads my people like a shepherd leads his sheep. Then the people will scatter just like sheep are scattered.

I will kill the one who takes care of my people like a shepherd, and they will be scattered like sheep.

If your language does not have words for "shepherd" or "sheep," you may be able to use a descriptive phrase for "shepherd" and use a borrowed word for "sheep." For example:

I will kill the person who takes care of my sheep animals, and they will be scattered.

The leader of my people is like someone who cares for animals called sheep. I will kill that leader, and then my people will scatter.

See the note in 6:34c for more details on translating a figure of speech with "shepherd" and "sheep."

14:27c

'I will strike the Shepherd,

- God says, 'I will kill the shepherd,
- 'I will kill the shepherd,
- 'I will kill the one who takes care of my people like a shepherd,

I: The pronoun I refers to God. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. However, you should not make it explicit in the direct quote. It is often possible to introduce the quote by indicating that God is the speaker. For example:

for it is written, God says, ‘I will kill the shepherd’

for it is written in God’s Word that he said that he would kill the shepherd

will strike: The word that the BSB translates here as strike is used in this context to mean “kill.” It does not mean “hit.”

the Shepherd: A Shepherd is a person who cares for sheep or goats. In this context the Shepherd is the Messiah who cares for his “sheep,” that is, the people who follow him.

In some areas, shepherds are not known. If that is true in your language, you can use a descriptive phrase. For example:

one who takes care of sheep

one who watches over sheep

See how you translated Shepherd in 6:34c.

14:27d and the sheep will be scattered.’

- then the sheep will scatter.’”
- and then the sheep will disperse.’”
- and then they will scatter like sheep.’”

and the sheep: The sheep represent the people who follow the Messiah. There are many places in the Old Testament and the New Testament where the text figuratively describes God (or his Son, the Messiah) as a shepherd and the people who belong to him as sheep. (For example, Ezekiel 34:17, Matthew 25:32.)

will be scattered: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as will be scattered is passive. However, here it is the sheep who scatter themselves.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

will scatter (NCV)

will run away

Mark 14:28

Section 14:27–31: Jesus predicted that Peter would deny him

In this section Jesus told his disciples what would happen. He predicted that his disciples would desert him and run away and that Peter would deny him. Jesus told his disciples that he would be killed and then he would rise from death. He assured them that after the resurrection he would meet them in Galilee. Peter insisted that he would never deny Jesus, but in 14:66–72 Peter denied him, just as Jesus had predicted.

The text does not say exactly where Jesus and his disciples had this conversation. In 14:26 Jesus and the disciples “went out to the Mount of Olives.” In 14:32 “they went to a place called Gethsemane.” It is likely that in 14:27–31 Jesus and the disciples were talking as they walked to Gethsemane.

The BSB creates a new paragraph for each speaker. You may follow this style, or you may prefer to have one paragraph for the whole section.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples of Jesus say that they will not leave/abandon him

Jesus’ prediction that Peter would lie about being his disciple

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:31–35; Luke 22:31–34; and John 13:36–38.

14:28a But after I have risen,

- Then Jesus said, “But when I am raised from the dead,
- Then Jesus continued, “Even so, when I come back to life,

At the end of 14:27 Jesus stopped quoting the prophecy from Zechariah. Here in 14:28 Jesus began to speak his own words again. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

Then Jesus said

Jesus continued

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But indicates a contrast. The contrast is between the sad prediction of 14:27 and the hopeful prediction in 14:28. Connect these verses in a natural way in your language.

after I have risen: Here Jesus indicated that he would live again after he died. In some languages it may be necessary to make his death explicit. For example:

But after I have died and am alive again

have risen: The Greek word that the BSB translates as have risen is passive. It is implied that God caused Jesus to rise. He caused Jesus to rise from death and live again. In some languages it may be necessary to use an active expression and specify “God” as the subject. For example:

But after I have died and God has caused me to live again

See how you translated this idea in 6:14, 6:16, 12:26.

14:28b **I will go ahead of you into Galilee.”**

- I will precede you to Galilee.”
- I will go to Galilee before you and meet you there.”

I will go ahead of you into Galilee: When Jesus said to his disciples, I will go ahead of you into Galilee, he implied that he would go before his disciples went. He implied that they should join him there later. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

I will go ahead of you to Galilee and meet you there. (NLT)

I will go ahead of you to Galilee and you will meet/see me there again.

Galilee: Galilee is a province or region. See how you translated Galilee in 1:9a.

Mark 14:29

Section 14:27–31: Jesus predicted that Peter would deny him

In this section Jesus told his disciples what would happen. He predicted that his disciples would desert him and run away and that Peter would deny him. Jesus told his disciples that he would be killed and then he would rise from death. He assured them that

after the resurrection he would meet them in Galilee. Peter insisted that he would never deny Jesus, but in 14:66–72 Peter denied him, just as Jesus had predicted.

The text does not say exactly where Jesus and his disciples had this conversation. In 14:26 Jesus and the disciples “went out to the Mount of Olives.” In 14:32 “they went to a place called Gethsemane.” It is likely that in 14:27–31 Jesus and the disciples were talking as they walked to Gethsemane.

The BSB creates a new paragraph for each speaker. You may follow this style, or you may prefer to have one paragraph for the whole section.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples of Jesus say that they will not leave/abandon him

Jesus’ prediction that Peter would lie about being his disciple

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:31–35; Luke 22:31–34; and John 13:36–38.

14:29 **Peter declared, “Even if all fall away, I never will.”**

- Then Peter said to him, “Even if all of these others abandon you, as for me, I will never do that to you.”
- Peter responded, “Everyone else may desert you, but as for me, I will not do so.”

In this verse Peter responded to what Jesus said in 14:27. Jesus said that all of his disciples would abandon him, but Peter protested that he would never do that.

The Greek begins with a conjunction to link what Peter said in 14:29 with what Jesus said in 14:28. You should connect these verses in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Then Peter said to him (JBP)

Peter, as for him, spoke this word:

Peter declared: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as declared is literally “said.” Even though Jesus spoke to the whole group of disciples, Peter spoke in protest. Use an appropriate verb in your language.

Even if all fall away, I never will: When Jesus said that all of the disciples would fall away, Peter emphatically protested. He declared that even if everyone else stopped trusting Jesus and following him, he would never stop following him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

I will never leave you, even though all the rest do! (GNT)

Everyone else may desert you, but as for me, I will not do so.

all: The word all here refers to all the (other) disciples.

fall away: The expression fall away was also used in 14:27a. It is good to translate in the same way here to make the connection clear.

I never will: The words I never will imply “I will not fall away.” In some languages you will need to make these words explicit. For example:

I will not fall away.

Mark 14:30

Section 14:27–31: Jesus predicted that Peter would deny him

In this section Jesus told his disciples what would happen. He predicted that his disciples would desert him and run away and that Peter would deny him. Jesus told his disciples that he would be killed and then he would rise from death. He assured them that after the resurrection he would meet them in Galilee. Peter insisted that he would never deny Jesus, but in 14:66–72 Peter denied him, just as Jesus had predicted.

The text does not say exactly where Jesus and his disciples had this conversation. In 14:26 Jesus and the disciples “went out to the Mount of Olives.” In 14:32 “they went to a place called Gethsemane.” It is likely that in 14:27–31 Jesus and the disciples were talking as they walked to Gethsemane.

The BSB creates a new paragraph for each speaker. You may follow this style, or you may prefer to have one paragraph for the whole section.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples of Jesus say that they will not leave/abandon him

Jesus’ prediction that Peter would lie about being his disciple

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:31–35; Luke 22:31–34; and John 13:36–38.

14:30a

“Truly I tell you,” Jesus replied,

- Jesus said, “Truly I tell you,^(sing)
- Jesus answered him, “I assure you^(sing) that

In this verse Jesus responded to what Peter said in 14:29. Connect these verses in a natural way in your language.

Truly I tell you: Jesus often used the words Truly I tell you to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. The clause Truly I tell you in also occurs in Mark 3:28, 8:12, 9:1, 9:41, 10:15, 11:23, 12:43, 13:30, 14:9, 14:18, 14:25, and 14:30. It indicates that the statement was important and totally reliable, and that people should listen carefully to it.

See how you translated this phrase in 14:25a. In some languages you may need to translate the phrase differently in different contexts. In this context it introduces what Jesus said to Peter in 14:30b. He said that Peter would deny him three times.

you: Here the word you is singular in Greek. It refers to Peter.

Jesus replied: The BSB places the words Jesus replied after “I tell you the truth.” In Greek, these words occur at the beginning of 14:30a. Place the words Jesus replied where it is natural in your language.

14:30b

“this very night, before the rooster crows twice,

- this very night, before the rooster sounds two times,
- later tonight, before a rooster even crows two times,

this very night, before the rooster crows twice: It was early evening when Jesus said this. This was the beginning of a new Jewish day. The words this very night define even more precisely when Peter would deny him. He would deny him before sunrise. Peter would deny Jesus three times before a rooster crowed twice.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

today—yes, tonight (NIV)

tonight (GNT)

during exactly this night

the rooster crows: The phrase the rooster crows indicates that a male chicken was going to make the noise that it normally makes sometime before dawn. Use the natural way in your language to describe this noise. For example:

a rooster calls/cries

the rooster: The phrase the rooster does not indicate that Jesus was thinking of a particular rooster. Some ways to translate this are:

a rooster will crow two times

some rooster will crow twice

twice: The word twice means two times. The crowing of a rooster would be heard two times.

14:30c

you will deny Me three times.”

- already three times you^(sing) will have said that you^(sing) do not know me.”
- as for you, Peter, three times you^(sing) will deny that you^(sing) are my disciple.”
- you^(sing) will say to people, ‘I do not know him.’”

you will deny Me three times: Peter would say three times that he did not know Jesus.

you: In the Greek text the pronoun you refers to Peter and emphasizes him. If your language has a natural way to emphasize Peter, it may be helpful to use it here. For example:

As for you, Peter...

deny: In this context the word deny indicates that Peter would refuse to admit that he was one of Jesus’ followers. He would deny that he knew Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate deny:

say three times that you do not know/follow me

disown me three times (NIV)

Some languages will need to translate deny as a direct quote. For example:

As for you, Peter, you will say, ‘I do not know Jesus.’

Mark 14:31

Section 14:27–31: Jesus predicted that Peter would deny him

In this section Jesus told his disciples what would happen. He predicted that his disciples would desert him and run away and that Peter would deny him. Jesus told his disciples that he would be killed and then he would rise from death. He assured them that after the resurrection he would meet them in Galilee. Peter insisted that he would never deny Jesus, but in 14:66–72 Peter denied him, just as Jesus had predicted.

The text does not say exactly where Jesus and his disciples had this conversation. In 14:26 Jesus and the disciples “went out to the Mount of Olives.” In 14:32 “they went to a place called Gethsemane.” It is likely that in 14:27–31 Jesus and the disciples were talking as they walked to Gethsemane.

The BSB creates a new paragraph for each speaker. You may follow this style, or you may prefer to have one paragraph for the whole section.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples of Jesus say that they will not leave/abandon him

Jesus’ prediction that Peter would lie about being his disciple

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:31–35; Luke 22:31–34; and John 13:36–38.

14:31a

But Peter kept insisting,

- Peter disagreed strongly with that, and he said,
- Peter did not agree with that, and he said repeatedly,

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces how Peter responded to what Jesus said in 14:30. In this response, Peter contradicted what Jesus had just said. Connect these two verses in a natural way in your language.

Peter kept insisting: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Peter kept insisting is literally “very emphatically he was saying.” The tense of the Greek verb

indicates that Peter insisted repeatedly that he would not disown Jesus. English versions do not reflect the sense of the Greek imperfect here, but many commentaries mention that the imperfect indicates that Peter objected repeatedly.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

But Peter kept saying even more insistently

But Peter strengthened his words all the more, and replied to Jesus:

Peter did not agree with that, and he said repeatedly

14:31b

“Even if I have to die with You, I will never deny You.”

- “Even if I die with you,^(sing) I will not deny that I know you!^(sing)”
- “I am willing to be killed along with you,^(sing) rather than say that I do not know you.^(sing)”
- “I will never say that I do not know you,^(sing) even if I am caused to die with you.^(sing)”

Even if I have to die with You, I will never deny You:

In this part of the verse, Peter indicated emphatically that he was ready to be killed along with Jesus. He said that he would never desert Jesus and say that he did not know him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Even if I have to die with you, I will never say that I don’t know you. (GW)

I will never say that, even if I have to die with you! (GNT)

General Comment on 14:31a–b

In many languages it is necessary to express the idea “insisted emphatically” (31a) within the direct quote (31b). For example:

But Peter said, “Never! Even if I have to die with you, I will never disown you.”

“Unthinkable!” Peter exclaimed. “I would rather die with you than disown you!”

14:31c

And all the others said the same thing.

- All the other disciples also said the same words.
- And all of his fellow disciples agreed.
- Then the rest of the followers there also said that they would never deny him/Jesus either.

And all the others said the same thing: The words And all the others said the same indicate that all the other disciples also said that they, too, would never deny Jesus.

said the same thing: You may add what the other disciples said. You may use direct or indirect speech. For example:

Each of the others also said: “I will never deny you either.”

Each of the others also said that he would never deny him/Jesus.

Mark 14:32

Section 14:32–42: Jesus prayed in a place called Gethsemane

The conversation in the preceding section occurred while Jesus and the disciples were walking toward the Mount of Olives (14:26–27). In this section, they came to a place where there were olive trees. This place was called Gethsemane. Jesus told his disciples to pray that God would give them strength not to sin. Jesus also prayed that he himself would do what his heavenly Father wanted him to do, rather than what he himself wanted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus prayed in the garden called Gethsemane

Jesus’ prayer in Gethsemane

Jesus prayed for God’s will to be done

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:36–46 and Luke 22:39–46.

14:32a

Then they came to a place called Gethsemane,

- ¶ They went/came to a place called Gethsemane.

- ¶ When Jesus and his followers arrived at a place called Gethsemane,

Then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Then is the most common Greek connector. Here it introduces a new event. The events in this paragraph begin immediately after the events in the preceding paragraph. Introduce the new event in a natural way in your language. In some languages, it is natural to begin a new part of the story with a time word. Here are some other ways to translate this:

After that

And (ESV)

they came: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as came is literally “come.” It can also be translated as “arrived.” Use a verb that is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

they walked to

they arrived at

they reached (REB)

they: The word they refers to Jesus and his disciples.

a place called Gethsemane: Gethsemane was the name of a place on the Mount of Olives where there were many olive trees. People had planted these trees and continued to care for them.

The Gospel of John refers to Gethsemane as a garden. So here is one way to translate this:

They went to a garden called Gethsemane.

If the word “garden” in your language refers primarily to a vegetable garden, it may be better not to use that word.

14:32b **and Jesus told His disciples, “Sit here while I pray.”**

- Then Jesus said to his disciples, “Sit^(plur) here while I go pray to God.”
- he said to some of his followers, “Stay^(plur) here. I will go talk to God.”

Jesus told His disciples: In this part of the verse the phrase His disciples does not refer to all the disciples. In 14:33a Jesus told Peter, James, and John to go with

him apart from the other eight disciples. This implies that he told the others to sit down in a particular place. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate that Jesus was not speaking to all of his disciples here. For example:

Jesus said to some of his disciples

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means “learners” who are in a relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

students/learners

apprentices

followers

See how you translated this term at 2:15b. See also disciple in the Glossary for more information.

Sit here while I pray: Here Jesus told some of his disciples to sit and wait for him while he prayed. Express this request in an appropriate way in your language. In some languages it may be natural in this request to address the disciples as “friends,” or “my disciples.” For example:

Friends, as for you,^(plur) sit^(plur) here. I will go farther and pray.

Stay^(plur) here, my disciples. As for me, I will go farther and pray.

while I pray: In this context the phrase while I pray implies “until I finish praying.” Another way to say this is:

Sit^(plur) here. I will go pray.

pray: The Greek word that the BSB translates as pray means “speak to God.” Some languages use different words to refer to specific kinds of prayer, such as requests, thanks, or praise. If your language has different words for pray, here you should use the word or phrase that means “request” or “ask.” For example:

Ask/Beg God

Request from/of God

Avoid a term that may imply magical or meaningless words.

Mark 14:33

Section 14:32–42: Jesus prayed in a place called Gethsemane

The conversation in the preceding section occurred while Jesus and the disciples were walking toward the Mount of Olives (14:26–27). In this section, they came to a place where there were olive trees. This place was called Gethsemane. Jesus told his disciples to pray that God would give them strength not to sin. Jesus also prayed that he himself would do what his heavenly Father wanted him to do, rather than what he himself wanted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus prayed in the garden called Gethsemane

Jesus' prayer in Gethsemane

Jesus prayed for God's will to be done

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:36–46 and Luke 22:39–46.

14:33a

He took with Him Peter, James, and John,

- He took/led Peter, James, and John with him a little farther,
- And then he invited Peter, James and John to go with him, and they went off together.

In Greek this verse begins with a conjunction that introduces the next event. Connect the events in 14:32 and 14:33 in a natural way in your language.

He took with Him Peter, James, and John: Among the disciples, Peter, James and John were special friends of Jesus. The text implies here that Jesus took them a little farther toward the middle of the olive grove in Gethsemane.

took with Him: Here the verb took indicates that Jesus asked his friends to accompany him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

caused/told them to go along with him

had them accompany him

said to them, "Come with me."

In some languages you may need to specify the destination or direction. If possible, use a general word, such as "ahead" or "a little ahead." For example:

He invited Peter, James and John to go with him; they went off together ahead

14:33b

and began to be deeply troubled and distressed.

- and he began to be very distressed and sorrowful.
- At that time as Jesus thought about what would soon happen, he felt great grief and horror.

and began to be deeply troubled: Mark used the verb began here to describe an action that started at this time and continued for some time.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Jesus entered time of deep distress

Distress overwhelmed him/Jesus

deeply troubled and distressed: The Greek words that the BSB translates as deeply troubled and distressed have a similar meaning. Together they emphasize that Jesus was very sorrowful and distressed. Some languages may have a single expression for this idea. Other languages may use an idiom. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

filled with horror and deep distress (NLT96)

In some languages it may be necessary to specify the reason that Jesus was troubled and distressed. You may make this explicit in a general way only if it is necessary to avoid a wrong meaning. For example:

Jesus began to be deeply distressed...because of what he was going to endure.

Mark 14:34

Section 14:32–42: Jesus prayed in a place called Gethsemane

The conversation in the preceding section occurred while Jesus and the disciples were walking toward the Mount of Olives (14:26–27). In this section, they came to a place where there were olive trees. This place was called Gethsemane. Jesus told his disciples to pray that God would give them strength not to sin. Jesus also prayed that he himself would do what his heavenly Father wanted him to do, rather than what he himself wanted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus prayed in the garden called Gethsemane

Jesus' prayer in Gethsemane

Jesus prayed for God's will to be done

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:36–46 and Luke 22:39–46.

14:34a

Then He said to them, "My soul is consumed with sorrow to the point of death."

- He said to them, "My heart is overcome by such anguish that I could/might die."
- He said to them, "I feel such intense sorrow that it may kill me."

Then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Then is the most common Greek connector and is often translated as "and." Here it introduces what happened next. Use a natural way in your language to do this.

He said to them: The BSB follows the order of the Greek and places the words He said to them before what Jesus said. The NIV reverses the order and places this phrase at the end of the verse. Place the words He said to them where it is natural in your language.

My soul: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as My soul is a way for a person to refer to himself. People often used this expression to show deep emotion. Languages have different ways to express this. Some languages have idioms that use other parts of the body, such as the heart or liver, in a figurative way.

is consumed with sorrow: The phrase consumed with sorrow indicates that Jesus was extremely grieved and troubled. He was very sorrowful and upset. Use an idiom or expression to describe this type of intense sorrow in a natural way. For example:

I am very sorrowful.

The sorrow in my heart is so great that it almost crushes me. (GNT)

Anguish is tearing me apart.

to the point of death: The phrase to the point of death indicates that Jesus was so sorrowful that he felt as if the grief might kill him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

I feel as if I'm dying (GW)

so that I am almost dying

14:34b

Stay here and keep watch."

- Stay here and do not go to sleep."
- You^(plur) wait here and stay awake/alert so that you will be ready for whatever happens."

Stay here: The phrase Stay here indicates that Jesus wanted the disciples to remain where they were. He would go some distance away to pray, and they should stay in the same place and wait for him to return.

keep watch: In earlier parts of Mark, the Greek expression that the BSB translates as keep watch means to be alert and ready for whatever may happen. Here it also means "stay awake, do not go to sleep." Jesus indicated that his disciples should remain awake and continue to be alert.

Mark 14:35

Section 14:32–42: Jesus prayed in a place called Gethsemane

The conversation in the preceding section occurred while Jesus and the disciples were walking toward the Mount of Olives (14:26–27). In this section, they came to a place where there were olive trees. This place was called Gethsemane. Jesus told his disciples to pray that God would give them strength not to sin. Jesus also prayed that he himself would do what his

heavenly Father wanted him to do, rather than what he himself wanted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus prayed in the garden called Gethsemane

Jesus' prayer in Gethsemane

Jesus prayed for God's will to be done

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:36–46 and Luke 22:39–46.

14:35a

Going a little farther,

- ¶ Then Jesus went on a little farther.
- ¶ Then Jesus moved away from them a little.

In some languages, it will be natural to begin this verse with a time word or phrase. For example:

Then

Afterwards he left them and

Connect the events in 14:34 and 14:35 in a natural way in your language.

Going a little farther: The phrase Going a little farther indicates a distance that is about as far as someone could throw a stone. The specific expression “a stone's throw” is used in another Gospel, but you should not use it here. Use an appropriate general term for this distance in your language.

You may also need to indicate the direction Jesus went. He continued to go in the same direction that he had been going. That is, he continued “going ahead,” or “going forward,” “or going away from the three disciples.”

14:35b

He fell to the ground and prayed

- He knelt and bowed with his face to the ground and prayed to God.
- There he lay face downward on the ground, and he requested/begged of God,

14:35c

that, if it were possible, the hour would pass from Him.

- He asked God that if it was possible, he would not have to endure the time of suffering that was coming.
- that if it was possible in God's plan, God would spare him the torment that he must suffer.
- saying, “Father, if it is possible in your plan, please allow me not to have to experience the time of torment that is coming.”

14:35b–c

He fell to the ground: In this context the clause He fell to the ground is an idiom. It indicates that Jesus deliberately knelt or lay face downward on the ground to pray to God. This expression does not indicate that Jesus accidentally fell down. In Jewish culture, people knelt or lay prostrate like this to humble themselves before God in prayer.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

lay/knelt face downward on the ground to pray

prostrated himself on the ground

and prayed: The word prayed here implies that Jesus prayed to God.

If it is not natural in your language to use a conjunction to connect these two verbs, you may need to omit and. For example:

...he knelt on the ground. He prayed to God...

prayed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as prayed means “spoke to God.” Some languages use different words to refer to specific kinds of prayer, such as requests, thanks, or praise. If your language has different words for pray, here you should use the word that means “requested.” For example:

asked/begged God

requested from/of God

Avoid a term that may imply magical or meaningless words.

prayed that, if it were possible, the hour would pass from Him: This part of the verse expresses the content of Jesus' prayer. If you begin a new sentence here you may need to repeat “prayed.” For example:

He prayed to God that if possible

See the General Comment on 14:35–36 at the end of 14:36d for a suggestion about expressing this as a direct quote.

if it were possible: The words if it were possible express a humble request. Jesus implied that God was the one who knew what should be done. He prayed that God would grant his request only if God knew that it would be good or possible to grant it.

Here are some ways to translate this in indirect speech:

that if God thought it was good

that if God could give permission

prayed that...the hour would pass from Him: The phrase prayed that...the hour would pass from Him is an idiom. It indicates that Jesus prayed that...he would not have to endure the time of suffering.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

that...he might not have to suffer what was ahead of him (GW)

that...he would not need to endure that day of suffering

that...the suffering that he was going to know would not arrive

Mark 14:36

Section 14:32–42: Jesus prayed in a place called Gethsemane

The conversation in the preceding section occurred while Jesus and the disciples were walking toward the Mount of Olives (14:26–27). In this section, they came to a place where there were olive trees. This place was called Gethsemane. Jesus told his disciples to pray that God would give them strength not to sin. Jesus also prayed that he himself would do what his heavenly Father wanted him to do, rather than what he himself wanted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus prayed in the garden called Gethsemane

Jesus' prayer in Gethsemane

Jesus prayed for God's will to be done

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:36–46 and Luke 22:39–46.

14:36a

“Abba, Father,” He said,

- Then he said, “My dear Father,
- Then he said, “My Father, my Father!

Abba, Father: Here Jesus spoke to God as his father. In the Aramaic language, Abba is the informal word for “father.” It was used by family members. He used Abba, the informal word for “father,” and followed it with the Greek word for “father.” It is not clear why Mark included two words that mean “father.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- If you have both a formal and informal word for “father” you may be able to use both here.
- Use an expression in your language which indicates that Jesus spoke to God, his Father in an affectionate way. For example:

my father, my father

dear father

- Transliterate Abba and explain it in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Jesus used the Aramaic word “Abba” here. It means “Daddy/Papa.” A person used this word to speak to his father when they were at home together.

If the word Abba has a different meaning in your language, you should not include this word in the text.

Use whichever form is most natural in your language for a son to address his father in a way that shows affection.

He said: The BSB places the words He said after “Abba, Father.” In Greek these words occur at the beginning of 14:36a. Place the words He said where it is natural in your language.

14:36b

“all things are possible for You.

- you are able to do everything.
- Nothing is impossible for you.

all things are possible for You: In this context the clause all things are possible for You indicates that God can do anything, and he can cause anything to happen.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

you are able to do everything

nothing is impossible for you

14:36c

Take this cup from Me.

- Please take this cup of suffering away from me.
- Save me from this suffering that I will endure.

Take this cup from Me: The words Take this cup from Me are a humble prayer. Be sure to express it in a humble and polite way in your language.

this cup: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as cup is used here as a figure of speech. It refers to the suffering that Jesus would soon experience. Jesus was asking God to rescue him from the suffering that he would endure on the cross. If your readers would not understand this, here are some ways to translate it:

- Keep the figure of speech and indicate that it refers to suffering. For example, the NLT says:

Please, take this cup of suffering away from me.

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

Save me from this suffering.

14:36d

Yet not what I will, but what You will.”

- But do not do what I will/desire. Do what you will/desire.”
- However, please do what you want to do about this. If you do not want to do what I have asked you, please do not do it.”

Yet: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Yet here introduces a limit or condition that Jesus added to his request. Jesus had asked to be saved from suffering, but he did not want God to save him if it was not God’s will.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

However

But even though I have asked this

not what I will, but what You will: There are implied words in this clause:

Do not do what I want you to do, but do what you want to do.

This clause indicates that Jesus accepted whatever his Father wanted to happen to him. He chose what his Father wanted, rather than what he wanted.

In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the order of these clauses and say:

your will be done, not my will

but what You will: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but indicates a contrast between two choices. In this context Jesus had to choose either what he wanted to happen or what God wanted to happen. Jesus chose what God wanted.

General Comment on 14:35–36

In 14:36 Mark gives the words that Jesus prayed as a direct quote. In some languages it may be necessary to translate 14:35c also as part of the direct quote. For example:

He prayed, “My Father, if it is possible in your plan, let me avoid the suffering that is about to strike me. Everything is possible for you. Cause this suffering not to come. Yet do what you want, not what I want.”

Mark 14:37

Section 14:32–42: Jesus prayed in a place called Gethsemane

The conversation in the preceding section occurred while Jesus and the disciples were walking toward the Mount of Olives (14:26–27). In this section, they came to a place where there were olive trees. This place was called Gethsemane. Jesus told his disciples to pray that God would give them strength not to sin. Jesus also prayed that he himself would do what his heavenly Father wanted him to do, rather than what he himself wanted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus prayed in the garden called Gethsemane

Jesus' prayer in Gethsemane

Jesus prayed for God's will to be done

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:36–46 and Luke 22:39–46.

14:37a

Then Jesus returned

- ¶ After that, Jesus returned to the three disciples,
- ¶ Then Jesus went to his three followers, the ones whom he had taken with him.

Then Jesus returned: The text implies here that Jesus returned to the group of three disciples, that is, to Peter, James, and John. Refer back to them in a natural way in your language. For example:

After that, Jesus returned to his three already mentioned disciples

14:37b

and found them sleeping.

- and he saw them there sleeping.
- He saw that they were sleeping.
- When he arrived, they were asleep. He woke them.

and found them sleeping: The phrase and found them sleeping indicates that Jesus saw that they were sleeping. It does not indicate that the disciples had been lost and Jesus found them.

14:37c

“Simon, are you asleep?” He asked.

- Then he said to Peter, “Simon, are you^(sing) still sleeping?”
- He said to Simon Peter, “Simon, you^(sing) should not be sleeping!”
- and then he said to Simon Peter, “Oh, you^(sing) are sleeping!”

In Greek this verse part begins with the common conjunction that is often translated as “and.” Here it introduces what Jesus said when he saw that the disciples were sleeping. Introduce it in a natural way in your language.

“Simon, are you asleep?” He asked: Jesus addresses Peter here as Simon. Peter's sleeping showed that he

was not acting according to his name, “Peter, the Rock.” In some languages it may cause confusion to use two different names like this for the same person. If that is true in your language, you can use both names to introduce the quote. For example:

He said to Simon Peter, “Simon...”

are you asleep?”: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus knew that Peter had been sleeping, and he asked him this question as a mild rebuke. Jesus wanted Peter to realize that he should not have been asleep; he needed to wake up. There are at least three ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why are you sleeping?

How could you be sleeping now?

- As a statement. For example:

You should not be sleeping.

- As an exclamation. For example:

Oh, you are sleeping!

Express this mild rebuke in a way that is natural in your language. If you translate it as an exclamation, introduce it with a verb that is appropriate for the context. For example:

He exclaimed: “Oh, you are sleeping!”

asked: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as asked is more literally “said.” The BSB translates the verb as asked here because it introduces a rhetorical question. When you decide how to translate the rhetorical question, choose an appropriate verb in your language to introduce it.

14:37d

“Were you not able to keep watch for one hour?”

- Could you not watch for a little while, even only one hour?
- You^(sing) should be able to stay awake for an hour!
- You^(sing) could not stay awake for even one hour!

Were you not able to keep watch for one hour?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus asked this question to rebuke Peter more emphatically. He rebuked him

because he did not stay awake and pray for even one hour. There are at least three ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example, the GNT has:

Weren't you able to stay awake for even one hour?

- As a statement. For example:

You should have been able to stay awake for one hour.

I'm surprised/disappointed that you weren't able to stay alert for even a short time. (TRT)

- As an exclamation. For example:

You^(sing) could not stay awake for even one hour!

Use whichever form is most natural to express this rebuke in your language. Remember that this rebuke should be more emphatic in your language than the rebuke "Are you asleep?" in 14:37c.

Were you not able: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Were you not able is literally "Do you not have the strength...?" In this context the phrase does not refer to physical strength but to strength of character or will. Most English versions translate it as "Could you not...?" or "Were you not able to...?" Express the idea in a natural way in your language.

keep watch: The Greek word that the BSB translates as keep watch is also translated as "stay awake" by some English versions. The Greek word has both meanings. This word is also used in 14:34b and 14:38a. In some languages it may be helpful to use two expressions. For example:

stay awake and alert

one hour: The phrase one hour can refer to a literal hour or to a short period of time. Here it probably refers to a literal hour as an example of a short period of time. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

Can you^(sing) not stay awake and watch for a little while, even for only one hour?

Mark 14:38

Section 14:32–42: Jesus prayed in a place called Gethsemane

The conversation in the preceding section occurred while Jesus and the disciples were walking toward the Mount of Olives (14:26–27). In this section, they came to a place where there were olive trees. This place was called Gethsemane. Jesus told his disciples to pray that God would give them strength not to sin. Jesus also prayed that he himself would do what his heavenly Father wanted him to do, rather than what he himself wanted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus prayed in the garden called Gethsemane

Jesus' prayer in Gethsemane

Jesus prayed for God's will to be done

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:36–46 and Luke 22:39–46.

14:38a

Watch and pray so that you will not enter into temptation.

- Stay^(plur) awake and pray so that you^(plur) will not sin when you^(plur) are tempted.
- Do^(plur) not sleep, but rather speak/talk to God, in order that he will help you^(plur) not to yield when Satan tempts you^(plur) to sin.

Watch and pray so that you will not enter into temptation:

The clause so that you will not enter into temptation is closely related to the words Watch and pray. Scholars interpret this relationship in two different ways:

1. The clause tells the purpose for which the disciples should watch and pray. For example:

Watch and pray so that you will not enter into temptation. (BSB)

Keep alert and pray. Otherwise temptation will overpower you. (NLT96) (BSB, NIV, KJV, NLT96)

1. The clause tells what the disciples should pray. For example, the GNT says:

pray that you will not fall into temptation (GNT, NJB, NCV)

The word “that” with certain speech verbs can introduce either the purpose or content of the speech, so some English versions are ambiguous. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This seems to fit both the Greek grammar and the context better. However, both interpretations are valid.

Watch and pray: The verbs Watch and pray are plural forms in Greek. This indicates that Jesus was speaking here to all three disciples. They were to continue to stay awake and continue to pray. See the comments on these verbs in 14:34b.

pray: The Greek word that the BSB translates as pray means “speak to God.” Some languages use different words to refer to specific kinds of prayer, such as requests, thanks, or praise. Here you should use a general term that means “speak” or “talk.”

Avoid a term that may imply magical or meaningless words.

enter into temptation: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as enter into temptation is literally “come into temptation.” The phrase is a figure of speech. It means “yield to temptation.” It implies that when a person is tempted to do something sinful, he agrees to do it.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

so that you will be able to resist temptation

so that you do not agree to sin when you are tempted

Notice that the second example uses a passive verb. In some languages it may be necessary to use an active verb and make the subject explicit. If that is true in your language, you may supply “Satan” or use an indefinite subject. For example:

so that if Satan tempts you, ^(plur) you ^(plur) will not yield

It may also be necessary to indicate what Satan was tempting the disciples to do. For example:

so that you ^(plur) will not sin when Satan tempts you ^(plur) to stop trusting me

temptation: The Greek word that the BSB translates as temptation here refers to an enticement to sin. A temptation is anything that makes a person consider sinning in order to avoid difficulty or receive some benefit.

See how you translated “tempted” at 1:13a. In some languages there may be an idiom to express the idea.

14:38b

For the spirit is willing, but the body is weak.”

- The/Your ^(plur) heart/mind wants to do right, but the/your ^(plur) body lacks strength.”
- People intend to do well/right but are weak and cannot do it.”

For the spirit is willing, but the body is weak: This statement expresses a contrast: a person wants to do what is right but he is not able to do it without God’s help.

Here are some other ways to translate this contrast:

I know that you ^(plur) want to do what is right, but you ^(plur) are unable to do it in/by your ^(plur) own strength.

Your ^(plur) heart/mind wants to do something good, but your ^(plur) body lacks strength.

the spirit...the body: Jesus was referring mainly to the disciples when he talked about the spirit and the body. However, Jesus expressed his statement in a general way that could also apply to other people who try to resist temptation. You may translate either way. Here is one way to refer to people in general:

A person’s spirit is willing, but his body is weak.

the spirit is willing: Jesus did not say what the disciples were willing to do. There are three possibilities:

1. They were willing to do the right thing.
2. They were willing to resist sin / temptation.
3. They were willing to watch.

The Greek text and English versions are ambiguous about this issue. If you are able to translate ambiguously in your language, it is recommended that you do so. If you need to specify what they were willing to do, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

the spirit: In this context the phrase the spirit refers to the part of a person that thinks and feels and determines his character. It represents the person himself and his own will. In some languages, this may be expressed as:

You^(plur)

People

In some languages speakers use a certain part of a person, such as “heart,” “liver,” or “thoughts,” to express this. If that is true in your language, consider whether you could use that expression here.

but: The connector that the BSB translates as but indicates a contrast. It shows that a person wants to do right, but is not able to resist temptation without God’s help. Express the contrast in a natural way in your language.

the body is weak: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the body is literally “the flesh” (RSV). In this context it represents human ability or human strength in general. It includes the physical body and also human self-control. Here it does not represent sinful human nature that is opposed to God.

In some languages a word like body may not be used in such a general way. If that is true in your language, here are some other ways to express the meaning of the phrase the body is weak:

your/their strength is lacking

they/you are weak

they/you are unable to do so

Mark 14:39

Section 14:32–42: Jesus prayed in a place called Gethsemane

The conversation in the preceding section occurred while Jesus and the disciples were walking toward the Mount of Olives (14:26–27). In this section, they came to a place where there were olive trees. This place was called Gethsemane. Jesus told his disciples to pray that God would give them strength not to sin. Jesus also prayed that he himself would do what his heavenly Father wanted him to do, rather than what he himself wanted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus prayed in the garden called Gethsemane

Jesus’ prayer in Gethsemane

Jesus prayed for God’s will to be done

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:36–46 and Luke 22:39–46.

14:39a

Again He went away

- ¶ Then, Jesus left them again.
- ¶ After Jesus said that, he again left his followers and went away from them to pray.

The events in this paragraph probably happened immediately after the events in the preceding paragraph. In some languages, it may be natural to have a time word or phrase here. For example:

Immediately after that

As soon as Jesus said that...

After that

In other languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this paragraph in a natural way in your language.

Again He went away: Again Jesus left the three disciples and went a short distance from them. This is the second time Jesus left the three disciples in order to pray. He probably went to the same place where he was in 14:35a.

He went away a third time at the end of 14:40. When you have translated 14:39a and 14:40 and 14:41, check to see if you have translated the verbs in a natural way in your language.

14:39b

and prayed, saying the same thing.

- He prayed the same prayer as before.
- He prayed using the same words as before.
- He requested/asked God to save him just as he had requested the first time.

prayed, saying the same thing: Jesus prayed to God using the same words or ideas as he used in 14:36. He requested/begged God to save him from the suffering.

Here are some ways to translate prayed, saying the same thing in this context:

prayed the same prayer as before

requested/asked/begged God to save him from the suffering if it was his will

In some languages it may be more natural to repeat Jesus' prayer from 14:36 as a direct quote. For example:

...prayed as before saying, "Father, everything is possible for you. Save me from this suffering. Yet do as you want, not as I want."

Mark 14:40

Section 14:32–42: Jesus prayed in a place called Gethsemane

The conversation in the preceding section occurred while Jesus and the disciples were walking toward the Mount of Olives (14:26–27). In this section, they came to a place where there were olive trees. This place was called Gethsemane. Jesus told his disciples to pray that God would give them strength not to sin. Jesus also prayed that he himself would do what his heavenly Father wanted him to do, rather than what he himself wanted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus prayed in the garden called Gethsemane

Jesus' prayer in Gethsemane

Jesus prayed for God's will to be done

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:36–46 and Luke 22:39–46.

14:40a

And again Jesus returned and found them sleeping

- Afterwards he returned again to the three disciples, and he again saw that they were asleep,

- When he had finished praying, he returned again to those three followers of his. They were sleeping again,

And again Jesus returned: Jesus returned again to the three disciples. The action is similar to 14:37a, except that this is the second time that Jesus returned to see the disciples sleeping.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Afterwards he returned to the three disciples

After Jesus had prayed this, he came again to the three disciples

again: The context indicates that the word again applies to two different events:

1. Jesus returned again to his disciples. For example:

Again he returned to them. (NLT96)

And once more he came back (NJB)

1. He found them sleeping again. For example, the CEV says:

he found them sleeping again

The context indicates that both facts are true. Jesus came to his disciples again, and he found them sleeping again. Use a natural way in your language to indicate this.

14:40b

for their eyes were heavy.

- for they were very sleepy.
- because they were too tired to stay awake.

for their eyes were heavy: The word for here introduces the reason that the disciples were sleeping. In some languages a connector may not be needed.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

...they could not keep their eyes open. (NET)

They had not been able to stay awake.

their eyes were heavy: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as their eyes were heavy is an idiom. It means that they were very sleepy. If your language

has an idiomatic way to express this, you may want to use it here.

14:40c

And they did not know what to answer Him.

- They did not know what to say to him to excuse themselves.
- Then the disciples woke up. They did not know what they should say to Jesus.
- They felt embarrassed, and they did not know what to say to him.

And they did not know what to answer Him: In this part of the verse there is implied information. The text implies that Jesus woke the three disciples and rebuked them because they were asleep again. The clause They did not know what to answer Him indicates that they had no excuse to offer Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

They did not know what to say to him to excuse themselves.

When Jesus saw them sleeping, they woke up, and they did not know how to speak to Jesus about their sleeping.

Mark 14:41

Section 14:32–42: Jesus prayed in a place called Gethsemane

The conversation in the preceding section occurred while Jesus and the disciples were walking toward the Mount of Olives (14:26–27). In this section, they came to a place where there were olive trees. This place was called Gethsemane. Jesus told his disciples to pray that God would give them strength not to sin. Jesus also prayed that he himself would do what his heavenly Father wanted him to do, rather than what he himself wanted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus prayed in the garden called Gethsemane

Jesus' prayer in Gethsemane

Jesus prayed for God's will to be done

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:36–46 and Luke 22:39–46.

14:41a

When Jesus returned the third time, He said,

- ¶ Then he/Jesus went again to pray. Returning the third time, he said to those disciples of his,
- ¶ He went back and prayed again for a third time, and then he returned to where the three followers were. He said to them,

When Jesus returned the third time: In this part of the verse there is implied information. The text implies that Jesus went away a third time to pray, and he prayed as he had before. After he prayed, he went back to where the three disciples were. In some languages it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

He went back and prayed for a third time, and then he returned to where the three disciples were

He said: The BSB places the words He said after “returned the third time.” In Greek these words occur at the beginning of 14:41a. Place the words He said where it is natural in your language.

The phrase He said here introduces a rhetorical question that functions as a rebuke. Introduce the words that follow in a way that is natural in your language.

14:41b

“Are you still sleeping and resting?”

- “Why are you^(plur) still sleeping and taking a rest?”
- “Still sleeping? Still resting? (NLT96)”
- “I am amazed that you are still sleeping and resting.”

Are you still sleeping and resting?: There are two different ways to interpret this part of the verse:

1. Jesus was rebuking his disciples. He expressed surprise and disappointment that they were still sleeping. For example, the RSV says:

Are you still sleeping and taking your rest? (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NASB, REB, NET, CEV, NLT96, NCV, JBP, ESV)

1. Jesus was giving his disciples permission to continue to sleep and rest. See H. B. Swete page 347 He said this because he was disappointed that they were sleeping again after he warned them twice to stay awake. For example, the NJB says:

You can sleep on now and have your rest. (NJB, KJV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as the majority of English versions do. There are several ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Still sleeping? Still resting? (NLT96)

Up to now, in spite of the fact that I admonished you, are you sleeping, are you resting your body?

- As an exclamation or statement. For example:

I am amazed that you are still sleeping and resting!

Translate this in a natural way in your language for this context.

sleeping and resting: The words sleeping and resting have similar meanings, but they are different. A person can rest without sleeping. Also, one disciple could have been asleep, while another was just lying down and resting. Since the text does not specify the details, it is better to try to express both meanings in the translation, if possible. For example:

sleeping and taking a rest

14:41c **That is enough!**

- Enough!
- That's enough sleeping and resting!
- You have rested and slept enough!

That is enough!: Scholars connect the word enough to its context in two different ways:

1. The word enough refers to the sleeping and resting of the disciples. For example:

That's enough sleeping and resting!

You have rested and slept enough!

1. The word enough refers to warnings that Jesus was giving the disciples against sleeping. Jesus implied that he had warned them enough. Since Judas was coming to betray him, there was no more time to warn the disciples. For example:

That's enough of my rebuking you.

English versions are ambiguous about this issue. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

14:41d **The hour has come.**

- The day/time/hour has already arrived.
- Now is the time for God's plan/will to be fulfilled.

The hour has come: The words The hour has come refer to the "day" or "time" when the suffering that Jesus had prayed about would begin. This is the same hour that was mentioned in 14:35b-c. It would begin when Judas betrayed him and he was arrested.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

The day/time/hour that God has designated has already arrived.

Now is the time.

The time of suffering has begun.

14:41e **Look, the Son of Man is betrayed into the hands of sinners.**

- I, the Son of Man, will now be betrayed to the power of sinful people.
- Listen, someone is going to give me, the Son of Man, to evil men so that they will be able to arrest me.

Look: The word Look is used here to get the hearer's attention. It indicates to the hearer that the information that follows is important. The word indicates that Jesus wanted the disciples to give their attention to what he was going to tell them. Another way to say this is:

Listen!

Because it is not normal English style to use a word like "Look" in this context, many English versions do not translate this word. Consider whether there is a similar expression in your language that would be natural to say in this context. See how you translated this word in 1:2b-c, where the BSB translates it as "Behold."

the Son of Man is betrayed into the hands of sinners: This is a passive clause. It focuses on Jesus as the Son of Man. In some languages it may be necessary to use an active clause here. For example:

they betray/give me, the Son of Man, into the hands of sinful people

the Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is literally “the Son of the human/person.” Jesus used this title to imply that:

1. he was a true human being, and he represented all people.
2. he came from God and had authority from God.

Try to use an expression that implies both meanings. Here are some other expressions that translators have used:

the Man whom God Sent

the True Man from God/Heaven

the Representative of Mankind

The Older Brother of All People

In some cases, an unusual title may correctly suggest a deeper meaning. For example:

the Child of a Person

the One who was Born as a Human

Translators have also used expressions that are more literal. These more literal expressions may be appropriate where readers are familiar with a literal title in another version.

Jesus referred to himself here. See the example in the preceding note for a way to indicate that.

is betrayed: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as is betrayed refers to the action that is just then happening. In some languages it may be helpful to emphasize this, since 14:41d focuses on the fact that the hour has come. For example, the GNT says:

The hour has come! Look, the Son of Man is now being handed over to the power of sinners. (GNT)

betrayed into the hands of: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as betrayed into the hands of means “to deliver a person into the power of [someone else].” The words into the hands are a figure of speech. To put someone “into the hands” of others means to cause

others to gain power over them. Another way to say this is:

[be put] under the control/power of sinners

Betrayal often implies using deceit. For example, in this case Judas pretended to be Jesus’ friend, but he arranged for the enemies of Jesus to capture him.

The phrase into the hands of also occurs in 9:31c.

sinners: The word sinners means “sinful people” or “evil people.” They are people who habitually do what is contrary to God’s law.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

evil people

people who want to do evil

Mark 14:42

Section 14:32–42: Jesus prayed in a place called Gethsemane

The conversation in the preceding section occurred while Jesus and the disciples were walking toward the Mount of Olives (14:26–27). In this section, they came to a place where there were olive trees. This place was called Gethsemane. Jesus told his disciples to pray that God would give them strength not to sin. Jesus also prayed that he himself would do what his heavenly Father wanted him to do, rather than what he himself wanted.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus prayed in the garden called Gethsemane

Jesus’ prayer in Gethsemane

Jesus prayed for God’s will to be done

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:36–46 and Luke 22:39–46.

14:42a

Rise, let us go.

- Stand up and let us^(incl) go.
- Get up and come with me.

- Stand up! Let us^(incl) go

Rise: In this context the word Rise is a command that means “stand up” or “get up.” Jesus said this to the disciples.

let us go: In this context the words let us go are a command that means, “let us go to meet them.” It does not mean, “let us flee” or “let us run away.” Jesus intended that he and his disciples would go and meet Judas and the temple guards who were coming to arrest him.

14:42b

See, My betrayer is approaching!”

- Look! My betrayer is approaching!” (NET)
- The one who is betraying me to them is coming over there.”
- and meet the one who will betray me. There he comes!”

In Greek this part of the verse begins with the same word that the BSB translated as “Look” in 14:41e. Here the BSB has chosen to translate it as See. Here the word indicates again that Jesus wanted the disciples to give their attention to what he would tell them.

See how you translated this word in 14:41e.

See, My betrayer is approaching!”: The clause My betrayer is approaching! indicates that the person who would betray Jesus was already nearby.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Look! My betrayer is approaching! (NET)

Look, here comes the man who has turned against me. (NCV)

See, my betrayer is here! (NLT96)

My betrayer: Here are some other ways to translate My betrayer:

the one who betrays me

the person who will give me to my enemies

the one who will cause me to be captured

Translate My betrayer in a way similar to how you translated “betrayed” in 14:41e.

General Comment on 14:42a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder 14:42a and 14:42b. For example:

^{42b}Look, the one who is giving me into the hands of people in order that they kill me is coming.

^{42a}Stand up! Let’s go meet him.

Mark 14:43

Section 14:43–52: Judas betrayed Jesus, and then Jesus’ enemies arrested him

The events in this section, like those in the preceding section, happened at night in the olive grove called Gethsemane.

At the end of 14:42, Jesus told his disciples that the one who would betray him was coming. At the beginning of this section in 14:43, Judas, the betrayer, arrived. He came with a crowd of armed men that the Jewish religious leaders had sent. Judas betrayed Jesus by kissing him. Then the crowd of men arrested Jesus and the disciples fled. As one of them was running away, some people grabbed the linen cloth he had wrapped around himself. He left the cloth in their hands and ran away naked.

In this section Mark referred back to things that happened before the crowd came to arrest Jesus. Before Judas came with the crowd, he went to the chief priests, teachers of the law, and elders. He told them that he would betray Jesus to them. They agreed to send armed men with him to arrest Jesus. These men probably would not recognize which man was Jesus. Judas told them that he would kiss Jesus to show them the man whom they should arrest. Tell about these events in a way that will help people understand why that group of men arrived with Judas.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The betrayal and arrest of Jesus

Jesus is captured

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:47–56, Luke 22:47–53, and John 18:3.

14:43a

While Jesus was still speaking,

- ¶ While he was saying this to his disciples,

- ¶ Jesus was still speaking (GNT)

While Jesus was still speaking: The clause While Jesus was still speaking refers back to what Jesus was saying in 14:41–42. This clause introduces an important new event: Judas brought men to arrest Jesus. The introductory clause indicates that this event began even while Jesus was speaking. Here is one way to introduce this important event:

While he was still speaking, this is what happened: Judas, one of the twelve disciples, appeared.

Introduce this important event in a natural way in your language. See the note on 1:10 for a similar example.

Jesus was still speaking: In some languages, you may need to say to whom Jesus was speaking. For example, you could say:

he was speaking to his disciples

In some languages it may be natural to provide a direct object for the speech verb. For example:

he was saying these words

14:43b

Judas, one of the Twelve, arrived,

- Judas, one of the Twelve disciples, came to the place where Jesus was.
- when Judas, one of the Twelve followers, arrived. (GNT)

Judas, one of the Twelve: In this context the phrase one of the Twelve indicates that Judas was one of Jesus' twelve closest disciples. You may need to include your term for "disciples" in this phrase. For example:

Judas, who was one of Jesus' twelve disciples

arrived: In some languages it may be necessary to mention the place where Judas arrived. For example:

arrived at the place where Jesus was.

John 13:30 indicates that Judas had left the other disciples earlier in the evening during the supper. If readers wonder why Judas was not with the other disciples, you may want to supply this information in a footnote.

14:43c

accompanied by a crowd armed with swords and clubs,

- Coming with Judas there was a crowd armed with swords/daggers and clubs.
- A big group of people carrying long knives and big sticks accompanied Judas.

accompanied by a crowd: A crowd came with Judas to the place where Jesus was. In some languages it may be natural to mention Judas's name again here. For example:

A crowd accompanied Judas.

a crowd: The word crowd refers to many people. In this case the people were probably all men.

armed with swords and clubs: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as armed with is literally only "with," as in the RSV. In this context it indicates that the men were carrying swords and clubs to use as weapons. They were ready to fight anyone who resisted them. The NCV has:

carrying swords and clubs (NCV)

swords: The word swords refers to long metal knives or daggers that people used for fighting. According to the UBS (page 454), these were not necessarily official swords, but may have been knives. Louw & Nida (page 58) identify them as short swords or daggers used for stabbing and slicing. These long knives were sharp. If there is no word for swords or "daggers" in your language, you may:

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

long knives

- Use a cultural substitute. For example:

machetes/bolos/bush knives

clubs: The word clubs refers to heavy pieces of wood that people used for fighting. If there is no word for clubs in your language, you may use a descriptive phrase. For example:

heavy/big sticks

14:43d

sent from the chief priests, scribes, and elders.

- This crowd was sent by the chief priests, the teachers of the law, and the elders.
- The chief priests, the experts in the law, and the elders had sent the crowd to arrest Jesus.

sent from the chief priests, scribes, and elders: The clause sent from the chief priests, scribes, and elders is passive. If it is more natural in your language to use an active verb here, you can say:

...the chief priests, the teachers of the law, and the elders had sent the crowd.

sent from: The armed crowd was sent by the Jewish leaders. This means that the Jewish leaders planned the way to arrest Jesus and ordered some men to do that.

the chief priests, scribes, and elders: These three groups together represented all the leaders of the Jews. Mark wrote about these same three groups in 8:31c. See how you translated the description there.

chief priests: A Jewish priest was a man who offered sacrifices to God on behalf of the people. He also performed other rituals for them. The phrase chief priests refers to the leaders among these priests.

Here are some other ways to translate chief priests:

the leading/ruling priests

the elders among the Jewish sacrificers

the most prominent priests

This same term occurs in 14:1b and 14:10b.

scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes is sometimes translated as “teachers of the law” (as in the NIV). The original work of these men was to copy the laws of Moses by hand. In New Testament times, their main task was to study, interpret, and teach the law of Moses and Jewish laws and traditions that were based on the law of Moses.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

the teachers of the Law of Moses (CEV)

the teachers of religious law (NLT)

This same word occurs in 14:1b. See also teacher of the law in the Glossary.

elders: The elders were the civil leaders or rulers. They were generally older men. See how you translated this in 11:27.

Mark 14:44

Section 14:43–52: Judas betrayed Jesus, and then Jesus’ enemies arrested him

The events in this section, like those in the preceding section, happened at night in the olive grove called Gethsemane.

At the end of 14:42, Jesus told his disciples that the one who would betray him was coming. At the beginning of this section in 14:43, Judas, the betrayer, arrived. He came with a crowd of armed men that the Jewish religious leaders had sent. Judas betrayed Jesus by kissing him. Then the crowd of men arrested Jesus and the disciples fled. As one of them was running away, some people grabbed the linen cloth he had wrapped around himself. He left the cloth in their hands and ran away naked.

In this section Mark referred back to things that happened before the crowd came to arrest Jesus. Before Judas came with the crowd, he went to the chief priests, teachers of the law, and elders. He told them that he would betray Jesus to them. They agreed to send armed men with him to arrest Jesus. These men probably would not recognize which man was Jesus. Judas told them that he would kiss Jesus to show them the man whom they should arrest. Tell about these events in a way that will help people understand why that group of men arrived with Judas.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The betrayal and arrest of Jesus

Jesus is captured

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:47–56, Luke 22:47–53, and John 18:3.

14:44

Verse 44 provides background information. It describes the plan that Judas had previously made with the Jewish leaders to identify Jesus so that they could arrest him.

14:44a

Now the betrayer had arranged a signal with them:

- The man who was planning to betray Jesus had previously/already arranged a signal with them,
- The one who was going to give Jesus into the control of the authorities had already told the crowd how they would know whom to arrest.

Now: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as Now introduces background information. It is not a time word here. It explains what Judas had already told the crowd that came to arrest Jesus.

the betrayer: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the betrayer is literally “the one giving him over.” In this context it refers to someone who puts someone else into the power of his enemies. He causes that person’s enemies to gain control over him.

Mark uses the phrase the betrayer as another way to refer to Judas. See 14:42b for more discussion of the word betrayer.

In this verse Judas had not yet actually betrayed Jesus. In some languages it might be necessary to indicate that. For example:

the one intending to betray him

the person who was planning to betray him

In some languages it might be necessary to specify who the betrayer was. So you could say:

Judas, the betrayer

had arranged a signal with them: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as had arranged a signal with them is literally “had given a sign to them.” In this context it indicates that Judas had previously told the crowd what he would do to show them which man they should arrest.

a signal: A signal refers to something that people do or say to communicate a special meaning. Before they do it or say it, they agree on what it will mean. Judas had earlier told the crowd that they should watch for him to greet one man in a certain way. Greeting him with a kiss would be a signal. It would mean that Jesus was the man whom the crowd should arrest.

14:44b

“The One I kiss is the man;

- saying, “The person I kiss is the man whom you want to arrest.
- He had said to them, “The man whom I greet affectionately is the person whom you are looking for.

- He would greet that person with a kiss.

This part of the verse gives the words that Judas said to the crowd when he arranged the signal with them. In some languages it may be necessary to supply an introduction to these words. For example:

He had said to them, “The one I kiss...”

See the General Comment on 14:44a–c for a suggestion about indirect speech.

The One I kiss is the man: Judas said these words because he knew that there would be other people with Jesus. Judas planned to kiss Jesus to show the crowd that Jesus was the man whom they wanted to arrest. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

The one I kiss is the man you are looking for

The man I kiss is the person whom you want to arrest

The One: The One means “the person” or “the man.”

kiss: The word kiss means “to touch someone with the lips on one cheek or on both cheeks.” In some cultures it is unusual or inappropriate for a man to kiss another man. If that is true in your culture, here are some options to consider:

- Use an appropriate term for “kiss” and indicate the purpose of the kiss. For example:

whom I greet according to custom with a kiss

whom I greet by touching his cheek with my lips

- Use a more general expression for an appropriate greeting. For example:

to whom I give an affectionate greeting

whom I greet as my rabbi

whom I embrace respectfully

14:44c

arrest Him and lead Him away securely.”

- Seize^(plur) him and lead^(plur) him away securely.”

- Grab him and guard him carefully as you lead him away.”
- Then they should grab him and guard him carefully as they led him away.

arrest: The Greek word that the BSB translates arrest is literally “seize,” as in the RSV. See 14:1c for further discussion of arrest.

lead Him away securely: In this context securely means to watch a prisoner carefully.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

guard him closely as you take him away (GW)

get him safely away (REB)

lead him away under guard (NIV)

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate that this is the end of what Judas said to the crowd before they came to Jesus. For example:

“...lead him away under guard,” Judas told the crowd

General Comment on 14:44a–c

In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech in these verse parts. For example, you could say:

Now the betrayer had arranged a signal with them. He had told them that the one he kissed was the man they were looking for. They should arrest him and lead him away under guard.

Mark 14:45

Section 14:43–52: Judas betrayed Jesus, and then Jesus’ enemies arrested him

The events in this section, like those in the preceding section, happened at night in the olive grove called Gethsemane.

At the end of 14:42, Jesus told his disciples that the one who would betray him was coming. At the beginning of this section in 14:43, Judas, the betrayer, arrived. He came with a crowd of armed men that the Jewish religious leaders had sent. Judas betrayed Jesus by kissing him. Then the crowd of men arrested Jesus and the disciples fled. As one of them was running away, some people grabbed the linen cloth he

had wrapped around himself. He left the cloth in their hands and ran away naked.

In this section Mark referred back to things that happened before the crowd came to arrest Jesus. Before Judas came with the crowd, he went to the chief priests, teachers of the law, and elders. He told them that he would betray Jesus to them. They agreed to send armed men with him to arrest Jesus. These men probably would not recognize which man was Jesus. Judas told them that he would kiss Jesus to show them the man whom they should arrest. Tell about these events in a way that will help people understand why that group of men arrived with Judas.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The betrayal and arrest of Jesus

Jesus is captured

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:47–56, Luke 22:47–53, and John 18:3.

14:45

The background information in 14:44 has ended. In this verse Mark continued to tell what happened to Jesus when the men arrived. Use a natural way in your language to indicate that the author has returned to the story. For example:

When Judas and the crowd reached Jesus, Judas went to him at once...

14:45a

Going directly to Jesus, he said, “Rabbi!”

- When Judas came to the place where Jesus and the disciples were, he went immediately to Jesus and said, “Rabbi!”
- As soon as Judas arrived where Jesus was, he went up to Jesus and said, “Teacher!”

Going directly to Jesus, he said, “Rabbi!”: The phrase that the BSB translates as Going directly to Jesus indicates that when Judas came to where Jesus was, he immediately approached Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Judas went at once to Jesus and said, “Rabbi!”

When Judas came, he went to Jesus immediately and said “Rabbi!” (NET)

directly: Judas went straight to Jesus without delay. Judas had a plan that he intended to follow.

Rabbi: Judas addressed Jesus as Rabbi. This word is a transliteration of a Hebrew word that means “my great one.” At the time when Mark wrote this Gospel, people used this word as a title of respect for an important religious teacher or leader. It does not refer to a school teacher.

If you do not have a word that expresses this idea of a religious teacher, you can simply use the word “teacher” or “master.” If possible, use a word that implies that the teacher is respected. For example:

Teacher (GNT)

My teacher/master

In some languages you may need to add an expression of greeting. For example:

Greetings, teacher!

Use an expression in your language that is natural and shows proper respect.

14:45b and kissed Him.

- Then Judas kissed Jesus,
- and he greeted Jesus by kissing him on the cheek, as he had told the crowd.

and kissed Him: Judas kissed Jesus on the cheek as a part of his greeting. His kiss was really part of the signal that he had arranged to identify Jesus.

kissed: See 14:44b for a discussion of the word “kiss.”

Mark 14:46

Section 14:43–52: Judas betrayed Jesus, and then Jesus’ enemies arrested him

The events in this section, like those in the preceding section, happened at night in the olive grove called Gethsemane.

At the end of 14:42, Jesus told his disciples that the one who would betray him was coming. At the beginning of this section in 14:43, Judas, the betrayer, arrived. He came with a crowd of armed men that the Jewish religious leaders had sent. Judas betrayed Jesus by kissing him. Then the crowd of men arrested

Jesus and the disciples fled. As one of them was running away, some people grabbed the linen cloth he had wrapped around himself. He left the cloth in their hands and ran away naked.

In this section Mark referred back to things that happened before the crowd came to arrest Jesus. Before Judas came with the crowd, he went to the chief priests, teachers of the law, and elders. He told them that he would betray Jesus to them. They agreed to send armed men with him to arrest Jesus. These men probably would not recognize which man was Jesus. Judas told them that he would kiss Jesus to show them the man whom they should arrest. Tell about these events in a way that will help people understand why that group of men arrived with Judas.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The betrayal and arrest of Jesus

Jesus is captured

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:47–56, Luke 22:47–53, and John 18:3.

14:46 Then the men seized Jesus and arrested Him.

- and the crowd grabbed him and took him into custody.
- So they arrested Jesus and held him tightly.

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then connects the crowd’s reaction to what Judas did in the previous verse part. They understood that the kiss was the signal to arrest Jesus and that led to their next action. Some English versions translate the conjunction as “and” or “so.” For example:

So they arrested Jesus (GNT)

And they lay hands on him (NASB)

Introduce what happened next in a natural way in your language.

the men: The BSB supplies the phrase the men to refer back to the crowd that came with Judas to arrest Jesus. The Greek text refers to them in a way that could be translated as “they.” Refer back to them in a natural way in your language.

seized Jesus and arrested Him: The Greek words that the BSB translates as seized...and arrested are literally “laid their hands on him” and “seized him.” These expressions refer to grabbing another person, and then making sure that the person cannot get away. Use expressions that people would use in your culture in this context. For example:

They grabbed him and took him into custody.

So they arrested Jesus and held him tight. (GNT)

If you do not have two similar words or expressions to describe this action, you may use only one expression. For example:

Then the men arrested Jesus.

Mark 14:47

Section 14:43–52: Judas betrayed Jesus, and then Jesus’ enemies arrested him

The events in this section, like those in the preceding section, happened at night in the olive grove called Gethsemane.

At the end of 14:42, Jesus told his disciples that the one who would betray him was coming. At the beginning of this section in 14:43, Judas, the betrayer, arrived. He came with a crowd of armed men that the Jewish religious leaders had sent. Judas betrayed Jesus by kissing him. Then the crowd of men arrested Jesus and the disciples fled. As one of them was running away, some people grabbed the linen cloth he had wrapped around himself. He left the cloth in their hands and ran away naked.

In this section Mark referred back to things that happened before the crowd came to arrest Jesus. Before Judas came with the crowd, he went to the chief priests, teachers of the law, and elders. He told them that he would betray Jesus to them. They agreed to send armed men with him to arrest Jesus. These men probably would not recognize which man was Jesus. Judas told them that he would kiss Jesus to show them the man whom they should arrest. Tell about these events in a way that will help people understand why that group of men arrived with Judas.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The betrayal and arrest of Jesus

Jesus is captured

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:47–56, Luke 22:47–53, and John 18:3.

14:47a

And one of the bystanders drew his sword

- Then someone who was standing near Jesus unsheathed his sword/dagger
- Then a bystander pulled out a long knife from its covering.

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And introduces what happened after the crowd arrested Jesus. What happened next was that someone opposed the men who were arresting Jesus. Introduce this next event in a natural way in your language.

one of the bystanders: The phrase one of the bystanders refers to someone who was standing near Jesus when the crowd arrested him. John 18:10 mentions that this was Peter. You may wish to mention this in a footnote.

bystanders: In some languages, it may be not be natural to refer to this person in a way that refers to standing. If this is true for your language, you could say:

Then one of those who was there near Jesus

drew his sword: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as drew means “to pull.” The person pulled his sword out of the place where he normally kept it covered. This place was probably a sheath. If your language has a word for removing a knife or sword from its covering, you should use it here.

sword: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sword here was also used in 14:43c. You can translate it in the same way here.

14:47b

and struck the servant of the high priest,

- and hit the servant of the high priest with it,
- He used his sword to strike/attack the high priest’s slave

struck the servant of the high priest: The Greek word that the BSB translates as struck is literally “hit” or “strike.” In this context it implies that the person used his sword to hit the servant and cut him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

used his sword to strike/attack/hit the high priest's servant

struck the servant of the high priest with his sword

the servant of the high priest: The phrase the servant of the high priest probably implies that this was the high priest's only servant who was in the crowd that night. It does not mean that this was the high priest's only servant.

Here is another way to translate this:

the servant who belonged to the high priest

servant: The Greek word that the BSB translates as servant literally means "slave." This Greek word refers to someone who was owned by another person. He worked for his owner/master without receiving pay. He had no rights of his own (or very few rights).

In some cultures, slaves may not be known. In other cultures, the word for "slave" may not be appropriate in this context.

If that is true in your language, here are some other ways to translate this:

a person who belongs to someone else

a person whom someone else owns

a person who serves someone

a lowly worker

The BSB translates this same word as "slave" in 10:44.

high priest: The high priest was the leader of all the Jewish priests. All Jewish priests offered sacrifices on behalf of the people. The high priest offered certain special sacrifices that no other priest could offer. In a special way, he represented the Jewish people to God.

Here are some other ways to translate high priest:

the chief/leader of all the priests

the main/principal Priest

the highest/leading priest

See how you translated this term in 2:26a.

14:47c cutting off his ear.

- and cut/sliced off his ear.
- and severed his ear from his head with the sword.

cutting off his ear: The phrase cutting off his ear indicates the result of what happened in 14:47b. When the man hit the servant with his sword, it cut off his ear. Express that in a natural way in your language. For example:

and cut/sliced/slashed off his ear.

his ear: In some languages it may be necessary to specify "right" ear or "left" ear. If this is true in your language, then you may indicate that it was the right ear. (We know this from what Luke and John wrote about this event in Luke 22:50 and John 18:10.)

General Comment on 14:47a–c

In some languages it may be necessary to reorder the phrases in 14:47a–c to make it sound natural. The NLT96 has one way to do this:

^{47a}But someone pulled out a sword ^{47b}and slashed ^{47c}off an ear ^{47b}of the high priest's servant.

Mark 14:48

Section 14:43–52: Judas betrayed Jesus, and then Jesus' enemies arrested him

The events in this section, like those in the preceding section, happened at night in the olive grove called Gethsemane.

At the end of 14:42, Jesus told his disciples that the one who would betray him was coming. At the beginning of this section in 14:43, Judas, the betrayer, arrived. He came with a crowd of armed men that the Jewish religious leaders had sent. Judas betrayed Jesus by kissing him. Then the crowd of men arrested Jesus and the disciples fled. As one of them was running away, some people grabbed the linen cloth he had wrapped around himself. He left the cloth in their hands and ran away naked.

In this section Mark referred back to things that happened before the crowd came to arrest Jesus. Before Judas came with the crowd, he went to the chief priests, teachers of the law, and elders. He told them that he would betray Jesus to them. They agreed to send armed men with him to arrest Jesus. These men probably would not recognize which man was Jesus.

Judas told them that he would kiss Jesus to show them the man whom they should arrest. Tell about these events in a way that will help people understand why that group of men arrived with Judas.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The betrayal and arrest of Jesus

Jesus is captured

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:47-56, Luke 22:47-53, and John 18:3.

14:48-49

Verses 14:48-49 contain the words that Jesus spoke while he was being arrested. He began with a rhetorical question that he used to rebuke those who came to arrest him. He ended by focusing the men's attention on the fact that the way he was arrested fulfilled Scripture. In other words, the way he was arrested was exactly the way words of Scripture from the Old Testament had said it would happen.

14:48a

Jesus asked the crowd,

- Jesus asked them,
- Jesus said,
- Jesus said to the crowd,

14:48a-c

Jesus asked the crowd, “Have you come out with swords and clubs to arrest Me as you would an outlaw?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus asked this question to rebuke those who had come to arrest him. He rebuked them because they came to capture him with swords and clubs as if he were a dangerous criminal. There are at least two ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Have you come out with swords and clubs to arrest me as if I were a criminal? (GW)

Am I some dangerous criminal, that you come armed with swords and clubs to arrest me? (NLT96)

- Use a statement. For example:

You came to get me with swords and clubs as if I were a criminal. (NCV)

I am not a bandit. You did not need to come armed with swords and clubs to capture me.

Use whichever form is most natural to express a rebuke in your language.

14:48b

“Have you come out with swords and clubs

- “Is that the reason that you have come carrying swords and clubs
- “Have you come here with your long knives and big sticks
- “You did not need to bring swords and clubs

Have you come out with swords and clubs: The clause Have you come out with swords and clubs continues to describe the manner in which the men arrested Jesus. They were acting as though he was violent and dangerous.

with swords and clubs: The phrase with swords and clubs means “carrying swords and clubs.”

Here is another way to translate this:

armed with swords and clubs.

See the notes on 14:43c, where the same Greek phrase occurs.

14:48c

to arrest Me as you would an outlaw?

- to arrest me? Am I a criminal?”
- to take me away? You are acting as though I were a thief. Is that the right way to treat me?”
- to capture me. I am not a bandit!”

to arrest: The Greek word that the BSB translates as arrest can also mean “seize” or “capture.” Here it is a synonym of the word that the BSB translates as “arrest” in 14:44c and “arrested” in 14:46.

as you would an outlaw: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as as you would an outlaw is literally “as against a criminal.” This phrase indicates the manner in which the mob was arresting Jesus. They came to him to arrest him as if he were a dangerous criminal.

an outlaw: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as an outlaw:

1. It means “robber, bandit, or criminal.” This refers to someone who breaks the law. For example:

Have you come out with swords and clubs to arrest me as if I were a criminal? (GW)

“Am I a bandit,” he said, “that you had to set out to capture me with swords and clubs?” (NJB) (BSB, GNT, RSV, NJB, NET, ESV, CEV, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, REB, NLT96)

1. It means “rebel or revolutionary.” This refers to someone who fights against the rulers of his country. For example:

Have you come with swords and clubs to arrest me as though I were a rebel?

Am I some dangerous revolutionary, that you come with swords and clubs to arrest me? (NLT) (NIV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and the majority of English versions.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Have you come carrying swords and clubs because you think that I am a criminal?

Have you come carrying swords and clubs to arrest me like you would arrest a bandit?

Remember that this rhetorical question can also be translated as a statement, if that is more natural in your language. See the examples in the note on 14:48a–c.

General Comment on 14:48a–c

The BSB has changed the Greek order of the verse parts in order to make a more natural English sentence.

The RSV has followed the Greek order. The raised numbers show the BSB order that corresponds to lines in the Display:

^{48a}And Jesus said to them, ^{48b}“Have you come out ^{48c}as against a robber, ^{48b}with swords and clubs ^{48c}to capture me?” (RSV)

The NIV has reordered this verse in another way. Again, the raised numbers show the BSB order:

^{48c}“Am I leading a rebellion,” ^{48a}said Jesus, ^{48b}“that you have come out with swords and clubs ^{48c}to capture me?”

Use whatever order is the most natural in your language.

Mark 14:49

Section 14:43–52: Judas betrayed Jesus, and then Jesus’ enemies arrested him

The events in this section, like those in the preceding section, happened at night in the olive grove called Gethsemane.

At the end of 14:42, Jesus told his disciples that the one who would betray him was coming. At the beginning of this section in 14:43, Judas, the betrayer, arrived. He came with a crowd of armed men that the Jewish religious leaders had sent. Judas betrayed Jesus by kissing him. Then the crowd of men arrested Jesus and the disciples fled. As one of them was running away, some people grabbed the linen cloth he had wrapped around himself. He left the cloth in their hands and ran away naked.

In this section Mark referred back to things that happened before the crowd came to arrest Jesus. Before Judas came with the crowd, he went to the chief priests, teachers of the law, and elders. He told them that he would betray Jesus to them. They agreed to send armed men with him to arrest Jesus. These men probably would not recognize which man was Jesus. Judas told them that he would kiss Jesus to show them the man whom they should arrest. Tell about these events in a way that will help people understand why that group of men arrived with Judas.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The betrayal and arrest of Jesus

Jesus is captured

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:47–56, Luke 22:47–53, and John 18:3.

14:49a–b

Every day I was with you, teaching in the temple courts, and you did not arrest Me: In this part of the verse Jesus continued the rebuke that he began in verse 48. Jesus’ words continue to the end of 14:49c.

He indicated that there was no reason for the crowd to come to arrest him armed with swords and clubs. They knew that he was not a violent criminal. They had seen him every day when he was teaching in the temple courtyard. They had made no attempt to arrest him at that time.

14:49a

Every day I was with you, teaching in the temple courts,

- Day after day I was among you teaching in the yard/courtyard of the temple,
- You were there when I was teaching in the area around the temple every day.

Every day: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as Every day means “day by day, regularly, for many days.” Jesus was probably particularly thinking of the week that had just past.

I was with you, teaching in the temple courts: Jesus often had taught publicly in the temple area. Many of his enemies had been there, too, listening to him. It is possible to translate this as:

you were there while I was teaching in the temple courts

temple courts: The Greek word that the BSB translates as temple courts is literally “temple,” as in most English versions. The temple consisted of the temple building itself and the walls and courtyards that surrounded it. Here “temple” refers specifically to the courtyard. People did not meet inside the temple building because only the priests could go there.

Some English versions have made this clear by translating “temple” as temple courts (BSB, NIV, NET) or “temple courtyard” (GW). You may want to do this also if your word or phrase for “temple” would make readers think that Jesus taught people inside the temple building.

Here are some other ways to translate the term temple courts:

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

courtyard of the house of God

the area around/belonging to the house of sacrifice

holy/sacred house courtyard/area

- If your language has a word for “temple,” consider using it. But you may need to modify it by saying:

courtyard of our temple/the temple of the Lord

big/great temple area/clearing

See how you translated this in 11:16. See also temple, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information about the temple and how to translate it.

14:49b

and you did not arrest Me.

- but you did not arrest me even though you had the opportunity.
- So, why did you not arrest me then?

and you did not arrest Me: Jesus was implying that if he had really done anything wrong, the authorities would have arrested him openly. They did not arrest him in public, because they knew that he had not done anything wrong and they were afraid the people would riot.

In some languages it may be natural to express this as a rhetorical question. For example:

So, why did you not arrest me then?

arrest: This is the same word that is used in 14:44c. See how you translated arrest in that verse.

General Comment on 14:49a–b

In some languages it might be more natural to change the order of the clauses and ask the question first. For example:

^{49b}Why did you not arrest me ^{49a}in the temple area? I was there teaching every day.

14:49c

But this has happened that the Scriptures would be fulfilled.”

- But what God caused to be written about me must occur. That is why this is happening.”
- But this is happening so that the events that people wrote about me in the word of God will happen just as they wrote.”

But this has happened that the Scriptures would be fulfilled: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But indicates a contrast with 14:49b. In this context the contrast involves implied information. Jesus was in the temple every day and it would have been easy to

arrest him. But the Scriptures must be fulfilled, so they arrested him as though he were a bandit (14:48). In other words, the way the crowd arrested Jesus fulfilled the Scriptures. This contrasted with what would have been the right way to treat Jesus.

Other ways to express this implied information are given in the meaning lines of the Display for 14:49c. Decide whether you need to make this information explicit.

the Scriptures: Here the phrase the Scriptures refers to the books of the Old Testament. See how you translated Scriptures in 12:24a–c.

Jesus may have been thinking about such OT passages as Zechariah 13:7 and Isaiah chapter 53.

would be fulfilled: God caused men to write in the Scripture about some things that would happen later. When those things actually occurred, the people who understood that connection said that Scripture was fulfilled.

Here are some other ways of translating this phrase:

must happen

must come true

Mark 14:50

Section 14:43–52: Judas betrayed Jesus, and then Jesus' enemies arrested him

The events in this section, like those in the preceding section, happened at night in the olive grove called Gethsemane.

At the end of 14:42, Jesus told his disciples that the one who would betray him was coming. At the beginning of this section in 14:43, Judas, the betrayer, arrived. He came with a crowd of armed men that the Jewish religious leaders had sent. Judas betrayed Jesus by kissing him. Then the crowd of men arrested Jesus and the disciples fled. As one of them was running away, some people grabbed the linen cloth he had wrapped around himself. He left the cloth in their hands and ran away naked.

In this section Mark referred back to things that happened before the crowd came to arrest Jesus. Before Judas came with the crowd, he went to the chief priests, teachers of the law, and elders. He told them that he would betray Jesus to them. They agreed to send armed men with him to arrest Jesus. These men probably would not recognize which man was Jesus. Judas told them that he would kiss Jesus to show them

the man whom they should arrest. Tell about these events in a way that will help people understand why that group of men arrived with Judas.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The betrayal and arrest of Jesus

Jesus is captured

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:47–56, Luke 22:47–53, and John 18:3.

14:50

Then everyone deserted Him and fled.

- ¶ Then all Jesus' disciples deserted him and fled.
- ¶ Then all of his followers abandoned him and ran away.

This verse says that Jesus' disciples abandoned him and ran away. In Mark 14:27, Jesus himself predicted that this would happen. This event also fulfilled Zechariah 13:7 in the Old Testament. It was another example of how the events that were happening fulfilled Scripture, as Jesus said in 14:49c.

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then here introduces the next event. Connect this verse with 14:49 in a way that is natural in your language.

everyone deserted Him and fled: As Jesus finished speaking in 14:49, his followers realized that he was going to allow the crowd to arrest him. They feared that they would also be arrested, so they abandoned him and ran away.

everyone: The word everyone refers to Jesus' disciples. It does not include Judas, who betrayed Jesus, or the crowd who arrested him.

deserted Him: The phrase deserted Him means "abandoned him," "left him without support."

fled: The word fled indicates that the disciples "ran away." Jesus' disciples fled because they were afraid that the crowd would seize and arrest them, too.

Mark 14:51

Section 14:43–52: Judas betrayed Jesus, and then Jesus' enemies arrested him

The events in this section, like those in the preceding section, happened at night in the olive grove called Gethsemane.

At the end of 14:42, Jesus told his disciples that the one who would betray him was coming. At the beginning of this section in 14:43, Judas, the betrayer, arrived. He came with a crowd of armed men that the Jewish religious leaders had sent. Judas betrayed Jesus by kissing him. Then the crowd of men arrested Jesus and the disciples fled. As one of them was running away, some people grabbed the linen cloth he had wrapped around himself. He left the cloth in their hands and ran away naked.

In this section Mark referred back to things that happened before the crowd came to arrest Jesus. Before Judas came with the crowd, he went to the chief priests, teachers of the law, and elders. He told them that he would betray Jesus to them. They agreed to send armed men with him to arrest Jesus. These men probably would not recognize which man was Jesus. Judas told them that he would kiss Jesus to show them the man whom they should arrest. Tell about these events in a way that will help people understand why that group of men arrived with Judas.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The betrayal and arrest of Jesus

Jesus is captured

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:47–56, Luke 22:47–53, and John 18:3.

14:51a

One young man who had been following Jesus was wearing a linen cloth around his body.

- ¶ There was a young man dressed/wrapped only in a high quality cloth/sheet who was following Jesus.
- ¶ One young man who was following Jesus was wearing only a linen cloth/garment, nothing else.

One young man who had been following Jesus was wearing a linen cloth around his body: This part of the verse introduces One young man into the story for the first time. Mark does not say who he was. In some

languages, there may be a special way to introduce him here. For example:

There was a young man wearing a linen cloth who was also following Jesus.

Notice that the example above introduces the facts about the young man in a different order. Introduce the young man in a way that is natural in your language.

One young man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as young man normally refers to a young, unmarried male person. This young man would probably have been about twenty years old.

who had been following Jesus: This young man was following along with Jesus that night, but he probably was not one of Jesus' twelve disciples. He was not part of the crowd that arrived with Judas to arrest Jesus.

was wearing a linen cloth around his body: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as was wearing a linen cloth around his body is literally "having been clothed with linen over his naked body." He was wearing only a linen cloth or garment.

The Greek word for "linen" specifies only the type of cloth, not the shape or style of his clothes. Most scholars think that in this context it refers to a linen sheet/cloth or outer garment.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

with nothing on but a linen cloth (REB, NJB)

wearing only a linen cloth (RSV, NCV, CEV, NET)

wearing nothing but a linen sheet over his naked body (NASB)

wrapped in a linen cloth/sheet and that's all

Some languages have a specific verb for wrapping a blanket or other piece of cloth around one's body. Other languages may have a specific noun for a wrap-around garment. If that is true in your language, you may use either of these here.

linen cloth: The Greek word that the translates as linen cloth is literally "linen." Linen is a certain type of expensive, good quality cloth. If linen is unknown in your language, you may use a descriptive term. For example:

fine/good/expensive cloth

In translating this phrase, be careful not to imply that the young man was wearing a full set of clothes. It is clear from the context that he was not fully dressed.

14:51b

They caught hold of him,

- When they grabbed him by the cloth/sheet,
- The crowd/people attempted to arrest him,

They caught hold of him: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as They caught hold of him indicates that some people in the crowd grabbed the young man. They were trying to arrest him too, but he escaped.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

and the people also grabbed him (NCV)

They tried to arrest him (GNT)

It is implied that the people grabbed the young man by the cloth that he had wrapped around his body. That explains why he ran away naked. In some languages it may be necessary to make this information explicit. For example:

When they grabbed onto his garment

General Comment on 14:51a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to move 14:51b to the beginning of the verse. For example:

^{51b}They seized a young man ^{51a}who was following Jesus wearing only a linen cloth/garment.

Mark 14:52

Section 14:43–52: Judas betrayed Jesus, and then Jesus' enemies arrested him

The events in this section, like those in the preceding section, happened at night in the olive grove called Gethsemane.

At the end of 14:42, Jesus told his disciples that the one who would betray him was coming. At the beginning of this section in 14:43, Judas, the betrayer, arrived. He came with a crowd of armed men that the Jewish religious leaders had sent. Judas betrayed Jesus by kissing him. Then the crowd of men arrested Jesus and the disciples fled. As one of them was running away, some people grabbed the linen cloth he

had wrapped around himself. He left the cloth in their hands and ran away naked.

In this section Mark referred back to things that happened before the crowd came to arrest Jesus. Before Judas came with the crowd, he went to the chief priests, teachers of the law, and elders. He told them that he would betray Jesus to them. They agreed to send armed men with him to arrest Jesus. These men probably would not recognize which man was Jesus. Judas told them that he would kiss Jesus to show them the man whom they should arrest. Tell about these events in a way that will help people understand why that group of men arrived with Judas.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The betrayal and arrest of Jesus

Jesus is captured

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:47–56, Luke 22:47–53, and John 18:3.

14:52

but he pulled free of the linen cloth and ran away naked.

- he escaped naked, leaving his cloth/sheet behind.
- but he left his cloth/garment in the hands of his captors and ran away naked.

but: The Greek word that the BSB translates as but is a conjunction that connects the crowd's action in 14:51 with the unexpected information in 14:52 that he got away from them. Connect these verses in a way that is natural in your language.

he pulled free of the linen cloth: There is implied information here. The young man wrenched himself free of their grasp and ran away naked. They were left holding his cloth or garment in their hands. The young man did not set down the cloth and leave it behind. In some languages it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

he wrenched himself out of it and ran away naked

he left his cloth in their hands and ran away naked

ran away: The clause ran away indicates that the young man ran away from them. The young man was

able to escape from them, even though they were holding him.

naked: The word naked indicates that the young man did not have any clothes on.

Mark 14:53

Section 14:53–65: The Jewish leaders decided that Jesus should die

After the crowd arrested Jesus, they took him to the high priest's house. The Jewish leaders had gathered there to have Jesus' trial in an upper level of that house. Peter followed the crowd at a distance and went into the courtyard outside the house. The Jewish leaders tried to find witnesses who would accuse Jesus of doing something against their law.

When the witnesses could not agree with each other, the high priest questioned Jesus. He wanted to learn about anything that Jesus had done wrong. Then he would use that as a good reason to take Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate, for an official trial. When the high priest asked Jesus if he was the Messiah, the Son of the Blessed One, Jesus said that he was. This allowed the Jewish leaders to accuse Jesus of blasphemy. They said that Jesus deserved to die. So they had a good reason to take Jesus to Pilate for trial to get the death sentence. Then they abused and mocked Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus is tried/questioned by the Jewish council

The Jewish leaders condemned Jesus

Jesus' trial before the leaders of the Jews

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:57–68, Luke 22:54, 66–71, and John 18:12–15, 19–24.

Paragraph 14:53–54

Most of the people whom Mark mentioned in this Section 14:53–72 were already mentioned earlier, but they are introduced again in this paragraph. In verse 53 Mark listed the high priest as well as the chief priests, elders, and teachers of the law. They were the ones who sent the crowd to arrest Jesus (14:43c–d). These Jewish leaders were the members of the Jewish council, which was called the Sanhedrin (see 14:55a).

In verse 54 Mark described what Peter was doing. This prepares his readers for the account of how Peter denied Jesus (14:66–72).

14:53a

They led Jesus away to the high priest,

- ¶ They took Jesus to the high priest,
- ¶ The crowd who had arrested Jesus brought him to the high priest's house.

They: The word They refers to the people in the crowd who arrested Jesus in 14:46. Refer back to them in a natural way in your language. The NCV says:

The people who arrested Jesus (NCV)

led away: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as led away can mean either “took” or “led.” In this context they brought Jesus to the house of the high priest.

to the high priest: The phrase to the high priest indicates that the crowd took Jesus to the place where the high priest was. The high priest was the leader of the Jewish council, so he would guide Jesus' trial. The next verse indicates that the trial happened in the high priest's house, which was a large house with a courtyard. In some languages it may be more natural to mention the high priest's house here in 14:53, as several English versions do. For example, the REB says:

Then they led Jesus away to the high priest's house.

high priest: The Greek word that the BSB translates as high priest literally means the “most important priest.” The high priest was the leader of all the other Jewish priests, including the chief priests. See how you translated high priest in 2:26a.

14:53b

and all the chief priests, elders, and scribes assembled.

- and all the chief priests, elders, and teachers of the law gathered together with the high priest at his house.
- All the chief priests, leaders, and experts in the law met together with the high priest.

all the chief priests, elders, and scribes: These three groups together represented the Jewish leaders.

the chief priests: A Jewish priest was a man who offered sacrifices to God on behalf of the people. He also performed other rituals for them. The phrase chief priests refers to the leaders among these priests.

Here are some other ways to translate chief priests:

the leading/ruling priests

the elders among the Jewish sacrificers

the most prominent priests

See how you translated chief priests in 14:43d.

elders: The elders were the civil leaders or rulers. See how you translated elders in 8:31c and 11:27c.

scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes is sometimes translated as “teachers of the law” (as in the NIV). In the time of Jesus, their main work was to study, interpret, and teach the law of Moses, as well as other Jewish laws and traditions. This same title was in 14:1b and 14:43d. See also teacher of the law in the Glossary.

assembled: The Greek word that the BSB translates as assembled can also mean “gathered themselves together” or “met together.” The text implies that these men had already come together with the high priest at his house.

Mark 14:54

Section 14:53–65: The Jewish leaders decided that Jesus should die

After the crowd arrested Jesus, they took him to the high priest’s house. The Jewish leaders had gathered there to have Jesus’ trial in an upper level of that house. Peter followed the crowd at a distance and went into the courtyard outside the house. The Jewish leaders tried to find witnesses who would accuse Jesus of doing something against their law.

When the witnesses could not agree with each other, the high priest questioned Jesus. He wanted to learn about anything that Jesus had done wrong. Then he would use that as a good reason to take Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate, for an official trial. When the high priest asked Jesus if he was the Messiah, the Son of the Blessed One, Jesus said that he was. This allowed the Jewish leaders to accuse Jesus of blasphemy. They said that Jesus deserved to die. So they had a good reason to take Jesus to Pilate for trial to get the death sentence. Then they abused and mocked Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus is tried/questioned by the Jewish council

The Jewish leaders condemned Jesus

Jesus’ trial before the leaders of the Jews

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:57–68, Luke 22:54, 66–71, and John 18:12–15, 19–24.

Paragraph 14:53–54

Most of the people whom Mark mentioned in this Section 14:53–72 were already mentioned earlier, but they are introduced again in this paragraph. In verse 53 Mark listed the high priest as well as the chief priests, elders, and teachers of the law. They were the ones who sent the crowd to arrest Jesus (14:43c–d). These Jewish leaders were the members of the Jewish council, which was called the Sanhedrin (see 14:55a).

In verse 54 Mark described what Peter was doing. This prepares his readers for the account of how Peter denied Jesus (14:66–72).

14:54a

Peter followed Him at a distance,

- Peter followed Jesus at a safe/sufficient distance,
- Peter followed behind Jesus and his captors, but not very near.

Peter followed Him at a distance: The clause Peter followed Him at a distance tells what Peter had done while the crowd was leading Jesus to the high priest. This action happened at the same time as all of the Jewish leaders came together in 14:53.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Meanwhile, Peter followed him at a distance (NLT)

And Peter had followed him from a distance (NET)

Express the sequence of events in a natural way in your language.

followed Him at a distance: The words at a distance indicate that Peter was walking behind the crowd of people who were taking Jesus away. He did not get close to them. He did not want them to see him. In some languages the phrase followed...at a distance may need to be expressed in other ways. For example:

followed but not very close

followed from slightly far away

See if the way you translated this same Greek phrase in 5:6 and 11:13 can be used here also.

Him: The pronoun Him refers to Jesus.

14:54b

right into the courtyard of the high priest.

- and he continued to follow them right into the courtyard of the high priest.
- He followed them all the way into the courtyard of the high priest's house.

right into: The words right into indicate that Peter entered the courtyard area. He was in the courtyard outside while Jesus was inside the house.

the courtyard of the high priest: A courtyard is an open area that is surrounded by buildings or high walls on one family's land. In that setting, the courtyard of the high priest was the yard that was inside the area that belonged to the high priest's house. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example, the NCV says:

courtyard of the high priest's house (NCV)

If you already mentioned the high priest's house in 14:53, you may be able to make some of the information implicit here. For example:

courtyard of that house

14:54c

And he sat with the officers

- There in the courtyard he sat with the temple guards/attendants
- He sat down in the courtyard among the temple guards who worked for the high priest

14:54d

and warmed himself by the fire.

- near the fire and warmed himself.
- to keep warm by the fire.

14:54c–d

And he sat with the officers and warmed himself by the fire: Jesus was arrested in April when the nights were cold. Someone had lit a fire in the high priest's courtyard so that people could warm themselves. After Peter entered the courtyard, he stopped and sat down

with the guards, who were sitting near the fire to get warm.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

He joined the guards who were sitting there around a fire to keep warm.

There in the courtyard the temple guards were sitting at a fire. Peter sat down with them and warmed himself.

officers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as officers is a general word that means "servants" or "attendants." Many Bible scholars believe that these men were Jewish temple guards who obeyed the orders of the high priest. They were not Roman soldiers.

Mark 14:55

Section 14:53–65: The Jewish leaders decided that Jesus should die

After the crowd arrested Jesus, they took him to the high priest's house. The Jewish leaders had gathered there to have Jesus' trial in an upper level of that house. Peter followed the crowd at a distance and went into the courtyard outside the house. The Jewish leaders tried to find witnesses who would accuse Jesus of doing something against their law.

When the witnesses could not agree with each other, the high priest questioned Jesus. He wanted to learn about anything that Jesus had done wrong. Then he would use that as a good reason to take Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate, for an official trial. When the high priest asked Jesus if he was the Messiah, the Son of the Blessed One, Jesus said that he was. This allowed the Jewish leaders to accuse Jesus of blasphemy. They said that Jesus deserved to die. So they had a good reason to take Jesus to Pilate for trial to get the death sentence. Then they abused and mocked Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus is tried/questioned by the Jewish council

The Jewish leaders condemned Jesus

Jesus' trial before the leaders of the Jews

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:57–68, Luke 22:54, 66–71, and John 18:12–15, 19–24.

Paragraph 14:55–59

The chief priests and other leaders wanted to find witnesses who would testify that Jesus had disobeyed the law in a serious way. This testimony would give the leaders a reason to say that Jesus should be killed as a criminal. Jewish law required that at least two witnesses must accuse a person of doing the same offense. Only then could he be put to death. But the Jewish leaders were not able to find two witnesses who accused Jesus of exactly the same offense.

14:55a

Now the chief priests and the whole Sanhedrin

- ¶ As for the chief priests and the whole council,
- ¶ Inside the house, the chief priests and the other members of the Jewish council

The previous verse takes place in the courtyard. It focuses on what Peter was doing. Here in 14:55 the focus changes back to the Jewish leaders inside the high priest's house (14:53). Indicate this change of focus in a way that is natural in your language. In some languages it may be helpful to specifically indicate the change. For example:

As for the chief priests and the whole Sanhedrin, they were looking...

Meanwhile, inside the high priest's house, the chief priests and the whole Sanhedrin were looking...

Now the chief priests and the whole Sanhedrin:

The whole Sanhedrin included the chief priests, the elders, and the scribes. These three groups were all mentioned in 14:53b (see the note there). Here the chief priests were probably mentioned separately because they led the trial.

chief priests: This is the same term as in 14:53b. Translate it here as you did there.

the whole Sanhedrin: In this context the whole Sanhedrin refers to all the members of the council who were present at Jesus' trial. The chief priests have already been mentioned specifically. Because of this, it may be more natural in some languages to say "and all the other members of the Sanhedrin."

Sanhedrin: The word Sanhedrin is a Greek word that the BSB has borrowed. It means "council" and refers to

the Jewish court with the highest authority over their people.

Here are some other ways to translate Sanhedrin:

council (RSV, GNT)

Jewish council (NCV)

highest group of Jewish leaders

14:55b

were seeking testimony against Jesus

- they were trying to find evidence that Jesus had disobeyed the law
- tried to find people who were willing to testify that Jesus had committed a crime

were seeking testimony against Jesus: The clause were seeking testimony against Jesus shows that the Council thought Jesus was guilty of doing things that they thought he should die for. They had already decided that they wanted the death penalty for Jesus. According to the normal practice of the Council, this hearing was unfair. Normally the Council would first listen to the witnesses before they made a decision. The phrase were seeking testimony against Jesus indicates that the council members were trying to find people who would say that Jesus had disobeyed the law.

testimony against Jesus: The phrase testimony against Jesus refers to the testimony that witnesses would give about Jesus. The council members wanted witnesses to say that Jesus had broken the law in a serious way.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

tried to find some evidence against Jesus (GNT)

were trying to find witnesses who would testify against Jesus (NLT96)

searched for people who would say how Jesus had disobeyed the law

testimony: The word that the BSB translates as testimony is a legal term. It refers to a statement that a witness gives about a crime.

14:55c

to put Him to death,

- so that they could ask for him to be put to death.
- so that they could have him executed.

to put Him to death: This clause indicates the purpose for the testimony mentioned in 14:55b. The testimony of the witnesses would give the leaders a reason to say that Jesus should be killed as a criminal.

Because the Jews were ruled by the Romans, the Jewish council did not have the authority to put someone to death. They would need to convince the Roman authorities to agree with their decision to condemn Jesus to be killed. In some languages you may need to imply this in some way. For example:

so that they could cause him to be put to death

evidence...that would warrant a death sentence
(REB)

General Comment on 14:55a–c

In some languages it may be clearer to reorder 14:55a–c. For example:

^{55a}The chief priests and the whole Jewish council
^{55c}wanted the Roman authorities to put Jesus to death. ^{55b}So they tried to find evidence that he had violated the law.

14:55d but they did not find any.

- But they could not find any adequate evidence against Jesus.
- But the testimony they heard was not valid/reliable.

but they did not find any: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as but they did not find any indicates that the leaders did not hear any evidence that Jesus had done anything wrong. None of the testimony that the leaders heard proved that Jesus had broken the law. In some languages it may be necessary to make this meaning more explicit. For example:

but they did not find any true/convincing evidence against Jesus

but they did not get/hear any adequate testimony against him

Mark 14:56

Section 14:53–65: The Jewish leaders decided that Jesus should die

After the crowd arrested Jesus, they took him to the high priest's house. The Jewish leaders had gathered there to have Jesus' trial in an upper level of that house. Peter followed the crowd at a distance and went into the courtyard outside the house. The Jewish leaders tried to find witnesses who would accuse Jesus of doing something against their law.

When the witnesses could not agree with each other, the high priest questioned Jesus. He wanted to learn about anything that Jesus had done wrong. Then he would use that as a good reason to take Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate, for an official trial. When the high priest asked Jesus if he was the Messiah, the Son of the Blessed One, Jesus said that he was. This allowed the Jewish leaders to accuse Jesus of blasphemy. They said that Jesus deserved to die. So they had a good reason to take Jesus to Pilate for trial to get the death sentence. Then they abused and mocked Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus is tried/questioned by the Jewish council

The Jewish leaders condemned Jesus

Jesus' trial before the leaders of the Jews

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:57–68, Luke 22:54, 66–71, and John 18:12–15, 19–24.

Paragraph 14:55–59

The chief priests and other leaders wanted to find witnesses who would testify that Jesus had disobeyed the law in a serious way. This testimony would give the leaders a reason to say that Jesus should be killed as a criminal. Jewish law required that at least two witnesses must accuse a person of doing the same offense. Only then could he be put to death. But the Jewish leaders were not able to find two witnesses who accused Jesus of exactly the same offense.

14:56a–b

For many bore false witness against Jesus, but their testimony was inconsistent: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For is a conjunction that often intro-

duces an explanation. Here this sentence explains why the evidence against Jesus was not adequate or convincing. Introduce this reason in a way that is natural in your language.

14:56a

For many bore false witness against Jesus,

- Many witnesses gave false evidence against Jesus,
- Many people came into the Council and said things that were not true about him,

For many bore false witness against Jesus: The clause For many bore false witness against Jesus indicates that many witnesses accused Jesus of disobeying the law, but the things that they said were not true.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Many people came and told false things about him (NCV)

Many witnesses told lies against Jesus (GNT)

Many gave false evidence against him (REB)

14:56b

but their testimony was inconsistent.

- but what they said did not agree with what other witnesses said.
- but what one witness said contradicted what another witness said.

but their testimony was inconsistent: This part of the verse indicates that the witnesses said different things about Jesus that contradicted each other. Jewish law required that at least two witnesses must agree in what they say when they accuse a person. They must give the same evidence against him. Otherwise, the accusation was not considered to be true. The reason the leaders could not find evidence against Jesus was that no two witnesses agreed with each other.

was inconsistent: The phrase was inconsistent means that what one person said contradicted what another person said. Their testimony was not the same.

Here is another way to translate this:

but each one said different things and none of them agreed with any other witness.

Translate was inconsistent in a way that sounds natural in your language.

Mark 14:57

Section 14:53–65: The Jewish leaders decided that Jesus should die

After the crowd arrested Jesus, they took him to the high priest's house. The Jewish leaders had gathered there to have Jesus' trial in an upper level of that house. Peter followed the crowd at a distance and went into the courtyard outside the house. The Jewish leaders tried to find witnesses who would accuse Jesus of doing something against their law.

When the witnesses could not agree with each other, the high priest questioned Jesus. He wanted to learn about anything that Jesus had done wrong. Then he would use that as a good reason to take Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate, for an official trial. When the high priest asked Jesus if he was the Messiah, the Son of the Blessed One, Jesus said that he was. This allowed the Jewish leaders to accuse Jesus of blasphemy. They said that Jesus deserved to die. So they had a good reason to take Jesus to Pilate for trial to get the death sentence. Then they abused and mocked Jesus.

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The chief priests and other leaders wanted to find witnesses who would testify that Jesus had disobeyed the law in a serious way. This testimony would give the leaders a reason to say that Jesus should be killed as a criminal. Jewish law required that at least two witnesses must accuse a person of doing the same offense. Only then could he be put to death. But the Jewish leaders were not able to find two witnesses who accused Jesus of exactly the same offense.

14:57a

Then some men stood up

- Finally some witnesses got up,

- Then some other witnesses came to the Council

Then some men stood up: Many witnesses had already given false testimony (14:56). The word Then in the BSB introduces the last false testimony that people were going to give in 14:57–58. This meaning may be expressed as:

Finally, some men stood up

some men: The words some men refers to some other people who came as witnesses to testify against Jesus.

stood up: In this context the phrase stood up implies “stood to give testimony” or “came forward as witnesses.” In some cultures, a witness sits while giving testimony. If that is true in your culture, translate in a more general way. For example:

Then some witnesses presented themselves before the council.

14:57b

and testified falsely against Him:

- and they told the following lies about Jesus:
- and what they testified was also not true. They said:

and testified falsely against Him: The phrase testified falsely against Him refers to the testimony that is quoted next in 14:58. In Greek, 14:57 ends with a word that means “saying.” Some English versions include this word. For example:

Then some people stood up and lied about Jesus, saying... (NCV)

Then some men stood up and gave false testimony against him. They said... (GW)

Introduce the false testimony in a natural way in your language. You may need a speech word or you may not need it.

testified falsely: The Greek word that the BSB translates as testified falsely means “said something untrue as evidence in court.”

Mark 14:58

Section 14:53–65: The Jewish leaders decided that Jesus should die

After the crowd arrested Jesus, they took him to the high priest’s house. The Jewish leaders had gathered

there to have Jesus’ trial in an upper level of that house. Peter followed the crowd at a distance and went into the courtyard outside the house. The Jewish leaders tried to find witnesses who would accuse Jesus of doing something against their law.

When the witnesses could not agree with each other, the high priest questioned Jesus. He wanted to learn about anything that Jesus had done wrong. Then he would use that as a good reason to take Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate, for an official trial. When the high priest asked Jesus if he was the Messiah, the Son of the Blessed One, Jesus said that he was. This allowed the Jewish leaders to accuse Jesus of blasphemy. They said that Jesus deserved to die. So they had a good reason to take Jesus to Pilate for trial to get the death sentence. Then they abused and mocked Jesus.

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Paragraph 14:55–59

The chief priests and other leaders wanted to find witnesses who would testify that Jesus had disobeyed the law in a serious way. This testimony would give the leaders a reason to say that Jesus should be killed as a criminal. Jewish law required that at least two witnesses must accuse a person of doing the same offense. Only then could he be put to death. But the Jewish leaders were not able to find two witnesses who accused Jesus of exactly the same offense.

14:58

This verse gives the words of the men’s testimony. In their testimony they claimed that they had heard Jesus say certain things about the temple. Mark used a direct quote to report those things. In some languages it may be more natural to use an indirect quote. See the General Comment on 14:58a–d at the end of 14:58d for an example.

14:58a**“We heard Him say,**

- “We^(excl) heard this person/man say,
- “We^(excl) heard Jesus say that

We heard Him say: The phrase We heard Him say introduces what the witnesses claimed that Jesus had said. The false witnesses were probably referring to what Jesus had said in John 2:19: “Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up again.” But the author, John, explained in 2:21 that Jesus had been referring to his body as a temple. He had not been referring to the temple in Jerusalem. Also, Jesus did not say, “I will destroy....” He actually said, “Destroy^(2pl) this temple, and in three days I will raise it up again.” The witnesses misinterpreted what Jesus meant and they did not quote Jesus correctly.

14:58b**‘I will destroy this man-made temple,**

- ‘I will tear down this temple made by human beings
- he would tear down this temple that people built,

I will destroy this man-made temple: The pronoun I here refers to Jesus. When the men claimed that Jesus referred to this man-made temple, the Jewish council would interpret this phrase as referring to the temple of God in Jerusalem.

destroy: The word destroy here means “to completely tear down.” The temple was constructed of huge stones. In order to destroy it, many persons must work hard to tear down all of the stones.

To destroy a temple was considered an extremely serious crime. The Roman government punished this crime with the penalty of death.

man-made: The word man-made means that the temple was “made or built by human beings” rather than by God. It does not mean “made by male human beings.” Another way to translate this is:

I will destroy this temple that human beings built...

temple: The Greek word that the BSB translates as temple here refers to the main temple building. The main building was the holiest part of the temple. It was the part where God was present in a special way. This is the first time that this Greek word occurs in Mark. The Greek word for temple used in 14:49a included the entire courtyard area, as well as the temple building.

Here are some ways to translate temple in this context:

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

house/building of God

house/place where God dwells

house/place where God is

holy/sacred house

- If your language has a word for “temple,” consider using it. But you may need to modify it. For example:

temple of the Lord

See temple, Meaning 2, in the Glossary. Be sure to use a different term from the one you have chosen for “synagogue.” There was only one temple, but there were many synagogues throughout the land of Israel where the Jews met regularly for worship.

14:58c**and in three days I will build another**

- and in three days I will build another temple.
- and that within three days he would build another temple

and in three days I will build another: This clause is an ellipsis. It has some implied words, as shown here:

in three days I will build another temple

Express the meaning of the clause in a clear and natural way in your language.

in three days: The phrase in three days means “within a three-day period.”

14:58d**that is made without hands.”**

- This one will be one that human beings did not build.”
- that people did not make.”

that is made without hands: The phrase made without hands refers to a temple that human beings did not build. This phrase is passive. For example:

that human beings did not build

General Comment on 14:58a–d

In some languages it may be more natural to use an indirect quote for the words that the witnesses claimed that Jesus had said. For example:

They said about Jesus, “This man said that he is able to destroy this temple built by people and rebuild it again in three days!”

Use the manner of speaking that people in your culture use when they speak in court about what another person said.

Mark 14:59

Section 14:53–65: The Jewish leaders decided that Jesus should die

After the crowd arrested Jesus, they took him to the high priest’s house. The Jewish leaders had gathered there to have Jesus’ trial in an upper level of that house. Peter followed the crowd at a distance and went into the courtyard outside the house. The Jewish leaders tried to find witnesses who would accuse Jesus of doing something against their law.

When the witnesses could not agree with each other, the high priest questioned Jesus. He wanted to learn about anything that Jesus had done wrong. Then he would use that as a good reason to take Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate, for an official trial. When the high priest asked Jesus if he was the Messiah, the Son of the Blessed One, Jesus said that he was. This allowed the Jewish leaders to accuse Jesus of blasphemy. They said that Jesus deserved to die. So they had a good reason to take Jesus to Pilate for trial to get the death sentence. Then they abused and mocked Jesus.

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The Jewish leaders condemned Jesus

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There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:57–68, Luke 22:54, 66–71, and John 18:12–15, 19–24.

Paragraph 14:55–59

The chief priests and other leaders wanted to find witnesses who would testify that Jesus had disobeyed the law in a serious way. This testimony would give the leaders a reason to say that Jesus should be killed as a criminal. Jewish law required that at least two witnesses must accuse a person of doing the same offense. Only then could he be put to death. But the Jewish leaders were not able to find two witnesses who accused Jesus of exactly the same offense.

14:59

But even their testimony was inconsistent.

- But even though they testified that, what they said was contradictory.
- but even their reports of what Jesus had said did not agree.

But even their testimony was inconsistent: Even this serious accusation about destroying the temple failed to be adequate evidence against Jesus. It failed because not even two of the witnesses agreed with each other.

But even: The phrase that the BSB translates as But even means “even about this one point.” Even though the witnesses were now giving testimony only about the destruction of the temple, they still did not agree with each other.

In Greek the phrase But even has a position of emphasis in the sentence. It implies that this last group of witnesses had the best chance of condemning Jesus with their evidence, but even this evidence was inadequate.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

But even on this point (REB)

But even the things these people said (NCV)

Yet even then (NIV)

their testimony: The words their testimony refers to what they claimed Jesus had said about the temple in 14:58.

was inconsistent: See how you translated was inconsistent in 14:56b.

Mark 14:60

Section 14:53–65: The Jewish leaders decided that Jesus should die

After the crowd arrested Jesus, they took him to the high priest's house. The Jewish leaders had gathered there to have Jesus' trial in an upper level of that house. Peter followed the crowd at a distance and went into the courtyard outside the house. The Jewish leaders tried to find witnesses who would accuse Jesus of doing something against their law.

When the witnesses could not agree with each other, the high priest questioned Jesus. He wanted to learn about anything that Jesus had done wrong. Then he would use that as a good reason to take Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate, for an official trial. When the high priest asked Jesus if he was the Messiah, the Son of the Blessed One, Jesus said that he was. This allowed the Jewish leaders to accuse Jesus of blasphemy. They said that Jesus deserved to die. So they had a good reason to take Jesus to Pilate for trial to get the death sentence. Then they abused and mocked Jesus.

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There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:57–68, Luke 22:54, 66–71, and John 18:12–15, 19–24.

Paragraph 14:60–62

In the previous paragraph, many witnesses had accused Jesus of disobeying the law (14:56–59). But the Jewish leaders could not condemn him because no two of the witnesses said the same thing. Now the high priest started to question Jesus.

14:60a

So the high priest stood up before them and questioned Jesus,

- ¶ Then the high priest stood up in front of the council and asked Jesus,
- ¶ Then the high priest stood where everyone could see him and questioned Jesus,

So: In Greek this verse begins with the common conjunction that is often translated as “and.” Here it introduces what happened next in the story. The high priest himself now began to question Jesus. Introduce this event in a natural way in your language.

the high priest stood up before them: The Sanhedrin normally sat in a raised area in a semi-circle. The high priest sat at the highest spot between the two halves of the semi-circle. This material is taken from a suggested footnote in TRT. The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as before them is literally “into the middle.” This probably means that the high priest stepped down into the area between the two halves of the semi-circle. That is where Jesus was standing. The chief priest did this so that everyone would be able to see and hear him clearly.

This meaning may be expressed in various ways. Here are some other ways to translate stood up before them:

stood up in the center (GW)

stood up in front of them all (GNT)

stood up where everyone could see him

and questioned Jesus: The Greek words that the BSB translates as and questioned Jesus are literally “and questioned him saying.” Use a natural way in your language to introduce the high priest's words that follow in 14:60b–c.

14:60b–c

The BSB, along with the majority of English versions, translates 14:60b–c as two questions. A few English versions write 14:60b–c as a single question. See the General Comment on 14:60a–c for further discussion.

14:60b

“Have You no answer?”

- “Are you not going to reply to what they accused you of and defend yourself?”
- “Are you going to respond or not to what they have said?”

Have You no answer?: The Greek question that the BSB translates as Have You no answer? implies a rebuke. The high priest implied that Jesus should have responded to what the people had accused him of doing. The high priest also expected Jesus to answer this question by defending himself. Be sure that both of these implications are clear in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Are you not going to answer to defend yourself?

Do you have a reply to what these men are/were saying against you?

In some languages it may be more natural to indicate the implied information as a rebuke or a command. For example:

Let us hear whether you have an answer to all this evidence.

14:60c

What are these men testifying against You?"

- What do you say about what these men have said against you?"
- Explain to us what these witnesses are/were saying against you. Is what they are/were saying true?"

What are these men testifying against You?: This question implies, "What do you have to say about what these men are saying against you?" The men had finished giving their testimony when the high priest asked this question. In English it is natural for the high priest to refer to their testimony with a present tense verb. In some languages it may be more natural to use different verb forms. For example:

What do you have to say about what these men were saying against you? Is what they said true?

What do you say about the evidence that these men have given against you?

Use natural verb forms in your language for this context.

testifying: The word testifying refers to the action of giving evidence. See how you translated the word "testified" in 14:57b.

against You: The phrase against You could also be translated as "saying against you."

General Comment on 14:60a–c

In some languages it may be more natural to translate the questions in this verse with a different number of questions. You could also use a combination of questions, statements, or commands. For example:

Then the high priest stood in the midst of the council to question Jesus. He said, "Why do you not respond to the things that people are/were

saying against you? Are these things true? Do you have any answers? Let us hear it."

Mark 14:61

Section 14:53–65: The Jewish leaders decided that Jesus should die

After the crowd arrested Jesus, they took him to the high priest's house. The Jewish leaders had gathered there to have Jesus' trial in an upper level of that house. Peter followed the crowd at a distance and went into the courtyard outside the house. The Jewish leaders tried to find witnesses who would accuse Jesus of doing something against their law.

When the witnesses could not agree with each other, the high priest questioned Jesus. He wanted to learn about anything that Jesus had done wrong. Then he would use that as a good reason to take Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate, for an official trial. When the high priest asked Jesus if he was the Messiah, the Son of the Blessed One, Jesus said that he was. This allowed the Jewish leaders to accuse Jesus of blasphemy. They said that Jesus deserved to die. So they had a good reason to take Jesus to Pilate for trial to get the death sentence. Then they abused and mocked Jesus.

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Paragraph 14:60–62

In the previous paragraph, many witnesses had accused Jesus of disobeying the law (14:56–59). But the Jewish leaders could not condemn him because no two of the witnesses said the same thing. Now the high priest started to question Jesus.

14:61a

But Jesus remained silent and made no reply.

- But Jesus was silent and did not respond to the high priest.

- But Jesus said nothing at all to defend himself.

But Jesus remained silent and made no reply: In this context the Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *But* introduces a contrast. Jesus behaved in a way that the high priest did not expect. He expected Jesus to defend himself. But Jesus said nothing, even though he was innocent. Jesus knew that what the men said against him was not valid evidence. Therefore he did not need to defend himself against them.

In some cultures people may think that Jesus did not defend himself because he was guilty or afraid. If this is true in your culture, you may want to indicate explicitly that Jesus was innocent. For example:

But even though he was not guilty, Jesus did not say anything.

remained silent and made no reply: The phrases *remained silent* and *made no reply* have almost the same meaning. In some languages it may be more natural to use one expression rather than two. For example:

But Jesus said nothing at all to the high priest.

But Jesus gave no answer to defend himself.

14:61b

Again the high priest questioned Him,

- Then the high priest asked him another question,
- So the high priest questioned him further. He asked him,

Again the high priest questioned Him: The phrase *Again the high priest questioned Him* here indicates that the high priest asked Jesus another question. The words do not imply that the high priest asked Jesus the same question again. The CEV says:

The high priest asked him another question (CEV)

14:61c

“Are You the Christ, the Son of the Blessed One?”

- “Are you the Messiah/Christ, the Son of the honored God?”
- “Are you the Messiah, the Son of the God whom we^(incl) worship/praise?”

Are You the Christ, the Son of the Blessed One?: Here the high priest asked Jesus to tell him and the

rest of the council whether he was the Messiah, the Son of God.

Christ: The Jews used the title *Christ* to refer to the special person whom God had appointed and promised to send as king and savior. The title *Christ* is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word “Messiah,” and the two words have the same meaning.

Here are some other ways to translate *Christ*:

- Transliterate it according to the sounds of your language. For example:

Krais

Karisiti

- Transliterate it and indicate in some way that it is a title. For example:

the Christ

the Kirisita

- Transliterate *Christ* and include a phrase that explains the meaning. For example:

Christ, the appointed one

Cristo, the savior God promised

the Christ who comes from God

If you do not indicate the meaning of *Christ* in the text, you may want to include the information in a footnote. For example:

The word/title “Christ” refers to the King and Savior whom God had promised to send.

See how you translated *Christ* in 1:1 and 12:35c. See also *Christ* in the Glossary.

Son of the Blessed One: The expression *Son of the Blessed One* was another way to refer to the Messiah. This person was sometimes referred to as a “son of God.”

the Blessed One: The Jews often did not use God’s name when they referred to him. The expression *the Blessed One* is one way to refer to God without using his name.

The word Blessed here means “praised,” “honored,” or “worshiped.” For example you could say:

Are you the Messiah, the son of the One whom we honor/worship?

If it is not clear in your language that Blessed One refers to God, you may need to refer to him explicitly. For example:

Are you the Messiah, the son of God whom we praise?

If you follow a model like this, be sure that the phrase “whom we praise” refers to God and not to the Messiah. See bless, Meaning 3, in the Glossary.

Mark 14:62

Section 14:53–65: The Jewish leaders decided that Jesus should die

After the crowd arrested Jesus, they took him to the high priest’s house. The Jewish leaders had gathered there to have Jesus’ trial in an upper level of that house. Peter followed the crowd at a distance and went into the courtyard outside the house. The Jewish leaders tried to find witnesses who would accuse Jesus of doing something against their law.

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Paragraph 14:60–62

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14:62a

“I am,” said Jesus,

- Jesus answered, “I am indeed he,
- Jesus said, “Yes indeed.

“I am,” said Jesus: By saying I am, Jesus answered “yes” to the high priest’s question. In his reply Jesus indicated that he was the Messiah, the Son of the Blessed One. In languages that do not have a verb “to be,” here are some other ways to translate Jesus’ answer:

Jesus said in reply, “Yes indeed.”

Jesus replied, “Yes, that is true.”

said Jesus: In Greek the phrase that the BSB translates as said Jesus occurs at the beginning of this verse. Place it where it is natural in your language. The NCV says:

Jesus answered, “I am....” (NCV)

14:62b

“and you will see the Son of Man sitting at the right hand of Power

- and you^(plur) will see me, the Son of Man, sitting next to the powerful God on his right side.
- You^(plur) will see me, the Son of Man, seated at the right side of God, who is very powerful.

and you will see the Son of Man sitting at the right hand of Power:

Here Jesus predicted that the high priest and council members would see him sitting at God’s right hand side. When Jesus said this, he predicted that what Psalm 110:1 said about the Messiah would be fulfilled. You may want to include a cross-reference to Psalm 110:1 here.

and: The Greek word that the BSB translates as and shows that the clause in this part of the verse continues what Jesus was saying in 14:62a.

you: The pronoun you is plural and refers to the high priest and council members.

the Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is literally “the Son of the human/person.” It is a title that Jesus often used to refer to himself. It implies that:

1. he was a true human being, and he represented all people.
2. he came from God and had authority from God.

Here are some other ways to translate this title:

the Man whom God Sent

the True Man from God/Heaven

the Representative of Mankind

The Older Brother of All People

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate explicitly that Jesus was referring to himself here. For example:

I, the Son of Man

This same term occurs in 14:21a.

sitting at the right hand: The phrase sitting at the right hand refers to the place of special honor next to God. In the culture at that time, the king or person having the greatest authority sat on a throne. The person with the next greatest authority and power after the king would sit at the king’s right hand side.

In many languages you may need to make the meaning of sitting at the right hand more explicit. For example:

sitting in the place of special honor at the right hand side

Power: The Jews often did not use God’s name when they were referring to him. The word Power is another way to refer to God without using his name. The word Power means “God, the One with all power and authority.” (See 14:61c for the note on “Blessed One,” which is a similar way to refer to God without using his name.)

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

the Almighty (GNT)

God, the Powerful One (NCV)

14:62c

and coming with the clouds of heaven.”

- You will also see me come on/with the clouds of heaven.”
- You will also see me come surrounded by clouds from the place where he/God lives.”

coming with the clouds of heaven: The phrase coming with the clouds of heaven refers back to the phrase “you will see the Son of Man” in 14:62b. It indicates another way that the council members will see Jesus. They will see him coming with the clouds of heaven. Jesus referred here to the prophecy in Daniel 7:13–14. The Jewish leaders all knew that this prophecy was about the Messiah, so they knew that Jesus was claiming to be the Messiah.

The phrase coming with the clouds of heaven is similar to words in 13:26, “men will see the Son of Man coming in clouds with great power and glory.” There is another statement about Jesus’ coming in 8:38: “when he comes in his Father’s glory with the holy angels.”

In the Old Testament a cloud often symbolized God’s presence, power, and glory. In this context coming with the clouds of heaven may imply that Jesus will be coming with God’s glory from heaven, the place where God lives. Another way to translate coming with the clouds of heaven here is:

coming with glorious/magnificent clouds from the place where God lives

If a literal translation will not be meaningful in your language, you may need to indicate the symbolism more explicitly. For example:

coming with the power and glory of God

See how you translated the similar phrase in 13:26. See also heaven, Meaning 2, in the Glossary.

To help your readers understand the significance of this phrase, you may want to add a footnote. For example:

When Jesus said this, he was quoting the prophecy about the Messiah in Daniel 7:13–14. In that prophecy, someone like a “Son of Man”

comes with great power to rule as king and to judge those who do evil.

with the clouds: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates here literally as with the clouds has a different Greek word than the similar phrase in 13:26 that can mean either “on” or “in” the clouds. There is little practical difference in meaning, so you may translate both phrases the same way.

Mark 14:63

Section 14:53–65: The Jewish leaders decided that Jesus should die

After the crowd arrested Jesus, they took him to the high priest’s house. The Jewish leaders had gathered there to have Jesus’ trial in an upper level of that house. Peter followed the crowd at a distance and went into the courtyard outside the house. The Jewish leaders tried to find witnesses who would accuse Jesus of doing something against their law.

When the witnesses could not agree with each other, the high priest questioned Jesus. He wanted to learn about anything that Jesus had done wrong. Then he would use that as a good reason to take Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate, for an official trial. When the high priest asked Jesus if he was the Messiah, the Son of the Blessed One, Jesus said that he was. This allowed the Jewish leaders to accuse Jesus of blasphemy. They said that Jesus deserved to die. So they had a good reason to take Jesus to Pilate for trial to get the death sentence. Then they abused and mocked Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus is tried/questioned by the Jewish council

The Jewish leaders condemned Jesus

Jesus’ trial before the leaders of the Jews

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:57–68, Luke 22:54, 66–71, and John 18:12–15, 19–24.

14:63a

At this, the high priest tore his clothes and declared,

- ¶ Then the high priest tore his clothing to show his horror, and he said,
- ¶ When the high priest heard what Jesus said, he tore his clothes in anger and said,

At this, the high priest tore his clothes: The high priest tore his clothes deliberately in order to express anger and horror at what Jesus had said in 14:62. He probably made only one tear in the robe or tunic that he was wearing. He did not rip his clothing in pieces.

It was a Jewish custom for a person to tear his clothes when someone had spoken blasphemy. When the high priest tore his clothes, his action had symbolic meaning. It indicated that the high priest believed that Jesus had spoken blasphemy. In some languages it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

When the high priest heard what Jesus said he tore his own clothes because he was angry/horrified.

See the note on “blasphemy” in 14:64a.

his clothes: The word his refers to the high priest’s own clothes, not to Jesus’ clothes.

and declared: The Greek word that the BSB translates as declared is literally “he says.” Translate this word in a way that is natural in this context to fit with the way you translated the rhetorical question.

14:63b

“Why do we need any more witnesses?”

- “Do we need any other witnesses?”
- “We certainly do not need any more witnesses!”

Why do we need any more witnesses?: The clause Why do we need any more witnesses? is a rhetorical question. It is an emphatic way to express a statement. There are at least three ways to translate this statement:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why do we still need witnesses? (RSV)

Do we need further witnesses? (REB)

- As a statement. For example, the GNT says:

We don’t need any more witnesses!

- As a tag question. For example:

Surely, we do not need any other witnesses, do we?

Use whichever option is most natural in your language in this context.

Mark 14:64

Section 14:53–65: The Jewish leaders decided that Jesus should die

After the crowd arrested Jesus, they took him to the high priest's house. The Jewish leaders had gathered there to have Jesus' trial in an upper level of that house. Peter followed the crowd at a distance and went into the courtyard outside the house. The Jewish leaders tried to find witnesses who would accuse Jesus of doing something against their law.

When the witnesses could not agree with each other, the high priest questioned Jesus. He wanted to learn about anything that Jesus had done wrong. Then he would use that as a good reason to take Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate, for an official trial. When the high priest asked Jesus if he was the Messiah, the Son of the Blessed One, Jesus said that he was. This allowed the Jewish leaders to accuse Jesus of blasphemy. They said that Jesus deserved to die. So they had a good reason to take Jesus to Pilate for trial to get the death sentence. Then they abused and mocked Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus is tried/questioned by the Jewish council

The Jewish leaders condemned Jesus

Jesus' trial before the leaders of the Jews

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:57–68, Luke 22:54, 66–71, and John 18:12–15, 19–24.

14:64a

You have heard the blasphemy.

- You have heard him blaspheme God.
- You have heard him say these things that dishonor God.

You have heard the blasphemy: The high priest's words You have heard the blasphemy indicate that all

the council members had heard what Jesus said. The high priest thought that they all should understand what Jesus said in 14:62 was blasphemy. Here are some ways to translate the high priest's statement:

You've heard him dishonor God! (GW)

You all heard him say these things against God. (NCV)

You: The word You is plural and refers to the council members.

the blasphemy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as blasphemy refers to the sin of dishonoring or speaking evil of God. In 14:62b–c, Jesus indicated that he was the Son of God and that he would sit at the right hand of God. The high priest thought that Jesus was an ordinary man, so such statements blasphemed God. He thought that Jesus was dishonoring God by claiming to be equal to God.

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase the blasphemy:

way he dishonored God

the insult he gave to God by claiming to be equal to God

See how you translated this term in 3:28b.

14:64b

What is your verdict?"

- What is your decision?"
- Do you think he is innocent or do you think he is guilty?"

What is your verdict?: The high priest asked the members of the court to say whether they thought Jesus was innocent or guilty of the charge of blasphemy. He wanted them to tell him what they had decided.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

What is your decision? (GNT)

Which do you think he is, guilty or innocent?

What do you think? (NIV)

14:64c

And they all condemned Him as deserving of death.

- They all declared that he was guilty and said that he deserved death.
- All the council members there agreed that Jesus was guilty and deserved to die.
- They all said, “He is guilty and he ought to die for his blasphemy.”

And they all condemned Him as deserving of death:

The council’s decision was that Jesus was guilty of blaspheming God and that he deserved to die.

And they all: The words they all refer to the other members of the council who were mentioned in 14:53b.

condemned Him: The phrase condemned Him means “officially declared him to be guilty.” The council members decided that what Jesus had done was wrong and that he should be punished.

deserving of death: The phrase deserving of death means “deserving to be killed.” In other words, the council decided that it was right to kill Jesus because he was guilty of blaspheming God.

In some languages it may be more natural to express this decision as a direct quote. For example:

They said, “He is guilty and he deserves the death penalty.”

Mark 14:65

Section 14:53–65: The Jewish leaders decided that Jesus should die

After the crowd arrested Jesus, they took him to the high priest’s house. The Jewish leaders had gathered there to have Jesus’ trial in an upper level of that house. Peter followed the crowd at a distance and went into the courtyard outside the house. The Jewish leaders tried to find witnesses who would accuse Jesus of doing something against their law.

When the witnesses could not agree with each other, the high priest questioned Jesus. He wanted to learn about anything that Jesus had done wrong. Then he would use that as a good reason to take Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate, for an official trial. When the high priest asked Jesus if he was the Messiah, the Son of the Blessed One, Jesus said that he was. This allowed the Jewish leaders to accuse Jesus of blasphemy. They said that Jesus deserved to die. So they had a good reason to take Jesus to Pilate for trial to get the death sentence. Then they abused and mocked Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus is tried/questioned by the Jewish council

The Jewish leaders condemned Jesus

Jesus’ trial before the leaders of the Jews

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:57–68, Luke 22:54, 66–71, and John 18:12–15, 19–24.

14:65a

Then some of them began to spit on Him.

- Then some of them began spitting at Jesus.
- Then some of those who were there started to spit at Jesus to show their contempt for him.

Then some of them began to spit on Him: After the trial was over, some of them started to insult and abuse Jesus.

some of them: The phrase some of them probably refers to members of the council.

spit on Him: In Jewish culture spitting at a person was a way to insult him. When they spit at Jesus, they showed that they felt contempt for him. They thought that he had no value. If the meaning of spit on Him is not clear in your language, you may want to make it explicit. For example:

Some began to spit at him to shame/insult him

14:65b–c

They blindfolded Him, struck Him with their fists, and said to Him, “Prophecy!”: These people mocked Jesus by telling him to prophesy. They meant that they wanted Jesus to tell them who hit him, while his eyes were covered so that he could not see. They implied that because he claimed to be from God, he should show the powers of a prophet. He should tell them who hit him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

They blindfolded him, hit him with their fists, and said, “Tell us who hit you!” (CEV)

and they blindfolded him and hit his face with their fists. “Who hit you that time, you prophet?” they jeered. (NLT96)

They blindfolded him and beat him with their fists and said, “Prove you are a prophet!” (NCV)

14:65b

They blindfolded Him, struck Him with their fists,

- They put a blindfold on him, hit him with their fists,
- They covered his eyes with a cloth, then boxed/punched him

They blindfolded Him: The phrase They blindfolded Him means that these people tied a cloth over Jesus’ eyes so that he could not see.

They: The word They refers to the same people as the word “some” in 14:65a. They were the same people who spit at Jesus.

struck Him with their fists: The Greek word that the BSB translates as struck Him with their fists literally means “beat or hit him with a closed fist.” In some languages this may be expressed with a single verb, as in the Greek. For example:

boxed him

14:65c

and said to Him, “Prophecy!”

- and said to him, “Tell us who hit you!”
- and mocked him saying, “If you are a prophet, then tell us who struck you!”

Prophecy: The verb Prophecy means for a person to speak/say information that God reveals to him or her. In this context it means that the council members were asking Jesus to identify the people who were hitting him. They implied that he should be able to identify them even though his eyes were covered. They were challenging his claim to be the Christ by asking him to use powers from God.

Here is another way to translate this:

...they said to him, “If you are truly from God, then tell us who hit you!”

See prophet in the Glossary.

14:65d

And the officers received Him with slaps in His face.

- The guards also took Jesus and beat/struck him.

- Then the temple guards led Jesus away, and they hit and slapped him.

And the officers received Him: After the members of the council insulted and mocked Jesus, the guards were again responsible for him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Then the guards took charge of Jesus (CEV)

Then the guards led Jesus away (NCV)

officers: See how you translated officers in 14:54c-d.

with slaps in His face: The Greek word that the BSB translates as with slaps in His face can mean to hit someone with an open hand or with a fist. It can also mean to beat someone with a whip or a stick. Try to use a general word in your translation.

Mark 14:66

Section 14:66–72: Peter denied that he was a disciple of Jesus

In the last event of the preceding section, the guards were abusing Jesus after his trial before the council. In this section the focus shifts to Peter in the courtyard. In 14:54 Peter had entered the courtyard of the high priest’s house. Jesus was inside the high priest’s house, declaring that he was the Son of God. At the same time, Peter was in the courtyard denying that he knew Jesus. These stories contrast dramatically with each other.

In this section people asked Peter three times whether he knew Jesus. Each time Peter denied that he knew him, just as Jesus had predicted in 14:30. Then Peter became deeply sorry and wept because he had denied that he knew Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Peter denied Jesus

Peter said that he did not know Jesus

Peter’s denial of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:69–75, Luke 22:55–62, and John 18:15–18, 25–27.

14:66a

While Peter was in the courtyard below,

- ¶ While Peter was still down in the courtyard by the fire,
- ¶ As for Peter, he was outside in the courtyard near the fire.

This part of the verse indicates that the focus in the story shifts to what Peter did while Jesus stood before the council. In some languages there may be a special way to indicate that these events happened at the same time. Here are some ways to do this in English:

Meanwhile, Peter was in the courtyard below.

Now while Peter was below in the courtyard (NET)

in the courtyard below: The word below indicates that the courtyard was at a lower level than the room in the high priest's house where Jesus' trial occurred. This room may have been in an upper story of the house overlooking the courtyard or it may have been up a few steps from the courtyard. If possible, translate below in a way that would allow either meaning. In some languages it may be necessary to leave the location of the courtyard implied. For example:

in the courtyard (NCV, GW, CEV)

14:66b

one of the servant girls of the high priest came down

- one of the high priest's female servants passed by where Peter was.
- A woman/maid who worked for the high priest came/approached there.

one of the servant girls of the high priest came down: One of the high priest's servant girls came to where Peter was. In 14:67 the text indicated that Peter was sitting by the fire. See the General Comment on 14:66b–67a for a possible way to reorder the information in these verse parts.

servant girls: The Greek word that the BSB translates as servant girls refers to female slaves or domestic servants. It does not imply anything regarding the servant's age.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

female servants (GW)

servant women (GNT)

maids who worked for...

Be careful not to use an expression that may imply a sexual relationship.

came down: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as came down is literally “comes.” It may indicate either that the maid was passing by the fire where Peter was or that she came to the fire.

Mark 14:67

Section 14:66–72: Peter denied that he was a disciple of Jesus

In the last event of the preceding section, the guards were abusing Jesus after his trial before the council. In this section the focus shifts to Peter in the courtyard. In 14:54 Peter had entered the courtyard of the high priest's house. Jesus was inside the high priest's house, declaring that he was the Son of God. At the same time, Peter was in the courtyard denying that he knew Jesus. These stories contrast dramatically with each other.

In this section people asked Peter three times whether he knew Jesus. Each time Peter denied that he knew him, just as Jesus had predicted in 14:30. Then Peter became deeply sorry and wept because he had denied that he knew Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Peter denied Jesus

Peter said that he did not know Jesus

Peter's denial of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:69–75, Luke 22:55–62, and John 18:15–18, 25–27.

14:67a

and saw him warming himself there.

- When she saw Peter trying to stay warm by the fire,

- When she saw Peter in the firelight trying to warm himself,

and saw him warming himself there: Peter was warming himself by the fire. See the note on 14:54c–d.

General Comment on 14:66b–67a

In some languages it may be natural to change the order of some of the information in these verse parts. For example:

^{67a}Peter was warming himself by the fire ^{66b} when one of the servant girls of the high priest came to where Peter was. ^{67a} When she saw him...

14:67b

She looked at Peter and said,

- she looked straight at him. Then she said,
- she gazed intently at him. She said to Peter,

She looked at Peter: The words She looked at Peter indicate that the girl looked carefully at Peter. She did this because she thought that she recognized him.

It is important to translate looked at differently from the way you translated “saw” in 14:67a. The word “saw” indicates that she “noticed” him. But looked at indicates that she focused her attention on Peter.

14:67c

“You also were with Jesus the Nazarene.”

- “You, too, were with Jesus, that person/fellow from Nazareth.”
- “You also were with that man/fellow from Nazareth, that Jesus.”

You also were with Jesus the Nazarene: The position in the sentence of the Greek phrase the BSB translates as the Nazarene emphasizes Jesus’ identity as a person from Nazareth and also implies mild contempt. People from the city of Jerusalem despised the people who lived in the province of Galilee where Nazareth is. The servant girl would certainly have been aware of this attitude. This emphasis may be expressed in different ways. For example:

Jesus, that man from Nazareth (NCV)

If it is not possible to express the implied disrespect in the translation itself, you may want to add a footnote that tells about it. For example:

The way the servant girl refers here to Jesus shows a lack of respect for him. People from the city of Jerusalem generally despised people from

Nazareth. See John 1:46. This suggested footnote is adapted from TRT.

also: The Greek word that the BSB translates as also implies that the servant girl had seen another one of Jesus’ disciples, perhaps in the courtyard that same night. According to John 18:15, another disciple went to the high priest’s house with Peter. You might want to include a footnote indicating that also implies that another disciple was also present in the courtyard that night. But it is best not to include this information in the translation itself.

Mark 14:68

Section 14:66–72: Peter denied that he was a disciple of Jesus

In the last event of the preceding section, the guards were abusing Jesus after his trial before the council. In this section the focus shifts to Peter in the courtyard. In 14:54 Peter had entered the courtyard of the high priest’s house. Jesus was inside the high priest’s house, declaring that he was the Son of God. At the same time, Peter was in the courtyard denying that he knew Jesus. These stories contrast dramatically with each other.

In this section people asked Peter three times whether he knew Jesus. Each time Peter denied that he knew him, just as Jesus had predicted in 14:30. Then Peter became deeply sorry and wept because he had denied that he knew Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Peter denied Jesus

Peter said that he did not know Jesus

Peter’s denial of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:69–75, Luke 22:55–62, and John 18:15–18, 25–27.

14:68a

But he denied it.

- But he denied that what she said was true.
- But he replied to the servant girl, “What you are saying is not true!”

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *But* here indicates that Peter's response to the servant girl will not agree with what she said. He denied that what she had said was true. Some English versions do not use a conjunction here. Connect Peter's response to 14:67 in a natural way in your language.

he denied it: The phrase *he denied it* here means that Peter said that what the servant girl had said was not true. Of course, Peter had been with Jesus, but he was afraid to admit it.

In some languages it may be more natural to express the words *denied it* as a direct quote. For example:

He replied to the servant girl, "What you are saying is not true!"

denied it: The Greek words that the BSB translates as *denied it* is literally, "denied, saying." Some languages may also need to include a word like "saying" or "said." For example:

But he denied it and said

But he said

If you do not use a word like *denied* to introduce the quote, then you should clearly communicate the idea of denial in 14:68b.

it: The BSB has supplied the word *it* to make the sentence sound natural in English. This word is not in the Greek text, but English requires that there be a direct object with the verb "deny." Follow the pattern of your own language in this matter.

14:68b

"I do not know or even understand what you are talking about," he said.

- He said to her, "I do not know what you are referring to, and I do not understand why you are saying it!"
- I have no idea whatsoever what you are talking about!"

I do not know or even understand what you are talking about: In this context the verbs *know* and *understand* have almost the same meaning. Peter repeated the same idea in order to emphasize what he was saying. He wanted to make it clear to the servant girl that she was mistaken.

In some languages it may not be natural in this context to use two verbs with almost the same meaning, like *know* and *understand*. If this is true in your lan-

guage, you may be able to translate Peter's reply with a different type of emphatic phrase. For example:

I do not have any idea what you are talking about!

he said: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *he said* occurs at the beginning of 14:68b, along with the phrase "he denied it." Place it where it is natural in your language. One way to do this in English is:

He denied what she said and replied, "I do not know or understand what you are talking about!"

14:68c

Then he went out to the gateway, and the rooster crowed.

- Then Peter left the fire and went toward the gate/entrance near the street, and a rooster crowed.
- And he got up and went to the edge of the courtyard near the gate. Then the sound of a rooster was heard.

Then he went out to the gateway: The phrase *Then he went out to the gateway* indicates that Peter left the fire in the courtyard and went out into the covered passageway that led toward the outer gate. Louw & Nida (page 87) define *proaulion* as "the area in front of an entrance to a building," but this may be misleading if it is understood as the entrance "into" the building rather than the entrance "from" the street into the courtyard of the building. When you translate this, indicate clearly that Peter went toward the place where he could go out into the street, not toward the entry into the house.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

went toward the entrance of the courtyard (NCV)

went out to the gate (CEV)

went to the edge of the yard near the gate

and the rooster crowed: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts include words that are often translated as, "and a rooster crowed." This text is followed by most English versions. (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, KJV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NET, NJB, NLT, NRSV, GNT)
2. Other Greek manuscripts do not include the words "and a rooster crowed." This is followed by a few English versions. (NIV, RSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It has very good manuscript support and most English versions follow this option.

However, if the major language version in your area does not include these words, you may want to use brackets around them or include them only in a footnote. An example of a possible footnote is:

Some manuscripts include “and the rooster crowed.”

If you follow option (1), you could include the following footnote:

Some Greek manuscripts do not have “and the rooster crowed.”

the rooster crowed: The phrase the rooster crowed indicates that a male fowl made the noise that it normally makes sometime before dawn. Use the natural way in your language to describe this noise. For example:

a rooster called/cried

See how you translated the similar phrase in 14:30b.

Mark 14:69

Section 14:66–72: Peter denied that he was a disciple of Jesus

In the last event of the preceding section, the guards were abusing Jesus after his trial before the council. In this section the focus shifts to Peter in the courtyard. In 14:54 Peter had entered the courtyard of the high priest’s house. Jesus was inside the high priest’s house, declaring that he was the Son of God. At the same time, Peter was in the courtyard denying that he knew Jesus. These stories contrast dramatically with each other.

In this section people asked Peter three times whether he knew Jesus. Each time Peter denied that he knew him, just as Jesus had predicted in 14:30. Then Peter became deeply sorry and wept because he had denied that he knew Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Peter denied Jesus

Peter said that he did not know Jesus

Peter’s denial of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:69–75, Luke 22:55–62, and John 18:15–18, 25–27.

14:69a

There the servant girl saw him

- When the servant girl saw Peter there by the entrance/gate,
- Then the servant girl saw Peter again.

There the servant girl saw him: The BSB has supplied the word *There* to make clear that this was the second time that the servant girl saw Peter. The Greek text does not include this word. In this verse, the servant girl saw Peter at the entryway, not by the fire. In some languages it may not be necessary to add a word such as *There*. For example, the GW has:

The servant saw him. (GW)

In other languages it may be clearer to add a word such as “again.” For example, the CEV has:

The servant girl saw Peter again (CEV)

In still other languages it may be helpful to make explicit what *there* refers to. For example:

When the servant girl saw him there by the gateway

Translate in a way that will make the sequence of events clear in your language.

the servant girl: This is the same servant girl mentioned in 14:66b. See how you translated servant girl in 14:66b.

14:69b

and again said to those standing nearby,

- she again said to the people who were there,
- she began telling those who were standing there,
- So she repeated to the bystanders what she had said before,

again said: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *again said* is literally “began again to say” (as in the RSV). In this context, the word “began” may indicate that the servant girl said this more than one time.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

again she said to the people who were standing nearby (NCV)

she again was telling those standing around

again: The word again indicates that the servant girl repeated the idea that Peter was Jesus' disciple. The first time, she spoke directly to Peter. This time, she spoke to the bystanders. Be careful not to imply that this was the second time she had told the bystanders about Peter. One way to avoid this misunderstanding is to translate as the NLT has done:

she began telling the others (NLT)

those standing nearby: The phrase those standing nearby refers to the people who were out near the gate where Peter was.

14:69c

“This man is one of them.”

- “This man is one of his followers.”
- “This man/guy here is a follower of Jesus.”
- that he/Peter was one of Jesus' followers.

This man is one of them: The servant girl was speaking directly to the people who were standing at the entryway. She spoke about Peter as This man. The text implies that Peter heard all that she said, since he responded to her in 14:70a.

one of them: The phrase one of them means “one of the followers of Jesus.”

Mark 14:70

Section 14:66–72: Peter denied that he was a disciple of Jesus

In the last event of the preceding section, the guards were abusing Jesus after his trial before the council. In this section the focus shifts to Peter in the courtyard. In 14:54 Peter had entered the courtyard of the high priest's house. Jesus was inside the high priest's house, declaring that he was the Son of God. At the same time, Peter was in the courtyard denying that he knew Jesus. These stories contrast dramatically with each other.

In this section people asked Peter three times whether he knew Jesus. Each time Peter denied that he knew him, just as Jesus had predicted in 14:30. Then Peter became deeply sorry and wept because he had denied that he knew Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Peter denied Jesus

Peter said that he did not know Jesus

Peter's denial of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:69–75, Luke 22:55–62, and John 18:15–18, 25–27.

14:70a

But he denied it again.

- Once again Peter denied it.
- But Peter denied it again.
- Then Peter again said that it was not true.

But he denied it again: The word again indicates that Peter had denied this before. Peter's first denial was in 14:68b. 14:70a records his second denial.

he denied it again: The phrase he denied it indicates that Peter denied that he was one of Jesus' disciples.

14:70b

After a little while, those standing nearby said once more to Peter,

- After a while, those people who were standing near Peter repeated what the woman/servant had said,
- A short time later, it was the bystanders who again said to Peter,
- Later, the bystanders again told Peter

After a little while, those standing nearby said once more to Peter:

There were people standing near Peter out by the entryway. They probably had heard what the servant girl said about Peter (see 14:69b–c).

After a little while: According to Luke 22:59, the little while was about an hour. You should not specify “an hour” here, but you may want to add a footnote with this information.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

after a short time had passed

a little later

those standing nearby said once more to Peter: The Greek word that the BSB translates as once more, in this context, probably indicates that again people said that Peter was one of Jesus' disciples, as the servant

girl had said in previous verses. The phrase once more does not imply that these particular people had already said that to Peter.

One way to avoid this wrong meaning is to leave “once more” implied, as some English versions have done. It may also be possible to emphasize that this time it was the bystanders, not the servant girl, who made the same accusation. For example, the NJB has:

A little later the bystanders themselves said to Peter

Translate the idea of “once more” in a way that is natural in your language.

14:70c

“Surely you are one of them, for you too are a Galilean.”

- “You are certainly/definitely one of his disciples, because you are from Galilee too.”
- “You too are obviously from the region of Galilee, so you must be one of his followers.”
- that they were sure that he was one of his/Jesus’ followers, because Peter was from Galilee just as Jesus’ other followers were.

Surely you are one of them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Surely literally means “truly” or “really.” These people felt certain that Peter was one of Jesus’ disciples.

for you too are a Galilean: The clause that the BSB translates as for you...are a Galilean gives the reason for the people’s conclusion that Peter was one of the disciples. There is implied reasoning here. The people knew that Jesus and most of his disciples were from Galilee. They could tell that Peter was also from Galilee. Therefore they concluded that Peter must belong to the same group.

You may want to add a footnote here to explain how the people knew that Peter was from Galilee. For example:

These people knew that Jesus and Peter were from Galilee Province, because people from Galilee spoke with an accent that was different from the accent of people from Jerusalem (Matthew 26:73). Jesus and His disciples were all from Galilee, except for Judas Iscariot. (TRT)

you too are a Galilean: The word “too” implies “like Jesus and his other disciples.” Some scholars feel that the use of kai ‘also’ here is an interpretation issue.

(1) kai indicates that Peter is a Galilean also, along with Jesus and the other disciples; (2) kai introduces another reason for their conclusion that Peter is a disciple. The first reason is not stated, but it may be the confidence of the maid; (3) kai ‘indeed’ indicates that Peter is indeed a Galilean. Many English versions (NIV, RSV, REB, NLT, CEV, GW, NJB, JBP, KJV) do not translate kai here. In some languages this implied information may need to be made explicit. Most English versions, including the NIV and RSV, do not include the word “also.” Versions that make it explicit include BSB, NASB, GNT, NCV and NET. For example:

you are from Galilee Province just like the rest of them (TRT)

a Galilean: The phrase a Galilean refers to a person from the region of Galilee. Galilee was a region, district or province north of Judea. Nazareth was a town in that region. See how you translated “Galilee” in 1:9a.

General Comment on 14:70c

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the clauses in this part of the verse. For example:

You are from Galilee just like they are, so you must be one of them.

Mark 14:71

Section 14:66–72: Peter denied that he was a disciple of Jesus

In the last event of the preceding section, the guards were abusing Jesus after his trial before the council. In this section the focus shifts to Peter in the courtyard. In 14:54 Peter had entered the courtyard of the high priest’s house. Jesus was inside the high priest’s house, declaring that he was the Son of God. At the same time, Peter was in the courtyard denying that he knew Jesus. These stories contrast dramatically with each other.

In this section people asked Peter three times whether he knew Jesus. Each time Peter denied that he knew him, just as Jesus had predicted in 14:30. Then Peter became deeply sorry and wept because he had denied that he knew Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Peter denied Jesus

Peter said that he did not know Jesus

Peter's denial of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:69–75, Luke 22:55–62, and John 18:15–18, 25–27.

14:71a

But he began to curse

- He began to invoke God's judgment on himself,
- Peter responded by asking God to punish him if he were lying.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as “But” here, connects Peter's response to the people's statement that he was one of Jesus' followers. The NIV and the NLT do not translate the conjunction. The GNT, CEV and GW translate it as “Then.” This is the same Greek word that was used in 14:68a in a similar context. Connect this verse to 14:70 in a natural way in your language.

he began to curse: The word began is probably used here to indicate that Peter called down curses on himself several times.

began to curse: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as began to curse indicates that Peter was asking God to punish him if he was not telling the truth. He did this to try to convince his listeners that he did not know Jesus.

Here are other some ways to translate 14:71a:

Then Peter began to place a curse on himself (NCV)

But he began to invoke a curse on himself (RSV)

I swear that I am telling the truth! May God punish me if I am not! (GNT)

14:71b

and swear,

- and he swore an oath to them,
- He put himself under God's curse and said,
- He swore to them, insisting that

swear: In this context the word swear has the same meaning as “curse” in 14:71a. Mark used both of these words here for emphasis.

In some languages it may be necessary to include a word like “said” here. For example:

he swore to them and said

General Comment on 71a–b

In some languages it may be difficult to find two different words or expressions that mean “call down curses on oneself.” If that is true in your language, try to express the emphasis in another way. For example:

Peter began calling down God's judgment on himself, and he said to them

Mark does not actually record the words that Peter used to call down God's curse on himself. 14:71c is not the curse. It is Peter's denial of Jesus.

14:71c

“I do not know this man of whom you speak!”

- “I do not know this person to whom you refer!”
- “I certainly do not know this man whom you accuse me of following!”
- he did not know the man that they were talking about.

“I do not know this man of whom you speak!”: This part of the verse gives the words that Peter used to deny knowing Jesus. In Greek the word man is literally “person.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I do not know this person of whom you speak.

I don't even know the man you're talking about! (CEV)

Mark 14:72

Section 14:66–72: Peter denied that he was a disciple of Jesus

In the last event of the preceding section, the guards were abusing Jesus after his trial before the council. In this section the focus shifts to Peter in the courtyard. In 14:54 Peter had entered the courtyard of the high priest's house. Jesus was inside the high priest's house, declaring that he was the Son of God. At the same time, Peter was in the courtyard denying that he knew Jesus. These stories contrast dramatically with each other.

In this section people asked Peter three times whether he knew Jesus. Each time Peter denied that he knew him, just as Jesus had predicted in 14:30. Then Peter became deeply sorry and wept because he had denied that he knew Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Peter denied Jesus

Peter said that he did not know Jesus

Peter's denial of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 26:69–75, Luke 22:55–62, and John 18:15–18, 25–27.

14:72a

And immediately the rooster crowed a second time.

- Right away the rooster crowed a second time.
- As soon as Peter said this, the rooster crowed for the second time.

And immediately the rooster crowed a second time:

Right after Peter's third denial of Jesus, the rooster crowed a second time. The first time it crowed was in 14:68c. This happened just as Jesus said in 14:30 that it would happen.

And immediately: The word immediately here means "as soon as" or "without delay." In this context it refers to the time immediately after Peter spoke.

14:72b

Then Peter remembered the word that Jesus had spoken to him:

- Then Peter remembered what Jesus had said to him,
- Then Peter recalled what Jesus had predicted that he would do:
- Then Peter remembered that Jesus had told him

Then Peter remembered the word that Jesus had spoken to him: When the rooster crowed a second time, Peter remembered what Jesus had earlier said to him. This word is referring to what Jesus had already said in 14:30.

the word: The phrase the word refers to the words that Jesus had spoken to Peter earlier. These words are quoted in 14:72c. Although the word is a singular form, it does not refer literally to only one word but to all that Jesus had said about this as a unit.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Then Peter remembered the words Jesus had said to him.

Then Peter remembered what Jesus had said to him.

14:72c

"Before the rooster crows twice, you will deny Me three times."

- "Before the rooster crows a second time you will have said three times that you do not know me."
- "You will deny me three times before the rooster has crowed two times."
- that before the rooster cried two times, he/Peter would deny him/Jesus three times.

Before the rooster crows twice, you will deny Me three times: See how you translated this clause in 14:30. You should translate it in the same way here.

In some languages it may be necessary to introduce the words that Jesus had spoken in some way. For example:

Jesus had said, "Before the rooster crows twice..."

14:72d

And he broke down and wept.

- Then Peter could not control his grief and wept bitterly.
- Then Peter began to cry uncontrollably, because of his deep remorse/sorrow.

And he broke down and wept: Peter cried because he was very sorry that he had denied Jesus three times. Peter had made a solemn promise to Jesus in 14:31, "Even if I have to die with you, I will never disown you." He knew that he had failed to be loyal to Jesus.

broke down and wept: There are two ways that the versions interpret the Greek expression that the BSB translates as broke down and wept:

1. It indicates that Peter was so overcome by grief and remorse that he wept. The phrase broke down is an English idiom that expresses this meaning. For example:

Then Peter lost control of himself and began to cry. (NCV)

And he broke down and cried. (GNT) (BSB, ESV, NAB, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT, NRSV, RSV, GNT)

1. It indicates that Peter began to weep. For example, the NASB says:

And he began to weep. (CEV, GW, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) with the majority of English versions. There is a great deal of debate by scholars on the meaning of the Greek word that the BSB translates as “broke down.” Three versions (NCV, NJB and REB) seem to be incorporating both ideas, especially NCV which says: “Then Peter lost control of himself and began to cry.” Most scholars, however, think that the meaning in this context is closer to interpretation (1). See especially BDAG (page 367 ἐπιβάλλω, 2.b) which discusses this particular verse as well as France, page 623.

Mark 15:1

Section 15:1–15: Pilate judged Jesus

This section continues the story of Jesus’ trial. In 14:64 the Jewish leaders had decided that Jesus deserved to die. In this section, the Jewish leaders tied Jesus and took him away to Pilate for trial. Pilate was the Roman governor of the Jewish district of Judea. The Jewish leaders took Jesus to Pilate because they wanted to have Jesus put to death. Pilate questioned Jesus but did not find him guilty of any crime. Pilate wanted to release Jesus, but the Jewish leaders stirred up the crowd to demand that Pilate condemn him to death. Pilate finally agreed to do what the crowd demanded and condemned Jesus to be crucified.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Pilate Questions Jesus (CEV)

The trial of Jesus by Pilate

Jesus before Pilate (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:1–2, 11–26, Luke 23:1–5, 13–25, and John 18:28–19:16.

15:1a

Early in the morning,

- ¶ Very early the next morning,
- ¶ As soon as the sun rose,

Early in the morning: The phrase that the BSB translates as Early in the morning refers to dawn or sunrise. Your language may have a special word or phrase for this.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Early the next morning (CEV)

As soon as it was morning (RSV)

15:1b

the chief priests, elders, scribes, and the whole Sanhedrin devised a plan.

- the chief priests, along with the elders, the teachers of the law, and the whole Jewish council, decided what they would do with/about Jesus.
- after having made plans, the chief priests, along with the elders, the experts in the law, and the whole council,

the chief priests, elders, scribes, and the whole Sanhedrin devised a plan:

This part of the verse indicates that the whole Jewish council (the Sanhedrin) met together. The Greek has a word that literally translates as “with” (as in the NIV). Although the BSB does not translate this word, it probably indicates that the chief priests took the main responsibility in making the decision about what to do next with Jesus. Although the chief priests took the main responsibility for the decision, the elders, scribes, and other members of the Sanhedrin were also at the meeting.

The phrase the whole Sanhedrin emphasizes that the whole Sanhedrin decided what to do about Jesus. It may be necessary to reword the phrases to make this clearer. For example:

...the chief priests met with the elders and the teachers of the law. Together, every member of the Sanhedrin reached a decision.

chief priests: A Jewish priest was a man who offered sacrifices to God on behalf of the people. He also performed other rituals for them. The phrase chief priests refers to the leaders among these priests.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the leading/ruling priests

the elders among the Jewish sacrificers

the most prominent priests

The term chief priests first occurs in Mark in 8:31c. See how you translated it there.

elders: The elders were the civil leaders or rulers. They were generally older men. See how you translated elders in 8:31c and 11:27c.

scribes: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as scribes is sometimes translated as “teachers of the law” (as in the NIV). The original work of these men was to copy the laws of Moses by hand. In New Testament times, their main task was to study, interpret, and teach the law of Moses and related Jewish laws and traditions.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

teachers of the Law of Moses (CEV)

teachers of religious law (NLT)

teachers of the law of the Jews

the experts on the law

See how you translated scribes in 14:43d and 14:53b. See also teacher of the law in the Glossary.

Sanhedrin: The word Sanhedrin is a Greek word that the BSB has borrowed. It means “council” and refers to the court with the highest authority over the Jews.

Here are some other ways to translate Sanhedrin:

council (RSV, GNT)

Jewish council (NCV)

highest group of Jewish leaders

See how you translated Sanhedrin in 14:55a.

devised a plan: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as devised a plan:

1. It means “made a decision” or “formed a plan.” For example:

made their plans (GNT)

decided what to do with Jesus (NCV) (GW, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, REB, GNT)

1. It means “held a council session” or “consulted together.” For example:

met together (CEV)

called together a meeting (JBP) (CEV, ESV, NASB, NLT, RSV, JBP)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

15:1c

They bound Jesus, led Him away,

- Then they tied Jesus with rope/chains and led him away
- tied up Jesus. Then they took him away from the high priest’s house

They bound Jesus: The clause They bound Jesus means that the Jewish leaders tied Jesus’ hands together with ropes or chains. It was most likely the temple guards who actually tied Jesus up and not the leaders themselves.

led Him away: The Greek word that the BSB translates as led...away also means “took away” or simply “took.” The council led Jesus away from the house of the high priest and took him to Pilate.

In some languages, it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

...they led him away from the high priest’s house and took him to where Pilate the governor was.

15:1d

and handed Him over to Pilate.

- to deliver him to Pilate.
- and gave him to Governor Pilate to be judged/tried.

handed Him over to Pilate: The expression handed Him over to Pilate means that the Jewish leaders “delivered Jesus into the control of Pilate.” In this context it indicates that the leaders brought Jesus to Pilate so that Pilate could judge him and condemn him to death. Pilate was the Roman governor. He had the power to order that Jesus be killed.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

gave him to Pilate

turned him over to Pilate (NCV)

Pilate: This is Pontius Pilate, who was the Roman governor of the district of Judea. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Governor Pilate

Pilate the Roman leader

Mark 15:2

Section 15:1–15: Pilate judged Jesus

This section continues the story of Jesus' trial. In 14:64 the Jewish leaders had decided that Jesus deserved to die. In this section, the Jewish leaders tied Jesus and took him away to Pilate for trial. Pilate was the Roman governor of the Jewish district of Judea. The Jewish leaders took Jesus to Pilate because they wanted to have Jesus put to death. Pilate questioned Jesus but did not find him guilty of any crime. Pilate wanted to release Jesus, but the Jewish leaders stirred up the crowd to demand that Pilate condemn him to death. Pilate finally agreed to do what the crowd demanded and condemned Jesus to be crucified.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Pilate Questions Jesus (CEV)

The trial of Jesus by Pilate

Jesus before Pilate (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:1–2, 11–26, Luke 23:1–5, 13–25, and John 18:28–19:16.

15:2a

So Pilate questioned Him, “Are You the King of the Jews?”

- Pilate asked him, “Is it you who are the king of/over the Jews?”
- Then Pilate questioned Jesus, “Are you the ruler/ chief of the Jewish people?”
- Then Pilate asked Jesus whether he was the king of the Jewish people.

So Pilate questioned Him: The Greek clause that the BSB literally translates as Pilate questioned Him occurs before the question. Here is another way to order this phrase:

“Are you the king of the Jews?” asked Pilate (NIV11)

Order in a way that is natural in your language.

“Are You the King of the Jews?”: The title King of the Jews is used here for the first time in Mark.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Are you king of the Jewish people?

Are you the Jews' chief/leader?

Pilate was probably concerned that Jesus might claim to be the king of the Jews and challenge Roman authority.

You: In Greek, the word You is emphatic. In some languages this emphasis can be shown by saying something like:

Is it you who are the king of the Jews?

Are you the one who is king of the Jews?

King of the Jews: Since the Romans ruled the Jewish people, a claim to be King of the Jews would be a challenge to Roman authority. It would be a form of treason which was punishable by death.

15:2b

“You have said so,” Jesus replied.

- Jesus answered, “You say so/it.”
- “Those are your words,” Jesus answered. (CEV)
- Jesus replied that it was Pilate who had used those words.

You have said so: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as You have said so is literally “You^(sing) yourself say so.” The word in Greek that means “you” is probably emphatic.

Scholars disagree about what Jesus indicated by his answer. Here are the two interpretations:

1. Jesus did not indicate whether he agreed with Pilate. He indicated only that it was Pilate who had used the words “king of the Jews.” For example, the RSV says:

You have said so. (BSB, NIV11, GNT, RSV, NJB, NET, CEV, ESV, KJV, NCV, NLT04, REB)

1. Jesus indicated that he agreed with Pilate. For example, the GW says:

Yes, I am. (NIV84, GW, NASB, NLT96)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Jesus did not deny what Pilate had said. But he did not indicate definite agreement. Jesus did not claim to be a political king. Therefore, he was not a threat to the Roman emperor. He was a different sort of king.

Jesus replied: The BSB places the clause Jesus replied after Jesus' answer. In Greek, this clause occurs before Jesus' answer. Place this clause where it is natural in your language.

Mark 15:3

Section 15:1–15: Pilate judged Jesus

This section continues the story of Jesus' trial. In 14:64 the Jewish leaders had decided that Jesus deserved to die. In this section, the Jewish leaders tied Jesus and took him away to Pilate for trial. Pilate was the Roman governor of the Jewish district of Judea. The Jewish leaders took Jesus to Pilate because they wanted to have Jesus put to death. Pilate questioned Jesus but did not find him guilty of any crime. Pilate wanted to release Jesus, but the Jewish leaders stirred up the crowd to demand that Pilate condemn him to death. Pilate finally agreed to do what the crowd demanded and condemned Jesus to be crucified.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Pilate Questions Jesus (CEV)

The trial of Jesus by Pilate

Jesus before Pilate (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:1–2, 11–26, Luke 23:1–5, 13–25, and John 18:28–19:16.

15:3

And the chief priests began to accuse Him of many things.

- The chief priests brought many charges against Jesus. (CEV)
- The chief priests told Pilate about the many wrong things that they thought that Jesus had done.

chief priests: The chief priests are the same group of men as in 15:1b. You should translate it here as you did there.

began to accuse Him of many things: The words began to accuse Him of many things indicates that the chief priests told Pilate about the many wrong things

that they thought that Jesus had done. They presented their evidence against Jesus to Pilate.

Mark 15:4

Section 15:1–15: Pilate judged Jesus

This section continues the story of Jesus' trial. In 14:64 the Jewish leaders had decided that Jesus deserved to die. In this section, the Jewish leaders tied Jesus and took him away to Pilate for trial. Pilate was the Roman governor of the Jewish district of Judea. The Jewish leaders took Jesus to Pilate because they wanted to have Jesus put to death. Pilate questioned Jesus but did not find him guilty of any crime. Pilate wanted to release Jesus, but the Jewish leaders stirred up the crowd to demand that Pilate condemn him to death. Pilate finally agreed to do what the crowd demanded and condemned Jesus to be crucified.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Pilate Questions Jesus (CEV)

The trial of Jesus by Pilate

Jesus before Pilate (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:1–2, 11–26, Luke 23:1–5, 13–25, and John 18:28–19:16.

15:4a

Then Pilate questioned Him again, “Have You no answer?”

- So Pilate questioned Jesus some more and said, “Are you not going to respond?”
- But Jesus did not reply. So Pilate said to Jesus, “You should defend yourself against all these accusations!”

Then Pilate questioned Him again, “Have You no answer?: The leaders of a court normally allowed the accused person to defend himself. Pilate expected Jesus to defend himself. That is why he asked Jesus another question.

It is clear that Jesus did not answer the accusations. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit and put some information from 15:5a here. For example:

But Jesus did not reply. So Pilate asked him, “Aren't you going to answer?”

Pilate questioned Him again: The clause Pilate questioned Him again means “Pilate continued to question him” or “Pilate asked him another question.” It does not mean that Pilate asked him the same question a second time. For example, you could say:

Pilate asked Jesus another question (NCV)

Pilate questioned Jesus some more

Have You no answer?: This is a real question. Pilate asked this question and expected Jesus to respond. Pilate’s question implied that Jesus ought to answer the accusations.

15:4b

Look how many charges they are bringing against You!”

- Listen to the many things/crimes of which they are accusing you.”
- Do you not hear all these accusations being brought against you?”

Look: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Look has a figurative meaning here. Pilate used this word to call attention to and emphasize what follows in the sentence. It does not literally mean “to see with the eyes.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Pay attention

Listen carefully

Take this seriously

how many charges they are bringing against You!:

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the many things/crimes of which they are accusing you

all the accusations of wrong behavior they are bringing against you

In some languages, it may be effective to use a rhetorical question for 15:4b. This could be combined with the emphatic statement in 15:4a. For example:

^{4a}You should defend yourself! ^{4b}Don’t you hear all these accusations being brought against you?

General Comment on 15:4a–b

Verse 15:4b gives the reason why Jesus should do as Pilate suggested in 15:4a. So in some languages, it will be more natural to change the order of 15:4a and 15:4b. For example, the NCV says:

^{4b}You can see that they are accusing you of many things. ^{4a}Aren’t you going to answer?

Mark 15:5

Section 15:1–15: Pilate judged Jesus

This section continues the story of Jesus’ trial. In 14:64 the Jewish leaders had decided that Jesus deserved to die. In this section, the Jewish leaders tied Jesus and took him away to Pilate for trial. Pilate was the Roman governor of the Jewish district of Judea. The Jewish leaders took Jesus to Pilate because they wanted to have Jesus put to death. Pilate questioned Jesus but did not find him guilty of any crime. Pilate wanted to release Jesus, but the Jewish leaders stirred up the crowd to demand that Pilate condemn him to death. Pilate finally agreed to do what the crowd demanded and condemned Jesus to be crucified.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Pilate Questions Jesus (CEV)

The trial of Jesus by Pilate

Jesus before Pilate (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:1–2, 11–26, Luke 23:1–5, 13–25, and John 18:28–19:16.

15:5a–b

But to Pilate’s amazement, Jesus made no further reply: The BSB reverses the order of the Greek clauses. The Greek literally means “But Jesus no longer answered anything, so that Pilate was amazed.” It may be more natural in your language to follow the Greek order.

15:5a

But to Pilate’s amazement,

- and/so Pilate was surprised.
- As a result, Pilate was thoroughly astonished.
- This amazed Pilate.

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But indicates a contrast with Pilate's question in 15:4a. Pilate expected Jesus to verbally defend himself against the things that the chief priests accused him of. But he did not.

to Pilate's amazement: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to literally means "so that" or "with the result that." Another way to translate this phrase is:

as a result, Pilate was amazed.

so that Pilate was amazed.

If you are following the order of the BSB, it may be helpful to translate this phrase as a separate sentence. For example:

this amazed Pilate:

Pilate's amazement: The Greek word that the BSB translates as amazement is a verb that means "marveled," "impressed," "astonished," "surprised," or "wondered."

Pilate was amazed that Jesus did not respond to the things of which they were accusing him. In some languages, it may be natural to make some of this information explicit. For example:

Pilate was amazed that Jesus remained silent and did not attempt to defend himself.

Pilate was surprised that Jesus did not defend himself.

15:5b

Jesus made no further reply.

- But Jesus still said nothing, (NCV)
- But Jesus remained silent.

Jesus made no further reply: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Jesus made no further reply is literally "Jesus no longer answered anything."

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus still did not say anything.

Jesus continued to remain silent.

Jesus did not answer (CEV)

Jesus still said nothing (NCV)

Mark 15:6

Section 15:1–15: Pilate judged Jesus

This section continues the story of Jesus' trial. In 14:64 the Jewish leaders had decided that Jesus deserved to die. In this section, the Jewish leaders tied Jesus and took him away to Pilate for trial. Pilate was the Roman governor of the Jewish district of Judea. The Jewish leaders took Jesus to Pilate because they wanted to have Jesus put to death. Pilate questioned Jesus but did not find him guilty of any crime. Pilate wanted to release Jesus, but the Jewish leaders stirred up the crowd to demand that Pilate condemn him to death. Pilate finally agreed to do what the crowd demanded and condemned Jesus to be crucified.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Pilate Questions Jesus (CEV)

The trial of Jesus by Pilate

Jesus before Pilate (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:1–2, 11–26, Luke 23:1–5, 13–25, and John 18:28–19:16.

15:6–7

Verses 15:6 and 15:7 provide background information that is important for the next part of the story. Verse 15:6 indicates that it was Pilate's custom to release a prisoner from prison each year during Passover. Verse 15:7 talks about a particular prisoner who was being held by the Romans. Translate this background information in a way that is natural in your language.

15:6a

Now it was Pilate's custom at the feast

- ¶ Now each year at the feast, it was his/Pilate's custom
- ¶ Every year during the Passover festival,

15:6b

to release to the people a prisoner of their choosing.

- to release/free one prisoner whom the people asked for.
- Pilate always released any one prisoner whom the people wanted him to release.

15:6a–b

Now it was Pilate’s custom at the feast to release to the people a prisoner of their choosing: Each year during the time of the Passover festival, Pilate released one prisoner. The people told Pilate which prisoner they wanted to be released. After he was released, the prisoner did not receive any more punishment.

Now: Verse 15:6 is background information. The BSB indicates this by translating the Greek conjunction here as Now. If your language has a special word to introduce background information, you could use that word here. The GNT and other English versions do not translate this conjunction.

it was Pilate’s custom at the feast to release: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as it was Pilate’s custom at the feast to release is literally “at every festival he was releasing.” This means that each year during the Passover festival, Pilate released a prisoner. This had become a custom.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

At every Passover Festival Pilate was in the habit of setting free (GNT)

...it was the governor’s custom each year during the Passover celebration to release (NLT)

During Passover, Pilate always freed (CEV)

at the feast: The phrase at the feast here refers to the time during the Passover festival or celebration that was held each year. For example, the GW says:

At every Passover festival

The word at does not indicate that Pilate released the prisoner at the place where the people were feasting. Instead, it refers to the period of time during which the feast took place. As such it can be translated as “during.”

Some languages may not have a general word meaning “feast” or “celebration” that can refer to the Passover. If that is true in your language, then use the full expression for Passover that you used in 14:1a.

to release: The word release means “free” or “liberate.” In this context it refers to freeing a prisoner.

a prisoner of their choosing: The words a prisoner of their choosing indicates that the people could ask Pilate to free any one prisoner whom they wanted.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

one prisoner whom the people asked for (GW)

one prisoner whom the people chose (NCV)

Mark 15:7**Section 15:1–15: Pilate judged Jesus**

This section continues the story of Jesus’ trial. In 14:64 the Jewish leaders had decided that Jesus deserved to die. In this section, the Jewish leaders tied Jesus and took him away to Pilate for trial. Pilate was the Roman governor of the Jewish district of Judea. The Jewish leaders took Jesus to Pilate because they wanted to have Jesus put to death. Pilate questioned Jesus but did not find him guilty of any crime. Pilate wanted to release Jesus, but the Jewish leaders stirred up the crowd to demand that Pilate condemn him to death. Pilate finally agreed to do what the crowd demanded and condemned Jesus to be crucified.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Pilate Questions Jesus (CEV)

The trial of Jesus by Pilate

Jesus before Pilate (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:1–2, 11–26, Luke 23:1–5, 13–25, and John 18:28–19:16.

15:7a**And a man named Barabbas**

- There was a man named Barabbas
- At that time a man named Barabbas
- There was a certain man. His name was Barabbas.

And a man named Barabbas: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as And a man named Barabbas is literally “there was a man called Barabbas” (as in the RSV). This is the first time that Barabbas is mentioned in Mark. Introduce this new character into the story in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

There was a man named Barabbas (GW)

There was a certain man. His name was Barabbas.

named: The word named here means that this man's name was Barabbas.

Here is another way to translate this:

a man called Barabbas (NIV)

15:7b

was imprisoned with the rebels

- who was in prison with the rebels
- had been arrested and was in prison with the other men who had fought against the government.

was imprisoned: Barabbas, along with other people, was a prisoner and had to live in the prison or jail. The word that the BSB translates as was imprisoned is passive. It may be helpful to translate this as an active phrase. For example:

was in prison (NIV11)

one of those in prison was (NLT)

with the rebels: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rebels refers to a group of people who had rebelled and fought against the Roman government. They refused to obey the Roman authorities and had been involved in riots against the government.

Here are some other ways to translate the word rebels:

the insurrectionists (NIV11)

some other rioters (JBP)

men who fought against the government

15:7c

who had committed murder during the insurrection.

- who had all murdered people during the rebellion.
- They had killed people during the riot/fight against the government.

who had committed murder: The clause who had committed murder means that the rebels had killed people intentionally and illegally.

during the insurrection: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the insurrection also means “the rebellion” or “the riot” (as in the GNT). This word insurrection refers to a serious disturbance or fight. It

often refers specifically to rebels who fight against a government.

The phrase the insurrection means that this was a specific rebellion against the Romans that had occurred. It is referred to in a definite way by the word “the.” This means that the event was probably known to the readers. Barabbas and the other rebels had been arrested because they participated in this particular insurrection.

Mark 15:8

Section 15:1–15: Pilate judged Jesus

This section continues the story of Jesus' trial. In 14:64 the Jewish leaders had decided that Jesus deserved to die. In this section, the Jewish leaders tied Jesus and took him away to Pilate for trial. Pilate was the Roman governor of the Jewish district of Judea. The Jewish leaders took Jesus to Pilate because they wanted to have Jesus put to death. Pilate questioned Jesus but did not find him guilty of any crime. Pilate wanted to release Jesus, but the Jewish leaders stirred up the crowd to demand that Pilate condemn him to death. Pilate finally agreed to do what the crowd demanded and condemned Jesus to be crucified.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Pilate Questions Jesus (CEV)

The trial of Jesus by Pilate

Jesus before Pilate (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:1–2, 11–26, Luke 23:1–5, 13–25, and John 18:28–19:16.

15:8a

So the crowd went up

- The crowd came up to where Pilate was
- Then the crowd went to Pilate

As mentioned above, 15:6–7 is background information. In 15:8, the main story continues.

So: If there is a word or phrase in your language to indicate that the main story is continuing, you should use it here. For example:

Then (NET)

the crowd went up: There is a textual issue with came up: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have “having gone up” which the BSB translates as “went up” (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NRSV, NJB, NLT, REB, RSV, GNT). (2) Other Greek manuscripts have “crying out/shouting.” This is only followed by the KJV. It is recommended that you follow option (1). It has better manuscript support and nearly every English version follows this option. The Greek word that the BSB translates as went up probably indicates that the people walked from a lower to a higher place in Jerusalem.

In some languages, it is important to say whether a person goes up or down when he travels. If your language has a way to indicate movement to a higher place, you should use it here. In other languages, it may not be necessary or possible to include this idea. These languages can say:

came (NCV)

approached

15:8b and began asking Pilate to keep his custom.

- and asked Pilate to do what he always did for them each year.
- and began to ask him to free a prisoner as he always did. (NCV)
- and made a request. They said, “Do for us^(excl) as it is your^(sing) custom to do each year during the festival and release a prisoner.”

began asking Pilate to keep his custom: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as began asking Pilate to keep his custom means that the crowd asked Pilate to release a prisoner just like he did for them every year.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

ask him to free a prisoner as he always did (NCV)

ask Pilate for the usual favor (GNT)

ask Pilate the customary favor (NJB)

General Comment on 15:8a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to express this verse with a direct quote. For example:

The crowd came up to Pilate to request a favor. They said, “Do for us as it is your custom to do each year during the festival by releasing a prisoner.”

Mark 15:9

Section 15:1–15: Pilate judged Jesus

This section continues the story of Jesus’ trial. In 14:64 the Jewish leaders had decided that Jesus deserved to die. In this section, the Jewish leaders tied Jesus and took him away to Pilate for trial. Pilate was the Roman governor of the Jewish district of Judea. The Jewish leaders took Jesus to Pilate because they wanted to have Jesus put to death. Pilate questioned Jesus but did not find him guilty of any crime. Pilate wanted to release Jesus, but the Jewish leaders stirred up the crowd to demand that Pilate condemn him to death. Pilate finally agreed to do what the crowd demanded and condemned Jesus to be crucified.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Pilate Questions Jesus (CEV)

The trial of Jesus by Pilate

Jesus before Pilate (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:1–2, 11–26, Luke 23:1–5, 13–25, and John 18:28–19:16.

15:9

“Do you want me to release to you the King of the Jews?” Pilate asked.

- Pilate asked them, “Would you^(plur) like me to release the king of the Jews for you?”
- He asked them if they wanted him to free the king of the Jews for them.
- Pilate responded to them, “Do you^(plur) want me to free/liberate the king of the Jews?”

Do you want me to release to you the King of the Jews?: This is a real question.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

Would you like me to release for you the king of the Jews?

Do you want me to free the king of the Jews for you? (GW)

to you: The phrase to you means “for you” in the sense of “as a favor to you” or “to benefit you.” The GNT has:

Do you want me to set free for you the king of the Jews?

In some languages it may be more natural to leave this phrase implied. For example, the REB says:

Would you like me to release the king of the Jews?

the King of the Jews: The phrase the King of the Jews is the title Pilate had used to refer to Jesus in 15:2a. You should translate this title here as you did there.

Pilate asked: The BSB puts the phrase Pilate asked after the question. In Greek, this phrase occurs before the question. You should place this phrase where it is most natural in your language.

Mark 15:10

Section 15:1–15: Pilate judged Jesus

This section continues the story of Jesus’ trial. In 14:64 the Jewish leaders had decided that Jesus deserved to die. In this section, the Jewish leaders tied Jesus and took him away to Pilate for trial. Pilate was the Roman governor of the Jewish district of Judea. The Jewish leaders took Jesus to Pilate because they wanted to have Jesus put to death. Pilate questioned Jesus but did not find him guilty of any crime. Pilate wanted to release Jesus, but the Jewish leaders stirred up the crowd to demand that Pilate condemn him to death. Pilate finally agreed to do what the crowd demanded and condemned Jesus to be crucified.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Pilate Questions Jesus (CEV)

The trial of Jesus by Pilate

Jesus before Pilate (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:1–2, 11–26, Luke 23:1–5, 13–25, and John 18:28–19:16.

15:10

For he knew it was out of envy that the chief priests had handed Jesus over.

- Pilate knew that it was because of their envy that the chief priests had brought Jesus to him for trial.
- Pilate asked this because he knew that the chief priests had delivered Jesus to him because they were jealous of him/Jesus.
- Pilate knew that the chief priests were jealous of Jesus and so had brought Jesus to him.

This verse provides some background information. It explains why Pilate responded to the crowd by asking them if they wanted him to release Jesus. The NET puts 15:10 in parentheses to show that it is background information:

(For he knew that the chief priests had handed him over because of envy.)

You should indicate that this is background information in the way that is natural in your language.

Pilate knew that Jesus had not done anything against Roman law. He knew the chief priests were angry because many Jewish people were following Jesus rather than the chief priests. The chief priests had accused Jesus of wrong because they were envious of him and wanted to kill him.

For he knew: The Greek has a clause here that the BSB literally translates as For he knew . In some languages, it may be more natural to add some implicit information here. For example:

Pilate asked this because he knew...

This clause indicates that Pilate understood why the chief priests handed Jesus over to him for trial. Someone had probably given him information that helped him understand.

it was out of envy: The phrase it was out of envy means “because they were jealous.” The chief priests were envious or jealous of Jesus. This was probably because the ordinary people liked to listen to Jesus more than they liked listening to the chief priests.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

because they were envious of him/Jesus

because they were jealous of his popularity

Some languages have special idioms to express envy.

the chief priests: A Jewish priest was a man who offered sacrifices to God on behalf of the people. He

also performed other rituals for them. The phrase the chief priests refers to the leaders among these priests. Here are some other ways to translate this:

the leading/ruling priests

the elders among the Jewish sacrificers

the most prominent priests

See how you translated priest at 15:1b.

had handed Jesus over: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as the idiom had handed...over means “delivered into the control of someone else.” In this case they gave Jesus to Pilate to judge him.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

gave/delivered

brought Jesus to him. (CEV)

This verb also occurs in 15:1d. See how you translated it there.

Mark 15:11

Section 15:1–15: Pilate judged Jesus

This section continues the story of Jesus’ trial. In 14:64 the Jewish leaders had decided that Jesus deserved to die. In this section, the Jewish leaders tied Jesus and took him away to Pilate for trial. Pilate was the Roman governor of the Jewish district of Judea. The Jewish leaders took Jesus to Pilate because they wanted to have Jesus put to death. Pilate questioned Jesus but did not find him guilty of any crime. Pilate wanted to release Jesus, but the Jewish leaders stirred up the crowd to demand that Pilate condemn him to death. Pilate finally agreed to do what the crowd demanded and condemned Jesus to be crucified.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Pilate Questions Jesus (CEV)

The trial of Jesus by Pilate

Jesus before Pilate (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:1–2, 11–26, Luke 23:1–5, 13–25, and John 18:28–19:16.

15:11a

But the chief priests stirred up the crowd

- But the chief priests incited/roused the crowd
- But the chief priests persuaded the crowd of people

But the chief priests stirred up the crowd: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as the idiom stirred up also means “roused,” “incited,” or “moved to action.” The chief priests roused or incited the crowd so that they would request the release of Barabbas and turn against Jesus. They persuaded the crowd to ask for the release of Barabbas.

chief priests: This is the same word as in 15:10. Translate here as you did there.

15:11b

to have him release Barabbas to them instead.

- to request/ask Pilate to release Barabbas instead of Jesus.
- to demand that Pilate free Barabbas, rather than freeing Jesus.
- to say to Pilate, “No, do not release Jesus! We want you to release Barabbas!”

to have him release Barabbas to them instead: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to have him release Barabbas to them instead is literally “that rather he should release Barabbas to them.” Here, “he” refers to Pilate.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to ask Pilate to free Barabbas, not Jesus (NCV)

to demand the release of Barabbas instead of Jesus (NLT)

Mark 15:12

Section 15:1–15: Pilate judged Jesus

This section continues the story of Jesus’ trial. In 14:64 the Jewish leaders had decided that Jesus deserved to die. In this section, the Jewish leaders tied Jesus and took him away to Pilate for trial. Pilate was the Roman governor of the Jewish district of Judea. The Jewish leaders took Jesus to Pilate because they wanted to have Jesus put to death. Pilate questioned Jesus but did not find him guilty of any crime. Pilate wanted to release Jesus, but the Jewish leaders stirred up the crowd to demand that Pilate condemn him to death.

Pilate finally agreed to do what the crowd demanded and condemned Jesus to be crucified.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Pilate Questions Jesus (CEV)

The trial of Jesus by Pilate

Jesus before Pilate (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:1–2, 11–26, Luke 23:1–5, 13–25, and John 18:28–19:16.

15:12

So Pilate asked them again, “What then do you want me to do with the One you call the King of the Jews?”

- Then Pilate asked them, “So what should I do with the one you^(plur) refer to as the king of the Jews?”
- So Pilate asked them, “If I release Barabbas, then what do you^(plur) want me to do with this man whom you^(plur) call the ruler of the Jewish people?”

So Pilate asked them again: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as So Pilate asked them occurs at the beginning of 15:12. Some versions place the words Pilate asked them at the end of this verse instead, after quoting his words. Place these words where it is most natural in your language.

What then do you want me to do with the One you call the King of the Jews?: There is a textual issue in this verse. Some Greek manuscripts include a word that means “you wish”:

1. Some Greek manuscripts do not include this word. They have only “What should I do...?” For example:

Then what shall I do with the man...? (RSV) (NIV, RSV, NJB, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NLT, REB)

1. Other Greek manuscripts include this word, as the BSB does. They have “What do you wish/want I should do...?” For example:

What do you want me to do with this man...? (CEV) (BSB, GNT, CEV, NRSV, KJV, NET)

Option (1) has the strongest manuscript support. However, there is no significant difference in meaning

between the two options. So you may follow whatever option is more natural in your language.

Pilate asked the crowd what he should do with Jesus if he released Barabbas. In some languages, it may be natural to make this information explicit. For example:

If I release Barabbas, what shall I do, then, with the one you call the king of the Jews?

then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as then is literally “therefore” or “so.” For example, the NCV says:

So what should I do with this man you call the king of the Jews? (NCV)

It does not mean “next.”

In Greek, this word occurs after the word “what,” as the BSB translates it. You should place it where it is natural in your language.

the One you call the King of the Jews: There is a textual issue in this part of the verse. Many major Greek manuscripts (and the UBS4 page 185 and Majority Text) include the phrase “the one you call” here. However, many others do not include it. Of the versions consulted, only the GW omits this phrase. Pilate used the phrase the One you call the King of the Jews to indicate that he was using the same title for Jesus that the Jews used. (However, the leaders of the Jews did not call Jesus that.)

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

this man you call the king of the Jews (NLT)

this man you say is the king of the Jews (CEV)

Mark 15:13

Section 15:1–15: Pilate judged Jesus

This section continues the story of Jesus’ trial. In 14:64 the Jewish leaders had decided that Jesus deserved to die. In this section, the Jewish leaders tied Jesus and took him away to Pilate for trial. Pilate was the Roman governor of the Jewish district of Judea. The Jewish leaders took Jesus to Pilate because they wanted to have Jesus put to death. Pilate questioned Jesus but did not find him guilty of any crime. Pilate wanted to release Jesus, but the Jewish leaders stirred up the crowd to demand that Pilate condemn him to death. Pilate finally agreed to do what the crowd demanded and condemned Jesus to be crucified.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Pilate Questions Jesus (CEV)

The trial of Jesus by Pilate

Jesus before Pilate (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:1–2, 11–26, Luke 23:1–5, 13–25, and John 18:28–19:16.

15:13

And they shouted back, “Crucify Him!”

- They yelled, “Nail him to a cross!” (CEV)
- They shouted to Pilate, “Kill him on a cross!”

And they shouted back, “Crucify Him!”: The Greek verb that the BSB literally translates as they shouted back occurs before Crucify Him, as it does in the BSB. You should put these phrases in the order that is natural in your language. For example:

“Crucify him!” they shouted (NIV11)

Crucify Him!: The word Crucify means to execute (kill) someone by nailing or tying him to a cross, then setting the cross upright. This was a Roman way to cause criminals to die a slow and painful death.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Kill/Execute him on a cross!

Nail/Fasten him to a cross to kill him!

Here are some other ways to translate the word “cross”:

plank/wood of death

crossed-beam(s) of death

a tree for killing people

a stake/post to which they fasten/nail someone to kill him

The word “cross” first occurs at 8:34d. See how you translated it there.

You may want to include a footnote to explain more about crucifixion. For example:

One Roman method to execute a criminal was to crucify him. They crossed two large pieces of wood and joined them together. Then soldiers nailed or tied the criminal’s arms to one piece of wood and his feet to the other. They set the cross upright and allowed him to die a slow and painful death on it.

Mark 15:14

Section 15:1–15: Pilate judged Jesus

This section continues the story of Jesus’ trial. In 14:64 the Jewish leaders had decided that Jesus deserved to die. In this section, the Jewish leaders tied Jesus and took him away to Pilate for trial. Pilate was the Roman governor of the Jewish district of Judea. The Jewish leaders took Jesus to Pilate because they wanted to have Jesus put to death. Pilate questioned Jesus but did not find him guilty of any crime. Pilate wanted to release Jesus, but the Jewish leaders stirred up the crowd to demand that Pilate condemn him to death. Pilate finally agreed to do what the crowd demanded and condemned Jesus to be crucified.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Pilate Questions Jesus (CEV)

The trial of Jesus by Pilate

Jesus before Pilate (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:1–2, 11–26, Luke 23:1–5, 13–25, and John 18:28–19:16.

15:14a

“Why?” asked Pilate. “What evil has He done?”

- Pilate asked them, “What crime is he guilty of?”
- Pilate responded to them, “What has he done wrong?”

Why?...What evil has He done?: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Why?...What evil has He done? is literally “What evil has he done?” (as in the RSV). It is only one question in Greek.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

What wrong has he done? (NCV)

What has he done wrong? (NET)

What illegal thing has he done?

Of what crime is he guilty?

evil: The word evil in this context refers to bad/wrong behavior that was against Roman law. The NIV translates this word as “crime.”

asked Pilate: The BSB inserts the words asked Pilate in the middle of Pilate’s question. In the Greek, these words are at the beginning of 15:14. For example:

And Pilate said to them, “Why? What evil has he done?” (ESV)

However, the NIV places these words at the end of Pilate’s question:

“Why? What crime has he committed?” asked Pilate (NIV11).

Place the words asked Pilate where it is most natural in your language.

15:14b

But they shouted all the louder, “Crucify Him!”

- But they shouted even louder, “Kill him on the cross!”
- But they yelled back to Pilate even louder than before, “Nail him to a cross!”
- But they shouted even louder that he should nail Jesus to a cross.

But they shouted all the louder, “Crucify Him!”: Even though Pilate asked a real question, the crowd did not give him a real answer. They ignored his question and repeated their demand. They shouted to Pilate even louder than before. They were probably getting angry.

shouted all the louder: The phrase shouted all the louder means they “shouted more loudly” and “more insistently” than the first time.

Here is another way to translate this:

they yelled even louder (CEV)

Crucify Him!: Translate Crucify Him! in the same way you translated it in 15:13.

Mark 15:15

Section 15:1–15: Pilate judged Jesus

This section continues the story of Jesus’ trial. In 14:64 the Jewish leaders had decided that Jesus deserved to die. In this section, the Jewish leaders tied Jesus and took him away to Pilate for trial. Pilate was the Roman governor of the Jewish district of Judea. The Jewish leaders took Jesus to Pilate because they wanted to have Jesus put to death. Pilate questioned Jesus but did not find him guilty of any crime. Pilate wanted to release Jesus, but the Jewish leaders stirred up the crowd to demand that Pilate condemn him to death. Pilate finally agreed to do what the crowd demanded and condemned Jesus to be crucified.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Pilate Questions Jesus (CEV)

The trial of Jesus by Pilate

Jesus before Pilate (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:1–2, 11–26, Luke 23:1–5, 13–25, and John 18:28–19:16.

15:15a

And wishing to satisfy the crowd,

- Pilate wanted to please the crowd.
- Because Pilate wanted to do what would make the crowd happy,

And wishing to satisfy the crowd: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as And wishing to satisfy the crowd means “Because Pilate wanted to satisfy/please the crowd.” This clause gives the reason for what Pilate did in the next part of this verse.

Here is another way to translate this:

Pilate wanted to make the crowd happy, and so...

15:15b

Pilate released Barabbas to them.

- So he released Barabbas from prison for them.
- he freed Barabbas from prison as they asked.

Pilate released Barabbas to them: The clause Pilate released Barabbas to them means “Pilate freed Barabbas from prison for them.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Pilate freed Barabbas as a favor to them.

Pilate set Barabbas free from prison as they had requested.

15:15c

But he had Jesus flogged,

- Pilate commanded that Jesus be whipped,
- Then Pilate ordered some soldiers to beat Jesus with a whip

But he had Jesus flogged: The clause But he had Jesus flogged means that Pilate ordered other people (probably soldiers) to flog/whip Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Pilate ordered some soldiers to beat Jesus with whips.

flogged: The Greek word that the BSB translates as flogged also means “scourged,” “beat,” “whipped,” or “lashed.” According to Roman custom, the prisoner was beat with a whip made of several leather strips attached to a wooden handle. Often the strips had pieces of metal or bone attached to them to cause greater pain.

Use whatever word or phrase in your language that best describes this type of beating.

15:15d

and handed Him over to be crucified.

- and then he delivered/gave Jesus to some soldiers to be nailed to a cross.
- and then take him away to kill him on the cross.

and handed Him over to be crucified: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as the English idiom handed... over means “delivered into the power of someone else” or simply “gave.” This means that Pilate gave Jesus to the soldiers and told them to take Jesus away to crucify him. This is the same verb as in 15:1d and 15:10.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

and gave Jesus to the soldiers to take Jesus away to crucify him

then turned him over to the Roman soldiers to be crucified (NLT)

crucified: See how you translated “crucify” in 15:13.

General Comment on 15:15c–d

If you have mentioned the word “soldiers” in 15:15c, it may be more natural to include the verb “handed over” in 15:15c rather than in 15:15d. Or it may be natural to leave this verb implicit. For example:

^{15c}Pilate handed Jesus over to some soldiers and ordered them to whip him ^{15d}and then take him away and crucify him.

^{15c}Then he ordered his soldiers to beat Jesus with a whip ^{15d}and nail him to a cross. (CEV)

Mark 15:16

Section 15:16–20: The Roman soldiers mocked Jesus

The events of this section occurred immediately after the soldiers whipped Jesus in 15:15. One crime that the Jewish leaders accused Jesus of was that he claimed to be the king of the Jews (see Luke 23:2 and John 19:12). The soldiers did not believe Jesus was a king, so they mocked him by pretending that he was a king. They gave him a robe like a king’s robe and a crown of thorns in place of a king’s crown. They greeted him like a king, and they bowed before him in false honor. At the same time they treated him cruelly and shamefully by striking him on the head and spitting on him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus was mocked by Roman soldiers

The soldiers mistreated/mockd Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:27–31 and John 19:2–3.

Paragraph 15:16–20

The place where Pilate met with Jesus and the Jewish leaders (15:1–15) was probably in the public square in front of the palace. The events in this paragraph happened inside the palace. The Roman governor, Pontius Pilate, lived in the palace when he was in Jerusalem. He also used this palace as his headquarters when he was there.

15:16a

Then the soldiers led Jesus away into the palace

- ¶ The soldiers took Jesus into the palace

- ¶ Then Pilate's soldiers led Jesus as a prisoner/captive into the courtyard of the governor's/royal house.

The part of the story that is in 15:16–20 began immediately after the part of the story in 15:1–15.

Then: In some languages, it is natural to begin a new part of a story with a time word or phrase. For example:

But before they crucified Jesus

In other languages, a time word or phrase may not be necessary. Introduce this story in a natural way in your language.

the soldiers: The phrase the soldiers probably refers to the soldiers in 15:15d. Pilate had given Jesus to these soldiers to be crucified (though they were not specifically mentioned there). If you have not mentioned soldiers in 15:15, you may want to introduce them here in a general way. For example:

Some soldiers

His/Pilate's soldiers

led Jesus away: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as led...away here means to lead someone from one place to another. This was done as part of the legal process (The person was led to trial, to punishment/prison, or to execution). If possible, use a word that can describe leading a prisoner or captive by force or leading him toward punishment.

into the palace: The Greek word that the BSB translates as palace can refer to the palace building itself. Or it can refer to a courtyard inside the palace compound. This scene probably took place in the large inner courtyard of the palace compound.

You can translate this either as:

the palace (NIV)

the courtyard of the palace (GW)

palace: A palace is a large, beautiful house that a king or other high official lives in.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

governor's/king's house

royal house

15:16b (that is, the Praetorium)

- where the governor lived,
- That place was the government headquarters.

(that is, the Praetorium): The phrase that is, the Praetorium identifies which palace was meant in 15:16a. The BSB puts this phrase in parentheses to show that it is background information.

Praetorium: The Greek word that the BSB transliterates as Praetorium is a borrowed Latin word. It refers to the residence and headquarters of a Roman governor. The Praetorium also had barracks where the governor's soldiers stayed.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

where the governor stayed/lived

in which the governor, Pilate, stayed

of the governor/leader

That place/building was the government headquarters.

15:16c and called the whole company together.

- and summoned the whole battalion/troop.
- Then they told/called all of the rest of the soldiers to come.

and called the whole company together: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as called...together here means that the soldiers asked or told other soldiers to come and gather together.

the whole company: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the whole company refers to a group/troop of about six hundred soldiers. Here it probably refers to all the soldiers of the company who were on duty and were there at that moment. It probably does not indicate that all six hundred soldiers were called. Translate this with a word in your language that refers to a large group of soldiers.

Some soldiers of the company did the calling. So it may be more natural in some languages to say that they called together the other soldiers. For example:

the rest of the company (GNT)

the other soldiers in their troop/group

General Comment on 15:16c

In some languages it may be natural to express this with direct speech. For example:

...and said to other soldiers in their troop/group,
“Come here.”

Mark 15:17

Section 15:16–20: The Roman soldiers mocked Jesus

The events of this section occurred immediately after the soldiers whipped Jesus in 15:15. One crime that the Jewish leaders accused Jesus of was that he claimed to be the king of the Jews (see Luke 23:2 and John 19:12). The soldiers did not believe Jesus was a king, so they mocked him by pretending that he was a king. They gave him a robe like a king's robe and a crown of thorns in place of a king's crown. They greeted him like a king, and they bowed before him in false honor. At the same time they treated him cruelly and shamefully by striking him on the head and spitting on him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus was mocked by Roman soldiers

The soldiers mistreated/mockered Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:27–31 and John 19:2–3.

Paragraph 15:16–20

The place where Pilate met with Jesus and the Jewish leaders (15:1–15) was probably in the public square in front of the palace. The events in this paragraph happened inside the palace. The Roman governor, Pontius Pilate, lived in the palace when he was in Jerusalem. He also used this palace as his headquarters when he was there.

15:17–19

In these verses, the soldiers were cruel to Jesus and mocked his kingship. However, mockery is not explicitly mentioned until 15:20. The mockery included:

1. dressing Jesus in a purple robe (15:17a)
2. placing a crown of thorns on his head (15:17b)
3. crying out “Hail, King of the Jews” (15:18)
4. bowing before him (15:19b).

If people might not understand these actions as mockery, consider making the idea of mockery explicit in each action. For example:

they mocked him by dressing him in a purple/
royal robe

they dressed him in a purple robe to pretend he
was a king

15:17a

They dressed Him in a purple robe,

- They dressed Jesus in a red/purple robe.
- The soldiers placed a robe on Jesus pretending it was a royal/king's robe to mock him.

Mark 15:20c says that the soldiers put Jesus' clothes on him. But Mark never says when they took off his clothes. Matthew 27:28 mentions that the soldiers first took Jesus' clothes off before they put the purple robe on him. Consider if it may be necessary or more natural in your language to mention this here.

They dressed Him in a purple robe: A purple robe was a type of outer garment or coat that kings wore. The robe was dyed a purple color. These clothes generally cost a lot of money because the material and the purple dye were expensive. The soldiers put a purple robe on Jesus in mockery of his kingship.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Translate it literally. For example:

purple robe/coat

- Use a cultural substitute. If there is an expensive piece of clothing from your culture that people of high status wear, you could use it here. You should say that the color of the clothing was purple. If you translate in this way, you may want to include a footnote to explain the significance of the color. For example:

Purple clothing was very expensive and was commonly worn by kings. The soldiers dressed Jesus in purple in mockery of the idea that he was a king.

- If the color purple is difficult to translate, you could translate this simply as a “royal robe” and not translate the color. Most likely, the robe was not an actual royal robe, but a robe put on Jesus which imitated a royal robe. For example:

they put a robe on him in place/imitation of a royal robe

they put a robe on him as if it were a royal robe

they put a robe on him pretending it was a royal robe

purple: The Greek word that the BSB translates as purple describes a color that could either be dark red or dark blue. (Purple is a color between red and blue).

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Use a term that describes the color that is closest to dark red or dark blue. For example:

a kind of blue/black/red

like blue/black/red If you have to choose between red and blue, choose red. See Matthew 27:28, which describes the robe as being red or scarlet.

- Use a term that describes the color of something known in your culture that is dark red or dark blue. For example, a flower, berry, or bird.

15:17b

twisted together a crown of thorns,

- Then they twisted/wove thorn branches together into the shape of a crown,
- They also made a circle of thorny branches as if it were what a king would wear on his head

twisted together a crown of thorns: The soldiers made a mock crown for Jesus out of small branches or twigs. These branches had sharp thorns. The Greek word that the BSB translates as twisted together indicates that the soldiers wove or braided the branches together.

crown: A crown is a type of hat that kings wear. It is a symbol of the king's authority. Roman crowns were often made of leafy branches woven together into a circle. Some crowns were made of gold and were shaped like leafy branches.

If you do not have a specific word in your language for crown, you could say:

they...wove together some branches with thorns in a circle like a king's hat/headpiece

they...made something like what a king wears on his head out of thorny branches that were twisted together

15:17c

and set it on His head.

- and they placed it/them on his head.
- and put it on Jesus' head.

and set it on His head: The phrase set it on His head indicates that the soldiers placed the crown of thorns on Jesus' head.

Mark 15:18

Section 15:16–20: The Roman soldiers mocked Jesus

The events of this section occurred immediately after the soldiers whipped Jesus in 15:15. One crime that the Jewish leaders accused Jesus of was that he claimed to be the king of the Jews (see Luke 23:2 and John 19:12). The soldiers did not believe Jesus was a king, so they mocked him by pretending that he was a king. They gave him a robe like a king's robe and a crown of thorns in place of a king's crown. They greeted him like a king, and they bowed before him in false honor. At the same time they treated him cruelly and shamefully by striking him on the head and spitting on him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus was mocked by Roman soldiers

The soldiers mistreated/mockd Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:27–31 and John 19:2–3.

Paragraph 15:16–20

The place where Pilate met with Jesus and the Jewish leaders (15:1–15) was probably in the public square in front of the palace. The events in this paragraph happened inside the palace. The Roman governor, Pontius Pilate, lived in the palace when he was in Jerusalem. He also used this palace as his headquarters when he was there.

15:18a

And they began to salute Him:

- Then they began to greet him,
- They pretended to honor him, greeting him like a king,

they began to salute Him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as began means that the soldiers started greeting Jesus in a mocking way. Then they continued doing this over a period of time. In this context it does not imply that the soldiers began to call out but did not finish calling out to him.

Here is another way to translate this idea:

Then they repeatedly called out to him

You may also follow versions like the NLT96 that leave this idea implicit:

Then they saluted, yelling, “Hail! King of the Jews!” (NLT96)

to salute: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as to salute means “to greet.” Here it refers to formal words of greeting spoken to a king.

15:18b

“Hail, King of the Jews!”

- “Be blessed/happy, you who are the king of the Jews!”
- “Long live the king who rules the Jews!”

Hail, King of the Jews!: The soldiers said Hail, King of the Jews! to imitate how people would greet the Roman emperor. People greeted the emperor like this to wish him health and happiness. The soldiers spoke these words to mock Jesus.

If you have an expression that you use in your language to greet a king or some other important person, consider using it here. A common phrase used in Europe to greet a king would be something like “Long live the king!”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

King of the Jews, we greet you!

Honor to you, O King of the Jews!

Mark 15:19

Section 15:16–20: The Roman soldiers mocked Jesus
The events of this section occurred immediately after the soldiers whipped Jesus in 15:15. One crime that the Jewish leaders accused Jesus of was that he claimed to be the king of the Jews (see Luke 23:2 and John 19:12). The soldiers did not believe Jesus was a king, so they mocked him by pretending that he was a king. They gave him a robe like a king’s robe and a crown

of thorns in place of a king’s crown. They greeted him like a king, and they bowed before him in false honor. At the same time they treated him cruelly and shamefully by striking him on the head and spitting on him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus was mocked by Roman soldiers

The soldiers mistreated/mockd Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:27–31 and John 19:2–3.

Paragraph 15:16–20

The place where Pilate met with Jesus and the Jewish leaders (15:1–15) was probably in the public square in front of the palace. The events in this paragraph happened inside the palace. The Roman governor, Pontius Pilate, lived in the palace when he was in Jerusalem. He also used this palace as his headquarters when he was there.

15:19a–c

The form of the Greek verbs in this verse (“struck,” “spit,” and “paid homage”) indicates repeated action. Probably many different soldiers did each of these things. Translate this verse in a natural way in your language that indicates that all of these actions were done many times. Here are some ways to do this in English:

Again and again (NIV)

kept beating...and spitting...and kneeling and bowing (NASB)

one after another they struck...spit...and bowed

Some languages may use repetition. For example:

They beat him and beat him on his head...they spit on him and spit on him...

15:19a

They kept striking His head with a staff

- They repeatedly struck his head with a heavy/strong reed,

- Then one after another, they beat/hit him on the/his head with a cane/stick many times.

They kept striking His head with a staff: This clause indicates that the soldiers took a staff and hit Jesus' head with it many times.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

They kept hitting him on the head with a stick (GW)

The soldiers beat Jesus on the head many times with a stick. (NCV)

a staff: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a staff generally refers to a reed. The reeds in Israel are like a stick or cane. They have a hollow stalk similar to bamboo. So this staff was something that was neither solid wood nor a fragile reed that broke easily. To make this clear you may want to translate it as:

a strong/heavy reed

a cane/stick

15:19b and spitting on Him.

- spit on him,
- They also spit on him many times to insult him,

spitting on Him: In Jewish culture, spitting on a person was one of the worst ways to insult him. It was an attempt to cause him to feel completely worthless. If spitting on someone does not mean this in your culture, you may need to make this explicit:

spitting on him to insult him

We are not told which part of Jesus' body the soldiers spat on. If you must state a specific body part, you can say his face or his head.

15:19c And they knelt down and bowed before Him.

- got on their knees and bowed down to him.
- and they bowed down to him pretending to honor/worship him.

And they knelt down: The phrase And they knelt down means that the soldiers purposely got on their knees. They did not stumble and fall by accident. They did this to pretend to honor Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Falling on their knees (NIV11)

bowing on their knees (NCV)

bowed down to him

and bowed before Him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates with the English idiom bowed here means "bowed down in order to show honor to someone." This verb is often translated as "worshipped." In this context it refers to the way people honored kings and emperors. The soldiers mimicked or imitated this action in order to mock Jesus.

Here the soldiers were only pretending to honor Jesus. In some languages it may be necessary to include this implied information. For example:

as though they were honoring him

to pretend to honor him as king

General Comment on 15:19c

Here Mark described both the posture of the soldiers (kneeling) and the function of that gesture (bowing down). It is possible to have one expression that describes both the posture and function at the same time.

Mark 15:20

Section 15:16–20: The Roman soldiers mocked Jesus

The events of this section occurred immediately after the soldiers whipped Jesus in 15:15. One crime that the Jewish leaders accused Jesus of was that he claimed to be the king of the Jews (see Luke 23:2 and John 19:12). The soldiers did not believe Jesus was a king, so they mocked him by pretending that he was a king. They gave him a robe like a king's robe and a crown of thorns in place of a king's crown. They greeted him like a king, and they bowed before him in false honor. At the same time they treated him cruelly and shamefully by striking him on the head and spitting on him.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus was mocked by Roman soldiers

The soldiers mistreated/mockled Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:27–31 and John 19:2–3.

Paragraph 15:16–20

The place where Pilate met with Jesus and the Jewish leaders (15:1–15) was probably in the public square in front of the palace. The events in this paragraph happened inside the palace. The Roman governor, Pontius Pilate, lived in the palace when he was in Jerusalem. He also used this palace as his headquarters when he was there.

15:20a

After they had mocked Him,

- When they had mocked/ridiculed him,
- After they had finished mocking him,

After they had mocked Him: The phrase After they had mocked him in this context means “and when they had finished mocking him.” Some English versions make this clear. For example:

And when they had finished making fun of him
(NJB)

mocked: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mocked means “ridiculed” or “made fun of” Jesus. Here the soldiers mocked Jesus to humiliate and shame him.

This word also occurs in 10:34a.

15:20b

they removed the purple robe

- they took the red/purple robe off of him
- they removed the royal/king’s robe from him

15:20c

and put His own clothes back on Him.

- and put his own clothes back on him.
- and dressed him in his own clothes again.

15:20b–c

they removed the purple robe and put His own clothes back on Him: The phrase put His own clothes back on him implies that the soldiers had previously taken off Jesus’ clothes. Matthew 27:28 indicates that they did this before they put the royal robe on him.

In some languages, it may be natural to say that the soldiers took Jesus’ clothes off before saying that they put them back on him. See the note on 15:17a.

15:20d

Then they led Him out to crucify Him.

- Then they led him out of the palace in order to kill/execute him on a cross.
- Then they made him go out to the place where they would nail/fasten him to a cross to die.

they led Him out: As in 15:1c and 15:16a, your verb for led should describe leading a prisoner or captive.

In some languages, it may be necessary to say from where the soldiers led Jesus out. If so, you could say that they led him out of the palace. For example, the NCV says:

they led him out of the palace to be crucified.
(NCV)

they: The pronoun they here refers to the Roman soldiers responsible for crucifying Jesus. Generally four soldiers plus one officer (a centurion) were responsible for crucifying someone. The pronoun does not refer to the whole company of soldiers that took part in mocking Jesus in 15:16–20.

to crucify Him: The word crucify means to execute (kill) someone by nailing or tying him to a cross, then setting the cross upright. This was a Roman way to cause criminals to die a slow and painful death.

Here are some other ways to translate crucify him:

to kill/execute him on a cross

to nail/fasten him to a cross to kill him

See the note on “crucify” at 15:13.

Mark 15:21

Section 15:21–32: The soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross

In this section, Jesus was crucified. This is the climax of the book of Mark. Three times Jesus had predicted these events (8:31, 9:31, and 10:33–34). Now they really happened. Mark has presented Jesus as the Messiah and King who the prophets in the Old Testament predicted would come. By dying on the cross, Jesus did what the Messiah had to do to save his people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The soldiers fastened Jesus to a cross to kill him

Jesus was executed on a cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:32–44, Luke 23:26–43, and John 19:17–27.

15:21

This verse introduces a new character in the story (Simon). It gives some details about him and tells what he did. See the General Comment on 15:21a–b at the end of 15:21b for suggestions on how to change the order of the information in this verse.

15:21a

Now Simon of Cyrene, the father of Alexander and Rufus, was passing by on his way in from the country,

- ¶ There was a certain man named Simon who was from Cyrene. (He was the father of Alexander and Rufus.) At that moment, he was coming into the city from the rural area outside of it.
- ¶ As they were going out of the city, a man was by chance coming into it. His name was Simon, the father of Alexander and Rufus. He was from the city of Cyrene.

Verse 15:21a introduces Simon and gives several details about him. Some English versions (for example, the GNT) place some of these details in parentheses to show that they are background information. Translate this information in a way and in an order that is natural in your language.

Now Simon of Cyrene: This is the first (and only) mention of this Simon in Mark. Consider how you would naturally introduce a new person into the story in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

There was a certain man. His name was Simon. He came from the town of Cyrene.

There was a certain man from Cyrene named Simon.

At that moment a man named Simon was passing by. He was from Cyrene.

of Cyrene: Cyrene is the name of a city. It was on the coast of north Africa in what is present-day Libya. Simon was of Cyrene in the sense that it was his home town.

the father of Alexander and Rufus: Mark mentioned that Simon was the father of Alexander and Rufus.

He probably included this information because he expected his readers to know these men.

was passing by: The verb was passing by indicates that Simon was by chance walking by. He was walking by at the time when the soldiers were looking for someone to carry Jesus' cross. He was not part of the group that went out with Jesus toward the place where Jesus was crucified.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Simon...happened to be coming in (CEV)

Simon...was coming in from the country just then. (NLT96)

Simon...was on his way in from the country and was there by chance/accident.

on his way in from the country: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as on his way in from the country is literally “coming from (the) field/countryside.” Here it means that Simon was coming into the city from the rural area outside of it. Try to use a general expression that indicates that he was coming from an area that was not a “town” or “city.”

In some languages, you may want to say that he was coming “into the city.” If you do, it may not be necessary to explicitly translate the phrase from the country.

15:21b

and the soldiers forced him to carry the cross of Jesus.

- The soldiers forced him/Simon to carry the cross.
- The soldiers ordered him to carry the cross to the place where they would crucify Jesus.
- The soldiers ordered him, “Take^(sing) this cross and carry it!”

and the soldiers forced him to carry the cross of Jesus:

It was the custom for Roman soldiers to force a criminal to carry his own cross. Jesus started to carry his cross (see John 19:17), but it is implied that he became too tired to carry it any further. You may want to explain this in a footnote. For example:

Jesus carried the cross first (see John 19:17). When he could not carry it any further, the soldiers forced Simon to carry it. Roman soldiers had a legal right to command anyone to carry something for them.

forced him to carry: The Greek word that the BSB translates as forced refers to the authority that soldiers could use to force someone to carry something for them. Some English versions translate this word with a specific military term. For example:

drafted (NET)

enlisted (NJB)

pressed into service (NASB)

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase forced him to carry:

ordered him to carry

forced/caused him to carry against his will

In some languages it may be natural to translate the idea of forced him to carry as direct speech. For example:

...and they ordered him, “You, take this cross and carry it for this man.”

the cross: A cross refers to two large wooden boards or beams that were attached to each other. Roman soldiers used crosses to kill criminals. They nailed or tied a criminal to these wooden beams, then set them upright. They did this in order to cause the criminal to die slowly and painfully.

The word cross comes from the fact that the beams were crossed and attached. This made the shape of a + or † (or sometimes a T).

In many languages there may be no word for cross. If that is true in your language, you may need to use a descriptive phrase. For example:

board/wood of death

crossed-beam(s) of death

a tree for killing people

a stake/plank to which they fasten/nail someone to kill him

See how you translated cross at 8:34d.

General Comment on 15:21a–b

This verse contains (a) some background information about Simon and (b) a main event in the story. The BSB gives the background information first. In other languages it may be more natural to state what happened first and then to give the background information.

Here are some examples of ways to order the information in this verse:

And they compelled a passer-by, Simon of Cyrene, who was coming in from the country, the father of Alexander and Rufus, to carry his cross. (RSV)

They ordered a man named Simon to carry the cross for Jesus. This Simon was from Cyrene and was the father of Alexander and Rufus. He was just coming into town from the rural area at that moment.

On the way they met a man named Simon, who was coming into the city from the country, and the soldiers forced him to carry Jesus’ cross. (Simon was from Cyrene and was the father of Alexander and Rufus.) (GNT)

Mark 15:22

Section 15:21–32: The soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross

In this section, Jesus was crucified. This is the climax of the book of Mark. Three times Jesus had predicted these events (8:31, 9:31, and 10:33–34). Now they really happened. Mark has presented Jesus as the Messiah and King who the prophets in the Old Testament predicted would come. By dying on the cross, Jesus did what the Messiah had to do to save his people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The soldiers fastened Jesus to a cross to kill him

Jesus was executed on a cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:32–44, Luke 23:26–43, and John 19:17–27.

15:22a

They brought Jesus to a place called Golgotha,

- They led Jesus to the place called Golgotha,
- They caused Jesus to go to the place that the Jews call Golgotha.

They brought Jesus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as brought here means “led” or “caused to go.”

to a place called Golgotha: Golgotha was the name (in the language of the Jews) of a place where the Romans often crucified criminals. It was probably a short distance outside the city walls. You should transliterate this name according to the sounds and letters in your language.

15:22b
which means The Place of the Skull.

- which means place of a/the skull.
- Its meaning/translation in our language is a/the skull place.

which means: The words which means introduce the translation or meaning of the word “Golgotha.” Use a natural way in your language to introduce the translation or meaning of something said in another language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

This means...

That name means in our^(incl) language...

Translated in our^(incl) language, that would be...

The Place of the Skull: Here are some other ways to translate this:

Skull Place

Skull Hill (NLT96)

It is not certain why this place was called The Place of the Skull. It may have been a small hill that had the shape of a skull. Or it may have been given this name simply because so many people had died there.

This should not be translated in a way that means that many skulls could be seen there.

Skull: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Skull refers to the bony upper part of the head. Use a word that refers to the head bone of a dead person.

Mark 15:23

Section 15:21–32: The soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross

In this section, Jesus was crucified. This is the climax of the book of Mark. Three times Jesus had predicted these events (8:31, 9:31, and 10:33–34). Now they really happened. Mark has presented Jesus as the Messiah and King who the prophets in the Old Testament predicted would come. By dying on the cross, Jesus did what the Messiah had to do to save his people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The soldiers fastened Jesus to a cross to kill him

Jesus was executed on a cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:32–44, Luke 23:26–43, and John 19:17–27.

15:23a

There they offered Him wine mixed with myrrh,

- Then they gave/offered him wine mixed with a medicine called myrrh,
- They tried to give Jesus some wine that had a medicine in it to dull/reduce the pain he would feel,

they offered Him wine: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as they offered Him wine means that some people attempted to give Jesus wine to drink. He did not actually drink it. The GNT translates this as:

they tried to give him wine

they: It is not clear whether they refers here to the soldiers or to someone else such as Jewish women. It is recommended that you leave this general if possible.

Here is another way to translate this:

there were those/people who...

If you must specify who they refers to, it is recommended that you say “the soldiers.” Scholars are divided in their opinion about this. Our translation advice follows the majority of English versions since “they” in English must refer to “the soldiers” in this context.

wine: The beverage called wine is an alcoholic drink. It is made from the juice of a fruit called grapes. When grape juice ferments, it becomes wine.

In some areas, people may not be familiar with grapes or with wine. If that is true in your area, some other ways to translate wine are:

- Use a general term for an alcoholic drink.
- Use a specific term that can also be used to refer to alcoholic drinks in general. For example:

millet beer

palm wine

something like palm wine

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

fruit juice/water

grape juice

fermented grape juice

See how you translated wine in 2:22a.

mixed with myrrh: The word myrrh refers to the sap of a kind of tree. It had many uses and was very valuable. When myrrh was mixed with wine, it probably acted like a medicine to reduce pain. Some ways to translate myrrh are:

- Transliterate the word according to the sounds of your language. For example:

mur

muri

- Transliterate the word and add a descriptive phrase. For example:

a medicine/drug called mur

- Use only a descriptive phrase. For example:

a medicine

a drug (CEV)

Most people will not understand the purpose of myrrh. Here are some other ways to explain the purpose in your translation:

- Make the purpose explicit in the text. For example:

wine mixed with myrrh so he would not feel so much pain

wine that had been mixed with a medicine that reduces/stops the pain called myrrh

- Explain the purpose in a footnote. The footnote could say:

The myrrh and wine together acted as a medicine to reduce the pain of the person who was crucified.

15:23b

but He did not take it.

- but he did/would not drink it.
- but he refused to drink it.

He did not take it: The phrase He did not take it indicates that Jesus refused to drink the wine mixed with myrrh. According to Matthew 27:34, he took a taste of the wine and then refused to drink it. If possible, translate the phrase here in a way that allows for the fact that Jesus tasted the wine but did not drink it.

Mark 15:24

Section 15:21–32: The soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross

In this section, Jesus was crucified. This is the climax of the book of Mark. Three times Jesus had predicted these events (8:31, 9:31, and 10:33–34). Now they really happened. Mark has presented Jesus as the Messiah and King who the prophets in the Old Testament predicted would come. By dying on the cross, Jesus did what the Messiah had to do to save his people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The soldiers fastened Jesus to a cross to kill him

Jesus was executed on a cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:32–44, Luke 23:26–43, and John 19:17–27.

15:24a**And they crucified Him.**

- Then they nailed him to the cross.
- They fastened him with nails to the cross, and stood it up and waited for him to die on it.

they crucified Him: The clause they crucified him means that the soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross. They did this to kill him. This was a Roman method of execution that was slow and painful.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

they nailed him to the cross

they nailed him to the cross to kill him

The way you translate “crucify” should not imply that Jesus died at the moment that they nailed him to the cross.

After the soldiers nailed Jesus to the cross, they raised the cross to a standing position. Consider if it may be helpful to make this explicit in your translation. See how you translated “crucify” at 15:13 and 15:20d.

15:24b**They also divided His garments**

- They shared his clothes among them.
- They decided who would get which items of his clothing

They also divided His garments: The clause They also divided His garments here means that the soldiers decided who would get the different items of Jesus’ clothing. It does not mean that they tore his clothes into pieces and distributed the pieces among themselves.

It was a Roman custom that the soldiers who crucified a criminal had the right to take his clothes for themselves. Jesus’ clothing included an outer robe, a tunic (a shirt worn under the robe), and probably also a belt and sandals.

15:24c**by casting lots to decide what each of them would take.**

- They did this by selecting by chance who would get which clothes.
- by playing a game of chance.

by casting lots: The clause by casting lots indicates that the soldiers threw small objects (possibly dice) on the ground. Then they looked at the way these things fell. They did this to decide which soldier would get

which item of Jesus’ clothing. For example, the GW says:

they divided his clothes among themselves by throwing dice to see what each one would get

If you have a similar way to choose something by chance, consider using it here. If not, you could say something general like:

They selected by chance

They played a game of luck

to decide what each of them would take: The phrase to decide what each of them would take here means “in order to decide which soldier would receive which item of clothing.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to determine who would win which piece/item of his clothes

to decide what each of them should take

General Comment on 15:24b–c

The meaning of “to see what each would get” (15:24c) is similar to the meaning of “dividing up his clothes” (15:24b). In some languages it will be natural to combine these phrases. For example:

They decided/chose who would get which item of his clothing by casting lots.

They cast lots to determine/choose which one of them would take each item of Jesus’ clothing.

Mark 15:25**Section 15:21–32: The soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross**

In this section, Jesus was crucified. This is the climax of the book of Mark. Three times Jesus had predicted these events (8:31, 9:31, and 10:33–34). Now they really happened. Mark has presented Jesus as the Messiah and King who the prophets in the Old Testament predicted would come. By dying on the cross, Jesus did what the Messiah had to do to save his people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The soldiers fastened Jesus to a cross to kill him

Jesus was executed on a cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:32–44, Luke 23:26–43, and John 19:17–27.

15:25

It was the third hour when they crucified Him.

- ¶ It was three hours after sunrise when they crucified him.
- ¶ They nailed him/Jesus to the cross at 9:00 a.m.

It was the third hour: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as the third hour refers to 9:00 a.m. According to the Jewish way of keeping time, the day began with sunrise (6:00 a.m.). So the third hour was 9:00 a.m.

You may have a specific term in your language for this time of day. If not, here are some other ways you can translate this:

in the middle of the morning

when the sun was halfway up

about three hours after sunrise

It was nine o'clock in the morning. (GNT)

when they crucified Him: The word crucified is the same word as in 15:24a. Translate it here as you did there.

Mark 15:26

Section 15:21–32: The soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross

In this section, Jesus was crucified. This is the climax of the book of Mark. Three times Jesus had predicted these events (8:31, 9:31, and 10:33–34). Now they really happened. Mark has presented Jesus as the Messiah and King who the prophets in the Old Testament predicted would come. By dying on the cross, Jesus did what the Messiah had to do to save his people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The soldiers fastened Jesus to a cross to kill him

Jesus was executed on a cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:32–44, Luke 23:26–43, and John 19:17–27.

15:26a

And the charge inscribed against Him read:

- The writing/words that told the crime that he was accused of doing was/said:
- There was a sign attached to the cross on which was written the accusation against him. It said/read:
- The soldiers put a sign/board on the cross over Jesus' head. It said/gave the reason that he was being crucified. These words were written on the board:

And the charge inscribed against Him read: The Greek word that the BSB translates as charge literally means “writing.” Here this word refers to the “writing” that was inscribed on a sign. The Romans had the custom of attaching a sign to the cross. On the sign someone wrote the crime for which the person was being punished.

In some languages, it may be helpful to first say something about the sign and where it was attached. (For example, Matthew 27:37 says that the sign was put over Jesus' head.) You may want to do this before you give the words that were written on it. For example:

There was a sign with this charge against Jesus written on it: (NCV)

A signboard was fastened to the cross above Jesus' head, announcing the charge against him. (NLT96)

The soldiers attached a sign to the cross. It stated the charge against Jesus:

the charge...against Him: The phrase the charge...against Him here means “what he/Jesus was accused of doing wrong.” It refers to the type of crime for which he was being punished. Jesus claimed to be the Messiah and king. This was considered an act of rebellion against Rome.

Here are some other ways you could translate the charge...against Him:

the crime that he had done

what he was accused of doing wrong

what bad/wrong thing that they believed that he had done

why he was nailed there (CEV)

You may want to include a footnote to explain why Jesus' claim to be king was a crime against Rome. For example:

The Romans had one supreme ruler who was called Caesar. Caesar appointed or allowed kings to rule over certain provinces under his authority. A claim to be king without Caesar's permission would be interpreted as rebellion against Rome.

read: The word read here introduces what was written on the sign.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the sign said:

the charge/crime was:

on the sign these words were written:

15:26b

THE KING OF THE JEWS.

- "The king of/over the Jews."
- "The ruler/chief of the Jewish people."

THE KING OF THE JEWS: See how you translated this phrase at 15:2a. If it is better in your language to express this as a complete sentence, you could say:

This person/man is the king of the Jews.

Mark 15:27

Section 15:21–32: The soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross

In this section, Jesus was crucified. This is the climax of the book of Mark. Three times Jesus had predicted these events (8:31, 9:31, and 10:33–34). Now they really happened. Mark has presented Jesus as the Messiah and King who the prophets in the Old Testament predicted would come. By dying on the cross, Jesus did what the Messiah had to do to save his people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The soldiers fastened Jesus to a cross to kill him

Jesus was executed on a cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:32–44, Luke 23:26–43, and John 19:17–27.

15:27a

Along with Jesus, they crucified two robbers,

- They nailed two men who were violent robbers to other crosses near Jesus.
- On each side of Jesus, the soldiers also nailed/fastened to crosses two other men. Those men had robbed people using violence.

Along with Jesus, they crucified two robbers: The clause Along with Jesus, they crucified two robbers means that the soldiers nailed a robber to a cross on each side of Jesus. The two robbers were on their own crosses near Jesus. They were not all crucified on the same cross.

robbers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as robbers refers to people who steal from other people in a violent manner. An alternative interpretation prominent in the commentaries is to understand the word translated "robbers" (λῃστές) as "insurrectionist/rebel." This makes good sense in context, but none of the English versions consulted translated in this way, maybe due to the strong translation tradition connected to this passage. If you have more than one word for "robber," use a word that describes a dangerous robber. This kind of robber may hurt people when he steals from them. Do not use a word that describes someone who secretly steals small things.

15:27b

one on His right and one on His left.

- They put/placed one on/to the right side of Jesus, and they put/placed the other one on/to the left side of Jesus.
- They nailed one of them to a cross on the right of Jesus, and they nailed the other man/robber to another cross on the left of Jesus.

one on His right and one on His left: In some languages it may be necessary to repeat your word or phrase for "crucified." For example:

They nailed one man/robber to a cross and placed it to the right of Jesus, and they nailed one man/robber to a cross and placed it to the left of Jesus.

In some languages it may be more natural to say “one on each side of Jesus” instead of one on His right and one on His left.

Mark 15:28

Section 15:21–32: The soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross

In this section, Jesus was crucified. This is the climax of the book of Mark. Three times Jesus had predicted these events (8:31, 9:31, and 10:33–34). Now they really happened. Mark has presented Jesus as the Messiah and King who the prophets in the Old Testament predicted would come. By dying on the cross, Jesus did what the Messiah had to do to save his people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The soldiers fastened Jesus to a cross to kill him

Jesus was executed on a cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:32–44, Luke 23:26–43, and John 19:17–27.

15:28

[Most English versions do not translate this verse. See the Notes on 15:28.]

There is a textual issue here. Only some Greek manuscripts include 15:28. It is good to include this verse only as a footnote, as many English versions do. Here is an example footnote:

Only some Greek manuscripts include 15:28, which says: “And the Scripture was fulfilled which says, ‘And He was numbered with transgressors.’”

If the major language version in your area includes this verse in the text, you may want to include it in brackets. This is what the NASB does.

If you put 15:28 in a footnote, here are several ways to number the verses:

- Put the number 28 after the number 27. For example, the CEV says:

²⁷⁻²⁸The soldiers also nailed two criminals on crosses, one to the right of Jesus and the other to his left.

- Put in the number 28 after the last word of 15:27, and have the footnote marker after it. For example, the NCV says:

²⁷They also put two robbers on crosses beside Jesus, one on the right, and the other on the left.

²⁸ ‡ ²⁹People walked by...

- Do not include the number 28. Put the footnote after verse 27. For example, the GW says:

²⁷They crucified two criminals with him, one on his right and the other on his left. ‡ ²⁹Those who passed by insulted him.

Because you may need to translate the words of this verse, consider the following notes. (The words cited below are taken from the footnote that the BSB provides for this verse.)

So the Scripture was fulfilled that says: The clause the Scripture...that says refers to a passage in the Old Testament that Isaiah had written (Isaiah 53:12). The clause the Scripture was fulfilled means that this scripture was a prophecy. It predicted something that would happen in the future, and the event that it prophesied was now happening.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The Scripture became true which says

The Scripture was happening which says

The thing/event that the Scripture said would happen was now happening

the Scripture: Here the Scripture refers to a specific sentence in the Old Testament.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the sacred writing/word/words

this word that Isaiah wrote in God’s book

this part of God’s word/message

And He: In the passage in Isaiah, He refers to the servant of the Lord. Here the servant of the Lord is identified with Jesus. However, it is important to keep the pronoun in this quotation. Do not translate He

here as “Jesus.” The pronoun you use should be able to refer both to Jesus and to the servant of the Lord.

was numbered with the transgressors: The phrase was numbered with the transgressors means “was counted/considered a law-breaker” or “was considered to be of the group of those who broke the law of God.” He was both considered a lawbreaker and, as a result, treated as one. Your translation could focus on either aspect. For example:

He was considered a criminal. (CEV from Luke 22:37)

He was treated like a criminal. (NCV from Luke 22:37)

He shared the fate of criminals. (GNT from Luke 22:37)

If you need to change the passive verb into an active verb, you should use a very general subject. For example:

People/they considered/counted him a law-breaker.

the transgressors: The Greek word here translated as the transgressors means “law-breakers” or “those who break the law of God.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

those who break the law

those who are not concerned to keep/obey the law of God

criminals

This word is similar in meaning to “sinners.” In some languages it may not be easy to find two terms, one for “sinner” and one for “those who break the law of God.” If that is true in your language, you could use the same term for both.

General Comment on 15:28

Here are some ways to translate this verse:

And the part of the sacred writings that says “He was considered a law-breaker” became true.

This word that Isaiah, the prophet, wrote in God’s book was happening: “He was treated as a criminal.”

God’s word said “People counted him as a law-breaker.” This thing was now happening just as God’s word said that it would.

Mark 15:29

Section 15:21–32: The soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross

In this section, Jesus was crucified. This is the climax of the book of Mark. Three times Jesus had predicted these events (8:31, 9:31, and 10:33–34). Now they really happened. Mark has presented Jesus as the Messiah and King who the prophets in the Old Testament predicted would come. By dying on the cross, Jesus did what the Messiah had to do to save his people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The soldiers fastened Jesus to a cross to kill him

Jesus was executed on a cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:32–44, Luke 23:26–43, and John 19:17–27.

15:29a

And those who passed by heaped abuse on Him,

- Those who passed/walked by were insulting Jesus
- Those who by chance walked past/near the place said insulting/bad/terrible things about him/Jesus.

And those who passed by: The clause those who passed by refers to people who by chance were walking by the place where Jesus was crucified. They did not come to watch the crucifixion on purpose.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

people who walked by

those who happened to pass/walk by the cross at that moment

heaped abuse on Him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as the English idiom heaped abuse on Him means “to speak evil of him.” (This verb often refers to speaking against God, but can also refer to speaking

against a person. The Greek word is *βλασφημέω* and is primarily used in Scripture of speech against God. Some commentators (Edwards page 473, for example) see divine overtones here.) An example of the words these people spoke against Jesus are given in 15:29c–30.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

insulted him (GW)

said terrible things about Jesus (CEV)

The form of the Greek verb for heaped abuse indicates that this action was repeated many times. Many people who walked by insulted Jesus. Consider using a verb form or another way in your language to indicate this. For example:

were insulting him

repeatedly insulted him

15:29b

shaking their heads and saying,

- by shaking their heads and saying,
- They shook their heads in mockery and said,

shaking their heads and saying: The phrase shaking their heads describes a gesture that indicates that the people were insulting Jesus. When Jews shook their heads, they showed that they did not respect the person whom they were looking at or talking to.

If people in your culture will not understand the meaning of this gesture, you could:

General Comment on 15:29a–b

- Translate it literally and include a footnote to explain the meaning. A sample footnote could be:

Jews “shook their heads” at a person to indicate that they considered that person very low/shameful and therefore did not respect them.

- Translate it in a way that makes the meaning clear. For example, the NLT says:

shaking their heads in mockery

- Translate only the meaning and not the gesture. For example:

and said in mockery

and said with scorn/disrespect

It may not be necessary or natural in your language to have two verbs of speaking, such as “insulted” (15:29a) and “said” (15:29b). These could be combined into one verb. Also the action “shaking their heads” (15:29b) could be placed either before or after the verb/verbs of speaking. For example, you could say:

Those who passed by shook their heads and insulted him, “So! You who are...”

15:29c–30

Aha! You who are going to destroy the temple and rebuild it in three days, come down from the cross and save Yourself!:

The people passing by said this to mock Jesus. It is based on something that Jesus had previously said. What he said was probably misunderstood by most people (see John 2:19–22 and Mark 14:58–59). This is the sense of the mockery:

1. You said you can do great miracles such as destroying the temple and rebuilding it in three days.
2. If you can do that, then do this: come down from the cross and save yourself.

These people did not believe that Jesus could do either (a) or (b). They believed that his being on the cross was proof that he did not have power to do great miracles.

Translate this in a natural way in your language to show that they were mocking Jesus. It should be clear that the people did not believe that he could do what they were telling him to do.

15:29c

“Aha! You who are going to destroy the temple

- “Ha! You^(sing) who said/claimed that you will destroy the temple
- “If you^(sing) can tear/break down the temple
- “You^(sing) said that you could destroy the holy building where God dwells

15:29d

and rebuild it in three days,

- and build it again in/within three days,
- and rebuild it in just three days’ time,
- and build it again in three days.

15:29c–d

Aha!: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Aha! is an exclamation that here expresses mocking or ridicule. If you have a word or expression in your language that expresses mocking or ridicule, consider

using it here. If you do not have such a word, you could leave this word untranslated.

You who are going to destroy the temple and rebuild it in three days: These words in Greek are spoken as a way to address Jesus. They are not a complete sentence in themselves but simply lead to the command to “come down....” It may be natural in your language to make this a separate sentence as a number of English versions have done. For example:

So you would destroy the Temple and rebuild it in three days! (NJB)

You were going to tear down the Temple and build it back up in three days! (GNT)

It is implied here that Jesus had said or claimed he would do this. You may want to make this explicit in your language:

You said you could destroy the Temple and build it again in three days. (NCV)

So you’re the one who claimed you could tear down the temple and build it again in three days. (CEV)

Didn’t you say that you would destroy the temple and build it in three days?

temple: The Greek word that the BSB translates as temple here refers to the main temple building. The main building was the holiest part of the temple. It was the part where God was present in a special way. Here are some other ways to translate the word temple:

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

house/building of God

house/place where God dwells

house/place where God is

holy/sacred house

- If your language has a word for “temple,” consider using it. But you may need to modify it. For example:

temple of the Lord

Be sure to use a different term from the one you have chosen for “synagogue.” There was only one temple, but there were many synagogues throughout the land of Israel where the Jews met regularly for worship.

See how you translated this term in 14:58b, where the same word occurs. See also temple, Meaning 2, in the Glossary for more information.

rebuild it: The temple had already been built when Jesus made this statement. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

build it again

put it back together again

in three days: The phrase in three days refers to how much time it would take Jesus to rebuild the temple. It does not mean that he would wait three days and then begin rebuilding the temple. Nor does it mean that he would wait three days and then rebuild it in an instant. See how you translated this at 14:58c.

Mark 15:30

Section 15:21–32: The soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross

In this section, Jesus was crucified. This is the climax of the book of Mark. Three times Jesus had predicted these events (8:31, 9:31, and 10:33–34). Now they really happened. Mark has presented Jesus as the Messiah and King who the prophets in the Old Testament predicted would come. By dying on the cross, Jesus did what the Messiah had to do to save his people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The soldiers fastened Jesus to a cross to kill him

Jesus was executed on a cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:32–44, Luke 23:26–43, and John 19:17–27.

15:30

come down from the cross and save Yourself!”

- save/rescue yourself by descending from the cross!”
- then save yourself from dying/death and climb down from the cross!”

- If you can do that, then come down from that cross! Save yourself!”

come down from the cross and save Yourself!”: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as come down means “descend.” Jesus was hanging above the ground on the cross.

The two clauses come down from the cross and save Yourself describe the same action. They are not two different actions. The action come down from the cross is more specifically what Jesus might do to save himself. Here are some other ways to express this:

...come down from the cross and so save yourself!

...save yourself by coming down from the cross!

...save yourself; that is, descend from the cross!

save: The Greek word that the BSB translates as save means to rescue someone from danger or trouble. In this context it means that Jesus should rescue himself from staying fastened to the cross and from death. It does not refer here to rescuing someone from the spiritual dangers of sin and the punishment that results from sin.

General Comment on 15:30

The order of this verse in Greek is literally: “save yourself coming down from the cross.” Some English versions, such as the BSB, have changed the order and placed “come down” before “save yourself.” Follow the order that is most natural in your language.

Mark 15:31

Section 15:21–32: The soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross
In this section, Jesus was crucified. This is the climax of the book of Mark. Three times Jesus had predicted these events (8:31, 9:31, and 10:33–34). Now they really happened. Mark has presented Jesus as the Messiah and King who the prophets in the Old Testament predicted would come. By dying on the cross, Jesus did what the Messiah had to do to save his people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The soldiers fastened Jesus to a cross to kill him

Jesus was executed on a cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:32–44, Luke 23:26–43, and John 19:17–27.

15:31a

In the same way, the chief priests and scribes mocked Him among themselves, saying,

- Likewise, the leading priests, together with the teachers of the Law of Moses, were mocking him to each other, saying,
- The elders among the sacrifice-makers and the experts in the law also mocked Jesus. They said

In the same way: The Greek word that the BSB translates as In the same way indicates that the Jewish leaders insulted and mocked Jesus just as the people walking by had done.

Here is another way to translate this word:

The leading priests and the teachers of the law were also making fun of Jesus. (NCV)

chief priests: A Jewish priest was a man who offered sacrifices to God on behalf of the people. He also performed other rituals for them. The phrase chief priests refers to the leaders among these priests.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the leading/ruling priests

the elders among the Jewish sacrificers

the most prominent priests

This term also occurs in 15:10.

scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes is sometimes translated as “teachers of the law” (as in the NIV). The original work of these men was to copy the laws of Moses by hand. In New Testament times, their main task was to study, interpret, and teach the law of Moses and related Jewish laws and traditions.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

teachers of the Law of Moses (CEV)

teachers of religious law (NLT)

teachers of the law of the Jews

the experts on the law

This word also occurs in 15:1b. See also teacher of the law in the Glossary for more information.

mocked Him among themselves, saying: The form of the Greek verbs that the Greek translates as mocked and saying indicates that the Jewish leaders repeatedly mocked Jesus. Consider using a verb form or another way in your language to indicate this. For example, the NRSV says:

the chief priests, along with the scribes, were also mocking him

among themselves: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as among themselves indicates that the Jewish leaders were speaking to one another as they mocked Jesus. However, it is likely that they spoke loud enough for Jesus to hear their words of mockery. The NCV has another way to translate this:

They said to each other...

saying: The BSB places the words saying in the middle of the quoted speech. In Greek, the verb translated as saying occurs before words that they said. Place this verb where it is natural in your language.

15:31b

“He saved others, but He cannot save Himself!

- “Other people he saved. Himself he cannot save.
- to one another, “He rescued others. But he cannot rescue himself.
- that he saved others but could not save himself.

“He saved others, but He cannot save Himself!: The Greek word that the BSB translates as saved and save has several meanings. It can mean “help,” “heal,” and “rescue/save.” The word saved in the clause He saved others can mean both “healed” and “rescued.” It refers to the times when Jesus healed the sick and raised the dead.

others, but He cannot save Himself!: In Greek, the words others and Himself are emphasized and contrasted. Literally it says: “others he saved, himself he cannot save.” Many English versions have supplied the conjunction but in order to indicate a contrast. Show the emphasis and contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

The word save in the clause He cannot save Himself means “rescue/save.” The leaders believed that he could not rescue himself from dying on the cross.

You should use a word that means “to save/rescue from death.” If you have a word that can be used both for rescuing (healing) someone from sickness and rescuing someone from death, it would be good to use it here.

Mark 15:32

Section 15:21–32: The soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross

In this section, Jesus was crucified. This is the climax of the book of Mark. Three times Jesus had predicted these events (8:31, 9:31, and 10:33–34). Now they really happened. Mark has presented Jesus as the Messiah and King who the prophets in the Old Testament predicted would come. By dying on the cross, Jesus did what the Messiah had to do to save his people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The soldiers fastened Jesus to a cross to kill him

Jesus was executed on a cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:32–44, Luke 23:26–43, and John 19:17–27.

15:32a–b

In 15:32a–b, the Jewish leaders continued to mock and insult Jesus. They were also being sarcastic. They did not actually want to see Jesus come down from the cross. They probably would not have believed on him if he had. Express this mockery and sarcasm in a way that is natural in your language.

15:32a

Let the Christ, the King of Israel, come down now from the cross,

- This one/man who is the Christ, the king of Israel, should come down now from the cross
- He says/claims that he is the Christ/Messiah and the king of the people of Israel. If he really is, then we want to see him climb down from the cross right now.

Let the Christ, the King of Israel, come down now from the cross: The Jewish leaders implied that Jesus falsely claimed to be the Christ. They also implied that if he really was the Christ, he should show his power and save himself by coming down from the cross. Their words seemed to indicate that they wanted to see him do that, but actually they did not want that. They wanted him to die on the cross.

In some languages it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

If he is really the Christ..., let him come down now from the cross. (NCV)

He claims/says that he is the Christ.... If this is true, we want to see him come down from the cross.

Didn't he say that he was the Christ...? Then he should come down now from the cross.

Let...come down: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Let...come down is an indirect command. In this context, it indicates that the leaders wanted Jesus to come down from the cross. They implied that "he should/must come down."

Notice that the word Let does not mean "allow" here. The leaders did not mean that someone should allow/permit Jesus to come down. Here are some other ways to translate this indirect command:

This Christ...should/must come down.

If we see him come down...

We want to see this Christ...come down.

In some languages it may be necessary to translate this phrase as a direct command to Jesus. For example:

You, Christ!...Come down from the cross.

the Christ, the King of Israel: The Greek titles that the BSB literally translates as the Christ, the King of Israel refer to Jesus. The two titles are related. That is, the Jews believed that the Christ would also be the king of Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

This man said that he was the Christ and the King of Israel.

If he is the Christ, and if he is the one who is also the King of Israel...

Christ: Here the religious leaders used the word Christ as a descriptive title for Jesus. This title refers to the

special person whom God appointed and promised to send as king and savior. The title Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word "Messiah," and the two words have the same meaning.

Some ways to translate Christ are:

- Transliterate it according to the sounds of your language. For example:

Krais

Karisiti

- Transliterate it and indicate in some way that it is a title. For example:

the Christ

the Kirisita

- Transliterate Christ and include a phrase that explains the meaning. For example:

Christ, the appointed one

Cristo, the savior God promised

the Christ who comes from God

If you do not indicate the meaning of Christ in the text, you may want to include a footnote. For example:

The word/title "Christ" refers to the King and Savior whom God had promised to send.

See how you translated the word "Christ" at 1:1 and 14:61c. See also Christ in the Glossary.

15:32b so that we may see and believe!"

- so that we^(incl) may see it and believe in him."
- Then we^(incl) will see it and believe that he is who he says he is."

so that we may see and believe: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as so that we may see and believe expresses the effect of Jesus coming down from the cross. In English, this effect can be expressed as result and purpose.

Some English versions emphasize the result by saying:

^{32a}Let this Christ...come down now from the cross.

^{32b}Then we will see and believe.

Other English versions emphasize the purpose by saying:

^{32a}Let this Christ...come down now from the cross

^{32b}in order that we may see and believe.

Translate this in a natural way in your language that indicates either purpose or result.

believe: The Greek word that the BSB translates as believe indicates that the chief priests and teachers of the law would believe what Jesus said.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

believe that he is who he says he is

trust what he says

agree with what he said

Your language may use an idiom for this meaning. See believe, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

15:32c

And even those who were crucified with Him berated Him.

- The men on crosses next to his cross were also insulting him.
- The two robbers whom they crucified beside/near him also spoke cruelly to/against him.

those who were crucified with Him: The verb crucified is a passive. If it would be more natural in your language to make this active, you can say:

those men whom they crucified with him

the robbers whom the soldiers crucified with Jesus

berated Him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as the English idiom berated is different from the Greek words used at 15:29a (“heaped abuse”) and 15:31a (“mocked”). But the meaning is very similar. Here the word means “to speak against a person in a way that says that he is wrong or bad.” The word also indicates that the robbers, as well as the Jewish leaders, insulted Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

also accused him of doing wrong

also insulted

also said cruel things (CEV)

The form of the Greek verb for berated indicates repeated action. The robbers spoke against Jesus many times. Indicate this in a way that is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

repeatedly reproached him

were insulting him (GW)

Mark 15:33

Section 15:33–41: Jesus died

Mark told the story of Jesus’ death and indicated the time certain important events happened. Jesus was nailed to the cross at the third hour of the day (9:00 a.m.). Then at the sixth hour (12:00 noon) it became as dark as nighttime. It probably remained dark until Jesus died sometime during the ninth hour (3:00 p.m.).

Three important events happened in this section. First, Jesus shouted, “My God, my God, why have you abandoned me?” These are the only words that Mark recorded that Jesus spoke while on the cross. They show that God the Father rejected Jesus while he took upon himself the sins of mankind. Second, when Jesus died, the curtain in the temple was torn in two. This curtain represented the barrier between mankind and the presence of God. Third, the Roman centurion in charge of the crucifixion confessed that Jesus was the Son of God. (He was the first man in the book of Mark to say this.)

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The death of Jesus

Jesus dies on the cross

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:45–56, Luke 23:44–49, and John 19:28–30.

15:33

From the sixth hour until the ninth hour darkness came over all the land.

- ¶ At midday and until the middle of the afternoon, there was darkness on/in/across the whole land.
- ¶ At noon, it became dark like nighttime everywhere in the land of the Jews. It remained/stayed that way for three hours.
- ¶ At midday, the light of the sun stopped shining in all the land. It was still that way by/at the middle of the afternoon.

From the sixth hour: The phrase the sixth hour refers to around 12:00 noon.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

At midday

When the sun was high in the sky

At 12:00/noon

until the ninth hour: The phrase the ninth hour refers to around 3:00 p.m. It was the middle of the afternoon.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

until the middle of the afternoon

until about three hours before sunset

until 3:00 p.m.

Mark does not say clearly that the darkness ended right at this point in the story and before Jesus died. It would be somewhat strange to imagine that the darkness lifted before Jesus cried out that God had abandoned him.

darkness came over all the land: The clause darkness came over all the land means that the whole land became dark. People could not see any light from the sun. It was as dark as it is at nighttime.

In some languages there may be an idiom expressing this. For example:

The whole land became pitch-black.

all the land: The Greek word that the BSB translates as land can mean region, country, or earth. In this context it probably refers to Judea, the land of the Jews.

Mark 15:34**Section 15:33–41: Jesus died**

Mark told the story of Jesus' death and indicated the time certain important events happened. Jesus was nailed to the cross at the third hour of the day (9:00 a.m.). Then at the sixth hour (12:00 noon) it became as dark as nighttime. It probably remained dark until Jesus died sometime during the ninth hour (3:00 p.m.).

Three important events happened in this section. First, Jesus shouted, "My God, my God, why have you abandoned me?" These are the only words that Mark recorded that Jesus spoke while on the cross. They show that God the Father rejected Jesus while he took upon himself the sins of mankind. Second, when Jesus died, the curtain in the temple was torn in two. This curtain represented the barrier between mankind and the presence of God. Third, the Roman centurion in charge of the crucifixion confessed that Jesus was the Son of God. (He was the first man in the book of Mark to say this.)

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The death of Jesus

Jesus dies on the cross

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:45–56, Luke 23:44–49, and John 19:28–30.

15:34a

At the ninth hour, Jesus cried out in a loud voice,

- At the middle of the afternoon, Jesus shouted loudly,
- At that time, Jesus said very loudly in his language,

At the ninth hour: Because the phrase the ninth hour is also mentioned in 15:33, in some languages it may be more natural to say here:

at that time

cried out in a loud voice: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as cried out means "shouted" or "spoke in a very loud voice." It does not mean "wept." In some languages, it may not be necessary to say in a loud voice because this may already be implied by the verb used.

Jesus was speaking to God the Father. So the word you choose should not indicate that he was angry.

15:34b

“Eloi, Eloi, lema sabachthani?”

- “Eloi, Eloi, lama sabaktani?”
- “Eloyi, Eloyi, lama sabakatani?”

Eloi, Eloi, lema sabachthani?: Jesus spoke these words in the language of the Jews (Hebrew or Aramaic). There is much discussion in the commentaries about whether Mark’s original text is a transliteration of this quote from Aramaic or Hebrew, or a mix of the two. And behind that question is the question of whether Jesus spoke these words in Hebrew or Aramaic. This is a quote from Psalm 22:1. You may want to say that Jesus spoke these words “in his own language.”

You should transliterate these words according to the sounds and letters in your language. Different English versions spell the third word in slightly different ways (some “lema”; others “lama”). This is because there are some differences of spelling in Greek manuscripts. You should follow the major language version of the Bible in your country when you transliterate these words.

15:34c

which means, “My God, My God, why have You forsaken Me?”

- This means, “My God, my God, why have you deserted/abandoned me?”
- Its meaning/translation in our^(incl) language is “My God, my God, why have you left me?”

which means: The words which means introduce the translation/meaning of the words in 15:34b. Introduce this translation in a way that is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

This means

These words mean in our^(incl) language

Translated in our^(incl) language that would be

My God, My God, why have You forsaken Me?:

This question is an expression of extreme grief and anguish. It expresses the grief that Jesus felt because God had left him alone. If a literal translation would give a wrong meaning in your language, you may need to change the form so that it expresses Jesus’ grief.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

My God, my God, why did you abandon me? (GNT)

My God, my God, how could it happen that you have deserted me?

My God, you have deserted me! How can I endure that?

My God, I grieve deeply that you have left me.

My God, My God: The repetition of the words My God adds emphasis to what Jesus said. Consider if it would be natural in your language to repeat them. If it is not, think of a way to show this emphasis in a natural way in your language.

My God: The pronoun My indicates that Jesus has a personal relationship with God. In some languages it may not be natural to address God as “my God.” If that is true in your language, you could say:

God, God

O God, O God

God, God whom I serve/trust

have...forsaken: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as have...forsaken means “go away from a person leaving him alone and not cared for.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

have...abandoned (GW)

have...deserted (CEV)

Mark 15:35

Section 15:33–41: Jesus died

Mark told the story of Jesus’ death and indicated the time certain important events happened. Jesus was nailed to the cross at the third hour of the day (9:00 a.m.). Then at the sixth hour (12:00 noon) it became as dark as nighttime. It probably remained dark until Jesus died sometime during the ninth hour (3:00 p.m.).

Three important events happened in this section. First, Jesus shouted, “My God, my God, why have you abandoned me?” These are the only words that Mark

recorded that Jesus spoke while on the cross. They show that God the Father rejected Jesus while he took upon himself the sins of mankind. Second, when Jesus died, the curtain in the temple was torn in two. This curtain represented the barrier between mankind and the presence of God. Third, the Roman centurion in charge of the crucifixion confessed that Jesus was the Son of God. (He was the first man in the book of Mark to say this.)

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The death of Jesus

Jesus dies on the cross

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:45–56, Luke 23:44–49, and John 19:28–30.

15:35a

When some of those standing nearby heard this, they said,

- Some of the people standing there heard him say this and said,
- Some of the people who were there/near heard him say this, misunderstood the word “Eloi” and said to others there,

15:35b

“Behold, He is calling Elijah.”

- “Listen/Look! He is calling Elijah.”
- “Hey! He is calling to Elijah, the prophet, to come and help him.”

15:35a–b

When some of those standing nearby heard this, they said, “Behold, He is calling Elijah.”: The Hebrew (or Aramaic) words for “my God” are very similar in sound to “Elijah.” So these people misunderstood what Jesus said. They wrongly thought that he was calling Elijah. You may want to put this information in a footnote. In some languages you may want to make it explicit in the text. For example:

When some of those standing nearby heard this, they did not hear him clearly and so they said...

When some of those standing nearby heard the word “Eloi,” they misunderstood and said...

some of those standing nearby: The Greek word that the BSB translates as those standing nearby in this context means “those who were near” or “those who were there.” It is true that these people were probably standing, but the focus is not on their posture.

Behold: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Behold is literally “Look.” However, the speakers were calling attention to what they were about to say. Some languages may have a word that people use to get the attention of other people. In other languages it may be natural to leave this word untranslated.

See also the note on 1:2b–c, where a similar word is used in Greek.

Elijah: The word Elijah is the name of a prophet. He lived about nine hundred years before Jesus. Some Jews believed that Elijah would come to rescue righteous people at a time of trouble. So these people probably thought Jesus was calling for Elijah to come and help him. If people do not know who Elijah was, you could say:

Elijah the prophet

Mark 15:36

Section 15:33–41: Jesus died

Mark told the story of Jesus’ death and indicated the time certain important events happened. Jesus was nailed to the cross at the third hour of the day (9:00 a.m.). Then at the sixth hour (12:00 noon) it became as dark as nighttime. It probably remained dark until Jesus died sometime during the ninth hour (3:00 p.m.).

Three important events happened in this section. First, Jesus shouted, “My God, my God, why have you abandoned me?” These are the only words that Mark recorded that Jesus spoke while on the cross. They show that God the Father rejected Jesus while he took upon himself the sins of mankind. Second, when Jesus died, the curtain in the temple was torn in two. This curtain represented the barrier between mankind and the presence of God. Third, the Roman centurion in charge of the crucifixion confessed that Jesus was the Son of God. (He was the first man in the book of Mark to say this.)

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The death of Jesus

Jesus dies on the cross

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:45–56, Luke 23:44–49, and John 19:28–30.

15:36a

And someone ran and filled a sponge with sour wine.

- One of these men ran, got a sponge, and soaked up some sour wine with it.
- One of the men there hurried and brought something that soaks up liquids. Then he dipped it in some sour wine.

And someone ran and filled a sponge with sour wine: This phrase indicates that someone there hurried to get a sponge and use it to soak up some wine vinegar.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

ran and got a sponge, filled it with vinegar (NCV)

One of them ran and grabbed a sponge. After he had soaked it in wine, he.... (CEV)

And someone: The word someone refers to one of the people in 15:35 who heard Jesus' words. He was one person who wrongly thought that Jesus was calling Elijah.

sponge: A sponge is something that can soak up water or other liquids. If sponges are unknown in your language, you could:

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

something that soaks/drinks water

something that takes/sucks up liquids

- Substitute something that is known in your culture that is used to soak up water. Add the words “something like” so that you do not change the facts of the historical incident. For example:

something like gourd fibers

something like cotton/cloth

sour wine: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sour wine refers to a cheap kind of wine or vinegar. It was known to be good for quenching thirst.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

cheap wine (GNT)

sour wine (NET)

wine (CEV)

See the note on “wine” at 15:23a.

15:36b

He put it on a reed

- Then he put/impaled the sponge on a reed
- He attached it to the tip of a stick/staff

He put it on a reed: The Greek words that the BSB translates as put...on literally mean “placed around.” The sponge may have been fastened around the reed. Or the man may have stabbed the end of the reed into the sponge.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

He tied it to a stick (NCV)

He impaled it on a reed

Use a natural verb in your language to describe this kind of action.

reed: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as reed generally refers to a stick. In this case, the man soaked a sponge with wine. Then he put the sponge on the stick in order to put the sponge as high as Jesus' mouth.

15:36c

and held it up for Jesus to drink,

- and gave/offered it to Jesus to drink.
- and lifted/raised it to Jesus' mouth so he could suck/sip some of the wine from it.

and held it up for Jesus to drink: The clause held it up for Jesus to drink indicates that the man lifted the sponge on the stick to Jesus' mouth. He did this so that Jesus could suck some of the wine from it. In some languages you will need to use a verb like “suck” rather than “drink” for this action.

The Greek verb here implies that Jesus drank this wine. John 19:28–30 also indicates that Jesus did drink what was offered to him this time. (This is a different situation from Mark 15:23. There, he did not drink the wine mixed with myrrh).

15:36d**saying, “Leave Him alone.**

- Then he said, “Leave him as he is.
- He said, “Wait and do not do anything.

saying: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as saying introduces direct speech. Some translations place the phrase “he said” at the end of the words that the man spoke in 15:36e. You should put this where it is most natural in your language.

Leave Him alone: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Leave Him alone in this context probably means “leave things as they are.” That is, no one is not clear whether this is addressed to the soldiers, the bystanders, or both. France (page 653) suggests that it generally addresses all who were present, that it is “used...not necessarily to avert any specific interference, but generally asking the bystanders and/or the soldiers to leave the field clear for Elijah to intervene if he so chose.” should do anything to hasten Jesus’ death. No one should do anything that would prevent Elijah from coming and saving him. Versions that translate this as “Wait” mean “Wait and do not do anything.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Leave him as he is.

Do not disturb him.

Leave things just as they are.

Wait and do not do anything.

15:36e**Let us see if Elijah comes to take Him down.”**

- Let us see/observe if Elijah will come and rescue him.”
- We should watch whether the prophet Elijah will come and free him from the cross.”

Let us see: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Let us see here means “Let us watch or observe.” The Greek verb form (and the English “let us...”) encourages other people to join with the speaker in doing something. (In this context, “let” does not mean “permit” or “allow.”)

Here are some other ways to translate Let us see:

Let us watch/observe

We should watch/look

if Elijah comes to take Him down: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to take...down means “to cause to descend.” In this context, it means “to remove Jesus,” “to rescue Jesus,” or “to free Jesus” from the cross.

Mark 15:37**Section 15:33–41: Jesus died**

Mark told the story of Jesus’ death and indicated the time certain important events happened. Jesus was nailed to the cross at the third hour of the day (9:00 a.m.). Then at the sixth hour (12:00 noon) it became as dark as nighttime. It probably remained dark until Jesus died sometime during the ninth hour (3:00 p.m.).

Three important events happened in this section. First, Jesus shouted, “My God, my God, why have you abandoned me?” These are the only words that Mark recorded that Jesus spoke while on the cross. They show that God the Father rejected Jesus while he took upon himself the sins of mankind. Second, when Jesus died, the curtain in the temple was torn in two. This curtain represented the barrier between mankind and the presence of God. Third, the Roman centurion in charge of the crucifixion confessed that Jesus was the Son of God. (He was the first man in the book of Mark to say this.)

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The death of Jesus

Jesus dies on the cross

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:45–56, Luke 23:44–49, and John 19:28–30.

15:37**But Jesus let out a loud cry and breathed His last.**

- Then Jesus spoke/shouted in a loud voice, and he stopped breathing.
- Jesus shouted and then died. (CEV)

But Jesus let out a loud cry: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Jesus let out a loud cry means that Jesus shouted. This does not mean that Jesus wept. We are not told what he shouted, but he probably shouted words and not just a noise. For example:

Jesus shouted (CEV)

cried out loudly

spoke/said something in a loud voice

and breathed His last: The Greek clause that the BSB translates with the English idiom and breathed His last means “Jesus died.” For example, the CEV says:

and then died

Many languages have a polite expression, an idiom, or a euphemism for death. You may want to use such an expression here.

Mark 15:38

Section 15:33–41: Jesus died

Mark told the story of Jesus’ death and indicated the time certain important events happened. Jesus was nailed to the cross at the third hour of the day (9:00 a.m.). Then at the sixth hour (12:00 noon) it became as dark as nighttime. It probably remained dark until Jesus died sometime during the ninth hour (3:00 p.m.).

Three important events happened in this section. First, Jesus shouted, “My God, my God, why have you abandoned me?” These are the only words that Mark recorded that Jesus spoke while on the cross. They show that God the Father rejected Jesus while he took upon himself the sins of mankind. Second, when Jesus died, the curtain in the temple was torn in two. This curtain represented the barrier between mankind and the presence of God. Third, the Roman centurion in charge of the crucifixion confessed that Jesus was the Son of God. (He was the first man in the book of Mark to say this.)

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The death of Jesus

Jesus dies on the cross

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:45–56, Luke 23:44–49, and John 19:28–30.

15:38a

And the veil of the temple was torn in two

- ¶ The curtain that was in the temple tore/ripped into two pieces,
- ¶ Just then, the heavy cloth divider that hung/was in the temple split/divided in two.

15:38b

from top to bottom.

- starting at the top and going to the bottom.
- The tear went from the top of the cloth divider to the bottom.

15:38a–b

And: The Greek word that the BSB translates as And introduces what happened immediately after Jesus died. In some languages, it may be natural to use a time word or phrase here. For example:

At once (CEV)

Just then

the veil of the temple: The phrase the veil of the temple refers to the large, thick cloth that hung in the temple. It either hung at the entrance to the temple building or between two rooms in the temple building. (These two rooms are known as “The Holy Place” and “The Holy of Holies.”) In the commentaries there is much discussion of which of these two curtains is intended and with divided opinion. The outer curtain is favored by some because of its public aspect. The inner curtain is favored by others because of references to it in Hebrews (6:19, 9:3; 10:19–20) and because the Greek word used here is more consistently used of the inner curtain. In the end, the choice of curtain does not greatly effect the sense. The tearing of either curtain would speak of the destruction of the temple and Old Testament system and symbolically show that a new way has been opened for man to approach God.) This curtain was possibly as much as twenty-five meters tall.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

cloth door of the temple

cloth divider of the temple

heavy cloth that separated two rooms in the temple

temple: The Greek word that the BSB translates as temple here refers to the main temple building. This is

the same word as in 14:58b and 15:29c–d. See temple, Meaning 2, in the Glossary for more information.

was torn in two from top to bottom: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as was torn in two means that the curtain was ripped/split into two pieces. The same Greek verb is used in a figurative sense in 1:10b (“He saw the heavens breaking open”). If possible, use the same word you used there.

If possible, use an expression that does not identify who (or what) caused the curtain to tear. For example:

the curtain tore/ripped in two

the curtain was torn/divided in two

If it is necessary in your language to identify who caused this to happen, you should say “God.” For example:

God tore the curtain in two.

Mark 15:39

Section 15:33–41: Jesus died

Mark told the story of Jesus’ death and indicated the time certain important events happened. Jesus was nailed to the cross at the third hour of the day (9:00 a.m.). Then at the sixth hour (12:00 noon) it became as dark as nighttime. It probably remained dark until Jesus died sometime during the ninth hour (3:00 p.m.).

Three important events happened in this section. First, Jesus shouted, “My God, my God, why have you abandoned me?” These are the only words that Mark recorded that Jesus spoke while on the cross. They show that God the Father rejected Jesus while he took upon himself the sins of mankind. Second, when Jesus died, the curtain in the temple was torn in two. This curtain represented the barrier between mankind and the presence of God. Third, the Roman centurion in charge of the crucifixion confessed that Jesus was the Son of God. (He was the first man in the book of Mark to say this.)

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The death of Jesus

Jesus dies on the cross

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:45–56, Luke 23:44–49, and John 19:28–30.

15:39a

When the centurion standing there in front of Jesus

- When the Roman officer who was there/near and facing Jesus
- The leader/chief of the soldiers was standing near and looking at Jesus.

centurion: A centurion was a Roman military officer. He was the leader of eighty to one hundred soldiers. This particular centurion was the officer in charge of crucifying Jesus and the two robbers.

Here are some other ways to translate centurion:

officer

elder/leader of one hundred soldiers

soldiers’ chief

elder/leader of many soldiers

standing there: The Greek word that the BSB translates as standing there in this context means “who was near” or “who was there.” It is true that this officer was probably standing, but the focus is not on his posture. See how you translated the similar expression at 15:35a–b.

in front of Jesus: The phrase in front of Jesus implies that the Roman officer was facing Jesus and looking at him.

15:39b

saw how He had breathed His last,

- saw how Jesus died,
- When he saw the way that Jesus died,

saw how He had breathed His last: There is textual issue with this verse. In some Greek manuscripts, there is a word that means “crying out”:

1. Some Greek manuscripts do not have this word. Most English versions follow these manuscripts. For example, the GNT says:

The army officer...saw how Jesus had died. (GNT) (BSB, RSV, GNT, CEV, GW, ESV, JBP, NASB, NET, NCV, NJB, NLT, REB)

1. Other Greek manuscripts have this word that means crying out. Only a few English versions follow these manuscripts. For example, the NIV says:

heard his cry and saw how he died (NIV11) (NIV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), since it has strong manuscript support and most English versions follow this option. However, you should check the major language version in your area. If it follows option (2), then you may want to follow it. Both options have strong manuscript support.

how He had breathed His last: The Greek word that the BSB translates as how also means “in this way/manner.” It is not exactly clear what this word refers to. Many things about the way Jesus died may have caused the centurion to say what he did in 15:39c. Many events that happened in connection with Jesus’ death may have also cause him to say this. So you should translate this in a general way. For example you could translate 15:39b as:

how Jesus died

When he saw the way that Jesus died

15:39c

he said, “Truly this man was the Son of God!”

- he said, “It is true that this man was God’s son.”
- he said, “There is no doubt that this man was the son of God.”

Truly this man was: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Truly literally means “certainly.” The centurion’s use of this word expresses his confidence in what he is about to say about Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Certainly, this man was (GW)

This man really was (CEV)

the Son of God: The Bible uses the title Son of God to express the fact that Jesus has the same nature as God. The title also indicates that the relationship between God and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship of human fathers and sons. God does not have a physical body, and he did not create/produce Jesus the way a human father produces a son. Jesus existed eternally as the Son with his Father.

In areas where people do not understand the term Son of God in this way, you may wish to include a footnote. For example:

God is the Father of Jesus the Son in a different way than human males are fathers of their sons. The Bible uses the word Son to express the fact that Jesus has the same nature as God. It also indicates that the relationship between God and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship of human fathers and sons.

In languages where there is no single word for “son,” many translators have used a more general expression, such as:

child of God

Other verses will usually make clear that Jesus was a male child. If you use a descriptive phrase such as “male child of God,” be sure that this expression does not imply that God had another child who was female.

The phrase the Son of God also occurs in 1:1 and 3:11. You should translate it here as you did there.

Some languages must distinguish between “the son of God” and “a son of God.” “The son of God” implies that there is only one. “A son of God” implies one son among several. If you must distinguish this in your language, you should say “the son of God.” In the commentaries, there is much discussion about whether this should be translated as “the son of God” or “a son of God,” about whether the meaning should come from what the centurion intended or what Mark intended, and if focused on the centurion, whether he understood Jesus as the unique son of God or simply a heroic man or demi-God according to Greco-Roman thought. The Greek grammar here can support translation into English as either “a” or “the” son of God (Colwell’s rule). However, the anarthrous construction highlights the character or nature of being a “son of God.” It is an English issue that forces us to decide between “a” or “the” son of God since English does not support “this man was son of God” (but see NJB). The distinction between “a son of God” (implying one among many) and “the son of God” (implying unique) need not have been in either the centurion’s or Mark’s mind.

Mark 15:40

Section 15:33–41: Jesus died

Mark told the story of Jesus' death and indicated the time certain important events happened. Jesus was nailed to the cross at the third hour of the day (9:00 a.m.). Then at the sixth hour (12:00 noon) it became as dark as nighttime. It probably remained dark until Jesus died sometime during the ninth hour (3:00 p.m.).

Three important events happened in this section. First, Jesus shouted, "My God, my God, why have you abandoned me?" These are the only words that Mark recorded that Jesus spoke while on the cross. They show that God the Father rejected Jesus while he took upon himself the sins of mankind. Second, when Jesus died, the curtain in the temple was torn in two. This curtain represented the barrier between mankind and the presence of God. Third, the Roman centurion in charge of the crucifixion confessed that Jesus was the Son of God. (He was the first man in the book of Mark to say this.)

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The death of Jesus

Jesus dies on the cross

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:45–56, Luke 23:44–49, and John 19:28–30.

15:40a

And there were also women watching from a distance.

- ¶ Several women were standing some distance away and were watching what was happening.
- ¶ There were a number of women who were there. They were watching these events from far away.

And there were also women: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as And there were also women refers to the women who were present, three of whom are mentioned in verse 15:40b. Verse 15:41b says that there were "many others." Use a term that can include all of these women.

watching from a distance: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as watching from a distance also means "watching from far away." The women were not standing near the cross and watching.

In some languages there are specific verbs for observing or viewing an event. There may also be specific verbs for looking at something from a distance. Use a verb or phrase that is natural in your language.

15:40b–d

Mark mentioned the names of three women here. The first two were named Mary. The third woman was Salome.

15:40b

Among them were Mary Magdalene,

- Among them were Mary of/from Magdala,
- This group of women included Mary who was from the town called Magdala,

Mary Magdalene: The first Mary in 15:40b was called Mary Magdalene because she was probably from the town of Magdala. Mary was a common name in Israel. So calling her Mary Magdalene distinguished her from the other Marys who are mentioned in Mark and the other Gospels.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Mary of Magdala (NJB)

Mary from Magdala (GW)

Mary who was from the town of Magdala

15:40c

Mary the mother of James the younger and of Joses,

- Mary who was the mother of the younger James and of Joses/Joseph,
- another Mary who was the mother of the young James and of Joses,

15:40d

and Salome.

- and Salome.
- and a third woman called Salome.

15:40c–d

Mary the mother of James the younger and of Joses, and Salome: Mark referred to the second Mary as the mother of James...and of Joses. James and Joses are the names of her two sons.

Mark may have mentioned the names of James and Joses because they were known in the churches to which he was writing.

Be careful in the way you translate this list. People should not think that James is the only son and Joses

is another woman. Be careful too that Salome will not be confused as another child of Mary. Salome is another woman who was there watching at a distance.

James: James is an English form of the name Jacob. You can follow the form of this name found in a major language Bible version. Or you can transliterate it on the basis of either the Greek or Hebrew form Iacob/Yacob.

the younger: James was probably called James the younger to distinguish him from another James. (Other men with this name are James the son of Zebedee and James the brother of Jesus). In some languages, it may not be natural to call him “younger” when it is not clear whom he was younger than. If that is true in your language, then you could simply call him “the young James” (as in the GW).

Joses: In Greek, this name is Ioses. It was probably an alternative Greek form for “Joseph” (see Matthew 27:56, which has the name “Joseph”). You can follow the form of this name found in a major language Bible version. Or you can transliterate it as either “Joses/Ioses” or “Joseph.”

If you follow the form “Joses/Ioses,” it may help to avoid confusion with the name “Joseph of Arimathea” in 15:43. If you follow the form “Joseph,” that would make the name in this verse the same as the name in Matthew 27:56.

General Comment on 14:40b–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order in which the women are named. For example:

^{40b}Among these were three women. ^{40d}One was named Salome ^{40b}and two were named Mary. The first Mary was from Magdala. ^{40c}The second Mary was the mother of James (called “Younger James”) and Joses.

Mark 15:41

Section 15:33–41: Jesus died

Mark told the story of Jesus’ death and indicated the time certain important events happened. Jesus was nailed to the cross at the third hour of the day (9:00 a.m.). Then at the sixth hour (12:00 noon) it became as dark as nighttime. It probably remained dark until Jesus died sometime during the ninth hour (3:00 p.m.).

Three important events happened in this section. First, Jesus shouted, “My God, my God, why have you abandoned me?” These are the only words that Mark recorded that Jesus spoke while on the cross. They show that God the Father rejected Jesus while he took

upon himself the sins of mankind. Second, when Jesus died, the curtain in the temple was torn in two. This curtain represented the barrier between mankind and the presence of God. Third, the Roman centurion in charge of the crucifixion confessed that Jesus was the Son of God. (He was the first man in the book of Mark to say this.)

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The death of Jesus

Jesus dies on the cross

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:45–56, Luke 23:44–49, and John 19:28–30.

15:41a

These women had followed Jesus and ministered to Him while He was in Galilee,

- These women had followed/accompanied Jesus and served/helped him in Galilee.
- When Jesus traveled around in the province of Galilee, these three women followed him as his disciples and provided what he needed.

These women: The phrase These women refers to the three women who were named in 15:40b–d. This phrase does not refer to the whole group of women who were there.

had followed Jesus: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as had followed is the verb commonly used to mean “follow as a disciple.” That is, these women went where Jesus went and learned from his teaching.

ministered to Him: Luke 8:3 says that women helped support the group financially. They may also have cooked for the group and taken care of their clothing. If possible, translate this in a way that indicates that these women generally served Jesus. Be careful that the way you translate this does not imply that these women served Jesus as wives or concubines.

The NCV has another way to translate this:

helped him

while He was in Galilee: The phrase while He was in Galilee refers to the time when Jesus was living and traveling in the province of Galilee.

15:41b

and there were many other women who had come up to Jerusalem with Him.

- There were many other women who had come up to Jerusalem with him and were also there.
- Many other women had been with him in Galilee and had come to Jerusalem with him. They too were watching from a distance.

and there were many other women: The phrase there were many other women refers to other women besides Salome and the two women named Mary. They came up with Jesus to Jerusalem.

who had come up to Jerusalem with Him: Jerusalem was built on a hill, and it was the most important city in Israel. So the Jews described coming to Jerusalem as coming up to Jerusalem.

In some languages, it is important to indicate whether a person goes up or down when he travels. In other languages, this may be confusing or not understood. If it is not natural to say this in your language, you can say:

had come with Jesus to Jerusalem (CEV)

General Comment on 15:40–41

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of parts of 15:40–41. For example:

^{41a}There were women who followed Jesus when he traveled around in Galilee. Some of them had cared for his needs ^{40b}such as Mary from Magdala, ^{40c}Mary the mother of James the Younger and of Joses, and Salome. ^{41b}These three and many of the others came up with him to Jerusalem. ^{40a}They were there now watching these events from a distance.

^{40a}Many women were watching from a distance.

^{41b}They had come up with Jesus to Jerusalem.

^{40b}Among them were Mary Magdalene, ^{40c}Mary the mother of James the younger and of Joses, and Salome. ^{41a}These three women had followed him in Galilee and cared for his needs.

Mark 15:42**Section 15:42–47: Joseph buried Jesus**

After someone died on a cross, his body was normally left on the cross to rot. Sometimes the Romans threw the body in a group grave and buried it without any honor. But for the Jews, a proper burial was important.

It was their custom to bury the body on the same day that a person died.

Joseph was determined to give Jesus a proper burial. So he bravely went to Pilate and asked permission to do this. When he did this, he risked being punished. Pilate might have thought that since he was a friend of Jesus, he was also rebelling against Rome.

The Sabbath day began just a few hours after Jesus died. On the Sabbath, it was forbidden to move a dead body. So Joseph had to act very quickly in all that he did.

In this section, Mark emphasized two important facts that help readers understand that Jesus truly rose from the dead. First, he showed that Jesus was really dead. Second, he said that the women in 15:47 observed and noted carefully the location of the tomb where Jesus was laid. They did not mistakenly go to the wrong tomb later.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Joseph put/laid the body of Jesus in a tomb

Jesus was placed in a burial cave.

The burial of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:57–61, Luke 23:50–55, and John 19:38–42.

Paragraph 15:42–47

In Jewish culture, a new day started at sunset. Jesus had died sometime during the middle of the afternoon. The Sabbath day would begin in a few hours. On the Sabbath day, a dead body could be washed and prepared for burial, but it could not be moved. This explains why Joseph had to hurry to bury Jesus' body.

15:42–43

See the General Comment on 15:42–43 at the end of 15:43e for suggestions about how to change the order of these verses.

15:42a

Now it was already evening.

- ¶ It was late in the afternoon,
- ¶ The evening/end of that day was approaching.
- ¶ Now it was almost evening/sunset

it was already evening: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as it was already evening is literally “evening had already come.” In this context, this phrase indicates “late afternoon” or “before sunset.” Jesus died in the middle of the afternoon. So Joseph had to get the body and bury it before sunset when the Sabbath would begin. Indicate the time between late afternoon and sunset in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

it was becoming dusk

late in the afternoon

as evening approached (NIV)

It was toward evening (GNT)

In some languages, it will be helpful to put a footnote here. For example:

At sunset, the Sabbath would begin. The religious law of the Jews did not permit them to move a dead body on the Sabbath day.

15:42b

Since it was Preparation Day (that is, the day before the Sabbath),

- and it was the day called Preparation Day, that is, the day before the Sabbath day.
- It was the day before the Jewish rest day, which was the day when people had to prepare things, since people could not work on the rest day.
- on the day of preparation, the day before the day for resting.

Since: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Since indicates that 15:42 gives the reason for what Joseph did in 15:43. The relationship between the verses is this:

⁴² (reason) It was late on the Preparation Day. The next day will be the Sabbath Day when a dead body should not be moved in order to bury it.

⁴³ (result) Joseph realized that he had to act immediately in order to give Jesus a proper burial. So he went quickly to Pilate and asked for Jesus' body.

Connect these verses in a way that is natural in your language.

it was Preparation Day: Preparation Day was the name for the Jewish day of the week that preceded the Sabbath. It was called Preparation Day because people needed to prepare for the Sabbath, the day when they could not do any work. Preparation Day began on Thursday at sunset and continued until Friday at sunset.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the day of the week called Preparation Day

the day people prepared things

Friday, the day people prepared for the Sabbath

You may want to include a footnote here. For example:

The Jewish law did not allow people to work on the Sabbath day (which started at sunset on Friday). So the day before the Sabbath day was called Preparation Day because everyone had to work to prepare things for the Sabbath.

(that is, the day before the Sabbath): This phrase further explains the meaning of “Preparation Day.” It explains why this day is important in this context. You could combine the way you translate this phrase with the way you translate “Preparation Day.” For example:

It was the day before the Sabbath. That day is called “Preparation Day” because people must work to prepare for the Sabbath.

It was Preparation Day, the day before the Sabbath when people had to prepare for the Sabbath.

According to Jewish law, people should bury a dead body soon after the person had died. But the law forbade people to move a dead body on the Sabbath day. So Joseph only had a short time to bury the body before the start of the Sabbath day. You may want to include some of this information in a footnote. For example:

According to Jewish law, people could not move a dead body on the Sabbath day. So Joseph had to quickly bury the body before the Sabbath day began.

Sabbath: The word Sabbath is the name of the seventh and last day of the week for the Jews. The Sabbath was the special day of the week when the Jews rested and worshiped God. The Law of Moses said that the Jews must not do any work on that day (Deuteronomy 5:12–15).

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the Jewish rest day

the day for resting

the day to rest and worship God

If the word Sabbath is already known in your area, you may write it according to the sounds of your language. You may also want to include a phrase to explain the meaning. For example:

the Sabat, the Jews' day for resting

Be careful that the term you choose is not confused with Sunday, the day when Christians worship. The Sabbath for the Jews began at sundown on Friday and went until sundown on Saturday. You may want to include a footnote to give more information. For example:

The Sabbath is a name for the seventh day of the week. It is the day when the Jews rested from work and worshiped God.

Mark 15:43

Section 15:42–47: Joseph buried Jesus

After someone died on a cross, his body was normally left on the cross to rot. Sometimes the Romans threw the body in a group grave and buried it without any honor. But for the Jews, a proper burial was important. It was their custom to bury the body on the same day that a person died.

Joseph was determined to give Jesus a proper burial. So he bravely went to Pilate and asked permission to do this. When he did this, he risked being punished. Pilate might have thought that since he was a friend of Jesus, he was also rebelling against Rome.

The Sabbath day began just a few hours after Jesus died. On the Sabbath, it was forbidden to move a dead body. So Joseph had to act very quickly in all that he did.

In this section, Mark emphasized two important facts that help readers understand that Jesus truly rose from the dead. First, he showed that Jesus was really dead. Second, he said that the women in 15:47 observed and noted carefully the location of the tomb where Jesus was laid. They did not mistakenly go to the wrong tomb later.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Joseph put/laid the body of Jesus in a tomb

Jesus was placed in a burial cave.

The burial of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:57–61, Luke 23:50–55, and John 19:38–42.

Paragraph 15:42–47

In Jewish culture, a new day started at sunset. Jesus had died sometime during the middle of the afternoon. The Sabbath day would begin in a few hours. On the Sabbath day, a dead body could be washed and prepared for burial, but it could not be moved. This explains why Joseph had to hurry to bury Jesus' body.

15:43

In 15:43, many details are given about Joseph. These details include his name, where he was from, that he was a member of the Jewish high council, and that he desired the coming of God's reign. Put these details in an order that is natural in your language when introducing a new person in a story.

15:43a

Joseph of Arimathea,

- So Joseph of/from Arimathea,
- There was a certain man. His name was Joseph. He was from the town of Arimathea.

Joseph of Arimathea: This man was called Joseph of Arimathea to distinguish him from other men named Joseph in the Gospels. (Some other men named Joseph are Mary's husband and Joseph/Joses who is mentioned in Mark 15:40). The phrase of Arimathea means "from the town of Arimathea." (Arimathea was a town about twenty miles northwest of Jerusalem.)

This is the first time that Joseph of Arimathea is mentioned in Mark. Introduce him in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

There was a man named Joseph who was from the town of Arimathea.

15:43b

a prominent Council member

- an honored member of the high/supreme court of the Jews,
- He was a highly respected person of the Jewish high council.

a prominent Council member: The phrase a prominent Council member means that Joseph was “a highly respected/honored” member of the Jewish high court. This high court was called the Council or “the Sanhedrin” (14:55). This Council had condemned Jesus to death.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

an honored member of the high council (NLT)

a respected person in the Jewish high/supreme court

The related word “Sanhedrin” occurs at 14:55a and 15:1b (see the notes on “Sanhedrin”). See how you translated it there.

15:43c

who himself was waiting for the kingdom of God,

- who himself was eager for God’s rule/reign to begin,
- He was one of the people who desired that the time would come when God would rule as king.

who himself was waiting: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as who himself was waiting emphasizes that Joseph was personally waiting for the kingdom of God. Try to show this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways this has been done in English versions:

who was also himself looking for... (RSV)

Joseph...was one of the people who was waiting for... (NCV)

was waiting for the kingdom of God: The Greek verb phrase that the BSB translates as was waiting in this context means “desired very much” that something would come or happen. Joseph wanted the time to come when God would establish his kingdom.

The phrase kingdom of God refers to God’s activity of ruling and caring for his people as their king. It does not refer to a land or territory that he rules over. In this context, Joseph was desiring the time when God would rule his people as king. Here are some other ways to translate kingdom of God in this context:

- As a noun. For example:

God’s rule/reign

God’s kingship

God’s chieftaincy/government

- As a verbal expression:

the time when God will rule

when God will protect/deliver his people as their king

See how you translated this phrase in similar contexts such as 9:47b. See also kingdom of God, Context 3, in the Glossary.

15:43d

boldly went to Pilate

- went bravely to Pilate
- There was little time in which to do something before the Sabbath/rest day began, so he went with courage to Pilate

boldly went to Pilate: The word boldly here means that Joseph showed “courage” or “bravery” when he went to Pilate to ask for the body. It was dangerous for Joseph to ask this. It was dangerous because he would be letting Pilate know that he was the friend of a rebel against Rome.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

bravely went in to Pilate (REB)

showed bravery/courage in going to Pilate

The word boldly here does not refer to the manner in which Joseph approached Pilate. Nor does it show the attitude he had when he spoke to him.

15:43e

to ask for the body of Jesus.

- and asked if he could take/have Jesus’ body.

- to ask for permission to take/lift Jesus' body/corpse down from the cross.
- and asked/said: "May I take the body of Jesus so that I may bury it/him?"

to ask for the body of Jesus: In this context to ask for the body of Jesus means that Joseph asked Pilate for permission to have Jesus' body. He did this so that he could bury the body. Jesus' body was still on the cross. It was not at Pilate's residence where he could give it to Joseph. You may want to make this explicit. For example:

asked for permission to take Jesus' body from the cross and bury it/him

In some languages, it may be natural to state Joseph's request using direct speech. For example:

Joseph bravely went to Pilate and asked/said:
"Please sir, may I take the body of Jesus so that I may bury it/him?"

General Comment on 15:42–43

In verses 15:42–43, Mark:

1. introduces Joseph (15:43a–c)
2. says what Joseph did (15:43d–e)
3. gives the reason for what Joseph did (15:42a–b)

These verses could be ordered in many different ways. If you change the order of these verses, you can put the numbers 42–43 before the first word of these two verses. For examples, the GNT has:

^{42–43}It was toward evening when Joseph of Arimathea arrived. He was a respected member of the Council, who was waiting for the coming of the Kingdom of God. It was Preparation day (that is, the day before the Sabbath), so Joseph went boldly into the presence of Pilate and asked him for the body of Jesus.

Here is another way to reorder these verses:

^{43a}There was a man named Joseph who was from Arimathea. ^{43b}He was a prominent member of the Council ^{43c}and was himself waiting for the kingdom of God. ^{43d}He bravely went to Pilate ^{43e}and asked for the body of Jesus. ^{42a}He did this because it was already late afternoon ^{43b}on Preparation Day. This was the day before the rest day of the Jews when it was forbidden to move a body for burial.

Mark 15:44

Section 15:42–47: Joseph buried Jesus

After someone died on a cross, his body was normally left on the cross to rot. Sometimes the Romans threw the body in a group grave and buried it without any honor. But for the Jews, a proper burial was important. It was their custom to bury the body on the same day that a person died.

Joseph was determined to give Jesus a proper burial. So he bravely went to Pilate and asked permission to do this. When he did this, he risked being punished. Pilate might have thought that since he was a friend of Jesus, he was also rebelling against Rome.

The Sabbath day began just a few hours after Jesus died. On the Sabbath, it was forbidden to move a dead body. So Joseph had to act very quickly in all that he did.

In this section, Mark emphasized two important facts that help readers understand that Jesus truly rose from the dead. First, he showed that Jesus was really dead. Second, he said that the women in 15:47 observed and noted carefully the location of the tomb where Jesus was laid. They did not mistakenly go to the wrong tomb later.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Joseph put/laid the body of Jesus in a tomb

Jesus was placed in a burial cave.

The burial of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:57–61, Luke 23:50–55, and John 19:38–42.

Paragraph 15:42–47

In Jewish culture, a new day started at sunset. Jesus had died sometime during the middle of the afternoon. The Sabbath day would begin in a few hours. On the Sabbath day, a dead body could be washed and prepared for burial, but it could not be moved. This explains why Joseph had to hurry to bury Jesus' body.

15:44a

Pilate was surprised to hear that Jesus was already dead,

- Pilate was amazed/astonished that Jesus had already died.
- When Pilate heard/learned from Joseph that Jesus was already dead, he was surprised.

Pilate was surprised to hear that Jesus was already dead: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Pilate was surprised to hear that Jesus was already dead is literally “Pilate was surprised that he was already dead.” The BSB has supplied the phrase to hear to make the clause natural English.

was surprised: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as was surprised expresses surprise or amazement. Here it includes an element of doubt. Pilate was surprised or amazed to hear that Jesus had already died, and he sent for the centurion to confirm the report.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

was astonished/amazed that

wondered/marveled that

15:44b

so he summoned the centurion

- He sent for the centurion
- He sent for the officer who was in charge of crucifying Jesus.
- So he sent/commanded someone to tell the leader/ chief of the soldiers to come to him in order to be sure.

so: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates here as so introduces what Pilate did as a result of what he heard from Joseph. He summoned the centurion to investigate. Connect 15:44b to 15:44a in a way that is natural in your language for this context.

he summoned the centurion: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as summoned here means “commanded to come.” The centurion was still by the cross, so Pilate sent someone to tell the centurion to come to him. The REB translates this as:

sent for the centurion (REB)

15:44c

to ask if this was so.

- and asked him if Jesus was already dead.
- When the officer came/arrived, Pilate asked him if it was true that Jesus had already died.
- He asked the leader/chief, “Has Jesus already died?”

to ask if this was so: In some languages, it may be natural to use direct speech for this question. For example:

...he/Pilate asked him, “Has Jesus already died?”

...he asked him, “Is it true that Jesus is already dead?”

Mark 15:45

Section 15:42–47: Joseph buried Jesus

After someone died on a cross, his body was normally left on the cross to rot. Sometimes the Romans threw the body in a group grave and buried it without any honor. But for the Jews, a proper burial was important. It was their custom to bury the body on the same day that a person died.

Joseph was determined to give Jesus a proper burial. So he bravely went to Pilate and asked permission to do this. When he did this, he risked being punished. Pilate might have thought that since he was a friend of Jesus, he was also rebelling against Rome.

The Sabbath day began just a few hours after Jesus died. On the Sabbath, it was forbidden to move a dead body. So Joseph had to act very quickly in all that he did.

In this section, Mark emphasized two important facts that help readers understand that Jesus truly rose from the dead. First, he showed that Jesus was really dead. Second, he said that the women in 15:47 observed and noted carefully the location of the tomb where Jesus was laid. They did not mistakenly go to the wrong tomb later.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Joseph put/laid the body of Jesus in a tomb

Jesus was placed in a burial cave.

The burial of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:57–61, Luke 23:50–55, and John 19:38–42.

Paragraph 15:42–47

In Jewish culture, a new day started at sunset. Jesus had died sometime during the middle of the afternoon. The Sabbath day would begin in a few hours. On the Sabbath day, a dead body could be washed and prepared for burial, but it could not be moved. This explains why Joseph had to hurry to bury Jesus' body.

15:45a**When Pilate had confirmed it with the centurion,**

- When Pilate heard from the centurion that Jesus was indeed dead,
- The officer confirmed that it was true.
- The leader/chief of the soldiers answered him, "Yes sir, he has died."

When Pilate had confirmed it with the centurion:

The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as When Pilate had confirmed it with the centurion is literally "knowing from the centurion." That is, the centurion answered Pilate's question and confirmed that Jesus was already dead. In some languages, the verb for "knowing" that the BSB translates as confirmed might be more naturally translated as "knew" or "understood."

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

When the officer had assured him that... (GW)

After hearing the officer's report (GNT)

In some languages it may be more natural to say explicitly that the centurion answered Pilate's question. For example:

The centurion answered/confirmed that...

The centurion answered, "Yes, sir..."

it: The word it means "that Jesus had already died." Pilate now knew that what Joseph had said was true. If you are translating the centurion's response as direct speech, you may wish to translate this as:

"Yes, he is already dead."

"It is true that he has died."

15:45b**he granted the body to Joseph.**

- he granted permission to Joseph to take the corpse.

- So Pilate said that Joseph could take Jesus' body in order to bury it.

he granted the body to Joseph: The Greek word that the BSB translates as granted refers to someone in authority officially giving something. Some English versions translate it as "give." Pilate himself did not give Jesus' body to Joseph. He granted permission for Joseph to take the body in order to bury it.

the body: The Greek word that the BSB translates as body refers specifically to a dead body. Some English versions translate it as "corpse."

Mark 15:46**Section 15:42–47: Joseph buried Jesus**

After someone died on a cross, his body was normally left on the cross to rot. Sometimes the Romans threw the body in a group grave and buried it without any honor. But for the Jews, a proper burial was important. It was their custom to bury the body on the same day that a person died.

Joseph was determined to give Jesus a proper burial. So he bravely went to Pilate and asked permission to do this. When he did this, he risked being punished. Pilate might have thought that since he was a friend of Jesus, he was also rebelling against Rome.

The Sabbath day began just a few hours after Jesus died. On the Sabbath, it was forbidden to move a dead body. So Joseph had to act very quickly in all that he did.

In this section, Mark emphasized two important facts that help readers understand that Jesus truly rose from the dead. First, he showed that Jesus was really dead. Second, he said that the women in 15:47 observed and noted carefully the location of the tomb where Jesus was laid. They did not mistakenly go to the wrong tomb later.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Joseph put/laid the body of Jesus in a tomb

Jesus was placed in a burial cave.

The burial of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:57–61, Luke 23:50–55, and John 19:38–42.

Paragraph 15:42–47

In Jewish culture, a new day started at sunset. Jesus had died sometime during the middle of the afternoon. The Sabbath day would begin in a few hours. On the Sabbath day, a dead body could be washed and prepared for burial, but it could not be moved. This explains why Joseph had to hurry to bury Jesus' body.

15:46a**So Joseph bought a linen cloth,**

- Then Joseph bought a piece/sheet of linen cloth,
- Joseph bought a large piece/sheet of burial cloth.

15:46a–b

So: There are several ways to connect 15:46 to 15:45:

- The events in 15:46 were the result of Pilate giving Joseph permission to take Jesus' body. So some English versions connect 15:46 to 15:45 with the word "So." For example:

So (REB)

- The events in 15:46 happened immediately after 15:45. So some English versions connect 15:46 to 15:45 with the word "Then." For example:

Then (NRSV)

- Other English versions do not use a connecting word or phrase here.

Connect 15:46 to 15:45 in a way that is natural in your language for this context.

a linen cloth: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a linen cloth describes a piece of cloth of high quality. It was made from flax fibers. It was a Jewish custom to wrap a dead body in such a cloth before burying it.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Use a specific word for cloth made from flax. For example, the CEV says:

some linen cloth

- Use a specific word for cloth that is used to wrap a body for burial. For example, the RSV says:

a linen shroud

- Use a general expression for cloth. You could add the purpose for the cloth, but that should be clear from 15:46b. For example:

some cloth

a burial cloth

cloth used for/when burying bodies

It may be helpful to indicate the size of the piece of cloth. For example, the NLT says:

a long sheet of linen cloth

This kind of cloth was mentioned in 14:51–52. However, there it was used as clothing, and not as a burial cloth.

15:46b**took down the body of Jesus,**

- took/lifted him/Jesus down,
- Then he went and brought the body of Jesus down from the cross.

took down the body of Jesus: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as took down means "to cause to descend." Jesus was hanging above the ground on the cross. In order to move Jesus' body, Joseph had to remove it from the cross and bring it down.

The soldiers or other men probably helped Joseph take down the body of Jesus. Mark only mentions Joseph since he is in focus. If people understand that Joseph took down the body by himself, you may want to say:

Joseph, with the help of others, took down the body.

Joseph, along with others, brought down Jesus' body from the cross.

the body: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the body is literally "him" (as in the RSV). Translate this as either "the corpse/body" or "him/Jesus" depending on which is more natural in your language. Do not translate this as "him" if that will imply that Jesus was still alive or that he was a ghost. If you have a euphemism that you use to refer to a dead body, you may use it here.

15:46c**wrapped it in the cloth,**

- wrapped him in the cloth,
- He wrapped the cloth around the body/corpse

wrapped it in the cloth: The word wrapped in this context means "wrapped the cloth around the body

many times.” The cloth was first cut into strips and then the strips were wrapped around the body.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

wrapped the linen cloth around the body

wrapped him/it in strips of the linen/cloth

15:46d

and placed it in a tomb that had been cut out of the rock.

- and put him in a tomb that had been dug/chiseled out of rock.
- and laid it in a burial cave that people had carved from a hillside of solid rock.

placed it in a tomb that had been cut out of the rock:

The clause placed it in a tomb that had been cut out of the rock indicates the type of grave into which Joseph put Jesus’ body. It was Jewish custom to bury dead bodies in caves (see 5:2b–c) or in tombs that were like caves. These tombs were dug or cut into rock. These were not dug down into the ground. Rather, they were often dug into a hillside of solid rock. These tombs were often large enough for several bodies and for several people to enter carrying a dead body.

In some languages, the word tomb strongly implies that Jesus was buried in a hole in the ground that could be filled with dirt and stones. If that is true in your language, you should use a phrase that describes a Jewish tomb. For example:

placed it in a tomb that was cut into a hillside of solid rock

placed it in a burial cave that was dug out of rock

buried him in a place for dead bodies that was carved from solid rock

See how you translated this word in 5:2b.

placed it in a tomb: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as placed it in a tomb indicates that Joseph put or buried Jesus’ body in a tomb. If you have a specific word in your language for placing or putting a body in a tomb, consider using it here. However, be sure that it does not imply a way of burying dead bodies that is different from the Jewish custom.

15:46e

Then he rolled a stone against the entrance to the tomb.

- Finally he rolled a great/huge stone in front of the entrance of the tomb.
- Then he with the help of other men rolled a large heavy stone/rock in front of the entrance to the tomb to seal/close it.

Then: The word Then introduces what happened next in the story. The burial ended when the stone was rolled to cover the entrance to the tomb.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Finally

In the end

he rolled a stone against the entrance to the tomb:

After the Jews buried someone, it was common for them to cover the entrance to their tombs with a large stone or rock. The purpose of this stone was to keep animals or robbers from entering the tomb.

he rolled a stone: The stone was round and often set in a track in which it could roll to cover the entrance. Joseph certainly needed the help of other men to roll the stone. If simply saying “he rolled” in your language would imply that he did this alone, you may want to make it clear that other men helped him. For example:

he together with some other men rolled

he helped to roll

a stone: This stone was very large and heavy. It was probably between one and two meters tall. It was round and flat.

Some languages have different words for different sizes of stones. Some examples are pebbles, stones, rocks, and boulders. If your language has these different words, you should use the word for a very large rock.

the entrance to the tomb: The phrase the entrance of the tomb refers to the hole or opening cut into the rock. This entrance was not a door made of wood or some other material.

Mark 15:47

Section 15:42–47: Joseph buried Jesus

After someone died on a cross, his body was normally left on the cross to rot. Sometimes the Romans threw the body in a group grave and buried it without any honor. But for the Jews, a proper burial was important. It was their custom to bury the body on the same day that a person died.

Joseph was determined to give Jesus a proper burial. So he bravely went to Pilate and asked permission to do this. When he did this, he risked being punished. Pilate might have thought that since he was a friend of Jesus, he was also rebelling against Rome.

The Sabbath day began just a few hours after Jesus died. On the Sabbath, it was forbidden to move a dead body. So Joseph had to act very quickly in all that he did.

In this section, Mark emphasized two important facts that help readers understand that Jesus truly rose from the dead. First, he showed that Jesus was really dead. Second, he said that the women in 15:47 observed and noted carefully the location of the tomb where Jesus was laid. They did not mistakenly go to the wrong tomb later.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Joseph put/laid the body of Jesus in a tomb

Jesus was placed in a burial cave.

The burial of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 27:57–61, Luke 23:50–55, and John 19:38–42.

Paragraph 15:42–47

In Jewish culture, a new day started at sunset. Jesus had died sometime during the middle of the afternoon. The Sabbath day would begin in a few hours. On the Sabbath day, a dead body could be washed and prepared for burial, but it could not be moved. This explains why Joseph had to hurry to bury Jesus' body.

15:47a

Mary Magdalene and Mary the mother of Joseph

- Mary of/from Magdala and Mary the mother of Joseph

- Mary of/from the town of Magdala and Mary who was the mother of James/Jacob and of Joseph

Mary Magdalene: The name Mary Magdalene indicates that Mary was from a town called Magdala. The name Mary Magdalene also occurs in 15:40b.

Mary the mother of Joseph: This is the Mary who is called “Mary the mother of James the younger and of Joseph” in 15:40c–d. She is mentioned once more in 16:1b, where she is called “Mary the mother of James.” To avoid confusion, you may want to refer to her in the same way each time she is mentioned. For example:

Mary the mother of James/Jacob and Joseph/Joseph

15:47b

saw where His body was placed.

- observed where he/Jesus was put/placed.
- carefully noticed where Joseph of Arimathea laid the/his body/corpse.

saw: The Greek word that the BSB translates as saw means “watched purposefully and with attention.” Here the women saw where Joseph laid Jesus' body. They carefully noticed where it was so that they could find their way there again.

Here is another way to translate this:

attentively/carefully observed

where His body was placed: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as was placed is the same Greek word as in 15:46d. There the BSB translates this word as “placed.” In both places, you should use whatever word is most natural in your language for the context.

Mark 16:1

Section 16:1–8: Jesus rose from the dead

In this section, Mark wrote about what happened when Jesus rose from the dead. He rose just as he had told his disciples that he would.

When the Sabbath was over, some women who knew Jesus bought spices. They planned to bring them to Jesus' tomb early the next morning to anoint his body. When they arrived at the tomb, they saw that someone had rolled the large stone away from the entrance. A young man dressed in a white robe was sitting inside the tomb. He told them that Jesus was not there. He was alive again! Then the women became afraid and ran from the tomb.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Comes Back to Life (GW)

The Resurrection of Jesus (NRSV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 28:1–8; Luke 24:1–12; and John 20:1–12, 20:15.

Paragraph 16:1–4

The events of this paragraph happened on the day after the Sabbath. It was against the Jewish religious law to do any work on the Sabbath day. So the women had to wait until the next day to anoint Jesus' body.

16:1a

When the Sabbath was over,

- ¶ At the end of the Sabbath day,
- ¶ In the evening when the rest day had passed,

When the Sabbath was over: The clause When the Sabbath was over refers to the end of the Sabbath day. The Sabbath day ended when the sun went down. So the phrase When the Sabbath was over refers to the evening of the seventh day of the week (Saturday).

Sabbath: The word Sabbath is the name of the seventh and last day of the week for the Jews. The Sabbath was the special day of the week when the Jews rested and worshiped God. The Law of Moses said that the Jews must not do any work on that day (Deuteronomy 5:12–15).

Here are some other ways to translate Sabbath:

the Jewish rest day

the day for resting

the day to rest and worship God

If the word Sabbath is already known in your area, you may write it according to the sounds of your language. You may also want to include a phrase to explain the meaning. For example:

the Sabat, the Jews' day for resting

Be careful that the term you choose is not confused with Sunday, the day when Christians worship. The

Sabbath for the Jews began at sundown on Friday and went until sundown on Saturday. You may want to include a footnote to give more information. For example:

The Sabbath is a name for the seventh day of the week. It is the day when the Jews rested from work and worshiped God.

Use the same word or phrase for Sabbath as you did in 1:21b and 15:42b. See the note there.

16:1b

Mary Magdalene, Mary the mother of James, and Salome

- the three women named Mary Magdalene, Mary the mother of James, and Salome
- Salome, Mary who was from Magdala, and Mary who was the mother of James and Joses

Mary Magdalene, Mary the mother of James, and Salome: These three women were mentioned in 15:40b and 15:40c–d. Mary Magdalene and Mary the mother of James were also mentioned in 15:47a.

In some languages the order of this list of women may be confusing. Your translation should not imply that the second Mary is the mother of both James and Salome. One way to avoid this is to change the order of the list. For example:

Salome, Mary Magdalene, and Mary the mother of James

See how you translated these names in 15:40b, 15:40c–d and 15:47a.

Mary the mother of James: Notice that Mary the mother of James is referred to as “Mary the mother of James and Joses” in 15:40. In 15:47 she is referred to as “Mary the mother of Joses.”. In some languages it may be necessary to refer to her in the same way each time she is mentioned. For example:

Mary the mother of James and Joses

Another option is to translate the names as they occur in each reference and add a footnote. A footnote here could say:

Mary was also the mother of Joses. See 15:40 and 15:47.

16:1c**bought spices so they could go and anoint the body of Jesus.**

- bought fragrant oil to take to the tomb to prepare Jesus' body/corpse.
- went and bought ointments to honor Jesus by putting/using them on his dead body.

bought spices: The women bought these spices in order to follow a burial custom of the Jews. Jews put spices onto a person's dead body so that it would smell good. In this way they honored the dead person. In some languages it may be natural to include a verb like "went" here. For example, the NLT says:

went out and purchased burial spices

spices: The Greek word that the BSB translates as spices refers in general to things that smell good such as ointments, oils, and perfumes. In this context, the oil or ointment was to be used to anoint Jesus' dead body. Make sure that your translation does not give the impression that the spices were for food preparation.

so they could go and anoint the body of Jesus: This clause tells the women's purpose for buying spices. They wanted to carry them to the tomb and use them to anoint Jesus' body.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

intending to go and anoint him (REB)

to take to the tomb to anoint Jesus' body

to put on Jesus' body (CEV)

go: In some languages it may be natural to use a verb like "come" here. According to 16:2, the women did not actually go (or "come") to the tomb until the next morning. Your translation should not imply here that they went to the tomb as soon as they bought the spices. In some languages, it may be natural to leave the verb go untranslated here. See the General Comment on 16:1-2 at the end of 16:2b for a way to do this.

and anoint the body of Jesus: In this context, the verb anoint means "to put oil or ointment on a person's corpse to prepare it for burial." Jesus' body had already been wrapped in cloth, so the women were probably intending to pour or rub the ointment onto the cloth.

Some languages have a word that refers to putting, rubbing or pouring oil or ointment on a person's body as a part of burial preparations. If you have such a word, you may use it here. Otherwise, you should use a general expression, since we do not know exactly how the women intended to anoint Jesus' body. For example:

to prepare Jesus' body

to use on Jesus' corpse

The Jews did not embalm dead bodies. They used the spices to reduce the smell and to show respect. See the notes on 14:8b-c for similar information. See also the account in John 19:39-40, which describes how Nicodemus and Joseph wrapped Jesus' body along with burial spices.

General Comment on 16:1a-c

In some languages it may be more natural to tell about what the women did before giving their names. For example:

^{1a}When the Sabbath was over, some women
^{1c}bought spices so that they might go to anoint Jesus' body. ^{1b}The women's names were Salome, Mary Magdalene, and Mary who was the mother of James.

Mark 16:2**Section 16:1-8: Jesus rose from the dead**

In this section, Mark wrote about what happened when Jesus rose from the dead. He rose just as he had told his disciples that he would.

When the Sabbath was over, some women who knew Jesus bought spices. They planned to bring them to Jesus' tomb early the next morning to anoint his body. When they arrived at the tomb, they saw that someone had rolled the large stone away from the entrance. A young man dressed in a white robe was sitting inside the tomb. He told them that Jesus was not there. He was alive again! Then the women became afraid and ran from the tomb.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Comes Back to Life (GW)

The Resurrection of Jesus (NRSV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 28:1–8; Luke 24:1–12; and John 20:1–12, 20:15.

Paragraph 16:1–4

The events of this paragraph happened on the day after the Sabbath. It was against the Jewish religious law to do any work on the Sabbath day. So the women had to wait until the next day to anoint Jesus' body.

16:2a

Very early on the first day of the week, just after sunrise,

- And very early on the first day of the week, at sunrise, (NET)
- At daybreak on Sunday,

Very early on the first day of the week, just after sunrise: This verse part uses several phrases to describe the time that the women went to the tomb.

Very early: In this context the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Very early emphasizes the time, which was immediately after sunrise.

on the first day of the week: The phrase the first day of the week refers to the day after the Sabbath. This corresponds to Sunday. Several English versions have the word Sunday here. For example, the CEV says:

on Sunday

You may want to include a footnote about this. For example:

The Greek text has literally “the first day of the week.” The Jews considered the day after the Sabbath to be the first day of the week. So “the first day of the week” is Sunday.

just after sunrise: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as just after sunrise is literally “the sun having risen.” Each of the other three Gospels use a slightly different way to talk about the time. But all of them indicate that the women went to the tomb around the time that the sun was rising. It may have been dark when they started walking and just after sunrise when they arrived (See John 20:1). It is good to use a general expression here that refers to this time of day. For example, the GNT says:

at sunrise (GNT)

16:2b

they went to the tomb.

- as they came to the tomb,
- they began to walk to the tomb.
- they came to the tomb. (NLT)

they went to the tomb: The context shows that they had not yet arrived at the tomb when they asked the question in 16:3. They asked the question before they saw the entrance to the tomb (16:4). The GNT makes this explicit:

On the way they said to one another...

the tomb: The phrase the tomb refers to the tomb where Jesus' body had been buried after he died. The Greek word that the BSB translates as tomb was also used in 15:46d. This is the first time that the tomb has been mentioned in this section. In some languages it may be natural to refer to it with a more specific phrase. For example:

the tomb where Jesus had been buried

General Comment on 16:2a–b

The RSV has followed the Greek order of the phrases in the verse. It mentions sunrise at the end of the verse:

^{2a}And very early on the first day of the week ^{2b}they went to the tomb ^{2a}when the sun had risen.

You should follow the order that is most natural in your language.

General Comment on 16:1–2

The idea of going to the tomb is mentioned in both 16:1 and 16:2. In some languages it may be natural to mention it only in 16:2, as the CEV has done:

^{1a}After the Sabbath, Mary Magdalene, Salome, and Mary the mother of James ^{1b}bought some spices to put on Jesus' body. ^{2a}Very early on Sunday morning, just as the sun was coming up, ^{2b}they went to the tomb.

Mark 16:3

Section 16:1–8: Jesus rose from the dead

In this section, Mark wrote about what happened when Jesus rose from the dead. He rose just as he had told his disciples that he would.

When the Sabbath was over, some women who knew Jesus bought spices. They planned to bring them to Jesus' tomb early the next morning to anoint his body. When they arrived at the tomb, they saw that someone had rolled the large stone away from the entrance. A young man dressed in a white robe was sitting inside the tomb. He told them that Jesus was not there. He was alive again! Then the women became afraid and ran from the tomb.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Comes Back to Life (GW)

The Resurrection of Jesus (NRSV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 28:1–8; Luke 24:1–12; and John 20:1–12, 20:15.

Paragraph 16:1–4

The events of this paragraph happened on the day after the Sabbath. It was against the Jewish religious law to do any work on the Sabbath day. So the women had to wait until the next day to anoint Jesus' body.

16:3a

They were asking one another,

- they were saying to each other,
- As they walked, they talked about
- On the way they were discussing (NLT96)

In some languages it may be natural to connect verses 2–3 with a phrase. For example:

On the way (GNT)

As they walked

16:3b

“Who will roll away the stone from the entrance of the tomb?”

- “Who will roll away the stone for us that blocks the entrance of the tomb?”
- the heavy stone that was in the entrance of the tomb. They asked, “Who can roll away the stone for us?”
- who would roll the stone away from the entrance to the tomb. (NLT96)

Who will roll away the stone from the entrance of the tomb?: In the Greek text, 16:3b includes a phrase that means “for us,” as in the NJB:

Who will roll away the stone for us from the entrance to the tomb?

The phrase “for us” indicates that the stone was too large for the women to roll away from the entrance (see 16:4b). They wondered whom they could ask to roll it away for them. Express this idea in a natural way in your language. Another way to say this is:

Who will move the stone aside so that we can enter the tomb?

roll away the stone from the entrance of the tomb:

In 15:46e Mark said that Joseph “rolled a stone against the entrance of the tomb.” This was a common way to protect the dead bodies inside a tomb so that people or animals could not easily enter to harm them. Only a very strong person could move this stone away from the entrance.

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate that the stone was blocking the entrance to the tomb so that people could not enter. For example:

roll back the stone that blocks the entrance to the tomb

General Comment on 16:3a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to translate the women's words using indirect speech. For example, the NLT96 says:

On the way they were discussing who would roll the stone away from the entrance to the tomb.

In other languages it may be helpful to give information about the stone before the women's speech. For example:

^{3a}As they walked, they talked about ^{3b}the stone that was at the entrance of the tomb. ^{3a}They asked each other, ^{3b}“Who will roll that stone aside for us?”

See the General Comment on 16:3–4 at the end of 16:4b for a suggestion about reordering.

Mark 16:4

Section 16:1–8: Jesus rose from the dead

In this section, Mark wrote about what happened when Jesus rose from the dead. He rose just as he had told his disciples that he would.

When the Sabbath was over, some women who knew Jesus bought spices. They planned to bring them to Jesus' tomb early the next morning to anoint his body. When they arrived at the tomb, they saw that someone had rolled the large stone away from the entrance. A young man dressed in a white robe was sitting inside the tomb. He told them that Jesus was not there. He was alive again! Then the women became afraid and ran from the tomb.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Comes Back to Life (GW)

The Resurrection of Jesus (NRSV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 28:1–8; Luke 24:1–12; and John 20:1–12, 20:15.

Paragraph 16:1–4

The events of this paragraph happened on the day after the Sabbath. It was against the Jewish religious law to do any work on the Sabbath day. So the women had to wait until the next day to anoint Jesus' body.

16:4a

But when they looked up,

- But when they looked ahead,
- Then they looked toward the tomb and

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But is often translated as “and.” Here it connects the women's question in 16:3 with what they saw in 16:4. They did not expect to see that the stone was already rolled away from the entrance to the tomb. Some English versions use “then” or do not use a conjunction to connect the verses. Connect these verses in a natural way in your language.

when they looked up: Here in 16:4 the women were close enough to see the entrance to the tomb. The clause when they looked up indicates that the women looked toward the tomb. It does not imply that they looked up at the sky.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

when they looked ahead

when they looked

16:4b

they saw that the stone had been rolled away, even though it was extremely large.

- they saw that the very large stone had already been rolled away from the entrance.
- saw that someone had already rolled away the stone, which was a very large one.

they saw that the stone had been rolled away: This clause is passive. It does not tell who rolled away the stone, and the women did not know how it had been rolled away. In some languages it may be necessary to use an active verb here and to supply a subject. If this is the case in your language, you should supply a general subject. For example:

they saw that someone had rolled away the stone

even though it was extremely large: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as even though it was extremely large is literally “for it was very large.” The word “for” often introduces an explanation. In this context the clause probably explains why the stone could not be moved easily. It may also explain why the women could see from a distance that the stone had already been rolled away.

In Greek this explanation comes at the end of 16:4. In some languages it may be more natural to place it in a different place in 16:3 or 16:4. See the General Comment on 16:3–4 for suggestions.

extremely large: In this context the words extremely large also imply that the stone was extremely heavy. The women were not strong enough to move such a large and heavy stone.

General Comment on 16:3–4

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the clause “for the stone was very large.” For example:

^{3a}They asked each other, ^{3b}“Who will roll away the stone for us from the entrance of the tomb?”

^{4a-b}And looking up they saw that this very large stone had already been rolled away from the entrance.

³⁻⁴On the way they said to one another, “Who will roll away the stone for us from the entrance to the tomb?” (It was a very large stone.) Then they looked up and saw that the stone had already been rolled back. (GNT)

Mark 16:5

Section 16:1–8: Jesus rose from the dead

In this section, Mark wrote about what happened when Jesus rose from the dead. He rose just as he had told his disciples that he would.

When the Sabbath was over, some women who knew Jesus bought spices. They planned to bring them to Jesus’ tomb early the next morning to anoint his body. When they arrived at the tomb, they saw that someone had rolled the large stone away from the entrance. A young man dressed in a white robe was sitting inside the tomb. He told them that Jesus was not there. He was alive again! Then the women became afraid and ran from the tomb.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Comes Back to Life (GW)

The Resurrection of Jesus (NRSV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 28:1–8; Luke 24:1–12; and John 20:1–12, 20:15.

Paragraph 16:5

In this paragraph, the women arrived at the tomb and entered it. Inside, they met a young man dressed in a white robe.

16:5a

When they entered the tomb,

- ¶ When they stepped into the tomb,
- ¶ When the women arrived at the tomb and went inside,

When they entered the tomb: The women arrived at the tomb and went into it. In some languages it may be helpful to mention that they arrived. For example:

When the women came to the tomb, they entered it...

they: The pronoun they refers to the women whose names were mentioned in 16:1.

entered the tomb: The women entered the tomb in the same way people enter a small room. They were not going down into a hole. John 20:5 mentions that it was necessary to stoop to enter the tomb. This was because the opening to the tomb was probably about one meter square.

tomb: See how you translated tomb in 16:2b and 16:3b.

16:5b

they saw a young man dressed in a white robe

- they saw a young man wearing a long white robe,
- they saw a young man. He was dressed in a white robe (GW)

they saw a young man: The women saw someone who appeared to be a young man. Use a general term that refers to a man who is old enough to marry.

Most Bible scholars say that the young man was one of the angels that Matthew and Luke mentioned in their accounts of Jesus’ resurrection. Mark did not say that the young man was an angel, so you should not specify that in the text here. You may want to include a footnote that explains the differences between Mark and the other two gospel accounts. For example:

This young man was an angel sent from God. See Matthew 28:2 and Luke 24:4.

Matthew 28:2 and Luke 24:4 describe this person as an angel sent from God. This angel looked like a young man, so that was how Mark described him.

dressed in a white robe: The young man was wearing a white robe. Use a general term for a long outer garment. See how you translated robe in 12:38c, where the same Greek word is used.

16:5c

sitting on the right side,

- who was sitting inside on their right.
- and sat on the right side. (GW)

sitting on the right side: The young man was sitting to the right of the women as they entered the tomb. You may need to make it clear that he was sitting inside the tomb. The text does not say what he was sitting on. If the verb sitting in your language requires that you say what he was sitting on, you could use a more general verb here. For example:

waiting there on their right side

16:5d and they were alarmed.

- The women were very afraid.
- They were amazed and terrified.

they were alarmed: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as alarmed indicates that the women were amazed and afraid.

Mark 16:6

Section 16:1–8: Jesus rose from the dead

In this section, Mark wrote about what happened when Jesus rose from the dead. He rose just as he had told his disciples that he would.

When the Sabbath was over, some women who knew Jesus bought spices. They planned to bring them to Jesus' tomb early the next morning to anoint his body. When they arrived at the tomb, they saw that someone had rolled the large stone away from the entrance. A young man dressed in a white robe was sitting inside the tomb. He told them that Jesus was not there. He was alive again! Then the women became afraid and ran from the tomb.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Comes Back to Life (GW)

The Resurrection of Jesus (NRSV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 28:1–8; Luke 24:1–12; and John 20:1–12, 20:15.

Paragraph 16:6–7

In this paragraph, the young man in the tomb first told the women not to be afraid of him. He then told them that Jesus has risen from the dead and was going ahead of his disciples to Galilee.

16:6a

But he said to them, “Do not be alarmed.

- ¶ He said to them, “Do not be afraid.
- ¶ But the young man told them not to fear,

But: The word But introduces the way that the young man (the angel) responded to the women's alarm. Even though they were afraid, he told them they did not need to be and explained why. This word indicates that contrast and introduces what he said to them.

he said to them: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as he said to them occurs at the beginning of this verse. Place it where it is natural in your language.

Do not be alarmed: The young man calmed the women by telling them not to be alarmed. The Greek verb that the BSB translates as alarmed is the same one that was used in 16:5c. You may translate it in the same way here.

16:6b

You are looking for Jesus the Nazarene, who was crucified.

- I know you are looking for Jesus the Nazarene, the one they killed on a cross.
- and he said, “You have come here to see the body of Jesus from/of Nazareth, who was nailed to a cross.

You are looking for Jesus the Nazarene: The young man knew why the women had come. They were expecting to find the dead body of Jesus. Do not translate You are looking for Jesus the Nazarene in a way that sounds as though they expected Jesus to be alive.

Jesus the Nazarene: The phrase Jesus the Nazarene identifies Jesus as a person from the town of Nazareth (see 10:47a). See also how you translated this phrase in 14:67c.

who was crucified: The phrase who was crucified identifies very clearly the person whom the women were looking for. The young man indicated clearly that Jesus had really been killed. This phrase makes the following statement in 16:6c more dramatic because of the contrast.

The verb was crucified is a passive. In some languages it may be necessary to make it active. For example:

whom they/men crucified

who died on a cross

crucified: The word crucified comes from the verb “crucify.” It means to execute (kill) someone by nailing or tying him to a cross, then setting the cross upright. This was a Roman way to cause criminals to die a slow and painful death.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

killed/executed on a cross

nailed/fastened to a cross to kill him

Here are some other ways to translate cross:

plank/wood of death

crossed-beam(s) of death

a tree for killing people

a stake/post to which they fasten/nail someone to kill him

See how you translated crucified in 15:13.

16:6c

He has risen! He is not here!

- He is alive again! He is not here anymore.
- God raised him from the dead! He is not here in the tomb.
- He is not here. God has caused him to live again!

He has risen: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as He has risen is literally “he was raised.” It is a passive. It means “He has risen from the dead” or “He is alive again.” If you need to say who raised Jesus from the dead, you should say that it was God. For example:

God has raised him to life (CEV)

God has caused him to live again

He is not here: The phrase He is not here refers to the fact that Jesus was not in the tomb anymore.

General Comment on 16:6c

In your language it may be more natural to reorder the two statements in this part of the verse. For example:

He is not here. God raised him from the dead!

16:6d

See the place where they put Him.

- Look, there is the place they laid him. (NRSV)
- Look! That is the place where his body was laid.

See the place where they put Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as See is often used to call attention to something. In this context the word See calls the women’s attention to the place where Jesus’ body had been. The man was probably pointing to this place.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Look, there is the place they laid him.

Here is the place where they placed him.

the place where they put Him: The young man was probably pointing to the stone shelf inside the tomb, where Jesus’ body had been placed when he was buried.

The pronoun they refers to Joseph of Arimathea and the people who helped him place the body of Jesus in the tomb. In some languages it may be natural to translate this pronoun with a general word such as “people”:

the place where the people/men laid him

In some languages it may be natural to use a passive. For example:

the place where he was placed (GNT)

the place where his body was laid

Mark 16:7

Section 16:1–8: Jesus rose from the dead

In this section, Mark wrote about what happened when Jesus rose from the dead. He rose just as he had told his disciples that he would.

When the Sabbath was over, some women who knew Jesus bought spices. They planned to bring them to Jesus’ tomb early the next morning to anoint his body. When they arrived at the tomb, they saw that someone had rolled the large stone away from the entrance. A young man dressed in a white robe was sitting inside the tomb. He told them that Jesus was not there. He was alive again! Then the women became afraid and ran from the tomb.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Comes Back to Life (GW)

The Resurrection of Jesus (NRSV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 28:1–8; Luke 24:1–12; and John 20:1–12, 20:15.

Paragraph 16:6–7

In this paragraph, the young man in the tomb first told the women not to be afraid of him. He then told them that Jesus has risen from the dead and was going ahead of his disciples to Galilee.

16:7a

But go, tell His disciples and Peter,

- But go to his disciples, including Peter, and say to them,
- But now you must go to Peter and to Jesus' other followers and tell them that

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But is used here to introduce a new instruction to the women. The new instruction contrasts with the instruction to them in 16:6. In 16:6 the young man told the women to look and see that Jesus was no longer there in the tomb. Here in 16:7 he told them not to stay there but to go and tell others the news. Introduce this new instruction in a way that is natural in your language. For example, the GNT says:

Now (GNT)

go, tell His disciples and Peter: The verbs go and tell are both commands. The verb go indicates that the women must leave the tomb and go to where the disciples were. Be sure to translate this so that it does not sound rude.

Here are some other ways to express these two commands:

go to his disciples and Peter and tell them...

go to where the disciples and Peter are and say...

His disciples and Peter: Peter was one of Jesus' disciples. If the phrase His disciples and Peter implies that Peter was not a disciple, you may need to translate in a different way. For example:

Peter and his/Jesus' other disciples

his disciples, including Peter (GNT, NLT)

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means "learners" who are in a relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to

their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

students/learners

apprentices

followers

See how you translated this word at 2:15b and 9:14a–b. See also disciple in the Glossary for more information.

16:7b

'He is going ahead of you into Galilee.'

- 'Jesus is on his way to Galilee before you.'^(plur)
- Jesus is alive. He is going to Galilee, and you^(plur) must all go there too.

He is going ahead of you into Galilee: This part of the verse is the message that the women should tell the disciples. The young man did not say that they must tell the disciples that Jesus was alive, but this is implied. See how you translated Jesus' statement, "I will go ahead of you into Galilee" in 14:28b.

He: The pronoun He refers to Jesus. You may need to make this explicit in your translation.

going ahead of you: The expression going ahead of you refers here to arriving in Galilee before the disciples would arrive. It does not refer to leading them to Galilee.

you: The pronoun you refers to Jesus' disciples.

16:7c

There you will see Him, just as He told you.'"

- Go there and you^(plur) will see him, just as he said you would."
- You will see him there, just as he told you." (CEV)

There you will see Him: This statement implies that Jesus expected his disciples to go to Galilee to see him. See Matthew 28:16–20, where Jesus met in Galilee with his disciples.

just as He told you: See 14:28b, where Jesus told them he would go ahead of them to Galilee after he had risen.

Mark 16:8

Section 16:1–8: Jesus rose from the dead

In this section, Mark wrote about what happened when Jesus rose from the dead. He rose just as he had told his disciples that he would.

When the Sabbath was over, some women who knew Jesus bought spices. They planned to bring them to Jesus' tomb early the next morning to anoint his body. When they arrived at the tomb, they saw that someone had rolled the large stone away from the entrance. A young man dressed in a white robe was sitting inside the tomb. He told them that Jesus was not there. He was alive again! Then the women became afraid and ran from the tomb.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Comes Back to Life (GW)

The Resurrection of Jesus (NRSV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 28:1–8; Luke 24:1–12; and John 20:1–12, 20:15.

Paragraph 16:8

In this paragraph, the women were completely unprepared to meet this young man and hear his message to them. They left the tomb too afraid to say anything to anyone else.

16:8a

So the women left the tomb and ran away, trembling and bewildered.

- ¶ So the women left the tomb and hurried away, confused and trembling.
- ¶ So the women began to tremble with fear and were amazed. They left the tomb and hurried away.

So the women left the tomb and ran away, trembling and bewildered: Some versions change the order of the Greek text in this verse. For example:

Trembling and bewildered, the women went out and fled from the tomb (NIV11)

Use a natural order in your language.

left the tomb and ran away: The women were not hurrying to do what the young man told them to do.

Instead, they were running away because they were afraid and did not want to stay there.

trembling and bewildered: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as trembling and bewildered is literally “trembling and bewilderment had them.” This is a figure of speech. It indicates that the women were so afraid that they were shaking, and they were confused. They had gone to the tomb expecting to find the body of Jesus. Instead, Jesus' body was gone and the young man told them that he was alive. This caused them to feel afraid, and they were not able to think clearly.

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of trembling and bewildered. For example:

The women were confused and shaking from fear.

16:8b

And in their fear they did not say a word to anyone.

- They did not tell anyone about what happened, because they were afraid. (NCV)
- They were too afraid to tell anyone what had happened. (CEV)
- They did not tell anyone what had they had seen and heard because they were afraid.

And in their fear they did not say a word to anyone:

The reason that the women did not say a word to anyone is because of their fear. Some commentators say that 16:8b indicates that they went straight to the disciples to tell them the message, without saying anything to anyone along the way. Other commentators say that the women were too afraid even to take the message to the disciples at first. Most English versions translate 16:8b without reflecting either of these interpretations, and you should do the same. The other Gospels indicate that the women did give the disciples the message, but at first they may have been too frightened to do so.

You may want to include this information in a footnote. For example:

We know from Matthew 28:9–10 that Jesus appeared to these women a short time later, probably so that they would not be afraid to tell his disciples the angel's message. We also know from Luke 24:9–11 that the women told Jesus' disciples the angel's message after they got back from the tomb, but no one believed them.

General Comment on 16:8b

It may be more natural in some languages to reverse the order of these two clauses. For example, the CEV says:

They were too afraid to tell anyone what had happened.

The rest of chapter 16, verses 9–20, is often referred to as “The Longer Ending of Mark.” There is a textual issue concerning this section:

1. Most Greek manuscripts include 16:9–20. Every major English version includes these verses. However, many versions place them inside brackets, or separate them in some other way, indicating that they were probably not part of the original text. For example, the GNT gives these verses the heading:

An Old Ending to the Gospel

1. Some important early Greek manuscripts do not include 16:9–20. The UBS4 (pages 190–192) gives this reading an A rating, indicating that it is likely that the original text of Mark did not include these verses.

Most Bible scholars do not believe that 16:9–20 was part of the story as Mark first wrote it. Some believe that Mark wrote more after 16:8b, but that we do not have the end of the story as he wrote it. Others believe that he stopped writing at 16:8b and that 16:9–20 was added later by a different person.

It is therefore recommended that you follow option (1) and put these verses in brackets, or separate them from the main text in some other way, to indicate that they were probably not part of Mark’s original text. You may also want to add a note such as the following:

Although the two oldest Greek manuscripts do not have verses 9–20, most major Greek manuscripts include them. Most Bible scholars think these verses were written by someone other than Mark, TRT note 168 on page 227. but they are still considered to be a valuable ancient witness to what happened after Jesus rose from the dead. There are similarities in 16:9–20 to Matthew 28:9–10, 16–20, Luke 24:13–49, John 20:10–23, and Acts 1:6–8.

There is also a second ending to Mark, often referred to as “The Shorter Ending of Mark.” It will be discussed later in a separate section after the notes on Mark

16:9–20. The BSB includes the longer ending of Mark in the main text. There is a footnote in the BSB that mentions the shorter ending.

Mark 16:9

Section 16:9–11: Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene

Some time after the women fled from the tomb, Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene. She then told Jesus’ disciples that she had seen Jesus alive again, but they did not believe her.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

Jesus comes to Mary Magdalene

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 28:9–10 and John 20:11–18.

16:9a

Early on the first day of the week, after Jesus had risen,

- ¶ Early in the morning on the first day of the week, when Jesus rose from the dead,
- ¶ Jesus rose to life early in the morning on the first day of the week.

Early on the first day of the week: See how you translated the phrase “early on the first day of the week” in 16:2a. The women arrived at the tomb very early on that day, and Jesus had already been raised from the dead.

If the first day of the week in your language is not Sunday, you may want to make this explicit, as some of the English versions do. For example, the GW says:

early on Sunday

after Jesus had risen: The phrase after Jesus had risen refers to his resurrection from the dead. The context shows that it introduces an event that happened soon after he became alive again.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

After Jesus rose from death (GNT)

after Jesus had risen to life (CEV)

After God had caused Jesus to live again

See how you translated “He has risen” in 16:6c.

16:9b

He appeared first to Mary Magdalene,

- the first person to whom he appeared was Mary Magdalene,
- The first person he allowed to see him after he rose was Mary from Magdala.

He appeared first to Mary Magdalene: The first person to see Jesus after he rose from the dead was Mary Magdalene (see John 20:10–18).

He appeared: The words He appeared refer to the fact that Jesus came to Mary so that she could see him. Jesus appeared, or allowed Mary to see him, in order for her to know that he really was alive again. You should be careful not to translate this in a way that implies that he let her see his body in an inappropriate way.

Mary Magdalene: The name Mary Magdalene means “Mary who came from the town of Magdala.” See how you wrote this name in 15:40b.

16:9c

from whom He had driven out seven demons.

- the woman from whom Jesus had long before driven out seven demons.
- In the past seven demons were controlling her, and Jesus forced them to release their control.
- This was the Mary whom he had freed/released from the control/influence of seven evil spirits.

from whom He had driven out seven demons: Mary was a common name among the Jews, and there may have been several women named Mary in the town of Magdala. This verse part identifies which Mary Jesus appeared to.

Jesus drove the demons out of Mary sometime before he died. He did not drive out the demons after he rose from the dead and appeared to Mary. Be sure to make this clear in your translation.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

from whom Jesus had long before driven out seven demons

One time in the past, he had forced seven demons out of her. (NCV)

In some languages it may be more natural to first say that Mary had been controlled by seven demons before saying that Jesus had driven them out. For example:

In the past seven demons controlled her, but Jesus forced them to release their control.

from whom He had driven out...demons: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as from whom He had driven out...demons is literally “out of whom he had cast/thrown out...demons.” This phrase implies that demons had previously controlled Mary’s thoughts and actions. Jesus had forced them to stop controlling her.

Jewish people often spoke of demons as being in someone. Different cultures have different ways of speaking about people being controlled by demons and being released from the control of demons. Use a natural expression for this in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

from whom he had forced out...demons (GW)

had sent away...demons from her

had exorcized the demons from her

had freed her from the control of...demons

See how you translated the idea of driving out demons in 1:34b.

demons: The Greek word that the BSB translates as demons refers to spirits that are evil and can control people’s actions. The word demons refers to the same type of spirits as the Greek terms that are often translated as “evil spirits” and “unclean spirits.”

Here are some other ways to translate demons:

- Use a general term in your language that refers to spirits that are evil and can control people.
- Use a specific term in your language that refers to a certain type of spirits. These spirit should be able to do what is described in this context. Do not use a term that refers to the spirits of dead people.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

evil/bad spirits

unclean spirits Be sure that an expression like “unclean spirits” does not imply that the spirits are literally dirty.

See also evil spirit in the Glossary for more information.

Mark 16:10

Section 16:9–11: Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene

Some time after the women fled from the tomb, Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene. She then told Jesus' disciples that she had seen Jesus alive again, but they did not believe her.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

Jesus comes to Mary Magdalene

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 28:9–10 and John 20:11–18.

16:10a

She went and told those who had been with Him,

- She went to Jesus' followers and told them what had happened.
- Mary went and told the news to those who had been Jesus' friends/companions.

She went and told those who had been with Him:

Mary told Jesus' followers what the young man had told her to say (see 16:7).

those who had been with Him: The phrase those who had been with Him refers to the eleven disciples and the other men and women who had been followers of Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

his friends (CEV)

his followers (NCV)

his companions (GNT)

16:10b

who were mourning and weeping.

- They had been mourning and weeping.
- When she found them, they were grieving and crying about his death.

who were mourning and weeping: Jesus' friends were mourning and weeping because Jesus had died. They were grieving over his death. They had not been mourning and weeping while they were with Jesus (16:10a). Be sure that this is clear in your translation.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

who were very sad and were crying (NCV)

The words mourning and weeping have very similar meanings. If your language has one expression that includes the meanings of sadness/mourning and crying/weeping, you may use one expression here.

Mark 16:11

Section 16:9–11: Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene

Some time after the women fled from the tomb, Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene. She then told Jesus' disciples that she had seen Jesus alive again, but they did not believe her.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

Jesus comes to Mary Magdalene

There are parallel passages for this section in Matthew 28:9–10 and John 20:11–18.

16:11

In this verse, Mary told Jesus' followers that she had seen him alive again, and they did not believe her.

See also the General Comment on 16:11a–c for a suggestion about reordering the parts of this verse.

16:11a

And when they heard that Jesus was alive

- And when they heard that Jesus had come back to life
- But Mary told them that Jesus was alive. (NCV)
- But Mary told them, "Jesus is alive,

16:11b

and she had seen Him,

- and that Mary had seen him,
- She said that she had seen him, (NCV)
- and I have just seen him!"

16:11a–b

And: There is a contrast here between the sadness of the disciples in 16:10b and Mary's good news in 16:11a–b. Because of this, some versions translate this conjunction as "but". Other versions do not use a conjunction. Introduce the verse in a way that is natural in your language.

when they heard that Jesus was alive and she had seen Him: The clauses in 16:11a–b tell two things that Mary told Jesus' followers:

1. Jesus was alive, and
2. Mary had seen him.

The NCV shows another way to translate these verse parts:

But Mary told them that Jesus was alive. She said that she had seen him (NCV)

16:11c **they did not believe it.**

- they did not believe the news.
- but his friends/companions did not believe her.
- Then they thought, “That cannot be true.”

they did not believe it: The disciples did not believe either of the two things that Mary told them. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate what the pronoun it refers to. For example:

they did not believe what she said.

General Comment on 16:11a–c

It may be clearer in some languages to reorder the clauses in 16:11. For example, the NJB says:

^{11c}But they did not believe her ^{11a}when they heard her say that he was alive ^{11b}and that she had seen him.

Mark 16:12

Section 16:12–13: Jesus appeared to two of his followers

In this section, Jesus met two of his followers on the road outside of Jerusalem. At first, the two men did not know that they were talking to Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

Two disciples saw the risen/living Lord Jesus

Luke 24:13–35 provides more details about the events in this paragraph.

16:12a **After this, Jesus appeared in a different form to two of them**

- ¶ After this, Jesus allowed two of his followers to see him in a form that they did not recognize,
- ¶ After this, Jesus changed his appearance and came to two of his followers

After this: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as After this is literally “after these things.” The words “these things” probably refer to the events in 16:9–11. According to Luke 24:13, the event in 16:12–13 happened later the same day. Use a general word or expression that can refer to several hours later.

Jesus appeared: In 16:9b, Jesus “appeared first to Mary Magdalene.” Here in 16:12, he appeared to two other disciples. The verb appeared indicates that Jesus showed himself to them, that is, he allowed them to see him. You may be able to use the same verb as you used in 16:9b. The Greek verb is slightly different here, but it has the same meaning.

in a different form: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in a different form refers to Jesus’ outward appearance. He did not look the same as he looked before his resurrection. Some commentators say that this refers to appearing in a different form than the form in which he had appeared to Mary Magdalene. But in the story about Jesus appearing to the two disciples, they did not recognize him. Therefore, the main idea here is probably that Jesus appeared in a different form than the one they knew.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in a form they did not recognize

he looked different than he looked before

Be careful not to translate this phrase in a way that would make people think Jesus had the form of an animal or anything other than a man.

to two of them: The phrase to two of them means “to two of Jesus’ other followers.” This phrase indicates that they were two of Jesus’ followers mentioned in 16:10. You may need to make this explicit. For example, the NCV says:

to two of his followers (NCV)

16:12b **as they walked along in the country.**

- as they were walking out into the open fields.
- as they were on their way into the countryside.

as they walked along: Jesus met the two men as they walked along. According to Luke 24:15, he talked with them as they were walking together.

in the country: There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in the country:

1. They were going into the country. They had been in the city of Jerusalem and now were going out into the countryside. For example:

while they were on their way to the country (GNT)

as they were on their way out of the city (CEV)
(GNT, RSV, CEV, NLT, NASB, REB, NET, KJV, ESV, NJB)

1. They were in the country (on a road); that is, between one town and another, among the farms and fields. For example:

while they were walking in the country (NCV)
(BSB, NIV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

General Comment on 16:12a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of some of the information in this verse. For example:

^{12a}After that, Jesus appeared to two of his disciples ^{12b}as they were walking toward a rural area,
^{12a}but his appearance had changed.

Mark 16:13

Section 16:12–13: Jesus appeared to two of his followers

In this section, Jesus met two of his followers on the road outside of Jerusalem. At first, the two men did not know that they were talking to Jesus.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here is another possible heading for this section:

Two disciples saw the risen/living Lord Jesus

Luke 24:13–35 provides more details about the events in this paragraph.

16:13a

And they went back and reported it to the rest,

- And these two returned to the others and told them that they had seen Jesus.
- When they realized that it was Jesus, they went back and told the other followers.

And they went back and reported it to the rest:

There is implied information in this clause: The two

followers realized that they had seen Jesus. Then they returned and reported to the other followers that they had seen him. Although Jesus appeared to the two men in a different form (16:12), Jesus made himself known to them after a while. You may need to make this explicit in your translation. For example:

When they realized who he was, they rushed back to tell the others. (NLT96)

See Luke 24:30–32.

they: The Greek word that the BSB translates as they refers to the two followers of Jesus in 16:12.

went back: The phrase went back indicates that the two followers went back to where Jesus' other followers were (see Luke 24:33). They were probably in Jerusalem.

and reported it to the rest: The two disciples who saw Jesus while they were walking into the country told the other followers that they had seen him alive.

16:13b

but they did not believe them either.

- But the other followers did not believe what these two said either.
- But they did not believe them, just as they did not believe what Mary said.

but they did not believe them either: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as but they did not believe them either indicates that just as Jesus' followers/friends did not believe the women, so they did not believe the two disciples either. They did not believe that either the women or the two disciples had really seen Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

but nor did the rest of the disciples believe it

neither would they believe their report/words

who did not believe them either (NJB)

believe them: Here the phrase believe them means "believe what they said" or "believe what they said about seeing Jesus."

See believe, meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information about this word.

Mark 16:14

Section 16:14–18: Jesus told his disciples to preach the good news to all people

After Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene and two of his followers, he appeared to his eleven disciples. First, he rebuked them for their lack of faith and for refusing to believe that he had been raised from the dead. Then Jesus told them to go out into the world and preach the good news to everyone.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Appears to the Eleven (GNT)

What Jesus' Followers Must Do (CEV)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 28:16–20.

16:14a

Later, as they were eating, Jesus appeared to the Eleven

- ¶ Later, Jesus came to his eleven disciples while they were eating together.
- ¶ Later, Jesus showed himself to the eleven followers all at once, while they were eating supper/bread.

Later: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Later here introduces events that probably occurred after the events in 16:12–13 but on the same day. See Luke 24:36.

as they were eating, Jesus appeared to the Eleven:

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as appeared was also used in 16:12. Jesus showed himself to the eleven disciples; that is, he came to them.

as they were eating: It is implied that the disciples were eating together. Jesus appeared to them while they were together in the same place. In some languages it may be necessary to provide an object and say what they were eating. They were eating the evening meal:

as they were eating supper/dinner

the Eleven: The phrase the Eleven refers to the eleven remaining disciples. Judas was dead and another disciple had not yet been chosen to replace him. See Acts 1:18–22. In many languages it may be helpful to add your word for “disciples” to the phrase the Eleven. For example:

the eleven disciples (GNT)

16:14b

and rebuked them for their unbelief and hardness of heart,

- He reproached them for failing to believe and stubbornly refusing to accept
- He scolded them because they were too stubborn to believe (CEV)

and rebuked them: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as rebuked means to reprimand or reproach someone for doing something wrong. Jesus rebuked the disciples because they had refused to believe that he was alive, even though he had told them that he would rise from the dead. See 10:34.

for their unbelief and hardness of heart: The Greek phrases that the BSB translates as unbelief and hardness of heart mean “lack of faith” and “stubborn refusal to believe.” The expressions “unbelief” and “hardness of heart” have almost the same meaning in this context. They are probably used together here for emphasis. However, in a sense the disciples were guilty of two different things: failing to believe what Jesus had said would happen and refusing to believe those who knew that it had happened.

In some languages it may not be natural to use two different phrases to express this emphasis. If that is true in your language, express the emphasis in a different way. For example:

they were too stubborn to believe (CEV)

they completely refused to believe

See the General Comment on 16:14b–c for a discussion of how this part of the verse is related to the context.

16:14c

because they did not believe those who had seen Him after He had risen.

- the testimony of the people who had seen him after he rose from the dead.
- when those who saw him after he came to life again told what they had seen.

believe: In this context, the word believe refers to the situation where the eleven disciples did not believe that some people had seen Jesus risen from the dead. They did not accept this report as true. Here, the word believe does not mean “believe in” or “trust in” Jesus.

See believe, meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information about this word.

those who had seen Him after He had risen: The clause those who had seen Him after He had risen refers to Mary Magdalene in 16:9–11 and the two disciples in 16:12–13. These people had seen Jesus after he rose from the dead. The text implies here that these people told the disciples what they had seen. You may need to make this explicit. For example:

the testimony of the people who had seen him
after he rose from the dead

General Comment on 16:14b–c

16:14c expresses the reason that Jesus reproached the disciples in 16:14b. In some languages it may be necessary to express this relationship explicitly, as the Greek text does. The NJB follows the Greek text:

^{14b}He reproached them for their incredulity and obstinacy, ^{14c}because they had refused to believe those who had seen him after he had risen.

Mark 16:15

Section 16:14–18: Jesus told his disciples to preach the good news to all people

After Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene and two of his followers, he appeared to his eleven disciples. First, he rebuked them for their lack of faith and for refusing to believe that he had been raised from the dead. Then Jesus told them to go out into the world and preach the good news to everyone.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Appears to the Eleven (GNT)

What Jesus' Followers Must Do (CEV)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 28:16–20.

16:15–18

In these verses Jesus spoke to his disciples. In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect quotes for his words. See the General Comment on 16:15–18 at the end of the notes on 16:18c for an example.

16:15a

And He said to them,

- Then Jesus said to them,
- But after that, he told them,

He said to them: The words He said to them introduce important instructions that Jesus gave his disciples. You may need to make it clear in your translation that 16:15–18 is not part of Jesus' rebuke. For example:

And then he told them (NLT)

But after that he said to them

16:15b

“Go into all the world

- “Go everywhere
- “Go to all places

16:15c

and preach the gospel to every creature.

- and preach the good news to everyone.
- and tell all people the good news about me.

16:15b–c

Go into all the world and preach the gospel to every creature: The command in 16:15b–c is often called “the Great Commission.” It indicates that Jesus wanted his disciples to preach the good news to everyone in every place in the world.

into all the world...to every creature: The expressions into all the world and to every creature have similar meanings. The Greek text uses two similar words that are translated as all and every in the BSB. This repetition emphasizes that Jesus wanted everyone in the whole world to hear the good news. Emphasize this in a way that is natural in your language.

into all the world: In this context the expression into all the world means “to every place” or “everywhere” in the world.

preach: The Greek word that the BSB translates as preach means to publicly tell people something important. In Mark, it usually refers to speaking about God and his kingdom to a group or crowd of people. The word should not only refer to what a preacher does in church.

Here are some other ways to translate preach:

announce

proclaim

tell people

See how you translated this word in 1:38b and 14:9b.

the gospel: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as the gospel is the same word that the BSB translates as “gospel” in 1:1. In Mark, this word refers to the good news about Jesus Christ and the kingdom of God.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

good/sweet news

good news about Jesus Christ

good news from God

message/report that causes joy

Be sure that the term you choose does not refer only to a news report or to a story that is not true.

See how you translated this term in 1:1. In 14:9b, the BSB translates this same term as the “gospel.”

to every creature: The expression every creature is a figure of speech that refers to all of mankind. It does not include other animals or plants.

Here are some other ways it has been translated:

everyone (NLT)

all people (GNT)

Mark 16:16

Section 16:14–18: Jesus told his disciples to preach the good news to all people

After Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene and two of his followers, he appeared to his eleven disciples. First, he rebuked them for their lack of faith and for refusing to believe that he had been raised from the dead. Then Jesus told them to go out into the world and preach the good news to everyone.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Appears to the Eleven (GNT)

What Jesus’ Followers Must Do (CEV)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 28:16–20.

16:16a

Whoever believes and is baptized will be saved,

- Anyone who believes the good news and is baptized will be saved from sin,
- God will save/rescue from sin the people who believe in me and who receive baptism,

Whoever believes: In some languages it is necessary to have an object for a verb like believes. In this context, the object is either the good news about Jesus that was mentioned in 16:15 or Jesus himself. You may need to make this explicit. For example:

Whoever believes this good news

Whoever trusts in me

Everyone who believes me (CEV)

believes: In this context, the word believes refers to believing or trusting in Jesus and his message. It refers to a person “putting his trust in Jesus” and “placing himself in the complete care of Jesus.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

relies/depends on me

trusts in me

trusts in the good news

have confidence in the good news

Your language may use an idiom for this meaning. See believe, Meaning 1 & 2, in the Glossary.

is baptized: The expression is baptized here refers to the action of receiving baptism. Baptism is a ritual that uses water to indicate that a person is being purified. In some verses, the verbs “wash” and “clean” are used to translate the Greek verb “baptize.” Luke 11:38 says, “But the Pharisee was surprised to see that Jesus did not first wash (baptize) before the meal.” (The Greek verb here is baptizo, but English versions translate it as “wash.” The context refers to a ritual washing, not merely a removal of dirt.). Mark 7:4 and Matthew 23:25 both speak of washing/cleaning cups and other utensils. The verb in Mark is baptizo while the verb in Matthew is katharizo (clean). Again,

a ritual cleansing is involved. Mark 7:4 says, “And there are many other traditions for them to observe, including the washing (baptizing) of cups, pitchers, kettles, and couches for dining.” Matthew 23:25 says, “You clean (katharizo) the outside of the cup and dish.” However, the above references do not prove that “wash/cleanse” is the only meaning of the rite of baptism as practiced by John and by the early Christians. And certainly Jesus’ baptism of people with the Holy Spirit signified more than purification from sin. When a believer in Jesus is baptized, it also indicates that he or she is being recognized and initiated as a follower of Jesus and one of God’s people.

The expression is baptized is passive here. In some languages it may not be possible to use a passive expression for this idea.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

accepts/receives baptism

causes himself to be baptized

someone does the purifying ceremony for him

submits to God’s purification rite

they use the water ceremony to purify him for God

See how you translated the word baptized in 1:5b. See the note on “baptism” in 1:4c. See also baptize, Meaning 1, in the Glossary.

will be saved: The Greek word that the BSB translates as will be saved means “will be rescued from some kind of trouble or danger.” In this context it refers to being rescued from sin and the punishment from God that results from sin. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate what the person will be saved from. For example:

will be saved from sin

will be rescued from punishment for sin

The verb will be saved is in a passive form here. It does not specify who will save the person. In some languages it may be necessary to use an active form. If that is true in your language, you can specify God as the subject. For example:

God will save him from sin.

See how you translated “save” in 3:4d, 8:35a, and 8:35b.

16:16b

but whoever does not believe will be condemned.

- but anyone who does not believe the good news will be judged as guilty and will be punished.
- but God will condemn and punish the people who do not believe in me.
- but anyone who does not believe, God will sentence him to be punished.

but: The Greek word that the BSB translates as but here introduces a contrasting statement. The statement in 16:16a tells the result of believing, and the one in 16:16b tells the result of not believing. Connect these statements in a natural way in your language. In some languages a conjunction may not be needed. For example, the GNT says:

Whoever believes and is baptized will be saved;
whoever does not believe will be condemned.
(GNT)

whoever does not believe will be condemned: Try to translate this clause in a way that is similar to how you translated 16:16a.

does not believe: In this context the phrase does not believe implies “does not believe the good news” or “does not believe in me.” If you must supply an object, you should supply the same object as in 16:16a. See also believe, Meaning 1 & 2, in the Glossary.

will be condemned: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as will be condemned means “will be judged to be guilty.” It indicates that a judge will decide that he is guilty. It also implies that they will be sentenced to be punished. The verb will be condemned is a passive verb. It does not specify who will judge and condemn the unbeliever. If you used a passive form in 16:16a, you should also use one here. If you need to use an active verb, you may specify God as the subject. For example:

God will condemn him for punishment.

Mark 16:17

Section 16:14–18: Jesus told his disciples to preach the good news to all people

After Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene and two of his followers, he appeared to his eleven disciples. First, he rebuked them for their lack of faith and for

refusing to believe that he had been raised from the dead. Then Jesus told them to go out into the world and preach the good news to everyone.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Appears to the Eleven (GNT)

What Jesus' Followers Must Do (CEV)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 28:16–20.

16:17a

And these signs will accompany those who believe:

- And those who believe will be able to do these miraculous signs:
- I will help those who believe in me to do miracles that will show my power.

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *And* loosely connects 16:17a to 16:16, especially to 16:16a. Many English versions do not use a conjunction here, but it does not connect very naturally with the idea of people being condemned in 16:16b. The GW gives one way to translate this verse without a conjunction:

These are the miraculous signs that will accompany believers (GW)

these signs will accompany those who believe: In this context the phrase *signs will accompany those who believe* indicates that the people who believe in the good news about Jesus will be able to do miracles. These miracles will show that what they say is true. In some languages it may not be natural to talk about signs accompanying people. You may need to use a different verb. For example:

And those who believe will be able to do these things as proof (NCV)

Believers will be given the power to perform miracles (GNT)

these signs: The phrase *these signs* refers specifically to the list of miraculous signs in 16:17–18. These miracles are evidence or proof to others that what the believers are saying about Jesus and the good news is true. It shows that the Lord approves of the message

because he has allowed them to use his power to do miracles.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

miracles (GNT)

these wonderful things/acts

See how you translated the word *sign* in 8:11b.

believe: Here the word *believe* has the same meaning as in 16:16a. It means “believe/trust in Jesus and the good news about Jesus.”

See also *believe*, Meaning 1 & 2, in the Glossary.

16:17b

In My name they will drive out demons;

- In my name they will set people free from demons that possess/control them.
- They will use my authority to force demons to leave/free people,

In My name: The phrase *In My name* indicates the way that believers will be able to do the miraculous signs in 16:17–18. They will do them by means of the power and authority that Jesus has and that he will give to them. That is, believers will be able to do each of the signs in 16:17–18 “in the name” of Jesus. In some languages it may be necessary to repeat this idea for each one of these signs. See the General Comment on 16:17b–18c at the end of 16:18c for an example.

Here are some other ways to translate *In My name*:

They will use the power and authority of my name (GW)

by my power/authority

I will help them to...

I will give them power to...

See how you translated the similar phrase “in Your name” in 9:38b.

they will drive out demons: This is the first of the signs that believers will perform in Jesus' name. When demons are troubling people, believers will force the demons to leave those people and stop troubling them. See how you translated *drive out demons* in 3:15 and 9:38b.

demons: The word demons refers to evil spirits. See evil spirit in the Glossary.

16:17c

they will speak in new tongues;

- they will speak languages they did not know before,
- and I will make them able to speak languages that they did not speak before.

they will speak in new tongues: The phrase they will speak in new tongues indicates that believers will be able to speak languages that they did not speak before. The context implies that Jesus will cause them to be able to speak these languages as a miraculous sign. This probably implies that they will be able to speak them without studying to learn them. See Acts 2:1-10. The GW has another way to translate this clause:

They will speak new languages. (GW)

Mark 16:18

Section 16:14–18: Jesus told his disciples to preach the good news to all people

After Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene and two of his followers, he appeared to his eleven disciples. First, he rebuked them for their lack of faith and for refusing to believe that he had been raised from the dead. Then Jesus told them to go out into the world and preach the good news to everyone.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Appears to the Eleven (GNT)

What Jesus' Followers Must Do (CEV)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Matthew 28:16–20.

16:18a

they will pick up snakes with their hands,

- they will pick up poisonous snakes in their hands and not be harmed,
- I will protect them if they pick up a poisonous snake in their hands;

they will pick up snakes with their hands: The clause they will pick up snakes with their hands contains implied information. This clause describes a miracle. If believers pick up poisonous snakes in their hands, the snakes will not harm them. Jesus will protect them by his name, that is, his power, from being harmed by the

snakes. You may need to make this information more explicit in your translation. For example:

If they handle poisonous snakes, the snakes...will not harm them.

See the General Comment on 16:18a–b at the end of 16:18b for another suggestion.

16:18b

and if they drink any deadly poison, it will not harm them;

- and they will drink deadly poison and yet nothing bad will happen;
- and if they drink something poisonous, it will certainly not hurt them.

and if they drink any deadly poison, it will not harm them:

This part of the verse is similar to 16:18a. By Jesus' name, that is, his power, believers will be protected from harm if people try to poison them. The GW has another way to say this:

and if they drink any deadly poison, it will not hurt them (GW)

deadly poison: The Greek word that the BSB translates as deadly poison means “something that causes death.” In this context it refers to a poisonous liquid.

it will not harm them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as not is literally “in no way.” It is used to emphasize that believers will not be harmed in any way by drinking the poison. Try to emphasize this in a natural way in your language.

General Comment on 16:18a–b

In some languages it may be helpful to combine 16:18a–b. For example:

They will pick up snakes and drink poison without being hurt. (NCV)

...if they pick up snakes or drink any poison, they will not be harmed (GNT)

16:18c

they will lay their hands on the sick, and they will be made well.”

- they will place their hands on sick people and heal them.”
- I will make them able to heal sick people by placing their hands on them.”

they will lay their hands on the sick, and they will be made well: Jesus often healed sick people by placing his hands on them. For example, see 6:5b. Here, he said that believers would be able to heal sick people in this way. They would be able to do that in his name, that is, by using the authority that he would give them.

and they will be made well: The pronoun they refers to the sick people. Make sure that this is clear in your translation.

General Comment on 16:17b–18c

The phrase “in my name” in 16:17b indicates that believers will use the name of Jesus (that is, the authority and power of Jesus) to perform each of the signs in 16:17–18. In some languages it may be necessary to repeat the idea “in my name” with each of the signs. For example:

In my name they will drive out demons, and I will make them able to speak new languages. I will protect them if they pick up a poisonous snake, and if they drink any poison, I will cause it not to hurt them. They will lay their hands on sick people and because of my name, the sick people will recover.

General Comment on 16:15–18

In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech for Jesus’ words in these verses. For example:

^{15a}Then Jesus told them ^{15b}to go to all places and tell all people the good news. ^{16a}He said that people who believe in him and receive baptism will be saved, ^{16b}but that people who do not believe in him will be condemned. ^{17a}He promised to help those who believe in him to do miraculous signs, ^{17b}that they will use his name to force demons to leave people ^{17c}and they will speak different languages. ^{18a-b}If they pick up a snake in their hands or drink poison, he said that he will protect them from harm. ^{18c}He also promised that they will lay hands on sick people, and the sick people will get well.

If you make God explicit as the subject in any of the verses, be sure that you indicate clearly whether each clause is referring to God or to Jesus.

Mark 16:19

Section 16:19–20: Jesus was lifted up into heaven

This section describes how Jesus went back to heaven. This event is often called “the Ascension of Jesus.” The concluding statement informs readers that the disciples did as Jesus instructed them to do in 16:15–18.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Is Taken up to Heaven (GNT)

The Ascension of Jesus (NRSV)

Jesus went up to heaven

There are parallel passages for this section in Luke 24:50–53 and Acts 1:9–11.

16:19a

After the Lord Jesus had spoken to them,

- ¶ After the Lord Jesus had said these things to the disciples, (CEV)
- ¶ After the Lord Jesus had talked with his followers,

After the Lord Jesus had spoken to them: The clause After the Lord Jesus had spoken to them introduces the final event in the Longer Ending of Mark’s Gospel. This event happened some time after Jesus said the things in 16:15–18 to his disciples. The CEV has another way to translate this:

After the Lord Jesus had said these things to the disciples (CEV)

After: The Greek word that the BSB translates as After is the same word that it translates as “After” in 16:12a. See how you translated it there.

the Lord Jesus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “master,” or “one who has authority over others.” The Greek text often uses this same word to translate the personal name of God in Hebrew.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Master Jesus

Chief Jesus

Sovereign Jesus

In some languages it may be necessary to add a word to indicate whose Lord or Chief is referred to. If that is true in your language, you can add a word like “our.” Although not everyone serves Jesus as Lord, he is master over everyone, so you can use an inclusive form. For example:

our Chief Jesus

See Lord, Context 2, in the Glossary.

had spoken: In this context the words had spoken refer specifically to the things that Jesus said in 16:15–18.

to them: The pronoun them refers to Jesus’ disciples.

16:19b

He was taken up into heaven

- he was raised up into heaven,
- God lifted him up into heaven.

He was taken up into heaven: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as was taken up means here “lifted up and carried.” The verb is passive, and God is the implied subject. God lifted the Lord Jesus and carried him into heaven. Your translation should not imply that God forcefully took Jesus against his will.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

he was carried up to heaven (NCV)

he was lifted up into heaven

God received him into heaven.

God raised him up to heaven.

Acts 1:9 indicates that the disciples watched the Lord Jesus go into the sky until a cloud covered him. God took him all the way into heaven to sit at God’s right hand (16:19c).

In some languages it may be necessary to use both a term for sky and a term for heaven, because Jesus was carried through the sky and also into heaven. For example:

God lifted Jesus up into the sky and carried him to heaven.

See how you translated the word heaven in 10:21d and 12:25c. See also heaven, Meaning 2, in the Glossary.

See how the BSB translates the similar Greek clause in Luke 24:51. The Greek verbs are different in the two passages, but the meaning is the same.

16:19c

and sat down at the right hand of God.

- and he sat down in the position of honor at God’s right side.
- Then he sat down beside God to rule with him at his right side.

sat down at the right hand of God: The phrase at the right hand of God refers to the place of special honor next to God. In the culture at that time, the king or person having the greatest authority sat on a throne. The person with the next greatest authority and power after the king sat at the king’s right hand.

In many languages you may need to make the meaning of sat down at the right hand more explicit. For example:

sat in the place of special honor/authority at God’s right hand

See how you translated this idea in 12:36c and 14:62b.

at the right hand: The expression at the right hand means on the right side of someone, that is, to that person’s right.

Mark 16:20

Section 16:19–20: Jesus was lifted up into heaven

This section describes how Jesus went back to heaven. This event is often called “the Ascension of Jesus.” The concluding statement informs readers that the disciples did as Jesus instructed them to do in 16:15–18.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Is Taken up to Heaven (GNT)

The Ascension of Jesus (NRSV)

Jesus went up to heaven

There are parallel passages for this section in Luke 24:50–53 and Acts 1:9–11.

16:20a**And they went out and preached everywhere,**

- Then the disciples went everywhere and preached the good news.
- And Jesus' followers left and proclaimed the good news to people everywhere.

And they went out and preached everywhere: This part of the verse tells what the disciples did in response to the instructions that Jesus gave them in 16:15b–c. In 16:15 he told them to go everywhere and preach the good news, and in this verse they did that. Your translation of 16:20a should remind people of your translation of 16:15.

they: The pronoun they refers here to Jesus' disciples to whom he gave the instructions in 16:15–18.

went out: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as went out is literally “having gone forth.” In this context it indicates that the disciples went to many places. It does not imply that the disciples were indoors at the time Jesus was speaking to them.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

went (GNT)

left (CEV)

preached: In some languages it may be necessary to indicate what the disciples preached. If that is true in your language, indicate that they preached the good news about Jesus. For example:

preached Jesus' message

proclaimed the Good News

It may also be necessary in some languages to indicate who they preached to. For example, the NCV says:

told the Good News to people (NCV)

This same word occurs in 16:15b–c.

everywhere: The Greek word that the BSB translates as everywhere is used figuratively here. It emphasizes that the disciples went to many places. It does not indicate that they went to literally every place in the world. You may need to connect this idea directly with the verb “went.” For example:

went to many places

16:20b**and the Lord worked through them,**

- And the Lord helped them
- The Lord Jesus gave them power,

This part of the verse refers back to 16:15, where Jesus sent the disciples out to proclaim the good news.

the Lord: The title Lord in 16:20b refers back to “the Lord Jesus” in 16:19a.

worked through them: The phrase worked through them indicates that the Lord Jesus helped his disciples and gave them power to preach his word and to do the miraculous signs that he mentioned in 16:17–18. Although he was no longer present on earth as a human being, he worked through them by sending his Holy Spirit to help them (Acts 1:8).

Here are some other ways to translate this:

helped them (NCV)

gave them power

16:20c**confirming His word by the signs that accompanied it.**

- by confirming their message/word with miraculous signs.
- and the miracles they worked proved that their message was true. (CEV)

confirming His word by the signs that accompanied it: This statement is similar to what Jesus said in 16:17a. He indicated that he would prove or confirm by miraculous signs that he had sent the disciples. These signs showed that what they said was true.

confirming: In the context of this verse, confirming means “proved the truthfulness and trustworthiness” of the good news. The signs showed that what the disciples said about the good news was true.

Here is another way to translate this:

proved...was true (GNT)

His word: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as His word is literally “the word.” It refers to the good news that the disciples preached everywhere. There are two ways to interpret it in this context:

1. It refers to the disciples' word. For example:

their preaching (GNT) (GNT, CEV, NLT, NCV, REB, JBP)

1. It refers to the Lord's word. For example:

his word (NIV11) (BSB, NIV, GW)

The NJB, KJV, NET, ESV, and NASB translate this literally as “the word/message.” However, if it is not natural to translate this way in your language, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as most English versions do. This interpretation supports what Jesus said in 16:17a.

Here are some other ways to translate confirmed the word:

confirming what they said (NLT)

proved that their preaching was true (GNT)

proved that their message was true (CEV)

signs: See how you translated signs in 16:17a.

(RSV:) Amen: There is a textual issue at the end of 16:20. It concerns the word that the RSV transliterates as Amen:

1. Many Greek manuscripts do not have the word Amen. (BSB, NIV, GNT, NRSV, CEV, GW, REB, NASB, NET, NCV, NLT)
2. Some Greek manuscripts end the verse with the word Amen. (RSV, KJV) The UBS4 (page 192) gives this reading a C rating.

It is recommended that you follow option (1). However, if the major language version in your area includes the word Amen, you may follow it.

The word Amen means “Indeed it is true” or “May it be so.” Here are two ways to translate it:

- Use a word in your language with this meaning. Choose a word that would be appropriate to end this section. For example:

Truly!

Indeed!

So it shall be.

- Transliterate the word Amen according to the sounds of your language.

[[Mark 16:9–10: The Shorter Ending of Mark]]

This section is often referred to as “The Shorter Ending of Mark.” There is a textual issue concerning this section:

1. Most Greek manuscripts do not include 16:9–10. Many Bible scholars do not believe that Mark wrote it. They believe that someone else added it later to certain Greek manuscripts. Some English versions do not include it or mention it at all, such as the KJV and GW16:20 See also NCV.. Other English versions mention these verses in a footnote, such as BSB and NIV1116:20 Also see NET..
2. Only a few Greek manuscripts include 16:9–10. Some English versions include this shorter ending of Mark, usually setting it apart in some way like brackets, italics, or a special heading. There are two places in the text to include it:
3. At the end of 16:8. (NRSV, REB, NLT)
4. At the end of 16:20. (NASB, GNT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) and do not include 16:9–10 in the text of your translation. However, because a few Greek manuscripts and some English versions include this shorter ending of Mark, you may want to include it in a footnote, as the ESV does. Here is a suggested footnote:

A few Greek manuscripts include additional text at the end of 16:8. This text is usually called “The Shorter Ending of Mark.” However, none of the most ancient Greek manuscripts have it. The additional text is: “[Put your translation here, based on the Notes and Display for 16:9–10 below.]”

There are similarities in this section to Matthew 28:8, 18–20, Luke 24:9–10, and Acts 1:8.

16:9

And all that had been commanded them they told briefly to those around Peter: The Greek clause that the NRSV translates as all that had been commanded them is the object of the verb told. In some languages a more natural order for this sentence may be:

And they briefly told those around Peter all that had been commanded them.

In Greek the words all that had been commanded them occur at the beginning of 16:9 to emphasize them. If possible, you should emphasize the fact that they told

all that had been commanded them in your translation. The NLT96 translates this clause as:

Then they reported all these instructions briefly to Peter and his companions. (NLT96)

all that had been commanded them: The Greek verb that the NRSV translates as had been commanded is passive. In some languages it may be necessary to use an active verb and supply the subject. For example:

all that the young man had commanded them to say

This clause refers here to the message that the young man gave the women to tell Peter and the other disciples (16:7).

them: The pronoun them refers to the women who came to the tomb. See 16:1 for details.

they told briefly: The Greek clause that the NRSV translates as they told briefly refers to reporting something in a short way.

those around Peter: The Greek phrase that the NRSV translates as those around Peter may also be translated as “those with Peter.” This refers to Peter himself and the other disciples.

Here are some other ways you could translate this phrase:

Peter and the other disciples

Peter and his companions (NLT)

16:10a–b

This verse indicates that Jesus sent his disciples to proclaim salvation all over the world. It is similar to Matthew 28:18–20 and Acts 1:8.

And afterward: The Greek conjunction that the NRSV translates as And introduces what happened after 16:9. It does not indicate how much time passed between 16:9 and 16:10. If 16:10 refers to the same event as the one in Matthew 28:18–20, it would be several weeks afterward. Translate with a general word or expression meaning “some time later.”

Jesus himself sent out through them...the...proclamation of eternal salvation: This clause indicates that Jesus sent out...the...proclamation of eternal salvation by sending his followers to tell people about this salvation.

Here is another way to translate this:

Jesus himself sent them to proclaim to people the message of eternal salvation.

Jesus himself...through them: The words Jesus himself...through them emphasize the fact that it was Jesus who sent the disciples to proclaim the good news. Peter and the other disciples did not just decide on their own to go proclaim the message of salvation. The other Gospels tell about how Jesus appeared to them after his resurrection and sent them to proclaim the message.

them: The pronoun them refers to Jesus’ disciples. In 16:9, them referred to the women who were at the tomb. You will probably need to make this explicit in your translation. For example, the CEV says:

Later, Jesus sent the disciples

of eternal salvation: The phrase of eternal salvation refers to the content of the proclamation or message. The message is about how God saves people forever from sin. This is possible because Jesus took their punishment when he died on the cross, and then rose from the dead to give them eternal life.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

salvation that gives eternal life (NLT)

how people can be saved forever (CEV)

how God saves people for eternity

salvation: In this context the word salvation refers to deliverance from spiritual and eternal danger. It refers specifically to the way that Jesus rescues people from sin and from spiritual death and hell, which is the punishment for sin.

Here are some ways to translate salvation in this context:

deliverance from sin and hell

he rescues/saves people from sin and its punishment

from east to west: The expression from east to west is used figuratively. In this context it means “everywhere” or “all over the world.”

the sacred and imperishable proclamation: The Greek words that the NRSV translates as sacred and imperishable describe the message that Jesus sent his disciples to proclaim.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

to proclaim God’s unfailing message

to announce the holy and everlasting message

sacred: The Greek word that the NRSV translates as sacred indicates that the message is holy. It is holy because it is from God.

imperishable: The Greek word that the NRSV translates as imperishable is literally “undying.” It refers to something that does not die or decay. In this context it indicates that the message that Jesus sent his disciples to proclaim will never stop being true and powerful.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

always true

unfailing (NLT)

will never lose its power